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Psalms - Introduction

Psalms

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Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of Psalms

1. Book One (Psalms 1–41): Psalms of David
2. Book Two (Psalms 42–72): Mostly psalms of David
3. Book Three (Psalms 73–89): Psalms of Asaph, the Korahites, Ethan
4. Book Four (Psalms 90–106): Mostly anonymous psalms
5. Book Five (Psalms 107–150): Mostly anonymous, several psalms of David

What is the book of Psalms?
The book of Psalms is a collection of songs that are addressed to God or that speak about God. The word "psalm" comes from a Greek term that described a song that a person would sing while playing a stringed instrument. In many languages, the word now refers to the songs in this collection in the Bible. (All of the songs were written in Hebrew, but they are now called by a Greek name because at one point many Jews became speakers of Greek.) People often call the writers of these psalms "psalmists."

What title should translators use for this book?
Translators may use the traditional title of this book, "The Book of Psalms," or just "Psalms." Another possible title for this book is "Songs for Worship," which expresses the meaning of the term "psalms" as it applies to the songs in this book. Translators may use a title that expresses that meaning in their own language, or they may choose to transliterate the term "psalms," that is, to use that word and spell it the way it sounds in their own language.

Why were the songs in this book written?
The psalmists composed these songs for a variety of reasons. In some psalms, they expressed their praise to God. In other psalms, they asked God for help and expressed confidence in his love and power. In still others, they confessed their sins and begged for mercy. The Israelites wrote some psalms to ask Yahweh to defeat their enemies. Other psalms celebrated the event of a new king beginning his reign. They wrote some psalms to instruct people on how to be wise by honoring Yahweh and obeying his law. Pilgrims sang some of the psalms while traveling to Jerusalem to worship there. Psalms written for all of these reasons became songs that people sang to worship Yahweh at his temple. Many songs that people found especially meaningful and enjoyable to sing in temple worship were collected together into this book, which has become part of the Bible.

When were the songs in the book of Psalms written?
The psalms were written over a long period of time. Moses probably wrote the earliest psalm around 1400 B.C. David and Asaph wrote their psalms between 1020 and 975 B.C. The Korahites may have written their psalms before Jerusalem was destroyed and the Jews were exiled to Babylon in 587 B.C. Psalm 126 appears to come from the period after the exile, which ended in 538 B.C.

Why do some versions number the psalms differently from others?
From ancient times, people have numbered the psalms in different ways. The Jews numbered the psalms in Hebrew in one way. When the psalms were translated into Greek, they were numbered in a different way. Also, the people who compiled and transmitted the book of Psalms seem to have wanted a round number of 150 psalms, and they divided and combined individual psalms in order to achieve that total. This was done in different ways in different versions. For example, in the traditional Hebrew text, Psalms 42 and 43 are presented as separate psalms while Psalm 116 is presented as a single psalm. In the ancient Greek version, Psalms 42 and 43 are a single psalm and Psalm 116 is presented in parts as two different psalms. The Hebrew and Greek numbering and the divisions and combinations of some psalms were passed down through the centuries, and a variety of systems are in use today. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the system that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the system that the ULT uses.

Part 2: Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Book

Most of the psalms were written in one of a few basic forms that were common in ancient Hebrew songwriting. These forms allowed the biblical songwriters to structure a creative expression of the powerful emotions and intense spiritual sensations that arose from their deep experiences with God. Psalmists used specific forms for specific purposes.

Notes to individual psalms will suggest what form they use. (Some psalms combine or adapt the basic forms.) Recognizing from the form the type of situation that the psalmist was addressing will help translators understand and appreciate each psalm as

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a whole in order to translate it effectively into their language.

Psalms of supplication (laments)
The most common type of psalm in this collection is a plea for God's help in a time of trouble. About one third of the psalms fit this type. These are often called "psalms of supplication" or "laments." Many begin with a cry for help. The psalmist calls out to God, begging for rescue in urgent and emotional tones. The psalmist may then describe the troubles he is experiencing, but he may also make a statement of trust, expressing his confidence in God's goodness and power despite these difficulties. He may ask God to do something specific to help him. He may say that God should do this because he is innocent of any wrongdoing. He may promise to praise God publicly once he has received his help. Not every psalm of supplication has all of these elements, and the elements that are present may appear in a variety of orders. Nevertheless, in these psalms of supplication, there is a recognizable basic pattern of calling for help from a standpoint of trust.

Psalms of thanksgiving
People who had promised to praise God publicly for his help sang another kind of psalm in order to do that. Those psalms are often called "psalms of thanksgiving." They too are composed from a number of common elements. There may be an opening summary statement that God helped the psalmist when he was in trouble. The psalmist may call others to join him in praising God for this. He may describe the trouble he was in and state specifically that he asked God to help him. He may then depict, often through vivid imagery, how God helped him, and he may conclude with an expression of praise and thanks. Once again, not every psalm of thanksgiving has all of these elements, and the elements that are present may appear in a variety of orders, but a basic pattern is recognizable.

Psalms of praise
The third basic type of song in this book is often called a "psalm of praise." Its focus is not on the writer and his situation but on God and his worthiness to be worshiped. In a psalm of praise, the writer calls other people to worship God with him, and he gives reasons why they should do that. The essential dynamic of psalms of praise is alternation between calls to worship and reasons to worship (though some of them consist almost entirely of a call to worship). A reason to worship is typically introduced with the term "for." Psalm 47:5–6 say, for example, "Sing praise to our king, sing praise! For God is the king of all of the earth." One particular type of praise psalm is a "song of Zion," which celebrates Mount Zion and the city of Jerusalem and the temple there as the center of God's presence and rule over the earth.

Psalms of trust
A psalmist may sometimes expand one element of a basic form so that it fills all or most of a psalm. For example, psalmists who asked God for help often expressed their trust in him. Some psalms consist almost entirely of an expression of trust. The troubles of the psalmist may be dimly perceptible in the background, but these psalms are essentially calm, stately affirmations of reliance on God. They are therefore called "psalms of trust."

Penitential psalms
Sometimes a psalmist recognizes that the trouble that he is experiencing is the result of sin that he has committed. In addition to difficulties that are consequences of his sin or punishments for it, he is deeply troubled by guilt. He asks God to forgive him and restore him. Expressing sorrow for doing wrong is sometimes called "penitence," and so such psalms are sometimes called "penitential psalms." They are a specific kind of psalm of supplication.

Imprecatory psalms
Sometimes psalmists who are troubled by wicked enemies become concerned not only for their own survival but for God's reputation for upholding justice. If treacherous people succeed and prosper, others may question whether God is good and powerful enough to vindicate the righteous and punish the wicked. Those others may then choose to act wickedly themselves, and the entire society will become violent and corrupt. So a psalm of supplication for deliverance from enemies may include a call for God to destroy the wicked. That kind of request is sometimes called an "imprecation." When this call expands and becomes the major element of a composition, that psalm may be called an "imprecatory psalm." Christian readers of such psalms, knowing that Jesus told his followers to love their enemies, are often troubled by the call for God to destroy wicked people. It is important to appreciate that psalmist is not asking for revenge. He is asking God to demonstrate his justice.

Wisdom psalms
Some psalms make a practical application of the truth about God's justice. They teach their listeners about the two very different fates that await wicked people and righteous people. These psalms urge their audiences to cultivate wisdom (the ability to choose the right course in life) by fearing God, that is, by having great reverence for God and obeying him. While some wisdom psalms present their teaching within the

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framework of one of the basic types, other wisdom psalms are different. They are addressed to people, rather than to God, and they consist essentially of teaching rather than of supplication, thanksgiving, or praise. One type of psalm that is similar to a wisdom psalm depicts God assembling and addressing the Israelites, commending those who are faithfully obeying his covenant but warning those who are acting wickedly.

Royal psalms

God's power and goodness can be questioned in a psalm of supplication, vindicated in a psalm of thanksgiving, and celebrated in a psalm of praise. Some praise psalms celebrate how God is enthroned as king above all the earth and how, from that position of authority, he exercises his power on behalf of justice and helps needy people. The description of God's enthronement as a reason to worship can expand to fill an entire psalm of praise. When it does, the psalm may be known as a "divine enthronement psalm" or "royal psalm." Another type of royal psalm is a prayer for God to help the Israelite king uphold justice and help needy people as God's representative on earth. This type of royal psalm, a specific kind of psalm of supplication, may also ask God to defeat the king's foreign enemies so that he can continue to rule. Some such psalms celebrate the occasion of a new king beginning his rule.

Styles of psalms

The background information that the book of Psalms provides about many of the songs in this collection (see the discussion of "superscriptions" in Part 3 of this introduction) sometimes includes a description of the style of a psalm.

In several cases, a psalm is identified as a "maskil." Biblical scholars have different understandings of what that term means. Some say it means "to instruct," while others say that the word refers to the skill used in creating the psalm. Still others think it means that meditation should be used in reading this psalm. Since the meaning is not certain, in your translation, you may wish to represent this word in its Hebrew form, as the ULT and UST do, and spell it the way it sounds in your language.

In several other cases, a psalm is identified as a "miktam." The exact meaning of this term is also uncertain. Some scholars think it may refer to a kind of writing or musical style, while others suggest it describes the psalm's tone or purpose. It may mean that a psalm is a prayer for protection or a song of confidence. Since the meaning is not certain, you may wish to represent this word as well in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language.

Fifteen short psalms, collected together as Psalms 120–134, are each called a "song of ascents." Most interpreters understand this title to mean that they were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for the great festivals of Passover, Pentecost, and Tabernacles. (The term "ascents" is used because going up to Jerusalem involved a climb of about 3,000 feet up Mount Zion.) These songs are written in a variety of forms, and while many of them refer directly to the journey and the festivals, they also speak about a broad range of other experiences. So this description refers as much to the occasion of these psalms as their style, although they are generally short and communal.

Several of the psalms follow a pattern in which the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet begin each poetic line, each half-line, every second line, or even every eight lines in a row. This pattern is known as an "acrostic," from a Greek term that describes the start of a line of poetry. The alphabetic pattern may be used as an aid to memory, and it may also depict a composition as speaking comprehensively about a subject. The background information that the book of Psalms provides does not identify these psalms as having been written in this style, since this would have been obvious to the original Hebrew audience, but notes to these psalms will identify them as acrostics.

Part 3: Translation Issues in This Book

How should translators represent the poetry in the book of Psalms?

The psalms, as the words to songs, are poetry. Hebrew poetry was based on the repetition of ideas. Typically the first part of a line would say something, and the second part of that line would repeat the same idea in different words. (In some cases, the second part of a line may elaborate on the idea in the first part or state something contrasting.) Translation teams must decide how to represent the lines in which both parts express the same idea. Readers may think that the psalmist is saying something different in the second part of the line but not be able to figure out what that is, since the psalmist is actually not doing that. So one approach is to combine the two parts into a single statement of the idea. However, to show readers the character of Hebrew poetry, it may be preferable to include both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. (This can be valuable in many cases because the second part, while restating the idea, often advances or intensifies it in some way.) Often the term "and" connects the two parts, and it may

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be clearer in your language to connect them with a different term in order to show that the second part of the line is repeating the idea in the first part, not saying something different. For example, Psalm 19:1 says, "The heavens are declaring the glory of God, and the sky is proclaiming the work of his hands." A translation might say, "The heavens are declaring the glory of God; indeed, the sky is proclaiming the work of his hands."

Translation teams must also decide whether to try to represent the poetry in the Psalms in a poetic form that is characteristic of their own language. This is often difficult to do, since poetic forms vary so much from one language to another. Unless poetry in the translators' language happens to be very similar to Hebrew poetry, a common approach is to represent the psalms as prose, that is, as ordinary language, but to format them in a way that shows they are poetry in the original language. The ULT and UST do that by setting each line farther to the right on the page than regular text. They indent the second part of a line (and a third part, if there is one) farther to the right than the first part of the line. Translators may have conventions in their own languages and cultures that will allow them to translate the psalms as ordinary language but display them as poetry.

However translation teams decide to represent the poetry in the Psalms, it is valuable to retain the images that the psalmists use, such as God being like a shepherd or like a huge rock. These images reflect the original cultural and historical context of the Bible, which is helpful background for readers to have in order to understand what the Bible is saying. In many cases the images are used in various parts of the Bible with similar meaning but significant shades of difference, and it is helpful for readers to see how the biblical writers are using images in these different ways. So if an image communicates well in your language, please use it in your translation. If not, consider expressing it as a comparison. For example, for the statement in Psalm 23:1, "Yahweh is my shepherd," you might say, "Yahweh cares for me as a shepherd cares for his sheep." For the statement in Psalm 18:2, "Yahweh is my rock," you might say, "Yahweh to me is like a high rock that I can climb up to reach safety from danger."

How should translators represent the introductions that many psalms have?

In many cases, information about a psalm is provided before the beginning of the psalm. This information is sometimes called a "superscription." That term describes something that is written above something else.

Some versions do not give verse numbers to the superscriptions, while other versions do. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to do what it does. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to do what the ULT does. Whether or not translators give the superscriptions in the Psalms verse numbers, they should consider them as part of the divinely inspired biblical text. They may wish to use special formatting to show that they are not part of the original composition of the psalm. The ULT does this by putting them in italics.

Translators should use care in translating the phrases in superscriptions that associate a psalm with a person. For example, about half of the psalms are called a "psalm of David" or simply "Of David." This may mean that King David wrote them. However, it could also mean that someone else wrote the psalm for David, or that the psalm was written in the same style that David used when he wrote songs. Translators can be more confident that this expression means that David wrote the psalm when the superscription describes a historical situation in David's life as the occasion of its composition. The UST models various ways to translate the phrases that associate a psalm with a person, sometimes with expressions that could allow a range of meanings ("A psalm of David") and sometimes with more specific expressions ("David wrote this psalm when ...").

Some superscriptions give instructions about how a psalm should be played and sung. They may tell which instruments, singers, or melodies should be used for that psalm. The superscriptions to about a third of the psalms indicate that they are "for the chief musician." This suggests that while they were originally composed in a variety of life situations, they have been collected for use in temple worship. The ULT and UST model how the technical terms in the superscription about performance can be translated in either a form-based or meaning-based way.

Some biblical scholars suggest that these musical instructions apply to the previous psalm rather than to the psalm that immediately follows them. For example, the current superscription to Psalm 4 reads, "For the director, with stringed instruments. Of David." The phrases "For the chief musician; with stringed instruments" may belong at the end of Psalm 3, so that the superscription to Psalm 4 would be just "Of David." Similarly, the superscription to Psalm 5 may be just "A psalm of David," and the musical instructions "For the chief musician; on the flutes" may belong at the

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end of Psalm 4. This suggestion is a matter of ongoing scholarly debate, and Bible publishers have so far not adopted it, so these resources treat the entire traditional superscriptions as applying to the psalms that immediately follow them. However, you may wish to consider the merits of this suggestion and make your own decision about it as a translation team.

"Selah" and "Higgaion"
The terms "Selah" and "Higgaion" occur within many psalms. They seem to be musical terms inserted as directions for singers and musicians. Scholars do not agree as to their exact meaning. For this reason, rather than try to translate them, translators may decide to include the Hebrew words and spell them the way they sound in their language or leave them out.

How should translators represent passages in the psalms that look forward to the Messiah?
New Testament writers quote many passages from the psalms as prophecies about the Messiah, Jesus Christ. The psalms that contain these prophecies are therefore sometimes called "Messianic psalms." In translating them, translators should take care not to limit the potential meaning only to the original writer. For example, David says in Psalm 16:10, "You will not hand over your godly one to see the pit." In speaking to Yahweh, he is referring initially to himself in the third person as "your godly one." In some languages, a speaker would not refer to himself in the third person in this way, and translators of the Bible into those languages might ordinarily use an expression such as "me, your godly one." However, Peter cites this statement in Acts 2:27 as a prophecy of the Messiah. So it would be preferable to translate the phrase "your godly one" with a phrase such as "any godly person who belongs to you."

"shall"
The ULT represents the Hebrew instructional verb form with the English helping verb "shall." For example, when Yahweh said, as quoted by Asaph in 81:9, "There shall not be a strange god among you." he was instructing the Israelites how to act. Other ways to say this are "You are not to have a strange god among you," "You should not have a strange god among you" "I want you not to have a strange god among you," or "Do not have a strange god among you." Translate this form with the most natural way in your language for giving instructions.

"let" and "may"
The ULT uses the English helping verbs "let" and "may" to show that a speaker is expressing a desire that something happen or that someone do something. It uses the verb "let" for more assertive expressions, and it uses the verb "may" for more deferential expressions. For example, when David says in 69:34 "Let the heavens and the earth praise him," he means "I want the heavens and the earth to praise him." Languages that do not have a volitional form might say "The heavens and earth ought to praise him," or they might use an imperative, "Praise him, heavens and earth!" When David says in 70:5 "Yahweh, may you not delay," he is being more deferential, even though his wish is urgent, because he is addressing a superior. Languages that do not have a volitional form might say "Yahweh, I desire that you do not delay," or they might use an imperative with an indication that it is a polite request, "Yahweh, please do not delay." Translate this volitional form in the most natural way in your language to indicate that the speaker is expressing what he wants someone to do or what he wishes someone would do.

"your God," "my God," and "our God"
Throughout this book, the psalmist refers to Yahweh with possessive forms such as "your God," "my God," and "our God." By using these possessive forms, he is not saying that the Israelites possess or control Yahweh. Rather he is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom the Israelites worship. Also, when the psalmist says, "your God," he is referring to the same God that he also worships. He is not distinguishing between the God of the Israelites and his own God.

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Structure and Formatting

Psalm 1 is usually considered to be a "wisdom psalm," which gives advice to those who hear it read or sung.

1. The happy: Those devoted to Yahweh's instruction prosper (1–3)
2. The unhappy: Those who reject Yahweh's instruction come to nothing (4–5)
3. Authority: Yahweh directs each path to its destination (6)

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: to celebrate the one who follows Yahweh's guidance
2. Content: It is the one who delights in Yahweh's guidance who is "happy." All of this is because Yahweh cares for righteous people, but wicked people keep sinning until Yahweh destroys them forever. (6)

3. Message: Devotion to Yahweh's guidance leads to success and honor.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. Words associated (whether by sound or by meaning) with a journey appear throughout the psalm.
2. In Hebrew, in the word "wicked" the consonant sounds in "happy" are reversed.
3. Verses 1 and 5 have a number of correspondences with one another. There are negated clauses in both verses, and both contain motion verbs. Additionally, the phrase "advice of the wicked" in verse 1a is similar to the phrase "congregation of the righteous" in verse 5b. The phrases also have similar structure. In Hebrew the words for "advice" and "congregation" sound very similar. See: Poetry
4. The psalm begins and ends with the metaphor of a journey.
5. There is agricultural imagery which is frequent in scripture: a tree by water (representing flourishing through God's blessing) and separating wheat from chaff (representing the different judgments of the righteous and wicked). See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

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Significant portions of the ULT, UST, and TNs for this psalm are derivative from "Psalms, Layer by Layer" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Welcome), "Psalm 1" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Psalm_1) by Cambridge Digital Bible Research, Katie Frost, Meaghan Smith, Nikki Mustin et al, used under CC BY

Psalms 1:1 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

"The happinesses of"

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, what constitutes true happiness from God's perspective. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 1:1 (#2)

אַשְׁרֵי־הָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר ׀ לֹא הָלַךְ בַּעֲצַת רְשָׁעִים וּבְדֶרֶךְ חַטָּאִים לֹא עָמָד וּבְמוֹשַׁב לֵצִים לֹא יָשָׁב

"The happinesses of the man who walks not in the advice of the wicked, and stands not in the pathway of sinners, and sits not in the seat of scoffers"

In some languages it may be more natural to place the declaration of the state of the man at the end of the verse after the description of the characteristics that he avoids. However, starting the psalm with the **happinesses of the man** was an intentional poetic decision by the author, who intended to set the mood of the psalm. Translators should consider how their language might start the psalm in this way. Alternate translation: [The man who does not walk in the advice of the wicked ones, and stands not in the pathway with sinners, and sits not in the seat of mockers is happy.]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 1:1 (#3)

הָאִישׁ

"the man"

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [any man] or [a person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 1:1 (#4)

לֹא הָלַךְ בַּעֲצַת רְשָׁעִים

"walks not in the advice of the wicked"

Here, **walks** refers to a man doing the things that **the wicked** suggest. This is the beginning of a pattern of doing wrong. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the comparison. Alternate translation: [does not walk into sin that wicked people suggest] or [never does what wicked people suggest]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 1:1 (#5)

רְשָׁעִים

"the wicked"

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 1:1 (#6)

לֹא הָלַךְ֨ בַּעֲצַ֪ת רְשָׁעִ֡ים וּבְדֶ֣רֶךְ חַטָּאִ֣ים לֹ֭א עָמָ֑ד וּבְמוֹשַׁ֖ב לֵ֣צִים לֹ֣א יָשָֽׁב

“walks not in the advice of the wicked, and stands not in the pathway of sinners, and sits not in the seat of scoffers”

It may be helpful to read these three phrases in an inverted way. That way the negative trajectory that the happy man avoids can be more clearly seen. Consider: “Unhappy is the man who walks in the advice of the wicked ones and then who stands in the pathway of sinners and then who sits in the seat of scoffers.” The meaning of each of these parts of this extended metaphor is expanded in later notes, but translators should see a trajectory of worsening character that a happy man avoids.

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 1:1 (#7)

וּבְדֶ֣רֶךְ חַטָּאִ֣ים לֹ֭א עָמָ֑ד

“and stands not in the pathway of sinners”

Here, **stands not in the pathway of sinners** refers to not copying how sinners continually live their lives, that is, their sinful habits. Standing means joining with sinners. The **pathway** means how a person lives his life. Not only does the happy man not do what the wicked say but he habitually avoids doing what sinners do. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the comparison. Alternate translation: [and does not stand with sinners in the path of sinning] or [and does not make sinning a habit]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 1:1 (#8)

חַטָּאִ֣ים

“sinners”

The psalmist is using the adjective **sinners** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [sinful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 1:1 (#9)

וּבְמוֹשַׁ֖ב לֵ֣צִים לֹ֣א יָשָֽׁב

“and sits not in the seat of scoffers”

Here, **sits not in the seat of scoffers** means to not become like people who spend their time mocking people, things, and God. By avoiding the previous two progressions towards a sinful life, the happy man avoids this final state where he would be just like the wicked. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the comparison. Alternate translation: [and does not sit with scoffers to join them in scoffing] or [so he never becomes like wicked mockers]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 1:2 (#1)

כִּ֤י אִם

“but”

The psalmist uses the word **but** here to indicate a strong contrast between what the happy man does and does not do. In your translation, indicate this strong contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Rather,]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 1:2 (#2)

בְּתוֹרַ֣ת & וּבְתוֹרָתֹ֣ו

“in the instruction of & and in his instruction”

Alternate translation: [in the instruction of ... and in his instruction]

Psalms 1:2 (#3)

חֶפְצ֑וֹ & יֶהְגֶּ֥ה

“is} his delight & he meditates”

Here, **his** and **he** refer to the happy man.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 1:2 (#4)

חֶפְצ֑וֹ

“is} his delight”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **delight**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he delights] or [he rejoices]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 1:2 (#5)

וּבְתוֹרָתֹ֣ו

“and in his instruction”

Here, **his** refers to Yahweh. Alternate translation: [and in Yahweh's instruction]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 1:2 (#6)

יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה

"day and night"

Here the psalmist is referring to all the time by naming two major components, **day and night**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [round-the-clock] or [all the time]

See: Merism

Psalms 1:3 (#1)

וְהָיָה֮ כְּעֵ֪ץ שָׁתוּל֮ עַל־פַּלְגֵ֪י מָ֫יִם אֲשֶׁ֤ר פִּרְי֨וֹ ׀ יִתֵּ֬ן בְּעִתּ֗וֹ וְעָלֵ֥הוּ לֹא־יִבּ֑וֹל וְכֹ֥ל אֲשֶׁר־יַ֝עֲשֶׂ֗ה יַצְלִֽיחַ

"And he is like a tree set to grow by streams of water, which gives its fruit in its season, and its leaf does not wither, and he makes successful all that he does"

The point of this verse's comparison between the happy man and a well-watered tree is that just like the streams of water cause the tree to flourish, learning Yahweh's instructions causes the man to flourish. (In the original, the phrases even sound similar.) Both a positive and negative comparison are given to strengthen the force of the point. The tree, fruit, and leaf references connect both back to Eden and forward to the end of Revelation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the argument a little more explicit as the "Like ... so" connection does in the UST. See 92:12–92:14 for another use of this imagery.

See: Simile

Psalms 1:3 (#2)

שָׁתוּל

"set to grow"

The point of the choice of the word **set** is to emphasize the intentional placement of a tree so that it gets abundant water. The word translated as **set to grow** refers to intentional planting or transplanting. Translators could use a word meaning "planted" if their readers would understand that this was intentional. Alternate translation: [deliberately planted] or [transplanted]

Psalms 1:3 (#3)

שָׁתוּל

"set to grow"

The expression **set to grow** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that someone set to grow]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 1:3 (#4)

וְעָלֵ֥הוּ לֹא־יִבּ֑וֹל

"and its leaf does not wither"

The psalmist is referring figuratively to the tree dying by association with the way the leaves on a tree **wither** when a tree is dead or dying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and it will not die]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 1:3 (#5)

וְעָלֵ֥הוּ לֹא־יִבּ֑וֹל

"and its leaf does not wither"

Here the psalmist is emphasizing a strong positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with a word that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [and its leaves are strong and green]

See: Litotes

Psalms 1:3 (#6)

וְכֹ֥ל אֲשֶׁר־יַ֝עֲשֶׂ֗ה יַצְלִֽיחַ

"and he makes successful all that he does"

Here, both instances of **he** refer to the happy man.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 1:4 (#1)

לֹא־כֵ֫ן

"Not so"

The **so** here refers to everything in the first three verses. The wicked are not in any way like the happy man. If your language has a way to indicate that **so** refers back not just to the last line about success but

to the wider context of the first three verses, consider using it.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 1:4 (#2)

הָרְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 1:4 (#3)

כַּמֹּץ

“they are} like & chaff”

The word **chaff** refers to the parts of a wheat or other grain plant that are not food. The husk that surrounds the edible seed is very light, and it blows away when the wheat is threshed to separate out the edible seed. Thus, the chaff is with the grain until harvest but then separated and blown away. If your readers would not be familiar with the word **chaff** you could use a more general term or use another light and worthless material to describe the wicked. Alternate translation: [they are like ... dried seed husks] or [they are like ... fallen]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 1:4 (#4)

כִּי אִם־כַּמֹּץ אֲשֶׁר־תִּדְּפֶנּוּ רוּחַ

“But {they are} like the chaff that wind chases away”

The idea of **the wicked** as waste material gathered at the harvest and eliminated in some way is a common biblical image of God judging the wicked. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 1:5 (#1)

עַל־כֵּן

“Thus”

Thus indicates that the connection between the previous statements and this is one of similarity. Just like the chaff is removed from the good harvest and destroyed, thus the wicked will be removed from Yahweh’s righteous people and destroyed. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [In the same way,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 1:5 (#2)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 1:5 (#3)

לֹא־יָקֻמוּ רְשָׁעִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט

“the wicked will not stand in the judgment”

The psalmist is using **stand in the judgment** as a common expression of his culture to mean to be declared innocent. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the wicked ones will not get off the hook] or [the wicked ones will not be found innocent]

See: Idiom

Psalms 1:5 (#4)

בַּמִּשְׁפָּט

“in the judgment”

This refers to the time when Yahweh will finally judge the whole world. If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in Yahweh’s final court]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 1:5 (#5)

וְחַטָּאִים

“nor sinners”

See how you translated **sinners** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 1:5 (#6)

וְחַטָּאִים

“nor sinners”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [nor will sinners stand]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 1:5 (#7)

צַדִּיקִֽים

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 1:6 (#1)

כִּֽי־יוֹדֵ֣עַ יְ֭הוָה דֶּ֣רֶךְ

“For Yahweh knows the way of”

Here, **knows the way of** is a common expression of the culture that refers to Yahweh’s intimate and active involvement in the life of the righteous. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh cares for the needs of]

See: Idiom

Psalms 1:6 (#2)

כִּ֣י

“For”

For here introduces an explanation of the contrast throughout this psalm. If possible, use a connector here that can refer back to more than just the immediate context.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 1:6 (#3)

צַדִּיקִ֑ים

“the righteous”

See how you translated the phrase **the righteous** in the previous verse.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 1:6 (#4)

דֶּ֣רֶךְ צַדִּיקִ֑ים וְדֶ֖רֶךְ רְשָׁעִ֣ים תֹּאבֵֽד

“the way of the righteous, but the way of the wicked will perish”

The psalmist is speaking of how a person lives or lifestyle as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the lifestyle of the righteous, but the lifestyle of those who are wicked causes them to perish]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 2 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 2 is usually considered a royal psalm because it is about the king.

1. Rebellion: Earthly kings plot rebellion (1–3)
2. Response: The Heavenly King laughs (4–6)
3. Decree: The King on Zion recounts Yahweh’s covenant (7–9)
4. Ultimatum: Earthly kings, “Serve Yahweh … Kiss the son!” (10–12)

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: It was probably first sung when a new person became the king.
2. Content: While there are (from the perspective of the New Testament) clear references to Jesus, the Anointed (Messiah) Son of God (Yahweh), translators should avoid bringing this fuller understanding into the translation of this psalm, which was written around 1,000 years before Christ.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. The place of reference moves between things being on earth (2), in heaven (4), on the mountain (often seen as a meeting place between heaven and earth) (6), and on earth again (10).
2. The rebellious words in verse 3 are echoed by similar sounding but very contrastive (obedient) words in verses 10–12.
3. The word for son in verse 12 is highlighted by being Aramaic rather than Hebrew and having several occurrences of similar sounding consonant groups near it. See: Poetry
4. Nations are personified.

5. Yahweh's rule is pictured as physical bonds.
6. Power is figured as an iron rod.
7. Nations are figured as pottery.

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Psalms 2:1 (#1)

לָ֤מָּה רָגְשׁ֨וּ גוֹיִ֪ם וּלְאֻמִּ֡ים יֶהְגּ֬וּ־רִ֗יק

"Why do nations conspire and peoples plot futilely"

The proper understanding of the questions that make up this verse is provided in verses 4 and those that follow. They are not true questions; they are statements of mocking disbelief. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Nations are in turmoil and peoples are complaining uselessly.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 2:1 (#2)

גּוֹיִם

"nations"

Here, **nations** represents either the people of the nations or the leaders of the nations. If **nations** could not be understood to **conspire**, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. However, it is best to not narrow the meaning to leaders yet, as the psalm will do that in the next verse. Alternate translation: [people from other nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 2:1 (#3)

What the **nations** are conspiring and the **peoples** are plotting is not mentioned in this verse, but since it becomes clear from the next two verses, you do not need to explain its meaning further here.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 2:2 (#1)

יִתְיַצְּב֤וּ ׀ מַלְכֵי־אֶ֡רֶץ וְרוֹזְנִ֗ים נוֹסְדוּ־יָ֥חַד

"The kings of the earth take their stand, and the rulers conspire together"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [The kings of the earth take their stand; indeed, the rulers conspire together]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 2:3 (#1)

נְנַתְּקָ֥ה אֶת־מוֹסְרוֹתֵ֑ימוֹ וְנַשְׁלִ֖יכָה מִמֶּ֣נּוּ עֲבֹתֵימוֹ

"Let us tear apart their bonds and cast their cords away from us"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Let us tear apart their bonds; truly, let us cast their cords away from us.]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 2:3 (#2)

נְנַתְּקָ֥ה אֶת־מוֹסְרוֹתֵ֑ימוֹ וְנַשְׁלִ֖יכָה מִמֶּ֣נּוּ עֲבֹתֵימוֹ

"Let us tear apart their bonds and cast their cords away from us"

The people of other nations speak of Yahweh and his anointed one's rule over them as if it were **bonds** and **cords**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We should free ourselves from their control; we should not let them rule over us any longer]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 2:4 (#1)

יוֹשֵׁ֣ב בַּשָּׁמַ֣יִם יִשְׂחָ֑ק אֲדֹנָ֖י יִלְעַג־לָֽמוֹ

“He who is sitting in the heavens laughs; the Lord mocks them”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He who sits in the heavens sneers; indeed, the Lord mocks them.]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 2:4 (#2)

יוֹשֵׁ֣ב

“He who is sitting”

The psalmist is referring specifically to God **sitting** on his throne, and he is using that action to represent God ruling. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [He who is enthroned] or [He who rules]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 2:5 (#1)

בְּאַפּ֑וֹ וּבַחֲרוֹנ֥וֹ

“in his anger and & in his fury”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **anger** and **fury**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [when he is angry and ... with how furious he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 2:6 (#1)

וַ֭אֲנִי נָסַ֣כְתִּי מַלְכִּ֑י עַל־צִ֝יּ֗וֹן הַר־קָדְשִֽׁי

“I, I have poured out my king on Zion, the mountain of my holiness”

This verse is a quotation of Yahweh (who is mentioned before this verse as the Lord who is sitting in the heavens). If the speaker would be unclear, you may want to introduce him as the UST does.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 2:6 (#2)

וַ֭אֲנִי נָסַ֣כְתִּי

“I, I have poured out”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will cut** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize how significant it was that it was he and not someone else who was setting up this king on Zion. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I alone have poured out]

See: Reflexive Pronouns

Psalms 2:6 (#3)

נָסַ֣כְתִּי

“I have poured out”

Scholars debate the meaning of this verb. However, all the options lead either symbolically or literally to the idea that Yahweh has made his king the ruler on Zion. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have installed] or [I have placed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 2:7 (#1)

אֲסַפְּרָ֥ה אֶ֝֗ל חֹ֣ק יְהוָ֑ה

“I will describe a decree of Yahweh”

The person saying this is the king that Yahweh placed in Zion. This is a change of speaker from the previous verse, though both are unmarked in the original. You can include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The king says he will describe a decree of Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 2:8 (#1)

נַחֲלָתֶ֑ךָ וַ֝אֲחֻזָּתְךָ֗

“as} your inheritance and & as} your possession”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **inheritance** and **possession**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [for you to inherit and ... you shall possess]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 2:8 (#2)

אַפְסֵי־אָ֥רֶץ

“the extremities of the earth”

Here, **the extremities of the earth** is referring to all of the world by naming its edges or limits. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the entire world]

See: Merism

Psalms 2:9 (#1)

תְּנַפְּצֵם

"You will break them with an iron rod; like a jar of a potter, you will smash them to pieces"

Here the king is speaking of his own power and anger as if it was an **iron rod** and of nations as if they were a **jar of a potter**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning another way. Alternate translation: [Your power is like an iron rod, which will shatter the nations, which are like mere clay pots.]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 2:9 (#2)

תְּנַפְּצֵם

"like a jar of a potter, you will smash them to pieces"

Using a simile in the second clause is a way to intensify the statement in biblical poetry. Use a method in your language's poetic forms to intensify the second clause if possible. Alternate translation: [more than that, you will smash them to pieces like a jar of a potter]

See: Poetry

Psalms 2:9 (#3)

כִּכְלִי יוֹצֵר

"like a jar of a potter"

A **potter** is a person who makes clay pots and jars. These are fragile and can be broken easily. If your readers would not be familiar with this, you could use the name of something similar in your area or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [like a clay jar]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 2:10 (#1)

הִוָּסְרוּ

"be admonished"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [listen to this warning]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 2:11 (#1)

בִּירְאָה וְגִילוּ בִּרְעָדָה

"with fear and rejoice with trembling"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **fear** and **rejoice**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [fearfully, and joyfully tremble]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 2:12 (#1)

נַשְּׁקוּ־בַר

"Kiss the son"

To **kiss the son** is a symbolic action showing loyalty and pledged obedience. If this would not be clear to your readers, you can explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. People would show their king that they were loyal to him by kissing him, perhaps on the feet. Alternate translation: [Show the son that you are truly loyal to him] or [Bow down humbly before his son]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 2:12 (#2)

וְתֹאבְדוּ דָּרֶךְ

"and you perish in the way"

The implication is that the **son** will kill you if you are not loyal to him. You can include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and he kill you in the way]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 2:12 (#3)

כִּי־יִבְעַר כִּמְעַט אַפּוֹ

"for his anger burns for just a moment"

The anger of the **son** is spoken of as if it were a fire that **burns**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when he suddenly becomes very angry]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 2:12 (#4)

אַשְׁרֵי כָּל־חוֹסֵי בּוֹ

“The happinesses of all the seekers of refuge in him”

The protection that submitting to the **son** provides is spoken of as if the son himself were a safe place or **refuge** within which people could be protected. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Everyone who asks the king to protect them is happy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 2:12 (#5)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy are]

See: Exclamations

Psalms - Chapter 3 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Foes “rising” against psalmist (1–2)
2. Trust expressed to Yahweh (on his holy hill, see 2:6) (3–4)
3. Trust in Yahweh proclaimed (5–6)
4. Help petitioned from Yahweh (“rising” and saving refer back to 1–2) (7–8)

See 2 Samuel 15–18 for the story of David fleeing from Absalom.

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: to pray for salvation from enemies
2. Content: Yahweh, save me! My enemies are many, but you are my defense.
3. Message: Salvation is of Yahweh

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. The psalm divides into four sections that are nearly the same length (14 words / 14 words / 14 words / 15 words).
2. The second and third sections share similar beginnings; both begin with an independent personal pronoun (3a: “you;” 5a: “I”). “You” (=Yahweh) is the topic of the second section (3–4), and “I” (=David) is the topic of the third section (5–6).
3. The first section (1–2) and the two middle sections (3–6) are connected by the ideas of “many/multitudes ... against me.” See: Poetry
4. Yahweh is pictured as a shield.
5. Safety is pictured as sleeping.
6. Yahweh’s salvation from enemies is pictured in violent graphic language.
7. Wicked people’s power is represented by their teeth.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

1. Selah: This psalm contains the first instances of the Hebrew word “Selah.” Refer to the introduction to Psalms for more information.
2. Superscriptions: This psalm is the first one which starts with a superscription. Refer to the introduction to Psalms for more information.

Psalms 3:0 (#2)

לְדָוִד

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לְדָוִד”

This could mean: (1) David wrote the psalm or (2) the psalm is about David or (3) the psalm is in the style of David’s psalms.

Psalms 3:1 (#1)

יְהוָה מָה־רַבּוּ צָרָי

“Yahweh, how many my oppressors have become”

The word **how** marks this as an emotional outburst that is emphasizing to Yahweh how very desperate the author’s situation is. Use an exclamation that would communicate that meaning in your language. Alternate translation: [Oh Yahweh, I have so many enemies]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 3:1 (#2)

קָמִים עָלָי

“The risers against me”

Here, **risers against me** is an common expression that means “people who rebel against me” or “people who wish to fight me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, use an expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Those getting in my face] or [Those who rebel against me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 3:2 (#1)

אֵין יְשׁוּעָתָה לֹּו בֵּאלֹהִים

“There is no salvation for him in God”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Surely God will not save him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 3:2 (#2)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

This is the first instance of the Hebrew word **Selah**, the meaning of which is unknown. The ancient Greek translation uses a term that means “musical interlude.” Your translation team should decide if you will (1) spell this word to reflect its Hebrew form, “Selah,” or (2) omit “Selah” or (3) translate with a word meaning something like “musical interlude” or “pause” in your language.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 3:3 (#1)

מָגֵן בַּעֲדִי

“are a shield round about me”

Here, **shield** represents protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are my protection]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 3:3 (#2)

כְּבוֹדִי

“my glory”

Because Yahweh is the actor in all the other actions in this verse, calling **Yahweh** his **glory** probably means that Yahweh gives the psalmist glory or honor. Since the psalmist has just spoken about his enemies and about Yahweh being his protector, he probably means that Yahweh gives him glory by giving him victory over his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who gives me glory] or [the one who gives me victory]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 3:3 (#3)

וּמֵרִים רֹאשִׁי

“and the lifter up of my head”

Lifting the author’s **head** could mean (1) giving him courage or (2) giving him victory over his enemies or (3) restoring him to being king of Israel (given the context of David fleeing from his son’s usurping). If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the one who encourages me] or [and the one who lifts me over my enemies] or [and the one who lifts me to the throne]

See: Idiom

Psalms 3:4 (#1)

אֶקְרָא וַיַּעֲנֵנִי

“I call & and he answered me”

The implication is that the psalmist is calling to Yahweh for help and that Yahweh’s answer takes the form of giving help. You can include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I call for help … and he helped me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 3:5 (#1)

אֲנִי שָׁכַבְתִּי וָאִישָׁנָה הֱקִיצוֹתִי כִּי יְהוָה יִסְמָכֵנִי

“I laid myself down and slept. I awoke, for Yahweh protects me”

The phrase **laid myself down and slept** is not a one-time occurrence but a universal statement about his daily peace because of Yahweh. If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases since the second phrase, **for Yahweh protects me**, gives the reason for the result, **I awoke** as well as the reason for the author’s confidence that he can lie down and sleep. Alternate translation: [Because Yahweh protects me, I lie down, sleep, and awake]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 3:6 (#1)

לֹא־אִירָא

“I will not fear”

The psalmist does **not fear** because of Yahweh's protection, mentioned in verse 5. Be sure that connection is clear in your language.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 3:7 (#1)

קוּמָה

"Rise up"

The psalmist is using **rise up** as a common expression of the culture to ask Yahweh to take action. He is not telling him to get out of bed or stand up from a seated position. If this expression does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take action] or [Do something]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 3:7 (#2)

אֱלֹהַי

"my God"

The psalmist is not using the phrase **my God** to mean that he possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God he worships. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion. Alternate translation: [oh God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 3:7 (#3)

הִכִּיתָ אֶת־כָּל־אֹיְבַי לֶחִי שִׁנֵּי רְשָׁעִים שִׁבַּרְתָּ

"you hit all my enemies on the cheek; the teeth of the wicked you break"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. Translate these phrases according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. See the Introduction to Psalms (../front/intro.md) for more information. The phrases **my enemies** and **the wicked** refer to the same group of people. Alternate translation: [you hit all my enemies on the jaw; you even break those wicked enemies' teeth] or [you destroy all my enemies]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 3:7 (#4)

הִכִּיתָ אֶת־כָּל־אֹיְבַי לֶחִי

"you hit all my enemies on the cheek"

Hitting an enemy on the cheek was a way of insulting people. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [you will insult all my enemies like someone hitting them on the jaw]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 3:7 (#5)

שִׁנֵּי רְשָׁעִים שִׁבַּרְתָּ

"the teeth of the wicked you break"

Animals attack with their teeth. Breaking their teeth takes away their power to attack. David speaks as if Yahweh would come and physically fight against the wicked. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you make the wicked unable to harm me like someone breaking the teeth of a ferocious animal]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 3:7 (#6)

רְשָׁעִים

"the wicked"

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 3:8 (#1)

לַיהוָה הַיְשׁוּעָה

"Salvation {is} of Yahweh"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. The meaning of this phrase is that Yahweh is characterized by saving his people. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is the savior] or [Yahweh saves his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 3:8 (#2)

עַל־עַמְּךָ בִרְכָתֶךָ

"Your blessing {is} on your people"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **blessing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Please bless your people] or [You always bless your people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 4 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Distress (1)
2. Rebuke (2–6)
3. Blessing (7–8)

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: to intercede for the people and call them to repentance
2. Content: People, trust in Yahweh alone! He has relieved our suffering in the past, and he will help us again when I call to him. Yahweh, shine on us!
3. Message: Yahweh alone gives peace and security in times of distress.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. Features between verses 1, 6, and 8. See the note in verse 6.
2. Hebrew roots from verse 5 repeat in verses 7–9. See the note in verse 5.
3. There seems to be a morning and night pattern. The word translated **call** in verses 1 and 3 sound like the Hebrew word for morning, and then bed is mentioned in verse 4. Yahweh lifting up the light of his face is like the dawn in verse 6 and in verse 8 the psalmist lies down to sleep.
4. The last verse of the psalm seems to wind down peacefully, even repeating "s" sounds. See the note in verse 8.

See: Poetry

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Psalms 4:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 4:1 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵי צִדְקִי

"God of my righteousness"

Here **God of my righteousness** could mean: (1) my righteous God or (2) God who vindicates me. Both options are grammatically possible, and both fit the context well. The following relative clause (verse 1b), which highlights God's past faithfulness, may suggest that it is God's righteousness that is in view (hence the UST rendering). You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Possession

Psalms 4:1 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵי צִדְקִי

"God of my righteousness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my God, the righteous one]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 4:1 (#3)

בַּצָּר

"in distress"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. The original word is related to narrowness. Alternate translation: [in trouble] or [when I am oppressed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 4:2 (#1)

בְּנֵי אִישׁ

"Son of man"

Son of man could refer to: (1) the mortality and finitude of his enemies (as opposed to God's eternal infinitude), (2) important or wealthy men, or (3) the fact that the psalmist is now addressing people rather than God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You men]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 4:2 (#2)

עַד־מָתַי כְּבוֹדִי לִכְלִמָּה תְּאֶהָבוּן רִיק תְּבַקְשׁוּ כָזָב

“until when {will} my glory become shame? {Until when} will you love futility, {until when} will you seek falsehood”

The psalmist is using the question form to rebuke his enemies. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate these three questions as statements or exclamations. Alternate translation: [stop calling glory shame! Stop loving futility! Stop seeking falsehood!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 4:2 (#3)

כְּבוֹדִי לִכְלִמָּה

“my glory become shame”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory** and **shame**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [you consider my glorious deeds as shameful deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 4:2 (#4)

תֶּאֱהָבוּן רִיק תְּבַקְּשׁוּ כָזָב

“Until when} will you love futility, {until when} will you seek falsehood”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **futility** and **falsehood**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [How long will you love vain things? How long will you pursue untrue things?]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 4:3 (#1)

חָסִיד

“the faithful”

David is using the adjective **godly** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [godly people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 4:4 (#1)

רִגְזוּ וְאַל־תֶּחֱטָאוּ

“Tremble and do not sin”

The implication could be: (1) that the hearers should **tremble** in fear of Yahweh’s punishment for the unfaithful or (2) that if the hearers are angry, they should control themselves and not sin. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Tremble in fear and do not sin] or [Even if you tremble in anger, do not sin]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 4:4 (#2)

אִמְרוּ בִלְבַבְכֶם

“Meditate in your heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and motives exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Consider your thoughts and motives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 4:4 (#3)

אִמְרוּ בִלְבַבְכֶם עַל־מִשְׁכַּבְכֶם

“Meditate in your heart on your bed”

The Hebrew root words for speak, **heart**, and **bed** in this verse appear in verses 6 (as “say”), 7, and 8 (as “lie down”) respectively (in the same order). Consider if a similar pattern would create a natural poetic effect in your language.

See: Poetry

Psalms 4:4 (#4)

אִמְרוּ בִלְבַבְכֶם

“Meditate in your heart”

Alternate translation: [Think to yourselves]

Psalms 4:4 (#5)

וְדֹמּוּ

“and be silent”

Here, **be silent** means that the listeners should show self-control and not act on sinful impulses. You could include this information in your translation if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and do not act on evil thoughts]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 4:5 (#1)

זִבְחֵי־צֶדֶק

“sacrifices of righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [sacrifices that are righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 4:5 (#2)

צֶֽדֶק וּבִטְחוּ

“righteousness and trust”

The words **righteousness** and **trust** form the poetic center of this psalm. **Righteousness** is mentioned in verse 1 and **trust** is the same word translated as “securely” in verse 8. You may wish to explore whether you can reflect this symmetry in a natural way in your language.

See: Poetry

Psalms 4:6 (#1)

מִֽי־יַרְאֵ֥נוּ טֽוֹב

“Who will show us good”

The people asking this are using the question form to make a complaint and an implied request. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as an exclamation or plain request. Alternate translation: [No one is showing us good!] or [Please, someone show us good!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 4:6 (#2)

מִֽי־יַרְאֵ֥נוּ טֽוֹב

“Who will show us good”

Here, **good** is spoken of as if it were something that someone could **show** to someone else. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Who will do good things for us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 4:6 (#3)

נְסֵ֣ה־עָלֵ֣ינוּ אוֹר פָּנֶ֑יךָ

“Lift up the light of your face on us”

The writer speaks of Yahweh acting favorably towards them as if Yahweh’s face shone a light on them. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Act favorably towards us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 4:6 (#4)

נְסֵ֣ה־עָלֵ֣ינוּ אוֹר פָּנֶ֑יךָ יְהוָֽה

“Lift up the light of your face on us, Yahweh”

This is a reference to the high priest’s blessing in Numbers 6:25.

Psalms 4:7 (#1)

נָתַ֣תָּה שִׂמְחָ֣ה בְלִבִּ֑י

“You have put joy in my heart”

Here the phrase **put joy in my heart** represents that the author’s emotional state is joyful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have made me happy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 4:7 (#2)

נָתַ֣תָּה שִׂמְחָ֣ה בְלִבִּ֑י

“You have put joy in my heart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You have made me glad]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 4:7 (#3)

דְּגָנָ֖ם וְתִירוֹשָׁ֣ם רָבּֽוּ

“their grain and their new wine abound”

Here, **grain and new wine** represent basic food necessities. An abundance of them represents material prosperity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they have a lot of bread and fresh milk] or [they are quite rich]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 4:7 (#4)

In Hebrew, this verse uses progressively shorter lines and repeated sounds to create a sense of peaceful rest. Consider if there is a way in your language to create the same sensation.

See: Poetry

Psalms 4:8 (#1)

בְּשָׁלוֹם יַחְדָּו֮ אֶשְׁכְּבָה וְאִישָׁן כִּי־אַתָּה יְהוָה לְבָדָד לָבֶטַח תּוֹשִׁיבֵנִי

“In peace I will both lie down and sleep, for you alone, Yahweh, cause me to dwell securely”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since you alone, Yahweh, cause me to dwell securely, therefore in peace I will both lie down and sleep.]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 4:8 (#2)

בְּשָׁלוֹם

“In peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 5 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Appeal (1–2)
2. Precedent (3–7)
3. Petition (8–11)
4. Resolution (12)

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: to petition the divine King and Judge for justice from enemies
2. Content: Yahweh, act justly! Banish the evildoers! Shelter the righteous!
3. Message: Yahweh is a just ruler, and he blesses the just.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. The first word of the content portion of the psalm starts with the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet and the final word starts with the last letter of the Hebrew alphabet. This symbolizes completeness; the author’s appeal to Yahweh is complete.
2. There is a parallel structure between verses 3–7 and verses 8–11:

A. Verses 3 and 8 start with an address to Yahweh, who is also the subject.

B. Verses 4 and 9 start with “For” followed by a word of negation. They use a verbless clause in Hebrew, and the wicked are the topic.

C. Verses 7 and 11 contrast with what is immediately before, and they speak of being with Yahweh.

D. There is also progression between each earlier verse and its related later verse either in specificity or time. See: Poetry

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Psalms 5:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 5:1,3,8,12 (#1)

יְהוָֹה & יְהוָֹה & יְהוָה & יְהוָה

“Yahweh & Yahweh & Yahweh & Yahweh”

The direct address to **Yahweh** in each of these verses marks the start of a new section of the psalm. If your language marks section beginnings in poetry in a certain way, you could use it at the beginning of these verses.

See: Poetry

Psalms 5:1 (#2)

אֲמָרַי

“To} my words”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of spoken **words**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [To what I say]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:1 (#3)

הַאֲזִינָה

“give ear”

Here, **give ear** is an idiom that means “listen.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have this meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [pay attention]

See: Idiom

Psalms 5:2 (#1)

מַלְכִּי וֵאלֹהָיַ

“my king and my God”

The psalmist is not referring to two people; both of these terms refer to Yahweh. He is also not using the phrase **my king** or **my God** to mean that he possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God he worships. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion. Alternate translation: [you are the king and God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 5:2–3 (#1)

לְקוֹל & קוֹלִי

“to the sound of & my voice”

The words translated as **sound** and **voice** are the same in the original. If your language has a word that could be the same in both places, you could consider using it to follow the poetic parallel of the original.

See: Poetry

Psalms 5:3 (#1)

אֶעֱרֹךְ־לְךָ֥ וַאֲצַפֶּֽה

“I prepare for you and watch”

This could mean: (1) the psalmist prepares his argument or legal case for Yahweh. Alternate translation: [I prepare my case for you and watch for your judgment] (2) the psalmist prepares to be rescued by Yahweh. Alternate translation: [I prepare to be rescued by you and wait for you] You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 5:4 (#1)

רֶ֭שַׁע

“wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wicked deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:5 (#1)

לֹא־יִתְיַצְּבוּ֣ הוֹלְלִ֣ים לְנֶגֶ֑ד עֵינֶ֥יךָ

“The arrogant will not stand in front of your eyes”

The psalmist is using **stand in front of your eyes** as a common expression of his culture to mean “come near you,” which implies worshiping Yahweh. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The arrogant will not be allowed to draw near to you] or [The arrogant will not be allowed to offer pleasing worship to you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 5:5 (#2)

פֹּ֝עֲלֵ֗י אָ֫וֶן

“doers of iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who trouble others]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:6 (#1)

אִ֭ישׁ־דָּמִ֣ים וּמִרְמָ֑ה יְתָעֵ֖ב ׀ יְהוָֽה

“the man of blood and deceit Yahweh abhors”

The psalmist now speaks about Yahweh in the third person. If changing between second and third person like this would not be natural in your language, you could continue the second person form. Alternate translation: [the man of blood and deceit you, Yahweh, abhor]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 5:7 (#1)

וַאֲנִ֗י

“But I”

Here the psalmist mentions himself explicitly to make a contrast between himself and the wicked people he’s been talking about. Draw attention to this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alter-

nate translation: [I, on the other hand] or [In contrast, I]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 5:7 (#2)

בְּרֹ֣ב חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“in the greatness of your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea behind the word **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you always keep your covenant promises]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:7 (#3)

הֵיכַל־קָ֝דְשְׁךָ֗

“your temple of holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your holy temple]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:7 (#4)

אֶשְׁתַּחֲוֶ֣ה אֶל־הֵיכַל־קָ֝דְשְׁךָ֗ בְּיִרְאָתֶֽךָ

“I will bow down toward your temple of holiness in fear”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fear**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will reverently bow down toward your temple of holiness]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:8 (#1)

נְחֵ֣נִי בְצִדְקָתְךָ֣

“guide me in your righteousness”

The psalmist speaks of **righteousness** as if it were a path, and of teaching as guiding. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [teach me to do what is righteous as you are righteous] or [teach me to do what is righteous as you do what is righteous]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 5:8 (#2)

שׁוֹרְרָ֑י

“my watchers”

Alternate translation: [those who watch for a chance to attack me]

Psalms 5:8 (#3)

הושר לְפָנַ֥י דַּרְכֶּֽךָ

“straighten before my face your path”

The psalmist speaks of following Yahweh’s commands as if doing so were a path. He asks Yahweh to put a straightened path before him, because a straight path is easy to see or walk on. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [show me clearly how to live in the right way] or [make it easy for me to do what is right]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 5:9 (#1)

אֵ֤ין בְּפִ֨יהוּ נְכוֹנָ֗ה

“there is no firmness in his mouth”

Here, **firmness** means trustworthiness or dependability. If your language does not use an abstract noun for this idea, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you cannot trust what they say] or [you cannot rely on them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:9 (#2)

בְּפִ֨יהוּ & גִּרוֹנָ֪ם לְ֫שׁוֹנָ֥ם

“in his mouth & is their throat; their tongue”

The words translated **his mouth**, **their throat**, and **their tongue** represent people’s speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in their speech … are their words … their talk] or [what they say … is everything they say … everything they say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 5:9 (#3)

קִרְבָּ֥ם הַ֝הַוּ֗וֹת

“their inward being is destruction”

The **inward being** represents people’s thoughts and desires. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their thoughts and desires are for destruction]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 5:9 (#4)

קֶבֶר־פָּתוּחַ גְּרוֹנָם

“An open tomb is their throat”

Their **throat** is spoken of as if it were an open tomb. This could mean: (1) what they say is bad, like the smell of dead bodies. Alternate translation: [Their words are as bad as the smell from a tomb] or (2) it is ready for dead bodies to be put into it. Alternate translation: [They say that they will kill people] or [What they say kills people] If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 5:9 (#5)

לְשׁוֹנָם יַחֲלִיקוּן

“their tongue they make smooth”

Here the psalmist is comparing what the enemies say to something **smooth**, which means they flatter people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they lie to people to get what they want] or [they say nice things about people without really meaning it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 5:10 (#1)

מֹעֲצוֹתֵיהֶם בְּרֹב פִּשְׁעֵיהֶם

“due to their schemes! Because of their many transgressions”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **schemes** and **transgressions**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [due to their scheming! Because they transgress many times]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 5:10 (#2)

יִפְּלוּ

“may they fall”

Here, **fall** represents the moral, spiritual, or social decline of the author’s enemies as the inevitable and divinely caused consequences of opposing God’s will. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may they suffer]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 5:11 (#1)

חוֹסֵי

“refuge seekers”

Here the psalmist speaks of people who trust in Yahweh to save and protect them as if they were **seekers** and Yahweh were a **refuge**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who seek protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 5:11 (#2)

לְעוֹלָם

“to eternity”

Alternate translation: [forever]

Psalms 5:11 (#3)

וְתָסֵךְ עָלֵימוֹ

“and may you cover over them”

Here the psalmist is speaking of protection as if it were to **cover over** someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and may you defend them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 5:11 (#4)

אֹהֲבֵי שְׁמֶךָ

“lovers of your name”

Here Yahweh’s **name** represents his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [lovers of your good reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 5:12 (#1)

צַדִּיק

“the righteous”

See how you translated the phrase **the righteous** in 1:5.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 5:12 (#2)

כַּצִּנָּה רָצ֣וֹן תַּעְטְרֶ֑נּוּ

“you surround him {with} favor as a shield”

Yahweh’s **favor** is spoken of as if it were **a shield**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you favor them and protect them as a soldier protects himself with his shield] or [because you are kind to them, you will protect them]

See: Simile

Psalms 5:12 (#3)

תַּעְטְרֶ֑נּוּ

“you surround him”

Alternate translation: [you crown him]

Psalms - Chapter 6 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Plea (1–5)
2. Death (6–7)
3. Answer (8–10)

The psalm divides neatly in half between verses 5 and 6 with 34 words in each. The first half divides into two parts, verses 1–2 and verses 4–5, which parallel each other in structure and content.

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: to plead for mercy and healing
2. Content: Yahweh have mercy and heal me, because I am near death, and no one can praise you in death.
3. Message: Yahweh’s loyalty to David is stronger than sin and death (30:6)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. The first section (1–3) and the last section (8–10) are parallel. Not only are they the same length (3 verses, 6 lines), but they are also similar in content and sounds. Structurally, the first section and the last section stand in a symmetrical relationship to one another. The parallels help to define the structure of the psalm.
2. The effect of the repetition in the last section is to highlight the complete resolution and reversal of the situation. David’s prayer has been heard, his question of “How long?” has been answered (“in an instant!”), and the deep dismay that he experienced is now imparted to his enemies on whom Yahweh’s punishment rightfully falls.
3. The second section (6–7) stands out in a number of ways, including figurative language, line structure, use of rare words, alliteration, delay of information, word repetition, and use of similar-sounding words. The effect is to draw attention to this section of the poem, wherein David, on the brink of death, reaches to the heights of poetic/rhetorical technique in order to express the depths of his suffering in a last-ditch effort to persuade Yahweh to rescue him.
4. Yahweh’s name appears eight times throughout the psalm, but it is conspicuously absent from the second section (6–7), which follows the Psalmist’s statement that “in death, there is no remembrance of you” (5a).
5. In verses 6–7, it is as though David has descended into the world of the dead, the place where Yahweh is neither named nor praised. It is a place of darkness (night) and associated with watery chaos (tears/swim/melt). In the last section (8–10), David regains energy, confidence, and authority, and he proclaims Yahweh’s name three times, as though he has come back from the dead.
6. Almost every verse in this psalm displays parallelism. Verse 2 and the first line of verse 3 are a three-part parallel while the last line of verse 3 and the first line of verse 4 seem to be the only lines not in a parallelism construction. While all these phrases mean basically the same thing with the second emphasizing the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words, Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. (See: Parallelism)

See: Poetry

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Psalms 6:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 6:0 (#3)

עַל־הַשְּׁמִינִֽית

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־הַשְּׁמִינִֽית"

The exact meaning of the word translated as **Sheminith** is uncertain. It is related to the word for "eight." It may refer to (1) the pitch of the music. Alternate translation: [perform an octave lower] or (2) a type of instrument. Alternate translation: [perform with an eight-stringed lyre] or (3) the tune of the song. Alternate translation: [perform to the tune "Sheminith"]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 6:1 (#1)

אַל־בְּאַפְּךָ תוֹכִיחֵנִי וְאַל־בַּחֲמָתְךָ תְיַסְּרֵנִי

"rebuke me not in your nose, and in your rage discipline me not"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. See the Introduction to this chapter for additional information on parallelism. Alternate translation: [do not rebuke or discipline me when you are angry]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 6:1 (#2)

בְּאַפְּךָ

"in your nose"

Here the **nose** represents anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in your anger]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 6:1 (#3)

בַּחֲמָתְךָ

"in your rage"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rage**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [furiously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 6:2 (#1)

נִבְהֲלוּ עֲצָמָי

"my bones are shaking"

The **bones** represent the whole body. His body may have been shaking because he was sick or extremely tired. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my whole body is shaking]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 6:3 (#1)

נִבְהֲלָה

"disturbed"

Alternate translation: [terrified] or [shaken]

Psalms 6:3 (#2)

וְאַתָּה יְהוָה עַד־מָתָי

"And you, Yahweh, until when"

The psalmist is using the question form to request an end to his suffering. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please, do not let this continue!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 6:3–4 (#1)

וְנַפְשִׁי נִבְהֲלָה מְאֹד & נַפְשִׁי

"And my soul is very disturbed & my soul"

The psalmist is using **My soul** to represent his entire person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I am very disturbed ... me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 6:4 (#1)

שׁוּבָה

"Turn back"

Here, **Turn back** refers to a change from one activity to another, in this case from anger to mercy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Have mercy on me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 6:4 (#2)

הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי לְמַעַן חַסְדֶּךָ

“Save me for the sake of your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Save me because you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 6:5 (#1)

בַּמָּוֶת

“in death”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **death**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when someone has died]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 6:5 (#2)

זִכְרֶךָ

“remembrance of you”

Here, **remembrance** represents praise or honor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [praise of you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 6:5 (#3)

כִּי אֵין בַּמָּוֶת זִכְרֶךָ

“For in death, there is no remembrance of you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **remembrance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [For in death people cannot remember you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 6:5 (#4)

בִּשְׁאוֹל מִי יוֹדֶה־לָּךְ

“In Sheol, who will thank you”

David uses this question to emphasize that no one in Sheol thanks God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for this purpose, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No one in Sheol will give you thanks!] or [The dead cannot praise you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 6:6 (#1)

יָגַעְתִּי ׀ בְּאַנְחָתִי

“I am weary with my groaning”

The author’s **groaning** represents the pain or distress that he feels. If your language does not use an abstract noun for that idea, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I am very tired because I hurt]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 6:6 (#2)

מִטָּתִי & עַרְשִׂי

“my bed & my couch”

These are different words for the same thing. Alternate translation: [my sleeping place ... my sleeping place]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 6:6 (#3)

אַשְׂחֶה בְכָל־לַיְלָה מִטָּתִי בְּדִמְעָתִי עַרְשִׂי אַמְסֶה

“During every night, I cause my bed to swim, With my tears, my couch I melt”

The psalmist says his **tears cause** his **bed to swim** and his **couch** to **melt** as extreme statements for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [Every night my bed gets very wet from my many tears that make my whole couch very wet]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 6:7 (#1)

In this verse, the implied cause of the eye (vision) problems the psalmist is having is his excessive crying. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 6:7 (#2)

עָשְׁשָׁה & עֵינִי

“My eye has wasted away”

Here, **eye** represents the ability to see. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My vision has wasted away] or [I cannot see clearly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 6:7 (#3)

עָשְׁשָׁה & עֵינִי

“My eye has wasted away”

Here the **eye** having **wasted away** means to lose the ability to see. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have lost the ability to see well]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 6:7 (#4)

מִכַּעַס

“from grief”

Here, **grief** represents crying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from crying] or [because I cry so much]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 6:7 (#5)

עָתְקָה

“it advances”

Here the **eye** is said to **advance** which figuratively means to grow old or weak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [it weakens] or [my sight weakens]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 6:8–9 (#1)

יְהוָה & יְהוָה & יְהוָה

“Yahweh & Yahweh & Yahweh”

Yahweh is mentioned three times in these verses to focus the audience on who has changed the author’s circumstances. However, if repeating a name like this in your culture would not create a similar focus effect you could substitute some with pronouns as in the UST.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 6:9 (#1)

תְּחִנָּתִי

“my appeal for mercy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **mercy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my appeal for him to be merciful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 6:9 (#2)

יְהוָה תְּפִלָּתִי יִקָּח

“Yahweh accepts my prayer”

Being willing to do what the psalmist prayed for is spoken of as if his **prayer** was something that **Yahweh accepts** from him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will respond to my prayer]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 7 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Injustice Rejected (1–5)
2. Justice Requested (6–9)
3. Justice Expected (10–16)
4. Justice Praised (17)

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: to invoke justice from Yahweh towards both the righteous (specifically himself) and the wicked (false accusers)
2. Content: God is a righteous judge. He saves the upright, and he brings an end to the wicked’s violence.
3. Message: King Yahweh will see to it that the wicked receive their punishment and that the righteous are vindicated.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Heights and depths provide the structure of the Psalm.

1. The Psalmist is brought down (1–5)
2. Yahweh goes up to the highest place (6–9)
3. The enemies are brought down (10–16)
4. Praise to the Most High God (17)

Other translation issues

1. There are a number of explicit and implicit references to Yahweh as both warrior and judge, which are both important functions of a king, especially King Yahweh—a metaphor that runs throughout the Psalms.
2. The subject in verses 12–16 is ambiguous; only the pronoun "he" is used (but it must be the wicked in verses 14–16). The psalmist might have chosen to leave the participants grammatically ambiguous in this entire section to create tension in what is a prominent section of the psalm (which is it, Yahweh or the wicked?!), as well as to teach an important lesson in line with the meaning of this psalm: to be wicked is to bring death upon oneself, but Yahweh is the one who ensures the destruction. In the UST and notes, the most likely persons are identified.

Cush the Benjamite

Note the superscription and the specific circumstances. There is no other reference to this incident in the Scriptures. But there are references to David being opposed by those of the tribe of Benjamin during the time he was serving King Saul. See: Poetry

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Psalms 7:0 (#2)

שִׁגְיוֹן לְדָוִד

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שִׁגְיוֹן לְדָוִד"

Alternate translation: [This is a song that David wrote]

Psalms 7:1 (#1)

אֱלֹהַי

"my God"

The psalmist is not using the phrase **my God** to mean that he possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God the one he worships. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion. Alternate translation: [the God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 7:1 (#2)

בְּךָ חָסִיתִי

"in you I have taken refuge"

Here the psalmist is speaking of going to Yahweh for protection as taking refuge in him, as if Yahweh were something strong or safe he could hide inside of. Alternate translation: [I always go to you for protection]

Psalms 7:2 (#1)

יִטְרֹף כְּאַרְיֵה נַפְשִׁי

"he rip my life apart like a lion"

The psalmist is saying that, just **like a lion** would, his enemy would both rip his body apart and tear it in pieces. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they violently kill me like a lion ripping apart its victim's body] or [they violently put an end to my life]

See: Simile

Psalms 7:3 (#1)

אֱלֹהָי

"my God"

The psalmist is not using the phrase **my God** to mean that he possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God he worships. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion. Alternate translation: [the God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 7:3 (#2)

אִם־יֶשׁ־עָוֶל בְּכַפָּי

"if there is wrong on my hands"

Here the psalmist is speaking of **wrong** as if it were something that could be held in someone's hands. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [if I have done something wrong with my hands] or [if I have treated someone wrongly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 7:3 (#3)

אִם־יֶשׁ־עָוֶל בְּכַפָּי

"if there is wrong on my hands"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrong**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [if I have wronged someone]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 7:3–5 (#1)

In some languages, translating verses 3–5 might require a significant rearrangement to make the meaning clear. This section presents a hypothetical situation where the psalmist calls a potential curse onto himself. You might have to connect each hypothetical situation in verses 3–4 with a consequence in verse 5, or even put verse 5 before the hypotheticals. However, it is important to notice that both verses 3–4 and verse 5 build up to a greater level of tension, with the peak of this tension at the end of verse 5. As you translate, try to capture this growing sense of hypothetical sin and its consequences, doing so in a way that feels natural to the poetic style of your language.

See: Poetry

Psalms 7:3–5 (#2)

אִם־עָשִׂיתִי זֹאת אִם־יֶשׁ־עָוֶל בְּכַפָּי: אִם־גָּמַלְתִּי שְׁלֻמַּי רָעֶ֑ע
וָאֲחַלְּצָה צוֹרְרִי רֵיקָם

“if I have done this, if there is wrong on my hands,if I have repaid evil {to} one {who was at} peace with me, or senselessly rescued my adversary”

The psalmist presents a conditional statement that sounds hypothetical, but he is sure that the condition he describes is not true. He is making the case that he is not guilty. When translating, use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that the speaker believes is not true (similar to how it is done in the UST). Be careful, though: if you choose to translate it as a statement of the opposite, as seen in an alternate translation, you will need to also change the wording in verse 5 to reflect this negation, as shown at the end of the provided example. Alternate translation: [since I have not done this, and since there is no wrong on my hands, since I have not repaid evil to one who was at peace with me, or senselessly rescued my adversary, then do not]

See: Connect — Contrary to Fact Conditions

Psalms 7:4 (#1)

גָּמַלְתִּי שְׁלֻמַּי רָעֶ֑ע

“I have repaid evil {to} one {who was at} peace with me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I have acted evilly to one who was at peace with me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 7:4 (#2)

שְׁלֻמַּי

“to} one {who was at} peace with me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to my friend] or [to my peaceful neighbor]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 7:4 (#3)

וָאֲחַלְּצָה צוֹרְרִי רֵיקָם

“or senselessly rescued my adversary”

This could mean: (1) being an unfaithful friend by saving a person who is the author’s and his ally’s enemy. Alternate translation: [or saved my enemy for no reason] (2) attacking an enemy without immediate cause (in this case the verb translated rescue could be taken as plunder). Alternate translation: [or plundered my enemy without cause] (3) not only doing evil to friends but even doing good to enemies. In this case the phrase would be less logically connected to the previous one. Alternate translation: [and I even rescue one who is my enemy without reason]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 7:5 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי & חַיָּיִ֑ וּכְבוֹדִ֑י

“my soul & my life & my honor”

Here, **my soul**, **my life**, and **my honor** represent the whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [me … me … me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:5 (#2)

וּכְבוֹדִ֑י ׀ לֶעָפָ֥ר יַשְׁכֵּ֗ן

“and cause my honor to live in the dust”

This refers to lying dead and unburied in disgrace. (This is the same word for dust as in Genesis 3:19.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and throw my dead body on a dirt pile]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:5 (#3)

וְיַשֵּׂג

“and overtake {it”

This represents capturing him. Alternate translation: [capture me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:6 (#1)

קוּמָה

“Arise”

Arise represents doing something or taking action. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Do something] or [Take action]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:6 (#2)

בְּאַפֶּךָ

“In your nose”

Here, **In your nose** is an idiom meaning that **Yahweh** is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Because you are angry]

See: Idiom

Psalms 7:6 (#3)

הִתָּנַשֵּׂא

“be lifted”

Here, **be lifted** represents overcoming or conquering people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [overcome]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:6 (#4)

בְּעַבְרוֹת צוֹרְרָי

“with the rage of my adversaries”

The **rage of my adversaries** represents their attacks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [against the attacks of my adversaries] or [against my adversaries who attack me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:6 (#5)

וְעוּרָה

“And wake up”

The psalmist is speaking to **Yahweh** as if he were asleep and needed to **wake up**. Here waking up represents starting to do something or take action. It does not imply that the psalmist thinks Yahweh is asleep. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take action] or [Start to do this]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 7:6 (#6)

מִשְׁפָּט צִוִּיתָ

“You have ordered judgment”

This wording serves a dual function: it both justifies the demands made earlier in this verse and sets the stage for the expectations expressed in the following verses. When translating, consider how to maintain this two-fold connection in your language, ensuring that it aligns with the logical and emotional flow of the text.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 7:7 (#1)

וַעֲדַת לְאֻמִּים תְּסוֹבְבֶךָ

“And an assembly of peoples surround you”

Alternate translation: [And let an assembly of peoples surround you]

Psalms 7:7 (#2)

וְעָלֶיהָ לַמָּרוֹם שׁוּבָה

“and over it return on high”

Yahweh ruling the **assembly of peoples** from heaven is spoken of as being **over it** and **on high**. Alternate translation: [rule over them from heaven] or [rule over them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 7:8 (#1)

יְהוָה יָדִין עַמִּים שָׁפְטֵנִי יְהוָה

“Yahweh, adjudicate the peoples! Judge me, Yahweh”

The word **adjudicate** is used to show that in the original two different words meaning judge are used. If you have two terms in your language, you can use two; if not, you can use the same term twice. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, judge the peoples! Judge me, Yahweh]

See: Poetry

Psalms 7:8 (#2)

שָׁפְטֵנִי

“Judge me”

The implication is that Yahweh will find the psalmist innocent. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Judge me innocent]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 7:8 (#3)

כְּצִדְקִ֥י וּכְתֻמִּ֗י

“according to my righteousness and according to my integrity”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **integrity**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [according to how I live rightly and according to how I live honestly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 7:8 (#4)

עָלָי

“Most High”

This could be: (1) a title for Yahweh. Alternate translation: [O you, Above All] (2) a clause locating the author’s righteousness and integrity in himself. Alternate translation: [which is in me]

Psalms 7:9 (#1)

רַ֭ע

“the evil of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the evil things of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 7:9 (#2)

רְשָׁעִ֑ים

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 7:9 (#3)

צַדִּ֗יק

“the righteous”

See how you translated the phrase **the righteous** in 1:5.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 7:9 (#4)

לִבּ֖וֹת וּכְלָיֽוֹת

“hearts and kidneys”

The **hearts and kidneys** are internal organs that represent peoples’ thoughts and desires in the author’s culture. If these body parts do not have that meaning in your language, you could use an equivalent expression that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [thoughts and motives]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:9 (#5)

וּבֹחֵ֣ן לִבּ֖וֹת וּכְלָיֽוֹת אֱלֹהִ֥ים צַדִּֽיק

“The righteous God examines hearts and kidneys”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could move the last clause in this verse to the beginning as in the UST.

See: Information Structure

Psalms 7:10 (#1)

מָגִנִּ֥י עַל־אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“My shield is with God”

The word **shield** represents God’s protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God protects me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 7:10 (#2)

יֹשֵׁ֖רֵי־לֵֽב

“the upright of heart”

Here the **heart** represents the thoughts and motives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those whose thoughts and motives are upright]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 7:11 (#1)

וְאֵ֣ל זֹעֵ֣ם בְּכָל־יֽוֹם

“and a God {who is} indignant on every day”

The psalmist assumes that his readers will understand that God is indignant with the wicked. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and a God who is angry with evil people every day]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 7:11 (#2)

בְּכָל־יֽוֹם

“on every day”

Here, **on every day** represents a constant state. God is angry with the wicked all the time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all the time]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 7:12 (#1)

אִ֤ם לֹ֣א יָשׁ֣וּב חַרְבּ֣וֹ יִלְטָ֑וֹשׁ קַשְׁתּ֥וֹ דָ֝רַ֗ךְ

“he does & repent, his sword he will sharpen, his bow he has bent”

The first **he** in this verse refers to the wicked. After the word **repent** all the **he** and **his** refer to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 7:12–13 (#1)

חַרְבּ֣וֹ יִלְטָ֑וֹשׁ

“his sword he will sharpen”

In verses 12 and 13, David speaks of God deciding to punish the wicked as if God were a warrior preparing to fight against them with weapons. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will prepare to punish him like a warrior prepares to fight by sharpening his sword]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 7:13 (#1)

וְ֝לֹ֗ו

“And for him”

This could mean: (1) for the wicked, that is, God has prepared to use these weapons against the wicked. Alternate translation: [and for the wicked] (2) for himself, that is, God has prepared the weapons for his own use. Alternate translation: [and for himself]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 7:14 (#1)

יְחַבֵּ֣ל־אָ֭וֶן וְהָרָ֣ה עָ֑מָל וְיֶ֖לֶד שֶׁ֣קֶר

“he is pregnant with wickedness, and he conceives trouble, and he births lies”

These three phrases mean basically the same thing. The second and third emphasize the meaning by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the later phrases are repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [he who is pregnant with wickedness, who also conceives trouble, who even births lies]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 7:14 (#2)

יְחַבֵּ֣ל־אָ֭וֶן וְהָרָ֣ה עָ֑מָל וְיֶ֖לֶד שֶׁ֣קֶר

“he is pregnant with wickedness, and he conceives trouble, and he births lies”

The psalmist speaks of the things that a wicked person does as if the person were **pregnant**, and **wickedness**, **trouble**, and **lies** are the baby. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Just as a woman conceives a child, carries it to term, and gives birth to it, so evil people think of wrong things to do, they do those wrong things, and then they lie about what they have done] or [the person ready to do wicked things. He makes plans for trouble and produces lies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 7:14 (#3)

יְחַבֵּל

“he is pregnant”

Here the subject switches from God back to the evil person. Alternate translation: [the wicked person is pregnant]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 7:14 (#4)

יְחַבֵּל־אָ֭וֶן וְהָרָ֣ה עָ֑מָל וְיֵ֝לֵד שָֽׁקֶר

“he is pregnant with wickedness, and he conceives trouble, and he births lies”

Here, **he** represents evil people in general. It may be strange in some languages to use a masculine pronoun when talking about someone being pregnant or giving birth, even in a figure of speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a more natural expression. Alternate translation: [the person pregnant with wickedness, who conceives trouble, who births lies]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 7:16 (#1)

יָשֻׁ֣ב עֲמָל֣וֹ בְרֹאשׁ֑וֹ וְעַ֥ל קָ֝דְקֳד֗וֹ חֲמָסֹ֥ו יֵרֵֽד

“His trouble returns on his head, and his violence comes down on the top of his head”

Here, **trouble** and **violence** are spoken of as if they hit a person’s head or fall down on it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression in your translation or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His own destructive plans destroy him, for his violence attacks him] or [When he plans to trouble others, others trouble him; when he attacks others, others attack him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 7:16 (#2)

יָשֻׁ֣ב עֲמָל֣וֹ בְרֹאשׁ֑וֹ וְעַ֥ל קָ֝דְקֳד֗וֹ חֲמָסֹ֥ו יֵרֵֽד

“His trouble returns on his head, and his violence comes down on the top of his head”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **trouble** and **violence**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [His troubling others returns on his head, and his violently attacking others comes down on the top of his head]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 7:17 (#1)

כְּצִדְקָתֹ֑ו וַאֲזַמְּרָ֥ה

“according to his righteousness, and sing praise to”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **praise**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because he is righteous and sing a praise song to]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 7:17 (#2)

שֵׁם־יְהוָ֥ה

“the name of Yahweh”

Here, **name** represents reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 8 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Superscription
2. Introduction (1–2)
3. Question (3–4)
4. Answer (5–8)
5. Closing (9)

About the Psalm

1. Purpose: to praise Yahweh for his majesty throughout all the earth
2. Content: Your name is majestic in all the earth! You bestow your glory on the heavens above, and you bestow glory on weak humans below.
3. Message: Yahweh’s majesty is revealed in weakness.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. The psalm begins and ends with the exact same exclamation—this serves to point out the purpose of the psalm.
2. The psalm progresses from top to bottom several times.

A. In verse 1b–2 it goes from the heavens down to the weakest of humans.

B. Verses 3–4 again go down from the heavens to man.

C. Verses 5–8 move from the heavenly beings through man, who is exalted and crowned with glory as Yahweh's representative ruler of all creation, and down and out into creation, moving away from man's primary spheres of dominion (domestic animals) progressively outward.

1. There are many echoes of Genesis 1. References include: the heavens as created by Yahweh's fingers (3), the animals as made by his hands (6), the dominion of man over creation (6–8, see also Genesis 1:26).
2. Magnificent, Majesty, Splendor, Glory: Yahweh gives his weak representative (humans) many of his glorious attributes, and humans rule for Yahweh.

See: Poetry

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Portions of the ULT, UST, and TNs for this psalm are derivative from "Psalms, Layer by Layer" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Welcome), "Psalm 8" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Psalm_8) by Cambridge Digital Bible Research, Katie Frost, Meaghan Smith, Nikki Mustin et al, used under CC BY

See their top three exegetical issues in Psalm 8 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=L5-NpONilOs) for discussion of verses 1, 2, and 5 and their top three poetic features of Psalm 8 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XcRob_g2g2Q) on YouTube.

Psalms 8:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 8:0 (#3)

עַל־הַגִּתִּ֑ית

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־הַגִּתִּ֑ית"

The exact meaning of the term **Gittith** is uncertain. The word could be related to the name of the Philistine city of Gath or to a term relating to wine production, which was accompanied by singing. It could refer to: (1) a musical instrument. Alternate translation: [accompany with a Philistine lute] or (2) the tune. Alternate translation: [use the winepress tune]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 8:1 (#1)

שִׁשְׁמְךָ

"your name"

Yahweh's **name** represents his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your reputation] or [your fame]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 8:1 (#2)

בְּכָל־הָאָ֥רֶץ

"in all the earth"

Here, **earth** represents all the people in the world. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to all people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 8:1 (#3)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר תְּנָ֣ה הוֹדְךָ֣ עַל־הַשָּׁמָ֑יִם

"you} whose splendor is bestowed on the heavens"

The expression **whose splendor is bestowed on the heavens** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you who bestow your splendor on the heavens]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 8:1 (#4)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר תְּנָ֣ה הוֹדְךָ֣ עַל־הַשָּׁמָ֑יִם

"you} whose splendor is bestowed on the heavens"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you show in the heavens how splendid you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 8:2 (#1)

מִפִּ֤י עוֹלְלִ֨ים ׀ וְ֭יֹנְקִים

"Out of the mouth of children and nursing ones"

Out of the mouth of children and nursing ones is placed at the front of the sentence here to help create

a strong sense of surprise that this weak thing would be the means that Yahweh uses to establish **strength**. Consider using a poetic method in your language to make the connection of the weak and strong surprising.

See: Poetry

Psalms 8:2 (#2)

מִפִּ֤י עוֹלְלִ֨ים ׀ וְיוֹנְקִ֗ים יִסַּ֫דְתָּ֥ עֹ֭ז לְמַ֣עַן צוֹרְרֶ֑יךָ

“Out of the mouth of children and nursing ones you have established strength because of your adversaries”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because of your adversaries, you have established strength out of the mouth of children and nursing ones]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 8:2 (#3)

מִפִּ֤י

“Out of the mouth of”

Here, **mouth** represents the babies’ crying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From the crying of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 8:2 (#4)

עוֹלְלִ֨ים ׀ וְיוֹנְקִ֗ים

“children and nursing ones”

The two words translated **children** and **nursing ones** expresses a single idea. The word **nursing** further describes the age of the **children**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [nursing babies]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 8:2 (#5)

עֹ֭ז

“strength”

The Hebrew reads **strength**. The ULT follows that reading. The ancient Greek translation reads “praise.” The Greek version is quoted in Matthew 21:16. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 8:2 (#6)

עֹ֭ז

“strength”

Because the word translated **established** is strongly associated with making a building, here, **strength** probably represents a fortress—a strong building that can be defended easily. Kings or Lords, as Yahweh is depicted in verse 1, often built fortresses to protect their domains and people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a building that is easy to defend]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 8:2 (#7)

עוֹלְלִ֨ים ׀ וְיוֹנְקִ֗ים

“children and nursing ones”

Because of the parallelism between verse 2 and verse 4, **children and nursing ones** may represent all of humanity (as weak and helpless people needing Yahweh’s protection). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [even the weakest humans]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 8:2 (#8)

לְהַשְׁבִּ֖ית אוֹיֵ֣ב וּמִתְנַקֵּֽם

“to cause the enemy and avenger to end”

Here, **to** marks **cause the enemy and avenger to end** as the goal or purpose of establishing **strength**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose.

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 8:2 (#9)

אוֹיֵ֣ב וּמִתְנַקֵּֽם

“the enemy and avenger”

The two words **enemy** and **avenger** may express a single idea. The word **avenger** further describes the **enemy**. If it would be more natural in your language,

you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [the vengeful enemy]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 8:3 (#1)

מַעֲשֵׂי אֶצְבְּעֹתֶיךָ

“the work of your fingers”

Yahweh’s **fingers** represent his capability. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the work of your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 8:3 (#2)

מַעֲשֵׂי אֶצְבְּעֹתֶיךָ

“the work of your fingers”

Here, **work of your fingers** represents what Yahweh has created. Alternate translation: [the things that you made]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 8:4 (#1)

מָה־אֱנוֹשׁ כִּי־תִזְכְּרֶנּוּ וּבֶן־אָדָם כִּי תִפְקְדֶנּוּ

“what is mankind that you remember him, or the son of man that you pay attention to him”

The psalmist is using the question form to express surprise. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. These remarks have been expressed in the form of a question to add emphasis. Alternate translation: [It is amazing that you are concerned for people and care about them!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 8:4 (#2)

מָה־אֱנוֹשׁ כִּי־תִזְכְּרֶנּוּ וּבֶן־אָדָם כִּי תִפְקְדֶנּוּ

“what is mankind that you remember him, or the son of man that you pay attention to him”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. Translate them according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information. Alternate translation: [What is mankind that you remember him? I say again, what is the son of man that you pay attention to him] or [What difference does the things that happen to humans make to you, that you are concerned for them?]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 8:4 (#3)

אֱנוֹשׁ & וּבֶן־אָדָם

“is mankind & or the son of man”

Here, **mankind** and **son of man** represent people in general and not a specific person. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use expressions that would be more natural in your language.

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 8:5 (#1)

וַתְּחַסְּרֵֽהוּ

“Yet you have made him to lack”

It is not entirely clear in what way humans **lack little from the heavenly beings**. It could be in their status somehow or in their perceived glory and majesty. Because of this ambiguity, it would be best not to try to explain this **lack** in your translation.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 8:5 (#2)

מֵאֱלֹהִים

“from the heavenly beings”

The Hebrew word here could mean: (1) **heavenly beings**. This generic term encompasses any sort of supernatural being in the heavens that humans are slightly less than (like the heavenly court in Job 1). (2) God. The most common translation for this word is God. However, the psalmist is speaking to Yahweh in this psalm, so if he meant God here, it would make more sense for him to say, ‘from you.’ (3) angels. The ancient Greek translation uses this option, but this Hebrew word does not seem to mean angels elsewhere. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

Psalms 8:5 (#3)

וְכָבוֹד וְהָדָר תְּעַטְּרֵֽהוּ

“and {with} glory and majesty you have crowned him”

Here, **glory and majesty** are spoken of as if they were crowns. Because kings wear crowns this means

Yahweh is sharing his glory and majesty with humans like they were lesser kings under him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and have given them glory and honor] or [and have caused them to be like kings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 8:5 (#4)

וְכָבוֹד וְהָדָר

“and {with} glory and majesty”

The terms **glory** and **majesty** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [and with great majesty]

See: Doublet

Psalms 8:5 (#5)

וְכָבוֹד וְהָדָר

“and {with} glory and majesty”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory** and **majesty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and gloriously and majestically]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 8:6 (#1)

תַּמְשִׁילֵהוּ בְּמַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ כֹּל שַׁתָּה תַחַת־רַגְלָיו

“You made him rule over the works of your hands, everything you have put under his feet”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. Translate them according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information. Alternate translation: [You made him rule over the works of your hands; in fact, you have put everything under his feet] or [You made him the ruler over everything that you made]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 8:6 (#2)

תַּמְשִׁילֵהוּ & רַגְלָיו

“You made him rule over & his feet”

The words **him** and **his** here refer to all of humanity and not to specific persons. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use expressions that would be more natural in your language.

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 8:6 (#3)

בְּמַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ

“the works of your hands”

Yahweh’s **hands** represent his capability. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the works of your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 8:6 (#4)

כֹּל שַׁתָּה תַחַת־רַגְלָיו

“everything you have put under his feet”

Having authority to rule others or control things is spoken of as having them **under** one’s **feet**. This means Yahweh gave people authority over all that he created. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have given him authority over all things]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 8:9 (#1)

This verse is exactly the same as the first half of Psalm 8:1. See how you translated it there.

Psalms - Chapter 9 Introduction

Psalms 9–10 as One Psalm

This psalm has a superscription, but Psalm 10 does not. This fact and the acrostic nature of the two psalms (lines start with consecutive letters of the alphabet) has led many scholars to believe these two psalms may have originally been written as one psalm. The analysis of the structure of these psalms presented here will assume that. It is recommended that you follow the versification and chapter structure of other Bibles you are familiar with.

Structure and Formatting

The outlines for psalms 9 and 10 are combined here and in the introduction to psalm 10 because they were probably originally one psalm. Your translation will probably be best if you translate them together.

1. Psalm 9:1–10 Praise of the King
2. Psalm 9:11–20 Petition the King

3. Psalm 10:1–11 Persecution of the Poor
4. Psalm 10:12–18 Proclamation of the King

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Order and chaos
The first letter of many of the lines of these two psalms follows an acrostic (alphabetic) pattern. In some places, however, this orderly pattern is interrupted. The places where it is interrupted are places where the wicked are mentioned or acting. It is as if the presence of the wicked disrupts the orderliness over even the poetry, but it is restored and kept by Yahweh. If your language has a poetic style which can indicate order and chaos, you may wish to translate:

1. 9:1–4 in an orderly style
2. 9:5–6 in a slightly chaotic style
3. 9:7–15 in an orderly style
4. 9:16–17 in a slightly chaotic style
5. 9:18 in neither
6. 9:19–20 in an orderly style
7. 10:1 in an orderly style
8. 10:2–11 in a very chaotic style
9. 10:12–18 in an orderly style

The fortress and the pit
There are two chiasms in psalm 9. In the first half, Yahweh is compared to a fortress (9) and, poetically, his judgment forms a barrier between the enemies and the psalmist and the oppressed.

1. people trust Yahweh (1–2)
2. Yahweh is a judge (3–4)
3. The enemy (5–6)
4. Yahweh is a king and judge (7–8)
5. People trust Yahweh (9–10)

In the second half, people's prayers poetically encircle the wicked, causing them to fall into their own pit.

1. People pray to Yahweh for help (especially verse 13) (11–14)
2. The wicked are destroyed by their own pit (15–18)
3. People pray to Yahweh for help (19–20)

As you translate this psalm, you will probably have a structure that matches this which may or may not be meaningful in your language. You could also consider if there is a way to poetically "surround" the wicked, with Yahweh as judge and the prayers of his people in the two sections.

Adjectives used as generic nouns:
The adjectives "wicked, afflicted, innocent", and "oppressed" are nominal adjectives used as generic nouns in these psalms. See Nominal Adjectives; and Generic Noun Phrases. CCBYSA

Portions of the ULT, UST, and TNs for this psalm are derivative from "Psalms, Layer by Layer" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Welcome), "Psalm 9" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Psalm_9) by Cambridge Digital Bible Research, Katie Frost, Meaghan Smith, Nikki Mustin et al, used under CC BY

See their overview video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VRQZ1eytMJ8) and top three exegetical issues in Psalm 9 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MvT6YH3bkuI) and their top three poetic features of Psalms 9–10 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=moXvQUAMudo) on YouTube.

exegetical 9 (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MvT6YH3bkuI) exegetical 10 (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W4w8G32hfyI) poetic (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=moXvQUAMudo)

See: Poetry

Psalms 9:0 (#2)

לַֽמְנַצֵּ֗חַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַֽמְנַצֵּ֗חַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 9:1 (#1)

בְּכָל־לִבִּ֑י

"with all my heart"

Here the speaker is using one part, the **heart**, to represent the whole person. If another body part represents this in your culture, you could use it or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with all my being] or [with my whole person]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 9:1 (#2)

כָּל־נִפְלְאוֹתֶ֥יךָ

“all your wonders”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wonders**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all the marvelous things you do] or [all your marvelous actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:2 (#1)

אֶשְׂמְחָה וְאֶעֱלֹצָה

“I will rejoice and exult”

The two words **rejoice** and **exult** may express a single idea. The word **exult** tells how the psalmist is rejoicing. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [I will rejoice exuberantly]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 9:2 (#2)

אֲזַמְּרָה שִׁמְךָ

“I will sing praise to your name”

Here, his **name** represents Yahweh: him, his reputation, and what he does. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I will sing praise to you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:3 (#1)

מִפָּנֶיךָ

“from your face”

Here, **face** represents the presence of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:3–4 (#1)

מִפָּנֶיךָ׃ כִּי

“from your face.For”

The last part of verse 3 (**from your face**) and the first line of verse 4 give the reason why the **enemies turn back, they stumble and perish**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is the reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because of your angry presence, and because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 9:4 (#1)

עָשִׂיתָ

“you have done”

Alternate translation: [you have ruled on] or [you have declared] or [you have accomplished]

Psalms 9:4 (#2)

כִּי־עָשִׂיתָ מִשְׁפָּטִי וְדִינִי & שׁוֹפֵט צֶדֶק

“For you have done my justice and my claim & a judge of righteousness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **justice**, **claim**, and **righteousness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [For you have answered me justly when I petitioned in your court ... a righteous judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:4 (#3)

עָשִׂיתָ מִשְׁפָּטִי וְדִינִי

“you have done my justice and my claim”

The two words **justice** and **claim** may express a single idea. The word **justice** tells how Yahweh views the author’s legal **claim**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [you have ruled that my claim is just] or [you have answered my just claim]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 9:4 (#4)

יָשַׁבְתָּ לְכִסֵּא

“you have sat on your throne”

Here, **throne** represents kingship. Kings had authority to judge people, and they would sit on their throne when they judged. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are like a king who judged his people from his throne] or [you are a king]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:4 (#5)

יָשַׁבְתָּ לְכִסֵּא שׁוֹפֵט צֶדֶק

“you have sat on your throne, a judge of righteousness”

Alternate translation: [you are like a royal judge who always issues correct judgments from his throne] or [you sit on your judgment throne and judge righteously]

Psalms 9:5 (#1)

שְׁמָמָם מָחִיתָ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד

“you blotted out their name forever and ever”

This could mean: (1) Yahweh caused these people to be forgotten. The end of verse 6 is parallel with this verse if you favor this interpretation. Alternate translation: [you have caused them to be forgotten as if their name was blotted out] or [no one will ever remember them again], (2) Yahweh will not give these people eternal life (other parts of the Bible speak of this as blotting them out from the Book of Life). Alternate translation: [you send them to eternal punishment]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:5 (#2)

רָשָׁע

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 9:5 (#3)

מָחִיתָ

“you blotted out”

Alternate translation: [you erased]

Psalms 9:5 (#4)

לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד

“forever and ever”

The terms **forever** and **ever** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [eternally]

See: Doublet

Psalms 9:6 (#1)

הָאוֹיֵב ׀ תַּמּוּ

“The enemy are finished”

In this verse, the word **enemy** is singular in form, but it refers to all enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form to make this clear. Alternate translation: [The enemies are finished]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 9:6 (#2)

חֳרְבוֹת לָנֶצַח

“desolation forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desolation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they are made desolate forever] or [you make them desolate forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:6 (#3)

וְעָרִים נָתַשְׁתָּ

“and you pulled up cities”

Here, **cities** is spoken of as if it were a plant that could be **pulled up**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when you destroyed their cities]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:6 (#4)

אָבַד זִכְרָם הֵמָּה

“As for} them, their remembrance perished”

Here, **remembrance** is spoken of as if it were a living being that could die. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All remembrance of them has stopped] or [There is no longer any remembrance of them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:6 (#5)

אָבַד זִכְרָם הֵמָּה

“As for} them, their remembrance perished”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **remembrance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [No one remembers them at all]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:6 (#6)

הֵמָּה

“As for} them”

The psalmist uses the words **As for them** here to indicate an emphatic contrast between what happens to the **enemy** and Yahweh. In your translation, indicate this strong contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Now speaking of the enemy]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 9:7 (#1)

יֵשֵׁ֫ב

“will sit”

Here, to **sit** represents the authority of the king to judge. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [reigns] or [is king]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:7 (#2)

כּוֹנֵ֣ן לַמִּשְׁפָּ֣ט כִּסְא֑וֹ

“He has established his throne for justice”

The phrase **his throne** represents God’s rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He rules in order to judge people] or [He rules over people justly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:7 (#3)

לַמִּשְׁפָּ֣ט

“for justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to do justly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:8 (#1)

וְה֭וּא יִשְׁפֹּט־תֵּ֣בֵל בְּצֶ֑דֶק יָדִ֥ין לְ֝אֻמִּ֗ים בְּמֵישָׁרִֽים

“as for him, he will judge the world with righteousness, and he will adjudicate for the peoples with fairness”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. Translate them according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information. Alternate translation: [as for him, he will judge the world with righteousness, yes, he will adjudicate for the peoples with fairness] or [as for him, he will judge the people of the world with righteousness and fairness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 9:8 (#2)

תֵּ֣בֵל

“the world”

Here, **the world** refers to all the people in the world. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everyone in the world]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:8 (#3)

בְּצֶ֑דֶק & בְּמֵישָׁרִֽים

“with righteousness & with fairness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **fairness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [righteously ... fairly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:9 (#1)

וַיְהִ֣י יְהוָ֣ה מִשְׂגָּ֣ב לַדָּ֑דָ֥ךְ מִ֝שְׂגָּ֗ב לְעִתּ֥וֹת בַּצָּרָֽה

“And may Yahweh be a secure height for the oppressed, a secure height for times with distress”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **Yahweh** as if he were a place that people could go to for safety. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And may Yahweh protect the oppressed, may he protect them in times with distress] or [And may Yahweh provide safety for those who are oppressed, making them safe in times with distress]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:9 (#2)

לְעִתּ֥וֹת בַּצָּרָֽה

“for times with distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for distressing times]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:10 (#1)

יוֹדְעֵי שְׁמֶךָ

“the knowers of your name”

Here, **your name** represents Yahweh and his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who know you] or [those who have heard what you do]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:10 (#2)

יוֹדְעֵי & דֹרְשֶׁיךָ

“the knowers of & the seekers of you”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **knowers** and **seekers**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [people who know ... people who seek you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:11 (#1)

יֹשֵׁב

“the sitter”

Here, being **the sitter** represents sitting on the throne as king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the king] or [the ruler]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:11 (#2)

זַמְּרוּ לַיהוָה & עֲלִילוֹתָיו

“Sing praises to Yahweh & his deeds”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praises**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Praise Yahweh with a song] or [Sing to praise Yahweh]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:12 (#1)

דֹּרֵשׁ דָּמִים

“the seeker of {vengeance for} bloodshed”

Here, **the seeker** refers to the avenger of blood, who hunts down and kills a murderer. Yahweh is the avenger in this case. See Numbers 35 for more information.

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 9:12 (#2)

אוֹתָם זָכָר

“remembered them”

The implication is that the **seeker of vengeance** will remember to avenge for the murder of **them** (the victims calling for justice). You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [remembered to avenge those who were murdered]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 9:12 (#3)

דֹּרֵשׁ דָּמִים אוֹתָם

“the seeker of {vengeance for} bloodshed & them”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **seeker**, **vengeance**, and **bloodshed**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the one who seeks to avenge anyone who was murdered ... them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:12 (#4)

לֹא־שָׁכַח

“he does not forget”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this double negative that consists of the negative particle **not** and the negative idea of **forget**. Alternate translation: [he surely remembers]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 9:12 (#5)

עניים

“the poor”

The psalmist is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [poor people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 9:13 (#1)

חָנְנֵנִי & עָנְיִי מִשֹּׂנְאָי

“Have mercy on me & my affliction from my haters”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **mercy**, **affliction**, and **haters**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Be merciful to me … how I am afflicted by those who hate me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:13 (#2)

רְאֵה

“See”

The implication is that Yahweh will act, not just **See**. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Take action because of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 9:13 (#3)

מְרוֹמְמִי מִשַּׁעֲרֵי מָוֶת

“O lifter of me from the gates of death”

Here, **death** is spoken of as if it were a city that had **gates** through which people enter in. If someone is near the **gates of death**, it means that he will die soon. Keeping someone from dying is spoken of as lifting him away from the gates of death. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [O you who can rescue me from death] or [O you who can keep me from dying]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:14 (#1)

בְּשַׁעֲרֵי

“in the gates of”

The **gate** is the place of trade, business, and justice in the ancient city. If your readers would not be familiar with this, you could use the location where similar things happen in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [in the central market of] or [in the place of trade and settling legal disputes of]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 9:14 (#2)

תְּהִלָּתֶיךָ & בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ

“your praise & in your salvation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **praise** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [your praiseworthy deeds … because you saved me] or [the reasons to praise you … because you are a savior]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:15 (#1)

טָבְעוּ גּוֹיִם בְּשַׁחַת עָשׂוּ בְּרֶשֶׁת־זוּ טָמָנוּ נִלְכְּדָה רַגְלָם

“The nations have sunk down into the pit they made; their foot is caught in the net that they hid”

People dig pits so they can catch animals that fall into them. They also hide nets to catch animals. Here digging a **pit** or hiding a **net** represents making plans to destroy people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The nations are like people who dig a pit for others and then fall into it; like people who hide a net to catch people and then get caught in it] or [The nations get caught in their own traps.]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:15 (#2)

טָבְעוּ גּוֹיִם בְּשַׁחַת עָשׂוּ בְּרֶשֶׁת־זוּ טָמָנוּ נִלְכְּדָה רַגְלָם

“The nations have sunk down into the pit they made; their foot is caught in the net that they hid”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. Translate them according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information.

See: Parallelism

Psalms 9:15–16 (#1)

נִוָּדַע ׀ יְהוָה מִשְׁפָּט עָשָׂה & נוֹקֵשׁ רָשָׁע

“Yahweh has revealed himself, he has done justice; the wicked is ensnared”

Both the cause and the result of everything else in verses 15–16 are in the sentence **Yahweh has revealed himself, he has done justice**. The cause of the wicked nations being trapped by their own traps is Yahweh doing justice; the result is that he is revealed as being just. In your translation, use a structure that makes

these connections clear. Alternate translation: [This happens because Yahweh is acting justly toward them. Yahweh reveals himself by justly causing the wicked to be ensnared]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 9:16 (#1)

נִנְוֹדַ֣ע

“has revealed himself”

The word **himself** indicates that the object of the verb is the same as the subject of the verb. Use a way that is natural in your language to indicate that the same person fills two roles in the sentence. Alternate translation: [has revealed Yahweh]

See: Reflexive Pronouns

Psalms 9:16 (#2)

מִשְׁפָּ֑ט

“justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [things justly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:16 (#3)

רָשָׁ֥ע

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 9:16 (#4)

בְּפֹ֣עַל כַּפָּ֣יו נוֹקֵ֣שׁ רָשָׁ֣ע

“the wicked is ensnared by the work of his hands”

The expression **the wicked is ensnared** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the wicked person harms himself by the wicked things he does]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 9:16 (#5)

בְּפֹ֣עַל כַּפָּ֣יו

“by the work of his hands”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **work**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by what he does] or [by his own evil deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 9:17 (#1)

יָשֻׁ֥בוּ

“will turn back”

See how you translated the idea of “turn back” in verse 3, as this is likely connected.

Psalms 9:17 (#2)

שְׁכֵחֵ֖י אֱלֹהִֽים

“are forgetful of God”

Here, **are forgetful of God** is a common expression that means “they forget or ignore God.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use an expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [dismiss God] or [neglect to honor and worship God]

See: Idiom

Psalms 9:17 (#3)

כָּל־גּוֹיִ֥ם שְׁכֵחֵ֖י אֱלֹהִֽים

“all nations are forgetful of God”

If the connection between **all nations** in this phrase and the **wicked** of the last phrase is not clear, you may want to show this connection. Alternate translation: [the wicked ones from all nations who are forgetful of God]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 9:17 (#4)

כָּל־גּוֹיִ֥ם

“all nations”

Here, **nations** represents the people in the nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people in every nation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:17–18 (#1)

Verses 17–18 form a poetic device called a chiasm where the inner two lines parallel each other and the

outer two lines also parallel each other. In this case this artistic device creates a strong contrast between the verses by contrasting people forgetting God with God not forgetting the needy and contrasts the death of the wicked with the hope of the afflicted which does not die. If your language has a poetic structure that can make contrasts stand out markedly like this, consider using it here.

See: Poetry

Psalms 9:18 (#1)

לֹֽא־לָנֶ֣צַח יִשְׁכַּ֣ח אֶבְי֑וֹן

“the needy will not be forgotten eternally”

The expression **the needy will not be forgotten** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God will not always forget the needy]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 9:18 (#2)

לֹֽא־לָנֶ֣צַח יִשְׁכַּ֣ח אֶבְי֑וֹן

“the needy will not be forgotten eternally”

The figure of speech here expresses a strongly positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with an expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning. Alternate translation: [the needy will be remembered eventually]

See: Litotes

Psalms 9:18 (#3)

תִּקְוַ֖ת עניים תֹּאבַ֣ד לָעַֽד

“nor} will the hope of the afflicted perish forever”

The negation in the first clause of this verse carries over to the second half. Translate this in a way that both halves of the verse are negated (but making a positive statement as the previous note explains). Alternate translation: [indeed, the hope of the afflicted will not perish forever] or [neither will the hope of the afflicted perish forever] or (assuming the first half is translated positively) [the hope of the afflicted lives on]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 9:18 (#4)

תִּקְוַ֖ת עניים תֹּאבַ֣ד לָעַֽד

“nor} will the hope of the afflicted perish forever”

Here, **hope** is spoken of as if it were something that could perish. This would mean that what they hope for does not happen. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [nor will the oppressed hope forever without results] or [someday what the afflicted hope for will happen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:19 (#1)

קוּמָ֣ה

“Arise”

Here, **Arise** represents starting to act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take action]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:19 (#2)

יִשָּׁפְט֣וּ גֹויִ֑ם

“let nations be judged”

Here judging includes punishing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let nations be judged and punished]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:19 (#3)

עַל־פָּנֶ֗יךָ

“On your face”

Here, **on your face** represents being in Yahweh’s presence, which can be considered in his courtroom (as in the UST). If it would be helpful, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 9:19 (#4)

יִשָּׁפְט֣וּ גֹויִ֑ם עַל־פָּנֶ֗יךָ

“On your face let nations be judged”

The expression **let nations be judged** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Judge the nations in your presence] or [Take the nations into your presence and punish them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 9:20 (#1)

שִׁ֭ישֵׁתָה יְהוָ֣ה ׀ מוֹרָ֑ה לָ֝הֶ֗ם

"Put terror to them, Yahweh"

Here, **terror** is spoken of as something that could be **put** to the wicked, meaning to cause them to feel terror. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Make them be terrified Yahweh!] or [Terrify them Yahweh!]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 9:20 (#2)

יֵ֝דְע֗וּ גּוֹיִ֥ם אֱנ֥וֹשׁ הֵ֗מָּה

"May nations know they are human"

Here the psalmist is speaking of **nations** as if they were living humans. There are two points: (1) nations do not last forever; they pass away or are mortal like humans, and (2) the leaders of nations are not gods, but humans who die. In both instances, they need to recognize that Yahweh is the supreme, never-ending power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May nations know they are temporary] or [May wicked human kings stop pretending to be eternal gods]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 10 Introduction

Psalms 9–10 as One Psalm

Psalm 9 has a superscription but Psalm 10 does not. This fact and the acrostic nature of the two psalms (lines start with consecutive letters of the alphabet) has led many scholars to believe these two psalms may have originally been written as one psalm. The analysis of the structure of these psalms presented here will assume that. It is recommended that you follow the versification and chapter structure of other Bibles you are familiar with.

Structure and Formatting

The outlines for psalms 9 and 10 are combined here and in the introduction to psalm 10 because they were probably originally one psalm. Your translation will probably be best if you translate them together.

1. Psalm 9:1–10 Praise of the King
2. Psalm 9:11–20 Petition the King
3. Psalm 10:1–11 Persecution of the poor
4. Psalm 10:12–18 Proclamation of the King

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Order and chaos

The first letter of many of the lines of these two psalms follows an acrostic (alphabetic) pattern. In some places, however, this orderly pattern is interrupted. The places where it is interrupted are places where the wicked are mentioned or acting. It is as if the presence of the wicked disrupts the orderliness over even the poetry, but it is restored and kept by Yahweh. If your language has a poetic style which can indicate order and chaos, you may wish to translate:

1. 9:1–4 in an orderly style
2. 9:5–6 in a slightly chaotic style
3. 9:7–15 in an orderly style
4. 9:16–17 in a slightly chaotic style
5. 9:18 in neither
6. 9:19–20 in an orderly style
7. 10:1 in an orderly style
8. 10:2–11 in a very chaotic style
9. 10:12–18 in an orderly style

The fortress and the pit

There are two chiasms in psalm 9. In the first half, Yahweh is compared to a fortress (9) and, poetically, his judgment forms a barrier between the enemies and the psalmist and the oppressed.

1. People trust Yahweh (1–2)
2. Yahweh is a judge (3–4)
3. The enemy (5–6)
4. Yahweh is a king and judge (7–8)
5. People trust Yahweh (9–10)

In the second half, people's prayers poetically encircle the wicked, causing them to fall into their own pit.

1. People pray to Yahweh for help (especially verse 13) (11–14)
2. The wicked are destroyed by their own pit (15–18)

3. People pray to Yahweh for help (19–20)

As you translate this psalm, you will probably have a structure that matches this which may or may not be meaningful in your language. You could also consider if there is a way to poetically "surround" the wicked with the prayers of Yahweh's people and with Yahweh as judge, in the two sections.

Adjectives used as generic nouns:
The adjectives "wicked, afflicted, innocent", and "oppressed" are nominal adjectives used as generic nouns in these psalms. See Nominal Adjectives; and Generic Noun Phrases. See: Poetry

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Portions of the ULT, UST, and TNs for this psalm are derivative from "Psalms, Layer by Layer" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Welcome), "Psalm 10" (https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/Psalm_10) by Cambridge Digital Bible Research, Katie Frost, Meaghan Smith, Nikki Mustin et al, used under CC BY

See their overview video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VRQZ1eytMJ8) and top three exegetical issues in Psalm 10 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W4w8G32hfyI) and their top three poetic features of Psalms 9–10 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=moXvQUAMudo) on YouTube.

Psalms 10:1 (#1)

לָמָּה יְהוָה תַּעֲמֹד בְּרָחֳק תַּסְתִּיר לְעִתּוֹת בַּצָּרָה

"Why, Yahweh, do you stand far-off? {Why} do you hide in times of trouble"

The speaker is using the question form to express his distress that Yahweh has not helped him. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, it seems as though you are far away from me and you hide from me whenever I am in trouble.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 10:1 (#2)

לְעִתּוֹת בַּצָּרָה

"in times of trouble"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trouble**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when we are troubled]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:2 (#1)

בְּגַאֲוַת

"In arrogance"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **arrogance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Arrogantly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:2 (#2)

רָשָׁע

"the wicked"

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 10:2 (#3)

יִתָּפְשׂוּ ׀ בְּמִזְמֹּות זָּוּ חָשָׁבוּ

"may they be caught by the schemes that they have planned"

It is not clear who **they** are. Options include: (1) that **they** are the wicked in both cases. In that case this would either be a prediction or a wish. This would fit with what is said in 9:15–16. Alternate translation: [the wicked are caught by the schemes that they themselves have planned] or [may the wicked be caught by the schemes that they themselves have planned] or (2) the first **they** is the **afflicted** and the second is the **wicked**. This would fit with the very negative outlook of 10:1–11. Alternate translation: [the afflicted are caught by the schemes that the wicked have planned]. You may wish to follow the choice that translations you are familiar with have made.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 10:2 (#4)

יִתָּפְשׂוּ ׀ בְּמִזְמֹּות זָּוּ חָשָׁבוּ

"may they be caught by the schemes that they have planned"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **schemes**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they are caught in the traps they have planned] or [they are caught in their own scheming]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:3 (#1)

כִּי

“Indeed”

Alternate translation: [For]

Psalms 10:3 (#2)

רָשָׁע

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 10:3 (#3)

תַּאֲוַת נַפְשׁוֹ

“the desires of his soul”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desires**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what his soul longs to do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:3 (#4)

וּבֹצֵעַ בֵּרַךְ נִנְאַץ ׀ יְהוָה

“and he blesses the robber; he despises Yahweh”

It is difficult to discern who is the subject and object of both verbs in the second half of this verse. Additionally, some believe that **blesses** is an euphemism for “curses” here. The ULT seeks to offer a reasonable translation where **the wicked** is the subject throughout (occurrences of **he** in the ULT refer to **the wicked**). You may wish to follow the rendering of a translation in your region that you are familiar with. Alternate translation: [and the robber curses and disrespects Yahweh] or [and he blesses the robber whom Yahweh despises]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 10:3 (#5)

וּבֹצֵעַ

“and & the robber”

Alternate translation: [and ... the greedy]

Psalms 10:3 (#6)

נִנְאַץ

“he despises”

Alternate translation: [he spurns] or [he rejects]

Psalms 10:4 (#1)

כְּגֹבַהּ אַפּוֹ

“According to the haughtiness of his nose”

Here, **the haughtiness of his nose** is a common expression of the culture that means pride or arrogance. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In his arrogant attitude] or [In his pride]

See: Idiom

Psalms 10:4 (#2)

בַּל־יִדְרֹשׁ

“seeks not”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. It is unclear **who** does not seek **what** here. It could be that (1) the wicked **seeks not** God. They do not fear him or obey him, or (2) the wicked think that God does not seek them out or notice them, to punish them. Alternate translation: [thinks God seeks not]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 10:4 (#3)

אֵין אֱלֹהִים כָּל־מְזִמֹּתָיו

“All his thoughts {are}, “{There is} no God”

Alternate translation: [God is not in all his thoughts]

Psalms 10:5 (#1)

יָחִילוּ דרכו

“His ways endure”

Here a person’s lifestyle is spoken of as if it was **ways**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What he does endures]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 10:5 (#2)

מָרוֹם מִמְּשָׁפָטֶיךָ מִנֶּגְדּוֹ

“your judgments are high from in front of him”

Yahweh’s judgments are compared to something high above the wicked like a bird or mountain top. This could mean: (1) Yahweh’s judgments are far from his thinking; he ignores them. Alternate translation: [he pays no attention to your judgments] or (2) he

does not understand Yahweh's judgments. Alternate translation: [your judgments are beyond his comprehension]. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 10:5 (#3)

כָּל־צֹרְרָ֥יו יָפִ֗יחַ בָּהֶם

"as for} all his enemies, he snorts at them"

Here, **snorts** (blowing air loudly out of the nose) is a symbolic action that expresses contempt and mocking. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [he shows that he thinks that all his enemies are weak and worthless] or [he sneers at all his enemies]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 10:6 (#1)

בַּל־אֶמּ֑וֹט

"I will not be shaken"

Here, **I will not be shaken** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Nothing can shake me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 10:6 (#2)

לְדֹ֣ר וָ֭דֹר

"to generation and generation"

To generation and generation is an extreme statement used for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [at any possible time]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 10:6 (#3)

בְּרָ֥ע

"be} in distress"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [be distressed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:7 (#1)

פִּ֭יהוּ מָלֵ֣א

"His mouth is full of"

Here, **mouth** represents speaking. To say that the **mouth is full** means he is always speaking **curses and lies and oppression**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He is constantly speaking] or [His speech is characterized by]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:7 (#2)

תַּ֭חַת לְשׁוֹנ֑וֹ

"under his tongue are"

Here the **tongue** represents speaking. To say that these things are **under his tongue** means they are always ready to come out when he talks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what he says is always] or [his speech is characterized by]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:7 (#3)

אָלָ֣ה פִּ֭יהוּ מָלֵ֣א וּמִרְמ֑וֹת וְתַ֝חְתָּ֗יו תַּ֣חַת לְשׁוֹנ֑וֹ עָ֖מָל וָאָֽוֶן

"His mouth is full of curses and lies and oppression; under his tongue are mischief and evil"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **curses and lies and oppression** and **mischief and evil**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Every word he speaks is harmful, false, or threatening; he always talks about mischievous plans for evil deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:8 (#1)

נָקִ֑י

"the innocent"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **innocent**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [innocent people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:8 (#2)

עֵינָ֥יו לְחֵלְכָ֗ה יִצְפֹּנ֥וּ

“his eyes stealthily watch for a helpless person”

The **eyes** represent him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he stealthily watches for a helpless person]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 10:9 (#1)

כְּאַרְיֵה בְסֻכֹּה

“like a lion in cover”

This is saying that the wicked are **like a lion** because they hide, lying it wait to ambush their prey like a lion does. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a lion ambushes its prey from cover]

See: Simile

Psalms 10:9 (#2)

יֶאֱרֹב בַּמִּסְתָּתֶר ׀ כְּאַרְיֵה בְסֻכֹּה יֶאֱרֹב לַחֲטָטֹף עָנִי

“He ambushes in a secret place like a lion in cover; he ambushes to seize the afflicted”

In order to follow the original and highlight the parallelism with the previous verse, the ULT leaves out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. In English **ambushes** requires an object. You could supply these words or modify the sentence structure if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He ambushes the afflicted in secret like a lion in cover; he ambushes them to seize them] or [He waits secretly in ambush like a lion in cover; he waits to ambush and seize the afflicted] or [He lies in wait in secret like a lion in cover; he lies in wait to seize the afflicted]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 10:9 (#3)

יַחְטֹף עָנִי בְּמָשְׁכוֹ בְרִשְׁתּוֹ

“He seizes the afflicted by pulling in his net”

The writer speaks of the wicked person catching people as if he were a hunter using a **net** to catch animals. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He seizes the afflicted like a hunter that catches an animal in a net and drags it away]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 10:10 (#1)

וְנָפַל בַּעֲצוּמָיו חלכאים

“and unfortunate people fall by his power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and unfortunate people fall because he is powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:11 (#1)

אָמַר בְּלִבּוֹ

“He says in his heart”

Here saying **in his heart** means that he thinks or believes something without necessarily speaking it out loud. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He thinks to himself] or [He believes deep down]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:11 (#2)

שָׁכַח אֵל הִסְתִּיר פָּנָיו בַּל־רָאָה לָנֶצַח

“God has forgotten; he has hidden his face; to perpetuity he sees not”

The object of these sentences is unspoken. If it would be helpful in your language, you could supply these missing words from the context. Alternate translation: [God has forgotten my deeds; he has hidden his face from my deeds; to perpetuity he sees my deeds not.]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 10:11 (#3)

שָׁכַח אֵל

“God has forgotten”

Here, **God has forgotten** is a common expression from the culture that means that God is not paying attention or does not care about what is happening. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will not make me pay] or [God does not notice]

See: Idiom

Psalms 10:11 (#4)

הִסְתִּיר פָּנָיו

“he has hidden his face”

Here, **he has hidden his face** is a common expression that means that God is deliberately ignoring or not paying attention to what is happening. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he averts his eyes] or [he does not care]

See: Idiom

Psalms 10:11 (#5)

בַּל־רָאָ֥ה לָנֶ֗צַח

“to perpetuity he sees not”

This is an exaggeration to emphasize the wicked person’s belief that God will never intervene or punish him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [what I do is completely invisible to him]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 10:12 (#1)

קוּמָ֣ה

“Arise”

Here, **Arise** represents doing something or taking action. If it would be helpful, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take action]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 10:12 (#2)

נְשָׂ֣א יָ֭דֶךָ

“lift up your hand”

Here the **hand** represents God’s power. To **lift up** the hand means to use it. If it would be helpful, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [use your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:13 (#1)

אָמַ֣ר בְּלִבּ֑וֹ לְ֝לֹ֗א תִּדְרֹֽשׁ

“He says in his heart, “You will not seek”

Here saying **in his heart** means that he thinks or believes something without necessarily speaking it out loud. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He thinks to himself, “You will not seek] or [He believes deep down, “You will not look]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:13 (#2)

לֹ֣א תִדְרֹֽשׁ

“You will not seek”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if it would be clearer in your language. It is clearer here than in 10:3 who is seeking what. The wicked think that God does not seek them out, or notice them, to punish them. Alternate translation: [You, God, will not punish me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 10:14 (#1)

רָאִ֑יתָה

“You have seen”

There is a strong contrast between what the wicked think in the previous verse and what the psalmist declares to be the truth in this verse. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But you do seek, and you have seen] or [However you really do see]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 10:14 (#2)

עָ֭מָל וָכַ֣עַס

“mischief and vexation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **mischief and vexation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the mischievous and vexing things they do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 10:14 (#3)

לָתֵ֣ת בְּיָדֶ֑ךָ

“to take {it} in your hand”

Here, **to take it in your hand** represents exercising power to take control of a situation. If it would be helpful, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to powerfully intervene]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:15 (#1)

שְׁבֹר זְרוֹעַ רָשָׁע וְרָ֑ע

“Break the arm of the wicked and the evil”

Here, **arm** represents power. If it would be helpful, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Destroy the power of wicked and evil people] or [Make wicked and evil people weak]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:15 (#2)

רָשָׁע

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 10:15 (#3)

וְרָ֑ע

“and the evil”

The psalmist is using the adjective **evil** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and evil people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 10:15 (#4)

רָשָׁע וְרָ֑ע

“the wicked and the evil”

The terms **wicked** and **evil** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the very wicked] or [the very evil]

See: Doublet

Psalms 10:15 (#5)

תִּדְרוֹשׁ־רִשְׁעֹו֙ בַּל־תִּמְצָֽא

“May it seek his wickedness, {but} not find {it”

There is significant debate about who or what may **seek** and **find**. The interpretation suggested here is that the wicked and evil people’s arm (power for harm) is personified as looking to do the evil they have planned but is unable to because Yahweh has broken the arm (power). If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May the wicked, evil person try to use his power for harm but discover you have destroyed it]; or another common interpretation is that Yahweh will seek out (hunt down, punish) the wicked, evil person’s wickedness until he can no longer find it (because it is eradicated). Alternate translation: [Hunt down his wickedness until no more can be found]. You may wish to follow the interpretation of a translation commonly used in your region. For more information, see the Psalms layer by layer exegetical discussion at https://psalms.cdbr.org/w/The_Division_of_Psalm_10:15.

See: Personification

Psalms 10:16 (#1)

אָבְד֣וּ גֹ֭וֹיִם מֵאַרְצֹֽו

“the nations have perished from his land”

The expression **the nations have perished** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh forces foreigners to leave his land]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 10:17 (#1)

תַּאֲוַ֣ת עֲ֭נָוִים שָׁמַ֣עְתָּ

“The desire of afflicted ones, you have heard”

The implication is that the afflicted people expressed their desire for mercy to Yahweh. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When afflicted people told you about their desire for mercy, you listened to them tell you what they needed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 10:17 (#2)

תָּכִ֣ין לִ֭בָּם

“you strengthen their heart”

Here, a strong **heart** represents courage and **you strengthen their heart** represents encouraging them. If it would be helpful, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you encourage them] or [you make them confident]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 10:17 (#3)

תַּקְשִׁ֣יב אָזְנֶ֑ךָ

“you cause your ear to attend”

Here the psalmist speaks of the **ear** as if it were a person who could attend to, listen, or pay attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your ear hears] or [you listen carefully]

See: Personification

Psalms 10:18 (#1)

לִשְׁפֹּ֥ט

“to judge”

The implication is that Yahweh will judge in favor of the orphan and oppressed. You could include this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to administer justice for] or [to judge in favor of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 10:18 (#2)

לַעֲרֹ֗ץ

“terrify”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [terrify anyone] or [terrify the orphan and the oppressed]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms - Chapter 11 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 11 is considered to be one of the “psalms of trust.” (See the Introduction to Psalms.) He will judge the wicked and reward the righteous. (See: deliver, deliverer, deliverance, delivered; and good, right, pleasant, better, best, goodness; and evil, wicked, wickedness, unpleasant)

1. David asserts his trust in God (1a)
2. The words of David’s advisors (1b–3)
3. David’s response to the words of his advisors (4–5)
4. David asks God to judge righteously (6–7)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Justice

David says that wicked people try to destroy righteous people, but God knows everything that evil people try to do. David says that “Yahweh is righteous” (7) and “he hates those who love to do violence” (5). David asks God to judge the wicked (6) and says that “the upright” will be rewarded by seeing his face (7). (See: just, justice, unjust, injustice, justify, justification; and save, saved, safe, salvation, rescue)

Psalms 11:1 (#1)

לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ

“To the chief musician”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 11:1 (#2)

בַּֽיהוָ֥ה ׀ חָסִ֗יתִי

“In Yahweh I take refuge”

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a physical place of safety or shelter. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I trust in Yahweh to keep me safe] or [I depend on Yahweh to protect me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 11:1 (#3)

אֵ֤יךְ תֹּאמְרוּ֙ לְנַפְשִׁ֔י

“How can you say to my soul”

David is using the question form to challenge what people are telling him. His question continues from this verse to the end of verse 3. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not say to my soul]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 11:1 (#4)

תֹּאמְרוּ֙ לְנַפְשִׁ֔י

“can you say to my soul”

The psalmist is using **my soul** to represent all of himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [can you say to me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 11:1 (#5)

נודו הַרְכֶכֶם צִפּוֹר

“Flutter {like} a bird to your mountain”

Here the speaker’s advisors are speaking of him as if he were actually a **bird** that should fly away to safety in the mountains. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Run away and hide in the mountains] or [Escape to safety in the mountains]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 11:1–3 (#1)

אֵאֵיךְ תֹּאמְרוּ לְנַפְשִׁי נודו הַרְכֶכֶם צִפּוֹר: כִּי הִנֵּה הָרְשָׁעִים יִדְרְכוֹן קֶשֶׁת כּוֹנְנוּ חִצָּם עַל־יֶתֶר לִירוֹת בְּמוֹ־אֹפֶל לְיִשְׁרֵי־לֵב: כִּי הַהֲשָׁתוֹת יֶהֱרָסוּן צַדִּיק מַה־פָּעָל

“How can you say to my soul, “Flutter {like} a bird to your mountain.For behold, the wicked, they bend a bow; they have set their arrow on the string to shoot in the darkness at the upright of heart.If the foundations are destroyed, what can the righteous do”

Many Bible scholars think that David’s quote of his advisors begins with the words **Flutter like a bird to your mountain** and ends at the end of verse three. Some Bible scholars think that **Flutter like a bird to your mountain** are the only words of his advisors that David is quoting and that verses 2–3 are his own words. The ULT and UST follow option one. If a translation exists in your region that follows option two, you may wish to follow that option.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 11:2 (#1)

כִּי הִנֵּה

“For behold”

The psalmist is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen carefully] or [Pay attention to this]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 11:2 (#2)

הָרְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1. Alternate translation: [wicked men]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 11:2 (#3)

לְיִשְׁרֵי־לֵב

“at the upright of heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and motives exist. The phrase **upright of heart** describes people whose thoughts and motives are morally straight and righteous. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at those who think and act righteously] or [at those who live with pure motives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 11:3 (#1)

כִּי הַהֲשָׁתוֹת יֶהֱרָסוּן צַדִּיק מַה־פָּעָל

“If the foundations are destroyed, what can the righteous do”

The speaker is using the question form to emphasize that the **righteous** cannot do anything if the foundations of society are destroyed. If your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement. [If the foundations are destroyed, the righteous can do nothing.] or [If the foundations are destroyed, there is nothing the righteous can do.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 11:3 (#2)

כִּי הַהֲשָׁתוֹת יֶהֱרָסוּן צַדִּיק מַה־פָּעָל

“If the foundations are destroyed, what can the righteous do”

This question is the end of what people are saying to David, which he uses the question form in verses 1–3 to challenge. If you chose in verse 1 to represent his challenge as a statement or exclamation, end this with a period or exclamation point.

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 11:3 (#3)

הַֽהֲשָׁתוֹת יֶֽהֱרָסְוּן

“the foundations are destroyed”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the principles of justice and morality were actually **foundations** of a building. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the principles of justice and morality are destroyed] or [the moral order has broken down]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 11:3 (#4)

צַדִּֽיק

“the righteous”

See how you translated the phrase **the righteous** in 1:5. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 11:4 (#1)

יְהוָ֗ה ׀ בְּהֵ֣יכַל֮ קָדְשׁ֪וֹ יְהוָ֫ה֥ בַּשָּׁמַ֥יִם כִּסְא֑וֹ

“Yahweh {is} in his holy temple; Yahweh {is} in the heavens, his throne”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God’s presence in heaven as if he were actually in a **temple** and as if **the heavens** were a place with a **throne**. You could translate the words literally or your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is present in his holy sanctuary and rules as king from heaven]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 11:4 (#2)

יְהוָ֗ה ׀ בְּהֵ֣יכַל֮ קָדְשׁ֪וֹ יְהוָ֫ה֥ בַּשָּׁמַ֥יִם כִּסְא֑וֹ

“Yahweh {is} in his holy temple; Yahweh {is} in the heavens, his throne”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation, if possible. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is in his holy temple; yes, Yahweh is in the heavens, his throne] or [Yahweh is in his holy temple; indeed, Yahweh is in the heavens, his throne]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 11:4 (#3)

יְהוָ֫ה֥ בַּשָּׁמַ֥יִם כִּסְא֑וֹ

“Yahweh {is} in the heavens, his throne”

The psalmist is not distinguishing this **throne** from another throne that is not in heaven. The psalmist is showing God’s greatness compared to human rulers who rule from a throne on earth, by adding that **the heavens** are the place of God’s **throne** (where he rules from). Be sure that this is clear in your translation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is in the heavens, they are his throne] or [Yahweh’s throne is in the heavens]

See: Distinguishing Versus Informing or Reminding

Psalms 11:4 (#4)

יְהוָ֫ה֥ בַּשָּׁמַ֥יִם כִּסְא֑וֹ

“Yahweh {is} in the heavens, his throne”

Here, God’s **throne** represents his “rule.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh rules from the heavens]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 11:4 (#5)

עֵינָ֣יו יֶחֱזָ֑וּ

“His eyes see”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [His eyes see the sons of men] or [His eyes see everything that people do]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 11:4 (#6)

עֵינָ֣יו יֶחֱזָ֑וּ עַפְעַפָּ֥יו יִבְחֲנ֗וּ

“His eyes see, his eyelids test”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation, if possible. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way

that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [His eyes see, yes, his eyelids test] or [His eyes see, indeed, his eyelids test]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 11:4 (#7)

עֵינָיו יֶחֱזָיוּ עַפְעַפָּיו יִבְחֲנוּ

“His eyes see, his eyelids test”

Here, **eyes** and **eyelids** represent God’s ability to see and evaluate everything people do. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [He sees, he tests]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 11:4 (#8)

בְּנֵי אָדָם

“the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “all human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the children of mankind] or [every human being]

See: Idiom

Psalms 11:5 (#1)

צַדִּיק

“the righteous”

See how you translated the phrase **the righteous** in 1:5. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 11:5 (#2)

וְרָשָׁע

“and the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1. Alternate translation: [wicked men]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 11:5 (#3)

שָׂנְאָה נַפְשׁוֹ

“his soul hates”

The psalmist is using **soul** to represent all of Yahweh in the act of hating. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he hates]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 11:6 (#1)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1. Alternate translation: [wicked men]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 11:6 (#2)

אֵשׁ וָגָפְרִית וְרוּחַ זִלְעָפוֹת מְנָת כּוֹסָם

“fire and brimstone and a scorching wind the portion of their cup”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [may fire and brimstone and a scorching wind be the portion of their cup]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 11:6 (#3)

אֵשׁ וָגָפְרִית וְרוּחַ זִלְעָפוֹת

“fire and brimstone and a scorching wind”

The phrase **fire and brimstone and a scorching wind** could refer to: (1) an actual physical judgment of fire and brimstone such as what happened to the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah in Genesis 19:24–25 (2) a judgment of some type, but not necessarily with fire and brimstone and a scorching wind. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 11:6 (#4)

מְנָת כּוֹסָם

“the portion of their cup”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if **the portion of their cup** is what the wicked would receive as their share, like a drink that had been poured into their cup. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could

state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what Yahweh will give them as their punishment]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 11:7 (#1)

צְדָקוֹת אָהֵב

“he loves righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he loves those who do righteous things] or [he loves when people do what is righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 11:7 (#2)

יָשָׁר

“the upright”

The psalmist is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [upright people] or [those who do what is right]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 11:7 (#3)

יֶחֱזוּ פָנָימוֹ

“will see his face”

David is using Yahweh’s **face** to represent Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will see him]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms - Chapter 12 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 12 has different types of themes in it. It has elements in it that belong to “lament psalms,” “psalms of trust,” and “imprecatory psalms.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about these types of psalms.

1. David laments that godly people seem to be no more (1)
2. The deceptive speech of wicked people (2)
3. David asks Yahweh to stop men who use their speech for evil purposes (3–4)
4. Yahweh’s response to the mistreatment of “the poor” and “the needy” (5)
5. Yahweh’s speech is perfect and trustworthy (6)
6. Yahweh’s “the poor” and “the needy” (7)
7. David observes the prideful boldness of wicked men as a result of society not condemning their evil actions (8)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh saves “the poor” and “the needy” from the oppressive acts of wicked people

Even though wicked people are temporarily succeeding in oppressing poor and needy people, Yahweh sees and will help “the poor” and “the needy” people who long for deliverance from their oppression (5). (See: save, saved, safe, salvation, rescue)

Words

A major focus of this psalm is the deceptive and prideful words that wicked people use (2–4). This psalm then shows that Yahweh’s speech, in contrast to the speech of wicked people, is morally perfect and trustworthy (6).

Psalms 12:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 12:0 (#3)

עַל־הַשְּׁמִינִית

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־הַשְּׁמִינִית”

See how you translated the term **Sheminith** in the superscription to Psalm 6.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 12:1 (#1)

חָסִיד

“the faithful”

See how you translated the phrase **the godly** in 4:3. Alternate translation: [godly people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 12:1 (#2)

מִבְּנֵי אָדָם

“from {among} the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **the sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “all human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the human race] or [from humanity]

See: Idiom

Psalms 12:2 (#1)

שָׁוְא ׀ יְדַבְּרוּ־אִישׁ אֶת־רֵעֵהוּ

“Man, they speak falsehood with his neighbor”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **Man**. He means all wicked people among mankind in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Mankind speaks with falsehood with their neighbors]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 12:2 (#2)

שָׁוְא

“falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [lies] or [what is untrue]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 12:2 (#3)

רֵעֵהוּ

“his neighbor”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if anyone a person speaks to were actually their **neighbor**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [other people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 12:2 (#4)

שְׂפַת חֲלָקוֹת בְּלֵב וָלֵב

“with} lip of smoothness, with a heart and a heart”

These two phrases, **with lip of smoothness** and **with a heart and a heart**, mean very similar things. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating a similar idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [with deceptive flattery]

See: Doublet

Psalms 12:2 (#5)

שְׂפַת חֲלָקוֹת

“with} lip of smoothness”

The psalmist is using **lip of smoothness** as a common expression of his culture to mean “flattering speech.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with flattering words]

See: Idiom

Psalms 12:2 (#6)

אֶת & בְּלֵב וָלֵב

“with & with a heart and a heart”

The psalmist is using **with a heart and a heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “with divided loyalty” or “with deceitful intentions.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with deceitful hearts] or [speaking dishonestly]

See: Idiom

Psalms 12:3 (#1)

יַכְרֵת יְהוָה כָּל־שִׂפְתֵי חֲלָקוֹת

“May Yahweh cut off all lips of smoothness”

The psalmist is using **cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “destroy” or “bring to an end.” See how you translated the expression “with lip of smoothness” in the previous verse. So in this context, **cut off all lips of smoothness** means “bring to an end all those who speak with flattering lips.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers,

you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh bring to an end all people who speak with flattering words] or [May Yahweh stop all people who speak with flattering speech]

See: Idiom

Psalms 12:3 (#2)

לָשׁוֹן מְדַבֶּרֶת גְּדֹלוֹת

“the tongue speaking great things”

Here, **tongue** represents a person who speaks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the person speaking great things]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 12:3 (#3)

לָשׁוֹן מְדַבֶּרֶת גְּדֹלוֹת

“the tongue speaking great things”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh cut off the tongue speaking great things]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 12:3 (#4)

מְדַבֶּרֶת גְּדֹלוֹת

“speaking great things”

The implication is that the people who are **speaking great things** are bragging and making proud claims. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [that brags] or [that makes proud claims]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 12:4 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר אָמְרוּ

“which say”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [lips which say]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 12:4 (#2)

לְלְשֹׁנֵנוּ נַגְבִּיר שְׂפָתֵינוּ אִתָּנוּ

“With our tongue we will make strong. Our lips {are} with us”

Here, **tongue** and **lips** represent speech and the ability to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [We will prevail through what we say. We can speak as we please]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 12:4 (#3)

לְלְשֹׁנֵנוּ נַגְבִּיר

“With our tongue we will make strong”

Here the wicked people are speaking of their **tongue** as if it were a weapon that could defeat others. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [By our speech we will defeat others] or [We will overpower others with our words]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 12:4 (#4)

שְׂפָתֵינוּ אִתָּנוּ

“Our lips {are} with us”

The implication is that these speakers are claiming to be in complete control of what they say and do not need to answer to anyone else. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [We can say whatever we want]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 12:4 (#5)

מִי אָדוֹן לָנוּ

“who {is} master over us”

The speakers are using the question **who is master over us?** as a way of making a defiant statement. They are not expecting an answer but are expressing their belief that no one has authority over them. If a speaker of your language would not use a question form for this purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [no one will be master over us!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 12:5 (#1)

מִשֹּׁ֣שֹׁד עֲנִיִּ֣ים ׀ מֵֽאַנְקַ֣ת אֶבְיוֹנִ֣ים

“Because of oppression of the poor, because of {the} groaning of the needy”

These two phrases **Because of oppression of the poor** and **because of the groaning of the needy** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation, if possible. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Because of how the poor are being cruelly oppressed and suffering]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 12:5 (#2)

עֲנִיִּ֣ים ׀ & אֶבְיוֹנִ֣ים

“the poor & of the needy”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **poor** and **needy** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [poor people ... of needy people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 12:5 (#3)

מֵֽאַנְקַ֣ת אֶבְיוֹנִ֣ים

“because of {the} groaning of the needy”

Here, **groaning** represents the suffering of the needy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [because the needy are suffering so severely that it causes them to groan] or [because of the suffering of the needy]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 12:5 (#4)

עַתָּ֣ה אָ֭קוּם

“Now I will arise”

Yahweh is using **Now I will arise** as a common expression of the culture to indicate that he is about to take action against those who oppress the poor and needy. He is not saying that he will get out of bed or stand up from a seated position. If this expression does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Now I will take action]

See: Idiom

Psalms 12:5 (#5)

אָשִׁ֖ית בְּיֵ֣שַׁע

“I will place in {the} safety”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **safety**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will keep safe]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 12:5 (#6)

יָפִ֣יחַ לֽוֹ

“he pants for it”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if someone were actually **panting** for safety like a thirsty person pants for water. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he longs for it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 12:5 (#7)

יָפִ֣יחַ לֽוֹ

“he pants for it”

It might seem that the expression **he pants for** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [he pants for] or [he longs for]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 12:6 (#1)

אִמְרָ֣ות טְהֹרֹ֣ות כֶּ֭סֶף

“are} pure words, silver”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh’s **pure words** were actually refined **silver**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [are pure words, like silver]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 12:6 (#2)

כֶּ֭סֶף צָר֣וּף בַּעֲלִ֑יל לָ֝אָ֗רֶץ מְזֻקָּ֥ק שִׁבְעָתָֽיִם

“silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God’s promises were actually **silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven** times. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [like silver that is refined in a furnace on the ground seven times]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 12:6 (#3)

כֶּ֭סֶף צָר֣וּף בַּעֲלִ֑יל לָ֝אָ֗רֶץ מְזֻקָּ֥ק שִׁבְעָתָֽיִם

“silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [silver that is refined in a furnace on the ground seven times] or [pure like silver that is refined seven time in a furnace on the ground]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 12:7 (#1)

אַתָּ֣ה יְ֭הוָה תִּשְׁמְרֵ֑ם

“You Yahweh, you will keep them”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you will keep them** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is Yahweh himself who will **keep** and **protect** “the poor” and “the needy” mentioned in verse 5. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Indeed, it is you Yahweh who will keep them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 12:7 (#2)

אַתָּ֣ה יְ֭הוָה תִּשְׁמְרֵ֑ם תִּצְּרֶ֥נּוּ

“You Yahweh, you will keep them. You will protect him”

These two phrases **you will keep them** and **You will protect him** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [You yourself, Yahweh, will surely keep the poor and the needy safe]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 12:7 (#3)

אַתָּ֣ה יְ֭הוָה תִּשְׁמְרֵ֑ם תִּצְּרֶ֥נּוּ

“You Yahweh, you will keep them. You will protect him”

The pronoun **them** refers to the poor and needy people, while the pronoun **him** also refers to these same people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You yourself Yahweh will keep the poor and needy. You will protect the poor and the needy]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 12:7 (#4)

לְעוֹלָֽם

“for eternity”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that the phrase **for eternity** means “forever” or “continually.” You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [forever]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 12:8 (#1)

סָבִ֣יב רְ֭שָׁעִים יִתְהַלָּכ֑וּן כְּרֹ֖ם זֻלֻ֣לוּת לִבְנֵ֣י אָדָֽם

“The wicked walk about on every side when vileness is high among the sons of man”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that **The wicked walk about on every side** describes. Alternate translation: [When vileness is exalted among the sons of man, the wicked ones walk about on every side]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 12:8 (#2)

רְ֭שָׁעִים

“The wicked”

See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 1:1. Alternate translation: [The wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 12:8 (#3)

יִתְהַלָּכֽוֹן

“walk about”

By **walk about**, the psalmist means that the wicked walk around freely doing evil things without anyone stopping them and that they walk around proudly as a result of being able to do evil things. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [walk about freely] or [walk about proudly]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 12:8 (#4)

כְּרֹ֣ם זֻלֻּ֣לוּת

“when vileness is high”

The implication is that wicked people are the ones who are promoting or honoring vileness. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [when people exalt vileness]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 12:8 (#5)

כְּרֹ֣ם זֻלֻּ֣לוּת

“when vileness is high”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **vileness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when what is vile is exalted]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 12:8 (#6)

לִבְנֵ֥י אָדָֽם

“among the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings” or “people.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [among people] or [among humanity]

See: Idiom

Psalms - Chapter 13 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 13 is considered to be one of the “lament psalms.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the lament psalms.

1. David calls out to Yahweh regarding Yahweh’s seeming inattention to his troubles (1–2)
2. David asks Yahweh to “consider” and “answer” him and tells Yahweh what the result will be if Yahweh does not help him (3–4)
3. David expresses his trust in Yahweh’s “covenant faithfulness” and the fact that he will “rejoice” because of his hope that Yahweh will save him (5)
4. David will sing to Yahweh because of Yahweh’s kind actions towards him (6)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s help

In this psalm David expresses to Yahweh that he desperately needs his help or else he will die (3) resulting in his enemies rejoicing at his downfall (4). David then affirms that he trusts that Yahweh’s “covenant faithfulness” will cause Yahweh to save him from his enemies and he will “sing to Yahweh” and “rejoice” as a result of Yahweh saving him. The word “salvation” in 13:5 refers to help or deliverance from one’s enemies. (See: save, saved, safe, salvation, rescue; deliver, deliverer, deliverance, delivered; and call, called)

Psalms 13:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 13:1 (#1)

עַד־אָ֭נָה יְהוָ֑ה

“How long, Yahweh”

David is probably implying the words “will you forget me,” but since the next two phrases in this verse indicates what David is asking Yahweh, you do not need to fill in the implied words in this phrase.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 13:1 (#2)

תִּשְׁכָּחֵנִי נֶ֝צַח

“Will you forget me forever”

The implication is that **forget** means “not help.” You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Will you not help me forever] or [Will you not ever answer me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 13:1 (#3)

תַּסְתִּ֣יר אֶת־פָּנֶ֣יךָ מִמֶּ֑נִּי

“will you hide your face from me”

Here, **face** represents God’s attention and favor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [will you continue to ignore me] or [will you keep withdrawing your favor from me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 13:2 (#1)

בְּנַפְשִׁ֑י

“in my soul”

Here, **in my soul** represents David’s whole self as he experiences emotions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 13:2 (#2)

יָ֭גוֹן בִּלְבָבִ֑י

“sorrow in my heart”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [having sorrow in my heart]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 13:2 (#3)

יָ֭גוֹן

“sorrow”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sorrow**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [feeling sorrowful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 13:2 (#4)

בִּלְבָבִ֑י

“in my heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and feelings exist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in my thoughts] or [in my inner being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 13:2 (#5)

יוֹמָ֑ם

“by day”

The implication is that David was distressed and in anguish throughout the entire daytime. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [daily] or [continually]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 13:2 (#6)

יָרוּם אוֹיְבִ֖י עָלָֽי

“will the one being hostile to me be high over me”

By **be high over me**, the psalmist means that his enemy will defeat him and triumph over him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [will the one being hostile to me be exalted over me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 13:3 (#1)

הָאִ֣ירָה עֵ֭ינַי

“give light to my eyes”

Here David is speaking of having energy and hope as if it were **light** coming into his eyes. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [restore my strength and hope] or [make me feel alive again]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 13:3 (#2)

פֶּן

“lest”

David is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first asks God to help him so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the request. Alternate translation: [otherwise] or [or else]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 13:3 (#3)

אִישַׁן הַמָּוֶת

“I sleep the {sleep of} death”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. If it would be clearer in your language, you can supply these words from the context, as in the ULT, which supplies **sleep of**.

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 13:3 (#4)

אִישַׁן הַמָּוֶת

“I sleep the {sleep of} death”

The psalmist is referring to death in a polite way by using the phrase **sleep the sleep of death**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [I die]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 13:4 (#1)

פֶּן־יֹאמַר אֹיְבִי

“Lest the one being hostile to me say”

David is using the word translated as **Lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first asks God to help him (3) so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the request. Alternate translation: [Otherwise the one being hostile to me will say] or [Or else the one being hostile to me will say]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 13:4 (#2)

צָרַי יָגִ֗ילוּ

“and} my adversaries rejoice”

The psalmist is leaving out a word that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. Here the word is either “and” (which the ULT supplies) or “lest.” You can supply the word or words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [lest my adversaries rejoice]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 13:4 (#3)

כִּֽי

“when”

The word the ULT translates as **when**, in this context, could mean: (1) “when” or (2) “because.” Alternate translation: [because]

Psalms 13:4 (#4)

אֶמּוֹט

“I am shaken”

The expression **I am shaken** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they shake me] or [they overcome me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 13:4 (#5)

אֶמּוֹט

“I am shaken”

Here David is speaking of himself as if he were an object that could be **shaken**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am overcome] or [I am defeated]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 13:5 (#1)

וַאֲנִי

“But I”

The psalmist uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the possibility of his enemies triumphing over him and his trust in Yahweh’s faithfulness. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a

way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Nevertheless, I] or [However, I]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 13:5 (#2)

בְּחַסְדְּךָ

“in your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in all the ways you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 13:5 (#3)

יָגֵל לִבִּי

“let my heart rejoice”

The word the ULT translates as **let my heart rejoice**, in this context, could mean: (1) “let my heart rejoice” or (2) “will rejoice.” Alternate translation: [my heart will rejoice]

Psalms 13:5 (#4)

יָגֵל לִבִּי

“let my heart rejoice”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and feelings exist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let everything in me rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 13:5 (#5)

בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ

“in your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because of the way you have saved me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 13:6 (#1)

אָשִׁירָה לַיהוָה כִּי גָמַל עָלָי

“I will sing to Yahweh, because he has dealt bountifully with me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because Yahweh has dealt bountifully with me, I will sing to him]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 13:6 (#2)

גָּמַל עָלָי

“he has dealt bountifully with me”

David could be using the past tense **he has dealt bountifully**: (1) in order to describe something that is going to happen in the future to show that the event will certainly happen. Alternate translation: [he will deal bountifully with me] or (2) to refer to things Yahweh has done for him in the past, in which case you can translate this phrase as in the ULT.

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms - Chapter 14 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 14 is “wisdom psalm” that describes the difference between how righteous people and wicked people live and the difference between what happens to them. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the Introduction to Psalms.

1. A description of wicked people (1–4)
2. God punishes wicked people but helps his own people (5–7)

Psalms 14:1 (#1)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“For the chief musician”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 14:1 (#2)

נָבָל

“The fool”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **fool**. He means foolish people in general. If it would be helpful

to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [A foolish person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 14:1 (#3)

בְּלִבּוֹ

“in his heart”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s thoughts. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to himself] or [in his thoughts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 14:1 (#4)

אֵין אֱלֹהִים

“No God”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [There is no God]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 14:1 (#5)

הִשְׁחִיתוּ הִתְעִיבוּ עֲלִילָה

“They are corrupt, they do a deed abominably”

These two phrases, **They are corrupt** and **they do a deed abominably**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [They behave in ways that are corrupt and terribly wicked]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 14:1 (#6)

הִשְׁחִיתוּ

“They are corrupt”

The pronoun **They** refers to foolish people who deny God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Such foolish people are corrupt]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 14:1 (#7)

הִתְעִיבוּ עֲלִילָה

“they do a deed abominably”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **deed**. He means the deeds of foolish people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they do deeds abominably] or [what they do is abominable]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 14:2 (#1)

בְּנֵי־אָדָם

“the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 14:2 (#2)

דֹּרֵשׁ אֶת־אֱלֹהִים

“one seeking God”

Since the psalmist has already used the name God earlier in this sentence, it may be more natural in your language to use a pronoun here. Alternate translation: [one seeking him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 14:3 (#1)

הַכֹּל סָר יַחְדָּו נֶאֱלָחוּ

“The whole has turned aside. Together they have corrupted themselves”

These two phrases, **The whole has turned aside** and **Together they have corrupted themselves**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the

first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [All have rebelled, that is, they have all become completely corrupt]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 14:3 (#2)

הַכֹּ֗ל

“The whole”

The expression **The whole** refers back to the “sons of man” in the previous verse. It may be helpful to use a term in your translation that will clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [All of mankind has turned aside]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 14:3 (#3)

הַכֹּ֗ל סָ֫רוּ֥

“The whole has turned aside”

The psalmist is speaking of people abandoning God’s ways as if they had literally **turned aside** from a path they had been walking on. He means that they stopped living in the manner in which God wants people to live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All people have rejected how God wants them to live] or [Everyone has stopped obeying God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 14:3 (#4)

אֵ֤ין עֹשֵׂה־טּ֨וֹב אֵ֖ין גַּם־אֶֽחָד

“There is} none doing good, not even one”

The psalmist is saying **none** and **not even one** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [All people are sinful]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 14:3 (#5)

טּ֨וֹב

“good”

The psalmist is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [good things] or [what is good]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 14:4 (#1)

הֲלֹ֤א יָ֝דְע֗וּ כָּל־פֹּ֣עֲלֵי אָ֑וֶן אֹכְלֵ֤י עַמִּ֨י אָ֖כְלוּ לֶ֣חֶם

“Do they not know, all of the doers of iniquity, the ones eating my people {as} they eat bread”

The psalmist is using the question form to express amazement that wicked people oppress others without recognizing that God will judge and punish them for doing that. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [They ought to know better, the doers of iniquity, the ones eating my people as they eat bread!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 14:4 (#2)

אֹכְלֵ֤י עַמִּ֨י אָ֖כְלוּ לֶ֣חֶם

“the ones eating my people {as} they eat bread”

The point of this comparison is that just as someone can **eat bread** easily and quickly, so these **doers of iniquity** readily oppress and exploit vulnerable people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the ones eating my people as readily as they eat bread]

See: Simile

Psalms 14:4 (#3)

אֹכְלֵ֤י עַמִּ֨י אָ֖כְלוּ לֶ֣חֶם

“the ones eating my people {as} they eat bread”

The psalmist is speaking as if these **doers of iniquity** were actually **eating** the **people** of his nation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones exploiting my people as readily as they eat bread]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 14:5 (#1)

שָׁ֫ם

“There”

The word the ULT translates as **There** could refer to: (1) a place. Alternate translation: [At the place God will judge the wicked] or (2) a time. Alternate translation: [At the time God will judge the wicked]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 14:5 (#2)

פָּחֲדוּ פָּחַד

“they feared a fear”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [they feared greatly]

See: Poetry

Psalms 14:5 (#3)

בְּדוֹר צַדִּיק

“is} with the generation of the righteous”

By **the generation of the righteous**, the psalmist means “the people who are righteous.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [is with righteous people]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 14:5 (#4)

אֱלֹהִים בְּדוֹר צַדִּיק

“God {is} with the generation of the righteous”

The psalmist is using **{is} with** as a common expression of his culture to mean “helps.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God helps righteous people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 14:5 (#5)

צַדִּיק

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 14:6 (#1)

עֲצַת־עָנִי תָּבִישׁוּ

“You shame the counsel of the afflicted”

The pronoun **You** refers to the wicked people who do the evil things that are described in the previous verses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You wicked people shame the counsel of the afflicted]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 14:6 (#2)

עֲצַת־עָנִי תָּבִישׁוּ

“You shame the counsel of the afflicted”

The psalmist is using the possessive form **the counsel of the afflicted** to mean the counsel that poor but godly people have decided to follow, that is, their decision to obey God. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You wicked people try to humiliate the afflicted for deciding to obey God]

See: Possession

Psalms 14:6 (#3)

עָנִי

“the afflicted”

The psalmist is using the adjective **afflicted** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [an afflicted person] or [people in humble circumstances]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 14:6 (#4)

יְהוָה מַחְסֵהוּ

“Yahweh {is} his refuge”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were actually a **refuge**, that is, a place where someone can go to be safe from danger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh protects him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 14:7 (#1)

מִמִּי יִתֵּן מִצִּיּוֹן יְשׁוּעַת יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Who will give the salvation of Israel from Zion”

The psalmist is using **Who will give** as a common expression of his culture to introduce a fervent wish.

If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [O that salvation for Israel would come from Zion!] or [I fervently wish that salvation for Israel would come from Zion!]

See: Idiom

Psalms 14:7 (#2)

מִמִּי יִתֵּ֣ן מִצִּיּ֣וֹן יְשׁוּעַ֣ת יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Who will give the salvation of Israel from Zion”

The psalmist is using Mount **Zion**, the location of God’s sanctuary, to represent God himself in the act of providing **salvation** for **Israel**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [O that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to provide for the salvation of Israel!] or [I fervently wish that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to provide for the salvation of Israel!]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 14:7 (#3)

מִמִּי יִתֵּ֣ן מִצִּיּ֣וֹן יְשׁוּעַ֣ת יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Who will give the salvation of Israel from Zion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [O that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to save Israel!] or [I fervently wish that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to save Israel!]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 14:7 (#4)

בְּשׁ֣וּב יְ֭הוָה שְׁב֣וּת עַמּ֑וֹ

“When Yahweh restores the prosperity of his people”

The word that the ULT translates as **prosperity** can also mean “captivity.” If that is the meaning, then this verse could have been added to the psalm later, after the Israelites were conquered and taken into captivity. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to follow the translation that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [When God restores the captivity of his people] or [When God brings his people back from captivity]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 14:7 (#5)

יָגֵ֣ל יַ֭עֲקֹב יִשְׂמַ֣ח יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Jacob will be glad, Israel will rejoice”

These two phrases, **Jacob will be glad** and **Israel will rejoice**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Jacob will be glad, yes, Israel will rejoice]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 14:7 (#6)

יָגֵ֣ל יַ֭עֲקֹב יִשְׂמַ֣ח יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Jacob will be glad, Israel will rejoice”

The psalmist is using the two names of the ancestor of the Israelites, **Jacob** and **Israel**, to represent the Israelites themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The descendants of Jacob will be glad; indeed, the Israelites will rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 15 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 15 is considered to be one of the “wisdom psalms.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the wisdom psalms. (See: wise, wisdom)

1. Two parallel rhetorical questions with the same meaning (1)
2. Ten character traits of the type of person Yahweh lets enter his presence (2–5b)
3. The promised reward for the person meeting Yahweh’s requirements (5c)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

The type of person who may enter into God's presence

Verse one begins with two questions that are both asking the same thing (parallelism). They are both rhetorical questions that are meant to make the reader think intently about the type of behaviors and attitudes that God requires. Verses 2–5b provide the answer to the questions in verse one. They indicate ten character traits that God requires. The last sentence in verse five is the conclusion to this psalm and states the promised reward for meeting Yahweh's moral requirements. (See: godly, godliness, ungodly, godless, ungodliness, godlessness; and good, right, pleasant, better, best, goodness; and promise, promised)

Moral Conditions for Worship

Scholars have noted that this psalm contains a list of ten different conditions for those who want to participate in worship at the temple. The list consists of three positives in verse two, three negatives in verse three, two positives in verse four, followed by two negatives in verse five. (See: temple, house, house of God)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Who do the pronouns "he," "his," and "him" refer to?

All occurrences of the pronouns "he," "his," and "him" refer to the same type of person. The person being described is not one particular person but rather anyone who exhibits the behaviors described in verses 2–5.

Psalms 15:1 (#1)

מִי־יָגֻ֥ור בְּאָהֳלֶ֑ךָ מִי־יִשְׁכֹּ֥ן בְּהַ֝ר קָדְשֶׁ֗ךָ

"who may sojourn in your tent? Who may dwell on your holy mountain"

These two phrases, **who may sojourn in your tent** and **Who may dwell on your holy mountain**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [who may sojourn in your tent, yes, who may dwell on your holy mountain]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 15:1 (#2)

מִי־יָגֻ֥ור בְּאָהֳלֶ֑ךָ מִי־יִשְׁכֹּ֥ן בְּהַ֝ר קָדְשֶׁ֗ךָ

"who may sojourn in your tent? Who may dwell on your holy mountain"

David uses these two questions to make the reader think deeply about how to live a righteous life. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for this purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or exclamations. Alternate translation: [this is the type of person who may sojourn in your tent. This is the type of person who may dwell on your holy mountain.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 15:1 (#3)

יָגֻ֥ור

"may sojourn"

The word **sojourn** means to be living somewhere, either temporarily or permanently, as a resident alien. By **may sojourn**, David means someone who is allowed to visit and come as a guest. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [may dwell as a guest] or [may be welcomed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:1 (#4)

בְּאָהֳלֶ֑ךָ

"in your tent"

By **your tent**, David means Yahweh's Temple that was in Jerusalem on Mount Zion. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in your temple] or [in your dwelling place]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:1 (#5)

בְּהַ֝ר קָדְשֶׁ֗ךָ

"on your holy mountain"

By **your holy mountain**, David means Mount Zion, the place where Yahweh's Temple was. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [on your holy mountain, Mount Zion]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:1 (#6)

מִי־יָגוּר בְּאָהֳלֶךָ מִי־יִשְׁכֹּן בְּהַר קָדְשֶׁךָ

“who may sojourn in your tent? Who may dwell on your holy mountain”

Here, **tent** and **holy mountain** represent Yahweh’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who may sojourn in your presence? Who may dwell with you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 15:2 (#1)

הוֹלֵךְ תָּמִים וּפֹעֵל צֶדֶק וְדֹבֵר אֱמֶת בִּלְבָבוֹ

“The one walking blamelessly, and doing righteousness and speaking truth in his heart”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The person who may enter your presence, Yahweh, is the one walking blamelessly, and doing righteousness, and speaking truth in his heart] or [The person who may sojourn in your house and dwell on your holy mountain is the one walking blamelessly, doing righteousness, and speaking truth in his heart]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 15:2 (#2)

הוֹלֵךְ תָּמִים

“The one walking blamelessly”

David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a way or path that the person was **walking** along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The one living blamelessly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 15:2 (#3)

הוֹלֵךְ תָּמִים וּפֹעֵל צֶדֶק וְדֹבֵר אֱמֶת בִּלְבָבוֹ

“The one walking blamelessly, and doing righteousness and speaking truth in his heart”

David is not referring to a specific **one**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Those who walk blamelessly, do righteousness, and speak truth] or [Anyone who walks blamelessly, does righteousness, and speaks truth in his heart]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 15:2 (#4)

צֶדֶק

“righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 15:2 (#5)

וְדֹבֵר אֱמֶת

“and speaking truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and speaking what is true]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 15:2 (#6)

וְדֹבֵר אֱמֶת בִּלְבָבוֹ

“and speaking truth in his heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and intentions exist. The phrase **speaking truth in his heart** means “speaking the truth within himself in his thoughts” and refers to a person thinking true thoughts within and then speaking out loud to others according to that truth. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 15:3 (#1)

עַל־לְשֹׁנוֹ

“with his tongue”

Here, **tongue** represents speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with his speech]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 15:3 (#2)

לֹא־עָשָׂה & רָעָה

“he does not do evil”

The psalmist is using the adjective **evil** as a noun to mean evil things. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [he does not do evil things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 15:3 (#3)

וְחֶרְפָּה לֹא־נָשָׂא עַל־קְרֹבוֹ

“and an insult he does not raise up against one close to him”

By **an insult he does not raise up**, David means “an insult he does not speak.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [an insult he does not speak against one close to him] or [an insult he does not speak against his neighbor]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:3 (#4)

קְרֹבוֹ

“one close to him”

By **one close to him**, David could mean: (1) a person who has a close relationship with him. Alternate translation: [his friend] or (2) a person who lives within a close physical distance from him. Alternate translation: [his neighbor]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:4 (#1)

בָּעֵינָיו

“In whose eyes”

The psalmist is using **In whose eyes** as a common expression meaning “in the judgment of” or “in the opinion of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In whose judgment] or [In whose opinion]

See: Idiom

Psalms 15:4 (#2)

נִמְאָס

“one being rejected”

By **one being rejected**, the psalmist means one whom God has rejected or despised. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [one whom God has rejected]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:4 (#3)

נִבְזֶה ׀ בָּעֵינָיו נִמְאָס

“In whose eyes one being rejected is despised”

The expression **one being rejected** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [He despises the person God rejects]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 15:4 (#4)

נִשְׁבַּע לְהָרַע

“He swears to his own hurt”

The implication is that he keeps his promise even when doing so will cause him difficulty or loss. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He keeps his promises even when it costs him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:4 (#5)

וְלֹא יָמֵר

“and does not change”

The implication is that the person does not change his oath or promise even when circumstances make it difficult or costly to keep. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and does not break his promise]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:5 (#1)

כַּסְפּוֹ & נָתַן בְּנֶשֶׁךְ

“He does & put out his money at interest”

By **put out his money at interest**, the psalmist means charge interest when lending money. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He does ... charge interest when he lends his money]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 15:5 (#2)

נָקִֽי

“the innocent”

David is using the adjective **innocent** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [innocent people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 15:5 (#3)

עֹשֵׂה־אֵ֑לֶּה לֹ֖א יִמּ֣וֹט לְעוֹלָֽם

“The one doing these {things} will not be shaken for eternity”

David is speaking of the person God accepts as if he were an object that could be **shaken**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will ensure that the one doing these things will always live securely] or [Yahweh will protect and provide for the ones doing these things so that the circumstances of life do not overwhelm them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 15:5 (#4)

לֹ֖א יִמּ֣וֹט לְעוֹלָֽם

“will not be shaken for eternity”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **shaken**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [will remain secure for eternity]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 15:5 (#5)

עֹשֵׂה־אֵ֑לֶּה לֹ֖א יִמּ֣וֹט לְעוֹלָֽם

“The one doing these {things} will not be shaken for eternity”

See how you translated the phrase “I will not be shaken” in 10:6 and the phrase “when I am shaken” in 13:4. Alternate translation: [Nothing will ever shake the one doing these things]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 15:5 (#6)

לֹ֖א יִמּ֣וֹט לְעוֹלָֽם

“will not be shaken for eternity”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that the phrase **for eternity** means “forever.” You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [will never be shaken]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 16 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 16 is considered to be one of the “psalms of trust.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the psalms of trust.

1. David’s prayer (1)
2. David recalls what he said to Yahweh (2)
3. David’s delight in godly people (3)
4. The sorrows of those who pursue gods besides Yahweh and David’s refusal to participate in their idolatry (4)
5. David acknowledges that Yahweh is in control of his destiny and has greatly blessed him (5–6)
6. David blesses Yahweh for guiding him (7)
7. David’s resolve to continually focus on Yahweh (8a)
8. David’s trust that God will protect him from troubles (8b–c)
9. The result of David’s trust in God (9)
10. David’s trust that God will protect his life (10)
11. David’s acknowledgement that Yahweh has made him know “the path of life” and that an intimate relationship with Yahweh results in abundant and eternal joys (11)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “miktam.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Land and inheritance imagery in 16:5–6.
The historical and cultural background for 16:5–6 is the inheritance of land. 16:6 uses the imagery of measuring cords (lines) which were used to measure and distribute land. These verses probably also have as their background the distribution of the Promised Land to the tribes of Israel and Yahweh promising to

be the inheritance of the tribe of Levi. If it would help you to better understand and translate these verses, you can read more about the inheritance of land in Joshua 18–19 and God providing for the Levites in Numbers 18:20–24.

Messiah
In Peter's sermon (Acts 2:14–36), he quotes Psalm 16:8–11 in 2:25–28 and then explains that David was a prophet and was speaking of the resurrection of the Messiah. (See: resurrection; and anoint, anointed, anointing)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

What does David mean by "you will not abandon my soul to Sheol. You will not hand over your godly one to see the pit" in 16:10?
The word "Sheol" refers to the place or location of the dead (where dead people go). The word "pit" also refers to the grave. In this verse David is not saying that God will keep him from ever dying. 1 Kings 2:1–10 records that David died of old age. Here David is asserting his trust that God will save him from dying an unnatural death. In other words, he trusts that God will save him from being killed by evil men. Notice that this psalm begins with a prayer for protection. (See: Hades, Sheol)

Psalms 16:1 (#1)

מִכְתָּם לְדָוִד

"A miktam of David"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **miktam**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 16:1 (#2)

חָסִיתִי בָךְ

"I take refuge in you"

See how you translated the phrase "I take refuge" in 11:1. Alternate translation: [I am safe because I trust in you] or [I depend on you to protect me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:2 (#1)

אָמַרְתְּ לַיהוָה

"You said to Yahweh"

The pronoun **You** refers to David himself. If this is not clear for your readers, you could use David's name here. Alternate translation: [David said to Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 16:2 (#2)

טּוֹבָתִי בַּל־עָלֶיךָ

"my good is not beyond you"

By **my good is not beyond you**, David means that he does not experience happiness apart from Yahweh and does not experience material blessings or provision apart from Yahweh. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I have no good apart from you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 16:2 (#3)

טּוֹבָתִי בַּל־עָלֶיךָ

"my good is not beyond you"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **good**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [both my happiness and material provision come from you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 16:3 (#1)

לִקְדוֹשִׁים

"As for the holy {ones"

The term **holy ones** refers to godly people or faithful believers. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [As for the godly people] or [As for the people who are faithful to Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 16:3 (#2)

לִקְדוֹשִׁים & וְאַדִּירֵי

"As for the holy {ones & the majestic {ones"

David is using the adjectives **holy** and **majestic** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [As for the holy people ... the majestic people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 16:3 (#3)

כָּל־חֶפְצִי־בָם

“all my delight is in them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **delight**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I fully delight in them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 16:4 (#1)

יִרְבּוּ עַצְּבוֹתָם אַחֵר מָהָרוּ

“Their sorrows will be multiplied, they {who} hasten {after} another {god”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sorrows**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [They will suffer greatly, they who hasten after another god]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 16:4 (#2)

אַחֵר מָהָרוּ

“they {who} hasten {after} another {god”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from the context, as in the ULT, if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [those who hasten after another god]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 16:4 (#3)

אַחֵר מָהָרוּ

“they {who} hasten {after} another {god”

Here David is speaking as if those who seek out and eagerly worship other gods actually **hasten after** them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they who worship another god]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:4 (#4)

בַּל־אַסִּיךְ נְסָכֵיהֶם מִדָּם

“I will not pour out their drink offerings from blood”

By **I will not pour out their drink offerings of blood**, the psalmist means that he will not participate in the pagan worship practices that involve offering drinks mixed with blood to false gods. You could include this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I will not participate in their blood offerings to other gods]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 16:4 (#5)

וּבַל־אֶשָּׂא אֶת־שְׁמוֹתָם עַל־שְׂפָתָי

“and I will not take up their names on my lips”

Here, **lips** represents speaking or saying something aloud. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will not speak their names] or [and I will not say their names]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 16:5 (#1)

מְנָת־חֶלְקִי וְכוֹסִי אַתָּה תּוֹמִיךְ גּוֹרָלִי

“the portion of my inheritance and my cup. You are holding my lot”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the phrase **my cup** before the phrases **the portion of my inheritance** and **holding my lot**. Alternate translation: [my cup. You are the portion of my inheritance, and you are holding my lot] or [you are my cup. You are the portion of my inheritance, and you are holding my lot]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 16:5 (#2)

וְכוֹסִי

“and my cup”

By saying that Yahweh is **my cup** David could mean: (1) that Yahweh controls his destiny in which case he uses **cup** to refer to what one drinks and therefore, metaphorically, to what one receives in life. Alternate translation: [and the one who controls my future], or (2) [provision] in which case **cup** refers to physical provision. Alternate translation: [and the one who gives me great blessings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:5 (#3)

מְנָת־חֶלְקִי

“the portion of my inheritance”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were actually **the portion of my inheritance**. David is alluding to the inheritance of and distribution of land. (See the Introduction to this psalm for more information.) He means that Yahweh is his most valuable possession and the source of all his blessings and sustenance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my most precious possession, my source of blessing]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:5 (#4)

אַתָּה תּוֹמִיךְ גּוֹרָלִי

“You are holding my lot”

Here David is speaking as if God were literally **holding** his lot, as if his destiny were a physical object that could be grasped in someone’s hand. He means that God controls and secures his future. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are maintaining my lot] or [You are maintaining my destiny]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:6 (#1)

חֲבָלִים נָפְלוּ־לִי בַּנְּעִמִים אַף־נַחֲלָת שָׁפְרָה עָלָי

“The} measuring cords have fallen for me in pleasant {places}; indeed, {the} inheritance is beautiful for me”

Here David is speaking as if his inheritance from God were actually **measuring cords** (used to divide land) that **have fallen** (were put) in **pleasant places**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison or in plain language. Alternate translation: [God has given me a delightful inheritance; indeed, what I have received is wonderful]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:7 (#1)

אַף

“even”

Here the word the ULT translates as **even** could: (1) be adding an additional thought. Alternate translation: [also,] or (2) be functioning to emphasize or assert what follows it. Alternate translation: [indeed]

Psalms 16:7 (#2)

יִסְּרוּנִי כִלְיוֹתָי

“my kidneys instruct me”

Here the **kidneys** represent where a person’s thoughts and conscience exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language that you could use, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my mind instructs me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:7 (#3)

יִסְּרוּנִי כִלְיוֹתָי

“my kidneys instruct me”

David is speaking of **my kidneys** as if they were a living thing that could **instruct** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh instructs my mind]

See: Personification

Psalms 16:7 (#4)

יִסְּרוּנִי כִלְיוֹתָי

“my kidneys instruct me”

Here David assumes that readers will know that when he speaks of his mind instructing him, this happens as he thinks about Yahweh and what is pleasing to Yahweh, and probably also as he prays. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [my mind instructs me as I think about Yahweh] or [my mind instructs me as I pray and think about Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 16:8 (#1)

שִׁוִּיתִי יְהוָה לְנֶגְדִּי תָמִיד

“I have set Yahweh continually before me”

The implication is that David is deliberately making Yahweh his constant focus and priority in life. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I constantly focus on Yahweh] or [In all that I do I am conscious of Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 16:8 (#2)

מִמֶּימִינִי

“he is at my right hand”

David is using **he is at my right hand** as a common expression of his culture to mean "he is helping me" or "he is protecting me." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he is helping me] or [he is protecting me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 16:8 (#3)

בַּל־אֶמּוֹט

"I will not be shaken"

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:5.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:8 (#4)

בַּל־אֶמּוֹט

"I will not be shaken"

This is a double negative. David uses the negative particle **not**, with the negative word **shaken** to express a positive meaning strongly. The phrase **I will not be shaken** means that David will remain firm and secure. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [he makes me live securely]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 16:8–9 (#1)

שִׁוִּיתִי יְהוָה לְנֶגְדִּי תָמִיד כִּי מִֽימִינִי בַּל־אֶמּוֹט׃ לָכֵן ׀ שָׂמַח לִבִּי וַיָּגֶל כְּבוֹדִי אַף־בְּשָׂרִי יִשְׁכֹּן לָבֶטַח

"I have set Yahweh continually before me, because he is at my right hand, I will not be shaken.Therefore my heart is glad, and my glory rejoices. Also, my flesh will dwell in security"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of the content of these verses, since 16:8 gives the reason for the result that 16:9 describes. Alternate translation: [My heart is glad, and my glory rejoices. Also, my flesh will dwell in security. This is because I have set Yahweh before me continually, and because he is at my right hand and I know that I will not be shaken]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 16:9 (#1)

שָׂמַח לִבִּי וַיָּגֶל כְּבוֹדִי

"my heart is glad, and my glory rejoices"

These two phrases **my heart is glad** and **my glory rejoices** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [my heart is glad, yes, my whole being rejoices] or [my heart is glad, yes, my glory rejoices]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 16:9 (#2)

שָׂמַח לִבִּי

"my heart is glad"

Here the **heart** represents where a person's emotions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am glad] or [I feel glad]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:9 (#3)

וַיָּגֶל כְּבוֹדִי

"and my glory rejoices"

Here, **glory** represents David's "spirit" and by extension his feelings that come from his spirit (inner person). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 16:9 (#4)

בְּשָׂרִי יִשְׁכֹּן

"my flesh will dwell"

Here, **flesh** represents David himself, specifically his body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will dwell]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 16:9 (#5)

לָבֶטַח

"in security"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **security**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [securely]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 16:10 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 16:10 (#2)

לֹא־תַעֲזֹב נַפְשִׁי לִשְׁאוֹל לֹא־תִתֵּן חֲסִידְךָ לִרְאוֹת שָׁחַת

“you will not abandon my soul to Sheol. You will not hand over your faithful one to see the pit”

These two phrases **you will not abandon my soul to Sheol** and **You will not hand over your godly one to see the pit** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [you will save me, your faithful follower, from death] or [you will save me, a godly person, from the grave]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 16:10 (#3)

לֹא־תַעֲזֹב נַפְשִׁי לִשְׁאוֹל לֹא־תִתֵּן חֲסִידְךָ לִרְאוֹת שָׁחַת

“you will not abandon my soul to Sheol. You will not hand over your faithful one to see the pit”

See the Introduction to this psalm for a discussion of this phrase. Here, David is referring to Yahweh saving him from evil men who might try to kill him. David is not saying that he will not die of old age. Avoid translating this verse in a way that might make it appear that David thinks he will not die of old age.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 16:10 (#4)

לֹא־תִתֵּן חֲסִידְךָ לִרְאוֹת שָׁחַת

“You will not hand over your faithful one to see the pit”

David assumes that readers will know that **the pit** refers to the grave or death. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You will rescue your godly one from death] or [You will rescue your godly one from the grave]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 16:10 (#5)

חֲסִידְךָ

“your faithful one”

Even though David is addressing Yahweh directly, he is speaking of himself in the third person as **your godly one** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [me, your godly one]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 16:11 (#1)

אֹרַח חַיִּים

“the path of life”

Here David is speaking of how to live as if it were actually **the path**. The phrase **of life** indicates he is speaking of living in a way that results in a joyful and blessed life in the present and in the future. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how to live in a way that results in me being joyful and blessed, both now and in the future]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 16:11 (#2)

אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ נְעִמְמוֹת

“are before your face & are delights”

Here, **before your face** represents being in Yahweh’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [are in your presence ... are joys] or [are with you ... are pleasures]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 16:11 (#3)

אֶת & נְעִמְמוֹת בִּימִינְךָ נֶצַח

“are before & in your right hand are delights forever”

Here, **right hand** represents God’s power and ability to give something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are before … with you are delights forever] or [are before … you give delights forever]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 17 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 17 is one of five psalms that are labeled as “prayers.” (See: deliver, deliverer, deliverance, delivered; and innocent)

1. David asks Yahweh to heed his prayer and pleads his innocence (1–5)
2. David asserts his belief that God will listen to him and answer him and will save everyone who seeks refuge in God (6–7)
3. David asks Yahweh to protect him (8–9)
4. David describes his enemies (10–12)
5. David asks Yahweh to save him by defeating his enemies who are worldly men (13–14)
6. David’s hope (15)

Psalms 17:1 (#1)

שִׁמְעָה יְהוָה ׀ צֶדֶק הַקְשִׁיבָה רִנָּתִי הַאֲזִינָה תְּפִלָּתִי

“Listen, Yahweh {to} righteousness. Pay attention to my cry! Give ear to my prayer”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please listen, Yahweh, to righteousness. Please pay attention to my cry! Please give ear to my prayer]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 17:1 (#2)

צֶדֶק

“to} righteousness”

See how you translated this word in 11:7.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 17:1 (#3)

הַאֲזִינָה תְּפִלָּתִי

“Give ear to my prayer”

David is using **Give ear** as a common expression of his culture to mean “listen” or “pay attention.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Listen to my prayer] or [Hear my prayer]

See: Idiom

Psalms 17:1 (#4)

הַאֲזִינָה תְּפִלָּתִי בְּלֹא שִׂפְתֵי מִרְמָה

“Give ear to my prayer from lips without deceit”

Here, **lips** represents the person who is speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Give ear to my prayer, since I speak without deceit] or [Give ear to my prayer, for I am not deceiving you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:1 (#5)

בְּלֹא שִׂפְתֵי מִרְמָה

“from lips without deceit”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [lips that do not deceive] or [lips that speak truthfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 17:2 (#1)

מִמְּךָ מִשְׁפָּטִי יֵצֵא עֵינֶיךָ תֶּחֱזֶינָה מֵישָׁרִים

“Let my vindication come from your face; let your eyes see rightly”

By using **let**, David is expressing what he desires or prays will happen. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [My vindication should come from your face; your eyes should see rightly]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 17:2 (#2)

מִשְׁפָּטִי

“my vindication”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **vindication**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a declaration of my innocence]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 17:2 (#3)

מִמֶּךָ֥ פָּנֶ֗יךָ

“from your face”

Here, **your face** represents God’s presence or his judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from your presence] or [from you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:2 (#4)

עֵינֶ֗יךָ תֶּחֱזֶ֥ינָה מֵישָׁרִֽים

“let your eyes see rightly”

Here, **eyes** represents God’s ability to judge or evaluate. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may you judge rightly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:3 (#1)

לִבִּ֑י

“my heart”

Here, **my heart** represents David’s thoughts, feelings, and motives. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my thoughts] or [my inner being]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 17:3 (#2)

פָּקַ֣דְתָּ לַ֭יְלָה

“you have visited {me in the} night”

By **you have visited me in the night**, David means that God examines his heart and thoughts during the quiet hours when his true character is most evident. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you have examined my heart at night]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 17:3 (#3)

פָּקַ֣דְתָּ לַ֭יְלָה

“you have visited {me in the} night”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context (as in the ULT) if that would be clearer in your language.

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 17:3 (#4)

צָרַ֣פְתָּ בַל־תִּמְצָ֑א

“you have tested me {and} have detected nothing”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [you have tested me and have detected nothing that displeases you]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 17:3 (#5)

זַמּ֥וֹתִי בַל־יַעֲבָ֗ר־פִּֽי

“I have purposed that my mouth will not transgress”

Here, **mouth** represents “speech.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I have purposed that I will not transgress with my speech]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:4 (#1)

אָדָ֑ם

“man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [mankind]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 17:4 (#2)

בִּדְבַר שְׂפָתֶיךָ אֲנִי שָׁמַרְתִּי אָרְחוֹת פָּרִיץ

“by the word of your lips I have kept myself away from the paths of the violent”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [I have kept myself away from the paths of the violent by the word of your lips]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 17:4 (#3)

בִּדְבַר שְׂפָתֶיךָ

“by the word of your lips”

Here, **word** represents God’s oral or written communication. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by your word] or [by what you have spoken]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:4 (#4)

אָרְחוֹת פָּרִיץ

“the paths of the violent”

Here David is speaking of how people live as if they were actually **paths** that they walk on. The phrase **paths of the violent** refers to living in a way that is characterized by unjust violence against innocent people. (David performed violent actions in the context of war but this refers to non-military violence.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a violent way of life] or [a destructive lifestyle characterized by violence]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 17:4 (#5)

פָּרִיץ

“the violent”

David is using the adjective **violent** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [violent people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 17:5 (#1)

תָּמַךְ אֲשֻׁרַי בְּמַעְגְּלוֹתֶיךָ בַּל־נָמֹוטוּ פְּעָמָי

“My steps hold firmly to your tracks; my footsteps have not slipped”

Here David is speaking as if his obedience to God were actually **steps** that **hold firmly to** God’s **tracks**. (God’s **tracks** refer to the actions and lifestyle that God desires for people.) Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have consistently obeyed your commands; I have not disobeyed you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 17:6 (#1)

אֲנִי־קְרָאתִיךָ כִּי־תַעֲנֵנִי אֵל

“I have called upon you, for you will answer me, God”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because you will answer me God, I have called upon you]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 17:6 (#2)

הַט

“Incline”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please incline]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 17:6 (#3)

הַט־אָזְנְךָ לִי

“Incline your ear to me”

Here, **ear** represents hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Listen to me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:6 (#4)

שְׁמַע אִמְרָתִי

“listen to my speech”

By **my speech**, David means his prayer. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [listen to my prayer]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 17:7 (#1)

הַפְלֵה חֲסָדֶיךָ

“Set apart your covenant faithfulness”

The implication of **Set apart** is that David wants God to show his covenant faithfulness in a special or extraordinary way to help him in his current situation. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Show your covenant faithfulness in a special way] or [Display your covenant faithfulness remarkably]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 17:7 (#2)

חֲסָדֶיךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all the ways you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 17:7 (#3)

בְּיִמִינֶךָ

“by your right hand”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:7 (#4)

חוֹסְסִים מִמִּתְקוֹמְמִים

“the ones seeking refuge {in you} from those rising up”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the ones seeking refuge in you from those rising up against them]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 17:7 (#5)

חוֹסְסִים

“the ones seeking refuge {in you”

Here David is speaking of **the ones seeking refuge** in God as if they were literally seeking physical shelter or protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who trust in you for protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 17:7 (#6)

מִמִּתְקוֹמְמִים

“from those rising up”

David is using **those rising up** as a common expression of his culture to mean “those who oppose” or “enemies.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from those taking action against them] or [from those trying to harm them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 17:8 (#1)

שָׁמְרֵנִי כְּאִישׁוֹן בַּת־עָיִן

“Keep me as the pupil of your eye”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the pupil of your eye** is carefully protected, so David wants God to protect him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Protect me carefully] or [Guard me protectively]

See: Simile

Psalms 17:8 (#2)

בְּצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ תַּסְתִּירֵנִי

“hide me under the shadow of your wings”

David is speaking as if Yahweh were a bird and he were one of its chicks. Your language may have a comparable expression you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation:

[protect me as a mother bird protects its chicks by covering them with its wings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 17:9 (#1)

מִפְּנֵי

“from the faces of”

Here the phrase **from the faces of** was a common expression meaning “from the presence of” or “because of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the presence of]

See: Idiom

Psalms 17:9 (#2)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean wicked people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people] or [wicked men]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 17:9 (#3)

בְּצָרֲנֶפֶשׁ

“against my soul”

David is using the term **my soul** to mean his entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:10 (#1)

חֶלְבָּמוֹ סָגָרוּ

“Their fat they have closed up”

Here, **fat** represents their hearts or inner beings that have become hardened and unfeeling. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They have hardened their hearts] or [Their hearts have become unfeeling]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:10 (#2)

פִּיהֶם דִּבְּרוּ בְּגַאֲוָה

“with their mouths they speak with pride”

It might seem that the expression **with their mouths they speak** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [they speak with pride]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 17:11 (#1)

אֲאֲשֻׁרֵינוּ עַתָּה סבבוני

“They have surrounded me now {in} our steps”

By **our steps**, David means the steps that both he and his enemies are taking as they move. The enemies are surrounding him at every point along their path. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [They have surrounded me now wherever we go] or [They have surrounded me at every point along our path]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 17:11 (#2)

סבבוני

“They have surrounded me”

Some ancient manuscripts read **They have surrounded me**. The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “They have surrounded us.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 17:11 (#3)

עֵינֵיהֶם יָשִׁיתוּ לִנְטֹתוֹת בָּאָרֶץ

“Their eyes they have set, crouching down to the earth”

By **Their eyes they have set, crouching down to the earth**, the psalmist means that his enemies are watching him carefully and getting ready to attack him like wild animals that crouch low before they pounce on their prey. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to

your readers. Alternate translation: [They stare at me intently, crouched low and ready to attack]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 17:12 (#1)

דְּמוּתֹנוֹ כְּאַרְיֵה יִכְסֹף לִטְרֹף וְכִכְפִיר יֹשֵׁב בְּמִסְתָּרִים

“His likeness is as a lion, he longs to tear; and as a young lion he is dwelling in hiding places”

The pronoun **His** refers to the wicked person described in the previous verses. The pronoun **he** refers to this same wicked person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The wicked person’s likeness is as a lion, the wicked person longs to tear; and as a young lion the wicked person is dwelling in hiding places]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 17:12 (#2)

דְּמוּתֹנוֹ כְּאַרְיֵה יִכְסֹף לִטְרֹף וְכִכְפִיר יֹשֵׁב בְּמִסְתָּרִים

“His likeness is as a lion, he longs to tear; and as a young lion he is dwelling in hiding places”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a lion** longs to tear apart its prey, so the wicked person’s **likeness** resembles a lion that longs to attack. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [He is like a lion that longs to tear apart its prey, and like a young lion hiding and waiting to attack]

See: Simile

Psalms 17:12 (#3)

יִכְסֹף לִטְרֹף

“he longs to tear”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he longs to tear his prey]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 17:13 (#1)

קוּמָה יְהוָה קַדְּמָה פָּנָיו הַכְרִיעֵהוּ פַּלְטָה נַפְשִׁי

“Arise, Yahweh, confront his face, make him bow down! Rescue my soul”

Here David is using imperative forms **Arise**, **confront**, **make him bow down**, and **Rescue** to communicate polite requests to God rather than commands. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please arise, Yahweh, please confront his face, please make him bow down! Please rescue my soul]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 17:13 (#2)

קַדְּמָה פָּנָיו

“confront his face”

Here, **his face** represents his presence or confronting him directly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [confront him directly] or [face him in battle]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:13 (#3)

הַכְרִיעֵהוּ

“make him bow down”

By **make him bow down** David means “throw him to the ground” or “cause him to fall to the ground” and probably means “fall to the ground dead.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [make him fall down dead] or [cause him to fall to the ground defeated]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 17:13 (#4)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using one part of a person, his **soul**, to mean all of him in the act of being rescued. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 17:13 (#5)

מֵרָשָׁע

“from the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this

adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [from wicked people] or [from wicked men]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 17:13 (#6)

חַרְבֶּךָ

“with} your sword”

Here, **sword** represents power or strength used for powerful, violent action. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:14 (#1)

מֵמְתִים יָדְךָ ׀ יְהוָה מֵמְתִּים מֵחֶלֶד חֶלְקָם בַּחַיִּים

“From men {with} your hand Yahweh, from men from {the} world, their portion in life”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Rescue me from men by your hand, Yahweh, from men of this world whose portion is in this life]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 17:14 (#2)

מֵמְתִים יָדְךָ ׀ יְהוָה

“From men {with} your hand Yahweh”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Rescue me from evil men by your power Yahweh] or [From men, with your power Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 17:14 (#3)

וצפינך תְּמַלֵּא בִטְנָם

“and with your treasure you fill their belly”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God providing abundantly for his people as if he would literally with his treasure **fill their belly**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you abundantly provide for them from your riches]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 17:14 (#4)

בָּנִים

“with sons”

Here the masculine term **sons** has a generic sense that includes both sons and daughters. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both sons and daughters. Alternate translation: [with children]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 17:14 (#5)

יִתְרָם

“their abundance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **abundance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [their abundant possessions] or [great wealth]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 17:15 (#1)

בְּצֶדֶק

“in righteousness”

David is using the adjective **righteousness** as a noun to mean a state or condition of being righteous. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase as in the UST.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 17:15 (#2)

אֶחֱזֶה פָנֶיךָ

“will see your face”

David is using **your face** to represent all of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will see you]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 17:15 (#3)

בְּהָקִיצֹתִי

“when I awake”

Some Bible scholars think that the phrase **when I awake** is a reference to David’s future bodily resurrec-

tion. If it would help your readers, you could include a footnote explaining this.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 17:15 (#4)

אֶשְׂבְּעָ֥ה & תְמוּנָתֶֽךָ

“I will be satisfied {with} your manifestation”

The implication is that David will be satisfied when he sees God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I will be satisfied with your presence]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 18 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This is a song by David about Yahweh’s deliverance. This song is also recorded in the Bible in 2 Samuel 22.

1. David sings to Yahweh that he loves him and calls Yahweh his “strength” (1)
2. David describes what Yahweh is to him (2)
3. David recounts that God has answered his prayer and saved him from his enemies when he was in a dangerous situation (3–6)
4. David compares Yahweh’s act of saving him to three different natural disasters (7–14)
5. David recounts Yahweh delivering him (15–19)
6. David gives the reason Yahweh has delivered him (20–27)
7. David recounts the different things Yahweh has done for him (28–48)
8. David thanks and praises Yahweh (49)
9. Yahweh saves David his chosen king and shows covenant faithfulness to David and his descendants forever (50)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Hebrew poetry

The verses of this song by David continually present two phrases that mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases with a word other than “and” in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. But you may find that in some cases it is appropriate to combine the two phrases. For example:

- both phrases

18:23 And I have been blameless with him, and I have kept myself from my iniquity. “And I have been blameless with him, yes, I have kept myself from my iniquity.”

18:21 For I have kept the ways of Yahweh, and I have not been wicked from my God. “For I have kept the ways of Yahweh, no, I have not been wicked from my God.”

- combined into one

18:6 In my distress I called {to} Yahweh, and to my God I called “In my distress I called out to Yahweh, my God”

Extended metaphor

In 7–14, David describes Yahweh coming to help him as being like the greatest natural forces that people of his culture knew, which were an earthquake (7), a volcano (8), and a thunderstorm (9–14). He describes each of these forces in poetic language. In other words, after stating his topic, which is how Yahweh delivered him (6), David then depicts it with multiple images that communicate multiple ideas. Think about how you might show in your translation that 7–14, while describing three different things, all illustrate the same topic.

Psalms 18:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 18:0 (#3)

מִכַּ֖ף כָּל־אֹיְבָ֑יו וּמִיַּ֖ד שָׁאֽוּל

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִכַּ֖ף כָּל־אֹיְבָ֑יו וּמִיַּ֖ד שָׁאֽוּל”

Here **palm** and **hand** represent power or control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the control of all his enemies]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:1 (#1)

חִזְקִי

“my strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who makes me strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:2 (#1)

יְהוָה ׀ סַלְעִי & צוּרִי

“Yahweh is my rock & my rock”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were actually a high **rock** that he could climb up to reach safety from danger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is like a rock that keeps me safe from danger ... he is like a rock to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:2 (#2)

וּמְצוּדָתִי

“and my stronghold”

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a **stronghold** or a strong structure where people go to be protected. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my place of safety]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:2 (#3)

אֶחֱסֶה־בּוֹ

“I take refuge in him”

Here David uses **take refuge in him** as if God were a place of safety in which he could hide. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I depend on him to keep me safe] or [I trust him to protect me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:2 (#4)

מָגִנִּי

“my shield”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shield** that protected him from attack. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:2 (#5)

וְקֶרֶן־יִשְׁעִי

“and the horn of my salvation”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **horn** that is characterized by providing **salvation**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the horn that saves me]

See: Possession

Psalms 18:2 (#6)

וְקֶרֶן־יִשְׁעִי

“and the horn of my salvation”

David is speaking of God’s power to save him as if it were a powerful **horn** of an animal. A horn was a symbol of strength in ancient Israelite culture because animals use their horns as weapons. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the one who saves me by his power] or [and the one who powerfully saves me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:3 (#1)

מְהֻלָּל אֶקְרָא יְהוָה

“To} the one being praised I call, {to} Yahweh”

The expression **being praised** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I call to Yahweh, the one whom people praise] or [I call to Yahweh, the one whom I praise]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:3 (#2)

אִוָּשֵׁעַ

“I am saved”

The expression **I am saved** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way

that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [and he saves me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:4 (#1)

אֲפָפוּנִי חֶבְלֵי־מָוֶת

“The cords of death encompassed me”

Here David is speaking as if death were actually **cords** that could wrap around and bind a person. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Death threatened to bind me like cords] or [I was in danger of dying]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:4 (#2)

וְנַחֲלֵי בְלִיַּעַל יְבַעֲתוּנִי

“and the torrents of wickedness terrified me”

David speaks here of **torrents of wickedness** as if wickedness were a flood of rushing water that could overwhelm and destroy him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a wicked person was pursuing me relentlessly, and that terrified me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:5 (#1)

חֶבְלֵי שְׁאוֹל סְבָבוּנִי

“The cords of Sheol surrounded me”

Here, **Sheol**, the dwelling place of the dead according to Hebrew culture, represents death itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The cords of death surrounded me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:5 (#2)

חֶבְלֵי שְׁאוֹל סְבָבוּנִי

“The cords of Sheol surrounded me”

David is speaking as if Sheol or death actually had **cords** that it could use to bind him. This suggests he felt trapped in a situation where he thought he would die. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [I thought I was bound to die]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:5 (#3)

קִדְּמוּנִי מְקוֹשֵׁי מָוֶת

“the snares of death confronted me”

David speaks here of **snares of death** as if death were a hunter that could set traps for people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [death had me in its clutches]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:6 (#1)

בַּצַּר־לִי

“In my distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [When I was distressed] or [When I felt distressed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:6 (#2)

וְשַׁוְעָתִי לְפָנָיו

“and my cry to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents being in God’s presence or coming before him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and my call for help]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:6 (#3)

יִשְׁמַע & קוֹלִי

“He heard my voice”

Here, **voice** represents the words David spoke in his prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [He heard my prayer]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:6 (#4)

מֵהֵיכָלוֹ

“from his temple”

By **his temple**, David means God’s temple in heaven. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if

that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from his heavenly temple]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:6 (#5)

תְּבוֹא בְאָזְנָיו

“went in his ears”

David is using the term **ears** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he heard]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:7 (#1)

וַתִּגְעַשׁ וַתִּרְעַשׁ הָאָרֶץ ׀ וּמוֹסְדֵי הָרִרִים יִרְגָּזוּ וַיִּתְגָּעֲשׁוּ כִּי־חָרָה לוֹ

“Then the earth shook and trembled, and the foundations of the mountains quaked and shook themselves because it burned to him”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Then, because it burned to him, the earth shook and trembled. The foundations of the heavens quaked and shook themselves]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 18:7 (#2)

וַתִּגְעַשׁ & הָאָרֶץ & וַיִּתְגָּעֲשׁוּ

“Then the earth shook & and shook themselves”

The terms that the ULT translates as **shook** and **shook themselves** represent two different verbs in the original. Hebrew had more synonyms for this idea than some other languages may have. David expresses some of these with the verbs translated as **trembled** and **quaked**. It may be necessary for you to use the same words rather than different ones. However, if you do have a variety of terms for this, it would be appropriate to use different words for **shook** and **shook themselves**.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:7 (#3)

וַתִּגְעַשׁ וַתִּרְעַשׁ הָאָרֶץ ׀

“Then the earth shook and trembled”

The terms **shook** and **trembled** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Then the earth shook violently]

See: Doublet

Psalms 18:7 (#4)

וַתִּגְעַשׁ וַתִּרְעַשׁ הָאָרֶץ ׀ וּמוֹסְדֵי הָרִרִים יִרְגָּזוּ וַיִּתְגָּעֲשׁוּ

“Then the earth shook and trembled, and the foundations of the mountains quaked and shook themselves”

David is speaking as if the **earth** and the **foundations of the mountains** were actually a person who could shake and tremble. This expresses how powerfully God responded to David’s prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then it was as though a violent earthquake occurred and shook the earth and the foundations of the mountains]

See: Personification

Psalms 18:7 (#5)

יִרְגָּזוּ וַיִּתְגָּעֲשׁוּ

“quaked and shook themselves”

The terms **quaked** and **shook themselves** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [quaked mightily]

See: Doublet

Psalms 18:7 (#6)

חָרָה לוֹ

“it burned to him”

Here, **it burned to him** represents his anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he was angry]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:8 (#1)

עָלָה עָשָׁן ׀ בְּאַפּוֹ וְאֵשׁ־מִפִּיו תֹּאכֵל גֶּחָלִים בָּעֲרוּ מִמֶּנּוּ

“Smoke went up from his nose, and fire from his mouth devoured. Coals from him burned”

David is saying that when Yahweh came to help him, Yahweh’s power was so great that it was like a volcano. David describes the opening at the top of a volcano, from which **Smoke** and **fire** and **Coals** come

out, as if it were the **nose** and **mouth** of the volcano. If your readers would be familiar with what a volcano is, you could express in your translation how David is using a volcano as an image to describe Yahweh's power. If not, you could describe in more general terms how Yahweh's power is like fire and smoke.

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 18:8 (#2)

וְאֵשׁ־מִפִּ֥יו תֹּאכֵ֑ל

"and fire from his mouth devoured"

David is speaking of the fire that comes from a volcano, which represents God here, as if it were a wild animal that **devoured** its prey. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and fire from his mouth completely destroyed everything] or [and fire from his mouth consumed everything]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:9 (#1)

וַיֵּ֣ט שָׁמַ֣יִם וַיֵּ֑רֶד וַ֝עֲרָפֶ֗ל תַּ֣חַת רַגְלָֽיו

"And he lowered the heavens, and he came down, and a dark cloud was under his feet"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And he came standing on a dark cloud, and thus he lowered the heavens]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 18:10 (#1)

וַיִּרְכַּ֣ב עַל־כְּר֣וּב וַיָּ֑עָף

"And he rode on a cherub, and he flew"

The words **rode** and **flew** express a single idea. The word **flew** tells more about how he **rode**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [And he flew by riding on a cherub]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 18:10 (#2)

וַיִּרְכַּ֣ב עַל־כְּר֣וּב וַיָּ֑עָף

"And he rode on a cherub, and he flew"

David is speaking as if God were actually riding on a **cherub** and flying through the sky. This is part of a poetic description of God's power and swift action to help David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he came very quickly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:10 (#3)

וַ֝יֵּ֗דָא עַל־כַּנְפֵ֥י־רֽוּחַ

"and he flew swiftly on the wings of the wind"

David is speaking as if the wind actually had **wings** and that it could fly through the sky carrying Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and it appeared as if the wind were a great bird that was carrying him swiftly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:11 (#1)

יָ֭שֶׁת חֹ֣שֶׁךְ ׀ סִתְרֹ֑ו

"He set darkness his covering"

David is speaking as if the darkness were actually **set** like a physical object that could be arranged in place. He means that God caused darkness to surround himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It was as if he were dwelling within the darkness of the storm]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:11 (#2)

יָ֭שֶׁת חֹ֣שֶׁךְ ׀ סִתְרֹ֑ו סְבִיבוֹתָ֥יו סֻכָּתֹ֗ו חֶ֭שְׁכַת־מַ֣יִם

"He set darkness his covering, the booth around him {was} a darkness of waters"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He set darkness as his covering—yes, the shelter around him was dark storm clouds]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 18:12 (#1)

נֶגְדּוֹ

“before him”

Here, **before him** represents being in God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:12 (#2)

וְגַחֲלֵי־אֵשׁ

“and coals of fire”

David assumes that readers will know that **coals of fire** means “flashes of lightning.” You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and flashes of lightning] of [and bolts of lightning]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:13 (#1)

בָּ֭בָרָ֣ד וְגַחֲלֵי־אֵֽשׁ

“hailstones and coals of fire”

Some ancient manuscripts include the words **hailstones and coals of fire**. The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts do not have these words. It is possible that during the process of copying, they were repeated here from the previous verse. The ancient Greek translation does not have them. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 18:13 (#2)

בָּ֭בָרָ֣ד וְגַחֲלֵי־אֵֽשׁ

“hailstones and coals of fire”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [there were hailstones and coals of fire]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 18:14 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֣ח חִצָּ֭יו וַיְפִיצֵ֑ם וּבְרָקִ֥ים רָָ֝֗ב וַיְהֻמֵּֽם

“And he sent out his arrows and he scattered them and lightnings in abundance and he panicked them”

Here David is using an image within an image. Within the image of a thunderstorm that represents Yahweh coming powerfully to help him, David speaks of lightning bolts as if they were **arrows**. You might be able to clarify this by combining the two parts of this verse, which mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [And he sent out lightning bolts like arrows and panicked them so that they scattered]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 18:14 (#2)

וַיְפִיצֵ֑ם & וַיְהֻמֵּֽם

“and he scattered them & and he panicked them”

The pronoun **them** refers in each instance to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and he scattered my enemies ... and he panicked those enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 18:14 (#3)

וּבְרָקִ֥ים רָָ֝֗ב

“and lightnings in abundance”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [yes, and he sent out lightnings in abundance]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 18:15 (#1)

וַיֵּרָאֽוּ ׀ אֲפִ֣יקֵי מַ֭יִם וַיִּגָּל֑וּ מוֹסְדֹ֖ות תֵּ֣בֵ֑ל

“And the channels of the sea were seen, and the foundations of the world were uncovered”

The expressions **were seen** and **were uncovered** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the channels of the sea became visible; ground no longer covered the foundations of the world]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:15 (#2)

וַיֵּרָאוּ ׀ אֲפִקֵ֣י מַ֭יִם וַיִּגָּל֣וּ מוֹסְדֹ֣ות תֵּ֑בֵל מִגַּעֲרָתְךָ֥ יְ֝הוָ֗ה מִנִּשְׁמַ֥ת רוּחַ֥ אַפֶּֽךָ

“And the channels of the sea were seen, and the foundations of the world were uncovered, from your rebuke, Yahweh, from the blast of the breath of your nose”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And at the rebuke of Yahweh, from the blast of the breath of his nose, the channels of the sea were seen, the foundations of the world were uncovered]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 18:16 (#1)

יִשְׁלַ֥ח

“He stretched out”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He stretched out his hand]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 18:16 (#2)

מִמָּרֹ֑ום

“from the height”

Here, **height** represents “heaven” as God’s dwelling place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from heaven]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:16 (#3)

מִמַּ֥יִם רַבִּֽים

“out of many waters”

Here, **many waters** represents the sea. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [out of the sea]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:16 (#4)

מִמַּ֥יִם רַבִּֽים

“out of many waters”

Here, **many waters**, meaning the sea, represents deep trouble or dangerous situations. David uses this image because he had earlier described his enemies as dangerous flood waters. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [out of great trouble]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:17 (#1)

יַצִּילֵ֥נִי מֵאֹיְבִ֗י עָ֫זֹּ֥ו וּמִשֹּׂנְאַ֑י כִּֽי־אָ֝מְצְ֗ווּ מִמֶּֽנִּי

“He delivered me from my strong enemy, from the ones hating me, for they were stronger than me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because they were stronger than me, he delivered me from my strong enemy, from the ones hating me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 18:18 (#1)

בְּיֹ֣ום־אֵ֭ידִי

“on the day of my calamity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **calamity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [on a day that would have been disastrous for me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:19 (#1)

וַיֹּוצִיאֵ֥נִי לַ֝מֶּרְחָ֗ב

“And he brought me out to an open space”

Here David is speaking of being rescued as if he had been squeezed into a narrow space and God brought him out to an **open space**. The image suggests that David had been in a dangerous situation with no way to escape, but God enabled him to escape. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he set me free from danger] or [And he rescued me from my desperate situation]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:19 (#2)

יְחַלְּצֵ֑נִי כִּֽי־חָ֝פֵ֗ץ בִּֽי

“he delivered me because he delighted in me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase **delivered me** describes. Alternate translation: [because he delighted in me, he delivered me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 18:20 (#1)

יִגְמְלֵנִי יְהוָה כְּצִדְקָתִי כְּבֹר יָדַי יָשִׁיב לִי

“Yahweh has rewarded me according to my righteousness, according to the cleanness of my hands he has given back to me”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has rewarded me according to my righteousness; yes, according to the cleanness of my hands he has given back to me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 18:20 (#2)

כְּצִדְקָתִי

“according to my righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to the right things I have done] or [because I have acted righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:20 (#3)

כְּבֹר יָדַי

“according to the cleanness of my hands”

David is speaking of his actions as if they were his **hands**, which could be physically clean or dirty. He means that his behavior has been morally pure. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly here and in verse 25. Alternate translation: [according to the innocence of my actions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:20 (#4)

יָשִׁיב לִי

“he has given back to me”

David is using **he has given back to me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “he has treated me in the same way.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has treated me in the same way]

See: Idiom

Psalms 18:21 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 18:21 (#2)

שָׁמַרְתִּי דַּרְכֵי יְהוָה

“I have kept the ways of Yahweh”

David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a way or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have lived as Yahweh commands] or [I have obeyed Yahweh’s commands]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:21 (#3)

וְלֹא־רָשַׁעְתִּי מֵאֱלֹהָי

“and I have not been wicked from my God”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context, specifically in the next verse, if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and I have not been so wicked as to turn away from my God]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 18:22 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation of why Yahweh has rewarded David according to his righteousness. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a word that introduces an explanation. Alternate translation: [Indeed,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 18:22 (#2)

כָּל־מִשְׁפָּטָ֥יו לְנֶגְדִּ֑י

“all of his judgments {are} before me”

David is speaking of **judgments** as if they were objects that could be physically placed in front of him. This means that he constantly remembers and thinks about God’s laws. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am always mindful of his judgments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:22 (#3)

וְחֻקֹּתָ֥יו לֹא־אָסִ֖יר מֶּ֣נִּי

“and his statutes, I have not turned away from them”

David is speaking of God’s **statutes** as if they were objects that he could physically turn away from. Your language may have a comparable expression you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I have not disobeyed his statutes]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:23 (#1)

מֵעֲוֹנִֽי

“from my iniquity”

David is using the possessive form to mean sin that he could have committed. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [from any iniquity that I might have committed]

See: Possession

Psalms 18:24 (#1)

כְּצִדְקָתִ֑י

“according to my righteousness”

See how you translated the phrase **according to my righteousness** in 18:20.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:24 (#2)

כְּבֹ֖ר יָדַ֣י

“according to the cleanness of my hands”

See how you translated the phrase **according to the cleanness of my hands** in 18:20.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:24 (#3)

לְנֶ֥גֶד עֵינָֽיו

“before his eyes”

Here, **before his eyes** represents how God sees and evaluates people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his judgment] or [by his standards]

See: Idiom

Psalms 18:25 (#1)

עִם־חָסִ֣יד

“With the faithful”

David is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [To people who are faithful]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 18:26 (#1)

נָבָ֑ר

“the purified”

The expression **the purified** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [those who purify themselves] or [those who keep themselves pure]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:26 (#2)

עִ֝עָקֵ֗שׁ

“the crooked”

Here David is speaking of people who deliberately do what is wrong as if they were physically **crooked** or bent. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who do evil] or [those who are dishonest]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:27 (#1)

עַם־עָנִ֥י & רָמִ֗ים

“a lowly people & the ones being high”

Here David is speaking as if oppressed or poor people were **lowly**, that is, in a physically low place, and as if proud people were physically **high**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [an oppressed people ... prideful people] or [poor people ... prideful people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:27 (#2)

וְעֵינַ֖יִם רָמִ֣ות תַּשְׁפִּֽיל

“but the eyes {of} the ones being high, you bring them down”

Here, **eyes** represents the proud looks or arrogant attitude of people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but the proud looks of the ones being high, you humble]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:28 (#1)

אַתָּ֣ה תָאִ֣יר נֵרִ֑י יְהוָ֥ה אֱלֹהַ֝י יַגִּ֗יהַּ חָשְׁכִּֽי

“you light my lamp; Yahweh my God lightens my darkness”

Here David is speaking as if his life were actually **a lamp** that God lights and as if his troubles were actually **darkness** that God brightens. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [you give me life like lighting a lamp; Yahweh my God helps me through troubles like someone who brightens darkness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:29 (#1)

אָרֻ֣ץ גְּד֑וּד

“I run {after} a troop”

This could mean: (1) that David is saying that by God’s help, he can pursue and overtake a **troop**. He may be recalling how he and his men were able to overtake the Amalekite “troop” (1 Samuel 30:8) that had raided Ziklag and rescue their families and possessions. Alternate translation: [I can pursue and overtake a raiding band], or (2) that David is saying that by God’s help, he can directly attack and disperse an opposing group of soldiers. Alternate translation: [I can run through a troop] or [I can attack and disperse an opposing troop]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:29 (#2)

אֲדַלֶּג־שֽׁוּר

“I leap {over} a wall”

David is speaking of successfully leading troops to capture a fortified city as if he and they would **leap** over its walls. He may be recalling how he and his soldiers were able to capture the stronghold of Zion in Jerusalem (2 Samuel 5:6–9). If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I can surmount the walls of a fortified city]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:30 (#1)

תָּמִ֣ים דַּרְכּ֑וֹ

“his way {is} perfect”

Here David is speaking of how God acts and directs others as if it were a **way** or path that he was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everything he does is faultless] or [he always acts righteously]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:30 (#2)

אִמְרַת־יְהוָ֥ה

“The word of Yahweh”

Here, **word of Yahweh** represents what Yahweh says by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What Yahweh says]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:30 (#3)

צְרוּפָ֥ה

“is refined”

The expression **is refined** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [is pure]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:30 (#4)

מָגֵ֣ן הֽוּא־לְכֹ֔ל ׀ הַחֹסִ֖ים בּֽוֹ

“He {is} a shield to all of the ones taking refuge in him”

David is speaking as if God were actually **a shield** behind which people take **refuge**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He protects everyone who trusts him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:31 (#1)

כִּ֤י מִֽי־אֱ֙לוֹהַּ֙ מִבַּלְעֲדֵ֣י יְהוָ֔ה וּמִ֥י צ֖וּר זוּלָתִ֥י אֱלֹהֵֽינוּ

“For who is God except Yahweh? And who is a rock except our God”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [For Yahweh is the only God! And our God is the only rock!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 18:31 (#2)

צ֖וּר

“is a rock”

David speaks of God here as if he were a **rock** that people can hide behind or stand on for safety. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [provides safety]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:32 (#1)

הָ֝מְאַזְּרֵ֗נִי חָ֫יִל

“is the one girding me {with} valor”

Here David is speaking of valor as if it were a piece of clothing with which God **is the one girding** him, like a belt or piece of armor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [makes me valiant]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:32 (#2)

וַיִּתֵּ֖ן תָּמִ֣ים דַּרְכִּֽי

“and he makes my way perfect”

This could mean: (1) that God makes the **way** on which a person travels **perfect**, that is, free from obstacles. Alternate translation: [and he removes all the obstacles in my path] or [and he enables me to live the life he has chosen for me without hindrance], or (2) that David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person is walking along. Alternate translation: [and he enables me to live in just the way that he wants people to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:33 (#1)

מְשַׁוֶּ֣ה רַגְלַ֣י כָּאַיָּל֑וֹת

“making my feet like a deer”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [making my feet like the feet of a deer]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 18:33 (#2)

מְשַׁוֶּ֣ה רַגְלַ֣י כָּאַיָּל֑וֹת

“making my feet like a deer”

Here David is comparing his ability to move quickly and surely with the way a deer moves in difficult terrain. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [making my feet secure] or [keeping me from stumbling]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:33 (#3)

וְעַ֖ל בָּמֹתַ֣י יַעֲמִידֵֽנִי

“and he makes me stand on my high places”

David may be using this possessive form, referring to these as **my high places**, because he is recalling how

he had to hide among cliffs when Saul was trying to kill him. It may be more natural in your language to express this meaning with a different form. Alternate translation: [and he keeps me from falling from any high places where I have to go]

See: Possession

Psalms 18:34 (#1)

מְלַמֵּד יָדַי לַמִּלְחָמָה

“training my hands for war”

David is using his **hands** to represent all of him in the act of fighting in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [training me for war]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 18:35 (#1)

וַתִּתֶּן־לִי֙ מָגֵ֣ן יִשְׁעֶ֔ךָ

“And you give to me the shield of your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the shield you provide for me saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:35 (#2)

וַתִּתֶּן־לִי֙ מָגֵ֣ן יִשְׁעֶ֔ךָ

“And you give to me the shield of your salvation”

Here David is speaking of God’s power to save him as if it were a **shield** that could protect him from physical attacks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you protect me by saving me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:35 (#3)

וִימִינְךָ֣

“and your right hand”

Here, **right hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:35 (#4)

וְעַנְוָתְךָ֣

“and your humility”

By **your humility**, David means God’s humbleness in responding to his prayers requesting help. Because God was much greater and more powerful than David, David views God’s response to his prayers as an act of humility. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and your answer to my prayers] or [and your humble answer to my prayers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:36 (#1)

תַּרְחִיב צַעֲדִי תַחְתָּנִי

“You enlarge my step under me”

Here David’s **step** represents the place where he would step. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [You enlarge the place where I step under me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:36 (#2)

תַּרְחִיב צַעֲדִי תַחְתָּנִי

“You enlarge my step under me”

David is speaking as if God had made the area where he needed to walk more spacious. This represents having freedom to move and act without being constrained by enemies. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [You give me room to maneuver]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:38 (#1)

וְלֹא־יָכְל֣וּ קָ֭קוּם יִפְּל֣וּ תַ֥חַת רַגְלָֽי

“so that they were not able to rise; they fell under my feet”

David is describing one event before describing another event that preceded it. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they happened, as in the UST. Alternate translation: [so that they fall under my feet and were not able to arise]

See: Order of Events

Psalms 18:38 (#2)

יִפְּל֣וּ

“they fell”

The implication is that David’s enemies fall and remain dead. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they fall down dead]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:39 (#1)

וַתְּאַזְּרֵנִי חַיִל

“And you gird me {with} valor”

Here David is speaking as if God were actually girding him **with valor**, as if valor were a belt or sash that could be wrapped around him. David means that God gives him courage and strength for battle. See how you translated a similar expression in 18:32. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you make me valiant]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:39 (#2)

תַּכְרִיַע קָמַי תַּחְתָּי

“you make the ones rising up under me bow down”

David means that people who try to rebel against him ultimately **bow down** as a symbolic action by which they show renewed submission to his authority. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [you make the ones rising up under me submit humbly to my authority]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 18:39 (#3)

קָמַי תַּחְתָּי

“the ones rising up under me”

David is using **the ones rising up under me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “those who rebel against my rule.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones revolting against my rule]

See: Idiom

Psalms 18:40 (#1)

נָתַתָּה לִּי עֹרֶף

“you give to me the back of {their} neck”

David is describing a symbolic action in which victorious soldiers would make defeated enemies lie face down on the ground and then would step on their necks to demonstrate their complete triumph (as in Joshua 10:24, for example). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [you enable me to step in complete triumph on the back of their necks]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 18:40 (#2)

עֹרֶף

“the back of {their} neck”

In this verse, the words **back** and **neck** are singular in form, but they refer to all the enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use plural forms of “back” and “neck.” Alternate translation: [the backs of their necks]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 18:40 (#3)

וּמְשַׂנְאַי

“the ones hating me”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [you give to me the ones hating me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 18:41 (#1)

עַל־יְהוָה

“to Yahweh”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [they called to Yahweh]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 18:41 (#2)

וְלֹא עָנָם

“but he did not answer them”

By **he did not answer them**, David means that Yahweh did not help his enemies as they had asked. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [but he did not do what they asked]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:42 (#1)

וְאֶשְׁחָקֵם כְּעָפָר עַל־פְּנֵי־רוּחַ

“And I beat them fine as dust upon the face of the wind”

Here David is making a comparison between his defeated enemies and **dust upon the face of the wind**. The point of this comparison is that just as dust upon the face of the wind is completely scattered and powerless, so his enemies became completely defeated and scattered. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And I beat them so that they scattered completely like dust blown by the wind]

See: Simile

Psalms 18:42 (#2)

וְאֶשְׁחָקֵם כְּעָפָר עַל־פְּנֵי־רוּחַ

“And I beat them fine as dust upon the face of the wind”

Here David is speaking as if he had literally beaten his enemies into **dust** that blows away in the wind. He means that he completely defeated and destroyed them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I completely destroyed them and scattered them] or [And I crushed them completely and scattered them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:42 (#3)

כְּטִט־חוּצוֹת אֲרִיקֵם

“like the mud of the streets I cast them out”

David is making a comparison between his enemies and **mud of the streets**. The point of this comparison is that just as **mud of the streets** is worthless and easily discarded, so are his defeated enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I threw them out like worthless mud from the streets]

See: Simile

Psalms 18:43 (#1)

תְּפַלְּטֵנִי מֵרִיבֵי עָם

“You rescue me from the disputes of people”

By **people**, David most likely means “my people” as in the parallel passage in (2 Samuel 22:44). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation, as in the UST, if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You rescue me from the disputes of my people]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:43 (#2)

לְרֹאשׁ גּוֹיִם

“as the head of nations”

Here David is speaking of his leadership role as if he were the **head** of a body. Just as the head directs the rest of the body, David ruled over other nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as the ruler of nations] or [to govern the nations]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:44 (#1)

לִשְׁמַע אֹזֶן

“At the hearing of an ear”

David is using one part of a person, the **ear** to represent entire people in the act of hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When they listen]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 18:44 (#2)

לִשְׁמַע אֹזֶן

“At the hearing of an ear”

David means that these people hear specifically about him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When they hear about me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:44 (#3)

יִשָּׁמָעוּ לִי

“they hear me”

By **they hear me**, David means that they obey him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they obey me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:44 (#4)

בְּנֵי־נֵכָר

“sons of the foreigner”

David is not referring to a specific **foreigner**. He means foreigners in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [sons of foreigners]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 18:44 (#5)

בְּנֵי־נֵכָר

“sons of the foreigner”

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the common expression of their culture **sons of** to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, these people have the characteristic of being foreigners or people from other nations. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [foreigners]

See: Idiom

Psalms 18:44 (#6)

יְכַחֲשׁוּ־לִי

“cringe to me”

By **cringe to me**, David means that foreigners will submit to him and show him respect out of fear. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [cringe before me] or [came cringing before me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 18:45 (#1)

בְּנֵי־נֵכָר

“Sons of the foreigner”

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the expression **Sons of** to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, the people whom David is describing have the characteristic of being soldiers of foreign countries that are resisting his rule. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Foreign soldiers]

See: Idiom

Psalms 18:45 (#2)

יִבֹּלוּ

“fade away”

Here David is speaking of foreign armies as if they were plants that **fade away** and lose their vitality. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [lose strength]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:46 (#1)

חַי־יְהוָה

“Yahweh is alive”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, joy. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [I rejoice that Yahweh is alive] or [How wonderful that Yahweh lives]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 18:46 (#2)

וּבָרוּךְ צוּרִי

“And blessed be my rock”

The expression **blessed be** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And I bless my rock]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:46 (#3)

צוּרִי

“my rock”

See how you translated a similar phrase in 18:31.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:46 (#4)

וְיָרוּם אֱלוֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי

“and may the God of my salvation be exalted”

The expression **be exalted** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and I exalt the God of my salvation]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:46 (#5)

אֱלוֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי

“the God of my salvation”

David is using this possessive form to describe **the God** who provides salvation to him. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the God who saves me]

See: Possession

Psalms 18:46 (#6)

אֱלוֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי

“the God of my salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who is the rock that saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:47 (#1)

וַיַּדְבֵּר עַמִּים תַּחְתָּי

“and he subdues peoples under me”

Here David is speaking of conquering **peoples** as if they were being brought down physically **under** his feet. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he defeats peoples before me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:48 (#1)

מִן־קָמַי תְּרוֹמְמֵנִי

“from the ones arising {against} me you lift me up”

Here David is speaking of his enemies as if they were physically **arising** upward to attack him, and he speaks of God as One who will physically **lift me up** above them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you make me prevail over those who attack me] or [you protect me from those who oppose me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 18:48 (#2)

מֵאִישׁ חָמָסׂ

“from a man of violence”

David is not referring to a specific **man of violence**. He means violent people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [from violent men]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 18:49 (#1)

וּלְשִׁמְךָ אֲזַמְּרָה

“and I will sing praise to your name”

Here, **name** represents Yahweh himself, in light of his fame and reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and I will sing praise to you] or [and I will sing praise to you, Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 18:50 (#1)

מגדל יְשׁוּעוֹת מַלְכּוֹ

“the one magnifying the salvation of his king”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one saving his king by great deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:50 (#2)

וְעֹשֶׂה חֶסֶד

“and doing covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and being faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 18:50 (#3)

לִמְשִׁיחוֹ

“to his anointed”

The expression **his anointed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could

express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [to the one he anointed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 18:50 (#4)

וּלְזַרְעֹו

“and to his seed”

Here David is speaking of his offspring as if they were actually **seed**. Just as a seed can grow into a plant that produces more seeds, David’s descendants would continue to come from his family line. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and to all who descend from him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 19 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 19 is a psalm about how God has revealed himself and glorifies himself through his physical creation, and how he reveals himself through his written revelation which he gave to the Israelites through Moses.

1. The heavens declare God’s glory (1–4b)
2. The sun in the heavens (4c–6)
3. The greatness and worth of God’s word and its effect (7–9)
4. The desirableness of God’s word (10)
5. The benefit of God’s word (11–12a)
6. Closing prayer (12b–14)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Terms for God’s commands and instructions

The psalmist uses many different words to refer to God’s message to us. You could decide to use a different word for each term, but most languages will not have that many, so just use the words that your language has. In verses 7–9 there are six different terms used for things that God commanded and taught his people.

1. “The law of Yahweh” in 19:7a. (See: law, law of Moses, law of Yahweh, law of God)
2. “The testimony of Yahweh” in 19:7b. Here the word “testimony” has a similar meaning to the word “law” in 19:7a, making the phrases “The law of Yahweh” and “the testimony of Yahweh” complementary. The phrase “the testimony of Yahweh” refers either to God’s entire law as a whole that he gave to the Israelites or more specifically to his law that he gave them through Moses on Mount Sinai.
3. “The precepts of Yahweh” in verse 19:8a. The word that is translated as “precepts” refers to something that is appointed or mandated so the phrase “the precepts of Yahweh” refers to the things that Yahweh mandated.
4. “The commandment of Yahweh” in 19:8b. See the note on this phrase in 19:8.
5. “The fear of Yahweh” in 19:9a. See the note on this phrase in 19:9.
6. “The judgments of Yahweh” in 19:9b. The word translated as “judgments” could also be translated as “ordinances” or “decisions” here and refers to decisions or judgments that are made. Here the phrase “the judgments of Yahweh” refers to the judicial instructions that Yahweh gave the Israelites for handling different types of situations involving people.

Psalms 19:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 19:1 (#1)

הַשָּׁמַיִם מְסַפְּרִים כְּבוֹד־אֵל וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדָיו מַגִּיד הָרָקִיעַ

“The heavens are declaring the glory of God, and the sky is proclaiming the work of his hands”

David is speaking of **the heavens** and **the sky** as if they were living things that could declare and proclaim God’s glory and works. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What people see in the heavens shows them the glory of God, and what they see in the sky tells them about the work of his hands]

See: Personification

Psalms 19:1 (#2)

כְּבוֹד־אֵל

“the glory of God”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that God is glorious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 19:1 (#3)

הַשָּׁמַיִם מְסַפְּרִים כְּבוֹד־אֵל וּמַעֲשֵׂי יָדָיו מַגִּיד הָרָקִיעַ

“The heavens are declaring the glory of God, and the sky is proclaiming the work of his hands”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [The heavens are declaring the glory of God, yes, the sky is proclaiming the work of his hands]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 19:1 (#4)

וּמַעֲשֵׂי יָדָיו מַגִּיד הָרָקִיעַ

“and the sky is proclaiming the work of his hands”

Here, **hands** represents the power and creative ability of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the sky is proclaiming what he has powerfully made] or [and the sky is proclaiming his mighty works]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 19:2 (#1)

יוֹם לְיוֹם יַבִּיעַ אֹמֶר וְלַיְלָה לְלַיְלָה יְחַוֶּה־דָּעַת

“Day to day makes flow forth a word, and night to night declares knowledge”

David is speaking of **Day to day** and **night to night** as if they were living things that could speak and declare knowledge. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Each day it is as if the daytime is speaking, and each night it is as if the nighttime is declaring knowledge]

See: Personification

Psalms 19:2 (#2)

יוֹם לְיוֹם יַבִּיעַ אֹמֶר

“Day to day makes flow forth a word”

Within the image of the day speaking, David is speaking of the day as if it were a spring that flows or bubbles forth water. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [It is as if each day is a spring that pours out words declaring God’s glory]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 19:2 (#3)

אֹמֶר

“a word”

David is not referring to a specific **word**. He means words in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [words]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 19:2 (#4)

יוֹם לְיוֹם & וְלַיְלָה לְלַיְלָה

“Day to day & and night to night”

David assumes that readers will understand that **Day to day** means that each successive day continues to proclaim God’s glory, and **night to night** means that each successive night continues to declare knowledge about God. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Each day ... and each night]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 19:3 (#1)

בְּבִלְתִּי נִשְׁמָע קוֹלָם

“their voice is not being heard”

The pronoun **their** refers to the heavens. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [where the voice of the heavens is not being heard]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 19:3 (#2)

בְּבִלְתִּי נִשְׁמָע קוֹלָם

“their voice is not being heard”

The expression **their voice is not being heard** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [where people do not hear their voice]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 19:3 (#3)

בְּלִ֣י נִשְׁמָ֣ע קוֹלָֽם

“their voice is not being heard”

Here David speaks of the “heavens” as if they were a living thing that could speak and have their **voice** heard but remains silent. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they do not have a voice to speak]

See: Personification

Psalms 19:4 (#1)

קַוָּ֗ם & מִלֵּיהֶ֫ם & בָּ֥הֶם

“Their line & their words & in them”

The pronouns **Their** and **them** refer to the heavens. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The heaven’s line ... the heaven’s words ... in the heavens] or [The line of the heaven’s ... the words of the heaven’s ... in the heavens]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 19:4 (#2)

בְּכָל־הָאָ֥רֶץ ׀ יָ֘צָ֤א קַוָּ֗ם

“Their line has gone out through all of the earth”

The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) and the Peshitta (the Syriac translation of the Bible) read “Their voice” instead of “their line.” That may have been the original reading, particularly since it would then make this line a parallelism with the second line in the verse with “Their voice” and **their words** being parallel ideas. At one point in the process of transmission, scribes may have accidentally left out the additional Hebrew letter that would have spelled “Their voice” rather than **Their line**. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 19:4 (#3)

וּבִקְצֵ֖ה תֵּבֵ֣ל מִלֵּיהֶ֑ם

“and their words to the end of the world”

David is speaking of the heavens as if they were living things that could speak **words**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they display God’s glory to the end of the world]

See: Personification

Psalms 19:4 (#4)

וּבִקְצֵ֖ה תֵּבֵ֣ל מִלֵּיהֶ֑ם

“and their words to the end of the world”

David assumes that readers will know that **their words to the end of the world** refers to the message that the heavens proclaim about God’s glory and **to the end of the world** refers to the furthest extremities of the earth. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and their message to the furthest extremities of the earth] or [and their message to the most remote parts of the earth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 19:4 (#5)

לַשֶּׁ֥מֶשׁ שָׂ֝֗ם־אֹ֣הֶל בָּהֶֽם

“He has set in them a tent for the sun”

David is speaking of the heavens as if they were **a tent for the sun**. He means that God has placed the sun in the skies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has placed the sun in the heavens] or [He has put the sun in the skies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 19:5 (#1)

וְה֭וּא & יָשִׂ֣ישׂ & אֹ֑רַח

“and that & it rejoices & its path”

The demonstrative pronoun **that** and the pronouns **it** and **its** all refer to the sun. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the sun ... the sun rejoices ... its path]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 19:5 (#2)

וְהוּא כְּחָתָן יֹצֵא מֵחֻפָּתוֹ

“and that is like a bridegroom coming out from his chamber”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a bridegroom coming out from his chamber** is satisfied, joyful and radiant so is the sun as it rises. (Here the word **chamber** refers to a bedroom.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and that joyfully rises like a bridegroom coming out from his chamber] or [and it comes out joyfully and eagerly like a bridegroom leaving his bedroom]

See: Simile

Psalms 19:5 (#3)

יָשִׂישׂ כְּגִבּוֹר לָרוּץ אֹרַח

“it rejoices like a strong man to run its path”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **strong man** is eager and enthusiastic to **run**, so is the sun eager and enthusiastic to travel across the sky. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [it moves eagerly across the sky like a strong man who is eager to run a race]

See: Simile

Psalms 19:6 (#1)

מִקְצֵה הַשָּׁמַיִם ׀ מוֹצָאוֹ וּתְקוּפָתוֹ עַל־קְצוֹתָם

“From the end of the heavens is its going forth, and its circuit to the ends of them”

David assumes that readers will know that **the end of the heavens** and **the ends of them** refer to opposite horizons where the sun appears to begin and complete its daily journey across the sky. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [From the furthest extremities of the heavens is its going forth, and its circuit to the furthest extremities of them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 19:6 (#2)

מוֹצָאוֹ וּתְקוּפָתוֹ & מֵחַמָּתוֹ

“is its going forth, and its circuit & from its heat”

The pronouns **its** in the phrase **its going forth, and its circuit** and in the phrase **its heat** all refer to the sun. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [is the sun’s going forth, and the sun’s circuit ... from the sun’s heat]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 19:6 (#3)

וְאֵין נִסְתָּר מֵחַמָּתוֹ

“and there is nothing hidden from its heat”

The expression **nothing hidden** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and there is nothing that is able to escape from its heat]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 19:7 (#1)

מְשִׁיבַת נָפֶשׁ

“restoring the soul”

Here the word the ULT translates as **restoring** could mean: (1) “turning back” or “converting” and refer to changing one’s mind leading them to turn from (stop) a wrong way of living and turn towards (obey) God. Alternate translation: [converting the soul] or [turning one back to God], or (2) [refreshing.] Alternate translation: [refreshing the soul] or [reviving the soul]

Psalms 19:7 (#2)

מְשִׁיבַת נָפֶשׁ

“restoring the soul”

David is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [restoring the person]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 19:7 (#3)

פֶּתִי

“the simple”

David is using the adjective **simple** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [simple people] or [inexperienced people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 19:8 (#1)

מְשַׂמְּחֵי־לֵֽב

“making the heart rejoice”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s inner being, where emotions and desires exist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [causing people to rejoice]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 19:8 (#2)

מִצְוַת יְהוָ֥ה בָּ֝רָ֗ה

“the commandment of Yahweh is pure”

David is not referring to a specific **commandment** of God. He means Yahweh’s entire law as a whole, which includes all Yahweh’s commandments. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the commandments of Yahweh are pure]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 19:8 (#3)

בָּ֝רָ֗ה

“is pure”

David is speaking of **the commandment of Yahweh** as if it were physically **pure**, like something that contains no impurities or contaminants. He means that the commandment is morally perfect and completely right. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is totally righteous]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 19:8 (#4)

מְאִירַ֥ת עֵינָֽיִם

“enlightening the eyes”

Here, **eyes** represents the ability to see and understand. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [giving guidance for living] or [giving insight for how to live wisely]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 19:9 (#1)

יִרְאַ֣ת יְהוָ֣ה ׀ טְהוֹרָ֣ה

“The fear of Yahweh is clean”

Here, **The fear of Yahweh** represents the obedience to his laws or commands that is the result of that reverence and that produces a clean life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Carefully obeying the law of Yahweh keeps one clean] or [the reverence given to Yahweh that results in obedience to him produces a clean life]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 19:9 (#2)

יִרְאַ֣ת יְהוָ֣ה ׀ טְהוֹרָ֣ה

“The fear of Yahweh is clean”

David is speaking of the fear of Yahweh as if it were something that could be **clean**. He means that the fear of Yahweh causes people to obey him, which results in a life that is pure and without moral fault. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The fear of Yahweh results in a morally pure life] or [The fear of Yahweh results in obedience to him which produces a faultless life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 19:10 (#1)

הַנֶּחֱמָדִ֤ים מִזָּ֨הָב֙ וּמִפַּ֣ז רָ֔ב וּמְתוּקִ֖ים מִדְּבַ֣שׁ וְנֹ֑פֶת צוּפִֽים

“They are to be desired more than gold, and more than much fine gold, and they are more sweet than honey and nectar of honeycombs”

The point of this comparison is that just as **gold** is valuable and therefore desirable, and as **honey** is sweet, so the commandments of Yahweh are valuable and pleasant. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [The commandments of Yahweh are extremely valuable and pleasant, like gold and honey]

See: Simile

Psalms 19:10 (#2)

הַנֶּחֱמָדִ֤ים & וּמְתוּקִ֖ים מִדְּבַ֣שׁ

“They are to be desired & and they are more sweet than honey”

The pronoun **They** refers to the “commandments” of Yahweh mentioned in the preceding verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The commandments of Yahweh are worth

... the commandments of Yahweh are sweeter than honey]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 19:10 (#3)

וְנֹפֶת

“and nectar of”

The word translated as **nectar** refers specifically to honey which drips or flows from a honeycomb. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly by translating it as “honey.” Alternate translation: [and honey of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 19:11 (#1)

עַבְדְּךָ נִזְהָרָ֥ בָהֶ֗ם בְּשָׁמְרָ֥ם עֵ֝קֶב רָֽב

“by them your servant is warned; in keeping them there is great reward”

Both occurrences of the pronoun **them** refer to the commandments and teachings of Yahweh described in verses 7–10. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [by Yahweh’s commandments your servant is warned; in obeying his commandments there is great reward]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 19:11 (#2)

עַבְדְּךָ נִזְהָרָ֥

“your servant is warned”

David is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [I, your servant, am warned] or [I am warned]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 19:11 (#3)

עַבְדְּךָ נִזְהָרָ֥ בָהֶ֗ם

“by them your servant is warned”

The expression **by them your servant is warned** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [they warn your servant] or [Yahweh warns your servant by them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 19:12 (#1)

שְׁגִיא֑וֹת מִֽי־יָ֝בִ֗ין

“Who can discern {his} errors”

David is using the question form to emphasize that no one can fully understand all of their own sins and mistakes. If you would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate his words as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No one can discern all his own errors!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 19:12 (#2)

שְׁגִיא֑וֹת & מִנִּסְתָּרוֹת

“his} errors & from hidden {faults”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context, as in the ULT, if that would be clearer in your language.

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 19:12 (#3)

מִנִּסְתָּרוֹת נַקֵּ֥נִי

“Acquit me from hidden {faults”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. David is asking God to forgive him. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please acquit me from hidden faults]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 19:13 (#1)

מִזֵּדִ֗ים ׀ חֲשֹׂ֣ךְ עַבְדֶּ֣ךָ אַל־יִמְשְׁלוּ־בִ֑י

“keep back your servant from presumptuous ones; let them not rule over me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please keep back your servant from presumptuous ones; please do not let them rule over me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 19:13 (#2)

חַשֹּׂךְ עַבְדֶּךָ

“keep back your servant”

David is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [keep me back]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 19:13 (#3)

מִזֵּדִים

“from presumptuous ones”

David is using the adjective **presumptuous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of sin. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [presumptuous sins] or [deliberate sins]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 19:13 (#4)

אַל־יִמְשְׁלוּ־בִּי

“let them not rule over me”

David assumes that readers will know that **them** refers to **presumptuous** sins. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [let presumptuous sins not rule over me] or [let these presumptuous sins not rule over me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 19:13 (#5)

מִפֶּשַׁע רָב

“from great transgression”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgression**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from doing something very wrong] or [from sinning greatly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 19:14 (#1)

יִהְיוּ & אִמְרֵי־פִי

“Let the words of my mouth & be”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. David is using this form to make a humble petition to Yahweh. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [I ask that the words of my mouth ... be] or [Please let the words of my mouth ... be]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 19:14 (#2)

אִמְרֵי־פִי

“the words of my mouth”

Here, **the words of my mouth** represent what David says by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what I say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 19:14 (#3)

וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי

“and the meditation of my heart”

Here **my heart** represents where David’s thoughts and feelings exist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my inner thoughts] or [and what I think within myself]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 19:14 (#4)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here God’s **face** represents his presence and by extension his sight. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to you] or [in your sight]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 19:14 (#5)

צוּרִי

“my strength”

See how you translated the phrase “my strength” in 18:1.

Psalms - Chapter 20 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 20 is considered to be one of the "royal psalms." See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the royal psalms.

1. Prayer for the king that Yahweh would protect and help him in battle (1–2)
2. Prayer that Yahweh would accept the king's offerings (3)
3. Prayer that Yahweh would fulfill the king's desires and plans (4)
4. Anticipation of Yahweh giving his king victory (5)
5. Expression of confidence in Yahweh (6–8)
6. Closing prayer (9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Trust

In verse 7 David asserts that trusting in Yahweh is better than trusting in military might. (See: trust, trusted, trustworthy, trustworthiness)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

In verses 1–5 who do the pronouns "you" and "your" refer to?

In this psalm all occurrences of the pronouns "you" and "your" that occur in verses 1–5 are singular and refer to Yahweh's anointed king mentioned in verse 6. Because verse 6 identifies who the pronouns "you" and "your" refer to, you do not need to make this explicit in your translation. Also, if your language has both singular and plural second person pronouns, you should use the singular forms each time you translate the pronouns "you" and "your" in verses 1–5.

Psalms 20:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 20:1 (#1)

בְּיוֹם צָרָה

"in the day of trouble"

David is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when you experience trouble] or [in time of trouble]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 20:1 (#2)

שֵׂשֶׂם ׀ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב

"the name of the God of Jacob"

David is using the term **name** to represent the person and character of God himself, including his attributes and covenant faithfulness to deliver his people when they call on him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the God of Jacob]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 20:1 (#3)

יְשַׂגֶּבְךָ

"may & set you on high"

David is speaking of Yahweh protecting his anointed king as if Yahweh would **set** him up on a **high** place where his enemies could not reach and harm him. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may ... keep you safe] or [may ... keep you from being harmed by your enemies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 20:2 (#1)

יִשְׁלַח־עֶזְרְךָ

"May he send you help"

David assumes that readers will know that **help** means military assistance or deliverance from enemies. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [May he help you prevail against your adversaries with aid]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:2 (#2)

יִשְׁלַח־עֶזְרְךָ מִקֹּדֶשׁ

"May he send you help from the sanctuary"

David assumes that readers will know that **the sanctuary** refers to the temple in Jerusalem, the place where God's presence dwells. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers.

Alternate translation: [May he send you help from his sanctuary, the Temple]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:2 (#3)

יִשְׁלַח־עֶזְרְךָ מִקֹּדֶשׁ וּמִצִּיּוֹן יִסְעָדֶךָּ

“May he send you help from the sanctuary and support you from Zion”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [May he send you help from the sanctuary, yes, may he support you from Zion]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 20:3 (#1)

יִזְכֹּר כָּל־מִנְחֹתֶיךָ

“May he remember all of your grain offerings”

David assumes that readers will know that when God remembers someone’s offerings, he acts favorably toward that person based on those offerings. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [May he take notice of all of your offerings and act accordingly]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:3 (#2)

וְעוֹלָתְךָ יְדַשְּׁנֶה

“and regard as fat your burnt offering”

David is using **regard as fat** as a common expression of his culture to mean “accept” or “be pleased with.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Idiom

Psalms 20:4 (#1)

כִּלְּבָבֶךָ

“according to your heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s desires exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what you desire] or [the desires of your heart]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 20:4 (#2)

כִּלְּבָבֶךָ

“according to your heart”

David assumes that readers will understand that **your heart** refers to the king’s desires or wishes. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [according to your heart’s desire]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:5 (#1)

נָרַנְנָה & נִדְגְּלָה

“We will shout for joy & we will set up {our} banners”

In this context, the forms of the two verbs the ULT translates as **We will shout for joy** and **we will set up our banners** could indicate: (1) a resolution of the will and therefore be translated as in the ULT, or (2) a request. Alternate translation: [May we shout for joy … may we set up our banners]

Psalms 20:5 (#2)

נָרַנְנָה ׀ בִּֽישׁוּעָתֶךָ

“We will shout for joy over your salvation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **joy** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [When you save us, then we will joyfully shout]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 20:5 (#3)

וּבְשֵׁם־אֱלֹהֵֽינוּ

“and in the name of our God”

Here David is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to his reputation. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and for the glory of our God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 20:5 (#4)

נְדַגֹּ֗ל

“we will set up {our} banners”

A **banner** is a flag made from a large piece of cloth that is attached to a long pole. People, groups, and kings had their own unique banners by which they identified themselves. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of flag, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [we will set up our flags]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 20:5 (#5)

וּבְשֵׁ֣ם־אֱלֹהֵ֣ינוּ נְדַגֹּ֑ל

“and in the name of our God we will set up {our} banners”

Raising banners was a symbolic action by which armies showed victory. In this context it was done in order to give God the glory for helping the soldiers of the Israelite army defeat their enemies. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and in the name of our God we will raise our banners to celebrate the victory Yahweh has given us]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 20:6 (#1)

מָשִׁ֥יחַ

“his anointed”

You may be used to indicating when David is referring to himself in the third person by saying something such as “me, his anointed.” However, we recommend that you not do that in this instance, since the term **anointed** here refers to others besides David.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 20:6 (#2)

מָשִׁ֥יחַ

“his anointed”

David assumes that readers will know that **his anointed** refers to the king of Israel, whom God had chosen and set apart by anointing with oil. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [his anointed king]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:6 (#3)

מְשִׁיחוֹ

“his anointed”

The expression **his anointed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [the one whom he had anointed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 20:6 (#4)

בִּגְבֻר֣וֹת יֵ֖שַׁע יְמִינֽוֹ

“with mighty deeds of salvation of his right hand”

Here, **right hand** represents the power of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with mighty deeds by his great power to save]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 20:6 (#5)

בִּגְבֻר֣וֹת יֵ֖שַׁע יְמִינֽוֹ

“with mighty deeds of salvation of his right hand”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with mighty deeds of his saving right hand]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 20:7 (#1)

אֵ֭לֶּה בָּרֶ֣כֶב וְאֵ֑לֶּה בַּסּוּסִ֥ים

“These in chariots and these in horses”

David is using **These in chariots and these in horses** as a common expression of his culture to mean “Some trust in chariots and some in horses” or “Some trust in chariots and others in horses.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Some in chariots and some in horses] or [Some trust in chariots and others trust in horses]

See: Idiom

Psalms 20:7 (#2)

אֵ֭לֶּה בָּרֶ֣כֶב וְאֵ֑לֶּה בַּסּוּסִ֥ים

“These in chariots and these in horses”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [These trust in chariots and these trust in horses]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 20:7 (#3)

אֵ֭לֶּה בָּרֶ֣כֶב וְאֵ֑לֶּה בַּסּוּסִ֥ים

“These in chariots and these in horses”

David assumes that readers will know that chariots and horses were military equipment that symbolized military power and strength. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [These trust in their military chariots and these in their war horses]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:7 (#4)

וַ֝אֲנַ֗חְנוּ

“but we”

David uses the word **but** here to indicate a contrast between those who trust in military power and those who trust in Yahweh. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [however, we] or [in contrast, we]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 20:7 (#5)

נַזְכִּ֥יר

“will remember”

David assumes that readers will know that remembering the name of Yahweh means trusting in him and calling on him for help. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [will keep in mind] or [will be confident in]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:7 (#6)

בְּשֵׁ֖ם־יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵ֑ינוּ

“the name of Yahweh our God”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and his character which includes being very powerful. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh our God] or [Yahweh our powerful God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 20:8 (#1)

הֵ֭מָּה & וַ֝אֲנַ֗חְנוּ

“They & but we”

The pronoun **They** refers to those who trust in chariots and horses (mentioned in the previous verse), while the pronoun **we** refers to David and those who trust in Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Those who trust in those things ... but we who trust in Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 20:8 (#2)

הֵ֭מָּה כָּרְע֣וּ וְנָפָ֑לוּ

“They bow down and fall”

David assumes that readers will know that **bow down and fall** refers to being defeated in battle. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [They collapse and fall in battle]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 20:8 (#3)

וְנָפָ֑לוּ

“and fall”

Here, **fall** represents dying in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and fall dead]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 20:9 (#1)

יְהוָ֥ה הוֹשִׁ֑יעָה

“Save, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression

such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, please save]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 20:9 (#2)

יְהוָה הוֹשִׁיעָה

“Save, Yahweh”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, save the king] or [Yahweh, save us, your people]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 20:9 (#3)

יְהוָה הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ יַעֲנֵנוּ

“Save, Yahweh; may the king answer us”

The word the ULT translates as **the king** could belong: (1) with the second line, as in the ULT, or (2) with the first line. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, save the king! May he answer us]

Psalms 20:9 (#4)

בְיוֹם

“on the day”

David is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the time] or [when]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 21 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 21 is considered to be one of the “royal psalms.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the royal psalms.

1. The king rejoices in Yahweh’s strength (1)
2. Yahweh’s blessing of his chosen king (2–6)
3. The king’s trust in Yahweh (7)
4. The king will defeat his enemies with Yahweh’s help (8–12)
5. Final words regarding Yahweh’s strength and power (13)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Pronouns

There is a shift in how Yahweh is referred to in this psalm. In verses 1–6 David uses second person pronouns when Yahweh is addressed. In verse 7 Yahweh is referred to in the third person as “Yahweh” and as “the Most High.” In verses 8–13 David shifts back to using second person pronouns when Yahweh is being addressed. (See: First, Second or Third Person)

In this psalm, when the pronouns “you,” “we,” “them,” “their,” and “they” are used, it may at times be unclear to whom these pronouns are referring to. For help translating these pronouns, see the notes in the individual verses where these pronouns occur. (See: Pronouns — When to Use Them)

Psalms 21:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 21:1 (#1)

בְּעָזְּךָ & וּבִישׁוּעָתְךָ

“in your strength & and in your salvation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **strength** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because you are strong ... and because you save me] or [because you are powerful ... and because you save those who trust in you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 21:1 (#2)

יִשְׂמַח־מֶלֶךְ & יגיל

“the king rejoices & he exults”

You may be used to indicating when David is referring to himself in the third person by saying something such as “I, the king rejoice ... I exult.” However, we recommend that you not do that in this instance, since **the king** here, while including David, refers to others besides him.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 21:1 (#3)

מַה־יָּגִיל מְאֹד

“how greatly he exults”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [he rejoices so very much] or [he is extremely glad]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 21:2 (#1)

תַּאֲוַת לִבּוֹ

“the desire of his heart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desire**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what he desired]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 21:2 (#2)

תַּאֲוַת לִבּוֹ

“the desire of his heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s desires exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what he desired] or [what he desired in his inmost being]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 21:2 (#3)

וַאֲרֶשֶׁת שְׂפָתָיו

“and the request of his lips”

Here, **the request of his lips** represents what the king asked for by using his lips to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and what he asked for]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 21:3 (#1)

תְּקַדְּמֶנּוּ בִּרְכֹת טוֹב

“you meet him with blessings of good”

Here the phrase **you meet him** could mean: (1) that Yahweh met the king. Alternate translation: [you come to him with good blessings] or [you greet him with excellent blessings], or (2) that Yahweh anticipated what the king needed and was already working ahead of time before the king prayed in order to meet his needs. Alternate translation: [you anticipated his needs and came to him with blessings of good] or [you knew what he needed and met him with blessings of good]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:3 (#2)

בִּרְכֹת טוֹב

“with blessings of good”

The implication is that God blesses the king with good things. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [with good blessings] or [with excellent blessings]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:3 (#3)

בִּרְכֹת טוֹב

“with blessings of good”

This is poetic language. If your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [with rich blessings]

See: Poetry

Psalms 21:3 (#4)

תָּשִׁית

“you place”

David assumes that readers will know that Yahweh himself did not physically **place** a crown on David’s head but rather chose him to be king and had people crown him as king by placing a crown on his head. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you cause to be placed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:3 (#5)

תָּשִׁית לְרֹאשׁוֹ עֲטֶרֶת פָּז

“you place on his head a crown of refined gold”

Placing **a crown** on the king’s **head** was a symbolic action by which God showed that he was establishing the king in his royal authority and giving him honor. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [you

place on his head a crown of refined gold, showing that you have established him as king]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 21:4 (#1)

חַיִּים ׀ שָׁאַל מִמְּךָ

“He asked life from you”

Because the following line in this verse explains what **life** refers to, there is no need to explain this further here.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 21:4 (#2)

חַיִּים ׀ שָׁאַל מִמְּךָ נָתַתָּה לּוֹ אֹרֶךְ יָמִים עוֹלָם וָעֶד

“He asked life from you; you gave {it} to him, length of days, forever and ever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **life**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He asked you that he might live, and you granted his request and gave him length of days, forever and ever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 21:4 (#3)

אֹרֶךְ יָמִים

“length of days”

David assumes that readers will know that **length of days** means to live for many years. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [a long life] or [a lengthy life]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:5 (#1)

גָּדוֹל כְּבוֹדוֹ בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ הוֹד וְהָדָר תְּשַׁוֶּה עָלָיו

“His glory is great through your salvation; splendor and majesty you place on him”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **salvation**, **splendor**, and **majesty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [You glorify him greatly by saving him; you make him splendorous and majestic]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 21:5 (#2)

הוֹד וְהָדָר תְּשַׁוֶּה עָלָיו

“splendor and majesty you place on him”

The terms **splendor** and **majesty** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [great honor you place on him] or [magnificent glory you place on him]

See: Doublet

Psalms 21:5 (#3)

תְּשַׁוֶּה עָלָיו

“you place on him”

David assumes that readers will know that **place on him** here means “give to him.” You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you bestow on him] or [you give to him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:6 (#1)

תְּשִׁיתֵהוּ

“you place on him”

David assumes that readers will know that **him** refers to the king mentioned in the superscription and throughout the psalm. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you bestow on the king] or [you grant the king]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:6 (#2)

תְּשִׁיתֵהוּ בְרָכוֹת לָעַד תְּחַדֵּהוּ בְּשִׂמְחָה אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ

“you place on him eternal blessings; you make him glad with joy with your face”

The implication is that the king will rejoice in the presence of God, that is, he will rejoice because God is with him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you make him glad with joy because you are present with him] or [you make him rejoice because he is in your presence]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:6 (#3)

תְּשִׁיתֵהוּ בְרָכוֹת לָעַד

“you place on him eternal blessings”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **blessings**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you bless him eternally]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 21:6 (#4)

תְּחַדֵּהוּ בְּשִׂמְחָה

“you make him glad with joy”

This is poetic language. If your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [you make him very glad] or [you make him exceedingly glad]

See: Poetry

Psalms 21:6 (#5)

אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ

“with your face”

Here, **with your face** represents being in Yahweh’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in your presence] or [with your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 21:7 (#1)

הַמֶּלֶךְ

“the king”

Translate the phrase **the king** as you did in verse one of this Psalm.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 21:7 (#2)

וּבְחֶסֶד

“and through the covenant faithfulness of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and because he is faithful to the covenant of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 21:7 (#3)

עֶלְיוֹן

“the Most High”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:2.

Psalms 21:7 (#4)

בַּל־יִמּוֹט

“he will not be shaken”

See how you translated the similar phrase “I will not be shaken” in 15:5.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 21:8 (#1)

תִּמְצָא יָדְךָ לְכָל־אֹיְבֶיךָ יְמִינְךָ תִּמְצָא שֹׂנְאֶיךָ

“Your hand will find all of your enemies; your right hand will find the ones hating you”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Your hand will find all of your enemies, indeed, your right hand will find those who hate you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 21:8 (#2)

יָדְךָ

“Your hand”

The pronoun **Your** refers to the king. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You, the king’s hand] or [The king’s hand]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 21:8 (#3)

תִּמְצָא יָדְךָ & יְמִינְךָ תִּמְצָא

“Your hand will find & your right hand will find”

David is using **Your hand will find** as a common expression of his culture to mean “You will reach” or “You will overtake.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You will reach … you will overtake]

See: Idiom

Psalms 21:9 (#1)

תְּשִׁיתֵ֣מוֹ

“You will make them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the king’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You, the king, will make your enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 21:9 (#2)

תְּשִׁיתֵ֣מוֹ ׀ כְּתַנּ֣וּר אֵ֭שׁ

“You will make them as an oven of fire”

The point of this comparison is that just as **an oven of fire** completely consumes what is placed in it, so David is saying that God will completely destroy his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [You will completely consume them like fire in an oven]

See: Simile

Psalms 21:9 (#3)

תְּשִׁיתֵ֣מוֹ ׀ כְּתַנּ֣וּר אֵ֭שׁ

“You will make them as an oven of fire”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [You will make them as something that is burned in an oven of fire]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 21:9 (#4)

לְעֵ֣ת פָּ֭נֶיךָ

“at the time of your face”

Here, **your face** represents your presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [at the time of your appearing]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 21:9 (#5)

בְּאַפּ֑וֹ

“In his nose”

David is using the phrase **In his nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean that Yahweh is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In his anger] or [In his wrath]

See: Idiom

Psalms 21:9 (#6)

יְ֭הוָה & יְבַלְּעֵ֣ם וְתֹאכְלֵ֑ם אֵֽשׁ

“Yahweh will swallow them and will consume them {with} fire”

David is speaking of Yahweh destroying his enemies as if Yahweh will literally **swallow** them and burn them up with **fire**. If these images communicate well in your language, please use them. If not, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will destroy them completely, as if swallowing them or consuming them with fire]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 21:9 (#7)

יְ֭הוָה & יְבַלְּעֵ֣ם וְתֹאכְלֵ֑ם אֵֽשׁ

“Yahweh will swallow them and will consume them {with} fire”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will completely destroy them as if he was swallowing them; yes, he will consume them as if he was burning them with fire]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 21:10 (#1)

תְּאַבֵּ֣ד

“You will destroy”

The pronoun **You** refers to the king. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You, God’s king, will destroy]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 21:10 (#2)

פִּרְיָמוֹ & וְזַרְעָם

“their fruit & and their seed”

David is speaking of **their fruit** and **their seed** as if his enemies’ descendants were literal **fruit** and literal **seed** that could be destroyed. If this image does not communicate well in your language, you could express this as a comparison or use plain language. Alternate translation: [their descendants ... and their offspring]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 21:10 (#3)

מִבְּנֵי אָדָם

“from {among} the sons of man”

David is using **from among the sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “from among humanity” or “from the human race.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from among the human race] or [from among humanity]

See: Idiom

Psalms 21:11 (#1)

כִּי־נָטוּ עָלֶיךָ רָעָה חָשְׁבוּ מְזִמָּה בַּל־יוּכָלוּ

“Though they stretch out evil against you, they plan a plot they will not be able”

The pronoun **they** refers to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Though his enemies stretch out evil against you; his enemies plan a plot they will not be able]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 21:11 (#2)

נָטוּ עָלֶיךָ רָעָה

“they stretch out evil against you”

Here David is speaking of the king’s enemies’ plans to harm him as if they would physically **stretch out evil** like a net or trap. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they plan to harm you] or [they devise evil schemes against you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 21:11 (#3)

נָטוּ עָלֶיךָ רָעָה

“they stretch out evil against you”

David is using the adjective **evil** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [they stretch out evil things against you]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 21:11 (#4)

חָשְׁבוּ מְזִמָּה בַּל־יוּכָלוּ

“they plan a plot they will not be able”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [they plan a plot they will not be able to accomplish]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 21:12 (#1)

תְּשִׁיתֵמוֹ שֶׁשֶׁם

“you will make them shoulder”

David is using **you will make them shoulder** as a common expression of his culture to mean “you will make them turn and flee.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will make them turn their backs to you] or [you will put them to flight]

See: Idiom

Psalms 21:12 (#2)

בְּקֵמֶיתֶיךָ תְּכוֹנֵן

“on your strings you will set {your arrows”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language as the ULT has done by supplying the phrase **your arrows**. Alternate translation: [on your bow strings you will set your arrows]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 21:12 (#3)

עַל־פְּנֵיהֶם

“toward their faces”

David is using **their faces** to represent all of them in the act of fleeing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [toward them]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 21:13 (#1)

רָרוּמָה יְהוָה בְּעֻזֶּךָ & וְנְזַמְּרָה גְבוּרָתֶךָ

“Be exalted, Yahweh, in your strength & and we will praise your power”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **strength** and **power**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Be exalted, Yahweh, because you are strong ... and we will praise you because of how powerful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 21:13 (#2)

נָשִׁירָה וְנְזַמְּרָה גְבוּרָתֶךָ

“we will sing and we will praise your power”

The implication is that this singing and praising will happen after Yahweh shows his strength by defeating the enemies. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [then we will sing and we will praise your power]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 21:13 (#3)

נָשִׁירָה וְנְזַמְּרָה גְבוּרָתֶךָ

“we will sing and we will praise your power”

The pronoun **we** refers to David and the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [we, your people, will sing and we will praise you because of your power]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 22 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 22 contains several different but related themes of lament, prayer, trust, and hope for the future. Verses 1–21 are a lament. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about psalms of lament. Verses 22–31 praise Yahweh for his deliverance and kingship over the nations, and the worship he will receive in the future. Many Bible scholars consider Psalm 22 to be one of the “messianic psalms” because different New Testament authors quote parts of this psalm in relation to Jesus and because Jesus quotes the first line of verse 1 while on the cross. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the messianic psalms. (See: Christ, Messiah; and crucify, crucified; and lament, lamentation)

1. An anguished call to God (1–2)
2. An affirmation of God’s holiness and past deliverance of the Israelites (3–5)
3. David describes his situation (6–18)
4. A prayer for help (19–21)
5. Yahweh’s deliverance of David results in Yahweh being praised (22–26)
6. People from all parts of the world, all people groups, and rich and poor people will turn to Yahweh and worship him as king (27–29)
7. Future generations will praise Yahweh and will be told about his saving acts (30–31)

Psalms 22:0 (#2)

לַלַּמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַלַּמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 22:1 (#1)

מִמַּיְשׁוּעָתִי

“from the salvation of me”

David is using this possessive form to mean salvation that would come to him or rescue that he would receive. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [from saving me] or [from rescuing me]

See: Possession

Psalms 22:1 (#2)

מִמַּיְשׁוּעָתִי

“from the salvation of me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from saving me] or [from helping me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 22:1 (#3)

דִּבְרֵ֥י שַׁאֲגָתִֽי

“far from} the words of my groaning”

David is using this possessive form to mean words that express his groaning or words spoken while groaning. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [far from my groaning words] or [far from the words I speak while groaning]

See: Possession

Psalms 22:2 (#1)

אֱקְרָ֣א יוֹמָ֣ם וְלֹ֣א תַעֲנֶ֑ה וְ֝לַ֗יְלָה

“I call by day, but you do not answer, and {in} the night”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I call to you by day, but you do not answer, and I call to you in the night]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 22:2 (#2)

וְלֹא־דוּמִיָּ֥ה לִֽי

“and there is no silence for me”

By **there is no silence for me**, David means that he cannot rest or find peace because he is crying out to God throughout the night. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I cannot rest] or [and I find no peace]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:3 (#1)

יֹושֵׁ֣ב תְּהִלּ֣וֹת יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“sitting {in} the praises of Israel”

Here the phrase **the praises of Israel** could (1) be using the word **praises** to represent the Tabernacle where the Israelite people offered God their praises. Alternate translation: [sitting in the praises of us Israelite people, that we give to you in your Tabernacle] or [sitting in your Tabernacle] (2) mean that Yahweh is the object of Israel’s praises. Alternate translation: [sitting as the object of the praises of Israel] or [ruling as the one whom Israel praises]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:4 (#1)

אֲבֹתֵ֥ינוּ

“our fathers”

David is using the term **fathers** to mean “ancestors.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our forefathers]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:4 (#2)

בָּ֝טָ֗חוּ

“they trusted”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [they trusted in you]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 22:5 (#1)

וְנִמְלָ֑טוּ

“and they were rescued”

The expression **they were rescued** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form, as in the UST, or in another way that is natural in your language.

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 22:6 (#1)

וְאָנֹכִ֥י תוֹלַ֗עַת וְלֹא־אִ֫ישׁ

“But I am a worm and not a man”

Here David is speaking of himself as if he were a **worm**. He means that other people treat him as if he were worthless and do not care if he lives or not. If it would be helpful, you could use a comparable expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But I am treated as if I were a worthless worm and not a human]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:6 (#2)

חֶרְפַּ֣ת אָ֭דָם

“a reproach of mankind”

By **a reproach of mankind**, David means that he has become someone whom all people mock and shame. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [someone whom people mock] or [an object of shame to everyone]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:6 (#3)

וּבְז֣וּי עָֽם

“and despised by the people”

The expression **despised by the people** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and the people despise me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 22:7 (#1)

יַפְטִ֣ירוּ בְשָׂ֑פָה

“they open wide with the lip”

Here, **the lip** represents the mouth or speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they open their mouths wide] or [they sneer at me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:7 (#2)

יָנִ֖יעוּ רֹֽאשׁ

“They shake the head”

To **shake the head** was a symbolic action by which people showed contempt or mockery. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [They shake the head in mockery] or [They shake the head to show contempt]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 22:8 (#1)

גֹּ֣ל אֶל־יְהוָ֣ה יְפַלְּטֵ֑הוּ יַצִּילֵ֥הוּ כִּֽי־חָ֝פֵ֗ץ בּֽוֹ

“Roll to Yahweh; let him deliver him. Let him rescue him, since he delights in him”

This is the beginning of what David’s enemies said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of these enemies. Alternate translation: [saying “Roll to Yahweh; let him deliver him. Let him rescue him, since he delights in him]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 22:8 (#2)

גֹּ֣ל אֶל־יְהוָ֣ה

“Roll to Yahweh”

The enemies are using **Roll to** as a common expression of their culture to mean “commit your cause to” or “trust completely in.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Commit yourself to Yahweh] or [Trust completely in Yahweh]

See: Idiom

Psalms 22:8 (#3)

יְפַלְּטֵ֑הוּ יַצִּילֵ֥הוּ כִּֽי־חָ֝פֵ֗ץ בּֽוֹ

“let him deliver him. Let him rescue him, since he delights in him”

In this verse, the first and third occurrence of the pronoun **him**, and the pronoun **he** refer to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [let Yahweh deliver him. Let Yahweh rescue him, since Yahweh delights in him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 22:8 (#4)

יְפַלְּטֵ֑הוּ יַצִּילֵ֥הוּ

“let him deliver him. Let him rescue him”

The terms **deliver** and **rescue** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [let him save him]

See: Doublet

Psalms 22:9 (#1)

אַתָּ֣ה גֹחִ֣י מִבָּ֑טֶן

“you are the one pulling me out from the womb”

The implication is that God was the one who brought David safely into the world at birth. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you are the one who brought me safely into the world]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:9 (#2)

מַמַבְטִיחִ֥י עַל־שְׁדֵ֗י אִמִּֽי

“making me trust upon the breasts of my mother”

By **making me trust upon the breasts of my mother**, David means that God caused him to trust in God even when he was a nursing infant dependent on his mother. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [causing me to trust in you while I nursed at my mother’s breasts]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:10 (#1)

עָלֶ֥יךָ הָשְׁלַ֗כְתִּי מֵרֶ֫חֶם

“Upon you I was cast from the womb”

Here David is speaking as if he were literally **cast** upon God. He means that he has been made to rely on God from the moment of his birth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have been caring for me from the womb] or [I have depended on you from birth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:10 (#2)

עָלֶ֥יךָ הָשְׁלַ֗כְתִּי

“Upon you I was cast”

The expression **I was cast** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [You took me as your own] or [Yahweh, you took care of me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 22:11 (#1)

אַל־תִּרְחַ֥ק מִמֶּ֑נִּי

“You {do} not be far away from me”

Here David is giving a command, **do not be far away from me**, but he intends it to communicate a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [I ask you, please do not be far away from me] or [Yahweh, please do not be far away from me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 22:11 (#2)

כִּי־צָרָ֥ה קְרוֹבָ֑ה

“for trouble is near”

The implication is that David’s enemies or persecutors are approaching to harm him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for my enemies are approaching] or [for those who want to harm me are near]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:12 (#1)

סְ֭בָבוּנִי פָּרִ֣ים רַבִּ֑ים אַבִּירֵ֖י בָּשָׁ֣ן כִּתְּרוּנִֽי

“Many bulls surround me; strong ones of Bashan encircle me”

Here David is speaking of his enemies as if they were **bulls** that **surround** and **encircle** him. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Many enemies surround me like bulls; strong ones like those of Bashan encircle me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:12 (#2)

אַבִּירֵ֖י בָּשָׁ֣ן

“strong ones of Bashan”

The phrase **strong ones of Bashan** gives further information about the **Many bulls**. (David refers to **Bashan** because it was known for its rich pasturelands and so the bulls there would have been well fed and strong.) David is not distinguishing these **strong ones** from other bulls that are not strong. Be sure that this is clear in your translation. Alternate translation: [the powerful bulls of Bashan] or [the mighty bulls of Bashan]

See: Distinguishing Versus Informing or Reminding

Psalms 22:13 (#1)

פָּצְר֣וּ עָלַ֣י פִּיהֶ֑ם אַ֥רְיֵ֝֗ה טֹרֵ֥ף וְשֹׁאֵֽג

“They open their mouths against me, a tearing and roaring lion”

Here David is speaking of his enemies as if they were **a tearing and roaring lion**. He means that they are fierce and dangerous and want to destroy him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They open their mouths against me, like a fierce, roaring lion that tears apart its prey]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:14 (#1)

כַּמַּ֥יִם נִשְׁפַּ֑כְתִּי

“I am poured out like water”

The point of this comparison is that just as **water** flows away and cannot be gathered back, so David feels completely drained of strength and energy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I am completely drained of strength like spilled water]

See: Simile

Psalms 22:14 (#2)

כַּמַּ֥יִם נִשְׁפַּ֑כְתִּי

“I am poured out like water”

The expression **I am poured out** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the same idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I pour out like water] or [I flow away like water]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 22:14 (#3)

וְהִתְפָּרְד֥וּ כָל־עַצְמ֑וֹתָ֝י

“and all of my bones are dislocated”

David says **all of my bones are dislocated** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [and my whole body is in pain] or [and I feel like my bones are coming apart]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 22:14 (#4)

הָיָ֣ה לִ֭בִּי כַּדּוֹנָ֑ג נָ֝מַ֗ס בְּתוֹךְ־מֵעָֽי

“My heart is like wax; it has melted within my inner parts”

The point of this comparison is that just as **wax** melts and becomes soft when heated, so David’s **heart** has become weak and soft from fear and distress. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [My heart has become weak like melted wax within me]

See: Simile

Psalms 22:14 (#5)

הָיָ֣ה לִ֭בִּי כַּדּוֹנָ֑ג

“My heart is like wax”

Here David is speaking of his **heart** as if it were **wax** that has melted. This image emphasizes how completely weak and helpless he feels in his distress. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My courage has completely failed me] or [I feel completely weak inside]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:14 (#6)

כַּדּוֹנָ֑ג

“like wax”

Wax is a soft, fatty substance that becomes liquid when heated and is used to make candles. If your readers would not be familiar with what wax is, you could use the name of a similar substance that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [like soft fat] or [like something soft that melts]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 22:15 (#1)

יָבֵ֣שׁ כַּחֶ֣רֶשׁ ׀ כֹּחִ֑י

“My strength is dried up like a shard”

David is making a comparison between his strength and **a shard**. The point of this comparison is that just as a shard is completely dried out and brittle, so is his strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [My strength is completely dried up] or [I have lost my strength]

See: Simile

Psalms 22:15 (#2)

כַּחֶרֶשׂ

“like a shard”

A **shard** was a piece of broken pottery. If your readers would not be familiar with what a shard is, in your translation you could use the name of a comparable object that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [like a broken piece of pottery]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 22:15 (#3)

וּלְשׁוֹנִי מֻדְבָּק מַלְקוֹחָיִ

“and my tongue is being made to cling to my gums”

The expression **my tongue is being made to cling to my gums** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [my tongue clings to my gums] or [and you, Yahweh, allow me to suffer so that my tongue clings to my gums]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 22:15 (#4)

וְלַעֲפַר־מָוֶת תִּשְׁפְּתֵנִי

“and to the dust of death you lay me”

Here, **dust of death** represents the grave or dying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you lay me in the grave] or [and you bring me to death]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:16 (#1)

כִּי סְבָבוּנִי כְּלָבִים

“For dogs have surrounded me”

Here David is speaking of his enemies as if they were **dogs** that hunt in packs. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [For my enemies have surrounded me like dogs]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:16 (#2)

כָּאֲרִי

“like the lion”

The Hebrew text that the ULT is translated from reads **like the lion**. Other ancient manuscripts have a verb (instead of the noun translated as **like the lion**). At one point in the process of transmission, scribes may have mistakenly changed the last letter of the verb with the meaning “they have pierced” to a different (and similar looking) letter, resulting in the word **like the lion**. All the ancient versions of the Old Testament, as well as the early Jewish sources have verb forms instead of the noun form **like the lion**. The original text probably had the verb meaning “they have pierced” instead of the noun form translated **like the lion**. For this reason, you may wish to use the verb “they have pierced.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use whatever form it uses.

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 22:16 (#3)

כָּאֲרִי יָדַי וְרַגְלָי

“like the lion, my hands and my feet”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [like the lion tears my hands and my feet] or [like the lion attacks my hands and my feet]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 22:16 (#4)

כָּאֲרִי יָדַי וְרַגְלָי

“like the lion, my hands and my feet”

David is speaking of his enemies as if they were a **lion** tearing at his hands and feet. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [like a lion, they have mangled my hands and my feet]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:17 (#1)

אֲסַפֵּר כָּל־עַצְמוֹתָי

“I can count all of my bones”

David says **I can count all my bones** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your

language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [I am so thin and emaciated that I can count many of my bones] or [I am so thin and emaciated that people can see many of my bones]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 22:17 (#2)

הֵ֭הָמָּה יַבִּ֣יטוּ יִרְאוּ־בִֽי

“They look {and} they stare at me”

The pronoun **They** refers to David’s enemies who have surrounded him (mentioned in the previous verses as “dogs” and “a company of ones doing evil”). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [My enemies look and they stare at me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 22:17 (#3)

הֵ֭הָמָּה יַבִּ֣יטוּ יִרְאוּ־בִֽי

“They look {and} they stare at me”

The implication is that David’s enemies stare at him and gloat. You could include this information, as in the UST, if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:19 (#1)

וְאַתָּ֣ה

“But you”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between his enemies who surround and torment him and Yahweh whom he calls upon for help. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, you] or [As for you]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 22:19 (#2)

וְאַתָּ֣ה יְ֭הוָה אַל־תִּרְחָ֑ק אֱ֝אֵילוּתִ֗י לְעֶזְרָתִ֥י חוּשָֽׁה

“But you, Yahweh, {do} not be far away. My strength, hurry to help me”

The phrases **do not be far away** and **hurry to help me** are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than a commands. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [But you, Yahweh, please do not be far away. My strength, please hurry to help me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 22:19 (#3)

אַל־תִּרְחָֽק

“do} not be far away”

The implication is that David wants Yahweh to come near to help him in his time of great distress. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [come near to help me] or [be close and help me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:19 (#4)

אַל־תִּרְחָֽק

“do} not be far away”

David is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with a mild expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [be very near] or [stay close to me]

See: Litotes

Psalms 22:20 (#1)

הַצִּ֣ילָה

“Deliver”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please deliver]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 22:20 (#2)

מֵחֶ֑רֶב

“from the sword”

Here, **sword** represents “death by violence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from death]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:20 (#3)

מִיַּד & יְחִידָתִי

“my only one from the hand of”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [deliver my only one from the hand of]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 22:20 (#4)

יְחִידָתִי

“my only one”

David is using **my only one** as a common expression of his culture to mean “my precious life” or “my dear life.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my precious life]

See: Idiom

Psalms 22:20 (#5)

מִיַּד

“from the hand of”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:20 (#6)

כֶּלֶב

“the dog”

Here David is speaking of his enemies as if they were **the dog**. This continues the imagery from verse 16 where enemies are described as dogs that have surrounded him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my enemies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:21 (#1)

הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“Save me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please save me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 22:21 (#2)

מִפִּי אַרְיֵה וּמִקַּרְנֵי רֵמִים

“from the mouth of the lion, and from the horns of wild oxen”

Here David is speaking as if his enemies were dangerous animals with **mouths** and **horns** that could attack and kill him. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [from my enemies who attack me like lions and wild oxen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:22 (#1)

אֲסַפְּרָה שִׁמְךָ

“I will declare your name”

Here David is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I will declare how wonderful you are] or [I will proclaim your character]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:22 (#2)

לְאֶחָי

“to my brothers”

David is using the term **brothers** to describe people who are descended from the same ancestor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to my fellow Israelites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:23 (#1)

כָּל־זֶרַע יַעֲקֹב כַּבְּדוּהוּ וְגוּרוּ מִמֶּנּוּ כָּל־זֶרַע יִשְׂרָאֵל

“All of the seed of Jacob, honor him, and be terrified from him, all of the seed of Israel”

Here David is speaking of the descendants of Jacob, who Yahweh later renamed Israel, as if they were his **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the term "seed" in 18:50. Alternate translation: [All of the descendants of Jacob, honor him, and be terrified from him, all of you descendants of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:24 (#1)

עֱנֻוּת עָנְיִ֑י

"the affliction of the afflicted"

David is using the adjective **afflicted** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the affliction of the afflicted person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 22:24 (#2)

וְלֹא־הִסְתִּ֣יר פָּנָ֣יו מִמֶּ֑נּוּ

"and he has not hidden his face from him"

David is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with a mild expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [and he has shown his face to him] or [and he has listened to him]

See: Litotes

Psalms 22:24 (#3)

וְלֹא־הִסְתִּ֣יר פָּנָ֣יו מִמֶּ֑נּוּ

"and he has not hidden his face from him"

David is using **hidden his face from him** as a common expression of his culture to mean "ignored him" or "refused to help him." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he has not ignored him]

See: Idiom

Psalms 22:24 (#4)

שָׁמֵֽעַ

"he heard"

David assumes that readers will know that **he heard** means God heard his prayer and responded favorably to it. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he responded]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:25 (#1)

מֵֽאִתְּךָ֥ תְהִלָּ֑תִי

"From with you my praise"

Here, **with you** represents "because of what you have done." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Because you have delivered me I praise you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:26 (#1)

עֲנָוִ֥ים

"The poor"

David is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [The poor ones] or [Poor people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 22:26 (#2)

יְהַלְלוּ

"will praise"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [will praise him]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 22:26 (#3)

יְחִ֖י לְבַבְכֶ֣ם לָעַֽד

"May your heart live forever"

David is using **May your heart live forever** as a common expression of his culture to mean "May you live a long and prosperous life." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning

plainly. Alternate translation: [May you live long and prosper] or [May you have a long and blessed life]

See: Idiom

Psalms 22:26 (#4)

לְבַבְכֶם

“your heart”

The word **your** is plural here because David is addressing all the worshipers, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [your hearts]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 22:27 (#1)

כָּל־אַפְסֵי־אָרֶץ

“All of the ends of the earth”

Here the phrase, **the ends of the earth**, represents the people who live in the most distant places on earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [People everywhere on earth] or [People who live in the most distant places of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:27 (#2)

יִזְכְּרוּ

“will remember”

The implication is that the people **will remember** Yahweh and what he has done. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [will remember Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:27 (#3)

וְיָשֻׁבוּ אֶל־יְהוָה

“and turn to Yahweh”

David is speaking as if people had been walking in one direction but then **turned** to walk toward Yahweh. He means that they will start worshiping and obeying Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and worship Yahweh] or [and start following Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:27 (#4)

כָּל־מִשְׁפְּחֹות גּוֹיִם

“all of the families of the nations”

The implication is that all people groups or clans throughout the world will worship Yahweh. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [all the people groups of the world]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:27 (#5)

וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לְפָנֶיךָ כָּל־מִשְׁפְּחֹות גּוֹיִם

“and all of the families of the nations will bow down to your face”

To **bow down** was a symbolic action by which people showed reverence and submission. Sometimes it was also done as an act of worship. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation. Alternate translation: [and all the families of the nations will bow down in worship]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 22:27 (#6)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here Yahweh’s **face** represents being in front of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:28 (#1)

כִּי לַיהוָה הַמְּלוּכָה

“For to Yahweh the kingdom”

David assumes that readers will know that here the word **to** means “belongs” and that the word **kingdom** refers to Yahweh’s “reign.” You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [For the kingship belongs to Yahweh] or [For Yahweh reigns as king]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:29 (#1)

אָכְלוּ וַיִּשְׁתַּחֲווּ ׀ כָּל־דִּשְׁנֵי־אֶרֶץ לְפָנָיו יִכְרְעוּ כָּל־יוֹרְדֵי עָפָר

“All of the fat of the earth will eat and will bow down; to his face will kneel all of the ones going down to the dust”

David is referring to all people by naming two extremes, **the fat of the earth** (the wealthy and prosperous who were well-fed and healthy), and **the ones going down to the dust** (the dying). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [All people will eat and will bow down; to his face will kneel every person]

See: Merism

Psalms 22:29 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁתַּחֲווּ

“and will bow down”

See how you translated this expression in 22:27.

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 22:29 (#3)

דִּשְׁנֵי־אֶרֶץ

“the fat of the earth”

David is using the adjective **fat** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the fat ones of the earth] or [the fat people of the earth]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 22:29 (#4)

דִּשְׁנֵי־אֶרֶץ

“the fat of the earth”

Here, **the fat of the earth** represents the wealthy and prosperous people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the wealthy people of the earth] or [the prosperous people of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:29 (#5)

לְפָנָיו

“to his face”

Here Yahweh’s **face** represents being in front of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:29 (#6)

יִכְרְעוּ

“will kneel”

To **kneel** was a symbolic action by which people showed reverence and submission to God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [will kneel down in worship]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 22:29 (#7)

כָּל־יוֹרְדֵי עָפָר וְנַפְשׁוֹ לֹא חִיָּה

“all of the ones going down to the dust, even his self he kept not alive”

These two phrases **all of the ones going down to the dust** and **even his self he kept not alive** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [all of the ones going down to the dust, that is, those who cannot keep themselves alive]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 22:29 (#8)

יוֹרְדֵי עָפָר

“the ones going down to the dust”

Here the phrase **the ones going down to the dust** represents people who are dying or close to death. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the ones going down to the grave] or [the ones who are dying]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 22:29 (#9)

וְנַפְשׁוֹ לֹא חִיָּה

“even his self he kept not alive”

The implication is that they were not able to keep themselves alive. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [even him who could not keep himself alive]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:29 (#10)

וְנַפְשׁוֹ לֹא חִיָּה

“even his self he kept not alive”

In this verse, the words **his** and **he** are singular in form, but they refer to all humans as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural forms of “his” and “he” or plural forms that include both men and women since this phrase refers to all people, as no one is able to keep themselves from eventually dying. Alternate translation: [even those who could not keep themselves alive]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 22:30 (#1)

זֶרַע יַעַבְדֶנּוּ

“Seed will serve him”

See how you translated the similar expression in 22:23. Alternate translation: [Descendants will serve him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 22:30 (#2)

יְסֻפַּר לָאדֹנָי לַדּוֹר

“it will be told of the Lord to the generation”

The expression **it will be told** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people will tell of the Lord to the next generation] or [people will tell the next generation about the Lord’s works]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 22:30 (#3)

יְסֻפַּר לָאדֹנָי לַדּוֹר

“it will be told of the Lord to the generation”

David assumes that readers will know that **it** refers to the great works of the Lord that have been described throughout the psalm. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the next generation will be told about the great works of the lord]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 22:30 (#4)

לַדּוֹר

“to the generation”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [to future generations] or [to the next generation]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 22:31 (#1)

וְיַגִּידוּ צִדְקָתוֹ לְעַם נִוֹּלָּד כִּי עָשָׂה

“and will declare his righteousness to a people who will be born, that he has done {it”

David is using the adjective **his righteousness** as a noun to mean something that shows God is righteous. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and will declare to a people who will be born, that because he is righteous, he has done it]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 22:31 (#2)

כִּי עָשָׂה

“that he has done {it”

David assumes that readers will know **that he has done it** refers to God’s acts of deliverance and salvation described throughout the psalm. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [what he has done to save his people]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 23 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 23 is considered to be one of the “psalms of trust.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the “psalms of trust.”

1. Yahweh depicted as a good and trustworthy shepherd (1–4)
2. Yahweh depicted as a good and generous banquet host (5)

3. David affirms his trust in Yahweh's faithful goodness and love and asserts that he will dwell with him forever (6)

Translation Issues in this Psalm

Metaphor
Psalm 23:1–4 is an extended metaphor in which David speaks of Yahweh as if he were a shepherd, and of himself as a sheep. Psalm 23:5 is a metaphor in which David depicts himself as a guest at a banquet at which Yahweh is the host. (See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors; and Metaphor)

Referring to Yahweh in the first person and second person
In verses 1–3 and 6, David writes about Yahweh in the second person. In verses 4–5, David addresses Yahweh directly, in the first person. Yahweh's name is used in verses 1 and 6, but in verses 2–5 pronouns are used. Second person pronouns are used in verses 2–3 when referring to Yahweh, and David addresses God directly in verses 4–5 and therefore uses first person pronouns. If your language uses pronouns, use the appropriate pronouns in verses 2–5. (See: First, Second or Third Person)

Psalms 23:1 (#1)

יְהוָה רֹֽעִי

"Yahweh is my shepherd"

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shepherd** who cares for and protects his sheep. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison as in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 23:1 (#2)

לֹ֣א אֶחְסָֽר

"I will lack nothing"

David is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **nothing**, together with a mild expression, **I will lack**, that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [I will have everything I need] or [I will be completely satisfied]

See: Litotes

Psalms 23:2 (#1)

בִּנְאוֹת֣ דֶּ֭שֶׁא יַרְבִּיצֵ֑נִי עַל־מֵ֖י מְנֻחֹ֣ות יְנַהֲלֵֽנִי

"He makes me lie down in green pastures; he leads me to waters of rest"

David continues to draw an extended comparison between Yahweh's care for him and a shepherd caring for his sheep. Here David compares Yahweh's care for him to a shepherd who brings his sheep to **green pastures** and **waters of rest**. If it would be helpful for your readers, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [He gives me what I need to be satisfied and at peace, like a shepherd who provides pasture and water for his sheep]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 23:2 (#2)

בִּנְאוֹת֣ דֶּ֭שֶׁא יַרְבִּיצֵ֑נִי

"He makes me lie down in green pastures"

By **He makes me lie down**, David means "He takes me to where I can lie down" or "He lets me lie down." You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He takes me to green pastures where I can lie down] or [He lets me lie down in green pastures]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 23:2 (#3)

עַל

"to"

Here the word **to** could mean: (1) "to" as in the ULT or (2) "alongside." Alternate translation: [alongside]

Psalms 23:2 (#4)

מֵ֖י מְנֻחֹ֣ות

"waters of rest"

The phrase **waters of rest** could refer to: (1) still or calm bodies of water. Alternate translation: [calm waters] or [quiet waters] or (2) the location of the water and refer to bodies of water that were located at resting places. Alternate translation: [waters at resting places]

See: Possession

Psalms 23:3 (#1)

נַפְשִׁ֥י יְשׁוֹבֵ֑ב יַ֝נְחֵ֗נִי בְּמַעְגְּלֵי־צֶ֥דֶק לְמַ֝עַ֗ן שְׁמֹֽו

"He restores my soul. He leads me in right paths for the sake of his name"

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a shepherd who **restores** his **soul** and **leads** him **in right**

paths. David means that Yahweh renews his spiritual and emotional strength and guides him to live in a way that pleases Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He renews my spiritual strength. He guides me to live righteously for the sake of his name] or [He renews my spiritual strength. He guides me regarding how to live in the right way, for the sake of name]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 23:3 (#2)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

Here David is using the term **my soul** to mean himself from the perspective of his spiritual or emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [me] or [my spiritual strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 23:3 (#3)

לְמַעַן שְׁמוֹ

“for the sake of his name”

Here David is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. Alternate translation: [for the sake of his reputation] or [to bring honor to himself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 23:4 (#1)

גַּם כִּי־אֵלֵךְ בְּגֵ֣יא צַלְמָ֣וֶת לֹא־אִירָ֣א רָ֔ע כִּי־אַתָּ֥ה עִמָּדִ֖י שִׁבְטְךָ֣ וּמִשְׁעַנְתֶּ֑ךָ הֵ֖מָּה יְנַחֲמֻֽנִי

“Even though I walk through {the} valley of deep darkness, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me”

David continues to draw an extended comparison between his relationship with God and a shepherd caring for his sheep. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the comparison. Alternate translation: [Even though I experience great danger or hardship, I will not be afraid because you protect and guide me like a shepherd protects and guides his sheep with his rod and staff]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 23:4 (#2)

בְּגֵ֣יא צַלְמָ֣וֶת

“through {the} valley of deep darkness”

The phrase the ULT translates as **the valley of deep darkness** could be translated: (1) as the ULT does and refer to a dark valley or ravine. Alternate translation: [through a dark valley] or (2) as [the valley of the shadow of death.] Alternate translation: [through the valley of the shadow of death]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 23:4 (#3)

לֹא־אִירָ֣א רָ֔ע

“I will fear no evil”

David is using the adjective **evil** as a noun to mean things that people might do to harm him. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [I will fear no harm] or [I will fear no danger]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 23:4 (#4)

לֹא־אִירָ֣א רָ֔ע כִּי־אַתָּ֥ה עִמָּדִ֖י

“I will fear no evil, for you are with me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [because you are with me, I will fear no evil]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 23:4 (#5)

שִׁבְטְךָ֣ וּמִשְׁעַנְתֶּ֑ךָ הֵ֖מָּה יְנַחֲמֻֽנִי

“your rod and your staff, they comfort me”

Here, **rod** and **staff** represent the shepherd’s protection and guidance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your protection and guidance comfort me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 23:5 (#1)

תַּעֲרֹךְ֤ לְפָנַ֨י ׀ שֻׁלְחָ֗ן נֶ֣גֶד צֹרְרָ֑י דִּשַּׁ֖נְתָּ בַּשֶּׁ֣מֶן רֹאשִׁ֣י כּוֹסִ֔י רְוָיָֽה

“You arrange a table before my face in front of my enemies; you have anointed my head with oil; my cup overflows”

David is speaking of God’s care and provision as if God were a host preparing a feast for an honored guest. The image includes arranging a table with food, anointing the guest’s head with oil as a sign of welcome and honor, and filling the guest’s cup to overflowing. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [In front of my enemies you provide for me and honor me like a host preparing a feast for a special guest]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 23:5 (#2)

לְפָנָ֑י

“before my face”

Here, **before my face** represents being in David’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in my presence] or [for me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 23:5 (#3)

נֶ֖גֶד צֹרְרָ֣י

“in front of my enemies”

The implication is that God provides for and protects David even when he is surrounded by those who wish to harm him. This demonstrates God’s protection and care in dangerous situations. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [while my enemies watch] or [even though my enemies are present]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 23:5 (#4)

דִּשַּׁ֣נְתָּ בַשֶּׁ֣מֶן רֹ֭אשִׁי

“you have anointed my head with oil”

In that culture, putting scented **oil** on a guest’s head was a symbolic action by which a host showed honor to and welcomed a guest. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [you have honored me by anointing my head with oil] or [you have honored and welcomed me by anointing my head with oil]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 23:5 (#5)

כּוֹסִ֖י רְוָיָֽה

“my cup overflows”

In that culture, filling a guest’s wine cup to overflowing was a symbolic action by which a host showed that they intended to abundantly and liberally provide for their guest. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [you have blessed me abundantly]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 23:6 (#1)

טֹ֤וב וָחֶ֨סֶד֙ יִ֣רְדְּפ֣וּנִי

“goodness and covenant faithfulness will pursue me”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **goodness** and **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will continually show me how good he is and how faithful he is to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 23:6 (#2)

וְשַׁבְתִּ֥י

“and I will dwell”

The Hebrew word that the ULT translates as **and I will dwell** could be: (1) a contracted form of the Hebrew word that means “dwell,” in which case it should be translated as the ULT does, or (2) a form of the Hebrew word meaning “return.” Alternate translation: [and I will return and go]

Psalms 23:6 (#3)

וְשַׁבְתִּ֥י בְּבֵית־יְהוָ֑ה

“and I will dwell in the house of Yahweh”

David is using the phrase **the house of Yahweh** to refer to Yahweh’s tabernacle (tent of meeting), where Yahweh was worshiped, as if it were a **house** in which Yahweh lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will dwell in the tabernacle of Yahweh] or [and I will dwell in Yahweh’s sanctuary]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 23:6 (#4)

לְאֹרֶךְ יָמִים

“for length of days”

The implication is that David will dwell with God for his entire life. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for my whole life] or [as long as I live]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 24 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 24 is a “royal psalm.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the royal psalms. It is also a psalm that the Israelites used for their processional liturgy as they entered Jerusalem or as they proceeded to Yahweh’s Tabernacle on Mount Zion in Jerusalem. In this psalm there is a clear call-and-response pattern in which someone leading the procession would have called out parts of this psalm (verse 3, 8a, 10a), and those in the procession would have responded and answered with the words in verses 4–6, 8b, and 10b–c.

Among Bible scholars there are different opinions about the exact setting and context of this psalm. Because this psalm begins with “of David” the events in this psalm are most likely during David’s lifetime.

1. Yahweh created the world and it belongs to him (1–2)
2. Yahweh requires righteousness to enter his presence and rewards and vindicates those who are righteous (3–6)
3. Yahweh is the glorious and victorious king (7–10)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Righteous people

“Clean hands” and a “pure heart” (being morally pure in action and in thought and intention) are required to enter Yahweh’s presence. (See: righteous, righteousness, unrighteous, unrighteousness, upright, uprightness)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Rhetorical Questions

David uses three rhetorical questions in this psalm. Each rhetorical question forms a unit with a response. The three rhetorical questions are found in verses 3, 8, and 10. (See: Rhetorical Question)

Psalms 24:2 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 24:2 (#2)

כִּי־הוּא עַל־יַמִּים יְסָדָהּ וְעַל־נְהָרוֹת יְכוֹנְנָהָ

“For he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers”

By **the seas** and **the rivers** David means the waters that existed before God created the dry land. David, and people in his culture, thought of the world as being founded and placed by God upon subterranean waters. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [For he has founded it upon the waters that were there before creation] or [For he has founded it upon the deep waters under the earth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 24:3 (#1)

מִי־יַעֲלֶה בְהַר־יְהוָה וּמִי־יָקוּם בִּמְקוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ

“Who may ascend on the mountain of Yahweh? And who may stand in his holy place”

David is using questions to cause his readers to think deeply about who is qualified to approach God. David is not asking for information, but is emphasizing that only people who meet certain requirements can approach God. If you would not use rhetorical questions for this purpose in your language, you could translate his questions as statements or exclamations. Alternate translation: [Only certain people may ascend on the mountain of Yahweh! Only certain people may stand in his holy place!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 24:3 (#2)

מִי־יַעֲלֶה בְהַר־יְהוָה וּמִי־יָקוּם בִּמְקוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ

“Who may ascend on the mountain of Yahweh? And who may stand in his holy place”

David assumes that readers will know that **the mountain of Yahweh** and **his holy place** refer to Mount

Zion in Jerusalem, where the Tabernacle of Yahweh was located. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Who may ascend Mount Zion, the mountain of Yahweh? And who may stand in his holy Tabernacle]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 24:4 (#1)

נְקִי כַפַּיִם וּבַר־לֵבָב

“The} one clean of hands and pure of heart”

David is using the possessive form to describe **one** that is characterized by **clean of hands and pure of heart**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The one who has clean hands and a pure heart]

See: Possession

Psalms 24:4 (#2)

נְקִי כַפַּיִם וּבַר־לֵבָב

“The} one clean of hands and pure of heart”

Here, **hands** represents a person’s actions or conduct. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The one whose actions are clean and whose heart is pure] or [The one who acts righteously]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 24:4 (#3)

וּבַר־לֵבָב

“and pure of heart”

In this image, the **heart** represents a person’s thoughts, feelings, and motives, and David speaks of them as if they could be physically clean. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and whose thoughts are pure] or [and whose motives are pure]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 24:4 (#4)

אֲשֶׁר ׀ לֹא־נָשָׂא לַשָּׁוְא נַפְשִׁי

“who has not lifted up his soul to what is false”

David is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who has not devoted himself to falsehood] or [who has not set his heart to worship idols] or [who has not set his heart to worship what is false]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 24:4 (#5)

לַשָּׁוְא

“to what is false”

David assumes that readers will know that **what is false** refers to idol worship. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to idols]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 24:5 (#1)

יִשָּׂא

“He will take up”

The implication is that the person described in the previous verse will receive these things from God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He will receive]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 24:5 (#2)

יִשָּׂא בְרָכָה מֵאֵת יְהוָה וּצְדָקָה מֵאֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעוֹ

“He will take up a blessing from Yahweh and righteousness from the God of his salvation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **blessing** and **righteousness** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will bless him and act righteously toward him; this is what the God who saves him will do for him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 24:5 (#3)

וּצְדָקָה מֵאֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעוֹ

“and righteousness from the God of his salvation”

By **and righteousness from the God of his salvation**, David means that God will vindicate this type of person by declaring that they are righteous. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and vindication from the God of his salvation] or [and God will vindicate this person by declaring him righteous]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 24:5 (#4)

מֵאֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעוֹ

“from the God of his salvation”

See how you translated the similar phrase “the God of my salvation” in 18:46. Alternate translation: [from the God who saves him]

See: Possession

Psalms 24:6 (#1)

זֶה דּוֹר דרשו

“This {is} the generation of the ones seeking him”

Here, **generation** represents a type or class of people who have something in common. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [This is the kind of people who seek him] or [These are the people who seek him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 24:6 (#2)

דרשו מְבַקְשֵׁי פָנֶיךָ

“the ones seeking him, the ones seeking your face”

These two phrases **the ones seeking him** and **the ones seeking your face** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the ones seeking him, yes, the ones seeking your face]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 24:6 (#3)

מְבַקְשֵׁי פָנֶיךָ

“the ones seeking your face”

Here, **face** represents God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the ones seeking to be in your presence] or [the ones seeking to know you intimately]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 24:6 (#4)

יַעֲקֹב

“Jacob”

Here, **Jacob** represents the people of Israel, who are the descendants of Jacob and who sought God’s favor like Jacob did. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel] or [the descendants of Jacob]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 24:7 (#1)

שְׂאוּ שְׁעָרִים ׀ רָאשֵׁיכֶם וְהִנָּשְׂאוּ פִּתְחֵי עוֹלָם

“Lift up your heads, {you} gates, and be lifted up, {you} ancient doors”

These two phrases **Lift up your heads, you gates** and **be lifted up, you ancient doors** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Lift up your heads, you gates, yes, be lifted up, you ancient doors]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 24:7 (#2)

שְׂאוּ שְׁעָרִים ׀ רָאשֵׁיכֶם וְהִנָּשְׂאוּ פִּתְחֵי עוֹלָם

“Lift up your heads, {you} gates, and be lifted up, {you} ancient doors”

Here the words **gates** and **doors** could refer to: (1) the gates leading into Yahweh’s Tabernacle on Mount Zion. Alternate translation: [Lift up your heads, you Tabernacle gates, and be lifted up, you ancient doors], or (2) the gates leading into the city of Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [Lift up your heads, you city gates, and be lifted up, you ancient doors]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 24:7 (#3)

שְׂאוּ שְׁעָרִים ׀ רָאשֵׁיכֶם וְהִנָּשְׂאוּ פִּתְחֵי עוֹלָם

“Lift up your heads, {you} gates, and be lifted up, {you} ancient doors”

David is speaking of the **gates** and **doors** that led into Yahweh's Tabernacle as if they were living things that could lift up their heads. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Open wide the Tabernacle gates]

See: Personification

Psalms 24:7 (#4)

וְהִנָּשְׂאוּ פִּתְחֵי עוֹלָם

"and be lifted up, {you} ancient doors"

The expression **be lifted up** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and lift yourselves up, you ancient doors] or [and you gatekeepers, lift up the ancient doors]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 24:7 (#5)

וְיָבֹא מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד

"so that the King of Glory may come in"

David is using this possessive form to mean a king who has glory or a king who is glorious. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [so that the glorious king may come in]

See: Possession

Psalms 24:7 (#6)

וְיָבֹא מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד

"so that the King of Glory may come in"

In a context such as this, your language might say "go" instead of **come**. Alternate translation: [so that the King of glory may go in]

See: Go and Come

Psalms 24:8 (#1)

מִי זֶה מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד

"Who {is} this King of Glory"

David is using the question **Who is this King of glory?** to introduce and emphasize the answer that follows. This is not a request for information, but a way to draw attention to Yahweh's identity and attributes. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could express this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [This is the King of glory] or [I will tell you who this King of glory is]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 24:8 (#2)

מִי זֶה מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד

"Who {is} this King of Glory"

See how you translated the phrase **King of glory** in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [Who is this glorious king]

See: Possession

Psalms 24:8 (#3)

יְהוָה עִזּוּז וְגִבּוֹר

"Yahweh, strong and mighty"

The terms **strong** and **mighty** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. [Yahweh, who is very strong] or [Yahweh, the powerful one]

See: Doublet

Psalms 24:9 (#1)

שְׂאוּ שְׁעָרִים ׀ רָאשֵׁיכֶם וְהִנָּשְׂאוּ פִּתְחֵי עוֹלָם וְיָבֹא מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד

"Lift up your heads, {you} gates, and lift up, {you} ancient doors, so that the King of Glory may come in"

Here David is speaking of **gates** and **doors** as if they were people who could lift up their heads. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Open wide, you gates, and open wide, you ancient doors, so that the King of glory may come in]

See: Personification

Psalms 24:10 (#1)

מִי הוּא זֶה מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד

"Who {is} he, this King of Glory"

See how you translated the similar expression in 24:8.

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 24:10 (#2)

יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת

"Yahweh of Armies"

David is using this possessive form to mean that Yahweh is the commander of **armies** (the army of Israel and the army of heaven made of up angels). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the commander of armies] or [Yahweh, who commands armies]

See: Possession

Psalms - Chapter 25 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 25 has several different themes or topics within it. These include assertions of trust in Yahweh, lament (complaints about the present situation), and asking Yahweh for forgiveness of sin, deliverance from enemies and troubles, and for guidance. This psalm is an acrostic poem which follows the order of the Hebrew alphabet, with a few exceptions.

1. David's first prayer (1–7)
2. Yahweh guides humble people in the right way to live (8–9)
3. Yahweh's positive response to "the ones keeping his covenant and his testimonies" (10)
4. David's second prayer (11)
5. Ways that Yahweh blesses those who fear him (12–14)
6. David looks to Yahweh for deliverance from his enemies (15)
7. David's third prayer (16–22)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh's guidance of David described using the metaphor of "path" and a "way"

In verses 4–5, 8–9, and 12 David describes the right way to live, the way that Yahweh desires a person to live, as a "path" and a "way." David asks Yahweh to lead him in this proper way of living (4–5), says that Yahweh will teach humble people his "way" (8–9), and will teach those who fear him the proper "way" (12). See the individual notes in these verses for specific translation guidance. (Because David uses a parallelism in verse 4, we know that the words "ways/way" and "paths" have the same meaning in these particular verses.)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Singular forms of "you" and "your."

In verses 1–7, 11, and 16–22 David prays directly to Yahweh. Each time David uses the pronouns "you" and "your" in these verses they are the singular form (in the language he wrote in, Hebrew) because they refer to Yahweh. If your language has singular and plural forms of the pronouns "you" and "your," make sure you use the singular forms in these verses. (See: Forms of 'You' — Singular)

Psalms 25:1 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי אֶשָּׂא

"I lift up my soul"

David is speaking of his earnest prayer and worship as if he were to physically **lift up** his **soul** to Yahweh. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I pour out my heart] or [I come in prayer]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:2 (#1)

אֱלֹהַי

"My God"

David is not using the phrase **My God** to mean that he is the only one who worships Yahweh nor that he possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather he uses these words to emphasize that Yahweh is the God that he worships. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You God, whom I worship,]

See: Possession

Psalms 25:2 (#2)

אַל־אֵבוֹשָׁה אַל־יַעַלְצוּ אוֹיְבַי לִי

"do not let me have shame; do not let my enemies exult over me"

David is using imperative forms, **do not let me be ashamed** and **do not let my enemies exult over me**, but he intends these as polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative forms do not communicate polite requests in your language, you could use forms that communicate polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not let me have shame; please do not let my enemies exult over me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:3 (#1)

כָּל־קֹוֶיךָ

“all the ones waiting on you”

By **the ones waiting on you**, David means people who trust in Yahweh and depend on him for help. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [all those who trust in you] or [all the ones trusting in you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:3 (#2)

כָּל־קֹוֶיךָ֥ לֹ֣א יֵבֹ֑שׁוּ

“all the ones waiting on you will not have shame”

David is using a double negative that consists of **not** and the negative meaning contained in the word **ashamed**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [all the ones waiting on you, you will help]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 25:4 (#1)

דְּרָכֶ֣יךָ יְהוָ֣ה הוֹדִיעֵ֣נִי אֹ֭רְחֹתֶ֣יךָ לַמְּדֵֽנִי

“Make me know your ways, Yahweh; teach me your paths”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative forms do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please make me know your ways, Yahweh; please teach me your paths]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:4 (#2)

דְּרָכֶ֣יךָ יְהוָ֣ה הוֹדִיעֵ֣נִי אֹ֭רְחֹתֶ֣יךָ לַמְּדֵֽנִי

“Make me know your ways, Yahweh; teach me your paths”

These two phrases **Make me know your ways, Yahweh** and **teach me your paths** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Make me know your ways, Yahweh, yes, teach me your paths]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 25:4 (#3)

אֹ֭רְחֹתֶ֣יךָ לַמְּדֵֽנִי

“teach me your paths”

David is speaking of how to live as if it were **paths** that he could walk along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [teach me how to live according to your will] or [teach me how I should live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:5 (#1)

הַדְרִיכֵ֣נִי בַ֭אֲמִתֶּ֑ךָ

“Lead me in your truth”

David is speaking of God’s **truth** as if it were a path that he could walk on. He means that he wants God to help him live according to God’s truth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Help me to live according to your truth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:5 (#2)

הַדְרִיכֵ֣נִי בַ֭אֲמִתֶּ֑ךָ

“Lead me in your truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Lead me according to what is true] or [Lead me by your true teaching]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:5 (#3)

הַדְרִיכֵ֣נִי בַ֭אֲמִתֶּ֑ךָ ׀ וְלַמְּדֵ֑נִי

“Lead me in your truth and teach me”

The expressions **Lead me in your truth** and **teach me** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Instruct me in your truth]

See: Doublet

Psalms 25:5 (#4)

הַדְרִיכֵנִי בַאֲמִתֶּךָ ׀ וְלַמְּדֵנִי

“Lead me in your truth and teach me”

The verbs **Lead** and **teach** are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. David is humbly asking God to guide and instruct him. If the imperative form does not communicate a polite request in your language, you could use a form that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please lead me in your truth and teach me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:5 (#5)

אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי

“the God of my salvation”

See how you translated the similar phrase “the God of his salvation” in 24:5.

See: Possession

Psalms 25:5 (#6)

כִּי־אַתָּה אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי

“for you are the God of my salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for you are the God who saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:5 (#7)

אוֹתְךָ קִוִּיתִי כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“on you I wait all the day”

The implication is that David waits on God to help him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I continually wait for you to help me] or [I wait on you to help me all the day]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:6 (#1)

זְכֹר־רַחֲמֶיךָ יְהוָה וַחֲסָדֶיךָ

“Remember your compassion, Yahweh, and your covenant faithfulness”

David assumes that readers will know that when he asks God to **Remember** his compassion and covenant faithfulness, he is asking God to act according to these qualities, not simply to recall them mentally. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Act according to your compassion, Yahweh, and your covenant faithfulness]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:6 (#2)

זְכֹר־רַחֲמֶיךָ יְהוָה וַחֲסָדֶיךָ

“Remember your compassion, Yahweh, and your covenant faithfulness”

The word translated as **Remember** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please remember your compassion, Yahweh, and your covenant faithfulness]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:6 (#3)

זְכֹר־רַחֲמֶיךָ יְהוָה וַחֲסָדֶיךָ

“Remember your compassion, Yahweh, and your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **compassion** and **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Remember how you are compassionate, Yahweh, and how you are faithful to your covenant] or [Remember to be compassionate, Yahweh, and to be faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:6 (#4)

מֵעוֹלָם הֵמָּה

“they are from ancient times”

The implication is that God has always been compassionate and faithful, not just recently. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you have acted with compassion and covenant faithfulness since ancient times]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:7 (#1)

חַטֹּאות נְעוּרַי

“the sins of my youth”

David is using the possessive form to describe **sins** that were committed during his **youth**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the sins I committed when I was young] or [the sinful things I did in my youth]

See: Possession

Psalms 25:7 (#2)

כְּחַסְדְּךָ זְכָר־לִי

“according to your covenant faithfulness remember me”

By **according to your covenant faithfulness remember me**, David means that he wants God to remember him with favor and blessing, not with judgment. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [because of your covenant faithfulness remember me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:7 (#3)

וּפְשָׁעַי

“or my transgressions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgressions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [or the ways I have disobeyed your instructions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:7 (#4)

כְּחַסְדְּךָ

“according to your covenant faithfulness”

See how you translated the phrase **covenant faithfulness** in the previous verse.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:7 (#5)

לְמַעַן טוּבְךָ יְהוָה

“for the sake of your goodness, Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the sake of the fact that you are good, Yahweh]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:8 (#1)

טוֹב־וְיָשָׁר יְהוָה עַל־כֵּן יוֹרֶה חַטָּאִים בַּדָּרֶךְ

“Good and upright is Yahweh, therefore he teaches the sinful in the way”

David is using **therefore** to introduce a result clause that explains what follows from Yahweh being good and upright. If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because Yahweh teaches sinners the way, he is good and upright]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 25:8 (#2)

חַטָּאִים

“the sinful”

David is using the adjective **sinful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [sinners]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 25:8 (#3)

בַּדָּרֶךְ

“in the way”

Here David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path for a person to walk on. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how to live] or [how they should conduct their lives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:9 (#1)

יַדְרֵךְ עֲנָוִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט וִילַמֵּד עֲנָוִים דַּרְכּוֹ

“He leads the humble in justice, and he teaches the humble his way”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a guide who **leads** people along paths and a teacher who **teaches** them the right way to take. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation:

[He guides the humble to do what is just and he shows the humble how he wants them to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:9 (#2)

יַדְרֵךְ עֲנָוִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט וִילַמֵּד עֲנָוִים דַּרְכּוֹ

“He leads the humble in justice, and he teaches the humble his way”

David is using the adjective **humble** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [He leads humble people in justice and he teaches humble people his way]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 25:9 (#3)

יַדְרֵךְ עֲנָוִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט

“He leads the humble in justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He leads the humble to do what is just] or [He guides the humble to act justly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:10 (#1)

כָּל־אָרְחוֹת יְהוָה חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת

“All the paths of Yahweh are covenant love and faithfulness”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh’s actions as if they were **paths** that a person could walk along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All the actions of Yahweh are covenant love and faithfulness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:10 (#2)

כָּל־אָרְחוֹת יְהוָה חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת

“All the paths of Yahweh are covenant love and faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant love** and **faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [All the paths of Yahweh are loving and faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:11 (#1)

לְמַעַן־שִׁמְךָ

“For the sake of your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh’s reputation. Alternate translation: [For your sake] or [For the sake of your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 25:11 (#2)

וְסָלַחְתָּ לַעֲוֹנִי

“forgive my iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [forgive me for the wrong things I have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:12 (#1)

מִי־זֶה הָאִישׁ יְרֵא יְהוָה יֹורֶנּוּ בְּדֶרֶךְ יִבְחָר

“Who is the man fearing Yahweh? He will teach him in the way he is to choose”

David is using a rhetorical question **Who is the man fearing Yahweh?** to emphasize that God is faithful to guide those who revere him. If a speaker of your language would not use a question for this purpose, you could translate this as a statement or exclamation. Alternate translation: [The man who fears Yahweh—God will teach him in the way he is to choose]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 25:12 (#2)

מִי־זֶה הָאִישׁ יְרֵא יְהוָה יֹורֶנּוּ בְּדֶרֶךְ יִבְחָר

“Who is the man fearing Yahweh? He will teach him in the way he is to choose”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Who are the people fearing Yahweh? He will teach them in the way they are to choose]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 25:12 (#3)

זֶה הָאִישׁ

“the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone]

Psalms 25:12 (#4)

יוֹרֶנּוּ בְּדֶרֶךְ יִבְחָר

“He will teach him in the way he is to choose”

David is speaking of how a person conducts themselves as if that were **the way** or path for a person to walk on. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He will teach him how he should live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:13 (#1)

נַפְשׁוֹ

“His soul”

David is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [He]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 25:13 (#2)

נַפְשׁוֹ בְּטוּב תָּלִין

“His soul will remain in good”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **good**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [His soul will remain prosperous] or [He will continue to be blessed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:13 (#3)

בְּטוּב

“in good”

By **in good**, David means in prosperity or in favorable circumstances. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in prosperity]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:13 (#4)

וְזַרְעוֹ

“and his seed”

See how you translated the term “seed” in 18:50. Alternate translation: [and his descendants]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:13 (#5)

יִירַשׁ אָרֶץ

“will inherit the earth”

By **will inherit the earth**, David means that their descendants will continue to live in the promised land of Israel. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [will inherit the land]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:14 (#1)

סוֹד יְהוָה לִירֵאָיו

“The secret of Yahweh is for the ones fearing him”

David assumes that readers will know that **the secret of Yahweh** refers to an intimate relationship with Yahweh. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s intimate friendship is for the ones fearing him] or [Yahweh shares his plans with the ones fearing him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:15 (#1)

עֵינַי תָּמִיד אֶל־יְהוָה כִּי הוּא־יוֹצִיא מֵרֶשֶׁת רַגְלָי

“My eyes are continually toward Yahweh, for he will make my feet go out of the net”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because Yahweh will make my feet go out of the net, my eyes are continually toward him]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 25:15 (#2)

עֵינַי תָּמִיד אֶל־יְהוָה

“My eyes are continually toward Yahweh”

Here, **eyes** represents David’s attention and focus. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [I am continually focused on Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 25:15 (#3)

הוּא־יוֹצִיא מֵרֶשֶׁת רַגְלָי

“he will make my feet go out of the net”

Here David is speaking as if his troubles were a **net** that had trapped his feet and as if Yahweh could free his feet from that trap. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will free me from my troubles like feet freed from a net] or [he will rescue me from my troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:16 (#1)

פְּנֵה־אֵלַי וְחָנֵּנִי

“Turn toward me and be gracious to me”

David is using imperative forms, but he is communicating polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please turn toward me and be gracious to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:16 (#2)

פְּנֵה־אֵלַי

“Turn toward me”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a person who could physically **Turn toward** him to give attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Pay attention to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:16 (#3)

פְּנֵה־אֵלַי וְחָנֵּנִי כִּי־יָחִיד וְעָנִי אָנִי

“Turn toward me and be gracious to me, for I am alone and afflicted”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I am alone and afflicted, turn toward me and be gracious to me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 25:16 (#4)

וְעָנִי

“and afflicted”

The expression **afflicted** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and experiencing hardship]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 25:17 (#1)

צָרוֹת לְבָבִי הִרְחִיבוּ

“The troubles of my heart are enlarged”

Here David is speaking of **The troubles of my heart** as if they were physical objects that could become larger in size. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My heart is filled with many troubles] or [The troubles I feel have become very great]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:17 (#2)

מִמְּצוּקוֹתַי הוֹצִיאֵנִי

“bring me out of my distresses”

Here David is speaking as if his distresses were a place from which he could be brought **out**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [free me from my distresses] or [rescue me from my distresses]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:17 (#3)

מִמְּצוּקוֹתַי הוֹצִיאֵנִי

“bring me out of my distresses”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distresses**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [deliver me from the things that distress me] or [bring me out of the circumstances that distress me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:18 (#1)

רְאֵה

“See”

By **See**, David means “take notice of” or “pay attention to.” David is asking God to consider his difficult situation with compassion. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Consider]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:18 (#2)

רְאֵה עָנְיִי וַעֲמָלִי וְשָׂא לְכָל־חַטֹּאותָי

“See my affliction and my trouble, and forgive all of my sins”

The words **See** and **forgive** are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative form does not communicate polite requests in your language, you could use a form that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please see my affliction and my trouble, and please forgive all of my sins]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:18 (#3)

רְאֵה עָנְיִי וַעֲמָלִי וְשָׂא לְכָל־חַטֹּאותָי

“See my affliction and my trouble, and forgive all of my sins”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **affliction** and **trouble**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [See how I am afflicted and troubled, and forgive all of the sinful things that I have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:19 (#1)

רְאֵה

“See”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please look at] or [Please consider]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:19 (#2)

וְשִׂנְאַת חָמָס שָׂנְאוּנִי

“and with hatred of violence they hate me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hatred**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and they violently hate me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:19 (#3)

וְשִׂנְאַת חָמָס

“and with hatred of violence”

David is using this possessive form **hatred of violence** to mean violent hatred. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and with violent hatred] or [and with brutal hatred]

See: Possession

Psalms 25:20 (#1)

שָׁמְרָה נַפְשִׁי וְהַצִּילֵנִי אַל־אֵבוֹשׁ

“Guard my life and deliver me; do not let me have shame”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please guard my life and deliver me; please do not let me have shame]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:20 (#2)

שָׁמְרָה נַפְשִׁי

“Guard my life”

By **Guard my life**, David means protect him from his enemies who want to harm or kill him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Protect my life]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:20 (#3)

כִּי־חָסִיתִי בָךְ

“for I take refuge in you”

See how you translated the phrase **for I take refuge in you** in 16:1.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 25:21 (#1)

תֹּם־וְיֹ֫שֶׁר

“May integrity and uprightness”

The terms **integrity** and **uprightness** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [May complete righteousness]

See: Doublet

Psalms 25:21 (#2)

תֹּם־וְיֹ֫שֶׁר יִצְּרֻ֥נִי

“May integrity and uprightness preserve me”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **integrity** and **uprightness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [May my honest and upright character preserve me] or [May I be preserved because I am honest and do what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 25:21 (#3)

תֹּם־וְיֹ֫שֶׁר יִצְּרֻ֥נִי

“May integrity and uprightness preserve me”

Here David speaks of **integrity and uprightness** as if they were people who could **preserve** or protect him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May my integrity and uprightness be the means by which you preserve me]

See: Personification

Psalms 25:21 (#4)

כִּ֝֗י קִוִּיתִ֥יךָ

“for I wait for you”

See how you translated the phrases “the ones waiting on you” in 25:3 and “on you I wait” in 25:5 where the words “waiting” and “wait” are used with the same meaning as the word **wait** in this verse.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 25:22 (#1)

פְּדֵ֣ה

“redeem”

The word **redeem** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please redeem]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 25:22 (#2)

אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵ֥ל מִכֹּ֖ל צָרוֹתָֽיו

“Israel from all of his troubles”

Here, **Israel** represents the Israelite people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [us Israelite people from all our troubles]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 26 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. David asks Yahweh to give him justice because of his righteous lifestyle (1–6a)
2. David vows to thank Yahweh and recount all his wondrous deeds (6b–7)
3. David proclaims that he loves to be in Yahweh’s presence in the Tabernacle (8)
4. David asks Yahweh not to punish him with the wicked (9–10)
5. David vows to live with integrity and asks Yahweh to redeem him and be gracious to him as a result (11)
6. David’s closing words (12)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Praise
The psalmist delights in praising God and doing good deeds. It is striking how this psalm uses the first person pronoun. This is an individual psalm of petition. Each of the four petitions are accompanied with various claims. (See: good, right, pleasant, better, best, goodness)

Psalms 26:1 (#1)

שָׁפְטֵ֥נִי

“Vindicate me”

By **Vindicate me**, David means that he wants God to prove to others that he is innocent of wrongdoing. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Prove that I am righteous] or [Show others that I am innocent]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 26:1 (#2)

שָׁפְטֵ֥נִי

“Vindicate me”

Here David is using an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please vindicate me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 26:1 (#3)

כִּ֤י־אֲנִ֨י בְתֻמִּ֪י הָלַ֫כְתִּי

“for I have walked in my integrity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **integrity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for I have done what is right] or [for I have lived uprightly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 26:1 (#4)

כִּ֤י־אֲנִ֨י בְתֻמִּ֪י הָלַ֫כְתִּי

“for I have walked in my integrity”

Here David is speaking of his manner of living and conducting himself as if it were a path he **walked**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for I have lived with integrity] or [for I have acted with integrity]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 26:2 (#1)

בְּחָנֵ֣נִי יְ֭הוָה וְנַסֵּ֑נִי צרופה

“Examine me, Yahweh, and test me; try”

David is using imperatives to make polite requests rather than to give commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests in your language, you could use a form that communicates a polite request. Alternate translation: [Please examine me, Yahweh, and test me; please try]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 26:2 (#2)

בְּחָנֵ֣נִי יְ֭הוָה וְנַסֵּ֑נִי

“Examine me, Yahweh, and test me”

These two phrases, **Examine me** and **test me**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, examine and test me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 26:2 (#3)

צרופה כִלְיוֹתַ֖י וְלִבִּֽי

“try my kidneys and my heart”

See how you translated the similar phrase “The righteous God examines hearts and kidneys” in 7:9. Alternate translation: [try my motives and my thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 26:3 (#1)

כִּֽי־חַסְדְּךָ֥ לְנֶ֫גֶד עֵינָ֑י

“For your covenant faithfulness is before my eyes”

David is using **before my eyes** as a common expression of his culture to mean “constantly in my thoughts” or “always in my awareness.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am always mindful of your covenant faithfulness] or [I constantly remember your covenant faithfulness]

See: Idiom

Psalms 26:3 (#2)

כִּֽי־חַסְדְּךָ֥

“For your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [For the way you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 26:3 (#3)

וְהִתְהַלַּכְתִּי בַּאֲמִתֶּךָ

“and I walk about in your truth”

David is speaking of living according to God’s truth as if it were a path he could **walk about** on. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I live according to your truth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 26:3 (#4)

בַּאֲמִתֶּךָ

“in your truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in what is true]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 26:4 (#1)

לֹא־יָשַׁבְתִּי עִם־מְתֵי־שָׁוְא

“I do not sit with men of falsehood”

Here, **sit** represents associating with or spending time with people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I do not associate with men of falsehood]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 26:4 (#2)

מְתֵי־שָׁוְא

“men of falsehood”

The phrase **men of falsehood** refers to people who are characterized by dishonesty, deception, or lies. David is describing those who habitually speak or act falsely. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [deceitful people] or [dishonest men]

See: Possession

Psalms 26:4 (#3)

מְתֵי־שָׁוְא

“men of falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [lying men] or [men who lie]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 26:4 (#4)

וְעִם נַעֲלָמִים לֹא אָבוֹא

“and I will not go with the ones concealing themselves”

The implication is that these people are concealing their evil intentions or dishonest behavior. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I will not go with those who hide their evil deeds] or [and I will not go with those who hide their evil deeds and intentions]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 26:5 (#1)

מְרֵעִים

“the ones doing evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ones who do evil things] or [the ones who act wickedly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 26:5 (#2)

וְעִם לֹא אֵשֵׁב &

“and I will not sit with”

See how you translated the similar phrase “I do not sit with” in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [and I will not associate with]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 26:5 (#3)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

See how you translated the phrase “the wicked” in 1:1.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 26:6 (#1)

אֶרְחַ֣ץ בְּנִקָּיָ֣ון כַּפָּ֑י

“I wash my hands in innocence”

Washing hands **in innocence** was a symbolic action by which David showed that he had not done anything wrong. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [I demonstrate my innocence by washing my hands]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 26:6 (#2)

בְּנִקָּיָ֣ון

“in innocence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **innocence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as an innocent person] or [because I am innocent]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 26:7 (#1)

לְהַשְׁמִ֥עַ

“to cause to be heard”

The expression **to cause to be heard** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to proclaim] or [to make known]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 26:8 (#1)

מְעֹ֣ון בֵּיתֶ֑ךָ

“the habitation of your house”

David is speaking of the tabernacle of Yahweh as if it were a **house**, which Yahweh makes his **habitation** or dwelling place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your tabernacle] or [the tabernacle where you are present in a special way]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 26:8 (#2)

מְעֹ֣ון בֵּיתֶ֑ךָ

“the habitation of your house”

David is using this possessive form, **habitation of your house**, to mean the place where Yahweh has made his special **habitation** (dwelling place). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the house where you dwell]

See: Possession

Psalms 26:9 (#1)

אַל־תֶּאֱסֹ֣ף

“Do not gather”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not gather]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 26:9 (#2)

אַל־תֶּאֱסֹ֣ף עִם־חַטָּאִ֣ים נַפְשִׁ֑י וְעִם־אַנְשֵׁ֖י דָּמִ֣ים חַיָּֽי

“Do not gather my soul with the sinful, nor my life with men of blood”

David assumes that readers will know that **gather** refers to God gathering wicked people to judge them. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Do not cause me to die and be judged along with the sinful, nor let me perish in judgment with men of blood] or [Do not take me away to be judged along with the sinful, nor let me perish in judgment with men of blood]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 26:9 (#3)

נַפְשִׁ֑י

“my soul”

Here David is using the term **my soul** to mean himself, his very life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 26:9 (#4)

חַטָּאִ֣ים

“the sinful”

David is using the adjective **sinful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjec-

tives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [sinful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 26:9 (#5)

אַנְשֵׁי דָמִים

“men of blood”

David is using the possessive form to describe **men** that are characterized by violence and bloodshed. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [violent men] or [murderers]

See: Possession

Psalms 26:10 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר־בִּידֵיהֶם זִמָּה

“who {have} in their hands an evil scheme”

Here, **hands** represents what these evil men do (their actions) or plan to do. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who plan an evil scheme]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 26:10 (#2)

וְ֝יִמִינָם מָלְאָה שֹׁחַד

“and their right hand is full of bribes”

The phrase **their right hand is full of bribes** could mean: (1) that these wicked men are in positions of authority and they accept bribes and make unjust decisions or rulings as a result. Alternate translation: [and their right hand is full of bribes which they have accepted] or (2) that these evil men give bribes to those in positions of authority in order to influence them to make wrong and unjust decisions. Alternate translation: [and they give bribes] or [and they pervert justice by giving bribes]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 26:11 (#1)

וַאֲנִי בְתֻמִּי אֵלֵךְ

“But I will walk in my integrity”

See how you translated the similar phrase “for I have walked in my integrity” in verse 1.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 26:11 (#2)

פְּדֵנִי וְחָנֵּנִי

“redeem me and be gracious to me”

In this context, David is using imperative forms to make polite requests to God rather than to give commands. The words **redeem me and be gracious to me** are requests for God’s help and mercy. If the imperative forms do not communicate polite requests in your language, use a form that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please redeem me and be gracious to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 26:12 (#1)

רַגְלִי עָמְדָה בְמִישׁוֹר

“My foot stands on level ground”

Here David is speaking as if his **foot stands on level ground**. He means that he is in a stable and secure position because he has lived righteously. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am secure because I have lived righteously]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 26:12 (#2)

בְּ֝מַקְהֲלִים אֲבָרֵךְ יְהוָה

“among the assemblies will I bless Yahweh”

David assumes that readers will know that **assemblies** refers to gatherings of God’s people for worship. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the gatherings of God’s people I will bless Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 27 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 27 is considered to be one of the “psalms of trust.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the psalms of trust.

1. David declares his confidence in God (1–6)
2. David prays for help (7–12)
3. David affirms his faith in God and calls on others to patiently endure (13–14)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh's help
Because of God's help, he has nothing to fear, no matter what happens. The psalmist shows his confidence in God; he also asks God for help.

Psalms 27:1 (#1)

יְהוָה ׀ אוֹרִי

"Yahweh is my light"

David is speaking of **Yahweh** as if he were **light** that illuminates, guides, helps, and encourages him. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is like light to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:1 (#2)

וְיִשְׁעִי

"and my salvation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the one who saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 27:1 (#3)

מִמִּי אִירָא & מִמִּי אֶפְחָד

"whom will I fear & whom will I dread"

David is using two rhetorical questions, **whom will I fear** and **whom will I dread**, to emphasize that he does not fear anyone because Yahweh protects him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements. Alternate translation: [there is no one I fear ... there is no one I dread] or [there is no one I need to fear ... there is no one I need to dread]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 27:1 (#4)

יְהוָה מָעוֹז־חַיַּי

"Yahweh is the refuge of my life"

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a physical location, a **refuge**, that could provide safety and protection. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Yahweh protects my life like a place of refuge] or [Yahweh is like a safe place for me where I can go to be safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:2 (#1)

לֶאֱכֹל אֶת־בְּשָׂרִי

"to devour my flesh"

David is speaking of his enemies' attacks as if they were wild animals trying **to devour** his **flesh**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly or express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [to destroy me completely] or [to attack me like wild beasts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:2 (#2)

צָרַי וְאֹיְבַי

"my enemies and the ones being hostile to me"

The terms **enemies** and **the ones being hostile to me** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my fierce enemies]

See: Doublet

Psalms 27:2 (#3)

הֵמָּה כָשְׁלוּ וְנָפָלוּ

"they stumbled and fell"

Here, **they stumbled and fell** represents being defeated. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they were defeated] or [they failed in their attack]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 27:3 (#1)

אִם־תַּחֲנֶה עָלַי מַחֲנֶה לֹא־יִירָא לִבִּי אִם־תָּקוּם עָלַי מִלְחָמָה בְּזֹאת אֲנִי בוֹטֵחַ

"Though an army encamps against me, my heart will not fear; though war arises against me, in this I will be confident"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may

want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Though an army encamps against me and war arises against me, my heart will not fear but will be confident]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 27:3 (#2)

אִם־תַּחֲנֶה עָלַי ׀ מַחֲנֶה׃

“Though an army encamps against me”

In this verse, the word **army** is singular in form, but it refers to all soldiers as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning of “army” in another way. Alternate translation: [Though enemy troops encamp against me]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 27:3 (#3)

לֹא־יִירָא לִבִּי

“my heart will not fear”

Here David is speaking of **my heart** as if it were the part of him that experiences fear. In your language, it may be more natural to say that David himself will not fear. Alternate translation: [I will not fear]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:3 (#4)

אִם־תָּקוּם עָלַי מִלְחָמָה

“though war arises against me”

David is using **war arises against me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “when enemies attack me” or “when I am attacked in battle.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [though enemies attack me] or [though I am under attack]

See: Idiom

Psalms 27:4 (#1)

אַחַת ׀ שָׁאַלְתִּי מֵאֵת־יְהוָה׃ אוֹתָהּ אֲבַקֵּשׁ

“One {thing} I have asked from Yahweh, that I will seek”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [One thing I have asked from Yahweh, yes, this is what I will seek]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 27:4 (#2)

אוֹתָהּ אֲבַקֵּשׁ

“that I will seek”

Here David is speaking of the object of his desire (dwelling in God’s tabernacle) as if it were something he could physically pursue or chase after. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that I long for] or [that I desire]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:4 (#3)

שִׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית־יְהוָה כָּל־יְמֵי חַיַּי

“that I may dwell in the house of Yahweh all the days of my life”

See how you translated the similar phrase “and I will dwell in the house of Yahweh for length of days” in 23:6.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:4 (#4)

לַחֲזוֹת בְּנֹעַם־יְהוָה

“to look upon the beauty of Yahweh”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were actually looking at the physical **beauty** of Yahweh with his eyes. He means that he wants to experience and appreciate Yahweh’s wonderful character and presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to experience Yahweh’s wonderful presence] or [to appreciate Yahweh’s glorious character]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:4 (#5)

בְּהֵיכָלוֹ

“in his temple”

David is speaking of the **temple** of Yahweh as if it were a **house** in which he lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in his tabernacle]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:5 (#1)

כִּֽי־ יִצְפְּנֵ֣נִי ׀ בְּסֻכֹּה֮ בְּי֪וֹם רָ֫עָ֥ה יַסְתִּרֵ֥נִי בְּסֵ֖תֶר אָהֳלֹ֑ו

“For in the day of trouble he will hide me in his hut; he will hide me in the hiding-place of his tent”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [For in the day of trouble he will hide me in his hut, yes, he will conceal me in his tent]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 27:5 (#2)

יִצְפְּנֵ֣נִי ׀ בְּסֻכֹּה֮ & יַסְתִּרֵ֥נִי בְּסֵ֖תֶר אָהֳלֹ֑ו

“he will hide me in his hut; he will hide me in the hiding-place of his tent”

David assumes that readers will know that **his hut** and **his tent** refer to God’s tabernacle. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he will hide me in his tabernacle; he will hide me in the hiding-place of his sacred tent] or [he will hide me in his tabernacle; he will hide me in the hiding-place of his tabernacle]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 27:5 (#3)

יִצְפְּנֵ֣נִי ׀ בְּסֻכֹּה֮ & יַסְתִּרֵ֥נִי בְּסֵ֖תֶר אָהֳלֹ֑ו

“he will hide me in his hut; he will hide me in the hiding-place of his tent”

Here David is referring to Yahweh’s tabernacle as a **hut** and **tent** and is speaking as if Yahweh was actually hiding him from his enemies there. David means that by his being in Yahweh’s tabernacle, Yahweh will protect him from his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will protect me and keep me safe in his tabernacle]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:5 (#4)

בְּי֪וֹם רָ֫עָ֥ה

“in the day of trouble”

David is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time of distress or difficulty. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when I have trouble] or [in times of trouble]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 27:5 (#5)

בְּי֪וֹם רָ֫עָ֥ה

“in the day of trouble”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trouble**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when I am troubled]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 27:5 (#6)

בְּצ֥וּר יְרוֹמְמֵֽנִי

“He will lift me high upon a rock”

David is speaking of Yahweh protecting him and keeping him safe as if Yahweh would literally lift him up and place him on a high **rock** where he would be safe from the attacks of his enemies. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison as in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:6 (#1)

וְעַתָּ֤ה יָרוּם֮ רֹאשִׁ֪י עַ֫ל

“And now my head will be lifted up above”

David is using **my head will be lifted up** as a common expression of his culture to mean “I will be exalted” or “I will triumph.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And now I will be exalted above]

See: Idiom

Psalms 27:6 (#2)

בְּאָהֳלֹ֑ו

“in his tent”

See how you translated the phrase “his tent” in the previous verse where it is used with the same meaning. Alternate translation: [in his tabernacle]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 27:6 (#3)

וְאֶזְבְּחָה בְאָהֳלוֹ זִבְחֵי תְרוּעָה

“and I will sacrifice in his tent sacrifices of a shout of joy”

By **sacrifices of a shout of joy**, David means sacrifices that he offers while shouting joyfully to God. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I will joyfully shout as I sacrifice in his tent]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 27:7 (#1)

שְׁמַע־יְהוָה קוֹלִי אֶקְרָא וְחָנֵּנִי וַעֲנֵנִי

“Hear, Yahweh, my voice {when} I cry out, and be gracious to me, and answer me”

Here David is using the imperative forms **Hear**, **be gracious to me**, and **answer me**, but he intends to communicate polite requests rather than commands. If these imperative forms do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hear, Yahweh, my voice when I cry out, and please be gracious to me, and answer me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 27:7 (#2)

קוֹלִי אֶקְרָא

“my voice {when} I cry out”

Here, **voice** represents David’s prayer or request. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my request when I cry out]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 27:8 (#1)

לְךָ ׀ אָמַר לִבִּי בַּקְּשׁוּ פָנָי אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ יְהוָה אֲבַקֵּשׁ

“Seek my face.” My heart said to you, “Your face, Yahweh, I will seek”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [When you said, “Seek my face,” my heart said to you, “Your face, Yahweh, I will seek.”]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 27:8 (#2)

בַּקְּשׁוּ פָנָי

“Seek my face”

The Hebrew verb the ULT translates as **Seek** is plural here because Yahweh is addressing his people or people in general who are willing to seek and trust him, and not just David. So use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 27:8 (#3)

לִבִּי

“My heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and desires exist. David is speaking of his inner self as if it were his physical heart that could speak. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My inner self] or [I]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:8 (#4)

פָּנַי אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ

“my face & Your face”

Here, **face** represents being in the presence of God and also God’s favor and intervention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my presence and help ... Your presence and help]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 27:9 (#1)

אַל־תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ ׀ מִמֶּנִּי ׀ אַל־תַּט־בְּאַף עַבְדֶּךָ & אַל־תִּטְּשֵׁנִי וְאַל־תַּעַזְבֵנִי

“Do not hide your face from me; do not turn your servant away in anger & Do not abandon me nor leave me”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not hide your face from me; please do not turn your servant away in anger ... Please do not abandon me or leave me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 27:9 (#2)

אַל־תַּסְתֵּ֣ר פָּנֶ֣יךָ ׀ מִמֶּ֑נִּי

"Do not hide your face from me"

David is using **hide your face** as a common expression of his culture to mean "reject me" or "turn away from me." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not reject me] or [Do not turn away from me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 27:9 (#3)

אַל־תִּטְּשֵׁ֥נִי וְאַל־תַּֽעַזְבֵ֑נִי

"Do not abandon me nor leave me"

The terms **abandon** and **leave** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Do not forsake me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 27:9 (#4)

אֱלֹהֵ֖י יִשְׁעִֽי

"God of my salvation"

See how you translated the phrase "God of my salvation" in 18:46 where it occurs with the same meaning. Alternate translation: [the God who saves me]

See: Possession

Psalms 27:10 (#1)

כִּֽי־אָבִ֣י וְאִמִּ֣י עֲזָבֻ֑נִי

"For my father and my mother have left me"

Because David does not explain in what way his father and mother have left him, it is best not to add any additional explanatory information to your translation to clarify how or why his parents might have left him. It is suggested that you simply translate this phrase as it is. It may be that David's father and mother had died by this time in his life and had not intentionally left him.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 27:11 (#1)

הֹורֵ֣נִי יְ֭הוָה דַּרְכֶּ֑ךָ וּ֝נְחֵ֗נִי בְּאֹ֣רַח מִישֹׁ֑ור

"Teach me your way, Yahweh, and lead me on a level path"

Here David uses imperative forms, but he is making polite requests rather than giving commands. If the imperative form does not communicate a polite request in your language, then use a form that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please teach me your way, Yahweh, and please lead me on a level path]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 27:11 (#2)

הֹורֵ֣נִי דַּרְכֶּ֑ךָ &

"Teach me your way"

See how you translated the similar phrase "make me know your ways" in 25:4.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:11 (#3)

וּ֝נְחֵ֗נִי בְּאֹ֣רַח מִישֹׁ֑ור

"and lead me on a level path"

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh would **lead** him **on a level path**. He is picturing his life as if it were a journey and asking Yahweh to guide him along a smooth, safe route. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 27:11 (#4)

וּ֝נְחֵ֗נִי בְּאֹ֣רַח מִישֹׁ֑ור לְ֝מַ֗עַן שֹׁורְרָֽי

"and lead me on a level path because of my enemies"

David is using **because of my enemies** to give the reason for the result that **lead me on a level path** describes. If it would be more natural in your language,

you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [and because of my enemies, lead me on a level path]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 27:12 (#1)

אַל־תִּתְּנֵ֥נִי בְנֶ֗פֶשׁ צָרָ֫י כִּֽי־קָמוּ־בִ֥י עֵדֵי־שֶׁ֜קֶר וְיִפֵּ֣חַ חָמָֽס

“Do not give me up to the desire of my adversaries, for false witnesses have risen against me, and a witness of violence”

David is giving the reason why God should not give him up to his enemies. If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second and third phrases give the reasons for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because false witnesses have risen against me, and a witness of violence, do not give me up to the desire of my adversaries]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 27:12 (#2)

אַל־תִּתְּנֵ֥נִי

“Do not give me up”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. David is asking God not to hand him over to his enemies. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not give me up]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 27:12 (#3)

אַל־תִּתְּנֵ֥נִי בְנֶ֗פֶשׁ צָרָ֫י

“Do not give me up to the desire of my adversaries”

David is using **give me up to the desire of** as a common expression of his culture to mean “deliver me over to” or “hand me over to.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not deliver me over to the desire of my adversaries]

See: Idiom

Psalms 27:12 (#4)

אַל־תִּתְּנֵ֥נִי בְנֶ֗פֶשׁ צָרָ֫י

“Do not give me up to the desire of my adversaries”

David assumes that readers will know that **the desire of my adversaries** refers to the harmful things that his enemies want to do to him. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Do not deliver me over to my adversaries so that they can do the harmful things they desire to do to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 27:12 (#5)

קָמוּ־בִ֥י

“have risen against me”

David is using **have risen against me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “have taken action to oppose me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have opposed me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 27:12 (#6)

וְיִפֵּ֣חַ חָמָֽס

“and a witness of violence”

The Hebrew word that the ULT translates as **a witness of** could be either: (1) a noun that means “a testifier” or “a witness.” Alternate translation: [and a testifier of violence] or [and a violent testifier who is violent] or (2) an adjective that means “one breathing out” or “one puffing out.” Alternate translation: [and one who breathes out violence]

Psalms 27:12 (#7)

וְיִפֵּ֣חַ חָמָֽס

“and a witness of violence”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **witness** that is characterized by **violence**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and a violent witness] or [and a witness who speaks violently]

See: Possession

Psalms 27:12 (#8)

וְיֹפֵחַ חָמָס

“and a witness of violence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and a witness who plans violent things] or [and a witness who acts violently]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 27:13 (#1)

לוּלֵא֮ הֶ֪אֱמַ֫נְתִּי לִרְא֥וֹת בְּט֣וּב־יְ֭הוָה בְּאֶ֣רֶץ חַיִּֽים

“Unless I had believed that I would look on the goodness of Yahweh in the land of the living”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Unless I had believed that I would look on the goodness of Yahweh in the land of the living, I would have grown discouraged] or [I am certain that I will see the goodness of Yahweh in the land of the living]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 27:13 (#2)

לוּלֵא֮ הֶ֪אֱמַ֫נְתִּי לִרְא֥וֹת בְּט֣וּב־יְ֭הוָה

“Unless I had believed that I would look on the goodness of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Unless I had believed that I would see Yahweh do good things for me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 27:13 (#3)

בְּאֶ֣רֶץ חַיִּֽים

“in the land of the living”

David is using **in the land of the living** as a common expression of his culture to mean “while I am still alive” or “during my lifetime.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [while I am still alive] or [during my lifetime]

See: Idiom

Psalms 27:14 (#1)

קַוֵּ֣ה אֶל־יְ֭הוָה & וְקַוֵּ֣ה אֶל־יְהוָ֑ה

“Wait on Yahweh & and wait on Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expressions in 25:3, 25:5, and 25:21.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 27:14 (#2)

קַוֵּ֣ה אֶל־יְ֭הוָה חֲזַ֣ק וְיַאֲמֵ֣ץ לִבֶּ֑ךָ וְקַוֵּ֣ה אֶל־יְהוָֽה

“Wait on Yahweh. Be strong, and let your heart be courageous, and wait on Yahweh”

The words that the ULT translates as **wait**, **your**, and **be courageous** are all singular here. David is either speaking to himself or to some other individual, or he is speaking collectively to each individual person experiencing discouragement or fear who might hear or read this psalm. So use the singular forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 27:14 (#3)

חֲזַ֣ק וְיַאֲמֵ֣ץ לִבֶּ֑ךָ

“Be strong, and let your heart be courageous”

The terms **Be strong** and **let your heart be courageous** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Be very courageous]

See: Doublet

Psalms 27:14 (#4)

וְיַאֲמֵ֣ץ לִבֶּ֑ךָ

“and let your heart be courageous”

Here David is speaking of **heart** as if it were something that could be courageous. The heart represents a person’s inner being or emotions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and be courageous within yourself] or [and be inwardly courageous]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 28 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 28 begins as a lament psalm and then transitions into praise, thanksgiving, and affirmation of his trust in Yahweh.

1. David prays for deliverance (1–2)
2. David asks God to judge the wicked (3–5)
3. David praises God and affirms his goodness (6–9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Trust

David trusted God completely and God rescued him. This is similar to Psalm 7 and 17 because it is an individual psalm of lament. (See: lament, lamentation)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Text variant in 28:8

In 28:8 some Hebrew manuscripts contain the Hebrew word that could be literally translated as "for them" while other Hebrew manuscripts contain the word that could be literally translated as "for his people." The Hebrew manuscript that the ULT follows contains the word that reads "for them" but the ULT translates this word as "for his people" because this word is being considered an alternate spelling of the word "for his people." For the reasoning behind this decision, see the portion on "The Text of v. 8a" in this video produced by the "Psalms: Layer by Layer" project titled "Psalm 28: Exegetical Issues." See the video at (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QHlm_UCsX-A&t=1037s)

"The Psalms: Layer by Layer" videos are part of the "Psalms: Layer by Layer" project, which is run by Scriptura (formerly Cambridge Digital Bible Research).

To visit the Psalms: Layer by Layer website go to https://psalms.scriptura.org. These videos are used under CC BY

Psalms 28:1 (#1)

צוּרִי׃

"my rock"

See how you translated this phrase in 18:2 where it is used with the same meaning.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:1 (#2)

אֵל־תֶּחֱרַשׁ מִמֶּמֶּנִּי

"do not be deaf to me"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not be deaf to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 28:1 (#3)

אֵל־תֶּחֱרַשׁ מִמֶּמֶּנִּי

"do not be deaf to me"

David is using **do not be deaf to me** as a common expression of his culture to mean "do not ignore me" or "do not refuse to answer me" (and here it specifically refers to Yahweh answering his prayers for help). If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not ignore my prayers]

See: Idiom

Psalms 28:1 (#4)

פֶּן־תֶּחֱשֶׁה מִמֶּמֶּנִּי וְנִמְשַׁלְתִּי עִם־יוֹרְדֵי בוֹר

"lest you be deaf to me, and I be equal with those going down to the pit"

Here, **lest, if you are deaf to me, then I will be together with the ones going down to the pit** introduces a possible condition and its consequence. David is saying that if Yahweh does not respond to his prayer, then he will die. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [If you are silent, then I will join those who go down to the grave]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 28:1 (#5)

בּוֹר

"the pit"

David is using **the pit** as a common expression of his culture to mean "the grave" or "death." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the grave]

See: Idiom

Psalms 28:2 (#1)

שְׁמַ֣ע

“Hear”

David is using an imperative form, but **Hear** communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hear]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 28:2 (#2)

שְׁמַ֣ע

“Hear”

By **Hear**, David means pay attention to and respond favorably to his request. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Pay attention to]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 28:2 (#3)

שְׁמַ֣ע קוֹל֮ תַּחֲנוּנַ֒י

“Hear the voice of my pleas”

Here, **voice** represents what David is saying by using his voice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Hear the words of my pleas]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 28:2 (#4)

בְּנָשְׂאִ֣י יָ֭דַי

“when I lift up my hands”

Here, **when I lift up my hands** was a symbolic action by which David showed that he was appealing to God for help. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [when I raise my hands in prayer]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 28:2 (#5)

דְּבִ֣יר קָ֭דְשֶׁךָ

“your inner sanctuary of holiness”

By **your inner sanctuary of holiness**, David means the inner sanctuary of the Tabernacle where God dwelled with the Israelites in a special way. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the holy inner sanctuary in your Tabernacle]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 28:2 (#6)

דְּבִ֣יר קָ֭דְשֶׁךָ

“your inner sanctuary of holiness”

Here David uses the possessive form **inner sanctuary of holiness** to mean the inner sanctuary of the Tabernacle that was characterized by holiness. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the most holy place where you dwell] or [your inner sanctuary that is very holy]

See: Possession

Psalms 28:3 (#1)

אַל־תִּמְשְׁכֵ֣נִי עִם־רְ֭שָׁעִים

“Do not drag me away with the wicked”

Here **Do not drag me away** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not drag me away with the wicked]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 28:3 (#2)

אַל־תִּמְשְׁכֵ֣נִי עִם־רְ֭שָׁעִים

“Do not drag me away with the wicked”

Here David is speaking of God taking his life as if God were someone who might **drag** him away by force in order to kill him or judge and punish him. See how you translated the similar phrase “Do not gather my soul with the sinful” in 26:9. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not bring me away and punish me with the wicked] or [Do not let me die with the wicked]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:3 (#3)

רְשָׁעִים֮ וְעִם־פֹּעֲלֵ֪י אָ֫וֶן

“the wicked and with the workers of iniquity”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the wicked, that is, with the workers of iniquity] or [the wicked people who do evil deeds]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 28:3 (#4)

רְשָׁעִים֮

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase as in the UST.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 28:3 (#5)

וְעִם־פֹּעֲלֵ֪י אָ֫וֶן

“and with the workers of iniquity”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and do not drag me away with the workers of iniquity]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 28:3 (#6)

פֹּעֲלֵ֪י אָ֫וֶן דֹּבְרֵ֣י שָׁ֭לוֹם עִם־רֵעֵיהֶ֑ם

“the workers of iniquity, the ones speaking of peace with their neighbors”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ones who do wicked things, the ones speaking of peaceful things with their neighbors]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 28:3 (#7)

וְ֝רָעָ֗ה בִּלְבָבָֽם

“while evil is in their hearts”

David is using the adjective **evil** as a noun to mean evil thoughts or evil intentions. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [while evil thoughts are in their hearts]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 28:3 (#8)

וְ֝רָעָ֗ה בִּלְבָבָֽם

“while evil is in their hearts”

Here David is speaking of **evil** as if it were an object that could be located inside people’s **hearts**. The “heart” represents the center of a person’s thoughts and intentions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [while they intend to do evil] or [while they have evil intentions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:4 (#1)

תֵּ֣ן־לָ֭הֶם & תֵּ֣תֶּן לָהֶ֑ם הָשֵׁ֖שׁב & לָהֶֽם

“Give to them & give to them & return to them”

David is using the imperative form **Give** to make a polite request to God rather than to give a command. If the imperative form would not communicate a polite request in your language, you could use a different form that would communicate a polite request. [Please give them … please give to them … please return to them] or [I ask that you give them … I ask that you give to them … I ask that you return to them]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 28:4 (#2)

תֵּ֣ן־לָ֭הֶם כְּפָעָלָ֑ם וּכְרֹ֖עַ מַעַלְלֵיהֶ֣ם כְּמַעֲשֵׂ֣ה יָדֵיהֶ֔ם תֵּ֥תֶּן לָהֶ֖ם

“Give to them according to their work and according to the evil of their deeds; give to them according to the work of their hands”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that

the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Give to them according to their work, yes, according to the evil of their deeds and the work of their hands]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 28:4 (#3)

כְּפָעֳלָֽם׃

“according to their work”

By **their work**, David means the evil deeds and wicked actions of his enemies that he mentioned in the previous verse. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [according to their evil actions] or [according to what their wicked deeds deserve]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 28:4 (#4)

כְּמַעֲשֵׂ֥ה יָ֝דֵיהֶ֗ם

“according to the work of their hands”

Here, **work of their hands** represents the actions that they have done. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [according to their actions] or [according to what their evil deeds deserve]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 28:4 (#5)

הָשֵׁ֣ב גְּמוּלָ֣ם לָהֶ֑ם

“return to them their recompense”

By **return to them their recompense**, David means give them the punishment they deserve. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [give them the punishment they deserve]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 28:5 (#1)

לֹ֤א יָ֘בִ֤ינוּ אֶל־פְּעֻלֹ֣ת יְ֭הוָה

“they do not give heed to the works of Yahweh”

The implication is that the wicked do not pay attention to or consider what God has done. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they do not pay attention to the works of Yahweh] or [they do not consider the works of Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 28:5 (#2)

לֹ֤א יָ֘בִ֤ינוּ אֶל־פְּעֻלֹ֣ת יְ֭הוָה וְאֶל־מַעֲשֵׂ֣ה יָ֝דָ֗יו

“they do not give heed to the works of Yahweh or the action of his hands”

These two phrases **the works of Yahweh** and **the action of his hands** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [they do not give heed to what Yahweh has done]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 28:5 (#3)

יְֽהָרְסֵ֥ם וְלֹ֝֗א יִבְנֵֽם

“he will tear them down and not build them up”

David is speaking of God’s judgment as if it is a building **he will tear** down and **not build** up. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will destroy them and not restore them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:6 (#1)

בָּר֣וּךְ יְהוָ֑ה

“Blessed be Yahweh”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I bless Yahweh] or [I will praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 28:6 (#2)

בָּר֣וּךְ יְהוָ֑ה כִּֽי־שָׁ֝מַ֗ע קֹ֣ול תַּחֲנוּנָֽי

“Blessed be Yahweh, because he has heard the voice of my pleas”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second

phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because he has heard the voice of my pleas, blessed be Yahweh]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 28:6 (#3)

שָׁמַע קֹלִי תַּחֲנוּנָי

“he has heard the voice of my pleas”

Here, **voice** represents the words that David spoke. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has heard my pleas]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 28:7 (#1)

יְהוָה ׀ עֻזִּי

“Yahweh is my strength”

See how translated the similar phrase “Yahweh, my strength” in 18:1.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 28:7 (#2)

וּמָגִנִּי

“and my shield”

See how you translated the phrase “my shield” in 18:2 where it is used with the same meaning.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:7 (#3)

בּוֹ בָטַח לִבִּי & וַיֵּעָזֵר לִי לִבִּי

“in him my heart trusts & therefore my heart exults”

Here David is speaking of his **heart** as if it were a person who **trusts** and **exults**. The heart represents the center of his emotions and will. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I trust in him with all my being … therefore I greatly rejoice]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:8 (#1)

יְהוָה עֹז־לָמוֹ

“Yahweh is strength for his people”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh makes his people strong] or [Yahweh strengthens his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 28:8 (#2)

לָמוֹ

“for his people”

Some ancient manuscripts read “for them” and some read **for his people**. For an explanation of the reason why the ULT reads **for his people** see the section in the Psalm 28 Introduction titled “Text variant in 28:8.”

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 28:8 (#3)

וּמָעוֹז יְשׁוּעוֹת מְשִׁיחוֹ הוּא

“and he is a refuge of help {for} his anointed”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **refuge** that provides protection and safety. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and he protects his anointed one like a refuge] or [and he is the one who protects his anointed one]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:8 (#4)

וּמָעוֹז יְשׁוּעוֹת & הוּא

“and he is a refuge of help”

David is using this possessive form **refuge of help** to mean a place of protection and safety. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and a helpful refuge] or [and a refuge that provides help]

See: Possession

Psalms 28:8 (#5)

מְשִׁיחוֹ

“for} his anointed”

David is using the adjective **anointed** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [for his anointed king]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 28:9 (#1)

הוֹשִׁ֤יעָה ׀ אֶת־עַמֶּ֗ךָ וּבָרֵךְ֮ אֶת־נַחֲלָתֶ֢ךָ֢ וּרְעֵ֫ם וְנַשְּׂאֵ֥ם עַד־הָעוֹלָֽם

“Save your people and bless your inheritance, and shepherd them and carry them unto the eternity”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, please save your people and bless your inheritance; please be their shepherd and carry them forever]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 28:9 (#2)

אֶת־נַחֲלָתֶֽךָ

“your inheritance”

Here David is speaking of God’s people as if they were his **inheritance**. David is picturing God’s people as something valuable that belongs to God, like property or possessions that are passed down in a family. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your own people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:9 (#3)

וּרְעֵ֫ם וְנַשְּׂאֵ֥ם

“and shepherd them and carry them”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shepherd** who would guide and protect his people as a shepherd would guide and protect his flock. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [guide and protect them like a shepherd does his flock]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 28:9 (#4)

עַד־הָעוֹלָֽם

“unto the eternity”

David assumes that readers will know that **unto the eternity** means for all time without end. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 29 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 29 is a “psalm of praise.” It tells how Yahweh rules all nature.

1. A call to worship (1–2)
2. Declarations of God’s voice over creation depict natural phenomena (3–9)
3. The Lord sovereignty (10–11)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

The Cultural and Religious Background of verses 3–10

The cultural and religious background of verses 3–10 is the worship of the false gods of the nations who lived around the Israelites. Verses 3–10 are a firm declaration of Yahweh’s power and rule over the entire universe and an implicit denunciation of putting trust in false gods such as the Canaanite god Baal.

Because David does not state the historical and religious background information explicitly in verses 3–10, it is recommended that you not include this information either but if you are using footnotes or chapter introductions in your translation, you may wish to include some of the background information there if it would help your readers.

Yahweh’s power

God is powerful. All he has to do is to speak in order to control nature.

For an overview of Psalm 29 and help understanding some of the important exegetical and poetical issues in this psalm, see the Psalms: Layer by Layer videos below. These videos are part of the Psalms: Layer by Layer project, which is run by Scriptura (formerly Cambridge Digital Bible Research). See their overview video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_aoWN_yFa0E) and top three exegetical issues in Psalm 29 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nnL109G57mg&t=452s) and their top three poetic features of Psalm 29 video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ygoKm9HWKQU&t=181s) on YouTube.

To visit the Psalms: Layer by Layer website go to https://psalms.scriptura.org. These videos are used under CC BY

Psalms 29:1 (#1)

הָבוּ לַיהוָה בְּנֵי אֵלִים הָבוּ לַיהוָה כָּבוֹד וָעֹז

“Ascribe to Yahweh, sons of God, ascribe to Yahweh glory and strength”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Ascribe these things to Yahweh, sons of God, ascribe to Yahweh glory and strength]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 29:1 (#2)

בְּנֵי אֵלִים

“sons of God”

David assumes that readers will know that **sons of God** refers to angels or heavenly beings. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you angels]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 29:1 (#3)

הָבוּ לַיהוָה כָּבוֹד וָעֹז

“ascribe to Yahweh glory and strength”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory** and **strength**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [acknowledge that Yahweh is glorious and strong] or [praise Yahweh because he is glorious and strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 29:2 (#1)

הָבוּ לַיהוָה כְּבוֹד שְׁמוֹ

“Ascribe to Yahweh the glory of his name”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Declare that Yahweh is glorious because of his name] or [Praise Yahweh for how glorious his name is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 29:2 (#2)

כְּבוֹד שְׁמוֹ

“the glory of his name”

David is using this possessive form **the glory of his name** to mean the glory that his name deserves. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the glory his name deserves]

See: Possession

Psalms 29:2 (#3)

כְּבוֹד שְׁמוֹ

“the glory of his name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the glory due to Yahweh] or [the glory Yahweh’s reputation deserves]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 29:2 (#4)

הִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לַיהוָה

“bow down to Yahweh”

Here, **bow down** was a symbolic action by which people showed reverence and worship to Yahweh. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [bow down in worship to Yahweh]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 29:2 (#5)

בְּהַדְרַת־קֹדֶשׁ

“in the adornment of holiness”

The phrase **adornment of holiness** refers to the garments the Levitical priests wore while serving in Yahweh’s tabernacle. David is using the possessive form to describe **adornment** that is characterized by **holiness** because of the purpose for which it was made. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this purpose, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in holy adornment] or [in adornment that is holy]

See: Possession

Psalms 29:2 (#6)

בְּהַדְרַת־קֹדֶשׁ

“in the adornment of holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in holy clothing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 29:3 (#1)

See the Psalm 29 Introduction for more information regarding the historical and religious background of verses 3–10.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Psalms 29:3 (#2)

קוֹל יְהוָה עַל־הַמָּיִם

“The voice of Yahweh over the waters”

The phrase **The voice of Yahweh** could: (1) refer to the actual voice of Yahweh or (2) this phrase could mean “The thunder of Yahweh” since this phrase sometimes had that meaning in Hebrew. Alternate translation: [The thunder of Yahweh is over the waters]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 29:3 (#3)

הַמָּיִם

“the waters”

By **the waters**, David means the sea and here he probably specifically means the Mediterranean Sea. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use plain language as in the UST.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 29:3 (#4)

קוֹל יְהוָה עַל־הַמָּיִם & יְהוָה עַל־מַיִם רַבִּים

“The voice of Yahweh over the waters & Yahweh over many waters”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The voice of Yahweh is heard over the waters … Yahweh’s voice is heard over many waters]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 29:3 (#5)

עַל & עַל

“over & over”

Here the word the ULT translates as **over**, both times it occurs in this verse, could mean: (1) **over**, as in the ULT, or (2) “against.” Alternate translation: [is against … is against]

Psalms 29:3 (#6)

אֵל־הַכָּבוֹד הִרְעִֽים

“the God of glory thunders”

The phrase **the God of glory thunders** could mean: (1) that Yahweh’s powerful voice sounds like thunder. Alternate translation: [the glorious God speaks with a voice like thunder] or [the God of glory speaks powerfully], or (2) that Yahweh sends thunder. Alternate translation: [the God of glory sends thunder]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 29:3 (#7)

אֵל־הַכָּבֹד

“the God of glory”

David is using the possessive form to describe **the God** who is characterized by **glory**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the glorious God]

See: Possession

Psalms 29:4 (#1)

קוֹל־יְהוָה בַּכֹּ֫חַ קוֹל יְהוָה בֶּהָדָֽר

“The voice of Yahweh is with power; the voice of Yahweh is with majesty”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **power** and **majesty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [The voice of Yahweh is powerful; the voice of Yahweh is majestic]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 29:4 (#2)

קוֹל־יְהוָה בַּכֹּ֫חַ קוֹל יְהוָה בֶּהָדָֽר

“The voice of Yahweh is with power; the voice of Yahweh is with majesty”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. David is emphasizing the awesome nature of Yahweh’s voice by using both **power** and **majesty** to describe it. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [The voice of Yahweh is very powerful]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 29:5 (#1)

קוֹל יְהוָה שֹׁבֵר אֲרָזִים

“The voice of Yahweh is breaking cedars”

Here, **voice** represents the sound of Yahweh’s voice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 29:5 (#2)

קוֹל יְהוָה שֹׁבֵר אֲרָזִים וַיְשַׁבֵּר יְהוָה אֶת־אַרְזֵי הַלְּבָנוֹן

“The voice of Yahweh is breaking cedars, and Yahweh breaks the cedars of Lebanon”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [The voice of Yahweh is breaking cedars, yes, breaking the cedars of Lebanon]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 29:6 (#1)

וַיַּרְקִידֵם כְּמוֹ־עֵגֶל לְבָנוֹן וְשִׂרְיֹן כְּמוֹ בֶן־רְאֵמִים

“And he makes Lebanon skip like a calf and Sirion like a son of wild oxen”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [And he makes Lebanon and Sirion skip like calves, like young wild oxen]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 29:6 (#2)

וַיַּרְקִידֵם כְּמוֹ־עֵגֶל לְבָנוֹן וְשִׂרְיֹן כְּמוֹ בֶן־רְאֵמִים

“And he makes Lebanon skip like a calf and Sirion like a son of wild oxen”

David is comparing how Lebanon and Sirion shake to how young animals jump around. The point of this comparison is that just as **a calf** and **a son of wild oxen** skip and jump with energetic movement, so do these mountains shake when God’s voice thunders. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And he makes Lebanon shake with energetic movement like a calf, and Sirion like a son of wild oxen]

See: Simile

Psalms 29:6 (#3)

וְשִׂרְיֹן

“and Sirion”

The word **Sirion** is the name of a mountain. It is another name for Mount Hermon. If it would help your readers, you could use that name instead as in the UST.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 29:6 (#4)

בֶּן־רְאֵמִים

“a son of wild oxen”

David assumes that readers will know that **a son of wild oxen** means a young wild ox. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [a young wild ox]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 29:7 (#1)

קוֹל־יְהוָה חֹצֵצֵב לַהֲבוֹת אֵשׁ

“The voice of Yahweh is hewing out with flames of fire”

The phrase **The voice of Yahweh** could: (1) refer to the actual voice of Yahweh, or (2) could mean “The thunder of Yahweh” since this phrase sometimes has that meaning in Hebrew. Alternate translation: [The thunder of Yahweh is hewing out with flames of fire] See how you translated the phrase **The voice of Yahweh** in verse 3.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 29:7 (#2)

חֹצֵצֵב

“is hewing out”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [is hewing out stone] or [is hewing out rock]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 29:7 (#3)

לַהֲבוֹת אֵשׁ

“with flames of fire”

By **flames of fire**, David means lightning. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [with lightning] or [with flashes of lightning]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 29:8 (#1)

קוֹל יְהוָה יָחִיל מִדְבָּר

“The voice of Yahweh shakes the wilderness”

Here, **voice** represents the sound of Yahweh’s voice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 29:8 (#2)

מִדְבַּר קָדֵשׁ

“the wilderness of Kadesh”

The word **Kadesh** is the name of a place.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 29:9 (#1)

קוֹל יְהוָה

“The voice of Yahweh”

Here, **voice** represents the sound of Yahweh’s voice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 29:9 (#2)

וּבְהֵיכָלוֹ

“and in his temple”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh’s tabernacle in Jerusalem as if it were a **temple**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and in his tabernacle]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 29:9 (#3)

כָּבוֹד

“Glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [How glorious Yahweh is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 29:10 (#1)

יְהוָה לַמַּבּוּל יָשָׁב וַיֵּשֶׁב יְהוָה מֶלֶךְ לְעוֹלָם

“Yahweh sits over the flood; Yahweh sits as king forever”

Here both times the word **sits** is used, it represents “ruling” as king since at that time kings sat on a throne from which they ruled, made decisions, and gave commands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 29:10 (#2)

יְהוָה & יָשָׁב

“Yahweh sits & as”

David assumes that readers will know that **sits** means “rules as king.” You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh sits enthroned ... as]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 29:10 (#3)

לַמַּבּוּל

“over the flood”

The phrase **the flood** could refer to: (1) the water that is above the sky as in the UST, or (2) the great flood recorded in Genesis chapters 6–9 that God sent during the time of Noah. Alternate translation: [over the flood that covered the earth] or [over the Flood]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 29:11 (#1)

יְהוָ֤ה עֹ֣ז לְעַמּ֣וֹ יִתֵּ֑ן יְהוָ֥ה ׀ יְבָרֵ֖ךְ אֶת־עַמּ֣וֹ בַשָּׁלֽוֹם

“Yahweh will give strength to his people; Yahweh will bless his people with peace”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **strength** and **peace**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will make his people strong; Yahweh will bless his people so that they live peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 30 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 30 is a psalm of praise and thanksgiving to God. The psalmist was so sick that he was near death, but God healed him.

1. Call to praise and testimony (1–5)
2. The crisis remembered (6–7)
3. The prayer for help (8–10)
4. The deliverance and vow of praise (11–12)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

The possibility of David dying from sickness

In this psalm David recounts how he was close to death and then pleaded with God. David asked God to heal him and told God that if he died, it would not benefit God, since dead people do not praise God in this life. God healed David with the result that David sings praises to God and thanks him.

Psalms 30:1 (#1)

אֲרוֹמִמְךָ֣ יְהוָ֣ה כִּֽי־דִלִּיתָ֑נִי וְלֹא־שִׂמַּ֖חְתָּ אֹיְבַ֣י לִֽי

“I will extol you, Yahweh, for you have drawn me up and have not let the ones being hostile to me rejoice over me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because you have drawn me up and have not let the ones being hostile to me rejoice over me, I will extol you, Yahweh] or [Yahweh, because you have drawn me up and have not let the ones being hostile to me rejoice over me, I will extol you]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 30:1 (#2)

אֲרוֹמִמְךָ֣ יְהוָ֣ה כִּֽי־דִלִּיתָ֑נִי

“I will extol you, Yahweh, for you have drawn me up”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put **Yahweh** at the beginning of this verse. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, I will extol you for you have drawn me up]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 30:1 (#3)

דִּלִּיתָ֑נִי

“you have drawn me up”

Here David is speaking of God’s help as if God had physically raised him up from a lower place to a higher place. The other times the word the ULT translates as **have drawn me up** occurs in the Old Testament, it refers to drawing water out of a well with a bucket. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have helped me] or [you have delivered me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 30:2 (#1)

יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהָ֑י

“Yahweh my God”

David is not using the phrase **my God** to mean that he is the only one who worships Yahweh nor that he possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God that he worships. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You, Yahweh, God whom I worship,]

See: Possession

Psalms 30:3 (#1)

הֶֽעֱלִ֣יתָ מִן־שְׁא֭וֹל נַפְשִׁ֑י חִיִּיתַ֥נִי מיורדי־בֽוֹר

“you have brought up my soul from Sheol; you have kept me alive from the ones going down to the pit”

The word **Sheol** refers to the place of the dead, where dead people go, and the word **pit** also refers to the grave. These two phrases, **you have brought up my soul from Sheol** and **you have kept me alive from the ones going down to the pit**, mean basically the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind

of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [you have brought up my soul from Sheol, yes, you have kept me alive from the ones going down to the pit]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 30:3 (#2)

הֶעֱלִֽיתָ & נַפְשִׁ֣י

“you have brought up my soul”

David is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have brought me up]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 30:3 (#3)

מיורדי־בֽוֹר

“from the ones going down to the pit”

David assumes that readers will know that **the pit** refers to the grave or death. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from the ones going down to death] or [from the ones going down to the grave]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 30:4 (#1)

לְזֵ֣כֶר קָדְשֽׁוֹ

“at the remembrance of his holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the ideas of **remembrance** and **holiness**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Here the phrase **his holiness** refers to Yahweh’s holy character and the actions that he had done in the past as a result of his holy character. Alternate translation: [when you remember how holy he is and the great things that he has done as a result]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 30:4–5 (#1)

זַמְּר֣וּ לַיהוָ֣ה חֲסִידָ֑יו וְ֝הוֹד֗וּ לְזֵ֣כֶר קָדְשֽׁוֹ׃ כִּ֤י רֶ֣גַע ׀ בְּאַפּ֣וֹ חַ֭יִּים בִּרְצֹונֹ֑ו בָּעֶ֥רֶב יָלִ֗ין בֹּ֫כִ֥י וְלַבֹּ֥קֶר רִנָּֽה

“Sing praise to Yahweh, {you} his faithful ones, and give thanks at the remembrance of his holiness.For his anger is {for} a moment, {but} his favor is {for} a lifetime. In the evening weeping may come to lodge but rejoicing {comes} in the morning”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of verse 4 and the first half of verse 5, since the first half of verse 5 gives the reason for the result that verse 4 describes. Alternate translation: [Because his anger is {for} a moment, {but} his favor is {for} a lifetime, sing praise to Yahweh, {you} his faithful ones, and give thanks at the remembrance of his holiness]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 30:5 (#1)

כִּ֤י רֶ֣גַע ׀ בְּאַפּ֣וֹ חַ֭יִּים בִּרְצֹונֹ֑ו

“For his anger is {for} a moment, {but} his favor is {for} a lifetime”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **anger** and **favor**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [For he is angry only for a moment, but he shows kindness for a lifetime]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 30:5 (#2)

רֶ֣גַע ׀ בְּאַפּ֣וֹ

“his anger is {for} a moment”

David is using **a moment** as a common expression of the culture to mean “a very short time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his anger is for a brief time] or [his anger is only temporary]

See: Idiom

Psalms 30:5 (#3)

בָּעֶ֥רֶב יָלִ֗ין בֹּ֫כִ֥י וְלַבֹּ֥קֶר רִנָּֽה

“In the evening weeping may come to lodge but rejoicing {comes} in the morning”

David is speaking of **weeping** and **rejoicing** as if they were living things that could come to a place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In the evening people may weep, but in the morning people will rejoice]

See: Personification

Psalms 30:6 (#1)

בְּשַׁלְוִ֑י

“in my ease”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **ease**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when my life was easy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 30:6 (#2)

בַּל־אֶמּ֥וֹט לְעוֹלָֽם

“I will never be shaken”

The expression **I will never be shaken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [nothing will ever shake me] or [I will always remain secure]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 30:6 (#3)

בַּל־אֶמּ֥וֹט לְעוֹלָֽם

“I will never be shaken”

David is speaking of himself as if he were an object that could not be**shaken** (physically moved or disturbed). He means that he felt completely secure and believed nothing could threaten his stability or well-being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will always be secure] or [nothing will ever threaten me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 30:7 (#1)

בִּרְצוֹנְךָ֣

“by your favor”

See how you translated the word **favor** in 30:5.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 30:7 (#2)

הֶֽעֱמַדְתָּ֥ה לְהַרְרִ֗י עֹ֫ז

“you have made my mountain stand strong”

The phrase **you have made my mountain stand strong** could be: (1) David speaking of his security and strength as if they were **my mountain**. Alternate translation: [you have made me as secure as a mountain] or [you have given me great strength and security] (2) David using the phrase **my mountain** to refer to Mount Zion in which case David would be using Mount Zion to represent his rule as king which he would do from Mount Zion. Alternate translation: [you have made my reign secure] or [you have firmly established my rule]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 30:7 (#3)

הִסְתַּתַּ֣רְתָּ פָנֶ֣יךָ

“you hid your face”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [then you hid your face from me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 30:7 (#4)

הִסְתַּתַּ֣רְתָּ פָנֶ֣יךָ

“you hid your face”

Here, **your face** represents Yahweh’s presence or attention (and consequently also some of the help or protection that would have come as a result). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you withdrew your presence from me] or [you turned your attention away from me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 30:8 (#1)

אֶתְחַנָּֽן

“I pled for favor”

See how you translated the word **favor** in 30:5.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 30:9 (#1)

מַה־בֶּ֭בָצַע בְּדָמִ֑י בְּרִדְתִּ֥י אֶ֝֗ל־שָׁ֫חַ֥ת הֲיוֹדְךָ֥ עָפָ֑ר הֲיַגִּ֥יד אֲמִתֶּֽךָ

“What profit {is there} in my blood, in my descent to the pit? Will the dust praise you? Will it declare your faithfulness”

David is using a question to emphasize that his death would not benefit God and to make the point that dead people cannot praise God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for this

purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or exclamations. Alternate translation: [There is no profit in my blood, in my descent to the pit. The dust will not praise you! It will not declare your faithfulness!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 30:9 (#2)

מַה־בֶּ֭בַצַע בְּדָמִ֑י בְּרִדְתִּ֖י אֶ֣ל־שָׁ֣חַת

“What profit {is there} in my blood, in my descent to the pit”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. [What advantage is there in my death, yes, in my going down to the grave]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 30:9 (#3)

בְּדָמִ֑י

“in my blood”

Here, **blood** represents “death.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in my death]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 30:9 (#4)

אֶ֣ל־שָׁ֣חַת

“to the pit”

David assumes that readers will know that **the pit** refers to the dwelling place of the dead. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. (In 30:3 David uses a different Hebrew word for “pit,” but there the word has the same meaning as it does here so you could see how you translated “pit” there.) Alternate translation: [to the place of the dead] or [to the abode of the dead]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 30:9 (#5)

הֲיוֹדְךָ֥ עָפָ֑ר

“Will the dust praise you”

Here, **dust** represents those who are dead. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Will those who are dead praise you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 30:9 (#6)

אֲמִתֶּֽךָ

“your faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way as in the UST.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 30:9–10 (#1)

מַה־בֶּ֭בַצַע בְּדָמִ֑י בְּרִדְתִּ֖י אֶ֣ל־שָׁ֣חַת הֲיוֹדְךָ֥ עָפָ֑ר הֲ֝יַגִּ֗יד אֲמִתֶּֽךָ׃
שְׁמַע־יְהוָ֣ה וְחָ֭נֵּנִי יְ֣הוָ֑ה הֱיֵה־עֹזֵ֖ר לִֽי

“What profit {is there} in my blood, in my descent to the pit? Will the dust praise you? Will it declare your faithfulness?Hear, Yahweh, and be gracious to me. Yahweh, be my helper”

This is the beginning of what David said or prayed to Yahweh. The ULT indicates the beginning and end of David’s direct address of Yahweh with quotation marks and the UST introduces David’s words with the phrase “I said.” Consider natural ways of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [I prayed, “What profit is there…”]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 30:10 (#1)

שְׁמַע

“Hear”

Here, **Hear** represents “Listen and respond.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Listen to me and respond] or [Pay attention to me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 30:10 (#2)

שְׁמַע־יְהוָ֣ה וְחָ֭נֵּנִי יְ֣הוָ֑ה הֱיֵה־עֹזֵ֖ר לִֽי

“Hear, Yahweh, and be gracious to me. Yahweh, be my helper”

David is using imperative forms, but he is communicating polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative forms **Hear**, **be gracious to me**, and **be my helper** do not communicate polite requests in your language, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hear, Yahweh, and please be gracious to me. Yahweh, please be my helper]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 30:11 (#1)

פִּתַּחְתָּ שַׂקִּי וַתְּאַזְּרֵנִי שִׂמְחָה

"you have loosed my sackcloth and have clothed me with gladness"

David assumes that readers will know **sackcloth** was a coarse material worn as a sign of mourning or distress. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you have removed my mourning clothes and have clothed me with gladness]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 30:11 (#2)

שִׂמְחָה

"with gladness"

Here, **gladness** represents clothing that was worn for joyous occasions that would express gladness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with celebratory clothes] or [with clothes worn to celebrate]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 30:11 (#3)

וַתְּאַזְּרֵנִי שִׂמְחָה

"and have clothed me with gladness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **gladness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and have covered me with clothes that show that I am glad] or [and have clothed me with celebratory clothes]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 30:12 (#1)

לְמַעַן

"in order that"

Here, **so that** marks **my glory may sing praise to you and not be silent** as the goal or purpose of "You have turned for me, my mourning into dancing; you have loosed my sackcloth and have clothed me with gladness" in the previous verse. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [for the purpose that] or [to the end that]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 30:12 (#2)

יְזַמֶּרְךָ כָבוֹד

"my} glory may sing praise to you"

By **my glory**, David probably means some part of his inner being that represented where his honor was. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [my soul may sing praise to you] or [I may sing praise to you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 30:12 (#3)

יְהוָה אֱלֹהַי

"Yahweh my God"

David is not using this possessive form **my God** to indicate that he possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather, David is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom he worships. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the God I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms - Chapter 31 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 31 is considered to be one of the "psalms of deliverance." See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the psalms of deliverance.

1. Declaration of trust (1–8)
2. Lament over suffering (9–13)
3. Affirmation of faith (14–18)
4. Praise and thanksgiving (19–22)
5. Final Exhortation (23–24)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Abandonment

Even though everyone deserted and despised the psalmist, God did not abandon him.

Psalms 31:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 31:1 (#1)

בְּךָ יְהוָה חָסִיתִי

"In you, Yahweh, I take refuge"

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a physical place of safety or shelter. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I trust in you, Yahweh, to keep me safe] or [I depend on you, Yahweh, to protect me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:1 (#2)

אַל־אֵבֹושָׁה לְעוֹלָם בְּצִדְקָתְךָ פַלְּטֵנִי

"do not ever let me have shame; in your righteousness deliver me"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not ever let me have shame; please deliver me in your righteousness]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 31:1 (#3)

בְּצִדְקָתְךָ

"in your righteousness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:2 (#1)

הַטֵּה אֵלַי ׀ אָזְנְךָ מְהֵרָה הַצִּילֵנִי הֱיֵה לִי ׀ לְצוּר־מָעוֹז

"Incline your ear to me; rescue me quickly; be for me a rocky summit of refuge"

David is using imperative forms, but these communicate a polite request rather than commands. If the imperative form does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use forms in your language that communicate polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please incline your ear to me; please rescue me quickly; please be for me a rocky summit of refuge]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 31:2 (#2)

הַטֵּה אֵלַי ׀ אָזְנְךָ

"Incline your ear to me"

Here David is using the term **ear** to mean hearing or attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Listen and respond to me] or [Pay attention to me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:2 (#3)

הֱיֵה לִי ׀ לְצוּר־מָעוֹז לְבֵית מְצוּדוֹת

"be for me a rocky summit of refuge, a dwelling place of strongholds"

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a **rocky summit** used as a **refuge** and as if he were actually a place that had **strongholds** where he could hide and be safe from his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [be for me like a rocky summit of refuge, and like a dwelling place of strongholds]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:2 (#4)

הֱיֵה לִי ׀ לְצוּר־מָעוֹז לְבֵית מְצוּדוֹת

"be for me a rocky summit of refuge, a dwelling place of strongholds"

David is using these possessive forms, **a rocky summit of refuge** and **a dwelling place of strongholds**, to describe places that are characterized by providing refuge and strength. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive forms for this, you could express these ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [be for me a rocky summit that provides refuge, a stronghold in which to dwell]

See: Possession

Psalms 31:3 (#1)

סַלְעִי֥ וּמְצוּדָתִ֑י אָֽתָּה

“you are my rock and my stronghold”

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a large **rock** and a **stronghold** to which he could flee to be safe from his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [you are like a rock that I can flee to for safety and like a stronghold in which I can be safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:3 (#2)

וּלְמַ֥עַן שִׁמְךָ֗

“therefore for the sake of your name”

David is using the term **name** to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:3 (#3)

תַּנְחֵ֥נִי וְתְנַהֲלֵֽנִי

“you lead me and guide me”

The terms **lead** and **guide** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [direct me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 31:3 (#4)

תַּנְחֵ֥נִי וְתְנַהֲלֵֽנִי

“you lead me and guide me”

Here the Hebrew verbs that the ULT translates as **you lead me and guide me** could be: (1) expressing a general truth that has been part of David’s ongoing experience. If you decide this is the meaning, then you can translate the two verbs in this phrase in a similar way to the ULT. (2) expressing something that will happen in the future. Alternate translation: [you will lead me and guide me] or (3) a request that is a prayer to Yahweh. (This option is less likely since David does not use the imperative forms of these verbs as would be expected if these verbs were meant to be requests.) Alternate translation: [lead me and guide me] or [please lead me and guide me]

Psalms 31:3 (#5)

תַּנְחֵ֥נִי וְתְנַהֲלֵֽנִי

“you lead me and guide me”

The implication is that David wants God to lead and guide him so that his enemies do not harm him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you lead me and guide me so that my enemies do not harm me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 31:4 (#1)

תּוֹצִיאֵ֥נִי מֵרֶ֗שֶׁת זָ֭זוּ טָ֣מְנוּ לִֽלְכֹּד־לִֽי

“You will pull me out of the net which they have secretly laid for me”

Here David is speaking as if his enemies’ plans to harm him were a **net** that they had hidden to trap him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Rescue me from being harmed by the plans that they have secretly made to harm me] or [Rescue me from the ambush that they have secretly set for me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:4 (#2)

Here the Hebrew verb that the ULT translates as **You will pull me** could be: (1) expressing something that will happen in the future as in the ULT or (2) a request that is a prayer to Yahweh. (This option is less likely since David does not use the imperative form of this verb as would be expected if this was a request.) Alternate translation: [Please pull me] or [Pull me]

Psalms 31:4 (#3)

אַתָּ֥ה מָעוּזִּֽי

“you are my refuge”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **refuge**, a physical place of safety and protection from danger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are my protector] or [you keep me safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:5 (#1)

בְּיָדְךָ֣

“Into your hand”

Here, **hand** represents God’s power, control and care. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Into your care] or [Into your control]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:5 (#2)

אַפְקִ֥יד רוּחִ֑י

“I commit my spirit”

David is using the term **spirit** to mean his enlivening spirit that causes him to be physically alive. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I commit myself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:5 (#3)

אֵ֥ל אֱמֶֽת

“God of faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God who is faithful to me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:6 (#1)

שָׂנֵ֗אתִי הַשֹּׁמְרִ֥ים

“I hate the ones keeping”

Here, **the ones keeping** represents those who worship idols. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I hate those who worship]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:6 (#2)

הַבְלֵי־שָׁ֫וְא

“idols of worthlessness”

David is using the possessive form to describe **idols** that are characterized by **worthlessness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [worthless idols]

See: Possession

Psalms 31:7 (#1)

אָגִ֣ילָה וְאֶשְׂמְחָ֑ה

“I will be glad and rejoice”

The terms **be glad** and **rejoice** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I will rejoice greatly]

See: Doublet

Psalms 31:7 (#2)

בְּחַסְדֶּ֗ךָ אֲשֶׁ֤ר רָ֫אִ֥יתָ אֶת־עָנְיִ֑י יָ֝דַ֗עְתָּ בְּצָר֥וֹת נַפְשִֽׁי

“in your covenant faithfulness, for you have seen my affliction; you have known the troubles of my soul”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **affliction**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because you are faithful to your covenant, for you have seen how I have suffered; you have known how my soul is troubled]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:7 (#3)

בְּצָר֥וֹת נַפְשִֽׁי

“the troubles of my soul”

David is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the troubles I have experienced] or [my inner distress]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:8 (#1)

בְּיַד־אוֹיֵ֑ב

“into the hand of the ones being hostile to me”

Here, **hand** represents the power or control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [into the power of the ones being hostile to me] or [under the control of the ones being hostile to me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:8 (#2)

הֶֽעֱמַדְתָּ בַמֶּרְחָב רַגְלָי

“you have set my feet in an open space”

Here David is speaking of being rescued as if he had been squeezed into a narrow, dangerous space with no way to escape and God enabled him to escape into an **open space**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have set me free from danger] or [you have rescued me from my desperate situation]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:9 (#1)

חָנֵּנִי

“Be gracious to me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please be gracious to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 31:9 (#2)

כִּֽי צַר־לִי עָשְׁשָׁה בְכַעַס עֵינִי

“for I am in distress; my eye has wasted away from grief”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **grief**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for I am distressed, because of my grieving my eye has wasted away]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:9 (#3)

עָשְׁשָׁה בְכַעַס עֵינִי

“my eye has wasted away from grief”

David says **my eye has wasted away from grief** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [I cry so much that my eyes feel like they are wasting away] or [I am crying so much that my eyes hurt]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 31:9 (#4)

בְּכַעַס

“from grief”

Here, **grief** represents crying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from crying] or [because I cry so much]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:9 (#5)

נַפְשִׁי וּבִטְנִי

“my soul and my body”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [my soul and my body have wasted away from grief]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 31:9 (#6)

נַפְשִׁי וּבִטְנִי

“my soul and my body”

David is referring to all of himself by naming two major components, **my soul** and **my body**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all of me] or [my whole being]

See: Merism

Psalms 31:10 (#1)

כִּֽי כָלּוּ בְיָגוֹן חַיָּי וּשְׁנוֹתַי בַּאֲנָחָה כָּשַׁל בַּעֲוֹנִי כֹחִי וַעֲצָמַי עָשֵׁשׁוּ

“For my life has come to an end with sorrow, and my years with groaning; my strength fails from my iniquity, and my bones waste away”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [For my life comes to an end with sorrow, yes, my years with

groaning; my strength fails from my iniquity, indeed, my bones waste away]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 31:10 (#2)

כִּכְלוּ בְיָגוֹן חַיַּי

"For my life has come to an end with sorrow"

By **For my life has come to an end with sorrow**, David means that his life is being consumed or shortened by grief and distress. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [For my life is being consumed by sorrow] or [For sorrow is shortening my life]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 31:10 (#3)

בְיָגוֹן

"with sorrow"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sorrow**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [sorrowfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:10 (#4)

בַּעֲוֹנִי

"from my iniquity"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I have sinned] or [because of the wrong things I have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:10 (#5)

וַעֲצָמַי עָשֵׁשׁוּ

"and my bones waste away"

David is using one part of his body, his **bones**, to represent his entire physical being as it deteriorates. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my entire body wastes away]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 31:11 (#1)

הָיִיתִי חֶרְפָּה

"I have become a reproach"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I have become someone whom people reproach] or [I have become someone whom people despise]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:11 (#2)

וְלִשְׁכֵנַי ׀ מְאֹד וּפַחַד לְמְיָדָעָי

"and especially to my neighbors, and dread to the ones knowing me"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and I have become especially a reproach to my neighbors, and I have become a dread to the ones knowing me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 31:11 (#3)

וּפַחַד לְמְיָדָעָי

"and dread to the ones knowing me"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dread**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the ones knowing me are afraid of me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:12 (#1)

נָשְׁכַּחְתִּי

"I have been forgotten"

The expression **I have been forgotten** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [People have forgotten me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 31:12 (#2)

נָשְׁכַּחְתִּי כְּמֵת מִלֵּב

"I have been forgotten like a dead man out of mind"

David is making a comparison between himself and **a dead man out of mind**. The point of this comparison is that just as a dead man is completely forgotten by

people, so David feels that he has been completely forgotten. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I have been completely forgotten, just as people forget about the dead]

See: Simile

Psalms 31:12 (#3)

מִלֵּֽב

“out of mind”

David is using **out of mind** as a common expression of the culture to mean “completely forgotten.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is completely forgotten] or [whom people have completely forgotten]

See: Idiom

Psalms 31:12 (#4)

הָֽיִיתִי כִּכְלִי אֹבֵד

“I am like a broken vessel”

Here David is comparing himself to **a broken vessel** using the word **like**. The point of this comparison is that just as a broken vessel is useless and discarded, so David feels useless and discarded by others. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I am useless like a broken vessel] or [I am discarded like a broken vessel]

See: Simile

Psalms 31:13 (#1)

כִּֽי־ שָׁמַ֥עְתִּי ׀ דִּבַּ֣ת רַבִּ֑ים מָגֹ֥ור מִסָּ֝בִֽיב

“For I hear the whispering of many— terror on every side”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [For I hear the whispering of many, and there is terror on every side]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 31:13 (#2)

כִּֽי־ שָׁמַ֥עְתִּי ׀ דִּבַּ֣ת רַבִּ֑ים מָגֹ֥ור מִסָּ֝בִֽיב

“For I hear the whispering of many— terror on every side”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about **terror on every side** with the information about **the whispering of many**. Alternate translation: [For I hear the whispering of many and there is terror on every side]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 31:13 (#3)

מָגֹ֥ור מִסָּ֝בִֽיב

“terror on every side”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **terror**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [terrifying things on every side]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:13 (#4)

לָקַ֣חַת נַפְשִׁ֣י זָמָ֑מוּ

“they plan to take my life”

David is using **they plan to take my life** as a common expression of the culture to mean “they plan to kill me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they plan to murder me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 31:14 (#1)

וַ֝אֲנִ֗י

“But I”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between his distressing circumstances and his trust in Yahweh. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, I] or [Yet I]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 31:14 (#2)

אֱלֹהַ֣י אָ֑תָּה

“You are my God”

David is not using this possessive form **my God** to indicate that he possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather he is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the

God whom he worships. If it would help your readers, you could indicate this explicitly as in the UST.

See: Possession

Psalms 31:15 (#1)

בְּיָדְךָ עִתֹּתָי הַצִּילֵנִי מִיַּד

“My times are in your hand; rescue me from the hand of”

Here, **hand** represents the power or control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My times are in your control; rescue me from the power of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:15 (#2)

הַצִּילֵנִי

“rescue me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please rescue me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 31:15 (#3)

עִתֹּתָי

“My times”

David assumes that readers will know that **My times** refers to the events and circumstances of his life, including its duration. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The events of my life] or [My life and circumstances]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 31:15 (#4)

אֹיְבַי וּמֵרֹדְפָי

“the ones being hostile to me and from the ones pursuing me”

The terms **the ones being hostile to me** and **the ones pursuing me** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my relentless enemies]

See: Doublet

Psalms 31:16 (#1)

הָאִירָה פָנֶיךָ עַל־עַבְדֶּךָ הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“Make your face shine upon your servant; save me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please make your face shine upon your servant; save me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 31:16 (#2)

הָאִירָה פָנֶיךָ עַל

“Make your face shine upon”

David is using **Make your face shine on** as a common expression of the culture to mean “show favor to” or “be gracious to.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Show favor to] or [Be gracious to]

See: Idiom

Psalms 31:16 (#3)

עַבְדֶּךָ

“your servant”

David is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 31:16 (#4)

בְחַסְדֶּךָ

“in your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:17 (#1)

יֵבֹ֣שׁוּ רְ֭שָׁעִים יִדְּמ֣וּ לִשְׁא֑וֹל

“let the wicked have shame; let them be silent in Sheol”

By using **let**, the psalmist is expressing what he thinks should happen. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [the wicked should have shame; they should be silent in Sheol]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 31:17 (#2)

יְהוָ֗ה אַל־אֵ֫בוֹשָׁ֥ה כִּֽי־קְרָאתִ֥יךָ

“Yahweh, do not let me have shame, for I have called upon you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I have called upon you, Yahweh, do not let me have shame]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 31:17 (#3)

רְ֭שָׁעִים

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 31:17 (#4)

יִדְּמ֣וּ לִשְׁא֑וֹל

“let them be silent in Sheol”

David assumes that readers will know that **Sheol** is the place of the dead. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [let them be silent in the place of the dead]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 31:18 (#1)

תֵּאָלַ֗מְנָה שִׂפְתֵ֫י שָׁ֥קֶר

“Let lying lips be silenced”

The expression **Let lying lips be silenced** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [May God silence lying lips] or [May lying lips become silent]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 31:18 (#2)

שִׂפְתֵ֫י שָׁ֥קֶר

“lying lips”

Here, **lying lips** represents people who tell lies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who lie]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:18 (#3)

צַדִּ֑יק

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase as in the UST.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 31:18 (#4)

בְּגַאֲוָ֖ה וָבֽוּז

“in pride and contempt”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **pride** and **contempt**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [proudly and contemptuously] or [in a proud and contemptuous manner]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:18 (#5)

בְּגַאֲוָ֖ה וָבֽוּז

“in pride and contempt”

The terms **pride** and **contempt** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If

it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [with great arrogance]

See: Doublet

Psalms 31:19 (#1)

מָ֭ה רַב־טוּבְךָ֣

“How great is your goodness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [How incredibly good you are] or [How abundant are the good things you do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:19 (#2)

צָפַ֣נְתָּ

“you have stored up”

David is speaking of God’s goodness as if it were something physical that God had **stored up** like treasure in a storehouse. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:19 (#3)

לַחֹסִ֥ים בָּ֝ךְ

“for the ones taking refuge in you”

See how you translated the similar phrase “I take refuge” in 31:1.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:19 (#4)

בְּנֵ֣י אָדָֽם

“the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 31:20 (#1)

תַּסְתִּירֵ֤ם ׀ בְּסֵ֬תֶר פָּ֭נֶיךָ מֵרַכְסֵ֣י אִ֑ישׁ תִּצְפְּנֵ֖ם בְּסֻכָּ֣ה מֵרִ֣יב לְשֹׁנֽוֹת

“You hide them in the hiding-place of your presence from the plots of man; you hide them in a shelter from the strife of tongues”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [You hide them in the safety of your presence, protecting them from those who plot against them and from cruel words]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 31:20 (#2)

תַּסְתִּירֵ֤ם ׀ בְּסֵ֬תֶר פָּ֭נֶיךָ מֵרַכְסֵ֣י אִ֑ישׁ

“You hide them in the hiding-place of your presence from the plots of man”

Here David is speaking of **the hiding-place of your presence** as if it were a physical shelter where Yahweh could hide people from danger. David means that Yahweh protects people by his divine presence and power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You protect them by your presence from the plots of man]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:20 (#3)

אִ֑ישׁ

“man”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language as in the UST.

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 31:20 (#4)

תִּצְפְּנֵ֖ם בְּסֻכָּ֣ה מֵרִ֣יב לְשֹׁנֽוֹת

“you hide them in a shelter from the strife of tongues”

Here David is speaking of God's protection and help as if it were a physical **shelter** in which God would hide righteous people from the accusatory words of evil people. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [you protect them from people who attack with their words as if you were hiding them in a shelter]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:20 (#5)

מֵרִיב לְשֹׁנוֹת

"from the strife of tongues"

Here, **tongues** represents people speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from people who accuse them with their words] or [from verbal attacks]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:21 (#1)

בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה

"Blessed be Yahweh"

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I bless Yahweh] or [Let me praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 31:21 (#2)

בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה כִּי הִפְלִיא חַסְדּוֹ לִי בְּעִיר מָצוֹר

"Blessed be Yahweh, for he has shown marvelously his covenant faithfulness to me in a besieged city"

David is giving the reason that Yahweh should be blessed after stating that he should be blessed. If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because he has shown marvelously his covenant faithfulness to me in a besieged city, blessed be Yahweh]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 31:21 (#3)

חַסְדּוֹ

"his covenant faithfulness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all the ways he is faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:21 (#4)

בְּעִיר מָצוֹר

"in a besieged city"

The expression **in a besieged city** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is his enemies. Alternate translation: [in a city that my enemies had surrounded]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 31:22 (#1)

בְּחָפְזִי

"in my alarm"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **alarm**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when I was alarmed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 31:22 (#2)

נִגְרַזְתִּי מִנֶּגֶד עֵינֶיךָ

"I am cut off from your eyes"

Here, **eyes** represents God's attention or awareness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I am cut off from your attention] or [you are no longer watching over me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:22 (#3)

אָכֵן

"But indeed"

David uses the words **But indeed** here to indicate a contrast between his fearful thoughts and God's actual response. In your translation, indicate this

contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However] or [Yet]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 31:22 (#4)

קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנָי

“the voice of my pleas”

Here, **voice** represents the pleas themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 31:22 (#5)

שָׁמַעְתָּ קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנַי בְּשַׁוְּעִי אֵלֶיךָ

“you heard the voice of my pleas when I cried out to you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [when I cried out to you, you heard the voice of my pleas]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 31:23 (#1)

אֱמוּנִים

“the faithful”

David is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [faithful people] or [those who are faithful]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 31:24 (#1)

חִזְקוּ

“Be firm”

David is using **Be firm** as a common expression of the culture to mean “be strong.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Idiom

Psalms 31:24 (#2)

לְבַבְכֶם

“your heart”

The word **your** is plural here because David is speaking to **all the ones waiting for Yahweh**. Use the plural form in your language if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 31:24 (#3)

וְיַאֲמֵץ לְבַבְכֶם

“and let your heart be courageous”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and feelings exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 31:24 (#4)

כָּל־הַמְיַחֲלִים לַיהוָה

“all the ones waiting for Yahweh”

David assumes that readers will know that here **waiting** refers to waiting on Yahweh to help them. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [all the ones waiting for Yahweh to help you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 32 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 32 is a psalm about confession of sin. It is considered to be one of the “penitential” psalms. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the penitential psalms. (See: confess, confession; and sin, sinful, sinner, sinning)

1. The type of person who God says is blessed (1–2)
2. The results of concealing one’s sin (3–4)
3. David confesses his sin to Yahweh and Yahweh forgives his sin (5)
4. David gives reasons for confessing one’s sin to Yahweh (6–7)
5. David instructs his readers (8–9)
6. Conclusion (10–11)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “maskil.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Confession of sin

This Psalm tells of the sorrow of unconfessed sin. It also tells of the blessing of confession and of receiving God's forgiveness. It is a blessing when God forgives sin. Trouble comes when sin is hidden and not confessed. (See: bless, blessed, blessing; and forgive, forgiven, forgiveness, pardon, pardoned)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Who is speaking in verses 8–9?

Among Bible scholars there are several different views regarding who is speaking in verses 8 and 9. Some Bible scholars think that it is David speaking, and others think that it is God speaking. Because these verses do not explicitly state who is speaking, you should not indicate who the speaker is in your translation.

Psalms 32:1 (#1)

לְדָוִ֗ד מַ֫שְׂכִּ֥יל

"A maskil of David"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 32:1 (#2)

אַשְׁרֵ֣י

"The happinesses of"

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, what constitutes true happiness from God's perspective. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 32:1 (#3)

נְשׂוּי־פֶ֭שַׁע כְּסוּי חֲטָאָֽה

"the one whose transgression is lifted up, the one covered from sin"

The expressions **transgression is lifted up** and **covered from sin** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [the one whose transgression God has lifted up, the one whose sin God has covered]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 32:1 (#4)

נְשׂוּי־פֶ֭שַׁע כְּסוּי חֲטָאָֽה

"the one whose transgression is lifted up, the one covered from sin"

These two phrases **the one whose transgression is lifted up** and **the one covered from sin** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. It may be helpful in your language to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the one whose transgression is lifted up, that is, whose sin is covered]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 32:1 (#5)

כְּסוּי חֲטָאָֽה

"the one covered from sin"

Here the phrase **the one covered from sin** means "the one whose sin is covered." David is speaking of sin as if it were an object that could be covered. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one whose sin Yahweh takes away]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:1 (#6)

נְשׂוּי־פֶ֭שַׁע כְּסוּי חֲטָאָֽה

"the one whose transgression is lifted up, the one covered from sin"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **transgression** and **sin**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the one forgiven of the wrong things that one has done, forgiven for how that one has disobeyed you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:1 (#7)

נְשׂוּי־פֶּ֥שַׁע כְּסוּי חֲטָאָֽה

“the one whose transgression is lifted up, the one covered from sin”

Here, **one whose transgression is lifted up** and **one covered from sin** represent people in general, not specific individuals. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use expressions that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone whose transgression is lifted up, and anyone who is covered from sin]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 32:2 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, what constitutes true happiness from God’s perspective. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 32:2 (#2)

אָדָ֗ם

“the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [any person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 32:2 (#3)

לֹ֤א יַחְשֹׁ֨ב יְ & עָוֹ֗ן וְאֵ֣ין בְּרוּחֹ֣ו רְמִיָּֽה

“reckons no guilt, and in whose spirit {there is} no deceit”

The abstract nouns **guilt** and **deceit** express the ideas of being guilty and being deceitful. If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **guilt** and **deceit**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [does not reckon what he has done wrong and who is not deceitful] or [does not reckon to him what he is guilty of and who does not act deceitfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:2 (#4)

וְאֵ֣ין בְּרוּחֹ֣ו

“and in whose spirit {there is} no”

Here, **spirit** represents the person’s inner being or character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and in whom there is no]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 32:3 (#1)

כִּֽי־הֶחֱרַ֥שְׁתִּי

“When I kept silent”

By **kept silent**, David means that he did not confess his sin to God. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When I kept silent about my sin]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 32:3 (#2)

בָּלְל֣וּ עֲצָמַ֑י

“my bones wasted away”

Here David is speaking as if his **bones** were actually deteriorating. He means that his body was becoming weak, and he felt as if he was ill. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my vitality was depleted]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:3 (#3)

בְּשַׁאֲגָתִֽי

“through my screaming”

The word translated as **through** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [which caused me to scream]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 32:3 (#4)

בְּשַׁאֲגָתִֽי

“through my screaming”

David says **through my screaming** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [through my groaning]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 32:3 (#5)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“all of the day”

David is using **all of the day** as a common expression of his culture to mean “continually.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [continually]

See: Idiom

Psalms 32:4 (#1)

יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה׃

“by day and night”

The psalmist is referring to all of time by naming two major components, **day** and **night**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [continually] or [all of the time]

See: Merism

Psalms 32:4 (#2)

תִּכְבַּד עָלַי יָדֶךָ

“your hand was heavy upon me”

David is using **your hand was heavy upon me** as a common expression of his culture to mean that God afflicted or disciplined him severely. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Idiom

Psalms 32:4 (#3)

נֶהְפַּךְ לְשַׁדִּי

“My vitality was changed”

The expression **My vitality was changed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [God drained my strength] or [My strength dried up]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 32:4 (#4)

נֶהְפַּךְ לְשַׁדִּי בְּחַרְבֹנֵי קָיִץ

“My vitality was changed {as} by the heat of summer”

The point of this comparison is that just as the **heat of summer** is extremely intense and withering, so David’s **vitality was changed** due to his unconfessed sin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [My strength was completely drained like something withered by intense heat]

See: Simile

Psalms 32:5 (#1)

חַטָּאתִי אוֹדִיעֲךָ וַעֲוֹנִי לֹא־כִסִּיתִי

“My sin I acknowledged to you, and my guilt I did not cover”

These two phrases **My sin I acknowledged to you** and **my guilt I did not cover** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [I confessed my sin to you—I did not hide my guilt]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 32:5 (#2)

חַטָּאתִי & חַטָּאתִי

“My sin & my sin”

See how you translated the similar expression in 32:1.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:5 (#3)

וַעֲוֹנִי & עֲוֹן

“and my guilt & the guilt of”

See how you translated the similar expression in 32:2.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:5 (#4)

וַעֲוֹנִ֣י לֹא־כִסִּ֑יתִי

“and my guilt I did not cover”

Here David is speaking of **sin** and **guilt** as if they were something that could be covered. He means that he did not try to hide his sin from God. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my guilt I did not refuse to confess]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:5 (#5)

פְּשָׁעַ֖י

“my transgressions”

See how you translated the similar expression in 32:1.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:5 (#6)

וְאַתָּ֣ה נָשָׂ֔אתָ עֲוֹ֖ן חַטָּאתִ֣י

“and you lifted up the guilt of my sin”

See how you translated the similar expression in 32:1. Alternate translation: [and you forgave the guilt of my sin] or [and you took away the guilt of my sin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:6 (#1)

לְעֵ֣ת מְ֭צֹא

“at a time of finding”

Here David is speaking of God’s forgiveness as if it were something that could be found. He also indicates that there is a favorable time in which to seek forgiveness. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [while there is an opportunity]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:6 (#2)

לְ֝לַשֵּׁ֗טֶף מַ֣יִם רַבִּ֑ים אֵ֖לָיו לֹ֣א יַגִּיעוּ

“in a flood of great waters, they will not reach to him”

Here David is speaking as if troubles were actually a **flood of great waters** that could overwhelm someone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when great trouble comes, God will rescue those who trust in him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:6 (#3)

אֵ֖לָיו

“to him”

Here, **him** represents godly people in general, not a specific person. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to them]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 32:7 (#1)

אַתָּ֣ה ׀ סֵ֣תֶר לִ֑י

“You are a hiding place for me”

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a **hiding place**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are the one who causes me to be safe] or [You are like a hiding place for me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:7 (#2)

אַתָּ֣ה ׀ סֵ֣תֶר לִ֭י מִצַּ֣ר תִּ֝צְּרֵ֗רֵנִי

“You are a hiding place for me; you preserve me from distress”

These two phrases **You are a hiding place for me** and **you preserve me from distress** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. Alternate translation: [You protect me as my refuge; you keep me safe from trouble]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 32:7 (#3)

מִצַּ֣ר

“from distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from things that cause me trouble] or [when others afflict me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:7 (#4)

רָנַנִּי פַלֵּט תִּסִּרֵנִי

“you will surround me {with} shouts of deliverance”

The implication is that there will be people around the writer who will be shouting joyfully about how God has rescued him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You surround me with people who are celebrating your deliverance with joyful shouts]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 32:8 (#1)

אַשְׂכִּילְךָ ׀ וְאוֹרְךָ

“I will instruct you and teach you”

The terms **instruct** and **teach** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I will carefully teach you]

See: Doublet

Psalms 32:8 (#2)

בְּדֶרֶךְ־זוּ תֵּלֵךְ

“in the way which you are to go”

Here the psalmist is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in how you should live] or [regarding how you should live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 32:8 (#3)

אִיעֲצָה עָלַיִךְ עֵינִי

“I will counsel you {with} my eye upon you”

Yahweh is using **with my eye upon you** as a common expression of the culture to mean “watching you closely and guiding you directly.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will teach you directly] or [I will look you in the eyes when I counsel you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 32:9 (#1)

אַל־תִּהְיוּ ׀ כְּסוּס כְּפֶרֶד

“Do not be like a horse {or} like a mule”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **horse** and a **mule** are stubborn animals that must be controlled with bits and bridles, so are people who refuse to follow God’s guidance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Do not be stubborn like horses and mules that must be controlled with bits and bridles]

See: Simile

Psalms 32:9 (#2)

עֶדְיָיו לִבְלוֹם

“ornament of him to curb”

The psalmist assumes that his readers will know that here **ornament** refers to “trappings”, functional pieces that are used on horses and mules in order to guide and restrain them. The implication of the phrase **ornament of him to curb** is that a horse or mule must be controlled by these trappings in order to guide and restrain (or **curb**) them. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [his trappings must restrain him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 32:9 (#3)

עֶדְיָיו לִבְלוֹם

“ornament of him to curb”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [ornament of him to curb his behavior]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 32:9 (#4)

בְּמֶתֶג־וָרֶסֶן

“with bit and bridle”

A **bit and bridle** is a kind of harness that fits around a horse's head and includes a metal bar that goes in its mouth. If your readers would not be familiar with what a bit and bridle are, you could use more general terms as in the UST or explain them in a footnote.

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 32:10 (#1)

רַבִּ֣ים מַכְאֹובִ֣ים לָ֭רָשָׁ֑ע

"Many {are the} pains of the wicked"

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Many are the pains of those who do wicked things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 32:10 (#2)

חֶ֣סֶד יְסֹובְבֶ֣נּוּ

"covenant faithfulness surrounds him"

The psalmist is speaking of **covenant faithfulness** as if it were a living thing that could protect someone by surrounding them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh's faithful love will protect him] or [Yahweh's covenant faithfulness will protect him]

See: Personification

Psalms 32:10 (#3)

חֶ֣סֶד יְסֹובְבֶ֣נּוּ

"covenant faithfulness surrounds him"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who acts faithfully toward him according to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:11 (#1)

צַדִּיקִ֑ים

"righteous"

See how you translated the phrase **the righteous** in 1:5. Alternate translation: [righteous people] or [people who do what is right]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 32:11 (#2)

וְהָרְנִ֥ינוּ

"and shout for joy"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and shout joyfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 32:11 (#3)

כָּל־יִשְׁרֵי־לֵֽב

"all {you} upright of heart"

Here the **heart** represents where a person's thoughts and motives exist. The phrase **upright of heart** describes people whose thoughts and motives are morally straight and righteous. Alternate translation: [all who think and act righteously] or [all who live with pure motives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 33 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 33 is a "psalm of praise" telling how great God is.

1. Call the righteous to praise Yahweh (1–3)
2. Yahweh's word and works are true and powerful (4–9)
3. Yahweh rules over nations and cares for his people (10–19)
4. Trust and hope in Yahweh's steadfast love (20–22)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh's power

Yahweh is the creator and also the God of his people, Israel. Whatever he plans works out. He alone provides safety in battle.

Psalms 33:1 (#1)

רַנְּנ֣וּ צַ֭דִּיקִים בַּֽיהוָ֑ה

"Shout for joy in Yahweh, righteous {ones"

This is an imperative, but it communicates an exhortation rather than a command. The psalmist is encouraging **righteous ones** to worship. If the imperative does not communicate an exhortation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation or invitation. Alternate translation: [You righteous ones should shout for joy in Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 33:1 (#2)

רַנְּנוּ

“Shout for joy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Rejoice]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:1 (#3)

צַדִּיקִים

“righteous {ones”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 33:1 (#4)

לַיְשָׁרִים נָאוָה תְהִלָּה

“praise {is} fitting for the upright”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the upright should praise him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:1 (#5)

לַיְשָׁרִים

“for the upright”

The psalmist is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [for those who are upright]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 33:2 (#1)

בְּנֵבֶל עָשׂוֹר

“of ten {strings”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [give thanks with a lyre of ten strings]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 33:2 (#2)

בְּנֵבֶל עָשׂוֹר

“of ten {strings”

A **lyre of ten** is a kind of musical instrument that has ten strings stretched across it and is plucked to produce sound. If your readers would not be familiar with what a lyre is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a ten-stringed instrument]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 33:3 (#1)

שִׁירוּ־לוֹ שִׁיר חָדָשׁ

“Sing to him a new song”

This is an imperative, but it communicates an exhortation rather than a command. The psalmist is encouraging the people to worship. If the imperative does not communicate an exhortation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation or invitation. Alternate translation: [You should sing to him a new song]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 33:4 (#1)

כִּי־יָשָׁר דְּבַר־יְהוָה

“For the word of Yahweh {is} upright”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh always speaking truth as if his **word** were standing straight or **upright**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For Yahweh always does what he says that he will do]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:4 (#2)

דְּבַר־יְהוָה

“the word of Yahweh”

Here, **the word of Yahweh** represents what Yahweh said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what Yahweh has said]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:4 (#3)

בֶּאֱמוּנָה

“is} in faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is done in a faithful way] or [is done faithfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:5 (#1)

חֶסֶד יְהוָה מָלְאָה הָאָרֶץ

“the covenant faithfulness of Yahweh fills the earth”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **Yahweh** who is characterized by **covenant faithfulness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh faithfully keeps his covenant throughout the earth]

See: Possession

Psalms 33:5 (#2)

צְדָקָה וּמִשְׁפָּט

“righteousness and justice”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **justice**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [what is righteous and fair]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:5 (#3)

חֶסֶד יְהוָה

“the covenant faithfulness of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all the ways Yahweh is faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:5 (#4)

מָלְאָה הָאָרֶץ

“fills the earth”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the **covenant faithfulness of Yahweh** as if it were something that could **fill** the earth like water fills a container. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [extends to everyone on the earth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:5 (#5)

הָאָרֶץ

“the earth”

The psalmist is using **the earth** to represent everyone who lives on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everyone on the earth]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 33:6 (#1)

בִּדְבַר יְהוָה שָׁמַיִם נַעֲשׂוּ וּבְרוּחַ פִּיו כָּל־צְבָאָם

“By the word of Yahweh, the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth, all of their host”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Another approach would be to combine them and express the emphasis in another way. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [By the word of Yahweh the heavens were made, indeed, by the breath of his mouth, all of their host] or [By his command, Yahweh made the heavens and everything in them]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 33:6 (#2)

בִּדְבַר יְהוָה

“By the word of Yahweh”

Here, **the word of Yahweh** represents the command that Yahweh spoke using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [By the command of Yahweh] or [When Yahweh commanded]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:6 (#3)

שָׁמַ֥יִם נַעֲשׂ֑וּ

“the heavens were made”

The expression **were made** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [he made the heavens]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 33:6 (#4)

וּבְר֖וּחַ פִּ֣יו

“and by the breath of his mouth”

Here, **the breath of his mouth** represents Yahweh speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and by what Yahweh spoke]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:6 (#5)

כָּל־צְבָאָֽם

“all of their host”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [all the stars in the heavens were made]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 33:7 (#1)

כַּנֵּ֣ד

“like a heap”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **heap** is a large mass piled together, so Yahweh gathered the sea waters together into a large mass. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [all piled together into one place]

See: Simile

Psalms 33:7 (#2)

נֹתֵ֣ן בְּאֹצָר֖וֹת תְּהוֹמֽוֹת

“putting the deeps into storehouses”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the deep waters of the ocean as if they were goods that could be placed in **storehouses**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he contains the deep waters within their boundaries]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:8 (#1)

יִירְא֣וּ מֵ֭יְהוָה כָּל־הָאָ֑רֶץ מִמֶּ֥נּוּ יָ֝גֻ֗רוּ כָּל־יֹשְׁבֵ֥י תֵבֵֽל

“let all of the earth fear Yahweh; let all of the dwellers of the world be in dread of him”

The psalmist is saying what he wants the people to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [all of the earth should fear Yahweh; all of the dwellers of the world should be in dread of him]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 33:8 (#2)

יִירְא֣וּ מֵ֭יְהוָה כָּל־הָאָ֑רֶץ מִמֶּ֥נּוּ יָ֝גֻ֗רוּ כָּל־יֹשְׁבֵ֥י תֵבֵֽל

“let all of the earth fear Yahweh; let all of the dwellers of the world be in dread of him”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [everyone in the world should fear Yahweh, indeed, they should all be in dread of him]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 33:8 (#3)

כָּל־הָאָ֑רֶץ

“all of the earth”

The psalmist is using the term **earth** to mean all the people who live on the earth. Alternate translation: [all the people of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:9 (#1)

כִּֽי־הֽוּא֮ אָמַ֪ר וַ֫יֶּהִ֥י הֽוּא־צִוָּ֥ה וַיַּעֲמֹֽד

“For he, he spoke, and it came to be; he, he commanded, and it stood”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Because when he spoke, everything he commanded came into existence]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 33:9 (#2)

הוּא אָמַר וַיֶּהִי הוּא־צִוָּה

“he, he spoke, and it came to be; he, he commanded”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verbs translated as **he spoke** and **he commanded** already include this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it was Yahweh and no other who spoke and commanded. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [he himself spoke and it came to be; he himself commanded, and it stood]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 33:9 (#3)

וַיֶּהִי הוּא־צִוָּה וַיַּעֲמֹד

“and it came to be; he, he commanded, and it stood”

The pronoun **it** refers to the earth. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the earth came to be; he, he commanded, and the earth stood]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 33:9 (#4)

וַיַּעֲמֹד

“and it stood”

By **it stood**, the psalmist means that the earth came into existence or was created. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and it was created]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 33:10 (#1)

יְהוָה הֵפִיר עֲצַת־גּוֹיִם הֵנִיא מַחְשְׁבוֹת עַמִּים

“Yahweh frustrates the counsel of nations; he thwarts the plans of peoples”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Yahweh prevents the people of the nations from accomplishing what they plan]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 33:10 (#2)

עֲצַת־גּוֹיִם

“the counsel of nations”

Here, **nations** represents either the people of the nations or the leaders of the nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the counsel of the leaders of other nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:10 (#3)

עֲצַת־גּוֹיִם

“the counsel of nations”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **counsel**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what nations decide to do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:10 (#4)

מַחְשְׁבוֹת עַמִּים

“the plans of peoples”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **plans**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what the people plan to do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:11 (#1)

עֲצַת יְהוָה לְעוֹלָם תַּעֲמֹד מַחְשְׁבוֹת לִבּוֹ לְדֹר וָדֹר

“The counsel of Yahweh stands forever, the plans of his heart, to generation and generation”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the

emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [What Yahweh has decided will endure through all generations]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 33:11 (#2)

עֲצַ֣ת יְהוָ֑ה

“The counsel of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **counsel**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Everything Yahweh decides]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:11 (#3)

לְעוֹלָ֥ם תַּעֲמֹ֗ד

“stands forever”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **counsel** as if it were something that could **stand** in the sense of remaining upright and stable for all time. He means that Yahweh’s decisions are permanent and will never change or fail. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [endures forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:11 (#4)

מַחְשְׁבֹ֣ות לִ֭לְבּוֹ לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹֽר

“the plans of his heart, to generation and generation”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the plans of his heart stand to generation and generation]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 33:11 (#5)

מַחְשְׁבֹ֣ות לִ֭לְבּוֹ

“the plans of his heart”

Here the **heart** represents where Yahweh’s thoughts and intentions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his intentions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:11 (#6)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹֽר

“to generation and generation”

The psalmist is using **to generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “forever” or “through all time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [through all generations] or [forever]

See: Idiom

Psalms 33:12 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵ֣י הַ֭גּוֹי

“The happiness of the nation”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is the nation] or [How blessed will be the nation]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 33:12 (#2)

הַ֭גּוֹי

“of the nation”

Here, **nation** represents the people of the nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of the nation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:12 (#3)

לְנַחֲלָ֖ה לֹֽו

“for an inheritance for himself”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **the people** as if they were **an inheritance** that Yahweh received as a possession. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to be his own possession]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:13 (#1)

מִמָּשְׁמַיִם הִבִּיט יְהוָה רָאָה אֶת־כָּל־בְּנֵי הָאָדָם

“From the heavens, Yahweh looks down; he sees all of the sons of man”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [From the heavens, Yahweh looks down, indeed he sees all the sons of man]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 33:13 (#2)

בְּנֵי הָאָדָם

“the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **the sons of man** as a common expression of the culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [humanity] or [the people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 33:14 (#1)

מִמְּכוֹן־שִׁבְתּוֹ הִשְׁגִּיחַ

“From the place of his dwelling he gazes”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a person who **gazes** from a physical **place of his dwelling**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From where he rules, he watches carefully]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:15 (#1)

הַיֹּצֵר יַחַד לִבָּם

“together”

Here the **hearts** represents their inner person, including thoughts and desires. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one forming all of their inner beings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:16 (#1)

אֵין־הַמֶּלֶךְ נוֹשָׁע בְּרָב־חָיִל

“The king is not saved by a great army”

The expression **is not saved** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [A great army does not save the king]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 33:16 (#2)

גִּבּוֹר לֹא־יִנָּצֵל בְּרָב־כֹּחַ

“a warrior is not delivered by great strength”

The expression **is not delivered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [great strength does not deliver a warrior]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 33:16 (#3)

בְּרָב־כֹּחַ

“by great strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by being very strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:17 (#1)

שֶׁשֶׁק הַסּוּס לִתְשׁוּעָה וּבְרֹב חֵילוֹ לֹא יְמַלֵּט

“The horse {is} a falsehood for salvation, and by its great strength, it does not deliver”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [The horse is a falsehood for salvation, indeed, by its great strength, it does not deliver]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 33:17 (#2)

שֶׁשֶׁק הַסּוּס לִתְשׁוּעָה

“The horse {is} a falsehood for salvation”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the horse as if it were a lie or **a falsehood** because it gives a false sense of security. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The horse gives a false sense of security]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:17 (#3)

הַסּוּס

“The horse”

The psalmist is using one part of an army, a **horse**, to represent the strongest part of the army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Having an army with strong horses]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 33:17 (#4)

לִתְשׁוּעָה

“for salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for saving anyone]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:18 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The psalmist is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look] or [Pay attention]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:18 (#2)

עֵין יְהוָה

“the eye of Yahweh”

Here, **the eye of Yahweh** represents Yahweh’s watchful care and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the watchful attention of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:18 (#3)

לְחַסְדּוֹ

“for his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he will faithfully keep his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 33:19 (#1)

נַפְשָׁם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: נַפְשָׁם”

The psalmist is using **soul** to represent the people who fear Yahweh themselves from the perspective of their spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who fear him]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 33:20 (#1)

נַפְשֵׁנוּ חִכְּתָה לַיהוָה

“for Yahweh”

The psalmist is using **Our soul** to represent the himself and the people from the perspective of their spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We ourselves wait for Yahweh]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 33:20 (#2)

עֶזְרֵנוּ וּמָגִנֵּנוּ

“is} our help”

The terms **our help** and **our shield** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [our sure protector]

See: Doublet

Psalms 33:20 (#3)

עֶזְרֵנוּ וּמָגִנֵּנוּ

“is} our help”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh protecting his people as if he were a battle **shield**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning

plainly. Alternate translation: [is our helper and our protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:21 (#1)

יִשְׂמַח לִבֵּנוּ

“our heart rejoices”

Here the **our hearts** represents their inner person, including thoughts and desires. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we rejoice in our inner beings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 33:21 (#2)

בְּשֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

“in the name of his holiness”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and his character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in Yahweh’s holiness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 33:22 (#1)

יְהִי־חַסְדְּךָ יְהוָה עָלֵינוּ

“Let your covenant faithfulness, Yahweh, be upon us”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a prayer request rather than a command. The psalmist is asking Yahweh for something. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please let your covenant faithfulness, Yahweh, be upon us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 33:22 (#2)

יְהִי־חַסְדְּךָ יְהוָה עָלֵינוּ

“Let your covenant faithfulness, Yahweh, be upon us”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May you be faithful to your covenant with us, Yahweh]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 34 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 34 is a “psalm of thanksgiving.” It teaches that living right leads to a good life.

1. Praise Yahweh and testify of his deliverance (1–7)
2. Invite others to trust and fear Yahweh (8–14)
3. Yahweh watches over and rescues the righteous (15–22)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s help

Good people can have problems, but God brings them through these. (See: good, right, pleasant, better, best, goodness)

Psalms 34:0 (#2)

לִפְנֵי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִפְנֵי”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of or in front of the king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of] or [in front of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:0 (#3)

וַיְגָרְשֵׁהוּ וַיֵּלֶךְ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וַיְגָרְשֵׁהוּ וַיֵּלֶךְ”

The pronoun in **he sent him** refers to Abimelech, while the pronouns in **him away** and **he left** refer to David. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the king sent David away and David left]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 34:1 (#1)

אֲבָרְכָה אֶת־יְהוָה בְּכָל־עֵת תָּמִיד תְּהִלָּתוֹ בְּפִי

“I shall bless Yahweh at all times; continually his praise {is} in my mouth”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another

approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I will praise Yahweh without ceasing] or [I will bless Yahweh at all times, indeed, continually his praise is in my mouth]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 34:1 (#2)

תְּהִלָּתוֹ בְּפִי

“his praise {is} in my mouth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [praising him with my mouth]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:1 (#3)

תְּהִלָּתוֹ בְּפִי

“his praise {is} in my mouth”

Here, **my mouth** represents David’s speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I shall praise him with my words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:2 (#1)

תִּתְהַלֵּל נַפְשִׁי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: תִּתְהַלֵּל נַפְשִׁי”

Here, **my soul** represents David himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I will boast]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:2 (#2)

עֲנָוִים

“the humble”

David is using the adjective **humble** as a noun to mean people who are humble. If your language would not use an adjective this way, you could translate it with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [those who are humble]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 34:3 (#1)

גַּדְּלוּ לַיהוָה אִתִּי וּנְרוֹמְמָה שְׁמוֹ יַחְדָּו

“Yahweh & and let us exalt”

See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Let us declare together that Yahweh is great]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 34:3 (#2)

גַּדְּלוּ לַיהוָה אִתִּי

“Yahweh”

Here David is speaking of praising Yahweh as if Yahweh were something that they could **Magnify** or make larger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Everyone should join me in telling others about how great Yahweh is]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:3 (#3)

וּנְרוֹמְמָה שְׁמוֹ יַחְדָּו

“and let us exalt”

This is an imperative, but it communicates an exhortation rather than a command. David is encouraging the people to worship. If the imperative does not communicate an exhortation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation or invitation. Alternate translation: [and we should all exalt his name]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 34:3 (#4)

שְׁמוֹ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שְׁמוֹ”

Here, **his name** represents Yahweh himself and his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everything about him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:4 (#1)

דָּרַשְׁתִּי אֶת־יְהוָה

“Yahweh”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a lost object which could be **sought** and found. He means that the people should pray to Yahweh and desire to be in his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I asked Yahweh for help]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:4 (#2)

וְעָנָנִי

“and he answered me”

David is using **answered me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “acted on my behalf” in response to a request. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he acted in my behalf]

See: Idiom

Psalms 34:4 (#3)

מְגֻרוֹתַי

“my fears”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fears**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all the things I feared]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:5 (#1)

הִבִּיטוּ

“They look”

Here, **They** refers to those who seek Yahweh mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Those who seek Yahweh look]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 34:5 (#2)

הִבִּיטוּ אֵלָיו

“They look to him”

David is using **look to him** as a common expression of the culture to mean to “trust in Yahweh and ask him for help.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They trust him to help them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:5 (#3)

וְנָהָרוּ

“and are radiant”

The psalmist is speaking of the joy and gladness those who trust Yahweh feel as if they were shining with **radiant** light. If it would be helpful for your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and are glad]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:5 (#4)

וּפְנֵיהֶם אַל־יֶחְפָּרוּ

“let their faces not have shame”

The expression **let their faces not have shame** was a common expression meaning that they would not be ashamed because of some public failure or discouraged. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly or state it positively as in the UST. Alternate translation: [they should never be put to shame]

See: Idiom

Psalms 34:6 (#1)

זֶה עָנִי

“This afflicted {one”

David is using the adjective **afflicted** as a noun to mean a person who is afflicted. Here David is referring to himself. If your language would not use an adjective this way, you could translate it with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [I was the suffering person who]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 34:6 (#2)

וַיהוָה שָׁמֵעַ

“and Yahweh heard”

David assumes that readers will know that **Yahweh heard** means he listened to his prayer and responded favorably to it. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh did what I asked]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 34:6 (#3)

צָרוֹתָיו

“his troubles”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **troubles**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things that were troubling him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:7 (#1)

חֹנֶה מַלְאַךְ־יְהוָה סָבִיב לִירֵאָיו

“The angel of Yahweh is encamping around the fearers of him”

David is speaking of the angel protecting God’s people as if the angel were an army **encamping** around them to protect them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The angel of Yahweh stands guard around those who fear him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:7 (#2)

מַלְאַךְ־יְהוָה

“The angel of Yahweh”

David is using the possessive form to describe an **angel** that is sent by Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The angel sent by Yahweh]

See: Possession

Psalms 34:8 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“the happinesses of”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 34:8 (#2)

הַגֶּבֶר יֶחֱסֶה

“the man—he takes refuge”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the person who takes refuge]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 34:8 (#3)

יֶחֱסֶה־בּוֹ

“he takes refuge in him”

David is speaking of trusting in Yahweh as if it were physically seeking shelter or **refuge** in a safe place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he puts his trust in him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:8 (#4)

טַעֲמוּ וּרְאוּ כִּי־טוֹב יְהוָה

“Taste and see that Yahweh {is} good”

David is speaking of experiencing Yahweh’s goodness as if it were some kind of food one could **Taste** and **see**. He means that one can discover Yahweh’s goodness by personal trial and experience. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Try for yourself and discover that Yahweh is good]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:9 (#1)

קְדֹשָׁיו

“his holy {ones”

David is using the adjective **holy** as a noun to mean people who belong to Yahweh and are set apart for him. If your language would not use an adjective this way, you could translate it with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [his people who are set apart for him]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 34:9 (#2)

אֵין מַחְסוֹר

“there is no lack”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **lack**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [there is provision]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 34:9 (#3)

מַמַּחְסוֹר

“lack”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **lack**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [going without anything they need]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:10 (#1)

לֹא־יַחְסְרוּ

“will not lack”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **lack**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this as modeled in the UST.

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 34:11 (#1)

בָּנִים

“sons”

Although the term **sons** is masculine, David is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a phrase that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [children]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 34:11 (#2)

בָּנִים

“sons”

David is speaking of his listeners as if they were his **sons**. He means that they are his students whom he will instruct. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [students]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:12 (#1)

מִי־הָאִישׁ הֶחָפֵץ חַיִּים אֹהֵב יָמִים לִרְאוֹת טוֹב

“Who {is} the man, the {one} desiring life, loving days to see good”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for that purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [If you want to live and enjoy a long time of seeing good, then do what follows.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 34:12 (#2)

הָאִישׁ

“is} the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [is the person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 34:12 (#3)

חַיִּים

“life”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **life**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to live]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:12 (#4)

יָמִים

“days”

Here, **days** represents one’s lifespan or period of living. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to live a long time]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:13 (#1)

נְצֹר לְשׁוֹנְךָ מֵרָע וּשְׂפָתֶיךָ מִדַּבֵּר מִרְמָה

“Guard your tongue from evil & deceit”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean

basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Do not say anything that is evil or deceptive]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 34:13 (#2)

לְשׁוֹנְךָ מֵרָ֑ע

“your tongue from evil”

David is using one part of a person, their **tongue**, to mean all of them in the act of speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [yourself from speaking evil words]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 34:13 (#3)

וּ֝שְׂפָתֶ֗יךָ מִדַּבֵּ֥ר מִרְמָֽה

“deceit”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from context if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [guard your lips from speaking deceit]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 34:13 (#4)

וּ֝שְׂפָתֶ֗יךָ מִדַּבֵּ֥ר מִרְמָֽה

“deceit”

David is using one part of a person, their **lips**, to mean all of them in the act of speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and yourself from deceptive speech]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 34:13 (#5)

מֵרָ֑ע & מִרְמָֽה

“from evil & deceit”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **evil** and **deceit**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [from saying evil things ... deceitful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:14 (#1)

סְ֭ור מֵרָ֑ע

“Turn away from evil”

David is speaking of doing what is evil as if it were walking on a path that a person could stop doing or **Turn away from**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Refuse to do what is evil]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:14 (#2)

סְ֭ור מֵרָ֑ע

“Turn away from evil”

This is an imperative, but it communicates an exhortation rather than a command. The psalmist is exhorting his students to stay away from evil. If the imperative does not communicate an exhortation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation. Alternate translation: [You should turn away from evil]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 34:14 (#3)

מֵרָ֑ע וַעֲשֵׂה־טּ֝וֹב בַּקֵּ֣שׁ שָׁלֹ֗ום וְרָדְפֵֽהוּ

“from evil & good & and pursue it”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **evil**, **good**, and **peace**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [from doing what is wrong and do what is right; strive to live at peace with others and pursue living peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:14 (#4)

בַּקֵּ֣שׁ שָׁלֹ֗ום וְרָדְפֵֽהוּ

“and pursue it”

The terms **seek** and **pursue** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [earnestly strive to live peacefully]

See: Doublet

Psalms 34:15 (#1)

עֵינֵ֣י יְ֭הוָה אֶל־צַדִּיקִ֑ים

“The eyes of Yahweh {are} toward the righteous”

Here, **eyes** represent Yahweh’s attention and watchful care. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language.

Alternate translation: [Yahweh watchfully cares for the righteous]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:15 (#2)

צַדִּיקִֽים

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean people who do what is right. If your language would not use an adjective this way, you could translate it with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 34:15 (#3)

וְאָזְנָ֗יו אֶל־שַׁוְעָתָֽם

“and his ears {are} toward their cry”

Here, **ears** represents Yahweh’s attentive responsiveness to prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and he listens attentively to their cry]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:15 (#4)

שַׁוְעָתָֽם

“their cry”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **cry**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [them when they cry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:16 (#1)

פְּנֵ֣י יְהוָ֣ה בְּעֹשֵׂ֣י רָ֑ע

“The face of Yahweh {is} against the doers of evil”

Here, **face of Yahweh** represents his active presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh sets himself against the doers of evil]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:16 (#2)

לְהַכְרִ֖ית מֵאֶ֣רֶץ זִכְרָֽם

“to cut off their remembrance from the earth”

Here, **their remembrance** represents the lasting legacy or memory that people leave behind. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [so that no one on earth will remember them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:16 (#3)

לְהַכְרִ֖ית

“to cut off”

The psalmist is using **cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “destroy” or “remove.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to remove]

See: Idiom

Psalms 34:16 (#4)

רָ֑ע & זִכְרָֽם

“evil & their remembrance”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **evil** and **remembrance**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [what is wicked … any trace of them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:17 (#1)

צָעֲק֣וּ

“They cry out”

Here, **They** refers to the righteous people mentioned in verse 15. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the referent explicitly. Alternate translation: [Righteous people cry out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 34:17 (#2)

וַיהוָ֖ה שָׁמֵ֑עַ

“and Yahweh hears”

David assumes that readers will know that **Yahweh hears** means he listens to their prayer and responds favorably to it. You could say that explicitly if that

would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh did what they asked]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 34:18 (#1)

קָרוֹב יְהוָה

“Yahweh {is} near”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh’s availability or willingness to help as if he were standing right beside or **near** to those who cry out to him for help. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will always give help]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:18 (#2)

לִנְשְׁבְּרֵי־לֵב

“heart”

David is using **broken of heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “overwhelmed with grief.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to those who are overwhelmed with grief]

See: Idiom

Psalms 34:18 (#3)

וְאֶת־דַּכְּאֵי־רוּחַ

“and the crushed of spirit”

David is using **crushed of spirit** as a common expression of his culture to mean “in deep despair.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and those who have lost all hope]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 34:19 (#1)

רָעוֹת צַדִּיק

“are} the evils of the righteous”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evils**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [trials can happen to the righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 34:19 (#2)

צַדִּיק

“of the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a person who does what is right. If your language would not use an adjective this way, you could translate it with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [of the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 34:19 (#3)

וּמִכֻּלָּם יַצִּילֶנּוּ יְהוָה

“but Yahweh delivers him from all of them”

Here, **him** refers to the righteous and **them** refers to the evils they experience. David uses the singular **him** to refer to the righteous as a collective group. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [but Yahweh delivers each one of the righteous from all of those troubles]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 34:20 (#1)

שֹׁמֵר כָּל־עַצְמוֹתָיו

“He is guarding all of his bones”

Here, **He** refers to Yahweh, and **his** refers to the righteous person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is guarding all of the righteous person’s bones]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 34:20 (#2)

כָּל־עַצְמוֹתָיו

“all of his bones”

David is using one part of the body, **his bones**, to mean the whole physical body of the righteous person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [his physical body]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 34:20 (#3)

אַחַת מֵהֵנָּה לֹא נִשְׁבָּרָה

“not one of them is broken”

The expression **is broken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [nothing breaks any one of them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 34:21 (#1)

תְּמוֹתֵ֣ת רָ֭שָׁע רָעָ֑ה

“Evil”

David speaks of **Evil** as if it were a person who could kill **the wicked**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this meaning in a non-figurative way. Alternate translation: [The evil deeds of the wicked will destroy them]

See: Personification

Psalms 34:21 (#2)

רָ֭שָׁע & צַדִּ֣יק

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: רָ֭שָׁע & צַדִּ֣יק”

David is using the adjectives **the wicked** and **the righteous** as nouns to mean people who are wicked and people who are righteous. If your language would not use adjectives this way, you could translate them with equivalent expressions. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked ... those who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 34:22 (#1)

נֶ֣פֶשׁ עֲבָדָ֑יו

“the soul of his servants”

David is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the lives of those who worship him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 34:22 (#2)

הַחֹסִ֖ים בּֽוֹ

“taking refuge in him”

David is speaking of trusting in Yahweh as if he were a physical location, a **refuge**, that could provide safety and protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [trusting in him for protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 35 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This psalm is considered to be one of the “imprecatory psalms.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the imprecatory psalms.

1. Ask Yahweh to fight against adversaries (1–10)
2. Lament unjust hatred and false accusations (11–18)
3. Pray for vindication and justice from Yahweh (19–28)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Enemies

When David’s enemies were sick, he tried to comfort them, but when he was in trouble his enemies used this as a time to attack him.

Translation Issues in this Psalm

Imperatives

Throughout this psalm, David is requesting things from Yahweh by using an imperative form which may sound like a command in your language. If this would be impolite in your language to address a superior in this way, then use a form that would be more appropriate for addressing Yahweh with a request.

Psalms 35:1 (#1)

רִיבָ֣ה יְ֭הוָה אֶת־יְרִיבַ֑י לְ֝חַ֗ם אֶת־לֹחֲמָֽי

“Yahweh, oppose my opponents; fight those fighting me”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [contend against those who fight against me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 35:1 (#2)

רִיבָ֣ה יְ֭הוָה אֶת־יְרִיבַ֑י לְ֝חַ֗ם אֶת־לֹחֲמָֽי

“Yahweh, oppose my opponents; fight those fighting me”

The words **oppose** and **fight** are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. Here and throughout the psalm where this form is used, it may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, please oppose my opponents; please fight those fighting me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 35:1 (#3)

רִיבָ֣ה & אֶת־יְרִיבַ֣י לְ֭חַמָּם אֶת־לֹחֲמָֽי

"oppose my opponents; fight those fighting me"

David is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root in both of these phrases. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [go to battle against my enemies; fight against those who are attacking me]

See: Poetry

Psalms 35:2 (#1)

וְקוּמָ֥ה

"rise up"

David is using **rise up** as a common expression of the culture to ask Yahweh to take action. He is not telling him to get out of bed or stand up from a seated position. If this expression does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [take action]

See: Idiom

Psalms 35:3 (#1)

וְהָ֣רֵ֣ק חֲנִ֣ית וּסְגֹ֑ר

"Draw out spear and javelin"

The terms **spear** and **javelin** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Draw out your weapons]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:3 (#2)

אֱמֹ֖ר לְנַפְשִׁ֣י

"say to my soul"

David is using the term **my soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [assure me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 35:3 (#3)

יְשׁוּעָתֵ֣ךְ

"your salvation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who rescues you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:4 (#1)

יֵבֹ֣שׁוּ וְיִכָּלְמ֗וּ מְבַקְשֵׁ֫י נַפְשִׁ֥י יִסֹּ֣גוּ אָח֑וֹר וְיַחְפְּר֥וּ חֹשְׁבֵ֝֗י רָעָתִֽי

"May those who seek my life have shame and be dishonored. May those who plan my harm be turned back and confounded"

In this verse and throughout the psalm, David is saying what he wants Yahweh to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about "let" and "may" and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do.

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 35:4 (#2)

יֵבֹ֣שׁוּ וְיִכָּלְמ֗וּ מְבַקְשֵׁ֫י נַפְשִׁ֥י

"May those who seek my life have shame and be dishonored"

The expressions **have shame** and **be dishonored** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [May those who want to kill me be utterly disgraced]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:4 (#3)

מְבַקְשֵׁ֫י נַפְשִׁ֥י

"those who seek my life"

David is using **seek my life** as a common expression to mean "try to kill me." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who try to kill me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 35:4 (#4)

וְיִכָּלְמוּ׃

"and be dishonored"

The expression **be dishonored** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, it is clear from the context that it was Yahweh. Alternate translation: [and may Yahweh dishonor them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 35:4 (#5)

יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיַחְפְּרוּ חֹשְׁבֵי רָעָתִי

"May those who plan my harm be turned back and confounded"

Here David is speaking of being unable to accomplish a goal as if the enemies were walking one direction and had to **be turned back**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May those who plan my harm be unsuccessful and confused]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:4 (#6)

יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיַחְפְּרוּ חֹשְׁבֵי רָעָתִי

"May those who plan my harm be turned back and confounded"

The expression **be turned back** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, it is clear from the context that it was Yahweh. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh cause those who plan my harm to be unsuccessful and confused]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 35:5 (#1)

כְּמֹץ לִפְנֵי־רוּחַ

"as chaff before the wind"

The point of this comparison is that just as **chaff** is easily blown away by the wind, so David's enemies will be easily scattered. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [easily scattered like chaff before the wind]

See: Simile

Psalms 35:6 (#1)

יְהִי־דַרְכָּם חֹשֶׁךְ וַחֲלַקְלַקּוֹת

"May their way be dark and slippery places"

David is speaking of how his enemies live as if that were a **way** or path that they were walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May their lives be full of danger and uncertainty]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:6 (#2)

רֹדְפָם

"chasing them"

Here David is speaking of keeping the enemies from harming him as if the **angel of Yahweh** were physically running and **chasing them** away. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [keeps them from harming me]

Psalms 35:7 (#1)

כִּי־חִנָּם טָמְנוּ־לִי שַׁחַת רִשְׁתָּם חִנָּם חָפְרוּ לְנַפְשִׁי

"For without cause they hid for me a pit, their net; without cause they dug for my life"

The phrases **they hid for me a pit, their net; without cause they dug for my life** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. Scholars have proposed that a scribe may have accidentally switched the order of the words for "pit" and "their net." Many translations put "their net" first so that "a pit" begins the second line, and you may want to do the same. Alternate translation: [For they hid for me their net; a pit without cause they dug for my life]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 35:7 (#2)

טָמְנוּ־לִ֥י שַׁ֝חַת רִשְׁתָּ֗ם

“they hid for me a pit, their net”

David is speaking of his enemies’ schemes as if they were **a pit** and a **net** used to trap animals. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they secretly plotted to trap me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:8 (#1)

תְּבוֹאֵ֣הוּ שׁוֹאָ֣ה ׀ לֹ֣א יֵ֭דָע וְרִשְׁתּ֣וֹ אֲשֶׁר־טָמַ֣ן תִּלְכְּדֶ֑נּוּ בְּ֝שׁוֹאָ֗ה יִפָּל־בָּֽהּ

“Let destruction overtake him; he does not know. Let the net that he hid catch him. In destruction, let him fall into it”

Throughout this verse, the pronouns **him** and **he** are singular, but they refer to all of David’s enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural forms as modeled in the UST.

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 35:8 (#2)

תְּבוֹאֵ֣הוּ שׁוֹאָ֣ה ׀ לֹ֣א יֵ֭דָע

“Let destruction overtake him; he does not know”

David is speaking of **destruction** as if it were a living thing that could a dangerous animal that would chase the enemies down and suddenly attack them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let them be surprised because you destroy them suddenly]

See: Personification

Psalms 35:8 (#3)

תְּבוֹאֵ֣הוּ שׁוֹאָ֣ה ׀

“Let destruction overtake him”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Let him be destroyed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:8 (#4)

וְרִשְׁתּ֣וֹ אֲשֶׁר־טָמַ֣ן תִּלְכְּדֶ֑נּוּ בְּ֝שׁוֹאָ֗ה יִפָּל־בָּֽהּ

“Let the net that he hid catch him. In destruction, let him fall into it”

David is describing the ironic reversal in which the traps his enemies prepared will instead ensnare them. The **net** they set for David will **catch** them, and they will fall to their own **destruction** into the “pit” they “dug.” If a speaker of your language would not express this reversal in this way, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let his own trap catch him; let him fall into ruin by his own scheming]

See: Irony

Psalms 35:9 (#1)

וְנַפְשִׁ֥י תָּגִ֗יל בַּ֭יהוָה תָּ֣שִׂישׂ

“But my soul will be joyful in Yahweh; it will rejoice”

David is using the term **my soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [But I will be joyful in Yahweh; I will rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 35:9 (#2)

וְנַפְשִׁ֥י תָּגִ֗יל

“But my soul will be joyful”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the destruction of his enemies and his own joy in Yahweh. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Despite all this, my soul will be joyful in Yahweh]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 35:9 (#3)

תָּגִ֗יל בַּ֭יהוָה תָּ֣שִׂישׂ

“will be joyful in Yahweh; it will rejoice”

The terms **joyful** and **rejoice** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my soul will celebrate with great gladness]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:9 (#4)

בִּישׁוּעָתֽוֹ

“in his salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he rescued me]

Psalms 35:10 (#1)

כָּל־עַצְמוֹתַ֗י ׀ תֹּאמַרְנָה֮

“All my bones will say”

David speaks of his **bones** as if they were a person who could speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Every part of me will declare]

See: Personification

Psalms 35:10 (#2)

כָּל־עַצְמוֹתַ֗י

“All my bones”

David is using one part of his body, his **bones**, to represent his entire being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Everything within me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 35:10 (#3)

יְהוָ֥ה מִֽי־כָ֝מ֗וֹךָ מַצִּ֣יל עָ֭נִי מֵחָזָ֣ק מִמֶּ֑נּוּ וְעָנִ֖י וְאֶבְי֣וֹן מִגֹּזְלֽוֹ

“Yahweh, who is like you, rescuing the oppressed from those stronger than them and the oppressed and needy from those robbing them”

David is using the question form to emphasize that no one is comparable to Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [There is no one like you, Yahweh! You rescue the oppressed from those stronger than them and the oppressed and needy from those robbing them.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 35:10 (#4)

עָ֭נִי מֵחָזָ֣ק מִמֶּ֑נּוּ וְעָנִ֖י וְאֶבְי֣וֹן

“the oppressed from those stronger than them and the oppressed and needy”

David is using the adjectives **oppressed** and **needy** as nouns to mean a certain kind of person. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate these with equivalent expressions. Alternate translation: [those who are oppressed from those stronger than them and those who are oppressed and needy]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 35:10 (#5)

וְעָנִ֖י וְאֶבְי֣וֹן

“and the oppressed and needy”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and rescuing the oppressed and needy]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 35:11 (#1)

יָקוּמ֣וּן עֵדֵי־חָ֑מָס

“Witnesses of violence rise up”

David is using the possessive form to describe **Witnesses** that are characterized by **violence**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Witnesses who wish me harm rise up]

See: Possession

Psalms 35:11 (#2)

יָקוּמ֣וּן עֵדֵי־חָ֑מָס

“Witnesses of violence rise up”

David is using **rise up** as a common expression of the culture to mean to take action. He is not saying that they get out of bed or stand up from a seated position. If this expression does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Witnesses take violent action against me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 35:12 (#1)

רָעָ֥ה תַ֝תַּ֗חַת טוֹבָ֥ה

“evil in place of good”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **evil** and **good**, you could express the same

ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [by doing bad things to me in place of the good things I did for them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:12 (#2)

יְשַׁלְּמוּנִי

“They repay me”

Here David is speaking of the way his enemies treated him as if they were paying back a loan or trying to **repay** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They treated me with]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:12 (#3)

שְׁכוֹל לְנַפְשִׁי

“bereavement to my soul”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **bereavement**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they have bereaved my soul]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:12 (#4)

שְׁכוֹל לְנַפְשִׁי

“bereavement to my soul”

David is using the term **my soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I feel bereaved]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 35:13 (#1)

וַאֲנִי

“But I”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between his enemies’ cruelty toward him and his kindness toward them when they were sick. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I, on the other hand]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 35:13 (#2)

לְבוּשִׁי שָׂק

“my clothing {was} sackcloth”

Wearing **sackcloth** was a symbolic action by which David expressed grief and mourning. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [I dressed in rough cloth as a sign of sorrow for them]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 35:13 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using the term **my soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [myself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 35:13 (#4)

בַצּוֹם

“with fasting”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fasting**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by refusing to eat]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:13 (#5)

וּתְפִלָּתִי עַל־חֵיקִי תָּשׁוּב

“and my prayer returned upon my bosom”

David is using **my prayer returned upon my bosom** as a common expression of his culture to mean that he prayed sincerely, with his head bowed to his chest. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I prayed with my head bowed down]

See: Idiom

Psalms 35:14 (#1)

כְּרֵעַ־כְּאָח לִי הִתְהַלָּכְתִּי כַּאֵבֶל־אֵם קֹדֵר שַׁחוֹתִי

“As {for} a friend, as {for} a brother to me, I walked about; as {one} lamenting {for} a mother, mourning, I bowed down”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [I walked about as one lamenting for a mother, as for a friend, as for a brother; mourning, I bowed down]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 35:14 (#2)

כְּרֵ֣עַ־כְּאָ֣ח

“As {for} a friend, as {for} a brother”

The point of this comparison is that just as a person would grieve for **a friend** or **a brother**, so David grieved for his enemies when they were sick. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [As if each one were my close friend or a brother, I walked about]

See: Simile

Psalms 35:14 (#3)

כַּאֲבֶ֣ל־אֵ֣ם

“as {one} lamenting {for} a mother”

The point of this comparison is that just as a person in deep grief would be **lamenting** the loss of **a mother**, so David mourned deeply for his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [with grief as deep as one who has lost his mother]

See: Simile

Psalms 35:14 (#4)

כַּאֲבֶ֣ל־אֵ֣ם

“as {one} lamenting {for} a mother”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [as one who was lamenting for his mother]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 35:14 (#5)

קֹדֵ֥ר שַׁחֹ֗תִי

“mourning, I bowed down”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **mourning**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I mourned and bowed down]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:14 (#6)

שַׁחֹ֗תִי

“I bowed down”

The action of **bowing down** was a symbolic action by which David showed deep grief and mourning. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [I expressed deep sorrow]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 35:15 (#1)

וּבְצַלְעִ֣י

“But at my stumbling”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between his compassion for his enemies and their cruelty when he suffered. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, at my stumbling]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 35:15 (#2)

וּבְצַלְעִ֣י

“But at my stumbling”

David is speaking of experiencing trouble as if it were physically **stumbling**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But at my time of difficulty]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:15 (#3)

שָׂמְח֣וּ וְנֶאֱסָ֔פוּ

“they rejoiced and gathered together”

The pronoun **they** refers to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [my enemies rejoiced and gathered together]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 35:15 (#4)

נֻכִּים וְלֹא יָדַעְתִּי

“the stricken {ones}, and I did not know”

The word translated as **the stricken ones** represents the written Hebrew text. This could refer to the mockers imitating David’s lameness as possibly described in verse 16, if vowels are used to read “deformity” instead of “food” in that verse. However, scholars have proposed that changing one vowel here would make the word “the strikers,” which seems to fit better the meaning of this verse. The UST follows that interpretation. You may want to follow the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [the strikers I did not even know]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 35:15 (#5)

קָרְעוּ וְלֹא־דָמּוּ

“They tore and did not cease”

David is speaking of his enemies’ verbal attacks as if they physically **tore** at him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They attacked me with words and did not cease]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:16 (#1)

מָעֻג

“food”

The word translated as food represents the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. Scholars have proposed that by changing the vowels of this word it would say “deformity,” which seems to fit better the meaning of this passage. The UST follows that interpretation. You may want to follow the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [my deformity]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 35:16 (#2)

חָרַק עָלַי שִׁנֵּימוֹ

“they gnashed their teeth at me”

They gnashed their teeth at me describes a symbolic action by which the enemies express rage and contempt. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [they showed their anger and hostility toward me]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 35:17 (#1)

אֲדֹנָי֙ כַּמָּ֣ה תִּרְאֶ֔ה הָשִׁ֥יבָה נַפְשִׁ֖י

“Lord, how long will you look on? Restore my soul”

David is using the question form to urgently appeal to God for help. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Lord, you have looked on long enough!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 35:17 (#2)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using the term **my soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 35:17 (#3)

מִשֹּׁאֵיהֶם

“from their destructions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destructions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the things they do to try to destroy me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:17 (#4)

יְחִידָתִי

“my only {one”

David is using **my only one** as a common expression to mean his precious, irreplaceable life. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my precious life]

See: Idiom

Psalms 35:17 (#5)

יְחִידָתִי

“my only {one”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [please rescue my life]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 35:17 (#6)

מִמַּכְפִּירִ֗ים

“from the young lions”

David is speaking of his enemies as if they were **young lions** that were attacking him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from these fierce enemies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:19 (#1)

שֹׁנְאַ֣י חִנָּ֣ם יִקְרְצוּ־עָֽיִן

“let {not} the haters of me without cause wink the eye”

David is using **wink the eye** to show a symbolic action by which someone showed scorn or signaling conspiracy against someone else. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [let not the haters of me without cause signal their contempt]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 35:20 (#1)

כִּ֤י לֹ֣א שָׁלֹ֣ום יְדַבֵּ֑רוּ

“For they do not speak peace”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason the enemies should not rejoice over David’s suffering mentioned in the previous verses. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Since they do not speak peace]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 35:20 (#2)

שָׁלֹ֣ום

“peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [peaceful words]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:20 (#3)

וְעַ֥ל רִגְעֵי־אֶ֝רֶץ

“and against the quiet {ones} of the earth”

David is speaking of peaceable people as **the quiet ones**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and against those who live quietly in the land]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:20 (#4)

רִגְעֵי־אֶ֝רֶץ

“the quiet {ones} of the earth”

David is using the adjective **quiet** as a noun to mean people who are quiet and peaceable. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [the peaceful people of the land]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 35:20 (#5)

דִּבְרֵ֣י מִ֭רְמֹות

“words of deceits”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceits**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [deceptive words]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:21 (#1)

וַיַּרְחִ֖יבוּ עָלַ֣י פִּ֑יהֶם

“They open their mouth wide against me”

David is using the phrase **open their mouth wide** to represent what the enemies shouted loudly. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They speak loudly against me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 35:21 (#2)

הֶאָחּ ׀ הֶאָחּ

“Aha, Aha”

David’s enemies are using **Aha, Aha,** as a phrase that expresses a strong feeling or gloating and malicious delight at the misfortune of another person. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [You did it!]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 35:21 (#3)

רָאֲתָה עֵינֵנוּ

“our eyes have seen”

David’s enemies are using **our eyes** to represent what they have witnessed. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we have witnessed it]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 35:22 (#1)

אַל־תֶּחֱרַשׁ

“do not be silent”

David is speaking of a lack of intervention as being **silent**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not remain inactive]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:22 (#2)

אַל־תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי

“do not be far from me”

David is speaking of a lack of help as being physically **far** from him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not withhold your help from me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:23 (#1)

הָעִירָה וְהָקִיצָה

“Awake and arouse yourself”

David is speaking of God as if he were sleeping and needed to **Awake** or **arouse** himself from sleep. He means that he is asking God to act on his behalf and intervene in this situation. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take action] or [I ask you to intervene]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:23 (#2)

הָעִירָה וְהָקִיצָה

“Awake and arouse yourself”

The expressions **Awake** and **arouse yourself** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Rouse yourself fully]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:23 (#3)

לְמִשְׁפָּטִי אֱלֹהַי וַאדֹנָי לְרִיבִי

“for my justice, my God and my Lord, for my cause”

The terms **my justice** and **my cause** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to come to my defense, my God and my Lord]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:23 (#4)

לְמִשְׁפָּטִי

“for my justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for you to judge me fairly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:23 (#5)

לְרִיבִי

“for my cause”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **cause**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to defend me against my accusers]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:24 (#1)

כְּצִדְקְךָ

“according to your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to the right way that you judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:25 (#1)

אַל־יֹאמְרוּ בְלִבָּם הֶאָח נַפְשֵׁנוּ אַל־יֹאמְרוּ בִּלַּעְנוּהוּ

“Do not let them say in their heart, “Aha, our soul!” Do not let them say, “We have swallowed him up”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express these as indirect quotations. Alternate translation: [Do not let them think that they have gotten what they desire. Do not let them say that they have destroyed me]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Psalms 35:25 (#2)

אַל־יֹאמְרוּ בְלִבָּם

“Do not let them say in their heart”

David is using **say in their heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean “say to themselves.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not let them say to themselves]

See: Idiom

Psalms 35:25 (#3)

הֶאָח נַפְשֵׁנוּ

“Aha, our soul”

The exclamation **Aha** expresses the enemies’ malicious gloating. The phrase **our soul** in this context means “we have gotten what we desired” which is to have him be declared guilty. Your language may have a comparable exclamation that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Hurrah! Our wish has been fulfilled] or [We are so glad he has been declared guilty just as we desired]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 35:25 (#4)

בִּלַּעְנוּהוּ

“We have swallowed him up”

David’s enemies are speaking of defeating him completely as if they were wild animals who had **swallowed him up**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We have totally overcome him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:26 (#1)

יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ

“Let them be ashamed and confounded”

The expressions **be ashamed** and **confounded** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [be completely put to shame together]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:26 (#2)

רָעָתִי

“at my evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [at my misfortune]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:26 (#3)

יִלְבְּשׁוּ־בֹשֶׁת וּכְלִמָּה

“Let them be clothed with shame and humiliation”

David is speaking of **shame and humiliation** as if these were garments that his enemies would wear or **be clothed** in. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [be completely covered in disgrace]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 35:26 (#4)

יִלְבְּשׁוּ־בֹשֶׁת וּכְלִמָּה

“Let them be clothed with shame and humiliation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **shame** and **humiliation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Let them be completely ashamed and humiliated]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:26 (#5)

יִלְבְּשׁוּ

“Let them be clothed”

The expression **be clothed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [May God clothe them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 35:26 (#6)

בֹּשֶׁת וּכְלִמָּה

“with shame and humiliation”

The terms **shame** and **humiliation** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [with utter disgrace]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:26 (#7)

הַמַּגְדִּילִים עָלָי

“the ones magnifying {themselves} against me”

David is using **magnifying themselves against me** as a common expression to mean boasting or exalting themselves in defiance of him. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who exalt themselves over me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 35:27 (#1)

יָרֹנּוּ וְיִשְׂמְחוּ

“Let them shout for joy and be glad”

The expressions **shout for joy** and **be glad** mean similar things. David is using the two expressions together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let them greatly rejoice]

See: Doublet

Psalms 35:27 (#2)

צִדְקִי

“my righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my being declared right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:27 (#3)

וְיֹאמְרוּ תָמִיד יְגְדַּל יְהוָה הֶחָפֵץ שְׁלוֹם עַבְדּוֹ

“and let them say continually, “Let Yahweh be great, the {one} delighting in the peace of his servant”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [and let them continually declare that Yahweh is great, the one delighting in the peace of his servant]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Psalms 35:27 (#4)

שְׁלוֹם

“the peace of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **word**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the welfare of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:28 (#1)

וּלְשׁוֹנִי תֶּהְגֶּה צִדְקֶךָ

“And my tongue will meditate on your righteousness”

The word translated as **And** connects this verse to what came before as a result. David is saying that because Yahweh will act on his behalf, he will respond with praise. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [Because of this, my tongue will meditate on your righteousness]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 35:28 (#2)

וּלְשׁוֹנִי תֶּהְגֶּה

“And my tongue will meditate on”

David is using one part of his person, his **tongue**, to mean all of him in the act of meditating. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For I will speak about]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 35:28 (#3)

צִדְקֶךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ways you act righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 35:28 (#4)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“all the day”

David is saying **all the day** as an overstatement to emphasize that his praise will be constant and habitual. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [continually]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 35:28 (#5)

תְּהִלָּתֶךָ

“your praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [praising you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 36 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 36 is a “psalm of praise.” It speaks of how good God is to those who love him.

1. The depth of human sin (1–4)
2. The greatness of Yahweh’s steadfast love (5–9)
3. Prayer for continued protection and justice (10–12)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

God and man

Evil people do not think about God; but he is such a pleasure to all who honor him.

Psalms 36:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 36:1 (#1)

נְאֻם־פֶּשַׁע לָרָשָׁע בְּקֶרֶב לִבִּי

“The declaration of transgression to the wicked {is} in the midst of my heart”

David is speaking of **transgression** as if it were a living thing that could speak a **declaration** to the wicked. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Sin causes a person to act like they are listening to bad advice within themselves]

See: Personification

Psalms 36:1 (#2)

נְאֻם־פֶּשַׁע

“The declaration of transgression”

If your language does not use an abstract nouns for the idea of **declaration** and **transgression**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [What rebelling against God declares]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:1 (#3)

לָרָשָׁע

“to the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 36:1 (#4)

בְּקֶרֶב לִבִּי

“is} in the midst of my heart”

The phrase **my heart** is a translation of the majority of Hebrew manuscripts. Other Hebrew manuscripts and ancient translations say, “his heart,” which seems to make better sense. The UST follows that reading. You may want to follow the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [is in the midst of his heart]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 36:1 (#5)

בְּקֶרֶב לִבִּי

“is} in the midst of my heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and understanding exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is in his deepest understanding]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:1 (#6)

פַּחַד

“dread of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dread**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [reverence for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:1 (#7)

לְנֶגֶד עֵינָיו

“before his eyes”

Here, **before his eyes** represents the wicked person’s awareness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his awareness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 36:1 (#8)

עֵינָיו

“his eyes”

The pronoun **his** refers to the wicked person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the wicked person’s eyes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 36:2 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 36:2 (#2)

הֶחֱלִיק אֵלָיו בְּעֵינָיו

“it is slippery to him in his eyes”

David is describing the way that a wicked person flatters himself and is proud by saying that recognizing his sin **is slippery to him in his eyes**, that is, his pride blinds him to it and he convinces himself that he is not sinful. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this in another way. Alternate translation: [he flatters himself too much]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:2 (#3)

לִמְצֹא עֲוֹנוֹ

“to find his iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to acknowledge that he acts wrongly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:2 (#4)

לִשְׂנֹא

“to hate {it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the wicked person’s sin. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [so he hates his sin]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 36:3 (#1)

דִּבְרֵי־פִיו

“The words of his mouth”

David is using the phrase **words of his mouth** to represent what the wicked person said by using words.

If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The things he says]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 36:3 (#2)

אָוֶן וּמִרְמָה

“are} iniquity and deceit”

The terms **iniquity** and **deceit** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [thoroughly wicked speech]

See: Doublet

Psalms 36:3 (#3)

אָוֶן וּמִרְמָה

“are} iniquity and deceit”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **iniquity** and **deceit**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [are what is wicked and deceptive]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:3 (#4)

חָדַל לְהַשְׂכִּיל לְהֵיטִיב

“he has ceased to act wisely, to do good”

These two phrases **to act wisely** and **to do good** mean basically the same thing. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [he has completely ceased to do things that are good]

See: Doublet

Psalms 36:4 (#1)

אָוֶן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how to act wickedly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:4 (#2)

יֵתְיַצֵּב עַל־דֶּרֶךְ לֹא־טוֹב

“he stations himself on the not-good road”

David is speaking of how the wicked person commits to a bad way of living as if it were a **not-good road** that he chose and that he **stations himself on**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he commits himself to a wicked way of living]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:4 (#3)

רָע

“evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [doing wicked things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:5 (#1)

בַּשָּׁמַיִם חַסְדֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness {is} in the heavens”

David is speaking as if Yahweh’s covenant faithfulness were so vast that it fills **the heavens**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your covenant faithfulness is immeasurably great]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:5 (#2)

חַסְדֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:5 (#3)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ עַד־שְׁחָקִים

“your trustworthiness, to the clouds”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language.

Alternate translation: [your trustworthiness extends to the clouds]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 36:5 (#4)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ

“your trustworthiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trustworthiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how trustworthy you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:6 (#1)

צִדְקָתְךָ ׀ כְּהַרְרֵי־אֵ֗ל

“Your righteousness {is} like the mountains of God”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the mountains of God** are immovable and enduring, so is his **righteousness**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your righteousness is as enduring as the highest mountains]

See: Simile

Psalms 36:6 (#2)

צִדְקָתְךָ

“Your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The way you do what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:6 (#3)

מִשְׁפָּטֶ֣יךָ תְהוֹם רַבָּ֑ה

“your judgments {are} the great deep”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [your judgments are like the great deep]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 36:6 (#4)

מִשְׁפָּטֶ֣יךָ תְהוֹם רַבָּ֑ה

“your judgments {are} the great deep”

David is using another comparison to describe Yahweh’s ways. The point of this comparison is that just as **the great deep** or the deepest ocean is vast and mysterious, so are God’s **judgments**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [your judgments are as immeasurable and unsearchable as the deepest ocean]

See: Simile

Psalms 36:6 (#5)

מִשְׁפָּטֶ֣יךָ

“your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way you act justly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:7 (#1)

חַסְדְּךָ

“is} your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is the way you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:7 (#2)

וּבְנֵי אָדָ֑ם

“And the sons of man”

David is using **the sons of man** as a common expression of the culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 36:7 (#3)

בְּצֵ֣ל כְּנָפֶ֣יךָ יֶחֱסָיוּן

“take refuge in the shadow of your wings”

David is speaking of God’s protection as if he were a bird that provides a **refuge** or protection under

the shadow of its **wings**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [can find their protection in you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:8 (#1)

יִרְוְיֻן

“They are refreshed”

The pronoun **They** refers to “the sons of man” or people mentioned in verse 7. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [People are refreshed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 36:8 (#2)

יִרְוְיֻן

“They are refreshed”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [You refresh them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 36:8 (#3)

מִדֶּשֶׁן בֵּיתֶךָ

“from the fatness of your house”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fatness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [from all that you so abundantly provide]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:8 (#4)

וְנַחַל עֲדָנֶיךָ תַשְׁקֵם

“and {from} the river of your delights you give them drink”

David is speaking as if God’s blessings were a **river** of **delights** that people could **drink** from. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they experience the abundance of your blessings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:9 (#1)

מְקוֹר חַיִּים

“is} the fountain of”

David is speaking as if God were a **fountain** from which **life** flows. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is the source of life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:9 (#2)

חַיִּים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: חַיִּים”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **life**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ability to live]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:9 (#3)

בְּאֹרְךָ נִרְאֶה־אוֹר

“we see light”

David is speaking as if God’s presence were **light** that enables people to see **light**, representing understanding. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because you reveal yourself to us, we are able to understand truth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:10 (#1)

חַסְדְּךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: חַסְדְּךָ”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:10 (#2)

וְצִדְקָתְךָ

“and your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same

idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and how you do what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:10 (#3)

לְיִשְׁרֵי־לֵֽב

“heart”

David is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [to those who are upright in heart]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 36:10 (#4)

לְיִשְׁרֵי־לֵֽב

“heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s motives and intentions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to those who have right intentions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 36:11 (#1)

אַל־תְּבוֹאֵנִי רֶגֶל גַּאֲוָה וְיַד־רְשָׁעִים אַל־תְּנִדֵּנִי

“Let not the foot of pride come to me, and let not the hand of the wicked remove me”

David is expressing a wish to God. In your translation, use a form that people would recognize as a wish or request in your language. You might express this as a prayer, if that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Please keep the foot of pride from coming to me, and the hand of the wicked from removing me]

See: Blessings

Psalms 36:11 (#2)

רֶגֶל גַּאֲוָה

“the foot of pride”

Here, **the foot** represents the power to trample or overcome another person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the overwhelming power of the proud]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 36:11 (#3)

גַּאֲוָה

“pride”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pride**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [proud people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:11 (#4)

וְיַד־רְשָׁעִים אַל־תְּנִדֵּנִי

“and let not the hand of the wicked remove me”

Here, **the hand** represents the power and action of **the wicked**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and let not the power of the wicked remove me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 36:11 (#5)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 36:12 (#1)

אָוֶן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is wicked]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 36:12 (#2)

דָּחֹ֥ו

“they are thrust down”

The expression **are thrust down** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God has thrust them down]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 37 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 37 is considered to be one of the "wisdom psalms." See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about the wisdom psalms.

1. Do not envy the wicked but trust Yahweh (1–11)
2. Yahweh upholds the righteous and judges the wicked (12–20)
3. The righteous are sustained and secure in Yahweh (21–31)
4. Wait for Yahweh and observe his final justice (32–40)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Envy

Do not envy evil people. Although it appears as though they prosper, soon they will be destroyed and the good people will continue on living.

Psalms 37:1 (#1)

לְדָוִד ׀ אַל־תִּתְחַר בַּמְרֵעִים אַל־תְּקַנֵּא בְּעֹשֵׂי עַוְלָה

"Of David Do not be upset about evildoers; do not be envious of the doers of unrighteousness"

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Do not let yourself be troubled by those who do evil] or [Do not be upset about evildoers; indeed, do not be envious of the doers of unrighteousness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 37:2 (#1)

כִּֽי

"For"

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 37:2 (#2)

כֶּחָצִיר מְהֵרָה יִמָּֽלּוּ

"like the grass they will quickly wither"

The point of this comparison is that just as **the grass** quickly **withers** and dies, so the wicked will quickly perish. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as the grass quickly withers, they will quickly perish]

See: Simile

Psalms 37:2 (#3)

וּכְיֶרֶק דֶּשֶׁא יִבּוֹלֽוּן

"and like a green plant they will fade"

The point of this comparison is that just as a **green plant** will **fade** and die, so the wicked will not last. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and just as a green plant fades, they too will fade away]

See: Simile

Psalms 37:3 (#1)

טֹ֣וב

"good"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **good**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the right thing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:3 (#2)

וּרְעֵ֖ה אֱמוּנָֽה

"and feed faithfulness"

The word translated as **feed** is used to describe what shepherds do for sheep as they care for them, and also for what sheep do as they feed themselves. So this could mean: (1) Cultivate, develop, or practice faithfulness to Yahweh (and each other). Alternate translation: [and practice faithfulness] or (2) Enjoy the faithfulness that Yahweh offers to his people. Alternate translation: [and experience Yahweh's faithfulness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:3 (#3)

וּרְעֵ֥ה אֱמוּנָֽה

“and feed faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and act faithfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:4 (#1)

מִשְׁאֲלֹ֖ת לִבֶּֽךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִשְׁאֲלֹ֖ת לִבֶּֽךָ”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s **desires** exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what you truly desire]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:5 (#1)

גֹּ֣ל עַל־יְהוָ֣ה דַּרְכֶּ֑ךָ

“Roll your way upon Yahweh”

David is using **Roll your way upon Yahweh** as a common expression of his culture to mean to turn over or entrust your plans to Yahweh. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Commit your plans to Yahweh]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:5 (#2)

וְהוּא֥ יַעֲשֶֽׂה

“and he, he will act”

David is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will act** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the only one who can do this. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh himself will act]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:6 (#1)

כָּאוֹר֙ צִדְקֶ֔ךָ

“your righteousness like the light”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the light** is clearly visible to everyone, so Yahweh will make the person’s righteousness clearly evident. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [your righteousness so that it is as clearly visible as the light]

See: Simile

Psalms 37:6 (#2)

צִדְקֶ֔ךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how righteous you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:6 (#3)

וּמִשְׁפָּטֶ֖ךָ כְּצָהֳרָֽיִם

“and your justice like the noonday”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and publicly defend your just cause]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:6 (#4)

וּמִשְׁפָּטֶ֖ךָ כְּצָהֳרָֽיִם

“and your justice like the noonday”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the noonday** sun shines at its brightest, so Yahweh will make the person’s justice unmistakably clear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he will bring out that you are innocent so that it is as clear as the noonday sun]

See: Simile

Psalms 37:7 (#1)

דֹּ֣ם ׀ לַיהוָ֗ה

“Be silent to Yahweh”

David is using **Be silent to Yahweh** as a common expression of the culture to mean "wait patiently and reverently for Yahweh." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Rest quietly before Yahweh]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:7 (#2)

וְהִתְחוֹלֵ֣ל

"and tremble"

The word translated as **tremble** represents the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense here. Scholars have proposed that a different word with a similar spelling was intended that means "to wait" that seems to better fit the meaning of this passage. You may want to follow the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [and wait]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 37:7 (#3)

לֽוֹ

"for him"

The pronoun **him** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and tremble for Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:7 (#4)

דַּרְכּ֑וֹ

"his way"

David is speaking of how a wicked person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a wicked person's way]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:7 (#5)

עֹשֶׂ֖ה מְזִמּֽוֹת

"doing schemes"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **schemes**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [carrying out wicked plans]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:8 (#1)

מֵ֭אַף וַעֲזָ֣ב חֵמָ֑ה

"of nose and abandon wrath"

The terms **nose** and **wrath** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [of intense anger]

See: Doublet

Psalms 37:8 (#2)

מֵ֭אַף

"of nose"

David is using the **nose** here as a common expression of the culture, **the burning of his nose** to mean "anger." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of anger]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 37:8 (#3)

חֵמָ֑ה

"wrath"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being furious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:9 (#1)

כִּ֤י

"For"

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Since]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 37:9 (#2)

מְ֭רֵעִים יִכָּרֵתָ֑ון

"evildoers will be cut off"

David is using **cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean "destroy." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [evildoers will perish]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:9 (#3)

מְֽרֵעִ֥ים יִכָּרֵ֑תְנָה

"evildoers will be cut off"

The expression **will be cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will cut off evildoers]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:9 (#4)

הֵ֥מָּה יִ֝ירְשׁוּ־אָֽרֶץ

"they, they will inherit the land"

David is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they will inherit** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that, unlike the evildoers in the previous line, those who wait for Yahweh will inherit the land. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [they themselves will inherit the land]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:10 (#1)

וְע֣וֹד מְ֭עַט וְאֵ֣ין

"And yet a little and there are no"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And yet a little while and then there are no more]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 37:10 (#2)

רָ֑שָׁע

"wicked"

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:10 (#3)

מְקוֹמ֗וֹ

"his place"

The pronoun **his** refers to the wicked person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [where the wicked person was]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:11 (#1)

וַ֭עֲנָוִים

"But the meek"

David is using the adjective **meek** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [But meek people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:11 (#2)

רֹ֣ב שָׁ֑לוֹם

"an abundance of"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [living so peacefully and prosperously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:12 (#1)

זֹמֵ֣ם רָ֭שָׁע לַצַּדִּ֑יק

"is plotting"

David is using the adjectives **wicked** and **righteous** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase.

Alternate translation: [The wicked person is plotting against the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:12 (#2)

וְחֹרֵ֖ק עָלָ֣יו שִׁנָּ֑יו

“and is gnashing & against him”

The pronoun **his** refers to the wicked person, while the pronoun **him** refers to the righteous person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the wicked person is gnashing his teeth against the righteous person]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:12 (#3)

וְחֹרֵ֖ק עָלָ֣יו שִׁנָּ֑יו

“and is gnashing & against him”

The action of **gnashing his teeth** describes a symbolic action by which the wicked person expresses rage and contempt against the righteous person. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and showing his rage against the righteous]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 37:13 (#1)

אֲדֹנָ֥י יִשְׂחַק־לּ֗וֹ

“The Lord & at him”

David is speaking of **the Lord** as if he were a person who could **laugh at** someone. This represents the Lord’s contempt for the wicked person and his plans. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The Lord regards him with contempt]

See: Personification

Psalms 37:13 (#2)

כִּֽי־רָ֭אָה כִּי־יָבֹ֣א יוֹמ֑וֹ

“he sees & his day is coming”

The pronoun **he** refers to the Lord, while the pronoun **his** refers to the wicked person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Lord sees that the wicked person’s day is coming]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:13 (#3)

יָבֹ֣א יוֹמ֑וֹ

“his day is coming”

David is speaking of the wicked person’s judgment as if it were a time or a **day** that is **coming** toward him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the time of his judgment is near]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:14 (#1)

רְשָׁעִ֗ים

“The wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:14 (#2)

לְ֭הַפִּיל עָנִ֣י וְאֶבְי֑וֹן

“to bring down the poor and the needy”

Here, **to** marks **bring down the poor and the needy** as the goal or purpose of the wicked preparing their weapons to kill, having **opened a sword** and **trodden their bow**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. [in order to bring down the poor and the needy]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 37:14 (#3)

עָנִ֣י וְאֶבְי֑וֹן

“the poor and the needy”

David is using the adjectives **poor** and **needy** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [those who are poor people and needy]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:14 (#4)

עָנִ֣י וְאֶבְי֑וֹן

“the poor and the needy”

The terms **the poor** and **the needy** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the very vulnerable]

See: Doublet

Psalms 37:14 (#5)

יִשְׁרֵי־דָֽרֶךְ

“the upright of way”

David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who live uprightly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:15 (#1)

חַרְבָּם תָּבֹאנָה בְלִבָּם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: חַרְבָּם תָּבֹאנָה בְלִבָּם”

David is speaking as if the violent plans of the wicked were a **sword** that would pierce their own **heart**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Their own schemes will bring about their ruin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:15 (#2)

וְקַשְׁתוֹתָם תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְקַשְׁתוֹתָם תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה”

The expression **will be broken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will destroy their bows]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:16 (#1)

טוֹב־מְעַט לַצַּדִּיק מֵֽהֲמוֹן רְשָׁעִים רַבִּים

“Better {is} the little & than the abundance of”

David is using the possessive form to describe the **little** amount that **the righteous** person possesses as being far better in contrast to the great wealth or **abundance** that **many wicked** people possess. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Better is what little the righteous person owns than what many wicked people have in abundance]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:17 (#1)

זְרוֹעֹות רְשָׁעִים תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה

“the arms of the wicked will be broken”

David is speaking as if the strength of the wicked were **arms** that could be **broken**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the power of the wicked will fail]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:17 (#2)

זְרוֹעֹות רְשָׁעִים תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה

“the arms of the wicked will be broken”

The expression **will be broken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will break the arms of the wicked]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:17 (#3)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:17 (#4)

וְסוֹמֵךְ צַדִּיקִים יְהוָה

“but Yahweh is supporting the righteous”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh’s care and protection as if he were physically holding up or **supporting** the righteous. Your language may have a comparable

expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but Yahweh protects and sustains the righteous]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:17 (#5)

צַדִּיקִֽים

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:18 (#1)

יוֹדֵ֣עַ יְ֭הוָה יְמֵ֣י

“Yahweh is knowing the days of”

David is using **knowing the days of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “concerned for the needs of.” This refers to Yahweh’s intimate and active involvement in the life of his people. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is concerned for the needs of]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:18 (#2)

יְמֵ֣י תְמִימִ֑ם

“the days of the blameless”

David is using the possessive form to describe the **days** that **the blameless** live. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the days that the blameless live]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:18 (#3)

תְמִימִ֑ם

“the blameless”

David is using the adjective **blameless** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who live blameless lives]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:18 (#4)

וְ֝נַחֲלָתָ֗ם

“and their inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and what they inherit]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:19 (#1)

לֹֽא־יֵ֭בֹשׁוּ

“They will not have shame”

The pronoun **They** refers to the blameless people from the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The blameless will not have shame]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:19 (#2)

לֹֽא־יֵ֭בֹשׁוּ

“They will not have shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [They will not be ashamed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:19 (#3)

בְּעֵ֣ת רָ֑עָה

“in a time of evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a time when evil things happen]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:19 (#4)

וּבִימֵ֖י רְעָבוֹ֣ן

“and in the days of famine”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **famine**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and in the days when people are starving]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:20 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

David uses the word **For** here to indicate a contrast between the fate of “the blameless” mentioned in vs. 18 and the fate of **the wicked**. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However,]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 37:20 (#2)

רְשָׁעִ֗ים

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:20 (#3)

כִּיקַ֣ר כָּרִ֣ים

“will be} like the precious of pastures”

The word translated as **pastures** could also be translated as “rams.” So this could refer to: (1) flowers that grow in the meadows and then quickly fade away. Alternate translation: [will be like the flowers of the meadow] or (2) the choicest parts of the ram that is offered for sacrifice. Alternate translation: [will be like the choice parts of rams]

Psalms 37:20 (#4)

וְאֹיְבֵ֣י יְ֭הוָה כִּיקַ֣ר כָּרִ֣ים

“and the enemies of Yahweh {will be} like the precious of pastures”

The point of this comparison is that just as the wildflower in the field or **the precious of pastures** is beautiful but quickly fades away, so **the enemies of Yahweh** will quickly perish. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and the enemies of Yahweh will be like flowers in the meadow that quickly wither]

See: Simile

Psalms 37:20 (#5)

כִּיקַ֣ר כָּרִ֣ים

“will be} like the precious of pastures”

David is using the adjective **precious** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [will be like the beautiful flowers in the pastures]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:20 (#6)

כָּלֹ֣ו בֶּעָשָׁ֣ן כָּלֽוּ

“they vanish, in smoke they vanish”

David is speaking of the disappearance of the wicked as if they were **smoke** that quickly vanishes. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they disappear completely, they are utterly gone]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:21 (#1)

רָ֭שָׁע

“The wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [The wicked person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:21 (#2)

וְ֝צַדִּ֗יק

“but the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [but the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:21 (#3)

חוֹנֵ֣ן

“is showing grace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **grace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is acting graciously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:22 (#1)

מְבֹרָכָיו

“those blessed by him”

The pronoun **him** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [those blessed by Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:22 (#2)

וּמְקֻלָלָיו יִכָּרֵתוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וּמְקֻלָלָיו יִכָּרֵתוּ”

The expression **will be cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [but Yahweh will cut off those he has cursed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:22 (#3)

יִכָּרֵתוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: יִכָּרֵתוּ”

David is using **be cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “be destroyed.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will be destroyed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:23 (#1)

מֵיְהוָה מִצְעֲדֵי־גֶבֶר כּוֹנָנוּ

“From Yahweh the steps of a man are established”

The expression **are established** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh establishes people’s steps]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:23 (#2)

מִצְעֲדֵי־גֶבֶר כּוֹנָנוּ

“the steps of a man are established”

David is speaking of a person’s life course as if it were **steps** that a person walks. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the life of a man is directed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:23 (#3)

גֶבֶר

“a man”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [each person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 37:23 (#4)

וְדַרְכּוֹ יֶחְפָּץ

“and he delights in his way”

David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he delights in the way he lives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:23 (#5)

וְדַרְכּוֹ יֶחְפָּץ

“and he delights in his way”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, while the pronoun **his** refers to the man. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh delights in that man’s way]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:24 (#1)

כִּי־יִפֹּל

“Though he falls”

David is presenting a possible condition, that a righteous man might have something bad happen to him. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [Even if he falls]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 37:24 (#2)

יִפֹּֽל

“he falls”

The pronoun **he**and **his** in this verse refer to the righteous man described in verse 23. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the righteous man falls]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:24 (#3)

יִפֹּֽל

“he falls”

Here David is speaking of the reaction the righteous have to difficult times as if he stumbles and **falls**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has difficult times]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:24 (#4)

לֹא־יוּטָ֑ל

“he will not be hurled down”

The expression **will not be hurled down** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [nothing will hurl him down]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:24 (#5)

יְהוָ֥ה סוֹמֵ֗ךְ יָדֽוֹ

“Yahweh is supporting his hand”

David is speaking of Yahweh’s help as if Yahweh were physically holding him up by **supporting his hand**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is helping him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:25 (#1)

צַדִּ֣יק נֶ֭עֱזָב

“the righteous abandoned”

The word **abandoned** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh abandoning the righteous]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:25 (#2)

צַדִּ֣יק

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [any righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:25 (#3)

וְזַרְעֹ֖ו

“or his seed”

Here David is speaking of the offspring of the righteous person as if they were actually his **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [or his offspring]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:25 (#4)

לָֽחֶם

“bread”

David is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for enough food to eat]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 37:26 (#1)

חוֹנֵ֣ן

“he is showing grace”

The pronoun **he** refers to the righteous person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the righteous person is showing grace]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:26 (#2)

חוֹנֵן

“he is showing grace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **grace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he is being gracious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:26 (#3)

וְזַרְעוֹ

“and his seed”

Here David is speaking of the offspring of the righteous person as if they were actually his **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and his offspring]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:26 (#4)

לִבְרָכָה

“are} for a blessing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **blessing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are able to bless others]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:27 (#1)

סוּר מֵרָע

“Turn away from evil”

David is speaking of **evil** as if it were an object that they should physically **turn away** from. Your language may have a comparable expression you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Stop doing what is bad]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:27 (#2)

מֵרָע וַעֲשֵׂה־טּוֹב

“from evil & good”

If your language does not use an abstract nouns for the ideas of **evil** and **good**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [from doing evil things and instead do good things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:28 (#1)

מִשְׁפָּט

“justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is just]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:28 (#2)

אֶת־חֲסִידָיו

“his faithful”

David is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [his faithful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:28 (#3)

נִשְׁמָרוּ

“they are preserved”

The expression **are preserved** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh preserves them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:28 (#4)

וְזֶרַע רְשָׁעִים נִכְרֵת

“but the offspring of the wicked will be cut off”

The expression **will be cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [but Yahweh will cut off the offspring of the wicked]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:28 (#5)

וְזֶ֖רַע רְשָׁעִ֣ים

“but the offspring of the wicked”

David is using the possessive form to describe **offspring** that belong to **the wicked**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [but the children of wicked people]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:28 (#6)

רְשָׁעִ֣ים

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:28 (#7)

נִכְרֵֽת

“will be cut off”

David is using **be cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “be destroyed.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will be destroyed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:29 (#1)

צַדִּיקִ֣ים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: צַדִּיקִ֣ים”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:30 (#1)

פִּי־צַדִּ֥יק

“The mouth of the righteous”

David is using one part of a person, his **mouth**, to mean all of him in the act of speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The righteous person]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 37:30 (#2)

צַדִּ֑יק

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:30 (#3)

חָכְמָ֥ה

“wisdom”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wisdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wise words]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:30 (#4)

וּלְשׁוֹנ֗וֹ תְּדַבֵּ֥ר מִשְׁפָּֽט

“and his tongue speaks justice”

David is using one part of a person, his **tongue**, to mean all of the righteous person in the act of speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he speaks justice]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 37:30 (#5)

מִשְׁפָּֽט

“justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is just]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:31 (#1)

אֱלֹהָ֥יו

“his God”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **law** that comes from **his God**. Also, by using the phrase **his God** he does not mean that the righteous person possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God he worships. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion. Alternate translation: [The law given by the God whom he worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:31 (#2)

בְּלִבּוֹ

“is} in his heart”

Here the **his heart** represents where a person’s thoughts exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is always in his thoughts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:31 (#3)

לֹא תִמְעַד אֲשֻׁרָיו

“his steps will not slip”

David is speaking as if the righteous person were walking along a path and his **steps** could **slip**. He means that the righteous person will not fail in his conduct. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will not fail in the way he lives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:32 (#1)

צוֹפֶה רָשָׁע לַצַּדִּיק

“is watching”

David is using the adjectives **wicked** and **righteous** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [The wicked person is watching the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:32 (#2)

לַהֲמִיתוֹ

“to kill him”

The pronoun **him** refers to the righteous person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to kill the righteous person]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:33 (#1)

יְהוָה לֹא־יַעַזְבֶנּוּ בְיָדוֹ וְלֹא יַרְשִׁיעֶנּוּ בְּהִשָּׁפְטוֹ

“Yahweh will not abandon him into his hand, and will not condemn him when he is judged”

In this verse, both of uses of the pronoun **him** refer to the righteous person as well as the **he** at the end while the pronoun **his** refers to the wicked person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will not abandon the righteous person into the hand of the wicked person, and will not condemn the righteous person when he is judged]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:33 (#2)

בְיָדוֹ

“into his hand”

Here, **his hand** represents the power of the wicked person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the power of the wicked person]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 37:33 (#3)

בְּהִשָּׁפְטוֹ

“when he is judged”

The expression **is judged** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [when he comes to trial]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:34 (#1)

וּשְׁמֹר דַּרְכּוֹ

“and keep his way”

David is speaking of how Yahweh wants a person to live as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and live how he wants you to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:34 (#2)

דַּרְכּוֹ

“his way”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **way** that belongs to **Yahweh**. He means the way of living that Yahweh prescribes. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way that Yahweh commands]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:34 (#3)

וְיָרוֹמֵמְךָ

“and he will raise you up”

Here David is speaking of honoring someone as if they were and object that someone would **raise** up. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will honor you in order for you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:34 (#4)

בְּהִכָּרֵת רְשָׁעִים

“When the wicked are cut off”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [When those who are wicked are cut off]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:34 (#5)

בְּהִכָּרֵת רְשָׁעִים

“When the wicked are cut off”

The expression **are cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh cuts off the wicked]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:34 (#6)

בְּהִכָּרֵת רְשָׁעִים

“When the wicked are cut off”

David is using **cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “destroyed.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When the wicked are destroyed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:35 (#1)

וּמִתְעָרֶה כְּאֶזְרָח רַעֲנָן

“and spreading himself out like a green native {tree”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a green native tree** spreads out and flourishes, so the wicked person was **spreading himself out** and becoming powerful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [becoming powerful like a flourishing native tree that spreads out]

See: Simile

Psalms 37:36 (#1)

וַיַּעֲבֹר

“And he passed away”

The pronouns **he** and **him** throughout this verse refer to the wicked person mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the wicked man passed away]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:36 (#2)

וְלֹא נִמְצָא

“and he was not found”

The expression **was not found** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [but I could not find him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:37 (#1)

תָּם וּרְאֵה יָשָׁר

“the blameless and see the upright”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **blameless** and **upright** as nouns to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [blameless people and see upright people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:37 (#2)

אַחֲרִית

“there is} a future”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **future**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [there is something good ahead]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:37 (#3)

לְאִישׁ שָׁלוֹם

“for the man of peace”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **man** that is characterized by **peace**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the peaceful man]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:37 (#4)

לְאִישׁ שָׁלוֹם

“for the man of peace”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means anyone in general who lives peacefully. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [for anyone who lives peacefully]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 37:38 (#1)

וְנִפְשָׁעִים נִשְׁמְדָדוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְנִפְשָׁעִים נִשְׁמְדָדוּ”

The expression **are destroyed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh destroys the transgressors]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:38 (#2)

וְנִפְשָׁעִים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְנִפְשָׁעִים”

The psalmist is using the adjective **transgressors** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the people who transgress]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:38 (#3)

אַחֲרִית רְשָׁעִים נִכְרָתָה

“the future of & is cut off”

The expression **is cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh cuts off the future of the wicked]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 37:38 (#4)

אַחֲרִית רְשָׁעִים

“the future of”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe the future lives that wicked people would have. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the future life of the wicked]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:38 (#5)

רְשָׁעִים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: רְשָׁעִים”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:38 (#6)

נִכְרֶתָה

“is cut off”

David is using **cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “destroyed.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is destroyed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 37:39 (#1)

וּתְשׁוּעַת צַדִּיקִים

“And the salvation of the righteous”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the righteous being saved]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:39 (#2)

וּתְשׁוּעַת צַדִּיקִים

“And the salvation of the righteous”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **the salvation** that **the righteous** receive. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the salvation that righteous people receive]

See: Possession

Psalms 37:39 (#3)

צַדִּיקִים

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:39 (#4)

מָעֻזָּם בְּעֵת צָרָה

“their fortress in the time of distress”

David is speaking of Yahweh’s protection as if it were a **fortress** or a strong building that protects them from enemies. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their protector in the time of distress]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 37:39 (#5)

בְּעֵת צָרָה

“in the time of distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when they are troubled]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 37:40 (#1)

וַיַּעְזְרֵם יְהוָה וַיְפַלְּטֵם

“And Yahweh helps them and delivers them”

The pronouns **them** and **they** in this verse refer to the righteous people mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh helps the righteous and delivers them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 37:40 (#2)

מֵרְשָׁעִים

“from the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [from those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 37:40 (#3)

חָסוּ בוֹ

“they have taken refuge in him”

The psalmist is speaking of trusting in Yahweh as if the righteous had **taken refuge in him**, as people take shelter in a safe place. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they have depended on him to keep them safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 38 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 38 is a "psalm of supplication" or "lament." It is a confession of sin and a prayer for deliverance.

1. Cry to Yahweh under discipline and distress (1–8)
2. Describe suffering and isolation (9–14)
3. Hope in Yahweh for healing and help (15–22)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

David's sickness

The psalmist was very sick and his enemies were seeking ways to destroy him.

Psalms 38:1 (#1)

יְהוָ֗ה אַל־בְּקֶצְפְּךָ֥ תוֹכִיחֵ֑נִי וּ֝בַחֲמָתְךָ֗ תְּיַסְּרֵֽנִי

"Yahweh, do not rebuke me in your anger, nor discipline me in your wrath"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional as in the UST. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, please do not continue to discipline me in your anger]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 38:1 (#2)

בְּקֶצְפְּךָ֥

"in your anger"

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **anger** you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when you are angry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:1 (#3)

וּבַחֲמָתְךָ֗ תְּיַסְּרֵֽנִי

"nor discipline me in your wrath"

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [nor discipline me when you are furious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:2 (#1)

חִצֶּ֣יךָ נִ֭תָּחֲתוּ בִּ֑י

"your arrows have sunk into me"

David is speaking of Yahweh's punishment as if it were **arrows** that had pierced him and **sunk into** his flesh. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your punishment has wounded me deeply]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:2 (#2)

וַתִּ֖נְחַת עָלַ֣י יָדֶֽךָ

"and your hand has come down on me"

David is using **your hand** as part of a common expression of his culture as seen in Psalm 32:4, "your hand was heavy upon me" to mean that Yahweh has afflicted or disciplined him severely. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you have afflicted me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 38:3 (#1)

אֵין־מְתֹ֣ם בִּבְשָׂ֑רִי מִפְּנֵ֖י זַעְמֶּֽךָ

"There is no soundness & your indignation"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **soundness** and **indignation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [There is no healthy part in my flesh from the face of your anger]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:3 (#2)

בִּבְשָׂ֑רִי

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בִּבְשָׂ֑רִי"

David is using **my flesh** to represent his whole body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use

an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my entire body]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 38:3 (#3)

מִפָּנֶ֫יךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִפָּנֶ֫יךָ”

David is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of” or “on account of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of]

See: Idiom

Psalms 38:3 (#4)

אֵין־שָׁלֹ֥ום בַּבַּ֫עְצָמַ֥י מִפְּנֵ֥י חַטָּאתִֽי

“there is no”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **peace** and **sin**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [there is nothing healthy in my body because I have sinned]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:3 (#5)

בַּבַּ֫עְצָמַ֥י

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בַּבַּ֫עְצָמַ֥י”

David is using **my bones** to represent his whole body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my whole body]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 38:3 (#6)

מִפָּנֶ֫יךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִפָּנֶ֫יךָ”

David is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of” or “on account of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of]

See: Idiom

Psalms 38:4 (#1)

עֲוֹנֹתַ֥י עָבְר֫וּ רֹאשִׁ֥י

“my iniquities have passed over my head”

David is speaking of his sins or **iniquities** overwhelming him as if they were flood waters that had **passed over** his head. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my iniquities have overwhelmed me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:4 (#2)

עֲוֹנֹתַ֥י

“my iniquities”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquities**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the sins I have committed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:5 (#1)

מִפְּנֵ֥י

“from the face of”

David is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of” or “on account of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of]

See: Idiom

Psalms 38:5 (#2)

אִוַּלְתִּֽי

“my foolishness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **foolishness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my foolish sins]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:6 (#1)

נַעֲוֵ֫יתִי שַׁחֹ֥תִי עַד־מְאֹ֑ד

“I am twisted & exceedingly”

The expressions **am twisted** and **bowed down** are passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Sickness has twisted my body and made it very bent over]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 38:7 (#1)

כְּסָלַי מָלְאוּ נִקְלֶה

“my loins are full of burning”

David is speaking as if his physical suffering were a **burning** fire filling his body. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my body is full of feverish pain]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:7 (#2)

נִקְלֶה וְאֵין מְתֹם

“burning, and there is no soundness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **burning** and **soundness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [fever and there is no healthy part]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:7 (#3)

בִּבְשָׂרִי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בִּבְשָׂרִי”

David is using **my flesh** to represent his whole body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [anywhere in my body]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 38:8 (#1)

נְפוּגֹתִי וְנִדְכֵּיתִי

“I am numb”

The expressions **am numb** and **crushed** are passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Sickness has made my body feel numb and broken down]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 38:8 (#2)

מֵנַהֲמַת לִבִּי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מֵנַהֲמַת לִבִּי”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s feelings and emotions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of all the anxiety I feel]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:9 (#1)

תַּאֲוָתִי

“my desire”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **desire**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I desire]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:9 (#2)

וְאַנְחָתִי מִמְּךָ לֹא־נִסְתָּרָה

“and my sighing is not hidden from you”

The expression **is not hidden** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and you know all my sighing]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 38:9 (#3)

מִמְּךָ לֹא־נִסְתָּרָה

“is not hidden from you”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **hidden**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [is very clear to you]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 38:10 (#1)

עֲזָבַנִי כֹחִי

“my strength has left me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea

in another way. Alternate translation: [I am no longer strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:10 (#2)

עֲזָבַנִי כֹחִי

“my strength has left me”

David is speaking of **his strength** as if it were a living thing that could walk away and **leave** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my strength has faded away]

See: Personification

Psalms 38:10 (#3)

וְאוֹר־עֵינַי גַּם־הֵמָּה אֵינָם אִתִּי

“and the light of my eyes—even they {are} not with me”

David is speaking of his ability to see as if it were a **light** that was in his **eyes**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and all I can see with my eyes is darkness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:11 (#1)

אֹהֲבַי ׀ וְרֵעַי מִנֶּגֶד נִגְעִי יַעֲמֹדוּ וּמְקֹרוֹבַי מֵרָחוֹק עָמָדוּ

“My loved ones and my friends stand from before my plague, and my relatives stand from afar”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [My loved ones all stand far away from me because of my sickness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 38:12 (#1)

וַיְנַקְּשׁוּ ׀ מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי

“And the seekers of my life lay snares”

David is speaking as if his enemies’ plots were **snares** set to trap an animal. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the seekers of my life plot against me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:12 (#2)

מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי

“the seekers of my life”

David is using **the seekers of my life** as a common expression of the culture to mean “those who want to kill me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all my enemies who want to see me dead]

See: Idiom

Psalms 38:12 (#3)

הַוּוֹת וּמִרְמוֹת כָּל־הַיּוֹם יֶהְגּוּ

“destructions and mutter treacheries all the day”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **destructions** and **treacheries**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [about their plans to destroy me and constantly mutter lies against me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:13 (#1)

וַאֲנִי

“But I”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between his enemies’ hostile actions and his own silence in response. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, I]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 38:13 (#2)

כְּחֵרֵשׁ לֹא אֶשְׁמָע

“am} like a deaf man; I do not hear”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a deaf man** cannot hear what is said to him, so David deliberately does not listen to his enemies’ accusations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [am like a man who deliberately does not hear; I do not pay attention to what they say]

See: Simile

Psalms 38:13 (#3)

וּכְאִלֵּם לֹא יִפְתַּח־פִּיו

“and like a mute man—he does not open his mouth”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a mute man** cannot speak, so David deliberately does not respond to his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I deliberately do not open my mouth to respond to them]

See: Simile

Psalms 38:14 (#1)

כְּאָדָם אֲשֶׁר לֹא־שֹׁמֵעַ

“like a man who is not hearing”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a man who is not hearing** does not hear or respond to what is said, so David deliberately does not pay attention to his enemies’ words. See how you translated the very similar comparison in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [like a man who does not pay attention to what his enemies are saying]

See: Simile

Psalms 38:14 (#2)

וְאֵין בְּפִיו תּוֹכָחוֹת

“and there are no rebukes in his mouth”

David is using the term **mouth** to mean speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he does not respond to anyone]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 38:15 (#1)

אַתָּה תַּעֲנֶה

“you, you will answer”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you will answer** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh alone is the one who will respond to him. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you alone will answer me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 38:15 (#2)

אֲדֹנָי

“my God”

David is not using the phrase **my God** to mean that he possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God he worships. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion. Alternate translation: [the God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 38:16 (#1)

פֶּן־יִשְׂמְחוּ־לִי בְּמוֹט רַגְלִי עָלַי הִגְדִּילוּ

“Lest they rejoice over me; at the slipping of my foot, they magnify {themselves} against me”

David is using the word translated as **Lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the instruction. Alternate translation: [I pray that they will not rejoice over me; at the slipping of my foot, may they not magnify themselves against me]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 38:16 (#2)

בְּמוֹט רַגְלִי

“at the slipping of my foot”

David is speaking as if experiencing misfortune were his **foot slipping**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at my misfortune]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:16 (#3)

בְּמוֹט רַגְלִי

“at the slipping of my foot”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **slipping**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when my foot slips]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:16 (#4)

עָלַי הִגְדִּילוּ

“they magnify {themselves} against me”

David is using **magnify themselves against me** as a common expression of the culture to mean "they exalt themselves over me" or "they gloat over me." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they exalt themselves over me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 38:17 (#1)

אֲנִי לְצֶלַע נָכוֹן

"I am set up for a stumbling"

David is speaking of experiencing something bad happen as if it were a **stumbling** that he is about to experience. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am about to experience calamity]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:18 (#1)

עֲוֹנִי

"my iniquity"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wrong I have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:18 (#2)

מֵחַטָּאתִי

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מֵחַטָּאתִי"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because of how sinful I am]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:19 (#1)

שֹׂנְאַי שֶׁקֶר

"my haters of falsehood"

David is using the possessive form to describe a **hater** that is characterized by **falsehood**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those who hate me without cause]

See: Possession

Psalms 38:20 (#1)

וּמְשַׁלְּמֵי רָעָה תַּחַת טוֹבָה

"And the repayers of evil in exchange for good"

If your language does not use an abstract nouns for the ideas of **evil** and **good**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [And those who treat me evilly for doing good things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:20 (#2)

וּמְשַׁלְּמֵי רָעָה

"And the repayers of evil"

David is using the possessive form to describe a **repayer** that is characterized by **evil**. He means those who repay the good things he does for them with evil. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And those who repay me with evil]

See: Possession

Psalms 38:20 (#3)

יִשְׂטְנְנוּנִי תַּחַת רדופי־טוֹב

"accuse me in exchange for my pursuing of good"

If your language does not use an abstract nouns for the ideas of **pursuing** and **good**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [accuse me falsely even though I pursue doing good things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 38:21 (#1)

אֱלֹהָי

"my God"

David is not using this possessive form **my God** to indicate that he possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather David is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom he worships. Alternate translation: [oh God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 38:21 (#2)

אַל־תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי

"do not be far from me"

David is speaking of a lack of help as if it were being physically **far** from God. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not withhold your help from me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 38:22 (#1)

חִוּשָׁה לְעֶזְרָתִי

“to my help”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hurry to my help]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 38:22 (#2)

לְעֶזְרָתִי אֲאֲדֹנָי תְּשׁוּעָתִי

“to my help, Lord”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **help** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [to help me, Lord, the one who saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 39 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 39 is a “psalm of supplication” or “lament.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about “psalms of supplication” or “laments.”

1. Struggle with silence and the weight of life (1–6)
2. Place hope in Yahweh alone (7–11)
3. Plead for mercy in light of life’s shortness (12–13)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Life

Life on earth is short. The psalmist wanted God’s healing so he can enjoy the rest of his life.

This psalm shares some characteristics of a wisdom book called Ecclesiastes but is more positive.

Psalms 39:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 39:0 (#3)

לִידִיתוּן

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִידִיתוּן”

Jeduthun was a Levite who was one of the worship leaders in the temple during the reign of David. The expression **on Jeduthun** could mean: (1) that David gave this song to Jeduthun and his choir to perform. Alternate translation: [for Jeduthun’s choir] or (2) that singers were to perform this song in the style of Jeduthun’s choir. Alternate translation: [perform in the style of Jeduthun]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 39:1 (#1)

אָמַרְתִּי

“I said”

The phrase **I said** is here represented as introducing a direct quotation although it was likely an unspoken thought. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing unspoken thoughts in your language as modeled in the UST. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 39:1 (#2)

אֶשְׁמְרָה דְרָכַי׀

“Let me guard my ways”

This is an imperative, but it communicates David’s personal resolve rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a personal resolve for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a personal resolve. Alternate translation: [I resolve to guard my ways]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 39:1 (#3)

אֶשְׁמְרָה דְרָכַי׀

“Let me guard my ways”

David is speaking of his behavior as if it were paths or **ways** where there could be a **guard** posted to control access. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [control my conduct]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:1 (#4)

מֵֽחֲטֹא֥ בִלְשׁוֹנִ֑י

“from sinning with my tongue”

David is using the term **tongue** to mean speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from sinning by what I say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 39:1 (#5)

אֶשְׁמְרָה לְפִ֥י מַחְסֹ֑ום

“Let me guard a muzzle for my mouth”

David is speaking of restraining his speech as if he were putting a **muzzle** on his **mouth** like one would muzzle an animal. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will keep silent]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:2 (#1)

דָּ֝מִ֗יָּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: דָּ֝מִ֗יָּה”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **silence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by not saying a word]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:2 (#2)

הֶֽחֱשֵׁ֥יתִי מִטּ֑וֹב

“from good”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I refrained from saying anything good]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 39:2 (#3)

וּכְאֵבִ֥י נֶעְכָּֽר

“and my pain”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pain**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and my suffering increased]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:2 (#4)

וּכְאֵבִ֥י נֶעְכָּֽר

“and my pain”

The expression **was stirred up** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and my silence only made my pain worse]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 39:2 (#5)

וּכְאֵבִ֥י

“and my pain”

David uses the word **and** here to indicate a contrast rather than adding information. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [but instead, my pain]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 39:3 (#1)

חַם־לִבִּ֑י ׀ בְּקִרְבִּ֥י

“My heart became hot within me”

David is speaking of his intense emotions as if his **heart became hot** like something burning with fire. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I burned with anxiety within me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:3 (#2)

בַּהֲגִיגִ֣י

“in my sighing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sighing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the more I was distressed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:3 (#3)

תִּבְעַר־אֵֽשׁ

“fire burned”

David is speaking of his emotional turmoil as if **fire burned** within him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my distress intensified]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:3 (#4)

דִּבַּ֥רְתִּי בִלְשֹׁנִֽי

“I spoke with my tongue”

The phrase **I spoke with my tongue** introduces a direct quotation that begins in the next verse. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [I finally said,]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 39:3 (#5)

דִּבַּ֥רְתִּי בִלְשֹׁנִֽי

“I spoke with my tongue”

David is using the term **tongue** to mean speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I spoke these words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 39:4 (#1)

הוֹדִיעֵ֣נִי יְהוָ֣ה ׀ קִצִּ֑י

“Make me know my end, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please let me know my end, Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 39:4 (#2)

קִצִּ֑י

“my end”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [when my life will end]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 39:5 (#1)

טְפָחוֹת ׀ נָתַ֣תָּה יָמַ֑י

“you have given my days {as} handbreadths”

David is speaking of his life span as if it were **days** that could be measured out in **handbreadths** of time, a very small measure. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have made my lifetime as short as a handbreadth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:5 (#2)

וְחֶלְדִּ֥י כְאַ֗יִן נֶגְדֶּ֥֫ךָ

“and my lifetime {is} as nothing before you”

David says **my lifetime is as nothing before you** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [and my lifetime is extremely brief from your point of view]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 39:5 (#3)

כָּל־הֶ֥בֶל כָּל־אָ֝דָ֗ם נִצָּ֥ב

“every man stands {as} all vapor”

The point of this comparison is that just as the time that a man **stands** or lives is frail and transient, so is **vapor** or a mere breath. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [each man’s life is frail and transient]

See: Simile

Psalms 39:6 (#1)

בְּצֶ֣לֶם ׀ יִתְהַלֶּךְ־אִ֗ישׁ

“a man walks about as an image”

The point of this comparison is that just as an **image** is insubstantial and fleeting, so is a person’s life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [a man walks about but has no real substance]

See: Simile

Psalms 39:6 (#2)

יִתְהַלֶּךְ־אִ֑ישׁ

“a man walks about”

Here David is speaking of people going through life as if it were **a man** who **walks about**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people go through life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:6 (#3)

אִ֑ישׁ

“a man”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [a person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 39:6 (#4)

אַךְ־הֶ֥בֶל יֶהֱמָיֻ֗ון

“surely they make an uproar for vapor”

David is speaking of people’s pursuits as if they were **vapor**, something futile and insubstantial. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [surely they make an uproar over what is futile and worthless]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:6 (#5)

יֶהֱמָיֻ֗ון

“they make an uproar”

The pronoun **they** refers to people in general. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [everyone bustles around]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 39:6 (#6)

יִ֭צְבֹּר

“He heaps up”

David assumes that readers will know that by **heaps up** he means acquiring a lot of possessions. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He acquires possessions]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 39:6 (#7)

מִי־אֹ֝סְפָ֗ם

“who will be gathering them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the things that the person has heaped up. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [who will be getting all of those things]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 39:7 (#1)

וְעַתָּ֥ה

“And now”

The word **And** here introduces a transition from David’s reflection on the brevity of life to his direct appeal to God. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Now then]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 39:7 (#2)

מַה־קִּוִּ֣יתִי אֲדֹנָ֑י

“what do I wait for, Lord”

David is using the question form to emphasize that there is nothing worth waiting for apart from God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [there is nothing I should wait for, Lord!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 39:7 (#3)

תֹּ֝וחַלְתִּ֗י

“My hope”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [What I wait hopefully for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:8 (#1)

מִכָּל־פְּשָׁעַי

“from all my transgressions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgressions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from all the ways I have sinned against you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:8 (#2)

חֶרְפַּת נָבָל

“the reproach of a fool”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [someone whom a fool insults]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:9 (#1)

נָאֱלַמְתִּי לֹא אֶפְתַּח־פִּי כִּי אַתָּה עָשִׂיתָ

“I am mute; I do not open my mouth, for you, you have done {it”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because you have done it, I am mute; I do not open my mouth]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 39:9 (#2)

לֹא אֶפְתַּח־פִּי

“I do not open my mouth”

The expression **I do not open my mouth** represents David choosing not to speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I do not say anything]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 39:9 (#3)

כִּי אַתָּה עָשִׂיתָ

“for you, you have done {it”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have done** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is Yahweh who is responsible for what has happened. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [because of what you specifically have done]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 39:10 (#1)

הָסֵר מֵעָלַי נִגְעֶךָ

“Remove your plague from upon me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please remove your plague from upon me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 39:10 (#2)

מִתִּגְרַת יָדְךָ

“from the blow of your hand”

David is using **your hand** as part of a common expression of his culture as seen in Psalm 32:4, “your hand was heavy upon me” to mean that Yahweh has afflicted or disciplined him severely. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the way you have afflicted me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 39:10 (#3)

אֲנִי כָלִיתִי

“I, I am finished”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I am finished** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize his own

desperate condition. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [indeed, I am finished]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 39:11 (#1)

בְּתוֹכָ֥חוֹת

“With rebukes”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rebukes**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [By rebuking a man]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:11 (#2)

עַל־עָוֹן

“on account of iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the sinful things he has done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:11 (#3)

יִסַּ֣רְתָּ אִ֭ישׁ

“you discipline a man”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you discipline a person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 39:11 (#4)

וַתְּתָ֣מֶס כָּעָ֣שׁ חֶמוּדֹ֑ו

“and you dissolve like a moth his desired thing”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **moth** gradually destroys clothing, so Yahweh destroys what a person treasures. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and like a moth destroys clothing, you dissolve the things he desires]

See: Simile

Psalms 39:11 (#5)

אַ֣ךְ הֶ֭בֶל כָּל־אָדָ֣ם

“Surely all mankind {is} vapor”

David is speaking of all human existence as if it were **vapor** that quickly disappears. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar phrase “every man stands as all vapor” in verse 5. Alternate translation: [Surely all mankind lives but a short time]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:12 (#1)

תְּפִלָּתִ֑י

“my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I pray]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 39:12 (#2)

הַאֲזִינָ֥הּ

“and give ear to”

David is using the term **ear** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and hear]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 39:12 (#3)

אַל־תֶּ֝֗חֱרַשׁ

“Do not be deaf”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **deaf**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [Please pay attention]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 39:12 (#4)

גֵּ֣ר אָ֭נֹכִי עִמָּ֑ךְ תֹּ֝֗שָׁב

“I {am} a sojourner with you, a foreigner”

David is speaking of his temporary time on earth as if he were a **sojourner** and a **foreigner** who is only passing through. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or

you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am only passing through with you, a temporary visitor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:12 (#5)

אֲבוֹתָי

“my fathers”

David is using the term **fathers** to mean “ancestors.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my forebears]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 39:13 (#1)

הָשַׁ֣עְ מִמֶּ֣נִּי וְאַבְלִ֑יגָה

“Look away from me that I may be cheerful”

Here, **that** marks **I may be cheerful** as the goal or purpose of David’s request for Yahweh to **Look away** from him. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [Turn your angry gaze away from me so that I may be cheerful]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 39:13 (#2)

אֵלֵ֥ךְ וְאֵינֶ֗נִּי

“I go and I am no more”

David is referring to dying in a polite way by using the phrase **I go and I am no more**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [I pass away]

See: Euphemism

Psalms - Chapter 40 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 40 is considered to be one of the “psalms of praise.” At the same time, it is a “messianic psalm” that looks forward to the triumph of Jesus Christ. The writer of Hebrews (Hebrews 10:5–7) applies this passage (Psalm 40:6–8) to Jesus using the ancient Greek version. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Praise Yahweh for past deliverance (1–5)
2. Commit to obey Yahweh’s will (6–10)
3. Ask Yahweh for continued help and rescue (11–17)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Sacrifices

God is not interested in sacrifices but wants people to obey him and fulfill his plans for them.

Psalms 40:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 40:1 (#1)

קַוֹּ֣ה קִוִּ֣יתִי

“Waiting, I waited for”

David is repeating forms of the verb **wait** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I waited expectantly for]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 40:1 (#2)

וַיֵּ֖ט אֵלַ֣י

“and he inclined to me”

David is speaking of Yahweh’s attentive concern for him as if Yahweh were physically bending down or **inclined** toward him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he paid close attention to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:1 (#3)

וַיִּשְׁמַ֥ע

“and heard”

David assumes that readers will know that by **heard** he means Yahweh listened and responded favorably to his prayer. You could say that explicitly if that would

be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and responded to]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 40:1 (#4)

שַׁוְעָתִי

“my cry”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **cry**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [me cry out]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:2 (#1)

וַיַּעֲלֵנִי

“And he brought me up”

Here David is speaking Yahweh’s rescuing him from a terrible situation as if he were lifted or **brought up** from a deep hole. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he saved me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:2 (#2)

מִבּוֹר שָׁאוֹן

“from the pit of tumult”

David is speaking as if his distress were a deep **pit** from which he could not escape. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the terrible danger I was in]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:2 (#3)

מִבּוֹר שָׁאוֹן

“from the pit of tumult”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **pit** that is characterized by **tumult**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the tumultuous pit]

See: Possession

Psalms 40:2 (#4)

מִטִּיט הַיָּוֵן

“from the mud of the mire”

David is speaking as if his desperate situation were **mud** and **mire** from which he could not free himself. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the terrible situation in which I was stuck]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:2 (#5)

וַיָּקֶם עַל־סֶלַע רַגְלַי

“and he set my feet on a rock”

David is speaking as if Yahweh’s deliverance were Yahweh physically placing his **feet on a rock**, giving him stability and safety. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he made me stable and safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:2 (#6)

כּוֹנֵן אֲשֻׁרָי

“he established my steps”

David is speaking as if his way of living were **steps** that Yahweh made firm. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he made my way of life secure]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:3 (#1)

וַיִּתֵּן בְּפִי ׀ שִׁיר חָדָשׁ

“And he put a new song in my mouth”

David is speaking of Yahweh giving him reason to sing a song of praise as if **a new song** were a physical object that he placed into his **mouth**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he made me want to sing a different song of]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:3 (#2)

תְּהִלָּה לֵאלֹהֵינוּ

“praise to our God”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a song that says that our God is great]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:3 (#3)

לֵאלֹהֵינוּ

“to our God”

David is not using the possessive form **our God** to indicate that he and his people possess or control Yahweh. Rather David is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom they worship. Alternate translation: [to the God we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 40:3 (#4)

יִרְאוּ רַבִּים וְיִירָאוּ

“Many will see and will fear”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Many people will see what God has done for me and will reverence him]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 40:3 (#5)

רַבִּים

“Many”

David is using the adjective **Many** as a noun to mean a certain group of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [There will be many people who]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 40:4 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי הַגֶּבֶר

“The happinesses of the man”

David is using the phrase **The happinesses of** to express a strong feeling of admiration for those who trust in Yahweh. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could express the idea of how fortunate such a person is. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is the person]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 40:4 (#2)

הַגֶּבֶר

“the man”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the one]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 40:4 (#3)

מִבְטַחוֹ

“his trust”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trust**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one he relies on]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:4 (#4)

וְלֹא־פָנָה אֶל־רְהָבִים

“and has not turned to the proud”

David is speaking as if choosing to follow or trust the proud were physically having **turned** to face them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has not put his trust in the proud]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:4 (#5)

רְהָבִים

“the proud”

David is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [arrogant people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 40:4 (#6)

וְשָׂטֵי כָזָב

“and the goers aside to falsehood”

By **the goers aside**, David means "those who have gone astray after falsehood." You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and those who follow after falsehood]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 40:4 (#7)

כָּזָב

"falsehood"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [lies]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:5 (#1)

רַבּוֹת עָשִׂיתָ ׀ אַתָּה ׀ יְהוָה אֱלֹהַי

"Many {things} you have done, you, Yahweh my God"

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have done** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one who performed these wonderful deeds. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [For it is you, Yahweh my God, who has done many things]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 40:5 (#2)

יְהוָה אֱלֹהַי

"Yahweh my God"

David is not using the possessive form **my God** to indicate that he possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather David is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom he worships. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the God I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 40:5 (#3)

וּמַחְשְׁבֹתֶיךָ אֵלֵינוּ

"and your thoughts toward us"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thoughts**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and what you have planned for us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:5 (#4)

אֵין ׀ עֲרֹךְ אֵלֶיךָ

"there is none to line up against you"

The clause translated as **there is none to line up against you** could refer to: (1) anyone who might compare to Yahweh. Alternate translation: [there is no one to compare to you] or (2) all of the things that Yahweh has done, that cannot be listed. Alternate translation: [there is no way to enumerate them to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:5 (#5)

עָצְמוּ מִסָּפֵר

"they are more than to recount"

David says **they are more than to recount** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [there are too many to count]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 40:5 (#6)

אַגִּידָה וַאֲדַבֵּרָה

"Should I declare and speak {them"

The terms **declare** and **speak** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Should I be able to tell all about those deeds]

See: Doublet

Psalms 40:5 (#7)

עָצְמוּ מִסָּפֵר

"they are more than to recount"

The pronoun **they** refers to all Yahweh's wonderful deeds and plans. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [all those wonderful deeds are more than can be recounted]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 40:6 (#1)

אָזְנַיִם כָּרִיתָ לִּי

“ears you have dug for me”

David is using **ears you have dug for me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “you gave me the ability to hear and obey you.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have given me ears to hear] or [you have made me able to listen to you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 40:7 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

David is using the term **Behold** to call attention to what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:7 (#2)

כָּתוּב עָלָי

“it is written about me”

The expression **it is written about me** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [a prophet has written about me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 40:8 (#1)

רְצוֹנְךָ

“your will”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **will**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what you want]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:8 (#2)

אֱלֹהַי

“my God”

David is not using the possessive form **my God** to indicate that he possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather David is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom he worships. Alternate translation: [the God I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 40:8 (#3)

וְתוֹרָתְךָ בְּתוֹךְ מֵעָי

“and your law {is} in the midst of my inward parts”

David is speaking as if his deep commitment to Yahweh’s law were that law being physically present **in the midst of** his **inward parts**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I am deeply committed to keeping your law]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:9 (#1)

צֶדֶק

“righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that you are righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:9 (#2)

הִנֵּה

“behold”

See how you translated the similar expression in 40:7.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:9 (#3)

שְׂפָתַי לֹא אֶכְלָא

“I will not restrain my lips”

Here, **my lips** represents David’s speech. By saying he will not **restrain** them, David means he will not stop speaking about Yahweh’s righteousness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I will not stop telling others]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 40:9 (#4)

יְהוָה אַתָּה יָדָעְתָּ

“Yahweh, you, you know”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you know** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh himself is fully aware of David's faithfulness. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Yawheh, you know this is true]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 40:10 (#1)

צִדְקָתְךָ

"your righteousness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your righteous acts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:10 (#2)

בְּתוֹךְ לִבִּי

"in the midst of my heart"

David is using **heart** to mean the place where his thoughts and intentions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [just within my own thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 40:10 (#3)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ וּתְשׁוּעָתֶךָ

"your faithfulness and your salvation"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **faithfulness** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are and how you have saved us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:10 (#4)

חַסְדְּךָ וַאֲמִתְּךָ

"your covenant faithfulness and your trustworthiness"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **trustworthiness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how you faithfully keep your covenant and how trustworthy you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:11 (#1)

רַחֲמֶיךָ

"your compassion"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being compassionate]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:11 (#2)

חַסְדְּךָ וַאֲמִתְּךָ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: חַסְדְּךָ וַאֲמִתְּךָ"

See how you translated the same abstract nouns in verse 10.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:12 (#1)

רָעוֹת

"evils"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evils**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [evil things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:12 (#2)

אָפְפוּ־עָלַי

"have surrounded me"

Here David is speaking of bad things happening to him as if they were objects that **surrounded** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are constantly happening all around me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:12 (#3)

עַד־אֵין מִסְפָּר

"until there is no number"

David says **until there is no number** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the

emphasis. Alternate translation: [there are too many to count]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 40:12 (#4)

הִשִּׂיגֻנִי עֲוֹנֹתַי

“my iniquities have overtaken me”

Here David is speaking his sins overwhelming him as if they were actually something chasing after and having caught up or **overtaken** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my sins have caught up with me] or [my iniquities have overwhelmed me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:12 (#5)

עֲוֹנֹתַי

“my iniquities”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquities**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the sins I have committed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:12 (#6)

וְלֹא־יָכֹלְתִּי לִרְאוֹת

“and I am not able to see”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and I am not able to see a way out]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 40:12 (#7)

עָצְמוּ מִשַּׂעֲרוֹת רֹאשִׁי

“They are more numerous than the hairs of my head”

David says **more numerous than the hairs of my head** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [They are too many for me to count]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 40:12 (#8)

וְלִבִּי עֲזָבָנִי

“and my heart has abandoned me”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and emotions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my courage has failed me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:13 (#1)

רְצֵה יְהוָה לְהַצִּילֵנִי יְהוָה לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה

“Be pleased, Yahweh & Yahweh & to my help”

These lines are imperatives, but they communicate a polite request or prayer rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear as modeled in the UST.

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 40:13 (#2)

לְעֶזְרָתִי

“to my help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to rescue me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:14 (#1)

יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ ׀ יַחַד׃

“Let them have shame and have disgrace together”

By using **Let** in each of the phrases in this and the following verses, David is expressing what he desires or prays will happen. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants to happen. Alternate translation: [I desire that they all have shame and disgrace]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 40:14 (#2)

יֵבֹשׁוּ

“Let them have shame”

The pronoun **them** here and in the next several verses refers to **the seekers of my life** mentioned in the next line. These were the enemies who were trying to kill David. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Let my enemies have shame]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 40:14 (#3)

יֵֽבֹ֖שׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ֑

“Let them have shame and have disgrace”

The terms **shame** and **disgrace** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let them be utterly ashamed]

See: Doublet

Psalms 40:14 (#4)

יֵֽבֹ֖שׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ֑

“Let them have shame and have disgrace”

If your language does not use an abstract nouns for the ideas of **shame** and **disgrace**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Let them be ashamed and disgraced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:14 (#5)

מְבַקְשֵׁ֣י נַפְשִׁ֣י לְסִפּוֹתָ֑הּ

“the seekers of my life to sweep it away”

David is using **the seekers of my life** as a common expression of the culture to mean “those who want to kill me.” See how you translated this same phrase in 38:12. Alternate translation: [all my enemies who want to see me dead]

See: Idiom

Psalms 40:14 (#6)

יִסֹּ֣גוּ אָ֭חוֹר וְיִכָּלְמ֣וּ

“Let them be turned back and be confounded”

The expressions **be turned back** and **be confounded** are passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [Let God turn them back and confuse them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 40:14 (#7)

יִסֹּ֣גוּ אָ֭חוֹר

“Let them be turned back”

Here David is asking that his enemies be stopped as if they were walking on a path and then were blocked or **turned back**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let them be stopped]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 40:14 (#8)

חֲפֵ֖צֵי רָעָתִֽי

“those pleased with my harm”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **harm**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those wanting to harm me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:15 (#1)

בָּשְׁתָּ֗ם

“their shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how disgraced they are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:15 (#2)

הֶ֘אָ֤ח ׀ הֶאָ֗ח

“Aha! Aha”

David’s enemies using **Aha! Aha!** as a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of malicious glee at his misfortune. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what those people were feeling. Alternate translation: [We are glad to see your downfall]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 40:16 (#1)

יָ֭שׂוֹשׂוּ וְיִשְׂמְח֣וּ ׀ בְּךָ֣ כָל־מְבַקְשֶׁ֑יךָ

“Let all the seekers of you rejoice and be glad in you”

The terms **rejoice** and **be glad** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let all those who seek you greatly rejoice in you]

See: Doublet

Psalms 40:16 (#2)

תְּשׁוּעָתֶךָ

“of your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how you save them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:17 (#1)

עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן

“poor and needy”

The terms **poor** and **needy** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [in great need]

See: Doublet

Psalms 40:17 (#2)

עֶזְרָתִי וּמְפַלְטִי

“my help and my deliverer”

The terms **help** and **deliverer** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my great deliverer]

See: Doublet

Psalms 40:17 (#3)

עֶזְרָתִי וּמְפַלְטִי

“my help and my deliverer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who helps and delivers me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 40:17 (#4)

אֱלֹהַי

“my God”

See how you translated the similar expression in 40:8. Alternate translation: [oh, God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 40:17 (#5)

אַל־תְּאַחַר

“do not delay”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not delay]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms - Chapter 41 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 41 is a “psalm of supplication” or “lament.” See the Introduction to Psalms for more information about types of psalms.

1. Blessing for those who care for the weak (1–3)
2. Cry for mercy amid betrayal and sickness (4–9)
3. Trust Yahweh for restoration and justice (10–12)
4. Conclusion of Book 1, which consists of Psalms 1–41 (13)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Enemies

The author’s best friend had become an enemy. His enemies were happy because they were sure his sickness would result in death.

Psalms 41:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 41:1 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי מַשְׂכִּיל

“The happinesses of the one considering”

David is using the phrase **The happinesses of** to express a strong feeling of admiration. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could express the idea of how fortunate such a person is. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is the one considering]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 41:1 (#2)

אֶל־דָּל

“the lowly”

David is using the adjective **lowly** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who are lowly]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 41:1 (#3)

בְּיוֹם רָעָה

“In the day of evil”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **day**, time, or occasion that is characterized by **evil**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [When evil things are happening]

See: Possession

Psalms 41:1 (#4)

רָעָה

“evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [harmful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:2 (#1)

יאשר

“and he will be called happy”

The expression **be called happy** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and people will call him happy]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 41:2 (#2)

וְאַל־תִּתְּנֵהוּ

“so do not give him”

David switches to addressing Yahweh directly in order to make his conclusion more vivid. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the third person for consistency. Alternate translation: [so may Yahweh not give him]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 41:2 (#3)

בְּנֶפֶשׁ אֹיְבָיו

“into the soul of his enemies”

Here, **soul** represents “desire.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [over to the desire of his enemies]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 41:3 (#1)

עֶרֶשׂ דְּוָי

“the bed of suffering”

The psalmist is speaking of the person’s time of illness as if it were **the bed of suffering** on which the person lies. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his sickbed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 41:3 (#2)

עַל־עֶרֶשׂ דְּוָי

“on the bed of suffering”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **suffering**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when he suffers]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:3 (#3)

הָפַכְתָּ

“you transformed”

As he did in the previous verse, David switches to addressing Yahweh directly in order to make his conclusion more vivid. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the third person for consistency. Alternate translation: [Yahweh transformed]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 41:3 (#4)

כָּל־מִשְׁכָּבוֹ הָפַכְתָּ בְחָלְיוֹ

“you transformed each bed of his in his sickness”

By **transformed each bed of his in his sickness**, David means that Yahweh transforms his illness into health. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh transformed his sickness into health]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 41:3 (#5)

בְחָלְיוֹ

“in his sickness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sickness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when he is ill]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:4 (#1)

אֲנִי־אָמַרְתִּי

“I, I said”

The pronoun **I** refers to David. David is stating the pronoun **I** separately for emphasis even though the verb translated as **I said** already includes this meaning. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I, David, said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 41:4 (#2)

חָנֵּנִי יְהוָה

“be gracious to me! Heal”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear as modeled in the UST.

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 41:4 (#3)

רְפָאָה נַפְשִׁי

“Heal my soul”

David is using the term **soul** to mean his entire person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Please make me whole again]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 41:4 (#4)

רְפָאָה נַפְשִׁי כִּי־חָטָאתִי לָךְ

“Heal my soul, for I have sinned against you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since I have sinned against you, I need you to heal me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 41:5 (#1)

רַע

“evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. See how you translated the similar expression in verse 1. Alternate translation: [harmful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:5 (#2)

מָתַי יָמוּת וְאָבַד שְׁמוֹ

“When will he die and his name perish”

David’s enemies are using the question form to express their hostile wish that David would die. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [We wish he would die and his name would perish!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 41:5 (#3)

וְאָבַד שְׁמוֹ

“and his name perish”

Here, **his name** represents “his memory” or “his reputation.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and the memory of him will perish]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 41:6 (#1)

לִבּוֹ יִקְבָּץ־אָוֶן לוֹ

“his heart gathers iniquity to itself”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and intentions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his mind plans evil]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 41:6 (#2)

וְאִם־בָּבֵא

“And if he comes”

The pronouns **he** and **his** in this verse refer to one of David’s enemies mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And if one of my enemies comes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 41:6 (#3)

שָׁשְׁוְא יְדַבֵּר

“he speaks worthlessness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **worthlessness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he speaks empty words] or [he pretends to be friendly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:6 (#4)

לִבּוֹ יִקְבָּץ־אָוֶן לוֹ

“his heart gathers iniquity to itself”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts exist so the phrase **his heart gathers iniquity to itself** means that the enemy is secretly trying to think of bad things to say about David. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he thinks of evil things he can say]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 41:6 (#5)

לִבּוֹ יִקְבָּץ־אָוֶן

“his heart gathers iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [ways to defame]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:7 (#1)

רָעָה לִי

“evil to me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. See how you translated the similar expression in 41:1. Alternate translation: [things that will harm me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:8 (#1)

דְּבַר־בְּלִיַּעַל יָצוּק בּוֹ

“A matter of wickedness is poured on him”

David’s enemies are speaking of **A matter of wickedness** as if it were a liquid that is **poured** on a person. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Something wicked has overwhelmed him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 41:8 (#2)

דְּבַר־בְּלִיַּעַל יָצוּק בּוֹ

“A matter of wickedness is poured on him”

The expression **is poured** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Terrible things are happening to him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 41:8 (#3)

דְּבַר־בְּלִיַּעַל

“A matter of wickedness”

This is the beginning of what David’s “haters” (enemies mentioned in the previous verse) are saying about him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of SPEAKER. Alternate translation: [My enemies are saying, “A matter of wickedness]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 41:8 (#4)

בְּלִיַּעַל

“wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [something very evil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:8 (#5)

וַאֲשֶׁר שָׁכַב לֹא־יוֹסִיף לָקוּם

“and he who has lain down will not repeat to rise”

David’s enemies are referring to dying in a polite way by using the phrase **he who has lain down will not repeat to rise**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will die from this illness]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 41:9 (#1)

אִישׁ שְׁלוֹמִי

“the man of my peace”

David is using **the man of my peace** as a common expression of his culture to mean “my close friend” or “my trusted ally.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my closest ally]

See: Idiom

Psalms 41:9 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר־בָּטַחְתִּי בּוֹ

“whom I trusted in him”

It might seem that the expression **whom I trusted in him** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [in whom I trusted]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 41:9 (#3)

אוֹכֵל לַחְמִי

“the eater of my bread”

David is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food or in general so **the eater of my bread** here means “the one who shared meals with me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who ate meals with me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 41:9 (#4)

הִגְדִּיל עָלַי עָקֵב

“has made great the heel against me”

David is using **has made great the heel against me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “has greatly betrayed me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has greatly turned against me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 41:10 (#1)

וַאֲשַׁלְּמָה לָהֶם

“so that I may repay them”

Here, **so that** marks **I may repay them** as the goal or purpose of **be gracious to me and raise me up**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order that I may repay them]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 41:11 (#1)

לֹא־יָרִיעַ אֹיְבִי עָלָי

“my enemy does not shout over me”

Here, **shout** represents “triumph.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent

expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my enemy does not triumph over me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 41:12 (#1)

וַאֲנִי

“And I”

The pronoun **I** refers to David. David places this pronoun at the front of the sentence for emphasis, contrasting himself with his enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [But as for me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 41:12 (#2)

בְּתֻמִּי

“in my integrity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **integrity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I am honest]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 41:12 (#3)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **to your face** represents being in front of or in the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 41:13 (#1)

בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה

“Blessed {be} Yahweh”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I bless Yahweh] or [Let us all praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 41:13 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the God of Israel”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form **the God of Israel** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control God. Rather the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the one whom Israel worships. Alternate translation: [who is the God whom Israel worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 41:13 (#3)

מֵהָעוֹלָם וְעַד הָעוֹלָם

“from the everlasting and unto the everlasting”

David is referring to all of time by naming two extremes, **from the everlasting** and **unto the everlasting**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from before time began and continuing forever]

See: Merism

Psalms - Chapter 42 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalms 42 and 43 were originally one psalm. They are presented that way in many Hebrew manuscripts and ancient versions. A repeated refrain joins them together. Psalm 43 has no superscription. This psalm was divided in two in the traditional Hebrew text probably to achieve a round total of 150 psalms. See the discussion of the numbering of the psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

Psalm 42–43 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It presents all the basic elements of that type of psalm. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. First stanza (42:1–4): Description of troubles and cry for help
2. First refrain (42:5): Statement of trust
3. Second stanza (42:6–10): Description of troubles and cry for help
4. Second refrain (42:11): Statement of trust
5. Third stanza (43:1–4): Petition and vow of praise
6. Third refrain (43:5): Statement of trust

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a "maskil." See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Why was a Levite worship leader far away from Jerusalem?
This psalm is one of nine psalms attributed to "the sons of Korah," that is, to the Korahite clan, the descendants of a Levite named Korah. The members of this clan had a special responsibility for leading the Israelites in worship. They played musical instruments and sang in the temple courtyard, and they composed songs. However, some of the later kings of Judah worshiped false gods represented by idols. They tried to suppress the worship of Yahweh. Prophets, worship leaders, and faithful believers in Yahweh often had to flee for their safety. The Korahite who wrote this psalm records that he had gone to the region in the far northeast of the territory of Israel where the Jordan River begins. This territory was contested between Israel and Aram, and at the time when this psalm was written, the Arameans may have controlled the location where the psalmist was. (In 43:1, he asks God to defend him from "a nation not faithful.") So in this psalm, he laments that he has had to flee from Jerusalem, where he joyfully led the people in worship, probably to foreign territory. But he encourages himself with the memory of those experiences, and he asks God to make it possible for him to return to the temple and worship him there once more.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Repeated phrases
In 42:10, for poetic effect, the psalmist uses some the same phrases that he uses in 42:3. Similarly for poetic effect, the psalmist uses in 43:2 some of the same phrases that he uses in 42:9. And the refrain in 42:5, 42:11, and 43:5 uses the same phrases in each case. To help your readers appreciate this, we recommend that you represent the same phrases in the same way in your translation.

Psalms 42:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 42:0 (#3)

מַשְׂכִּֽיל

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּֽיל"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 42:0 (#4)

לִבְנֵי־קֹֽרַח

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבְנֵי־קֹֽרַח"

The psalmist of this psalm belonged to a clan of the tribe of Levi whose members led the Israelites in worship and composed many worship songs. The superscription to this psalm describes them as if they were actual **sons** or first-generation descendants of **Korah**, who was a great-grandson of Levi. They were instead later descendants of Korah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of the descendants of Korah] or [of the Korahites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:1 (#1)

כְּאַיָּ֤ל תַּעֲרֹג֙ עַל־אֲפִיקֵ֣י מָ֔יִם כֵּ֚ן נַפְשִׁ֣י תַֽעֲרֹ֔ג אֵלֶ֖יךָ אֱלֹהִֽים

"As a deer pants for streams of water, so my soul pants for you, God"

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul** or inner being, to mean all of him in the act of desiring God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [As a deer pants for streams of water, so in my inner being I pant for you, God]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 42:1 (#2)

כְּאַיָּ֤ל תַּעֲרֹג֙ עַל־אֲפִיקֵ֣י מָ֔יִם כֵּ֚ן נַפְשִׁ֣י תַֽעֲרֹ֔ג אֵלֶ֖יךָ אֱלֹהִֽים

"As a deer pants for streams of water, so my soul pants for you, God"

The point of this comparison is that just as a **deer**, when it is very thirsty in a dry place, **pants** desperately for water, so the psalmist desperately desires God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make

this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [As a deer pants desperately for streams of water, so in my inner being I pant desperately for you, God]

See: Simile

Psalms 42:1 (#3)

כְּאַיָּל תַּעֲרֹג עַל־אֲפִיקֵי־מָיִם כֵּן נַפְשִׁי תַעֲרֹג אֵלֶיךָ אֱלֹהִים

“As a deer pants for streams of water, so my soul pants for you, God”

The psalmist is speaking as if his soul were actually panting or taking short, quick breaths. He means that in his inner being, he is desperately feeling and expressing a desire for God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [As a deer pants desperately for streams of water, so in my inner being I desperately desire you, God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:2 (#1)

צָמְאָה נַפְשִׁי ׀ לֵאלֹהִים֮

“My soul thirsts for God”

See how you translated the expression “my soul” in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [In my inner being, I thirst for God]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 42:2 (#2)

צָמְאָה נַפְשִׁי ׀ לֵאלֹהִים֮

“My soul thirsts for God”

The psalmist is speaking as if he felt physical thirst for God. He is using this image to depict his great desire for God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In my inner being, I feel a great desire for God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:2 (#3)

מָתַי אָבוֹא וְאֵרָאֶה פְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים

“When will I come and appear to the face of God”

The psalmist is using the question form to express a strong desire. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I want very much to come and appear to the face of God!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 42:2 (#4)

פְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים

“to the face of God”

Here, **face** represents “presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 42:2 (#5)

פְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים

“to the face of God”

As 42:4 and 43:4 suggest, the psalmist is speaking of coming into the presence of God to mean coming into God’s temple. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in God’s temple again]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 42:3 (#1)

הָיְתָה־לִּי דִמְעָתִי לֶחֶם

“My weeping is bread to me”

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to represent food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My weeping is my food]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 42:3 (#2)

הָיְתָה־לִּי דִמְעָתִי לֶחֶם

“My weeping is bread to me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were actually eating his **weeping**. He means that he has been weeping so much that he has been unable to eat. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Instead of eating, I have been weeping]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:3 (#3)

יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה

“day and night”

The psalmist is using the two main components of time, **day** and **night**, to mean all of time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the time]

See: Merism

Psalms 42:3 (#4)

בֶּאֱמֹ֣ר אֵלַ֣י

“in {their} saying to me”

The psalmist does not indicate specifically who has been **saying** what he quotes. To make clear that someone else, not the psalmist, has been saying this, the ULT supplies the indefinite pronoun **their**. It may be natural in your language to do something similar. You could also use a general expression. Alternate translation: [as they say to me] or [as people say to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 42:3 (#5)

כָּל־הַיּ֑וֹם

“all of the day”

The psalmist is saying **all the day** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [constantly]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 42:3 (#6)

אַיֵּ֥ה אֱלֹהֶ֗יךָ

“Where {is} your God”

The psalmist’s enemies are using the question form to mock him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your God certainly does not appear to be helping you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 42:4 (#1)

אֵ֤לֶּה אֶזְכְּרָ֨ה ׀ וְאֶשְׁפְּכָ֬ה עָלַ֗י ׀ נַפְשִׁ֑י

“Let me remember these, and let me pour out my soul within me”

The psalmist is using a verbal form that expresses a resolution. In your translation, use an appropriate verbal form to indicate this. Alternate translation: [I will remember these, and I will pour out my soul within me]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 42:4 (#2)

אֵ֤לֶּה אֶזְכְּרָ֨ה ׀ וְאֶשְׁפְּכָ֬ה עָלַ֗י ׀ נַפְשִׁ֑י

“Let me remember these, and let me pour out my soul within me”

The phrases **Let me remember these** and **let me pour out my soul within me** together express a single idea. The second phrase describes the circumstances under which the psalmist is encouraging himself to do what the first phrase describes. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [Let me remember these as I pour out my soul within me] or [I will remember these as I pour out my soul within me]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 42:4 (#3)

אֵ֤לֶּה

“these”

The psalmist is using the demonstrative adjective **these** as a noun to mean things of a certain kind, the things he describes in the rest of the verse Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the following things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 42:4 (#4)

וְאֶשְׁפְּכָ֬ה עָלַ֗י ׀ נַפְשִׁ֑י

“and let me pour out my soul within me”

The psalmist is speaking as if his **soul** were actually a liquid that he could **pour out**. He is encouraging himself to give full expression, in his own private reflections (**within me**), to what he is feeling deeply in his inner being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and let me fully express to myself what I am feeling deep inside] or [as I fully express to myself what I am feeling deep inside]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:4 (#5)

בַּסָּ֡דְךְ אֲדַדֵּ֤ם עַד־בֵּ֖בִית אֱלֹהִ֑ים בְּקוֹל־רִנָּ֥ה וְתוֹדָ֗ה הָמ֥וֹן חוֹגֵֽג

“with the crowd. I led them in procession to the house of God with a voice of rejoicing and praise, a multitude celebrating a festival”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put together the information that this **crowd** was **a multitude celebrating a festival**. Alternate translation: [with the crowd, a multitude celebrating a festival. I led them in procession to the house of God with a voice of rejoicing and praise]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 42:4 (#6)

בֵּ֣ית אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“the house of God”

See how you translated the term “house” in 5:7. Alternate translation: [the temple of God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:4 (#7)

בְּקוֹל־רִנָּ֥ה וְתוֹדָ֗ה

“with a voice of rejoicing and praise”

The psalmist is using the **voice** that each person in the **crowd** used for shouting to represent the shouts of the crowd. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with shouts of rejoicing and praise]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 42:5 (#1)

מַה־תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִ֣י נַפְשִׁי֮ וַתֶּהֱמִ֪י עָ֫לָ֥י

“Why have you bowed yourself down, my soul, and are clamoring within me”

The psalmist is speaking as if his **soul** had actually **bowed** itself **down** and as if it were actually **clamoring** or making noises **within** him that indicated how upset it was. He is describing his own inner feelings of despondency and agitation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why do I feel so despondent and agitated inside]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:5 (#2)

מַה־תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִ֣י נַפְשִׁי֮ וַתֶּהֱמִ֪י עָ֫לָ֥י

“Why have you bowed yourself down, my soul, and are clamoring within me”

The psalmist is using the question form to give himself a mild rebuke and to encourage himself to consider his situation from a different perspective and so come to feel differently about it. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I do not have to feel so despondent and agitated inside!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 42:5 (#3)

הוֹחִ֣ילִי לֵאלֹהִ֑ים

“Wait for God”

The word that the ULT translates as **Wait** can mean simply not to do something until a certain time has passed or a certain other event has occurred. However, in many biblical contexts, it means to expect that God will do something to change an unfavorable situation that a person cannot change or that a person therefore should not try to change himself, and that is the meaning here. You may be able to use a different term to express this meaning in your language. Alternate translation: [Hope in God] or [I can hope in God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 42:5 (#4)

כִּ֤י

“for”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [after all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 42:5 (#5)

יְשׁוּעֹ֖ת פָּנָ֣יו

“the salvation of his face”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation, following the alternative reading of the ancient Greek translation: [the one who saves my face] or [the savior of my face]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 42:5 (#6)

יְשׁוּעֹ֖ת פָּנָ֣יו

“the salvation of his face”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **face**, to mean all of him in the act of receiving God's salvation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation, following the alternative reading of the ancient Greek translation: [the one who saves me] or [my savior]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 42:5–6 (#1)

יְשׁוּעֹעוֹת פָּנָיו: אֱלֹהָי

"the salvation of his face.My God"

At the end of 42:5 and the beginning of 42:5, the ULT translates the traditional written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. It is different from the other two occurrences of the refrain of this psalm in 42:11 and 43:5. It appears that a verse division has been placed in the middle of a word, so that the prefix that means "and" in those two verses has become a suffix that means "his" in this verse. You may want to follow an alternative reading from the ancient Greek translation. Alternate translation: [the salvation of my face and my God]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 42:6 (#1)

אֱלֹהָי

"My God"

See the explanation in a note to the previous verse of how this expression was likely put at the start of this verse when a verse division was mistakenly placed in the middle of a word. You may wish to put this expression at the end of the previous verse, as many versions do, so that the refrain of this psalm will be the same in all three of its occurrences.

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 42:6 (#2)

עָלַי נַפְשִׁי תִשְׁתּוֹחָח

"my soul has bowed itself down within me"

See how you translated the similar expression in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [I do feel despondent]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:6 (#3)

וְהַֽרְמוֹנִים

"and the Hermons"

The psalmist may be using the plural term **Hermons** because: (1) Mount Hermon has three distinct peaks. Alternate translation: [and Mount Hermon] or (2) he is referring to the range of mountains that includes Mount Hermon. Alternate translation: [and the Hermon mountain range]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 42:6 (#4)

מֵהַר מִצְעָר

"from Mount Mizar"

Mount Mizar seems to have been the psalmist's specific location within the general area he describes in the earlier part of this verse. It is not known to what mountain he was referring, so it is not possible to associate it with a mountain that is known by another name today. We therefore recommend that you use the name Mount Mizar in your translation.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 42:7 (#1)

תְּהוֹם־אֶל־תְּהוֹם קוֹרֵא לְקוֹל צִנּוֹרֶיךָ

"Deep is calling to deep at the sound of your waterfalls"

The psalmist is speaking as if the **sound** of the **waterfalls** he hears in the nearby forming Jordan River were actually one **Deep** (one large mass of water) **calling** to another such **deep**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. You could also express this image as a comparison, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [The powerful streams in the river make loud, echoing sounds as they flow over rock ledges as waterfalls]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:7 (#2)

כָּל־מִשְׁבָּרֶיךָ וְגַלֶּיךָ עָלַי עָבָרוּ

"All of your breakers and your waves pass over me"

The terms **breakers** and **waves** mean similar things. The term **waves** describes swellings of water that move across the surface of the ocean, and the term **breakers** describes those swellings as they crash onto the shore. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [As your waves break on the shore, the surf pounds me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 42:7 (#3)

כָּל־מִשְׁבָּרֶיךָ וְגַלֶּיךָ עָלַי עָבָרוּ

“All of your breakers and your waves pass over me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were actually in an ocean or on its shore and strong **waves** and **breakers** were crashing over him, tossing him about. He is representing how overwhelmed he feels. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. You could also express this image as a comparison, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [I am feeling overwhelmed by what you have allowed to happen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:8 (#1)

יוֹמָם ׀ יְצַוֶּה יְהוָה ׀ חַסְדּוֹ וּבַלַּיְלָה שִׁירָה עִמִּי

“By} day, Yahweh commands his covenant faithfulness, and at night, his song {is} with me”

As in verse 3, the psalmist is using the two main components of time, **day** and **night**, to mean all of time. See how you translated the expression “day and night” in verse 3. It would be appropriate to use similar language here, since the psalmist’s recognition of Yahweh’s covenant faithfulness and his celebration of it in worship are his intentional responses to the sorrow he described earlier. Alternate translation: [Yahweh commands his covenant faithfulness all the time, and his song is with me all the time]

See: Merism

Psalms 42:8 (#2)

יְצַוֶּה יְהוָה ׀ חַסְדּוֹ

“Yahweh commands his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh acts toward me in a way that is faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 42:8 (#3)

שִׁירָה עִמִּי תְּפִלָּה

“his song {is} with me, a prayer”

Since the psalmist is referring to a continual activity, he is likely not referring to one specific **song** that expresses one specific **prayer**. He probably means all of the songs that Yahweh enables him to compose in order to sing prayers to him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [his songs are with me, prayers]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 42:8 (#4)

שִׁירָה עִמִּי תְּפִלָּה

“his song {is} with me, a prayer”

The psalmist is speaking of this **song** as if it were a living thing that could be **with** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he enables me to compose songs, prayers]

See: Personification

Psalms 42:8 (#5)

לְאֵל חַיָּי

“to the God of my life”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to indicate that it is **God** who has given him **life** and who preserves his life. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who has given me life] or [the God who preserves my life]

See: Possession

Psalms 42:9 (#1)

אוֹמְרָה

“Let me say”

As in 42:4, the psalmist is using a verbal form that expresses a resolution. See how you translated the similar form there. Alternate translation: [I will say]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 42:9 (#2)

סַלְעִי

“my rock”

See how you translated the term “rock” in 18:2. Alternate translation: [who keeps me safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:9 (#3)

לָמָּה שְׁכַחְתָּנִי לָמָּה־קֹדֵר אֵלֵךְ בְּלַחַץ אוֹיֵב

“Why have you forgotten me? Why do I walk about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his feelings to God honestly and urgently. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [You appear to have forgotten me! I should not have to walk about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 42:9 (#4)

לָמָּה & אֵלֵךְ

“Why do I walk about”

As in 15:2 and many other places in the Psalms, the psalmist may be using the term **walk** to mean “live.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why do I go through life] or [I should not have to go through life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:9 (#5)

בְּלַחַץ אוֹיֵב

“because of the oppression of the enemy”

As the next verse makes clear, the psalmist is not referring to a specific **enemy**. He means all of the enemies who are oppressing him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [because of the oppression of my enemies]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 42:9 (#6)

בְּלַחַץ אוֹיֵב

“because of the oppression of the enemy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **oppression**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because of the enemies who are oppressing me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 42:10 (#1)

בְּרֶצַח ׀ בְּעַצְמוֹתַי

“With crushing in my bones”

The psalmist is speaking as if his afflicters were actually **crushing** his **bones**, that is, so badly mistreating him physically that his bones were bruised or broken. He is using this image to represent the deeply painful effect of their **reproach**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In a way that penetrates very painfully into my inner being]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 42:10 (#2)

בְּאָמְרָם אֵלַי כָּל־הַיּוֹם אַיֵּה אֱלֹהֶיךָ

“in their saying to me all of the day, “Where is your God”

For poetic effect, the psalmist is using again the same phrases that he used in 42:3. We recommend that you show this to your readers by translating the phrases here the same way that you translated them there. Alternate translation: [as they say to me constantly, “Your God certainly does not appear to be helping you!”]

See: Poetry

Psalms 42:11 (#1)

מַה־תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי נַפְשִׁי ׀ וּמַה־תֶּהֱמִי עָלָי הוֹחִילִי לֵאלֹהִים
כִּי־עוֹד אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעוֹת פָּנַי וֵאלֹהָי

“Why have you bowed yourself down, my soul, and why are you clamoring within me? Wait for God, for I will again thank him, the salvation of my face and my God”

This is the second occurrence of the refrain in this psalm. We recommend that you show this to your readers by translating the phrases here the same way that you translated them in the first occurrence of this refrain in 42:5. Alternate translation: [I do not have to feel so despondent and agitated inside! I can hope in God. After all, I will again praise him, the one who saves me and who is my God]

See: Poetry

Psalms - Chapter 43 Introduction

Psalms 42 and 43 were originally one psalm. For an introduction to what is now Psalm 43, see the introduction to Psalm 42, which discusses both psalms together.

Psalms 43:1 (#1)

שָׁפְטֵנִי אֱלֹהִים ׀ וְרִיבָה רִיבִי

“Vindicate me, God, and plead my plea”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were actually in a legal proceeding and wanted God to take his side, as if he were a judge who would **Vindicate** him or a defense attorney who would **plead** his case. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Recognize that I am innocent and defend me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 43:1 (#2)

וְרִיבָ֥ה רִיבִ֑י

“and plead my plea”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. If you decide to retain the legal image in your translation, you may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and plead my case]

See: Poetry

Psalms 43:1 (#3)

מֵאִ֣ישׁ־מִרְמָ֣ה וְעַוְלָ֣ה

“from a deceitful and unjust man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means all of the people who are acting in a **deceitful** and **unjust** way toward him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [from these deceitful and unjust people] or [from every deceitful and unjust person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 43:2 (#1)

כִּ֤י

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 43:2 (#2)

אַתָּ֣ה ׀ אֱלֹהֵ֣י מָעוּזִ֑י

“you {are} the God of my refuge”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **God** as being like a **refuge** for him. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you are the God who is like a refuge to me]

See: Possession

Psalms 43:2 (#3)

אַתָּ֣ה ׀ אֱלֹהֵ֣י מָעוּזִ֑י

“you {are} the God of my refuge”

See how you translated the term “refuge” in 11:1. Alternate translation: [you are the God who protects me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 43:2 (#4)

לָ֤מָּה זְנַחְתָּ֙נִי֙ לָ֣מָּה־קֹדֵ֔ר אֶתְהַלֵּ֖ךְ בְּלַ֣חַץ אוֹיֵֽב

“Why have you rejected me? Why do I walk about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy”

See how you translated the similar questions in 42:9. Alternate translation: [You appear to have rejected me! I should not have to walk about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 43:2 (#5)

לָ֣מָּה־קֹדֵ֔ר אֶתְהַלֵּ֖ךְ בְּלַ֣חַץ אוֹיֵֽב

“Why do I walk about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy”

For poetic effect, the psalmist is using again the same phrases that he used in 42:9. We recommend that you show this to your readers by translating the phrases here the same way that you translated them there. Alternate translation: [I should not have to go through life mourning because of the enemies who are oppressing me!]

See: Poetry

Psalms 43:2 (#6)

לָ֣מָּה & אֶתְהַלֵּ֖ךְ

“Why do I walk about”

While the psalmist uses essentially the same language here as in 42:9, he uses a different form of the verb translated as **walk**. The form used here can indicate repeated action, and that seems to be the sense in this context. Your language may have a comparable verbal form that you can use in your translation. If not,

you may be able to use a different verb or expression. Alternate translation: [Why do I wander about]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 43:3 (#1)

שְׁלַח־אוֹרְךָ֥ וַאֲמִתֶּ֑ךָ הֵ֥מָּה יַנְחֻ֝נִ֗י יְבִיאֻ֥נִי

“Send out your light and your faithfulness, them, let them lead me. Let them bring me”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s **light** and **truth** as if they were living things that God could **Send out** and that could **lead** the psalmist and **bring** him home. By **your light**, the psalmist probably means “the light of your face,” as in 4:6. This represents God’s favor, as if God were smiling and looking brightly at someone. By **faithfulness**, the psalmist probably means God’s covenant faithfulness, as in 42:8, that is, God’s commitment to fulfill the promises he has made to help people who are loyal to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Extend your favor and faithfulness to me, and exhibit those qualities as you lead me. Exhibit those qualities in order to bring me]

See: Personification

Psalms 43:3 (#2)

הֵ֥מָּה יַנְחֻ֝נִ֗י

“them, let them lead me”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **them** separately, even though the verb translated as **let them lead me** already includes this meaning. He is doing this because he is speaking of God’s **light** and **faithfulness** as if they were people and he wants to emphasize the personal role that he would like these qualities to take. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [let them be the ones who lead me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 43:3 (#3)

אֶל־הַ֥ר־קָ֝דְשְׁךָ֗

“to the mountain of your holiness”

The psalmist is not using the possessive form to ascribe **holiness** to the mountain where God’s **dwellings** are located. Instead, he is using the possessive form to indicate that God consecrated or set apart this mountain as a place where he would dwell, that is, where he would be present in a special way in his temple. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this purpose, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to the mountain that you have set apart] or [to the mountain that you have consecrated]

See: Possession

Psalms 43:3 (#4)

מִשְׁכְּנוֹתֶֽיךָ

“your dwellings”

The psalmist is using the plural form **dwellings** where he could have used the singular form, since the context indicates that he is referring to the temple in Jerusalem (“the house of God,” 42:4, the location of “the altar of God,” 43:4). This suggests that he is using the plural form to emphasize the magnificence of the temple and especially its sacred character as a place where God is present in a special way. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [your sacred temple]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 43:4 (#1)

מִזְבַּ֤ח אֱלֹהִ֨ים ׀ אֶל־אֵ֤ל שִׂמְחַת֙ גִּ֣ילִ֔י

“the altar of God, to the God of the joy of my gladness”

The psalmist is speaking of God in the third person even though he is addressing him directly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the second person. Alternate translation: [to your altar, O God, to you, the God of the joy of my gladness]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 43:4 (#2)

אֵ֤ל שִׂמְחַת֙ גִּ֣ילִ֔י

“the God of the joy of my gladness”

The psalmist is using the possessive expression **the joy of my gladness** to describe **joy** that is characterized by **gladness**, that is, great joy. He is using the fuller possessive expression **the God of the joy of my gladness** to describe God as the one who gives him this great joy. If a speaker of your language would not use possessive forms for these purposes, you could express these ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who gives me great joy]

See: Possession

Psalms 43:5 (#1)

מַה־תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי נַפְשִׁי וּמַה־תֶּהֱמִי עָלָי הוֹחִילִי לֵאלֹהִים כִּי־עוֹד אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעוֹת פָּנָיו וֵאלֹהָי

"Why have you bowed yourself down, my soul, and why are you clamoring within me? Wait for God, for I will again thank him, the salvation of my face and my God"

This is the third occurrence of the refrain in this psalm. We recommend that you show this to your readers by translating the phrases here the same way that you translated them in the first two occurrences of this refrain in 42:5 and 42:11. Alternate translation: [I do not have to feel so despondent and agitated inside! I can hope in God. After all, I will again praise him, the one who saves me and who is my God]

See: Poetry

Psalms - Chapter 44 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 44 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It presents most of the basic elements of that type of psalm, but in a different order than is common. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Statement of trust (1–8) including a short petition (4b)
2. Description of troubles (9–16, 22, 25)
3. Claim of innocence (17–21)
4. Cry for help (23–24)
5. Petition (25)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a "maskil." See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

If God had "scattered" the people "among the nations" (v. 11), how did they still have "armies" (v. 9)? It seems likely that this psalm was written not after the people of Judah had been deported to Babylon but while they were still in their land, ruled by a godly king, but suffering military defeats that led to some of their cities being conquered and the people of those cities being taken away into exile. One plausible historical setting for the composition of the psalm is the reign of Hezekiah, specifically during the invasion by the Assyrian king Sennacherib in 701 B.C. Hezekiah was an exceptionally godly king, which would correspond with the psalmist's statement that "we have not forgotten you, and we have not dealt falsely with your covenant" (v. 17). Nevertheless, the invading Assyrians repeatedly defeated the Judean defenders. They conquered most of the fortified cities in Judah and deported their inhabitants. This would correspond with the psalmist's complaint to God that "you do not go out with our armies" (v. 9) and "you have scattered us among the nations" (v. 11). Hezekiah's godliness, reforms, and previous military victories are described in 2 Kings 18:1–8. The Assyrian invasion is described in 2 Kings 18:9–19:34. And the defeat of the Assyrians by God's miraculous power, which would be an answer to this psalmist's prayer if that is the historical setting, is described in 2 Kings 19:35–37.

Psalms 44:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 44:0 (#3)

מַשְׂכִּיל

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 44:0 (#4)

לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח"

See how you translated the expression "the sons of Korah" in the superscription to Psalm 42. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Korah] or [the Korahites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:1 (#1)

בְּאָזְנֵינוּ שָׁמַעְנוּ אֱלֹהִים אֲבוֹתֵינוּ סִפְּרוּ־לָנוּ

“we have heard with our ears, our fathers have recounted to us”

Here and throughout this psalm, the psalmist is applying the terms **we**, **our**, and **us** to himself and his fellow Judeans but not to God, to whom he is speaking. So use the exclusive forms of those terms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Psalms 44:1 (#2)

בְּאָזְנֵינוּ שָׁמַעְנוּ

“we have heard with our ears”

It might seem that the expression **with our ears** adds extra information to this statement that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you may choose not to represent this expression in your translation. However, it does add some emphasis, and you may also choose to reflect that emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [we have heard] or [we have clearly heard]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 44:1 (#3)

אֲבוֹתֵינוּ

“our fathers”

See how you translated the term “fathers” in 22:4. Alternate translation: [our forefathers]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:1 (#4)

פֹּעַל פָּעַלְתָּ

“the work you worked”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [the work you did]

See: Poetry

Psalms 44:1 (#5)

בְּיָמֵיהֶם

“in their days”

The psalmist is using the term **days** to mean “time,” since time consists of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in their time]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:1 (#6)

בְּיָמֵיהֶם

“in their days”

The **fathers** or ancestors who **recounted** the **work** described in verses 2 and 3 did not experience it personally. The psalmist is using them generally to represent earlier generations of Israelites and specifically to represent the generation that conquered and occupied the land of Canaan. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for the generation that conquered and occupied the land of Canaan]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:1 (#7)

בִּימֵי קֶדֶם

“in the days of antiquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **antiquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in ancient times]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 44:2 (#1)

אַתָּה & הוֹרַשְׁתָּ

“You, you drove out”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **You** separately, even though the verb translated as **you drove out** already includes this meaning. He is doing that in order to emphasize a contrast between what the Israelites did not do, as described in the next verse, and what God did. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [You were the one who drove out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 44:2 (#2)

יָדְךָ

“by} your hand”

Here, **hand** represents “power.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:2 (#3)

וַתִּטָּעֵם & וְתְשַׁלְּחֵם

“but you planted them & but you sent them”

In each case, the pronoun **them** refers to the “fathers” or ancestors of the Israelites mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [but you planted our ancestors ... but you sent our ancestors]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 44:2 (#4)

וַתִּטָּעֵם

“but you planted them”

The psalmist is speaking as if God had actually **planted** the Israelites in the land of Canaan, as if they had been plants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but you settled our ancestors there]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:2 (#5)

וְתְשַׁלְּחֵם

“but you sent them”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [but you sent them into the land] or [but you sent our ancestors into the land]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 44:2 (#6)

וְתְשַׁלְּחֵם

“but you sent them”

While it is true that God **sent** the Israelites into the land of Canaan in the sense that he commanded them to go there, the sense here seems to be that God actively propelled them into the land by helping them. That was in contrast to the way he **caused harm** to the nations he drove out. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 44:3 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but a complementary truth by way of concession. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Indeed,] or [Admittedly,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 44:3 (#2)

בְחַרְבָּם

“with their sword”

The psalmist is using one kind of weapon, a **sword**, to mean weapons in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with their weapons] or [militarily]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 44:3 (#3)

וּזְרוֹעָם֮

“and their arm”

Here, **arm** represents “power.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and their own power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:3 (#4)

כִּֽי־יְמִינְךָ֤ וּזְרוֹעֲךָ֨ וְאוֹר֙ פָּנֶ֔יךָ כִּֽי רִצִּיתָֽם

“but your right hand and your arm and the light of your face, for you favored them”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [but your right hand and your arm and the light of your face saved them, for you favored them]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 44:3 (#5)

כִּי־יְמִינְךָ וּזְרוֹעֲךָ וְאוֹר פָּנֶיךָ כִּי רִצִּיתָם

“but your right hand and your arm and the light of your face, for you favored them”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [but because you favored them, your right hand and your arm and the light of your face saved them]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 44:3 (#6)

כִּי־יְמִינְךָ וּזְרוֹעֲךָ

“but your right hand and your arm”

In this context, the terms **right hand** and **arm** mean similar things, since they both represent power. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [but your very strong power]

See: Doublet

Psalms 44:3 (#7)

וְאוֹר פָּנֶיךָ

“and the light of your face”

The **light** of God’s **face** represents his favor, as if he were smiling and looking brightly at someone. See how you translated the similar expression in 4:6. Alternate translation: [and the favor you showed them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:4 (#1)

אַתָּה־הוּא מַלְכִּי

“You {are} he, my king”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** for clarity and emphasis. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [You are the one who is my king]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 44:4 (#2)

מַלְכִּי

“my king”

Since the psalmist uses first-person plural pronouns throughout most of this psalm, you may wish to use one here, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [our king]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 44:4 (#3)

צַוֵּה יְשׁוּעוֹת יַעֲקֹב

“Command the salvation of Jacob”

The psalmist is speaking of the **salvation of Jacob** as if it were a living thing that God could **Command**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Bring about the salvation of Jacob]

See: Personification

Psalms 44:4 (#4)

צַוֵּה יְשׁוּעוֹת יַעֲקֹב

“Command the salvation of Jacob”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Act to save Jacob]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 44:4 (#5)

צַוֵּה

“Command”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please command]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 44:4 (#6)

יַעֲקֹב

“Jacob”

The psalmist is using the name **Jacob** to represent the Israelite people, who were descendants of a man named Jacob. God gave him the name Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [us Israelites]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:5 (#1)

נְנַגֵּחַ & נָבְוּס

“we gore & we trample”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Israelite army were actually a horned animal that would **gore** and **trample** an opposing army as if it were another animal. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we push back ... we defeat]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:5 (#2)

בְּשִׁמְךָ

“by your name”

In this context, God’s **name** seems to represent his authority. The psalmist seems to mean that since God assigned the land of Canaan to the Israelites, when they fight to defend that territory, they are doing so on his authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by your authority]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:5 (#3)

קָמֵינוּ

“the ones arising {against} us”

The psalmist is speaking of the **adversaries** of Israel as if they were physically **arising** to a higher elevation. See how you translated the similar expression in 18:48. Alternate translation: [the ones attacking us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:6 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

As in verse 3, here the word **For** introduces not a reason but a complementary truth. Alternate translation: [Indeed,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 44:6 (#2)

לֹא בְקַשְׁתִּי אֶבְטָח וְחַרְבִּי לֹא תוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“I do not trust in my bow, and my sword does not save me”

The psalmist is using two kinds of weapons, his **bow** and his **sword**, to mean weapons in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I do not rely on my weapons, no, those weapons do not save me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 44:6 (#3)

לֹא בְקַשְׁתִּי אֶבְטָח וְחַרְבִּי לֹא תוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“I do not trust in my bow, and my sword does not save me”

If you decided to use first-person plural pronouns in verse 4, you may wish to do that here as well. Alternate translation: [We do not trust in our bows, and our swords do not save us] or [We do not rely on our weapons, no, those weapons do not save us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 44:6 (#4)

וְחַרְבִּי לֹא תוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“and my sword does not save me”

The psalmist is speaking of his **sword** as if it were a living thing that could **save** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I do not win victories with my sword]

See: Personification

Psalms 44:8 (#1)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“all of the day”

The psalmist is saying **all of the day** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [continually]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 44:8 (#2)

וְשִׁמְךָ נוֹדֶה &

“and we will praise your name”

In this context, God’s **name** seems to represent his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and we will praise your reputation] or [and we will praise you for who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:8 (#3)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

See how your translation team decided at 3:2 to represent the term “Selah.”

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 44:9 (#1)

וְלֹא־תֵצֵ֥א בְצִבְאוֹתֵ֗ינוּ

“and you do not go out with our armies”

The psalmist is speaking as if God would previously **go out** physically with the Israelite **armies**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you no longer help our armies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:10 (#1)

תְּשִׁיבֵ֣נוּ אָ֭חוֹר מִנִּי־צָ֑ר

“You make us turn back from the enemy”

The psalmist may not mean to say that God is actively opposing the Judeans. He may be describing the consequences of God no longer helping them. Alternate translation: [You oblige us to turn back from the enemy]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 44:10 (#2)

לָמוֹ

“for themselves”

In this context, the expression **for themselves** has the sense of “as they wish” or “at will,” that is, without any resistance. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [at will]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 44:11 (#1)

כְּצֹ֣אן מַ֭אֲכָל

“like sheep of food”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **sheep** that are characterized by being slaughtered and eaten as **food**. In context, the emphasis seems to be on the slaughtering, as the parallel phrase “sheep of slaughter” in verse 22 indicates. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [like sheep that are slaughtered]

See: Possession

Psalms 44:11 (#2)

כְּצֹ֣אן מַ֭אֲכָל

“like sheep of food”

The point of this comparison is that just as **sheep** that people slaughter for **food** are very vulnerable and easily killed, so the Judeans have become very vulnerable. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. The point of comparison is the same in verse 22. Alternate translation: [very vulnerable, like sheep that are slaughtered]

See: Simile

Psalms 44:12 (#1)

וְלֹ֣א־רִ֭בִּיתָ

“and you have not increased”

The psalmist means that God has not become greater in terms of wealth. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and you have not increased in wealth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 44:13 (#1)

תְּשִׂימֵ֣נוּ חֶ֭רְפָּה לִשְׁכֵנֵ֑ינוּ לַ֥עַג וָ֝קֶ֗לֶס לִסְבִיבוֹתֵ֥ינוּ

“You have made us a reproach to our neighbors, a scorn and a derision to {those} around us”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [You have made us a reproach to our neighbors, and you have made us a scorn and a derision to the ones around us]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 44:13 (#2)

תְּשִׂימֵ֣נוּ חֶ֭רְפָּה לִשְׁכֵנֵ֑ינוּ לַ֥עַג וָ֝קֶ֗לֶס לִסְבִיבוֹתֵ֥ינוּ

“You have made us a reproach to our neighbors, a scorn and a derision to {those} around us”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **reproach**, **scorn**, and **derision**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate trans-

lation: [You have given our neighbors occasion to reproach us, and you have given the ones around us occasion to scorn and deride us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 44:13 (#3)

תְּשִׂימֵמֵנוּ חֶרְפָּה לִשְׁכֵנֵינוּ לַעַג וָקֶלֶס

“You have made us a reproach to our neighbors, a scorn and a derision”

The psalmist does not mean that God has made the Judeans something that causes **reproach** to their **neighbors**. He means that they have become an object of their neighbors’ reproach. He means the same thing when he uses the terms **scorn** and **derision**. If you retain these abstract nouns in your translation, you could indicate this explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You have made us an object of reproach to our neighbors, an object of scorn and derision]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 44:14 (#1)

מָנוֹד־רֹאשׁ בַּל־אֻמִּים

“a shaking of the head among the peoples”

In this culture, shaking or wagging one’s head at a person or group was a symbolic action by which people showed contempt and expressed mockery toward that person or group. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [a group at which individuals among the peoples shake their heads contemptuously]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 44:15 (#1)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם כְּלִמָּתִי נֶגְדִּי

“All of the day my disgrace {is} before me”

See how you translated the phrase “all of the day” in 44:8. Alternate translation: [My disgrace is continually before me]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 44:15 (#2)

כְּלִמָּתִי נֶגְדִּי וּבֹשֶׁת פָּנַי כִּסָּתְנִי

“my disgrace {is} before me, and the shame of my face covers me”

If you decided to use first-person plural pronouns in verses 4 and 6, you may wish to do that here as well. Alternate translation: [our disgrace is before us, and the shame of our faces covers us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 44:15 (#3)

כְּלִמָּתִי נֶגְדִּי

“my disgrace {is} before me”

The psalmist is speaking as if his **disgrace** were actually an object that was **before** or in front of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am aware of my disgrace]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:15 (#4)

וּבֹשֶׁת פָּנַי כִּסָּתְנִי

“and the shame of my face covers me”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **face**, to mean all of him in the act of being ashamed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my shame covers me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 44:15 (#5)

וּבֹשֶׁת פָּנַי כִּסָּתְנִי

“and the shame of my face covers me”

The psalmist is speaking as if **shame** were physically covering him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the shame of my face overwhelms me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:15 (#6)

וּבֹשֶׁת פָּנַי כִּסָּתְנִי

“and the shame of my face covers me”

Hebrew culture associated **shame** with the **face**. If your culture does the same thing, you may wish to retain the figurative usage in your translation and express this in terms that the people of your culture would use. Alternate translation: [I have lost face, and shame overwhelms me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:16 (#1)

מִפְּנֵי

“from the face of”

Here, **face** represents “presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:16 (#2)

אֹויֵ֥ב וּמִתְנַקֵּם

“an enemy and one avenging”

Together, the expressions **an enemy** and **one avenging** express a single idea. The expression **one avenging** tells what kind of **enemy** the psalmist is describing. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [a vengeful enemy]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 44:17 (#1)

כָּל־זֹ֣את בָּ֭אָתְנוּ

“All of this has come {to} us”

The psalmist is speaking of the misfortunes he has described as if they were a living thing that could have **come** to the Judeans. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation, as in the UST: [All of this has happened to us]

See: Personification

Psalms 44:17 (#2)

וְלֹ֣א שְׁכַחֲנ֑וּךָ

“but we have not forgotten you”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Judeans might actually have **forgotten** their God, that is, ceased to have remember anything about him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. The meaning is similar in verse 20. Alternate translation: [but we have not neglected to worship you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:17 (#3)

וְלֹא־שִׁ֝קַּ֗רְנוּ בִּבְרִיתֶֽךָ

“and we have not dealt falsely with your covenant”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s **covenant** as if it were a person with whom the Judeans could have **dealt falsely**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and we have not dealt falsely with you by not keeping your covenant]

See: Personification

Psalms 44:18 (#1)

לֹא־נָ֭סֹג אָחֹ֑ור לִבֵּ֝֗נוּ

“Our heart has not turned itself back”

The psalmist is using one part of the Judeans, their **heart**, to mean all of them in the act of remaining loyal to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We have not turned ourselves back]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 44:18 (#2)

לֹא־נָ֭סֹג אָחֹ֑ור לִבֵּ֝֗נוּ

“Our heart has not turned itself back”

The term **heart** is singular in form, but it refers to the hearts of all of the Judeans. If you retain the image of the heart, if it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of that word. Alternate translation: [Our hearts have not turned themselves back]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 44:18 (#3)

לֹא־נָ֭סֹג אָחֹ֑ור לִבֵּ֝֗נוּ

“Our heart has not turned itself back”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Judeans were physically following God and had not **turned** to go in the opposite direction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We are still loyal to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:18 (#4)

לֹא־נָ֭סֹג אָחֹ֑ור לִבֵּ֝֗נוּ

“Our heart has not turned itself back”

The psalmist is using one part of the Judeans, their **steps**, to mean all of them in the act of remaining loyal to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and we have not turned aside from your way]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 44:18 (#5)

וַתֵּט אֲשֻׁרֵינוּ מִנְּגִי אָרְחֶךָ

“nor have our steps turned aside from your way”

The psalmist is speaking as if how God wants people to live were a **way** or path on which people were supposed to walk. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [nor have we stopped living as you want us to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:19 (#1)

בִּמְקוֹם תַּנִּים

“into a place of jackals”

The psalmist is using the phrase **a place of jackals** to represent a desolate area where only wild animals live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [so that our land is now desolate]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:19 (#2)

תַּנִּים

“jackals”

The term **jackals** describes wild dogs that live in desolate regions. If your readers would not be familiar with what a jackal is, in your translation you could use the name of a similar animal that your readers would recognize, or you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [wild dogs]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 44:19 (#3)

וַתְּכַסֵּנוּ בְּצַלְמָוֶת

“and you have covered over us with a dark shadow”

The psalmist is speaking as if God had actually **covered** the Judeans with a **dark shadow**. He means that God has allowed them to be in a situation in which they are in great danger of death. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you have brought us into a situation of mortal peril]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:20 (#1)

אִם־שָׁכַחְנוּ שֵׁם אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“If we had forgotten the name of our God”

In this context, **the name of our God** represents calling on God by name. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [If we had ceased to call on our God by name] or [If we had ceased to worship our God explicitly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:20 (#2)

וַנִּפְרֹשׂ כַּפֵּינוּ

“and spread out our palms”

The psalmist is using the action of spreading out one’s **palms** toward the sky to represent prayer, since that was the characteristic posture of prayer in this culture. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and prayed]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 44:20–21 (#1)

אִם־שָׁכַחְנוּ שֵׁם אֱלֹהֵינוּ וַנִּפְרֹשׂ כַּפֵּינוּ לְאֵ֣ל זָ֑ר׃ הֲלֹ֥א אֱ֝לֹהִ֗ים
יַחְקָר־זֹ֑את כִּי־ה֥וּא יֹ֝דֵ֗עַ תַּעֲלֻמ֥וֹת לֵֽב

“If we had forgotten the name of our God and spread out our palms to a foreign god,would God not have discovered this? For he is knowing the secrets of the heart”

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine 44:20 and 44:21 into a verse bridge and put the last phrase in verse 21 at the beginning of verse 20, since it gives the reason for the result that the material in the rest of these verses describes. Alternate translation: [Since our God knows the secrets of the heart, if we had forgotten his name and spread out our palms to a foreign god, would he not have discovered this?]

See: Verse Bridges

Psalms 44:21 (#1)

הֲלֹ֥א אֱ֝לֹהִ֗ים יַחְקָר־זֹ֑את

“would God not have discovered this”

The psalmist is using the question form to make a strong affirmation. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclama-

tion. Alternate translation: [God would certainly have discovered this!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 44:21 (#2)

תַּעֲלֵמְוֹת לֵב

“the secrets of the heart”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s private thoughts and memories. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the things that people do but do not tell others about]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:22 (#1)

הֹרַגְנוּ

“we are killed”

The expression **are killed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [our enemies are killing us]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 44:22 (#2)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“all of the day”

See how you translated the same expression in 44:8. Alternate translation: [continually]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 44:22 (#3)

נֶחְשַׁבְנוּ

“we are considered”

The expression **are considered** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [our enemies consider us]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 44:23 (#1)

עִוּרָה ׀ לָמָּה תִישַׁן ׀ אֲדֹנָי הָקִיצָה

“Awake! Why are you sleeping, Lord? Wake up”

The psalmist is using the question form as a rebuke. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Awake! You should not be sleeping, Lord! Wake up!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 44:23 (#2)

עִוּרָה ׀ לָמָּה תִישַׁן ׀ אֲדֹנָי הָקִיצָה

“Awake! Why are you sleeping, Lord? Wake up”

The psalmist is speaking as if God were actually **sleeping** and therefore unaware of or unconcerned about the Judeans’ situation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take action! You should not do nothing while we are in such danger! Help us!]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:23 (#3)

אַל־תִּזְנַח

“Do not reject {us”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a request rather than a command. (By contrast, the imperatives **Awake** and **Wake up** are urgent summonses rather than requests.) Use a form in your language that communicates a request. Alternate translation: [Please do not reject us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 44:24 (#1)

לָמָּה־פָנֶיךָ תַסְתִּיר תִּשְׁכַּח עָנְיֵנוּ וְלַחֲצֵנוּ

“Why do you hide your face, forget our affliction and our oppression”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Why do you hide your face, and why do you forget our affliction and our oppression]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 44:24 (#2)

לָמָּה־פָנֶיךָ תַסְתִּיר תִּשְׁכַּח עָנְיֵנוּ וְלַחֲצֵנוּ

“Why do you hide your face, forget our affliction and our oppression”

As in the previous verse, the psalmist is using the question form as a rebuke. If a speaker of your

language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not hide your face, and you should not forget our affliction and our oppression!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 44:24 (#3)

לָמָּה־פָנֶיךָ תַסְתִּיר תִּשְׁכַּח

“Why do you hide your face, forget”

The psalmist is speaking as if God had actually hidden his **face** so that the Judeans could not see it. He means that it is as if God had turned his face away from the Judeans rather than looking at them with a bright expression that indicated favor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why do you not regard us with favor] or [Please regard us with favor, and do not forget]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:24 (#4)

תִּשְׁכַּח

“forget”

The psalmist is speaking as if God had once known about the **affliction** and **oppression** of the Judeans but had now forgotten about them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [neglect to do anything about]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:25 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the psalmist is using the word **For** to introduce a reason why God should help the Judeans. Alternate translation: [Help us because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 44:25 (#2)

שָׁחָה לֶעָפָר נַפְשֵׁנוּ דָּבְקָה לָאָרֶץ בִּטְנֵנוּ

“our soul has sunk down into the dust, our belly clings to the earth”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Judeans had physically fallen onto the **earth** and could not get up and as if their **soul** or inner being had similarly **sunk down into the dust**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We have no physical strength left, as if we had fallen down and could not get up, and we have no strength in our inner beings either, as if they had collapsed into the dust]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:25 (#3)

שָׁחָה & נַפְשֵׁנוּ דָּבְקָה & בִּטְנֵנוּ

“our soul has sunk down & our belly clings”

In this verse, the words **soul** and **belly** are singular in form, but they refer to the souls and bellies of all of the Judeans. If you retain the images that the psalmist is using, if it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural forms of these words. Alternate translation: [our souls have sunk ... our bellies cling]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 44:25 (#4)

דָּבְקָה לָאָרֶץ בִּטְנֵנוּ

“our belly clings to the earth”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **belly**, to mean all of him in the act of clinging to the **earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our bodies cling to the earth]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 44:25 (#5)

דָּבְקָה לָאָרֶץ בִּטְנֵנוּ

“our belly clings to the earth”

The psalmist is speaking as if each Judean’s **belly** or body were actually clinging to the **earth**. He means that it is as if each Judean had fallen and could not get up. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our bodies have fallen to the earth and we cannot get up]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 44:26 (#1)

קוּמָה עֶזְרָתָה לָּנוּ וּפְדֵנוּ לְמַעַן חַסְדֶּךָ

“Arise {as} a helper to us and redeem us because of your covenant faithfulness”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first

phrase describes. Alternate translation: [because of your covenant faithfulness, arise as a helper to us and redeem us]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 44:26 (#2)

קוּמָה

“Arise”

The psalmist assumes that God will understand that by **Arise**, he means “Take action.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Take action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 44:26 (#3)

קוּמָה

“Arise”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please take action]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 44:26 (#4)

לְמַעַן חַסְדֶּךָ

“because of your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in order to be faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 45 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 45 is a royal psalm written for a king’s wedding day. At the same time, it is a Messianic psalm that looks forward to the reign of Jesus Christ. Hebrews 1:8–9 applies Psalm 45:6–7 to Jesus. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. The psalmist’s self-introduction (1)
2. Praise for the king as God’s representative who maintains justice (2–8)
3. Transition from the king to the bride (9)
4. Exhortation to the king’s bride (10–17)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “maskil.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Whose wedding was this?
Psalm 45 is a royal wedding song for a historical king, composed for an actual court marriage. This king was probably a descendant of David, and he was certainly loyal to Yahweh, but the psalmist does not name him, so it is uncertain exactly which king he is describing. The exalted language about the king’s eternal throne and perfectly just rule has led both ancient and modern interpreters to see this psalm as deliberately shaped to point beyond that occasion to God’s ultimate King. Because Hebrews 1:8–9 applies Psalm 45:6–7 to Christ, both Jewish and Christian traditions have often treated the psalm as Messianic, seeing the historical king and his bride as a type or foreshadowing of the ultimate King and his people. So we recommend that you not suggest in a note or in the text of your translation for which king the psalmist may have composed this wedding song.

Why does the psalmist call the king “God” in verse 6?
As a note to this verse suggests, the Hebrew term that is often translated as “God” in other contexts was also a respectful form of address for judges. Since this verse speaks of the king as upholding justice, that title would be appropriate for him in this context. That is one likely explanation of why the psalmist uses this term. However, other interpreters suggest that the phrase “Your throne, God” could mean “Your throne of God,” that is, “your divinely ordained throne.” Translators might represent this as “The kingdom that God has given you.” One other possibility is that the psalmist could be addressing God directly but briefly in this sentence and then returning to address the king through the end of verse 9, after which he addresses the bride. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to follow the interpretation that it does. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to follow the interpretation suggested in these notes.

Psalms 45:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some

languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 45:0 (#3)

מַשְׂכִּיל

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל”

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 45:0 (#4)

לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח”

See how you translated the expression “the sons of Korah” in the superscription to Psalm 42. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Korah] or [the Korahites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:0 (#5)

שִׁשַּׁיר יְדִידֹת

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שִׁשַּׁיר יְדִידֹת”

The superscription to this wedding psalm uses the plural form **loves** to refer to the love of the king for his new wife and the love of the queen for her new husband. It may be more natural in your language to use the singular form. Alternate translation: [A love song]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 45:1 (#1)

רָחַשׁ לִבִּי ׀ דָּבָר טוֹב

“My heart boils over {with} a good matter”

The verb that the ULT translates as **boils over** occurs only here in the Bible, but it comes from the same root as a term for a pot or cauldron, so that seems to be its meaning. However, in this context, the focus is not on the heat that causes a liquid to boil. It is on the way a boiling liquid may overflow from a pot. Particularly if your language and culture associate heat with anger, it may be helpful to express the general meaning in order not to suggest that the psalmist is angry. Alternate translation: [My heart overflows with a good matter]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 45:1 (#2)

רָחַשׁ לִבִּי ׀ דָּבָר טוֹב

“My heart boils over {with} a good matter”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My mind overflows with a good matter] or [My thoughts about a good matter are overflowing]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:1 (#3)

רָחַשׁ לִבִּי ׀ דָּבָר טוֹב

“My heart boils over {with} a good matter”

The psalmist is speaking as if his **heart** (his mind) were actually overflowing with the **matter** he will describe in this psalm. He means that he finds his subject so inspiring that he cannot contain his thoughts about it; that is, he must speak out loud what he thinks about it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. (See the further discussion of this in the introduction to this psalm.) Alternate translation: [My subject is so inspiring that I must express my thoughts about it aloud]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:1 (#4)

אֹמֵר אֲנִי

“I am reciting”

The psalmist says **I am reciting** because he has already begun to sing his composition. However, since he is referring to the part of it that will follow, in some languages it may be more natural to use a verb in the future tense here. Alternate translation: [I will recite]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 45:1 (#5)

מַעֲשַׂי

“my works”

The psalmist is using the plural term **works** to refer to the many elements he has incorporated into this song. In some languages it may be more natural to

use a singular term to refer to his entire composition. Alternate translation: [my work] or [my composition]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 45:1 (#6)

לְמֶ֫לֶךְ

“to the king”

The phrase that the ULT translates as **to the king** may indicate: (1) that the psalmist is performing this song for the king and directing it to him. The ULT reflects this meaning. (2) that the psalmist has composed this song about the king. Alternate translation: [about the king]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 45:1 (#7)

לְשׁוֹנִ֥י עֵ֝֗ט ׀ סוֹפֵ֥ר מָהִֽיר

“My tongue is the stylus of a quick scribe”

The psalmist is speaking as if his **tongue** were actually a **stylus** that belonged to a **scribe** who was able to record quickly and accurately what he heard people say. The psalmist means that even though he has many thoughts that he would like to share on this occasion, he will be able to sing them all articulately and continuously. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will be able to express all of my thoughts articulately and continuously in this song]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:2 (#1)

יָפְיְפִ֥יתָ מִבְּנֵ֑י אָ֝דָ֗ם

“You are fairer than the sons of man”

In verse 1, the psalmist was addressing all of his listeners. Here he begins to address the king directly. In some cultures, a person would not begin to speak to a ruler without using a specific form of address. If your culture has such a form, you could use it in your translation. Alternate translation: [Your Majesty, you are fairer than the sons of man]

See: Politeness

Psalms 45:2 (#2)

יָפְיְפִ֥יתָ מִבְּנֵ֑י אָ֝דָ֗ם הוּצַ֣ק חֵ֭ן בְּשִׂפְתוֹתֶ֑יךָ

“You are fairer than the sons of man. Grace is poured onto your lips”

The words **You** and **your** are singular here and in the rest of the psalm because the psalmist is always addressing an individual. So use singular forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 45:2 (#3)

יָפְיְפִ֥יתָ מִבְּנֵ֑י אָ֝דָ֗ם

“You are fairer than the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” He is not implying that the king is not a man. He means that he is **fairer** or more handsome than all the other **sons of man**. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You are more handsome than other people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 45:2 (#4)

יָפְיְפִ֥יתָ מִבְּנֵ֑י אָ֝דָ֗ם

“You are fairer than the sons of man”

The psalmist is making an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. (However, since an overstatement like this one was an appropriate compliment for a ruler in this culture, you may wish to retain the overstatement in your translation. The UST models one way to do that.) Alternate translation: [You are an exceptionally handsome man]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 45:2 (#5)

יָפְיְפִ֥יתָ מִבְּנֵ֑י אָ֝דָ֗ם

“You are fairer than the sons of man”

The psalmist is using or creating a special form of a verb that means “to be beautiful” by doubling its root. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [You are handsome, far more handsome than other men]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 45:2 (#6)

הוּצַ֣ק חֵ֭ן בְּשִׂפְתוֹתֶ֑יךָ

“Grace is poured onto your lips”

The expression **is poured** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. If you need to say who has done this action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [God has poured grace onto your lips]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 45:2 (#7)

הֻצַ֣ק חֵ֭ן בְּשִׂפְתוֹתֶ֑יךָ

“Grace is poured onto your lips”

The psalmist is speaking as if **Grace** had actually been **poured** onto the **lips** of the king. In context, the emphasis seems to be not on the action of pouring but on the result of pouring. When a liquid is poured onto a surface, it spreads out and covers that surface. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Grace covers your lips] or [Your lips are entirely gracious]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:2 (#8)

הֻצַ֣ק חֵ֭ן בְּשִׂפְתוֹתֶ֑יךָ

“Grace is poured onto your lips”

Here the king’s **lips** represent his speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Your speech is entirely gracious]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:2 (#9)

עַל־כֵּ֤ן

“Therefore”

The psalmist is not using the word **Therefore** to indicate that the king’s attractive appearance and gracious speech are the reasons why **God** has **blessed** him. He means that these characteristics of the king are evidence that God has blessed him. If a term such as “therefore” would not communicate this meaning in your language, you may want to use a different connecting word or phrase to show how the following statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [This is how we know that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 45:3 (#1)

חֲגֹ֣ר־חַ֭רְבְּךָ עַל־יָרֵ֑ךְ

“Gird your sword on your thigh”

The psalmist is using one action that a **warrior** would do in preparation for fighting a battle, strapping his **sword** onto his **thigh**, to refer to being equipped for battle in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Prepare yourself to do battle]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 45:3 (#2)

חֲגֹ֣ר־חַ֭רְבְּךָ עַל־יָרֵ֑ךְ

“Gird your sword on your thigh”

While the expression **Gird** is an imperative, the psalmist is not telling the king to do something or suggesting that he is not already doing it. Instead, the psalmist is celebrating what the king is already doing. It may be more natural in your language to express this meaning by using a form other than an imperative. Alternate translation: [You are always prepared to do battle]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 45:3 (#3)

חֲגֹ֣ר־חַ֭רְבְּךָ עַל־יָרֵ֑ךְ

“Gird your sword on your thigh”

As the next verse indicates, the psalmist wants the king to use his power specifically to uphold justice. This may not necessarily involve fighting an actual battle. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Be prepared to use your power to uphold justice] or [You are always prepared to use your power to uphold justice]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 45:3 (#4)

הֹודְךָ֥ וְהַדָרְךָ֑

“in} your glory and your majesty”

Together the terms **glory** and **majesty** express a single idea. The word **majesty** characterizes this man as a king, and the word **glory** tells what kind of king he is, specifically when he fights for justice. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [as a glorious king]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 45:4 (#1)

וַהֲדָרְךָ֥

“And {in} your majesty”

See how you represented the term “majesty” in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [And as a king]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 45:4 (#2)

צְלַ֤ח רְכַ֨ב

“prosper, ride out”

The phrase **prosper, ride out** expresses a single idea. The word **prosper**, meaning “succeed” or “triumph,” tells in what way the psalmist wants the king to **ride out** in his chariot. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [ride out triumphantly] or [ride out to victory]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 45:4 (#3)

צְלַ֤ח רְכַ֨ב

“prosper, ride out”

The psalmist is speaking as if he actually wanted the king to **ride out** in his chariot to fight a battle. As in the previous verse, he wants the king to use his power to uphold justice without necessarily involve fighting an actual battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [use your power triumphantly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:4 (#4)

עַל־דְּבַר־אֱמֶ֣ת וְעַנְוָ֣ה־צֶ֑דֶק

“for the sake of truth and humility {and} righteousness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **truth**, **humility**, and **righteousness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [to establish a reign that is truthful, humble, and righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 45:4 (#5)

וְתוֹרְךָ֖ נוֹרָא֣וֹת יְמִינֶֽךָ

“May your right hand teach you fearful things”

The psalmist is speaking of the king’s **right hand** as if it were a living thing that could **teach** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you discover that you can do fearful things with your right hand]

See: Personification

Psalms 45:4 (#6)

וְתוֹרְךָ֖ נוֹרָא֣וֹת יְמִינֶֽךָ

“May your right hand teach you fearful things”

The psalmist is using the king’s **right hand** to represent him using his sword and shooting arrows with that hand or, more generally, to represent him fighting against his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [May you discover that you can do fearful things by using your sword and shooting arrows] or [May you discover that you can do fearful things as you fight against your enemies]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:4 (#7)

נוֹרָא֣וֹת

“fearful things”

The expression **fearful things** is a passive verbal form, a participle that the psalmist is using as a noun. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [things that terrify your opponents]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 45:5 (#1)

חִצָּ֣יךְ שְׁנוּנִ֣ים עַ֭מִּים תַּחְתָּ֣יךְ יִפְּל֑וּ בְּלֵ֥ב אוֹיְבֵ֖י הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“Your arrows are sharp; the peoples fall under you; in the heart of the enemies of the king”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information that the arrows are **in the heart of the enemies of the king** with the information that the **arrows are sharp**. Alternate translation: [Your arrows are sharp in the heart of the enemies of the king; the peoples fall under you]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 45:5 (#2)

חִצֶּיךָ שְׁנוּנִים

“Your arrows are sharp”

The psalmist says that these **arrows** are **sharp** to mean that they penetrate through armor into the bodies of enemy soldiers. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Your arrows penetrate]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:5 (#3)

עַמִּים תַּחְתֶּיךָ יִפְּלוּ

“the peoples fall under you”

The psalmist is speaking as if **the peoples** who fight against the king actually **fall** down dead or wounded and he drives his chariot over them, so that they are **under** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you win victory over the peoples]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:5 (#4)

בְּלֵב אוֹיְבֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“in the heart of the enemies of the king”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. If you decide not to move this phrase to an earlier part of the verse, after **Your arrows are sharp**, you can supply those words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Your arrows are in the heart of the enemies of the king] or [Your arrows penetrate into the heart of the enemies of the king]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 45:5 (#5)

בְּלֵב

“in the heart of”

In this verse, the word **heart** is singular in form, but it refers to the hearts of all of the king’s **enemies**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “heart.” Alternate translation: [in the hearts of]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 45:5 (#6)

אוֹיְבֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“the enemies of the king”

The psalmist is speaking of the king in the third person even though he is addressing him directly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the second person. Alternate translation: [your enemies] or [your enemies, O king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 45:6 (#1)

כִּסְאֲךָ

“Your throne”

Here the king’s **throne** represents his reign. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Your reign]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:6 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים

“God”

The Hebrew term that is translated as “God” in most contexts can sometimes be used to refer respectfully to judges. There are probable examples of this in Exodus 21:6, Exodus 22:9, Exodus 22:28, and Psalm 82:1. Since the rest of this verse speaks of the king enforcing justice, this seems to be another instance of that usage. (The psalmist clarifies in the next verse that the king is subject to God himself, who is his God.) To avoid the impression that the psalmist is addressing the king as if he were God or a god, it may be helpful to use a comparable respectful form of address in your language. (See the further discussion of this in the introduction to this psalm.) Alternate translation: [O royal judge]

See: Politeness

Psalms 45:6 (#3)

שֵׁבֶט מִישֹׁר שֵׁבֶט מַלְכוּתֶךָ

“A scepter of justice {is} the scepter of your kingdom”

Here the king’s **scepter** represents his rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [You rule your kingdom with justice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:7 (#1)

אָהַבְתָּ צֶדֶק וַתִּשְׂנָא רֶשַׁע

“You love righteousness, and you hate wickedness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **wickedness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [You love right actions, and you hate wicked actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 45:7 (#2)

מָשָׁחַךָ & שֶׁמֶן שָׂשׂוֹן מֵחֲבֵרֶיךָ

“has anointed you {with} the oil of joy more than your companions”

The psalmist is speaking as if **God** had actually **anointed** the king with **oil** that consisted of or imparted **joy**. The image of pouring out a fluid so that it covers someone conveys the idea of abundance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has given you abundant joy, more than your companions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:7 (#3)

מָשָׁחַךָ & שֶׁמֶן שָׂשׂוֹן מֵחֲבֵרֶיךָ

“has anointed you {with} the oil of joy more than your companions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [has made you very joyful, more than your companions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 45:8 (#1)

מֹר־וַאֲהָלוֹת קְצִיעוֹת כָּל־בִּגְדֹתֶיךָ

“Myrrh and aloes, cassia, {are} all of your garments”

The psalmist is speaking as if the king’s **garments** were actually made of the spices **Myrrh**, **aloes**, and **cassia**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all of your garments are fragrant with myrrh and aloes and cassia] or [myrrh, aloes, and cassia scent all of your garments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:8 (#2)

מֹר־וַאֲהָלוֹת קְצִיעוֹת

“Myrrh and aloes, cassia”

Myrrh, **aloes**, and **cassia** are fragrant spices. If your readers would not be familiar with these spices, we do not recommend that you use the names of similar spices that your readers might recognize, since the psalmist is describing a real historical situation. Instead, you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [Fragrant spices]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 45:8 (#3)

הֵיכְלֵי

“palaces of”

The psalmist is using the plural **palaces** where he could have used the singular form. This suggests that he is using the plural form to emphasize the vast extent of the king’s palace complex, which may include several buildings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [your vast palace of]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 45:8 (#4)

מִנִּי שֵׁנִּי שִׂמְּחוּךָ

“stringed instruments make you rejoice”

The psalmist is using **stringed instruments** to represent the music that people are playing on those instruments. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the music of stringed instruments is making you rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:9 (#1)

בְּיִקְרוֹתֶיךָ

“are} among your precious {ones”

The psalmist is using the adjective **precious** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. (The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **ones**.) Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Al-

ternate translation: [are among your honored women] or [are among the ladies of your court]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 45:9 (#2)

נִצָּבָה

“is stationed”

The expression **is stationed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [is standing]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 45:9 (#3)

לְיָמִינְךָ בְּכֶתֶם אוֹפִיר

“at your right hand in gold of Ophir”

Having the **queen** stand at his **right hand** (that is, on his right side) was a symbolic action by which the king honored his bride. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [in a place of honor at your right side]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 45:9 (#4)

בְּכֶתֶם אוֹפִיר

“in gold of Ophir”

Here, **gold of Ophir** represents garments decorated with that very fine gold, as verses 13 and 14 indicate. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in garments decorated with gold of Ophir]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:9 (#5)

אוֹפִיר

“Ophir”

The word **Ophir** is the name of a land that produced gold of excellent quality.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 45:10 (#1)

שִׁמְעִי־בַת וּרְאִי וְהַטִּי אָזְנֵךְ

“Listen, daughter, and consider, and incline your ear”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and do that here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Listen carefully, daughter, and consider] or [Listen, daughter, and consider, yes, incline your ear]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 45:10 (#2)

בַּת

“daughter”

The psalmist is addressing the bride with the courteous and gentle expression that wise older people in this culture used to address young people whom they were teaching. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [young lady]

See: Politeness

Psalms 45:10 (#3)

וְהַטִּי אָזְנֵךְ

“and incline your ear”

The psalmist is speaking as if he wants the bride physically to **incline** her **ear**, that is, to lean over the way someone would do to pay close attention to someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and pay close attention]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:10 (#4)

וְשִׁכְחִי עַמֵּךְ וּבֵית אָבִיךְ

“and forget your people and the house of your father”

The psalmist is speaking as if he wanted the bride actually to **forget** her nation and family. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and do not wish that

you were still with your people and in the house of your father]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:10 (#5)

וּבֵ֖ית אָבִֽיךְ

“and the house of your father”

Here the term **house** represents the “household” of the bride’s **father**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and your family]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:11 (#1)

וְיִתְאָ֣ו הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ יָפְיֶ֑ךָ

“Then the king will desire your beauty”

The psalmist is using one part of the bride, her **beauty**, to mean all of her in the act of being attractive to the king. The psalmist means that if she gives the king her exclusive devotion, as he advised her in the previous verse, not just her physical appearance but her qualities of loyalty and faithfulness will make the king appreciate and love her. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [This will make you very attractive to the king]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 45:11 (#2)

וְהִשְׁתַּחֲוִי־לֽוֹ

“prostrate yourself to him”

Bowing low to the ground in front of the king was a symbolic action by which the bride showed her acceptance of his authority over her both as her new husband and as her new king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [prostrate yourself respectfully and submissively to him]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 45:12 (#1)

וּבַת־צֹ֗ר ׀ בְּמִנְחָה֮ פָּנַ֪יִךְ יְחַלּ֫וּ עֲשִׁשֵׁ֥י עָֽם

“The daughter of Tyre with a gift; the rich of the people will entreat your face”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from later in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The rich of the people will entreat your face; the daughter of Tyre will do so with a gift]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 45:12 (#2)

וּבַת־צֹֽר

“The daughter of Tyre”

The psalmist is speaking as if the city of **Tyre** were a mother and its people were its **daughter**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The people of Tyre]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:12 (#3)

וּבַת־צֹֽר

“The daughter of Tyre”

The psalmist may be using one particularly wealthy and influential kingdom, **Tyre**, to represent foreign kingdoms in general. This would be complementary to **the people** of Israel or Judah whom he mentions later in the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Representatives of foreign kingdoms]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 45:12 (#4)

עֲשִׁשֵׁ֥י עָֽם

“the rich of the people”

The psalmist is using the adjective **rich** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the rich citizens among our people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 45:12 (#5)

פָּנַ֥יִךְ

“your face”

Here the queen’s **face** represents her “favor.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your favor]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:13 (#1)

כָּל־כְּבוּדָּה בַת־מֶ֫לֶךְ פְּנִימָה מִמִּשְׁבְּצוֹת זָהָב לְבוּשָׁהּ

“All glorious {is} the daughter of the king within; from interweavings of gold {is} her clothing”

In this poem celebrating the king’s wedding, the psalmist is not following a strict chronological sequence. In verse 9, he presented a portrait of the bride, groom, and attendants in their formal places at the ceremony. In verses 13–15, he describes the procession of the bride and her attendants to the ceremony. That procession took place before he started singing this song, so in some languages, it may be appropriate to describe them in a past tense. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 45:13 (#2)

בַּת־מֶ֫לֶךְ

“is} the daughter of the king”

By **the daughter of the king**, the psalmist means the same person whom he calls the “queen” in verse 9. (This indicates that her father is the **king** of a foreign country.) You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the royal bride]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 45:13 (#3)

פְּנִימָה

“within”

The psalmist is using the term **within** to mean a room or apartment within the palace where the bride has dressed for her wedding. Alternate translation: [in her chamber]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 45:14 (#1)

תּוּבָל

“She will be led”

The expression **will be led** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Royal officials will lead her]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 45:14 (#2)

לַ֫מֶּלֶךְ

“to the king”

The psalmist is addressing the king once again, as the pronoun **you** at the end of the verse indicates. So it may be more natural in some languages to use a second-person form here. Alternate translation: [to you, O king,]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 45:14 (#3)

לְרִקְמוֹת֫

“in embroidery”

Here, **embroidery** represents embroidered garments, that is, garments decorated with embroidery. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in embroidered garments]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:14 (#4)

לְרִקְמוֹת֫

“in embroidery”

The term **embroidery** describes the art of making decorative designs in cloth by using needles to work colored threads into it to make beautiful images or patterns. If your readers would not be familiar with what embroidery is, in your translation you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [in garments decorated with colored thread]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 45:14 (#5)

בְּתוּלֹת אַחֲרֶ֫יהָ רֵעוֹתֶ֫יהָ מֻבָאוֹת לָךְ

“The virgins after her, her companions, will be brought to you”

The expression **will be brought** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Royal officials will bring her companions to you, the virgins who follow her]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 45:15 (#1)

תּוּבַלְנָה בְּשִׂמְחָה וְגִיל תּוּבָאֶ֫ינָה

“They will be led by joy and rejoicing; they will enter”

The psalmist is speaking of **joy** and **rejoicing** as if they were living things that could lead the bride and her attendants into the king’s palace. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [There will be joy and rejoicing as they will enter]

See: Personification

Psalms 45:15 (#2)

בְּשִׂמְחָ֥ת וְגִ֑יל

“by joy and rejoicing”

The terms **joy** and **rejoicing** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [with great joy]

See: Doublet

Psalms 45:15 (#3)

בְּהֵיכַ֖ל מֶֽלֶךְ

“into the palace of the king”

See how you translated the similar expression “to the king” in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [into your palace, O king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 45:16 (#1)

אֲבֹתֶ֗יךָ & בָּנֶ֫יךָ

“your fathers & your sons”

The psalmist is using the term **fathers** to represent “ancestors,” and he is using the term **sons** to represent “descendants.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your ancestors ... your descendants]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 45:16 (#2)

תְּשִׁיתֵ֥מוֹ

“you will make him”

Since the psalmist is referring to multiple people (**sons** or descendants), it may be more natural in many languages to use a plural pronoun here. Alternate translation: [you will make them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 45:16 (#3)

בְּכָל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“in all of the earth”

The psalmist is saying **all** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. (However, since an overstatement like this one was an appropriate compliment for a ruler in this culture, you may wish to retain the overstatement in your translation, as the UST does. See what you decided to do in verse 2.) Alternate translation: [in many parts of the world]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 45:17 (#1)

שְׁמֶ֑ךָ

“your name”

Here the king’s **name** represents his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 45:17 (#2)

בְּכָל־דֹּ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“in every generation to generation”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [in every generation] or [from generation to generation]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms - Chapter 46 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 46 is a psalm of trust. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. First stanza (1–3): God as a refuge in an earthquake and an ocean storm
2. Second stanza (4–6): God as a helper in the turmoil of the nations
3. First refrain (7): Statement of trust
4. Third stanza (8–10): Yahweh as the one who ends wars

5. Second refrain (11): Statement of trust

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

What "stream" is the psalmist describing in verse 4?
Like Psalm 44, this psalm could have been written during the Assyrian invasion of Judah and siege of Jerusalem in 701 B.C. During a siege, the attacking army tried to cut off supplies of food and water to the people inside a city to make them surrender. But Jerusalem had its own water supply. The Gihon spring higher up on Mount Zion produced a steady stream of water. Kings such as Hezekiah engineered channels to bring its water safely into the city even during a siege. The psalmist is most likely referring to the life-giving stream of water from the Gihon spring and using it as a symbol of Yahweh's care and provision for the people. The contrast between the images of this quiet stream and the violent ocean storm portrayed in the previous verse highlights the main theme of the psalm. Even in the midst of tumultuous and threatening events, Yahweh is always helping his people.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Intentionally repeated terms
The psalmist uses the same verb for "roared" in verse 6 as he does for "roar" in verse 3. He uses the same verb for "shook" in verse 6 as he does for "shaking" in verse 2. He expects readers to realize as a result that he was using the sea in verse 3 to represent the "nations" he describes in verse 6 and that he was using the mountains in verse 2 to represent the "kingdoms" he describes in verse 6. So that your readers can appreciate this, we encourage you to use the same terms in your language for "roared" and "shook" in verse 6 that you use in verses 2 and 3 for "roar" and "shaking."

Psalms 46:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 46:0 (#3)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח עַל־עֲלָמוֹת שִׁיר

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח עַל־עֲלָמוֹת שִׁיר"

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information that this is a **song** with the information that one of the **sons of Korah** wrote it. Alternate translation: [A song of the sons of Korah. On Alamoth]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 46:0 (#4)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 46:0 (#5)

לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח"

See how you translated the expression "the sons of Korah" in the superscription to Psalm 42. Alternate translation: [Of the descendants of Korah] or [Of the Korahites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:0 (#6)

עַל־עֲלָמוֹת

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־עֲלָמוֹת"

See how you translated the similar expression "On Sheminith" in the superscription to Psalm 6. Alternate translation: [Set to the tune Alamoth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 46:0 (#7)

עַל־עֲלָמוֹת

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־עֲלָמוֹת"

The term that the ULT translates as **Maidens** could be the name of the tune of this psalm. It might also be a musical instruction indicating that singers should perform the song in a higher range. Alternate translation: [Perform in a higher range]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 46:1 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים לָ֭נוּ מַחֲסֶ֣ה וְעֹ֑ז

“God {is} to us a refuge and strength”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were actually a refuge, that is, a place where people can go to be safe from danger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the term “refuge” in 14:6. Alternate translation: [God protects us and makes us strong]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:1 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים לָ֭נוּ מַחֲסֶ֣ה וְעֹ֑ז

“God {is} to us a refuge and strength”

The psalmist could be using the terms **refuge** and **strength** together to express a single idea. The word **strength** would tell what kind of **refuge** God is. If you follow this interpretation in your translation, and if it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [God is our strong refuge] or [God powerfully protects us]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 46:1 (#3)

עֶזְרָ֖ה בְּצָרוֹ֣ת נִמְצָ֣א מְאֹֽד

“being found greatly a help in trouble”

The term **greatly** describes the degree or extent to which God is **found** to be **a help in trouble**. Translators may choose to put the focus either on the finding or the helping. Alternate translation: [being dependably found a help in trouble] or [being found a great help in trouble]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 46:1 (#4)

עֶזְרָ֖ה בְּצָרוֹ֣ת נִמְצָ֣א מְאֹֽד

“being found greatly a help in trouble”

The psalmist is using the term **found** in a way characteristic of his language to mean that when one is **in trouble**, God can be **found**; that is, he is present. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He is dependably present to help in trouble]

See: Idiom

Psalms 46:1 (#5)

עֶזְרָ֖ה בְּצָרוֹ֣ת נִמְצָ֣א מְאֹֽד

“being found greatly a help in trouble”

The expression **being found** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, but a form of the verb “find” would communicate the psalmist’s meaning in your language, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural. Alternate translation: [We dependably find him a help in trouble] or [We find him a great help in trouble]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 46:2 (#1)

בְּלֵ֣ב

“into the heart of”

The psalmist is speaking as if the deep part of the sea were actually its **heart**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [into the depths of]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:2 (#2)

יַמִּ֑ים

“the seas”

The psalmist is using the plural **seas** where he could have used the singular form. (In the next verse, he refers back to the sea using a singular pronoun.) This suggests that he is using the plural form to emphasize the vastness of the sea. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [the vast sea]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 46:3 (#1)

יֶהֱמ֣וּ יֶחְמְר֣וּ מֵ֭ימָיו יִרְעֲשׁ֣וּ הָרִ֑ים בְּגַאֲוָתֹ֥ו

“should its waters roar and foam, should the mountains quake at its swelling”

In each instance, the pronoun **its** refers to “the seas” in the previous verse. Since that is a plural term, you may wish to use a plural pronoun or to repeat the noun for clarity. You may have chosen to use a singular form of the noun in your translation. Alternate translation: [should their waters roar and foam, should the mountains quake at their swelling] or [should the waters of the sea roar and foam, should the mountains quake at the swelling of the sea]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 46:3 (#2)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

To translate the term **Selah** here and in verses 7 and 11, see how your translation team decided to represent that term in 3:2.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 46:4 (#1)

עִיר־אֱלֹהִים

“the city of God”

The psalmist is using **the city of God** (that is, Jerusalem) to represent the people of that city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the city of God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 46:4 (#2)

קֹ֣דֶשׁ מִשְׁכְּנֵי֮ עֶלְיֽוֹן

“the holy {place} of the dwellings of the Most High”

The psalmist is using the adjective **holy** as a noun to mean a certain kind of place. (The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **place**.) Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the holy dwelling place of the Most High]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 46:4 (#3)

קֹ֣דֶשׁ מִשְׁכְּנֵי֮ עֶלְיֽוֹן

“the holy {place} of the dwellings of the Most High”

The psalmist is speaking of the temple in Jerusalem as if it were a place in which God actually lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the holy temple of the Most High]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:4 (#4)

קֹ֣דֶשׁ מִשְׁכְּנֵי֮ עֶלְיֽוֹן

“the holy {place} of the dwellings of the Most High”

The psalmist is using the plural **dwellings** where he could have used the singular form. This suggests that, as in 43:3, he is using the plural form to emphasize the sacred character of the temple as a place where God is present in a special way. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular form and express the emphasis in another way. If it would be extra information to say both “holy” and “sacred” in your translation, you could use another term to make one of those words emphatic. Alternate translation: [the very holy dwelling of the Most High] or [the very sacred temple of the Most High]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 46:5 (#1)

אֱלֹהִ֣ים בְּקִרְבָּ֣הּ בַּל־תִּמּ֑וֹט

“God {is} in the midst of her, she will not be shaken”

The pronouns **her** and **she** refer to the city of Jerusalem. It was common in this culture to envision a city as a mother and its residents as her children. If your language has a neuter pronoun that it uses for impersonal entities, it may be more natural to use that here. You could also repeat the noun from the previous verse. Alternate translation: [God is in the midst of the city, it will not be shaken]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 46:5 (#2)

בַּל־תִּמּ֑וֹט

“she will not be shaken”

The expression **will not be shaken** contains a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one will shake her] or [no one will shake it]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 46:5 (#3)

בַּל־תִּמּ֑וֹט

“she will not be shaken”

The psalmist is speaking as if the city of Jerusalem might actually be **shaken** by the “nations” he describes in the next verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [it will not be destroyed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:5 (#4)

יַעְזְרֶהָ אֱלֹהִים

“God will help her”

The pronoun **her**, referring to the city of Jerusalem, represents the people of that city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. See what you did in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [God will help the people of that city]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 46:5 (#5)

לִפְנוֹת בֹּקֶר

“at the turning of the morning”

The psalmist is using **at the turning of the morning** as a common expression of his culture to refer to the time when night ends and day begins. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the break of day] or [as soon as it becomes light]

See: Idiom

Psalms 46:5 (#6)

לִפְנוֹת בֹּקֶר

“at the turning of the morning”

The psalmist is speaking as if God were going to help the people of Jerusalem at the actual **turning of the morning**, that is, as soon as it became light on a certain day. He means that the time of trouble, pictured as a dark night, will surely end as God brings deliverance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when he brings deliverance]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:6 (#1)

הָמְּמוּ גֹיִם מָּמֲטוּ מַמְלָכוֹת

“Nations may roar; kingdoms may shake”

The psalmist is speaking as if these **nations** might actually **roar** and these **kingdoms** might actually **shake**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Nations may attack kingdoms and devastate them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:6 (#2)

נָתַן בְּקֹלוֹ

“He utters with his voice”

It was characteristic of this culture to speak of thunder as if it were actually the **voice** of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar expression in 18:13. Alternate translation: [He causes thunder]

See: Idiom

Psalms 46:6 (#3)

נָתַן בְּקֹלוֹ

“He utters with his voice”

The psalmist is speaking as if God actually causes thunder in the situations he is describing. He is doing that to represent God acting powerfully. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He acts powerfully]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:6 (#4)

תָּמֹוג אָרֶץ

“the earth melts”

The psalmist is speaking as if the **earth** actually **melts**. He is using the **earth** to represent the people of the earth, specifically hostile armies. He is using the term **melts** to mean that they will dissipate, that is, cease to be an organized force and go away. Alternate translation: [armies that threaten us dissipate]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:7 (#1)

עִמָּנוּ

“is} with us”

The psalmist is using a common expression of his culture to mean that Yahweh is helping the Judeans. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation, as in the UST: [is helping us]

See: Idiom

Psalms 46:7 (#2)

מִשְׂגָּב־לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב

“the God of Jacob {is} a stronghold to us”

See how you translated the similar term “refuge” in 46:1. Alternate translation: [the God of Jacob is protecting us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:7 (#3)

אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב

“the God of Jacob {is”

Here **Jacob**, the ancestor of the Israelites (whose name God changed to Israel), represents the nation that consists of his descendants. Alternate translation: [the God of us Israelites]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 46:8 (#1)

לְכוּ

“Come”

The psalmist is not telling his listeners to **Come** somewhere with him. He is saying **Come** to encourage them to take action. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [Come on]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 46:8 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר־שָׂשָׂם שַׁמּוֹת בָּאָרֶץ

“who makes desolations on the earth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desolations**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who makes the earth desolate]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 46:8 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר־שָׂשָׂם שַׁמּוֹת בָּאָרֶץ

“who makes desolations on the earth”

As in verse 6, here the **earth** seems to represent the people of the earth and specifically the armies that are threatening Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [who desolates armies that threaten us] or [who destroys armies that threaten us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:9 (#1)

עַד־קְצֵה הָאָרֶץ

“to the end of the earth”

The psalmist is speaking of the effects of Yahweh’s action from the perspective of looking off as far as he can see in one direction, to one **end** of the **earth**. He is using that one direction to represent how Yahweh’s action will have effects in every direction. (While in verses 6 and 9 the term “earth” had a symbolic meaning, now that Yahweh has defeated the forces opposing his people, the “earth” has the sense of a literal place.) Alternate translation: [to the ends of the earth] or [throughout the earth]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 46:9 (#2)

קֶשֶׁת יְשַׁבֵּר וְקִצֵּץ חֲנִית עֲגָלוֹת יִשְׂרֹף בָּאֵשׁ

“He shatters the bow and cuts the spear in pieces; he burns the wagons with fire”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **bow** or **spear** or to specific **wagons**. He means those things in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [He shatters bows and spears in pieces; he burns wagons with fire]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 46:9 (#3)

קֶשֶׁת יְשַׁבֵּר וְקִצֵּץ חֲנִית עֲגָלוֹת יִשְׂרֹף בָּאֵשׁ

“He shatters the bow and cuts the spear in pieces; he burns the wagons with fire”

The psalmist does not mean that Yahweh actually does these things personally. He is speaking of the effects of Yahweh’s action of ending wars. Alternate translation: [He keeps people from using weapons and equipment to wage war]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:9 (#4)

עֲגָלוֹת יִשְׂרֹף בָּאֵשׁ

“he burns the wagons with fire”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, if you retain this image in your translation, you can shorten this expression. Alternate translation: [he burns up the wagons]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 46:10 (#1)

הַרְפּוּ֥ וּדְע֑וּ כִּ֥י־אָ֝נֹכִ֗י אֱלֹהִ֥ים

“Be still and know that I {am} God”

This verse is a direct quotation of Yahweh. The ULT indicates that by putting the verse inside quotation marks. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could also use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh says, “Be still and know that I {am} God]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 46:10 (#2)

אָר֣וּם בַּגּוֹיִ֑ם אָר֖וּם בָּאָֽרֶץ

“I will be high among the nations, I will be high on the earth”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and do that here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I will be high among the nations of the earth] or [I will be high among the nations; indeed, I will be high on the earth]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 46:10 (#3)

אָר֣וּם בַּגּוֹיִ֑ם אָר֖וּם בָּאָֽרֶץ

“I will be high among the nations, I will be high on the earth”

Yahweh is speaking as if he were actually going to be in a **high** location. He means that he will receive honor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 46:11 (#1)

יְהוָ֣ה צְבָאוֹת֮ עִמָּ֪נוּ מִשְׂגָּ֫ב־לָ֥נוּ אֱלֹהֵ֖י יַעֲקֹ֣ב

“Yahweh of Armies {is} with us; the God of Jacob {is} a stronghold to us”

This is the second instance of the refrain of this poem. The first instance is in verse 7. To help your readers appreciate this, translate this verse the same way you translated that verse.

See: Poetry

Psalms - Chapter 47 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 47 is a psalm of praise. It is a specific type of praise psalm, a divine enthronement psalm. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship (1)
2. Reason to worship (2–5)
3. Call to worship (6)
4. Reason to worship (7–9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

What “peoples” and “nations” had Yahweh enabled the Israelites to subdue (v. 3)?

The psalmist does not give specific details of the victory he is celebrating. This might be a general song of praise to Yahweh, in which case verse 3 might be translated, “He subdues peoples under us and nations under our feet.” However, interpreters have suggested one likely historical occasion for the composition of this psalm. It is generally agreed that the Korahites wrote their psalms in the later years of the kingdom of Judah. During the reign of Jehoshaphat, as 2 Chronicles 20:1–30 relates, a huge army of Moabite, Ammonite, and Meunite soldiers attacked Judah. The Judeans felt unable to defeat this army, but people from all over Judah gathered at the temple and Jehoshaphat prayed for Yahweh’s help. He appealed to him on the grounds that he had promised to give the land of Israel to the descendants of Abraham. Yahweh made the invading soldiers from the different countries fight against each other, so the enemy army destroyed itself. As a result, the people of the surrounding kingdoms came to fear and respect Yahweh greatly. The psalmist may be referring to this in verse 9 when he describes people from all nations worshiping “the God of Abraham.”

Translation Issues in This Psalm

The order of reasons and results

As the introduction to the book of Psalms discusses, the typical pattern of a psalm of praise is to issue a call to worship and then give a reason to worship. A psalm of praise may do this more than once. (This psalm does it twice.) It would be helpful to follow this pattern to show your readers how these psalms work.

However, if, as a rule, your language would not give a reason after a result, you could create verse bridges for verses 1 and 2 and verses 6 and 7 in order to put the reasons before the results.

In the ULT, which follows the Hebrew order, verses 1 and 2 read this way: Clap a palm, all peoples! Shout to God with a voice of rejoicing. For Yahweh, the Most High, is to be feared, the great king over all of the earth.

In your translation, you might present them as verse 1–2 this way: Since Yahweh, the Most High, the great king over all of the earth, is to be feared, Clap a palm, all peoples! Shout to God with a voice of rejoicing.

In the ULT, verses 6 and 7 read this way: Sing praise {to} God, sing praise! Sing praise {to} our King, sing praise! For God {is} the king of all of the earth. Sing praise {with} a maskil.

In your translation, you might present them as verse 6–7 this way: Since God is the king of all of the earth, Sing praise to God, sing praise! Sing praise to our king, sing praise! Sing praise with a maskil.

Psalms 47:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 47:0 (#3)

לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח”

See how you translated the expression “the sons of Korah” in the superscription to Psalm 42. Alternate translation: [of the descendants of Korah] or [of the Korahites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 47:1 (#1)

תִּקְעוּ־כָף

“Clap a palm”

Since people strike their palms together in order to applaud, it may be more natural in your language to use a plural term here. Alternate translation, as in the UST: [Clap your hands]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 47:1 (#2)

הָרִיעוּ לֵאלֹהִים בְּקוֹל רִנָּה

“Shout to God with a voice of rejoicing”

It might seem that to say both **Shout** and **voice** would be to express extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you can use just one of these terms in your translation. Alternate translation: [Celebrate by shouting to God] or [Lift your voice to God in rejoicing]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 47:2 (#1)

כִּי־יְהוָה עֶלְיוֹן נוֹרָא מֶלֶךְ גָּדוֹל עַל־כָּל־הָאָרֶץ

“For Yahweh, the Most High, is to be feared, the great king over all of the earth”

This verse gives the reason for the result that the previous verse describes. See the discussion in the introduction to this psalm of how you might order the reason and result here and in verses 6 and 7.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 47:2 (#2)

יְהוָה עֶלְיוֹן נוֹרָא מֶלֶךְ גָּדוֹל עַל־כָּל־הָאָרֶץ

“Yahweh, the Most High, is to be feared, the great king over all of the earth”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information that Yahweh is **the great king over all of the earth** with the information that he is **the Most High**. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the Most High, the great king over all of the earth, is to be feared]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 47:2 (#3)

יְהוָה עֶלְיוֹן נוֹרָא

“Yahweh, the Most High, is to be feared”

The expression **is to be feared** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [People should fear Yahweh, the Most High]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 47:3 (#1)

יַדְבֵּר עַמִּים תַּחְתֵּינוּ וּלְאֻמִּים תַּחַת רַגְלֵינוּ

“He subdues peoples under us and nations under our feet”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. It may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Another approach would be to combine the phrases and express the emphasis in another way. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and do that here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [He has subdued peoples under us, yes, he has subdued nations under our feet] or [He has subdued many nations under our feet]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 47:3 (#2)

יַדְבֵּר עַמִּים תַּחְתֵּינוּ וּלְאֻמִּים תַּחַת רַגְלֵינוּ

“He subdues peoples under us and nations under our feet”

The psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh actually put **peoples** and **nations under** the **feet** of the Israelites. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has enabled us to defeat peoples, yes, he has enabled us to defeat nations] or [He has enabled us to defeat many nations]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 47:4 (#1)

לָּנוּ אֶת־נַחֲלָתֵנוּ

“our inheritance for us”

The psalmist is speaking as if the land of Canaan were something that the Israelites had inherited as a lasting possession. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the land that would be our lasting possession]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 47:4 (#2)

אֶת גְּאוֹן יַעֲקֹב אֲשֶׁר־אָהֵב

“the pride of Jacob, whom he loved”

The psalmist is using **Jacob** to represent his descendants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the pride of the descendants of Jacob, whom he loved]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 47:4 (#3)

אֶת גְּאוֹן יַעֲקֹב אֲשֶׁר־אָהֵב

“the pride of Jacob, whom he loved”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pride**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of which the descendants of Jacob, whom he loved, are proud]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 47:4 (#4)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

See how your translation team decided at 3:2 to represent the term **Selah**.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 47:5 (#1)

עָלָה אֱלֹהִים בִּתְרוּעָה יְהוָה בְּקוֹל שׁוֹפָר

“God has gone up with a shout, Yahweh with the sound of a shofar”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh our God has gone up with a shout and the sound of a shofar]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 47:5 (#2)

עָלָה אֱלֹהִים בִּתְרוּעָה יְהוָה בְּקוֹל שׁוֹפָר

“God has gone up with a shout, Yahweh with the sound of a shofar”

The psalmist is using the expression **gone up** to mean that God has ascended onto his throne as king. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [God has ascended his throne with a shout,

Yahweh with the sound of a shofar] or [Yahweh our God has ascended his throne with a shout and the sound of a shofar]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 47:5 (#3)

עָלָ֣ה אֱ֭לֹהִים בִּתְרוּעָ֑ה יְ֝הוָ֗ה בְּקֹ֣ול שֹׁופָֽר

“God has gone up with a shout, Yahweh with the sound of a shofar”

The psalmist is using God going up onto his throne to represent him assuming the role of king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [God has become king with a shout, Yahweh with the sound of a shofar] or [Yahweh our God has become king with a shout and the sound of a shofar]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 47:5 (#4)

עָלָ֣ה אֱ֭לֹהִים בִּתְרוּעָ֑ה יְ֝הוָ֗ה בְּקֹ֣ול שֹׁופָֽר

“God has gone up with a shout, Yahweh with the sound of a shofar”

As passages such as 2 Samuel 15:10 and 2 Kings 9:13 illustrate, shouting that a person was the king and blowing a shofar were symbolic actions by which people acclaimed that person as their new king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text of your translation or in a footnote. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 47:6 (#1)

זַמְּר֣וּ אֱלֹהִ֣ים זַמֵּ֑רוּ זַמְּר֖וּ לְ֝מַלְכֵּ֗נוּ זַמֵּֽרוּ

“Sing praise {to} God, sing praise! Sing praise {to} our king, sing praise”

In each part of this verse, the psalmist is repeating the expression “sing praise” in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat expressions for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Sing praise to God enthusiastically! Yes, sing praise to our king enthusiastically!]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 47:7 (#1)

מַשְׂכִּֽיל

“with} a maskil”

The psalmist is using a musical term here, **maskil**, that also occurs in the superscriptions to several psalms. Biblical scholars have different understandings of what this term means. (See the discussion in the introduction to the book of Psalms.) Since the meaning is not certain, in your translation, you may wish to represent this word in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language, as the ULT does. You could also use a general expression, as the UST does.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 47:8 (#1)

אֱ֭לֹהִים יָשַׁ֣ב ׀ עַל־כִּסֵּ֣א קָדְשֹֽׁו

“God sits on the throne of his holiness”

Since the psalmist has already used the name **God** earlier in this sentence, it may be more natural in your language to use a pronoun here. (However, the repetition of the name has a poetic effect, so you may wish to repeat the name in your own translation.) Alternate translation: [he sits on the throne of his holiness]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 47:8 (#2)

אֱ֭לֹהִים יָשַׁ֣ב ׀ עַל־כִּסֵּ֣א קָדְשֹֽׁו

“God sits on the throne of his holiness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **throne**, representing God’s reign, that is characterized by **holiness**. The idea is that God’s reign is not common, that is, it is not like the usual reign of kings on earth, who are not always just in their dealings with their people. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God reigns with perfect justice] or [he reigns with perfect justice]

See: Possession

Psalms 47:9 (#1)

כִּֽי

“for”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before as modeled in the UST.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 47:9 (#2)

לֵֽאלֹהִ֥ים מָגִנֵּי־אֶ֑רֶץ

“to} God are the shields of the earth”

Here, **shields** represents “rulers,” since rulers are protectors. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the rulers of the earth belong to God] or [God reigns over the rulers of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 47:9 (#3)

מְאֹ֣ד נַעֲלָֽה

“He is greatly exalted”

The expression **is greatly exalted** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. This could mean: (1) that God has exalted himself. Alternate translation: [He has exalted himself greatly] or (2) that people should or do exalt God. Alternate translation: [People should exalt him greatly] or [People exalt him greatly]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 48 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 48 is a psalm of praise. It is a specific type of praise psalm, a “song of Zion.” See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship (1–3)
2. Reason to worship (4–10)
3. Call to worship (11–13)
4. Reason to worship (14)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Who were the “kings” who “advanced” against Jerusalem?

The psalmist says in verse 4 that “kings assembled themselves” and “advanced together” to attack Jerusalem. He does not give enough information to identify these kings definitively. However, it is possible to understand Psalms 44, 46, and 48 as reflecting a sequence of compositions related to the Assyrian siege of Jerusalem in 701 B.C.

Psalm 44 is a psalm of supplication that complains to Yahweh that “you do not go out with our armies” even though “we have not forgotten you and we have not dealt falsely with your covenant.” This is an urgent cry for help in a desperate and dangerous situation.

Psalm 46 is psalm of trust. Even though there is warfare in the background (“Nations may roar; kingdoms may shake”), and this warfare seems to be ongoing, the psalmist expresses confident trust that Yahweh will help Jerusalem in time to save the city.

Psalm 48 is a psalm of praise. It celebrates Jerusalem as the city that God has chosen as the place for people to worship him. In this psalm, the psalmist says in verse 8 that just as he and his contemporaries had heard from their ancestors about Yahweh’s deliverance, now they have seen it for themselves. This could be understood as an allusion back to Psalm 44:1, where the psalmist said, “God, we have heard with our ears, our fathers have recounted to us, the work you worked in their days.”

While it is not necessarily the case that all three of these psalms relate to the same historical occasion, together they do represent the sequence of crying desperately to God for help, reaching a place of confident trust in God even before he acts, and celebrating God’s deliverance after he has brought it about. This rhythm characterizes the book of Psalms as a whole. See how you can translate these three psalms, which at least come from the same group of worship leaders and the same period in the history of the kingdom of Judah, in such a way as to highlight this rhythm.

Psalms 48:0 (#2)

לִבְנֵי־קֹ֗רַח

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבְנֵי־קֹ֗רַח”

See how you translated the expression “the sons of Korah” in the superscription to Psalm 42. Alternate translation: [of the descendants of Korah] or [of the Korahites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 48:1 (#1)

וּמְהֻלָּ֥ל

“and he is being praised”

The expression **is being praised** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and people are praising him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 48:1 (#2)

וּמְהֻלָּל

“and he is being praised”

In this context, the verbal form has the implied sense that Yahweh “is to be praised” or “ought to be praised.” Your language may have a verbal form that indicates that explicitly. If so, it would be appropriate to use it here in your translation. If not, you may be able to indicate this sense in another way. Alternate translation: [and he is worthy to be praised]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 48:1 (#3)

בְּעִ֣יר אֱלֹהֵ֑ינוּ

“in the city of our God”

Since the psalmist has used the name **Yahweh** earlier in this sentence, and since Yahweh is the same person as **our God**, it may be more natural in your language to use a pronoun here. Alternate translation: [in his city]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 48:1 (#4)

הַר־קָדְשׁוֹ

“on} the mountain of his holiness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **mountain**, Mount Zion, that is characterized by **holiness**. The idea is that Yahweh set apart this mountain as a place where he would be present in a special way and where people would worship him. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [on the mountain that he set apart for himself] or [on the mountain that he made a sacred place]

See: Possession

Psalms 48:2 (#1)

מְשׂ֣וֹשׂ כָּל־הָ֭אָרֶץ

“the joy of all of the earth”

Here the **earth** represents the people of the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the joy of all of the people of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 48:2 (#2)

מְשׂ֣וֹשׂ כָּל־הָ֭אָרֶץ

“the joy of all of the earth”

The psalmist is saying **all** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [the joy of people from throughout the earth]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 48:2 (#3)

מְשׂ֣וֹשׂ כָּל־הָ֭אָרֶץ

“the joy of all of the earth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [something that makes people from throughout the earth rejoice]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 48:2 (#4)

יַרְכְּתֵ֣י צָפ֑וֹן קִ֝רְיַ֗ת מֶ֣לֶךְ רָֽב

“in} the recesses of the north, the city of the great king”

This could mean: (1) that the psalmist is saying where on Mount Zion the **city** of Jerusalem, and especially the temple and the royal palace, are located. Alternate translation: [on its northern slope, where the city of the great king is] or (2) that the psalmist is using the phrase **the recesses of the north** in the same way as in Isaiah 14:13 to mean the distant north, where pagan nations believe the council of the gods met. The psalmist would be saying that Yahweh is the supreme God who actually rules the council of supernatural beings (as in 89:7) from his temple in Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [, the site of Jerusalem, the place from which Yahweh, the great king, rules as the supreme God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 48:3 (#1)

נוֹדַ֣ע בְּ֭מִשְׂגְּב

“He is known as a stronghold”

The expression **is known** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate transla-

tion: [People know him as a stronghold] or [He has made himself known as a stronghold]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 48:3 (#2)

לְמִשְׂגָּב

“as a stronghold”

See how you translated the term “stronghold” in 46:7 and 46:11. Alternate translation: [as a protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 48:4 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

As is characteristic in a psalm of praise, the word **For** introduces the reason why people should praise Yahweh as the psalmist has been saying they should. Alternate translation: [We should praise Yahweh because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 48:4 (#2)

הִנֵּה

“behold”

The psalmist is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [listen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 48:5 (#1)

הֵ֭מָּה רָ֣אוּ כֵ֑ן תָּ֝מָ֗הוּ

“They, they saw, then they marveled”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **They** separately, even though the verb translated as **they saw** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that this action took place at the same time as when the kings **marveled**. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [As soon as they saw it, they marveled]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 48:5 (#2)

נִבְהֲלוּ

“They were terrified”

The expression **were terrified** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [This terrified them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 48:5 (#3)

נָחְפָּזוּ

“they hastened themselves away”

In this clause, the psalmist is describing the result of the previous clause. It may be helpful to add a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [so they hastened themselves away]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 48:6 (#1)

רְ֭עָדָה אֲחָזָ֣תַם שָׁ֑ם

“Trembling seized them there”

The psalmist is speaking of **Trembling** as if it were a living thing that could have **seized** the enemy kings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [There they trembled uncontrollably]

See: Personification

Psalms 48:6 (#2)

חִ֝יל כַּיּוֹלֵדָֽה

“pain like childbearing”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [pain seized them there, like that of childbearing]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 48:6 (#3)

חִ֝יל כַּיּוֹלֵדָֽה

“pain like childbearing”

The point of this comparison is not that these kings felt physical **pain** but that they cried out in anguish

and distress as a woman would who was feeling the actual **pain** of **childbearing**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they cried out uncontrollably in anguish and distress]

See: Simile

Psalms 48:7 (#1)

תְּשַׁבֵּר

“you shatter”

The word **you** is singular here and through verse 11 because the psalmist is directly addressing Yahweh. So use the singular form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [you, Yahweh, shatter]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 48:7 (#2)

אֳנִיּוֹת תַּרְשִׁישׁ

“ships of Tarshish”

The psalmist is using **ships of Tarshish** as a common expression of his culture to mean “ocean-going ships” or “large, sturdy ships.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Kings, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Kings 10:22. Alternate translation: [ocean-going ships] or [large, sturdy ships]

See: Idiom

Psalms 48:8 (#1)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

See how your translation team decided at 3:2 to represent the term **Selah**.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 48:9 (#1)

דִּמִּינוּ & חַסְדֶּךָ

“We have compared your covenant faithfulness”

The psalmist means that he and his fellow Judeans have **compared** the **covenant faithfulness** that God showed on this occasion with the past covenant faithfulness that their ancestors related to them, as described in the previous verse. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [We have compared your present covenant faithfulness with your past covenant faithfulness]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 48:9 (#2)

דִּמִּינוּ & חַסְדֶּךָ

“We have compared your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [We have compared how faithful you were to your covenant on this occasion with how faithful you were to your covenant in the past]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 48:9 (#3)

דִּמִּינוּ

“We have compared”

By **We**, The psalmist means himself and his fellow Judeans but not Yahweh, to whom he is speaking. So use the exclusive form of that word in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Psalms 48:10 (#1)

כְּשִׁמְךָ אֱלֹהִים כֵּן תְּהִלָּתְךָ עַל־קַצְוֵי־אֶרֶץ

“As {is} your name, God, so {is} your praise to the ends of the earth”

In this context, God’s **name** represents his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [People to the ends of the earth praise you, God, as your reputation deserves]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 48:10 (#2)

צֶדֶק מָלְאָה יְמִינֶךָ

“Your right hand is full {of} righteousness”

The psalmist is speaking of **righteousness** as if it were an object with which God’s **right hand** could be **full**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your right hand is thoroughly characterized by righteousness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 48:10 (#3)

צֶדֶק מָלְאָה יְמִינֶךָ

“Your right hand is full {of} righteousness”

Here, God’s **hand** represents his powerful activity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You powerfully bring about righteousness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 48:10 (#4)

צֶדֶק מָלְאָה יְמִינֶךָ

“Your right hand is full {of} righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You powerfully do what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 48:11 (#1)

יִשְׂמַח ׀ הַר־צִיּוֹן תָּגֵלְנָה בְּנוֹת יְהוּדָה

“Let Mount Zion rejoice, let the daughters of Judah be glad”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and do that here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Let Mount Zion and the daughters of Judah rejoice greatly] or [Let Mount Zion rejoice; yes, let the daughters of Judah be glad]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 48:11 (#2)

יִשְׂמַח ׀ הַר־צִיּוֹן

“Let Mount Zion rejoice”

Here, **Mount Zion** represents the people who live on Mount Zion, that is, the people of the city of Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Let the people of Jerusalem rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 48:11 (#3)

תָּגֵלְנָה בְּנוֹת יְהוּדָה

“let the daughters of Judah be glad”

This could mean: (1) that the psalmist is speaking of the kingdom of **Judah** were a mother and of its people as if they were her **daughters**. Alternate translation: [let the people of Judah be glad] or (2) that the psalmist is speaking specifically of the women of the kingdom of **Judah** and encouraging them to have a victory celebration, as women in this culture did. Alternate translation: [let the women of Judah hold a victory celebration]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 48:12 (#1)

סֹבּוּ צִיּוֹן וְהַקִּיפُוהָ סִפְרוּ

“Circle Zion and go around her. Count”

The instances of the implied “you” in the imperatives **Circle**, **go around**, and **Count** are plural because the psalmist is addressing many people. In the next verse, the terms “your” and “you” and the instances of the implied “you” in the imperatives are plural for the same reason. So use plural forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 48:12 (#2)

סֹבּוּ צִיּוֹן וְהַקִּיפُוהָ

“Circle Zion and go around her”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Go all the way around Zion]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 48:12 (#3)

סֹבּוּ צִיּוֹן

“Circle Zion”

Since a mountain does not have **towers**, here **Zion** represents the city of Jerusalem. If it would be helpful

in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Circle the city on Mount Zion] or [Circle Jerusalem]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 48:13 (#1)

שִׁ֭שְׁי֣תוּ לִבְּכֶ֑ם ׀ לְ֝חֵילָ֗הּ

“put your heart to her rampart”

The psalmist is using **put your heart to** as a common expression of his culture to mean “carefully consider.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [keep in mind her rampart] or [carefully consider her rampart]

See: Idiom

Psalms 48:13 (#2)

לְ֝חֵילָ֗הּ

“to her rampart”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **rampart**. He means all the ramparts of the walls of Jerusalem. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [her ramparts]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 48:14 (#1)

כִּ֤י זֶ֨ה ׀ אֱלֹהִ֤ים אֱ֭לֹהֵינוּ

“For this God {is} our God”

As in verse 4, here the word **For** introduces the reason why people should praise Yahweh. It is not introducing the reason why people should walk around the walls of Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [We should praise this God because he is our God]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 48:14 (#2)

הַ֝הוּא֗ יְנַהֲגֵ֥נוּ עַל

“He, he will guide us”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **He** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will guide us** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the personal role of Yahweh in guiding the Judeans. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [He is the one who will guide us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 49 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 49 is a wisdom psalm that describes the difference between how righteous people and wicked people live and the difference between what happens to them. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Introduction: call to listen (1–4)
2. Reminder that all people die, just as animals do (5–13; refrain, 12)
3. The psalmist’s confident assertion that God will bring him out of Sheol (14–15)
4. Reassertion that all people die, just as animals do (16–19; refrain, 20)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Life after death

This psalm teaches that having wealth and power cannot keep anyone from dying. All people, whether they are rich or poor, will die. But in verses 14–15, the psalmist expresses his confident expectation that God will not leave him in the place where people go when they die. Instead, God will take him out of there and bring him to himself. While the belief in life after death and the resurrection from the dead is expressed more clearly in the New Testament, that belief is also expressed in the Old Testament in places such as this. Translators should translate this psalm, especially verses 14 and 15, in such a way that it is clear that this Old Testament writer had this expectation.

Psalms 49:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 49:0 (#3)

לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח"

See how you translated the expression "the sons of Korah" in the superscription to Psalm 42. Alternate translation: [of the descendants of Korah] or [of the Korahites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:1 (#1)

שִׁמְעוּ־זֹאת כָּל־הָעַמִּים הַאֲזִינוּ כָּל־יֹשְׁבֵי חָלֶד

"Hear this, all peoples! Listen, all dwellers of the world"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and do that here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Listen carefully to me, all of you people who live in the world] or [Hear this, all peoples! Yes, listen, everyone who lives in the world]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 49:1 (#2)

שִׁמְעוּ & הַאֲזִינוּ

"Hear & Listen"

The implied "you" in these imperatives is plural because the psalmist is addressing many people. So use plural forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Psalms 49:2 (#1)

גַּם־בְּנֵי אָדָם גַּם־בְּנֵי־אִישׁ

"both sons of a human and sons of a man"

The psalmist is using **sons of a human** as a common expression of his culture to mean "ordinary people," and he is using **sons of a man** as a common expression of his culture to mean "distinguished people." If these phrases do not have those meanings in your language, you could use comparable expressions from your language that do have those meanings, or you could state the meanings plainly. Alternate translation: [both the man on the street and the man in the corner office] or [both ordinary people and distinguished people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 49:2 (#2)

עָשִׁשַׁי֖ר וְאֶבְיֽוֹן

"the rich and the poor"

The psalmist is using the adjectives **rich** and **poor** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjective with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [rich people and poor people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 49:3 (#1)

פִּ֭י יְדַבֵּ֣ר חָכְמ֑וֹת וְהָגִ֖יוֹת לִבִּ֣י תְבוּנֽוֹת

"My mouth will speak wisdom, and the meditation of my heart, understanding"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [My mouth will speak wisdom, and the meditation of my heart will speak understanding]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 49:3 (#2)

פִּ֭י יְדַבֵּ֣ר חָכְמ֑וֹת וְהָגִ֖יוֹת לִבִּ֣י תְבוּנֽוֹת

"My mouth will speak wisdom, and the meditation of my heart, understanding"

The psalmist is using individual parts of a himself, his **mouth** and the **meditation of his heart**, to mean all of him in the act of speaking **wisdom** and **understanding**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [With my mouth I will speak wisdom, and from the meditation of my heart I will speak understanding]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 49:3 (#3)

וְהָגִ֖יוֹת לִבִּ֣י תְבוּנֽוֹת

"and the meditation of my heart, understanding"

Here the **heart** represents a person's thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the

meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and from the meditation of my thoughts I will speak understanding]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:3 (#4)

וְהָגִגּוֹת לִבִּי תְבוּנוֹת

“and the meditation of my heart, understanding”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **meditation** and **understanding**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and from what I have meditated on in my thoughts, I will say things that will help you understand]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 49:4 (#1)

אַטֶּה לְמָשָׁל אָזְנִי

“I will incline my ear to a proverb”

The psalmist is speaking as if he is going to physically **incline** his **ear**, that is, lean over the way someone would do to listen to someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will listen carefully to a proverb]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:4 (#2)

אַטֶּה לְמָשָׁל אָזְנִי

“I will incline my ear to a proverb”

The psalmist is speaking of this **proverb** as if it were a living thing that could speak to him. While he actually could listen to this proverb in the sense of hearing other people quote it, he means that he will carefully consider its meaning. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [I will see what a proverb has to say to me] or [I will carefully consider the meaning of a proverb]

See: Personification

Psalms 49:4 (#3)

אַטֶּה לְמָשָׁל אָזְנִי

“I will incline my ear to a proverb”

While the term that the ULT translates as **proverb** generally means a short, popular saying that expresses some wisdom or truth, the specific meaning in this context is a “comparison,” which many proverbs draw. The psalmist is probably referring to the comparison in the refrain in verses 12 and 20 of this psalm, that people are like beasts. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I will carefully consider the meaning of a comparison]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 49:4 (#4)

אֶפְתַּח בְּכִנּוֹר חִידָתִי

“I will open my enigma with a harp”

The psalmist is speaking as if his **enigma** (the difficult and puzzling question he is trying to solve) were a closed container that he is going to use a **harp** to **open**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will explain my enigma as I sing and accompany myself with a harp]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:5 (#1)

בִּימֵי רָעֶה

“in the days of evil”

The psalmist is using the term **days** to mean “time,” since time consists of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [during evil times] or [during troubled times]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 49:5 (#2)

עֲוֹן עְקֵבַי יְסוֹבֵנִי

“when} the iniquity of my heels surrounds me”

As the next verse indicates, the psalmist is using his **heels** to represent people who would trip him up at his heels, that is, make him fall down. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [when the iniquity of those who would trip me up surrounds me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 49:5 (#3)

עֲוֹן עְקֵבַי יְסוֹבֵנִי

“when} the iniquity of my heels surrounds me”

The psalmist is speaking as if people wanted to trip him physically and make him fall down. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [when the iniquity of those who want to cause my downfall surrounds me] or [when the iniquity of those who want to ruin me surrounds me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:5 (#4)

עֲוֹן עֲקֵבַי יְסוּבֵּנִי

“when} the iniquity of my heels surrounds me”

The psalmist is speaking of the **iniquity** of certain people as if it were a living thing that could surround him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when iniquitous people who want to ruin me surround me]

See: Personification

Psalms 49:5–6 (#1)

לָמָּה אִירָא בִּימֵי רָעָ֑ה עֲוֹן עֲקֵבַי יְסוּבֵּנִי׃ הַבֹּטְחִים עַל־חֵילָם וּבְרֹ֣ב עָ֭שְׁרָם יִתְהַלָּלוּ

“Why should I fear in the days of evil, {when} the iniquity of my heels surrounds me,the ones trusting in their wealth, and in the abundance of their treasure they boast”

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine 49:5 and 49:6 into a verse bridge in order to keep together the entire question that the psalmist is asking in these verses. The psalmist is using the question form to make a confident affirmation. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I do not have to be afraid in the days of evil, when the iniquity of my heels surrounds me, the ones trusting in their wealth, and in the abundance of their treasure they boast!]

See: Verse Bridges

Psalms 49:6 (#1)

הַבֹּטְחִים עַל־חֵילָם וּבְרֹ֣ב עָ֭שְׁרָם יִתְהַלָּלוּ

“the ones trusting in their wealth, and in the abundance of their treasure they boast”

The psalmist is using two different verb forms in parallel statements. It may be more natural in your language to use the same verb form in both statements. Alternate translation: [the ones trusting in their wealth and boasting in the abundance of their treasure]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 49:7 (#1)

אָח֤ לֹא־פָדֹ֣ה יִפְדֶּ֣ה אִ֭ישׁ לֹא־יִתֵּ֣ן לֵאלֹהִ֑ים כָּפְרֹֽו

“Redeeming, a man does not redeem a brother, he does not give his ransom to God”

The psalmist is repeating forms of the verb **redeem** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [A man certainly does not redeem a brother, he does not give his ransom to God]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 49:7 (#2)

אָח֤ לֹא־פָדֹ֣ה יִפְדֶּ֣ה אִ֭ישׁ לֹא־יִתֵּ֣ן לֵאלֹהִ֑ים כָּפְרֹֽו

“Redeeming, a man does not redeem a brother, he does not give his ransom to God”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [A man certainly does not pay a ransom to God to redeem a brother]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 49:7 (#3)

אָח֤

“a brother”

The psalmist is speaking as if a fellow human being were actually another person’s **brother**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a fellow human]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:8 (#1)

נַפְשָׁ֑ם

“their life”

In this verse, the word **life** is singular in form, but it refers to the lives of all humans as a group. If it would

be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of "life." Alternate translation: [their lives]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 49:8 (#2)

וְחָדַל לְעוֹלָם

"and it ceases forever"

The psalmist means that the attempt at the **redemption** of a life **ceases** in the sense that it does not succeed and must be abandoned. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and the attempt always fails]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 49:8–9 (#1)

וְיִקַר פִּדְיוֹן נַפְשָׁם וְחָדַל לְעוֹלָם: וְיִחִי־עוֹד לָנֶצַח לֹא יִרְאֶה הַשָּׁחַת

"For the redemption of their life is costly, and it ceases forever,that one should live on forever, {that} one should not see the pit"

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine verses 8 and 9 into a verse bridge in order to put the information about what **the redemption of their life** means right after that phrase. Alternate translation: [For the redemption of their life, that one should live on forever, that one should not see the pit, is costly, and it ceases forever]

See: Verse Bridges

Psalms 49:9 (#1)

לֹא יִרְאֶה הַשָּׁחַת

"that} one should not see the pit"

In this context, the term **see** has the sense of "experience." You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [that one should not experience the pit]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 49:9 (#2)

לֹא יִרְאֶה הַשָּׁחַת

"that} one should not see the pit"

The psalmist is using the expression **the pit** to refer to Sheol, the realm of the dead. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [that one should not experience the grave] or [that one should not go to the realm of the dead]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 49:10 (#1)

כִּי

"For"

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 49:10 (#2)

יִרְאֶה

"one will see"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [one will see the Pit]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 49:10 (#3)

חֲכָמִים

"The wise"

The psalmist is using the adjective **wise** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Wise people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 49:10 (#4)

כְּסִיל וּבַעַר

"the fool and the brute"

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **fool** or **brute**. He means such people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [fools and brutes] or [foolish people and brutish people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 49:11 (#1)

קִרְבָּם בָּתֵּימוֹ ׀ לְעוֹלָם

“Inside of them, their houses {are} forever”

This phrase is a translation of the written Hebrew text. You may wish to follow an alternative reading from the ancient Greek translation. Alternate translation: [Their graves {are} their houses forever]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 49:11 (#2)

קִרְבָּם

“Inside of them”

Here, what is **Inside** people represents their thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [In their thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 49:11 (#3)

קָרְאוּ בִשְׁמוֹתָם עֲלֵי אֲדָמוֹת

“They call over lands by their names”

The psalmist is using a common expression of his culture to mean that the people he is describing give new names, their own names, to **lands** or properties. If this expression does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They give their names to lands] or [They name lands after themselves]

See: Idiom

Psalms 49:12 (#1)

נִמְשַׁל כַּבְּהֵמוֹת נִדְמוּ

“He is likened to the beasts, they are destroyed”

The expressions **is likened** and **are destroyed** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [He is like the beasts, which perish]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 49:13 (#1)

זֶה דַּרְכָּם כֵּסֶל לָמוֹ

“This, their way, {is} folly to them”

In this context, **to them** is a possessive form. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [This, their way, is their folly]

See: Possession

Psalms 49:13 (#2)

זֶה דַּרְכָּם כֵּסֶל לָמוֹ

“This, their way, {is} folly to them”

The psalmist is speaking of how people live as if that were a **way** or path that they were walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [This, their manner of life, is their folly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:13 (#3)

וְאַחֲרֵיהֶם & יִרְצוּ

“but after them, they delight”

The psalmist is speaking as if those who admire them and want to be like these presumptuous rich people were walking **after** them on the same **way** or path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [but their followers delight]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:13 (#4)

בְּפִיהֶם

“in their mouths”

The psalmist is using the **mouths** of these presumptuous rich people to represent what they say by using their mouths. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in their sayings]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 49:13 (#5)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

To translate the term **Selah** here and in verse 15, see how your translation team decided to represent that term in 3:2.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 49:14 (#1)

כַּצֹּ֣אן

“Like sheep”

The point of this comparison is that just as **sheep** are vulnerable and easily killed, so these rich people are vulnerable to dying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [As if they were vulnerable sheep]

See: Simile

Psalms 49:14 (#2)

שַׁ֭תוּ

“they appoint {them”

Here the psalmist is using the pronoun **They** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. If you need to say specifically who does the action, the context in the next verse indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [They are appointed] or [God appoints them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 49:14 (#3)

מָ֑וֶת יִ֝רְעֵ֗ם

“death will shepherd them”

The psalmist is speaking of **death** as if it were a living thing that could **shepherd** these people. He means that just as a shepherd keeps all of his sheep under his control so that none wander away, none of these people will get away from the realm of the dead. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. (However, since the image of a **shepherd** here extends the image of **sheep** earlier in the verse, you may wish to express both images as comparisons. The UST models one way to do that.) Alternate translation: [they will not get away from the realm of the dead]

See: Personification

Psalms 49:14 (#4)

וַיִּרְדּ֣וּ בָ֭ם יְשָׁרִ֣ים ׀ לַבֹּ֑קֶר

“And the upright will rule over them in the morning”

The psalmist is speaking as if the **upright** were going to rule **in the morning** on a certain day over rich people who had been wicked. He means that the “days of evil” (that is, the troubled times) that he began describing in verse 5, pictured here as a dark night, will surely end as God delivers innocent people from oppression. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar expression in 46:5. Alternate translation: [And when God delivers the upright from their oppression, they will rule over them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:14 (#5)

יְשָׁרִ֣ים

“the upright”

The psalmist is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [upright people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 49:14 (#6)

וצירם לְבַלּ֣וֹת שְׁא֭וֹל

“and Sheol will consume their form”

The psalmist is speaking of **Sheol** as if it were a living thing that could **consume** the **form** or body of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and their body will decompose in the grave]

See: Personification

Psalms 49:14 (#7)

וצירם

“and & their form”

In this verse, the word **form** is singular in form, but it refers to the forms or bodies of these wicked people as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “form.” Alternate translation: [their forms] or [their bodies]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 49:14 (#8)

מִזְּבֻ֖ל לֽוֹ

“from the dwelling to it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the **form** of each wicked person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [from its dwelling] or [away from where they lived]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 49:15 (#1)

מִיַּד־שְׁאוֹל

“from the hand of Sheol”

Here, **hand** represents the power and control that a person or thing has over someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the control of Sheol] or [from the custody of Sheol]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 49:15 (#2)

כִּֽי יִקָּחֵנִי

“for he will take me”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [and he will do that by taking me]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 49:16 (#1)

אִישׁ

“a man”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [a person]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 49:16 (#2)

כִּֽי־יִרְבֶּה כְּבְוֹד בֵּיתוֹ

“when the glory of his house increases”

Here, a rich person’s **house** represents all of his possessions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [when the splendor of his estate increases]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 49:17 (#1)

כְּבוֹדוֹ

“his glory”

Here, **glory** represents “wealth.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [his wealth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 49:17 (#2)

לֹא־יֵרֵד

“will not go down”

The psalmist assumes that readers will understand that by **go down**, he means “go down to Sheol.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [go down to Sheol]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 49:18 (#1)

נַפְשׁוֹ & יְבָרֵךְ

“he blesses his soul”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **soul**, to mean all of him in the act of blessing himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he blesses himself]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 49:18 (#2)

נַפְשׁוֹ & יְבָרֵךְ

“he blesses his soul”

While the term “bless” usually refers to expressing hope that good things would happen to a person, in this context, it means saying that good things have happened to a person. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he congratulates himself]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 49:18 (#3)

וְיוֹדֶךָ כִּי־תֵיטִיב לָךְ

“and they do praise you when you do well for yourself”

Here the psalmist is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and people do praise

you when you do well for yourself] or [and you are praised when you do well for yourself]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 49:18 (#4)

וְיוֹדֶךָּ כִּי־תֵיטִיב לָךְ

“and they do praise you when you do well for yourself”

The words **you** and **yourself** are singular here because the psalmist is addressing each person in the audience as a representative individual who needs to consider whether what he says applies directly to him. So use singular forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction. If it does not, you may be able to communicate the meaning here in some other way. Alternate translation: [and they will praise any one of you if you do well for yourself] or [and any one of you will be praised if he does well for himself]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 49:19 (#1)

תָּבוֹא עַד־דּוֹר אֲבוֹתָיו

“he will come to the generation of his fathers”

In a context such as this, your language might say “go” instead of **come**. Alternate translation: [he will go to the generation of his fathers]

See: Go and Come

Psalms 49:19 (#2)

תָּבוֹא עַד־דּוֹר אֲבוֹתָיו

“he will come to the generation of his fathers”

The psalmist is using the term **fathers** to mean “ancestors.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will come to the generation of his ancestors]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 49:19 (#3)

תָּבוֹא עַד־דּוֹר אֲבוֹתָיו

“he will come to the generation of his fathers”

The psalmist assumes that his listeners will understand that by this phrase he means that the rich man he has been describing since verse 16 will join in death the **generation** of people that consists of his ancestors. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he will join his ancestors in death]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 49:19 (#4)

עַד־נֶנַצַח לֹא יִרְאוּ־אוֹר

“forever they will not see light”

The psalmist is using **they will not see light** as a common expression of his culture to mean that the rich man and his ancestors will not live on the earth again. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will never see the light of day] or [they will never live on the earth again]

See: Idiom

Psalms 49:20 (#1)

אָדָם בִּיקָר וְלֹא יָבִין נִמְשַׁל כַּבְּהֵמוֹת

“A human in honor, but he does not understand, he is likened to the beasts”

A human in honor, but he does not understand introduces the first part of a possible condition. What the psalmist describes in the rest of this verse is true if this condition happens. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [Suppose a human is in honor, but he does not understand. Then he is likened to the beasts]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 49:20 (#2)

נִמְשַׁל כַּבְּהֵמוֹת נִדְמוּ

“he is likened to the beasts, they are destroyed”

This is the second occurrence of the refrain in this psalm. We recommend that you show this to your readers by translating the phrases here the same way that you translated them in the first occurrence of this refrain in 49:12. Alternate translation: [he is like the beasts, which perish]

See: Poetry

Psalms - Chapter 50 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 50 is like a wisdom psalm in that it describes the difference between how righteous people and

wicked people live and the difference between what happens to them. But it is a particular type of psalm that depicts God assembling and addressing the Israelites, commending those who are faithfully obeying his covenant but warning those who are acting wickedly. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. God powerfully summons the Israelites (1–6)
2. God addresses faithful Israelites (7–15)
3. God addresses wicked Israelites (16–22)
4. God reassures faithful Israelites (23)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Who was Asaph?
Asaph was an Israelite man from the tribe of Levi who was an important singer and musician during the reigns of David and Solomon. He played instruments and led people to sing songs to worship Yahweh. In addition to leading music, he also wrote songs. A dozen of the psalms are attributed to him. Psalm 50 is the psalm by Asaph that comes earliest in the book of Psalms.

What was a "thank offering" (verses 14, 23), and why does God encourage the Israelites to make this offering?
A thank offering was one type of fellowship offering, as Leviticus 7:12–15 describes. A worshiper would sacrifice an animal from his flock, and together with other food that he would bring, this would provide a celebration meal for his family and friends. At this meal, the worshiper would describe publicly how God had helped him when he was in trouble. When God encourages the Israelites to make this offering, he is effectively encouraging them to pray to him for help when they are in trouble, as verse 15 describes, so that he can rescue them and they can honor him in this way. The Israelites were already offering all of the sacrifices that the law of Moses required, but God wanted them to go beyond what was required and live in a relationship of active devotion to him. He wanted them to experience his help and offer sacrifices freely in gratitude.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Repeated phrases
For poetic effect, Asaph repeats some key terms in this psalm. He says in verse 3 that God "is not silent," showing that the situation in verse 21, where God says "I was silent," no longer holds. In verse 8, God tells the Israelite people, "I do not accuse you regarding your sacrifices," but in verse 21, God tells a representative wicked person, "I will accuse you" of moral wrongdoing. To help your readers appreciate these connections, we recommend that in your translation, you translate the verbs that the ULT represents as "be silent" and "accuse" the same way in both of their occurrences.

Psalms 50:1 (#1)

אֵ֤ל ׀ אֱלֹהִ֬ים

"The God of gods"

Asaph is using a possessive form to express a superlative meaning. If a speaker of your language would not use a possessive form as a superlative, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The Supreme God] or [The God who is greater than all other gods]

See: Possession

Psalms 50:1 (#2)

אֶ֭רֶץ מִמִּזְרַח־שֶׁ֣מֶשׁ עַד־מְבוֹאֹ֑

"the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting"

Here, **the earth** represents the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 50:1 (#3)

אֶ֭רֶץ מִמִּזְרַח־שֶׁ֣מֶשׁ עַד־מְבוֹאֹ֑

"the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting"

Asaph is referring to the entire earth by naming two extremes, the east, where **the sun** rises, and the west, where the sun sets. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people who live everywhere on earth]

See: Merism

Psalms 50:2 (#1)

מִכְלַל־יֹ֝֗פִי

"the perfection of beauty"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **perfection** and **beauty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the perfectly beautiful place]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 50:2 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים הוֹפִיעַ

“God has shined forth”

Asaph is speaking as if God had actually **shined forth** from Zion. He is using the image of light to represent God’s presence radiating out from Zion. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God’s presence radiates out]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 50:3 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“Our God”

By **Our**, the psalmist means to include both himself and those he is addressing, so use the inclusive form of that word if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Psalms 50:3 (#2)

וְאַל־יֶחֱרַשׁ

“and he is not silent”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **silent**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [and he is going to speak]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 50:3 (#3)

אֵשׁ־לְפָנָיו תֹּאכֵל וּסְבִיבָיו נִשְׂעָרָה מְאֹד

“A fire devours to his face, and around him it is stormed greatly”

Asaph is using images from God’s appearance on Mount Sinai, where he made a covenant with the Israelites, to describe God’s approach to judge his people in light of that covenant on this occasion. Exodus 19:16–18 describes how a great thunderstorm and a burning fire preceded Yahweh’s descent onto Mount Sinai. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 50:3 (#4)

אֵשׁ־לְפָנָיו תֹּאכֵל

“A fire devours to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents “in front of him.” If you decide to retain this image in your translation, if it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [A fire devours in front of him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 50:3 (#5)

אֵשׁ־לְפָנָיו תֹּאכֵל

“A fire devours to his face”

Asaph is speaking as if this **fire** were actually devouring or eating what was in front of God. If you decide to retain this image in your translation, if it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [A fire burns up everything in front of him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 50:3 (#6)

נִשְׂעָרָה מְאֹד

“it is stormed greatly”

The expression **it is stormed** is a passive verbal form. If you decide to retain this image in your translation, if your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [a great storm rages]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 50:4 (#1)

יִקְרָא אֶל־הַשָּׁמַיִם מֵעָל וְאֶל־הָאָרֶץ

“He calls to the heavens above and to the earth”

Asaph assumes that listeners will understand that he means that God **calls** the **heavens** and the **earth** to serve as witnesses of what the Israelites promised to do when they made a covenant with Yahweh. Deuteronomy 4:26 and Deuteronomy 30:19 describe how Moses called upon the heavens and the earth to serve as witnesses in this way. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He calls to the heavens above and to the earth as witnesses]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:5 (#1)

אִסְפוּ־לִי חֲסִידָי

“Gather my faithful {ones} to me”

This verse is a direct quotation of God. The ULT indicates that by putting the verse inside quotation marks. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could also use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [He says, “Gather my faithful ones to me]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 50:5 (#2)

אִסְפוּ־לִ֥י חֲסִידָ֑י

“Gather my faithful {ones} to me”

Asaph does not identify to whom God is giving this command. (God is not addressing the heavens and the earth. Their role is to serve as witnesses.) The focus is more on the results than on the agents. It may be more natural in your language to express this with a form other than a command form. Alternate translation: [Let my faithful ones be gathered to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 50:5 (#3)

אִסְפוּ

“Gather”

The implied “you” in the imperative **Gather** is plural, so if you retain the command form, use its plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 50:5 (#4)

חֲסִידָ֑י

“my faithful {ones”

Asaph is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. (The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **ones**.) Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can use an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the ones who are faithful to me]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 50:5 (#5)

כֹּרְתֵ֖י בְּרִיתִ֣י

“the cutters of my covenant”

God is using **the cutters of my covenant** as a common expression of this culture to mean “those who made a covenant with me.” He is using the term “cut” because in some covenant ceremonies, the participants would cut up animals and then walk between the pieces. This was to indicate, “If I break this covenant, may I be destroyed in this same way.” It is not necessary to understand this background to covenant ceremonies in order to understand what God says in the rest of this psalm, so you do not have to use the term “cut” in your translation. You could simply say “make,” or you could use an expression from your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [those who made a covenant with me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 50:5 (#6)

עֲלֵי־זָבַ֗ח

“by sacrifice”

God is not using the phrase **by sacrifice** to refer to animals that were slaughtered and cut up when he made his covenant with the Israelites. (There is no description in the Bible of such a ceremony connected with that covenant.) He means that this covenant was sealed and was to be continually acknowledged by sacrificial worship, which is the main theme of this psalm. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [that was sealed and was to be continually acknowledged by sacrificial worship]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:6 (#1)

וַיַּגִּ֣ידוּ שָׁ֭מַיִם צִדְקָת֑וֹ

“The heavens declare his righteousness”

Asaph is speaking of the **heavens** as if they were a living thing that could **declare** God’s righteousness. This conveys two ideas. In the immediate context, the heavens witness that God has kept his part of the covenant. In the broader biblical context, as in 19:1 and 97:6, the characteristics of the heavens display the righteous character of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the broader meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The heavens display his righteousness]

See: Personification

Psalms 50:6 (#2)

צִדְקָת֑וֹ

“his righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he is righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 50:6 (#3)

כִּי־אֱלֹהִים ׀ שֹׁפֵט הוּא

“that God, he is judge”

Asaph is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though it could be omitted, in order to emphasize that the heavens declare that God is the supreme **judge** of everyone on earth. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [that it is God who is judge]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 50:6 (#4)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

See how your translation team decided at 3:2 to represent the term **Selah**.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 50:7 (#1)

שִׁמְעָה עַמִּי ׀ וַאֲדַבֵּרָה

“Hear, my people, and I will speak”

This verse begins a direct quotation of God that continues through verse 15. The ULT indicates that by putting these verses inside quotation marks. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could also use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [He says, “Hear, my people, and I will speak]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 50:7 (#2)

שִׁמְעָה & בָּבֶד & אֱלֹהֶיךָ

“Hear & against you & your God”

The pronouns **you** and **your** and the implied “you” in imperatives are singular here and through verse 15 because God is addressing his **people** as if they were a single individual. So use singular forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 50:7 (#3)

יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Israel”

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [listen, Israel]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 50:7 (#4)

יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents the nation that consisted of the descendants of Jacob, whom God renamed Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [you Israelites]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 50:8 (#1)

לֹא עַל־זִבְחֶיךָ אוֹכִיחֶךָּ וְעוֹלֹתֶיךָ לְנֶגְדִּי תָמִיד

“I do not accuse you regarding your sacrifices, for your burnt offerings are always before me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Your burnt offerings are always before me, so I do not accuse you regarding your sacrifices]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 50:9 (#1)

לֹא־אֶקַּח מִבֵּיתְךָ פָּר מִמִּכְלְאֹתֶיךָ עַתּוּדִים

“I will not take a bull from your house, goats from your folds”

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will not take a bull from your house, and I will not take goats from your folds] or [I will not take a bull from your house or goats from your folds]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 50:9 (#2)

לֹא־אֶקַּח מִבֵּיתְךָ פָּר מִמִּכְלְאֹתֶיךָ עַתּוּדִים

“I will not take a bull from your house, goats from your folds”

God is not saying that he will not accept bulls or goats from the Israelites as sacrifices. This psalm as a whole is supportive of the sacrificial system. However, its emphasis is on offering sacrifices for the right reasons. They are not something that God needs; they are a way of living in relationship with God (as verses 14 and 15 especially emphasize). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I do not need to take a bull from your house or goats from your folds]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:9 (#3)

מִבֵּיתְךָ

“from your house”

Here, a person’s **house** represents his “household” or “possessions.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from among your possessions]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 50:9 (#4)

עַתּוּדִים

“goats”

Here and in v. 13, the psalmist is using a specific term that means male goats. If your language does not have a general term for goats but must specify whether a goat is male or female, use your term for male goats in these places.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:10 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 50:10 (#2)

לִֽי כָל־חַיְתוֹ־יָ֑עַר בְּהֲמ֥וֹת בְּהַרְרֵי־אֶֽלֶף

“every beast of the forest {is} to me, the cattle on a thousand hills”

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [every beast of the forest is mine, and the cattle on a thousand hills are mine] or [every beast of the forest and the cattle on a thousand hills belong to me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 50:10 (#3)

בְּהֲמ֥וֹת בְּהַרְרֵי־אֶֽלֶף

“the cattle on a thousand hills”

God is using the number **a thousand** in a way that was common in this culture to mean a very large, uncountable number, not a precise figure. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the cattle on every hill] or [all cattle everywhere]

See: Idiom

Psalms 50:11 (#1)

יָדַ֥עְתִּי

“I know”

God is using the term **know** in a particular sense to mean that he owns **all the birds**. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I own]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:11 (#2)

וְזִ֖יז שָׂ֣דַי עִמָּדִֽי

“and the creature of the field {is} with me”

In this context, the phrase **with me** expresses a relationship of possession. Alternate translation: [and the creature of the field is mine]

See: Possession

Psalms 50:11 (#3)

וְזִ֖יז שָׂ֣דַי עִמָּדִֽי

“and the creature of the field {is} with me”

God is not referring to a specific **creature**. He means field creatures in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and every field creature is mine]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 50:11 (#4)

וְזִיז שָׂשָׂדַי עִמָּדִי

“and the creature of the field {is} with me”

The term that the ULT translates as **creature** refers to a “moving thing,” and in this context, it probably means a “swarming thing” or insect. (In the previous verse, God described how large animals belonged to him, and in this verse, he makes the focus much smaller and thus even more comprehensive.) You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and even the insects in the fields are mine]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:12 (#1)

אִם־אֶֽרְעַב לֹא־אֹמַר לָךְ כִּי־לִי תֵבֵל וּמְלֹאָהּ

“If I were hungry, I would not say {that} to you, for the world and its fulness {are} to me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since the world and its fulness are mine, I would not tell you if I were hungry]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 50:12 (#2)

וּמְלֹאָהּ

“and its fulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and what fills it] or [and everything in it]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 50:13 (#1)

הֲאָכֵל בְּשַׂר אַבִּירִים וְדַם עַתּוּדִים אֶשְׁתֶּה

“Do I eat the flesh of bulls, or do I drink the blood of goats”

God is using the question form to emphasize that what he is describing is certainly not true. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I certainly do not eat the flesh of bulls, and I do not drink the blood of goats!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 50:14 (#1)

זְבַח לֵאלֹהִים תּוֹדָה וְשַׁלֵּם לְעֶלְיוֹן נְדָרֶיךָ

“Sacrifice a thank offering to God, and pay your vows to the Most High”

God is speaking of himself in the third person because he is giving an authoritative command. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [Sacrifice a thank offering to me, God, and pay your vows to me, the Most High]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 50:15 (#1)

בְּיוֹם צָרָה

“in the day of trouble”

Asaph is using the term **day** to mean “time,” since time consists of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in any time of trouble]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 50:16 (#1)

וְלָרָשָׁע

“But to the wicked {one”

Asaph is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. (The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **one**.) Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can use an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [But to every wicked person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 50:16 (#2)

לְךָ & וַתִּשָּׂא & פִּיךָ

“to you & or that you should lift up & your mouth”

The pronouns **you** and **your** are singular here and through verse 21 because God is addressing a representative **wicked** individual. So use singular forms in

your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

Psalms 50:16 (#3)

מַה־לְּךָ֥ לְסַפֵּ֗ר חֻקַּ֫י וַתִּשָּׂ֥א בְרִיתִ֑י עָלֵ֖י־פִּֽיךָ

"What to you to recount my statutes, or that you should lift up my covenant onto your mouth"

God is using the question form to rebuke wicked people who speak as if they were loyal to his covenant but who disobey its commandments. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [It is not to you to recount my statutes, and you should not lift up my covenant onto your mouth!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 50:16 (#4)

מַה־לְּךָ֥ לְסַפֵּ֗ר חֻקַּ֫י וַתִּשָּׂ֥א בְרִיתִ֑י עָלֵ֖י־פִּֽיךָ

"What to you to recount my statutes, or that you should lift up my covenant onto your mouth"

God is using **What to you** as a common expression of this culture to mean that the person he is addressing has no valid connection with what he describes next. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have no business recounting my statutes or lifting up my covenant onto your mouth!] or [It is not appropriate for you to recount my statutes or to lift up my covenant onto your mouth.]

See: Idiom

Psalms 50:16 (#5)

וַתִּשָּׂ֥א בְרִיתִ֑י עָלֵ֖י־פִּֽיךָ

"or that you should lift up my covenant onto your mouth"

God is speaking as if his **covenant** were an object that this wicked person could actually **lift up** and put on his **mouth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [or that you should say that you are loyal to my covenant]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 50:16–17 (#1)

וְלָֽרָשָׁ֥ע ׀ אָמַ֣ר אֱלֹהִ֗ים מַה־לְּךָ֥ לְסַפֵּ֗ר חֻקַּ֫י וַתִּשָּׂ֥א בְרִיתִ֑י
עָלֵ֖י־פִּֽיךָ׃ וְאַתָּ֣ה שָׂנֵ֣אתָ מוּסָ֑ר וַתַּשְׁלֵ֖ךְ דְּבָרַ֣י אַחֲרֶֽיךָ׃

"But to the wicked {one} God says, "What to you to recount my statutes, or that you should lift up my covenant onto your mouth?For you, you hate instruction, and you cast my words behind you"

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine 50:16, which describes a result, and 50:17, which gives a reason, into a verse bridge in order to put the reason before the result. Alternate translation: [But to the wicked one God says, "Since you, you hate instruction, and you cast my words behind you, what to you to recount my statutes, or that you should lift up my covenant onto your mouth?]

See: Verse Bridges

Psalms 50:17 (#1)

וְאַתָּ֣ה שָׂנֵ֣אתָ מוּסָ֑ר

"For you, you hate instruction"

God is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have** already includes this meaning. He is doing that in order to emphasize a contrast between what faithful people are doing, as described in the previous part of this psalm, and what this wicked individual is doing. Alternate translation: [for your part, you hate]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 50:17 (#2)

וַתַּשְׁלֵ֖ךְ דְּבָרַ֣י אַחֲרֶֽיךָ׃

"and you cast my words behind you"

God is speaking as if his **words** were objects that this wicked person could actually **cast behind** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you disregard my words]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 50:17 (#3)

דְּבָרַ֣י

"my words"

God is using the term **words** to represent what he says by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what I say to you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 50:19 (#1)

פִּ֭יךָ שָׁלַ֣חְתָּ בְרָעָ֑ה

“You send your mouth in evil”

God is using the term **send** in a specific sense to mean “release” or “set free,” as in Deuteronomy 15:12. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You release your mouth in evil]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:19 (#2)

פִּ֭יךָ שָׁלַ֣חְתָּ בְרָעָ֑ה

“You send your mouth in evil”

God is speaking of this wicked person’s **mouth** as if it were itself a person that the wicked one could **send** away or release. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You say evil things without restraint]

See: Personification

Psalms 50:19 (#3)

וּ֝לְשׁוֹנְךָ֗ תַּצְמִ֥יד מִרְמָֽה

“and your tongue frames deceit”

God is speaking of this wicked person’s **tongue** as if it were itself a person who could **frame** (form or put together) **deceit**, which God is speaking of as if it were an object that could be assembled. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you make up deceitful things to say]

See: Personification

Psalms 50:20 (#1)

תֵּ֭שֵׁב & תְּדַבֵּ֑ר

“You sit, you speak”

God is using **You sit** as a common expression of this culture to indicate that the action he describes next, **you speak**, is something that this wicked person does deliberately and continuously. If this expression does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You sit around speaking] or [You habitually speak]

See: Idiom

Psalms 50:20 (#2)

בְּאָ֝חִ֗יךָ & בֶּן־אִמְּךָ֥

“against your brother & against the son of your mother”

The word that the ULT translates as **brother** is a general term that in various contexts can mean a full brother or a half-brother, a kinsman, or a fellow Israelite. The phrase **the son of your mother** explicitly describes a full brother. (It is characteristic of Hebrew poetry for the second part of a line to intensify and sharpen the first part of a line.) If your language has a general term for a relative that can include a brother, it would be appropriate to use it to translate **brother**. If not, if your language has a term for a half-brother (a son of the same father but not of the same mother), you might use that to translate **brother**, and you might use your term for a full brother (a son of the same mother and father) in the second part of the verse.

See: Kinship

Psalms 50:21 (#1)

דִּמִּ֗יתָ הָיוֹת־אֶ֫הְיֶ֥ה כָּמ֑וֹךָ

“You thought the being of I AM {was} like you”

This could mean: (1) that God is referring to himself in the third person by the name he revealed to Moses in Exodus 3:14. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [You thought that I, the I AM, was like you in my being] or (2) that God is repeating forms of the verb “to be” in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. Another way to translate the original text is, “You thought that being, I was like you.” Alternate translation: [You thought that surely I was like you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:21 (#2)

דִּמִּ֗יתָ הָיוֹת־אֶ֫הְיֶ֥ה כָּמ֑וֹךָ

“You thought the being of I AM {was} like you”

This sentence indicates the result of the reason that the previous sentence describes. It may be helpful to use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [Therefore, you thought the being of I AM was like you]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 50:21 (#3)

אוֹכִיחֲךָ וְאֶעֶרְכָה לְעֵינֶיךָ

“I will accuse you, and let me array to your eyes”

God is using the term **array**, which often describes armies forming battle lines, in a legal sense to mean that he will present evidence in a compelling order. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I will marshal the evidence against you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 50:21 (#4)

לְעֵינֶיךָ

“to your eyes”

Here, **eyes** represent sight. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for you to see]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 50:22 (#1)

בִּינוּ

“Consider”

The implied “you” in the imperative **Consider** is plural because God is addressing everyone who does not pay attention to his commandments, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 50:22 (#2)

שֹׁכְחֵי אֱלוֹהַּ

“forgetters of God”

God is speaking of himself in the third person because he is giving an authoritative command. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [you who forget me, God] or [you who disregard me, God]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 50:22 (#3)

פֶּן־אֶטְרֹף וְאֵין מַצִּיל

“lest I tear and none be delivering”

God is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first gives the people he is addressing an instruction to follow so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the instruction. Alternate translation: [Otherwise, I will tear you, and no one will be able to deliver you]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 50:22 (#4)

אֶטְרֹף

“I tear”

God is speaking as if he would actually **tear** wicked people into pieces the way a lion tears its victim apart. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I punish you severely]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 50:23 (#1)

וְשָׂשָׂם דֶּרֶךְ

“and the one placing a way”

God is speaking as if the person he is describing were actually **placing** or preparing a **way** or path on which he would walk. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the one ordering his conduct rightly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 50:23 (#2)

אַרְאֶנּוּ בִּישׁוּעַת אֱלֹהִים

“I will make him look upon the salvation of God”

In this context, to **look upon** salvation means to “experience” it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will make him experience the salvation of God]

See: Idiom

Psalms 50:23 (#3)

אַרְאֶנּוּ בִּישׁוּעַת אֱלֹהִים

“I will make him look upon the salvation of God”

God is speaking of himself in the third person because he is making an authoritative promise. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [I will make him experience my salvation]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms - Chapter 51 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 51 is a specific kind of psalm of supplication, a "penitential psalm" in which the psalmist is deeply troubled by guilt and asks God to forgive him and restore him. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. David's plea for forgiveness (1–9)
2. David's plea for restoration (10–15)
3. Rightly offered sacrifices (16–19)

Psalms 51:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 51:0 (#3)

בְּבֹא אֶל־בַּת־שָׁבַע

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּבֹא אֶל־בַּת־שָׁבַע"

This superscription, referring to events described in 2 Samuel 11:1–12:25, describes sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **had gone in to**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [he had slept with Bathsheba]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 51:1 (#1)

כְּחַסְדֶּךָ

"according to your covenant faithfulness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to all the ways you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 51:1 (#2)

רַחֲמֶיךָ מְחֵה פְשָׁעָי

"your compassions, wipe away my transgressions"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **compassions** and **transgressions**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [of ways you care for me, forgive all the ways I have sinned against you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 51:1 (#3)

מְחֵה פְשָׁעָי

"wipe away my transgressions"

David is speaking of his **transgressions** as if they were words written in ink on a scroll that God could **wipe away** to erase them and make them disappear. The basic idea is that David wants God to regard his transgressions as if they had never occurred; that is, he wants God to forgive him for committing them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [completely forgive my transgressions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:2 (#1)

הרבה כַּבְּסֵנִי מֵעֲוֹנִי וּמֵחַטָּאתִי טַהֲרֵנִי

"Make great, wash me from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin"

The expressions **Make great** and **wash me** together express a single idea. The expression **Make great** tells in what way David wants God to **wash**him. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 51:2 (#2)

הרבה כַּבְּסֵנִי מֵעֲוֹנִי וּמֵחַטָּאתִי טַהֲרֵנִי

"Make great, wash me from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with

a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and do that here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Wash me thoroughly to cleanse me of my sin] or [Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, yes, cleanse me from my sin]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 51:2 (#3)

הרבה כַּבְּסֵנִי מֵעֲוֹנִי וּמֵחַטָּאתִי טַהֲרֵנִי

“Make great, wash me from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin”

This could mean (both meanings may be present): (1) that David is speaking of his **iniquity** or **sin** as if it were actually dirt or a stain that God could **wash** off of him in order to **cleanse** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Completely take away my iniquity, yes, remove all of my sin] or (2) that David is speaking as if his **iniquity** or **sin** had made him ritually unclean and so unable to participate in the worship of God until he became ritually clean again through ceremonial washing. Alternate translation: [Take away all of my iniquity to make me acceptable to you again so that I can worship you freely]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:3 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an admission. Alternate translation: [Indeed,] or [Admittedly,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 51:3 (#2)

פְּשָׁעַי אֲנִי אֵדָע

“I, I know my transgressions”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I know** already includes this meaning. He is doing that because he is confronting himself with the fact of his **transgressions**. Alternate translation: [I know very well that I have committed transgressions]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 51:3 (#3)

וְחַטָּאתִי נֶגְדִּי תָמִיד

“and my sin {is} always before me”

David is speaking of his **sin** as if it were actually an object that was **always before** him or in front of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I am always conscious of my sin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:4 (#1)

לְךָ לְבַדְּךָ ׀ חָטָאתִי

“Against you, you only, I have sinned”

David is repeating the pronoun **you** for emphasis. If your language can repeat pronouns for emphasis, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [You are the only one I have sinned against]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 51:4 (#2)

לְךָ לְבַדְּךָ ׀ חָטָאתִי

“Against you, you only, I have sinned”

David is saying **only** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [You are the one I have essentially sinned against]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 51:4 (#3)

וְהָרַע

“and & evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is evil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 51:4 (#4)

בְּעֵינֶיךָ

“in your eyes”

Here, **eyes** represents “perspective.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent

expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in your perspective]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 51:5 (#1)

הֵן

“Behold”

David is using the term **Behold** to focus attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, here and in the next verse.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:5 (#2)

בְּעָוֹן חוֹלָלְתִּי וּבְחֵטְא יֶחֱמַתְנִי אִמִּי

“I was born in iniquity, and in sin my mother conceived me”

David does not mean that his **mother conceived** him as the result of a sinful act. Instead, he means that as a human being, he has been characterized by **iniquity** and **sin** for his entire life. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I have been iniquitous since I was born; indeed, I have been sinful from the time my mother conceived me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 51:5 (#3)

בְּעָוֹן חוֹלָלְתִּי וּבְחֵטְא יֶחֱמַתְנִי אִמִּי

“I was born in iniquity, and in sin my mother conceived me”

The expression **was born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I was in iniquity when my mother gave birth to me; indeed, I was in sin when my mother conceived me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 51:6 (#1)

אֱמֶת

“truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [trustworthiness] or [integrity]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 51:6 (#2)

בַּטֻּחוֹת

“in the kidneys”

Here the **kidneys** represents a person’s motives and intentions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in a person’s motives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:6 (#3)

וּבְסָתֻם

“and & in the closed {place”

The expression **closed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [in the place that people close up]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 51:6 (#4)

וּבְסָתֻם

“and & in the closed {place”

David is using the verbal form **closed**, which functions here as an adjective, as a noun to mean a certain place. (The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **place**.) Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in my inner being]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 51:7 (#1)

תְּחַטְּאֵנִי בְאֵזוֹב וְאֶטְהָרָ

“May you purify me with hyssop, that I may be clean”

David is speaking as if he wanted God to perform the ceremony that the law of Moses describes in Numbers 19:18, in which a ceremonially clean person would dip a **hyssop** branch in water and sprinkle water with it to **purify** a person or place that had become ritually unclean. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:7 (#2)

בְּאֵזוֹב

“with hyssop”

The term **hyssop** describes a leafy plant, an herb that was common in Israel. Its large and numerous leaves made it ideal for use in sprinkling, especially in ceremonial contexts. If your language does not have a word for this plant, consider using a general expression. Alternate translation: [with leafy branches]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 51:7 (#3)

תְּחַטְּאֵנִי

“May you wash me”

As in verse 2, David is speaking of his sin as if it were dirt that God could **wash** off of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar image in verse 2. Alternate translation: [May you take away my sin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:7 (#4)

וּמִשֶּׁלֶג אַלְבִּין

“that I may be whiter than snow”

David is speaking as if he would become bright white in color if God were to wash him. He is using the uniform whiteness of newly fallen snow to represent complete purity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that I may be purer than snow]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:8 (#1)

תַּשְׁמִיעֵנִי שָׂשׂוֹן וְשִׂמְחָה

“Make me hear joy and gladness”

David is using the expression **joy and gladness** to represent things that God would say to him that would make him feel those emotions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Make me hear things that will cause me to feel joy and gladness] or [Say things to me that will make me feel joy and gladness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 51:8 (#2)

תַּשְׁמִיעֵנִי שָׂשׂוֹן וְשִׂמְחָה

“Make me hear joy and gladness”

David means specifically that he wants God to tell him that he has forgiven him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Assure me that you have forgiven me, that I may feel joy and gladness]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 51:8 (#3)

שָׂשׂוֹן וְשִׂמְחָה

“joy and gladness”

The terms **joy** and **gladness** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [great joy]

See: Doublet

Psalms 51:8 (#4)

תָּגֵלְנָה עֲצָמוֹת דִּכִּיתָ

“may the bones you have crushed rejoice”

David is using one part of himself, his **bones**, to mean all of him in the act of being **crushed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may I, whom you have crushed, rejoice]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 51:8 (#5)

תָּגֵלְנָה עֲצָמוֹת דִּכִּיתָ

“may the bones you have crushed rejoice”

David is speaking as if God had actually **crushed** him by convicting him of his sin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may I, whom you have deeply convicted of sin, rejoice]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:9 (#1)

הַסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מֵחַטָּאָי

“Hide your face from my sins”

David is speaking as if he wanted God to position his **face** so that it would not be visible from the place

where his **sins** were. Effectively this means that he wants God not to look at his sins. However, he does not mean that he wants God to leave his sins in place but not regard them. He wants God to make his sins nowhere to be seen; that is, he wants God to forgive the sins so that it is as if he had not committed them. Alternate translation: [Make my sins nowhere to be seen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:9 (#2)

וְכָל־עֲוֹנֹתַ֥י מְחֵֽה

“and wipe away all of my iniquities”

See how you translated the same image in verse 1. Alternate translation: [and forgive all of my iniquities]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:10 (#1)

לֵ֤ב טָ֖הוֹר בְּרָא־לִ֑י

“Create for me a clean heart”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s thoughts or motives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Give me a new capacity for pure thoughts] or [Give me a new capacity for right motives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:10 (#2)

וְר֖וּחַ נָכ֣וֹן חַדֵּ֣שׁ בְּקִרְבִּֽי

“and renew an established spirit within me”

The expression **established** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and renew a steadfast spirit within me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 51:10 (#3)

וְר֖וּחַ נָכ֣וֹן חַדֵּ֣שׁ בְּקִרְבִּֽי

“and renew an established spirit within me”

Here a person’s **spirit** represents his attitude, in this case, one of determination. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and enable me once again to be steadfastly determined to obey you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:11 (#1)

אַל־תַּשְׁלִיכֵ֥נִי מִלְּפָנֶ֑יךָ

“May you not cast me away from your face”

Here God’s **face** represents his “presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [May you not cast me away from your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 51:11 (#2)

אַל־תַּשְׁלִיכֵ֥נִי מִלְּפָנֶ֑יךָ

“May you not cast me away from your face”

David is speaking as if God might actually **cast** or throw him away from his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you not banish me from your presence]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:11 (#3)

וְר֖וּחַ קָדְשְׁךָ֣ אַל־תִּקַּ֣ח מִמֶּֽנִּי

“and may you not take the Spirit of your holiness from me”

David is using the possessive form to describe how God’s **Spirit** is characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and may you not take your Holy Spirit from me]

See: Possession

Psalms 51:12 (#1)

הָשִׁ֣יבָה לִ֭י שְׂשׂ֣וֹן יִשְׁעֶ֑ךָ

“Restore to me the joy of your salvation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **joy** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Make me joyful again that you have saved me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 51:12 (#2)

וְר֖וּחַ נְדִיבָ֣ה תִסְמְכֵֽנִי

“and support me {with} a willing spirit”

David is speaking as if he wanted God to use a **willing spirit** like a cane or walking stick to **support** him, that

is, to keep him from falling down. Within this image, falling down represents disobeying and sinning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and to keep me from sinning, make me willing to obey you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:13 (#1)

דְּרָכֶיךָ

“your ways”

David is speaking of the manners in which God wants people to live as if they were **ways** or paths that people would be walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how you want people to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:13 (#2)

וְחַטָּאִים אֵלֶיךָ יָשׁוּבוּ

“that sinners may return to you”

David is speaking as if **sinners** had actually gone to some place away from God from which they would **return** to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that sinners may repent]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:14 (#1)

מִדָּמִים

“from blood”

Here, **blood** represents “bloodguiltiness,” that is, legal liability to punishment by death for murdering another person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the death penalty I deserve for killing someone]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 51:14 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים אֱלֹהֵי תְּשׁוּעָתִי

“God, the God of my salvation”

David is repeating the word **God** to emphasize that the basis of his plea is the merciful, saving character of God. If your language can repeat words for emphasis, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the emphasis. Alternate translation: [you who are God my Savior]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 51:14 (#3)

תְּרַנֵּן לְשׁוֹנִי

“may my tongue sing”

David is using one part of himself, his **tongue**, to mean all of him in the act of singing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may I sing]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 51:14 (#4)

צִדְקָתֶךָ

“about} your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [about how righteous you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 51:15 (#1)

אֲדֹנָי שְׂפָתַי תִּפְתָּח

“Lord, may you open my lips”

David is not asking God physically to **open** his **lips**. He means that he wants God to do something (forgive and restore him, as he has asked) that will cause him to open his lips and declare God’s praise with his mouth. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Do this, Lord, so that I may open my lips]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 51:15 (#2)

שְׂפָתַי תִּפְתָּח

“may you open my lips”

Here David’s **lips** represent him speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [give me something to speak about]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 51:15 (#3)

וּפִי יַגִּיד תְּהִלָּתֶךָ

“that my mouth may declare your praise”

David is using one part of himself, his **mouth**, to mean all of him in the act of praising God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that I may declare your praise]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 51:16 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** does not introduce a reason for what immediately precedes. Instead, it introduces a general explanation for what David has been asking throughout this psalm. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 51:16 (#2)

לֹא־תַחְפֹּ֣ץ זֶ֭בַח & וְאֶתְּנָ֑ה עֹלָ֥ה לֹ֝א תִרְצֶֽה

“you do not delight in sacrifice & you do not accept a burnt offering”

David means specifically that God does not want a **sacrifice** and that God does not **accept a burnt offering** as the grounds on which to pardon someone who has committed murder. (The law of Moses provides for no such sacrifice.) You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you do not delight in sacrifice in cases of murder ... you do not accept a burnt offering to pardon a murderer]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 51:17 (#1)

זִבְחֵי֥ אֱלֹהִ֗ים

“The sacrifices of God”

David is using this possessive form not to describe **sacrifices** that **God** makes but sacrifices that God wants and accepts. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The sacrifices that God wants] or [The sacrifices that God accepts]

See: Possession

Psalms 51:17 (#2)

רֽוּחַ֣ נִשְׁבָּ֑רָה

“are} a broken spirit”

The expression **broken** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [are a spirit that has broken]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 51:17 (#3)

רֽוּחַ֣ נִשְׁבָּ֑רָה

“are} a broken spirit”

David is speaking as if a person’s **spirit** were actually an object that could be **broken**. The image is of something that is broken so that it has fallen down in pieces, with lowliness representing humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are a humble spirit]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:17 (#4)

רֽוּחַ֣ נִשְׁבָּ֑רָה

“are} a broken spirit”

As in verse 10, here a person’s **spirit** represents his attitude. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are a humble attitude]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:17 (#5)

לֵ֤ב־נִשְׁבָּ֨ר֮ וְנִדְכֶּ֪ה

“A broken and crushed heart”

The expressions **broken** and **crushed** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the ideas in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [A heart that an awareness of the seriousness of sin has broken and crushed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 51:17 (#6)

לֵ֤ב־נִשְׁבָּ֨ר֮ וְנִדְכֶּ֪ה

“A broken and crushed heart”

The terms **broken** and **crushed** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [A completely broken heart] or [A heart that an awareness of the seriousness of sin has completely broken]

See: Doublet

Psalms 51:17 (#7)

לֵב־נִשְׁבָּר וְנִדְכֶּה

“A broken and crushed heart”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s inner being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [A person who is deeply humbled by an awareness of the seriousness of his sin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:18 (#1)

צִיּוֹן

“Zion”

David is using Mount **Zion**, the location of the Israelite capital city of Jerusalem, to represent the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 51:18 (#2)

בִּרְצוֹנְךָ

“in your acceptance”

The noun that the ULT translates as **acceptance** here comes from the same root as the verb that it translates as “accept” in verse 16. However, the perspective is broader here. David is not asking God to **Do good to Zion** based on God’s **acceptance** of him personally as a penitent and forgiven sinner. Instead, he is asking that all of the people of Israel would experience God’s renewed favor now that he, as their king, has repented. Your language may have a term that you can use in your translation to indicate this. Alternate translation: [in your favor]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 51:18 (#3)

תִּבְנֶה חוֹמֹת יְרוּשָׁלָ͏ִם

“build the walls of Jerusalem”

David is speaking as if **Jerusalem** did not have **walls**, and he wanted God to **build** some for the city. He is using Jerusalem to represent the people of Israel and walls to represent their protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [strengthen the defenses of Israel] or [strongly protect us Israelites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 51:19 (#1)

זִבְחֵי־צֶדֶק

“sacrifices of righteousness”

David is using the possessive form to describe **sacrifices** that are characterized by the **righteousness** of those offering them. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [rightly offered sacrifices]

See: Possession

Psalms 51:19 (#2)

עוֹלָה וְכָלִיל

“a burnt offering and a whole {one”

David is using the adjective **whole** as a noun to mean a certain kind of sacrifice. (The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **one**.) Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a burnt offering and a wholly consumed sacrifice]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 51:19 (#3)

עוֹלָה וְכָלִיל

“a burnt offering and a whole {one”

Together, the expressions **a burnt offering** and **a whole one** express a single idea. The word **whole** tells to what extent this **offering** would be **burnt**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [a wholly burnt offering]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 51:19 (#4)

עוֹלָה וְכָלִיל

“a burnt offering and a whole {one”

David is not referring to a specific wholly burnt offering. He means such offerings in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [wholly burnt offerings]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 51:19 (#5)

אָז יַעֲלוּ & פָּרִים

“Then they will offer bulls”

Here David is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Then people will offer bulls] or [Then bulls will be offered]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 52 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 52 is a specific kind of psalm of supplication, an “imprecatory psalm” in which the psalmist describes the actions of wicked people and asks God to judge and punish them. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Description of Doeg’s wickedness (1–4)
2. Declaration that God will punish Doeg (5–7)
3. David’s statement of his confidence in God (8–9)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “maskil.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

As its superscription indicates, the background to this psalm is an episode related in 1 Samuel 22:6–23, in which Doeg the Edomite, one of King Saul’s officers, killed Yahweh’s priests and their families. It may be helpful to read that episode before translating this psalm.

Psalms 52:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 52:0 (#3)

מַשְׂכִּיל

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל”

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 52:0 (#4)

בְּבֹא ׀ דוֹאֵג הָאֲדֹמִי וַיַּגֶּד לְשָׁאוּל וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ בָּבָא דָוִד אֶל־בֵּית אֲחִימֶלֶךְ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּבֹא ׀ דוֹאֵג הָאֲדֹמִי וַיַּגֶּד לְשָׁאוּל וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ בָּבָא דָוִד אֶל־בֵּית אֲחִימֶלֶךְ”

This superscription is referring to events related in 1 Samuel 22:6–23. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe these events more fully. Alternate translation: [David wrote this song when Doeg the Edomite, an officer of King Saul, came and told Saul that David, whom Saul was trying to kill, had gone to the high priest Ahimelech and that he had received help from him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 52:0 (#5)

וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ”

This phrase introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 52:0 (#6)

מַשְׂכִּיל לְדָוִד: בְּבֹא ׀ דוֹאֵג הָאֲדֹמִי וַיַּגֶּד לְשָׁאוּל וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ בָּבָא דָוִד אֶל־בֵּית אֲחִימֶלֶךְ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל לְדָוִד: בְּבֹא ׀ דוֹאֵג הָאֲדֹמִי וַיַּגֶּד לְשָׁאוּל וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ בָּבָא דָוִד אֶל־בֵּית אֲחִימֶלֶךְ”

This superscription is referring to events related in 1 Samuel 23:19–23. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe these events more fully. Alternate translation: [This is a maskil that David wrote when he was hiding in the wilderness of Ziph from King Saul,

who wanted to kill him, and the people who lived there went and told Saul that he was hiding among them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 52:1 (#1)

מַה־תִּתְהַלֵּ֥ל בָּרָעָ֗ה הַגִּבּ֫וֹר

"Why do you boast about harm, O warrior"

David actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here. While Doeg had caused great **harm** by killing all of Yahweh's priests and their families (1 Samuel 22:18–19), those were harmless, defenseless people, so this was not the kind of feat that a true **warrior** would **boast** about. If a speaker of your language would not say the opposite of what he meant as a way of showing how he felt about what he was saying, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why do you boast about killing defenseless people as if that made you a great warrior?]

See: Irony

Psalms 52:1 (#2)

מַה־תִּתְהַלֵּ֥ל בָּרָעָ֗ה הַגִּבּ֫וֹר

"Why do you boast about harm, O warrior"

David is using the question form to mock and ridicule Doeg. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not boast about killing defenseless people as if that made you great warrior!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 52:1 (#3)

מַה־תִּתְהַלֵּ֥ל בָּרָעָ֗ה הַגִּבּ֫וֹר

"Why do you boast about harm, O warrior"

Here and through verse 5, David addresses Doeg directly, even though he knows Doeg cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to himself and to anyone who hears this song that he feels very strongly about how Doeg killed the priests of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, here and through verse 5 you could translate what David says to Doeg as if he were speaking to other people about him. Alternate translation: [Doeg should not boast about killing defenseless people as if that made him great warrior!]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 52:1 (#4)

חֶ֣סֶד אֵ֑ל כָּל־הַיּ֗וֹם

"The covenant faithfulness of God all of the day"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The covenant faithfulness of God lasts all of the day]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 52:1 (#5)

חֶ֣סֶד אֵ֑ל כָּל־הַיּ֗וֹם

"The covenant faithfulness of God all of the day"

David is using the term **day** to mean "time," since time consists of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The covenant faithfulness of God lasts all the time]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 52:1 (#6)

חֶ֣סֶד אֵ֑ל כָּל־הַיּ֗וֹם

"The covenant faithfulness of God all of the day"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God is always faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 52:2 (#1)

כְּתַ֣עַר מְ֭מֻלָּטָ֑שׁ

"Like a sharpened razor"

The expression **sharpened** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Like a sharp razor] or [Like a razor that someone has sharpened]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 52:2 (#2)

כְּתַ֣עַר מְ֭מֻלָּטָ֑שׁ

"Like a sharpened razor"

The point of this comparison is that just as a **sharpened razor** is dangerous and potentially destructive, so is Doeg's **tongue**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Like a dangerous sharpened razor] or [Like a dangerously sharp razor]

See: Simile

Psalms 52:2 (#3)

הַֽהָוֹת תַּחְשֹׁ֥ב לְשׁוֹנֶ֗ךָ

"your tongue devises calamities"

David is speaking of Doeg's **tongue** as if it were a living thing that could devise calamities. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what you say causes calamities]

See: Personification

Psalms 52:2 (#4)

עֹשֵׂ֣ה רְמִיָּ֑ה

"worker of betrayal"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **betrayal**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you who have betrayed innocent people to their deaths]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 52:3 (#1)

שָׁ֝קֶ֗ר ׀ מִדַּבֵּ֥ר צֶֽדֶק

"lying more than speaking righteousness"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and you love lying more than speaking righteousness]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 52:3 (#2)

צֶֽדֶק

"righteousness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is right] or [truthfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 52:3 (#3)

סֶֽלָה

"Selah"

To translate the term **Selah** here and in verse 5, see how your translation team decided to represent that term in 3:2.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 52:4 (#1)

כָּל־דִּבְרֵ֖י־בָּלַ֣ע

"all words of destruction"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all words that destroy others]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 52:4 (#2)

כָּל־דִּבְרֵ֖י־בָּלַ֣ע

"all words of destruction"

David is using the term **words** to represent what Doeg says by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to say anything that will destroy other people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 52:4 (#3)

לְשׁ֣וֹן מִרְמָֽה

"tongue of betrayal"

David is using one part of Doeg, his **tongue**, to represent all of him in the act of saying things that betrayed innocent people to their deaths. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you treacherous person]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 52:5 (#1)

גַּם־אֵ֭ל יִתֶּצְךָ֣ לָ֑נֶצַח יַחֲתְךָ֥ וְיִסָּחֲךָ֗ מֵאֹ֫הֶל וְשֹׁרֶשְׁךָ֥ מֵאֶ֖רֶץ חַיִּ֣ים

"God will also tear you down forever. He will take you away and tear you from the tent and uproot you from the land of the living"

The verbs in this verse are in a form that Hebrew writers could use to express either a statement or a wish. It would be consistent with the usual pattern

of an imprecatory psalm (see the introduction to this psalm) for David to express a wish at this point that God would judge and punish this wicked person. However, he may also be making a confident statement about what God will do. The original audience would have heard both nuances. Use the verbal form in your language that seems most suitable. Alternate translation: [May God also tear you down forever! May he take you away and tear you from the tent and uproot you from the land of the living!]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 52:5 (#2)

גַּם־אֵ֭ל יִתְּצְךָ֣

“God will also tear you down”

David is speaking of Doeg as if he were actually a building or wall that God would **tear down**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will also destroy you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 52:5 (#3)

יַחְתְּךָ֥ וְיִסָּחֲךָ֗ מֵאֹ֫הֶל

“He will take you away and tear you from the tent”

David is describing one event before describing another event that would precede it. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they would happen. Alternate translation: [He will tear you from the tent and take you away]

See: Order of Events

Psalms 52:5 (#4)

יַחְתְּךָ֥ וְיִסָּחֲךָ֗ מֵאֹ֫הֶל

“He will take you away and tear you from the tent”

David is speaking as if Doeg were actually attached to or part of the **tent** in which he lived and as if God would physically **tear** him from the tent. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He will remove you from the tent you live in and take you away]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 52:5 (#5)

וְשֵׁרֶשְׁךָ֥

“and uproot you”

David is speaking as if Doeg were a plant that God would **uproot** from the soil. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and remove you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 52:5 (#6)

מֵאֶ֣רֶץ חַיִּ֑ים

“from the land of the living”

David is using the adjective **living** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [from the land of people who are alive]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 52:5 (#7)

מֵאֶ֣רֶץ חַיִּ֑ים

“from the land of the living”

Here the **land of the living** represents the people who figuratively inhabit that land. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from among people who are alive]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 52:6 (#1)

וְיִרְא֣וּ צַ֭דִּיקִים

“And the righteous will see”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [And righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 52:6 (#2)

וְעָלָ֥יו

“at him”

Since David has been addressing Doeg directly (even though he cannot hear him) to show that he feels strongly about what he did, you may wish to use the pronoun “you” here instead of the pronoun **him**. However, there is poetic effect in the change of pronoun. David describes in the previous verse how God will destroy Doeg, and in this verse it is as if that has already happened, so that Doeg is no longer around

to address directly. Use the pronoun that will be most natural and effective in your language.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 52:7 (#1)

הִנֵּה הַגֶּבֶר

“Behold, the man”

This verse is a direct quotation of the righteous people described in the previous verse. The ULT indicates that by putting this verse inside quotation marks. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could also use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [They will say, “Behold, the man]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 52:7 (#2)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

These righteous people are using the term **Behold** to focus their listeners’ attention on what they are about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 52:7 (#3)

הַגֶּבֶר לֹא יָשִׂים אֱלֹהִים מָעֻזּוֹ

“the man did not make God his refuge”

These people are speaking of Doeg as if he should actually have made God his **refuge**, that is, the place where he could go to be safe from danger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the term “refuge” in 14:6. Alternate translation: [the man did not depend on God for protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 52:7 (#4)

הַגֶּבֶר

“the man”

The term that the ULT translates as **man** refers to a full-grown male. It is related to the word that the ULT translates as “warrior” in verse 1, and it can refer to a soldier. The people may be using it in a mocking sense, like David did in verse 1. Your language may have a word or phrase that you can use to bring out this sense in your translation. Alternate translation: [the big man]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 52:8 (#1)

וַאֲנִי ׀ כְּזַיִת רַעֲנָן בְּבֵית אֱלֹהִים

“But I {am} like a green olive tree in the house of God”

The point of this comparison is that just as such a **tree** was secure and carefully tended, so God keeps David safe and cares for him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [But I am secure and well cared for, like a green olive tree in the house of God]

See: Simile

Psalms 52:8 (#2)

כְּזַיִת רַעֲנָן

“am} like a green olive tree”

David is using the term **green** not to describe the color of this **tree** but to indicate that it is alive. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [like a living olive tree] or [like a thriving olive tree]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 52:8 (#3)

בְּבֵית אֱלֹהִים

“in the house of God”

David is speaking of God’s sanctuary as if it were actually a **house** in which he lived. He does not mean that the tree to which he is comparing himself is actually within the sanctuary itself. There was probably a courtyard around the tent that David set up for the Box of Yahweh (2 Samuel 6:17), just as there was a courtyard around the temple that his son Solomon later built on the same site. In such courtyards there were trees that priests planted and tended. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the courtyard of the sanctuary of God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 52:8 (#4)

בְּחֶסֶד

“in the covenant faithfulness of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in all the ways he is faithful to the covenant of]

Psalms 52:9 (#1)

אוֹדְךָ֥ לְעוֹלָ֗ם כִּ֤י עָשִׂ֫יתָ

“I will thank you forever, for you have done {this”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because you have done this, I will praise you forever]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 52:9 (#2)

עָשִׂ֫יתָ

“you have done {this”

David is using a verbal form that typically describes action completed in the past. While verbal forms are more flexible in poetry, he may be using this form to describe something that is going to happen in the future in order to show that the event will certainly happen. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use the future tense. Alternate translation: [you will do this]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 52:9 (#3)

וַאֲקַוֶּ֣ה שִׁמְךָ֣ כִּי־טֹ֭וב נֶ֣גֶד חֲסִידֶֽיךָ

“I will await your name, for {it is} good before your faithful {ones”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because your name is good before your faithful ones, I will await it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 52:9 (#4)

וַאֲקַוֶּ֣ה שִׁמְךָ֣

“I will await your name”

Here God’s **name** represents his reputation. David means that he will wait for God to confirm his reputation for being just by judging and punishing Doeg. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I will wait for you to confirm your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 52:9 (#5)

טֹ֭וב נֶ֣גֶד חֲסִידֶֽיךָ

“it is} good before your faithful {ones”

Here God’s name being **before** his **faithful ones** represents it being where they can see it. In other words, God has shown them that his name is good, that is, that he deserves his good reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [you have shown your faithful ones that it is good]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 52:9 (#6)

חֲסִידֶֽיךָ

“your faithful {ones”

David is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **ones**. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [your faithful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms - Chapter 53 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 53 is a slightly modified version of Psalm 14, which is a wisdom psalm that describes the difference between how righteous people and wicked people live and the difference between what happens to them. The editor of this psalm reworked Psalm 14:5–6 into Psalm 53:5 in such a way that a foreign army that attacked the Israelites serves as a specific example of wicked people seeking to oppress innocent people, and God’s destruction of that army provides a specific example of how God judges and punishes wicked people. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. A description of wicked people (1–4)
2. God punishes wicked people but helps his own people (5–6)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “maskil.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Why does Psalm 53 say "God" in the places where Psalm 14 says "Yahweh"?
Except for the reworking of Psalm 14:5–6 into Psalm 53:5, Psalm 53 is essentially the same as Psalm 14, with only minor differences (such as saying "and they do" rather than just "they do" in verse 1). However, one significant difference is that in the four places where Psalm 14 uses the divine name "Yahweh," Psalm 53 says "God." Many interpreters believe that this is to show that God's judgment against wicked people and help for innocent people extend beyond the community of those who are in a specific covenant relationship with him. They apply to the entire world, as the destruction of this foreign army demonstrates.

Psalms 53:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 53:0 (#3)

עַל־מָחֲלַת

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־מָחֲלַת"

The term that the ULT translates as **Weakness** could be the name of the tune of this psalm. It might also be a musical instruction indicating that singers should perform the song in a minor key or in a somber tone. Alternate translation: [perform in a minor key] or [perform in a somber tone]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 53:0 (#4)

מַשְׂכִּיל

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 53:1 (#1)

נָבָל

"The fool"

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **fool**. He means foolish people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [A foolish person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 53:1 (#2)

אָמַר & בְּלִבּוֹ

"says in his heart"

Here the **heart** represents a person's thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [thinks]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 53:1 (#3)

אֵין אֱלֹהִים

"No God"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [There is no God]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 53:1 (#4)

הִשְׁחִיתוּ

"They are corrupt"

The pronoun **They** refers to foolish people who deny God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Such foolish people are corrupt]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 53:1 (#5)

טוֹב

"good"

The psalmist is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean a certain kind of action. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase, here and in verse 3. Alternate translation: [good things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 53:2 (#1)

בְּנֵי אָדָם

“the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 53:2 (#2)

דֹּרֵשׁ אֶת־אֱלֹהִים

“one seeking God”

Since the psalmist has already used the name “God” earlier in this sentence, it may be more natural in your language to use a pronoun here. Alternate translation: [one seeking him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 53:3 (#1)

כֻּלּוֹ סָגוֹג

“All of him has turned away”

The pronoun **him** refers back to “man” in the previous verse. It may be helpful to use a term in your translation that will clarify this for your readers. Another possibility would be to use a plural pronoun, as the psalmist does in the next sentence. Alternate translation: [All of mankind has turned away] or [All of them have turned away]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 53:3 (#2)

כֻּלּוֹ סָגוֹג

“All of him has turned away”

The psalmist is speaking as if people had physically **turned away** from God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All of them have abandoned God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 53:3 (#3)

אֵין עֹשֵׂה־טּוֹב אֵין גַּם־אֶחָד

“There is} none doing good, not even one”

The psalmist is saying **none** and **not even one** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [All people are sinful]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 53:4 (#1)

הֲלֹא יָדְעוּ פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן אֹכְלֵי עַמִּי אָכְלוּ לֶחֶם

“Do they not know, the doers of iniquity, the ones eating my people {as} they eat bread”

The psalmist is using the question form to express amazement that wicked people oppress others without recognizing that God will judge and punish them for doing that. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [They ought to know better, the doers of iniquity, the ones eating my people as they eat bread!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 53:4 (#2)

אֹכְלֵי עַמִּי אָכְלוּ לֶחֶם

“the ones eating my people {as} they eat bread”

The point of this comparison is that just as someone can **eat bread** easily and quickly, so these **doers of iniquity** readily oppress and exploit vulnerable people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the ones eating my people as readily as they eat bread]

See: Simile

Psalms 53:4 (#3)

אֹכְלֵי עַמִּי אָכְלוּ לֶחֶם

“the ones eating my people {as} they eat bread”

The psalmist is speaking as if these **doers of iniquity** were actually **eating** the **people** of his nation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones exploiting my people as readily as they eat bread]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 53:5 (#1)

פָּחֲדוּ־פָחַד

“they feared a fear”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [they feared greatly]

See: Poetry

Psalms 53:5 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים פִּזַּר עַצְמוֹת חֹנֶךָ הֱבִשׁוֹתָה כִּי־אֱלֹהִים מְאָסָם

“God scattered the bones of the one encamping against you. You have shamed {them}, for God despises them”

The psalmist is addressing the nation of Israel as if it were an individual, even though he knows that it cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to anyone who hears this song that he feels very strongly about how God defeated and destroyed this attacking army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if the psalmist were speaking objectively about this army. Alternate translation: [God scattered the bones of the ones encamping against Israel. The Israelites have shamed them, for God despises them]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 53:5 (#3)

אֱלֹהִים פִּזַּר עַצְמוֹת

“God scattered the bones of”

The psalmist is using the fact that the surviving soldiers of this army were not able to bury their fellow soldiers who were killed, so that their **bones** were left **scattered** on the field of battle, to represent how completely God defeated this army. Alternate translation: [God completely defeated and destroyed]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 53:5 (#4)

חֹנֶךָ

“the one encamping against you”

The psalmist is using one person who was involved in **encamping** against the Israelites, probably the king who commanded this army, to mean everyone who was involved. (This is clear from the way the psalmist says **them** later in this verse.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones encamping against you] or [the soldiers who attacked you]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 53:5 (#5)

חֹנֶךָ הֱבִשׁוֹתָה

“the one encamping against you. You have shamed {them”

The word “you” is singular in both instances in this verse, so use the singular form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 53:5 (#6)

חֹנֶךָ הֱבִשׁוֹתָה

“the one encamping against you. You have shamed {them”

The pronoun **you** seems to refer in context to “Israel” in the next verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [against you, Israel. You have shamed them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 53:6 (#1)

מִֽי יִתֵּ֣ן מִצִּיּ֣וֹן ׀ יְשׁוּעוֹת֮ יִשְׂרָאֵל֒

“Who will give the salvation of Israel from Zion”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Who will give that the salvation of Israel will come from Zion?]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 53:6 (#2)

מִֽי יִתֵּ֣ן מִצִּיּ֣וֹן ׀ יְשׁוּעוֹת֮ יִשְׂרָאֵל֒

“Who will give the salvation of Israel from Zion”

The psalmist is using **Who will give** as a common expression of his culture to introduce a fervent wish. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [O that salvation for Israel would come from Zion!] or [I fervently wish that salvation for Israel would come from Zion!]

See: Idiom

Psalms 53:6 (#3)

מִֽי־יִתֵּ֣ן מִצִּיּ֣וֹן׀ יְשׁוּעֹ֣ות יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Who will give the salvation of Israel from Zion”

The psalmist is using Mount **Zion**, the location of God’s sanctuary, to represent God himself in the act of providing **salvation** for **Israel**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [O that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to provide for the salvation of Israel!] or [I fervently wish that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to provide for the salvation of Israel!]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 53:6 (#4)

מִֽי־יִתֵּ֣ן מִצִּיּ֣וֹן׀ יְשׁוּעֹ֣ות יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Who will give the salvation of Israel from Zion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [O that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to save Israel!] or [I fervently wish that God would act from his sanctuary on Mount Zion to save Israel!]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 53:6 (#5)

בְּשׁ֥וּב אֱלֹהִ֗ים שְׁבוּת֥ עַמּ֑וֹ

“When God restores the prosperity of his people”

The word that the ULT translates as **prosperity** can also mean “captivity.” If that is the meaning, then this verse could have been added to the psalm later, after the Israelites were conquered and taken into captivity. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to follow the translation that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [When God restores the captivity of his people] or [When God brings his people back from captivity]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 53:6 (#6)

יָגֵ֣ל יַ֭עֲקֹב יִשְׂמַ֣ח יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Jacob will be glad, Israel will rejoice”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms. Alternate translation: [Israel will rejoice greatly] or [Jacob will be glad; indeed, Israel will rejoice]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 53:6 (#7)

יָגֵ֣ל יַ֭עֲקֹב יִשְׂמַ֣ח יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Jacob will be glad, Israel will rejoice”

The psalmist is using the two names of the ancestor of the Israelites, **Jacob** and **Israel**, to represent the Israelites themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The descendants of Jacob will be glad; indeed, the Israelites will rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 54 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 54 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–2)
2. Description of troubles (3)
3. Statement of trust (4–5a)
4. Petition (5b)
5. Vow of praise (6)
6. Renewed statement of trust (7)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “maskil.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

As its superscription indicates, the background to this psalm is an episode related in 1 Samuel 23:19–23 in which the people who lived in the wilderness of Ziph went and told Saul, who wanted to kill David, that he was hiding among them. It may be helpful to read that episode before translating this psalm.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Variation between "you" and "he"
In verses 1, 2, 6, and the second part of verse 5, David addresses Yahweh directly as "you." In verses 3, 4, 7, and the first part of verse 5, he speaks about Yahweh as "he." This variation of pronouns reflects the flow of a psalm of supplication from a cry for help ("you") to a description of troubles and statement of trust ("he") to a petition and vow of praise ("you") to a renewed statement of trust ("he"). However, if it would not be natural in your language to switch back and forth between second-person and third-person pronouns, you could use second-person pronouns throughout the psalm, as some versions do. For example, in verse 3, you might say, "They do not set you, God, before them"; in verse 4, you might say, "you, God, are a helper to me"; and in verse 7, you might say, "you deliver me from every trouble."

Psalms 54:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 54:0 (#3)

מַשְׂכִּיל

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 54:0 (#4)

הֲלֹא דָוִד מִסְתַּתֵּר עִמָּנוּ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הֲלֹא דָוִד מִסְתַּתֵּר עִמָּנוּ"

The Ziphites were using the question form to show that they were certain about what they were saying. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [David is definitely hiding among us]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 54:1 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים בְּשִׁמְךָ הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי וּבִגְבוּרָתְךָ תְדִינֵנִי

"Save me, God, by your name, and vindicate me by your might"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Deliver me, God, by your mighty name] or [Save me, God, by your name; yes, vindicate me by your might]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 54:1 (#2)

הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי וּבִגְבוּרָתְךָ תְדִינֵנִי

"Save me & and vindicate me by your might"

The terms **Save** and **vindicate** are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than a commands. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request in these cases and in the next verse. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make the meaning clear. Alternate translation: [Please save me ... yes, please vindicate me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 54:1 (#3)

בְּשִׁמְךָ

"by your name"

David is using God's **name** to represent the qualities that people associate with God when they hear his name; specifically in this context, his power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by your power] or [by the power for which you have a well-deserved reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 54:2 (#1)

לְאִמְרֵי־פִי

"to the words of my mouth"

David is using his **mouth** to represent what he is saying by using his mouth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the words that I am speaking]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 54:3 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** does not introduce the reason why God should listen to David. It introduces David’s explanation of why he is praying to God for help. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear. Alternate translation: [You see,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 54:3 (#2)

זָרִ֥ים

“foreigners”

David is speaking as if the Ziphites were actually **foreigners**, even though he and they belong to the same Israelite tribe of Judah, because they are not acting toward him with the loyalty that one would expect of kinsmen. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [treacherous people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 54:3 (#3)

קָ֭מוּ עָלָ֑י

“have arisen against me”

When David says that these people **have arisen**, he does not mean that they have stood up from a sitting or lying position. He means that they have taken action, in this context hostile action. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [have taken hostile action against me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 54:3 (#4)

וְעָרִיצִ֥ים

“and violent {ones”

David is using the adjective **violent** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **ones**. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and violent men]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 54:3 (#5)

לֹ֣א שָׁ֭מוּ אֱלֹהִ֣ים לְנֶגְדָּ֑ם

“They do not set God before them”

David is speaking as if **God** were an object that these people could **set** in front of them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They have no regard for God] or [They are not mindful of God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 54:3 (#6)

סֶֽלָה

“Selah”

See how your translation team decided at 3:2 to represent the term **Selah**.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 54:4 (#1)

הִנֵּ֣ה

“Behold”

David is using the term **Behold** to focus attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 54:4 (#2)

אֲ֭דֹנָי בְּסֹמְכֵ֣י נַפְשִׁ֑י

“the Lord {is} with the sustainers of my life”

David is using a common expression of his culture to mean that **the Lord** helps the **sustainers** of his **life**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Lord helps the sustainers of my life]

See: Idiom

Psalms 54:5 (#1)

בַּֽאֲמִתְּךָ֥

“In your faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Because you are faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 54:6 (#1)

אאֶוֹדֶה שִׁמְךָ יְהוָה כִּי־טוֹב

“I will praise your name, Yahweh, for {it is} good”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because your name is good, Yahweh, I will praise it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 54:6 (#2)

אאֶוֹדֶה שִׁמְךָ

“I will praise your name”

See how you translated the term “name” in verse 1. Alternate translation: [I will praise you for your character]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 54:7 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** does not introduce the reason why David is going to praise Yahweh and sacrifice to him. It introduces an explanation of why David is going to be able to do that. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 54:7 (#2)

וּבְאֹיְבַ֥י רָ֝אְתָ֗ה עֵינִֽי

“and my eye looks at my enemies”

David is using one part himself, his **eye**, to mean all of him in the act of looking upon his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I look at my enemies] or [and I personally see my enemies]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 54:7 (#3)

וּבְאֹיְבַ֥י רָ֝אְתָ֗ה עֵינִֽי

“and my eye looks at my enemies”

David means specifically that he sees that Yahweh has defeated his enemies. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I personally see that Yahweh has defeated my enemies]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 55 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 55 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm except a vow of praise. (Some elements are repeated.) See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–2)
2. Description of troubles (3–8)
3. Petition (9)
4. Description of troubles (10–14)
5. Petition (15)
6. Statement of trust (16–19a)
7. Description of troubles (19b–21)
8. Statement of trust (22–23)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “maskil.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

What former “companion” or friend is David describing in verses 12–14 and 20–21?

Many interpreters believe that David wrote this psalm after his counselor and friend Ahithophel turned against him and supported David’s son Absalom in his rebellion against him. (These events are described in 2 Samuel 15:12–36.) If so, then Ahithophel would be the former friend whom David describes in these verses. However, throughout the centuries, Christian interpreters have also seen this psalm as prophetic of Judas’s betrayal of Jesus (even though no New Testament writer directly quotes it as a Messianic prophecy that was fulfilled in the life of Jesus). For that reason, we recommend that translators take care not to translate it in a way that limits its potential meaning to the original circumstances, such as by saying in verse 13,

for example, “But it was you, Ahithophel” rather than simply “But it was you.” Instead, a translation can use footnotes to describe the likely historical background of this psalm.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Intentionally repeated terms
In two cases, David uses the same terms near the beginning and end of this psalm. In the first case, he does this to draw a contrast. In verse 3 he says that the wicked try to “shake” trouble onto the righteous, but in verse 22 he says that God will never allow their “shaking.” In the second case, he repeats terms to reassert something he said earlier that he would do. In verse 2, he says, “I am restless in my complaint, and let me moan.” In verse 17, after describing the trouble he is in, he says “let me complain and moan,” showing that his response to the trouble is to plead with God for help. So that your readers can appreciate these things, we encourage you, if possible, to use the same terms in your language in the later verses that you use in the earlier verses.

Psalms 55:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 55:0 (#3)

מַשְׂכִּיל

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל”

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 55:1 (#1)

הַאֲזִינָה אֱלֹהִים תְּפִלָּתִי וְאַל־תִּתְעַלַּם מֵהִתְחַנָּתִי

“Listen {to} my prayer, God, and do not hide yourself from my plea”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Listen carefully, God, as I plead with you in prayer] or [Listen {to} my prayer, God! Indeed, do not hide yourself from my plea!]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 55:1 (#2)

הַאֲזִינָה & וְאַל־תִּתְעַלַּם

“Listen & and do not hide yourself”

The expressions **Listen** and **do not hide** are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than a commands. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request in these cases and in the next verse. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make the meaning clear. Alternate translation: [Please listen ... and please do not hide]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 55:1 (#3)

וְאַל־תִּתְעַלַּם מֵהִתְחַנָּתִי

“and do not hide yourself from my plea”

David is speaking as if God might actually **hide** himself so that David could not find him and make a **plea** to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and do not disregard my plea]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:2 (#1)

וַעֲנֵנִי

“and answer me”

In this context, the expression **answer me** means more than “say something in response to me.” It means “do what I ask.” In this case, David is asking God specifically to protect him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and protect me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:2 (#2)

וְאָהֱמָה

“and let me moan”

David is using a verbal form in which he is addressing himself and suggesting a course of action. (It is common in psalms of supplication for the psalmist to move back and forth between calling to God for help and making observations to himself about his own situation.) If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this with the same kind of statement form that David uses in the first part of this sentence when he says **I am restless**. Alternate translation: [and I moan]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 55:3 (#1)

מִקּ֣וֹל אוֹיֵ֑ב

“from the voice of the enemy”

David is not referring to a specific **enemy**. He means all of the enemies who are threatening him on this occasion, as his use of the plural pronoun **they** later in this verse indicates. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [from the voice of my enemies]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 55:3 (#2)

מִקּ֣וֹל אוֹיֵ֑ב

“from the voice of the enemy”

Here a person’s **voice** represents what he is saying by using his voice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [because of what my enemies are saying]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:3 (#3)

מִפְּנֵ֥י עָקַ֗ת רָ֫שָׁ֥ע

“from the face of the oppression of the wicked”

David is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of” or “on account of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of the oppression of the wicked]

See: Idiom

Psalms 55:3 (#4)

מִפְּנֵ֥י עָקַ֗ת רָ֫שָׁ֥ע

“from the face of the oppression of the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [because of the oppression of wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 55:3 (#5)

מִפְּנֵ֥י עָקַ֗ת רָ֫שָׁ֥ע

“from the face of the oppression of the wicked”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **oppression**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because wicked people are oppressing me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 55:3 (#6)

כִּ֤י

“For”

Here the expression **For** introduces more detailed information about what David’s wicked enemies are doing. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly in your translation. Alternate translation: [You see,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 55:3 (#7)

יָ֭מִ֣יטוּ עָלַ֑י אָ֫וֶ֥ן

“they shake trouble onto me”

David is speaking as if **trouble** were an object such as a large rock that his enemies could **shake** loose so that it would fall **onto** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [they stir up trouble for me] or [they trouble me greatly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:3 (#8)

וּבְאַ֣ף

“and in nose”

Here the **nose** represents anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and in anger]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:3 (#9)

יִשְׁטְמוּנִי

“they persecute me”

The verb that the ULT translates here as **persecute** means generally to “hold a grudge.” The focus in this context is not on an inner feeling of resentment but on a relentless attempt by someone holding a grudge to harm another person. If your language has a verb or phrase that describes this action, it would be appropriate to use it in your translation. Alternate translation: [they try relentlessly to harm me] or [they pursue a vendetta against me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:4 (#1)

לִבִּי יָחִיל בְּקִרְבִּי

“My heart writhes in the midst of me”

This statement could have a figurative meaning or a literal meaning or both. If your language has a term such as “heart” that describes an internal organ and can also represent emotions, it would be appropriate to use it here in your translation. This could mean: (1) that David is using his **heart** to represent his emotions. Alternate translation: [I feel very distressed inside] or (2) that David is describing physical symptoms that he is experiencing. Alternate translation: [My heart is pounding inside me] or [My heart is racing fast]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:4 (#2)

וְאֵימְוֹת מָוֶת נָפְלוּ עָלָי

“and the terrors of death have fallen onto me”

David is speaking as if the **terrors of death** were actually objects that could have **fallen onto** him. He means that he is feeling them immediately and forcefully, as if they had struck him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I feel the terrors of death strikingly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:4 (#3)

וְאֵימְוֹת מָוֶת נָפְלוּ עָלָי

“and the terrors of death have fallen onto me”

David may be using the plural form **terrors**: (1) to indicate that the prospect of dying is making him feel a combination of fears. Alternate translation: [I feel strikingly all the fears that the prospect of dying makes a person feel] or (2) to emphasize that the fear of death is a very great fear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a singular form and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I feel strikingly the great fear of death]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 55:5 (#1)

יִרְאָה וָרַעַד יֵבֹא בִּי

“Fear and trembling have come on me”

David is speaking of **Fear and trembling** as if they were living things that could have **come** upon him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I cannot help feeling afraid and trembling]

See: Personification

Psalms 55:5 (#2)

וַתְּכַסֵּנִי פַּלָּצוּת

“and horror has covered me”

David is speaking as if **horror** had physically **covered** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and horror has overwhelmed me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:6 (#1)

וָאֹמַר

“I have said”

David has not **said** this to anyone else. He has said it to himself. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I have said to myself] or [I have thought]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:6 (#2)

מִי־יִתֶּן־לִי אֵבֶר כַּיּוֹנָה

“Who will give the wing of a dove to me”

Here the word **wing** is singular in form, but it refers to both of the two wings that a dove has. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural or dual form of “wing.” Alternate translation: [Who will give, the wings of a dove are to me?]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 55:6 (#3)

מִי־יִתֶּן־לִי אֵבֶר כַּיּוֹנָה

“Who will give the wing of a dove to me”

David is using **Who will give** as a common expression of his culture to introduce a fervent wish. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [O that I had the wings of a dove!] or [I fervently wish that I had the wings of a dove!]

See: Idiom

Psalms 55:6 (#4)

וְאֶשְׁכְּנָה

“and let me dwell”

David means implicitly that he wishes he could **dwell** somewhere safe. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and let me dwell somewhere safe]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:7 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

David is using the term **Behold** to focus attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:7 (#2)

אַרְחִיק נְדֹד

“I would make distance, wandering”

The verbs **make distance** and **wandering** together express a single idea. The verb **wandering** tells in what way David would **make distance** between himself and his enemies. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [I would wander far away]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 55:7 (#3)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

To translate the term **Selah** here and in verse 19, see how your translation team decided to represent that term in 3:2.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 55:8 (#1)

מִפְלָט

“to} an escape”

Here, **an escape** represents “a place of escape.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to a place of escape] or [to a place where I am safe]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:8 (#2)

מֵרָוַח סוֹעָה מִסָּעַר

“from the storming wind, from the tempest”

The terms **storming wind** and **tempest** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [from the raging tempest]

See: Doublet

Psalms 55:8 (#3)

מֵרָוַח סוֹעָה מִסָּעַר

“from the storming wind, from the tempest”

David is speaking as if the hostile opposition of his wicked enemies were actually a **storming wind** or **tempest**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from these looming calamities]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:9 (#1)

בַּלַּע אֲדֹנָי פַּלַּג לְשׁוֹנָם

“Swallow {them}, Lord, divide their tongue”

The verb that the ULT translates as **Swallow** means “to swallow” in every other instance in the Hebrew Bible. (For example, Jonah 1:17, “Yahweh appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah.”) However, many biblical scholars believe, based on languages similar to Hebrew, that there was another verb with the same consonants that meant “confuse” and that David was using that verb here. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [Confuse, Lord, divide their tongue] or [Lord, confuse and divide their tongue]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:9 (#2)

בַּלַּע

“Swallow {them”

If this verb means **Swallow**, then David is speaking as if he wants the **Lord** actually to eat his enemies and swallow them. See how you translated the similar term “devour” in 35:25. Alternate translation: [Destroy them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:9 (#3)

פַּלַּג לְשׁוֹנָם

“divide their tongue”

Here the word **tongue** is singular in form, but it refers to the tongues of all of David’s enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “tongue.” Alternate translation: [divide their tongues]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 55:9 (#4)

פַּלַּג לְשׁוֹנָם

“divide their tongue”

David is using the term **tongue** to represent what his enemies would by using their tongues. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [make them disagree in what they say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:9 (#5)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces an explanation for what David asks in the previous sentence. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 55:9 (#6)

חָמָס וְרִיב

“violence and strife”

The terms **violence** and **strife** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [much violence]

See: Doublet

Psalms 55:9 (#7)

בָּעִיר

“in the city”

To decide whether to be more specific in your translation about what **city** David is referring to, see the discussion in the introduction to this psalm of when and why he probably wrote it.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:10 (#1)

יוֹמָם וָלַיְלָה

“Day and night”

David is referring to all of time by naming its two major components, **Day** and **night**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [All the time] or [Constantly]

See: Merism

Psalms 55:10 (#2)

יְסוֹבְבֻהָ עַל־חוֹמֹתֶיהָ

“they go around it on its walls”

David is speaking of the “violence” and “strife” he mentioned in the previous verse (referring back to

them here as **they**) as if they were living things that could **go around** on the walls of a city. He is speaking of them as if they were watchmen who were supposed to make sure that there was good order in the city but who instead are making sure that there is continual fighting in the city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [there is violence all around the city]

See: Personification

Psalms 55:10 (#3)

וְאָוֶן וְעָמָל בְּקִרְבָּהּ

“and iniquity and trouble {are} in the midst of it”

David is speaking of **iniquity** and **trouble** as if they were living things that could dwell **in the midst of** a city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and wicked people cause trouble in the midst of it]

See: Personification

Psalms 55:11 (#1)

וְלֹא־יָמִישׁ מֵרְחֹבָהּ תּוֹכָהּ וּמִרְמָה

“and oppression and deceit do not depart from its open square”

David is speaking of **oppression** and **deceit** as if they were living things that could **depart** from the open square of a city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and oppression and deceit are continually present in it]

See: Personification

Psalms 55:12 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the expression **For** introduces more detailed information about the identify of one of David’s enemies. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly in your translation. Alternate translation: [You see,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 55:13 (#1)

וְאַתָּה אֱנוֹשׁ כְּעֶרְכִּי אַלּוּפִי וּמְיֻדָּעִי

“But {it was} you, a man according to my valuation, my companion and my acquaintance”

Here and in the next verse, David addresses this former **companion** directly, even though he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to himself and to anyone who hears this song that he feels very strongly about how this former friend has betrayed him. If it would be helpful in your language, here and in the next verse you could translate what David says to this former friend as if he were speaking to other people about him. Alternate translation: [But it was a man according to my valuation, my companion and my acquaintance]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 55:13 (#2)

אֱנוֹשׁ כְּעֶרְכִּי

“a man according to my valuation”

David is speaking as if someone had vowed both him and his former friend to God (as Leviticus 27:1–8 describes) and a priest had determined that they had the same **valuation**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a man equal to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:13 (#3)

אֱנוֹשׁ כְּעֶרְכִּי

“a man according to my valuation”

Since David was the king of Israel, this **man** could not have been his actual equal in rank. David is probably describing the regard in which he held this man. Alternate translation: [a man whom I esteemed as my equal]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:13 (#4)

אַלּוּפִי וּמְיֻדָּעִי

“my companion and my acquaintance”

To decide whether to be more specific in your translation about what **companion** and **acquaintance** David is referring to, see the discussion in the introduction to this psalm of when and why he probably wrote it.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:14 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר יַחְדָּו נַמְתִּיק סָוֹד & נְהַלֵּךְ

“we who together made counsel sweet; we walked”

By **we** in both instances, David means himself and his former friend, whom he is addressing, so use the inclusive form of that word in your translation if your language marks that distinction. However, if you translated verse 13 as if David were speaking about his friend rather than to him, then **we** would not include the people to whom he is speaking (anyone else hearing this song), so use the exclusive form of that word in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive 'We'

Psalms 55:14 (#2)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר יַ֭חְדָּו נַמְתִּ֣יק סֹ֑וד

"we who together made counsel sweet"

David is speaking as if he and his former friend had actually **made** the **counsel** they formerly shared together **sweet**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we who spoke together very pleasantly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:14 (#3)

בְּבֵ֖ית אֱ֣לֹהִ֑ים

"in the house of God"

David is speaking as if God's temple were actually a **house** in which he lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Since only priests could enter the temple building, David is referring to the courtyard of the temple. Alternate translation: [in the courtyard of the temple of God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:15 (#1)

יְשִׁימוֹת עָלֵ֗ימוֹ יֵ֭רְדוּ שְׁא֣וֹל חַיִּ֑ים כִּֽי־רָעוֹת֮ בְּמְגוּרָ֢ם בְּקִרְבָּֽם

"May} desolations {be} upon them; may they go down {to} Sheol alive, for evils {are} in their dwelling, in the midst of them"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because evils {are} in their dwelling, in the midst of them, may desolations be upon them; may they go down to Sheol alive]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 55:15 (#2)

יְשִׁימוֹת עָלֵ֗ימוֹ יֵ֭רְדוּ

"May} desolations {be} upon them; may they go down"

The pronouns **them** and **they** refer to the enemies whom David first described in verse 3. He is talking about them as a group again after focusing on a specific one of them in verses 12–14. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [May desolations be upon my enemies; may they go down]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 55:15 (#3)

יְשִׁימוֹת עָלֵ֗ימוֹ

"May} desolations {be} upon them"

This phrase is a translation of the written Hebrew text. Later Hebrew scribes, however, have recommended a correction in the margin of the text. You may want to follow this correction in your translation. Alternate translation: [May death seize upon them]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 55:15 (#4)

יְשִׁימוֹת עָלֵ֗ימוֹ

"May} desolations {be} upon them"

If this is the correct reading, David would be speaking of **desolations** as if they were objects that could be **upon** his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May things happen to them that desolate them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:15 (#5)

יְשִׁימוֹת עָלֵ֗ימוֹ

"May} desolations {be} upon them"

If the correct reading is "May death seize upon them," David would be speaking of death as if it were a living thing that could seize his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May they die without being able to resist dying]

See: Personification

Psalms 55:15 (#6)

יֵרְדוּ שְׁאוֹל חַיִּים

“may they go down {to} Sheol alive”

David is alluding to the episode described in Numbers 16:1–33 in which men named Korah, Dathan, and Abiram rebelled against Moses, and Yahweh judged and punished them by having the ground open up so that they “went down to Sheol alive.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [may they go down to Sheol alive, just like the people who rebelled against Moses]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:15 (#7)

רָעוֹת בְּמְגוּרָם

“evils {are} in their dwelling”

David is speaking as if **evils** actually lived with his enemies in their **dwelling**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [evil is at home with them] or [they live in an environment that is constantly evil]

See: Personification

Psalms 55:15 (#8)

בְּמְגוּרָם

“are} in their dwelling”

Here the word **dwelling** is singular in form, but it refers to the dwellings of all of David’s enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “dwelling.” Alternate translation: [are in their dwellings]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 55:16 (#1)

אֲנִי אֶל־אֱלֹהִים אֶקְרָא

“I, I will call to God”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will call** already includes this meaning. He is doing that in order to emphasize a contrast between what his enemies are doing (living wickedly, without regard for God), and what he will do. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [But as for me, I will call to God]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 55:17 (#1)

עֶרֶב וְבֹקֶר וְצָהֳרַיִם

“Evening and morning and noon”

David is referring to an entire day by naming three significant times in it, **Evening** (probably meaning sundown), **morning** (probably meaning dawn), and **noon**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Throughout the day]

See: Merism

Psalms 55:17 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁמַע קוֹלִי

“and he will hear my voice”

David is using the term **voice** to represent what he would say by using his voice. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will hear what I say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:17 (#3)

וַיִּשְׁמַע קוֹלִי

“and he will hear my voice”

David is using the term **hear** to mean that God will do what he is asking him to do, as he states confidently in the next verse. The meaning of “hear” is the same in verse 19. Alternate translation: [and he will do what I ask]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:18 (#1)

פָּדָה בְשָׁלוֹם נַפְשִׁי מִקְּרֹב־לִי

“He redeems my life in peace from the battle against me”

David is speaking as if God actually **redeems** him or pays a price to free him from slavery or captivity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He rescues my life in peace from the battle against me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:18 (#2)

פָּדָ֣ה בְשָׁלוֹם֮ נַפְשִׁי֒ מִקְּרַ֣ב־לִ֗י

“He redeems my life in peace from the battle against me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. In this context, that term has the sense of “well-being.” Alternate translation: [He rescues me, alive and well, from the battle against me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 55:18 (#3)

הָיוּ

“they are”

The pronoun **they** refers to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [my enemies are]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 55:19 (#1)

וַיַּעֲנֵ֑ם

“and answer them”

This phrase is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense, since in contexts like this, the term “answer” usually means “do what they ask” (as in verse 2). You may want to follow an alternative reading from the ancient Greek translation. Alternate translation: [and afflict them]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 55:19 (#2)

וְיֹ֖שֵׁ֣ב

“even the one sitting”

David is referring specifically to God **sitting** on his throne, and he is using that action to represent God ruling. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the one enthroned] or [the one ruling]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:19 (#3)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר אֵ֣ין חֲלִיפ֣וֹת לָ֑מוֹ

“to whom {there are} no changes”

The relative pronoun **whom** refers to David’s enemies. It may be more natural in your language to use a personal pronoun and begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [There are no changes to them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 55:19 (#4)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר אֵ֣ין חֲלִיפ֣וֹת לָ֑מוֹ

“to whom {there are} no changes”

By **changes**, David means misfortunes, losses, and disappointments in life. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [They have no reversals of fortune] or [They enjoy continuous prosperity]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:20 (#1)

שָׁלַ֣ח

“He stretches out”

The pronoun **He** refers to David’s former friend. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [My former friend stretches out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 55:20 (#2)

שָׁלַ֣ח יָדָ֣יו בְּשִׁלְמָ֑יו

“He stretches out his hands against his friends”

David is using **stretches out his hands** as a common expression of his culture to mean “commits violent acts.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My former friend lays violent hands on his friends] or [My former friend commits violent acts against his friends]

See: Idiom

Psalms 55:20 (#3)

חִלֵּ֥ל בְּרִיתֽוֹ

“he defiles his covenant”

The word “defile” means to treat something sacred as if it were common. The implication is that this former friend did not consider his **covenant** with David a sacred obligation that God would enforce. (David could be referring to a formal covenant or the implicit oblig-

ations of friendship.) As a result, he was not concerned that God would punish him if he broke the covenant. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he breaks his covenant] or [he disregards the obligations of friendship]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 55:21 (#1)

חָלְקְקוּ ׀ מַחְמָאֹת פִּיהוּ

“The curds of his mouth were smooth”

David is speaking as if the things that this former friend said with his **mouth** had actually been **curds**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this image as a comparison. Alternate translation: [The things that he said were so smooth, it was as if they were curds] or [What he said caused no concern, just as a person can swallow curds without difficulty because they are smooth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:21 (#2)

וְקֶרֶב־לֹּבְּוֹ

“but his heart {was} war”

David is speaking as if this former friend’s **heart**, which represents his feelings, had actually been **war**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but secretly he felt hostile toward me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:21 (#3)

רַכּוּ דְבָרָיו מִשֶּׁמֶן

“His words were softer than oil”

The point of this comparison is that while soft olive **oil** is soothing to the skin, the **words** of this former friend were even more soothing and reassuring to David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [His words were even more soothing to me than soft olive oil is to the skin]

See: Simile

Psalms 55:21 (#4)

וְהֵמָּה פְתִחוֹת

“but they {were} unsheathed {swords”

David is speaking as if this former friend’s words had actually been **swords** that soldiers had **unsheathed** so that they were ready to use. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but they were actually dangerous and deadly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:21 (#5)

פְתִחוֹת

“were} unsheathed {swords”

The expression **unsheathed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [were bare swords]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 55:22 (#1)

הַשְׁלֵךְ עַל־יְהוָה ׀ יְהָבְךָ֗ וְהוּא יְכַלְכְּלֶךָ

“Cast your burden on Yahweh, and he, he will sustain you”

The words **you** and **your** and the implied “you” in the imperative **Cast** are singular because David is addressing himself and any individual in a similar situation who hears this song. So, use singular forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 55:22 (#2)

הַשְׁלֵךְ עַל־יְהוָה ׀ יְהָבְךָ֗

“Cast your burden on Yahweh”

David is speaking of the difficulties that a person might have as if they were actually a **burden** that a person was carrying and that he could **Cast** onto **Yahweh** so that he would carry it instead. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Trust Yahweh to help you with your difficulties]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:22 (#3)

וְהוּא יְכַלְכְּלֶךָ

“and he, he will sustain you”

David is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will sustain** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize

the personal role that Yahweh will take in sustaining a person who trusts him. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and he will personally sustain you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 55:22 (#4)

לֹא־יִתֵּ֣ן & מ֣וֹט לַצַּדִּ֑יק

“he will not allow shaking to the righteous”

David is using the image of **shaking** something loose so that it falls from its position (he uses the same image in verse 3) to represent other people ruining righteous people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [he will not let the righteous down] or [he will not allow anyone to ruin the righteous]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 55:22 (#5)

לֹא־יִתֵּ֣ן & מ֣וֹט לַצַּדִּ֑יק

“he will not allow shaking to the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [he will not allow shaking to righteous people] or [he will not allow anyone to ruin righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 55:23 (#1)

לִבְאֵ֣ר שַׁ֭חַת

“to the pit of the grave”

David is using the term **grave** to represent the decay and destruction of physical bodies that occurs in a grave. By characterizing this **pit** in that way, he is indicating that it is the chasm beneath the earth where his culture understood dead people to be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the pit of destruction] or [to the pit where dead people go]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:23 (#2)

אַנְשֵׁ֣י דָ֭מִים וּמִרְמָ֑ה

“Men of blood and treachery”

Here, **blood** represents violently shedding blood. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Men of bloodshed and treachery] or [Murderous, treacherous men]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 55:23 (#3)

לֹא־יֶחֱצ֣וּ יְמֵיהֶ֑ם

“will not halve their days”

David is using **will not halve their days** as a common expression of his culture to mean “will not even live half as long as they otherwise would have.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will not reach middle age] or [will not even live half as long as they otherwise would have]

See: Idiom

Psalms 55:23 (#4)

וַ֭אֲנִי אֶבְטַ֣ח

“But I, I will trust”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will trust** already includes this meaning. He is doing that in order to emphasize a contrast between what will happen to the wicked people he has just described and what he will do himself. Alternate translation: [But for my part, I will trust]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 56 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 56 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm. (Some elements are repeated.) See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1a)
2. Description of troubles (1b–2)
3. Statement of trust (3–4)

4. Description of troubles (5–6)
5. Petition (7–8)
6. Statement of trust (9–11)
7. Vow of praise (12–13)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a "miktam." See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

As its superscription indicates, the background to this psalm is an episode related in 1 Samuel 21:10–15 in which David fled from King Saul to the Philistine city of Gath, and the Philistines, recognizing that he was a great Israelite military commander, imprisoned him. It may be helpful to read that episode before translating this psalm.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Variation between "you" and "he"
In verses 1–3, 8, and 12, David addresses God directly as "you." In verses 4 and 9–11, he speaks about him as "God." This variation of pronouns reflects the flow of a psalm of supplication from a cry for help to a description of troubles and statement of trust to a petition to a vow of praise. However, if it would not be natural in your language to switch back and forth between second-person and third-person pronouns, you could use second-person pronouns throughout the psalm, as some versions do. For example, in verses 4, 10, and 11, you might say "I praise your word" and "in you, God, I trust." In verse 9, you might say "you, God, are for me."

Psalms 56:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 56:0 (#3)

עַל־יוֹנַת אֵלֶם רְחֹקִים

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־יוֹנַת אֵלֶם רְחֹקִים"

See how you translated the similar expression "On Sheminith" in the superscription to Psalm 6. Alternate translation: [Set to the tune Yonath Elem Rehoqim] or [Perform in the Yonath Elem Rehoqim style]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 56:0 (#4)

יוֹנַת אֵלֶם רְחֹקִים

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: יוֹנַת אֵלֶם רְחֹקִים"

The words that the ULT translates as **A Faraway Silent Dove** could also mean "A Dove on Distant Oaks." If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [A Dove on Distant Oaks]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 56:0 (#5)

מִכְתָּם

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִכְתָּם"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **miktam**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 56:0 (#6)

בֶּאֱחֹז אֹתָו פְּלִשְׁתִּים בְּגָת

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בֶּאֱחֹז אֹתָו פְּלִשְׁתִּים בְּגָת"

This superscription is referring to events related in 1 Samuel 21:10–15. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe these events more fully. Alternate translation: [David wrote this song when he fled from Saul to the Philistine city of Gath, hoping he would be safe there, but the Philistines seized him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 56:1 (#1)

חָנֵּנִי אֱלֹהִים כִּי־שְׁאָפַנִי אֱנוֹשׁ

"Be gracious to me, God, for man tramples me"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Man tramples me, so be gracious to me, God!]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 56:1 (#2)

חָנֵּנִי

“Be gracious to me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request, here and in verses 7 and 8. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please be gracious to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 56:1 (#3)

שְׁאָפַנִי אֱנָוֹשׁ

“man tramples me”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means all of the Philistines who have captured him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [men are trampling me] or [people are trampling me]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 56:1 (#4)

שְׁאָפַנִי אֱנָוֹשׁ

“man tramples me”

David is speaking as if the Philistines were actually trampling on him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [men are harassing me] or [people are harassing me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 56:1 (#5)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“All of the day”

David is using the term **day** to mean “time,” since time consists of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, here and in verses 2 and 5. Alternate translation: [All the time] or [Continually]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:1 (#6)

לֹחֵם יְלָחֲצֵנִי

“fighting, he oppresses me”

The words **fighting** and **oppresses** together express a single idea. David is using the word **fighting** to tell in what way **man** (representing his human opponents) **oppresses** him. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [he oppresses me hostilely] or [they oppress me hostilely]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 56:2 (#1)

שָׁאֲפוּ שֹׁרְרַי כָּל־הַיּוֹם כִּי־רַבִּים לֹחֲמִים לִי מָרוֹם

“My enemies trample me all of the day, for many are fighting against me arrogantly”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because many are fighting against me arrogantly, my enemies trample me all of the day]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 56:3 (#1)

יוֹם אִירָא אֲנִי אֵלֶיךָ אֶבְטָח

“The day I fear, I, I will trust in you”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will trust** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to express a commitment or resolve. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I am resolved that the day I fear, I will trust in you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 56:3 (#2)

יוֹם

“The day”

David is using **The day** as a common expression of his culture to describe the occasion on which something might happen. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [If ever] or [When]

See: Idiom

Psalms 56:4 (#1)

בֵּאלֹהִים אֲהַלֵּל דְּבָרוֹ בֵּאלֹהִים בָּטַחְתִּי

“In God—I praise his word—in God I trust”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put David's statement **I praise his word** at the beginning of this verse so that it does not interrupt his statement **In God ... I trust**. However, it is for emphasis and emotional impact that David introduces the information that he praises God's word in the middle of the information that he trusts God, so if you move the former information to the beginning of the verse, you should try to convey the emphasis and emotional impact in another way. Alternate translation: [I praise God's word, so I trust completely in him] or [I celebrate God's promises, so I trust completely in him]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 56:4 (#2)

אֲהַלֵּל דְּבָרוֹ

"I praise his word"

David is using the term **word** to represent **God** speaking to him by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I praise him for what he has said to me] or [I praise him for his promise to me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:4 (#3)

מַה־יַּעֲשֶׂה בָשָׂר לִי

"What will flesh do to me"

Here, **flesh** represents human beings, who are made of flesh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [What will human beings do to me?]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:4 (#4)

מַה־יַּעֲשֶׂה בָשָׂר לִי

"What will flesh do to me"

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Human beings can certainly do nothing to me!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 56:5 (#1)

דְּבָרַי יְעַצֵּבוּ

"they vex my matters"

The term that the ULT translates as **matters** can also mean "words." So this could mean: (1) that the people David is describing are causing trouble in his affairs. Alternate translation: [they cause trouble in my affairs] or (2) that these people are figuratively reshaping, that is, distorting, what David says. Alternate translation: [they twist my words]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 56:5 (#2)

כָּל־מַחְשְׁבֹתָם

"all of their thoughts"

David is saying **all** as an overstatement for emphasis. He is referring not to every thought that his Philistine captors have but to **all of their thoughts** about him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [all of their thoughts about me]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 56:6 (#1)

הֵמָּה & יִשְׁמֹרוּ

"they, they watch"

David is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they watch** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the personal role that his enemies are taking in watching him. (They are not appointing others as spies but doing the spying themselves.) If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [they personally watch] or [it is they who watch]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 56:6 (#2)

עֲקֵבַי יִשְׁמֹרוּ

"they watch my heels"

David is using his **heels** to represent how he walks on his feet to go places. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [they watch my steps] or [they observe where I go]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:6 (#3)

קִוּוּ נַפְשִׁי

“they await my life”

Here, David’s **life** represents an opportunity to take his life or kill him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:7 (#1)

עַל־אָ֭וֶן פַּלֵּט־לָ֑מוֹ

“Upon iniquity {shall there be} an escape for them”

The word that the ULT translates as **Upon** could indicate: (1) that **iniquity** characterizes David’s enemies. Alternate translation: [Because of their iniquity, shall there be an escape for them] or (2) that **iniquity** is the means that David’s enemies would use to **escape** from the just consequences of their actions. Alternate translation: [Shall there be an escape for them by iniquity]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 56:7 (#2)

עַל־אָ֭וֶן פַּלֵּט־לָ֑מוֹ

“Upon iniquity {shall there be} an escape for them”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Because of their iniquity, there should not be an escape for them!] or [There should not be an escape for them by iniquity!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 56:7 (#3)

בְּ֝אַפְּ

“In nose”

Here the **nose** represents anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [In anger]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:7 (#4)

עַמִּ֥ים ׀ הוֹרֵ֗ד

“make the peoples go down”

David is speaking as if the **peoples** were actually in an elevated position and God would **make** them **go down** from there. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [destroy the peoples]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 56:8 (#1)

סָ֭פַּרְתָּה אָ֑תָּה

“You, you record”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you record** already includes this meaning. He is doing that in order to emphasize a contrast between what his enemies are doing to try to harm him and what God is doing to watch over him and care for him. Alternate translation: [But for your part, you record]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 56:8 (#2)

נֹדִ֥י ׀ סָ֝פַ֗רְתָּה

“you record my wandering”

David is speaking as if God had actually recorded his **wandering**, that is, as if God had written down that at this point David had left Israel to live among the Philistines. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are aware of my wandering]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 56:8 (#3)

שִׂ֣ימָה דִמְעָתִ֣י בְנֹאדֶ֑ךָ

“Put my tears in your bag”

David is speaking as if God actually had a leather **bag** that held fluids, such as people in this culture used to hold water or wine when traveling through arid regions, and that he wanted God to put his **tears** in it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Keep my tears close to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 56:8 (#4)

שִׂ֣ימָה דִמְעָתִ֣י בְנֹאדֶ֑ךָ

“Put my tears in your bag”

David is using his **tears** to represent the sorrows he has experienced. If it would be helpful in your lan-

guage, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Always be mindful of my sorrows]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:8 (#5)

הֲלֹא֥ בְסִפְרָתֶֽךָ

“Are they} not in your record”

David is using the question form to make a confident affirmation. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [After all, they are in your record.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 56:8 (#6)

הֲלֹא֥ בְסִפְרָתֶֽךָ

“Are they} not in your record”

Earlier in this verse, David portrays God as recording the details of his **wandering**. Here he speaks as if God had actually written in that **record** about the tears he has shed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [After all, you are aware of them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 56:9 (#1)

אָ֤ז יָשֻׁ֖בוּ אוֹיְבַ֑י אָ֝חֹ֗ור בְּיֹ֣ום אֶקְרָ֑א

“Then my enemies will turn back on the day I call”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [On the day I call, then my enemies will turn back]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 56:9 (#2)

אָ֤ז יָשֻׁ֖בוּ אוֹיְבַ֑י אָ֝חֹ֗ור בְּיֹ֣ום אֶקְרָ֑א

“Then my enemies will turn back on the day I call”

See how you translated the similar expression “The day” in verse 3. Alternate translation: [When I call, then my enemies will turn back]

See: Idiom

Psalms 56:9 (#3)

אָ֤ז יָשֻׁ֖בוּ אוֹיְבַ֑י אָ֝חֹ֗ור בְּיֹ֣ום אֶקְרָ֑א

“Then my enemies will turn back on the day I call”

David saying both **Then** and **on the day** (meaning “when”) for emphasis. However, in some languages this might seem to express extra information in a way that would not be natural. If so, you can use only one of these expressions. Alternate translation: [When I call, my enemies will turn back]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 56:9 (#4)

אֶקְרָ֑א

“I call”

David means implicitly that he will **call** to God for help. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I call to you for help]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 56:9 (#5)

זֶ֤ה־יָ֨דַ֗עְתִּי כִּֽי־אֱלֹהִ֥ים לִֽי

“This I know, for God {is} for me”

The word that the ULT translates as **for** could introduce: (1) the reason why David knows that what he has just said is true. Alternate translation: [I know this because God is for me] or (2) the content of what David knows. Alternate translation: [This I know, that God is for me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 56:9 (#6)

זֶ֤ה־יָ֨דַ֗עְתִּי כִּֽי־אֱלֹהִ֥ים לִֽי

“This I know, for God {is} for me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because God is for me, I know this]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 56:10–11 (#1)

בֵּֽאלֹהִ֥ים אְהַלֵּ֗ל דָּ֫בָ֥ר בַּֽיהוָ֥ה אְהַלֵּ֑ל דָּבָֽר׃ בֵּאלֹהִ֥ים בָּ֝טַ֗חְתִּי לֹ֣א אִירָ֑א מַה־יַּ֖עֲשֶׂ֣ה אָדָ֣ם לִֽי

“In God—I praise his word— in Yahweh—I praise his word—in God I trust. I will not fear. What will man do to me”

This is the second instance of the refrain in this psalm. (It occurs here in an expanded form.) We recommend that you show this to your readers by translating the phrases here the same way that you translated them in the first occurrence of this refrain in 56:4.

See: Poetry

Psalms 56:11 (#1)

מַה־יַּעֲשֶׂה אָדָם לִי

“What will man do to me”

See how you translated the term “man” in 56:1. (Although David says **man** here where he said “flesh” in verse 4, the meaning is the same in both instances of this refrain.) Alternate translation: [What will people do to me?] or [Human beings can certainly do nothing to me!]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 56:12 (#1)

עָלַי & נְדָרֶיךָ

“Your vows {are} on me”

David is using **Your vows {are} on me** as a common expression of his culture to mean that he has made vows to God that he will publicly thank him for helping him and that he is bound by those vows to keep that promise. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am under vows to you] or [I have made vows to you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 56:12 (#2)

נְדָרֶיךָ

“Your vows”

David is using the possessive form to describe not vows that God has made but **vows** that he has made to **God**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The vows I have made to you]

See: Possession

Psalms 56:12 (#3)

נְדָרֶיךָ

“Your vows”

David is probably not referring to several different vows he has made to God. He probably means that he has made the same vow several times, that he will sacrifice a thank-offering to God when God delivers him. If your language uses a different plural form for a repeated action than it does for separate actions, it would be appropriate to use that form here. In some languages it may be natural to use a singular form. Alternate translation: [The vow I have made to you]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 56:13 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** does not introduce the reason why David is going to make a thank-offering to God. It introduces an explanation of why David is going to be able to do that. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear. Alternate translation: [I will be able to do this because]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 56:13 (#2)

הִצַּלְתָּ נַפְשִׁי מִמָּוֶת׃

“you deliver my life from death”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [you deliver me from death] or [you rescue my life]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 56:13 (#3)

הֲלֹא֮ רַגְלַי מִדֶּחִי לְהִתְהַלֵּךְ לִפְנֵי אֱלֹהִים בְּאוֹר הַחַיִּים

“Are} not my feet from stumbling, that I may walk about to the face of God in the light of the living”

David is using the question form to make a confident assertion. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [My feet are from stumbling, so I may walk about to the face of God in the light of the living!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 56:13 (#4)

הֲלֹ֤א רַגְלַ֨י מִ֘מָּ֤דֶד֗חִי

“Are} not my feet from stumbling”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Are not my feet kept from stumbling] or, as an assertion, [You keep my feet from stumbling]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 56:13 (#5)

הֲלֹ֤א רַגְלַ֨י מִ֘מָּ֤דֶד֗חִי

“Are} not my feet from stumbling”

David is speaking as if God actually kept his **feet** from **stumbling**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do you not keep me safe] or, as an assertion, [You keep me safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 56:13 (#6)

לְ֝הִתְהַלֵּ֗ךְ

“that I may walk about”

David is using the image of walking to represent living. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that I may live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 56:13 (#7)

לִ֥פְנֵי

“to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:13 (#8)

בְּ֝אֹ֗ור הַחַיִּֽים

“in the light of the living”

Here, **light** represents the earth, which people of this culture considered to be a light place, by contrast with Sheol, the realm of the dead, which was a dark place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the world of the living] or [on this earth, where people are alive]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 56:13 (#9)

הַחַיִּֽים

“the living”

David is using the adjective **living** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [living people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms - Chapter 57 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 57 begins as a psalm of supplication or lament. It presents several of the basic elements of that type of psalm. But after the statement of trust, instead of a petition and a vow of praise, it turns into a psalm of worship. David experiences such confidence in God that instead of asking him to do something specific for him and promising to thank him publicly, David calls himself to praise God and says why he should do that. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–3)
2. Description of troubles (4)
3. Refrain (5)
4. Description of troubles (6)
5. Statement of trust (7)
6. Call to worship (8–9)
7. Reason to worship (10)
8. Refrain (11)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “miktam.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

As its superscription indicates, the background to this psalm is one of two episodes in which David fled from King Saul and hid in a cave. This could have been the cave of Adullam, as described in 1 Samuel 22:1–2, or the cave of En Gedi, as described in 1 Samuel 24:1–22. It may be helpful to read those episodes before translating this psalm.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Variation between "you" and "he"
In verses 1, 5, 7, and 9–11, David addresses God directly as "you." In verses 2–3, he speaks about him as "God." This variation of pronouns reflects the flow of psalm of supplication from a cry for help to a description of troubles to a statement of trust. This psalm then becomes a psalm of worship in which David continues to address God directly. However, if it would not be natural in your language to switch back and forth between second-person and third-person pronouns, you could use second-person pronouns throughout the psalm, as some versions do. For example, in verse 2 you might say "I call to you, God Most High," and in verse 9, you might say "May you send" and "May you reproach."

Psalms 57:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

See how you translated the term "chief musician" in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 57:0 (#3)

מִכְתָּם

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִכְתָּם"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **miktam**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 57:0 (#4)

בְּבָרְחוֹ מִפְּנֵי־שָׁאוּל בַּמְּעָרָה

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּבָרְחוֹ מִפְּנֵי־שָׁאוּל בַּמְּעָרָה"

This superscription is referring to one of two episodes in which David **fled** from King **Saul**, who wanted to kill him, and hid in a **cave**. This could have been the cave of Adullam, as described in 1 Samuel 22:1–2, or the cave of En Gedi, as described in 1 Samuel 24:1–22. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe these events more fully, even though the identity of this cave is not certain. Alternate translation: [David wrote this song while he was hiding in a cave to which he had fled in order to be safe from King Saul]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 57:0 (#5)

מִפְּנֵי־שָׁאוּל

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִפְּנֵי־שָׁאוּל"

The superscription is using one part of Saul, his **face**, to mean all of him in his determination to kill David. Alternate translation: [from Saul, who wanted to kill him]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 57:1 (#1)

חָנֵּנִי אֱלֹהִים ׀ חָנֵּנִי

"Be gracious to me, God, be gracious to me"

These are imperatives, but they communicate a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please be gracious to me; God, please be gracious to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 57:1 (#2)

חָנֵּנִי אֱלֹהִים ׀ חָנֵּנִי

"Be gracious to me, God, be gracious to me"

David is repeating a phrase in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If speakers of your language can repeat phrases for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I ask you earnestly to be gracious to me, God]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 57:1 (#3)

כִּי

"for"

Here the word **for** does not introduce the reason why God should be gracious to David. It introduces David's explanation of why he wants God to be gracious to him. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly in your translation.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 57:1 (#4)

בְּךָ֤ חָסָ֣יָה נַפְשִׁ֣י וּבְצֵל־כְּנָפֶ֣יךָ אֶחְסֶ֑ה עַ֥ד יַעֲבְר֥וֹ הַוּֽוֹת

“in you my soul takes refuge, and in the shadow of your wings I take refuge until the calamities have passed by”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [my soul takes refuge in the shadow of your wings until the calamities have passed by] or [in you my soul takes refuge, indeed, in the shadow of your wings I take refuge until the calamities have passed by]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 57:1 (#5)

בְּךָ֤ חָסָ֣יָה נַפְשִׁ֣י

“in you my soul takes refuge”

David is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of him in the act of taking refuge in God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in you I take refuge]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 57:1 (#6)

בְּךָ֤ חָסָ֣יָה נַפְשִׁ֣י

“in you my soul takes refuge”

David is speaking as if God were actually a **refuge** or place where he could go to be safe. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are the one who keeps me safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:1 (#7)

וּבְצֵל־כְּנָפֶ֣יךָ אֶחְסֶ֑ה

“and in the shadow of your wings I take refuge”

Here the **shadow** that wings cast represents the area under the wings that they shelter. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and in the shelter of your wings I take refuge] or [and under your wings I take refuge]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 57:1 (#8)

וּבְצֵל־כְּנָפֶ֣יךָ אֶחְסֶ֑ה

“and in the shadow of your wings I take refuge”

David is speaking as if God were actually a bird that had **wings** and as if he were one of that bird’s chicks that would **take refuge** under those wings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this image as a comparison. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:1 (#9)

עַ֥ד יַעֲבְר֥וֹ הַוּֽוֹת

“until the calamities have passed by”

David is speaking of the **calamities** he is experiencing as if it were living things that could pass by him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [until these calamities end]

See: Personification

Psalms 57:2 (#1)

גֹּמֵ֖ר עָלָֽי

“the one accomplishing for me”

David assumes that his listeners will understand that by **accomplishing**, he means that God accomplishes the purposes that he has for him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the one accomplishing his purposes for me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 57:3 (#1)

יִשְׁלַ֣ח מִשָּׁמַ֣יִם ׀ וְיוֹשִׁיעֵ֗נִי חֵרֵ֣ף שֹׁאֲפִ֑י & יִשְׁלַ֖ח אֱלֹהִ֣ים חַסְדּ֣וֹ וַאֲמִתּֽוֹ

“May he send from the heavens and save me. May he reproach the one trampling me & May God send his covenant faithfulness and his truth”

The two instances of the verb **send** in this verse are in a form that Hebrew writers could use to express either a statement or a wish. The verb **reproach** would conform to whichever sense the writer intended. At

this point in this psalm of supplication, David still seems to be expressing his cry for help, so the ULT translates these verbs as expressing a wish. (See the introduction to this psalm.) However, David may also be making an anticipatory confident statement about what God will do. The original audience may have heard both nuances. Use the verbal form in your language that seems most suitable. Alternate translation: [He will send from the heavens and save me. He will reproach the one trampling me. ... God will send his covenant faithfulness and his truth]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 57:3 (#2)

יִשְׁלַ֤ח מִשָּׁמַ֨יִם ׀ וְיוֹשִׁיעֵ֗נִי

“May he send from the heavens and save me”

David is speaking as if he wanted God actually to **send** someone or something **from the heavens** to **save** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May he act from the heavens to save me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:3 (#3)

יִשְׁלַ֤ח מִשָּׁמַ֨יִם ׀ וְיוֹשִׁיעֵ֗נִי

“May he send from the heavens and save me”

If you decide to retain the image of sending in your translation, it may be helpful to specify what God would **send**. Alternate translation: [May he send help from the heavens and save me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 57:3 (#4)

חֵרֵ֣ף שֹׁאֲפִ֑י

“May he reproach the one trampling me”

David is speaking as if someone were actually **trampling** on him and as if he wanted God to say something to make the person ashamed of doing that so that he would stop. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May he stop the person who is harassing me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:3 (#5)

סֶּ֥לָה

“Selah”

To translate the term **Selah** here and in verse 7, see how your translation team decided at 3:2 to represent that term.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 57:3 (#6)

יִשְׁלַ֤ח אֱ֭לֹהִים חַסְדּ֣וֹ וַאֲמִתּ֑וֹ

“May God send his covenant faithfulness and his truth”

David is speaking as if **covenant faithfulness** and **truth** were living things that God could **send** to help him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May God act in covenant faithfulness and truth to help me]

See: Personification

Psalms 57:3 (#7)

חַסְדּ֣וֹ וַאֲמִתּ֑וֹ

“his covenant faithfulness and his truth”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **truth** and **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways, here and in verse 10. Alternate translation: [the ways he is faithful to his covenant and his trustworthiness]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 57:4 (#1)

נַפְשִׁ֥י ׀ בְּתוֹךְ־לְבָא֗וֹת

“My soul {is} in the midst of lions”

David is using one part of himself, his **soul** or inner being, to mean all of him in the situation of being **in the midst of lions**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am in the midst of lions]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 57:4 (#2)

נַפְשִׁ֥י ׀ בְּתוֹךְ־לְבָא֗וֹת

“My soul {is} in the midst of lions”

The word that the ULT translates as **soul** can also mean “life.” The original audience would have heard both nuances. The implication is that David’s life is in danger, that is, he is in danger of being killed. Alternate translation: [My life is in danger because I am in the midst of lions]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 57:4 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי ׀ בְּתוֹךְ לְבָאִם׃

“My soul {is} in the midst of lions”

David is speaking as if he were actually surrounded by **lions**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this image as a comparison. Alternate translation: [I am in the midst of men who are as dangerous as lions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:4 (#4)

אֶשְׁכְּבָה לְלֹהֲטִים בְּנֵי־אָדָם

“I must lie down {among} blazing ones, sons of man”

By putting the phrase **sons of man** right after **blazing ones**, David is indicating that he is making a comparison between these people and things that are **blazing** and set other things on fire. The point of this comparison is that just as fire is destructive, so these people are trying to destroy him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I must lie down among people who are trying to destroy me]

See: Simile

Psalms 57:4 (#5)

בְּנֵי־אָדָם

“sons of man”

David is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 57:4 (#6)

שִׁנֵּיהֶם חֲנִית וְחִצִּים וּלְשׁוֹנָם חֶרֶב חַדָּה

“Their teeth {are} a spear and arrows, and their tongue {is} a sharp sword”

David is using the **teeth** and **tongue** of these men to represent them speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Their speech is a spear and arrows; yes, what they say is a sharp sword]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 57:4 (#7)

שִׁנֵּיהֶם חֲנִית וְחִצִּים וּלְשׁוֹנָם חֶרֶב חַדָּה

“Their teeth {are} a spear and arrows, and their tongue {is} a sharp sword”

David is speaking as if what these men say with their **teeth** and **tongue** were actually **a spear and arrows** and **a sharp sword**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this image as a comparison. Alternate translation: [What they say about me is as dangerous as a spear or arrows or a sharp sword]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:4 (#8)

וּלְשׁוֹנָם חֶרֶב חַדָּה

“and their tongue {is} a sharp sword”

Here the word **tongue** is singular in form, but it refers to the tongues of all of David’s enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “tongue.” Alternate translation: [and their tongues are sharp swords]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 57:5 (#1)

רָרוּמָה עַל־הַשָּׁמַיִם אֱלֹהִים עַל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“Be high above the heavens, God, {may} your glory {be} above all of the earth”

The expression **Be high** is an imperative, but it communicates a fervent wish rather than a command. Use a form in your language that will indicate this. Alternate translation: [Oh may you be high above the heavens, God, may your glory be above all of the earth]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 57:5 (#2)

רָרוּמָה עַל־הַשָּׁמַיִם אֱלֹהִים עַל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“Be high above the heavens, God, {may} your glory {be} above all of the earth”

David is speaking as if he actually wanted **God** and his **glory** to be in a physically high position relative to the **heavens** and the **earth**. In this context, God’s **glory** refers to the honor that he receives. The second part of this verse specifies in what way David wants the first part to be true. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate trans-

lation: [May people honor you, God, more than anyone else in heaven or on earth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:5 (#3)

רָר֣וּמָה עַל־הַשָּׁמַ֣יִם אֱלֹהִ֑ים עַ֖ל כָּל־הָאָ֣רֶץ כְּבוֹדֶֽךָ׃

“Be high above the heavens, God, {may} your glory {be} above all of the earth”

David is referring to the entire created realm by naming its two main components, **the heavens** and **the earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [May people honor you, God, more than anyone else anywhere]

See: Merism

Psalms 57:6 (#1)

רֶ֣שֶׁת ׀ הֵכִ֣ינוּ לְפָעָמַ֑י

“They prepare a net for my steps”

The pronoun **They** refers to the enemies whom David describes in verse 4. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [My enemies prepare a net for my steps]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 57:6 (#2)

רֶ֣שֶׁת ׀ הֵכִ֣ינוּ לְפָעָמַ֑י

“They prepare a net for my steps”

Here, David’s **steps** represent his feet walking along a path. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [They prepare a net for my feet] or [They prepare a net, hoping I will walk into it and it will trap my feet]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 57:6 (#3)

רֶ֣שֶׁת ׀ הֵכִ֣ינוּ לְפָעָמַ֑י

“They prepare a net for my steps”

David is speaking as if his enemies physically **prepare a net** to trap him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They take measures to capture me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:6 (#4)

כָּפְפָ֣ה נַפְשִׁ֑י

“my soul bows down”

David is using one part of himself, his **soul** or inner being, to mean all of him in the act of bowing down. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I bow down]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 57:6 (#5)

כָּפְפָ֣ה נַפְשִׁ֑י

“my soul bows down”

David is speaking as if he physically **bows down** when he realizes that his enemies are trying to capture him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I feel despair]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:6 (#6)

כָּר֣וּ לְפָנַ֣י שִׂיחָ֣ה נָפְל֣וּ בְתוֹכָ֣הּ

“They dig a pit to my face; they fall into the midst of it”

Here, **to my face** represents “in front of me.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [They dig a pit in front of me; they fall into the midst of it] or [They dig a pit where they expect me to walk, hoping I will fall into it, but they fall into it instead]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 57:6 (#7)

כָּר֣וּ לְפָנַ֣י שִׂיחָ֣ה נָפְל֣וּ בְתוֹכָ֣הּ

“They dig a pit to my face; they fall into the midst of it”

David is speaking as if his enemies physically **dig a pit** (covering it to conceal it) in order to trap him, but that they fall into it themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly (indicating that David is elaborating on the idea he expressed in the first part of this verse). Alternate translation: [Indeed, they do things to try to capture me, but what they do only hurts them instead]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:7 (#1)

נָכוֹן לִבִּי אֱלֹהִים נָכוֹן לִבִּי

“My heart is established, God, my heart is established”

The expression **established** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [My heart is steadfast, God, my heart is steadfast]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 57:7 (#2)

נָכוֹן לִבִּי אֱלֹהִים נָכוֹן לִבִּי

“My heart is established, God, my heart is established”

David is repeating a phrase in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If speakers of your language can repeat phrases for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [My heart is firmly established, God] or [My heart is firmly steadfast, God]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 57:7 (#3)

נָכוֹן לִבִּי אֱלֹהִים נָכוֹן לִבִּי

“My heart is established, God, my heart is established”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s feelings and intentions. David means that his confidence in God is unwavering. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have confidence in you, God, I have confidence in you] or [I have resolute confidence in you, God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:7 (#4)

אָשִׁירָה וַאֲזַמֵּרָה

“Let me sing and make music”

David is using a verbal form in which he is addressing himself and suggesting a course of action that is appropriate in light of what he has just said. In your translation, use an appropriate verbal form to indicate this, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [So I will sing and make music]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 57:7 (#5)

אָשִׁירָה וַאֲזַמֵּרָה

“Let me sing and make music”

The terms **sing** and **make music** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let me surely sing] or [So I will surely sing]

See: Doublet

Psalms 57:8 (#1)

עוּרָה כְבוֹדִי

“Awake, my glory”

David is using the term **glory** to represent his soul. People of this culture spoke of the soul or inner being as the most noble or glorious part of a person. (The use of this term here is similar to its use in 16:9, “my heart rejoices and my glory is glad,” and 30:12, “my glory will make music to you.”) If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Awake, my soul]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 57:8 (#2)

עוּרָה כְבוֹדִי

“Awake, my glory”

David is addressing one part of himself, his **glory** or soul, to tell all of himself to wake up. If your language has a verbal form that is marked for self-address, you could use it here. Other languages may have other ways of showing the meaning. Alternate translation: [I must wake up] or (self-address form) [Wake up!]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 57:8 (#3)

עוּרָה כְבוֹדִי

“Awake, my glory”

David is speaking as if he were actually asleep and needed to wake up. He is actually urging himself to apply vitality and creativity to the work of praising God in song. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [I must sing in a lively way] or (self-address form) [Come on, sing in a lively way]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:8 (#4)

עֲעוּרָה הַנֵּבֶל וְכִנּוֹר

“Awake, lyre and harp”

David is speaking of his **lyre** and **harp** as if they were living things that could wake up from sleep. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will start making music with my lyre and harp]

See: Personification

Psalms 57:8 (#5)

אָעִירָה שָׁחַר

“Let me awaken the dawn”

David is speaking of the **dawn** as if it were a living thing that he could **awaken**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will play them before the sun comes up]

See: Personification

Psalms 57:9 (#1)

אוֹדְךָ בָעַמִּים ׀ אֲדֹנָי אֲזַמְּרְךָ בַּל־אֻמִּים

“I will thank you, Lord, among the peoples; I will make music to you among the nations”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I will sing praises to you, Lord, among the peoples of other nations]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 57:10 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces more detailed information about the reasons David has for singing the Lord’s praises. Use a connecting word or phrase in your language that will make this clear. It may not be necessary to represent this word explicitly in your translation. Alternate translation: [I will do this because]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 57:10 (#2)

גָּדֹל עַד־שָׁמַיִם חַסְדֶּךָ וְעַד־שְׁחָקִים אֲמִתֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness {is} great to the heavens, and your truth to the clouds”

David is speaking of God’s **covenant faithfulness** and **truth** as if they were physical things that could extend from the earth to the **clouds** and the **heavens**. He means that these qualities of God are immeasurably great. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 57:10 (#3)

גָּדֹל עַד־שָׁמַיִם חַסְדֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness {is} great to the heavens”

David is using **is great to** as a common expression of his culture to mean “is as high as.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your covenant faithfulness reaches to the heavens] or [your covenant faithfulness is as high as the sky]

See: Idiom

Psalms 57:10 (#4)

חַסְדֶּךָ וְעַד־שְׁחָקִים אֲמִתֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness & and your truth to the clouds”

See how you translated the abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **truth** in verse 3.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 57:10 (#5)

וְעַד־שְׁחָקִים אֲמִתֶּךָ

“and your truth to the clouds”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and your truth is great to the clouds] or [and your truth is as high as the clouds]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 57:11 (#1)

רָרוּמָה עַל־שָׁמַיִם אֱלֹהִים עַל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“Be high above the heavens, God, {may} your glory {be} above all of the earth”

This is the second instance of the refrain in this psalm. We recommend that you show this to your readers by translating the phrases here the same way that you translated them in the first occurrence of this refrain in 57:5.

See: Poetry

Psalms - Chapter 58 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 58 is a wisdom psalm that describes the difference between how righteous people and wicked people live and the difference between what happens to them. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Introduction: rebuke of wicked judges (1–2)
2. Description of wicked people (3–5)
3. Prayer that God will punish the wicked (6–8)
4. Assertion that God will punish the wicked and reward the righteous (9–11)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “miktam.” See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

Psalms 58:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 58:0 (#3)

מִכְתָּם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִכְתָּם”

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **miktam**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 58:1 (#1)

הַאֻמְנָם אֵלֶּם צֶדֶק תְּדַבֵּרוּן מֵישָׁרִים תִּשְׁפְּטוּ בְּנֵי אָדָם

“Truly {in} silence do you speak righteousness? Do you judge uprightly, sons of man”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Truly in silence you do not speak righteousness! You do not judge uprightly, sons of man!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 58:1 (#2)

צֶדֶק

“righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 58:1 (#3)

בְּנֵי אָדָם

“sons of man”

David is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 58:2 (#1)

בְּלֵבָב

“in the heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and intentions exist. The psalmist means that they are planning and deciding to do wickedness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your thoughts] or [inwardly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 58:2 (#2)

עוֹלָלֶת

“wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wicked things] or [evil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 58:2 (#3)

חָמָס יְיַדֵּיכֶם תְּפַלֵּסוּן

“Your hands weigh out violence”

Here, **hands** represents the actions of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You intentionally commit violent acts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 58:2 (#4)

חָמָס

“violence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [violent acts] or [violent deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 58:3 (#1)

רְשָׁעִים

“The wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Those who act wickedly]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 58:3 (#2)

זֹרוּ & מֵרָחֶם

“turn aside from the womb”

The psalmist is using **turn aside from the womb** as a common expression to mean “go astray from birth.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [go astray from birth] or [are wicked from the day they are born]

See: Idiom

Psalms 58:3 (#3)

תָּעוּ מִבֶּטֶן

“they stray from the belly”

The psalmist is using **stray from the belly** as a common expression of the culture to mean “go astray from birth.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they err from birth] or [they go astray from the day they are born]

See: Idiom

Psalms 58:3 (#4)

זֹרוּ רְשָׁעִים מֵרָחֶם תָּעוּ מִבֶּטֶן דִּבְּרֵי כָזָב

“The wicked turn aside from the womb; they stray from the belly, speaking falsehood”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [The wicked turn aside from the womb, indeed, they stray from the belly, speaking falsehood.]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 58:3 (#5)

דִּבְּרֵי כָזָב

“speaking falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [speaking lies] or [saying things that are false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 58:4 (#1)

חֲמַת־לָמוֹ כִּדְמוּת חֲמַת־נָחָשׁ

“The poison to them {is} like the likeness of the poison of a serpent”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the poison of a serpent** is harmful and deadly, so is the speech or nature of the wicked. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Their words are as harmful as serpent venom] or [They are as poisonous as a serpent]

See: Simile

Psalms 58:4 (#2)

כְּמוֹ־פֶּ֥תֶן חֵ֝רֵ֗שׁ

“They are} like a deaf adder”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a deaf adder** does not listen, so the wicked do not listen to correction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [They are as unheeding as a deaf adder]

See: Simile

Psalms 58:4 (#3)

כְּמוֹ

“They are} like”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The wicked people are like]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 58:4 (#4)

יַאֲטֵ֖ם אָזְנֽוֹ

“that} shuts its ears”

The psalmist is speaking of the wicked as if they were snakes that could **shut** their **ears**. He means that they willfully refuse to listen. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that refuses to listen] or [that will not listen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 58:5 (#1)

לְקוֹל֥ מְלַחֲשִׁ֑ים

“to the voice of charmers”

The psalmist is using **the voice of charmers** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the music or incantations of snake charmers.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to the music of snake charmers] or [to the incantations of those who charm snakes]

See: Idiom

Psalms 58:5 (#2)

חוֹבֵ֥ר חֲבָרִֽים

“one charming charms”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [one who is charming them expertly] or [one who skillfully charms]

See: Poetry

Psalms 58:5 (#3)

מְחֻכָּֽם

“being made wise”

The expression **being made wise** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [a skilled charmer] or [an expert charmer]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 58:6 (#1)

אֱלֹהִ֗ים הֲרָס־שִׁנֵּ֥ימוֹ בְּפִ֑ימוֹ מַלְתְּעוֹת֖ כְּפִירִ֣ים נָתַ֣ץ ׀ יְהוָֽה

“God, break their teeth in their mouth! Break out the fangs of the young lions, Yahweh”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [God, break their teeth in their mouth; indeed, break out the fangs of the young lions, Yahweh]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 58:6 (#2)

אֱלֹהִ֗ים הֲרָס־שִׁנֵּ֥ימוֹ בְּפִ֑ימוֹ מַלְתְּעוֹת֖ כְּפִירִ֣ים נָתַ֣ץ ׀ יְהוָֽה

“God, break their teeth in their mouth! Break out the fangs of the young lions, Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of the wicked people as if they were dangerous animals with **teeth** and **fangs** that could harm others. He is asking God to destroy their power to harm people, as if God were breaking the teeth of dangerous animals. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God, destroy the power of the wicked! Take away their ability to harm people, Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 58:6 (#3)

הֲרֹס־שִׁנֵּימוֹ

“break their teeth”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a request. Alternate translation: [I ask you to break their teeth] or [please break their teeth]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 58:6 (#4)

מַלְתְּעוֹת & נְתֹּץ

“Break out the fangs of”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “Please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please break out the fangs of]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 58:7 (#1)

יִמָּאֲסוּ

“May they be melted”

The expression **May they be melted** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [May God melt them] or [May Yahweh cause them to melt]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 58:7 (#2)

כְּמוֹ־מַיִם יִתְהַלָּכוּ

“like waters {that} run off”

The point of this comparison is that just as **waters that run off** quickly disappear, so the psalmist wants his enemies to disappear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like waters that vanish from sight]

See: Simile

Psalms 58:7 (#3)

יְדֹרֵךְ חִצּוֹ

“When} he treads his arrows”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [When the wicked person treads his arrows] or [When each wicked person treads his arrows]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 58:7 (#4)

יְדֹרֵךְ חִצּוֹ

“When} he treads his arrows”

Here, **treads** represents “shoots.” Ancient archers would step on their bows in order to bend them so that they could string them. David means “when he steps on his bow to string it and then shoots arrows from it.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [When he launches his arrows] or [When he shoots his arrows]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 58:7 (#5)

כְּמוֹ יִתְמֹלָלוּ

“may they be} as if they are cut off”

The point of this comparison is that just as something that is **cut off** or blunted is ineffective, so the wicked person’s **arrows** would be ineffective. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [may they be as if they were blunted] or [may they be as if they had no points]

See: Simile

Psalms 58:7 (#6)

יִתְמֹלָלוּ

“they are cut off”

The expression **they are cut off** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh cuts them off] or [they break off]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 58:8 (#1)

כְּמוֹ שַׁשַׁבְלוּל תֶּתָּמֵס

“May they be} like a snail {that} melts”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a snail that melts** dissolves and disappears as it moves along, so the psalmist desires that his enemies would perish and vanish. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [May they be like a snail that liquifies and disappears]

See: Simile

Psalms 58:8 (#2)

כְּמוֹ

“May they be} like”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [May they be destroyed like] or [May they perish like]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 58:8 (#3)

נֵפֶל אֵשֶׁת

“May they be like} the miscarriage of a woman”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the miscarriage of a woman** never sees the light of day, so David’s enemies will never see **the sun**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [May they be like a stillborn baby which never experiences life]

See: Simile

Psalms 58:8 (#4)

נֵפֶל

“May they be like} the miscarriage of”

The psalmist is referring to a stillborn child in a polite way by using the term **miscarriage**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [May they be like a stillborn baby] or [May they be like a child who dies at birth]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 58:9 (#1)

בְּטֶרֶם יָבִינוּ סִירֹתֵיכֶם אָטָד

“Before your pots perceive the thorn”

The psalmist is using **Before your pots perceive the thorn** as a common expression of the culture to mean “very swiftly” or “before something can even begin.” The image refers to using thorns as quick-burning fuel to heat cooking pots, and the expression means that something will happen before the cooking process can even start. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In an instant] or [More swiftly than you can imagine]

See: Idiom

Psalms 58:9 (#2)

כְּמוֹ־חַי כְּמוֹ־חָרֹון

“like the living, like the burning”

The psalmist is speaking of the thorns as if they could be **the living** or **the burning** (that is, either green or dry). If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [whether green or dry]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 58:9 (#3)

חָרֹון

“the burning”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **burning**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what burns easily]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 58:9 (#4)

יִשְׂעֲרֶנּוּ

“he will whirlwind it away”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s judgment as if it were a powerful **whirlwind** that sweeps things away. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will sweep it away with great force] or [he will lift it from sight with a strong wind]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 58:10 (#1)

צַדִּיק

“The righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Righteous people] or [Those who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 58:10 (#2)

נָקָם

“vengeance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **vengeance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God punish the wicked] or [the wicked being punished]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 58:10 (#3)

פְּעָמָיו יִרְחַץ בְּדַם הָרָשָׁע

“He will wash his feet in the blood of the wicked”

David is speaking of the righteous person as if he were a warrior who could **wash his feet in the blood** that covered a battlefield after defeating enemies. This image expresses the idea of complete victory. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He will triumph completely over the wicked] or [He will celebrate total victory over the wicked]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 58:10 (#4)

כִּי־חָזָה נָקָם

“when he sees vengeance”

By **when he sees vengeance**, the psalmist means when he sees God punish the wicked. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [when he sees God take vengeance on the wicked] or [when he sees God punish those who are wicked]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 58:10 (#5)

הָרָשָׁע

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people] or [those who act wickedly]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 58:11 (#1)

וְיֹאמַר אָדָם

“Then man will say”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Then someone will say]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 58:11 (#2)

פְּרִי לַצַּדִּיק

“fruit {is} to the righteous”

The psalmist is using **fruit is to the righteous** as a common expression of the culture to mean “there is a reward for the righteous.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the righteous have a reward] or [the righteous are rewarded]

See: Idiom

Psalms 58:11 (#3)

פְּרִי

“fruit”

The psalmist is speaking of the reward or outcome that righteous people receive as if it were **fruit** such as that which a tree produces. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [benefit]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 58:11 (#4)

לַצַּדִּיק

“is} to the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [is to those who act righteously] or [comes to people who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 58:11 (#5)

אֱלֹהִים שֹׁפְטִים בָּאָרֶץ

“a God judging the earth”

The implication is that God actively judges the earth in contrast to the unjust judges mentioned earlier in the psalm. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [a God who actively judges the earth] or [a God who really does judge the earth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 59 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 59 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm. (Some elements are repeated.) See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–2)
2. Description of troubles (3–4)
3. Petition (5)
4. Refrain (6)
5. Description of troubles (7)
6. Statement of trust (8–10)
7. Petition (11–13)
8. Refrain (14–15)
9. Vow of praise (16–17)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “miktam.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

As its superscription indicates, the background to this psalm is an episode related in 1 Samuel 19:8–12 in which King Saul sent men to watch David’s house so that they could kill him when he left it. It may be helpful to read that episode before translating this psalm.

Psalms 59:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 59:0 (#3)

מִכְתָּם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִכְתָּם”

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **miktam**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 59:0 (#4)

בִּשְׁלֹחַ שָׁאוּל וַיִּשְׁמְרוּ אֶת־הַבַּיִת לַהֲמִיתוֹ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בִּשְׁלֹחַ שָׁאוּל וַיִּשְׁמְרוּ אֶת־הַבַּיִת לַהֲמִיתוֹ”

The implication is that Saul sent men to watch David’s house in order to kill him, as recorded in 1 Samuel 19:11. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When Saul sent men to watch David’s house to kill him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 59:1 (#1)

תְּשַׂגְּבֵנִי

“Set me on high”

This is an imperative, but it communicates an urgent request to God rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates an urgent request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please set me on high] or [I beg you to set me on high]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:1 (#2)

תְּשַׂגְּבֵנִי

“Set me on high”

David is speaking of protection as if Yahweh could **Set** him **on high** in an unreachable place above his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Keep me safe from them] or [Put me beyond their reach]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:1 (#3)

מִמִּתְקוֹמְמָי

“away from the ones rising up against me”

The pronoun **ones** refers to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [away from the enemies rising up against me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 59:2 (#1)

הַצִּילֵנִי

“Deliver me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please deliver me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:2 (#2)

מִפֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן

“from workers of iniquity”

David is using the possessive form to describe **workers** who are characterized by **iniquity**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from people who do wicked things] or [from those who practice evil]

See: Possession

Psalms 59:2 (#3)

מִפֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן

“from workers of iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from people who do evil things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:2 (#4)

הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“save me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates an urgent request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates an urgent request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please save me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:2 (#5)

וּמֵאַנְשֵׁי דָמִים הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“and save me from men of blood”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **men** who are characterized by **blood**. This refers to people who are violent or who commit murder. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and save me from violent men] or [and save me from murderers]

See: Possession

Psalms 59:2 (#6)

וּמֵאַנְשֵׁי דָמִים הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“and save me from men of blood”

Here, **blood** represents violence and murder. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [and save me from violent men] or [and save me from murderous men]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 59:3 (#1)

הִנֵּנָּה

“behold”

The psalmist is using **behold** as a common expression to draw the reader’s attention to what he is about to say. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [notice] or [see]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:3 (#2)

לְנַפְשִׁי

“for my life”

Here, **life** represents the whole person as the target of an attack. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to attack me] or [to murder me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 59:3 (#3)

עַזִּים

“the mighty”

David is using the adjective **mighty** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [mighty men] or [very strong men]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 59:3 (#4)

לֹא־פִשְׁעִי וְלֹא־חַטָּאתִי

“Not {for} my transgression and not {for} my sin”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [They gather against me not for my transgression and not for my sin] or [This is happening not for my transgression and not for my sin]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 59:3 (#5)

פִּשְׁעִי

“for} my transgression”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgression**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I transgressed against you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:3 (#6)

חַטָּאתִי

“for} my sin”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I have sinned]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:4 (#1)

בְּלִי־עָוֹן

“without iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [though I have done nothing wrong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:4 (#2)

עֹרָה לִקְרָאתִי

“Awake to meet me”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were asleep and needed to **Awake**. David means that he wants Yahweh to take action and help him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture or you could express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Come to meet me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:4 (#3)

עֹרָה

“Awake”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that would be used to make a polite re-

quest. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please awaken]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:4 (#4)

וּרְאֵה

“and see”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [and please look at my situation]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:5 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים ׀ צְבָאוֹת

“God of armies”

The expression **God of armies** refers to Yahweh as the commander of the heavenly armies, meaning the angelic hosts. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [God who rules over the angelic hosts]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 59:5 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the God of Israel”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form **the God of Israel** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control God. Rather the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the one whom Israel worships. Alternate translation: [who is the God whom Israel worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 59:5 (#3)

הָקִיצָה לִפְקֹד

“wake up to punish”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please arise to punish] or [I beg you to arise and punish]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:5 (#4)

הָקִיצָה

“wake up”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were asleep and needed to **wake up**. He means that he wants Yahweh to begin to intervene and punish the nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [come and act]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:5 (#5)

כָּל־הַגּוֹיִם

“all of the nations”

David says **all of the nations** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [the hostile nations] or [these enemy nations]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 59:5 (#6)

אַל־תָּחֹן

“Do not be gracious”

The word translated as **Do not be gracious** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not show favor] or [I beg you not to be gracious]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:5 (#7)

בֹּגְדֵי אָוֶן

“treacherous workers of iniquity”

David is using the possessive form to describe **workers** who are characterized by **iniquity**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people who are treacherous and who do wicked things] or [treacherous people who do evil]

See: Possession

Psalms 59:5 (#8)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

The word **Selah** is a Hebrew word. You will need to decide if you will use this word in its Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew word, you could spell it the way it sounds in your language and then put the translation in a footnote.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 59:6 (#1)

יָשׁוּבוּ

“They return”

The pronoun **They** refers to the enemies introduced in verses 1–3. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The psalmist’s enemies return]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 59:6 (#2)

יֶהֱמׇיוּ כַכֶּלֶב

“they growl like a dog”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a dog** is threatening and aggressive, so are the psalmist’s enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they make threatening sounds] or [they snarl aggressively]

See: Simile

Psalms 59:6 (#3)

וְיסֹובְבוּ עִיר

“and go around the city”

By **go around the city**, the psalmist means that David’s enemies are roaming around Jerusalem looking for victims. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [roam around the city looking for prey] or [prowl around the city seeking victims]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 59:7 (#1)

הִנֵּנָּה

“Behold”

The psalmist is using **Behold** as a common expression to draw attention to what follows. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Look] or [Pay attention]

See: Idiom

Psalms 59:7 (#2)

יַבִּיעוּן בְּפִיהֶם

“they belch out with their mouth”

The psalmist is using **they belch out with their mouth** as a common expression of the culture to mean that his enemies speak violently or arrogantly. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they speak violent threats] or [they pour out arrogant words]

See: Idiom

Psalms 59:7 (#3)

חֲרָבוֹת בִּשְׂפָתוֹתֵיהֶם

“swords {are} in their lips”

The psalmist is speaking of his enemies’ words as if they were **swords** that could physically harm people. This image emphasizes how dangerous and hurtful their speech is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their lips speak harmful words] or [their words are as dangerous as swords]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:7 (#4)

בִּשְׂפָתוֹתֵיהֶם

“are} in their lips”

Here, **lips** represents speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in their speech] or [in what they say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 59:7 (#5)

מִמִּי שֹׁמֵעַ

“Who is hearing”

The psalmist’s enemies are using the question form for emphasis. They assume that no one hears or cares what they say. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No one is hearing] or [No one hears us!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 59:8 (#1)

וְאַתָּה יְהוָה

“But you, Yahweh”

The psalmist uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the threats of his enemies and God’s response to them. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [You, however, Yahweh] or [You, Yahweh, on the other hand]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 59:8 (#2)

תִּשְׂחַק־לָמוֹ

“laugh at them”

The psalmist is using **laugh at them** as a common expression of the culture to mean “scorn them” or “treat them with contempt.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [ridicule them] or [look upon them with contempt]

See: Idiom

Psalms 59:8 (#3)

וְאַתָּה יְהוָה תִּשְׂחַק־לָמוֹ תִּלְעַג לְכָל־גּוֹיִם

“But you, Yahweh, laugh at them. You mock all of the nations”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [But you, Yahweh, laugh at them, indeed, you mock all of the nations]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 59:9 (#1)

עֻזּוֹ

“his strength”

The pronoun **his** may refer to God, but some Hebrew manuscripts and many translations understand it as **my**. This would make the psalmist say that God is **my strength**, which fits better with the context where he calls God **my stronghold**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could clarify this. Alternate translation: [my strength] or [you, my strength]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 59:9 (#2)

עֻזּוֹ

“his strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you who are strong] or [you who strengthen me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:9 (#3)

אֱלֹהִים מִשְׂגַּבִּי

“God {is} my stronghold”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a **stronghold**, that is, a fortified place of safety. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God protects me] or [God is my place of safety]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:10 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵי חסדו

“The God of my covenant faithfulness”

David is using the possessive form to describe **the God** who is characterized by **covenant faithfulness** toward him. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express

this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God, who is faithful to his covenant with me] or [God, who keeps his covenant promises to me]

See: Possession

Psalms 59:10 (#2)

חסדו

“my covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who is faithfully loyal to me in his covenant] or [who faithfully keeps his covenant with me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:10 (#3)

יַרְאֵנִי בְּשׁוּרָרָי

“will make me look upon my enemies”

The psalmist is using **will make me look upon my enemies** as a common expression of the culture to mean “will cause me to see my enemies defeated” or “will enable me to see my enemies humiliated.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will let me see my enemies defeated] or [will enable me to see myself humiliating my enemies]

See: Idiom

Psalms 59:11 (#1)

אַל־תַּהַרְגֵם

“Do not slay them”

The expression translated as **Do not slay them** is an imperative, but it communicates a request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a request. Alternate translation: [Please do not kill them] or [I ask that you not kill them]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:11 (#2)

פֶּן־יִשְׁכְּחוּ עַמִּי

“lest my people forget”

David is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first gives God an instruction to follow so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the instruction. Alternate translation: [so that my people will not forget] or [because if you do, my people will forget]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 59:11 (#3)

עַמִּי

“my people”

Here David is using the pronoun **my** with **people** to refer to the nation of Israel, over whom he reigns as king. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Israelites] or [the people of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 59:11 (#4)

הֲנִיעֵמוֹ

“Scatter them”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a request to God rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a request to God. It may be helpful to use a word such as “please.” Alternate translation: [Please scatter them] or [We ask that you scatter them]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:11 (#5)

בְּחֵילְךָ

“by your power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:11 (#6)

וְהוֹרִידֵמוֹ

“and bring them down”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please bring them down] or [I ask you to humble them]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:11 (#7)

מָגִנֵּנוּ

“our shield”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shield** that protects the Israelites. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:12 (#1)

חַטַּאת־פִּימוֹ

“For} the sin of their mouth”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **sin** that is characterized by **their mouth**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the sin characterized by their mouth] or [the sin that comes from their mouth]

See: Possession

Psalms 59:12 (#2)

חַטַּאת

“For} the sin of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [For what they say that is sinful] or [For the sinful words]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:12 (#3)

פִּימוֹ דְּבַר־שְׂפָתֵימוֹ

“their mouth, the word of their lips”

Here the phrases **their mouth** and **their lips** represent what the psalmist’s enemies say. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what they say] or [their spoken words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 59:12 (#4)

וְיִלָּכְדוּ בְגְאוֹנָם

“may they be taken in their pride”

The expression **may they be taken in their pride** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [may their pride trap them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 59:12 (#5)

בְגְאוֹנָם

“in their pride”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pride**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because they are proud]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:12 (#6)

וּמֵאָלָה

“and for the curse”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **the curse**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how they curse people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:12 (#7)

וּמִכַּחַשׁ

“and for the lying”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **lying**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and for the untruthful stories]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:13 (#1)

כַּלֵּה בְחֵמָה׀

“Consume {them} in wrath”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a request rather than a command for God to destroy his enemies. If the imperative does not communicate a request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a request. Alternate translation: [I ask that you consume them in wrath] or [Please consume them in wrath]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 59:13 (#2)

כַּלֵּה בְחֵמָה֮ כַּלֵּה

“Consume {them} in wrath; consume {them”

The psalmist is repeating forms of the verb **Consume** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Completely consume them in wrath]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 59:13 (#3)

בְחֵמָה֮

“in wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are angered] or [wrathfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:13 (#4)

וְאֵ֫אינֵמוֹ

“that they {may} not {be”

David is using the phrase **that they may not be** to introduce the goal or purpose of consuming his enemies in wrath. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that they will no longer exist] or [in order that they will be destroyed]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 59:13 (#5)

וְיֵדְעוּ֫

“that they may know”

Here, **that they may know** marks **that God is ruling in Jacob to the ends of the earth** as a further goal or purpose of **Consume them in wrath; consume them that they may not be**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that people may know] or [in order that all may know]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 59:13 (#6)

בְּיַעֲקֹ֗ב

“in Jacob”

Here, **Jacob** represents the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [over Israel] or [the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 59:13 (#7)

לְאַפְסֵי֥ הָאָ֗רֶץ

“to the ends of the earth”

The phrase **to the ends of the earth** was a common expression meaning “everywhere” or “throughout the entire world.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everywhere] or [throughout the whole world]

See: Idiom

Psalms 59:13 (#8)

סֶֽלָה

“Selah”

The word **Selah** is a Hebrew word. You will need to decide if you will use this word in its Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew word, you could spell it the way it sounds in your language and then put the translation in a footnote.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 59:14 (#1)

וְיָשֻׁ֫בוּ לָ֭עֶרֶב

“They return at evening”

This is poetic language. If your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [In the evening they return]

See: Poetry

Psalms 59:14 (#2)

יְהֻמּוּ֥ כַכֶּ֗לֶב

“they growl like a dog”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a dog** growls when it is threatening or angry, so the psalmist’s enemies make threatening sounds. If it

would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they make threatening sounds like an angry dog]

See: Simile

Psalms 59:15 (#1)

הֵ֭הָמָּה ינועון

“They, they wander around”

Here the psalmist is stating the pronoun **They** separately, even though the verb translated as **they wander** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the contrast between him and his enemies. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 59:15 (#2)

אִם־לֹ֣א יִשְׂבְּע֑וּ וְיָלִ֥ינוּ

“If they are not full, then they lodge”

David is speaking as if this were a hypothetical possibility, but he means that it is actually true. If your language does not state something as a condition if it is certain or true, or if your readers might think that what David is saying is uncertain, then you could translate this as a confident statement. Alternate translation: [When they are not full, they lodge]

See: Connect — Factual Conditions

Psalms 59:16 (#1)

וַ֭אֲנִי ׀ אָשִׁ֣ירָ

“But I, I will sing”

Here David is using the pronoun **I** twice for emphasis. He is doing this to contrast his response to God with the actions of his enemies, which he described earlier in the psalm. If a speaker of your language would repeat a pronoun in this way for emphasis, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [But as for me, I]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 59:16 (#2)

וַ֭אֲנִי

“But I”

David uses the words **But I** here to indicate a strong contrast between the enemies described in the previous verses and himself. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [As for me, however, I] or [In contrast to them, I]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 59:16 (#3)

עֻזֶּ֑ךָ

“about} your strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [about how strong you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:16 (#4)

חַסְדֶּֽךָ

“about} your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [about how you are faithful to your covenant] or [about how faithful you are to me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:16 (#5)

הָיִ֣יתָ מִשְׂגָּ֣ב לִ֑י

“you are a stronghold to me”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **stronghold** that protected him from enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable figure of speech or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are like a fortified place to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:16 (#6)

וּמָנ֥וֹס

“and a refuge”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were **a refuge** in which he could find safety from danger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and a place of safety]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:16 (#7)

בְּיוֹם צַר

“in the day of trouble”

David is using **in the day of trouble** as a common expression to mean “when I am in trouble.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when I am in trouble] or [in times of distress]

See: Idiom

Psalms 59:16 (#8)

בְּיוֹם צַר־לִי

“in the day of trouble to me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trouble**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when I am troubled] or [when I experience troubles]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:17 (#1)

עֻזִּי

“my strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you who make me strong] or [you who strengthen me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 59:17 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים מִשְׂגַּבִּי

“God {is} my stronghold”

David is speaking of God as if he were a **stronghold**, a fortified place where David could be protected from his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God protects me] or [God keeps me safe from my enemies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 59:17 (#3)

אֱלֹהֵי חַסְדִּי

“the God of my covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who is faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 60 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 60 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm except a vow of praise. (Some elements are repeated.) See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1)
2. Description of troubles (2–3)
3. Statement of trust (4–5a)
4. Petition (5b)
5. Statement of trust (6–8)
6. Petition (9–11)
7. Statement of trust (12)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a “miktam.” See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

As its superscription indicates, the background to this psalm consists of two episodes related in 2 Samuel 8:3–8 and 2 Samuel 8:13–14 in which David was leading the Israelite army to fight against Aramean armies northeast of Israel and his general Joab had to leave and fight against the Edomite army to the south of Israel. It may be helpful to read those episodes before translating this psalm.

Psalms 60:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

See how you translated the term “chief musician” in the superscription to Psalm 4. Alternate translation: [For the leader of worship music] or [For the music director]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 60:0 (#3)

עֵדֻת

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עֵדֻת”

The superscription to this psalm describes it as a **testimony**. This most likely means that the psalm is presenting the sufferings and defeats of the Israelites to Yahweh as a plea for him to help them on the basis that they are his covenant people. Alternate translation: [An appeal for help]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 60:0 (#4)

מִכְתָּם

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִכְתָּם"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **miktam**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 60:0 (#5)

אֲרַם נַהֲרַיִם׃

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: אֲרַם נַהֲרַיִם׃"

The words **Aram Naharaim** are the name of a place.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 60:0 (#6)

אֲרַם צוֹבָה

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: אֲרַם צוֹבָה"

The words **Aram Zobah** are the name of a place.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 60:0 (#7)

בְּגֵיא־מֶלַח

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּגֵיא־מֶלַח"

The phrase **Valley of Salt** is the name of a place.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 60:0 (#8)

שְׁנֵים עָשָׂר אָלֶף

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שְׁנֵים עָשָׂר אָלֶף"

The number **12,000** should be translated according to the conventions of your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [twelve thousand]

See: Numbers

Psalms 60:0 (#9)

בְּהַצּוֹתוֹ ׀ אֶת אֲרַם נַהֲרַיִם׃

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּהַצּוֹתוֹ ׀ אֶת אֲרַם נַהֲרַיִם׃"

Here the psalmist is providing background information about the historical circumstances in which David wrote this psalm. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Psalms 60:1 (#1)

פָּרַצְתָּנוּ

"you have broken through us"

David is speaking of God as if he had **broken through** the defenses of Israel like an enemy army that is breaching a wall or battle line. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have allowed our enemies to overcome our defenses] or [you have let our defenses collapse]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:1 (#2)

תְּשׁוֹבֵב לָנוּ

"restore us"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please restore us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 60:2 (#1)

הִרְעַשְׁתָּה אֶרֶץ פִּצַּמְתָּהּ

"You have made the earth tremble; you have broken it"

David is speaking of the nation of Israel as if it were **the earth** that Yahweh had caused to **tremble** and **broken** as in an earthquake. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have brought disaster on our nation; you have shattered it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:2 (#2)

רְפָ֣ה שְׁבָרֶ֣יהָ

“Heal its breaches”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please heal its breaches]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 60:2 (#3)

רְפָ֣ה שְׁבָרֶ֣יהָ

“Heal its breaches”

David is speaking of the nation of Israel as if it were land that had been damaged by an earthquake and needed to be **healed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Restore it] or [Repair the damage]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:3 (#1)

קָשָׁ֑ה

“the difficult”

The psalmist is using the adjective **difficult** as a noun to mean difficult things or hardship. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [difficult things] or [hardship]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 60:3 (#2)

הִשְׁקִיתָ֖נוּ יַ֣יִן תַּרְעֵלָֽה

“You have made us drink the wine of staggering”

The psalmist is speaking of God causing his people to be confused and helpless as if he had **made** them **drink wine** that caused **staggering**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [made us confused and helpless]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:4 (#1)

נֵ֗֜ס

“a banner”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **a banner** is a military flag used to mark a rallying point where troops assemble for safety and coordination during battle. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [a rallying flag] or [a flag to gather around for safety]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 60:4 (#2)

לִירֵאֶ֑יךָ

“to the ones fearing you”

The psalmist is using **the ones fearing you** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the ones who worship and honor you with reverence.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who worship you] or [those who approach you with reverence]

See: Idiom

Psalms 60:4 (#3)

מִפְּנֵ֣י קֶ֭שֶׁט

“from the face of the bow”

The psalmist is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of” or “on account of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of the bow] or [on account of the bow]

See: Idiom

Psalms 60:4 (#4)

סֶּֽלָה

“Selah”

The word **Selah** is a Hebrew word. You will need to decide if you will use this word in its Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew word, you could spell it the way it

sounds in your language and then put the translation in a footnote.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 60:5 (#1)

יֵחָלְצ֣וּן יְדִידֶ֑יךָ

“your beloved may be delivered”

The expression **may be delivered** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [you, God, may deliver your beloved]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 60:5 (#2)

הוֹשִׁ֖יעָה

“save {us”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please save us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 60:5 (#3)

יְמִינְךָ֥

“with} your right hand”

Here, **right hand** represents power or strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with your might] or [with your strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 60:5 (#4)

וענני

“and answer me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please answer me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 60:5 (#5)

וענני

“and answer me”

The pronouns shift from **us** to **me** in this verse. The psalmist is speaking as an individual representative of the people, first using “us” to refer to the collective group, then using “me” to refer to himself as their leader. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify this shift. Alternate translation: [answer me, your servant who speaks for your people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 60:6 (#1)

בְּקָדְשׁ֑וֹ

“in his holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by his holy character]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 60:6 (#2)

אֶֽעְלֹ֣זָה

“I will rejoice”

This is the beginning of what God said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of God. Alternate translation: [God has spoken in his holiness, saying, “I will rejoice] or [God has spoken in his holiness, from which he says, “I will rejoice]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 60:6 (#3)

אֲחַלְקָ֥ה שְׁכֶ֑ם

“I divide Shechem”

The implication is that David will divide Shechem as an inheritance among God’s people, demonstrating God’s sovereignty over the land. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I divide Shechem as an inheritance] or [I apportion Shechem to God’s people]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 60:7 (#1)

וְאֶפְרַ֥יִם מָעֹ֗וז רֹאשִׁ֫י

“And Ephraim {is} the protection of my head”

David is speaking of **Ephraim** as if it were **the protection of** his **head**, that is, as if the tribe were a helmet that protected him in battle. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Ephraim protects me like a helmet] or [Ephraim is my military defense]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:7 (#2)

וְאֶפְרַ֥יִם

“And Ephraim”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that while **Ephraim** was the name of one of the sons of Joseph, he and his brother, Manasseh, became patriarchs of two of the twelve tribes of Israel. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And the tribe of Ephraim]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 60:7 (#3)

רֹאשִׁ֫י

“my head”

Here, **head** represents the person himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 60:7 (#4)

יְהוּדָ֥ה מְחֹקְקִֽי

“Judah, my scepter”

David is speaking of **Judah** as if it were **my scepter**, the symbol of royal authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Judah, the source of my royal authority] or [Judah, the tribe from which my kingship comes]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:8 (#1)

מוֹאָ֥ב ׀ סִ֘יר רַחְצִ֪י

“Moab is the tub of my washing”

David is speaking of **Moab** as if it were **the tub of his washing**, a basin used by a servant to wash his master’s feet. This image expresses that Moab has been reduced to servant status under God’s authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Moab is my servant] or [I will make Moab serve me like a slave]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:8 (#2)

עַל־אֱ֭דוֹם אַשְׁלִ֣יךְ נַעֲלִ֑י

“Over Edom I throw my sandal”

Throwing a sandal **over Edom** was a symbolic action by which the psalmist showed that God was claiming ownership and dominion over that nation. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [I claim Edom as my own by throwing my sandal over it]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 60:8 (#3)

עָ֝לַ֗י פְּלֶ֥שֶׁת הִתְרֹֽעָעִי

“Over me, Philistia, shout triumphantly”

The psalmist is speaking to **Philistia**, which he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about God’s power over the Philistines. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Philistia. Alternate translation: [Philistia will shout triumphantly over me] or [Let Philistia shout triumphantly over me]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 60:8 (#4)

הִתְרֹֽעָעִי

“shout triumphantly”

The psalmist actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here. If a speaker of your language would not do that, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have nothing to shout about]

See: Irony

Psalms 60:9 (#1)

מִמִּי יְ֭בַלֵּנִי עִ֣יר מָצֹֽור

“Who will bring me {into} the city of fortification”

David is using the question form to express his need for God’s help to conquer the fortified city. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I need someone to bring me into the city of fortification!] or [Only you can bring me into the city of fortification.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 60:9 (#2)

עִ֣יר מָצֹֽור

“into} the city of fortification”

The implication is that **the city of fortification** refers to a well-fortified Edomite city, likely Petra or Bozrah. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Edom’s fortified capital city]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 60:9 (#3)

מִמִּי נָחַ֥נִי עַד־אֱדֹֽום

“Who will lead me to Edom”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Only you will lead me to Edom!] or [You alone will lead me to Edom.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 60:10 (#1)

הֲלֹ֤א & זְנַחְתָּ֨נוּ

“have you not rejected us”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his complaint to God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [you have rejected us!] or [it seems you have rejected us.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 60:10 (#2)

וְלֹא־תֵצֵ֖א & בְּצִבְאֹותֵֽינוּ

“And you do not go out with our armies”

The psalmist is using **go out with our armies** as a common expression of the culture to mean “accompany our armies into battle” or “help us fight our enemies.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you do not accompany our armies into battle] or [And you do not help us fight our enemies]

See: Idiom

Psalms 60:11 (#1)

הָבָה־לָ֥נוּ עֶזְרָ֗ת מִצָּ֥֫ר

“Give help against the enemy to us”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request to God. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please give us help against the enemy] or [We beg you to give us help against the enemy]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 60:11 (#2)

תְּשׁוּעַ֥ת

“the salvation of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [man cannot save us] or [people cannot rescue us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 60:11 (#3)

אָדָֽם

“man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [humankind] or [people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 60:11 (#4)

וְשָׁשְׁוְא תְּשׁוּעַת אָדָם

“for the salvation of man {is} futility”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **futility**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the salvation of man is useless] or [for the salvation of man cannot help]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 60:12 (#1)

נַעֲשֶׂה־חָיִל

“we will do valor”

The psalmist is using **do valor** as a common expression of the culture to mean “act valiantly” or “accomplish mighty deeds.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we will act valiantly] or [we will accomplish mighty deeds]

See: Idiom

Psalms 60:12 (#2)

יָבְבּוּס צָרֵינוּ

“he will trample our adversaries”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he would literally **trample** Israel’s enemies with his feet. He means that Yahweh will decisively defeat them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will crush our adversaries] or [he will give us complete victory over our adversaries]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 60:12 (#3)

וְ֭הוּא יָבְבּוּס

“for he, he will trample”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** twice for emphasis. He is doing this to stress that God alone will defeat the enemies. If a speaker of your language would use a repeated pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [he himself will trample our adversaries] or [it is he who will trample our adversaries]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 61 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 61 is a psalm of trust and petition in which the psalmist calls out to God from a distant place and expresses confidence in God as his protector.

1. Petition: The psalmist cries out for God to hear from far away (1–2)
2. Confidence: God has been a refuge and strong tower (3)
3. Desire: To dwell forever in God’s tent and under his wings (4)
4. Assurance: God has heard the psalmist’s vows and given an inheritance (5)
5. Prayer for the king: Long life in God’s presence, guarded by covenant faithfulness and truth (6–7)
6. Response: Perpetual praise and vow fulfillment (8)

The word “Selah” at the end of verse 4 marks a structural break between the personal petition (1–4) and the assurance and royal prayer (5–8).

About the Psalm

The superscription attributes this psalm to David and directs it to the music director with stringed instruments. The psalmist speaks as someone far from God’s dwelling place (“the end of the earth,” verse 2), calling out in a time of emotional weakness. The psalm moves from personal petition to a prayer for “the king” in the third person (verses 6–7), which likely refers to David speaking of himself as king, though some interpreters see a broader reference to the Davidic line.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

God as refuge and shelter

The psalm uses a series of protection images to describe God: a high rock (verse 2), a refuge (verse 3), a tower of strength (verse 3), a tent (verse 4), and sheltering wings (verse 4). Translators should be aware that these are distinct metaphors drawn from different areas of Israelite life—geography, military defense, hospitality, and nature—all conveying the idea of safety in God’s presence. (See: refuge, refugee, shelter, sheltered)

Covenant faithfulness and truth
In verse 7, the Hebrew words "hesed" (covenant faithfulness) and "emeth" (truth, faithfulness) appear together as a pair and are personified as guardians who preserve the king. When these two terms appear together, each enriches the other, expressing God's loyal, reliable love. (See: covenant faithfulness, covenant loyalty, covenant love)

Vows
Vows (solemn promises made to God) frame the second half of the psalm, appearing in both verse 5 and verse 8. In Israelite worship, a person in distress would make a vow to God, promising praise or offerings in return for deliverance. The psalmist's commitment to fulfill these vows "day by day" reflects ongoing, not one-time, worship. (See: oath, vow, swear, swearing, swear by, sworn)

Translation Issues

Person shift: first person to third person
The psalmist speaks in the first person through verses 1–5 ("I call," "my vows") but shifts to the third person in verses 6–7 ("the king," "he," "his years"), then returns to first person in verse 8. This is likely David referring to himself as king, but some languages may need to make the referent explicit to avoid confusion.

Psalms 61:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

For the chief musician is an instruction about who should lead people in singing or playing music with this psalm. This could refer to the person in charge of music for temple worship. If your readers would not be familiar with this role, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the worship leader]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 61:0 (#3)

נְגִינַת

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: נְגִינַת"

On a stringed instrument refers to a type of stringed musical instrument used in worship. This may indicate how the psalm was to be accompanied. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of instrument, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [To be accompanied by stringed instruments] or [With music from stringed instruments]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 61:1 (#1)

שִׁמְעָה אֱלֹהִים רִנָּתִי הַקְשִׁיבָה תְּפִלָּתִי

"Hear my cry, God; listen {to} my prayer"

These two phrases, **Hear my cry, God** and **listen to my prayer**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [God, hear my cry; yes, listen to my prayer]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 61:1 (#2)

שִׁמְעָה אֱלֹהִים רִנָּתִי הַקְשִׁיבָה תְּפִלָּתִי

"Hear my cry, God; listen {to} my prayer"

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. Alternate translation: [Please hear my cry, God; please listen to my prayer]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 61:1 (#3)

תְּפִלָּתִי

"my prayer"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I pray]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 61:2 (#1)

מִקְצֵה הָאָרֶץ ׀ אֵלֶיךָ אֶקְרָא

"From the end of the earth I call to you"

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about where David calls from after the information about calling to God. Alternate translation: [I call to you from the end of the earth]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 61:2 (#2)

מִקְצֵה הָאָרֶץ

“From the end of the earth”

David is using **From the end of the earth** as a common expression to mean from a very distant or remote place. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From a faraway place] or [From distant lands]

See: Idiom

Psalms 61:2 (#3)

בַּעֲטֹף לִבִּי

“when my heart is faint”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and feelings exist. David is speaking of his emotions as if they were physically weak. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when I am discouraged] or [when I feel weak]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 61:2 (#4)

בַּעֲטֹף לִבִּי

“when my heart is faint”

The word that the ULT translates as **when** indicates that David calls to God at the same time as **my heart is faint**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [at times when my heart is faint] or [during the times that my heart is faint]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

Psalms 61:2 (#5)

בְּצוּר & מִמֶּנִּי תַנְחֵנִי

“to the rock {that} is higher than me”

David is speaking of God as if God were a high **rock** that David could climb up to reach safety from danger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [to a place of safety that is like a high rock]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 61:2 (#6)

בְּצוּר־יָרוּם

“Lead me to the rock”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. Alternate translation: [Please lead me to the rock]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 61:3 (#1)

הָיִיתָ מַחְסֶה לִּי מִגְדַּל־עֹז מִפְּנֵי אוֹיֵב

“you are a refuge to me, a strong tower from the face of the enemy”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [you are a refuge to me, you are a strong tower from the face of the enemy]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 61:3 (#2)

הָיִיתָ מַחְסֶה לִּי מִגְדַּל־עֹז מִפְּנֵי אוֹיֵב

“you are a refuge to me, a strong tower from the face of the enemy”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [you are a refuge to me, indeed, you are a strong tower from the face of the enemy]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 61:3 (#3)

כִּי־הָיִיתָ מַחְסֶה לִּי

“For you are a refuge to me”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is

a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because you are a refuge to me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 61:3 (#4)

הָיִיתָ מַחְסֶה לִּי

“you are a refuge to me”

Here David is speaking as if God were a physical shelter. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are a place of protection for me] or [you are a place of safety for me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 61:3 (#5)

מִגְדַּל־עֹז מִפְּנֵי אוֹיֵב

“a strong tower from the face of the enemy”

Here David is speaking as if God were a fortified **tower**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a fortress that protects me from the enemy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 61:3 (#6)

מִפְּנֵי אוֹיֵב

“from the face of the enemy”

David is using **from the face of** as a common expression to mean “away from the presence of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the enemy] or [when the enemy comes]

See: Idiom

Psalms 61:4 (#1)

אָגוּרָה בְאָהֳלְךָ עוֹלָמִים אֶחֱסֶה בְסֵתֶר כְּנָפֶיךָ

“Let me sojourn in your tent forever! I will take refuge in the shelter of your wings”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Let me always live in your presence, taking refuge in the shelter of your wings]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 61:4 (#2)

בְאָהֳלְךָ

“in your tent”

Here David is speaking as if God’s presence and protection were a **tent** where he could stay as a guest. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your presence] or [with you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 61:4 (#3)

בְּסֵתֶר כְּנָפֶיךָ

“in the shelter of your wings”

Here David is speaking as if God were a bird sheltering its young under its **wings**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [under your care] or [in your protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 61:4 (#4)

בְּסֵתֶר כְּנָפֶיךָ

“in the shelter of your wings”

David is using this possessive form to mean the shelter that God’s wings provide. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in the shelter that your wings provide]

See: Possession

Psalms 61:5 (#1)

כִּי־אַתָּה אֱלֹהִים שָׁמַעְתָּ לִנְדָרָי

“For you, God, have listened to my vows”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because you, God, have listened to my vows]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 61:5 (#2)

יְרֻשַּׁ֣ת

“the inheritance of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is passed to]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 61:5 (#3)

יְרֻשַּׁ֣ת יִרְאֵ֣י שְׁמֶ֑ךָ

“the inheritance of the fearers of your name”

David is using this possessive form to mean the inheritance that belongs to those who fear God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [what you give to those who fear your name]

See: Possession

Psalms 61:5 (#4)

שְׁמֶ֑ךָ

“your name”

Here, **your name** represents God’s reputation and character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who you are] or [your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 61:6 (#1)

יָמִ֣ים עַל־יְמֵי

“Days upon days of”

The psalmist is using **Days upon days** as a common expression of the culture to mean “many days.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you add many days to the king’s lifetime]

See: Idiom

Psalms 61:6 (#2)

מֶ֗לֶךְ

“the king”

The phrase **the king** refers to David himself, who is speaking of himself in the third person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [me, the king]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 61:6 (#3)

תּוֹסִ֣יף שָׁ֭נוֹתָיו

“may you add {to} his years”

The pronoun **you** refers to God, while the pronoun **his** refers to the king. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [may you, God, add to the king’s years]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 61:6 (#4)

שָׁ֭נוֹתָיו

“to} his years”

Here, **his years** represents “his lifetime.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to his lifetime]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 61:6 (#5)

כְּמוֹ־דֹ֣ר וָדֹֽר

“as generation and generation”

The point of this comparison is that just as **generation and generation** spans a very long time, so should the king’s years be extended. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as if he would live for many generations]

See: Simile

Psalms 61:6 (#6)

דֹ֣ר וָדֹֽר

“generation and generation”

David is using **to generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “throughout all generations” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [throughout all generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 61:7 (#1)

יֵשֵׁ֣ב עֹ֭לָם

“May he dwell forever”

The pronoun **he** refers to the king mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [May the king dwell forever]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 61:7 (#2)

לִפְנֵ֣י אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“to the face of God”

Here, **to the face of God** represents being in the presence of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of God] or [before God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 61:7 (#3)

חֶ֖סֶד וֶ֣אֱמֶ֑ת

“covenant faithfulness and truth”

The phrase **covenant faithfulness and truth** expresses a single idea. The word **truth** tells more about **covenant faithfulness**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [true covenant faithfulness] or [faithful covenant love]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 61:7 (#4)

חֶ֖סֶד וֶ֣אֱמֶ֑ת מַ֝מָ֗ן

“Appoint covenant faithfulness and truth”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please appoint covenant faithfulness and truth]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 61:7 (#5)

חֶ֖סֶד וֶ֣אֱמֶ֑ת

“covenant faithfulness and truth”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **truth**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [evidences that you are truly faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 61:7 (#6)

חֶ֖סֶד וֶ֣אֱמֶ֑ת יִנְצְרֵֽהוּ׃ &

“covenant faithfulness and truth; may they preserve him”

David speaks of **covenant faithfulness and truth** as if they were living things that could **preserve** the king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [ways to show the king covenant faithfulness and truth so that he is preserved]

See: Personification

Psalms 61:8 (#1)

שִׁמְךָ֣

“to} your name”

Here, **name** represents God himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 61:8 (#2)

לְשַׁלְּמִ֖י נְדָרַ֣י יֽוֹם ׀ יֽוֹם

“that I may pay my vows day, day”

The phrase **that I may pay my vows** indicates the purpose or goal for which David will make music to God’s name. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [in order to pay my vows day after day] or [so that I may pay my vows day after day]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 61:8 (#3)

לְשַׁלְּמִ֖י נְדָרַ֣י

“that I may pay my vows”

David is using **pay my vows** as a common expression to mean “fulfill my vows” or “do what I have vowed to do.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your

readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fulfill my vows] or [do what I have promised]

See: Idiom

Psalms 61:8 (#4)

יוֹם ׀ יוֹם

“day, day”

David repeats the word **day** to emphasize the idea of continually or constantly. If your language can repeat words for emphasis, it would be appropriate to do that here. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the emphasis. Alternate translation: [day after day] or [continually]

See: Reduplication

Psalms - Chapter 62 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 62 is a specific kind of psalm of supplication, a psalm of trust. It is a calm affirmation of reliance on God, with the troubles of the psalmist mostly in the background. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Statement of trust (1–2)
2. Description of opponents (3–4)
3. Statement of trust (5–6)
4. Exhortation to listeners (8–10)
5. Affirmation of God’s power and goodness (11–12)

Psalms 62:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 62:0 (#3)

עַל־יְדוּתוּן

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־יְדוּתוּן”

See how you translated the expression “on Jeduthun” in the superscription to Psalm 39.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 62:1 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using **my soul** to represent all of himself in the act of waiting silently for God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all of myself]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 62:1 (#2)

מִמֶּנּוּ יְשׁוּעָתִי

“From him {is} my salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He is the one who saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:2 (#1)

צוּרִי

“is} my rock”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **rock** that provided stability and protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my foundation] or [my protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:2 (#2)

מִשְׂגַּבִּי

“my stronghold”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **stronghold**, a fortified place that protects people from danger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my place of safety] or [my protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:2 (#3)

לֹא־אֶמּוֹט רַבָּה

“I will not be greatly shaken”

The expression **I will not be greatly shaken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Nothing will shake me greatly] or [I will remain stable]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 62:3 (#1)

עַד־אָ֭נָה ׀ תְּהוֹתְת֣וּ עַל אִישׁ֑

“Until when will you shout at a man”

David is using the question form to express his frustration at his enemies for attacking him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You have attacked me far too long!] or [Stop attacking me!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 62:3 (#2)

אִישׁ֑

“a man”

Here the masculine term **a man** refers to the psalmist himself. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that makes this clear as modeled in the UST.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 62:3 (#3)

תְּרֻצָּחֻ֗ו

“You will be smashed”

The expression **You will be smashed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [God will smash you] or [God will crush you]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 62:3 (#4)

כְּקִ֥יר נָט֝וּי גָּ֗דֵר הַדְּחוּיָֽה

“like a leaning wall, an overthrown fence”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a leaning wall** and **an overthrown fence** will collapse, so the psalmist’s enemies will be destroyed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and will collapse like a leaning wall or an overthrown fence]

See: Simile

Psalms 62:4 (#1)

מְשְׂאֵ֑תוֹ & לְהַדִּיחָ֗ן

“to cast {him} down from his elevation”

The pronoun **him** refers to the psalmist. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to cast me down from my elevation]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 62:4 (#2)

מְשְׂאֵ֑תוֹ

“from his elevation”

The psalmist is speaking of the author’s honor and status as if it were **his elevation**, a high position from which he could be cast down. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from his honored position] or [from his high status]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:4 (#3)

בְּפִ֣יו

“with his mouth”

David is using one part of a person, his **mouth**, to mean all of him in the act of speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with their words] or [in their speech]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 62:4 (#4)

בְּפִ֣יו יְבָרֵ֑כוּ וּ֝בְקִרְבָּ֗ם יְקַלְלֽוּ׃

“with his mouth, they bless, but in their inside, they curse”

These two clauses, **with his mouth, they bless** and **in their inside, they curse**, mean basically opposite things. The psalmist is contrasting what his enemies say outwardly with what they feel inwardly. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition and contrast, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both clauses in your translation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the contrast more explicit. Alternate translation: [they say kind things, but they really wish harm]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 62:4 (#5)

וּֽבְקִרְבָּ֗ם

“but in their inside”

Here, **inside** represents their hearts or inner thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in their hearts] or [in their thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 62:4 (#6)

סֶֽלָה

“Selah”

The word **Selah** is a Hebrew word. You will need to decide if you will use this word in its Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew word, you could spell it the way it sounds in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Pause and praise]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 62:5 (#1)

דֹּ֭ומִּי נַפְשִׁ֣י

“Be silent, my soul”

The psalmist is speaking to **his own soul** as if he were speaking to another person who could hear him. He is doing this to emphasize how strongly he feels about waiting for God alone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to himself or expressing his own determination. Alternate translation: [I shall be silent before God alone] or [I tell myself to wait quietly for God alone]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 62:5 (#2)

נַפְשִׁ֣י

“my soul”

The psalmist is using **my soul** to represent all of himself in the act of waiting for God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I tell myself] or [self]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 62:5 (#3)

תִּקְוָתִֽי

“my hope”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I await] or [what I confidently wait for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:6 (#1)

צ֭וּרִי וְיִשׁוּעָתִ֑י מִשְׂגַּבִּ֥י

“is} my rock and my salvation, my stronghold”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **rock** and a **stronghold**, solid structures that could protect him from danger. If these images communicate well in your language, please use them. If not, you could express these as comparisons. Alternate translation: [the one who protects me as would a rock and a stronghold]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:6 (#2)

לֹ֣א אֶמּֽוֹט

“I will not be shaken”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Nothing will shake me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 62:7 (#1)

יְשָׁעְתִּ֑י

“is} my salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way, as modeled by the UST.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:7 (#2)

וְכְבוֹדִ֑י

“and my glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and what makes me honored]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:7 (#3)

צוּר־עֻזִּי

“the rock of my strength”

David is speaking of God as if he were **the rock of** his **strength**, that is, a high rock that he could climb up to reach safety from danger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [God, who is like a rock that protects me and makes me strong] or [my strong protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:7 (#4)

צוּר־עֻזִּי

“the rock of my strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the rock that strengthens me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:7 (#5)

מַחְסִי

“my refuge”

David is speaking of God as if he were a **refuge**, a place where he could go to be safe from danger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my place of safety] or [my place of protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:8 (#1)

בִּטְחוּ־בוֹ בְכָל־עֵת ׀ עָם

“Trust in him in every time, people”

The word translated as **Trust** is an imperative, but it communicates an exhortation rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation. Alternate translation: [I urge you to trust in him at all times, people]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 62:8 (#2)

שִׁפְכוּ & לְבַבְכֶם

“Pour out your heart”

The psalmist is using **Pour out your heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean “express your emotions openly.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Tell him honestly how you feel] or [Share your deepest emotions with him]

See: Idiom

Psalms 62:8 (#3)

לְפָנָיו

“to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents being in the presence of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 62:8 (#4)

מַחֲסֶה־לָּנוּ

“is} a refuge for us”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were **a refuge**, a safe place to which people can go to escape danger. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is a safe place for us] or [is the one who protects us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:8 (#5)

סֶלָה

“Selah”

The word **Selah** is a Hebrew word. You will need to decide if you will use this word in its Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew word, you could spell it the way it sounds in your language and then put the translation in a footnote.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 62:9 (#1)

הֶבֶל בְּנֵי־אָדָם כָּזָב בְּנֵי אִישׁ

“sons of a human {are} vapor, sons of a man {are} a lie”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [all people are vapor; indeed, they are a lie]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 62:9 (#2)

בְּנֵי־אָדָם֮ & בְּנֵי֪ אִ֫ישׁ

“sons of a human & sons of a man”

The psalmist is using **sons of a human** and **sons of a man** as common expressions of the culture to mean “people” or “human beings.” If these phrases do not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people … people] or [human beings … human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 62:9 (#3)

הֶ֭בֶל

“are} vapor”

The psalmist is speaking of people as if they were **vapor**. He means that people are transient and insubstantial. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are fleeting] or [have no substance]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:9 (#4)

כְּזָ֑ב

“are} a lie”

When the psalmist says that people **are a lie**, he means that humans are deceptive in appearance and cannot be relied upon. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are unreliable] or [are deceptive]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 62:9 (#5)

הֵ֤מָּה מֵ֖הֶבֶל יָ֣חַד

“they together {would be lighter} than vapor”

The psalmist says **they together would be lighter than vapor** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [together they would weigh almost nothing] or [all of them together have no weight at all]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 62:10 (#1)

בְּעֹ֭שֶׁק

“in oppression”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **oppression**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in oppressing others]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:10 (#2)

וּ֝בְגָזֵ֗ל

“and & in robbery”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **robbery**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by robbing people] or [in what you rob from others]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:10 (#3)

חַ֭יִל

“Wealth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Wealth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Should you become wealthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:10 (#4)

אַל־תְּשִׁ֣יתוּ לֵ֑ב

“do not set the heart”

Here, **heart** represents a person’s desires and focus of attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language.

Alternate translation: [do not fix your desires on it] or [do not focus your attention on it]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 62:11 (#1)

אַחַת & שְׁתַּיִם

“Once & twice”

The psalmist is using **Once** and **twice** as a common expression to mean “repeatedly” or “with certainty.” The phrase emphasizes that God’s declaration is reliable and sure. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Repeatedly] or [Most certainly]

See: Idiom

Psalms 62:11 (#2)

עֹז

“power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God is powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:12 (#1)

חֶסֶד

“is} covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you are faithful to your covenant] or [you are loyal and faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 62:12 (#2)

אַתָּה תְשַׁלֵּם

“you, you repay”

The psalmist is repeating the pronoun **you** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that God is the one who repays. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [you yourself repay] or [you alone repay]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 62:12 (#3)

לְאִישׁ

“to a man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to each person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 62:12 (#4)

כְּמַעֲשֵׂהוּ

“according to his doing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **doing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to what he does]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 63 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 63 is a psalm of praise. David is specifically encouraging himself to praise God for what he will do to help him. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. David’s longing for God (1–2)
2. Reason to worship (3a)
3. Call to worship (3b–6)
4. Reason to worship (7a)
5. Call to worship (7b–8)
6. God will punish David’s enemies (9–10)
7. Call to worship (11a)
8. Reason to worship (11b)

Psalms 63:0 (#2)

מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד בְּהִיוֹתוֹ בְּמִדְבַּר יְהוּדָה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד בְּהִיוֹתוֹ בְּמִדְבַּר יְהוּדָה”

This is a superscription to a psalm. It is written in poetic language and provides historical context for the psalm. If your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [A song of David written while he was in the wilderness of Judah]

See: Poetry

Psalms 63:1 (#1)

צָמְאָה לְךָ ׀ נַפְשִׁי

“My soul thirsts for you”

David is speaking of his intense desire for God as if his **soul** were physically **thirsting** for water. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My soul longs for you] or [I deeply desire to be near you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 63:1 (#2)

צָמְאָה & נַפְשִׁי

“My soul thirsts”

David is using **My soul** to represent all of himself in the act of thirsting for God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I thirst]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:1 (#3)

כָּמַהּ לְךָ בְשָׂרִי

“my flesh faints for you”

The psalmist is speaking of his intense longing for God as if his body were physically **fainting** from weakness or exhaustion. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my whole being aches for you] or [my body grows weak with longing for you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 63:1 (#4)

בְשָׂרִי

“my flesh”

David is using one part of a person, his **flesh**, to mean all of him in the act of longing for God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my whole being faints for you] or [I faint for you]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:1 (#5)

צָמְאָה לְךָ ׀ נַפְשִׁי כָּמַהּ לְךָ בְשָׂרִי

“My soul thirsts for you, my flesh faints for you”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [My whole being longs for you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 63:1 (#6)

צִיָּה וְעָיֵף

“dryness and weary”

The terms **dryness** and **weary** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [very dry] or [extremely parched]

See: Doublet

Psalms 63:2 (#1)

כֵּן

“Thus”

The word translated as **Thus** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [So] or [Because of this,]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 63:2 (#2)

עֻזֶּךָ

“your power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how powerful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 63:2 (#3)

וּכְבוֹדֶךָ

“and your glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in

another way. Alternate translation: [how glorious you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 63:2 (#4)

עֻזֶּךָ וּכְבוֹדֶךָ

“your power and your glory”

The terms **power** and **glory** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [your awesome power] or [your magnificent strength]

See: Doublet

Psalms 63:3 (#1)

כִּי

“Because”

The word translated as **Because** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came after. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came after. Alternate translation: [Since]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 63:3 (#2)

חַסְדְּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are to your covenant] or [how faithfully you keep your covenant promises]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 63:3 (#3)

טוֹב & מֵחַיִּים

“is} better than life”

The psalmist says **better than life** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [more valuable than anything] or [extremely valuable]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 63:3 (#4)

שְׂפָתַי יְשַׁבְּחוּנְךָ

“my lips will praise you”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **lips**, to mean all of him in the act of praising God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will praise you]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:4 (#1)

כֵּן

“Thus”

The word **Thus** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. David will bless God because of what he has just expressed in the previous verses. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [Because of this,] or [Therefore,]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 63:4 (#2)

בְּשִׁמְךָ אֶשָּׂא כַפָּי

“I will lift up my palms in your name”

Lifting up one’s palms was a symbolic action by which David showed his worship and prayer to God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [I will lift up my palms to worship you] or [I will lift up my palms in prayer to you]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 63:4 (#3)

בְּשִׁמְךָ

“in your name”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who God is, particularly God’s character and authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of who you are] or [because of your character]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 63:5 (#1)

כְּמוֹ חֵלֶב וָדֶשֶׁן

“As {with} fat and fatness”

The point of this comparison is that just as **fat and fatness** are deeply satisfying, so God's presence satisfies the psalmist's soul. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [My soul will be completely satisfied, just as if I had eaten the richest foods]

See: Simile

Psalms 63:5 (#2)

חֵ֭חֶלֶב וָדֶ֣שֶׁן

"with} fat and fatness"

The terms **fat** and **fatness** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the richest food]

See: Doublet

Psalms 63:5 (#3)

תִּשְׂבַּ֣ע נַפְשִׁ֑י

"my soul will be full"

By using the phrase **my soul will be full**, David is speaking as if Yahweh could satisfy him in the same way that rich food satisfies hunger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [I will be as satisfied as if I had eaten the richest foods]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 63:5 (#4)

נַפְשִׁ֑י

"my soul"

David is using **my soul** to represent all of himself in the act of being satisfied. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:5 (#5)

וְשִׂפְתֵ֣י רְ֭נָנוֹת

"and {with} lips of joyful shouts"

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **lips**, to mean all of him in the act of praising God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and with my joyful shouts]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:5 (#6)

וְשִׂפְתֵ֣י רְ֭נָנוֹת יְהַלֶּל־פִּֽי

"and {with} lips of joyful shouts my mouth will praise {you"

These two phrases, **lips of joyful shouts** and **my mouth will praise**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [and my mouth will praise you with lips of joyful shouts]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 63:5 (#7)

פִּֽי

"my mouth"

David is using one part of a person, his **mouth**, to mean all of him in the act of praising God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:6 (#1)

אִם־זְכַרְתִּ֥יךָ עַל־יְצוּעָ֑י

"When I remember you on my bed"

The word **When** indicates that David **remembering** God occurred at the same time as when he **meditates** on God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [As I remember you on my bed]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

Psalms 63:6 (#2)

בְּ֝אַשְׁמֻר֗וֹת

"in the night watches"

The term **night watches** refers to the divisions of the night during which guards were on duty. In ancient Israel, the night was typically divided into three or four such periods. If your readers would not be familiar with this, you could use a more general term. Alternate

translation: [during the night] or [in the hours of the night]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 63:6 (#3)

אִם־זְכַרְתִּיךָ עַל־יְצוּעָי בְּאַשְׁמֻרוֹת אֶהְגֶּה־בָּךְ

“When I remember you on my bed, I meditate on you in the night watches”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [When I remember you on my bed, yes, when I meditate on you in the night watches]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 63:7 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because] or [Since]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 63:7 (#2)

עֶזְרָתָה

“a help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [one who gives help] or [helpful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 63:7 (#3)

וּבְצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ

“and in the shadow of your wings”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a bird protecting him **in the shadow of** his **wings**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [while you protect me] or [as you shelter me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 63:7 (#4)

כְּנָפֶיךָ

“your wings”

David is speaking of God as if he had **wings** that cast a shadow providing protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your protective shelter] or [your protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 63:8 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי

“My soul”

David is using **My soul** to represent all of himself in the act of clinging to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:8 (#2)

דָּבְקָה & אַחֲרֶיךָ

“clings after you”

David is speaking of his devotion to God as if his soul physically **clings** to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [remains devoted to you] or [holds tightly to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 63:8 (#3)

יְמִינֶךָ

“your right hand”

Here, **right hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 63:9 (#1)

וְהֵמָּה & יְבַקְשֵׁי

“But they, they seek”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they seek** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that his enemies seek his life. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [But my enemies truly seek]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 63:9 (#2)

וְהֵ֫מָּה

“But they”

The pronoun **they** refers to David’s enemies, who have not been mentioned previously in this psalm. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [But those who are my enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 63:9 (#3)

נַפְשִׁשֵׁי

“my life”

David is using **my life** to represent his entire person in the act being killed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to kill me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:9 (#4)

לְשׁוֹאָה

“for devastation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **devastation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to destroy me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 63:9 (#5)

בָּתַחְתִּיִּיוֹת הָאָרֶץ

“into the lowest parts of the earth”

David is referring to death in a polite way by using the phrase **the lowest parts of the earth**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [to the grave] or [to Sheol]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 63:10 (#1)

יַגִּירֻ֥הוּ עַל־יְדֵי־חָ֑רֶב

“They will pour him into the hands of the sword”

The psalmist is using **pour him into the hands of the sword** as a common expression of the culture to mean “cause him to be killed by the sword.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They will hand him over to be slain by the sword] or [They will cause him to die by the sword]

See: Idiom

Psalms 63:10 (#2)

יְדֵי־חָ֑רֶב

“the hands of the sword”

The psalmist is speaking of **the sword** as if it were a living thing that could have **hands**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the destructive power of the sword] or [death by the sword]

See: Personification

Psalms 63:10 (#3)

מְנָ֣ת שֻׁעָלִ֑ים יִהְיוּ

“they will be a portion of jackals”

The psalmist is speaking of his enemies’ dead bodies as if they were **a portion of jackals**, that is, food that would be given to scavenging animals. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will become food for wild animals]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 63:10 (#4)

שֻׁעָלִ֑ים

“jackals”

A **jackal** is a kind of wild scavenging animal. If your readers would not be familiar with what a jackal is, you could use the name of a similar animal that your

readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [scavengers]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 63:10 (#5)

יַגִּירֻהוּ

“They will pour him”

The pronoun **him** is singular, but it refers to the psalmist’s enemies, who are plural. David may be referring to them collectively. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a plural form. Alternate translation: [them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 63:11 (#1)

וְהַמֶּלֶךְ

“But the king”

By **the king**, David means himself. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I, the king,]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 63:11 (#2)

בּוֹ

“by him”

The pronoun **him** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [by God]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 63:11 (#3)

כִּֽי יִסָּכֵר פִּי דֹּבְרֵי־שָׁקֶר

“for the mouth of speakers of falsehood will be shut”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, **the mouth**, to mean all of him in the act of speaking lies. The phrase **will be shut** means that they will be stopped or silenced. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [speakers of falsehood will be silenced] or [those who speak falsehood will be stopped]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 63:11 (#4)

שָׁקֶר

“falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [false things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 63:11 (#5)

יִסָּכֵֽר

“will be shut”

The expression **will be shut** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [God will shut the mouth of speakers of falsehood] or [will stop speaking]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 64 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 64 is a wisdom psalm that describes the difference between how righteous people and wicked people live and the difference between what happens to them. However, it begins like a psalm of supplication, with a cry for help. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Introduction: cry for help (1–3a)
2. What wicked people do (3b–6)
3. How God will judge and punish wicked people (6–8a)
4. How other people will respond when they see this (8b–10)

Psalms 64:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּ֥חַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 64:1 (#1)

שְׁמַע־אֱלֹהִ֥ים קוֹלִ֗י

“Hear my voice, God”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hear my voice, God] or [I ask you to hear my voice, God]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 64:1 (#2)

קוֹלִ֥י

“my voice”

Here, **voice** represents what David is saying in prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my prayer] or [my words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 64:1 (#3)

בְּשִׂיחִ֑י

“in my complaint”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **complaint**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as I complain to you] or [as I tell you what troubles me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 64:1 (#4)

תִּצֹּ֖ר חַיָּ֣י

“Preserve my life”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please preserve my life]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 64:1 (#5)

מִפַּ֥חַד

“from fear of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fear**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [so that I will not be afraid of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 64:2 (#1)

תַּסְתִּירֵ֑נִי

“Hide me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hide me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 64:2 (#2)

מִסְּ֣וד מְרֵעִ֣ים מֵֽרִגְשַׁ֣ת פֹּ֣עֲלֵי אָ֑וֶן

“from the council of evildoers, from the throng of the workers of iniquity”

The phrases **the council of evildoers** and **the throng of the workers of iniquity** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two phrases together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [from the large group of wicked people]

See: Doublet

Psalms 64:2 (#3)

אָ֑וֶן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [iniquitous things] or [perverted acts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 64:3 (#1)

שָׁנְנ֣וּ כַ֭חֶרֶב לְשׁוֹנָ֑ם דָּרְכ֥וּ חִ֝צָּ֗ם דָּבָ֥ר מָֽר

“have sharpened their tongue like a sword. They tread their arrow, a bitter word”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that

the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [have sharpened their tongue like a sword, yes, they tread their arrow, a bitter word]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 64:3 (#2)

שָׁנְנוּ כַחֶרֶב לְשׁוֹנָם

“have sharpened their tongue like a sword”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a sword** is sharp and able to cut and wound, so the **tongue** of the enemies is able to harm others with their words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [sharpened their tongue to wound like a sharp sword]

See: Simile

Psalms 64:3 (#3)

לְשׁוֹנָם

“their tongue”

Here, **their tongue** represents what they say. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their words] or [what they say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 64:3 (#4)

דָּרְכוּ חִצָּצָם דָּבָר מָר

“They tread their arrow, a bitter word”

The psalmist is speaking of **a bitter word** as if it were **their arrow**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They tread their cruel words as arrows]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 64:3 (#5)

דָּרְכוּ

“They tread”

Here, **tread** represents “shoot.” Ancient archers would step on their bows in order to bend them so that they could string them. David means “they step on their bows to string them and then shoot arrows from them.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [They shoot]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 64:4 (#1)

תָּמִּים

“the innocent”

The psalmist is using the adjective **innocent** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [innocent people] or [people who are innocent]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 64:4 (#2)

לִירוֹת & תָּמִּים

“to shoot the innocent”

The psalmist is speaking of **the innocent** as if they were targets that the wicked could **shoot** with arrows. He means that the wicked attack innocent people with harmful words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to attack the innocent with their words]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 64:4 (#3)

וְלֹא יִירָאוּ

“and they do not fear”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they do not fear judgment] or [and they do not fear consequences]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 64:5 (#1)

יְחַזְּקוּ־לָמוֹ ׀ דָּבָר רָע

“They strengthen for themselves an evil matter”

The psalmist is using **strengthen for themselves an evil matter** as a common expression of the culture to mean “encourage each other in their evil plans.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation:

[embolden one another to do evil] or [make each other more determined to carry out wicked schemes]

See: Idiom

Psalms 64:5 (#2)

מִמְּי יִרְאֶה־לָּמוֹ

“Who will see them”

The evildoers are using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No one will see them.] or [No one will see our schemes!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 64:5 (#3)

לָמוֹ

“them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the snares, not to the evildoers. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Who will see the snares]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 64:6 (#1)

עוֹלֹת

“iniquities”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquities**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [iniquitous things] or [things that are evil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 64:6 (#2)

וְקֶרֶב אִישׁ וְלֵב עָמֹק

“Both the inside of man and the heart {are} deep”

The terms **inside of man** and **the heart** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. [The human heart is very deep] or [Man’s private thoughts are beyond knowing]

See: Doublet

Psalms 64:6 (#3)

וְקֶרֶב אִישׁ

“Both the inside of man”

Here, **the inside of man** represents a person’s inner thoughts and motives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The thoughts of man] or [Man’s inner motives]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 64:6 (#4)

וְלֵב

“and the heart”

Here, **the heart** represents a person’s thoughts and motives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a person’s thoughts] or [people’s motives]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 64:6 (#5)

וְלֵב עָמֹק

“and the heart {are} deep”

The psalmist is speaking of **the heart** as if it were something **deep** that cannot be easily explored or understood. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the heart are hidden] or [and the heart are unfathomable]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 64:7 (#1)

וַיֹּרֵם אֱלֹהִים חֵץ

“But God will shoot an arrow”

David is speaking of God judging his enemies as if he were **shooting an arrow** at them. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [God will strike his enemies suddenly, like a warrior who shoots an arrow at them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 64:7 (#2)

וַיֹּרֵם אֱלֹהִים

“But God will shoot”

The psalmist uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the evildoers’ plans and God’s

response. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, God will shoot] or [In contrast, God will shoot]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 64:7 (#3)

פִּתְאֹ֥ם הָ֝יָ֗וּ מַכּוֹתָֽם

“suddenly their wounds will happen”

The psalmist actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here. He describes the wounding of the wicked as happening **suddenly**, just as the wicked planned to wound the innocent suddenly (verse 4). If a speaker of your language would not do that, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will receive the sudden wounds they planned for others]

See: Irony

Psalms 64:8 (#1)

וַיַּכְשִׁילֻ֥והוּ

“And they will make it stumble”

The pronoun **it** could refer to: (1) their tongue or (2) the arrow (see 64:7). If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And their tongue will make them stumble] or [And the arrow will make them stumble]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 64:8 (#2)

לְשׁוֹנָ֑ם

“their tongue”

Here, **their tongue** represents their harmful words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their own words] or [what they themselves have said]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 64:8 (#3)

יִ֝תְנֹדְד֗וּ כָּל־רֹ֣אֵה בָֽם

“Everyone seeing them will flee”

The psalmist is saying **Everyone seeing them will flee** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [All who see them will flee] or [People who see them will flee]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 64:9 (#1)

כָּל־אָ֑דָם

“all of mankind”

The psalmist is saying **all of mankind** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [all people who see this] or [everyone who observes these things]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 64:9 (#2)

וַיַּגִּ֥ידוּ פֹּ֝עַ֗ל אֱלֹהִ֥ים וְֽמַעֲשֵׂ֑הוּ הִשְׂכִּֽילוּ

“and they will declare the work of God, for they will consider his deed”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The first phrase states the general idea, and then the second phrase gives a specific example. Translate these phrases according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. Alternate translation: [and they will declare the work of God, certainly, they will consider his deed]

See: Doublet

Psalms 64:10 (#1)

צַדִּ֗יק

“The righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Righteous people] or [Those who do the right thing]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 64:10 (#2)

יִשְׂמַ֣ח צַדִּ֣יק בַּֽיהוָ֑ה וְחָ֥סָה בּ֝וֹ וְיִתְהַלְלוּ֗ כָּל־יִשְׁרֵי־לֵֽב

“The righteous will rejoice in Yahweh and take refuge in him, and all of the upright of heart will celebrate”

These two phrases, **The righteous will rejoice** and **the upright of heart will celebrate** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different

words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [The righteous will rejoice in Yahweh and take refuge in him; indeed, all of the upright of heart will celebrate.]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 64:10 (#3)

וְחָסָה בּוֹ

“and take refuge in him”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a safe **refuge** or shelter where the righteous could be protected from danger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and go to him for protection] or [and trust him to keep them safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 64:10 (#4)

יִשְׁרֵי־לֵב

“the upright of heart”

The psalmist is using the adjective phrase **upright of heart** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjective phrases in the same way. If not, you can translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the people who are upright in heart] or [those whose hearts are upright]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 64:10 (#5)

לֵב

“heart”

Here, **heart** represents a person’s inner character and motives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [character] or [motives]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 65 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 65 begins as a psalm of thanksgiving. David announces that he is paying a vow to God. He says what God has done for him: God has forgiven his sin. He invites people to share in a celebration meal. But after those standard elements, this turns into a psalm of worship. David describes the powerful things that God does, and he describes how people all over the world praise God for them. He then describes how God provides rain so that fields and pastures in meadows, hills, and valleys can produce good crops, and he depicts those places as praising God for that. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. David’s declaration that he is paying a vow (1)
2. Statement of what God has done in answer to prayer (2–3)
3. Invitation to share in a celebration meal (4)
4. Reason to worship: God powerfully controls nature and people (5–7)
5. Description of people worshiping God for this (8)
6. Reason to worship: God sends rain to make crops grow (9–11)
7. Description of fields and pastures worshiping God for this (12–13)

Psalms 65:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

For the chief musician is an instruction about who should lead people in singing or playing music with this psalm. This could refer to the person in charge of music for temple worship. If your readers would not be familiar with this role, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the worship leader]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 65:1 (#1)

לְךָ דֻמִיָּה תְהִלָּה

“Praise {is in} silence toward you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [We are praising you in silence]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:1 (#2)

דְּמִיָּה תְהִלָּה

“Praise {is in} silence”

The implication is that the people are waiting silently in reverent worship before they praise God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Waiting in silence to praise] or [Silent before worship directed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 65:1 (#3)

בְּצִיּוֹן

“in Zion”

The word **Zion** is the name of a place. It refers to Mount Zion in Jerusalem.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 65:1 (#4)

יְשֻׁלַּם־נֶדֶר

“a vow will be paid”

The expression **a vow will be paid** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the worshipers. Alternate translation: [the worshipers will pay their vows] or [people will fulfill their vows]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 65:2 (#1)

שֹׁמֵעַ תְּפִלָּה

“Hearer of prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You who hear people when they pray;]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:2 (#2)

כָּל־בָּשָׂר

“all flesh”

Here, **all flesh** represents all people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all people] or [everyone]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 65:3 (#1)

דִּבְרֵי עֲוֹנֹת

“Matters of iniquities”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquities**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The wrong things we have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:3 (#2)

פְּשָׁעֵינוּ

“our transgressions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgressions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ways we have disobeyed you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:3 (#3)

עֲוֹנֹת גָּבְרוּ מֻמֵּנִי פְּשָׁעֵינוּ

“iniquities prevail against me; our transgressions”

The terms **iniquities** and **transgressions** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Our many sins overwhelm me but]

See: Doublet

Psalms 65:3 (#4)

גָּבְרוּ מֻמֵּנִי

“prevail against me”

The pronoun **me** refers to the psalmist, while the pronoun “our” refers to the psalmist along with the rest of God’s people. The psalmist is speaking both personally and on behalf of the community. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [prevail against me and my people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 65:3 (#5)

אַתָּה תְכַפְּרֵם

“you, you cover them”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you cover them** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that God, to whom he is speaking, is the one forgiving them. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you, God, you cover them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 65:3 (#6)

תְּכַפְּרֵם

“you cover them”

The psalmist is using **you cover them** as a common expression of the culture to mean “you forgive them” or “you atone for them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you forgive them] or [you atone for them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 65:4 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is] or [Truly blessed is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 65:4 (#2)

בְּטוּב בֵּיתֶךָ

“of the goodness of your house”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the good things in your house] or [how good your house is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:4 (#3)

קְדֹשׁ הֵיכָלֶךָ

“the holiness of your temple”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how holy your temple is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:4 (#4)

בֵּיתֶךָ & הֵיכָלֶךָ

“your house & your temple”

Here, **your house** and **your temple** represent God’s presence at the temple in Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your presence in the temple ... your presence in the temple]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 65:4 (#5)

נִשְׂבְּעָה בְּטוּב בֵּיתֶךָ קְדֹשׁ הֵיכָלֶךָ

“May we be full of the goodness of your house, the holiness of your temple”

The terms **your house** and **your temple** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [May we be full of the goodness and holiness of your holy dwelling place]

See: Doublet

Psalms 65:5 (#1)

בְּצֶדֶק

“in righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by doing what is right] or [in a righteous way]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:5 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ

“God of our salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God who is saving us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:5 (#3)

מִבְטָחָה

“the confidence of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **confidence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the trusted one of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:5 (#4)

קַצְוֵי־אֶרֶץ

“the ends of the earth”

The psalmist is using **the ends of the earth** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the most distant places on earth” or “people everywhere.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the most remote places] or [people everywhere on earth]

See: Idiom

Psalms 65:5 (#5)

קַצְוֵי־אֶרֶץ וְיָם רְחֹקִים

“the ends of the earth and the distant seas”

The psalmist is referring to all of the earth by naming two extremes, **the ends of the earth** and **the distant seas**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everywhere on earth]

See: Merism

Psalms 65:6 (#1)

מֵכִין הָרִרִים בְּכֹחֲוֹ

“the one establishing mountains by his strength”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a builder who physically **establishes mountains** in place. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who created the mountains by his great power]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:6 (#2)

בְּכֹחֲוֹ

“by his strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by how strong he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:6 (#3)

נֶאְזָר בִּגְבוּרָה

“being girded with might”

The expression **being girded with might** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [who girds himself with might] or [who clothes himself with might]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 65:6 (#4)

בִּגְבוּרָה

“with might”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **might**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with powerful strength] or [by being mighty]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:6 (#5)

בְּכֹחֲוֹ & בִּגְבוּרָה

“by his strength & with might”

The terms **strength** and **might** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [great power]

See: Doublet

Psalms 65:6 (#6)

נֶאְזָר בִּגְבוּרָה

“being girded with might”

The psalmist is speaking of might as if it were clothing that God could wear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [possessing great power] or [having great might]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:7 (#1)

שְׁאוֹן יַמִּים שְׁאוֹן גַּלֵּיהֶם

“the roar of the seas, the roar of their waves”

These two phrases **the roar of the seas** and **the roar of their waves** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the roar of the seas, yes, the roar of their waves] or [the roaring seas and their waves]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 65:7 (#2)

שְׁאוֹן יַמִּים שְׁאוֹן גַּלֵּיהֶם

“the roar of the seas, the roar of their waves”

The terms **the roar of the seas** and **the roar of their waves** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the loud roaring of the seas]

See: Doublet

Psalms 65:7 (#3)

וַהֲמוֹן לְאֻמִּים

“and the tumult of the peoples”

The psalmist is speaking of **the tumult of the peoples** as if it were roaring like chaotic seas. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the unrest of the nations] or [the agitation of the peoples]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:7 (#4)

שְׁאוֹן יַמִּים & וַהֲמוֹן לְאֻמִּים

“the roar of the seas & and the tumult of the peoples”

The phrases **the roar of the seas** and **the tumult of the peoples** mean basically the same thing. The psalmist is speaking of the **peoples** as if they were **seas**, comparing the noise and chaos of nations to crashing waves. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the roar of the seas, that is, the tumult of the peoples]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 65:8 (#1)

יֹשְׁבֵי קְצָוֹת

“the dwellers of the ends”

The psalmist is using **the dwellers of the ends** as a common expression of the culture to mean “those who live in the farthest places” or “those who live at the remotest boundaries of the earth.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who live in the most distant places] or [people in the remotest parts of the earth]

See: Idiom

Psalms 65:8 (#2)

מֵאוֹתֹתֶיךָ

“at your signs”

Here, **signs** represents God’s miraculous deeds. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your miraculous works] or [your mighty acts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 65:8 (#3)

מְוֹצָאֵי־בֹקֶר וָעֶרֶב תַּרְנִין

“you make the goings forth of the morning and the evening shout joyfully”

The psalmist is speaking of **the goings forth of the morning and the evening** as if they were living things that could **shout joyfully**. The phrase **the goings forth of the morning and the evening** represents sunrise and sunset. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the places where the sun rises and sets rejoice] or [people everywhere from sunrise to sunset shout joyfully]

See: Personification

Psalms 65:8 (#4)

מְמֹוצָאֵי־בֹ֥קֶר וָעֶ֑רֶב

“the goings forth of the morning and the evening”

The psalmist is using **the goings forth of the morning and the evening** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the east and the west” or “all the earth from sunrise to sunset.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all the earth from the east to the west] or [everywhere the sun rises and sets]

See: Idiom

Psalms 65:8 (#5)

בֹ֥קֶר וָעֶ֑רֶב

“the morning and the evening”

The psalmist is referring to all times of day by naming two extremes, **the morning** and **the evening**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all day long] or [at all times]

See: Merism

Psalms 65:9 (#1)

פָּקַ֣דְתָּ הָאָ֭רֶץ

“You visit the earth”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a person who could come to **visit the earth**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [You come to the earth and care for it] or [You attend to the earth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:9 (#2)

פֶּ֣לֶג אֱ֭לֹהִים מָלֵ֣א מָ֑יִם

“The channel of God {is} full of water”

The psalmist is speaking of the rain that comes from the sky as if it flowed from **the channel of God**, a heavenly waterway. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The sky is full of rain from God] or [God’s heavenly reservoir is full of water]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:9 (#3)

דְּגָנָ֗ם

“their grain”

The pronoun **their** refers to people on earth who benefit from God’s provision. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [grain for people] or [grain for humanity]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 65:10 (#1)

תְּלָמֶ֥יהָ רַ֝וֵּ֗ה נַחֵ֣ת גְּדוּדֶ֑יהָ

“Watering its furrows, settling its ridges”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [You water its furrows, you settle its ridges]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 65:10 (#2)

צִמְחָתָ֥הּ תְּבָרֵֽךְ

“you bless its growth”

The psalmist is speaking of the growth of plants as if it were something that receives God’s **blessing**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you cause its crops to grow] or [you make it produce a good harvest]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:11 (#1)

עִ֭עַטַּרְתָּ שָׁנָ֣ה טוֹבָתֶ֑ךָ

“You crown the year {with} your goodness”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a king placing a **crown** on the year to adorn it with abundant blessings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You adorn the year

with your goodness] or [You make the year wonderful with your goodness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:11 (#2)

טוּבְתֶּךָ

“with} your goodness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how good you are] or [how generously you provide]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:11 (#3)

וּמַעְגָּלֶיךָ יִרְעֲפוּ דָּשֶׁן

“and your tracks drip fatness”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were driving a cart whose **tracks drip fatness** (that is, whose wheel ruts overflow with abundant crops). If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [you leave abundance behind you wherever you go]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:11 (#4)

וּמַעְגָּלֶיךָ

“and your tracks”

Here, **tracks** represents God’s presence as he passes by, bringing blessing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everywhere you pass by] or [the places where you have gone]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 65:11 (#5)

דָּשֶׁן

“fatness”

Here, **fatness** represents abundance and prosperity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [abundance] or [rich blessings]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 65:12 (#1)

יִרְעֲפוּ נְאוֹת מִדְבָּר

“The pastures of the wilderness drip”

The psalmist is speaking of **the pastures of the wilderness** as if they were living things that could **drip** with moisture or abundance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The pastures of the wilderness are covered with dew] or [The pastures of the wilderness are full of water]

See: Personification

Psalms 65:12 (#2)

וְגִבְעוֹת תַּחְגֹּרְנָה

“and the hills gird on rejoicing”

The psalmist is speaking of **the hills** as if they were living things that could put on clothing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the hills are like people who dress themselves in joyful celebration] or [it is as if the hills wear rejoicing]

See: Personification

Psalms 65:12 (#3)

וְגִיל

“rejoicing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rejoicing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [joy] or [what makes people rejoice]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 65:12 (#4)

וְגִיל & תַּחְגֹּרְנָה

“gird on rejoicing”

The psalmist is speaking of the hills as if they were people who could **gird on rejoicing** like a person putting on clothing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the hills are clothed with joy] or [the hills seem joyful]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:13 (#1)

לָבְשׁוּ כָרִים ׀ הַצֹּאן

“The meadows put on a flock”

The psalmist is speaking of **meadows** as if they were living things that could put on clothing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Flocks cover the meadows]

See: Personification

Psalms 65:13 (#2)

לָבְשׁוּ הַצֹּאן &

“put on a flock”

The psalmist is speaking of the meadows as if they were people who could **put on** flocks as clothing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The flocks cover the meadows] or [Flocks are spread across the meadows]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 65:13 (#3)

וַעֲמָקִים יַעֲטְפוּ־בָר

“and the valleys cover {themselves} {with} grain”

The psalmist is speaking of **the valleys** as if they were living things that could **cover themselves with grain**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [grain grows abundantly in the valleys] or [the valleys are filled with grain]

See: Personification

Psalms 65:13 (#4)

יָרִיעוּ אַף־יָשִׁירוּ

“They shout joyfully; indeed, they sing”

The psalmist is speaking of **the meadows** and **the valleys** as if they were living things that could **shout joyfully** and **sing**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It is as though they shout joyfully; indeed, it is as though they sing] or [They are like people shouting joyfully and singing]

See: Personification

Psalms 65:13 (#5)

יָרִיעוּ & יָשִׁירוּ

“They shout joyfully & they sing”

The terms **shout joyfully** and **sing** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [rejoice with loud songs]

See: Doublet

Psalms - Chapter 66 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 66 is a psalm of thanksgiving. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship (1–3)
2. Reason to worship (5–7)
3. Call to worship (8)
4. Reason to worship (9–12)
5. The psalmist’s declaration that he is paying a vow (13–15)
6. The psalmist’s declaration that God has answered his prayer (16–20)

Psalms 66:1 (#1)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“For the chief musician”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 66:1 (#2)

הָרִיעוּ לֵאלֹהִים כָּל־הָאָרֶץ

“Shout to God, all of the earth”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Let everyone on earth shout to God]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:2 (#1)

זַמְּרוּ כְּבוֹד־שְׁמוֹ

“Make music {to} the glory of his name”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please make music to the glory of his name]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:2 (#2)

כְּבוֹד

“to} the glory of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [glorious character]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:2 (#3)

שִׂשְׂימוּ כָּבֹד תְּהִלָּתוֹ

“make his praise glorious”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please make his praise glorious]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:2 (#4)

תְּהִלָּתוֹ

“his praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [praises]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:3 (#1)

אִמְרוּ לֵאלֹהִים

“Say to God”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please say to God]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:3 (#2)

מַה־נּוֹרָא מַעֲשֶׂיךָ

“How fearsome {are} your deeds”

The psalmist is using the question form to express amazement at God’s deeds. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your deeds are very fearsome!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 66:3 (#3)

בְּרֹב עֻזְּךָ

“Because of the greatness of your power”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **greatness** and **power**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [of your very great power]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:3 (#4)

יְכַחֲשׁוּ לְךָ אֹיְבֶיךָ

“your enemies cringe before you”

Here, **cringe** represents showing false submission out of fear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your enemies submit to you in fear]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 66:4 (#1)

כָּל־הָאָרֶץ ׀ יִשְׁתַּחֲוּוּ לְךָ

“All of the earth bows down to you”

The psalmist is saying **All of the earth bows down to you** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [Everyone on earth bows down to you]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 66:4 (#2)

כָּל־הָאָרֶץ ׀ יִשְׁתַּחֲוּוּ

“All of the earth bows down”

The psalmist is speaking of **the earth** as if it were a living thing that could bow down and worship. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Everyone on earth bows down]

See: Personification

Psalms 66:4 (#3)

שִׁמְךָֽ

“to} your name”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. Alternate translation: [to your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 66:5 (#1)

לְכ֤וּ וּ֝רְא֗וּ מִפְעֲלוֹת֮ אֱלֹהִ֪ים

“Come and see the works of God”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please come and see the works of God]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:5 (#2)

נוֹרָ֣א עֲ֭לִילָה

“fearsome in doing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **doing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [fearsome in what he does]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:5 (#3)

בְּנֵ֖י אָדָֽם

“the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of the culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 66:6 (#1)

הָהָפַ֣ךְ יָ֭ם ׀ לַיַּבָּשָׁ֑ה

“He turned the sea into dry land”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God had literally transformed the sea into solid ground. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He made a way through the sea on dry ground]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:6 (#2)

יַעַבְר֣וּ

“they passed through”

The pronoun **they** refers to the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Israelites passed through]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 66:6 (#3)

נִשְׂמְחָה־בּֽוֹ

“let us rejoice in him”

The psalmist is using the imperative form to communicate an exhortation. If the imperative does not communicate an exhortation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [we should rejoice in him]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:6 (#4)

יָ֭ם & בַּנָּהָ֑ר

“the sea & the river”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **the sea** refers to the Red Sea and **the river** refers to the Jordan River, both of which God miraculously parted for the Israelites to cross. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the Red Sea ... the Jordan River]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 66:7 (#1)

בִּגְבוּרָתוֹ

“by his might”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **might**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by being mighty]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:7 (#2)

עֵינָיו בַּגּוֹיִם תִּצְפֶּינָה

“his eyes watch over the nations”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God had physical **eyes** that could **watch over** the nations. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he observes the nations]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:7 (#3)

הַסּוֹרְרִים ׀ אַל־יָרִימוּ לָמוֹ

“Let the ones rebelling not exalt themselves”

See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [The ones rebelling should not exalt themselves]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 66:8 (#1)

בָּרְכוּ עַמִּים ׀ אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“Bless our God, peoples”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please bless our God, peoples]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:8 (#2)

וְהַשְׁמִיעוּ קוֹל תְּהִלָּתוֹ

“and make the sound of his praise heard”

The expression **make the sound of his praise heard** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and proclaim his praise aloud]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 66:8 (#3)

תְּהִלָּתוֹ

“his praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [praising him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:9 (#1)

הַשָּׂם נַפְשֵׁנוּ בַּחַיִּים

“the one putting our soul among the living”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if keeping them alive were **putting** their **soul among the living**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one keeping us alive]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:9 (#2)

וְלֹא־נָתַן לַמּוֹט רַגְלֵנוּ

“and he does not allow our foot to slip”

Here, **our foot to slip** represents falling into danger or ruin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and he does not allow us to stumble into disaster]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 66:10 (#1)

כִּי־בָחַנְתָּנוּ

“For you tested us”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the difficulties God allowed as if God had **tested** them as a refiner tests metal. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For you put us through difficulties to prove us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:10 (#2)

צְרַפְתָּנוּ כִּצְרֹף־כָּסֶף

“you refined us like the refining of silver”

The point of this comparison is that just as silver is purified by being heated in fire to remove impurities, so God allowed the people to go through difficulties to purify them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [you purified us through suffering just as a refiner purifies silver with fire]

See: Simile

Psalms 66:10 (#3)

כִּצְרֹף־כָּסֶף

“like the refining of silver”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **refining**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [just as silver is refined]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:11 (#1)

הֲבֵאתָנוּ בַמָּצוֹד

“You brought us into a net”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the difficult circumstances were a **net** that trapped them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You allowed us to be captured]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:11 (#2)

שַׂמְתָּ מוּעָקָה בְּמָתְנֵינוּ

“you put pressure on our loins”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if oppression and hardship were physical **pressure on our loins**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you placed a heavy burden on us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:12 (#1)

הִרְכַּבְתָּ אֱנוֹשׁ לְרֹאשֵׁנוּ

“You made man ride over our head”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if being conquered by enemies were having **man ride over our head**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You let our conquerors trample over us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:12 (#2)

בָּאנוּ־בָאֵשׁ וּבַמָּיִם

“we went through fire and through waters”

The psalmist is referring to all kinds of trials by naming two extremes, **fire** and **waters**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [we went through every kind of danger]

See: Merism

Psalms 66:12 (#3)

וַתּוֹצִיאֵנוּ לָרְוָיָה

“but you brought us out to abundance”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if prosperity and blessing were a place of **abundance** to which God brought them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but you brought us to where we prosper]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:12 (#4)

לָרְוָיָה

“to abundance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **abundance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to a place where we have all that we need]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:13 (#1)

בְּעוֹלוֹת

“with burnt offerings”

The **burnt offerings** are a kind of sacrifice in which whole animals are burned on an altar as an offering to God. If your readers would not be familiar with what burnt offerings are, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [with sacrifices that are totally burned on the altar]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 66:14 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר־פָּצְצוּ שְׂפָתָי

“for} which my lips opened”

Here, **my lips opened** represents the psalmist making vows by speaking them aloud. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [which I voiced]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 66:14 (#2)

פָּצְצוּ שְׂפָתָי וְדִבֶּר־פִּי

“my lips opened and my mouth spoke”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I solemnly vowed]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 66:14 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר־פָּצְצוּ שְׂפָתָי וְדִבֶּר־פִּי בַּצַּר־לִי

“for} which my lips opened and my mouth spoke when trouble {was} to me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about when the psalmist was in trouble before the information about what his lips and mouth did. Alternate translation: [{for} which, when trouble {was} to me, my lips opened and my mouth spoke]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 66:15 (#1)

עֹלוֹת מֵחִים אַעֲלֶה & אֶאֱעֶשֶׂה בָקָקָר עִם־עַתּוּדִים

“I will offer up burnt offerings of fatlings & I will offer cattle with male goats”

These two phrases **I will offer up burnt offerings of fatlings** and **I will offer cattle with male goats** mean basically the same thing. The first phrase states the general idea, and then the second phrase gives a specific example. Translate these phrases according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. Alternate translation: [I will offer up young animals fattened for burnt offerings ... including cattle with male goats]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 66:15 (#2)

עֹלוֹת מֵחִים

“burnt offerings of fatlings”

Fatlings are young animals that have been fattened for sacrifice. If your readers would not be familiar with what fatlings are, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [burnt offerings of young, fattened animals]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 66:15 (#3)

עִם־קְטֹרֶת אֵילִים

“with the smoke of rams”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know what he means. The **smoke of rams** is the fragrant smoke that rises when rams are burned as sacrifices on the altar. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [with the fragrant smoke from the burning of rams]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 66:16 (#1)

לְכוּ־שִׁמְעוּ וַאֲסַפְּרָה

“Come, listen, and let me recount”

These are imperatives, but they communicate a polite request rather than a command. If the imperatives do not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please come, listen, and let me recount]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 66:16 (#2)

אֲשֶׁשֶׁר עָשָׂה לְנַפְשִׁי

“what he has done for my soul”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [what he has done for me personally]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 66:17 (#1)

וְרוֹמַם תַּחַת לְשׁוֹנִי

“and he was exalted from my tongue”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if his praise were something physically lifted up from his **tongue**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I praised his greatness with my words]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:18 (#1)

אֱוֶן אִם־רָאִיתִי בְלִבָּבִי

“If I had regarded iniquity in my heart”

The psalmist is making a conditional statement that sounds hypothetical, but he knows that the condition is not true. He is stating it as a condition to show that the Lord not hearing is also not true. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that the speaker believes is not true. Alternate translation: [Suppose I had cherished iniquity in my heart]

See: Connect — Contrary to Fact Conditions

Psalms 66:18 (#2)

אֱוֶן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is wicked]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:18 (#3)

בְלִבָּבִי

“in my heart”

Here, **my heart** represents the psalmist’s inner thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in my mind]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 66:19 (#1)

אָכֵן שָׁמַע אֱלֹהִים

“Surely God has heard”

The psalmist uses the word **Surely** here to indicate a contrast between the hypothetical situation in which God would not have heard (verse 18) and the reality that God did hear. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But indeed God has heard]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 66:19 (#2)

בְּקוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי

“to the voice of my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to me as I prayed to him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:19 (#3)

בְּקוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי

“to the voice of my prayer”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if his prayer had a **voice** that could speak. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to my words as I prayed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 66:20 (#1)

בָּרוּךְ אֱלֹהִים

“Blessed {be} God”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise God. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Let me praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 66:20 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר לֹא־הֵסִיר תְּפִלָּתִי

“who has not turned away my prayer”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word for **turned away**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [who has certainly accepted my prayer]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 66:20 (#3)

תְּפִלָּתִי

“my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my crying to him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 66:20 (#4)

וְחַסְדּוֹ מֵאִתִּי

“or his covenant faithfulness from me”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [nor has he turned away his covenant faithfulness from me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 66:20 (#5)

וְחַסְדּוֹ

“or his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [or his loyal love]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 67 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 67 is a psalm of thanksgiving on the occasion of an abundant harvest. It includes requests at the beginning and end for God to bless the people, but given the occasion, these have the sense of “may God continue to bless us.” So while these requests have an element of supplication, the psalm as a whole is a psalm of praise. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Request for God to bless (1–2)
2. Refrain (3)
3. Call to worship (4a)
4. Reason to worship (4b)
5. Refrain (5)
6. Reason to worship (6a)
7. Request for God to bless (6a–7)

Allusion to Numbers

In verse 1, the psalmist says, “May God be gracious to us and bless us; may he make his face shine on us.” In Numbers 6:25, Yahweh told the priests to say this same thing in order to bless the Israelites. So that your readers will be able to recognize this allusion, we recommend that you translate this phrase in the same way here and in Numbers 6:25.

Psalms 67:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 67:1 (#1)

יָאֵר פָּנָיו אִתָּנוּ

“may he make his face shine on us”

The psalmist is speaking of God showing his favor as if God’s **face** were a light that could **shine** on people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may he show us his favor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 67:2 (#1)

לָדַעַת בָּאָרֶץ דַּרְכֶּךָ

“for the knowing of your way on the earth”

Here the word **for** marks **the knowing of your way** as the goal or purpose of the psalmist’s prayer for God’s blessing in the previous verse. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that people may know your way]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 67:2 (#2)

דַּרְכֶּךָ

“your way”

The psalmist is speaking of how God acts as if that were a **way** or path that God walks along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how you act]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 67:2 (#3)

בְּכָל־גּוֹיִם יְשׁוּעָתֶךָ

"your salvation among all of the nations"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and for the knowing of your salvation among all of the nations]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 67:2 (#4)

יְשׁוּעָתֶךָ

"your salvation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how you save people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 67:2 (#5)

דַּרְכֶּךָ בְּכָל־גּוֹיִם יְשׁוּעָתֶךָ

"your way & your salvation among all of the nations"

The pronoun **your** refers to God in both instances. Alternate translation: [God's way ... God's salvation among all the nations]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 67:3 (#1)

יוֹדוּךָ עַמִּים ׀ אֱלֹהִים יוֹדוּךָ עַמִּים כֻּלָּם

"May the peoples thank you, God; may the peoples thank you, all of them"

These two phrases **May the peoples thank you, God** and **may the peoples thank you, all of them** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with some different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [May all the peoples thank you, God] or [May all the peoples thank you, God; indeed, may everyone in the world thank you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 67:4 (#1)

יְשַׂמְּחוּ וִירַנְּנוּ לְאֻמִּים כִּי־תִשְׁפֹּט עַמִּים מִישֹׁר וּלְאֻמִּים ׀ בָּאָרֶץ תַּנְחֵם סֶלָה

"May the nations rejoice and shout joyfully, for you judge the peoples {with} uprightness, and the nations on the earth, you guide them. Selah"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because you judge the peoples {with} uprightness, and the nations on the earth, you guide them, may the nations rejoice and shout joyfully. Selah]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 67:4 (#2)

תִשְׁפֹּט עַמִּים מִישֹׁר וּלְאֻמִּים ׀ בָּאָרֶץ תַּנְחֵם

"you judge the peoples {with} uprightness, and the nations on the earth, you guide them"

These two phrases **you judge the peoples with uprightness** and **the nations on the earth, you guide them** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [you judge and guide all the peoples on the earth with uprightness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 67:4 (#3)

מִישֹׁר

"with} uprightness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **uprightness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [justly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 67:5 (#1)

יוֹדֻךָ עַמִּים ׀ אֱלֹהִים ׀ יוֹדוּךָ עַמִּים כֻּלָּם

“May the peoples thank you, God; may the peoples thank you, all of them”

This verse is a refrain that repeats the exact words of 67:3. If your language has a poetic way to indicate a refrain, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [May all the peoples thank you, God]

See: Poetry

Psalms 67:6 (#1)

אֶרֶץ נָתְנָה יְבוּלָהּ

“The earth has given its produce”

The psalmist is speaking of **the earth** as if it were a living thing that could **give** produce. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [There has been a good harvest from the earth]

See: Personification

Psalms 67:6 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“our God”

The psalmist is not using the possessive form **our God** to indicate that the people of Israel possess or control God. Rather the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the one whom they worship. Alternate translation: [the God whom we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 67:7 (#1)

כָּל־אַפְסֵי־אָרֶץ

“all of the ends of the earth”

Here, **all of the ends of the earth** represents people everywhere on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [people everywhere on the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 67:7 (#2)

אֹתוֹ

“him”

The pronoun **him** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 68 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 68 is a divine enthronement psalm. (See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.) Many interpreters believe that David wrote this psalm for the occasion when a great crowd of Israelites brought the Box of the Covenant to a sanctuary that David had prepared for it on Mount Zion. (His son King Solomon later built a temple for Yahweh on that location.) The psalm depicts God leading the people of Israel in a procession starting at Mount Sinai, through the wilderness, into the land of Canaan to conquer it, and finally up Mount Zion to the sanctuary. The psalm then describes the actual procession of Israelites. Finally, it describes how the Israelites will be safe from their enemies now that God will be ruling as their divine king from his sanctuary.

1. The Box of the Covenant sets out (1–2)
2. A call to worship God for his power and goodness (3–6)
3. God leads the Israelites through the desert and provides water (7–10)
4. The conquest of Canaan, viewed through a victory celebration afterwards (11–14)
5. God chooses Mount Zion for his sanctuary (15–18)
6. God will defeat the enemies of the Israelites (19–23)
7. Description of the procession up Mount Zion (24–27)
8. Foreign kingdoms will worship the God of Israel and pay tribute to him (28–35)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Allusion to Numbers

David begins this psalm by saying, “Let God arise, let his enemies scatter, and let the ones hating him flee from his face.” According to Numbers 10:35, whenever the Israelites picked up the Box of the Covenant in order to move to another place in the wilderness, Moses would say, “Arise, Yahweh, and let your enemies scatter, and let the ones hating you flee from your face.” So that your readers will be able to recognize this allusion, we recommend that you translate this phrase with the same terms here and in Numbers 10:35.

Mountains
David speaks of mountains in significant ways in this psalm. His overall message is that the same God who first appeared to the Israelites at Mount Sinai is now ruling over them from his sanctuary in Mount Zion. As he says in a compact way in verse 17, "Sinai is in the holy place." David also speaks of Mount Bashan, a high mountain to the northeast of Israel. In verses 15–16, he says poetically that this great mountain should not be jealous of Mount Zion. In verse 22, he uses it to represent a very high place to which enemies might try to flee, pairing it with the "depths of the sea," a very low place. Because of the significance of these mountains in the psalm, we recommend that you use the names Sinai and Bashan at each place where they occur, spelling them the way they sound in your language. You may also want to identify Mount Zion as the mountain that David describes in verse 17, as the UST does.

Walking
The image of walking or marching in a great procession unites all the sections of this psalm. David also uses the image of walking to mean other things. For example, in verse 21, he speaks of "the one walking ahead in his trespasses." This represents continuing to commit sins, as the UST indicates. It may be most natural to express the idea in that way in your translation. However, if your language can use the image of walking to represent living, we recommend that you do that so that your readers can appreciate how David is using this image.

Psalms 68:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

Psalms 68:1 (#1)

יָקוּם אֱלֹהִים יָפוּצוּ אוֹיְבָיו וְיָנֻסוּ מְשַׂנְאָיו

"Let God arise, let his enemies scatter, and let the ones hating him flee"

By using **Let**, the psalmist is expressing his wish or prayer. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about "let" and "may" and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that God should arise and make his enemies scatter and the ones hating him flee]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 68:1 (#2)

יָפוּצוּ אוֹיְבָיו וְיָנֻסוּ מְשַׂנְאָיו מִפָּנָיו

"let his enemies scatter, and let the ones hating him flee from his face"

These two phrases **let his enemies scatter** and **let the ones hating him flee from his face** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [may all who oppose him scatter and flee]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 68:1 (#3)

מִפָּנָיו

"from his face"

Here, **from his face** represents being away from God's presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from before him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:2 (#1)

כְּהִנְדֹּף עָשָׁן תִּנְדֹּף

"As smoke is driven away, drive {them} away"

The point of this comparison is that just as **smoke is driven away** easily and completely by wind, so should God's enemies be easily and completely driven away. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Scatter them completely, just as smoke is scattered by the wind]

See: Simile

Psalms 68:2 (#2)

כְּהִנְדֹּף עָשָׁן

“As smoke is driven away”

The expression **smoke is driven away** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the wind drives smoke away]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 68:2 (#3)

כְּהֵמַּס דּוֹנַג מִפְּנֵי־אֵשׁ יֹאבְדוּ רְשָׁעִים מִפְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים

“as wax melts from the face of fire, let the wicked perish from the face of God”

The point of this comparison is that just as **wax melts from the face of fire**, dissolving and disappearing before heat, so will the wicked perish before God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as wax dissolves when heat strikes it, let the wicked perish before God]

See: Simile

Psalms 68:2 (#4)

מִפְּנֵי־אֵשׁ

“from the face of fire”

Here, **from the face of fire** represents being near the front surface of fire. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the heat of fire]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:2 (#5)

יֹאבְדוּ רְשָׁעִים

“let the wicked perish”

By using **let**, the psalmist is expressing what he desires or prays will happen. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [the wicked should be destroyed]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 68:2 (#6)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 68:2 (#7)

מִפְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים

“from the face of God”

Here, **from the face of God** represents being away from God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from before God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:3 (#1)

וְצַדִּיקִים יִשְׂמָחוּ יָעֲלְצוּ לִפְנֵי אֱלֹהִים וְיָשִׂישׂוּ בְשִׂמְחָה

“But let the righteous rejoice, let them exult to the face of God, and let them be glad with rejoicing”

See how your translation team has decided to represent sets of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [But let the righteous celebrate joyfully in God’s presence]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 68:3 (#2)

וְצַדִּיקִים יִשְׂמָחוּ

“But let the righteous rejoice”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [But let righteous people rejoice]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 68:3 (#3)

לִפְנֵי אֱלֹהִים

“to the face of God”

Here, **to the face of God** represents being in God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:3 (#4)

בְּשִׂמְחָה

“with rejoicing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rejoicing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as they rejoice greatly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:4 (#1)

שִׁ֭ירוּ ׀ לֵֽאלֹהִ֑ים זַמְּרוּ֙ שְׁ֣מ֔וֹ

“Sing to God, make music {to} his name”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Sing praise to God, making music to him]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 68:4 (#2)

שְׁ֣מ֔וֹ

“to} his name”

The psalmist is using the term **his name** to represent who God is and to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who he is]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:4 (#3)

סֹ֭לּוּ לָרֹכֵ֣ב בָּֽעֲרָב֑וֹת

“lift up to the one riding over the plains”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [lift up a song to the one riding over the plains]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:4 (#4)

לָרֹכֵ֣ב בָּֽעֲרָב֑וֹת

“to the one riding over the plains”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God as if he were **the one riding over the plains**, evoking the image of a powerful warrior or king who commands the open wilderness. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who moves powerfully through the desert wastelands]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:4 (#5)

וְעִלְזוּ֖ לְפָנָֽיו

“yes, exult to his face”

Here, **exult to his face** represents rejoicing in God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [yes, exult before him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:5 (#1)

אֲבִ֣י יְתוֹמִ֑ים

“A father of orphans”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a father who is characterized by caring for orphans. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [A father to orphans]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:5 (#2)

אֲבִ֣י יְתוֹמִ֑ים

“A father of orphans”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God as if he were **A father of orphans**, meaning God cares for and protects those who have no earthly father. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [One who cares for orphans as a father would]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:5 (#3)

וְדַיַּ֖ן אַלְמָנ֣וֹת

“and a judge of widows”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a judge who is characterized by defending widows. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea

in another way. Alternate translation: [a defender of widows]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:5 (#4)

קָדְשׁוֹ

“his holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **his holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his holy being]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:6 (#1)

יְחִידִֽים

“the lonely”

The psalmist is using the adjective **lonely** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are lonely]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 68:6 (#2)

אַ֭ךְ סוֹרְרִ֣ים שָׁכְנ֑וּ צְחִיחָֽה

“But the ones rebelling dwell in dryness”

The psalmist uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between those whom God blesses and those who rebel against him. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, the ones rebelling dwell in dryness]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 68:6 (#3)

שָׁכְנ֑וּ צְחִיחָֽה

“dwell in dryness”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if **dryness** were a place where rebels must live, representing the barrenness and hardship of life without God’s blessing. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [dwell in a barren land]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:7 (#1)

בְּ֭הֵצֵאתְךָ לִפְנֵ֣י עַמֶּ֑ךָ בְּצַעְדְּךָ֖ בְּיִשִׁימֽוֹן

“when you went out to the face of your people, when you marched in the wilderness”

The psalmist is using the clause **when you went out to the face of your people, when you marched in the wilderness** to describe something that was ongoing. This provides the background for the events he describes in verse 8. Connect this clause to the following verse in a way that makes it clear in your language that this clause is describing something that was ongoing in the background. Alternate translation: [as you went out before your people, as you marched through the wilderness]

See: Connect — Background Information

Psalms 68:7 (#2)

בְּ֭הֵצֵאתְךָ לִפְנֵ֣י עַמֶּ֑ךָ בְּצַעְדְּךָ֖ בְּיִשִׁימֽוֹן

“when you went out to the face of your people, when you marched in the wilderness”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [when you marched before your people through the wilderness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 68:7 (#3)

לִפְנֵ֣י עַמֶּ֑ךָ

“to the face of your people”

Here, **to the face of your people** represents going out in front of and leading the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before your people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:8 (#1)

אֶ֣רֶץ רָ֭עָשָׁה

“the earth quaked”

The psalmist is speaking of **the earth quaked** as if the earth were a living thing that could react with fear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the earth trembled]

See: Personification

Psalms 68:8 (#2)

שָׁמַ֤יִם נָטְפ֗וּ

“the heavens dripped”

The psalmist is speaking of **the heavens dripped** as if the heavens were a living thing that could pour out rain. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [rain fell from the sky]

See: Personification

Psalms 68:8 (#3)

מִפְּנֵ֣י אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“from the face of God”

Here, **from the face of God** represents being in front of God, that is, in his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the presence of God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:8 (#4)

זֶ֥ה סִינַ֗י מִפְּנֵ֤י אֱלֹהִ֨ים ׀ אֱלֹהֵ֖י יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“this Sinai, from the face of God, the God of Israel”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The verb “quaked” from the previous clause is implied here. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [this Sinai also quaked, from the face of God, the God of Israel]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:8 (#5)

מִפְּנֵ֣י אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“from the face of God”

Here, **from the face of God** represents being in front of God, that is, in his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the presence of God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:8 (#6)

אֱלֹהֵ֖י יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“the God of Israel”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form **the God of Israel** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control God. Rather the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the one whom Israel worships. Alternate translation: [who is the God whom Israel worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:9 (#1)

גֶּ֭שֶׁם נְדָבוֹת֮ תָּנִ֪יף

“A rain of generosities you shook out”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **rain** that is characterized by **generosities**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You poured out abundant rainfall]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:9 (#2)

גֶּ֭שֶׁם נְדָבוֹת

“A rain of generosities”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **generosities**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [A generous rainful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:9 (#3)

נַחֲלָתְךָ֗

“your inheritance”

David is speaking as if the land of Israel were actually Yahweh’s **inheritance**, that is, as if it were something that belonged to him permanently because he inherited it from an ancestor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the land that belongs to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:9 (#4)

וְ֝נִלְאָ֗ה

“when it was wearied”

The expression **when it was wearied** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [when it grew weary]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 68:9 (#5)

אַתָּ֣ה כוֹנַנְתָּ֑הּ

“you, you established it”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you established** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that God himself is the one who acted. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [indeed, you established it]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:10 (#1)

חַיָּתְךָ

“Your flock”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God’s people were **your flock**, an animal herd cared for by a shepherd. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your nation]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:10 (#2)

בָּ֝הּ

“in it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the land, that is, the inheritance mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in the land]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:10 (#3)

בְּטוּבָתְךָ

“in your goodness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are good]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:10 (#4)

לֶעָנְיֶ֑ךָ

“for the poor”

The psalmist is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [for those who are needy]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 68:11 (#1)

אֲדֹנָ֥י יִתֵּן־אֹ֑מֶר

“The Lord utters the word”

The psalmist is using the term **word** to represent the message or command that the Lord spoke. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The Lord speaks his command]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:11 (#2)

הַֽמְבַשְּׂרוֹת צָבָ֥א רָֽב

“the {women} proclaiming good news {are} a great army”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the women proclaiming good news were **a great army**, a large and powerful fighting force. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the women proclaiming good news are a vast company]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:11 (#3)

הַֽמְבַשְּׂרוֹת

“the {women} proclaiming good news”

The Hebrew word translated as **the women proclaiming good news** is feminine in form, indicating that those who announced the victory were specifically women. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [the female heralds]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:12 (#1)

מַלְכֵ֣י צְבָאוֹת

“Kings of armies”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to mean kings who command armies. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Kings who command armies]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:12 (#2)

יִדֹּדוּן יִדֹּדוּן

“flee, they flee”

The words **flee** and **they flee** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two words together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [they flee in great haste]

See: Doublet

Psalms 68:12 (#3)

יִדֹּדוּן וּנְוַת בַּיִת תְּחַלֵּק

“they flee, and the habitation of the house, she divides”

The pronoun **they** refers to the kings, while the pronoun **she** refers to the woman who stays at home. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the kings flee, and the woman who stays at home divides]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:13 (#1)

אִם־תִּשְׁכְּבוּן

“Though you lie down”

The pronoun you does not refer to God, as in verses 7–10. It is plural, and it refers to Israelite men who stayed back to care for flocks instead of going into battle. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Even if you were among the Israelite men who lay down between the sheepfolds] or [Even if you were among the Israelite men who cared for flocks instead of going into battle]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:13 (#2)

כַּנְפֵי יוֹנָה נֶחְפָָּה בַכֶּסֶף

“the wings of a dove covered with silver”

The psalmist is using **the wings of a dove covered with silver** to represent a dove statue on which the wings are covered with silver. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a dove statue whose wings are covered with silver]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 68:13 (#3)

כַּנְפֵי יוֹנָה נֶחְפָָּה בַכֶּסֶף

“the wings of a dove covered with silver”

David assumes that his listeners will understand that he is describing the type of plunder that even men who stayed out of battle to care for flocks will receive. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you will still receive plunder such as a dove statue whose wings are covered with silver]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 68:13 (#4)

נֶחְפָָּה בַכֶּסֶף

“covered with silver”

The expression **covered with silver** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [with a silver covering]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 68:13 (#5)

וְאֶבְרוֹתֶיהָ בִּירַקְרַק חָרוּץ

“and its feathers, with greenness of gold”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The word “covered” from the previous clause is implied here. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and its feathers covered with greenness of gold]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:14 (#1)

בְּפָרֵשׂ שַׁדַּי מְלָכִים בָּהּ תַּשְׁלֶג בְּצַלְמוֹן

“When Shaddai scattered kings in it, it snowed on Zalmon”

The word **When** indicates that the scattering of kings and the snowfall on Zalmon happened at the same time. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could

describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [As Shaddai scattered kings in it, it snowed on Zalmon]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

Psalms 68:14 (#2)

בָּהּ

“in it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the land, the region where the battle took place. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in the place where the enemy army had assembled]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:14 (#3)

תַּשְׁלֶג בְּצַלְמוֹן

“it snowed on Zalmon”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the whitened, fleeing armies were **it snowed on Zalmon**, comparing their scattered flight to snowfall blanketing a dark mountain. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the battlefield was white, like snow on Zalmon]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:15 (#1)

הַר־אֱלֹהִים

“is} a mountain of God”

The psalmist is using **a mountain of God** as a common expression of the culture to mean “a very great mountain.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a magnificent mountain]

See: Idiom

Psalms 68:15 (#2)

הַהַר גַּבְנַנּוּנִים

“is} a mountain of peaks”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a mountain that is characterized by having many peaks. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a many-peaked mountain]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:16 (#1)

לָמָּה ׀ תְּרַצְּדוּן הָרִרִים גַּבְנַנּוּנִים הָהָר חָמַד אֱלֹהִים לְשִׁבְתּוֹ

“Why do you look enviously, mountains, peaks, {at} the mountain God desired for his dwelling”

The psalmist is using the question form to assert that God has chosen Mount Zion as his dwelling place, not the impressive Mount Bashan. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You other mountains and peaks should not look enviously at the mountain God desired for his dwelling!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 68:16 (#2)

לָמָּה ׀ תְּרַצְּדוּן הָרִרִים גַּבְנַנּוּנִים

“Why do you look enviously, mountains, peaks”

The psalmist is speaking of **mountains, peaks** as if they were living things that could feel envy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why do you look enviously, O rugged mountains]

See: Personification

Psalms 68:16 (#3)

הָרִרִים גַּבְנַנּוּנִים

“mountains, peaks”

The psalmist is speaking to **mountains, peaks** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about God’s choice of Zion. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the mountains. Alternate translation: [many-peaked mountains] or [dwellers among the many-peaked mountains]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 68:16 (#4)

לְשִׁבְתּוֹ

“for his dwelling”

The pronoun **his** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [for God’s dwelling]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:17 (#1)

רֶכֶב אֱלֹהִים

“The chariotry of God”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God’s overwhelming power were **the chariotry of God**, a vast military force of chariots. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The armies of God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:17 (#2)

רִבֹּתַיִם אַלְפֵי שִׁנְאָן

“is} two myriads, thousands of repetition”

The psalmist says **two myriads, thousands of repetition** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [tens of thousands upon thousands]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 68:17 (#3)

בָּם

“is} among them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the chariots/myriads. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [is among the chariots]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:18 (#1)

עָלִיתָ לַמָּרוֹם

“You have ascended to the height”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God’s victory as if it were **ascended to the height**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have risen to supremacy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:18 (#2)

שָׁבִיתָ שֶׁבִי

“you have taken captivity captive”

The psalmist is using **you have taken captivity captive** as a common expression of the culture to mean that he has taken a great multitude of prisoners. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have led a host of captives]

See: Idiom

Psalms 68:18 (#3)

שֶׁבִי

“captivity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **captivity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [captives]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:18 (#4)

בָּאָדָם

“among men”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [among people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 68:18 (#5)

לְשָׁכֵן ׀ יָהּ אֱלֹהִים

“that Yah God might dwell {there”

Here, **that Yah God might dwell there** marks the entire preceding action of ascending, taking captives, and receiving gifts as the goal or purpose of those acts —namely, that God would establish his dwelling. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that Yah God might dwell there]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 68:19 (#1)

בָּרוּךְ אֲדֹנָי

“Blessed {be} the Lord”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise the Lord. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [We bless the Lord] or [Let me praise the Lord]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 68:19 (#2)

יוֹם ׀ יוֹם

“Day, day”

The psalmist is repeating the word **Day** in order to intensify the meaning or the emotion that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Day after day]

See: Doublet

Psalms 68:19 (#3)

יַעֲמָס־לָנוּ

“he bears for us”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the Lord’s support as if he **bears** a load on behalf of his people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he carries our burdens]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:19 (#4)

הָאֵל יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ

“the God of our salvation”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **the God** who is characterized by saving. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who delivers us]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:19 (#5)

הָאֵל יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ

“the God of our salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who rescues us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:20 (#1)

הָאֵל ׀ לָנוּ אֵל לַמּוֹשָׁעוֹת וְלַיהוִה אֲדֹנָי לַמָּוֶת תּוֹצָאוֹת

“God {is} to us a God of salvations, and to Yahweh the Lord {are} exits from death”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [God is to us a God of salvations; indeed, Yahweh the Lord delivers us from death]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 68:20 (#2)

אֵל לַמּוֹשָׁעוֹת

“a God of salvations”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvations**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a God who saves]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:20 (#3)

לַמָּוֶת תּוֹצָאוֹת

“are} exits from death”

Here the psalmist is speaking of escaping death as if it were **exits from** a place called death. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [ways of escaping from death]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:21 (#1)

יִמְחַץ רֹאשׁ אֹיְבָיו

“will crush the head of his enemies”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, **the head**, to mean all parts of his enemies in the act of being defeated. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will crush his enemies]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 68:21 (#2)

קָדְקֹד שֵׂעָר מִתְהַלֵּךְ

“the pate of hair of the one walking ahead”

The psalmist is leaving out the verb **crush** that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply this word from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate

translation: [crushing the pate of hair of the one walking ahead in his trespasses]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:21 (#3)

מְמַתְהַלֵּךְ בַּאֲשָׁמָיו

“the one walking ahead in his trespasses”

Here the psalmist is speaking of persisting in sin as if it were **walking ahead** in a direction of one’s own choosing. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who continues in his trespasses]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:21 (#4)

בַּאֲשָׁמָיו

“in his trespasses”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trespasses**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who continues trespassing against God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:21 (#5)

אֹיְבָיו & בַּאֲשָׁמָיו

“his enemies & in his trespasses”

The pronoun **his** in “his enemies” refers to God, while the pronoun **his** in “his trespasses” refers to the enemy. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God’s enemies … in the enemy’s trespasses]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:22 (#1)

מְמִצֻלֹת יָם

“from the depths of the sea”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the deepest part of the sea. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [from the deep sea]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:22 (#2)

מִבָּשָׁן אָשִׁיב אָשִׁיב מִמְּצֻלֹת יָם

“I will bring back from Bashan, I will bring back from the depths of the sea”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The object “them” (referring to the enemies) is implied. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will bring them back from Bashan, I will bring them back from the depths of the sea]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:22 (#3)

מִבָּשָׁן & מְמִצֻלֹת יָם

“from Bashan & from the depths of the sea”

The psalmist is referring to all places by naming two extremes, **from Bashan** (high ground) and **from the depths of the sea** (the lowest depths). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the heights … from the depths]

See: Merism

Psalms 68:23 (#1)

לְמַעַן ׀ תְּמְחַץ רַגְלְךָ בְּדָם

“so that your foot may smash in blood”

Here, **so that your foot may smash in blood** marks the purpose of the Lord’s bringing the enemies back. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order that your foot may smash in blood]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 68:23 (#2)

תְּמְחַץ רַגְלְךָ בְּדָם

“your foot may smash in blood”

Here the psalmist is speaking of total victory over enemies as if it were to **smash in blood** with one’s foot. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your foot may trample over the defeated enemies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:23 (#3)

לְשׁוֹן כְּלָבֶיךָ מֵאֹיְבִים מִנֶּהוּ

“the tongue of your dogs, its portion from the enemies”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. A verb such as “will lick” is implied. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [“the tongue of your dogs will taste its portion from the enemies”]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:23 (#4)

לְשׁוֹן כְּלָבֶיךָ

“the tongue of your dogs”

The psalmist is using one part of the dogs, their **tongue**, to mean the dogs in the act of licking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your dogs will lick]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 68:23 (#5)

רַגְלְךָ & כְּלָבֶיךָ

“your foot & your dogs”

The pronoun **your** in both “your foot” and “your dogs” refers to God’s people, Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Israel’s foot ... Israel’s dogs]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:24 (#1)

רָאוּ הֲלִיכוֹתֶיךָ אֱלֹהִים הֲלִיכוֹת אֵלִי מַלְכִּי

“They see your processions, God, the processions of my God, my king”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [They see your processions, God—the triumphal march of my God and king]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 68:24 (#2)

רָאוּ הֲלִיכוֹתֶיךָ

“They see your processions”

The pronoun **They** has an unclear referent here; it may refer to the worshipers in Israel generally. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The people see your processions]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:25 (#1)

אַחֲרַ֗ נֹגְנִים

“the ones playing stringed instruments, behind”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The verb “go” from the first clause is implied. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the ones playing stringed instruments go behind]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:25 (#2)

בְּתוֹךְ עֲלָמוֹת תֻּפֵּפוֹת

“maidens playing timbrels, in the midst”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The verb “go” from the first clause is implied. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [maidens playing timbrels go in the midst]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:26 (#1)

יְהוָה מִמְּקוֹר יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Yahweh, from the fountain of Israel”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The verb “Bless” from the first line is implied. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [bless Yahweh, you from the fountain of Israel]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:26 (#2)

מִמְּקוֹר יִשְׂרָאֵל

“from the fountain of Israel”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the origin of the people of Israel as if it were a **fountain**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning

plainly. Alternate translation: [you who come from the stock of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:26 (#3)

מִמְּקוֹר יִשְׂרָאֵל

“from the fountain of Israel”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a fountain that is characterized by being Israel’s source or origin. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Israel’s source]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:27 (#1)

צָעִיר

“the littlest”

The psalmist is using the adjective **littlest** as a noun to mean the smallest tribe. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the least significant]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 68:27 (#2)

רֹדָם

“ruling them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the tribes of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [ruling the tribes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:27 (#3)

שָׂרֵי זְבֻלוּן שָׂרֵי נַפְתָּלִי

“the princes of Zebulun, the princes of Naphtali”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [there are the princes of Zebulun, the princes of Naphtali]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 68:27 (#4)

בִּנְיָמִן & שָׂרֵי יְהוּדָה & שָׂרֵי זְבֻלוּן שָׂרֵי נַפְתָּלִי

“is} Benjamin & the princes of Judah & the princes of Zebulun, the princes of Naphtali”

Here, **Benjamin**, **the princes of Judah**, **the princes of Zebulun**, and **the princes of Naphtali** represent the leaders of those tribes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the leaders of Benjamin … the chiefs of Judah … the chiefs of Zebulun … the chiefs of Naphtali]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:28 (#1)

עֻזֶּךָ

“your strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how strong you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:28 (#2)

עוּזָּה אֱלֹהִים

“Be strong, God”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please show your strength, God]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 68:28 (#3)

זֹּו פָּעַלְתָּ לָּנוּ

“You have done this for us”

The pronoun **You** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God, you have done this for us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:28 (#4)

צַוֵּה אֱלֹהֶיךָ עֻזֶּךָ

“Your God has commanded your strength”

In both uses, the pronoun **Your** refers to Israel being addressed. It may be helpful to clarify this for your

readers. Alternate translation: [Israel's God has commanded Israel's strength]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:29 (#1)

מֵֽהֵיכָלְךָ֥ עַל־יְרוּשָׁלַ֗͏ִם לְךָ֥ יוֹבִ֫ילוּ מְלָכִ֥ים שֵׁ֑י

"Because of your temple over Jerusalem, kings will bring a gift to you"

The word translated as **Because** indicates that what follows is a reason for the result described. If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the first phrase gives the reason for the result that the second phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Kings will bring a gift to you, for your temple stands over Jerusalem]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 68:29 (#2)

מֵֽהֵיכָלְךָ֥

"Because of your temple"

Here, **your temple** represents God's presence and dwelling place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Because of your dwelling place]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:30 (#1)

גְּעַ֣ר חַ֭יַּת קָנֶ֑ה

"Rebuke the beast of the reed"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please rebuke the beast of the reed]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 68:30 (#2)

חַ֭יַּת קָנֶ֑ה

"the beast of the reed"

Here the psalmist is speaking of Egypt as if Egypt were **the beast of the reed**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the enemy from the reeds]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:30 (#3)

עֲדַ֣ת אַבִּירִ֣ים ׀ בְּעֶגְלֵ֣י עַמִּ֗ים

"the assembly of the mighty with the calves of the peoples"

Here the psalmist is speaking as if powerful rulers were **the mighty** and the peoples under them were **the calves**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the assembly of the powerful leaders with the peoples under them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:30 (#4)

עֲדַ֣ת אַבִּירִ֣ים

"the assembly of the mighty"

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the assembly that consists of mighty ones. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the assembly made up of mighty rulers]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:30 (#5)

אַבִּירִ֣ים

"the mighty"

The psalmist is using the adjective **mighty** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the mighty rulers]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 68:30 (#6)

בְּעֶגְלֵ֣י עַמִּ֗ים

"with the calves of the peoples"

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **calves** that are characterized by belonging to **the peoples**—that is, the subject nations. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the peoples' young warriors]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:30 (#7)

מִתְרַפֵּס בְּרַצֵי־כָסֶף בִּזֵּר עַמִּים קְרָבוֹת יֶחְפָּצוּ

“humbling himself with pieces of silver. He scatters the peoples {who} delight in battles”

The pronoun **himself** and **He** are ambiguous in this context; they may refer to God scattering the enemy, or to the beast humbling itself before God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the beast humbling itself with pieces of silver. God scatters the peoples who delight in battles]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:31 (#1)

כּוּשׁ תָּרִיץ יָדָיו לֵאלֹהִים

“Cush will make its hands run to God”

The psalmist is speaking of **Cush** as if it were a person who could stretch out its hands toward God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Cush will eagerly bring offerings to God]

See: Personification

Psalms 68:31 (#2)

תָּרִיץ יָדָיו לֵאלֹהִים

“will make its hands run to God”

The psalmist is using **will make its hands run to God** as a common expression of the culture to mean “will hasten to bring offerings to God.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will quickly bring tribute to God]

See: Idiom

Psalms 68:31 (#3)

יָדָיו

“its hands”

The pronoun **its** refers to Cush the nation. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [its own hands]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 68:31 (#4)

יָדָיו

“its hands”

Here, **its hands** represents the offerings and tribute that Cush’s people bring. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [its tribute]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:32 (#1)

מַמְלְכוֹת הָאָרֶץ שִׁשִּׁירוּ לֵאלֹהִים

“Kingdoms of the earth, sing to God”

The psalmist is speaking to **Kingdoms of the earth** that he knows cannot literally hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about the worship of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the kingdoms of the earth. Alternate translation: [All the kingdoms of the world should sing to God]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 68:32 (#2)

שִׁשִּׁירוּ לֵאלֹהִים זַמְּרוּ אֶדֹנָי

“sing to God! Make music {to} the Lord”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [sing praises to the Lord God]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 68:33 (#1)

לָרֹכֵב בִּשְׁמֵי־שְׁמֵי־קֶדֶם

“to the rider on the heavens, of the heavens of antiquity”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God as if he were **the rider on the heavens, of the heavens of antiquity**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to him who rules over the ancient skies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:33 (#2)

שְׁמֵי־קֶדֶם

“the heavens of antiquity”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the highest and most ancient heavens. It may be helpful

to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the highest ancient heavens]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:33 (#3)

הֵ֤ן יִתֵּ֖ן בְּקֹל֣וֹ קֹ֣ול עֹֽז

“Behold, he utters with his voice, a voice of power”

The psalmist is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen! he utters with his voice, a voice of power]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 68:33 (#4)

קֹ֣ול עֹֽז

“a voice of power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a powerful voice]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:33 (#5)

בְּקֹל֣וֹ קֹ֣ול עֹֽז

“with his voice, a voice of power”

The psalmist is repeating forms of the word **voice** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [with his great, powerful voice]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 68:34 (#1)

עֹ֑ז

“strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how strong he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:34 (#2)

גַּאֲוָתֹ֣ו

“his majesty”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **majesty**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his majestic nature]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:34 (#3)

וְעֻזֹּֽו

“and his strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and his mighty rule]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:34 (#4)

בַּשְּׁחָקִֽים

“is} in the clouds”

Here, **in the clouds** represents the heavenly realm where God displays his power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the heavens above]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:35 (#1)

נֹורָ֣א אֱלֹהִ֣ים מִמִּקְדָּשֶׁ֑יךָ

“God, {you are} fearsome from your sanctuary”

The psalmist switches to addressing Yahweh directly for this line for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the third person for consistency. Alternate translation: [God is fearsome from his sanctuary]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 68:35 (#2)

מִמִּקְדָּשֶׁ֑יךָ

“from your sanctuary”

Here, **your sanctuary** represents the place where God dwells and from which he makes his power known. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from your holy dwelling place]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 68:35 (#3)

אֵל יִשְׂרָאֵל

“The God of Israel”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form **The God of Israel** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control God. Rather the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the one whom Israel worships. Alternate translation: [You are the God whom Israel worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 68:35 (#4)

עֹז וְתַעֲצֻמוֹת

“strength and forces”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **strength** and **forces**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the power to be strong and courageous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 68:35 (#5)

עֹז וְתַעֲצֻמוֹת

“strength and forces”

The terms **strength** and **forces** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [great power and might]

See: Doublet

Psalms 68:35 (#6)

בָּרוּךְ אֱלֹהִים

“Blessed {be} God”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I bless God] or [Let me praise God]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 69 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 69 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It presents the basic elements of that type of psalm. (Some elements are repeated.) Near its end, it becomes a specific kind of psalm of supplication, an “imprecatory psalm” in which the psalmist describes the actions of wicked people and asks God to judge and punish them. Furthermore, the New Testament writers considered Psalm 69 to be a Messianic psalm that looked forward to the reign of Jesus Christ. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–3)
2. Description of troubles (4)
3. Confession of sin (5–6)
4. Claim of devotion to God (7–12)
5. Statement of trust (13)
6. Petition (14–18)
7. Description of troubles (19–21)
8. Imprecation (22–28)
9. Vow of praise (29–36)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

While New Testament writers quote this psalm in several places, we encourage translators to translate the words of the Hebrew text as they appear in the Old Testament and the words of the Greek text as they appear in the New Testament, even if, inevitably, there is some difference between the words as the ideas are expressed in different languages. We encourage translators not to try to use similar words in both places so that readers will recognize the quotations. Instead, translators can use footnotes in the New Testament to identify the source of these quotations.

Here is a list of the places where New Testament writers quote this psalm: 69:4, “The ones hating me gratuitously,” John 15:25 69:9, “zeal for your house has consumed me,” John 2:17 69:9, “the reproaches of the ones reproaching you have fallen on me,” Romans 15:3 69:21, “they made me drink vinegar for my thirst,” Matthew 27:34 and John 19:28 69:22–23, “Let their table become a snare to their faces and a trap for their welfare. Let their eyes darken from seeing, make their loins tremble continually,” Romans 11:9–10 69:25, “Let their encampment be deserted; let there not be a dweller in their tents,” Acts 1:20

Psalms 69:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some lan-

guages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 69:1 (#1)

הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“Save me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please save me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:1 (#2)

בָּ֭אוּ מַ֣יִם עַד־נָ֑פֶשׁ

“waters have come up to {my} life”

David is speaking of his danger as if it were **waters** that had **come up** and were threatening his **life**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my troubles have threatened my life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:1 (#3)

נָפֶשׁ

“my} life”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **life**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my neck]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:2 (#1)

טָבַ֣עְתִּי ׀ בִּיוֵ֣ן מְ֭מָצוֹלָה

“I have sunk in mire of depth”

David is speaking of his distress as if he had **sunk in mire of depth**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am overwhelmed by my troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:2 (#2)

מְ֭מָצוֹלָה

“depth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **depth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [deep places]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:2 (#3)

וְאֵ֣ין מָ֑עֳמָד

“and there is no standing”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and there is no place for me to stand]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 69:2 (#4)

בָּ֝בָ֗אתִי בְּמַעֲמַקֵּי־מַ֥יִם וְשִׁבֹּ֗לֶת שְׁטָפָ֥תְנִי

“I have come into depths of waters, and a flood overflows me”

David is speaking of his danger as if he had **come into depths of waters** and **a flood** were overwhelming him. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am in overwhelming danger, and my troubles overwhelm me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:3 (#1)

יָגַ֣עְתִּי בְקָרְאִ֑י

“I am weary in my calling out”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I am weary from my calling out]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 69:3 (#2)

נִחַ֖ר גְּרוֹנִ֑י

“my throat is parched”

Here, **my throat is parched** represents David being exhausted from calling out to God. If it would be

helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I am exhausted from calling out]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:3 (#3)

כָּלְל֥וּ עֵינָ֑י

“My eyes fail”

David says **My eyes fail** to represent his losing strength and hope as he watches for God to act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [My strength fails]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:4 (#1)

רַבּ֤וּ ׀ מִשַּׂעֲרוֹת֮ רֹאשִׁי֒

“are more than the hairs of my head”

David says **more than the hairs of my head** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [are too many to count]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 69:4 (#2)

שֶׁ֫שֶׁק֥ר

“of falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who tell lies]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:5 (#1)

לְאִוַּלְתִּ֑תִי וְ֝אַשְׁמוֹתַ֗י

“my foolishness, and my sins”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **foolishness** and **sins**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [foolish deeds, and my sinful deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:5 (#2)

וְ֝אַשְׁמוֹתַ֗י מִמְּךָ֥ לֹא־נִכְחָ֑דוּ

“and my sins are not hidden from you”

The expression **my sins are not hidden from you** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and you know all my sins]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 69:6 (#1)

אַל־יֵ֘בֹ֤שׁוּ בִ֨י ׀ קֹוֶ֗יךָ

“May the ones waiting for you not have shame because of me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not let the ones waiting for you feel shame because of me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:6 (#2)

יֵ֘בֹ֤שׁוּ

“May & have shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May ... feel ashamed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:6 (#3)

אַל־יִכָּ֣לְמ֑וּ & מְ֝בַקְשֶׁ֗יךָ

“May the ones seeking you not be humiliated”

The expression **not be humiliated** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May no one humiliate the ones seeking you]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 69:6 (#4)

אֱלֹהֵ֥י יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“God of Israel”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form **God of Israel** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control God. Rather the psalmist is using these words

to indicate that God is the one whom Israel worships. Alternate translation: [oh, God whom Israel worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 69:7 (#1)

כִּי־עָלֶיךָ נָשָׂאתִי חֶרְפָּה

“For because of you I have borne reproach”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because of you I have borne reproach]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 69:7 (#2)

כִּסְּתָה כְלִמָּה פָנָי

“humiliation has covered my face”

David speaks of **humiliation** as if it were a person who could **cover** his face. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am completely humiliated]

See: Personification

Psalms 69:7 (#3)

פָּנָי

“my face”

Here, **my face** represents David himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [me completely]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:7 (#4)

חֶרְפָּה

“reproach”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being insulted]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:8 (#1)

מְמוּזָר & לְאֶחָיַ וְנָכְרִי לִבְנֵי אִמִּי

“a stranger to my brothers and a foreigner to the sons of my mother”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [completely rejected by my own family]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 69:9 (#1)

כִּי־קִנְאַת בֵּיתְךָ אֲכָלָתְנִי

“For zeal for your house has consumed me”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because zeal for your house has consumed me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 69:9 (#2)

קִנְאַת בֵּיתְךָ אֲכָלָתְנִי

“zeal for your house has consumed me”

David speaks of **zeal** for God’s house as if it were a person who could **consume** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I care so deeply about your house that it takes over all my thoughts]

See: Personification

Psalms 69:9 (#3)

קִנְאַת

“zeal for”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **zeal**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [caring deeply]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:9 (#4)

וְחֶרְפּוֹת חוֹרְפֶיךָ נָפְלוּ עָלָי

“and the reproaches of the ones reproaching you have fallen on me”

David speaks of **the reproaches** of the ones reproaching God as if they were persons who could fall on someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when people insult you, they also insult me]

See: Personification

Psalms 69:10 (#1)

וָאֶבְכֶּה בַצּוֹם נַפְשִׁי וַתְּהִי לַחֲרָפוֹת לִי

“Though I wept {in} my soul with fasting, yet it became reproaches to me”

David uses the words **Though** and **yet** here to indicate a contrast between his sincere mourning and the reproach he received for it. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I wept in my soul with fasting, but it became reproaches to me]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 69:10 (#2)

בַּצּוֹם

“with fasting”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fasting**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with going without food]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:11 (#1)

וָאֶתְּנָה לְבוּשִׁי שָׂק וָאֱהִי לָהֶם לְמָשָׁל

“though I made my clothing sackcloth, yet I became a proverb to them”

David uses the words **though** and **yet** here to indicate a contrast between his act of mourning and the ridicule he received. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [although I made my clothing sackcloth, still I became a proverb to them]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 69:11 (#2)

וָאֶתְּנָה לְבוּשִׁי שָׂק

“though I made my clothing sackcloth”

Wearing **sackcloth** was a symbolic action by which David showed his grief and repentance. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [though I wore rough clothing to show my sorrow]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 69:12 (#1)

יֹשְׁבֵי שָׁעַר

“The sitters at the gate”

The phrase **The sitters at the gate** represents the leaders and judges of the city, since city leaders conducted public business at the gate of the city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The city leaders]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:13 (#1)

וַאֲנִי תְּפִלָּתִי־לְךָ

“But I, my prayer {is} to you”

David uses the words **But I** here to indicate a contrast between the behavior of those who mock him and his own response of praying to God. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Yet I, my prayer is to you]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 69:13 (#2)

תְּפִלָּתִי־לְךָ

“my prayer {is} to you”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [my prayer is offered to you]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 69:13 (#3)

תְּפִלָּתִי

“my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [praying to God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:13 (#4)

רָצוֹן

“favor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **favor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being favorable]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:13 (#5)

עֲנֵנִי

“answer me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please answer me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:13 (#6)

חַסְדֶּךָ & בֶּאֱמֶת יִשְׁעֶךָ

“your covenant faithfulness & in the truth of your salvation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness**, **truth**, and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [faithfully keeping your covenant ... true way that you are saving]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:14 (#1)

הַצִּילֵנִי מִטִּיט וְאַל־אֶטְבָּעָה אִנָּצְלָה מִמְּשַׂנְאַי וּמִמַּעֲמַקֵּי־מָיִם

“Deliver me from the mire, and let me not sink. Let me be delivered from the ones hating me and from the depths of the waters”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please deliver me from the mire, and please let me not sink. Please let me be delivered from the ones hating me and from the depths of the waters]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:14 (#2)

הַצִּילֵנִי מִטִּיט

“Deliver me from the mire”

David is speaking of his distress as if it were **mire** that he is stuck in. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Rescue me from my troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:14 (#3)

אִנָּצְלָה מִמְּשַׂנְאַי

“Let me be delivered from the ones hating me”

The expression **Let me be delivered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [Deliver me from the ones hating me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 69:14 (#4)

וּמִמַּעֲמַקֵּי־מָיִם

“and from the depths of the waters”

David is speaking of his danger as if it were **the depths of the waters** that could drown him. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and from overwhelming danger]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:15 (#1)

אַל־תִּשְׁטְפֵנִי שִׁבֹּלֶת מַיִם וְאַל־תִּבְלָעֵנִי מְצוּלָה וְאַל־תֶּאְטַר־עָלַי בְּאֵר פִּיהָ

“Let the flood of waters not overflow me, and let the deep not swallow me, and let the pit not close its mouth over me”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not let the flood of waters overflow me, and please do not let the deep swallow me, and please do not let the pit close its mouth over me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:15 (#2)

אַל־תִּשְׁטְפֵ֥נִי ׀ שִׁבְכָ֗ת מָ֫יִם

“Let the flood of waters not overflow me”

David is speaking of his troubles as if they were a **flood of waters** that could **overflow** or overwhelm him. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not let my troubles overwhelm me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:15 (#3)

וְאַל־תִּבְלָעֵ֥נִי מְצוּלָ֑ה

“and let the deep not swallow me”

David speaks of **the deep** as if it were a person who could **swallow** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and do not let me perish in the deep waters]

See: Personification

Psalms 69:15 (#4)

וְאַל־תֶּאְטַר־עָלַ֖י בְּאֵ֣ר פִּיהָ

“and let the pit not close its mouth over me”

David speaks of **the pit** as if it were a person who could **close its mouth** over him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and do not let the grave hold me]

See: Personification

Psalms 69:15 (#5)

מְצוּלָ֑ה & בְּאֵ֣ר

“the deep & the pit”

Here, **the deep** and **the pit** represent death and the grave. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use equivalent expressions or plain language. Alternate translation: [death ... the grave]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:16 (#1)

חַסְדֶּ֗ךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way you are faithfully committed to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:16 (#2)

רַ֭חֲמֶיךָ

“your compassion”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how compassionate you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:16 (#3)

פְּנֵ֣ה אֵלָ֑י

“turn to me”

The psalmist is speaking as if God were not looking at him and he asked him to **turn to** him and pay attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [pay attention to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:17 (#1)

וְאַל־תַּסְתֵּ֣תֶר פָּ֭נֶיךָ

“And may you not hide your face”

David is using **hide your face** as a common expression of the culture to mean “refuse to help” or “withdraw your presence.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And may you not turn away]

See: Idiom

Psalms 69:17 (#2)

פָּ֭נֶיךָ

“your face”

Here, **your face** represents “your presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your attention]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:17 (#3)

כִּֽי־צַר־לִ֥י

“for trouble {is} to me”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because trouble is to me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 69:17 (#4)

וְאַל־תַּסְתֵּ֣ר פָּנֶ֣יךָ מֵעַבְדֶּ֑ךָ כִּ֥י & מַהֵ֖ר עֲנֵֽנִי

“And may you not hide your face from your servant & hurry, answer me”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [And please do not hide your face from your servant … please hurry, please answer me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:18 (#1)

נַפְשִׁ֑י

“my soul”

David is using the term **my soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my life]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:18 (#2)

גְּאָלֶ֥הּ לְמַ֝עַ֗ן אֹיְבַ֥י פְּדֵֽנִי

“redeem it; because of my enemies, ransom me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [ransom me, because of my enemies]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 69:18 (#3)

קָ֭רְבָה אֶל־נַפְשִׁ֑י גְּאָלֶ֥הּ & פְּדֵֽנִי

“Draw near to my soul, redeem it & ransom me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please draw near to my soul, redeem it … please ransom me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:18 (#4)

גְּאָלֶ֥הּ & פְּדֵֽנִי

“redeem it & ransom me”

The terms **redeem** and **ransom** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [deliver it … deliver me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 69:19 (#1)

חֶרְפָּתִ֣י וּ֭בָשְׁתִּי וּכְלִמָּתִ֑י

“my reproach and my shame and my humiliation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **reproach**, **shame**, and **humiliation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [being reproached … being shamed … being humiliated]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:20 (#1)

חֶרְפָּ֥ה ׀ שָׁ֝בְרָ֗ה לִבִּ֑י

“Reproach has broken my heart”

David speaks of **Reproach** as if it were a person who could break a person’s heart. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am brokenhearted because of reproach]

See: Personification

Psalms 69:20 (#2)

לִבִּ֑י

“my heart”

Here, **my heart** represents “my emotions.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my spirit]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:20 (#3)

וָאֲקַוֶּה לָנוּד וָאַיִן

“Though I waited for sympathy, yet there was none”

David uses the word **Though** here to indicate a contrast between what he expected and what actually happened. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Even though I waited for sympathy, there was none]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 69:20 (#4)

וָאֲקַוֶּה לָנוּד וָאַיִן וְלַמְנַחֲמִים וְלֹא מָצָאתִי

“Though I waited for sympathy, yet there was none, and for comforters, yet I did not find”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I waited for someone to show compassion, yet no one came]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 69:21 (#1)

וַיִּתְּנוּ בְּבָרוּתִתִּי רֹאשׁ וְלִצְמָאִי

“But they put gall in my food, and & for my thirst”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the sympathy he hoped for and the cruelty he received. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Instead, they put gall in my food]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 69:21 (#2)

וַיִּתְּנוּ בְּבָרוּתִתִּי רֹאשׁ וְלִצְמָאִי

“But they put gall in my food, and & for my thirst”

Here, **they put gall in my food** represents the idea that David’s enemies gave him what was harmful instead of what was nourishing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [they gave me something bitter to eat]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:22 (#1)

יְהִי־שֻׁלְחָנָם לִפְנֵיהֶם לְפָח וְלִשְׁלוֹמִים לְמוֹקֵשׁ

“Let their table become a snare to their faces and a trap for their welfare”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [May their table become a snare to their faces and a trap for their welfare]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:22 (#2)

יְהִי־שֻׁלְחָנָם לִפְנֵיהֶם לְפָח וְלִשְׁלוֹמִים לְמוֹקֵשׁ

“Let their table become a snare to their faces and a trap for their welfare”

David is speaking of his enemies’ provision as if it were **a snare** and **a trap** that could catch and harm them. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let what they enjoy become something that harms them and ruins their welfare]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:22 (#3)

שֻׁלְחָנָם

“their table”

Here, **their table** represents “their provision.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [their feasting]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:22 (#4)

לִפְנֵיהֶם

“to their faces”

David is using **to their faces** as a common expression of the culture to mean "right in front of them." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [right before them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 69:22 (#5)

וְלִשְׁלוֹמִים לְמוֹקֵשׁ

"and a trap for their welfare"

David is using this possessive form to mean **a trap** that catches them when they are at ease. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [a trap that ruins their welfare]

See: Possession

Psalms 69:22 (#6)

לְפָח & לְמוֹקֵשׁ

"a snare & a trap"

The terms **a snare** and **a trap** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [a deadly trap before them]

See: Doublet

Psalms 69:23 (#1)

תֶּחְשַׁכְנָה עֵינֵיהֶם מֵרְאוֹת וּמָתְנֵיהֶם תָּמִיד הַמְעַד

"Let their eyes darken from seeing, and make their loins tremble continually"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [May their eyes darken from seeing, and may their loins tremble continually]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:23 (#2)

עֵינֵיהֶם

"their eyes"

Here, **their eyes** represents "their sight." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [their vision]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:23 (#3)

וּמָתְנֵיהֶם

"and & their loins"

Here, **their loins** represents "their strength." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [their legs]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:24 (#1)

שְׁפָךְ־עֲלֵיהֶם זַעְמֶךָ וַחֲרוֹן אַפְּךָ יַשִּׂיגֵם

"Pour your indignation on them, and let the burning of your nose overtake them"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please pour your indignation on them, and let the burning of your nose overtake them]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:24 (#2)

שְׁפָךְ־עֲלֵיהֶם זַעְמֶךָ וַחֲרוֹן אַפְּךָ יַשִּׂיגֵם

"Pour your indignation on them, and let the burning of your nose overtake them"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Pour your indignation on them; yes, let the burning of your nose overtake them]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 69:24 (#3)

שְׁפָךְ־עֲלֵיהֶם זַעְמֶךָ

"Pour your indignation on them"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **indignation**, you could express the same idea

in another way. Alternate translation: [Deal with them wrathfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:24 (#4)

וַחֲרוֹן אַפְּךָ יַשִּׂיגֵם

“and let the burning of your nose overtake them”

Here, **the burning of your nose** represents “your fierce anger.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and let your burning anger overtake them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:25 (#1)

תְּהִי־טִירָתָם נְשַׁמָּה בְּאָהֳלֵיהֶם אַל־יְהִי יֹשֵׁב

“Let their encampment be deserted; let there not be a dweller in their tents”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [May their encampment be deserted; may there not be a dweller in their tents]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:25 (#2)

תְּהִי־טִירָתָם נְשַׁמָּה בְּאָהֳלֵיהֶם אַל־יְהִי יֹשֵׁב

“Let their encampment be deserted; let there not be a dweller in their tents”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Let their encampment be completely deserted, with no one living there]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 69:25 (#3)

תְּהִי־טִירָתָם נְשַׁמָּה

“Let their encampment be deserted”

The expression **Let their encampment be deserted** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [Let God make their encampment deserted]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 69:26 (#1)

כִּי־אַתָּה אֲשֶׁר־הִכִּיתָ רָדָפוּ

“For you, whom you have struck, they have persecuted”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [This is because the ones whom you have struck, they have persecuted]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 69:26 (#2)

מַכְאוֹב חֲלָלֶיךָ

“the pain of your wounded”

David is using the possessive form to describe **pain** that is experienced by **your wounded**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [pain that your wounded ones feel]

See: Possession

Psalms 69:26 (#3)

מַכְאוֹב

“the pain of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pain**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the painful experience of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:27 (#1)

תְּנָה־עָוֹן עַל־עֲוֹנָם וְאַל־יָבֹאוּ בְּצִדְקָתֶךָ

“Add iniquity to their iniquity, and let them not come into your righteousness”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please add iniquity to their iniquity, and do not let them come into your righteousness]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:27 (#2)

תְּנָה־עָוֹן עַל־עֲוֹנָם

“Add iniquity to their iniquity”

The psalmist is using **Add iniquity to their iniquity** as a common expression of the culture to mean “Charge them with crime after crime.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Keep a record of their sins] or [Give punishment for their sins]

See: Idiom

Psalms 69:27 (#3)

בְּצִדְקָתֶךָ

“into your righteousness”

David is using the possessive form to describe **righteousness** that belongs to **you**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the righteousness that you grant]

See: Possession

Psalms 69:27 (#4)

עָוֹן & בְּצִדְקָתֶךָ

“iniquity & into your righteousness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **iniquity** and **righteousness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [acting wrongfully … what you consider right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:28 (#1)

יִמָּחוּ מִסֵּפֶר חַיִּים וְעִם צַדִּיקִים אַל־יִכָּתֵבוּ

“Let them be wiped from the book of the living, and let them not be written with the righteous”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please wipe them from the book of the living, and do not let them be written with the righteous]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:28 (#2)

יִמָּחוּ מִסֵּפֶר חַיִּים

“Let them be wiped from the book of the living”

The expression **Let them be wiped from the book of the living** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [Let God wipe them from the book of the living]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 69:28 (#3)

מִסֵּפֶר חַיִּים

“from the book of the living”

David is speaking of **the book of the living** as if it were a record that God keeps listing the names of all people who have eternal life. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the record of those who life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:28 (#4)

וְעִם צַדִּיקִים אַל־יִכָּתֵבוּ

“and let them not be written with the righteous”

The expression **let them not be written with the righteous** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [and do not write them with the righteous]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 69:28 (#5)

צַדִּיקִֽים

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 69:29 (#1)

וַֽאֲנִי֮ עָנִ֪י וְכוֹאֵ֫ב

“But I {am} poor and feeling pain”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between his enemies and himself. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Yet I, I am poor and feeling pain]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 69:29 (#2)

יְשׁוּעָתְךָ֣ אֱלֹהִ֣ים תְּשַׂגְּבֵֽנִי

“may your salvation, God, set me on high”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please let your salvation, God, set me on high]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:29 (#3)

יְשׁוּעָתְךָ֣

“your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [ability to save]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:30 (#1)

שֵׁם־אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“the name of God”

Here, **the name of God** represents who God is and his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [God himself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:30 (#2)

בְּתוֹדָֽה

“with thanksgiving”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thanksgiving**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [thankful words]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 69:31 (#1)

מִשּׁ֥וֹר פָּ֝֗ר

“than an ox, a bull”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that the ox, a bull, is to be offered to God as a sacrifice. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [than receiving the sacrifice of an ox, a bull]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 69:31 (#2)

פָּ֥ר מַקְרִ֗ן מַפְרִֽיס

“a bull having horns and having hooves”

This phrase distinguishes the full grown bulls from other younger ones. Alternate translation: [a bull that is full grown with horns and hooves]

See: Distinguishing Versus Informing or Reminding

Psalms 69:32 (#1)

דִּרְשֵׁ֣י אֱ֭לֹהִים

“seekers of God”

David is using the possessive form to describe **seekers** whose goal is **God**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You who seek God]

See: Possession

Psalms 69:32 (#2)

וִיחִ֖י לְבַבְכֶֽם

“let your heart live”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does

not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [may your heart live]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:32 (#3)

לְבַבְכֶם

“your heart”

Here, **your heart** represents your inner being where your thoughts and feelings exist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your spirit]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:32 (#4)

עֲנָוִים

“The poor”

David is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Poor people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 69:33 (#1)

כִּי־שֹׁמֵעַ אֶל־אֶבְיוֹנִים יְהוָה

“For Yahweh is hearing the needy”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is indeed hearing the needy]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 69:33 (#2)

אֶל־אֶבְיוֹנִים

“the needy”

David is using the adjective **needy** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are in need]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 69:33 (#3)

לֹא בָזָה

“he does not despise”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **despise**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [he cares for]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 69:33 (#4)

אֲאָסִירָיו

“his prisoners”

David is not using this possessive form **his prisoners** to indicate that God took these people prisoner. Rather David is using these words to indicate that people who belong to God are being held captive. Alternate translation: [the prisoners who belong to him]

See: Possession

Psalms 69:34 (#1)

יְהַלְלוּהוּ שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ יַמִּים וְכָל־רֹמֵשׂ בָּם

“Let the heavens and the earth praise him, the seas and everything moving in them”

David speaks of **the heavens and the earth** and **the seas and everything moving in them** as if they were persons who could praise God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let everything in the heavens and the earth praise him, and everything in the seas and all that moves in them]

See: Personification

Psalms 69:34 (#2)

יְהַלְלוּהוּ שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ יַמִּים וְכָל־רֹמֵשׂ בָּם

“Let the heavens and the earth praise him, the seas and everything moving in them”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Let the heavens and the earth praise him; let the seas and everything moving in them praise him]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 69:34 (#3)

יְהַלְלוּהוּ שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ

“Let the heavens and the earth praise him”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [May the heavens and the earth praise him]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 69:35 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Tall should praise him because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 69:35 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים ׀ יוֹשִׁיעַ צִיּוֹן

“God will save Zion”

Here “Zion” refers to the people in Zion. Alternate translation: [God will save the people of Zion]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 69:35 (#3)

וְיִרְשׁוּהָ

“and possess it”

The pronoun “it” refers to the land of Judah. Alternate translation: [and possess the land of Judah]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 69:36 (#1)

וְזֶרַע עֲבָדָיו

“And the seed of his servants”

David is speaking as if the people who will descend from God’s servants were actually their **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the descendants of his servants]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 69:36 (#2)

שְׁמוֹ

“his name”

Here, **his name** represents who God is and his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who he is]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 70 Introduction

Psalm 70 is a psalm of supplication or lament. Formally, it includes only two the basic elements of that type of psalm, a cry for help and a petition. But a description of troubles and a statement of trust are implicit in the background. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1)
2. Petition (2–4)
3. Repeated cry for help (5)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Similarity to Psalm 40
This words of this psalm are very similar to Psalm 40:13–17. If you have already translated Psalm 40, see what you did there. It may help you translate Psalm 70.

Psalms 70:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 70:1 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים לְהַצִּילֵנִי יְהוָה לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה

“Hurry, God, to deliver me, Yahweh, to my help”

These two phrases **Hurry, God, to deliver me** and **Yahweh, to my help** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with

a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Hurry, Yahweh God, to deliver me and help me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 70:1 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים לְהַצִּילֵנִי & חוּשָׁה

“Hurry, God, to deliver me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hurry, God, to deliver me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 70:1 (#3)

יְהוָה לְעֶזְרָתִי

“Yahweh, to my help”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, hurry to my help]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 70:1 (#4)

לְעֶזְרָתִי

“to my help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to help me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 70:2 (#1)

יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ֙ מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיִכָּלְמוּ֙ חֲפֵצֵי רָעָתִי

“Let the ones seeking my life have shame and have confusion; let the ones delighting in my harm be turned back and disgraced”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Let all who want to harm me be completely defeated and put to shame]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 70:2 (#2)

יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ֙ מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי

“Let the ones seeking my life have shame and have confusion”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **shame** and **confusion**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Let the ones trying to kill me be ashamed and be confused]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 70:2 (#3)

יֵבֹשׁוּ & מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי

“Let the ones seeking my life have shame”

By using **Let** in each of the phrases in this verse, the psalmist is expressing what he desires or prays will happen. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants to happen. Alternate translation: [I desire that the ones seeking my life have shame]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 70:2 (#4)

מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי

“the ones seeking my life”

David is using **seeking my life** as a common expression of the culture to mean “trying to kill me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones trying to kill me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 70:2 (#5)

יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיִכָּלְמוּ֙ חֲפֵצֵי רָעָתִי

“let the ones delighting in my harm be turned back and disgraced”

The expression **be turned back and disgraced** has passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If

you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [and God, please drive back and disgrace the ones delighting in my harm]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 70:2 (#6)

יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיִכָּלְמוּ חֲפֵצֵי רָעָתִי

“let the ones delighting in my harm be turned back and disgraced”

Here David is speaking of thwarting the enemies’ plans as if they were walking on a path and then could be blocked or **turned back**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let the ones delighting in my harm by thwarted in their plan and disgraced]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 70:2 (#7)

רָעָתִי

“in my harm”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **harm**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in harming me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 70:3 (#1)

יָשׁוּבוּ

“Let them turn back”

The pronoun **them** refers to the people described in the previous verse as “the ones seeking my life” and “the ones delighting in my harm.” It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Let those people turn back]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 70:3 (#2)

יָשׁוּבוּ

“Let them turn back”

Here David is speaking of stopping the enemies as if they were walking on a path and then were blocked or **turned back**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let them stop]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 70:3 (#3)

בָּשְׁתָּתָם

“their shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [their being ashamed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 70:3 (#4)

הֶאָח ׀ הֶאָח

“Aha! Aha”

David is using **Aha! Aha!** as a phrase that expresses a strong feeling: gloating and malicious delight at the misfortune of another person. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what those people were feeling. Alternate translation: [We are glad he is suffering]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 70:4 (#1)

יָשִׂישׂוּ וְיִשְׂמְחוּ ׀ בְּךָ כָּל־מְבַקְשֶׁיךָ וְיֹאמְרוּ תָמִיד יִגְדַּל אֱלֹהִים אֹהֲבֵי יְשׁוּעָתֶךָ

“Let all of the seekers of you rejoice and be glad in you, and let the lovers of your salvation say continually, “God is great”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Let all who seek you celebrate and continually praise your greatness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 70:4 (#2)

יָשִׂישׂוּ וְיִשְׂמְחוּ ׀ בְּךָ כָּל־מְבַקְשֶׁיךָ

“Let all of the seekers of you rejoice and be glad in you”

The terms **rejoice** and **be glad** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let all who seek you rejoice greatly]

See: Doublet

Psalms 70:4 (#3)

יְשׁוּעָתֶךָ

“your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way you save them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 70:4 (#4)

אֹהֲבֵי יְשׁוּעָתֶךָ

“the lovers of your salvation”

David is using this possessive form to mean those who are grateful that God saved them. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [those who are grateful for your salvation]

See: Possession

Psalms 70:4 (#5)

יִגְדַּל אֱלֹהִים

“God is great”

David is using **God is great!** as a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, praise and worship toward God. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [We praise God, for he is great]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 70:5 (#1)

וַאֲנִי ׀ עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן

“But I {am} poor and needy”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the praise of God’s people described in the previous verse and his own current desperate situation. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Yet I am poor and needy]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 70:5 (#2)

עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן

“am} poor and needy”

The terms **poor** and **needy** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [am very needy]

See: Doublet

Psalms 70:5 (#3)

אֱלֹהִים חוּשָׁה־לִּי

“God, hurry to me”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [God, please hurry to help me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 70:5 (#4)

עֶזְרִי וּמְפַלְטִי

“my help and my deliverer”

The terms **help** and **deliverer** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my sure deliverer]

See: Doublet

Psalms 70:5 (#5)

עֶזְרִי

“my help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my helper]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 70:5 (#6)

יְהוָה אַל־תְּאַחַר

“Yahweh, do not delay”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, please do not delay!]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms - Chapter 71 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 71 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It presents all of the basic elements of that type of psalm. (Some elements are repeated.) See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–4)
2. Statement of trust (5–7)
3. Petition (8–9)
4. Description of troubles (10–11)
5. Petition (12–13)
6. Statement of trust (14–17)
7. Petition (18–21)
8. Vow of praise (22–24)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Lifelong Dependence on God

The psalmist traces reliance on God from the womb (verse 6) through youth (verse 17) to old age (verses 9, 18), asking not to be abandoned as his strength fails.

God as Refuge and Rock

The psalmist calls God his rock, fortress, and refuge (verses 1–3, 7), using images of physical shelter to express trust in divine protection.

Psalms 71:1 (#1)

חָסִ֫יתִי

“I take refuge”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a safe place where David could **take refuge**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [I find safety]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 71:1 (#2)

אַל־אֵבֹ֥שָׁה לְעוֹלָֽם

“let me not ever have shame”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please never let me have shame]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:2 (#1)

בְּצִדְקָתְךָ֥

“In your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Because you act righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:2 (#2)

תַּצִּילֵ֗נִי וּ֭תְפַלְּטֵנִי

“deliver me and rescue me”

These are imperatives, but they communicate a polite request rather than a command. If the imperatives do not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please deliver me and rescue me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:2 (#3)

תַּצִּילֵ֗נִי וּ֭תְפַלְּטֵנִי

“deliver me and rescue me”

The terms **deliver** and **rescue** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [completely deliver me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 71:2 (#4)

הַטֵּה־אֵלַ֣י אָ֭זְנְךָ וְהוֹשִׁיעֵֽנִי

“incline your ear to me and save me”

These are imperatives, but they communicate a polite request rather than a command. If the imperatives do not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please incline your ear to me and save me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:2 (#5)

הַטֵּה־אֵלַי אָזְנְךָ

“incline your ear to me”

Here, **incline your ear to me** is a common expression that means “listen to me carefully.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [listen carefully to me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 71:3 (#1)

הֱיֵה לִי ׀ לְצוּר מָעוֹן לָבוֹא תָּמִיד

“Be to me a rock of abode for coming continually”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please be to me a rock of abode for coming continually]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:3 (#2)

הֱיֵה לִי ׀ לְצוּר מָעוֹן

“Be to me a rock of abode”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **rock** where David could live in safety. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Be to me like a rock where I can live safely]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 71:3 (#3)

לְצוּר מָעוֹן

“a rock of abode”

David is using this possessive form to mean “a rock upon which he could live.” It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [a safe place to dwell]

See: Possession

Psalms 71:3 (#4)

כִּי־סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי אָתָּה

“for you {are} my rock and my stronghold”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because you are my rock and my stronghold]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 71:3 (#5)

סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי

“my rock and my stronghold”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **rock** and **stronghold** that provided safety and protection. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [the one who protects me as would a rock and a stronghold]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 71:4 (#1)

פַּלְּטֵנִי מִיַּד רָשָׁע

“rescue me from the hand of the wicked”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please rescue me from the hand of the wicked]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:4 (#2)

מִיַּד רָשָׁע

“from the hand of the wicked”

Here **hand** represents power or control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of the wicked]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 71:4 (#3)

מִיַּד רָשָׁע מִכַּף מְעַוֵּל וְחוֹמֵץ

“from the hand of the wicked, from the palm of the one doing wrong and the one being cruel”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine

them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [from the hand of the wicked, yes, from the palm of the one doing wrong and the one being cruel]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:4 (#4)

רָשָׁ֑ע

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean wicked people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 71:4 (#5)

מִכַּ֥ף מְעַוֵּ֗ל

“from the palm of the one doing wrong”

Here **palm** represents power or control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the control of the one doing wrong]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 71:5 (#1)

כִּֽי־אַתָּ֣ה תִקְוָתִ֑י

“for you {are} my hope”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [because you are my hope]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 71:5 (#2)

תִקְוָתִ֑י

“are} my hope”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are the one in whom I hope]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:5 (#3)

מִבְטַחִ֥י מִנְּעוּרָֽי

“my confidence from my youth”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [you are my confidence from my youth]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 71:5 (#4)

מִבְטַחִ֥י

“my confidence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **confidence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one in whom I have been confident]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:6 (#1)

מִבֶּ֗טֶן

“from the womb”

Here, **from the womb** is a common expression that means “from birth” or “since I was born.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from my birth]

See: Idiom

Psalms 71:6 (#2)

בְּךָ֣ תְהִלָּתִ֣י תָמִ֑יד

“My praise {is} about you continually”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I praise you continually]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:7 (#1)

כְּמוֹפֵ֥ת

“like a wonder”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a wonder** causes amazement, so David causes amazement to

many people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like something that amazes people] or [like something that is shocking]

See: Simile

Psalms 71:7 (#2)

לְרַבִּ֥ים

“to many”

David is using the adjective **many** as a noun to mean many people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to a great number of people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 71:7 (#3)

וְאַתָּ֥ה מַחְסִי־עֹֽז

“but you {are} my refuge of strength”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **refuge** that is characterized by **strength**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [but you are my strong refuge]

See: Possession

Psalms 71:7 (#4)

מַחְסִי־עֹֽז

“are} my refuge of strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are my strong refuge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:8 (#1)

יִמָּלֵ֣א פִ֭י

“Let my mouth be filled {with”

The expression **Let my mouth be filled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [May you fill my mouth with]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 71:8 (#2)

יִמָּלֵ֣א פִ֭י

“Let my mouth be filled {with”

Here, **mouth** represents speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Let what I say be filled with] or [Let my speech be filled with]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 71:8 (#3)

תְּהִלָּתֶ֑ךָ

“your praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [praising you] or [words that praise you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:8 (#4)

כָּל־הַ֝יּ֗וֹם תִּפְאַרְתֶּֽךָ

“all of the day {with} your splendor”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [let all of the day be filled with your splendor]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 71:8 (#5)

תִּפְאַרְתֶּֽךָ

“with} your splendor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with how splendid you are] or [with your splendid deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:9 (#1)

אַל־תַּשְׁלִיכֵ֥נִי לְעֵ֥ת זִ֝קְנָ֗ה כִּכְל֣וֹת כֹּ֭חִי אַל־תַּעַזְבֵֽנִי

“May you not cast me away in the time of old age; may you & forsake me when my strength fails”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean

basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [May you not cast me away and forsake me when I am old and my strength fails]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:9 (#2)

אַל־תַּתַּשְׁלִיכֵנִי

“May you not cast me away”

David is speaking of God rejecting him as if God would **cast** him **away** like throwing away an unwanted object. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you not reject me] or [May you not abandon me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 71:9 (#3)

אַל־תַּעַזְבֵנִי

“may you & forsake me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not forsake me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:9 (#4)

כְּכַלּוֹת כֹּחִי

“when my strength fails”

The word **when** introduces a clause that tells the time of the event in the previous clause. Use the form in your language for introducing a simultaneous time clause. Alternate translation: [at the time that my strength fails]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

Psalms 71:9 (#5)

כְּכַלּוֹת כֹּחִי

“when my strength fails”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when I am no longer strong] or [when I become weak]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:10 (#1)

כִּי־אָמְרוּ אוֹיְבַי לִי

“For my enemies have spoken against me”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because my enemies have spoken against me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 71:10 (#2)

וְשֹׁמְרֵי נַפְשִׁי

“and the ones watching my life”

The phrase **the ones watching my life** refers to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and my enemies who are watching my life]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 71:10 (#3)

וְשֹׁמְרֵי נַפְשִׁי

“and the ones watching my life”

Here, **the ones watching my life** is a common expression that means “those who want to kill me.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and those who want to kill me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 71:11 (#1)

לֵאמֹר אֱלֹהִים עֲזָבוֹ רִדְפוּ וְתִפְשׂוּהוּ כִּי־אֵין מַצִּיל

“saying, “God has forsaken him; pursue and seize him, for there is none delivering”

You can indicate this as an indirect quote if that is more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [saying that God has forsaken him and that they should pursue and seize him because there is none delivering]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 71:11 (#2)

עֲזָבוֹ

“has forsaken him”

Here, **him** refers to David, the psalmist of this psalm. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [David]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 71:11 (#3)

כִּי־אֵ֣ין מַצִּ֑יל

“for there is none delivering”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because there is none delivering]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 71:12 (#1)

אַל־תִּרְחַ֣ק מִמֶּ֣נִּי אֱ֭לֹהַי לְעֶזְרָתִ֣י חִישָׁ֑ה

“may you not be far from me; my God, hasten to my help”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [may you not be far from me, but rather, my God, hasten to my help]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:12 (#2)

אַל־תִּרְחַ֣ק מִמֶּ֣נִּי

“may you not be far from me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not be far from me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:12 (#3)

אַל־תִּרְחַ֣ק מִמֶּ֣נִּי

“may you not be far from me”

David is speaking of God not helping him as if God were physically **far from** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not fail to help me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 71:12 (#4)

לְעֶזְרָתִ֣י חִישָׁ֑ה

“hasten to my help”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please hasten to my help]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:12 (#5)

לְעֶזְרָתִ֣י

“to my help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to meet my need]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:13 (#1)

יֵבֹ֤שׁוּ יִכָּלוּ֙ שֹׂטְנֵ֣י נַ֭פְשִׁי יַעֲטְט֣וּ חֶ֣רְפָּ֑ה וּכְלִמָּ֥ה מְ֝בַקְשֵׁ֗י רָעָתִֽי

“Let them shame and finish, the adversaries of my life; let them cover {with} reproach and disgrace, the ones seeking my harm”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Let them shame and finish the adversaries of my life; indeed, let them cover with reproach and disgrace the ones seeking my harm]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:13 (#2)

יֵבֹ֤שׁוּ יִכָּלוּ֙ שֹׂטְנֵ֣י נַ֭פְשִׁי יַעֲטְט֣וּ חֶ֣רְפָּ֑ה

“Let them shame and finish, the adversaries of my life; let them cover {with} reproach”

By using **let** in these phrases, the psalmist is expressing what he desires or prays will happen to his enemies. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I ask that they be put to shame and finished, the

adversaries of my life; I ask that they be covered with reproach]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 71:13 (#3)

יֵבֹ֣שׁוּ יִכְלוּ֣

“Let them shame and finish”

The pronoun **them** refers to the adversaries themselves. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [May the adversaries themselves be put to shame and finish]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 71:13 (#4)

יַֽעֲטוּ֤ חֶ֖רְפָּה וּכְלִמָּ֑ה

“let them cover {with} reproach and disgrace”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **reproach** and **disgrace**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [let them be reproached and disgraced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:13 (#5)

חֶ֖רְפָּה וּכְלִמָּ֑ה

“with} reproach and disgrace”

The terms **reproach** and **disgrace** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [with shameful disgrace]

See: Doublet

Psalms 71:13 (#6)

מְבַקְשֵׁ֖י רָעָתִֽי

“the ones seeking my harm”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **harm**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ones seeking to harm me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:14 (#1)

וַאֲנִ֣י & אֲיַחֵ֑ל

“But I, I will hope”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will hope** already includes this meaning. He is doing that because he is contrasting his response with the fate of his enemies. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [But as for me, I will hope]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 71:14 (#2)

תְּהִלָּתֶֽךָ

“your praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ways I praise you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:15 (#1)

פִּ֤י

“My mouth”

Here, **My mouth** represents David speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 71:15 (#2)

צִדְקָתֶ֑ךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how righteous you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:15 (#3)

כָּל־הַיּ֥וֹם

“all of the day”

David is saying **all of the day** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [continually]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 71:15 (#4)

תְּשׁוּעָתֶֽךָ

“your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how you save]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:15 (#5)

תְּשׁוּעָתֶֽךָ

“your salvation”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will recount your salvation]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 71:15 (#6)

כִּֽי לֹא יָדַ֥עְתִּי סְפִרֽוֹת

“for I do not know the numbers”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I do not know the numbers]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 71:16 (#1)

אָבֹ֗וא בִּגְבֻר֥וֹת אֲדֹנָ֑י יְהוָ֗ה

“I will come in the forces of Lord Yahweh”

David is using **I will come in the forces of Lord Yahweh** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I will act in the strength of Lord Yahweh.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will act in the strength of Lord Yahweh]

See: Idiom

Psalms 71:16 (#2)

צִדְקָתְךָ֥

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how righteous you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:17 (#1)

לִמַּדְתַּ֥נִי

“you have taught me”

The implied information may be stated clearly. “taught me many things”

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 71:18 (#1)

זִקְנָ֥ה ׀ וְשֵׂיבָ֗ה

“old age and gray hair”

The phrase **old age and gray hair** expresses a single idea. The word **gray hair** tells more about **old age**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [gray-haired old age]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 71:18 (#2)

אֱלֹהִ֗ים אַל־תַּעַזְבֵ֫נִי

“God, do not forsake me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not forsake me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:18 (#3)

עַד־אַגִּ֥יד זְרוֹעֲךָ֗ לְדֹ֫ר

“until I declare your arm to a generation”

Here, **until I declare your arm to a generation** marks the purpose for David’s request. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that I may declare your arm to a generation]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 71:18 (#4)

זְרוֹעֲךָ לְדוֹר לְכָל־יָבֹוא גְּבוּרָתֶךָ

“your arm to a generation, your might to everyone {who} will come”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [your arm to a generation, that is, your might to everyone who will come]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:18 (#5)

זְרוֹעֲךָ

“your arm”

Here, **arm** represents power or strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 71:18 (#6)

לְכָל־יָבֹוא גְּבוּרָתֶךָ

“your might to everyone {who} will come”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and I declare your might to everyone who will come]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 71:18 (#7)

גְּבוּרָתֶךָ

“your might”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **might**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how mighty you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:19 (#1)

וְצִדְקָתְךָ אֱלֹהִים עַד־מָרֹום

“For your righteousness, God, {is} to height”

David is speaking of God’s **righteousness** as if it were something that could reach up to a **height**. He means that God’s righteousness is very great. Alternate translation: [Great is For your righteousness, God is very great]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 71:19 (#2)

וְצִדְקָתְךָ

“For your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [How righteous you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:19 (#3)

מִמִּי כָמֹוךָ

“who {is} like you”

David is using the question form to emphasize that no one is like God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [there is no one like you.] or [no one is like you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 71:20 (#1)

תָּשׁוּב תחיינו וּמִתְּהֹמֹות הָאָרֶץ תָּשׁוּב תַּעֲלֵנִי

“may you return, may you revive me, and may you return, may you bring me up from the depths of the earth”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [please restore my life and bring me up from my troubles]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:20 (#2)

תָּשׁוּב תחיינו

“may you return, may you revive me”

This is a request. Alternate translation: [please return and revive me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:20 (#3)

תָּשׁוּב

“may you return”

David is using **may you return** as a common expression to mean “resume acting on my behalf.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may you act on my behalf again]

See: Idiom

Psalms 71:20 (#4)

תָּשׁוּב תְּחַיֵּנִי

“may you return, may you bring me up”

This is a request. Alternate translation: [please return and bring me up] or [please return and restore me to life]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:20 (#5)

וּמִתְּהֹמוֹת הָאָרֶץ תָּשׁוּב תַּעֲלֵנִי

“and may you return, may you bring me up from the depths of the earth”

David is speaking of extreme trouble or despair as if it were the **depths of the earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and may you return, may you restore me from the place of great trouble] or [and may you return, may you restore me from great despair]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 71:21 (#1)

תַּגְדִּיל ׀ וְתִסֹּב תְּנַחֲמֵנִי

“May you increase my greatness, and may you turn around, may you comfort me”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Please increase my greatness and comfort me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:21 (#2)

תַּגְדִּיל ׀ גְּדֻלָּתִי

“May you increase my greatness”

This is a request. Alternate translation: [Please increase my greatness]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:21 (#3)

גְּדֻלָּתִי

“my greatness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **greatness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how great I am]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:21 (#4)

וְתִסֹּב תְּנַחֲמֵנִי

“and may you turn around, may you comfort me”

This is a request. Alternate translation: [please turn around and comfort me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 71:22 (#1)

גַּם־אֲנִי ׀ אוֹדְךָ

“Also I, I will praise you”

The pronoun **I** appears twice for emphasis. David is emphasizing that he himself will praise God. Alternate translation: [I myself will praise you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 71:22 (#2)

אֲמִתְּךָ

“for} your faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:22 (#3)

אוֹדְךָ בִכְלִי־נֵבֶל אֱמִתְּךָ אֱלֹהָי אֲזַמְּרָה לְךָ בְכִנּוֹר

“I will praise you with the instrument of the lute {for} your faithfulness, my God; Let me make music to you with the harp”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [I will play music to praise you for your faithfulness, my God with stringed instruments]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:22 (#4)

קְדֹושׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Holy {One} of Israel”

David is using this possessive form to describe the holy God with whom the Israelites are in a covenant relationship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Holy God with whom we Israelites are in a covenant relationship]

See: Possession

Psalms 71:23 (#1)

שְׂפָתַי

“My lips”

Here, **lips** represents speech or singing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 71:23 (#2)

וְנַפְשִׁי אֲשֶׁר פָּדִיתָ

“and my soul, which you have redeemed”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and my soul will shout joyfully, which you have redeemed]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 71:23 (#3)

וְנַפְשִׁי

“and my soul”

David is using **soul** to represent the whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 71:24 (#1)

לְשֹׁונִי

“my tongue”

Here, **tongue** represents speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 71:24 (#2)

צִדְקָתֶךָ

“on} your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [on how righteous you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 71:24 (#3)

כָּל־הַיֹּום

“all of the day”

David is saying **all of the day** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [continually] or [very often]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 71:24 (#4)

כִּי־בֹשׁוּ כִי־חָפְרוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי רָעָתִי

“for they will shame, for they will confound the ones seeking my harm”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because those who seek my harm will be shamed and confounded]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 71:24 (#5)

בֹּשׁוּ כִי־חָפְרוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי רָעָתִי

“they will shame, for they will confound the ones seeking my harm”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [the ones seeking my harm will be thoroughly put to shame]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 71:24 (#6)

בֹּשׁוּ כִי־חָפְרוּ

“they will shame, for they will confound”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people who seek to harm David (see verse 13). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [shame and disgrace will come upon]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 72 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 72 is a royal psalm that celebrates the occasion of a new king beginning his rule. It is a prayer for God to help the new Israelite king uphold justice and help needy people as his representative on earth. It also asks God to defeat the king's foreign enemies so that he can continue to rule. This type of royal psalm is a specific kind of psalm of supplication. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Prayer that the new king will uphold justice (1–7)
2. Prayer that the new king will rule a great area (8–11)
3. Prayer that the new king will help needy people (12–14)
4. Prayer that the new king will bring blessings and be blessed (14–17)

Verses 18–20 are not part of the original psalm. They are a doxology (an expression of praise to God) that the editors of the book of Psalms added to mark the end of Book Two of the psalms. See how you translated the similar doxology in 41:13.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

"Of Solomon"

The superscription of this psalm is "Of Solomon." This may mean that Solomon wrote this psalm. But it may also mean that someone else wrote this psalm in honor of Solomon. If so, one likely possibility is that David wrote it for the coronation of his son as the next king. We recommend that you translate the superscription in a way that allows for this possibility as well as for the possibility that Solomon was the author.

Psalms 72:1 (#1)

אֱלֹהִ֗ים מִשְׁפָּטֶ֥יךָ לַמֶּ֑לֶךְ תֵּ֥ן

"God, give your judgments to the king"

The psalmist is using an imperative, but he is communicating a polite request to God rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [God, please give your judgments to the king]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 72:1 (#2)

מִשְׁפָּטֶ֥יךָ לַמֶּ֑לֶךְ תֵּ֥ן וְ֝צִדְקָתְךָ֗ לְבֶן־מֶֽלֶךְ

"give your judgments to the king and your righteousness to the son of the king"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [give your just decisions to the king, yes, give your righteousness to the king's son]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 72:1 (#3)

מִשְׁפָּטֶ֥יךָ

"your judgments"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your ability to judge rightly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:1 (#4)

וְ֝צִדְקָתְךָ֗ לְבֶן־מֶֽלֶךְ

"and your righteousness to the son of the king"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and give your righteousness to the son of the king]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 72:1 (#5)

וְ֝צִדְקָתְךָ֗

“and your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your righteous character]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:1 (#6)

לְבֶן־מֶלֶךְ

“to the son of the king”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe a social relationship. **The son of the king** refers to the king’s offspring. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the king’s son]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:2 (#1)

בְּצֶדֶק

“with righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:2 (#2)

יָדִ֣ין עַמְּךָ֣ בְצֶ֭דֶק וַעֲנִיֶּ֣יךָ בְמִשְׁפָּֽט

“May he judge your people with righteousness and your poor with justice”

The psalmist is saying what he wants God to make happen. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I want the king to judge your people with righteousness and your poor with justice]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 72:2 (#3)

וַעֲנִיֶּ֣יךָ

“and your poor”

The psalmist is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [your poor people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:2 (#4)

בְּמִשְׁפָּט

“with justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [justly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:3 (#1)

יִשְׂאוּ֤ הָרִ֨ים׀ שָׁ֘לוֹם֮ לָעָ֪ם וּ֫גְבָעוֹ֥ת בִּצְדָקָֽה

“May the mountains bring peace to the people, and the hills, in righteousness”

The psalmist is speaking of **the mountains** and **the hills** as if they were living things that could **bring peace** to the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May the land produce prosperity for the people, from the mountains to the hills, through righteousness]

See: Personification

Psalms 72:3 (#2)

שָׁלוֹם

“peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [peaceful conditions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:3 (#3)

וּגְבָעוֹת בִּצְדָקָה

“and the hills, in righteousness”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may the hills bring peace to the people, in righteousness]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 72:3 (#4)

בִּצְדָקָה

“in righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:4 (#1)

עֲנִיֵּי־עָם

“the poor of the people”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe the poor who are among the people. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those among the people who are poor]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:4 (#2)

עֲנִיֵּי

“the poor of”

The psalmist is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the poor people of]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:4 (#3)

לִבְנֵי אֶבְיוֹן

“the sons of the needy”

The psalmist is using **sons of** as a common expression of the culture to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, people have the characteristic of being needy. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people who are in need]

See: Idiom

Psalms 72:4 (#4)

אֶבְיוֹן

“the needy”

The psalmist is using the adjective **needy** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [needy people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:4 (#5)

עוֹשֵׁק

“the oppressor”

The psalmist is using the adjective **oppressor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the one who oppresses them]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:5 (#1)

יִירָאוּךָ

“May they fear you”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [May the people fear you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:5 (#2)

עִם־שֶׁמֶשׁ וְלִפְנֵי יָרֵחַ

“with the sun and to the face of the moon”

The psalmist is using the two extremes of **the sun** and **the moon** together to mean all of time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as long as the sun and moon endure]

See: Merism

Psalms 72:5 (#3)

וְלִפְנֵי יָרֵחַ

“and to the face of the moon”

Here, **the face of the moon** represents the presence and duration of the moon. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as long as the moon exists]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:5 (#4)

דֹּ֣ר דֹּרִ֑ים

“generation of generations”

The expression **generation of generations** is an idiom that means “for all successive generations,” that is, “forever.” If your readers would not understand this, you could use an equivalent idiom or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [throughout all future generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 72:6 (#1)

כִּמְטָ֣ר עַל־גֵּ֑ז

“like rain on mown grass”

The point of this comparison is that just as **rain** nourishes **mown grass** and causes it to grow again, so the king’s rule will nourish and refresh his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point of comparison explicit. Alternate translation: [like rain that falls on mown grass and refreshes it]

See: Simile

Psalms 72:6 (#2)

כִּ֝רְבִיבִ֗ים זַרְזִ֥יף אָֽרֶץ

“like showers, a drenching of the earth”

The point of this comparison is that just as **showers** drench and soak the earth, so the king’s influence will thoroughly bless his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point of comparison explicit. Alternate translation: [like showers that drench the earth]

See: Simile

Psalms 72:7 (#1)

יִפְרַ֣ח־בְּ֭יָמָיו צַדִּ֑יק

“May the righteous flourish in his days”

The psalmist is speaking of **the righteous** as if they were plants that **flourish** and grow. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May the righteous prosper in his days]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 72:7 (#2)

צַדִּ֑יק

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:7 (#3)

בְּ֝יָמָ֗יו

“in his days”

The pronoun **his** refers to the king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [in the king’s days]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:7 (#4)

בְּ֝יָמָ֗יו

“in his days”

Here, **his days** represents the time period of the king’s reign. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [during his reign]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:7 (#5)

וְרֹ֣ב שָׁ֑לוֹם

“and abundance of peace”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **abundance** and **peace**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and experience very peaceful life]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:8 (#1)

מִיָּ֣ם עַד־יָ֑ם וּ֝מִנָּהָ֗ר עַד־אַפְסֵי־אָֽרֶץ

“from sea to sea and from the River to the ends of the earth”

The psalmist is using two extremes of geography, **from sea to sea** and **from the River to the ends of the earth**, together to mean everywhere. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [over the whole earth, from sea to sea and from the River to the farthest lands]

See: Merism

Psalms 72:8 (#2)

וְיֵרְדְּ מִיָּם עַד־יָם וּמִנָּהָר עַד־אַפְסֵי־אָרֶץ

“May he rule from sea to sea and from the River to the ends of the earth”

The psalmist is saying how he wants the king to **rule**. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I want him to rule from sea to sea and from the River to the ends of the earth]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 72:8 (#3)

אַפְסֵי־אָרֶץ

“the ends of the earth”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe the farthest places on **the earth**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the farthest places on earth]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:9 (#1)

לְפָנָיו יִכְרְעוּ

“May & kneel to his face”

Here, **his face** represents his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [kneel before him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:9 (#2)

עָפָר יְלַחֵכוּ

“lick the dust”

The expression **lick the dust** is an idiom that means to be completely defeated and humiliated. If your readers would not understand this, you could use an equivalent idiom or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [be completely defeated]

See: Idiom

Psalms 72:9 (#3)

לְפָנָיו יִכְרְעוּ צִיִּים וְאֹיְבָיו עָפָר יְלַחֵכוּ

“May desert-dwellers kneel to his face, and may his enemies lick the dust”

In both instances, the pronoun **his** refers to the king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [May desert-dwellers kneel to the king’s face, and may the king’s enemies lick the dust]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:10 (#1)

מַלְכֵי תַרְשִׁישׁ וְאִיִּים מִנְחָה יָשִׁיבוּ מַלְכֵי שְׁבָא וּסְבָא אֶשְׁכָּר יַקְרִיבוּ

“May the kings of Tarshish and the coastlands return tribute; may the kings of Sheba and Seba bring near a gift”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [May kings from distant lands, from Tarshish to Sheba and Seba, bring tribute and gifts to him]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 72:10 (#2)

מַלְכֵי תַרְשִׁישׁ

“the kings of Tarshish”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe the kings who rule in **Tarshish**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the kings who rule in Tarshish]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:10 (#3)

מַלְכֵי שְׁבָא וּסְבָא

“the kings of Sheba and Seba”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe the kings who rule in **Sheba** and **Seba**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the kings who rule in Sheba and Seba]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:10 (#4)

וּסְבָא

“and Seba”

The word **Seba** is the name of a region.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 72:11 (#1)

וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ־לוֹ כָל־מְלָכִים כָּל־גּוֹיִם יַעַבְדוּהוּ

“And may all kings bow down to him; may all nations serve him”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [And may all kings and nations submit to him and serve him]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 72:11 (#2)

וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ־לוֹ כָל־מְלָכִים

“And may all kings bow down to him”

The word **And** escalates the stated desire from the specific kings mentioned in the previous verse to **all kings** and **all nations**. Use a connector in your language that communicates this escalation. Alternate translation: [Indeed, may all kings bow down to him]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 72:11 (#3)

כָּל־מְלָכִים כָּל־גּוֹיִם

“all kings & all nations”

The psalmist says **all kings** and **all nations** as a generalization to emphasize how widespread the king’s dominion will be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [kings everywhere … nations everywhere]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 72:12 (#1)

כִּי־יְ֭צִיל

“For may he deliver”

The word **For** introduces the reason why the kings and nations of the preceding verses should honor the king. Use a connector in your language that communicates that what follows is a reason. Alternate translation: [May they do this because he delivers]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 72:12 (#2)

אֶבְיוֹן

“the needy”

The psalmist is using the adjective **needy** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the needy person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:12 (#3)

וְ֝עָנִ֗י

“and the poor”

The psalmist is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the poor person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:12 (#4)

וְאֵין־עֹזֵ֥ר לֽוֹ

“when no helper {is} to him”

The pronoun **him** refers to the poor person. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [when no helper is available to that poor person]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:13 (#1)

יָ֭חֹס עַל־דַּ֣ל וְאֶבְי֑וֹן וְנַפְשׁ֖וֹת אֶבְיוֹנִ֣ים יוֹשִֽׁיעַ

“May he have pity on the weak and the needy, and may he save the lives of the needy”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [May he show compassion to weak and needy people by saving their lives]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 72:13 (#2)

דַּ֣ל וְאֶבְי֑וֹן

“the weak and the needy”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **weak** and **needy** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [weak people and needy people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 72:14 (#1)

מִתְּת֣וֹךְ וּמֵחָמָ֣ס יִגְאַ֣ל נַפְשָׁ֑ם וְיִ֖יקַר דָּמָ֣ם בְּעֵינָֽיו

“May he redeem their life from oppression and from violence, and may their blood be precious in his eyes”

In this verse, the pronoun **he** refers to the kings, **their** refers twice to the needy, and the pronoun **his** refers to the king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [May the king redeem the lives of the needy from oppression and from violence, and may the blood of the needy be precious in the king’s eyes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:14 (#2)

נַפְשָׁ֑ם

“their life”

The psalmist is using the singular **life** to refer collectively to the lives of multiple people. If your language would not use a singular noun in this way, you could use the plural form. Alternate translation: [their lives]

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 72:14 (#3)

מִתְּת֣וֹךְ וּמֵחָמָ֣ס

“from oppression and from violence”

The words **oppression** and **violence** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two words together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [from every kind of mistreatment]

See: Doublet

Psalms 72:14 (#4)

מִתְּת֣וֹךְ וּמֵחָמָ֣ס

“from oppression and from violence”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **oppression** and **violence**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [from those who oppress them and from those who harm them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:14 (#5)

דָּמָ֣ם

“their blood”

Here, **their blood** represents their lives, especially the shedding of blood through violence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their lives]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:14 (#6)

וְיִ֖יקַר דָּמָ֣ם בְּעֵינָֽיו

“and may their blood be precious in his eyes”

The expression **precious in his eyes** is an idiom that means he considers it to be very valuable. If your readers would not understand this, you could use an equivalent idiom or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and may their lives be valuable to him]

See: Idiom

Psalms 72:15 (#1)

מִזְּהַ֣ב שְׁשְׁבָ֑א

“from the gold of Sheba”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe gold that comes from **Sheba**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the gold that comes from Sheba]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:15 (#2)

וְיִתֶּן־לוֹ֨ & וְיִתְפַּלֵּ֣ל בַּעֲדֽוֹ

“And may one give to him & and may one pray for him”

The word **one** refers to people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [may people give to him ... may people pray for him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:15 (#3)

יְבָרְכֻ֣נְהוּ

“may they bless him”

The pronoun **they** refers to people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [may people bless him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:15 (#4)

וְיִתְפַּלֵּל בַּעֲדוֹ תָמִיד כָּל־הַיּוֹם יְבָרְכֻנְהוּ

“and may one pray for him continually; may they bless him all of the day”

The psalmist says **continually** and **all of the day** as generalizations to emphasize how frequently people should pray for and bless the king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [and may one pray for him continuously; may they bless him constantly]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 72:16 (#1)

פְּסַת־בַּר

“an abundance of grain”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **abundance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [abundant grain]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:16 (#2)

בְּרֹאשׁ הָהָרִים

“on the head of the mountains”

Here, **the head** of the mountains represents the tops or summits of the mountains. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on the tops of the mountains]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:16 (#3)

יִרְעַשׁ כַּלְּבָנוֹן פִּרְיוֹ

“may its fruit sway like Lebanon”

The point of this comparison is that the fruit of the grain will sway abundantly, just as the trees of **Lebanon** sway in the wind. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point of comparison explicit. Alternate translation: [may its fruit sway like the trees of Lebanon sway]

See: Simile

Psalms 72:16 (#4)

פִּרְיוֹ

“its fruit”

The pronoun **its** refers to the grain in the land. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [the grain’s fruit]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:16 (#5)

וְיָצְצִיצוּ מֵעִיר כְּעֵשֶׂב הָאָרֶץ

“and may they flourish from the city like the grass of the earth”

The point of this comparison is that just as **grass** grows abundantly on **the earth**, so the people will flourish and multiply in the cities. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point of comparison explicit. Alternate translation: [may the people of the city flourish as abundantly as does the grass of the earth]

See: Simile

Psalms 72:16 (#6)

וְיָצְצִיצוּ מֵעִיר

“and may they flourish from the city”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [may the people flourish from the city]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:17 (#1)

לִפְנֵי־שָׁמֶשׁ

“to the face of the sun”

Here, **the face of the sun** represents the presence and duration of the sun. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as long as the sun shines]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:17 (#2)

וְיִתְבָּרְכוּ בוֹ

“And may they be blessed by him”

The pronoun **they** refers to the nations, and the pronoun **him** refers to the king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [may the nations be blessed by the king]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 72:17 (#3)

וְיִתְבָּֽרְכוּ בוֹ

“And may they be blessed by him”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [may he bless them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 72:17 (#4)

וְיִתְבָּֽרְכוּ בוֹ

“And may they be blessed by him”

Here, **blessed** means to have good things done for someone. The psalmist is expressing a desire for the king to bring good things to all people. Alternate translation: [may he do good things for them]

See: Blessings

Psalms 72:17 (#5)

כָּל־גּוֹיִ֥ם

“all of the nations”

The psalmist says **all of the nations** as a generalization to emphasize how widespread the king’s fame will be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [nations everywhere]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 72:17 (#6)

יְהִ֤י שְׁמ֨וֹ לְעוֹלָ֗ם לִפְנֵי־שֶׁ֫מֶשׁ֥ ינין שְׁמ֑וֹ

“May his name be forever; may his name continue to the face of the sun”

Here, **his name** represents the king’s reputation and fame. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May his reputation last forever; may his fame continue to the face of the sun]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:18 (#1)

בָּר֣וּךְ ׀ יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“Blessed {be} Yahweh God”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I bless Yahweh] or [Let us all praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 72:18 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵ֖י יִשְׂרָאֵ֣ל

“the God of Israel”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form to indicate that the Israelites possess or control God. Rather, he is using it to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom Israel worships. Alternate translation: [who is the God whom Israel worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:18 (#3)

לְבַדּ֥וֹ

“he alone”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he alone can do]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 72:19 (#1)

וּבָר֣וּךְ ׀ שֵׁ֣ם כְּבוֹד֗וֹ לְעוֹלָ֥֫ם

“And blessed {be} the name of his glory forever”

Here, **blessed be** expresses praise to God. This is a doxology in which the psalmist declares that God’s glorious name is worthy of praise forever. If your readers would not understand this blessing formula, you could express this in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [may people praise his glorious name forever]

See: Blessings

Psalms 72:19 (#2)

שֵׁ֣ם כְּבוֹד֗וֹ

“the name of his glory”

Here, **the name** represents God’s reputation and character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his glorious reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 72:19 (#3)

שֵׁשֵׁם כְּבוֹדוֹ

“the name of his glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his glorious name]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 72:19 (#4)

וְיִמָּלֵא כְבֹודוֹ אֶת־כׇּל הָאָרֶץ

“and let all of the earth be filled {with} his glory”

The expression **be filled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and let his glory fill all of the earth]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 72:19 (#5)

אָמֵן ׀ וְאָמֵן

“Amen and amen”

The psalmist is repeating the word **Amen** for emphasis as a way of concluding Book 2 of Psalms (42–72). If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [May it certainly be so]

See: Poetry

Psalms 72:20 (#1)

בֶּן־יִשָׁי

“son of Jesse”

This possessive form describes a social relationship, for **son of Jesse** identifies David as the offspring of Jesse. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [, Jesse’s son,]

See: Possession

Psalms 72:20 (#2)

כָּלּוּ

“are finished”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [end here]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 73 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 73 is a wisdom psalm. It explains the problem of wicked people who seem to prosper. (See: wise, wisdom; and evil, wicked, wickedness, unpleasant)

Structure and Formatting

1. Affirmation that God is good to the righteous (1)
2. The psalmist recounts his experience of envy and confusion as he observes the prosperity of the wicked (2–16)
3. The psalmist goes to the sanctuary of God and understands what will happen to wicked people in the future (17–24)
4. The psalmist renews his commitment to God and to righteous living (25–26)
5. The psalmist’s final thoughts (27–28)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Evil people

Sometimes it seems that wicked people have no problems and that they live an easy and problem free life. Despite this, wicked people will eventually perish (18–19 and 27). In contrast, righteous people have the benefit of always having God’s presence with them during their life on earth (23), God guiding them during their life on earth (24a), and being with God in “glory” after they die. (See: righteous, righteousness, unrighteous, unrighteousness, upright, uprightness)

Psalms by Asaph

There are twelve psalms attributed to Asaph; the first one is Psalm 50, which is in Book Two, and the other eleven (Psalms 73–83) are at the beginning of Book Three.

Psalms 73:1 (#1)

אַךְ

“Surely”

The psalmist uses the word **Surely** to emphasize the truth of what follows. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation or use a natural form in your language for expressing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [Certainly]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 73:1 (#2)

לְיִשְׂרָאֵל

“to Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents the Israelite people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:1 (#3)

לְבָרֳרֵי לֵבָב

“to those with a pure heart”

Here the psalmist speaks of the **heart** of righteous people as **pure** and not blemished by wrong and sinful thoughts in contrast to having a **heart** that is impure because of sinful thoughts and motives and therefore morally dirty. What the psalmist means by **pure** here is that the person’s **heart** is “morally pure.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly or use an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [to the ones who think about and want what is pleasing to God] or [to those with a morally pure heart]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:1 (#4)

לְבָרֳרֵי לֵבָב

“to those with a pure heart”

In Jewish culture people considered the **heart** to be the center of a persons thoughts and feelings and here, the **heart** represents the intentions, thoughts and desires of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to those who think about and want what is pure] or [to those with a pure mind] or [to those with pure thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:2 (#1)

כְּמְעַט נטוי רַגְלָי כְּאַיִן שפכה אֲשֻׁרָי

“my feet almost slipped; my steps almost were caused to slide out {from under me”

Here, **my feet** and **my steps** represent the Psalmist himself and the phrases **slipped** and **slide out** refer to abandoning doing what pleases God and instead choosing to sin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with an equivalent expression or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I was tempted to stop obeying God. It was as if my feet almost slipped and as if my steps were almost caused to slide out from under me] or [I almost stopped trusting in God; I was almost guilty of sinning against him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:2 (#2)

כְּמְעַט נטוי רַגְלָי כְּאַיִן שפכה אֲשֻׁרָי

“my feet almost slipped; my steps almost were caused to slide out {from under me”

The phrases **my feet almost slipped** and **my steps almost were caused to slide out from under me** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [my feet almost slipped] or [my feet almost slid out from under me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 73:2 (#3)

כְּאַיִן שפכה אֲשֻׁרָי

“my steps almost were caused to slide out {from under me”

The expression **my steps almost were caused to slide out** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, the following verse implies that the Psalmist caused his own steps to almost slide out from under him when he looked at the “prosperity of the wicked” and did not also immediately go into “God’s sanctuary” so that he could “understand” the final “fate” of the wicked (see Psalm 73:17). Alternate translation: [I almost caused my steps to slide out from under me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 73:3 (#1)

כִּ֤י

“because”

Here the word **because** indicates that what follows it in this verse is the reason for what precedes it in 73:2. Use a natural form for indicating this relationship. Alternate translation: [for]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 73:3 (#2)

קִנַּ֣אתִי בְּהוֹלְלִ֑ים שְׁלֹ֖ום רְשָׁעִ֣ים אֶרְאֶֽה

“I was envious of the arrogant {when} I saw the prosperity of the wicked”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [when I saw the prosperity of the wicked, I was envious of the arrogant]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 73:3 (#3)

בְּהוֹלְלִ֑ים שְׁלֹ֖ום רְשָׁעִ֣ים אֶרְאֶֽה

“of the arrogant {when} I saw the prosperity of the wicked”

The Psalmist is using the adjectives **arrogant** and **wicked** as nouns in order to describe certain people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [of arrogant people when I saw the prosperity of wicked people] or [of the people who are arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the people who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 73:3 (#4)

שְׁלֹ֖ום רְשָׁעִ֣ים אֶרְאֶֽה

“when} I saw the prosperity of the wicked”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prosperity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when I saw how prosperous the wicked were]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:4 (#1)

חַרְצֻבּ֥וֹת

“ropes”

The word the ULT translates as **ropes** refers to ropes or bonds that constrain a person. Here the psalmist is speaking of struggles or pains as if they were **ropes** or “bonds.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with an equivalent expression, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [struggles] or [emotional pains] or [pains]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:4 (#2)

לְמוֹתָ֗ם

“until their death”

The word the ULT translates as **until their death** could refer to: (1) the time before the death of wicked people in which case you can use the ULT as a model, or (2) the time at which wicked people die. Alternate translation: [in their death] or [at their death]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:5 (#1)

בַּעֲמַ֣ל אֱנ֣וֹשׁ אֵינֵ֑מוֹ

“They {are} free from the trouble of man”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trouble**, you could express the same idea with a verb or in some other way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [They do not have to experience difficult things like the rest of man] or [They do not suffer the way other men do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:5 (#2)

אֱנ֣וֹשׁ & וְעִם־אָ֭דָם לֹ֣א יְנֻגָּֽעוּ

“man, and with {the rest of} man they are not afflicted”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people, and with people they are not afflicted] or [other people, and they are not afflicted like everyone else]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 73:5 (#3)

וְעִם־אָדָ֥ם לֹ֗א יְנֻגָּֽעוּ

“and with {the rest of} man they are not afflicted”

The expression **they are not afflicted** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, the context implies that God did it. Alternate translation: [and God does not afflict them like he does the rest of man] or [and God does not afflict them like he does everyone else]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 73:6 (#1)

לָ֭כֵן

“Therefore”

Here, the word **Therefore** introduces the result of 73:4–5. You can use a natural word or phrase in your language to express this relationship. Alternate translation: [As a result]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 73:6 (#2)

עֲנָקָ֣תְמוֹ גַאֲוָ֑ה

“pride is a necklace for them”

The psalmist is speaking of **pride** as if it were a **necklace** that wicked people wear around their neck. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparison, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they wear pride like a necklace] or [pride is like a necklace which they flaunt]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:6 (#3)

עֲנָקָ֣תְמוֹ גַאֲוָ֑ה

“pride is a necklace for them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pride**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they act pridefully for all to see, like someone who wears a necklace that they want everyone to see] or [they unashamedly act proud in front of everyone, like a person wearing a necklace that they want everyone to see]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:6 (#4)

עֲנָקָ֣תְמוֹ

“a necklace for them”

A **necklace** is a type of jewelry worn around the neck in order to adorn the body and make a person look more attractive. If your readers would not be familiar with necklaces, you could use the name of something similar that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternately, if you are using footnotes, you could make a footnote explaining what a **necklace** is. Alternate translation: [a neck ornament for them]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 73:6 (#5)

יַעֲטָ֣ף־שִׁ֭שִׁית חָמָ֣ס יָלְמוֹ

“a garment of violence covers them”

The psalmist is speaking of **violence** as it were a **garment** that people wear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with a comparable expression, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [violence covers them like a garment] or [violence covers them like clothing]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:6 (#6)

יַעֲטָ֣ף־שִׁ֭שִׁית חָמָ֣ס יָלְמוֹ

“a garment of violence covers them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they are proud of their violent actions and display them openly, as a person who wears a garment for all to see]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:7 (#1)

עָ֭עְבְרוּ מַשְׂכִּיּ֣וֹת לֵ֑בָב

“the imaginations of {their} heart overflow”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **imaginations**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they are constantly imagining evil things in their hearts] or [they are constantly thinking about evil things in their hearts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:7 (#2)

עָֽבְרוּ֙ מַשְׂכִּיּ֣וֹת לֵ֔ב

“the imaginations of {their} heart overflow”

Here the psalmist speaks of the **heart** of a wicked person as if it were a container that could overflow with evil **imaginations** (thoughts). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express the meaning using an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [their heart is constantly thinking of evil things to do] or [their heart is constantly imagining evil thoughts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:7 (#3)

עָֽבְרוּ֙ מַשְׂכִּיּ֣וֹת לֵ֔ב

“the imaginations of {their} heart overflow”

The psalmist is describing the mind of wicked people by association with their **heart**, which is where a person’s thoughts and intentions were viewed as coming from in Jewish culture. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [they constantly think of evil things to do] or [the imaginations of their inner being overflow]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:8 (#1)

וִֽידַבְּר֥וּ בְרָ֑ע עֹ֝שֶׁק

“and speak with evil of oppression”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the ideas of **evil** and **oppression**, you could express the same ideas in some other way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and wickedly speak about oppressing people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:8 (#2)

מִמָּר֣וֹם יְדַבֵּ֑רוּ

“they speak from an elevated place”

The phrase **they speak from an elevated place** means “they speak arrogantly.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [they speak arrogantly]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:9 (#1)

שַׁ֭תּוּ בַּשָּׁמַ֣יִם פִּיהֶ֑ם וּ֝לְשׁוֹנָ֗ם תִּֽהֲלַ֥ךְ בָּאָֽרֶץ

“They set their mouth in the heavens, and their tongue goes through the earth”

Here, **mouth** and **tongue** represents “speech.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [They talk as if they are God who is in the heavens, and their speech goes through the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:9 (#2)

שַׁ֭תּוּ בַּשָּׁמַ֣יִם פִּיהֶ֑ם

“They set their mouth in the heavens”

The word translated as **in the heavens** could be translated as: (1) **in the heavens** as modeled by the ULT in which case the psalmist is describing the role or authority of God by association with the **heavens**, Alternate translation: [They talk with their mouth as if they are God who is in heaven] or [They talk as if they are in the position of God] or (2) “against the heavens” in which case the psalmist is describing God by association with the **heavens**. Alternate translation: [They set their mouth against the heavens] or [They set their mouth against God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:9 (#3)

וּ֝לְשׁוֹנָ֗ם תִּֽהֲלַ֥ךְ בָּאָֽרֶץ

“and their tongue goes through the earth”

The psalmist is speaking of the **tongue** (words or speech) of wicked people as if it could go **through the earth**. What he means is that these wicked people go about talking wickedly (and bragging) as they live their daily lives on earth and proudly act as if they are not accountable to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they constantly talk wickedly as if they rule the earth] or [and they walk about talking wickedly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:10 (#1)

לָכֵ֤ן

“Therefore”

The term translated as **Therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connec-

tor in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [This is why]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 73:10 (#2)

יָשִׁיב עַמּוֹ הֵלֹם

“his people turn here”

This could mean: (1) “God’s people love the wicked people” or (2) “the wicked people return to this place”

Psalms 73:10 (#3)

וּמֵ֣י מָ֭לֵא יִמָּצוּ לָמוֹ

“and waters of a full {cup} are drained by them”

The expression **are drained** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, the context implies that people did it. Alternate translation: [and they drain the waters of a full cup]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 73:10 (#4)

וּמֵ֣י מָ֭לֵא יִמָּצוּ לָמוֹ

“and waters of a full {cup} are drained by them”

The psalmist is speaking of listening to words as if they were drinking **water** out of a cup. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with a simile or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and believe all that they say]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:10 (#5)

וּמֵ֣י מָ֭לֵא יִמָּצוּ לָמוֹ

“and waters of a full {cup} are drained by them”

This could mean: (1) “God’s people listen gladly to the words of the wicked people” or (2) “the wicked people have plenty of food to eat and wine to drink”

Psalms 73:11 (#1)

אֵיכָ֣ה יָ֭דַע־אֵ֑ל וְיֵ֥שׁ דֵּ֝עָ֗ה בָּעֶלְיֽוֹן

“How does God know? And is there knowledge in the Most High”

The phrases **How does God know** and **is there knowledge in the Most High** mean basically the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases into one. Alternate translation: [How could God know?] or [Does God have knowledge?]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 73:11 (#2)

וְאָמְרוּ

“And they say”

Here the word **they** could refer to: (1) wicked people. Alternate translation: [And those who are wicked say] or [And the wicked say] or (2) people who are righteous and obey God. Alternate translation: [And righteous people say] or [And godly people say]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:11 (#3)

אֵיכָ֣ה יָ֭דַע־אֵ֑ל וְיֵ֥שׁ דֵּ֝עָ֗ה בָּעֶלְיֽוֹן

“How does God know? And is there knowledge in the Most High”

Here wicked people are not asking for information but are using the question form to express that they do not think God knows or cares about the evil things they do. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate these questions as statements or exclamations and communicate the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Surely God does not know what we are doing! Surely the Most High has no knowledge of it!] or [Surely God does not care about we are doing! Surely what we are doing does not matter to the Most High!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 73:11 (#4)

אֵיכָ֣ה יָ֭דַע־אֵ֑ל וְיֵ֥שׁ דֵּ֝עָ֗ה בָּעֶלְיֽוֹן

“How does God know? And is there knowledge in the Most High”

This portion of this verse is a quotation of what the wicked people said or thought to themselves. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 73:12 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The psalmist is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [See]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:12 (#2)

רְשָׁעִים

“wicked”

The Psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun in order to describe a group of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. See how you translated the phrase **the wicked** in 73:3. Alternate translation: [wicked ones]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 73:12 (#3)

וְשַׁלְוֵי עֹלָם

“they are always at ease”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **ease**, you could express the same idea in some other way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they are always comfortable] or [they are always carefree]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:12 (#4)

הִשְׁגּוּ־חָיִל

“they increase in wealth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wealth**, you could express the same idea in some other way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they become increasingly wealthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:13 (#1)

אַךְ

“Surely”

Here the psalmist uses the word **Surely** to emphasize his strong thoughts and feelings about the certainty of what he states in this verse. Use a natural form in your language for expressing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [Certainly]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 73:13 (#2)

זִכִּֽיתִי לְבָבִי

“I have kept my heart clean”

The psalmist is describing his thoughts and intentions by association with his **heart**, which Jews viewed as the center of a person’s thoughts and intentions. The expression **I have kept my heart clean** means he has intentionally kept his thoughts and intentions morally pure (free from sin). You may have an equivalent expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have kept my thoughts pure]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:13 (#3)

וָאֶרְחַ֖ץ בְּנִקָּיּ֣וֹן כַּפָּֽי

“and washed my hands in innocence”

The psalmist is describing his actions by association with his **hands**, which he would use to do the actions. The psalmist is using the symbolic action of hand washing to declare his **innocence**. In that culture hand washing was a common practice that people did to publicly assert that they were innocent. (See Deuteronomy 21:6 and Matthew 27:24.) Here the psalmist is saying that he has **washed** his **hands in innocence** as a way to declare that he is guiltless. See how you translated the similar phrase in Psalm 26:6. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and kept my actions pure to show that I am innocent] or [and kept my actions free from sin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:14 (#1)

וְאֶֽהְיֶ֣ה נָ֭גוּעַ כָּל־הַיּ֑וֹם וְ֝תוֹכַחְתִּ֗תִי לַבְּקָרִֽים

“For I have been stricken all of the day and punished every morning”

The expression **I have been stricken ... and punished** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [For you have stricken me all of the day and punished me every morning] or [For you have

afflicted me all of the day and punished me every morning]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 73:14 (#2)

כָּל־הַיּוֹם

“all of the day”

The phrase **all of the day** is a common expression meaning “every day” or “constantly.” If this phrase does not have this meaning in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [constantly]

See: Idiom

Psalms 73:15 (#1)

אִם־אָמַרְתִּי אֲסַפְּרָה כְמוֹ֥ הִנֵּ֗ה דּ֫וֹר בָּנֶ֥יךָ בָּגָ֑דְתִּי

“If I had said, “I will recount such things,” behold, I would have betrayed the generation of your children”

The psalmist is describing a hypothetical situation in order to tell his readers what would have happened if he had said the things he was thinking out loud. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a situation that could happen. Alternate translation: [If I had said, ‘I will recount such things,’ then I would have betrayed the generation of your children.]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 73:15 (#2)

הִנֵּ֗ה

“behold”

The psalmist is using the term **behold** to emphasize what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [certainly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:15 (#3)

בָּנֶ֥יךָ

“your children”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s people, his spiritual children, as if they were his biological **children**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your followers] or [the people who obey you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:16 (#1)

בְּעֵינָי

“in my eyes”

Here the author’s **eyes** represent his evaluation or estimation as he tried to understand why wicked people seemed to prosper and he suffered. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to me] or [to think about]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:17 (#1)

מִקְדְּשֵׁי־אֵ֑ל

“the sanctuaries of God”

Here the plural word **sanctuaries** could: (1) refer to the Jerusalem temple, in which case the plural is intensifying the meaning. Alternate translation: [the great sanctuary of God] or [the great temple of God] (2) refer to the precincts of the Jerusalem temple. Alternate translation: [the precincts of the temple of God] or [the precincts of God’s temple]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Psalms 73:17 (#2)

אָ֭בִינָה לְאַחֲרִיתָ֗ם

“then} I discerned their end”

Alternate translation: [then I understood their fate] or [then I understood what will happen to those who are wicked]

Psalms 73:18 (#1)

אַ֭ךְ

“Surely”

See how you translated the word **Surely** in 73:1 where it is used with the same meaning.

See: Exclamations

Psalms 73:18 (#2)

בַּחֲלָקוֹת֮ תָּשִׁ֪ית לָ֫מוֹ

“you set them in slippery places”

The psalmist is speaking of the fact that God does not allow wicked people to have a secure future as if God had **set them in slippery places**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression, or you could state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [you do not give them a good future]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:18 (#3)

אַ֭ךְ בַּחֲלָקוֹת תְּשִׁיתֵ֣ם לָ֑מוֹ

“Surely you set them in slippery places”

Here the word **you** refers to God and the word **them** refers to wicked people. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [Surely you, God, set wicked people in slippery places]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:18 (#4)

הִ֝פַּלְתָּ֗ם לְמַשּׁוּאוֹת

“you make them fall to destruction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you cause them to be destroyed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:19 (#1)

אֵ֣יךְ

“How”

The psalmist is using the term **How** to focus attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation.

See: Exclamations

Psalms 73:19 (#2)

הָי֥וּ

“they are {brought”

The expression **they are brought** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use the passive form in this way, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, the context implies that “God” does it. Alternate translation: [God brings them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 73:19 (#3)

הָי֥וּ לְשַׁמָּ֗ה כְּרָ֫גַ֥ע

“they are {brought} to desolation as in a moment”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desolation**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God will destroy them as in a moment] or [they will be suddenly destroyed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:19 (#4)

כְּרָ֫גַ֥ע

“as in a moment”

The phrase **as in a moment** means “suddenly” or “all at once.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [all at once]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:19 (#5)

סָ֭פּוּ תַּ֣מּוּ

“They come to an end, they perish”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The psalmist is using the phrases **They come to an end** and **they perish** together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [They come to an end] or [They perish]

See: Doublet

Psalms 73:19 (#6)

סָ֭פּוּ תַּ֣מּוּ מִן־בַּלָּהֽוֹת

“They come to an end, they perish by terrors”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **terrors**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:20 (#1)

כַּחֲל֣וֹם מֵהָקִ֣יץ אֲדֹנָ֑י בָּ֝עִ֗יר ׀ צַלְמָ֥ם תִּבְזֶֽה

“Like a dream after {one} awakes, Lord, when you rouse {yourself}, you will despise their image”

The psalmist is comparing the short and temporary duration of a **dream**, which is over after a person **awakes**, to the fact that God will **despise** wicked people when he rouses himself to action and judges them. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the basis of this comparison or express

this meaning in plain language. Alternate translation: [They will disappear as quickly as a dream disappears when a person awakes in the morning; Lord, when you act, you will cause them to disappear]

See: Simile

Psalms 73:20 (#2)

צַלְמָם

“their image”

Alternate translation: [their form]

Psalms 73:21 (#1)

כִּֽי־יִתְחַמֵּ֣ץ לְבָבִ֣י וְ֭כִלְיוֹתַ֣י אֶשְׁתּוֹנָֽן

“When my heart was embittered, and I was pierced in my kidneys”

The phrases **When my heart was embittered** and **I was pierced in my kidneys** mean basically the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [When my heart was embittered, yes, when I was pierced in my kidneys]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 73:21 (#2)

יִתְחַמֵּ֣ץ לְבָבִ֣י

“my heart was embittered”

The psalmist is describing his inner being and thoughts by association with his **heart**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I was embittered] or [I was embittered within]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:21 (#3)

וְ֭כִלְיוֹתַ֣י אֶשְׁתּוֹנָֽן

“and I was pierced in my kidneys”

The psalmist is describing his feelings by association with his **kidneys**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language as modeled by the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:22 (#1)

וְלֹ֣א אֵדָ֑ע

“and I was not knowing”

The phrase **I was not knowing** means “I was without knowledge” or “I was ignorant.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I was without knowledge] or [and I was ignorant]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:22 (#2)

בְּ֝הֵמ֗וֹת הָיִ֥יתִי עִמָּֽךְ

“I was an animal with you”

The psalmist is speaking of his prior **stupid** and ignorant thinking and action toward God as if he had been behaving like an **animal**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with a comparison, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I acted like an animal toward you] or [I acted and thought like an animal before you] or [I acted like a fool toward you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:22 (#3)

עִמָּֽךְ

“with you”

Here the word **you** refers to God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [with you, God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:23 (#1)

אָ֭אֲחַזְתָּ בְּיַד־יְמִינִֽי

“you hold {me} by my right hand”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s continual presence with him as if God were continually holding his **right hand**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with a comparison, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are constantly with me] or [you are constantly with me. It is as if you are holding me by my right hand]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:24 (#1)

בַּעֲצָתְךָ תַנְחֵנִי

“You guide me with your counsel”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **counsel**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [You guide me by teaching me instructive things] or [You guide me by teaching me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:24 (#2)

וְאַחַר כָּבוֹד תִּקָּחֵנִי

“and afterward you will take me {to} glory”

Here the term **glory** could refer to: (1) God’s presence in this life or after death. Alternate translation: [and afterward you will take me into your glorious presence] or [and after I die you will take me into your presence] (2) the glory or honor that God would give the psalmist in this life or after death because he had remained faithful and lived a righteous life. Alternate translation: [and afterward you will receive me with honor] or [and when I die you will receive me with honor] or [and at the end of my life you will receive me and honor me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:24 (#3)

וְאַחַר כָּבוֹד תִּקָּחֵנִי

“and afterward you will take me {to} glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and afterward you will take me into your glorious presence] or [and afterward you will honor me when you receive me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:25 (#1)

מִי־לִי בַשָּׁמָיִם

“Whom have I in heaven {but you”

Here psalmist is implying the words “but you?” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly as modeled by the ULT. Alternate translation: [Whom have I in heaven but you?]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 73:25 (#2)

מִי־לִי בַשָּׁמָיִם

“Whom have I in heaven {but you”

The psalmist is not asking for information but is using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate these words as a statement or an exclamation and communicate the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [There is no one I have in heaven but you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 73:25 (#3)

וְעִמְּךָ לֹא־חָפַצְתִּי בָאָרֶץ

“And besides you {there is} nothing on the earth I desire”

Alternate translation: [And with you I desire nothing on the earth]

Psalms 73:26 (#1)

כָּלָה שְׁאֵרִי וּלְבָבִי

“My flesh and my heart fail”

The psalmist is referring to his entire body as if it were his **flesh**, and he is referring to his mind and/or spirit as if they were his **heart**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly or use an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [I may become physically and emotionally weak] or [My body and my mind may fail] or [My body and my spirit may fail]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 73:26 (#2)

כָּלָה שְׁאֵרִי וּלְבָבִי צוּר־לְבָבִי וְחֶלְקִי אֱלֹהִים לְעוֹלָם

“My flesh and my heart fail, {but} God {is} the rock of my heart and my portion forever”

Alternate translation: [My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart forever]

Psalms 73:26 (#3)

צוּר־לְבָבִי וְחֶלְקִי אֱלֹהִים לְעוֹלָם

“but} God {is} the rock of my heart and my portion forever”

The psalmist is speaking of **God** as if he were a **rock**. The term **rock** is associated with strength so by calling God **the rock of my heart**, he means that God

is the strength of his heart. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with a comparison, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but God, you are like a rock for my heart, and you are my portion forever] or [but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:27 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“behold”

The psalmist is using the term **behold** to bring attention to and emphasize the certainty of what he is about to say. Use a word or phrase that would communicate that meaning in your language. Alternate translation: [indeed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:27 (#2)

הִצְמַתָּה כָּל־זוֹנֶה מִמֶּךָּ

“you destroy every one being unfaithful to you”

Alternate translation: [you will destroy everyone who is unfaithful to you]

Psalms 73:28 (#1)

וַאֲנִי ׀ קָרְבַת אֱלֹהִים לִי־טוֹב

“But {for} me, the closeness of God for me {is} good”

Alternate translation: [But for me, God’s companionship is my greatest good] or [But for me, God’s presence is my good]

Psalms 73:28 (#2)

קָרְבַת אֱלֹהִים לִי־טוֹב

“the closeness of God for me {is} good”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **closeness**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [being close to God is good for me] or [being near to God is good for me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:28 (#3)

שַׁתִּתִי ׀ בַּאדֹנָי יְהוִה מַחְסִי

“I have made the Lord, Yahweh, my refuge”

The psalmist speaks of **Yahweh** as if he were a physical place that a person could go to for **refuge**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning with a comparison, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Like a person runs to a shelter to keep them safe when they are in danger, so I have chosen to trust you to keep me safe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 73:28 (#4)

שַׁתִּתִי ׀ בַּאדֹנָי יְהוִה מַחְסִי

“I have made the Lord, Yahweh, my refuge”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **refuge**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I trust the Lord, Yahweh, to protect me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 73:28 (#5)

לְסַפֵּר כָּל־מַלְאֲכוֹתֶיךָ

“in order to recount all your works”

The phrase **in order to** marks **recount all your works** as the goal or purpose for which the psalmist **made the Lord, Yahweh** his **refuge**. Use a natural way in your language for indicating that this is the goal or purpose.

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 73:28 (#6)

לְסַפֵּר כָּל־מַלְאֲכוֹתֶיךָ

“in order to recount all your works”

Alternate translation: [that I might make known to people all your works] or [that I may declare all your deeds]

Psalms - Chapter 74 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 74 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm except a vow of praise. (There is only the hint of a vow of praise in verse 21b.) See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–3)
2. Description of troubles (4–9)
3. Cry for help (10–11)

4. Statement of trust (12–17)
5. Petition (18–23)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a "maskil." See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

Translation Issues in this Psalm

Imperatives
Throughout this psalm, the psalmist is requesting things from Yahweh by using an imperative form which may sound like a command in your language. If this would be impolite in your language, then use a form that would be more appropriate for addressing Yahweh with a request.

Parallelisms
Parallelisms arise when two phrases occur together which mean the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea using different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one and not saying something additional. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing.

Psalms 74:1 (#1)

מַשְׂכִּיל

"A maskil"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 74:1 (#2)

לָמָּה אֱלֹהִים זָנַחְתָּ לָנֶצַח יֶעְשַׁן אַפְּךָ בְּצֹאן מַרְעִיתֶךָ

"Why, God, have you rejected {us} forever? {Why} does your nose smoke against the flock of your pasture"

Asaph is using the question form to express his anguish at God's anger toward his people. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [God, you have rejected us forever! Your nose should not smoke against the flock of your pasture.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 74:1 (#3)

יֶעְשַׁן אַפְּךָ

"Why} does your nose smoke"

Asaph is using **does your nose smoke** as a common expression of the culture to mean that God is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why are you angry]

See: Idiom

Psalms 74:1 (#4)

בְּצֹאן מַרְעִיתֶךָ

"against the flock of your pasture"

Here Asaph is speaking of God's people as if they were **the flock** of a shepherd, and of God as if he were a shepherd who cares for them in **your pasture**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [against the people you care for]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:1 (#5)

בְּצֹאן מַרְעִיתֶךָ

"against the flock of your pasture"

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe a **flock** that is associated with a **pasture**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express the idea in another way. Alternate translation: [against the flock that you pasture]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:2 (#1)

זְכֹר עֲדָתְךָ

"Remember your congregation"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. See the Introduction to this Psalm for more information on how to translate the imperative here and throughout this Psalm. Alternate translation: [Please remember your congregation]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 74:2 (#2)

שֵׁ֣בֶט נַחֲלָ֣תֶךָ

“the tribe of your inheritance”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean that the tribe itself is what God inherited. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the tribe that is your inheritance]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:2 (#3)

שֵׁ֣בֶט נַחֲלָ֣תֶךָ

“the tribe of your inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the tribe that you inherited] or [the people whom you have made your own]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 74:2 (#4)

הַר־צִיּ֥וֹן זֶ֗ה ׀ שָׁכַ֥נְתָּ בּֽוֹ

“this Mount Zion on which you have dwelt”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that a sentence in many languages would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if this would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [remember this Mount Zion on which you have dwelt]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 74:3 (#1)

הָרִ֣ימָה פְּ֭עָמֶיךָ

“Lift up your feet”

The psalmist speaks of God as if he were a person with **feet** which he could **Lift up** and come and see the ruined temple in Jerusalem. The phrase **Lift up your feet** is probably also indicating that the psalmist wants God to not only take notice but also to take notice quickly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Come and see the perpetual ruins] or [Please do not delay any longer. Please pay attention to these perpetual ruins]

See: Personification

Psalms 74:3 (#2)

בַּקֹּ֑דֶשׁ

“in the holy place”

Here and other places in this psalm, **the holy place** refers to the Temple in Jerusalem that had been destroyed. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly as modeled by the UST.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 74:4 (#1)

שָׁ֭אֲגוּ צֹרְרֶ֣יךָ

“Your adversaries roared”

Here Asaph is speaking of the **adversaries** as if they were wild animals that **roared**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your adversaries shouted loudly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:4 (#2)

שָׂ֣מוּ אוֹתֹתָ֑ם אֹתֹֽות

“they set up their signs {as} signs”

Setting up **signs** was a symbolic action by which the conquerors signified their victory over those conquered. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. The phrase **they have set up their signs as signs** could mean: (1) that God’s adversaries had set up their military banners as signs in the Temple. Alternate translation: [they have set up their banners as signs] or [they have set up their banners as a sign of their conquest] or (2) that God’s adversaries had set up items of worship and symbols related to their false religion. Alternate translation: [they have set up symbols and items for their pagan worship] or [they have set up idolatrous symbols and items of false worship]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 74:5 (#1)

יִוָּדַ֑ע

“It was known”

The expression **It was known** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [They appeared]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 74:5 (#2)

כְּמֵבִיא לְמָעְלָה בְּסָבָךְ־עֵץ קַרְדֻּמוֹת

“like one bringing upward axes in a thicket of trees”

The point of this comparison is that just as a woodsman swings **axes** to cut down trees **in a thicket**, so the enemies swung their weapons to destroy the carvings of the temple. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a woodsman chopping down trees in a forest]

See: Simile

Psalms 74:6 (#1)

ועת

“And now”

Here the words **And now** mark a shift from describing what the enemies did in the past to what they are doing in the present. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Now]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 74:6 (#2)

פִּתּוּחֶיהָ

“its carvings”

The pronoun **its** refers to the holy place. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the carvings of the holy place]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 74:7 (#1)

שִׁלְחוּ בָאֵשׁ מִקְדָּשֶׁךָ לָאָרֶץ חִלְּלוּ מִשְׁכַּן־שְׁמֶךָ

“They sent your holy place into fire; they profaned the dwelling of your name to the ground”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. For more information on translating parallelisms, see the Introduction to this Psalm. Alternate translation: [They completely burned down and desecrated the place where you dwell]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 74:7 (#2)

שִׁלְחוּ

“They sent”

The pronoun **They** refers to the enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The enemies sent]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 74:7 (#3)

מִשְׁכַּן־שְׁמֶךָ

“the dwelling of your name”

Asaph is using the term **name** to represent God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the place called by your name by bringing it] or [the dwelling where you are present by bringing it]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 74:7 (#4)

מִשְׁכַּן־שְׁמֶךָ

“the dwelling of your name”

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe a **dwelling** that is characterized by God’s **name**, that is, by his presence. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express the idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the dwelling place dedicated to you by burning it]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:8 (#1)

אָמְרוּ בְלִבָּם

“They said in their heart”

The phrase **They said in their heart** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [They thought to themselves]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 74:8 (#2)

אָמְרוּ בְלִבָּם

“They said in their heart”

Both occurrences of the pronoun **They** refer to the enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The enemies said in their heart]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 74:8 (#3)

בְּלִבָּם

“in their heart”

Asaph is using **in their heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean that the enemies thought this to themselves. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [within themselves]

See: Idiom

Psalms 74:8 (#4)

מוֹעֲדֵי־אֵל

“the meeting places of God”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean the places that are dedicated to **God** for worship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the places where people gather to worship God]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:9 (#1)

אוֹתֹתֵינוּ לֹא רָאִינוּ

“We do not see our signs”

Here the phrase **our signs** could refer to: (1) signs that God’s prophets gave. Alternate translation: [We do not see any prophetic signs for us] or [We do not see any signs given to us from a prophet] or (2) the military banners and symbols used by the Israelite army which represented their army. Alternate translation: [We no longer see any of our military banners] or (3) the Jewish festivals and religious observances which were the outward signs of their religion. Alternate translation: [We no longer see any signs of our religion] or [All our sacred observances are gone] or [All our sacred symbols are gone]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 74:10 (#1)

עַד־מָתַי אֱלֹהִים יְחָרֵף צָר יְנַאֵץ אוֹיֵב שִׁמְךָ לָנֶצַח

“Until when, God, will the adversary reproach? Will the enemy despise your name forever”

Asaph is using the question form to express his impatient plea for God to intervene. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or exclamations. Alternate translation: [God, the adversary has reproached you long enough! The enemy should not despise your name forever.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 74:10 (#2)

שִׁמְךָ

“your name”

Asaph is using the term **name** to represent God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 74:11 (#1)

לָמָּה תָשִׁיב יָדְךָ וִימִינֶךָ

“Why do you hold back your hand, even your right hand”

Asaph is using the question form to protest God’s inaction. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not hold back your hand, even your right hand!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 74:11 (#2)

תָשִׁיב יָדְךָ

“do you hold back your hand”

Asaph is using **hold back your hand** as a common expression of the culture to mean that God is withholding his action and not intervening. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do you refrain from acting with your great power]

See: Idiom

Psalms 74:11 (#3)

יָדְךָ וִימִינֶךָ

“your hand, even your right hand”

Here, **your hand, even your right hand** represents God’s power to act. If it would be helpful in your

language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your power, even your great strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 74:11 (#4)

חוקך

“your bosom”

Here, **your bosom** represents concealment and inaction, as though God were keeping his hand tucked inside his robe instead of stretching it out to act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your hiding place]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 74:12 (#1)

וֵאלֹהִים מַלְכִּי

“But God {is} my king”

Asaph uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the despair he has expressed about the destruction of the temple and his confidence in God as king. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Yet God is my king]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 74:12 (#2)

מַלְכִּי

“is} my king”

Asaph uses the pronoun **my** instead of “our” to express a personal declaration of trust. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [is my king whom I trust]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 74:12 (#3)

יְשׁוּעֹת

“salvations”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvations**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [mighty things to save his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 74:13 (#1)

אַתָּה פוֹרַרְתָּ

“You, you divided”

Asaph is stating the pronoun **You** separately, even though the verb translated as **you divided** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it was God himself who performed this mighty act. If it would be natural in your language to use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation, or you could express this emphasis in a different way. See how you as a team decide to translate this phrase and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [It was you who divided]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 74:13 (#2)

בְּעֻזֶּךָ

“by your strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 74:13 (#3)

רָאשֵׁי תַּנִּינִים

“the heads of the sea monsters”

Here Asaph is speaking of the forces of chaos as if they were **sea monsters** whose **heads** God crushed. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the powers of the chaotic waters]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:14 (#1)

רָאשֵׁי לִוְיָתָן

“the heads of Leviathan”

Here Asaph is speaking of the forces of chaos as if they were a great sea creature called **Leviathan**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the great chaos creature]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:14 (#2)

תִּתְּנֶנּוּ מַּֽאֲכָל לְעָ֥ם

“you gave him {as} food to a people”

Here Asaph is speaking of God’s defeat of Leviathan as if God had given **him as food** to people, meaning that God completely destroyed this power. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you left his remains for the people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:15 (#1)

בָּקַ֣עְתָּ מַעְיָ֣ן וָנָ֑חַל

“you split open spring and wadi”

Here, **split open spring and wadi** refers to Yahweh breaking open the ground and causing springs and streams to flow. Alternate translation: [you caused springs and streams to flow out of the ground]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:16 (#1)

לְךָ֣ יֹ֭ום אַף & לְךָ֣ לָ֑יְלָה

“The day {is} to you; the night & also”

Asaph is referring to all of time by naming two extremes, **the day** and **the night**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [All hours of the day and night are also]

See: Merism

Psalms 74:16 (#2)

אַף

“also”

Here the word **also** connects two parallel statements, emphasizing that both the day and the night belong to God. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [even]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 74:16 (#3)

מָאוֹר וְשָׁמֶשׁ

“the light and the sun”

Asaph is referring to all celestial light by naming two components, **the light and the sun**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [every source of light in the sky]

See: Merism

Psalms 74:17 (#1)

גְּבוּלֹ֣ות אָ֑רֶץ

“the boundaries of the earth”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean the boundaries that mark the extent of **the earth**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the boundaries that define the earth]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:17 (#2)

קַ֖יִץ וָחֹ֣רֶף

“summer and winter”

Asaph is referring to all the seasons of the year by naming two extremes, **summer and winter**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the seasons of the year]

See: Merism

Psalms 74:18 (#1)

זְכָר־זֹ֭את

“Remember this”

Here the words **Remember this** mark a shift from praising God’s mighty acts back to petitioning him for help. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Consider this]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 74:18 (#2)

אֹויֵ֣ב חֵרֵ֣ף ׀ יְהוָ֑ה

“the enemy has reproached Yahweh”

Even though Asaph is addressing God directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **Yahweh** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [the enemy has reproached you, Yahweh]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 74:18 (#3)

נִאֲצוּ שִׁמְךָ

“has despised your name”

Asaph is using the term **name** to represent God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [has despised your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 74:19 (#1)

נֶפֶשׁ תּוֹרְרֶךָ

“the life of your dove”

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe the **life** that belongs to the people he calls a **dove**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express the idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the lives of your people whom you cherish]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:19 (#2)

תּוֹרְרֶךָ

“your dove”

Here Asaph is speaking of God’s people as if they were a vulnerable **dove**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your defenseless people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:19 (#3)

לְחַיַּת

“to a beast”

Here Asaph is speaking of the enemy nation as if it were a wild **beast** that would devour its prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to the cruel enemy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:19 (#4)

עֲנִיֶּיךָ

“your poor”

Asaph is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [your poor people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 74:20 (#1)

כִּי מָלְאוּ מַחֲשַׁכֵּי־אֶרֶץ נְאוֹת חָמָס

“for pastures of violence fill the dark places of the land”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because violent places fill the dark places of the land]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 74:20 (#2)

נְאוֹת חָמָס

“pastures of violence”

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe **pastures** that are characterized by **violence**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this purpose, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [violent places]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:20 (#3)

חָמָס

“violence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [violent deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 74:20 (#4)

מַחֲשַׁכֵּי־אֶרֶץ

“the dark places of the land”

Here Asaph is speaking of places of oppression and danger as if they were **dark places**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the dangerous places of the land]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:20 (#5)

מַחְשַׁכֵּי־אֶ֫רֶץ

“the dark places of the land”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean the places in **the land** that are dark, that is, dangerous. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the dark places that are in the land]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:21 (#1)

דַּ֭ךְ

“the weak”

Asaph is using the adjective **weak** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the weak person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 74:21 (#2)

נִכְלָ֑ם

“ashamed”

The expression **ashamed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [feeling shame]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 74:21 (#3)

עָנִ֖י וְ֣אֶבְי֑וֹן

“the poor and the needy”

Asaph is using the adjectives **poor** and **needy** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [those who are poor and needy]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 74:22 (#1)

קוּמָ֣ה אֱ֭לֹהִים

“Arise, God”

Here the words **Arise, God** mark a shift to a final urgent appeal for God to act. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Take action, God]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 74:22 (#2)

רִיבָ֣ה רִיבֶ֑ךָ

“Plead your case”

Here Asaph is speaking of God as if he were a litigant who would **plead** a legal **case** in court. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Contend for yourself]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 74:22 (#3)

רִיבֶ֑ךָ

“your case”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean the case that is brought against God, that is, the insults directed at him. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the case against you]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:22 (#4)

חֶרְפָּתְךָ֥

“your reproach”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how the fool reproaches you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 74:22 (#5)

חֶרְפָּתְךָ֗ מִנִּ֥י־נָ֝בָ֗ל

“your reproach from the fool”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean the reproach that comes from **the fool**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the way the fool reproaches you]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:23 (#1)

קֹ֭ול צֹרְרֶ֑יךָ

“the voice of your adversaries”

Here, **the voice of your adversaries** represents what the adversaries are saying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the words of your adversaries]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 74:23 (#2)

קוֹל צֹרְרֶיךָ

“the voice of your adversaries”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean the voice that comes from **your adversaries**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [what your adversaries are saying]

See: Possession

Psalms 74:23 (#3)

שְׁאוֹן קָמֶיךָ

“the uproar of the ones rising against you”

Asaph is using this possessive form to mean the uproar that comes from **the ones rising against** God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the noise that your opponents make]

See: Possession

Psalms - Chapter 75 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Superscription
2. Community thanksgiving (1)
3. God’s promise of righteous judgment (2–5)
4. Declaration that God alone is judge (6–8)
5. Psalmist’s vow to praise (9)
6. God’s promise to judge (10)

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 75 is a psalm of Asaph that celebrates God as the righteous judge of all the earth.

1. Purpose: to declare that God will judge the earth with equity
2. Content: The psalm moves between different speakers—the community, God himself, and the psalmist—all affirming that God is the judge who humbles the wicked and exalts the righteous.
3. Message: God alone has the authority to judge, and he will do so at the appointed time.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. The psalm contains multiple speakers. Verse 1 is the community speaking. Verses 2–5 (and possibly continuing through verse 8) are God speaking. Verse 9 is the psalmist (Asaph) speaking. Verse 10 contains God’s words in quotation marks.
2. The image of the “horn” appears in verses 4, 5, and 10, representing power, pride, or strength.
3. The image of God’s judgment as a cup of wine appears in verse 8, a common biblical image.

See: Poetry

Psalms 75:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 75:1 (#1)

הוֹדִינוּ לְךָ ׀ אֱלֹהִים הוֹדִינוּ

“We give thanks to you, God; we give thanks”

The psalmist is repeating the phrase **We give thanks** in order to intensify the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [We thank you so very much]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 75:1 (#2)

וְקָרוֹב שְׁמֶךָ

“and your name is near”

By **your name is near**, the psalmist means that God is present and accessible to his people. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you are present with us] or [you are close to us]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 75:1 (#3)

שְׁמֶךָ

“your name”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent God himself and his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 75:1 (#4)

סִפְּרוּ

“they recount”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this explicitly. Alternate translation: [we your people recount]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 75:2 (#1)

כִּי אֶקַּח מוֹעֵד אֲנִי מֵישָׁרִים אֶשְׁפֹּט

“When I take the appointed time; I, I will judge {with} equity”

This is the beginning of what God said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of God. Alternate translation: [God said, “When I take the appointed time, I will judge with equity]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 75:2 (#2)

אֲנִי & אֶשְׁפֹּט

“I, I will judge”

God is stating the pronoun **I** twice, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he himself is the one speaking and acting. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [I myself will judge]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 75:2 (#3)

מֵישָׁרִים

“with} equity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **equity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is right] or [uprightly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 75:3 (#1)

נָמֹגִים אֶרֶץ וְכָל־יֹשְׁבֶיהָ

“The earth and all its inhabitants are melting”

The psalmist is speaking of the earth and its inhabitants as if they were **melting**. He means that they are overcome with fear and instability in the presence of God’s judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The earth and all its inhabitants are trembling with fear]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 75:3 (#2)

אֲנֹכִי תִכַּנְתִּי

“I, I established”

God is stating the pronoun **I** explicitly, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he himself is the one who establishes the earth’s foundations. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [I myself established]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 75:3 (#3)

תִכַּנְתִּי עַמּוּדֶיהָ

“I established its pillars”

The psalmist is speaking of the earth as if it were a building with **pillars** to support it. This image represents the stability that God provides and maintains for the earth. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [made it stable] or [keep it stable]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 75:4 (#1)

לַהוֹלְלִים

“to the boasters”

David is using the adjective **boasters** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who boast]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 75:4 (#2)

וְלָרְשָׁעִים

“and to the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 75:4 (#3)

תָּרִימוּ קָֽרֶן

“lift up a horn”

The psalmist is speaking of arrogant or defiant people as if they were to physically **lift up a horn** like an animal displaying strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [behave arrogantly] or [act defiantly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 75:5 (#1)

תָּרִֽימוּ לַמָּרוֹם קַרְנְכֶֽם

“lift up your horn to the height”

The psalmist is speaking of **to the height** as if it were a physical elevation to which one could **lift up** a **horn**. This intensifies the image of arrogance that the horn metaphor conveys. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [act with extreme arrogance]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 75:5 (#2)

תְּדַבְּרוּ בְצַוָּארׇ עָתָֽק

“speak with an arrogant neck”

Here, **neck** represents speaking with an arrogant attitude. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [speak arrogantly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 75:6 (#1)

מִמּֽוֹצָא וּמִמַּעֲרָב וְלֹ֣א מִמִּדְבַּ֣ר הָרִֽים

“from the east or from the west, and not from the wilderness {comes} lifting up”

The psalmist is referring to all directions on earth by naming two (or three) cardinal points, **the east**, **the west**, and **the wilderness** (the south). The word translated **comes lifting up** could possibly mean “mountains” which would refer to the north. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from any direction comes lifting up]

See: Merism

Psalms 75:6 (#2)

הָרִֽים

“comes} lifting up”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **lifting up**, you could express the same idea with a verb such as “lift” or “exalt.” Alternate translation: [to lift someone up]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 75:7 (#1)

זֶ֣ה יַשְׁפִּ֣יל וְזֶ֣ה יָרִֽים

“this one he brings low, and this one he lifts up”

The implication is that God brings low the proud and wicked, and lifts up the humble and righteous. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he humbles this proud person, and he exalts this humble person] or [he brings down the arrogant, and he raises up the lowly]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 75:8 (#1)

כ֤וֹס בְּיַד־יְהוָ֨ה

“a cup {is} in the hand of Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s judgment as if it were **a cup** that Yahweh held **in** his **hand** and forced people to drink. This is a common biblical image. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s judgment is like a cup in his hand]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 75:8 (#2)

וְיַ֤יִן חָמַ֨ר ׀ מָ֘לֵא֤ מֶסֶךְ֙

“and the wine foams, a full mixture”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **wine** that **foams** and is **a full mixture** refers to wine mixed with spices, making it very strong and intoxicating, representing the full strength of God’s judgment. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the wine foams, full of spices]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 75:8 (#3)

שְׁ֭שָׂמֶרֶיהָ יִמְצ֣וּ

“its dregs they will drain”

The psalmist is speaking of punishment as if it were a cup of wine and God’s enemies **will drain** even **its dregs**, the sediment at the bottom. He means that they will experience God’s judgment completely, even to its most severe and bitter aspects. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will experience the punishment fully, even its worst parts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 75:8 (#4)

רִשְׁעֵ֥י

“the wicked”

See how you translated the similar expression in verse 4.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 75:9 (#1)

וַ֭אֲנִי אַגִּ֣יד לְעֹלָ֑ם אֲזַמְּרָ֥ה לֵאלֹהֵ֖י יַעֲקֹֽב

“But I, I will declare to eternity; I will sing praise to the God of Jacob”

This is the beginning of what the psalmist said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of the psalmist. Alternate translation: [But as for me, I will declare to eternity; I will sing praise to the God of Jacob]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 75:9 (#2)

וַ֭אֲנִי אַגִּ֣יד

“But I, I will declare”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** twice for emphasis. He is doing that to emphasize his personal commitment and determination, in contrast to the wicked. If a speaker of your language would repeat a pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [But as for me, I will declare]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 75:9 (#3)

לֵאלֹהֵ֥י יַעֲקֹֽב

“to the God of Jacob”

Here, **Jacob** represents the people of Israel, the descendants of Jacob. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to the God of the people of Israel] or [to the God of the Israelites]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 75:10 (#1)

וְכָל־קַרְנֵ֣י רְ֭שָׁעִים אֲגַדֵּ֑עַ תְּ֝רוֹמַמְנָ֗ה קַרְנ֥וֹת צַדִּֽיק

“And all the horns of the wicked I will cut off; the horns of the righteous will be lifted up”

This is the beginning of what God said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of God. Alternate translation: [God says, “And all the horns of the wicked I will cut off; the horns of the righteous will be lifted up.”]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 75:10 (#2)

קַרְנֵ֣י רְ֭שָׁעִים & קַרְנ֥וֹת צַדִּֽיק

“the horns of the wicked & the horns of the righteous”

The psalmist is speaking of power and strength as if they were **horns**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the power of the wicked ... the power of the righteous]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 75:10 (#3)

רְשָׁעִים

“of the wicked”

See how you translated the similar expression in verse 4.

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 75:10 (#4)

צַדִּיק

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 75:10 (#5)

תְּוֹתַרְוֹמַמְנָה

“will be lifted up”

The expression **will be lifted up** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [I will lift up] or [God will lift up]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 76 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Superscription
2. God is known in Zion (1–3)
3. God’s judgment destroys the enemies (4–6)
4. God’s judgment causes fear (7–9)
5. Call to worship and vow to God (10–12)

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 76 is a psalm of Asaph that celebrates God’s victory over the enemies of his people and his dwelling in Zion.

1. Purpose: to praise God for his victory and to warn others to fear him
2. Content: The psalm describes God’s power in breaking the weapons of war and striking down the enemies who attacked Jerusalem. It affirms God’s sovereignty over all kings and leaders.
3. Message: God is the supreme judge and warrior who defends his people and dwells among them.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Images of War
The psalm uses several images related to war and judgment, such as “flames of the bow” (arrows), “mountains of prey” (victory), and “gird on wrath” (using wrath as a weapon).

God’s Names and Titles
The psalm uses “God of Jacob” (v6), “Fear” (or “Awesome One”, v11), and refers to his dwelling in “Salem” and “Zion” (v2).

Idioms
There are idioms like “stout of heart” (brave) and “found not their hands” (helpless).

See: Poetry

Psalms 76:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 76:1 (#1)

נוֹדָע בִּיהוּדָה אֱלֹהִים בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל גָּדוֹל שְׁמוֹ

“In Judah God is known; in Israel his name is great”

These lines mean basically the same thing. Translate according to your team’s decision on parallelism. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information.

See: Parallelism

Psalms 76:1 (#2)

נוֹדָע & אֱלֹהִים

“God is known”

The expression **is known** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people know God] or [God has revealed himself]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 76:1 (#3)

שְׁמֹו

“his name”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his reputation] or [he himself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 76:2 (#1)

וַיְהִי בְשָׁלֵם סֻכֹּו וּמְעֹונָתֹו בְּצִיֹּון

“And his abode is in Salem, and his dwelling place is in Zion”

These lines mean basically the same thing. Translate according to your team’s decision on parallelism. See the Introduction to Psalms for more information.

See: Parallelism

Psalms 76:2 (#2)

בְשָׁלֵם

“in Salem”

The word **Salem** is the name of a city. This is an ancient name for Jerusalem.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 76:2 (#3)

וַיְהִי בְשָׁלֵם סֻכֹּו וּמְעֹונָתֹו

“And his abode is in Salem, and his dwelling place”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a person who had an **abode** and a **dwelling place** in Salem and Zion. This represents Yahweh’s special presence among his people in those locations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And his home is in Salem, and where he lives] or [And he is present in Salem, and his presence]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:2 (#4)

בְּצִיֹּון

“is in Zion”

The word **Zion** is the name of a mountain in Jerusalem.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 76:3 (#1)

שָׁשָׁמָּה שָׁבַר רִשְׁפֵי־קֶשֶׁת מָגֵן וְחֶרֶב וּמִלְחָמָה

“There he broke the flames of the bow, the shield, and the sword, and the battle”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh providing peace for his people as if he were physically breaking weapons. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He provides peace by stopping all the enemies’ attacks]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:3 (#2)

רִשְׁפֵי־קֶשֶׁת

“the flames of the bow”

The psalmist is speaking of arrows as if they were **flames of the bow**. This could be because arrows move swiftly like lightning or because they were tipped with fire. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the arrows of the bow]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:3 (#3)

מָגֵן וְחֶרֶב וּמִלְחָמָה

“the shield, and the sword, and the battle”

The psalmist uses some weapons (**the shield and the sword**) to represent all weapons of war and then further uses **the battle** as a summary representing the weapons used in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [shields and swords and all other weapons of war]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 76:4 (#1)

נָאוֹר & אַדִּיר

“are shining, majestic”

The terms **shining** and **majestic** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase.

Alternate translation: [are brilliantly glorious] or [are radiant with glory]

See: Doublet

Psalms 76:4 (#2)

נָאוֹר

“are shining”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were **shining** with radiant light. If it would be helpful for your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are glorious] or [are radiant]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:4 (#3)

מֵהַרְרֵי־טָרֶף

“from the mountains of prey”

The psalmist is speaking of the mountains as if they were places where God had hunted down his enemies like **prey**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the mountains where you defeated your enemies] or [like the mountains of your victory]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:5 (#1)

אֲבִ֥ירֵי לֵ֗בָב

“The stout of heart”

The psalmist is using **stout of heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “brave” or “courageous.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The courageous] or [The brave warriors]

See: Idiom

Psalms 76:5 (#2)

אֻשְׁתּוֹלְלוּ

“were plundered”

The expression **were plundered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [lost all their possessions] or [had their possessions taken away]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 76:5 (#3)

נָמְמוּ שְׁנָתָ֑ם

“they slept their sleep”

The psalmist is referring to death in a polite way by using the phrase **slept their sleep**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [they died] or [they passed away]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 76:5 (#4)

וְלֹא־מָצְא֥וּ & יְדֵיהֶֽם

“and & found not their hands”

The psalmist is using **found not their hands** as a common expression of his culture to mean “were unable to use their strength or weapons.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and … could not lift their hands to fight] or [and … were helpless]

See: Idiom

Psalms 76:6 (#1)

מִגַּעֲרָתְךָ֥

“At your rebuke”

The expression **At your rebuke** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [When you rebuked them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 76:6 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵ֣י יַעֲקֹ֑ב

“O God of Jacob”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form **God of Jacob** to indicate that Jacob possessed or controlled God. Rather, the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the God whom Jacob worshiped. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God whom Jacob worshiped]

See: Possession

Psalms 76:6 (#3)

וְרֹכֵב וָסוּס

“both rider and horse”

The psalmist is using **rider and horse** to represent all the military forces of the enemy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [chariots and horses] or [riders and their horses]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 76:6 (#4)

נִנְעַר֖וּ

“fell deeply asleep”

The psalmist is speaking of **fell deeply asleep** as if dying were falling into a deep sleep. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fell down dead] or [died]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:7 (#1)

אַתָּ֣ה & אַתָּ֑ה

“You, you are”

The psalmist is repeating the pronoun **You** in order to intensify the emphasis on God himself. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [You yourself are] or [Truly you are]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 76:7 (#2)

נ֭וֹרָא אַתָּ֣ה

“you are to be feared”

The expression **you are to be feared** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you are fearsome] or [people must fear you]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 76:7 (#3)

וּמִי־יַעֲמֹ֥ד לְפָנֶ֗יךָ מֵאָ֥ז אַפֶּֽךָ

“and who can stand before your face from the time of your nose”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [and no one can stand before your face from the time of your nose!] or [and no one is able to stand before your face when your nose begins to burn!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 76:7 (#4)

יַעֲמֹ֥ד לְפָנֶ֗יךָ

“can stand before your face”

The psalmist is using **stand before your face** as a common expression of the culture to mean “withstand your judgment” or “endure your presence.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [can survive in your presence] or [can endure your anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 76:7 (#5)

מֵאָ֥ז אַפֶּֽךָ

“from the time of your nose”

The psalmist is using the phrase **from the time of your nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean “when you are angry.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when you are angry] or [when your anger flares up]

See: Idiom

Psalms 76:8 (#1)

מִשָּׁמַ֥יִם

“From heaven”

Here, **heaven** represents the place where God dwells. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [From the sky] or [From your dwelling place]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 76:8 (#2)

הִשְׁמַ֣עְתָּ דִּ֭ין

“you caused judgment to be heard”

The expression **caused judgment to be heard** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you proclaimed judgment] or [you announced your judgment]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 76:8 (#3)

אֶ֭רֶץ יָרְאָ֣ה וְשָׁקָטָ֑ה

“the earth feared and was quiet”

Here, **earth** represents the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of the earth were afraid and were quiet] or [everyone on earth feared and were quiet]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 76:9 (#1)

בְּקוּם־לַ֭מִּשְׁפָּ֑ט

“when & arose to judgment”

The psalmist is using **arose to judgment** as a common expression of his culture to mean “began to judge” or “decided to act in judgment.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when … began to judge] or [when …took action to judge]

See: Idiom

Psalms 76:10 (#1)

חֲמַ֣ת אָ֭דָם תּוֹדֶ֣ךָ

“the wrath of man will thank you”

The psalmist is speaking of **wrath** as if it were a living thing that could **praise** God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people’s anger will result in praise to you] or [you will be praised because of how you respond to human anger]

See: Personification

Psalms 76:10 (#2)

תַּחְגֹּ֑ר

“you will gird on”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he will **gird on** the remainder of wrath like a belt or weapon. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will wear like a belt] or [you will use like a weapon]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:11 (#1)

נִ֭דְּרוּ וְשַׁלְּמ֣וּ לַֽיהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵיכֶ֑ם

“Vow and pay to Yahweh your God”

The implication is that the people should fulfill the vows they make to God by doing what they promised. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Make vows to Yahweh your God and fulfill them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 76:11 (#2)

כָּל־סְבִיבָ֑יו

“all who are around him”

The implication is that **all who are around him** refers to the people of the nations surrounding Israel. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [all the people of the surrounding nations]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 76:11 (#3)

לַמּוֹרָ֣א

“to the Fear”

Here, **the Fear** represents God, the one who is to be feared. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the One who is to be feared] or [to the Awesome One]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 76:12 (#1)

יִבְצֹ֥ר

“He cuts off”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God as if he were using a tool and **cuts off the spirit of princes**. He means that God humbles or destroys them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He humbles] or [He destroys]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 76:12 (#2)

רוּחַ

“the spirit of”

Here, **spirit** represents the courage or pride of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the courage of] or [the pride of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 76:12 (#3)

נוֹרָא לְמַלְכֵי־אָרֶץ

“he is to be feared by the kings of the earth”

The expression **is to be feared by the kings of the earth** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the kings of the earth fear him] or [he causes the kings of the earth to fear him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 77 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Superscription
2. Lament and sleepless searching (1–6)
3. Questions about God’s favor (7–10)
4. Remembering Yah’s deeds (11–15)
5. God’s power over the waters and leading his people (16–20)

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 77 is a psalm of Asaph in which the psalmist moves from intense distress and questioning to renewed confidence by remembering God’s past saving actions.

1. Purpose: to express a lament and then to renew trust in God by recalling his mighty deeds.
2. Content: The psalm begins with the psalmist crying out in trouble and asking a series of questions about whether God has rejected him. It then turns to remembrance of God’s works and ends with vivid storm-and-sea imagery that recalls God leading his people.
3. Message: When God seems absent, the psalmist responds by remembering who God is and what he has done for his people.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

1. Rhetorical questions: Verses 7–9 contain a series of questions that function primarily to express grief and uncertainty, not to request information.
2. Figurative language for inner life: The psalm uses terms like “soul,” “heart,” and “spirit” to describe a person’s internal experience.
3. Body-part imagery for God’s power: Expressions like “right hand” and “arm” refer to God’s power and ability to act.
4. Nature imagery: The psalm personifies waters, clouds, skies, and the earth, and uses war/storm imagery such as “arrows” for lightning.
5. Key names and titles: The psalm includes the divine name “Yah,” the title “the Most High,” and references to Jacob, Joseph, Moses, and Aaron.
6. Selah: The term “Selah” appears in verses 3, 9, and 15 as a likely musical direction.

See: Poetry

Psalms 77:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

For the chief musician is an instruction about who should lead people in singing or playing music with this psalm. This could refer to the person in charge of music for temple worship. If your readers would not be familiar with this role, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the worship leader]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 77:0 (#3)

עַל־ידיתון

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־ידיתון”

See how you translated the expression “on Jeduthun” in the superscription to Psalm 39.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 77:1 (#1)

קוֹלִי אֶל־אֱלֹהִים וְאֶצְעָקָה קוֹלִי אֶל־אֱלֹהִים

“My voice {is} to God, and I cry out; my voice {is} to God”

Asaph is repeating the expression **my voice is to God** in order to intensify his expression of crying out to God. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I earnestly cry out to God] or [I cry out with my voice again and again to God]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 77:1 (#2)

קוֹלִ֥י

“My voice”

Here, **My voice** represents Asaph’s act of calling out to God in prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My prayer]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:2 (#1)

בְּי֣וֹם צָ֭רָתִי

“In the day of my trouble”

Asaph is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [At the time of my trouble] or [When I was in trouble]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:2 (#2)

יָדִ֤י ׀ לַ֣יְלָה נָגְרָ֣ה

“my hand was stretched out at night”

Here, **my hand was stretched out** was a symbolic action by which Asaph showed his persistent prayer and pleading to God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [I lifted my hands to God in continual prayer]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 77:2 (#3)

מֵאֲנָ֖ה הִנָּחֵ֣ם נַפְשִׁ֑י

“My soul refused to be comforted”

Asaph is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to represent all of him in his refusal of comfort. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I refused to be comforted]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 77:3 (#1)

אֶזְכְּרָ֣ה אֱלֹהִ֣ים וְאֶהֱמָיֶ֑ה אָשִׂ֥יחָה ׀ וְתִתְעַטֵּ֖ף רוּחִֽי

“I remembered God and I groaned; I meditated, and my spirit grew faint”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [I remembered God and groaned; yes, my spirit grew faint as I meditated]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 77:3 (#2)

וְתִתְעַטֵּ֖ף רוּחִֽי

“and my spirit grew faint”

Here, **spirit** represents Asaph’s inner strength or vitality. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I felt weak] or [and I became exhausted]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:4 (#1)

אָ֭אַחַזְתָּ שְׁמֻרוֹ֣ת עֵינָ֑י

“You held the lids of my eyes”

Asaph is speaking of God preventing him from sleeping as if God **held the lids of my eyes** open. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You prevented me from sleeping] or [You kept me awake]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:5 (#1)

יָמִ֥ים מִקֶּ֑דֶם שְׁ֝נ֗וֹת עוֹלָמִֽים

“days from antiquity, years of long ago”

These two phrases **days from antiquity** and **years of long ago** mean basically the same thing. The second

emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [times long, long ago]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 77:5 (#2)

יָמִים מִקֶּדֶם

“days from antiquity”

Here, **days** represents a particular period of time in the past. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the time long ago] or [the era of antiquity]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:6 (#1)

עִם־לְבָבִי אָשִׂיחָה

“with my heart I will meditate”

Asaph is speaking of **my heart** as if it were the place where thinking and reflection occur. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I meditate within myself] or [I reflect deeply]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:6 (#2)

וַיְחַפֵּשׂ רוּחִי

“and my spirit searches”

Asaph is using one part of a person, his **spirit**, to mean all of him in the act of searching for understanding. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I search diligently]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 77:7 (#1)

הַלְעוֹלָמִים יִזְנַח ׀ אֲדֹנָי וְלֹא־יֹסִיף לִרְצוֹת עֽוֹד

“Will the Lord reject {me} forever? And will he not again add to show favor”

Asaph is using the question form to express his distress and uncertainty. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [The Lord will surely not reject me forever! He will show me favor again!] or [I am afraid that the Lord will reject me forever and will never again show me favor.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 77:7 (#2)

וְלֹא־יֹסִיף לִרְצוֹת עֽוֹד

“And will he not again add to show favor”

Asaph is using **again add** as a common expression to mean “continue.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And will he not continue to show favor] or [And will he not ever show favor]

See: Idiom

Psalms 77:7 (#3)

יֹסִיף לִרְצוֹת

“will he & add to show favor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **favor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [will he ... treat me favorably] or [will he ... be favorable toward me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 77:8 (#1)

חַסְדּוֹ

“his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his faithfulness to his covenant] or [his faithful commitment to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 77:8 (#2)

לְדֹר וָדֹר

“for generation and generation”

Asaph is using **for generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “throughout all generations” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language

that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [throughout all generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 77:8 (#3)

הֶאָפֵס לָנֶנֶצַח חַסְדּוֹ גָּמַר אֹמֶר לְדֹר וָדֹר

“Has his covenant faithfulness ceased forever? Has a promise ended for generation and generation”

Asaph is using the question form to express his deep sorrow and fear that God has abandoned him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [Your covenant faithfulness must be gone forever! Your promise must have failed forever!] or [Surely your covenant faithfulness is gone forever. Surely your promise has failed forever.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 77:9 (#1)

הֲשָׁכַח חַנּוֹת אֵל אִם־קָפַץ בְּאַף רַחֲמָיו

“Has God forgotten to be gracious? Or has he shut up his compassions in {his} nose”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Has God forgotten to be gracious and shut up his compassions in his nose]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 77:9 (#2)

קָפַץ בְּאַף רַחֲמָיו

“has he shut up his compassions in {his} nose”

Asaph speaks of anger as if it were a person shutting a door to keep another person, compassion, from coming out. Alternate translation: [has God stopped showing us compassion because he is angry with us]

See: Personification

Psalms 77:9 (#3)

הֲשָׁכַח חַנּוֹת אֵל אִם־קָפַץ בְּאַף רַחֲמָיו סֶלָה

“Has God forgotten to be gracious? Or has he shut up his compassions in {his} nose? Selah”

Asaph is using the question form to express his anguish and doubt, not to seek information. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [God has forgotten to be gracious. He has shut off his compassion in anger.] or [Surely God has not forgotten to be gracious! Surely his anger has not shut off his compassion!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 77:9 (#4)

קָפַץ בְּאַף רַחֲמָיו

“has he shut up his compassions in {his} nose”

Asaph is speaking of God’s **compassions** as if they were something physical that his anger could **shut up**, like closing a door or stopping a flow. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has his anger caused him to withhold his compassion] or [has he withheld his compassion because of his anger]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:9 (#5)

בְּאַף

“in {his} nose”

Here, **nose** represents anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in his anger]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:10 (#1)

וָאֹמַר

“And I said”

This could mean: (1) Asaph was speaking to himself or (2) Asaph was speaking to Yahweh. Alternate translation: [And I said to myself] or [And I said to Yahweh]

Psalms 77:10 (#2)

חַלָּלוֹתִי הִוא

“This is my wounding”

Asaph is speaking of his great distress as if it were a physical **wounding**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [This is my great distress] or [This is what afflicts me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:10 (#3)

יְמִ֣ין

“the right hand”

Here, **the right hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the power] or [the strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:11 (#1)

מִקֶּ֣דֶם פִּלְאֶ֑ךָ

“your wonder from antiquity”

Here, **from antiquity** represents the distant past when God did his remarkable deeds. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the wonders you did long ago] or [your wonderful deeds in ancient times]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:11 (#2)

מִקֶּ֣דֶם פִּלְאֶ֑ךָ

“your wonder from antiquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wonder**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wonderful things that you did long ago]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 77:12 (#1)

וְהָגִ֣יתִי בְכָל־פָּעֳלֶ֑ךָ וּבַעֲלִילוֹתֶ֖יךָ אָשִׂיחָֽה

“And I will ponder on all your deeds, and on your works I will meditate”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [And I will ponder and meditate on all your deeds]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 77:13 (#1)

אֱלֹהִ֥ים בַּקֹּ֗דֶשׁ דַּרְכֶּ֫ךָ

“Your way, God, is in holiness”

Asaph is speaking of God’s manner of acting as if it were a **way** or path that he travels. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God, the manner in which you act is holy] or [God, everything you do is holy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:13 (#2)

בַּקֹּ֗דֶשׁ

“is in holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is a holy way] or [is a way that is holy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 77:13 (#3)

מִי־אֵ֣ל גָּ֭דוֹל כֵּאלֹהִֽים

“what god is great like God”

Asaph is using the question form to emphasize that no god compares to the true God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [no god is great like God] or [there is no god as great as God!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 77:14 (#1)

עֻזֶּ֑ךָ

“your strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how strong you are] or [how powerfully you act]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 77:15 (#1)

בִּזְרוֹעַ

“with {your} arm”

Here, **arm** represents God’s power and ability to rescue. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by your power] or [with your mighty strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 77:15 (#2)

בְּנֵי־יַעֲקֹב וְיוֹסֵף

“the sons of Jacob and Joseph”

Asaph is speaking of the later Israelites as if they were actually the **sons of Jacob and Joseph**. He means that they are the descendants of these ancestors. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Jacob and Joseph] or [the people descended from Jacob and Joseph]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:16 (#1)

רָאֻךָ מַיִם ׀ אֱלֹהִים רָאֻךָ מַיִם

“The waters saw you, God; the waters saw you”

Asaph is repeating the phrase **the waters saw you** in order to intensify his expression of the idea it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [The waters surely saw you, God]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 77:16 (#2)

רָאֻךָ מַיִם ׀ אֱלֹהִים רָאֻךָ מַיִם יָחִילוּ אַף יִרְגְּזוּ תְהֹמוֹת

“The waters saw you, God; the waters saw you, and they trembled; indeed the depths shook”

Starting in this verse and extending through verse 19, Asaph is speaking of God’s powerful actions during the exodus as if they were a storm, with **thunder** representing God’s voice, **arrows** and **lightning** representing God’s power striking out, and **the waters** and **the earth** reacting in fear by trembling. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express these images with a comparison or state the meaning plainly.

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 77:16 (#3)

רָאֻךָ מַיִם ׀ אֱלֹהִים רָאֻךָ מַיִם

“The waters saw you, God; the waters saw you”

Asaph is speaking of **the waters** as if they were living things that could see and respond with fear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When you, God, came to the waters, they moved back in fear] or [The waters moved away from you, God, as if they saw you]

See: Personification

Psalms 77:16 (#4)

יָחִילוּ אַף יִרְגְּזוּ תְהֹמוֹת

“and they trembled; indeed the depths shook”

These two phrases, **they trembled** and **the depths shook**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [and they trembled, even the depths shook]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 77:17 (#1)

עָבְתוּ קֹלוֹ נָתְנוּ

“the skies gave a sound”

By **gave a sound**, Asaph means that the skies thundered. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the skies thundered]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 77:17 (#2)

אַף־חִצָּצֶיךָ יִתְהַלָּכוּ

“your arrows also flew about”

Asaph is speaking of lightning bolts as if they were **arrows** that God shot. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression

from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your lightning bolts also flashed in all directions] or [you also shot lightning across the sky]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:18 (#1)

קֹ֣ול רַֽעַמְךָ֣ ׀ בַּגַּלְגַּ֗ל

“The sound of your thunder {was} in the whirlwind”

Asaph is speaking of the sound of God’s thunder as if it were **in the whirlwind** and as if God’s voice or presence were speaking from within the storm. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your voice thundered from the whirlwind] or [You spoke with thundering power in the storm]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:18 (#2)

רָגְזָ֖ה וַתִּרְעַ֣שׁ

“trembled and shook”

The terms **trembled** and **shook** mean similar things. Asaph is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [shook violently] or [quaked greatly]

See: Doublet

Psalms 77:19 (#1)

בַּיָּ֣ם דַּרְכֶּ֑ךָ ושבילך

“Your way went through the sea and your path”

Asaph is speaking of God’s actions and guidance as if they were a **way** and **path** that he traveled. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your deeds were done in the sea and your works] or [You acted in the sea, and you worked]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 77:19 (#2)

בַּיָּ֣ם דַּרְכֶּ֑ךָ ושבילך בְּמַ֖יִם רַבִּ֣ים

“Your way went through the sea and your path through many waters”

These two phrases, **Your way went through the sea** and **your path through many waters**, mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Your way went through the sea, yes, your path went through many waters]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 77:19 (#3)

וְ֝עִקְּבוֹתֶ֗יךָ לֹ֣א נֹדָֽעוּ

“but your footprints were not discerned”

Asaph is speaking of God as if he were a person who could leave **footprints** when walking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but no trace of your presence could be seen] or [but there was no sign of where you had been]

See: Personification

Psalms 77:19 (#4)

וְ֝עִקְּבוֹתֶ֗יךָ לֹ֣א נֹדָֽעוּ

“but your footprints were not discerned”

The expression **your footprints were not discerned** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [but no one could discern your footprints] or [but your footprints could not be seen]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 77:20 (#1)

כַּצֹּ֑אן

“like a flock”

The point of this comparison is that just as a shepherd leads and cares for **a flock**, so God led and cared for his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as a shepherd leads a flock] or [with the care and guidance of a shepherd]

See: Simile

Psalms 77:20 (#2)

בְּיַד־מֹשֶׁ֖ה וְאַהֲרֹֽן

“by the hand of Moses and Aaron”

Here, **hand** represents agency and leadership. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [through the leadership of Moses and Aaron] or [by means of Moses and Aaron]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 78 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 78 is a historical wisdom psalm—a maskil—of Asaph. It recounts Israel's history from the exodus to the reign of David, teaching each generation to trust God and to not repeat the failures of the past. (See: wise, wisdom)

1. Call to hear and teach the next generation (1–8)
2. Ephraim's failure and Israel's forgetfulness (9–11)
3. God's wonders in Egypt and the wilderness (12–16)
4. Rebellion in the wilderness and God's provision (17–31)
5. Continued sin and God's compassion (32–39)
6. Recounting the plagues and the exodus (40–55)
7. Rebellion in the land and God's judgment (56–64)
8. God's renewal: choosing Judah, Zion, and David (65–72)

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a "maskil." See the discussion of that term in the introduction to Psalms.

About the Psalm

Psalm 78 is the second longest psalm in the Psalter (after Psalm 119). It belongs to the Asaph collection (Psalms 73–83) and follows a pattern of historical recitation similar to Psalm 15, Psalm 16, and Nehemiah 9. The psalm opens with a didactic framework (verses 1–8) in which Asaph calls his audience to hear a "parable" and "riddles from antiquity." He establishes the purpose of the recitation: each generation must pass on the knowledge of God's deeds to the next, so that future generations will trust God and keep his commandments [[rc://*/tw/dict/bible/other/commandments]] rather than repeating the pattern of rebellion.

The historical narrative unfolds in two main cycles. The first cycle (verses 9–39) moves from Ephraim's failure through the exodus, God's provision of water, manna and quail, the people's rebellious demands, God's judgment, and then his compassion. The second cycle (verses 40–64) returns to the plagues in Egypt, recounts the exodus and conquest, and then describes Israel's idolatry in the land, culminating in God's abandonment of Shiloh and the capture of the ark. The psalm concludes (verses 65–72) with God choosing Judah, Zion, and David as shepherd-king over his people.

The historical events alluded to include the exodus and sea crossing (Exodus 14), the wilderness provision of water, manna, and quail (Exodus 16–17, Numbers 11), the plagues of Egypt (Exodus 7–12), the conquest of Canaan (Joshua 13–21), the capture of the ark at Shiloh (1 Samuel 4), and God's choice of David (2 Samuel 5–7).

Translation Issues in This Psalm

God's "nose" as an idiom for anger

The Hebrew word for "nose" is used throughout the psalm to represent God's anger (verses 21, 31, 38, 49, 50). This is a common Hebrew idiom based on the physical signs of anger (flared nostrils, heavy breathing). Translators should be aware of this recurring pattern and handle it consistently. See the notes on individual verses for guidance.

Anthropomorphism in verse 65

Verse 65 describes Yahweh awakening "as one sleeping" and "as a mighty man shouting from wine." This portrays God as having been inactive during the period of judgment, then suddenly rousing himself to action. These comparisons convey sudden, vigorous action after a period of apparent inactivity, not that God was literally asleep or intoxicated.

Psalms 78:1 (#1)

מַשְׂכִּיל

"A maskil"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 78:1 (#2)

הַאֲזִינָה עַמִּי תּוֹרָתִי הַטּוּ אָזְנְכֶם לְאִמְרֵי־פִי

"Hear my teaching, my people; incline your ears to the words of my mouth"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the

phrases and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how your team has decided to translate parallel phrases in the Psalms and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Hear my teaching, my people; yes, listen to the words of my mouth]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 78:1 (#3)

הַאֲזִינָה & תּוֹרָתִי

“Hear my teaching”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **teaching**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Listen to what I teach you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:1 (#4)

עַמִּי

“my people”

Asaph is using this possessive form **my people** to indicate that he is addressing the Israelites as a leader or teacher among them, not to indicate that they belong to him personally. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [fellow Israelites] or [people of Israel]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:1 (#5)

הַטּוּ אָאָזְנְכֶם

“incline your ears”

Asaph is speaking of paying careful attention to his teaching as if his audience could physically **incline** their **ears** toward him in order to listen better. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [pay close attention] or [listen carefully]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:1 (#6)

לְאִמְרֵי־פִי

“to the words of my mouth”

Here, **the words of my mouth** represents what a person says. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to what I say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:1–2 (#1)

See how you translated a similar introduction in Psalms 49:1–4.

Psalms 78:2 (#1)

אֶפְתְּחָה בְמָשָׁל פִּי אַבִּיעָה חִידוֹת מִנִּי־קֶדֶם

“I will open my mouth in a parable; I will pour out riddles from antiquity”

See the note on 78:1 or in the Introduction to the Psalms for more information on translating parallelisms. Alternate translation: [I will open my mouth in parables, yes, I will sing about hidden things from the past]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 78:2 (#2)

אֶפְתְּחָה & פִּי

“I will open my mouth”

Asaph is using **I will open my mouth** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I will speak” or “I will begin to teach.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will speak] or [I will begin to teach]

See: Idiom

Psalms 78:2 (#3)

בְמָשָׁל

“in a parable”

A **parable** is a type of teaching that uses comparisons, stories, or wise sayings to communicate deeper truths. If your readers would not be familiar with this concept, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [in wise sayings] or [in instructive stories]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 78:2 (#4)

בְמָשָׁל פִּי אַבִּיעָה חִידוֹת מִנִּי־קֶדֶם

“my mouth in a parable; I will pour out riddles from antiquity”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **parables** and **riddles**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [my mouth in symbolic sayings; I will pour out what is difficult to understand from antiquity] or [my mouth by speaking metaphorically; I will pour out enigmatic sayings from antiquity]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:2 (#5)

אַבִּֽיעָה חִֽידוֹת

“I will pour out riddles”

Asaph is speaking of sharing wisdom as if he were **pouring out riddles** like liquid from a container. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will utter riddles] or [I will proclaim mysteries]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:3 (#1)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר שָׁמַ֣עְנוּ וַנֵּדָ֑עֵם

“These are things that we have heard and learned, things”

The terms **heard** and **learned** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [These are things that we know well, things]

See: Doublet

Psalms 78:3 (#2)

וַאֲבוֹתֵ֥ינוּ

“that our fathers”

Asaph is speaking of earlier generations of Israelites as if they were **fathers**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that our forefathers] or [that those who came before us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:4 (#1)

לֹ֣א נְכַחֵ֣ד ׀ מִבְּנֵיהֶ֗ם

“We will not keep them from their descendants”

Asaph is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with a mild expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [We will certainly tell these things to their descendants]

See: Litotes

Psalms 78:4 (#2)

תְּהִלּ֣וֹת יְהוָ֑ה

“about the praises of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praises**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [about the praiseworthy deeds of Yahweh]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:4 (#3)

וְעֻזּ֥וֹ וְנִפְלְאוֹתָ֗יו

“his strength, and his wonders”

The phrase **his strength, and his wonders** expresses a single idea. The word **strength** tells more about **wonders**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [his powerful wonders] or [the mighty miracles]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 78:5 (#1)

עֵד֣וּת & וְתוֹרָ֔ה

“a testimony & and & a law”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **testimony** and **law**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [what he decreed and commanded] or [his requirements and commands]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:5 (#2)

בְּיַעֲקֹ֑ב וְתוֹרָ֥ה & בְּיִשְׂרָאֵ֗ל

“in Jacob and & a law in Israel”

Here, **Jacob** and **Israel** represent all the descendants of the patriarch Jacob, the Israelite nation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [among the people of Jacob and ... a law

among the people of Israel] or [among the descendants of Jacob and ... a law among the descendants of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:6 (#1)

לְמַעַן & דּוֹר אַחֲרוֹן

“So that the later generation”

So that marks the rest of verses 6–8 as the goal or purpose of verse five. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [He commanded this in order that the generation to come]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 78:6 (#2)

לְמַעַן יֵדְעוּ ׀ דּוֹר אַחֲרוֹן בָּנִים יִוָּלֵדוּ

“So that the later generation might know, the children yet to be born”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [so that the generation to come might know his decrees, and so that the children not yet born might also know them]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 78:6 (#3)

יָקֻמוּ וְיִסַּפְּרוּ

“and they will rise up and tell”

The psalmist is using **rise up** as a common expression of the culture to mean “take action” or “come along.” He does not mean that the children will literally stand up. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they in their turn will tell] or [and they will then tell]

See: Idiom

Psalms 78:7 (#1)

וְיָשִׂימוּ בֵאלֹהִים כִּסְלָם

“And they would place their confidence in God”

The psalmist is speaking of **confidence** as if it were something that could be physically **placed** in a secure location. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And they would trust in God] or [And they would rely on God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:7 (#2)

וְיָשִׂימוּ בֵאלֹהִים כִּסְלָם

“And they would place their confidence in God”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **confidence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And they would hope in God] or [And they would confidently trust in God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:8 (#1)

דּוֹר סוֹרֵר וּמֹרֶה דּוֹר

“a stubborn generation and a rebellious generation”

The terms **stubborn** and **rebellious** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [a very obstinate generation] or [an extremely defiant generation]

See: Doublet

Psalms 78:8 (#2)

לֹא־הֵכִין לִבּוֹ

“which} did not cause its heart to be steadfast”

Here, **heart** represents the inner disposition and loyalty of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who were not inwardly loyal] or [whose inner disposition was not right]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:8 (#3)

וְלֹא־נֶאֱמְנָה אֶת־אֵל רוּחוֹ

“and its spirit was not faithful with God”

Here, **spirit** represents the inner person or will. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they were not committed and faithful to God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:9 (#1)

הָֽפְכ֥וּ בְי֗וֹם קְרָֽב

“they turned back on the day of battle”

The psalmist is using **turned back on the day of battle** as a common expression of the culture to mean “retreated in battle” or “fled when they should have fought.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fled when they should have fought] or [retreated instead of fighting]

See: Idiom

Psalms 78:9 (#2)

בְּי֗וֹם קְרָֽב

“on the day of battle”

The psalmist is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when it was time to fight] or [at the time of battle]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:10 (#1)

לֹ֤א שָׁ֨מְר֗וּ בְּרִ֣ית אֱלֹהִ֑ים וּבְתוֹרָתֹ֥ו מֵאֲנ֗וּ לָלֶֽכֶת

“They did not keep the covenant of God, and they refused to walk in his law”

See the note on 78:1 or the Introduction to the Psalms for more information on how to translate parallelisms. Alternate translation: [They did not keep the covenant with God; indeed, they refused to obey his law]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 78:10 (#2)

בְּרִ֣ית אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“the covenant of God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form, **the covenant of God**, to mean the covenant that God had made with the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the covenant that God had made with them] or [God’s covenant]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:10 (#3)

וּבְתוֹרָתֹ֥ו מֵאֲנ֗וּ לָלֶֽכֶת

“and they refused to walk in his law”

The psalmist is speaking of obeying God’s law as if it were a path one could **walk** on. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they refused to obey his law]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:11 (#1)

וְ֝נִפְלְאוֹתָ֗יו אֲשֶׁ֣ר הֶרְאֽוּם

“and his wonders that he had shown them”

The psalmist is not distinguishing the **wonders that he had shown them** from other wonderful things that God had not shown them. The psalmist is reminding the people about the character of God’s deeds that they forgot. Be sure that this is clear in your translation. Alternate translation: [which were wonderful things that he had shown them]

See: Distinguishing Versus Informing or Reminding

Psalms 78:12 (#1)

שְׂדֵה־צֹֽעַן

“in the territory of Zoan”

The word **Zoan** is the name of a city.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 78:12 (#2)

נֶ֝גֶד אֲבוֹתָֽם

“before their fathers”

Here, **their fathers** represents their ancestors who were present to see the marvelous things. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when their ancestors were present] or [while their ancestors were watching]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:13 (#1)

וַיַּצֵּב־מַ֥יִם כְּמֹו־נֵֽד

“and he made the waters to stand like a heap”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a heap** is a vertical structure, so **the waters** stood upright. If it would be helpful in your language, you could

make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he made the waters stand upright like a solid wall]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:14 (#1)

וְכָל־הַלָּיְלָה בְּאוֹר אֵשׁ

“and all the night with the light of fire”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and all the night he led them with the light of fire]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 78:14 (#2)

בֶּעָנָן & בְּאוֹר אֵשׁ

“with the cloud & with the light of fire”

By **the cloud** and **the light of fire**, the psalmist means the pillar of cloud and the pillar of fire that guided Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 13:21–22). You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [with the pillar of cloud ... with the pillar of fire]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 78:15 (#1)

יְבַקַּע

“He split open”

The pronoun **He** refers to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God split open]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 78:15 (#2)

וַיַּשְׁקְ כִּתְהֹמוֹת רַבָּה

“and he gave drink abundantly as the deep”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the deep** has limitless water, so God provided limitless water for his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he gave them water as limitless as the deep]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:15 (#3)

וַיַּשְׁקְ כִּתְהֹמוֹת רַבָּה

“and he gave drink abundantly as the deep”

The psalmist says **and he gave drink abundantly as the deep** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [and he gave them an enormous amount of water to drink]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 78:16 (#1)

כַּנְּהָרוֹת

“like rivers”

The point of this comparison is that just as **rivers** are abundant and continuous in their flow, so was the water that God brought from the rock. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [in great abundance] or [in a continuous stream]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:17 (#1)

וַיּוֹסִיפוּ

“And they added”

The pronoun **they** refers to the Israelites, the ancestors of those whom the psalmist is addressing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the Israelite people added] or [And those ancestors added]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 78:17 (#2)

וַיּוֹסִיפוּ עַוד לַחֲטֹא־לוֹ

“And they added still to sin against him”

The psalmist uses the word **And** here to indicate a contrast between God’s gracious provision and the people’s sinful response. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But they added still to sin against him] or [Yet they added still to sin against him]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 78:18 (#1)

וַיְנַסּוּ־אֵל בִּלְבָבָם לִשְׁאָל־אֹכֶל לְנַפְשָׁם

“And they tested God in their hearts by asking {for} food for their appetite”

The psalmist is using the phrase **by asking for food for their appetite** to state the reason for the result that **they tested God in their hearts**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [And they tested God in their hearts when they asked for food for their appetite]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 78:18 (#2)

בִּלְבָבָם

“in their hearts”

Here, **hearts** represents the inner thoughts and attitudes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in their minds] or [inwardly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:18 (#3)

אׇכֶל לְנַפְשָׁם

“for} food for their appetite”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **appetite**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for what they craved] or [for what they desired to eat]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:19 (#1)

הֲיָיוּכַל אֵל לַעֲרֹךְ שֻׁלְחָן בַּמִּדְבָּר

“Can God arrange a table in the wilderness”

The Israelites are using the question form to express doubt about God’s ability to provide for them. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [God cannot arrange a table in the wilderness!] or [Surely God is not able to arrange a table in the wilderness!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 78:19 (#2)

לַעֲרֹךְ שֻׁלְחָן

“arrange a table”

The Israelites are speaking of God providing food as if he were **arranging a table** for a meal. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [provide food for us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:20 (#1)

הֲגַם־לֶחֶם יוּכַל תֵּתֵת אִם־יָכִין שְׁאֵאר לְעַמּוֹ

“Is he able to give bread also? Or can he provide meat for his people”

The Israelites are using the question form to express their doubt that God can provide different kinds of food. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [But surely he cannot give bread also! Surely he cannot provide meat for his people!] or [But he is not able to give bread also. He cannot provide meat for his people.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 78:20 (#2)

לְעַמּוֹ

“for his people”

The people are speaking of themselves in the third person as **his people** to acknowledge their relationship with God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [for us, his people]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 78:21 (#1)

וְאֵשׁ נִשְּׁקָה בְיַעֲקֹב

“and a fire was kindled against Jacob”

The expression **a fire was kindled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh kindled a fire against Jacob] or [and Yahweh’s anger burned against Jacob]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 78:21 (#2)

וְאֵשׁ נִשְּׁקָה בְיַעֲקֹב

“and a fire was kindled against Jacob”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s anger as if it were **a fire** that could be **kindled**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh became furiously angry against Jacob] or [and Yahweh’s anger burned against Jacob]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:21 (#3)

וְגַם־אַ֥ף עָ֝לָ֗ה בְּיִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“and also {his} nose went up against Israel”

Here, **nose** represents anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and also his anger burned against Israel] or [and also he became angry with Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:21 (#4)

בְּיַעֲקֹ֑ב & בְּיִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“against Jacob & against Israel”

Here, **Jacob** and **Israel** represent the entire nation descended from this patriarch. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [against the people of Jacob ... against the people of Israel] or [against the nation of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:22 (#1)

כִּֽי־לֹ֤א הֶ֥אֱמִינוּ בֵֽאלֹהִ֑ים וְ֝לֹ֗א בָּ֣טְחוּ בִּישׁוּעָתֽוֹ

“because they did not believe in God and did not trust in his salvation”

The word translated as **because** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [since they did not believe in God and did not trust in his salvation]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 78:22 (#2)

בָּ֣טְחוּ בִּישׁוּעָתֽוֹ

“and did & trust in his salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and that he would save them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:23 (#1)

וַיְצַ֥ו

“Yet he commanded”

The psalmist uses the word **Yet** here to indicate a contrast between the Israelites’ unbelief and God’s gracious provision. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But he commanded] or [Even so, he commanded]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 78:23 (#2)

וַיְצַ֣ו שְׁ֭חָקִים מִמָּ֑עַל וְדַלְתֵ֖י שָׁמַ֣יִם פָּתָֽח

“Yet he commanded the clouds from above and opened the doors of the sky”

The psalmist is speaking of the sky as if it were a building with **doors** that God opened. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yet he gave orders to the sky above and caused the heavens to open]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:23 (#3)

וַיְצַ֣ו שְׁ֭חָקִים

“Yet he commanded the clouds”

The psalmist is speaking of **the clouds** as if they were living things that could hear and obey God’s commands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He controlled the clouds]

See: Personification

Psalms 78:24 (#1)

וַיַּמְטֵ֣ר עֲ֭לֵיהֶם מָ֣ן לֶֽאֱכֹ֑ל

“And he rained down manna to eat on them”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a weather phenomenon, and **he rained down manna** from the sky. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the

meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He caused manna to fall down from the sky]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:24 (#2)

וּדְגַן־שָׁמַיִם

“and & the grain of heaven”

The phrase **the grain of heaven** could mean: (1) the grain that angels eat or (2) the grain that came from heaven. The next verse supports the first meaning.

Psalms 78:24 (#3)

וּדְגַן־שָׁמַיִם

“and & the grain of heaven”

The psalmist is using **grain** to represent all of the manna that God provided. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and ... the food from heaven] or [and ... the provision from heaven]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 78:25 (#1)

אָכַל אִישׁ

“Man ate”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **Man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [People ate]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 78:25 (#2)

לֶחֶם

“the bread”

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the food] or [the grain]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 78:25 (#3)

אַבִּירִים

“of the mighty”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **the mighty** refers to angels. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [of angels]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 78:25 (#4)

צֵידָה & לָשֹׂבַע

“provision to {their} satisfaction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **satisfaction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [enough food to satisfy them] or [abundant food]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:27 (#1)

וַיַּמְטֵר עֲלֵיהֶם כָּעָפָר שְׁאֵר

“And he rained down meat on them like dust”

The psalmist is speaking of the meat as if it were rain that God **rained down** on the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He caused meat to fall on them in great abundance] or [He gave them a huge amount of meat]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:27 (#2)

וְכִחוֹל יַמִּים עוֹף כָּנָף

“and birds of wing as the sands of the sea”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he rained down birds of wing as numerous as the sands of the sea]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 78:27 (#3)

עוֹף כָּנָף

“birds of wing”

It might seem that the expression **birds of wing** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [birds]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 78:27 (#4)

עֹעֵוף כָּנָף

“birds of wing”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **birds** that are characterized by having **wings**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [winged birds] or [flying birds]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:27 (#5)

כֶּעָפָר & וּכְחוֹל יַמִּים

“like dust, and & as the sands of the sea”

The psalmist says **like dust** and **as the sands of the sea** as extreme statements for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [in great quantities and ... beyond counting]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 78:28 (#1)

וַיַּפֵּל בְּקֶרֶב מַחֲנֵהוּ סָבִיב לְמִשְׁכְּנֹתָיו

“And he caused them to fall in the middle of his camp, around his dwellings”

The pronoun **his** refers to the people of Israel, not to God. The psalmist is describing the birds falling into the Israelites’ camp and near their tents. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [They fell in the middle of the Israelites’ camp, all around the Israelites’ tents]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 78:28 (#2)

מַחֲנֵהוּ סָבִיב לְמִשְׁכְּנֹתָיו

“of his camp, around his dwellings”

Here, **his** refers to the Israelites. See the book introduction for more information.

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 78:29 (#1)

וְתַאֲוָתָם יָבִיא לָהֶם

“And he brought their craving to them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **craving**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He gave them what they craved]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:30 (#1)

מִתַּאֲוָתָם

“from their craving”

See how you translated the similar expression in 78:29.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:31 (#1)

וְאַף אֱלֹהִים ׀ עָלָה בָהֶם

“and the nose of God went up in them”

See how you translated the similar expression in 78:21.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:31 (#2)

וּבַחוּרֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל הִכְרִיעַ

“and he caused the young men of Israel to bow down”

The psalmist is speaking of the young men dying as if God were physically forcing them to **bow down** to the ground. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he struck down the young men of Israel] or [and he made the young men of Israel fall dead]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:32 (#1)

בְּנִפְלְאוֹתָיו

“in his wonders”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wonders**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in the wonderful things he did] or [that he could do wonderful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:33 (#1)

וַיְכַל־בַּהֶבֶל יְמֵיהֶם וּשְׁנוֹתָם בַּבֶּהָלָה

“So he consumed their days in a vapor, and their years in terror”

This is poetic language. The psalmist moves from shorter units of time (**days**) to longer units (**years**) to emphasize the completeness of God’s judgment. If

your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [So he ended their lives quickly, like a breath, and their years were full of fear]

See: Poetry

Psalms 78:33 (#2)

וַיְכַל & יְמֵיהֶם

“So he consumed their days”

The psalmist is referring to God ending the lives of the Israelites in a polite way by using the phrase **he consumed their days**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [So he ended their days] or [So he caused their days to vanish]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 78:33 (#3)

וַיְכַל־בַּהֶבֶל יְמֵיהֶם

“So he consumed their days in a vapor”

The psalmist is speaking of **their days** as if they were something that could be **consumed** (used up) **in a vapor** (as quickly as a puff of breath disappears). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [So he caused their days to quickly vanish like vapor] or [So he caused their days to pass swiftly like a breath]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:33 (#4)

וּשְׁנוֹתָם בַּבֶּהָלָה

“and their years in terror”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he consumed their years in terror]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 78:33 (#5)

יְמֵיהֶם וּשְׁנוֹתָם

“their days & and their years”

Here, **their days** and **their years** represent their lives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their lives ... and their lives]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:34 (#1)

אִם־הָרָגָם וּדְרָשֻׁהוּ

“When he killed them, then they would seek him”

The psalmist is describing repeated events, not a single occurrence. The word **When** indicates that this pattern happened multiple times. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a word or phrase that shows this repetition. Alternate translation: [Each time God afflicted them, they would seek him]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Psalms 78:35 (#1)

וַיִּזְכְּרוּ כִּי־אֱלֹהִים צוּרָם וְאֵאֵל עֶלְיוֹן גֹּאֲלָם

“And they would remember that God was their rock and {that} God Most High was their redeemer”

See the note on 78:1 or the Introduction to the Psalms for more information on how to translate parallelisms. Alternate translation: [They would remember that God Most High was their rock and redeemer]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 78:35 (#2)

אֱלֹהִים צוּרָם

“God was their rock”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a **rock** that provided protection and stability. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture, or you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God was their refuge] or [God was their protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:35 (#3)

וְאֵאֵל עֶלְיוֹן גֹּאֲלָם

“and {that} God Most High was their redeemer”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they would remember that God Most High was their rescuer]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 78:36 (#1)

בְּפִיהֶם וּבִלְשׁוֹנָם

“with their mouth and & with their tongues”

Here, **with their mouth** and **with their tongues** represent what the people said by using their mouth and words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by what they said to him and … in what they told him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:37 (#1)

וְלִבָּם לֹא־נָכוֹן עִמּוֹ

“And their hearts were not steadfast with him”

Here, **hearts** represents the people’s inner desires and commitment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And they were not truly committed to him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:37 (#2)

וְלִבָּם לֹא־נָכוֹן עִמּוֹ

“And their hearts were not steadfast with him”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **steadfast**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And they were not loyal to him in their hearts] or [And they did not remain faithful toward him in their hearts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:38 (#1)

וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֵּר עָוֹן וְלֹא יַשְׁחִית וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ וְלֹא־יָעִיר כָּל־חֲמָתוֹ

“And many times he held back his nose and did not stir up all his wrath”

The psalmist is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with an expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [Many times he chose to be patient with his people]

See: Litotes

Psalms 78:38 (#2)

לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ

“he held back his nose”

Here, **nose** represents anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he held back his anger] or [he restrained his anger]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:38 (#3)

לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ

“he held back his nose”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s anger as if it were something physical that God **held back** to keep it from going out toward the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he restrained his anger] or [he controlled his anger]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:38 (#4)

וְלֹא־יָעִיר כָּל־חֲמָתוֹ

“and did not stir up all his wrath”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s wrath as if it were something dormant that he could **stir up** or arouse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and did not cause his full wrath to awaken] or [and did not unleash the full extent of his anger]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:39 (#1)

בָּשָׂר הֵמָּה

“they were flesh”

Here, **flesh** represents the weakness and frailty of human nature. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they were weak and frail] or [they were mortal]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:39 (#2)

רוּחַ הוֹלֵךְ וְלֹא יָשׁוּב

“a wind going and it does not return”

The psalmist is speaking of human beings as if they were **a wind going and it does not return**. He means

that human life is brief and fragile, like a wind that blows by once and then is gone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [mortal beings whose lives quickly end]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:41 (#1)

וַיָּשׁוּבוּ וַיְנַסּוּ אֵל

“And they returned and they tested God”

The psalmist is using the expression **they returned and they tested** as a common expression of the culture to mean “they repeatedly tested.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They tested God again and again] or [They continually tested God]

See: Idiom

Psalms 78:41 (#2)

וְקִדֹּושׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל הִתְווּ

“and grieved the Holy {One} of Israel”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe the holy God with whom the Israelites are in a covenant relationship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and grieved the holy God with whom the Israelites are in a covenant relationship]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:41 (#3)

וְקִדֹּושׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל

“and & the Holy {One} of Israel”

The expression **the Holy One of Israel** is a title for God.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 78:42 (#1)

לֹא־זָכְרוּ אֶת־יָדֹו

“They did not remember his hand”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his power] or [his strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:42 (#2)

יֹום

“the day”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **day**. He means the time in general when God redeemed the Israelites from Egypt. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the time]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 78:42 (#3)

פָּדָם מִנִּי־צָר

“he redeemed them from the adversary”

Here, **the adversary** represents Egypt and Pharaoh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [he redeemed them from Egypt] or [he redeemed them from Pharaoh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:43 (#1)

צֹעַן

“of Zoan”

See how you translated this in 78:12. **Zoan** was a city in Egypt.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 78:45 (#1)

וּצְפַרְדֵּעַ

“and the frog”

Here, **the frog** represents frogs in general, not one particular frog. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and the frogs]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 78:45 (#2)

וּצְפַרְדֵּעַ

“and the frog”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order

to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he sent the frog]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 78:46 (#1)

לֶחָסִיל & וְיִגִיעָם

“to the locust and their labor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **labor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and what they had labored to produce]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:46 (#2)

וְיִגִיעָם

“and their labor”

Here, **labor** represents the produce or results of their labor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and what their labor produced] or [and the fruit of their labor]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:48 (#1)

וַיַּסְגֵּר לַבָּרָד בְּעִירָם וּמִקְנֵיהֶם

“And he gave over their cattle to the hail and their livestock”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a commander who **gave over** the Egyptians’ **cattle to the hail** as if the hail were an enemy army that would attack them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he caused the hail to kill their cattle and gave their livestock] or [And he allowed the hail to strike down their cattle and gave their livestock]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:49 (#1)

בָּבָם ׀ חֲרוֹן אַפּוֹ עֶבְרָה וְזַעַם

“among them the burning of his nose, fury and indignation”

The psalmist is using the phrase **the burning of his nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean that God is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [among them his fierce anger] or [among them his burning anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 78:49 (#2)

עֶבְרָה וְזַעַם וְצָרָה

“fury and indignation and distress”

The terms **fury**, **indignation**, and **distress** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the three terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [great wrath]

See: Doublet

Psalms 78:49 (#3)

יְשַׁלַּח־בָּבָם ׀ חֲרוֹן אַפּוֹ עֶבְרָה וְזַעַם וְצָרָה מִמְשְׁלַחַת מַלְאֲכֵי רָעִים

“He sent among them the burning of his nose, fury and indignation and distress, a group of messengers of calamity”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **fury**, **indignation**, **distress**, and **calamity**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [He furiously and indignantly distressed them with disastrous messengers]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:49 (#4)

יְשַׁלַּח־בָּבָם ׀ חֲרוֹן אַפּוֹ עֶבְרָה וְזַעַם וְצָרָה מִמְשְׁלַחַת מַלְאֲכֵי רָעִים

“He sent among them the burning of his nose, fury and indignation and distress, a group of messengers of calamity”

The psalmist is speaking of **fury and indignation and distress** as if they were living things that could be sent as **messengers** to carry out God’s judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He vented on them his great anger and fury, causing them trouble and disaster]

See: Personification

Psalms 78:49 (#5)

יְשַׁלַּח־בָּבָם ׀ חֲרוֹן אַפּוֹ עֶבְרָה וְזַעַם

“He sent among them the burning of his nose, fury and indignation”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s anger as if it were a weapon or force that **He sent** out to strike the Egyptians. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His fierce anger struck them with fury and indignation] or [He attacked them with his fierce anger]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:50 (#1)

יְפַלֵּס נָתִיב לְאַפּוֹ

“He made level a path for his anger”

The psalmist is speaking of **his anger** as if it were something that could travel along a **path**. He means that God fully released his anger against the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He gave full vent to his anger] or [He released his anger without restraint]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:50 (#2)

וְחַיָּתָם לַדֶּבֶר הִסְגִּיר

“and their life he gave over to the plague”

The psalmist is speaking of the lives of the Egyptians as if they were something God could physically give **over to the plague**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but allowed them to die from the plague] or [but caused the plague to kill them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:51 (#1)

רֵאשִׁית אוֹנִים

“the beginning of strength”

The psalmist is using **the beginning of strength** as a common expression of the culture to mean the **firstborn** sons. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the firstborn sons] or [the oldest sons]

See: Idiom

Psalms 78:51 (#2)

בְּאָהֳלֵי־חָם

“in the tents of Ham”

Here, **tents** represents the families who lived in them, and **Ham** represents the people of Egypt, who were descended from him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the households of Egypt] or [among the people of Egypt]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:52 (#1)

וַיַּסַּע כַּצֹּאן עַמּוֹ וַיְנַהֲגֵם כַּעֵדֶר בַּמִּדְבָּר

“And he made his people journey like sheep, and he led them like a flock in the wilderness”

The point of this comparison is that just as **sheep** need a shepherd to guide and care for them, so did God’s people need God to guide and care for them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And he made his people journey, guiding and caring for them like a shepherd does for sheep, and he led them, protecting them like a shepherd protects a flock in the wilderness]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:53 (#1)

לָבֶטַח

“in security”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **security**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [securely] or [safely]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:54 (#1)

וַיְבִיאֵם

“And he brought them”

The pronoun **he** refers to God, while the pronoun **them** refers to the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And God brought the Israelites]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 78:54 (#2)

גְּבוּל קָדְשׁוֹ

“of his holiness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **the border** that is characterized by **his holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the border of the land he had set apart] or [the border of his holy land]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:54 (#3)

קָדְשֹׁ֑ו

“of his holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of what is holy to him] or [of what he had set apart]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:54 (#4)

קָנְתָ֥ה יְמִינֹֽו

“that his right hand acquired”

Here, **his right hand** represents the power of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that he acquired by his power] or [that his power acquired]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:55 (#1)

וַיְגָ֣רֶשׁ מִפְּנֵיהֶ֣ם ׀ גֹויִ֑ם

“And he drove out nations”

The pronoun **he** refers to God, while the pronoun **them** refers to the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God drove out nations from before the Israelites]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 78:55 (#2)

וַיַּפִּילֵ֣ם בְּחֶ֣בֶל נַחֲלָ֑ה

“of inheritance”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the Canaanites whom God **caused them to fall in a portion of inheritance**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and caused them to be defeated in each portion that Israel inherited] or [and defeated them in each portion that Israel inherited as they came to it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:55 (#3)

בְּחֶ֣בֶל נַחֲלָ֑ה

“of inheritance”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean a portion for inheriting. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in each portion inherited by Israel] or [in each portion that Israel inherited]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:55 (#4)

בְּחֶ֣בֶל נַחֲלָ֑ה

“of inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and gave each tribe a portion to inherit] or [and gave each tribe of Israel a portion as their own]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:56 (#1)

וַיְנַסּ֥וּ וַ֝יַּמְרֹ֗ו

“But they tested and rebelled”

The psalmist uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between God’s provision and the people’s rebellion. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Despite all this, they tested and rebelled] or [Even so, they tested and rebelled]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 78:56 (#2)

וַיְנַסּ֥וּ וַ֝יַּמְרֹ֗ו

“But they tested and rebelled”

The terms **tested** and **rebelled** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [But they continually pushed back] or [But they stubbornly rebelled]

See: Doublet

Psalms 78:57 (#1)

וַיִּסֹּ֣גוּ וַיִּבְגְּד֗וּ כַּאֲבוֹתָ֫ם נֶהְפְּכ֥וּ כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וַיִּסֹּ֣גוּ וַיִּבְגְּד֗וּ כַּאֲבוֹתָ֫ם נֶהְפְּכ֥וּ כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה”

For more information on translating parallelism, see the note at 78:1. Alternate translation: [They turned back and acted treacherously like their fathers, being as unreliable as a bow of deceit]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 78:57 (#2)

כַּאֲבוֹתָ֫ם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כַּאֲבוֹתָ֫ם”

The point of this comparison is that just as **their fathers** were unfaithful to God, so were the Israelites. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [in the same unfaithful way as their fathers]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:57 (#3)

כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a bow of deceit** is unreliable and does not shoot straight, so were the Israelites unreliable. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as unreliable as a faulty bow]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:57 (#4)

כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **a bow** that is characterized by **deceit**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [into a deceitful bow] or [as a faulty bow]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:57 (#5)

כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כְּקֶ֥שֶׁת רְמִיָּֽה”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [into a deceitful bow] or [as a faulty bow]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:58 (#1)

יַקְנִיאֻ֑הוּ

“they moved him to jealousy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **jealousy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they caused him to be jealous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:59 (#1)

שָׁמַ֣ע אֱ֭לֹהִים וַיִּתְעַבָּ֑ר

“God”

The term translated as **and** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [God heard, and as a result, he was furious] or [When God heard, he was furious]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 78:60 (#1)

וַיִּטֹּ֗שׁ מִשְׁכַּ֣ן שִׁלֹ֑ה

“And he abandoned the dwelling of Shiloh”

The term translated as **And** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [Therefore, he abandoned the dwelling of Shiloh] or [So he abandoned the dwelling of Shiloh]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 78:61 (#1)

וַיִּתֵּ֣ן לַשִּׁבְי֣וֹ עֻזּ֑וֹ

“And he gave his strength to captivity”

Here, **his strength** represents the box of the covenant, which showed God’s power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And he allowed the box to be captured] or [And he let the box that showed his power be captured]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:61 (#2)

עֻזּוֹ

“his strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what showed he was strong] or [the box that showed his power]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:61 (#3)

לַשִּׁבְיָ

“to captivity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **captivity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to be captured] or [to those who would capture it]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:61 (#4)

וְתִפְאַרְתּוֹ

“and his splendor”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he gave his splendor]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 78:61 (#5)

וְתִפְאַרְתּוֹ בְּיַד־צָר

“and his splendor into the hand of the enemy”

Here, **his splendor** represents the box of the covenant, and **the hand of the enemy** represents their power or control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use equivalent expressions or plain language. Alternate translation: [and his glorious box into the power of the enemy] or [and the box that showed his splendor to be controlled by the enemy]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:61 (#6)

וְתִפְאַרְתּוֹ

“and his splendor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and what was splendid to him] or [and the ark that showed he was glorious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:62 (#1)

וַיַּסְגֵּר לַחֶרֶב עַמּוֹ

“his people & to the sword”

Here, **the sword** represents warfare or violent death in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he allowed his people to be killed in battle] or [And he delivered his people over to violent death]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:62 (#2)

וּבְנַחֲלָתוֹ

“and & with his inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. See how you translated this in 78:55. Alternate translation: [and ... with the people he had chosen]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:63 (#1)

בַּחוּרָיו אָכְלָה־אֵשׁ וּבְתוּלֹתָיו לֹא הוֹלָלוּ

“Fire consumed his young men, and his virgins were not praised {in} wedding songs”

The phrases **Fire consumed his young men** and **his virgins were not praised** mean opposite things but work together to show the devastating completeness of the judgment. For emphasis, the psalmist is describing both the death of young men and the corresponding lack of marriage celebrations. If a speaker of your language would not use this kind of contrast, in your translation you can convey the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [Fire consumed his young men so that his virgins had no weddings]

See: Merism

Psalms 78:63 (#2)

בַּחוּרָיו אָכְלָה־אֵשׁ

“Fire consumed his young men”

The psalmist speaks of **Fire** as if it were a person that could actively consume people. If it would be helpful

in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His young men died in fires] or [His young men were burned to death]

See: Personification

Psalms 78:63 (#3)

וּבְתוּלֹתָ֖יו לֹ֣א הוֹלָ֑לוּ

“and his virgins were not praised {in} wedding songs”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and no one praised his virgins in wedding songs] or [and no one sang wedding songs for his virgins]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 78:64 (#1)

בַּחֶ֣רֶב נָפָ֣לוּ

“fell”

Here, **the sword** represents violent death in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [died in battle] or [were killed in war]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:65 (#1)

וַיִּקַ֣ץ & אֲדֹנָ֑י

“the Lord”

The psalmist uses the word **Then** to indicate a contrast between God’s judgment and his intervention. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But then the Lord awoke] or [After this, the Lord awoke]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 78:65 (#2)

וַיִּקַ֣ץ כְּיָשֵׁ֑ן ׀ אֲדֹנָ֑י

“the Lord”

The psalmist speaks of **the Lord** as if he were a person who could sleep and wake up. He means that God had seemed inactive during the time of judgment but then became active again to help his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then the Lord acted as if he had awakened from sleep] or [Then the Lord began to act again after seeming to be inactive]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:65 (#3)

כְּיָשֵׁ֑ן

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כְּיָשֵׁ֑ן”

The point of this comparison is that just as **one sleeping** must wake up before acting, so the Lord resumed acting after a period of seeming inactivity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like someone who had been asleep]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:65 (#4)

כְּגִבּ֥וֹר מִתְרוֹנֵ֗ן מִיָּֽיִן

“shouting”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a mighty man** who has been drinking wine might shout loudly and powerfully, so the Lord acted with great power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a powerful warrior shouting with great strength]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:66 (#1)

חֶרְפַּ֖ת עֹ֣לָ֑ם

“of perpetuity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **perpetuity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a shame that lasts forever] or [permanent disgrace]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:68 (#1)

וַיִּבְחַ֗ר אֶת־שֵׁ֫בֶט יְהוּדָ֥ה

“But he chose the tribe of Judah”

The psalmist uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between rejecting Joseph and Ephraim and choosing Judah. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Instead, he chose the tribe of Judah]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 78:68 (#2)

אֶת־הַר צִיּוֹן אֲשֶׁר

“Mount Zion, which”

Here, **Mount Zion** represents the tribe of Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Judah’s descendants, who]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 78:69 (#1)

וַיִּבֶן כְּמוֹ־רָמִים מִקְדָּשׁוֹ כְּאֶרֶץ יְסָדָהּ לְעוֹלָם

“And he built his sanctuary like the heights, like the earth he founded it forever”

The phrase **he built his sanctuary like the heights** is parallel to the statement **like the earth he founded it forever** and clarifies the relationship between the sanctuary’s grandeur and its permanence. Alternate translation: [And he built his sanctuary to be as exalted as the heavens and as permanent as the earth]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 78:69 (#2)

כְּמוֹ־רָמִים

“like the heights”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the heights** are exalted and majestic, so is God’s sanctuary. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as exalted as the heavens]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:69 (#3)

כְּאֶרֶץ יְסָדָהּ לְעוֹלָם

“like the earth he founded it forever”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the earth** is permanent and enduring, so God **founded** his sanctuary to last **forever**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as enduring as the earth, he founded it to last forever]

See: Simile

Psalms 78:71 (#1)

לִרְעוֹת בְּיַעֲקֹב עַמּוֹ

“to shepherd & his people”

The term translated as **to** indicates that what follows is a purpose or goal of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order to shepherd Jacob his people] or [so that he would shepherd Jacob his people]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 78:71 (#2)

לִרְעוֹת בְּיַעֲקֹב עַמּוֹ

“to shepherd & his people”

The psalmist is speaking of **Jacob his people** as if they were sheep that needed someone **to shepherd** them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to lead and care for Jacob his people] or [to rule over Jacob his people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 78:71 (#3)

נַחֲלָתוֹ

“his inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the people who belonged to him] or [the people he had chosen as his own]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:72 (#1)

כְּתֹם לְבָבָם

“of his heart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **integrity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with an honest heart] or [with a pure heart]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:72 (#2)

כְּתֹם לְבָבָם

“of his heart”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **his heart** that is characterized by **integrity**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to his honest heart]

See: Possession

Psalms 78:72 (#3)

וּבִתְבוּנוֹת כַּפָּיו יַנְחֵם

“and with the skillfulness & he guided them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **skillfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and with his skillful hands he guided them] or [and he guided them skillfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 78:72 (#4)

וּבִתְבוּנוֹת כַּפָּיו יַנְחֵם

“and with the skillfulness & he guided them”

Here, **his hands** represents the actions and capabilities of David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and with his skill he guided them] or [and he guided them with his abilities]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 79 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 79 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm except a statement of trust. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Description of troubles (1–4)
2. Cry for help (5–7)
3. Petition: request for forgiveness (8–9)
4. Petition: request for retribution (10–12)
5. Vow of praise (13)

Translation Issues in this Psalm

Imperatives

Throughout this psalm, the psalmist is requesting things from Yahweh by using an imperative form which may sound like a command in your language. If this would be impolite in your language, then use a form that would be more appropriate for addressing Yahweh with a request.

Parallelisms

Parallelisms arise when two phrases occur together which mean the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea using different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one and not saying something additional. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing.

Psalms 79:1 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים בָּאוּ גוֹיִם ׀ בְּנַחֲלָתֶךָ

“God, nations have come into your inheritance”

Asaph is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of anguish over the invasion of Israel. If your language has a comparable way to express this feeling, you could use it in your translation. Alternate translation: [O God, nations have invaded your inheritance]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 79:1 (#2)

גוֹיִם

“nations”

Here Asaph is introducing the **nations** as new participants in the psalm. He does not specify which nations, but refers to foreign peoples in general. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [foreign nations]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Psalms 79:1 (#3)

בְּנַחֲלָתֶךָ

“into your inheritance”

Here Asaph is speaking of the land of Israel being different than other parts of the earth by calling it God’s **inheritance**. This means the land that God specially reserved for him and his people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [into your special possession]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 79:1 (#4)

בְּנַחֲלָתֶֽךָ

“into your inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [into what you have inherited]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:1 (#5)

קָדְשֶֽׁךָ

“your holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you who are holy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:1 (#6)

בָּ֭אוּ גוֹיִ֣ם ׀ בְּנַחֲלָתֶ֑ךָ טִמְּא֥וּ אֶת־הֵיכַ֗ל קָדְשֶׁ֫ךָ שָׂ֥מוּ אֶת־יְרוּשָׁלַ֥ם לְעִיִּֽים

“nations have come into your inheritance; they have defiled the temple of your holiness; they have made Jerusalem into heaps”

These three phrases all describe the enemy’s attack on what belongs to God. Each phrase intensifies the devastation, moving from invasion to defilement to destruction. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. For more information on how to translate parallel phrases see the Psalm 79 Introduction. Alternate translation: [nations have invaded your land, made your holy temple unclean, and turned Jerusalem into piles of rubble]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 79:2 (#1)

לְע֣וֹף הַשָּׁמַ֑יִם

“to the bird of the heavens”

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe a **bird** that lives in **the heavens**, that is, the sky. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to the birds that fly in the sky]

See: Possession

Psalms 79:2 (#2)

בְּשַׂ֣ר חֲסִידֶ֭יךָ לְחַיְתוֹ־אֶ֑רֶץ

“the flesh of your faithful to the beast of the earth”

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they have given the flesh of your faithful as food to the beast of the earth]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 79:2 (#3)

חֲסִידֶ֭יךָ

“your faithful”

Asaph is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean people who are faithful to God. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [your faithful ones]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 79:2 (#4)

לְחַיְתוֹ־אֶ֑רֶץ

“to the beast of the earth”

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe a **beast** that lives on **the earth**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to the animals that live on the land]

See: Possession

Psalms 79:2 (#5)

לְע֣וֹף הַשָּׁמַ֑יִם & לְחַיְתוֹ־אֶ֑רֶץ

“to the bird of the heavens & to the beast of the earth”

The terms **the bird** and **the beast** are singular collective nouns that refer to all birds and all beasts as a group. If your language does not use singular nouns in that way, you can use plural forms in your translation.

See: Collective Nouns

Psalms 79:2 (#6)

לְע֣וֹף הַשָּׁמַ֑יִם & לְחַיְתוֹ־אֶ֑רֶץ

“to the bird of the heavens & to the beast of the earth”

Asaph is referring to all wild creatures by naming two major components, **bird of the heavens** and **beast of the earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to every kind of bird ... to every kind of wild creature]

See: Merism

Psalms 79:3 (#1)

דָּמָ֣ם

“their blood”

Here, **their blood** represents their violent death. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the blood of those they killed]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:3 (#2)

כַּמַּ֣יִם

“like water”

The point of this comparison is that just as **water** flows freely and abundantly, so the blood of the slain was shed in great quantity. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as freely as water is poured out]

See: Simile

Psalms 79:3 (#3)

וְאֵ֥ין קוֹבֵֽר

“and there is no burying”

Asaph is providing background information to help readers understand the situation. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Psalms 79:4 (#1)

הָיִ֥ינוּ

“We have become”

Here Asaph is using the word **We** to introduce the community of Israel as speakers for the first time in the psalm. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [We, your people, have become]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Psalms 79:4 (#2)

חֶ֭רְפָּה לִשְׁכֵנֵ֣ינוּ לַ֑עַג וָ֝קֶ֗לֶס לִסְבִיבוֹתֵֽינוּ

“a reproach to our neighbors, scorn and derision to the ones around us”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. The poetry of the original language was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [those whom our neighbors insult and mock]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 79:4 (#3)

חֶ֭רְפָּה

“a reproach”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people whom others reproach]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:4 (#4)

לַ֑עַג וָ֝קֶ֗לֶס לִסְבִיבוֹתֵֽינוּ

“scorn and derision to the ones around us”

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and we have become scorn and derision to the ones around us]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 79:4 (#5)

לַ֑עַג וָ֝קֶ֗לֶס

“scorn and derision”

The terms **scorn** and **derision** mean similar things. Asaph is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [utter mockery]

See: Doublet

Psalms 79:4 (#6)

לַֽעַג וָקֶ֗לֶס לִסְבִיבוֹתֵֽינוּ

“scorn and derision to the ones around us”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **scorn** and **derision**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [people whom others scorn and deride]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:5 (#1)

עַד־מָ֭תַי יְהוָ֣ה תֶּאֱנַ֣ף לָ֑נֶ֝צַח תִּבְעַ֣ר כְּמוֹ־אֵ֭שׁ קִנְאָתֶֽךָ

“Until when, Yahweh? Will you be angry forever? Will your jealousy burn like fire”

These two phrases **Will you be angry forever** and **Will your jealousy burn like fire** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. The poetry of the original language was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [How long, Yahweh, will you remain fiercely angry with us]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 79:5 (#2)

עַד־מָ֭תַי יְהוָ֣ה

“Until when, Yahweh”

Asaph is using the question form to express lament and anguish rather than to seek information. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, it has been so long!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 79:5 (#3)

תֶּאֱנַ֣ף לָ֑נֶ֝צַח

“Will you be angry forever”

Asaph is using the question form to express anguish at the duration of God’s anger rather than to ask for information. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please do not stay angry forever!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 79:5 (#4)

לָ֑נֶ֝צַח

“forever”

Asaph says **forever** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [without end]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 79:5 (#5)

תִּבְעַ֣ר כְּמוֹ־אֵ֭שׁ קִנְאָתֶֽךָ

“Will your jealousy burn like fire”

Asaph is using the question form to express distress rather than to ask for information. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Do not let your jealousy keep burning like fire!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 79:5 (#6)

קִנְאָתֶֽךָ

“your jealousy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **jealousy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how jealous you are cause us to]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:5 (#7)

כְּמוֹ־אֵ֭שׁ

“like fire”

The point of this comparison is that just as **fire** is intense and consuming, so is God’s jealousy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as intensely as a fire burns]

See: Simile

Psalms 79:6 (#1)

שְׁפֹ֤ךְ חֲמָתְךָ֙ אֶל־הַגּוֹיִ֣ם אֲשֶׁ֣ר לֹא־יְדָעֻ֑וךָ וְעַ֥ל מַמְלָכ֗וֹת אֲשֶׁ֤ר בְּשִׁמְךָ֙ לֹ֣א קָרָ֔אוּ

“Pour out your wrath on the nations that have not known you and on the kingdoms that have not called on your name”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request to God rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please.” For more information on imperatives, see the Psalm 79 Introduction. See how you as a team have decided to translate imperatives and follow that approach here and throughout this Psalm. Alternate translation: [Please pour out your wrath on the nations that have not known you and on the kingdoms that have not called on your name]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 79:6 (#2)

שְׁפֹךְ חֲמָתְךָ

“Pour out your wrath”

Here Asaph is speaking as if God’s wrath were a liquid that he could **pour out**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Unleash your wrath]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 79:6 (#3)

שְׁפֹךְ חֲמָתְךָ אֶל־הַגּוֹיִם֮ אֲשֶׁ֪ר לֹא־יְדָ֫עֻ֥וךָ וְעַ֥ל מַמְלָכ֑וֹת

“Pour out your wrath on the nations that have not known you and on the kingdoms”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Show the peoples that do not worship you how angry you are and also the kingdoms]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:6 (#4)

וְעַ֥ל מַמְלָכ֑וֹת אֲשֶׁ֪ר בְּ֫שִׁמְךָ֥ לֹ֣א קָרָ֑אוּ

“and on the kingdoms that have not called on your name”

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and pour out your wrath on the kingdoms that have not called on your name]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 79:6 (#5)

בְּ֫שִׁמְךָ֥

“on your name”

Here, **name** represents who God is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:7 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 79:7 (#2)

אָכַ֣ל אֶת־יַעֲקֹ֑ב

“one has devoured Jacob”

Here Asaph is speaking as if the enemy were a wild animal that **devoured** its prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [one has destroyed the people of Jacob]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 79:7 (#3)

אָכַ֣ל

“one has devoured”

The pronoun **one** is indefinite and refers to the enemy nations mentioned in verse 6. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the enemy has devoured]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 79:7 (#4)

אֶת־יַעֲקֹ֑ב

“Jacob”

Asaph is using the name **Jacob** to represent the nation of Israel, which descended from the patriarch Jacob.

If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:7 (#5)

הֵשַׁמּוּ

“they have desolated”

The pronoun **they** shifts from the singular “one” and refers to the enemy nations. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the nations have desolated]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 79:7 (#6)

נָוֵהוּ

“his habitation”

The pronoun **his** refers to Jacob, that is, the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Jacob’s habitation]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 79:8 (#1)

לָנוּ֣ אֲ֭בוֹתֵינוּ רִאשֹׁנִ֑ים

“former iniquities against us”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquities**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wicked things we did in the past]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:8 (#2)

יְקַדְּמ֣וּנוּ רַחֲמֶ֣יךָ

“let your compassions meet us”

Asaph is speaking of **your compassions** as if they were a living thing that could **meet** the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [show us compassion]

See: Personification

Psalms 79:8 (#3)

יְקַדְּמ֣וּנוּ רַחֲמֶ֣יךָ

“let your compassions meet us”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [come to us with your tender care]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:8 (#4)

כִּֽי־דַלּ֥וֹנוּ מְאֹֽד

“for we have become very weak”

Asaph is giving the reason for his urgent request. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this gives the reason for the preceding request. Alternate translation: [because we have become very weak]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 79:9 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵ֣י יִשְׁעֵ֑נוּ

“God of our salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God, the one who saves us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:9 (#2)

עַל־דְּבַ֥ר כְּב֣וֹד־שְׁ֭מֶךָ

“on account of the glory of your name”

Here, **on account of the glory of your name** marks the purpose for the preceding request. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that your name will be glorified]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 79:9 (#3)

כְּב֣וֹד־שְׁ֭מֶךָ

“the glory of your name”

Here, **name** represents God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your glorious reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:9 (#4)

כְּב֣וֹד־שְׁ֭מֶךָ

“the glory of your name”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your glorious name]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:9 (#5)

הַֽחַטֹּאתֵ֥ינוּ

“our sins”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sins**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wrong things we have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:9 (#6)

לְמַ֣עַן שְׁמֶ֑ךָ

“for the sake of your name”

Here, **for the sake of your name** marks the purpose for covering over their sins. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that people will honor your name]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 79:9 (#7)

לְמַ֣עַן שְׁמֶ֑ךָ

“for the sake of your name”

Here, **name** represents God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for the sake of your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:10 (#1)

לָ֤מָּה ׀ יֹ֘אמְרוּ֮ הַגּוֹיִם֒ אַיֵּ֣ה אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֗ם

“Why should the nations say, “Where {is} their God”

Asaph is using the question form to argue that God should act so that the nations will not mock him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Do not let the nations say that their God cannot help them!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 79:10 (#2)

אַיֵּ֣ה אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֗ם

“Where {is} their God”

The nations would be using the question form to mock Israel rather than to ask for information. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Their God cannot help them!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 79:10 (#3)

לָ֤מָּה ׀ יֹ֘אמְרוּ֮ הַגּוֹיִם֒ אַיֵּ֣ה אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֗ם

“Why should the nations say, “Where {is} their God”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [Why should the nations ask where their God is]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Psalms 79:10 (#4)

אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֗ם

“is} their God”

The pronoun **their** refers to the people of Israel, spoken from the perspective of the nations. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [is the God of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 79:10 (#5)

יִוָּדַ֣ע בגיים לְעֵינֵ֑ינוּ נִקְמַ֥ת דַּם־עֲבָדֶ֝יךָ֗ הַשָּׁפוּךְ

“Let the vengeance of the poured-out blood of your servants be known among the nations to our eyes”

The expression **be known among the nations** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Let the nations see you carry out vengeance for killing your servants]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 79:10 (#6)

נִקְמַ֥ת

“the vengeance of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **vengeance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how you avenge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:10 (#7)

דַּם־עֲבָדֶיךָ הַשָּׁפוּךְ

“the poured-out blood of your servants”

The psalmist is speaking as if someone had actually **poured out** the **blood** of Yahweh’s **servants** from a vessel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the shedding of the blood of your servants]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 79:10 (#8)

דַּם־עֲבָדֶיךָ הַשָּׁפוּךְ

“the poured-out blood of your servants”

Here, **the poured-out blood** represents the violent killing of God’s servants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the killing of your servants]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:10 (#9)

דַּם־עֲבָדֶיךָ הַשָּׁפוּךְ

“the poured-out blood of your servants”

The expression **the poured-out blood** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the blood that the nations have shed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 79:10 (#10)

לְעֵינֵינוּ

“to our eyes”

Here, **eyes** represents sight and perception. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [so that we can see it]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:11 (#1)

אֶנְקַת אָסִיר

“the groaning of the prisoner”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **groaning**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how the prisoners groan]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:11 (#2)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **face** represents God’s presence and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [into your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:11 (#3)

כְּגֹדֶל זְרוֹעֲךָ

“according to the greatness of your arm”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **greatness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your great arm]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:11 (#4)

זְרוֹעֲךָ

“your arm”

Here, **arm** represents God’s power and strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 79:11 (#5)

בְּנֵי תְמוּתָה

“the sons of death”

Asaph is using **sons of death** as a common expression to mean “those who are destined to die.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who are condemned to die]

See: Idiom

Psalms 79:12 (#1)

שִׁבְעָתַיִם

“sevenfold”

Asaph says **sevenfold** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [many times over]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 79:12 (#2)

אֶל־חֵיקָם

“into their bosom”

Asaph is using **into their bosom** as a common expression to mean “directly and personally to them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [directly upon them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 79:12 (#3)

חֶרְפָּתָם אֲשֶׁר חֵרְפוּךָ

“their reproach {with} which they have reproached you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could put the object **their reproach with which they have reproached you** before the other information in the sentence, so that the reader understands right away what is to be returned. Alternate translation: [And return their reproach with which they have reproached you, Lord, to our neighbors sevenfold, into their bosom]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 79:12 (#4)

חֶרְפָּתָם

“their reproach”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the insults they have spoken]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 79:13 (#1)

וַאֲנַחְנוּ

“And we”

Asaph places **And we** at the beginning of this verse to mark a shift from petition to a vow of praise. If it would be more natural in your language, you could indicate this transition in another way. Alternate translation: [Then we]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 79:13 (#2)

וְצֹאן מַרְעִיתֶךָ

“and the flock of your pasture”

Here Asaph is speaking of God’s people as if they were a **flock** of sheep that God tends in his **pasture**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones you tend and care for]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 79:13 (#3)

וְצֹאן מַרְעִיתֶךָ

“and the flock of your pasture”

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe a **flock** that is located in God’s **pasture**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the flock that feeds in your pasture]

See: Possession

Psalms 79:13 (#4)

נְנוֹדֶה לְךָ לְעוֹלָם

“will give thanks to you forever”

This concluding vow of praise signals the end of the psalm. Use the natural form in your language for signaling that a song or poem is ending. Alternate translation: [will always give thanks to you]

See: End of Story

Psalms 79:13 (#5)

לְעוֹלָם

“forever”

Asaph says **forever** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [always]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 79:13 (#6)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“to generation and generation”

Asaph says **to generation and generation** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [in every generation that follows]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 79:13 (#7)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“to generation and generation”

Asaph is using a poetic device found in the original language by repeating the word **generation** to express the idea of an unending succession. This is poetic language. If your language has a way to indicate this kind of poetic repetition, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [from one generation to the next]

See: Poetry

Psalms 79:13 (#8)

תְּהִלָּתֶֽךָ

“your praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how praiseworthy you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 80 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 80 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It includes all the basic elements of that type of psalm except a statement of trust. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the Introduction to the Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–2)
2. Refrain (3)
3. Description of troubles (4–6)
4. Refrain (7)
5. Description of troubles (8–13)
6. Petition (14–18)
7. Refrain (19)

Translation Issues in this Psalm

Imperatives

Throughout this psalm, the psalmist is requesting things from Yahweh by using an imperative form which may sound like a command in your language. If this would be impolite in your language, then use a form that would be more appropriate for addressing Yahweh with a request.

Psalms 80:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּ֗חַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּ֗חַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. See how this is translated in Psalm 4:1. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 80:0 (#3)

עֵדֻ֥ת

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עֵדֻ֥ת”

See how you translated the term **testimony** in the superscription to Psalm 8.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 80:1 (#1)

רֹ֭עֵה יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Shepherd of Israel”

Asaph is speaking as if God were a **Shepherd of Israel**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Caretaker of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:1 (#2)

הַאֲזִ֥ינָה

“give ear”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. See how you as

a team have decided to translate imperatives in the Psalms and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. For more information on how to translate imperatives see the Psalm 80 Introduction. Alternate translation: [please pay attention]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 80:1 (#3)

הַאֲזִינָה

“give ear”

Asaph is using the phrase **give ear** to mean “listen to me.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:1 (#4)

נֹהֵג כַּצֹּאן יוֹסֵף

“the one leading Joseph like a flock”

The point of this comparison is that just as a shepherd leads and cares for a flock, so God leads and cares for the descendants of Joseph. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the one caring for the descendants of Joseph as a shepherd cares for a flock]

See: Simile

Psalms 80:1 (#5)

יוֹסֵף

“Joseph”

Here, **Joseph** represents all the people of Israel, particularly the northern tribes descended from Joseph. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Joseph]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:1 (#6)

יֹשֵׁב הַכְּרוּבִים

“Sitter {on} the cherubim”

Asaph is speaking as if God were one who sits on the cherubim. This refers to God being enthroned above the ark of the covenant. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You who are enthroned above the cherubim]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:2 (#1)

לִפְנֵי אֶפְרַיִם

“To the face of Ephraim”

Here, **To the face of** represents being in front of or in the presence of these tribes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [In the presence of Ephraim]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:2 (#2)

עוֹרְרָה

“awaken”

Here Asaph is speaking of God displaying his **might** as if it were something that was sleeping and needed to be told to **awaken.** Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [display] or [take action by using]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:2 (#3)

אֶת־גְּבוּרָתֶךָ

“your might”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **might**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and display your power]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 80:2 (#4)

לִישֵׁעָתָה

“for salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to save us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 80:3 (#1)

וְהָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה

“and make your face shine and let us be saved”

This phrase indicates that what follows, **let us be saved**, is the purpose or goal of what came before. Use

a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [and make your face shine so that we will be saved]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 80:3 (#2)

וְהָאֵ֣ר פָּנֶ֣יךָ

“and make your face shine”

Asaph is speaking as if God’s face were a light that could shine. This represents God showing favor and blessing to his people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and show us your favor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:3 (#3)

וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה

“and let us be saved”

The expression **let us be saved** is a passive verbal form. If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and rescue us]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 80:4 (#1)

אֱלֹהִ֥ים צְבָאֹ֑ות

“God of armies”

Here Asaph is using the possessive form **God of armies** to mean “God, the one who commands the armies of heaven.” It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God who commands armies]

See: Possession

Psalms 80:4 (#2)

עַד־מָתַ֗י עָ֭שַׁנְתָּ בִּתְפִלַּ֣ת עַמֶּ֑ךָ

“until when will you smolder against the prayer of your people”

Asaph is using the question form to express strong emotion. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate his words as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You have smoldered against the prayer of your people for far too long!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 80:4 (#3)

עָ֭שַׁנְתָּ בִּתְפִלַּ֣ת

“will you smolder against the prayer of”

Asaph is speaking as if God’s anger were fire that continues to **smolder**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will you remain angry at]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:4 (#4)

בִּתְפִלַּ֣ת עַמֶּ֑ךָ

“against the prayer of your people”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when your people pray to you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 80:5 (#1)

הֶֽאֱכַלְתָּ֣ם לֶ֭חֶם דִּמְעָ֑ה וַתַּשְׁקֵ֥מֹו בִּדְמָעֹ֖ות שָׁלִֽישׁ

“You have made them eat bread of tears, and you have made them drink tears {in} triple measure”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [You have made them eat and drink tears abundantly]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 80:5 (#2)

הֶֽאֱכַלְתָּ֣ם

“You have made them eat”

The pronoun **them** refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You have made the people of Israel eat]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 80:5 (#3)

לֶ֭חֶם דִּמְעָ֑ה

“bread of tears”

Asaph is speaking as if tears were **bread** that people could eat. This means that sorrow has become their constant experience. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food of sorrow]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:5 (#4)

וַתַּשְׁקֵמוֹ בִּדְמָעוֹת שָׁלִישׁ

“and you have made them drink tears {in} triple measure”

Asaph is speaking as if **tears** were a liquid that people could drink in great quantity. This means that God has caused the people to experience overwhelming sorrow. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you have caused them to weep an overwhelming amount]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:5 (#5)

שָׁלִישׁ

“in} triple measure”

Asaph uses the phrase **in triple measure** as an exaggeration for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use another way to express this emphasis. Alternate translation: [much more than we deserve]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 80:6 (#1)

תְּשִׂימֵמוֹ מָדוֹן לִשְׁכֵנֵינוּ

“You have made us strife to our neighbors”

The first-person pronoun **us** here indicates a shift from the third person **them** in the previous verse. Asaph is now including himself among the suffering people. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use the same person as in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [You have made them strife to their neighbors]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 80:6 (#2)

מָדוֹן לִשְׁכֵנֵינוּ

“strife to our neighbors”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strife**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a cause of quarreling with our neighbors]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 80:6 (#3)

וְאֹיְבֵינוּ יִלְעֲגוּ־לָמוֹ

“and our enemies mock among themselves”

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and our enemies mock us among themselves]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 80:7 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת

“God of armies”

Here Asaph is using the possessive form **God of armies** to mean “God, the one who commands the armies of heaven.” It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. See how you translated this in verse 4. Alternate translation: [God who commands armies]

See: Possession

Psalms 80:7 (#2)

וְהָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה

“and make your face shine and let us be saved”

The word **and** indicates that what follows, **let us be saved**, is the purpose or goal of what came before. See how you translated this in 80:3. Alternate translation: [and make your face shine so that we will be saved]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 80:7 (#3)

וְהָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ

“and make your face shine”

Asaph is speaking as if God’s face were a light that could shine. See how you translated this in 80:3. Alternate translation: [and show us your favor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:7 (#4)

וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה

“and let us be saved”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and rescue us]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 80:8 (#1)

גֶּפֶן מִמִּצְרַיִם תַּסִּיעַ תְּגָרֵשׁ גּוֹיִם וַתִּטָּעֶהָ

“You pulled up a vine from Egypt; you drove out nations and planted it”

The structure here indicates events in sequence. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could show this relationship by using a fuller phrase. Alternate translation: [You pulled up a vine from Egypt, and then you drove out nations and planted it]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Psalms 80:8 (#2)

גֶּפֶן מִמִּצְרַיִם תַּסִּיעַ

“You pulled up a vine from Egypt”

Asaph is speaking of Israel as if it were a **vine**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [You pulled up a nation like a vine from Egypt]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:9 (#1)

פִּנִּיתָ לְפָנֶיהָ וַתַּשְׁרֵשׁ שָׁרָשֶׁיהָ וַתְּמַלֵּא־אָרֶץ

“You cleared to the face of it, and it rooted its roots and filled the land”

The structure here indicates events in sequence. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could show this relationship by using a fuller phrase. Alternate translation: [Then you cleared the ground for it, and it took root and filled the land]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Psalms 80:9 (#2)

לְפָנֶיהָ

“to the face of it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the vine (representing Israel). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to the face of the vine]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 80:9 (#3)

וַתַּשְׁרֵשׁ שָׁרָשֶׁיהָ וַתְּמַלֵּא־אָרֶץ

“and it rooted its roots and filled the land”

Asaph is speaking of Israel as if it were a vine that became established and spread. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and the people became established and filled the land]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:9 (#4)

וַתַּשְׁרֵשׁ שָׁרָשֶׁיהָ

“and it rooted its roots”

The phrase **rooted its roots** is an idiom using a verb and noun from the same root. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use an expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and it became deeply rooted]

See: Idiom

Psalms 80:10 (#1)

כָּסּוּ הָרִרִים צִלָּלָהּ

“The mountains were covered {with} its shadow”

Asaph is speaking of Israel as if it were a vine whose shadow covered the mountains. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [The people spread even over the mountains]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:10 (#2)

כָּסּוּ הָרִרִים צִלָּלָהּ

“The mountains were covered {with} its shadow”

The expression **were covered** is a passive verbal form. If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Its shadow covered the mountains]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 80:10 (#3)

וַעֲנָפֶיהָ אַרְזֵי־אֵל

“and its branches {were} cedars of God”

Asaph is speaking of Israel as if it were a vine whose branches were like the mighty cedars. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and the people became as strong as the mighty cedars]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:10 (#4)

אַרְזֵי־אֵֽל

"were} cedars of God"

Asaph is using the possessive form to describe the **cedars** as being characterized by extraordinary greatness, as if they belong to God. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [were very great cedars]

See: Possession

Psalms 80:11 (#1)

תְּשַׁלַּ֣ח קְצִירֶ֣הָ עַד־יָ֑ם

"It sent out its branches to the sea"

Asaph is speaking of Israel as if it were a vine that **sent out its branches**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this in another way. Alternate translation: [The people extended their territory]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:11 (#2)

יָ֝ם וְאֶל־נָהָ֗ר יְנִקוֹתֶֽיהָ

"the sea, and its shoots to the River"

Asaph is referring to the entire promised land by naming its two extreme boundaries, **the sea** (the Mediterranean Sea in the west) and **the River** (the Euphrates River in the east). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Mediterranean Sea, and its shoots to the Euphrates River]

See: Merism

Psalms 80:11 (#3)

וְאֶל־נָהָ֗ר יְנִקוֹתֶֽיהָ

"and its shoots to the River"

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and it sent out its shoots to the River]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 80:12 (#1)

לָ֭מָּה פָּרַ֣צְתָּ גְדֵרֶ֑יהָ וְ֝אָרֻ֗הָ כָּל־עֹ֣בְרֵי דָֽרֶךְ

"Why have you broken down its walls, so that all the ones passing {on} the way pluck it"

In this context, the second phrase states the result of what the first phrase describes. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [You have broken down its walls with the result that all the ones passing on the way pluck it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 80:12 (#2)

לָ֭מָּה פָּרַ֣צְתָּ גְדֵרֶ֑יהָ

"Why have you broken down its walls"

Asaph is using the question form to express strong emotion. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate his words as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not have broken down its walls]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 80:12 (#3)

פָּרַ֣צְתָּ גְדֵרֶ֑יהָ

"have you broken down its walls"

Asaph is speaking as if Israel were a vineyard with **walls** that God has broken down. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have you removed its protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:12 (#4)

גְדֵרֶ֑יהָ

"its walls"

The pronoun **its** refers to the vine (representing Israel). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the walls of the vine] or [our walls]

See: Possession

Psalms 80:12 (#5)

וְאָרְרוּהָ כָּל־עֹבְרֵי דָּרֶךְ

“so that all the ones passing {on} the way pluck it”

The phrase **all the ones passing on the way** is a generalization to emphasize how vulnerable the vine has become. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so that many people passing by pluck it]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 80:13 (#1)

יְכַרְסְמֶנָּה חֲזִיר מִיָּעַר וְזִיז שָׁדַי יִרְעֶנָּה

“The boar from the forest ravages it, and the creature of the field grazes on it”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Wild animals from the forest and the field ravage and consume it]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 80:13 (#2)

יְכַרְסְמֶנָּה חֲזִיר מִיָּעַר וְזִיז שָׁדַי יִרְעֶנָּה

“The boar from the forest ravages it, and the creature of the field grazes on it”

Asaph continues to draw an extended comparison between the nation of Israel, and a vineyard planted by a gardener. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the comparison. [Their enemies have destroyed your people like wild animals that root and destroy a vineyard]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 80:13 (#3)

יְכַרְסְמֶנָּה & יִרְעֶנָּה

“ravages it & grazes on it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the vine, which represents Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [ravages the vine … grazes on it]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 80:14 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת

“God of armies”

Here, **God of armies** describes God as the one who commands the armies of heaven. See how you translated this in 80:4. Alternate translation: [God who commands armies]

See: Possession

Psalms 80:14 (#2)

וּפִקְקִי גֶּפֶן זֹאת

“and visit this vine”

Asaph is speaking of Israel as if it were a **vine**. Your language may have a comparable expression you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and care for this people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:15 (#1)

וְעַל־בֵּן אֲשֶׁר־נָטְעָה יְמִינֶךָ

“even the stock that your right hand planted”

In the phrase **even the stock that your right hand has planted**, Asaph continues to extend the comparison between Israel and a vine. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the comparison. Alternate translation: [even the nation that you have established]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Psalms 80:15 (#2)

נָטְעָה יְמִינֶךָ

“your right hand planted”

Here, **your right hand** represents God’s power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you powerfully planted]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:15 (#3)

בֵּן

“the son”

Here, **the son** could refer to: (1) the vine, representing the people of Israel. Alternate translation: [the people] or [the nation] or (2) a particular leader of the people of Israel. Alternate translation: [the leader]

Psalms 80:16 (#1)

שְׂרֻפָה בָאֵשׁ כְּסוּחָה

“It is burned with fire, it is cut down”

Asaph is speaking of Israel’s destruction as if the vine had been **burned with fire** and **cut down**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It is destroyed, it is cut off]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:16 (#2)

שְׂרֻפָ֥ה בָאֵ֗שׁ כְּסוּחָ֫ה

“It is burned with fire, it is cut down”

The expressions **It is burned with fire** and **it is cut down** are passive verbal expressions. If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Enemies have burned it with fire and cut it down]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 80:16 (#3)

מִגַּעֲרַ֣ת פָּ֭נֶיךָ

“from the rebuke of your face”

Here, **your face** represents God’s presence and judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [because you rebuke them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:16 (#4)

מִגַּעֲרַ֣ת

“from the rebuke of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rebuke**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are angry with them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 80:16 (#5)

יֹאבֵֽדוּ

“they perish”

The pronoun shifts from the singular **it** (the vine) to the plural **they** (the people of Israel). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel perish]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 80:17 (#1)

תְּהִי־יָ֣דְךָ עַל

“Let your hand be on”

Here, **hand** represents power and protection. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Let your protection be on]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:17 (#2)

אִ֭ישׁ יְמִינֶ֑ךָ & בֶּן־אָ֝דָ֗ם אִמַּ֥צְתָּ לָּֽךְ

“the man of your right hand & the son of man you strengthened for yourself”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the one whom you have chosen and strengthened]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 80:17 (#3)

אִ֭ישׁ יְמִינֶ֑ךָ עַל־בֶּן־אָ֝דָ֗ם אִמַּ֥צְתָּ לָּֽךְ

“the man of your right hand, on the son of man you strengthened for yourself”

The expressions **on the man of your right hand** and **on the son of man you strengthened for yourself** both describe the same figure. This could refer to: (1) the nation of Israel as a whole, Alternate translation: [on the people at your right hand, on the ones you strengthened for yourself] or (2) to a particular leader or king. Alternate translation: [on the man of your right hand, on the one you strengthened for yourself]

Psalms 80:17 (#4)

אִ֭ישׁ יְמִינֶ֑ךָ

“the man of your right hand”

Here, **right hand** represents a position of strength and honor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [on the man you have placed in a position of honor]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:17 (#5)

בֶּן־אָ֝דָ֗ם

“the son of man”

Here Asaph is using the phrase **son of man** as a common expression of the culture to indicate a person that has the characteristic of being human. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the human being]

See: Idiom

Psalms 80:18 (#1)

וְלֹא־נָסֹג מִמֶּךָּ

“And we will not turn back from you”

Here, **And** introduces a vow or promise that Asaph makes as a consequence of God’s intervention. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Then we will not turn back from you]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 80:18 (#2)

וְלֹא־נָסֹג

“And we will not turn back”

Asaph is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with the phrase **turn back from you**. He means that if God acts on their behalf, they will continue to live the way God wants his people to live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [And we will continue to live the way you want your people to live]

See: Litotes

Psalms 80:18 (#3)

וּבְשִׁמְךָ נִקְרָא

“and we will call on your name”

Here, **your name** represents God himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and we will worship you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 80:19 (#1)

אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת

“God of armies”

Here, **God of armies** describes God as the one who commands the armies of heaven. See how you translated this in 80:4. Alternate translation: [God who commands armies]

See: Possession

Psalms 80:19 (#2)

הָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה

“Make your face shine, and let us be saved”

Here, **and** marks **let us be saved** as the goal or purpose of **Make your face shine**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. See how you translated this in 80:3. Alternate translation: [Make your face shine so that we will be saved]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 80:19 (#3)

הָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ

“Make your face shine”

Asaph is speaking as if God’s face were a light that could shine. See how you translated this in 80:3. Alternate translation: [Show us your favor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 80:19 (#4)

וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה

“and let us be saved”

The phrase **let us be saved** is a passive verbal form. If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and rescue us]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms - Chapter 81 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 81 begins like a psalm of praise. However, it then presents a direct address from Yahweh. He recalls that he delivered the Israelites from slavery in Egypt, but they nevertheless disobeyed him. He then describes how he would bless the Israelites if they did obey him. Many interpreters believe that this psalm was written for the occasion of one of the annual festivals, when many Israelites would be at the temple in Jerusalem and hear its message of warning and

promise. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the Introduction to Psalms.

1. Call to worship (1–3)
2. Reason to worship (4–5)
3. Yahweh testifies against the Israelites (6–12)
4. Yahweh says how he would bless the Israelites (13–16)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Parallelisms

Parallelisms arise when two phrases occur together which mean about the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea using different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one and not saying something additional. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. For more information, see the Introduction to the Psalms.

Imperatives

The ULT uses the imperative to show that a speaker is expressing a desire that something happen or that someone do something. When Asaph says in verse 1, "Shout joyfully to God", he means that it is his desire that the people should do this. Translate this form in the most natural way in your language to indicate that the speaker is expressing what he wants someone to do or what he wishes someone would do.

Psalms 81:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 81:0 (#3)

הַגִּתִּֽית

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הַגִּתִּֽית"

See how you translated the term **Gittith** in the superscription to Psalm 8.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 81:1 (#1)

הַרְנִ֣ינוּ לֵאלֹהִ֣ים עוּזֵּ֑נוּ הָרִ֥יעוּ לֵאלֹהֵ֖י יַעֲקֹֽב

"Shout joyfully to God, our strength; shout out to the God of Jacob"

These two phrases **Shout joyfully to God, our strength** and **shout out to the God of Jacob** mean basically the same thing. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. For more information on translating parallel phrases, see the Introduction to this psalm. Alternate translation: [Shout with great joy to God who is the strength of Jacob's descendants]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 81:1 (#2)

הַרְנִ֣ינוּ לֵאלֹהִ֣ים עוּזֵּ֑נוּ הָרִ֥יעוּ

"Shout joyfully to God, our strength; shout out"

Asaph is saying what he wants the people of Israel to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about this form of speech and follow the decision of your team, here and throughout this psalm, of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that all shout joyfully to God, our strength; you should all shout out]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 81:1 (#3)

עוּזֵּ֑נוּ

"our strength"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who strengthens us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 81:3 (#1)

בַּכֵּ֣סֶה

"at the full moon"

Asaph is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context

if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [also blow a shofar at the full moon]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 81:4 (#1)

כִּ֤י חֹ֣ק לְיִשְׂרָאֵ֣ל הוּא֮

“For {it is} a statute for Israel”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because it is a statute for Israel]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 81:4 (#2)

חֹ֣ק לְיִשְׂרָאֵ֣ל הוּא֮ מִ֝מִּשְׁפָּ֗ט לֵאלֹהֵ֥י יַעֲקֹֽב

“it is} a statute for Israel, a judgment of the God of Jacob”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the ideas of **statute** and **judgment**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [it is something that God decreed, what the God of Jacob decided]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 81:5 (#1)

עֵדֻ֑ת ׀ בִּיה֭וֹסֵ֣ף שָׂמ֣וֹ בְּצֵאתוֹ

“He set it as a testimony in Joseph when he went out”

The pronoun **He** refers to God, and the pronoun **he** in **when he went out** refers to Joseph (representing Israel). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God set it as a testimony in Joseph when Israel went out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 81:5 (#2)

עֵדֻ֑ת

“as a testimony”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **testimony**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as something to be observed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 81:5 (#3)

בִּיה֭וֹסֵ֣ף

“in Joseph”

The name **Joseph** represents the people of Israel, particularly the tribes descended from Joseph. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [among the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 81:5 (#4)

שְׂפַ֣ת

“a lip”

Here, **lip** represents language or speech. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [a tongue]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 81:6 (#1)

הֲסִירֹ֣תִי מִסֵּ֣בֶל שִׁכְמ֑וֹ

“I removed his shoulder from the burden”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh said. His speech continues through verse 16. You may wish to mark the words of this speech with a first-level quotation mark at the beginning and end of them or with some other punctuation or convention that your language uses to indicate a first-level quotation.

See: Quote Markings

Psalms 81:6 (#2)

הֲסִירֹ֣תִי מִסֵּ֣בֶל שִׁכְמ֑וֹ

“I removed his shoulder from the burden”

The phrase **I removed his shoulder from the burden** represents Yahweh completely liberating Israel from slavery in Egypt. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I freed him from his slavery]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 81:6 (#3)

מִסֵּ֣בֶל שִׁכְמ֑וֹ כַּ֝פָּ֗יו מִדּ֥וּד תַּעֲבֹֽרְנָה

“his shoulder from the burden; his palms passed from the basket”

The pronouns **his** refer to the people of Israel collectively. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the shoulder of my people from the burden; their palms passed from the basket]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 81:7 (#1)

בַּצָּרָה

“In distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [When you were suffering]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 81:7 (#2)

בְּסֵתֶר רַעַם

“from the secret place of thunder”

Yahweh is speaking as if he were concealed within **the secret place of thunder**. This represents God’s awesome and hidden presence in the storm. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the thunderstorm where I was hidden]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 81:7 (#3)

בְּסֵתֶר רַעַם

“from the secret place of thunder”

Yahweh is using this possessive form to describe a hidden place that is associated with thunder. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [from the place hidden by thunder]

See: Possession

Psalms 81:7 (#4)

מְרִיבָה

“Meribah”

The word **Meribah** is the name of a desert place.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 81:8 (#1)

יִשְׂרָאֵל אִם־תִּשְׁמַע־לִי

“Israel, if you would listen to me”

Here, **if you would listen to me** introduces the first part of a possible condition. Yahweh will only do the things described in verses 13–16 if this condition happens. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen.

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 81:8 (#2)

יִשְׂרָאֵל אִם־תִּשְׁמַע־לִי

“Israel, if you would listen to me”

Yahweh is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, a deep longing for Israel to obey. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what Yahweh was feeling. Alternate translation: [Israel, I so deeply wish you would listen to me]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 81:9 (#1)

לְאֵל נֵכָר

“to a god of foreignness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **foreignness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to a foreign god]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 81:10 (#1)

הַרְחֶב־פִּיךָ וַאֲמַלְאֵהוּ

“Open wide your mouth, and I will fill it”

Yahweh is speaking as if Israel’s dependence on him were opening a mouth wide to be fed. This represents trusting God to provide abundantly. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Depend on me completely, and I will provide for you abundantly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 81:10 (#2)

הַרְחֶב־פִּיךָ וַאֲמַלְאֵהוּ

“Open wide your mouth, and I will fill it”

The word translated as **Open wide** is an imperative, but it communicates a condition rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a condition for your readers, then use a form in your

language that communicates a condition. Alternate translation: [If you open wide your mouth, then I will fill it]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 81:11 (#1)

וְלֹא־שָׁמַע עַמִּי

“But my people did not listen”

Yahweh uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the commands he gave in verses 8–10 and the response of the people. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, my people did not listen]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 81:11 (#2)

לְקוֹלִי

“to my voice”

Here, **voice** represents Yahweh’s commands and instructions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to my commands]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 81:12 (#1)

וָאֲשַׁלְּחֵהוּ

“So I sent them away”

The term translated as **So** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [Therefore I sent them away]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 81:12 (#2)

בִּשְׁרִירוּת לִבָּם

“in the stubbornness of their heart”

Here, **heart** represents the will and inner attitude of the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the stubbornness of their wills]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 81:12 (#3)

בִּשְׁרִירוּת לִבָּם

“in the stubbornness of their heart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **stubbornness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with their stubborn hearts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 81:12 (#4)

יֵלְכוּ בְּמוֹעֲצוֹתֵיהֶם

“they walked in their counsels”

Yahweh is speaking of how the people lived as if that were a path that they were walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they lived according to their own plans]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 81:12 (#5)

בְּמוֹעֲצוֹתֵיהֶם

“in their counsels”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **counsels**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way they themselves chose]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 81:13 (#1)

לוּ עַמִּי שֹׁמֵעַ לִי יִשְׂרָאֵל בִּדְרָכַי יְהַלֵּכוּ

“If only my people were listening to me, {if} Israel would walk in my ways”

Yahweh is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, a deep longing for Israel to obey. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what Yahweh was feeling. Alternate translation: [How I long for my people to listen to me and for Israel to follow my ways]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 81:13 (#2)

יִשְׂרָאֵל בִּדְרָכַי יְהַלֵּכוּ

“if} Israel would walk in my ways”

Yahweh is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Israel would live according to my commands]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 81:14 (#1)

אָשִׁ֥יב יָדִ֗י

“I would turn my hand”

Here, **hand** represents Yahweh’s power and ability to act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I would use my power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 81:15 (#1)

יְכַחֲשׁוּ־לֹ֑ו

“would cringe before him”

The pronoun **him** refers to Yahweh. Even though Yahweh is speaking in the first person, he refers to himself in the third person here. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [would cringe before Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 81:15 (#2)

וְיִהְיֶ֖ה עִתָּ֣ם לְעֹולָֽם

“and their time would be forever”

Here, **time** represents the duration of their fate or condition. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and their punishment would last forever]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 81:16 (#1)

וַיַּאֲכִלֵ֥הוּ

“And he would feed him”

The pronouns **he** and **him** refer to Yahweh and Israel respectively. Even though Yahweh is speaking in the first person, he uses the third person here. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [I would feed Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 81:16 (#2)

מֵחֵ֣לֶב חִטָּ֑ה

“with the fat of the wheat”

Here, **fat** represents the best and richest portion of something. Yahweh is speaking as if the finest wheat had a rich fat. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with the finest wheat]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 81:16 (#3)

מֵחֵ֣לֶב חִטָּ֑ה

“with the fat of the wheat”

Yahweh is using this possessive form to describe the richest part of the wheat. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the richest part of the wheat]

See: Possession

Psalms 81:16 (#4)

וּ֝מִצֹּ֗ור דְּבַ֤שׁ אַשְׂבִּיעֶֽךָּ

“and I would satisfy you with honey from the rock”

The pronoun **you** marks an abrupt shift from the third person **him** earlier in the verse to the second person. Both refer to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [I would satisfy them with honey from the rock]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 82 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 82, like Psalm 81, seems to have been written for the occasion of one of the annual festivals, when many Israelites would have been at the temple in Jerusalem and heard its message of challenge and warning. It depicts God convening an assembly of rulers and passing judgment against them for failing to ensure justice.

1. God takes his place of authority in this assembly (1)
2. God demands that these rulers judge justly (2–4)
3. God passes judgment against these rulers (5–7)
4. The psalmist asks God to judge the earth (8)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Translation of the term “gods”

The psalmist describes these rulers as “gods” in verse 1, and God says to them “You are gods” in verse 6.

That has led many interpreters to conclude that this is a depiction of a divine assembly in heaven. However, that same Hebrew term can also mean "judges," as in Exodus 21:6 and 22:8, so other interpreters understand this as a depiction of God summoning human judges and indicting them for not upholding justice. If possible, translate this psalm in a way that allows for either interpretation. The UST models one way to do that.

Parallelisms
Parallelisms arise when two clauses occur together which mean the same thing. The second clause emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea using different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the clauses with a word that shows that the second clause is repeating the first one and not saying something additional. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing.

Psalms 82:1 (#1)

נִצָּב

"is standing"

The expression **is standing** was a common expression meaning to take one's position of authority in order to act. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [takes his position of authority]

See: Idiom

Psalms 82:1 (#2)

בְּקֶרֶב אֱלֹהִים

"in the midst of gods"

The term "god," when applied to a being other than Yahweh, can refer to an idol, but, as here, it can also refer to any lesser spirit being. Alternate translation: [in the midst of the spirit beings]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 82:2 (#1)

עַד־מָתַי תִּשְׁפְּטוּ־עָוֶל וּפְנֵי רְשָׁעִים תִּשָּׂאוּ

"Until when will you judge {with} injustice and lift up the faces of the wicked"

Asaph is using the question form to rebuke these judges for their corrupt rulings. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for this purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or exclamations. Alternate translation: [You must stop judging with injustice and stop making rulings that favor the wicked!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 82:2 (#2)

עָוֶל

"with} injustice"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **injustice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [unjustly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 82:2 (#3)

וּפְנֵי רְשָׁעִים תִּשָּׂאוּ

"and lift up the faces of the wicked"

The expression **lift up the faces of the wicked** was a common expression meaning "to show partiality or favoritism." If it would be helpful for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and show partiality to wicked people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 82:2 (#4)

רְשָׁעִים

"wicked"

Asaph is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 82:3 (#1)

דַּלּ וְיָתוֹם עָנִי וְרָשׁ הַצְדִּיקוּ

"the poor and the orphan; vindicate the poor and the destitute"

Asaph is using the adjectives **poor**, **orphan**, and **destitute** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [the poor people and

the fatherless children; vindicate the poor people and the destitute people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 82:4 (#1)

דַּל וְאֶבְיוֹן מִיַּד רְשָׁעִים הַצִּילוּ

“the poor and the needy; deliver {them} from the hand of the wicked”

Asaph is using the adjectives **poor**, **needy**, and **wicked** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [the poor people and the needy people; deliver them from the hand of the wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 82:4 (#2)

מִיַּד רְשָׁעִים

“from the hand of the wicked”

Here, **hand** represents the power or control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the control of the wicked people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 82:5 (#1)

לֹא יָדְעוּ ׀ וְלֹא יָבִינוּ

“They do not know and they do not understand”

The terms **do not know** and **do not understand** mean similar things. Asaph is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [They are completely ignorant]

See: Doublet

Psalms 82:5 (#2)

בַּחֲשֵׁכָה יִתְהַלָּכוּ

“they walk about in darkness”

Asaph is speaking of these judges as if they were walking around in a dark place. He means that they are morally ignorant and do not act according to what is right. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation, or you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they go about in moral ignorance]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 82:5 (#3)

יִמּוֹטוּ כָּל־מוֹסְדֵי אָרֶץ

“All of the foundations of the earth are shaken”

Asaph is speaking of the moral and social order of the world as if it had **foundations** like those under a building. He means that because of these unjust judges, the stability of the world is being destroyed. You may have a comparable expression in your language that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All the stability and order of the world is being undermined]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 82:5 (#4)

יִמּוֹטוּ

“are shaken”

The phrase **are shaken** is a passive verbal form. If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [shake] or [are trembling]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 82:6 (#1)

אֲנִי־אָמַרְתִּי אֱלֹהִים אַתֶּם

“I, I said, ‘You {are} gods”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. In that case, you could express what God said as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [I said that you are gods]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Psalms 82:6 (#2)

אֲנִי־אָמַרְתִּי

“I, I said”

Asaph is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I said** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one speaking. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I myself said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 82:6 (#3)

אֱלֹהִים

“gods”

See the discussion of the term “gods” in the introduction to this psalm.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 82:6 (#4)

וּבְנֵי עֶלְיוֹן

“and sons of the Most High”

Asaph is speaking of these judges as if they were **sons of the Most High**, that is, as if they belonged to God’s family. He means that God had given them a share in his authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and those who share the authority of the Most High]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 82:7 (#1)

אָכֵן

“But”

Asaph uses the word **But** here to introduce a contrast between the divine status declared in the previous verse and the mortality declared here. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However,]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 82:7 (#2)

כְּאָדָם תְּמוּתוּן

“you will die like man”

The point of this comparison is that despite being called gods, these judges will die just as any ordinary human person does. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point clear. Alternate translation: [like any mortal person, you will die]

See: Simile

Psalms 82:7 (#3)

וּכְאַחַד הַשָּׂרִים תִּפֹּלוּ

“and like one of the princes, you will fall”

The point of this comparison is that these judges will lose their position and power just as earthly rulers do when they are defeated. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like any other ruler, you will fall from power]

See: Simile

Psalms 82:8 (#1)

קוּמָה אֱלֹהִים שָׁפְטָה הָאָרֶץ

“Arise, God, judge the earth”

Asaph is using the imperative forms **Arise** and **judge** to make a request of God. If your language does not use the imperative to make requests, you could express this as a request or wish. Alternate translation: [Please arise, God, and judge the earth]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 82:8 (#2)

אַתָּה תִנְחַל

“you, you will inherit”

The word translated as **you** before **you will inherit** represents an independent pronoun used for emphasis in the original language, in addition to the pronoun expressed within the verb. If it would be helpful in your language, you could indicate the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [you yourself will inherit]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 82:8 (#3)

אַתָּה תִנְחַל בְּכָל־הַגּוֹיִם

“you, you will inherit among all of the nations”

Asaph is speaking of God’s sovereign ownership and authority over the nations as if God would **inherit** them as property. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you possess authority over all the nations]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 82:8 (#4)

כִּי־אַתָּה תִנְחַל בְּכָל־הַגּוֹיִם

“for you, you will inherit among all of the nations”

Asaph is giving a reason for what he said in the previous phrase. He asked God to judge the earth and he now gives the reason: God possesses authority over all the nations. If it would be helpful in your language,

you could make this connection more explicit. Alternate translation: [because you have authority over all the nations]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms - Chapter 83 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 83 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It is such a desperate, urgent plea for help that it presents only three of the basic elements of that type of psalm. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1)
2. Description of troubles (2–8)
3. Petition (9–18)

Many interpreters believe that this psalm was written during the reign of Jehoshaphat when a large army composed of Moabites, Ammonites, and Meunites, supported by other nations, invaded and attacked Judah, as described in 2 Chronicles 20:1–30. Yahweh inspired a Levite from the clan of Asaph to reassure the king and nation that he would defeat these invaders. The outcome was exactly what this psalm envisions and pleads for: "the fear of God was on all the kingdoms of the lands when they heard how Yahweh had fought with the enemies of Israel." It may be helpful to read this passage before translating this psalm.

Psalms 83:1 (#1)

אַל־דְּמִי־לָ֑ךְ

"may} silence not {be} to you"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **silence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [may you not be silent]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 83:1 (#2)

אַל־תֶּחֱרַ֥שׁ וְאַל־תִּשְׁקֹ֗ט

"do not be still, and do not be quiet"

The expressions **do not be still** and **do not be quiet** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [do not remain inactive]

See: Doublet

Psalms 83:1 (#3)

אַל־תֶּחֱרַ֥שׁ וְאַל־תִּשְׁקֹ֗ט

"do not be still, and do not be quiet"

The psalmist is using the imperative forms **do not be still** and **do not be quiet** to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a natural form for making a request. Alternate translation: [please do not be still, and please do not be quiet]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 83:1 (#4)

אַל־דְּמִי־לָ֑ךְ אַל־תֶּחֱרַ֥שׁ וְאַל־תִּשְׁקֹ֗ט

"may} silence not {be} to you; do not be still, and do not be quiet"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [do not remain silent and inactive]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 83:2 (#1)

כִּ֤י־הִנֵּ֨ה

"For behold"

The psalmist uses **For behold** to introduce the reason for his plea in verse 1. He is saying that God should take action because the enemies are rising up. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the connection clearer.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 83:2 (#2)

הִנֵּ֨ה

"behold"

The word **behold** is used here to draw attention to what follows. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this with a word or phrase that serves this purpose, or you could leave it untranslated. Alternate translation: [look]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 83:2 (#3)

וּמְשַׂנְאֶיךָ

“and the ones hating you”

The phrase **the ones hating you** refers to the same people as **your enemies** earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [those same enemies of yours]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:2 (#4)

אֹיְבֶיךָ יֶהֱמָיּוּן וּמְשַׂנְאֶיךָ נָשְׂאוּ רֹאשׁ

“your enemies roar, and the ones hating you lift up {the} head”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [your enemies are boldly rising up against you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 83:2 (#5)

נָשְׂאוּ רֹאשׁ

“lift up {the} head”

The expression **lift up the head** is an idiom that means to act boldly or defiantly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [act defiantly]

See: Idiom

Psalms 83:3 (#1)

עַל־עַמְּךָ יַעֲרִימוּ סוֹד וְיִתְיָעֲצוּ עַל־צְפוּנֶיךָ

“They are cunning {with} counsel against your people, and they conspire against your treasured ones”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [they are craftily plotting against your cherished people]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 83:3 (#2)

יַעֲרִימוּ

“They are cunning”

The pronoun **They** refers to the enemies mentioned in verse 2. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [Your enemies are cunning]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:3 (#3)

סוֹד

“with} counsel”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **counsel**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in counseling together]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 83:3 (#4)

צְפוּנֶיךָ

“your treasured ones”

The phrase **your treasured ones** refers to the people of Israel, whom God values. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [the Israelites, your treasured people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:4 (#1)

אָמְרוּ

“They have said”

The pronoun **They** refers to the enemies mentioned in verses 2–3. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [These enemies have said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:4 (#2)

שֵׁם־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the name of Israel”

Here, **the name of Israel** represents the nation of Israel itself and its existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the nation of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 83:4 (#3)

וְלֹא־יִזָּכֵר שֵׁם־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“that the name of Israel may not be remembered”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that no one may remember the name of Israel]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 83:5 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

The word **For** introduces the reason why the psalmist said what he said in verses 3–4. The enemies are conspiring because they want to destroy Israel. Use a connector in your language that introduces a reason. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 83:5 (#2)

נוֹעָ֣צוּ

“they have conspired”

The pronoun **they** refers to the nations listed in verses 6–8. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [these nations have conspired]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:5 (#3)

לֵ֑ב יַחְדָּ֥ו

“heart together”

Here, **heart** represents the will or intention. The psalmist is saying that these enemies have **conspired** with unified purpose. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with one purpose]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 83:5 (#4)

בְּרִ֖֥ית יִכְרֹֽתוּ

“they have cut a covenant”

The expression **they have cut a covenant** is an idiom that means they have made a formal agreement or alliance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they have allied themselves]

See: Idiom

Psalms 83:6 (#1)

אָהֳלֵ֣י אֱ֭דוֹם וְיִשְׁמְעֵאלִ֑ים

“the tents of Edom and the Ishmaelites”

The psalmist is leaving out the verb that would be expected in this phrase. The verb can be supplied from the context in verse 5. If it would be helpful in your language, you could supply this verb. Alternate translation: [the tents of Edom and the Ishmaelites have cut a covenant against you]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 83:6 (#2)

אָהֳלֵ֣י אֱ֭דוֹם

“the tents of Edom”

Here, **the tents of Edom** represents the people of Edom who live in those tents. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Edom]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 83:7 (#1)

גְּבָ֣ל וְ֭עַמּוֹן וַעֲמָלֵ֑ק

“Gebal and Ammon and Amalek”

The psalmist is leaving out the verb that would be expected in this phrase. The verb can be supplied from the context in verse 5. If it would be helpful in your language, you could supply this verb. Alternate translation: [Gebal and Ammon and Amalek have cut a covenant against you]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 83:8 (#1)

הָ֣יָה

“they”

The pronoun **they** refers to Assyria, mentioned earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [the Assyrians]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:8 (#2)

גַּם־אַ֭שּׁוּר נִלְוָ֣ה עִמָּ֑ם הָ֥יָה זְרֹ֖וַע לִבְנֵי־לֽוֹט

“Also Assyria has joined with them; they {are} an arm to the sons of Lot”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Also Assyria has joined with them; indeed, they {are} an arm to the sons of Lot]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 83:8 (#3)

הָ֭יָוּ זְרֹ֣עַ לִבְנֵי־לֽוֹט

“they {are} an arm to the sons of Lot”

Here, **an arm** represents military strength or support. The psalmist is saying that Assyria has provided military power to help the descendants of Lot. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they have given military support to the sons of Lot]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 83:8 (#4)

לִבְנֵי־לֽוֹט

“to the sons of Lot”

The psalmist is speaking of **the sons of Lot** to mean the descendants of Lot, that is, the Moabites and Ammonites. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Lot]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 83:9 (#1)

עֲשֵׂה־לָהֶ֥ם כְּמִדְיָ֑ן

“Do to them as {to} Midian”

The psalmist is using the imperative form **Do to them as to Midian** to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a natural form for making a request. Alternate translation: [Please do to them as to Midian]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 83:10 (#1)

נִשְׁמְד֥וּ

“They were destroyed”

The pronoun **They** refers to Midian, Sisera, and Jabin mentioned in verse 9. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [Those enemies were destroyed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:10 (#2)

נִשְׁמְד֥וּ

“They were destroyed”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God destroyed them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 83:10 (#3)

הָ֝יָ֗וּ דֹּ֥מֶן לָאֲדָמָֽה

“they became dung for the ground”

The psalmist is speaking of the dead enemies as if **they became dung for the ground**. He means that their corpses were left unburied and decayed on the ground like refuse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their dead bodies lay rotting on the ground]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 83:11 (#1)

שִׁיתֵ֣מוֹ נְ֭דִיבֵמוֹ כְּעֹרֵ֣ב וְכִזְאֵ֑ב

“Make them, their nobles, like Oreb and like Zeeb”

The psalmist uses the word **like** to compare the fate he requests for the current enemies to the fate of **Oreb** and **Zeeb**, who were Midianite commanders killed by Gideon. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [Defeat them and their nobles as Gideon defeated Oreb and Zeeb]

See: Simile

Psalms 83:11 (#2)

שִׁיתֵ֣מוֹ נְ֭דִיבֵמוֹ

“Make them, their nobles”

The psalmist is using the imperative form **Make them, their nobles** to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a natural form for making a request. Alternate translation: [Please make them, their nobles]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 83:11 (#3)

נְ֭דִיבֵמוֹ

“their nobles”

The psalmist is using the adjective **nobles** as a noun to refer to people who are noble. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate it with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [their noble leaders]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 83:11 (#4)

וְכִזְאֵ֣ב וְכִצַלְמֻנָּ֔ע כָּל־נְסִיכֵֽמוֹ

“and like Zebah and like Zalmunna, all of their princes”

The psalmist uses the word **like** to compare the fate he requests for the princes of the current enemies to the fate of **Zebah** and **Zalmunna**, who were Midianite kings defeated by Gideon. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and defeat all of their princes as Gideon defeated Zebah and Zalmunna]

See: Simile

Psalms 83:11 (#5)

נְסִיכֵֽמוֹ

“their princes”

The psalmist is using the adjective **princes** as a noun to refer to people who are princely rulers. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate it with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [their ruling princes]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 83:12 (#1)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר

“who”

The pronoun **who** refers to the nobles and princes mentioned in verse 11. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [Those nobles and princes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:12 (#2)

אֵ֖את נְאוֹת֣ אֱלֹהִֽים

“the pastures of God”

The psalmist is speaking of the land of Israel as **the pastures of God**. He means the land that God has given to his people as their dwelling place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the land that God gave to his people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 83:12 (#3)

אֵ֖את נְאוֹת֣ אֱלֹהִֽים

“the pastures of God”

The psalmist is using the possessive form **the pastures of God** to describe pastures that belong to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this relationship in another way. Alternate translation: [the pastures that belong to God]

See: Possession

Psalms 83:13 (#1)

שִׁיתֵ֣מוֹ כַגַּלְגַּ֑ל

“make them like tumbleweed”

The psalmist uses the word **like** to compare the enemies to **tumbleweed**, which is blown away by the wind. He means that God should scatter them completely. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [scatter them as the wind scatters tumbleweed]

See: Simile

Psalms 83:13 (#2)

שִׁיתֵ֣מוֹ כַגַּלְגַּ֑ל

“make them like tumbleweed”

The psalmist is using the imperative form **make them like tumbleweed** to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a natural form for making a request. Alternate translation: [please make them like tumbleweed]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 83:13 (#3)

כְּקַ֥שׁ לִפְנֵי־רֽוּחַ

“like chaff to the face of the wind”

The psalmist uses the word **like** to compare the enemies to **chaff** that is blown away by the wind. He means that God should scatter them as easily as the wind scatters chaff. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [like chaff blown away by the wind]

See: Simile

Psalms 83:13 (#4)

לִפְנֵי־רוּחַ

“to the face of the wind”

Here, **the face of the wind** represents the front of the wind, that is, the direction the wind blows. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [before the wind]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 83:14 (#1)

כְּאֵשׁ תִּבְעַר־יָעַר וּכְלֶהָבָה תְּלַהֵט הָרִים

“As fire burns a forest, and as flame kindles mountains”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [As fire burns a forest; indeed, as a flame kindles mountains]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 83:14 (#2)

כְּאֵשׁ תִּבְעַר־יָעַר וּכְלֶהָבָה תְּלַהֵט הָרִים

“As fire burns a forest, and as flame kindles mountains”

The psalmist uses the word **as** to compare his request for God’s action against the enemies to how **fire burns a forest** and how **flame kindles mountains**. He means that God should consume the enemies completely. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [As fire consumes a forest and as flames consume the mountainside]

See: Simile

Psalms 83:15 (#1)

כֵּן

“thus”

The word **thus** connects the similes in verses 13–14 to the request in verse 15. The psalmist is saying that just as fire consumes a forest and flame kindles mountains, so God should pursue the enemies. Use a connector in your language that draws a comparison. Alternate translation: [in that way,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 83:15 (#2)

תִּרְדְּפֵם בְּסַעֲרֶךָ

“pursue them with your tempest”

The psalmist is using the imperative form **pursue them with your tempest** to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a natural form for making a request. Alternate translation: [please pursue them with your tempest]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 83:15 (#3)

תִּרְדְּפֵם בְּסַעֲרֶךָ וּבְסוּפָתְךָ תְבַהֲלֵם

“pursue them with your tempest, and terrify them with your whirlwind”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [pursue and terrify them with your swirling tempest]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 83:16 (#1)

מַלֵּא פְנֵיהֶם קָלוֹן

“Fill their faces {with} shame”

The psalmist is using the imperative form **Fill their faces with shame** to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a natural form for making a request. Alternate translation: [Please fill their faces with shame]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 83:16 (#2)

מַלֵּא פְנֵיהֶם קָלוֹן

“Fill their faces {with} shame”

Here, **their faces** represents their public identity or reputation. The psalmist is asking God to bring shame upon these enemies publicly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Bring shame upon them publicly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 83:16 (#3)

מַלֵּא פְנֵיהֶם קָלוֹן

“Fill their faces {with} shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Make them thoroughly ashamed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 83:16 (#4)

וְיבַקְשׁוּ שִׁמְךָ

“that they may seek your name”

The phrase **that they may seek your name** states the goal or purpose of the request in the first part of the verse. The psalmist is asking God to shame the enemies so that they will turn to God. Use a connector in your language that introduces a goal or purpose. Alternate translation: [to the end that they may seek your name]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 83:16 (#5)

וְיבַקְשׁוּ שִׁמְךָ

“that they may seek your name”

Here, **your name** represents God himself and his authority. The psalmist is asking that the enemies would turn to seek God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that they may seek you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 83:17 (#1)

יֵבֹ֤שׁוּ וְיִבָּהֲלוּ֙ עֲדֵי־עַ֣ד וְיַחְפְּרוּ֖ וְיֹאבֵֽדוּ

“May they have shame and be terrified, eternities of eternity, and may they have disgrace and may they perish”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [May they be utterly shamed and destroyed forever]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 83:17 (#2)

יֵבֹ֤שׁוּ

“May they have shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May they be ashamed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 83:17 (#3)

וְיִבָּהֲלוּ֙

“and be terrified”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and may God terrify them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 83:17 (#4)

וְיַחְפְּרוּ֖

“and may they have disgrace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **disgrace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and may they be disgraced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 83:18 (#1)

וְיֵדְעוּ֙

“And may they know”

The phrase **may they know** refers to the enemies described in verses 2–8. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this explicit. Alternate translation: [And may those enemies know]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 83:18 (#2)

שִׁמְךָ֤ יְהוָה֙

“your name {is} Yahweh”

Asaph is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to his reputation. Alternate translation: [you are Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 84 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

While Psalm 84 is not identified explicitly in its superscription as a “song of ascents” like Psalms 120–134, it nevertheless seems to be that same type of psalm. It encourages and praises going to the temple in Jerusalem. Apparently writing from the perspective of his arrival at the temple, the psalmist describes how he longed to be there and the journey he made to get there. The superscription indicates that a Korahite Levite wrote this psalm, but it was evidently one who lived and worked at some distance from Jerusalem.

1. Celebration of the temple (1–4)

2. The journey to the temple (5–7)
3. Prayer for Yahweh to preserve the king (8–9)
4. Celebration of Yahweh, the God of this temple, for his goodness (10–12)

Psalms 84:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 84:0 (#3)

הַגִּתִּתִ֑ית

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הַגִּתִּתִ֑ית"

See how you translated the term **Gittith** in the superscription to Psalm 8.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 84:1 (#1)

מַה־יְּדִידֻ֥ות מִשְׁכְּנוֹתֶ֗יךָ

"How amiable {are} your dwellings"

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of amazement at the beauty of God's dwelling place. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Your dwellings are so lovely]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 84:2 (#1)

נִכְסְפָ֤ה וְגַם־כָּלְתָ֨ה ׀ נַפְשִׁ֗י

"My soul longs and even faints"

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of himself in the act of longing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I long and even faint]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 84:2 (#2)

נִכְסְפָ֤ה וְגַם־כָּלְתָ֨ה

"longs and even faints"

The terms **longs** and **faints** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [desperately yearns]

See: Doublet

Psalms 84:2 (#3)

לִבִּ֣י וּבְשָׂרִ֣י יְרַנְּנ֣וּ

"my heart and my flesh cry out"

The psalmist is speaking of **my heart and my flesh** as if they were living things that could **cry out**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my heart and my flesh groan loudly]

See: Personification

Psalms 84:2 (#4)

לִבִּ֣י וּבְשָׂרִ֣י

"my heart and my flesh"

The psalmist is referring to all of himself by naming two major components, **my heart** and **my flesh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with my whole being I]

See: Merism

Psalms 84:2 (#5)

לִבִּ֣י

"my heart"

Here, **my heart** represents the psalmist's desires and feelings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my inner self]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 84:3 (#1)

וּדְרוֹר ׀ קֵ֣ן לָהּ֮

"and the swallow, a nest for herself"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and the swallow has found a nest for herself]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 84:4 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

The psalmist is using a phrase **The happinesses of** that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy are]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 84:4 (#2)

בֵּיתֶךָ

“your house”

The psalmist is speaking of the temple of Yahweh as if it were a **house** in which he lived. Alternate translation: [your temple]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 84:5 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

See how you translated the phrase “The happinesses of” in the previous verse.

See: Exclamations

Psalms 84:5 (#2)

אָדָם

“the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 84:5 (#3)

עֹוז־לֹו בָּךְ

“strength to him {is} in you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you make him strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 84:5 (#4)

מְסִלֹּות בִּלְבָבָם

“Highways {are} in their heart”

The psalmist is speaking of the desire for pilgrimage as if there were **highways** in the hearts of the people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They desire to make the journey to your temple] or [Pilgrimage journeys are in their thoughts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 84:5 (#5)

בִּלְבָבָם

“are} in their heart”

The pronoun **their** refers to the kind of person described as **the man** in the first part of the verse. The psalmist shifts from singular to plural because he is speaking of everyone who fits this description. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [are in his heart]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 84:5 (#6)

בִּלְבָבָם

“are} in their heart”

Here, **their heart** represents the desires and intentions of the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [are in their thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 84:6 (#1)

מַעְיָן יְשִׁיתֻהוּ

“they make it a spring”

The psalmist is speaking of the pilgrims as if they transformed the Valley of Baca into **a spring** of water. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they find water there] or [they make it a place of refreshment]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 84:6 (#2)

בְּבָרָכוֹת

“with} blessings”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **blessings**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with good things from God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 84:7 (#1)

יֵלְכוּ

“They go”

The pronoun **They** refers to the pilgrims described in verses 5 and 6 who are traveling to God’s temple. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The pilgrims go]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 84:7 (#2)

מֵחַיִל אֶל־חָיִל

“from strength to strength”

The psalmist is using **from strength to strength** as a common expression meaning that the pilgrims grow increasingly strong as they travel. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with ever-increasing strength]

See: Idiom

Psalms 84:8 (#1)

תְּפִלָּתִי

“my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I pray]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 84:9 (#1)

מָגִנֵּנוּ

“our shield”

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a **shield** that protects in battle. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [our protector] or [the one who shields us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 84:9 (#2)

פְּנֵי מְשִׁיחֶךָ

“the face of your anointed”

Here, **the face** represents the person of the anointed king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your anointed one]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 84:9 (#3)

מְשִׁיחֶךָ

“your anointed”

The psalmist is using the adjective **anointed** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [your anointed one]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 84:10 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for the request made in verses 8 and 9. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 84:10 (#2)

מֵאָלָף

“than a thousand”

The psalmist says **than a thousand** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [than any number of days elsewhere]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 84:10 (#3)

בְּאָהֳלֵי־רֶשַׁע

“in the tents of wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same

idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the tents of wicked people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 84:10 (#4)

בְּאָהֳלֵי־רֶשַׁע

“in the tents of wickedness”

Here, **the tents** represents the homes and dwellings of wicked people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the homes of wickedness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 84:11 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a further reason for the psalmist’s desire to be in God’s courts. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 84:11 (#2)

שֶׁ֤מֶשׁ ו וּמָגֵן֮

“is} a sun and a shield”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh God as if he were **a sun** that gives life and light and **a shield** that protects from harm. If these images communicate well in your language, please use them. If not, you could express them as comparisons. Alternate translation: [the one who gives us life like the sun and protects us like a shield]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 84:11 (#3)

חֵ֣ן וְ֭כָבוֹד יִתֵּ֣ן

“gives favor and glory”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **favor** and **glory**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [treats people favorably and honors them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 84:11 (#4)

טֹ֑וב

“good”

The psalmist is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [good things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 84:11 (#5)

לַ֝הֹלְכִ֗ים בְּתָמִֽים

“from the ones walking in blamelessness”

The psalmist is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a path that the person was **walking** along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones living in blamelessness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 84:11 (#6)

בְּתָמִֽים

“in blamelessness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **blamelessness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [blamelessly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 84:12 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי־

“the happinesses of”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [oh, how happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 84:12 (#2)

אָ֝דָ֗ם

“the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be

more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms - Chapter 85 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 85 is a psalm of supplication or lament. In its core, it presents three of the basic elements of that type of psalm. (See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.) It was most likely written shortly after the first group of Judeans returned from exile in Babylon. Its first part is a recollection of how Yahweh has begun to restore the people, and its concluding part is a vision of how he will do that comprehensively. The supplication in the middle is the psalmist's plea to him to move the people from their difficult present into their hopeful future in light of what he has already done for them in the past.

1. Recollection of Yahweh's restoration of the people (1–3)
2. Cry for help (4–7)
3. Petition (7)
4. Statement of trust (8)
5. Prediction of Yahweh's future mercies (9–13)

Psalms 85:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 85:1 (#1)

רָצִיתָ יְהוָה אַרְצֶךָ שַׁבְתָּ שבות יַעֲקֹב

"You favored your land, Yahweh; you restored the captivity of Jacob"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [You showed favor to your land, Yahweh, by restoring the captivity of your people] or [You favored your land, Yahweh; indeed, you restored the captivity of Jacob]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 85:1 (#2)

יַעֲקֹב

"Jacob"

The psalmist is using the name of a man, **Jacob**, to refer to his descendants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the name of the people instead. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 85:2 (#1)

נָשָׂאתָ עֲוֹן עַמֶּךָ כִּסִּיתָ כָל־חַטָּאתָמֶּם

"You bore the iniquity of your people; you covered all of their sin"

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You completely forgave all the sins of your people]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 85:2 (#2)

נָשָׂאתָ עֲוֹן עַמֶּךָ

"You bore the iniquity of your people"

The psalmist is speaking of forgiving sin as if that were to physically carry the burden of the ones who sinned. If your language does not have a comparable expression, or if this image does not communicate well, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You forgave the iniquity of your people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 85:2 (#3)

עֲוֹן עַמֶּךָ

"the iniquity of your people"

The psalmist is using the possessive form to mean that **your people** committed **the iniquity**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the possessive form with a verb or in some

other way. Alternate translation: [the wickedness that your people did]

See: Possession

Psalms 85:2 (#4)

עֲוֹן

“the iniquity of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **the iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what your people did wrong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:2 (#5)

כִּסִּיתָ כָּל־חַטָּאתָם

“you covered all of their sin”

The psalmist is speaking of forgiving sin as if it were covering something so that it could no longer be seen. If your language does not have a comparable expression, or if this image does not communicate well, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you forgave all of their sin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 85:2 (#6)

חַטָּאתָם

“their sin”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **their sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what they did sinfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:3 (#1)

אָסַפְתָּ כָּל־עֶבְרָתֶךָ הֵשַׁבְתָּ מֵחֲרוֹן אַפֶּךָ

“You gathered up all of your wrath; you turned back from the burning of your nose”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You completely stopped being angry with us]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 85:3 (#2)

עֶבְרָתֶךָ

“your wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **your wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how wrathful you were]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:3 (#3)

מֵחֲרוֹן אַפֶּךָ

“the burning of your nose”

Meaning fierce anger, **the burning of your nose** was a common expression. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your fierce anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 85:4 (#1)

שׁוּבֵנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ

“Restore us, God of our salvation”

The psalmist is using the imperative form to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a form that is more natural for a request. Alternate translation: [Please restore us, God of our salvation]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 85:4 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ

“God of our salvation”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **God** as characterized by **salvation**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the possessive form in another way. Alternate translation: [God who saves us]

See: Possession

Psalms 85:4 (#3)

יִשְׁעֵנוּ

“our salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [saving us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:4 (#4)

וְהָפֵ֣ר כַּעַסְךָ֣ עִמָּ֑נוּ

“and break up your vexation with us”

The psalmist is using the imperative form to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a form that is more natural for a request. Alternate translation: [and please break up your vexation with us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 85:4 (#5)

כַּעַסְךָ֣

“your vexation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **your vexation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how vexed you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:5 (#1)

הַלְעוֹלָ֥ם תֶּאֱנַף־בָּ֑נוּ

“Will you be angry with us forever”

The psalmist is using the question form to express a plea. If you would not use the question form for this function in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please do not be angry with us forever.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 85:5 (#2)

תִּמְשֹׁ֣ךְ אַפְּךָ֣ לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“Will you prolong your nose to generation and generation”

The psalmist is using the question form to express a plea. If you would not use the question form for this function in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please do not prolong your anger to every generation.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 85:5 (#3)

אַפְּךָ֣

“your nose”

The psalmist is using the word **nose** to represent anger, since a person’s nose may flare or become hot when angry. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the name of the emotion instead. Alternate translation: [your anger]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 85:5 (#4)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“to generation and generation”

The expression **to generation and generation** was a common expression meaning “for a long time into the future.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all future generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 85:6 (#1)

הֲלֹא־אַתָּ֥ה תָשׁ֗וּב

“You, will you not return”

The psalmist is using the question form to express a plea. If you would not use the question form for this function in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please return to us.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 85:6 (#2)

הֲלֹא־אַתָּ֥ה תָשׁ֗וּב

“You, will you not return”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb form translated as **will you not return** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is posing the question to Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, will you not return]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 85:6 (#3)

תְּחַיֵּ֥ינוּ

“May you revive us”

The psalmist is using a jussive form to express a wish directed to God. If it would be helpful in your language,

you could use a form that is more natural for a request. Alternate translation: [Please revive us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 85:6 (#4)

וְֽעַמְּךָ

“that your people”

The psalmist has been speaking to God using the pronoun **us**, referring to himself and the people together, but now he switches to the third person, saying **your people**. The psalmist is referring to the same group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could maintain the same person throughout. Alternate translation: [we, your people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 85:7 (#1)

הַרְאֵ֣נוּ יְהוָ֣ה חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“Make us see your covenant faithfulness, Yahweh”

The psalmist is using the imperative form to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a form that is more natural for a request. Alternate translation: [Please make us see your covenant faithfulness]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 85:7 (#2)

הַרְאֵ֣נוּ יְהוָ֣ה חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“Make us see your covenant faithfulness, Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of experiencing God’s covenant faithfulness as if it were something that could be physically seen. If your language does not have a comparable expression, or if this image does not communicate well, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Make us experience your covenant faithfulness, Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 85:7 (#3)

חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **your covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are to your covenant with us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:7 (#4)

וְֽיֶשְׁעֲךָ֖ תִּתֶּן־לָֽנוּ

“and give your salvation to us”

The psalmist is using the imperative form to make a request to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a form that is more natural for a request. Alternate translation: [and please give your salvation to us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 85:7 (#5)

וְֽיֶשְׁעֲךָ֖ תִּתֶּן־לָֽנוּ

“and give your salvation to us”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **your salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and give your saving help to us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:7 (#6)

יְהוָ֣ה חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ וְֽיֶשְׁעֲךָ֖ תִּתֶּן־לָֽנוּ

“your covenant faithfulness, Yahweh, and give your salvation to us”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to mean that both **covenant faithfulness** and **salvation** come from God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea behind the possessive form in another way. Alternate translation: [the covenant faithfulness that you show, Yahweh, and the salvation that you give us]

See: Possession

Psalms 85:8 (#1)

אֶשְׁמְעָ֗ה

“Let me hear”

Up to this point, the psalmist has been speaking on behalf of the community, using **us** and **we**. Now the psalmist shifts to speaking individually, saying **me**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify this. Alternate translation: [Let me, the psalmist, hear]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 85:8 (#2)

כִּֽי־ יְדַבֵּ֣ר שָׁל֣וֹם

“for he will speak peace”

In this verse, the result is stated before the reason. The psalmist wants to hear what God will speak, and the reason is that God will speak **peace** to his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could reverse the order and put the reason before the result. Alternate translation: [because he will speak peace]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 85:8 (#3)

שָׁלֹום

“peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [peaceful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:8 (#4)

וְאַל־יָשׁוּבוּ לְכִסְלָה

“but let them not return to folly”

The psalmist is saying what he wants **his people** to do. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about this form of speech and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [but they should not return to folly]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 85:8 (#5)

וְאַל־יָשׁוּבוּ

“but let them not return”

The pronoun **them** refers to the people and faithful ones mentioned earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the referent more explicitly. Alternate translation: [but let his people not return]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 85:8 (#6)

וְאַל־יָשׁוּבוּ לְכִסְלָה

“but let them not return to folly”

The psalmist is speaking of resuming a sinful way of life as if it were physically turning around and going back to a place. If your language does not have a comparable expression, or if this image does not communicate well, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but let them not begin acting foolishly again]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 85:8 (#7)

לְכִסְלָה

“to folly”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **folly**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to foolish behavior]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:9 (#1)

יְשׁוּעָתוֹ

“his salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **his salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his saving help]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:9 (#2)

לִירֵאָיו

“to his reverent {ones”

The psalmist is using the adjective **reverent** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to the people who revere him]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 85:9 (#3)

לִשְׁכֹּן כָּבוֹד בְּאַרְצֵנוּ

“for glory to dwell in our land”

The psalmist is using the word **for** to introduce the purpose for which God’s salvation is near. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the purpose relationship more explicit. Alternate translation: [so that glory may dwell in our land]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 85:9 (#4)

לִשְׁכֹּן כָּבוֹד בְּאַרְצֵנוּ

“for glory to dwell in our land”

The psalmist is using the word **glory** to represent God’s manifest presence among his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this

meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for God's glorious presence to dwell in our land]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 85:9 (#5)

כָּבוֹד

"glory"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [glorious presence]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:9 (#6)

אַךְ ׀ קָרוֹב לִירֵאָיו יְשׁוּעָתוֹ לִשְׁכֹּן כָּבוֹד בְּאַרְצֵנוּ

"Surely his salvation {is} near to his reverent {ones}, for glory to dwell in our land"

In this verse, both uses of the pronoun **his** refer to Yahweh, and the pronoun **our** refers to the psalmist and the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify the referents. Alternate translation: [Surely Yahweh's salvation is near to the people who revere Yahweh, for glory to dwell in the land of the people of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 85:10 (#1)

חֶסֶד־וֶאֱמֶת נִפְגָּשׁוּ צֶדֶק וְשָׁלוֹם נָשָׁקוּ

"Covenant faithfulness and truth will meet together; righteousness and peace will kiss"

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [God will be completely faithful, true, righteous, and peaceful toward his people]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 85:10 (#2)

חֶסֶד־וֶאֱמֶת נִפְגָּשׁוּ

"Covenant faithfulness and truth will meet together"

The psalmist speaks of **Covenant faithfulness** and **truth** as if they were people who could **meet together**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God will be both faithful to his covenant and true to his word at the same time]

See: Personification

Psalms 85:10 (#3)

חֶסֶד־וֶאֱמֶת

"Covenant faithfulness and truth"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **Covenant faithfulness** and **truth**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [Being faithful to his covenant and being true to his word]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:10 (#4)

צֶדֶק וְשָׁלוֹם נָשָׁקוּ

"righteousness and peace will kiss"

The psalmist speaks of **righteousness** and **peace** as if they were people who could **kiss** in greeting. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [doing what is right and having peace will go together]

See: Personification

Psalms 85:10 (#5)

צֶדֶק וְשָׁלוֹם

"righteousness and peace"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **peace**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [acting rightly and being at peace]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:11 (#1)

אֱמֶת מֵאֶרֶץ תִּצְמָח

"Truth will sprout from the earth"

The psalmist speaks of **Truth** as if it were a plant that could **sprout from the earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Faithfulness will flourish among people on earth]

See: Personification

Psalms 85:11 (#2)

אֱמֶת

"Truth"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Truthful communication]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:11 (#3)

וְצֶדֶק מִשָּׁמַיִם נִשְׁקָף

"and righteousness will look down from the heavens"

The psalmist speaks of **righteousness** as if it were a person who could **look down from the heavens**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the right actions of God will descend from the heavens]

See: Personification

Psalms 85:11 (#4)

וְצֶדֶק

"and righteousness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and just actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:12 (#1)

וְאַרְצֵנוּ תִּתֵּן יְבוּלָהּ

"and our land will give its produce"

The psalmist speaks of **our land** as if it were a person who could **give** something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and our land will yield its produce]

See: Personification

Psalms 85:13 (#1)

צֶדֶק לְפָנָיו יְהַלֵּךְ

"Righteousness walks before him"

The psalmist speaks of **Righteousness** as if it were a person who could **walk** ahead of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will act rightly in all he does] or [Righteousness accompanies all that Yahweh does]

See: Personification

Psalms 85:13 (#2)

צֶדֶק

"Righteousness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [What is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 85:13 (#3)

צֶדֶק לְפָנָיו יְהַלֵּךְ וְיָשֵׂם לְדֶרֶךְ פְּעָמָיו

"Righteousness walks before him, and it puts his steps in the way"

The pronouns **him** and **his** refer to Yahweh. The pronoun **it** refers to righteousness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the referent more explicitly. Alternate translation: [Righteousness walks before Yahweh, and righteousness puts Yahweh's steps in the way]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 86 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 86 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It presents all of the basic elements of that type of psalm. (Some elements are repeated.) See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–4)
2. Statement of trust (5)
3. Cry for help (6)
4. Statement of trust (7–10)
5. Petition (11)
6. Vow of praise (12–13)
7. Description of troubles (14)
8. Petition (15–17)

Psalms 86:1 (#1)

הַטֵּה־יְהוָה אָזְנְךָ

"Incline your ear, Yahweh"

David is using the term **ear** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Pay attention to me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:1 (#2)

הַטֵּה־יְהוָה אָזְנְךָ

“Incline your ear, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please listen to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:1 (#3)

עֲנֵנִי

“answer me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please answer me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:1 (#4)

כִּי־עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן אָנִי

“for I {am} poor and needy”

The word **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I am poor and needy]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:1 (#5)

עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן

“am} poor and needy”

The terms **poor** and **needy** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [very poor]

See: Doublet

Psalms 86:2 (#1)

שָׁמְרָה נַפְשִׁי

“Guard my soul”

David is using **soul** to represent his whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Guard me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 86:2 (#2)

שָׁמְרָה נַפְשִׁי

“Guard my soul”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please guard my soul]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:2 (#3)

כִּי־חָסִיד אָנִי

“for I {am} faithful”

The word **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I am a godly one]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:2 (#4)

הוֹשַׁע עַבְדְּךָ

“save your servant”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please save your servant]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:2 (#5)

הַבּוֹטֵחַ אֵלֶיךָ

“the one trusting in you”

The phrase **the one trusting in you** refers to David himself. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [because I trust in you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 86:3 (#1)

חָנֵּנִי

“Favor me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please be gracious to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:3 (#2)

כִּֽי־אֵלֶ֥יךָ אֶקְרָ֗א כָּל־הַיּֽוֹם

“for to you I call all of the day”

The word **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because to you I call all the day]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:3 (#3)

כָּל־הַיּֽוֹם

“all of the day”

David is saying **all the day** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [all day long]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 86:4 (#1)

שַׂמֵּ֥חַ נֶֽפֶשׁ עַבְדֶּ֑ךָ

“Gladden the soul of your servant”

David is using **soul** to represent his whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Make glad your servant]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 86:4 (#2)

שַׂמֵּ֥חַ נֶֽפֶשׁ עַבְדֶּ֑ךָ

“Gladden the soul of your servant”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please make glad the soul of your servant]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:4 (#3)

כִּֽי אֵלֶ֥יךָ אֲדֹנָ֗י נַפְשִׁ֥י אֶשָּֽׂא

“for to you, Lord, I lift up my soul”

The word **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because to you, Lord, I lift up my soul]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:4 (#4)

נַפְשִׁ֥י אֶשָּֽׂא

“I lift up my soul”

Here David is speaking of directing his devotion to God as if he were physically **lifting up** his soul to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I pray to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 86:5 (#1)

כִּֽי־אַתָּ֣ה אֲדֹנָ֣י ט֭וֹב וְסַלָּ֑ח

“For you, Lord, {are} good and forgiving”

The word **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because you, Lord, are good and forgiving]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:5 (#2)

חֶ֝֗סֶד

“covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [faithfully keeping your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 86:6 (#1)

הַאֲזִינָה יְהוָה תְּפִלָּתִי וְהַקְשִׁיבָה בְּקוֹל תַּחֲנוּנוֹתָי

“Listen {to} my prayer, Yahweh, and attend to the voice of my pleas”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, listen carefully to my earnest prayer]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 86:6 (#2)

הַאֲזִינָה יְהוָה תְּפִלָּתִי

“Listen {to} my prayer, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please listen to my prayer, Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:6 (#3)

תְּפִלָּתִי

“to} my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to what I pray]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 86:6 (#4)

וְהַקְשִׁיבָה בְּקוֹל תַּחֲנוּנוֹתָי

“and attend to the voice of my pleas”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [and please attend to the voice of my pleas]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:6 (#5)

בְּקוֹל תַּחֲנוּנוֹתָי

“to the voice of my pleas”

Here, **voice** represents the content of what David is saying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my pleas]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:6 (#6)

תַּחֲנוּנוֹתָי

“my pleas”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pleas**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I plead]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 86:7 (#1)

בְּיוֹם צָרָתִי

“In the day of my trouble”

David is using **In the day of my trouble** as a common expression to mean “at the time of my trouble.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When trouble comes to me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 86:7 (#2)

כִּי תַעֲנֵנִי

“for you will answer me”

The word **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because you answer me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:8 (#1)

אֵין־כָּמוֹךָ בָאֱלֹהִים ׀ וְאֵין כְּמַעֲשֶׂיךָ

“There is none like you among the gods, Lord, and there is nothing like your works”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You are greater than all other gods, Lord, and your works surpass all others]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 86:9 (#1)

כָּל־גּוֹיִם

“All of the nations”

David is saying **All of the nations** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [Many nations]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 86:9 (#2)

וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לְפָנֶיךָ

“and bow down to your face”

Here, **your face** represents your presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [bow down before you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:9 (#3)

וְיכַבְּדוּ לִשְׁמֶךָ

“and they will glorify your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and to refer to his reputation. Alternate translation: [and they will glorify you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:9 (#4)

וְיכַבְּדוּ לִשְׁמֶךָ

“and they will glorify your name”

The pronoun **they** refers to the nations that Yahweh has made. The pronoun **your** refers to the Lord. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the nations will glorify your name, Lord]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 86:10 (#1)

כִּי־גָדוֹל אַתָּה

“For you {are} great”

The word **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because you are great]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:11 (#1)

הוֹרֵנִי יְהוָה ׀ דַּרְכֶּךָ

“Teach me your way, Yahweh”

Here David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Teach me how you want me to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 86:11 (#2)

הוֹרֵנִי יְהוָה ׀ דַּרְכֶּךָ

“Teach me your way, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please teach me your way]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:11 (#3)

אֶהֱלֵךְ בַּאֲמִתֶּךָ

“that I may walk in your truth”

Here David is speaking of living according to God’s truth as if he were **walking** along a path. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will live according to your truth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 86:11 (#4)

אֲהַלֵּךְ בַּאֲמִתֶּךָ

“that I may walk in your truth”

Here, **I will walk in your truth** marks David’s faithful living as the goal or purpose of the teaching he requests. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that I may walk in your truth]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 86:11 (#5)

בַּאֲמִתֶּךָ

“in your truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trustworthiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what you show to be true]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 86:11 (#6)

יַחֵד לְבָבִי

“Unite my heart”

Here, **heart** represents David’s will and desires. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Unite my will]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:11 (#7)

יַחֵד לְבָבִי

“Unite my heart”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please unite my heart]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:11 (#8)

לִירְאָה שְׁמֶךָ

“to fear your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and to refer to his reputation. Alternate translation: [to fear you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:12 (#1)

בְּכָל־לְבָבִי

“with all of my heart”

Here the **heart** represents where David’s thoughts and feelings exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with all of my being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:12 (#2)

וַאֲכַבְּדָה שִׁמְךָ

“and I will glorify your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and to refer to his reputation. Alternate translation: [I will glorify you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 86:13 (#1)

כִּי־חַסְדְּךָ גָּדוֹל עָלָי

“For your covenant faithfulness {is} great toward me”

The word **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because your covenant faithfulness is great toward me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:13 (#2)

חַסְדְּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithfully you keep your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 86:13 (#3)

וְהִצַּלְתָּ נַפְשִׁי

“and you have delivered my soul”

David is using **soul** to represent his whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you have delivered me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 86:14 (#1)

זֵדִ֣ים

“the arrogant”

David is using the adjective **arrogant** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [arrogant people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 86:14 (#2)

עָרִיצִ֥ים

“the violent”

David is using the adjective **violent** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [violent people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 86:14 (#3)

בִּקְשׁ֣וּ נַפְשִׁ֑י

“seek my life”

David is using **seek my life** as a common expression to mean “try to kill me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [try to kill me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 86:14 (#4)

וְלֹ֣א שָׂמ֣וּךָ לְנֶגְדָּ֑ם

“and they do not set you before them”

David is using **they have not set you before them** as a common expression to mean “they do not pay attention to you” or “they do not regard you.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they do not consider you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 86:14 (#5)

וְלֹ֣א שָׂמ֣וּךָ לְנֶגְדָּ֑ם

“and they do not set you before them”

The pronoun **they** refers to the arrogant and the violent ones described earlier in the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and these enemies do not set you before them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 86:15 (#1)

וְאַתָּ֣ה אֲדֹנָ֣י

“But you, Lord”

David uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the enemies described in the previous verse and Yahweh’s character. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, you, Lord]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 86:15 (#2)

אֵ֤ל־רַחוּם֙ וְחַנּ֔וּן

“are} a merciful and gracious God”

The terms **merciful** and **gracious** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [very compassionate]

See: Doublet

Psalms 86:15 (#3)

אֶ֥רֶךְ אַפַּ֗יִם

“long of nostrils”

David is using **long of nostrils** as a common expression to mean “slow to become angry.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [slow to anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 86:15 (#4)

וְרַב־חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת

“and plentiful of covenant faithfulness and truth”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **truth**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and being so very faithful to your covenant and being truthful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 86:16 (#1)

פְּנֵה אֵלַי וְחָנֵּנִי

“Turn to me and favor me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please turn to me and favor me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:16 (#2)

פְּנֵה אֵלַי

“Turn to me”

The psalmist is speaking as if God were not looking at him and he is asking him to **turn to** him and pay attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Please pay attention to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 86:16 (#3)

תְּנָה־עֻזְּךָ לְעַבְדֶּךָ

“give your strength to your servant”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please give your strength to your servant]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:16 (#4)

תְּנָה־עֻזְּךָ לְעַבְדֶּךָ

“give your strength to your servant”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [make your servant strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 86:16 (#5)

וְהוֹשִׁיעָה לְבֶן־אֲמָתֶךָ

“and save the son of your female servant”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [and please save the son of your female servant]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:16 (#6)

לְבֶן־אֲמָתֶךָ

“the son of your female servant”

David is using **the son of your female servant** as a common expression to indicate that he was born into Yahweh’s service. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your servant from birth]

See: Idiom

Psalms 86:17 (#1)

עֲשֵׂה־עִמִּי אוֹת לְטוֹבָה

“Work for me a sign for good”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please work for me a sign for good]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 86:17 (#2)

וְיִרְאוּ שֹׂנְאַי וְיֵבֹשׁוּ

“that the ones hating me may see and have shame”

Here, **that the ones hating me may see and have shame** marks the enemies' shame as the goal or purpose of the sign David requests. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that the ones hating me will see and have shame]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 86:17 (#3)

כִּי־אַתָּה יְהוָה עֲזַרְתַּנִי וְנִחַמְתָּנִי

"for you, Yahweh, you help me and comfort me"

The word **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because you, Yahweh, have help me and comfort me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 86:17 (#4)

כִּי־אַתָּה יְהוָה עֲזַרְתַּנִי

"for you, Yahweh, you help me and"

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **have helped** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh personally is the one who helps him. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you yourself, Yahweh, have helped me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 87 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 87 is a psalm of praise. It is a specific type of praise psalm, a "song of Zion." See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Celebration of how Yahweh chose Zion as the place for his temple (1–3)
2. Celebration of how people from all nations will worship Yahweh (4–6)
3. Celebration of how Yahweh's presence in Zion blesses people (7)

Psalms 87:1 (#1)

לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח

"Of the sons of Korah"

The word **sons** refers to the descendants of Korah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Of those who are descended from Korah]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 87:1 (#2)

יְסוֹדָתוֹ

"His foundation"

The pronoun **His** refers to Yahweh, who is named in the next verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh's foundation]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 87:1 (#3)

יְסוֹדָתוֹ בְּהַרְרֵי־קֹדֶשׁ

"His foundation {is} on the mountains of holiness"

Without naming it, the psalmist is speaking of the city of Zion as if it were a building that has a **foundation**. This represents the idea that God has firmly established the city. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The city he has established is on the mountains of holiness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 87:1 (#4)

בְּהַרְרֵי־קֹדֶשׁ

"is} on the mountains of holiness"

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **mountains** that are characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [mountains that are holy]

See: Possession

Psalms 87:1 (#5)

בְּהַרְרֵי־קֹדֶשׁ

"is} on the mountains of holiness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is on the mountains that are holy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 87:2 (#1)

שַׁעֲרֵי צִיּוֹן

“the gates of Zion”

The psalmist is using **the gates of Zion** to represent the entire city of Zion. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Zion itself]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 87:2 (#2)

מִשְׁכְּנוֹת יַעֲקֹב

“the dwellings of Jacob”

Here, **the dwellings of Jacob** represents the places where the descendants of Jacob live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the places where the descendants of Jacob live]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 87:3 (#1)

נְנִכְבָּדוֹת מְדֻבָּר בָּךְ

“Glorious things are spoken of you”

The expression **Glorious things are spoken of you** uses a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [God declares glorious things about you]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 87:3 (#2)

מְדֻבָּר בָּךְ עִיר הָאֱלֹהִים

“are spoken of you, city of God”

The psalmist is speaking to the city of Zion as if it could hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about how honored Zion is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if the psalmist were speaking to people about Zion. Alternate translation: [spoken about Zion, the city of God]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 87:3 (#3)

עִיר הָאֱלֹהִים

“city of God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean that Zion is the city where God dwells. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [city where God dwells]

See: Possession

Psalms 87:4 (#1)

אַזְכִּיר

“I will mention”

The pronoun **I** refers to Yahweh, who is the speaker from this point in the psalm. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [I, Yahweh, will mention]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 87:4 (#2)

רַהַב

“Rahab”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Egypt as if it were the sea monster **Rahab**. The psalmist may be comparing Egypt to Rahab because of the way God rescued Israel from Israel at the Sea of Reeds. It is not referring to the person named Rahab mentioned elsewhere in the Bible. You could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Egypt]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 87:4 (#3)

לְיֹדְעָי

“to the ones knowing me”

In the phrase **the ones knowing me**, the pronoun **me** refers to Yahweh, who is the speaker. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the ones knowing me, Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 87:4 (#4)

הִנֵּה

“behold”

Yahweh is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [take note]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 87:4 (#5)

פְּלֶשֶׁת וְצֹר עִם־כּוּשׁ

“Philistia and Tyre with Cush”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will also mention Philistia and Tyre with Cush]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 87:4 (#6)

זֶ֣ה יֻלַּד־שָׁ֑ם

“This one was born there”

This is a quotation that Yahweh says about each person from the nations he has listed. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate this with a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 87:4 (#7)

יֻלַּד

“was born”

The expression **was born** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [began life]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 87:5 (#1)

יֵאָמַ֥ר

“it will be said”

The expression **it will be said** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [everyone will declare]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 87:5 (#2)

אִ֭ישׁ וְאִ֣ישׁ יֻלַּד־בָּ֑הּ

“Man and man was born in her”

The psalmist is using **Man and man** as a common expression of the culture to mean “each and every person.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Each person was born in her] or [Person after person was born in her]

See: Idiom

Psalms 87:5 (#3)

אִ֭ישׁ וְאִ֣ישׁ יֻלַּד־בָּ֑הּ

“Man and man was born in her”

This is a direct quotation of what people will say about Zion. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate this with a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 87:5 (#4)

יֻלַּד

“was born”

The expression **was born** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [began life]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 87:5 (#5)

וְהִ֖וא יְכוֹנְנֶ֣הָ עֶלְיֽוֹן

“and he, he will establish her, the Most High”

The pronoun **he** refers to God Most High. The psalmist repeats the pronoun **he** for emphasis before naming **the Most High** directly. He is emphasizing that it is only God who can do this. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of

showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [God Most High himself will establish her]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 87:6 (#1)

בִּכְתָ֣וֹב עַמִּ֑ים

“in the writing of the peoples”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean a record that documents the peoples. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the record that lists the peoples]

See: Possession

Psalms 87:6 (#2)

בִּכְתָ֣וֹב

“in the writing of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **writing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is written about]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 87:6 (#3)

זֶ֣ה יֻלַּד־שָׁ֑ם

“This {one} was born there”

This is a quotation that Yahweh will record about each person from the nations. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate this with a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 87:6 (#4)

יֻלַּד

“was born”

The expression **was born** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [began life]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 87:7 (#1)

וְשָׁרְרִ֥ים כְּחֹלְלִ֑ים

“And the singers, like the pipers”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And the singers, like the pipers, will declare]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 87:7 (#2)

כְּחֹלְלִ֑ים

“like the pipers”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the pipers** play music, so **the singers** also make music. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [together with the pipers]

See: Simile

Psalms 87:7 (#3)

כָּל־מַעְיָנַ֖י בָּֽךְ

“All of my springs {are} in you”

The singers are speaking of Zion as if it were a place from which **springs** of water flow. This represents the idea that Zion is the source of all life and blessing. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All that sustains our lives comes from you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 87:7 (#4)

כָּל־מַעְיָנַ֖י בָּֽךְ

“All of my springs {are} in you”

This is a direct quotation of what the singers and pipers will say. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate this with a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms - Chapter 88 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 88 is a psalm of supplication or lament. Because the psalmist is feeling such despair, he does not make a statement of trust or a vow of praise, and he does not even make a petition. (The psalmist observes instead in verses 10–12 that if Yahweh does not heal him, he will not be able to praise him.) So only two

of the basic elements of a psalm of supplication are present. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry for help (1–2)
2. Description of troubles (3–8)
3. Cry for help (9–14)
4. Description of troubles (15–18)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Who wrote this psalm?
The superscription to Psalm 88 says that it is both a "psalm of the sons of Korah" and a "maskil of Heman the Ezrahite." The explanation for this is probably that the first part of the superscription belongs at the end of Psalm 87 (whose superscription attributes it to "the sons of Korah"). See the discussion of this in the introduction to the book of Psalms. As that discussion indicates, there is significant movement among biblical scholars toward seeing the musical instructions at the start of many psalm inscriptions as subscriptions to the previous psalms. However, published versions of the Bible do not yet tend to present them that way. Unless there is a Bible translation in your region that does, we recommend that you follow the current approach and retain both attributions in this superscription. The UST models one way to do that.

Psalms 88:0 (#2)

מַשְׂכִּיל

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 88:0 (#3)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 88:0 (#4)

עַל־מָחֲלַ֣ת לְעַנּ֑וֹת

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: עַל־מָחֲלַ֣ת לְעַנּ֑וֹת"

The phrase that the ULT translates as **Weakness of Afflicting** could be the name of the tune of this psalm. It might also be a musical instruction See how you translated the term **Weakness** in the superscription to Psalm 53. (The addition of the term **Afflicting** here seems to refer to what the psalmist says in verse 9, "My eye mourns from affliction.") Alternate translation: [perform this psalm about affliction in a minor key] or [perform this psalm about affliction in a somber tone]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 88:1 (#1)

יְשׁוּעָתִֽי

"my salvation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [saving me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:1 (#2)

יוֹם־צָעַ֥קְתִּי בַלַּ֗יְלָה

"by} day, in the night, I cry out"

The psalmist is referring to all times by naming two extremes, **day** and **night**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the time I cry out]

See: Merism

Psalms 88:2 (#1)

תָּבֹ֣וא לְפָנֶ֣יךָ תְּפִלָּתִ֑י הַטֵּ֖ה־אָ֣זְנְךָ֣ לְרִנָּתִֽי

"Let my prayer come to your face; incline your ear to my cry"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here

and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Let my prayer come to your face, indeed, please listen to what I cry out to you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:2 (#2)

תְּפִלָּתִֽי

“my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I pray]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:2 (#3)

לְפָנֶֽיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **to your face** represents being in front of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [into your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:2 (#4)

הַטֵּה־אָזְנְךָ֥ לְרִנָּתִֽי

“incline your ear to my cry”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as ‘please’ to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please pay attention to my cry]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 88:2 (#5)

הַטֵּה־אָזְנְךָ֥

“incline your ear”

The psalmist is using the term **ear** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [listen]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:2 (#6)

לְרִנָּתִֽי

“to my cry”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **cry**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to what I cry out]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:3 (#1)

כִּי־שָׂבְעָ֣ה בְרָעוֹת֮ נַפְשִׁי

“For my soul is full of troubles”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because my soul is full of troubles]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 88:3 (#2)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my whole being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:3 (#3)

בְרָעוֹת

“of troubles”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **troubles**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [troubling things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:3 (#4)

וְחַיַּ֥י לִשְׁאוֹל֮ הִגִּיעוּ

“and my life has come near to Sheol”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if his life were a journey that had nearly arrived at **Sheol**, which is the name of the realm of the dead. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am about to die]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 88:4 (#1)

נֶחְשַׁבְתִּי

“I am reckoned”

The expression **I am reckoned** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [People reckon me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 88:4 (#2)

יְוֹרְדֵי בֹּור

“the ones going down {into} the pit”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the dead were literally going down into **the pit** which associated with Sheol, the realm of the dead. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones who are dying]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 88:4 (#3)

כְּגֶ֥בֶר אֵין־אֱיָֽל

“like a man without strength”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a man without strength** is helpless, so is the psalmist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as a helpless man]

See: Simile

Psalms 88:4 (#4)

אֱיָל

“strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [anyone to make him strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:5 (#1)

בַּמֵּתִ֥ים חָפְשִׁ֑י

“free among the ones having died”

The psalmist actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here. If a speaker of your language would not do that, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [abandoned among the dead]

See: Irony

Psalms 88:5 (#2)

כְּמֹו֮ חֲלָלִ֪ים ׀ שֹׁ֫כְבֵ֥י קֶ֥בֶר

“like the slain lying in the grave”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the slain lying in the grave** are forgotten and helpless, so is the psalmist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as forgotten as corpses lying in the grave]

See: Simile

Psalms 88:5 (#3)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר לֹ֭א זְכַרְתָּ֣ם עֹ֑וד וְ֝הֵ֗מָּה מִיָּדְךָ֥ נִגְזָֽרוּ

“whom you do not remember them anymore, and they, they are cut off from your hand”

In the second half of the verse, the psalmist shifts from using **whom** to repeating **they, they**. Both refer to the dead. The doubled pronoun **they, they** reflects an emphasis in the original language on the finality of their separation from God.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 88:5 (#4)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר לֹ֭א זְכַרְתָּ֣ם

“whom you do not remember them”

It might seem that the expression **whom you do not remember them** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [whom you do not remember] or [You do not remember them]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 88:5 (#5)

וְ֝הֵ֗מָּה מִיָּדְךָ֥ נִגְזָֽרוּ

“and they, they are cut off from your hand”

The expression **they are cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [and they, you have cut them off from your hand]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 88:5 (#6)

נִגְזָרוּ

“they are cut off”

The psalmist is using **cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “removed.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they are removed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 88:5 (#7)

מִיָּדְךָ

“from your hand”

Here, **hand** represents the power and care of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from your care]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:6 (#1)

בְּבוֹר תַּחְתִּיּוֹת

“in the pit of the depths”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if **the pit of the depths** were literally a deep hole into which God had placed him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the lowest depths of suffering]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 88:6 (#2)

בְּמַחֲשַׁכִּים בִּמְצֹלוֹת

“in dark places, in deep places”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if **dark places** and **deep places** were the realm of death and separation from God. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in places of gloom and despair]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 88:7 (#1)

עָלַי סָמְכָה חֲמָתֶךָ וְכָל־מִשְׁבָּרֶיךָ עִנִּיתָ

“Your wrath rests heavily on me, and you overwhelm {me} {with} all of your waves”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You overwhelm me greatly with your wrath and your waves]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:7 (#2)

סָמְכָה חֲמָתֶךָ

“Your wrath rests heavily”

The psalmist is speaking of **wrath** as if it were a heavy weight that could press down on someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are very angry with me]

See: Personification

Psalms 88:7 (#3)

חֲמָתֶךָ

“Your wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Your being so angry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:7 (#4)

מִשְׁבָּרֶיךָ

“your waves”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God’s judgment were **waves** of water crashing over him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all of your punishments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 88:8 (#1)

הִרְחַקְתָּ מְיֻדָּעַי מִמֶּנִּי שַׁתַּתְנִי תוֹעֵבֹת לָמוֹ

“You have distanced my acquaintances from me; you have made me abominations to them”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You have distanced my acquaintances from me by making me so disgusting to them]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:8 (#2)

שַׂתַּתָּנִי תוֹעֵבֹת לָמוֹ

“you have made me abominations to them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the psalmist’s acquaintances mentioned in the previous phrase.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 88:8 (#3)

כָּלֻא וְלֹא אֵצֵא

“I am} shut in, and I do not go out”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [I am shut in so that I do not go out]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:8 (#4)

כָּלֻא

“I am} shut in”

The expression **shut in** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [You have confined me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 88:8 (#5)

כָּלֻא

“I am} shut in”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if he were literally **shut in** like a prisoner. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am trapped]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 88:9 (#1)

עֵינִי דָּאֲבָה

“My eye mourns”

Here, **My eye mourns** represents the psalmist himself weeping. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I weep]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:9 (#2)

עֹנִי

“affliction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **affliction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being afflicted]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:9 (#3)

קְרָאתִיךָ יְהוָה בְּכָל־יוֹם שִׁטַּחְתִּי אֵלֶיךָ כַּפָּי

“I call out to you, Yahweh, in all of the day; I spread out my palms to you”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [I call out to you, Yahweh, all day, spreading out my palms to you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:9 (#4)

כַּפָּי

“my palms”

Here, **palms** represents the act of praying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my hands in prayer]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:10 (#1)

הֲלַמֵּתִים תַּעֲשֶׂה־פֶּלֶא

“Will you do a wonder for the ones having died”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his belief that God does not do wonders for the dead. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You do not do a wonder for the ones having died.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 88:10 (#2)

פֶּלֶא

“a wonder”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wonder**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a wonderful thing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:10 (#3)

אִם־רְפָאִ֥ים יָקֻ֑מוּ

“Or will the Raphaites arise”

If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [And will the Raphaites arise?]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 88:10 (#4)

אִם־רְפָאִ֥ים יָקֻ֑מוּ

“Or will the Raphaites arise”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his belief that the Raphaites do not arise. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [The Raphaites will certainly not arise!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 88:10 (#5)

רְפָאִ֥ים

“will the Raphaites”

The word **Raphaites** is the name of a people group. Here it refers to the spirits of the dead in Sheol.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 88:10 (#6)

יוֹדֻ֥ךָ

“Will they thank you”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his belief that the dead do not thank God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [They will certainly not thank you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 88:11 (#1)

הֲיְסֻפַּ֣ר בַּקֶּ֣בֶר חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ אֱ֝מוּנָתְךָ֗ בָּאֲבַדּֽוֹן

“Will your covenant faithfulness be recounted in the grave, your faithfulness in Abaddon”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his belief that no one recounts God’s covenant faithfulness in the grave. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your covenant faithfulness will not be recounted in the grave, nor your faithfulness in Abaddon.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 88:11 (#2)

הֲיְסֻפַּ֣ר בַּקֶּ֣בֶר חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ אֱ֝מוּנָתְךָ֗ בָּאֲבַדּֽוֹן

“Will your covenant faithfulness be recounted in the grave, your faithfulness in Abaddon”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Will your covenant faithfulness be recounted in the grave and in the realm of the dead]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:11 (#3)

הֲיְסֻפַּ֣ר בַּקֶּ֣בֶר חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“Will your covenant faithfulness be recounted in the grave”

The expression **be recounted** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Will anyone recount your covenant faithfulness in the grave]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 88:11 (#4)

חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your being faithfully committed to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:11 (#5)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ בָּאֲבַדּוֹן

“your faithfulness in Abaddon”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and will your faithfulness be recounted in Abaddon]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 88:11 (#6)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ

“your faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your being faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:12 (#1)

הֲיִוָּדַע בַּחֹשֶׁךְ פִּלְאֶךָ וְצִדְקָתְךָ בְּאֶרֶץ נִשְׁיָה

“Will your wonder be known in the darkness, or your righteousness, in the land of forgetfulness”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his belief that God’s wonder and righteousness are not known in the darkness or the land of forgetfulness. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your wonder will not be known in the darkness nor your righteousness, in the land of forgetfulness.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 88:12 (#2)

הֲיִוָּדַע בַּחֹשֶׁךְ פִּלְאֶךָ וְצִדְקָתְךָ בְּאֶרֶץ נִשְׁיָה

“Will your wonder be known in the darkness, or your righteousness, in the land of forgetfulness”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Will your wonder and your righteousness be known in the darkness of the land of forgetfulness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:12 (#3)

פִּלְאֶךָ

“your wonder”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wonder**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wonderful deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:12 (#4)

הֲיִוָּדַע בַּחֹשֶׁךְ פִּלְאֶךָ

“Will your wonder be known in the darkness”

The expression **be known** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Will anyone know your wonder in the darkness]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 88:12 (#5)

וְצִדְקָתְךָ בְּאֶרֶץ נִשְׁיָה

“or your righteousness, in the land of forgetfulness”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [or will your righteousness be known in the land of forgetfulness]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 88:12 (#6)

וְצִדְקָתְךָ

“or your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [or your righteous acts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:12 (#7)

בְּאֶרֶץ נִשְׁיָה

“in the land of forgetfulness”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the place of the dead were literally **the land of forgetfulness**. Your language may have a comparable expression that

you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the place where everything is forgotten]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 88:12 (#8)

נְשִׁיָּה

“forgetfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **forgetfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [forgetting everything]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:13 (#1)

וַאֲנִי ׀ אֵלֶיךָ יְהוָה שִׁוַּעְתִּי וּבַבֹּקֶר תְּפִלָּתִי תְקַדְּמֶךָּ

“But I, I cry out to you, Yahweh, and in the morning my prayer precedes you”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [But I cry out to you every morning, Yahweh, and my prayer comes before you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:13 (#2)

וַאֲנִי ׀ אֵלֶיךָ יְהוָה שִׁוַּעְתִּי

“But I, I cry out to you, Yahweh”

The psalmist uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between his crying out to Yahweh and the silence of the dead in verses 10–12. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [However, I cry out to you, Yahweh]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 88:13 (#3)

וַאֲנִי

“But I”

The psalmist uses an independent pronoun, **I**, before the verb to emphasize that he, in contrast to the dead who cannot praise God, still cries out to Yahweh. Your language may use a similar construction to indicate emphasis.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 88:13 (#4)

תְּפִלָּתִי תְקַדְּמֶךָּ

“my prayer precedes you”

The psalmist is speaking of **my prayer** as if it were a living thing that could go ahead of someone to meet God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I come before you with what I pray]

See: Personification

Psalms 88:13 (#5)

תְּפִלָּתִי

“my prayer”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prayer**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I pray]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:14 (#1)

לָמָּה יְהוָה תִּזְנַח נַפְשִׁי תַּסְתִּיר פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי

“Why, Yahweh, do you reject my soul? {Why} do you hide your face from me”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Why, Yahweh, do you reject me and refuse to pay attention to me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:14 (#2)

לָמָּה יְהוָה תִּזְנַח נַפְשִׁי

“Why, Yahweh, do you reject my soul”

The psalmist is using the question form to express deep anguish and frustration at feeling rejected by God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, you should not reject my soul!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 88:14 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and

emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:14 (#4)

תַּסְתִּ֣יר פָּנֶ֣יךָ מִמֶּ֑נִּי

“Why} do you hide your face from me”

The psalmist is using the question form to express deep anguish at feeling that God is ignoring him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not hide your face from me!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 88:14 (#5)

פָּנֶ֣יךָ

“your face”

Here, **face** represents God’s presence and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [yourself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 88:15 (#1)

וְגֹוֵ֖עַ מִנֹּ֣עַר

“and expiring since youth”

The psalmist is saying **expiring since youth** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [and near death for as long as I can remember]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 88:15 (#2)

מִנֹּ֣עַר

“since youth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **youth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [since I was young]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:15 (#3)

אֶמְנֶ֑ה

“your terrors”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **terrors**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [things that terrify me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:16 (#1)

עָלַ֥י עָבְר֖וּ חֲרוֹנֶ֑יךָ בִּֽבְעוּתֶ֖יךָ צִמְּתוּתְנִֽי

“Your indignations pass over me; your terrors destroy me”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Your indignations and terrors pass over me and destroy me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:16 (#2)

עָבְר֖וּ חֲרוֹנֶ֑יךָ

“Your indignations pass”

The psalmist is speaking of **indignations** as if they were living things that could pass over a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You sweep over me with your indignations]

See: Personification

Psalms 88:16 (#3)

חֲרוֹנֶ֑יךָ

“Your indignations”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **indignations**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Your expressions of how indignant you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:16 (#4)

בִּֽבְעוּתֶ֖יךָ צִמְּתוּתְנִֽי

“your terrors destroy me”

The psalmist is speaking of **terrors** as if they were a living thing that could destroy someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you destroy me with things that terrify me]

See: Personification

Psalms 88:16 (#5)

בִּבְעוּתֶ֗יךָ

“your terrors”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **terrors**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things you do that terrify me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 88:17 (#1)

סַבּ֣וּנִי כַמַּ֣יִם כָּל־הַיּ֣וֹם הִקִּ֖יפוּ עָלָ֣י יָחַֽד

“They surround me like water all of the day; they close in upon me together”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [They surround me like water all of the day; indeed, they close in upon me together]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:17 (#2)

סַבּ֣וּנִי

“They surround me”

The pronoun **They** refers to the indignations and terrors mentioned in verse 16.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 88:17 (#3)

כַמַּ֣יִם

“like water”

The point of this comparison is that just as **water** surrounds and engulfs a person on all sides, so do the psalmist’s sufferings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a flood]

See: Simile

Psalms 88:17 (#4)

כָּל־הַיּ֣וֹם

“all of the day”

The psalmist is saying **all of the day** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [constantly]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 88:18 (#1)

הִרְחַ֣קְתָּ מִמֶּ֣נִּי אֹהֵ֔ב וָרֵ֖עַ מְיֻדָּעַ֑י מַחְשָֽׁךְ

“You have distanced friend and acquaintance from me; the ones known to me {are} darkness”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You have removed everyone I know from me, and I do not see them anymore]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 88:18 (#2)

מְיֻדָּעַ֑י מַחְשָֽׁךְ

“the ones known to me {are} darkness”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if **darkness** were literally his companion. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the only thing I know is loneliness and gloom]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 89 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 89 is a psalm of supplication or lament. It appears to have been written shortly after the destruction of Jerusalem to protest that while Yahweh had promised that David’s descendants would always rule as kings, and Yahweh had the power to make sure that happened, he allowed enemies to destroy Jerusalem and depose the king. The psalmist uses three of the basic elements of a psalm of supplication. (See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.) However, before he does that, the psalmist praises Yahweh for his power, and he cites his covenant with David as grounds for praying for restoration. These two first parts of the psalm correspond roughly to the other two basic elements of a psalm of supplication, a vow of praise and a statement of trust.

1. Praise of Yahweh’s power and greatness (1–18)
2. Yahweh’s covenant with David (19–37)
3. Description of troubles (38–45)
4. Cry for help (46–49)
5. Petition (50–51)

Verse 52 is not part of the original psalm. It is a doxology (an expression of praise to God) that the editors of the book of Psalms added to mark the end of Book Three of the psalms. See how you translated the similar doxologies in 41:13 and 72:18–20.

Psalms 89:0 (#2)

מַשְׂכִּיל

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל"

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 89:1 (#1)

חַסְדֵּי יְהוָה עוֹלָם אָשִׁירָה לְדֹר וָדֹר ׀ אוֹדִיעַ אֱמוּנָתְךָ בְּפִי

"I will sing the covenant faithfulness of Yahweh forever; to generation and generation I will make known your faithfulness with my mouth"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I will always sing about the covenant faithfulness of Yahweh; indeed, I will tell every generation how faithful you are]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 89:1 (#2)

חַסְדֵּי

"the covenant faithfulness of"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how Yahweh faithfully keeps his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:1 (#3)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ

"your faithfulness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:1 (#4)

בְּפִי

"with my mouth"

Here, **with my mouth** represents speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by my words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:2 (#1)

כִּי־אָמַרְתִּי

"For I said"

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because I said]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 89:2 (#2)

חֶסֶד יִבָּנֶה

"Covenant faithfulness will be built up"

Here Ethan is speaking as if covenant faithfulness were a structure that could be **built up**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Covenant faithfulness will be established] or [You will show covenant faithfulness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:2 (#3)

חֶסֶד

"Covenant faithfulness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The way you faithfully love]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:2 (#4)

יִבָּנֶה

“will be built up”

The expression **will be built up** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [you will build up]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 89:2 (#5)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ

“your faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:2 (#6)

תָּכִין אֱמוּנָתְךָ בָּהֶם

“you establish your faithfulness in them”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about the heavens after the information about establishing faithfulness. Alternate translation: [you establish your faithfulness in the heavens]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 89:3 (#1)

כָּרַתִּי בְרִית לִבְחִירִי נִשְׁבַּעְתִּי לְדָוִד עַבְדִּי

“I have cut a covenant with my chosen; I have sworn to David my servant”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [God said that he has cut a covenant with his chosen; he has sworn to David his servant]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Psalms 89:3 (#2)

כָּרַתִּי בְרִית לִבְחִירִי נִשְׁבַּעְתִּי לְדָוִד עַבְדִּי

“I have cut a covenant with my chosen; I have sworn to David my servant”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [I swore an oath to David, my chosen servant]

Psalms 89:4 (#1)

עַד־עוֹלָם אָכִין זַרְעֶךָ וּבָנִיתִי לְדֹר־וָדֹר כִּסְאֶךָ סֶלָה

“Until forever I will establish your seed, and I will build up your throne to generation and generation.’” Selah”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [I swore that I will establish his seed until forever, and I will build up his throne to generation and generation]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

Psalms 89:4 (#2)

אָכִין זַרְעֶךָ

“I will establish your seed”

Here Ethan is speaking as if descendants were **seed** that is planted. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will establish your descendants] or [I will establish your offspring]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:4 (#3)

וּבָנִיתִי לְדֹר־וָדֹר כִּסְאֶךָ

“and I will build up your throne to generation and generation”

Ethan is using **build up your throne** as a common expression of the culture to mean “firmly establish your rule.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will firmly establish your rule] or [I will make your kingdom strong]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:4 (#4)

כִּסְאֶךָ

“your throne”

Here, **your throne** represents royal authority and rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use

an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your royal authority]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:5 (#1)

וְיוֹדוּ שָׁמַיִם פִּלְאֲךָ

“And the heavens praise your wonder”

Ethan is speaking of **the heavens** as if they were a living thing that could praise God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the beings in heaven praise your wonder]

See: Personification

Psalms 89:5 (#2)

אֱמוּנָתְךָ

“your faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how faithful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:5 (#3)

בִּקְהַל קְדֹשִׁים

“in the assembly of the holy ones”

Ethan is using this possessive form to describe an assembly that is made up of the holy ones. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in the assembly where the holy ones gather]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:6 (#1)

כִּי מִי בַשַּׁחַק יַעֲרֹךְ לַיהוָה יִדְמֶה לַיהוָה בִּבְנֵי אֵלִים

“For who in the sky arrays with Yahweh, compares to Yahweh among the sons of God”

Ethan is using the question form to emphasize that no one is comparable to Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [For no one in the sky arrays with Yahweh; no one compares to Yahweh among the sons of God.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 89:6 (#2)

בִּבְנֵי אֵלִים

“among the sons of God”

Here Ethan is speaking as if the heavenly beings were literal **sons of God** who were born from him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [among the heavenly beings] or [among the divine beings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:7 (#1)

נַעֲרָץ בְּסוֹד־קְדֹשִׁים רַבָּה

“is greatly dreaded in the council of the holy ones”

The expression **greatly dreaded** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the holy ones. Alternate translation: [the holy ones greatly dread God]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 89:7 (#2)

בְּסוֹד־קְדֹשִׁים

“in the council of the holy ones”

Ethan is using this possessive form to describe a council that is made up of the holy ones. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [council where the holy ones gather]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:8 (#1)

מִי־כָמוֹךָ חֲסִין ׀ יָהּ

“who {is} like you, mighty Yah”

Ethan is using the question form to emphasize that no one is like Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [no one is like you, mighty Yah!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 89:8 (#2)

וֶאֱמוּנָתְךָ סְבִיבוֹתֶיךָ

“And your faithfulness {is} your surroundings”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And you are characterized by how faithful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:8 (#3)

יָהּ

"Yah"

Yah is a shortened form of the name "Yahweh," the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 89:9 (#1)

אַתָּתָה מֹמֵשׁל בְּגֵאוּת הַיָּם

"You are ruling over the surging of the sea"

Here Ethan is speaking as if the **surging of the sea** represented chaotic forces that oppose God. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are ruling over the raging of the sea] or [You control the powerful forces of the sea]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:9 (#2)

אַתָּתָה תְּשַׁבְּחֵם

"you, you still them"

Ethan is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is Yahweh alone who has the power to calm the waves. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you alone still them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 89:10 (#1)

אַתָּתָה דִּכִּאתָ כֶחָלָל רָהָב

"You, you shattered Rahab like a slain one"

The point of this comparison is that just as **a slain one** is completely defeated and left powerless, so is **Rahab**, the sea monster, after God shattered it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [You completely defeated Rahab, shattering it as one would kill an enemy]

See: Simile

Psalms 89:10 (#2)

אַתָּתָה דִּכִּאתָ

"You, you shattered"

Ethan is stating the pronoun **You** separately, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it was Yahweh himself who accomplished this mighty act. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [You yourself shattered]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 89:10 (#3)

בִּזְרֹעַ עֻזְּךָ

"with the arm of your strength"

Here, **the arm of your strength** represents God's great power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your mighty power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:10 (#4)

בִּזְרֹעַ עֻזְּךָ

"with the arm of your strength"

Ethan is using this possessive form to describe an arm that is characterized by strength. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [your strong arm]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:10 (#5)

בִּזְרֹעַ עֻזְּךָ

"with the arm of your strength"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with your strong arm]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:11 (#1)

אַף־לְךָ֣ אֶ֭רֶץ

“also to you, the earth”

Ethan is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [also to you belongs the earth]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 89:11 (#2)

וּ֝מְלֹאָ֗הּ

“and its fullness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fullness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [everything that fills it]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:11 (#3)

אַתָּ֣ה יְסַדְתָּ֑ם

“you, you founded them”

Ethan is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that God himself is the one who established the world. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you yourself founded them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 89:11 (#4)

לְךָ֣ שָׁ֭מַיִם אַף־לְךָ֣ אֶ֑רֶץ תֵּבֵ֥ל וּ֝מְלֹאָ֗הּ אַתָּ֣ה יְסַדְתָּ֑ם

“To you {are} the heavens, also to you, the earth; the world and its fullness, you, you founded them”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You created and you own the entire world and everything in it]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 89:12 (#1)

צָפ֣וֹן וְ֭יָמִין

“The north and the south”

Ethan is referring to all of creation by naming two extremes, **the north** and **the south**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Everything in every direction]

See: Merism

Psalms 89:12 (#2)

אַתָּ֣ה בְרָאתָ֑ם

“you, you created them”

Ethan is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that God alone is the creator. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you yourself created them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 89:12 (#3)

תָּבֹ֣ור וְ֭חֶרְמֹון בְּשִׁמְךָ֣ יְרַנֵּֽנוּ

“Tabor and Hermon shout joyfully in your name”

Ethan is speaking of **Tabor and Hermon** as if they were living things that could shout joyfully. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people at Tabor and Hermon shout joyfully because of you]

See: Personification

Psalms 89:12 (#4)

בְּשִׁמְךָ֣

“in your name”

Ethan is using the term **name** to represent who the person is or to refer to the person’s reputation. Alternate translation: [because of who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:13 (#1)

גְּבוּרָ֥ה

“might”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **might**, you could express the same idea

in another way. Alternate translation: [an arm that is mighty]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:13 (#2)

תְּעֹ֣ז יָ֭דְךָ תָּר֣וּם יְמִינֶֽךָ

“your hand is strong; your right hand is high”

Here, **hand** represents the power or control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your power is strong; your authority is supreme]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:13 (#3)

תָּר֣וּם יְמִינֶֽךָ

“your right hand is high”

Here Ethan is speaking as if God’s power were **high** or physically elevated. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your right hand is exalted] or [your power is supreme]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:13 (#4)

לְךָ֣ זְר֣וֹעַ עִם־גְּבוּרָ֑ה

“To you {is} an arm with might”

Here, **arm** represents the power or control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have great power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:14 (#1)

צֶ֣דֶק וּ֭מִשְׁפָּט

“Righteousness and justice”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **justice**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Acting rightly and judging fairly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:14 (#2)

מְכ֣וֹן כִּסְאֶ֑ךָ

“are} the foundation of your throne”

Ethan is using this possessive form to describe the base on which God’s rule rests. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the foundation on which your throne rests]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:14 (#3)

כִּסְאֶ֑ךָ

“your throne”

Here, **throne** represents God’s royal authority and rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your rule]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:14 (#4)

חֶ֥סֶד וֶ֝אֱמֶ֗ת יְקַדְּמ֥וּ פָנֶֽיךָ

“covenant faithfulness and truth precede your face”

Ethan is speaking of **covenant faithfulness and truth** as if they were living things that could walk before God as attendants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you always show covenant faithfulness and truth in everything you do]

See: Personification

Psalms 89:14 (#5)

חֶ֥סֶד וֶ֝אֱמֶ֗ת

“covenant faithfulness and truth”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **truth**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [being faithfully loving and being true to your promises]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:14 (#6)

יְקַדְּמ֥וּ פָנֶֽיךָ

“precede your face”

Here, **face** represents God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [go before you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:14 (#7)

צֶדֶק וּמִשְׁפָּט מְכוֹן כִּסְאֶךָ

“Righteousness and justice {are} the foundation of your throne”

Here Ethan is speaking as if God’s rule were a building and righteousness and justice were its **foundation**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your rule is based on righteousness and justice] or [You always rule righteously and justly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:15 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

Ethan is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is] or [Truly blessed is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 89:15 (#2)

בָּאוֹר־פָּנֶיךָ יְהַלֵּכוּן

“they walk in the light of your face”

Here Ethan is speaking as if people who live in God’s favor **walk in the light** of Yahweh’s face. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they live enjoying your favor] or [they live in the brightness of your presence]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:15 (#3)

יְהַלֵּכוּן

“they walk”

Here Ethan is speaking as if living one’s life were **walking** along a path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they live] or [they conduct their lives]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:15 (#4)

בָּאוֹר־פָּנֶיךָ

“in the light of your face”

Ethan is using this possessive form to describe light that comes from God’s presence. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in the light that shines from your face]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:15 (#5)

פָּנֶיךָ

“your face”

Here, **face** represents God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:16 (#1)

בְּשִׁמְךָ

“In your name”

Ethan is using the term **name** to represent who the person is or to refer to the person’s reputation. Alternate translation: [Because of who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:16 (#2)

וּבְצִדְקָתְךָ יָרוּמוּ

“and in your righteousness they rise high”

Here Ethan is speaking as if being honored were to be physically rising **high**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and in your righteousness they are honored] or [and because you are righteous, you give them a high position]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:16 (#3)

וּבְצִדְקָתְךָ

“and in your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because you are righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:17 (#1)

תִּפְאֶ֣רֶת עֻזָּ֑מוֹ

“the splendor of their strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who makes their strength splendid]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:17 (#2)

עֻזָּ֑מוֹ

“their strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how strong they are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:17 (#3)

וּ֝בְרְצֹנְךָ֗

“and by your favor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **favor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and because you desired the best for us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:17 (#4)

תָּרִ֥ים קַרְנֵֽנוּ

“you raise up our horn”

Here Ethan is speaking as if power were a **horn** that could be raised up. In this case, it is likely that he means that Yahweh has allowed them to have a powerful king. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have allowed us to have a powerful king] or [you make us a strong nation]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:18 (#1)

לַֽיהוָ֥ה מָגִנֵּ֑נוּ

“our shield {is} to Yahweh”

Here Ethan is speaking of the king who protects them as if he were a battle **shield**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our protector belongs to Yahweh] or [Yahweh is the one who gave us our protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:18 (#2)

וְלִקְדֹ֖ושׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֣ל מַלְכֵּֽנוּ

“and our king, to the Holy {One} of Israel”

Ethan is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and our king belongs to the Holy One of Israel]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 89:18 (#3)

וְלִקְדֹ֖ושׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֣ל מַלְכֵּֽנוּ

“and our king, to the Holy {One} of Israel”

Ethan is using this possessive form to describe the holy God with whom the Israelites are in a covenant relationship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and our king belongs to the holy God with whom we Israelites are in a covenant relationship]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:19 (#1)

אָ֤ז דִּבַּ֖רְתָּ

“Then you spoke”

Ethan is using the word translated as **Then** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Psalms 89:19 (#2)

וַתֹּ֣אמֶר שִׁוִּ֣יתִי עֶ֭זְרָה עַל־גִּבּ֑וֹר הֲרִימֹ֖תִי בָּח֣וּר מֵעָֽם

“and said, “I have placed help on a warrior; I have raised up a chosen one from the people”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [telling them that you have placed help on a warrior; you have raised up a chosen one from the people]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Psalms 89:19 (#3)

עֵזֶר

“help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my helping hand]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:20 (#1)

בְּשֶׁמֶן קָדְשִׁי

“with the oil of my holiness”

Ethan is using the possessive form to describe **oil** that is characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my holy oil]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:20 (#2)

בְּשֶׁמֶן קָדְשִׁי

“with the oil of my holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with my holy oil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:21 (#1)

יָדִי תִּכּוֹן

“my hand will be established”

The expression **my hand will be established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [I will establish my hand]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 89:21 (#2)

יָדִי תִּכּוֹן

“my hand will be established”

Here, **hand** represents the power or dominion of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my power will be established]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:21 (#3)

אַף־זְרוֹעִי תְאַמְּצֶנּוּ

“my arm will also strengthen him”

Here, **arm** represents power or strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my power will also strengthen him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:22 (#1)

וּבֶן־עַוְלָה

“and a son of wickedness”

God is using **son of** as a common expression of the culture to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, the person has the characteristic of being wicked. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and a wicked person]

See: Idiom

Psalms 89:22 (#2)

עַוְלָה

“wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people acting wickedly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:23 (#1)

וְכַתּוֹתִי מִפָּנָיו צָרָיו וּמְשַׂנְאָיו אֶגּוֹף

“And I will crush his adversaries from his face, and I will strike down the ones hating him”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [I will completely destroy all of his enemies]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 89:23 (#2)

מִפָּנָיו

“from his face”

Here, **face** represents a person’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from before him] or [from his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:24 (#1)

וְאֶמוּנָתִי וְחַסְדִּי עִמּוֹ

“And my faithfulness and my covenant faithfulness {will be} with him”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **faithfulness** and **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [I will be faithful to him and loyally love him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:24 (#2)

וּבִשְׁמִי תָּרוּם קַרְנוֹ

“and in my name his horn will be high”

Here God is speaking as if David’s strength and honor were a **horn** lifted high. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and by my authority he will be exalted] or [and in my name he will be powerful]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:24 (#3)

וּבִשְׁמִי

“and in my name”

God is using the term **name** to represent who the person is or to refer to the person’s reputation. Alternate translation: [by my authority]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:25 (#1)

וְשַׂמְתִּי בַיָּם יָדוֹ וּבַנְּהָרוֹת יְמִינוֹ

“And I will set his hand on the sea and his right hand on the rivers”

Here, **hand** and **right hand** represent the power or dominion of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will give him dominion over the sea and authority over the rivers]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:25 (#2)

וְשַׂמְתִּי בַיָּם יָדוֹ וּבַנְּהָרוֹת יְמִינוֹ

“And I will set his hand on the sea and his right hand on the rivers”

Here God is speaking as if David would physically place his hands on the sea and rivers to claim them. God means that David’s rule will extend across a vast territory. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And his rule will extend from the sea to the rivers] or [And he will rule over the land from the Mediterranean Sea to the Euphrates River]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:26 (#1)

הוּא יִקְרָאֵנִי אָבִי אָתָּה אֵלִי וְצוּר יְשׁוּעָתִי

“He, he will call to me, ‘You {are} my Father, my God and the rock of my salvation”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [He will call to me that I am his Father, his God, and the rock of his salvation]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Psalms 89:26 (#2)

הוּא יִקְרָאֵנִי

“He, he will call to me”

God is stating the pronoun **He** separately, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that his chosen one is the one who will name God as his father. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [My chosen one will call to me]

See: Poetry

Psalms 89:26 (#3)

וְצוּר יְשׁוּעָתִי

“and the rock of my salvation”

Here God is speaking as if he were a **rock** that provides stability and protection. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the one who saves and protects me] or [my strong savior]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:26 (#4)

וְצוּר יְשׁוּעָתִֽי

“and the rock of my salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the rock who saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:27 (#1)

אַף־אֲנִי בְּכוֹר אֶתְּנֵֽהוּ

“And I, I will make him the firstborn”

God is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is the one who will personally exalt David in response to David’s faithfulness. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Indeed, I will make him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 89:27 (#2)

בְּכוֹר אֶתְּנֵֽהוּ

“I will make him the firstborn”

Here God is speaking of David’s privileged status as if he were a **firstborn** son, who holds the most honored position in the family. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will give him the highest honor] or [I will give him the privileges of a firstborn son]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:28 (#1)

לְעוֹלָ֥ם אשמור־ל֝וֹ חַסְדִּ֗י

“I will keep my covenant faithfulness for him forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will always be loyally faithful to him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:29 (#1)

וְשַׂמְתִּ֣י לָעַ֣ד זַרְע֑וֹ

“And I will set up his seed forever”

Here God is speaking of David’s descendants as if they were **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will establish his descendants forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:29 (#2)

וְ֝כִסְא֗וֹ כִּימֵ֣י שָׁמָֽיִם

“and his throne like the days of the heavens”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the days of the heavens** endure without end, so will **his throne** endure. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and his throne will last as long as the heavens endure]

See: Simile

Psalms 89:29 (#3)

וְ֝כִסְא֗וֹ

“and his throne”

Here, **throne** represents royal authority and the right to rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and his royal authority]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:30 (#1)

אִם־יַֽעַזְבֽוּ בָנָ֥יו תּוֹרָתִ֑י

“If his sons forsake my law”

Here, **If his sons forsake my law** introduces a possible condition. God will only do the things in the following verse if this condition happens. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen.

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 89:30 (#2)

וּֽבְמִשְׁפָּטַ֖י לֹ֣א יֵלֵכֽוּן

“and they do not walk in my judgments”

Here God is speaking as if people who obey his commands were **walking** along a path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not live according to my decrees] or [do not obey my rules]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:30 (#3)

אִם־יַֽעַזְבֻ֣ו בָ֭נָיו תּוֹרָתִ֑י וּֽבְמִשְׁפָּטַ֖י לֹ֣א יֵלֵכֽוּן

“If his sons forsake my law and they do not walk in my judgments”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [If his sons completely reject and disobey my commandments]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 89:30 (#4)

אִם־יַֽעַזְבֻ֣ו בָ֭נָיו תּוֹרָתִ֑י וּֽבְמִשְׁפָּטַ֖י לֹ֣א יֵלֵכֽוּן

“If his sons forsake my law and they do not walk in my judgments”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **law** and **judgments**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [If his sons forsake what I have taught them and do not walk in the way that I have told them to live]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:31 (#1)

אִם־חֻקֹּתַ֥י יְחַלֵּ֑לוּ וּֽמִצְוֹתַ֖י לֹ֣א יִשְׁמֹֽרוּ

“if they profane my statutes and they do not keep my commandments”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **statutes** and **commandments**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [if they profane the rules I have established and they do not do the things I have commanded them to do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:32 (#1)

וּפָקַדְתִּ֣י

“then I will punish”

This verse introduces the consequence of the condition proposed in the previous verse. Use a natural form in your language for introducing the consequence of this possible condition. Alternate translation: [then I will visit]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 89:32 (#2)

וּפָקַדְתִּ֣י בְשֵׁ֣בֶט פִּשְׁעָ֑ם

“then I will punish their transgression with a rod”

Here, **rod** represents guiding, protecting, and directing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will discipline them for their transgression]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:32 (#3)

וּפָקַדְתִּ֣י בְשֵׁ֣בֶט פִּשְׁעָ֑ם וּבִנְגָעִ֥ים עֲוֹנָֽם

“then I will punish their transgression with a rod and their iniquity with blows”

God is using this possessive forms, **their transgression** and **their iniquity**, to assign to them the ownership of their behaviors. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [then I will punish the transgression they commit with a rod and the iniquity they commit with blows]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:32 (#4)

וּפָקַדְתִּ֣י בְשֵׁ֣בֶט פִּשְׁעָ֑ם וּבִנְגָעִ֥ים עֲוֹנָֽם

“then I will punish their transgression with a rod and their iniquity with blows”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **transgression** and **iniquity**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [then I will punish the ways they have rebelled with a rod and the wrong they have done with blows]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:33 (#1)

וְחַסְדִּ֥י

“But my covenant faithfulness”

God uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between the punishment he will bring in the previous verse and the loyal love he will not withdraw. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Nonetheless, my covenant faithfulness]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 89:33 (#2)

וַחַסְדִּי לֹא־אָפִיר מֵעִמּוֹ וְלֹא־אֲאַשֵּׁקֶר בֶּאֱמוּנָתִי

“But my covenant faithfulness I will not break off from him, and I will not deal falsely in my faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [But I will not stop being loyally faithful to him, and I will not be unfaithful to what I promised]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:34 (#1)

וּמוֹצָא שְׂפָתַי לֹא אֲשַׁנֶּה

“and I will not change the utterance of my lips”

Here, **the utterance of my lips** represents what God has spoken. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and I will not change what I have spoken]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:34 (#2)

וּמוֹצָא שְׂפָתַי לֹא אֲשַׁנֶּה

“and I will not change the utterance of my lips”

God is using the possessive form to describe what his **lips** have produced as speech. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and I will not change my words]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:35 (#1)

בְּקָדְשִׁי

“by my holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by my holy character]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:35 (#2)

אִם־לְדָוִד אֲכַזֵּב

“If I should lie to David”

Following the custom of the culture, God is swearing an oath by stating the first part of a condition (‘if’) but not the second part (‘then’). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explicitly state the second part of this condition. Alternate translation: [I will certainly not lie to David!]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 89:36 (#1)

זַרְעוֹ לְעוֹלָם יִהְיֶה

“His seed will be forever”

Here God is speaking of descendants as if they were **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His descendants will be forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:36 (#2)

וְכִסְאוֹ כַּשֶּׁמֶשׁ נֶגְדִּי

“and his throne, like the sun before me”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the sun** is enduring and permanent, so is **his throne**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [his throne will endure permanently like the sun before me]

See: Simile

Psalms 89:36 (#3)

זַרְעוֹ לְעוֹלָם יִהְיֶה וְכִסְאוֹ כַּשֶּׁמֶשׁ נֶגְדִּי

“His seed will be forever, and his throne, like the sun before me”

God is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [His seed will be forever, and his throne will be forever, like the sun before me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 89:37 (#1)

כְּיָרֵחַ יִכּוֹן עוֹלָם

“It will be established forever like the moon”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the moon** is permanent and enduring, so is **the dynasty of David**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I will establish it forever, as permanent as the moon]

See: Simile

Psalms 89:37 (#2)

יִכּוֹן

“It will be established”

The expression **It will be established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [I will establish it]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 89:37 (#3)

וְעֵ֣ד בַּ֭שַּׁחַק נֶאֱמָ֑ן

“yes, the attested witness in the sky”

Here God is speaking of the moon as if it were **the attested witness in the sky**, as though it testifies to the permanence of his covenant. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [which is a faithful sign in the sky]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:38 (#1)

וְאַתָּ֣ה זָ֭נַחְתָּ

“But you, you have rejected”

Ethan is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the sharp contrast between God’s promises and his present actions. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [But you yourself have rejected]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 89:38 (#2)

וְאַתָּ֣ה זָ֭נַחְתָּ

“But you, you have rejected”

Ethan uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between God’s covenant promises in the previous verses and his present treatment of the anointed king. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 89:38 (#3)

זָ֭נַחְתָּ וַתִּמְאָ֑ס

“you have rejected and spurned”

The terms **rejected** and **spurned** mean similar things. Ethan is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [you have completely rejected]

See: Doublet

Psalms 89:39 (#1)

בְּרִ֣ית עַ֭בְדֶּךָ

“the covenant of your servant”

Ethan is using the possessive form to describe the **covenant** that God made with his **servant**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [covenant you made with your servant]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:39 (#2)

חִלַּ֣לְתָּ לָאָ֑רֶץ נִזְרֹ֝ו

“you have profaned his crown to the ground”

Here Ethan is speaking as if God had thrown the king’s **crown to the ground**, treating his royal dignity as something that could be physically cast down. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have completely dishonored his royal dignity]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:40 (#1)

פָּ֭רַצְתָּ כָּל־גְּדֵרֹתָ֑יו שַׂ֝שְׂמְתָּ מִבְצָרָ֗יו מְחִתָּ֥ה

“You have broken down all of his walls; you have made his fortifications a ruin”

Here Ethan is speaking as if God had literally destroyed **walls** and **fortifications**, though he may be referring to the king’s defenses and protections more

broadly. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have removed all of his protections; you have let his defenses fall apart]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:41 (#1)

שַׁסֻּהוּ כָּל־עֹבְרֵי דָּרֶךְ הָיָה חֶרְפָּה לִשְׁכֵנָיו

“All of the passers of the way plunder him; he has become a reproach to his neighbors”

Here, **plunder him** represents plundering the people who live in the city of Jerusalem. Here, the current anointed king is most likely representing the people of Israel over whom he rules. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:41 (#2)

הָיָה חֶרְפָּה לִשְׁכֵנָיו

“he has become a reproach to his neighbors”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he has become someone whom his neighbors ridicule]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:42 (#1)

יְמִין צָרָיו

“the right hand of his adversaries”

Here, **the right hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the power of his adversaries]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:43 (#1)

צִצוּר חַרְבּוֹ

“the edge of his sword”

Here, **the edge of his sword** represents his military capability. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the effectiveness of his sword]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:43 (#2)

צִצוּר חַרְבּוֹ

“the edge of his sword”

Ethan is using the possessive form to describe the **edge** that is part of the **sword**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his sharp sword]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:44 (#1)

הִשְׁבַּתָּ מִטְהָרוֹ

“You have made his splendor cease”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You have made him no longer splendid]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:44 (#2)

וְכִסְאוֹ לָאָרֶץ מְגֵרְתָּה

“and you have cast his throne to the ground”

Here, **throne** represents the king’s royal authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and you have taken away his royal authority]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:45 (#1)

הִקְצַרְתָּ יְמֵי עֲלוּמָיו

“You have shortened the days of his youth”

Here Ethan is speaking as if God had physically **shortened** a period of time. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have cut short his time of youthful vigor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:45 (#2)

יְמֵי עֲלוּמָיו

“the days of his youth”

Here, **the days** represent the time period of his youth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use

an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the time of his youth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:45 (#3)

יְמֵי עֲלוּמָיו

“the days of his youth”

Ethan is using the possessive form to describe the **days** during which he was young. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the days when he was young]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:45 (#4)

יְמֵי עֲלוּמָיו

“the days of his youth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **youth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the time when he was young]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:45 (#5)

הֶעֱטִיתָ עָלָיו בוּשָׁה

“you have covered him over with shame”

Here Ethan is speaking as if shame were a garment with which God had **covered** the king. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have caused him to be thoroughly ashamed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:45 (#6)

בוּשָׁה

“with shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with what is shameful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:46 (#1)

עַד־מָתַי יְהוָה תִּסָּתֵר לָנֶצַח

“Until when, Yahweh? Will you hide yourself forever”

Ethan is using the question form to express his grief and impatience at God’s prolonged withdrawal. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, this has gone on too long! You must not hide yourself forever.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 89:46 (#2)

תִּסָּתֵר

“Will you hide yourself”

Here Ethan is speaking as if God would physically **hide** himself, though he means that God has withdrawn his favor and presence. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Will you withhold your favor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:46 (#3)

תִּבְעַר כְּמוֹ־אֵשׁ חֲמָתֶךָ

“Will your wrath burn like fire”

The point of this comparison is that just as **fire** consumes intensely, so does **God’s wrath** consume. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Will your wrath consume us intensely like fire]

See: Simile

Psalms 89:46 (#4)

תִּבְעַר כְּמוֹ־אֵשׁ חֲמָתֶךָ

“Will your wrath burn like fire”

Ethan is using the question form to express his distress at God’s ongoing anger. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your wrath burns like fire!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 89:46 (#5)

חֲמָתֶךָ

“your wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how angry you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:47 (#1)

זְכָר־אֲנִ֗י מֶ֫ה־חָ֥לֶד

“Remember me, what life {is”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as ‘please’ to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please remember me, what life is]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 89:47 (#2)

זְכָר־אֲנִ֗י מֶ֫ה־חָ֥לֶד עַל־מַה־שָּׁ֑וְא בָּרָ֖אתָ כָּל־בְּנֵי־אָדָֽם

“Remember me, what life {is}, for what emptiness you created all of the sons of man”

Ethan is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, grief at the brevity and futility of human life. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Please remember that we human beings are mere mortals!]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 89:47 (#3)

עַל־מַה־שָּׁ֑וְא

“for what emptiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **emptiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with what mortality]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:47 (#4)

כָּל־בְּנֵי־אָדָֽם

“all of the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all of humanity]

See: Idiom

Psalms 89:48 (#1)

יִֽחְיֶ֣ה וְלֹ֣א יִרְאֶ֣ה־מָ֑וֶת יְמַלֵּ֖ט נַפְשׁ֣וֹ מִיַּד־שְׁא֣וֹל

“will live and not see death, will deliver his soul from the hand of Sheol”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [will live forever, escaping death and Sheol]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 89:48 (#2)

מִֽי־גֶ֭בֶר יִֽחְיֶ֣ה וְלֹ֣א יִרְאֶ֣ה־מָ֑וֶת יְמַלֵּ֖ט נַפְשׁ֣וֹ מִיַּד־שְׁא֣וֹל

“What man will live and not see death, will deliver his soul from the hand of Sheol”

Ethan is using the question form to assert that no one can avoid death. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No man will live and not see death or deliver his soul from the hand of Sheol.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 89:48 (#3)

מִֽי־גֶ֭בֶר

“What man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [What person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 89:48 (#4)

וְלֹ֣א יִרְאֶ֣ה־מָ֑וֶת

“and not see death”

Here Ethan is speaking of dying as if it were to **see death**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and not experience dying]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 89:48 (#5)

וְלֹ֣א יִרְאֶה־מָּ֑וֶת

“and not see death”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **death**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and not see himself dying]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:48 (#6)

מִיַּד־שְׁא֥וֹל

“from the hand of Sheol”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of Sheol]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:49 (#1)

אַיֵּ֤יה ׀ חֲסָדֶ֣יךָ הָרִאשֹׁנִ֗ים ׀ אֲדֹנָ֥י נִשְׁבַּ֥עְתָּ לְדָוִ֑ד בֶּאֱמוּנָתֶֽךָ

“Where {are} your former covenant faithfulnesses, Lord, {which} you swore to David in your faithfulness”

Ethan is using the question form to express his grief and to accuse God of failing to act on his promises. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Lord, your former covenant faithfulnesses are nowhere to be seen, the ones which you swore to David in your faithfulness!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 89:49 (#2)

אַיֵּ֤יה ׀ חֲסָדֶ֣יךָ הָרִאשֹׁנִ֗ים ׀ אֲדֹנָ֥י נִשְׁבַּ֥עְתָּ לְדָוִ֑ד בֶּאֱמוּנָתֶֽךָ

“Where {are} your former covenant faithfulnesses, Lord, {which} you swore to David in your faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulnesses** and **faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Where are the ways you were formerly faithful to your covenant, Lord, that you faithfully swore to David]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:50 (#1)

זְכֹ֤ר אֲדֹנָ֨י ׀ חֶרְפַּ֬ת עֲבָדֶ֗יךָ

“Remember, Lord, the reproach of your servants”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as ‘please’ to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please remember, Lord, the reproach of your servants]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 89:50 (#2)

חֶרְפַּ֬ת עֲבָדֶ֗יךָ

“the reproach of your servants”

Ethan is using the possessive form to describe the **reproach** that is directed against God’s **servants**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how people reproach your servants]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:50 (#3)

חֶרְפַּ֬ת

“the reproach of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how people reproach]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 89:50 (#4)

שְׂאֵתִ֥י בְחֵיקִ֑י

“my carrying in my bosom”

Ethan shifts from the plural **your servants** to the singular **my** because he is now speaking of his own personal experience of bearing the insults. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could make this shift explicit. Alternate translation: [how I carry in my heart]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 89:50 (#5)

בְחֵיקִ֑י

“in my bosom”

Here, **in my bosom** represents bearing a heavy burden personally and intimately. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [within myself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:51 (#1)

עִקְּבוֹת מְשִׁיחֶךָ

“the footsteps of your anointed”

Here, **the footsteps** represent everywhere the anointed king goes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your anointed wherever he goes]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 89:51 (#2)

עִקְּבוֹת מְשִׁיחֶךָ

“the footsteps of your anointed”

Ethan is using the possessive form to describe the **footsteps** that belong to God’s **anointed** king. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wherever your anointed goes]

See: Possession

Psalms 89:52 (#1)

בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה

“Blessed {be} Yahweh”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [We bless Yahweh] or [Let us praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 89:52 (#2)

אָמֵן וְאָמֵן

“Amen and amen”

Ethan is repeating the word **Amen** for emphasis as a way of concluding Book 3 of Psalms (73–89). If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [May it certainly be so!]

See: Poetry

Psalms - Chapter 90 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 90 is a “wisdom psalm.” It instructs people how to be wise by honoring Yahweh and obeying him. (See the discussion of the types of psalms in the Introduction to Psalms.)

This psalm is a poem, the words to a song, and so the ULT sets its lines farther to the right on the page than ordinary text in order to show that they are poetry.

1. God’s eternity and human mortality (1–6)
2. People perish when God punishes them for sin (7–12)
3. A prayer for God’s mercy and favor (13–17)

The first part of verse 1, “A prayer of Moses, the man of God,” is the superscription to this psalm. Format it in the way that you have decided to format the other superscriptions in the book of Psalms.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Singular “you” and “your”
The pronouns “you” and “your” are singular throughout this psalm because Moses is addressing Yahweh directly. So use the singular forms of those pronouns in your translation if your language marks a distinction between singular and plural “you.”

Exclusive “we,” “us,” and “our”
The pronouns “we,” “us,” and “our” are exclusive throughout this psalm because Moses is speaking to Yahweh on behalf of the Israelites. So use the exclusive forms of those pronouns in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

Psalms 90:0 (#2)

לְמֹשֶׁה אִישׁ־הָאֱלֹהִים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לְמֹשֶׁה אִישׁ־הָאֱלֹהִים”

Here the superscription is providing some background information to remind readers who Moses was. The expression **man of God** is used to indicate that Moses was associated with God in a special way. Alternate translation: [of Moses, who represented God in his covenant with the Israelites]

See: Background Information

Psalms 90:1 (#1)

מָעוֹן אַתָּה הָיִיתָ לָּנוּ

“you have been a habitation to us”

Moses is speaking as if God were actually a **habitation** or place for the Israelites to live. He means that God has protected the Israelites, just as the walls of a home provide shelter. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have protected us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:1 (#2)

אַתָּה

“you”

As the introduction to this psalm discusses, the pronoun **you** is singular here and throughout the psalm because Moses is addressing Yahweh directly. So use the singular form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 90:1 (#3)

בְּדֹר וָדֹר

“in generation and generation”

Moses is using **in generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “in every generation.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in every generation] or [throughout all generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 90:2 (#1)

בְּטֶרֶם ׀ הָרִרִים יֻלָּדוּ וַתְּחוֹלֵל אֶרֶץ וְתֵבֵל

“Before the mountains were born or you brought forth the earth and the world”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Consider how you have decided as a translation team to represent Hebrew poetry in your translation, here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Before you created anything at all on the earth]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 90:2 (#2)

בְּטֶרֶם ׀ הָרִרִים יֻלָּדוּ וַתְּחוֹלֵל אֶרֶץ וְתֵבֵל

“Before the mountains were born or you brought forth the earth and the world”

Moses is speaking as if the **mountains** on earth had actually been **born** and as if God had actually **brought forth**, that is, given birth to, the **earth** and the **world**. He means that God created these things. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Before you created the mountains or formed the earth and the world]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:2 (#3)

אֶרֶץ וְתֵבֵל

“the earth and the world”

The terms **earth** and **world** mean similar things. Moses is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the entire earth]

See: Doublet

Psalms 90:2 (#4)

וּמֵעוֹלָם עַד־עוֹלָם

“even from forever to forever”

Moses is referring to all of time by naming two extremes, eternity past and eternity future. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [throughout all of time]

See: Merism

Psalms 90:2 (#5)

אַתָּה אֵל

“you {are} God”

As the ULT indicates by using brackets, the verb here is understood, so translators must decide what tense best fits the context. It would be conventional in many languages to use the past tense when describing something that was true a long time ago, so many languages might ordinarily say “you were God.” But Moses means that Yahweh was God long ago, that he is God now, and that he will continue to be God forever into the future. To convey this, the ULT uses the present tense, saying **you are God**. Decide what tense would best convey the meaning in your own language.

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

Psalms 90:3 (#1)

תָּשֵׁ֣שׁ אֱ֭נוֹשׁ עַד־דַּכָּ֑א וַתֹּ֥אמֶר שׁ֝וּבוּ בְנֵי־אָדָֽם

“You cause man to return to dust, and you say, “Return, sons of man”

Moses is describing one event, **man** returning to **dust**, before describing another event that preceded it, God telling him to do that. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they happened. Alternate translation: [You say, “Return, sons of man,” and you cause man to return to dust]

See: Order of Events

Psalms 90:3 (#2)

אֱ֭נוֹשׁ

“man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 90:3 (#3)

תָּשֵׁ֣שׁ אֱ֭נוֹשׁ עַד־דַּכָּ֑א & שׁ֝וּבוּ

“You cause man to return to dust & Return”

Moses is using the expression **return to dust** to mean “die.” It is an allusion to the way that God formed the first man from the dust of the ground, as described in Genesis 2:7. This is one of several mild or poetic ways in which Moses refers to death in this psalm. Your language may have a similar expression that you can use here in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [You cause people to pass away... Pass away] or [You cause people to die ... It is time for you to die]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 90:3 (#4)

בְנֵי־אָדָֽם

“sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 90:4 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an affirmation. Alternate translation: [Indeed]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 90:4 (#2)

בְּעֵינֶ֗יךָ

“in your eyes”

Moses is using the common expression of his culture **in your eyes** to mean “in your perspective.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in your perspective]

See: Idiom

Psalms 90:4 (#3)

כְּי֭וֹם אֶתְמ֣וֹל כִּ֑י יַעֲבֹ֥ר וְ֝אַשְׁמוּרָ֗ה בַּלָּֽיְלָה

“are} like the day before when it has passed, and a watch in the night”

The point of these comparisons is that both of the times that Moses mentions seem very short to people: **the day before**, once it is over, and a **watch in the night** that lasts only a few hours. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [seem very short, like yesterday, when it is over, or like a three-hour watch in the night]

See: Simile

Psalms 90:5 (#1)

זְ֭רַמְתָּם

“You flood them away”

The pronoun **them** refers to people, that is, to the “sons of man” whom Moses mentions in verse 3, not to the “thousand years” that he mentions in verse 4. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [You flood people away]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 90:5 (#2)

זְ֭רַמְתָּם

“You flood them away”

Moses is speaking as if God actually used a **flood** of water to sweep people **away** from the earth. He is using the image to convey the idea that God may cause people to die suddenly, unexpectedly, and with no recourse. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You bring people’s lives to a swift end]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:5 (#3)

שֵׁנָ֣ה יִהְיֽוּ

“they are sleep”

Moses is speaking as if people were actually **sleep**. This could mean: (1) that Moses is using the term **sleep** as a mild way of referring to death. Alternate translation: [then they are dead] or (2) that Moses is illustrating the brevity of human life by comparing it to **sleep** that lasts only a few hours and then is over. Alternate translation: [their lives are short, like a few hours of sleep that soon end]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:5 (#4)

כֶּ֭חָצִיר יַחֲלֹֽף

“like grass, it passes along”

The pronoun **it** refers to the life of a human being as compared to grass. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [like grass, a person’s life passes along]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 90:5 (#5)

כֶּ֭חָצִיר יַחֲלֹֽף

“like grass, it passes along”

The point of this comparison is that just as grass **passes along** through its brief cycle of life, so human life lasts for only a short time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [A person’s life is short, like grass that quickly passes along]

See: Simile

Psalms 90:6 (#1)

בַּבֹּ֗קֶר יָ֭צִיץ וְחָלָ֣ף לָ֑עָ֝רֶב יְמוֹלֵ֗ל וְיָבֵֽשׁ

“In the morning it sprouts and passes along; in the evening it withers and dries up”

Moses says that grass lives for only a single day, lasting only from **morning** to **evening**, as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [Grass blossoms and grows for only a short time; very soon it withers and dries up]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 90:6 (#2)

יְמוֹלֵ֗ל וְיָבֵֽשׁ

“it withers and dries up”

The terms **withers** and **dries up** mean similar things. Moses is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [it dries up completely]

See: Doublet

Psalms 90:7 (#1)

כִּֽי־כָ֭לִינוּ בְּאַפֶּ֑ךָ וּבַחֲמָתְךָ֥ נִבְהָלְנוּ

“For by your nose, we perish, and by your wrath we are terrified”

Moses is referring to God’s **nose** as a common expression of his culture to mean God’s anger. Your language and culture may also associate anger with a particular part of the body. If so, in your translation you could use an expression involving that part of the body. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [by your anger we perish, and by your wrath we are terrified]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:7 (#2)

כִּֽי־כָ֭לִינוּ בְּאַפֶּ֑ךָ וּבַחֲמָתְךָ֥ נִבְהָלְנוּ

“For by your nose, we perish, and by your wrath we are terrified”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to reverse the order of the phrases, since people would first be **terrified** by God’s **wrath** and then they would **perish** when he destroyed them in his anger. Alternate translation: [by your wrath we are terrified, and by your anger we perish]

See: Order of Events

Psalms 90:7 (#3)

וּבַחֲמָתְךָ֥ נִבְהָלְנוּ

“and by your wrath we are terrified”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and your wrath terrifies us]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 90:8 (#1)

שת עֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ לְנֶגְדֶּךָ עֲלֻמֵּנוּ לִמְאוֹר פָּנֶיךָ

“You have set our iniquities before you, our hidden {sin} in the light of your face”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [You have studied our iniquities, yes, you have carefully examined our hidden sin]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 90:8 (#2)

שת עֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ לְנֶגְדֶּךָ

“You have set our iniquities before you”

Moses is speaking as if God had actually **set** the **iniquities** of the Israelites in front of him where he could see them. The idea is that God is paying attention to the wrong things that the Israelites have done, and God is punishing them for doing those things, as the previous verse indicates. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You examine our iniquities]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:8 (#3)

עֲלֻמֵּנוּ לִמְאוֹר פָּנֶיךָ

“our hidden {sin} in the light of your face”

Moses is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [yes, you have set our hidden sin in the light of your face]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 90:8 (#4)

עֲלֻמֵּנוּ

“our hidden {sin”

The term **hidden** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [our sin that we have hidden]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 90:8 (#5)

לִמְאוֹר פָּנֶיךָ

“in the light of your face”

Moses is speaking as if there were actually **light** shining from God’s **face** that allowed him to see clearly what was in front of him. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [where you can clearly see it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:9 (#1)

כָּל־יָמֵינוּ פָּנָנוּ

“all of our days turn”

Moses is using **our days turn** as a common expression of his culture to describe **days** turning into nights, that is, to describe the light of day fading as evening approaches. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all of our days fade away] or [all of our days end]

See: Idiom

Psalms 90:9 (#2)

כָּל־יָמֵינוּ פָּנָנוּ

“all of our days turn”

Moses is using the parts of a lifetime, the **days** of which it consists, to mean an entire lifetime. So in this image, he is speaking of a lifetime that consists of many days as if it were a single day. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our lifetimes fade away] or [our lifetimes end]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 90:9 (#3)

כִּלִּינוּ שָׁנֵינוּ

“we end our years”

In this phrase as well, Moses is using the parts of a lifetime, the **years** of which it consists, to mean an entire lifetime. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our lives end]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 90:9 (#4)

כְּמוֹ־הֶגֶה

“like a sigh”

The point of this comparison could be: (1) that just as a **sigh** is a brief utterance, so people come to the **end** of their **years** after only a brief time, Alternate translation: [after only a brief time] or (2) that just as someone might **sigh** when they are sad, so we end our lives in despair. Alternate translation: [in sadness]

See: Simile

Psalms 90:10 (#1)

יְמֵי־שְׁנוֹתֵינוּ בָהֶם שִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה

“The days of our years, in them {are} 70 years”

Moses is using **The days of our years** as a common expression of his culture to mean “our lifetimes.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All our born days are 70 years] or [We humans tend to live for 70 years]

See: Idiom

Psalms 90:10 (#2)

וְאִם בִּגְבוּרֹת

“or, if by strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [or, if we are strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 90:10 (#3)

גָּ֭גָז חִ֣ישׁ

“it passes quickly”

The pronoun **it** refers to the human lifetime. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [our lifetime passes quickly]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 90:10 (#4)

וְנָעֻ֑פָה

“and we fly away”

Moses is referring to death in a poetic way by using the phrase **fly away**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite or poetic way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and we depart] or [and then we die]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 90:11 (#1)

מִ֤י־יוֹדֵ֨עַ֙ עֹ֣ז אַפֶּ֔ךָ וּ֝כְיִרְאָתְךָ֗ עֶבְרָתֶֽךָ

“Who knows the power of your nose, or your wrath according to your fear”

Moses is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Since Moses says “we” and “us” throughout the rest of the psalm, you could say “we” here in your translation. Alternate translation: [We ought to know the power of your anger, and we ought to know your wrath according to your fear!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 90:11 (#2)

אַפֶּ֔ךָ

“your nose”

See how you translated the term **nose** in verse 7. Alternate translation: [your anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 90:11 (#3)

וּ֝כְיִרְאָתְךָ֗ עֶבְרָתֶֽךָ

“or your wrath according to your fear”

Moses is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [or who knows your wrath according to your fear]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 90:11 (#4)

וּכְיִרְאָתְךָ עֶבְרָתֶךָ

“or your wrath according to your fear”

Moses is using the possessive form **your fear** to describe not fear that God has, but fear or reverent respect that people have for God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [or who fears you in a way that accords with your wrath] or [and we ought to fear you in a way that accords with your wrath against sin]

See: Possession

Psalms 90:12 (#1)

לִמְנוֹת יָמֵינוּ כֵּן הוֹדַע

“So teach {us} to number our days”

Moses is speaking as if he actually wanted God to help the Israelites **number** or count how many **days** they would be alive. The implication is that if they did this, they would realize how few days they actually have to live. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [So help us to recognize how short our lives actually are]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:12 (#2)

וְנָבִא לְבַב חָכְמָה

“that we might bring in a heart of wisdom”

Moses may be using the expression **bring in** to speak of the results of learning to number one’s days as if they were actually a harvest of crops that one had cultivated. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that we might acquire a heart of wisdom]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:12 (#3)

וְנָבִא לְבַב חָכְמָה

“that we might bring in a heart of wisdom”

Here the **heart** represents the thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that we might acquire a mind of wisdom]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:12 (#4)

וְנָבִא לְבַב חָכְמָה

“that we might bring in a heart of wisdom”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wisdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that we might acquire a wise mind] or [that we might understand how to live wisely]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 90:13 (#1)

שׁוּבָה יְהוָה

“Return, Yahweh”

Moses is using an emphatic imperative form here. It may be appropriate in your culture for someone to address God using an emphatic imperative, and your language may have such a form that you can use in your translation. But if people in your culture would not consider it appropriate for someone to address God in this way, you could translate this as a request rather than as a command. Alternate translation: [Please return, Yahweh.]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 90:13 (#2)

שׁוּבָה יְהוָה

“Return, Yahweh”

This could mean: (1) that Moses wants Yahweh to stop being angry and stop punishing the Israelites. He would be speaking as if Yahweh’s anger were literally a place from which he could **Return**. Alternate translation: [Stop being angry, Yahweh!] (2) that Moses wants Yahweh to abide peacefully among his people, protecting them and blessing them. This would be an allusion to the prayer that Moses always prayed in the wilderness when the cloud of Yahweh stopped moving and the Israelites made camp, as recorded in Numbers 10:36, “Return, Yahweh, to the multitudes of the thousands of Israel.” Alternate translation: [Dwell peacefully among us, Yahweh.]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:13 (#3)

עַד־מָתָי

“Until when”

Moses is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be com-

plete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be helpful in your language. Alternate translation: [Until when will you continue to be angry with us] or [For how long will you continue to be angry with us]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 90:13 (#4)

עַד־מָתָי

“Until when”

Moses is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I hope that your anger will not last long.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 90:13 (#5)

וְהִנָּחֵם עַל־עֲבָדֶיךָ

“Have compassion on your servants”

Moses is speaking of himself and his fellow Israelites in the third person as **your servants** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [us, your servants]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 90:14 (#1)

בַבֹּקֶר

“in the morning”

Moses is speaking as if he actually wanted God to **Satisfy** the Israelites **in the morning**, that is, at the beginning of an actual day. He could mean: (1) that he wants God to be eager to treat the Israelites mercifully. He would be using the expression **in the morning** by allusion to the way that people get up early in the morning to do something they are eager to do. Alternate translation: [eagerly] or [soon]; (2) that he wants God to treat the Israelites mercifully after a time of trouble. He would be speaking of that time of trouble as if it had actually been a night and of the time after it as if it were actually a morning. Alternate translation: [after this time of trouble]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:14 (#2)

חַסְדֶּךָ

“with} your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with all the ways you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 90:14 (#3)

וְנִרַנְּנָה וְנִשְׂמְחָה

“and we will rejoice and be glad”

The terms **rejoice** and **be glad** mean similar things. Moses is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be helpful for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [and we will rejoice greatly] or [and we will be very glad]

See: Doublet

Psalms 90:14 (#4)

בְּכָל־יָמֵינוּ

“in all of our days”

Moses is using the term **days** to refer to a specific time, the human lifetime, since time is made up of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all of the rest of our lives]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 90:14 (#5)

בְּכָל־יָמֵינוּ

“in all of our days”

Moses is saying that the Israelites will rejoice for **all** of the rest of their lives as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [throughout our lives]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 90:15 (#1)

כִּימוֹת עִנִּיתָנוּ שְׁנוֹת רָאִינוּ רָעָה

“according to the days you afflicted us the years we have seen trouble”

Moses is using the terms **days** and **years** to refer to specific times, since time is made up of days and years. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. However, since the

Israelites were **afflicted** and did experience **trouble** for a specific number of days and years, you may decide to retain those terms in your translation. Alternate translation: [for the same amount of time that you have afflicted us, yes, for the same amount of time that we have experienced trouble] or [for as many days as you have afflicted us, yes, for as many years as we have experienced trouble]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 90:15 (#2)

שְׂמָ֗חוֹת רָאִ֫ינוּ רָעָֽה

“the years we have seen trouble”

Moses is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be helpful in your language. Alternate translation: [yes, make us glad for as many years as we have seen trouble]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 90:16 (#1)

יֵרָאֶ֣ה אֶל־עֲבָדֶ֣יךָ פָּעֳלֶ֑ךָ וַֽהֲדָרְךָ֥ עַל־בְּנֵיהֶֽם

“May your work be seen by your servants, and your majesty by their sons”

Moses is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be helpful in your language. Alternate translation: [May your work be seen by your servants, and may your majesty be seen by their sons]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 90:16 (#2)

יֵרָאֶ֣ה אֶל־עֲבָדֶ֣יךָ פָּעֳלֶ֑ךָ וַֽהֲדָרְךָ֥ עַל־בְּנֵיהֶֽם

“May your work be seen by your servants, and your majesty by their sons”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May your servants see your work, and may their sons see your majesty]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 90:16 (#3)

יֵרָאֶ֣ה אֶל־עֲבָדֶ֣יךָ פָּעֳלֶ֑ךָ

“May your work be seen by your servants”

Moses is speaking about himself and his fellow Israelites in the third person as **your servants** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [May your work be seen by us, your servants] or [May we, your servants, see your work]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 90:16 (#4)

וַֽהֲדָרְךָ֥ עַל־בְּנֵיהֶֽם

“and your majesty by their sons”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **majesty**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and may their sons recognize how majestic you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 90:16 (#5)

עַל־בְּנֵיהֶֽם

“by their sons”

Moses is using the term **sons** to mean “descendants.” Alternate translation: [to their descendants]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 90:17 (#1)

וִיהִ֤י ׀ נֹ֘עַם אֲדֹנָ֪י אֱלֹהֵ֫ינוּ עָ֥לֵ֑ינוּ

“May the favor of the Lord our God be upon us”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **favor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May the Lord our God favor us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 90:17 (#2)

וּמַעֲשֵׂ֣ה יָ֭דֵינוּ & וְמַעֲשֵׂ֣ה יָ֭דֵינוּ

“And the work of our hands & indeed, the work of our hands”

Here, **hands** represent the capacity to do something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the work that we do … indeed, the work that we do]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 91 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 91 is a "psalm of trust." (See the discussion of the types of psalms in the General Introduction to Psalms.)

This psalm is a poem, the words to a song, and so the ULT sets its lines farther to the right on the page than ordinary text in order to show that they are poetry.

1. The psalmist describes how Yahweh protects those who trust him (1–13)
2. Yahweh describes how he protects those who trust him (14–16)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Singular "you" and "your"
The pronouns "you" and "your" are singular in verses 1–13 because the psalmist is speaking individually to people whom he wants to encourage to trust Yahweh. So use the singular forms of those pronouns in your translation if your language marks a distinction between singular and plural "you."

Psalms 91:1 (#1)

יֹושֵׁב בְּסֵתֶר עֶלְיֹון

"The one dwelling in the shelter of the Most High"

The psalmist is speaking as if the **Most High**, that is, God, were actually a **shelter** in which a person could live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The one who depends on the Most High for protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:1 (#2)

עֶלְיֹון

"the Most High"

The psalmist is using this expression as a title for God. Your language may have a comparable title that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. If you have already translated Psalm 18, see how you translated this title in Psalms 18:13. Alternate translation: [God Most High] or [the Supreme God]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 91:1 (#3)

בְּצֵל שַׁשַּׁדַּי יִתְלֹונָן

"will remain in the shadow of Shaddai"

The psalmist is speaking as if God actually had a **shadow**. He is using the image to represent care, the way a shadow provides a cool place to rest in hot climates. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will continually experience Shaddai's care]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:1 (#4)

שַׁשַּׁדַּי

"Shaddai"

The word **Shaddai** is a name for God. If you have already translated Psalm 68, see how you translated this name in Psalms 68:14. Alternate translation: [the Almighty]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 91:2 (#1)

אֹמַר לַיהוָה מַחְסִי וּמְצוּדָתִי אֱלֹהַי אֶבְטַח־בֹּו

"I will say to Yahweh, "My refuge and my fortress, my God, I trust in him"

The word translated **to** could indicate: (1) that the psalmist is saying this to Yahweh. You may wish to use second-person pronouns to indicate this. Alternate translation: [I will say to Yahweh, "You are my refuge and my fortress; you are my God, I trust in you"]; (2) that the psalmist is saying this about Yahweh. You may wish to use third-person pronouns to indicate this. Alternate translation: [I will say regarding Yahweh, "He is my refuge and my fortress; he is my God, I trust in him"]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 91:2 (#2)

מַחְסִי וּמְצוּדָתִי

"My refuge and my fortress"

The psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a **refuge** and a **fortress**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The source of my safety and my protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:2 (#3)

מַחְסִי וּמְצוּדָתִי

"My refuge and my fortress"

The terms **refuge** and **fortress** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be helpful for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [The one who keeps me completely safe]

See: Doublet

Psalms 91:3 (#1)

יַצִּ֥ילְךָ

“will rescue you”

As the Introduction to this psalm discusses, the pronoun **you** is singular here and throughout the psalm because the psalmist is speaking individually to people whom he wants to encourage to trust Yahweh. So use the singular form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 91:3 (#2)

מִפַּ֣ח יָקֹ֑וּשׁ מִדֶּ֥בֶר הַוּֽוֹת

“from the snare of the trapper, from the plague of calamities”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **plague**. He means plagues in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [from traps that people set for you and from deadly plagues]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 91:3 (#3)

מִפַּ֣ח יָקֹ֑וּשׁ

“from the snare of the trapper”

The psalmist is speaking as if the individual whom he is addressing were a bird or small animal that a **trapper** was trying to catch in a **snare**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from anyone who would deceptively try to harm you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:3 (#4)

מִדֶּ֥בֶר הַוּֽוֹת

“from the plague of calamities”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be helpful in your language. Alternate translation: [and he will also rescue you from the plague of calamities]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 91:3 (#5)

מִדֶּ֥בֶר הַוּֽוֹת

“from the plague of calamities”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe a **plague** that would cause **calamities**, meaning, specifically, many deaths. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from every deadly plague]

See: Possession

Psalms 91:4 (#1)

בְּאֶבְרָת֗וֹ ׀ יֶ֣סֶךְ לָ֭ךְ וְתַחַת־כְּנָפָ֣יו תֶּחְסֶ֑ה

“He will cover you with his feathers, and under his wings you will shelter”

These two phrases mean similar things. Translate them according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. Alternate translation: [He will cover you with his feathers, so you will be able to shelter under his wings] or [You will shelter under the cover of his wings]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 91:4 (#2)

בְּאֶבְרָת֗וֹ ׀ יֶ֣סֶךְ לָ֭ךְ וְתַחַת־כְּנָפָ֣יו תֶּחְסֶ֑ה

“He will cover you with his feathers, and under his wings you will shelter”

The psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh were a bird and as if the individual he is addressing were one of its chicks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He will protect you the way a bird protects its chicks by covering them with its wings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:4 (#3)

צִנָּ֖ה וְסֹחֵרָ֣ה אֲמִתּ֑וֹ

“His faithfulness {is} a shield and rampart”

The psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh’s **faithfulness** were actually a **shield** and **buckler**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning

plainly. Alternate translation: [His faithfulness is dependable protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:4 (#4)

צִנָּ֣ה וְסֹחֵ֣רָה אֱמִתּ֑וֹ

“His faithfulness {is} a shield and rampart”

The word translated as **rampart** could refer to: (1) a wall around a city that would protect it from enemy attack. In that case, the psalmist would be using a shield that protected an individual soldier and a wall that protected an entire city to mean protection in general. Alternate translation: [His faithfulness is like military protection] or (2) a small shield. In that case, the psalmist would be using a large shield and a small shield together to mean all of the armor that a soldier would wear into battle. Alternate translation: [His faithfulness is like protective armor]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 91:4 (#5)

צִנָּ֣ה וְסֹחֵ֣רָה אֱמִתּ֑וֹ

“His faithfulness {is} a shield and rampart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He will faithfully protect you like a shield and buckler]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 91:5 (#1)

מִפַּ֣חַד לָ֭יְלָה מֵחֵ֣ץ יָע֑וּף יוֹמָֽם

“the terror of the night, of the arrow {that} flies by day”

The psalmist is using things that might happen at **night** and during the **day** to mean things that might happen at any time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [of any dangers that might harm you at any time]

See: Merism

Psalms 91:5 (#2)

מִפַּ֣חַד לָ֭יְלָה

“the terror of the night”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe something that might happen during the **night** that would cause a person to feel **terror**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [of terrifying things that might happen during the night]

See: Possession

Psalms 91:5 (#3)

מֵחֵ֣ץ יָע֑וּף יוֹמָֽם

“of the arrow {that} flies by day”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be helpful in your language. Alternate translation: [and you will not be afraid of the arrow that flies by day]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 91:5 (#4)

מֵחֵ֣ץ יָע֑וּף יוֹמָֽם

“of the arrow {that} flies by day”

The psalmist is speaking of how an **arrow ... flies** without indicating that this is the result of someone shooting it from a bow. This may create the impression that an arrow is a living thing that can fly on its own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could indicate the agent who is responsible for the arrow flying. Alternate translation: [of an arrow that someone might shoot at you]

See: Personification

Psalms 91:5 (#5)

מֵחֵ֣ץ יָע֑וּף יוֹמָֽם

“of the arrow {that} flies by day”

The psalmist is using one type of weapon, an **arrow**, to mean weapons in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of any weapon that someone might use to try to harm you]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 91:6 (#1)

מִדֶּ֣בֶר בָּאֹ֣פֶל יַהֲלֹ֑ךְ מִ֝קֶּ֗טֶב יָשׁ֥וּד צָהֳרָֽיִם

“of the plague {that} walks in darkness, of the destruction that wastes {at} midday”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language.

Alternate translation: [and you will not be afraid of the plague that walks in darkness, and you will not be afraid of the destruction that wastes at midday]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 91:6 (#2)

מֵֽאֶ֤בֶר בָּאֹ֨פֶל֙ יְהַלֵּ֣ךְ מִקֶּ֔טֶב יָשׁ֖וּד צָהֳרָֽיִם

“of the plague {that} walks in darkness, of the destruction that wastes {at} midday”

The psalmist is using things that might happen secretly and things that might happen openly to mean things that might happen in any way. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [You will not have to be concerned about dangers that you cannot see coming or those that you can see coming]

See: Merism

Psalms 91:6 (#3)

יְהַלֵּ֣ךְ

“that} walks”

The psalmist is speaking of a **plague** as if it were a living thing that **walks** around. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that spreads]

See: Personification

Psalms 91:6 (#4)

בָּאֹ֨פֶל

“in darkness”

The psalmist is speaking as if this plague were actually spreading from person to person **in the darkness**, meaning at night. He means that the plague spreads without people realizing it, in the same way that people do not realize what is happening in the darkness of night because they cannot see it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [invisibly]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 91:6 (#5)

מִקֶּ֔טֶב יָשׁ֖וּד

“of the destruction that wastes”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of destructive things that cause great damage]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 91:6 (#6)

צָהֳרָֽיִם

“at} midday”

Here, **midday**, the time when the sun is brightest in the sky, represents “openly and obviously.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in broad daylight]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 91:7 (#1)

יִפֹּ֣ל מִצִּדְּךָ֣ ׀ אֶ֭לֶף וּרְבָבָ֣ה מִימִינֶ֑ךָ אֵלֶ֥יךָ לֹ֝֗א יִגָּֽשׁ

“A thousand may fall at your side, and a myriad at your right hand; it will not approach toward you”

The psalmist is using a hypothetical situation to help his listeners appreciate how confidently they can trust God to protect them. Use the natural form in your language for expressing a hypothetical situation. Alternate translation: [Suppose a thousand fell at your side. Suppose a myriad fell at your right hand. Even then, it would not approach toward you]

See: Hypothetical Situations

Psalms 91:7 (#2)

יִפֹּ֣ל מִצִּדְּךָ֣ ׀ אֶ֭לֶף וּרְבָבָ֣ה מִימִינֶ֑ךָ

“A thousand may fall at your side, and a myriad at your right hand”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [A thousand may fall at your side, and a myriad may fall at your right hand]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 91:7 (#3)

יִפֹּ֣ל מִצִּדְּךָ֣ ׀ אֶ֭לֶף וּרְבָבָ֣ה מִימִינֶ֑ךָ

“A thousand may fall at your side, and a myriad at your right hand”

The psalmist is using the term **fall** to mean “die,” since people typically fall down when they die. Be sure that it is clear in your translation that he is not referring to people falling down accidentally. Alternate transla-

tion: [A thousand may die at your side, and a myriad may die at your right hand]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 91:7 (#4)

אֵלֶ֗יךָ לֹ֣א יִגַּ֑שׁ

“it will not approach toward you”

The pronoun **it** refers to any deadly danger such as the psalmist has described in verses 5 and 6. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [no deadly dangerous thing will approach toward you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 91:7 (#5)

אֵלֶ֗יךָ לֹ֣א יִגַּ֑שׁ

“it will not approach toward you”

Since the psalmist says that people may die right next to and all around the individual whom he is addressing, he does not mean that danger will actually **not** even **approach** that individual. Rather, he is using this expression as an overstatement to mean that dangerous things will not kill him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [no deadly dangerous thing will kill you]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 91:8 (#1)

בְּעֵינֶ֥יךָ תַבִּ֑יט

“observe with your eyes”

It might seem that the expression **observe with your eyes** contains extra information that would be unnatural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [observe]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 91:8 (#2)

וְשִׁלֻּמַ֖ת רְשָׁעִ֣ים תִּרְאֶֽה

“and see the recompense of the wicked”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe the **wicked** receiving a **recompense**, not the wicked giving a recompense to someone. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and see the wicked receiving their recompense]

See: Possession

Psalms 91:8 (#3)

וְשִׁלֻּמַ֖ת רְשָׁעִ֣ים תִּרְאֶֽה

“and see the recompense of the wicked”

The psalmist is speaking as if God were actually repaying the wicked an amount that was due to them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and see God paying the wicked back for what they have done] or [and see God punishing the wicked]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:8 (#4)

רְשָׁעִ֣ים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 91:9 (#1)

אַתָּ֣ה יְהוָ֣ה מַחְסִ֑י עֶלְי֥וֹן שַׂ֝שַׂ֗מְתָּ מְעוֹנֶֽךָ

“you have made Yahweh, my refuge, the Most High, your dwelling”

The psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a **refuge** in which a person could take shelter and a **dwelling** in which a person could live. See how you translated the expression “dwelling in the shelter” in 91:1 and the expression “My refuge” in 91:2. Alternate translation: [you are depending on Yahweh, the source of my safety, the Most High, for your protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:10 (#1)

לֹֽא־תְאֻנֶּ֣ה אֵלֶ֣יךָ רָ֑עָה וְ֝נֶ֗גַע לֹא־יִקְרַ֥ב בְּאָהֳלֶֽךָ

“evil will not happen to you, and a plague will not approach your tent”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The first phrase states the general idea, and then the second phrase gives a specific example. Translate these phrases according to the decisions your team has made regarding translating parallelism in Hebrew poetry. Alternate translation: [evil will not happen to

you; no, a plague will not come near to your tent] or [bad things will not happen to you where you live]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 91:10 (#2)

לֹא־תְאֻנֶּה אֵלֶיךָ רָעָה וְנֶגַע לֹא־יִקְרַב בְּאָהֳלֶךָ

“evil will not happen to you, and a plague will not approach your tent”

The psalmist is speaking of how **evil will not happen** and **a plague will not come near** without indicating that these are the results of Yahweh’s actions on behalf of those who trust in him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate Yahweh’s agency explicitly here. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will prevent evil from happening to you; yes, he will keep plagues from coming near to your tent]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 91:10 (#3)

בְּאָהֳלֶךָ

“your tent”

The psalmist is using one kind of home, a **tent**, to mean all kinds of homes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your home]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 91:11 (#1)

יְצַוֶּה

“he will command”

The pronoun **he** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God will command]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 91:11 (#2)

בְּכָל־דְּרָכֶיךָ

“in all of your ways”

The psalmist is speaking of the activities of the individual he is addressing as if they were **ways** or paths that the individual was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in all of your activities]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 91:12 (#1)

פֶּן־תִּגֹּף בָּאֶבֶן רַגְלֶךָ

“lest you hit your foot against a stone”

The psalmist is using one harmful thing that might happen to a person, hitting his **foot** against a **stone**, to mean every kind of harmful thing that might happen to a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so that harmful things do not happen to you]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 91:12 (#2)

פֶּן־תִּגֹּף בָּאֶבֶן רַגְלֶךָ

“lest you hit your foot against a stone”

The psalmist is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first reassures the person he is addressing that God’s angels will protect him so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the instruction. Alternate translation: [Otherwise, you might hit your foot against a stone] or [Otherwise, harmful things might happen to you]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 91:13 (#1)

עַל־שַׁחַל וָפֶתֶן תִּדְרֹךְ תִּרְמֹס כְּפִיר וְתַנִּין

“You will tread on the lion and the adder; you will trample the young lion and the serpent”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **lion**, **adder**, **young lion**, or **serpent**. He means such animals in general. It may be more natural in your language to express this meaning by using plural forms. Alternate translation: [You will tread on lions and adders; you will trample young lions and serpents]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 91:13 (#2)

עַל־שַׁחַל וָפֶתֶן תִּדְרֹךְ תִּרְמֹס כְּפִיר וְתַנִּין

“You will tread on the lion and the adder; you will trample the young lion and the serpent”

The psalmist may be using the terms **tread** and **trample** to mean “defeat.” People in this culture would force defeated enemies to lie down and then place a foot on top of them to show how completely they had defeated them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate trans-

lation: [You will defeat any lion or adder that attacks you; yes, you will defeat any young lion or serpent that attacks you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 91:13 (#3)

עַל־שַׁחַל וָפֶתֶן תִּדְרֹךְ תִּרְמֹס כְּפִיר וְתַנִּין

"You will tread on the lion and the adder; you will trample the young lion and the serpent"

The psalmist is using a hypothetical situation to help the individual he is addressing appreciate how Yahweh will protect him. Use a natural form in your language for expressing a hypothetical situation. To do that, it may be helpful to combine the two parallel phrases in this verse. Alternate translation: [Suppose a lion or a snake attacks you. Yahweh will enable you to defeat it, and it will not harm you] or [If a lion or a snake attacks you, you will defeat it and it will not harm you]

See: Hypothetical Situations

Psalms 91:14 (#1)

כִּֽי־בִ֭י חָשַׁק

"Because he clings to me"

This is the beginning of a direct quotation from Yahweh. You may wish to indicate that in your translation, using a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh says, "Because he clings to me"]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 91:14 (#2)

בִּ֭י חָשַׁק

"he clings to me"

The psalmist assumes that his listeners will know that by **cling**, he means to cling to someone out of love and devotion. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he is devoted to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 91:14 (#3)

יָדַ֣ע שְׁמִ֑י

"he knows my name"

The word **name** could refer to: (1) Yahweh as a person, since each person has a name. Alternate translation: [he knows me personally]; (2) Yahweh's reputation, which reflects his character. Alternate translation: [he knows my character and so trusts me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 91:15 (#1)

וְאֶֽעֱנֵ֥הוּ

"and I will answer him"

The psalmist assumes that his listeners will know that by **answer**, he means that Yahweh will help this individual. Yahweh will not simply speak back to the person in response to his **call** for help. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I will help him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 91:16 (#1)

אׇ֭רֶךְ יָמִ֑ים

"with} length of days"

The psalmist is using the term **days** to refer to a specific time, the human lifetime. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with a long life]

See: Idiom

Psalms 91:16 (#2)

וְאַרְאֵ֖הוּ בִּישׁוּעָתִֽי

"and I will show him my salvation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and I will cause him to experience me saving him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 92 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 92 is a psalm of praise for God's kindness and faithfulness. (See: faithful, faithfulness, trustworthy)

1. It is good to praise the Lord (1–4)
2. God's works are great and his ways are deep (5–9)
3. God strengthens and honors the righteous (10–11)
4. The righteous will flourish (12–15)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Justice
God causes evil people to be destroyed and good people to be happy and useful, even after they grow old. (See: just, justice, unjust, injustice, justify, justification; and evil, wicked, wickedness, unpleasant)

Psalms 92:1 (#1)

וּלְזַמֵּר לְשִׁמְךָ

“and to sing praises to your name”

Here **name** represents God himself. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express this explicitly. Alternate translation: [and to sing praises to you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 92:2 (#1)

לְהַגִּיד בַּבֹּקֶר חַסְדֶּךָ

“to proclaim your covenant faithfulness in the morning”

The abstract noun **covenant faithfulness** refers to God’s faithful love for the people with whom he made a covenant. If your language does not use abstract nouns, you can translate this using another form. Alternate translation: [to proclaim in the morning that you are faithful to your covenant people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 92:2 (#2)

וֶאֱמוּנָתְךָ בַּלֵּילוֹת

“and your truthfulness in the nights”

The writer is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and to proclaim your truthfulness every night]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 92:2 (#3)

וֶאֱמוּנָתְךָ

“and your truthfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truthfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and that you are truthful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 92:3 (#1)

עָלֵי עָשׂוֹר

“a ten {string”

A **ten string** is a kind of musical instrument with multiple strings. If your readers would not be familiar with what a ten string is, you could use the name of a similar instrument that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [an instrument with ten strings]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 92:4 (#1)

בְּמַעֲשֶׂיךָ יְיָ

“because of the deeds of your hands”

Here, **your hands** represents the capability of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of the things that you have accomplished]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 92:5 (#1)

מָה־גָּדְלוּ מַעֲשֶׂיךָ יְיָ

“Your thoughts are very deep”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God’s **thoughts** as if they were a deep pool of water because we cannot see or reach them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Your thoughts are like a deep pool to us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:5 (#2)

מְאֹד עָמְקוּ מַחְשְׁבֹתֶיךָ

“Your thoughts”

The word **thoughts** is an abstract noun that refers to what someone thinks. Some languages may not use abstract nouns. If this is true in your language, you could translate this with a verb, such as “what you think.” Alternate translation: [The things you think] or [Your plans]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 92:6 (#1)

אִישׁ־בַּעַר לֹא יֵדָע וּכְסִיל לֹא־יָבִין אֶת־זֹאת

“A brutish person does not know, nor does a stupid {one} understand this”

These two phrases **A brutish person does not know** and **a stupid one does not understand this** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [A foolish person neither knows nor understands this] or [The foolish person completely fails to understand this]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 92:6 (#2)

וּכְסִ֣יל

“a stupid {one”

The psalmist is using the adjective **stupid** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [any stupid person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 92:6 (#3)

אֶת־זֹ֣את

“this”

The pronoun **this** refers to what the psalmist goes on to explain in verse 7 about wicked people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the following truth]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 92:7 (#1)

בִּפְרֹ֤חַ רְשָׁ֨עִ֨ים ׀ כְּמ֥וֹ עֵ֗שֶׂב

“When the wicked sprout like grass”

This is a simile that speaks of wicked people appearing and growing **like grass**. Grass springs up and spreads quickly but does not last long. This emphasizes that wicked people may seem to prosper for a while, but their success will be brief. Alternate translation: [When the wicked appear quickly and seem to be everywhere as grass does]

See: Simile

Psalms 92:7 (#2)

לְהִשָּׁמְדָ֥ם עֲדֵי־עַ֗ד

“they will be destroyed for eternity”

The words **they will be destroyed** express in passive form what Yahweh will do to the wicked. If your language does not use passive forms or if the passive form would be confusing here, you can translate this with an active form. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will destroy them completely]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 92:7 (#3)

לְהִשָּׁמְדָֽם

“they will be destroyed”

The pronoun **they** refers to the wicked and evildoers. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the wicked and evildoers will be destroyed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 92:7 (#4)

רְשָׁעִ֑ים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 92:8 (#1)

מָרוֹ֥ם

“are} exalted”

The expression **are exalted** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [will live on high]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 92:9 (#1)

יִתְפָּרְד֣וּ כָל־פֹּ֭עֲלֵי אָ֑וֶן

“All those who do evil will be scattered”

This text uses the passive verb **will be scattered** without identifying who will do the action. The psalmist of the psalm may have written it this way to focus on what will happen to the evildoers rather than on who will scatter them. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state this in active form with God as the subject, as in the alternate translation.

Alternate translation: [you will scatter all those who do evil]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 92:10 (#1)

וַתָּ֣רֶם כִּרְאֵ֣ים קַרְנִ֑י

“But you have lifted up my horn like a wild ox”

Here, **horn** represents strength or power. The psalmist is describing how God has given him strength like that of a wild ox. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state plainly what the horn represents. Alternate translation: [But you have made me as strong as a wild ox]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 92:10 (#2)

בַּלֹּתִ֥י בְּשֶׁ֗מֶן רַ֫עֲנָ֥ן

“I am saturated with fresh oil”

Here the psalmist is speaking of himself as if he were an offering that is **saturated with fresh oil**. The abundance of oil represents God’s abundant blessing and the joy that he feels as God has made him able to defeat his enemies. Alternate translation: [you have richly blessed me] or [I am filled with joy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:11 (#1)

וַתַּבֵּ֣ט עֵינִ֣י בְּשׁוּרָ֑רַי & תִּשְׁמַ֥עְנָה אָזְנָֽי

“My eye has looked on my foes & my ears have heard”

Here **eye** and **ears** represent the whole person who sees and hears. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have seen my foes … I have heard]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 92:11 (#2)

וַתַּבֵּ֣ט עֵינִ֣י בְּשׁוּרָ֑רַי בַּקָּמִ֥ים עָלַ֗י מְרֵעִ֫ים תִּשְׁמַ֥עְנָה אָזְנָֽי

“My eye has looked on my foes, those rising up against me; those doing evil my ears have heard”

Some scholars believe that these phrases imply what it is that the writer saw and heard. You could include this information if a translation of the Bible exists in your region that includes it. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [My eye has looked on my foes, those rising up against me, as you defeat them; those doing evil my ears have heard as you punish them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 92:12 (#1)

צַדִּ֥יק כַּתָּמָ֗ר יִפְרָ֫ח

“The righteous {one} will flourish like the palm tree”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the palm tree** is resilient and long-lived, so is **The righteous one**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [The righteous one will be resilient and long-lived like a palm tree]

See: Simile

Psalms 92:12 (#2)

כְּאֶ֥רֶז בַּלְּבָנ֗וֹן יִשְׂגֶּֽה

“he will grow like a cedar in Lebanon”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a cedar** is strong and admired for being tall and stately, so is **The righteous one**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [he will be strong and admired like a cedar tree in Lebanon]

See: Simile

Psalms 92:12 (#3)

צַדִּ֥יק

“The righteous {one”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Any righteous person] or [All righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 92:12 (#4)

יִשְׂגֶּֽה

“he will grow”

The pronoun **he** refers to any righteous person. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [they will grow]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 92:13 (#1)

שְׁתוּלִים

“They are planted”

The psalmist uses the passive verb **are planted** and does not tell who has done the planting. You may need to state clearly who did the planting if your language does not use passive verbs in this way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has planted them] or [Yahweh takes care of them as if they were trees that he had planted]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 92:13 (#2)

שְׁתוּלִים

“They are planted”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if righteous people were actually **planted** trees growing in Yahweh’s house. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [they flourish like trees] or [they live securely]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:13 (#3)

שְׁתוּלִים

“They are planted”

The pronoun **They** refers to righteous people, who are those who are planted in Yahweh’s house. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Righteous people are planted]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 92:13 (#4)

יַפְרִיחוּ

“they flourish”

Here the psalmist is speaking of righteous people as if they were plants that **flourish**, which means that they are strong and healthy. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this image differently or state this plainly without the image. Alternate translation: [they grow well] or [they prosper]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:14 (#1)

יְנוּבֻן

“They bear fruit”

The psalmist is speaking of people who are faithful to God as if they were **fruit**-bearing trees. This image emphasizes how they continue to be productive and do good things. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They continue doing good things]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:14 (#2)

יְנוּבֻן

“They bear fruit”

The pronoun **They** continues to refer to righteous people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Righteous people, like trees, bear fruit]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 92:14 (#3)

דְּשֵׁנִים וְרַעֲנַנִּים יִהְיוּ

“they are juicy and green”

Here the psalmist speaks of **juicy and green** as if the righteous people were plants that are healthy and full of life. This metaphor compares their spiritual and physical well-being to the freshness of a flourishing plant. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state plainly what this means. Alternate translation: [they remain strong and healthy] or [they always do what pleases God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:15 (#1)

לְהַגִּיד כִּי

“to proclaim that”

If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [showing that] or [which shows that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 92:15 (#2)

צוּרִי

“my rock”

Here the psalmist speaks of Yahweh as if he were a **rock**, because a large rock can provide protection and safety. You could keep this image in your translation if it is clear, or you could state the meaning plainly.

See how you translated this in Psalm 18:2. Alternate translation: [the one who protects me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:15 (#3)

וְלֹא־עַלְתָה בּוֹ

“and {there is} no unrighteousness in him”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **unrighteousness** as if it were a substance or object that could be present in or absent from someone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he is always righteousness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 92:15 (#4)

וְלֹא־עַלְתָה בּוֹ

“and {there is} no unrighteousness in him”

The phrase **no unrighteousness** uses two negative words to express a positive meaning. The psalmist is saying that God is completely righteous. If your language does not use double negatives, you could express this with a positive statement. Alternate translation: [and he is always righteousness]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms - Chapter 93 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 93 is a “worship psalm” about the power of Yahweh.

1. Yahweh reigns in glory and strength (1–2)
2. Yahweh is stronger than chaos and opposition (3–4)
3. Yahweh is trustworthy and holy (5)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s power

Yahweh is all powerful; He even controls the ocean.

Psalms 93:1 (#1)

יְהוָה מָלָךְ׀

“Yahweh reigns”

Verses 1 and 4 of this psalm refer to Yahweh as “he” and verses 2,3, and 5 refer to him as “you.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use “you” throughout the psalm, as in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 93:1 (#2)

גֵּאוּת לָבֵשׁ

“he wears majesty”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **majesty**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he is majestic]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 93:1 (#3)

גֵּאוּת לָבֵשׁ לָבֵשׁ יְהוָה עֹז הִתְאַזָּר

“he wears majesty; Yahweh wears, he girds himself with, strength”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if **majesty** and **strength** were actually garments that Yahweh **wears**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he displays his majesty; Yahweh’s strength is obvious for all to see]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 93:1 (#4)

לָבֵשׁ יְהוָה עֹז הִתְאַזָּר

“Yahweh wears, he girds himself with, strength”

The terms **wears** and **girds himself with** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Yahweh wraps strength all around himself]

See: Doublet

Psalms 93:1 (#5)

לָבֵשׁ יְהוָה עֹז הִתְאַזָּר

“Yahweh wears, he girds himself with, strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is obviously powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 93:1 (#6)

תִּכּוֹן תֵּבֵל

“the world is firmly established”

The expression **is firmly established** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you have firmly established the world]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 93:1 (#7)

בַּל־תִּמּוֹט

“it cannot be moved”

The expression **be moved** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one can ever move it]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 93:2 (#1)

נָכוֹן כִּסְאֲךָ מֵאָז

“Your throne is established from before”

The expression **is established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [You established your throne in ancient times]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 93:2 (#2)

כִּסְאֲךָ

“Your throne”

Here, **throne** represents royal authority and rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Your kingship]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 93:3 (#1)

נְהָרוֹת

“The seas”

The word translated as **seas** here refers to any kind of moving water; in other contexts it is translated as “rivers” or “floods” (See: “the River” in Psalms 72:8), but “seas” has been chosen here because seas, not rivers, have **pounding waves**.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 93:3 (#2)

נָשְׂאוּ נְהָרוֹת קוֹלָם

“the seas have lifted up their voice”

The psalmist is speaking of **the seas** as if they were living things that could lift their voices. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the seas make a roaring noise]

See: Personification

Psalms 93:4 (#1)

מִקֹּלוֹת ׀ מַיִם רַבִּים אַדִּירִים מִשְׁבְּרֵי־יָם אַדִּיר בַּמָּרוֹם יְהוָה

“More than the sounds of many waters, than the mighty breakers of the sea, Yahweh on high is mighty”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about **Yahweh on high is mighty** before the comparisons **than the sounds of many waters** and **than the mighty breakers of the sea**. Alternate translation: [Yahweh on high is mightier than the sounds of many waters, than the mighty breakers of the sea]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 93:4 (#2)

אַדִּירִים מִשְׁבְּרֵי־יָם

“than the mighty breakers of the sea”

By **breakers of the sea**, the psalmist means the waves of the sea that crash onto the shore. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [than the mighty waves of the sea crashing on land]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 93:4 (#3)

בַּמָּרוֹם

“on high”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God were actually in a place **on high**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who is greater than everything else]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 93:5 (#1)

לְבֵיתְךָ נַאֲוָה־קֹדֶשׁ

“holiness adorns your house”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if **holiness** were actually a decoration that **adorns** or beautifies the temple. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your house is beautiful because you are holy] or [your holiness is what attracts people to your house]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 93:5 (#2)

לְבֵיתְךָ֣ נַאֲוָה־קֹ֑דֶשׁ

“holiness adorns your house”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your house is beautiful because you are holy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 93:5 (#3)

לְאֹ֝רֶךְ יָמִֽים

“for length of days”

The psalmist is using **length of days** as a common expression of his culture to mean “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for always]

See: Idiom

Psalms - Chapter 94 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 94 is a prayer requesting that evil people be punished. (See: evil, wicked, wickedness, unpleasant)

1. A cry for Yahweh’s justice (1–7)
2. Yahweh sees and will judge (8–11)
3. Yahweh disciplines and helps his people (12–15)
4. Yahweh is the refuge of the oppressed (16–23)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Justice

Evil people expect God to ignore their injustices. But God knows what they are doing and will punish them for their evil deeds. (See: just, justice, unjust, injustice, justify, justification)

Psalms 94:1 (#1)

אֵל־נְקָמוֹת֮ יְהוָ֪ה אֵ֫ל נְקָמ֥וֹת

“God of vengeance, Yahweh, God of vengeance”

Here, **God of vengeance, Yahweh, God of vengeance** the psalmist is using repetition for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the God who avenges]

See: Poetry

Psalms 94:1 (#2)

אֵל־נְקָמוֹת & אֵ֫ל נְקָמ֥וֹת

“God of vengeance & God of vengeance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **vengeance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God who avenges ... God who avenges]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:1 (#3)

הוֹפִֽיעַ

“shine forth”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God were actually a light that could **shine forth**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Reveal yourself] or [Let them see how majestic you are]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:2 (#1)

הִתְנַשֵּׂ֑א

“Rise up”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God were actually someone who was sitting or lying down and needed to **rise up**. The psalmist means that God should take action to judge the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Take action] or [Act now]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:2 (#2)

הָאָ֗רֶץ

“of the earth”

Here, **the earth** represents all the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [of all people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 94:2 (#3)

הָשֵׁ֣שֶׁב גְּמ֣וֹל עַל

“return recompense upon”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **recompense**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [pay back] or [punish]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:2 (#4)

גֵּאִֽים

“the proud”

The psalmist is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [proud people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 94:3 (#1)

עַד־מָתַ֤י רְשָׁעִ֨ים ׀ יְהוָ֗ה עַד־מָ֭תַי רְשָׁעִ֣ים יַעֲלֽוּ

“Until when will the wicked, Yahweh, until when will the wicked rejoice”

The psalmist is using the question form **Until when will the wicked, Yahweh, until when will the wicked rejoice** to express his frustration and to make an urgent appeal to God for action. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the wicked have been rejoicing much too long.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:3 (#2)

עַד־מָתַ֤י רְשָׁעִ֨ים ׀ יְהוָ֗ה עַד־מָ֭תַי רְשָׁעִֽים

“Until when will the wicked, Yahweh, until when will the wicked”

These two phrases **Until when will the wicked, Yahweh** and **until when will the wicked** are basically the same. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating it again. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. Or if it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, just how long will you allow the wicked to rejoice?]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 94:3 (#3)

רְשָׁעִֽים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 94:4 (#1)

יַבִּ֥יעוּ יְדַבְּר֑וּ

“They pour out, they speak”

The phrases **pour out** and **speak** express a single idea. The word **pour out** tells more about **speak**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [In large amounts, they speak]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 94:4 (#2)

עָ֝תָ֗ק

“arrogance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **arrogance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [arrogant words]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:4 (#3)

אָ֑וֶן

“evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [evil actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:5 (#1)

יְדַכְּא֥וּ

“They crush”

The psalmist is speaking as if the wicked people were literally **crushing** God’s people with physical force. He means that they are oppressing them severely. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They oppress]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:5 (#2)

וְנַחֲלָתְךָ

“your inheritance”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s people as if they were actually **your inheritance**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your own people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:6 (#1)

אַלְמָנָה וְגֵר & וְיתוֹמִים יְרַצֵּחוּ

“the widow and the sojourner, and they murder the fatherless”

Here, **the widow and the sojourner** and **the fatherless** represent vulnerable people in general, not specific individuals. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use expressions that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [widows and sojourners & they murder those without fathers]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 94:6 (#2)

אַלְמָנָה וְגֵר יַהֲרֹגוּ וְיתוֹמִים יְרַצֵּחוּ

“They kill the widow and the sojourner, and they murder the fatherless”

The terms **kill** and **murder** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [They kill the widow, the sojourner, and the fatherless]

See: Doublet

Psalms 94:7 (#1)

וַיֹּאמְרוּ

“They say”

The pronoun **They** refers to the wicked people mentioned in the previous verses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The wicked people say]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 94:7 (#2)

וַיֹּאמְרוּ

“They say”

The implication is that the wicked people are thinking these thoughts silently to themselves rather than speaking them aloud to others. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [They say to themselves]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 94:7 (#3)

לֹא יִרְאֶה & וְלֹא־יָבִֽין

“does not see & does not perceive”

The implication is that God does not see or perceive what the wicked people are doing. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [does not see what we do ... does not perceive what we do]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 94:7 (#4)

לֹא יִרְאֶה־יָּהּ וְלֹא־יָבִין אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹֽב

“Yah does not see, the God of Jacob does not perceive”

These two phrases **Yah does not see** and **the God of Jacob does not perceive** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Yahweh does not see, no, the God of Jacob does not perceive]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 94:8 (#1)

וּכְסִילִ֗ים מָתַ֫י תַּשְׂכִּֽילוּ

“O fools, when will you have insight”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You fools need to gain insight!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:8 (#2)

תַּשְׂכִּילוּ

“will you have insight”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **insight**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [will you behave insightfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:8 (#3)

בִּבְינוּ בֹעֲרִרִים בָּעָם וּכְסִילִלִים מָתַי תַּשְׂכִּילוּ

“Understand, stupid ones among the people! O fools, when will you have insight”

These two phrases **Understand, stupid ones among the people** and **O fools, when will you have insight** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea in a different form. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Get insight and understanding, you stupid, foolish people!]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 94:9 (#1)

הֲנֹטַע אֹזֶן

“The one planting the ear”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God were actually **planting the ear**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The one creating the ear]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:9 (#2)

הֲלֹא יִשְׁמָע

“does he not hear”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [he certainly does hear!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:9 (#3)

הֲלֹא יַבִּיט

“does he not observe”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [he certainly does observe!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:10 (#1)

הֲלֹא יוֹכִיחַ

“does he not rebuke”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [he will certainly rebuke you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:10 (#2)

הַמְיַסֵּר אֲדָם דֵּעַת

“Does the one teaching mankind lack knowledge”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [The one teaching mankind certainly does not lack knowledge.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:10 (#3)

גּוֹיִם

“nations”

Here, **nations** represents the people of all nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people of all nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 94:10 (#4)

הַמְלַמֵּד אָדָם דָּעַת

“Does the one teaching mankind lack knowledge”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **knowledge**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Is there anything that the one teaching mankind does not know]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:11 (#1)

מַחְשְׁבוֹת אָדָם

“the thoughts of mankind”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thoughts**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things that people are thinking]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:11 (#2)

הֵמָּה הָבֶל

“they are vapor”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if people’s thoughts were actually **vapor**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [they are unimportant and useless]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:12 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The joys of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joys**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [How joyful is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:12 (#2)

הַגֶּבֶר

“the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 94:13 (#1)

לְהַשְׁקִיט לוֹ

“to give rest to him”

Here, **to give rest to him** marks this clause as the goal or purpose of God instructing and teaching the blessed person. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [which will allow him to have rest]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 94:13 (#2)

מִמֵּימֵי רָע

“from days of evil”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **days** that are characterized by **evil**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [during evil days]

See: Possession

Psalms 94:13 (#3)

יִכָּרֶה & שָׁחַת

“a pit is dug”

The expression **a pit is dug** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [Yahweh digs a pit]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 94:13 (#4)

יִכָּרֶה לָרָשָׁע שָׁחַת

“a pit is dug for the wicked”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God’s punishment of the wicked were actually **a pit** being dug. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh punishes the wicked]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:14 (#1)

לֹא־יִטֹּשׁ יְהוָה עַמּוֹ וְנַחֲלָתוֹ לֹא יַעֲזֹב

“Yahweh will not forsake his people and he will not abandon his inheritance”

These two phrases **will not forsake his people** and **he will not abandon his inheritance** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will not forsake his people, no, he will not abandon his inheritance]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 94:14 (#2)

וְנַחֲלָתוֹ לֹא יַעֲזֹב

“and he will not abandon his inheritance”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the people of Israel were actually **his inheritance**. He means that they are the people who belong to God in a special way, like a treasured possession that is passed down in a family. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will not abandon Yahweh’s own people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:14 (#3)

כִּֽי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 94:15 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [It will happen that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 94:15 (#2)

עַד־צֶ֭דֶק יָשׁ֣וּב מִשְׁפָּ֑ט

“judgment will return to the right”

Here, **judgment** represents “judges” or “the judicial system.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [judges will return to making right judgments]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 94:15 (#3)

צֶ֭דֶק

“the right”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **the right**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:15 (#4)

וְ֝אַחֲרָ֗יו כָּל־יִשְׁרֵי־לֵֽב

“and all the upright in heart {are} after it”

The implication is that all the upright in heart will support and follow righteous judgment when it is restored. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and all the upright in heart are in favor of that]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 94:16 (#1)

מִֽי־יָ֭קוּם לִ֣י עִם־מְרֵעִ֑ים

“Who will rise up for me against the evildoers”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I cannot find anyone who will rise up for me against the evildoers.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:16 (#2)

מִֽי־יִתְיַצַּ֣ב לִ֭י עִם־פֹּעֲלֵ֣י אָ֑וֶן

“Who will stand up for me against the workers of wickedness”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I cannot find anyone who will stand up for me against the workers of wickedness.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:16 (#3)

מִי־יָקוּם לִ֥י עִם־מְרֵעִ֑ים מִי־יִתְיַצַּ֖ב לִ֣י עִם־פֹּ֣עֲלֵי אָֽוֶן

“Who will rise up for me against the evildoers? Who will stand up for me against the workers of wickedness”

These two phrases **Who will rise up for me against the evildoers** and **Who will stand up for me against the workers of wickedness** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Who will rise up for me against the evildoers? I say again, who will stand up for me against the workers of wickedness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 94:16 (#4)

פֹּ֣עֲלֵי אָֽוֶן

“the workers of wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the people doing wicked things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:17 (#1)

לוּלֵ֣י יְ֭הוָה עֶזְרָתָ֣ה לִּ֑י כִּמְעַ֥ט ׀ שָׁ֝כְנָ֗ה דוּמָ֥ה נַפְשִֽׁי

“Unless Yahweh {had been} a help to me, shortly my soul would have dwelt in silence”

The psalmist says **Unless Yahweh had been a help to me** to introduce an imaginary situation to help explain what would have happened without God’s help. Use a natural method in your language for introducing an imaginary situation. Alternate translation: [Only because Yahweh was a help to me, my soul did not shortly dwell in silence]

See: Hypothetical Situations

Psalms 94:17 (#2)

עֶזְרָתָ֣ה לִּ֑י

“had been} a help to me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [had helped me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:17 (#3)

נַפְשִֽׁי

“my soul”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **soul**, to mean all of him in the act of dying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 94:17 (#4)

שָׁ֝כְנָ֗ה דוּמָ֥ה

“would have dwelt in silence”

The psalmist is referring to death in a polite way by using the phrase **would have dwelt in silence**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [would have been killed]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 94:18 (#1)

אִם־אָ֭מַרְתִּי

“When I said”

By **When I said**, the psalmist means “When I said to myself” or “When I thought to myself.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When I said to myself]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 94:18 (#2)

מָ֣מָּטָ֣ה רַגְלִ֑י

“My foot is slipping”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if his life were actually **a foot that was slipping**. He means that he was in great trouble or danger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am in big trouble] or [I need help]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:18 (#3)

חַסְדְּךָ֣

“Your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Because you are faithful to your covenant, you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:19 (#1)

בְּרֹ֗ב שַׂרְעַפַּ֫י בְּקִרְבִּ֥י

“When my cares within me {are} many”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **cares**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [When I am worried about many things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:19 (#2)

תַּ֭עֲנֻחוֹתֶ֣יךָ יְשַׁעֲשְׁע֣וּ נַפְשִׁ֑י

“your consolations gladden my soul”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **consolations**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your console me, which makes my soul glad]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:19 (#3)

נַפְשִׁ֑י

“my soul”

The psalmist is using **my soul** to represent all of himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 94:20 (#1)

הֲיָחְבָּ֣רְךָ֣ כִּסֵּ֣א הַוּ֑וֹת יֹצֵ֖ר עָ֣מָל עָלֵ֣י־חֹֽק

“Can a throne of destruction be your ally, one creating injustice by statute”

The psalmist is using the question form to express that God cannot be allied with corrupt rulers. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You can have nothing to do with a throne of destruction, one who creates injustice by statute.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 94:20 (#2)

כִּסֵּ֣א הַוּ֑וֹת

“a throne of destruction”

Here, **throne** represents a ruler who has authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a ruler who destroys people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 94:20 (#3)

כִּסֵּ֣א הַוּ֑וֹת

“a throne of destruction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a throne that destroys]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:20 (#4)

יֹצֵ֖ר עָ֣מָל עָלֵ֣י־חֹֽק

“one creating injustice by statute”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **injustice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [one who creates unjust statutes]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:21 (#1)

יָגֹ֥דּוּ

“They conspire together”

The pronoun **They** refers to the corrupt rulers from the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for

your readers. Alternate translation: [Such thrones of destruction conspire together] or [Wicked rulers like that conspire together]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 94:21 (#2)

עַל־נֶ֥פֶשׁ צַדִּ֗יק

“against the life of the righteous”

The psalmist is using **against the life of** as a common expression of his culture to mean “to kill” or “to destroy.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to kill the righteous]

See: Idiom

Psalms 94:21 (#3)

וְדָ֣ם נָ֭קִי יַרְשִׁיעוּ

“and they condemn innocent blood”

The psalmist is using **innocent blood** as a common expression of his culture to mean “innocent people” or “people who do not deserve to die.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they condemn innocent people to death]

See: Idiom

Psalms 94:21 (#4)

צַדִּֽיק

“the righteous”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **righteous** person. He means righteous people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [all righteous people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 94:22 (#1)

לְמִשְׂגָּ֑ב

“a high tower”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were **a high tower** because that is a place of protection. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [my protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:22 (#2)

וֵֽאלֹהַ֥י לְצ֝֗וּר

“and my God, the rock”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and my God has been the rock]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 94:22 (#3)

וֵֽאלֹהַ֥י לְצ֝֗וּר

“and my God, the rock”

The psalmist speaks of having God protect him as if God were a place where the psalmist could go to be safe. See how “rock” and “refuge” are translated in Psalms 62:7. Alternate translation: [and my God has kept me safe by his power]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 94:22 (#4)

וֵֽאלֹהַ֥י

“and my God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the God whom he worships. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 94:23 (#1)

וַיָּ֣שֶׁב עֲלֵיהֶ֣ם ׀ אֶת־אוֹנָ֑ם

“He will return on them their iniquity”

This could mean: (1) that Yahweh will do the same things to them that they did. Alternate translation: [He will do to them the evil things that they have done to others] or (2) that Yahweh will punish them for their evil. Alternate translation: [He will punish them for the evil things that they have done to others]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 94:23 (#2)

עֲלֵיהֶ֣ם

“on them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the corrupt rulers mentioned in verses 20–21. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [on those wicked rulers]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 94:23 (#3)

אֶת־אוֹנָ֑ם

“their iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the sinful things that they have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:23 (#4)

וּבְרָעָתָ֥ם יַצְמִיתֵ֑ם

“and he will destroy them in their wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and he will destroy them their wicked activities]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 94:23 (#5)

וּבְרָעָתָ֥ם יַצְמִיתֵ֑ם

“and he will destroy them in their wickedness”

This could mean: (1) that Yahweh will destroy them because of their wickedness. Alternate translation: [because they have done wicked things] or (2) that Yahweh will destroy them while they are doing wicked things. Alternate translation: [while they are doing wicked things]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 94:23 (#6)

וּבְרָעָתָ֥ם יַצְמִיתֵ֑ם יַצְמִיתֵ֥ם יְהוָ֖ה אֱלֹהֵ֣ינוּ

“and he will destroy them in their wickedness. Yahweh our God will destroy them”

These two phrases **he will destroy them in their wickedness** and **Yahweh our God will destroy them** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [and he will destroy them in their wickedness. It is Yahweh our God who will destroy them]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 94:23 (#7)

אֱלֹהֵ֣ינוּ

“our God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the God whom they worship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the God whom we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms - Chapter 95 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 95 is the first in a series of six “worship psalms” (Psalms 95–100).

1. Call to worship (1–5)
2. Call to bow in worship (6–7a)
3. Warning to listen and obey (7b–11)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

God’s care

God made everything and takes good care of people. People should not be stubborn, as the Israelites were in the days of Moses. The Israelites with Moses wandered in the desert for 40 years.

Psalms 95:1 (#1)

לְצ֖וּר יִשְׁעֵֽנוּ

“to the rock of our salvation”

Here the writer is speaking as if Yahweh were a **rock**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. See how “rock” and “of my salvation” are translated in Psalms 18:46. Alternate translation: [to our protector and savior]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 95:1 (#2)

לְצ֖וּר יִשְׁעֵֽנוּ

“to the rock of our salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to our steadfast savior]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 95:2 (#1)

נְקַדְּמָה פָנָיו

“Let us meet his face”

Here, **his face** represents being in the presence of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Let us go into his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 95:2 (#2)

בְּתוֹדָה

“with thanksgiving”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thanksgiving**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as we thank him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 95:3 (#1)

עַל־כָּל־אֱלֹהִים

“above all gods”

The term “god,” when applied to a being other than Yahweh, can refer to an idol, but, as here, it can also refer to any lesser spirit being. Alternate translation: [above any other spiritual being]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 95:3 (#2)

עַל־כָּל־אֱלֹהִים

“above all gods”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh were actually positioned **above all gods** in a physical sense. He means that Yahweh is superior to all other gods. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who is superior to all other gods]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 95:4 (#1)

בְּיָדוֹ

“in his hand {has”

The psalmist is using **in his hand** as a common expression of his culture to mean “in his control” or “under his authority.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in his control]

See: Idiom

Psalms 95:4 (#2)

מֶחְקְרֵי־אָרֶץ וְתוֹעֲפ֥וֹת הָרִ֗ים

“the depths of the earth; and the heights of the mountains”

The psalmist is referring to all of the earth by naming two extremes, **the depths of the earth** and **the heights of the mountains**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [every part of the earth; they all]

See: Merism

Psalms 95:4 (#3)

לֹו

“are} to him”

The psalmist is using **are to him** as a common expression of his culture to mean “belong to him” or “are his.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are his]

See: Idiom

Psalms 95:5 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר־לֹו

“who to him {is”

The psalmist is using **who to him is** as a common expression of his culture to mean “who owns.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who owns]

See: Idiom

Psalms 95:5 (#2)

וְהוּא עָשָׂהוּ

“and he, he made it”

The writer is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he made it** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one who made the sea. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and it was he who made it]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 95:5 (#3)

וְיַבֶּשֶׁת יָדָיו יָצָרוּ

“and his hands formed the dry land”

Here the word **hands** represents the action of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he himself formed the dry land]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 95:6 (#1)

וְנִכְרָעָה נִבְרְכָה

“and bow down; let us kneel”

The phrases **bow down** and **kneel** describe symbolic actions by which people showed submission and reverence to God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and show that we submit]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 95:6 (#2)

לִפְנֵי

“to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in front of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 95:7 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“our God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the God whom we worship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the God whom we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 95:7 (#2)

עַם מַרְעִיתוֹ

“the people of his pasture”

The psalmist is speaking as if the people were like God’s sheep in **his pasture**. He means that the people are like God’s sheep that he provides for. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people who belong to him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 95:7 (#3)

וְצֹאן יָדוֹ

“and the flock of his hand”

The psalmist is speaking here of God’s people as if they were **the flock of his hand**. This image portrays God as a shepherd who personally cares for and guides his people like sheep. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the group that he directs and guards]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 95:7 (#4)

אִם & תִּשְׁמָעוּ

“if only you would listen”

The psalmist says **if only you would listen** to introduce a wish that God’s people would obey him. Use a natural method in your language for introducing a wish. Alternate translation: [I wish you would listen]

See: Hypothetical Situations

Psalms 95:7 (#5)

בְּקֹלוֹ

“to his voice”

Here, **voice** represents what God says. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent

expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to what he says]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 95:8 (#1)

אַל־תַּקְשׁוּ לְלַבַבְכֶם

“Do not harden your heart”

The psalmist is using **harden your heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “become stubborn” or “refuse to listen and obey.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not be obstinate]

See: Idiom

Psalms 95:8 (#2)

כִּמְרִיבָה & מַסָּה

“as {at} Meribah & Massah”

The words **Meribah** and **Massah** are the names of places.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 95:9 (#1)

נִסּוּנִי & בְּחָנוּנִי

“tested me, tried me”

The terms **tested me** and **tried me** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [tested my patience] or [refused to trust me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 95:10 (#1)

אַרְבָּעִים שָׁנָה

“For 40 years”

Translate this number according to the conventions of your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [For forty years]

See: Numbers

Psalms 95:10 (#2)

תֹּעֵי לֵבָב

“wandering of heart”

God is using **wandering of heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “tending to stray” or “lacking in commitment.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [blowing hot and cold] or [lacking in commitment]

See: Idiom

Psalms 95:10 (#3)

וְהֵם לֹא־יָדְעוּ

“and they, they have not known”

The pronouns **they, they** refer to the people of Israel whom God is describing. The psalmist is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they have not known** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that these very people failed to know God’s ways. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [and those very people have not known]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 95:10 (#4)

דְּרָכָי

“my ways”

Here God is speaking of how he wants people to live as if that were **ways** that people could walk along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the way that I teach people to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 95:11 (#1)

בְּאַפִּי

“in my nose”

God is using **in my nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in my anger.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in my anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 95:11 (#2)

אִם־יְבֹאֻ֖ון אֶל־מְנוּחָתִֽי

“if they enter into my rest”

Following the custom of the culture, God is swearing an oath by stating the first part of a condition (**If they enter into my rest**) but not the second part (“then”). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explicitly state the second part of this condition. Alternate translation: [If they enter into my rest, then I am not Yahweh]

See: Oath Formulas

Psalms - Chapter 96 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 96 is one of six “worship psalms” (Psalms 95–100).

1. Call to sing and declare Yahweh’s greatness (1–6)
2. Call the nations to worship (7–9)
3. Yahweh’s reign and coming judgment (10–13)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh, the king

Yahweh is king over all the earth and is worthy of all praise.

Psalms 96:1 (#1)

כָּל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“all the earth”

Here, **all the earth** represents all the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all you people who live on the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:2 (#1)

בָּרֲכ֣וּ שְׁמֹ֑ו

“bless his name”

Here, **name** represents who Yahweh is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [bless everything that he is]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:2 (#2)

יְשׁוּעָתֹֽו

“his salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he is the one who saves]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:2 (#3)

מִיֹּ֖ום־לְיֹומ

“from day to day”

The psalmist is using **from day to day** as a common expression of his culture to mean “continually” or “regularly.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [every day]

See: Idiom

Psalms 96:3 (#1)

כְּבֹודֹ֑ו

“his glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he is extremely great]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:3 (#2)

נִפְלְאֹותָ֥יו

“his marvelous deeds”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [recount his marvelous deeds]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 96:4 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in

your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 96:4 (#2)

וּמְהֻלָּל

“and is to be praised”

The expression **is to be praised** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and everyone should praise him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 96:4 (#3)

נוֹרָא הוּא

“He is to be feared”

The expression **He is to be feared** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Everyone should fear him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 96:5 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [You see,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 96:6 (#1)

הוֹד־וְהָדָר לְפָנָיו

“Splendor and majesty {are} to his face”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **Splendor** and **majesty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [His presence is splendid and majestic]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:6 (#2)

עֹז וְתִפְאֶרֶת

“Strength and beauty {are”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **Strength** and **beauty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [He is strong and beautiful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:6 (#3)

לְפָנָיו

“are} to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents “in his presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [are in his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:7 (#1)

הָבוּ לַיהוָה & הָבוּ לַיהוָה

“Ascribe to Yahweh & ascribe to Yahweh”

These two phrases **Ascribe to Yahweh** and **ascribe to Yahweh** repeat the same meaning. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating it again. If it would be helpful to your readers, you say this once and express the emphasis in another way, as in the UST.

See: Parallelism

Psalms 96:7 (#2)

מִשְׁפְּחוֹת עַמִּים

“clans of peoples”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean clans that belong to various peoples or clans from among the peoples. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [all clans in all peoples]

See: Possession

Psalms 96:7 (#3)

כָּבוֹד וָעֹז

“glory and strength”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory** and **strength**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the fact that he is glorious and strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:8 (#1)

הָבוּ לַיהוָה כְּבוֹד שְׁמוֹ

“Give to Yahweh the glory of his name”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Praise Yahweh because he is the glorious one]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:8 (#2)

כְּבוֹד שְׁמוֹ

“the glory of his name”

Here, **name** represents who God is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the glory of who he is]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:9 (#1)

הִשְׁתַּחֲווּ

“Bow down”

To **Bow down** was a symbolic action by which people showed reverence and submission to Yahweh. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Bow down in worship]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 96:9 (#2)

בְּהַדְרַת־קֹדֶשׁ

“in the splendor of holiness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **splendor** and **holiness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because he is splendid and holy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:9 (#3)

חִילוּ

“tremble”

To **tremble** was a symbolic action by which people showed reverent fear and awe before God’s holy presence. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [tremble in reverent awe]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 96:9 (#4)

מִפָּנָיו

“from his face”

The psalmist is using **from his face** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of” or “on account of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of him]

See: Idiom

Psalms 96:9 (#5)

כָּל־הָאָרֶץ

“all the earth”

Here, **all the earth** represents all the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all you people of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:10 (#1)

תִּכּוֹן תֵּתֵבֵל

“the world is established”

The expression **the world is established** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [he established the world]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 96:10 (#2)

בַּל־תִּמּוֹט

“it cannot be shaken”

The expression **it cannot be shaken** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [nothing can shake it]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 96:10 (#3)

יָדִ֥ין

“He judges”

This could mean: (1) Yahweh always judges the peoples with evenness, as in the UST, or (2) on the future day of judgment, Yahweh will judge the peoples with evenness. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will judge]

Psalms 96:11 (#1)

יִשְׂמְח֣וּ הַשָּׁמַ֣יִם וְתָגֵ֣ל הָאָ֑רֶץ יִרְעַ֖ם הַיָּ֣ם

“Let the heavens be glad, and let the earth rejoice; let the sea roar”

Here the psalmist is calling on the heavens, earth, and sea to respond with praise to Yahweh. This is the author’s way of expressing that all of creation should respond to Yahweh with joy and praise. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team on how you could express this with statements about what creation should do, as modeled in the UST.

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 96:11 (#2)

וּמְלֹאֽוֹ

“and its fullness”

By **its fullness**, the psalmist means all of the creatures that fill the sea. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and all of the creatures that fill it]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 96:11 (#3)

יִשְׂמְח֣וּ הַשָּׁמַ֣יִם וְתָגֵ֣ל הָאָ֑רֶץ

“Let the heavens be glad, and let the earth rejoice”

This could mean: (1) **the heavens** and **the earth** represent those who dwell in those places. Alternate translation: [Let those who live in the heavens be glad and let those who live on the earth rejoice] or (2) the heavens and the earth are spoken of as if they had emotions like people have. Alternate translation: [The heavens should be glad and the earth should rejoice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:12 (#1)

יַעֲלֹ֣ז שָׂדַ֣י וְכָל־אֲשֶׁר־בּ֑וֹ אָ֥ז יְרַנְּנ֖וּ כָּל־עֲצֵי־יָֽעַר

“Let the fields rejoice and all that is in them. Then let all the trees in the forest shout for joy”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **fields** and **trees** as if they were living things that could **rejoice** and **shout for joy**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let it be as though the fields and all that is in them are celebrating. Then let it be as though all the trees in the forest are shouting happily]

See: Personification

Psalms 96:13 (#1)

לִפְנֵ֣י

“to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in front of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:13 (#2)

כִּ֤י בָ֣א כִֽי־בָ֣א

“for he is coming, for he is coming”

These two phrases **for he is coming** and **for he is coming** are the same. The words are repeated to emphasize their meaning. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [for it is sure that he is coming]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 96:13 (#3)

הָאָ֑רֶץ

“the earth”

Here, **the earth** represents the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:13 (#4)

תֵּבֵ֣ל

“the world”

Here, **the world** represents everyone who lives in the world. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everyone in the world]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 96:13 (#5)

בְּצֶדֶק

“with righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:13 (#6)

בֶּאֱמוּנָתוֹ

“with his faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [faithfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 96:13 (#7)

הָאָרֶץ & תֵּבֵל

“the earth & the world”

The terms **the earth** and **the world** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [everyone ... everyone]

See: Doublet

Psalms 96:13 (#8)

וְעַמִּים בֶּאֱמוּנָתוֹ

“and the peoples with his faithfulness”

The writer is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he will judge the peoples with his faithfulness]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms - Chapter 97 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 97 is one of six “worship psalms” (Psalms 95–100).

1. Yahweh reigns in power and glory (1–6)
2. Idols are exposed as worthless (7–9)
3. The righteous are called to love and rejoice in Yahweh (10–12)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s authority

All people who worship idols are disgraced because Yahweh rules over all the world.

Psalms 97:1 (#1)

הָאָרֶץ

“let the earth”

Here, **the earth** represents the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [let the people on the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:1 (#2)

אִיִּים רַבִּים

“let the many coastlands”

Here, **coastlands** represents the people who live on the coastlands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [let the people on the many coastlands]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:2 (#1)

עָנָן וַאֲרָפֶל

“Clouds and darkness”

The phrase **Clouds and darkness** expresses a single idea. The word **darkness** tells more about **clouds**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [Dark clouds]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 97:2 (#2)

צֶדֶק וּמִשְׁפָּט

“Righteousness and justice {are”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **Righteousness** and **justice**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Ruling righteously and justly is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 97:2 (#3)

מְכוֹן כִּסְאוֹ

“the foundation of his throne”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the way in which Yahweh rules were actually **the foundation of his throne**. The psalmist means that righteousness and justice are the basis on which God rules. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the very basis of his reign]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:2 (#4)

כִּסְאוֹ

“of his throne”

Here, **throne** represents God’s rule as king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of his rule as king]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:3 (#1)

לְפָנָיו

“to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents being in front of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:4 (#1)

רָאֲתָה & הָאָרֶץ

“the earth sees”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the earth sees the lightning]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 97:4 (#2)

רָאֲתָה וַתָּחֶל הָאָרֶץ

“the earth sees and trembles”

Here, **the earth** represents the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the earth see and tremble]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:4 (#3)

וַתָּחֶל

“and trembles”

The implication is that the earth trembles with fear when it sees God’s lightning. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and trembles with fear]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 97:5 (#1)

כַּדּוֹנַג נָמַסּוּ

“melt like wax”

The point of this comparison is that just as **wax** melts easily when heated, so the **mountains** will easily crumble before Yahweh’s power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [crumble as easily as wax melts]

See: Simile

Psalms 97:5 (#2)

מִלִּפְנֵי

“from to the face of”

Here, **from to the face of** represents the mountains reacting to being in the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before the presence of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:5 (#3)

מִלִּפְנֵי יְהוָה מִמִּלִפְנֵי אֲדוֹן כָּל־הָאָרֶץ

“from to the face of Yahweh, from to the face of the Lord of all the earth”

These two phrases **from to the face of Yahweh** and **from to the face of the Lord of all the earth** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [from the presence of Yahweh, the Lord of all the earth]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 97:6 (#1)

הִגִּ֣ידוּ הַשָּׁמַ֣יִם צִדְקֹ֑ו

“The heavens declare his righteousness”

The psalmist is speaking of **the heavens** as if they were a living thing that could **declare** Yahweh’s righteousness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The heavens display his righteousness so clearly, it is as though they declare it]

See: Personification

Psalms 97:6 (#2)

צִדְקֹ֑ו

“his righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he is righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 97:6 (#3)

כְּבֹודֹ֑ו

“his glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he is glorious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 97:7 (#1)

הַמִּתְהַלְלִ֣ים בָּאֱלִילִ֑ים

“those boasting in worthless idols”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [let those boasting in worthless idols feel shame]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 97:7 (#2)

הִשְׁתַּחֲוּ֖וּ־לֹֽו׃

“bow down to him”

The pronoun **him** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [bow down to Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 97:7 (#3)

הִשְׁתַּחֲוּ֖וּ־לֹֽו׃

“bow down to him”

To **bow down to him** was a symbolic action by which people showed worship and submission to a deity. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [bow down in worship to him]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 97:7 (#4)

הִשְׁתַּחֲוּ־לֹ֥ו כָל־אֱלֹהִֽים׃

“bow down to him, all you gods”

The psalmist has been addressing his audience, but now he briefly addresses **all you gods**, even though he knows that these gods cannot hear him. He does this in order to express more powerfully his feelings about Yahweh’s supremacy over all other so-called gods. If it would be helpful in your language, you could introduce this more clearly and put the rest of this address in quote marks. Alternate translation: [I would tell those worthless idols to bow down to him]

See: Aside

Psalms 97:8 (#1)

שָׁמְעָ֣ה וַתִּשְׂמַ֣ח ׀ צִיּ֑וֹן

“Zion heard and was glad”

Here, **Zion** represents the people who live in Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The people living in Zion heard and were glad]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:8 (#2)

שָׁמְעָה & צִיּוֹן

“Zion heard”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Zion heard Yahweh’s judgments]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 97:8 (#3)

וַתִּשְׂמַח

“and was glad”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and was glad to hear them]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 97:8 (#4)

בְּנוֹת יְהוּדָה

“and the daughters of Judah”

The psalmist is speaking as if the towns and cities throughout the territory of Judah were actually **daughters of Judah**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the people in the smaller towns in Judah]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:8 (#5)

מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ

“your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the righteous way that you judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 97:9 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

For introduces not a reason but an explanation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a word or phrase that makes this relationship clearer. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 97:9 (#2)

עֶלְיוֹן עַל

“are most high above”

The psalmist is speaking here as if Yahweh were actually **most high above** all the earth in a physical, spatial sense. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are completely in charge of]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:9 (#3)

מְאֹד נַעֲלֵיתָ עַל

“You are exalted far above”

The psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh were actually **exalted** in a physical, spatial sense high above all other things. The psalmist means that Yahweh has supreme authority and power over all creation. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have much more authority than]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:9 (#4)

כָּל־אֱלֹהִים

“all gods”

The term “god,” when applied to a being other than Yahweh, can refer to an idol, but, as here, it can also refer to any lesser spirit being. Alternate translation: [every other being]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 97:10 (#1)

רָעַ

“evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all that is evil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 97:10 (#2)

חֲסִידָ֑יו

“of his faithful”

The psalmist is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [of everyone loyal to him]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 97:10 (#3)

מִיַּ֥ד

“from the hand of”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 97:10 (#4)

רְׁשָׁעִֽים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [bad people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 97:10 (#5)

יַצִּילֵֽם

“he snatches them”

The psalmist is speaking here as if Yahweh actually **snatches** his faithful ones from danger. The image is of someone quickly grabbing something to pull it away from harm. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he saves them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:11 (#1)

אֹ֣ור זָרֻ֣עַ

“Light is sown”

The psalmist is speaking as if **light** were actually seeds that could be sown in the ground. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [He scatters light like seeds]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:11 (#2)

אֹ֣ור זָרֻ֣עַ

“Light is sown”

The psalmist is speaking here of good and beneficial things as if they were **light**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He gives good things]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:11 (#3)

אֹ֣ור זָרֻ֣עַ

“Light is sown”

The expression **Light is sown** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh sows light]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 97:11 (#4)

לַצַּדִּ֑יק

“for the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [for those who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 97:11 (#5)

וְלִישָׁרֵ֖י־לֵ֣ב שִׂמְחָֽה

“and for the upright of heart, gladness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **gladness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and he makes glad the upright of heart]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 97:11 (#6)

וְלִישָׁרֵי־לֵֽב

“and for the upright of heart”

The psalmist is using **upright of heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “sincere in their inner beings” or “honest in their intentions.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and for those who are sincere in their inner beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 97:11 (#7)

שִׂמְחָה

“gladness”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [gladness is sown]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 97:12 (#1)

בַּֽיהוָ֑ה

“in Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking as if being glad were actually something that could happen at a location, **in Yahweh**. He means that the righteous should be glad because of Yahweh or should find their gladness in their relationship with Yahweh. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 97:12 (#2)

צַדִּיקִ֗ים

“you righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [you who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 97:12 (#3)

לְזֵ֣כֶר קָדְשֽׁוֹ

“to the remembrance of his holiness”

The psalmist is using **to the remembrance of his holiness** as a common expression of his culture to mean “to his holy name” or “to him, whose reputation is holiness.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to his holy name] or [to him, whose reputation is holiness]

See: Idiom

Psalms - Chapter 98 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 98 is one of six “worship psalms” (Psalms 95–100).

1. Sing a new song for Yahweh’s saving work (1–3)
2. Shout and rejoice in worship (4–6)
3. All creation celebrates Yahweh’s righteous rule (7–9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Praise

Everyone and every thing should sing praises to Yahweh because he is worthy of all praise.

Psalms 98:1 (#1)

יְמִינ֣וֹ וּזְרֹ֣עַ קָדְשֽׁוֹ

“his right hand and the arm of his holiness”

Here, **his right hand and the arm of his holiness** represents God’s great power. The psalmist is using body parts to refer to God’s strength and ability to act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his great and holy power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:1 (#2)

וּזְרֹ֣עַ קָדְשֽׁוֹ

“and the arm of his holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and his holy arm]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:1 (#3)

הוֹשִׁיעָה־לּוֹ

“have brought him salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Make sure that your translation communicates that Yahweh is the one who saves his people; he is not the one who is saved. Alternate translation: [have saved his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:1 (#4)

שִׁ֭ירוּ

“Sing”

The word **Sing**, along with all of the command forms in this psalm, is plural here, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 98:2 (#1)

יְשׁוּעָתֹ֑ו

“his salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to everyone that he saves people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:2 (#2)

לְעֵינֵ֖י הַגּוֹיִֽם

“to the eyes of the nations”

Here, **eyes** represents the sight or observation of people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in full view of the nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:2 (#3)

הַגּוֹיִֽם

“the nations”

Here, **the nations** represents the people of all the nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of all the nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:2 (#4)

צִדְקָתֹֽו

“his righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he is righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:3 (#1)

זָ֭כַר

“He remembers”

By **He remembers**, the psalmist does not mean that God could forget something, since God cannot forget anything. He means that God consistently knows and acts according to his covenant loyalty and faithfulness. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He bears in mind]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 98:3 (#2)

חַסְדּ֣וֹ ׀ וֶ֭אֱמוּנָתֹו

“his covenant loyalty and his faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant loyalty** and **faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [that he has committed to love and to be faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:3 (#3)

לְבֵ֣ית יִשְׂרָ֑אֵל

“to the house of Israel”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [to the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 98:3 (#4)

אַפְסֵי־אָ֝רֶץ

“the ends of the earth”

The psalmist is referring to all of the earth by naming the extremes, **the ends of the earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [people all over the earth]

See: Merism

Psalms 98:3 (#5)

אֵ֣ת יְשׁוּעַ֣ת אֱלֹהֵ֑ינוּ

“the salvation of our God”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Make sure that your translation communicates that Yahweh is the one who saves his people; he is not the one who is saved. Alternate translation: [how our God saves people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:3 (#6)

אֱלֹהֵ֑ינוּ

“of our God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the God whom the people worship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [from the God whom we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 98:4 (#1)

כָּל־הָאָ֣רֶץ

“all the earth”

Here, **all the earth** represents all the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all people on the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:4 (#2)

פִּצְח֖וּ

“burst into song”

By **burst into song**, the psalmist means that people should suddenly begin singing with great emotion. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [express your joy by singing]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 98:4 (#3)

וְרַנְּנ֣וּ

“sing for joy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [sing joyfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:5 (#1)

בְּכִנּ֗וֹר

“with the harp”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **harp**. He means harps in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [with harps]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 98:5 (#2)

בְּכִנּ֗וֹר בְּכִנּ֥וֹר

“with the harp, with the harp”

The psalmist repeats the phrase **with the harp** to emphasize its meaning. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [with the harp, yes, with the harp]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 98:5 (#3)

וְקֹ֣ול זִמְרָֽה

“and the voice of a song”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe singing that is characterized by being vocal rather than instrumental. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and with people singing]

See: Possession

Psalms 98:6 (#1)

לִפְנֵ֣י

“to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in front of the King, Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:6 (#2)

הָרִ֣יעוּ

“shout”

Here, **shout** refers to joyfully cheering in front of Yahweh. Be sure that your translation does not communicate that this is angry shouting. Alternate translation: [raise a cheer]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 98:7 (#1)

וּמְלֹאֹ֑ו

“and its fulness”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and let its fullness roar]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 98:7 (#2)

וּמְלֹאֹ֑ו

“and its fulness”

By **its fullness**, the psalmist means all the creatures that live in the sea. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and everything that fills it]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 98:7 (#3)

תֵּ֖בֵל וְיֹ֣שְׁבֵי בָֽהּ

“the world and the dwellers in it”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [let the world and the dwellers in it roar]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 98:7 (#4)

תֵּ֖בֵל

“the world”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **the world** as if it were a living thing that could shout. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let it be as though the world were shouting]

See: Personification

Psalms 98:8 (#1)

נְהָרוֹת֙ יִמְחֲא֣וּ־כָ֔ף

“Let the rivers clap palm”

The psalmist is speaking of **rivers** as if they were living beings that could **clap palm**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let it be as though the rivers clap palm]

See: Personification

Psalms 98:8 (#2)

נְהָרוֹת֙ יִמְחֲא֣וּ־כָ֔ף

“Let the rivers clap palm”

The psalmist is using **clap palm** as a common expression of his culture to mean “clap their hands.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let the rivers clap their hands]

See: Idiom

Psalms 98:8 (#3)

יַ֥חַד הָרִ֖ים יְרַנֵּֽנוּ

“let the mountains rejoice together”

The psalmist is speaking of **the mountains** as if they were living things that could **rejoice**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let it be as though the mountains rejoice together]

See: Personification

Psalms 98:9 (#1)

לִפְנֵ֣י

“to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in front of the King, Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:9 (#2)

הָאָ֑רֶץ

“the earth”

Here, **the earth** represents the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:9 (#3)

תֵּבֵ֥ל

“the world”

Here, **the world** represents the people who live in the world. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people in the world]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 98:9 (#4)

יִשְׁפֹּ֣ט־תֵּבֵ֣ל בְּצֶ֑דֶק וְ֝עַמִּ֗ים בְּמֵישָׁרִֽים

“he will judge the world with righteousness and the peoples with fairness”

These two phrases **he will judge the world with righteousness** and **the peoples with fairness** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [he will judge the world with righteousness, yes, he will judge the peoples with fairness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 98:9 (#5)

בְּצֶ֑דֶק

“with righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [righteously]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:9 (#6)

בְּמֵישָׁרִֽים

“with fairness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fairness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [equally]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 98:9 (#7)

וְ֝עַמִּ֗ים בְּמֵישָׁרִֽים

“and the peoples with fairness”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he will judge the peoples with fairness]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms - Chapter 99 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 99 is one of six “worship psalms” (Psalms 95–100).

1. Yahweh reigns over all peoples (1–3)
2. Yahweh loves justice and rules rightly (4–5)
3. Yahweh answers his faithful servants (6–9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s justice

God is just and fair. Moses, Aaron and Samuel each prayed to him and obeyed him, and he answered their prayers. (See: just, justice, unjust, injustice, justify, justification)

Psalms 99:1 (#1)

יְהוָ֣ה מָ֭לָךְ יִרְגְּזוּ֣ עַמִּ֑ים יֹשֵׁ֥ב כְּ֝רוּבִ֗ים תָּנ֣וּט הָאָֽרֶץ

“Yahweh reigns—let the peoples tremble— sitting {above} the cherubim; let the earth quake”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could move the phrase **let the peoples tremble** so that it does not interrupt the larger sentence. Alternate translation:

[Yahweh reigns, sitting above the cherubim; let the peoples tremble and let the earth quake]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 99:1 (#2)

יֹשֵׁ֣ב כְּ֭רוּבִים

“sitting {above} the cherubim”

If it would be helpful, you could explain in the text or a footnote that Yahweh is pictured here as sitting above the cherubim that are on the lid of the ark of the covenant, which is in his temple in Jerusalem. The biblical writers often spoke of the ark of the covenant as if it were Yahweh’s footstool upon which he rested his feet as he sat on his throne in heaven above. Alternate translation: [he sits on his throne above the cherubim on the ark of the covenant]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 99:2 (#1)

גָּד֣וֹל

“is} great”

By **is great**, the psalmist means that Yahweh is powerful and mighty as a ruler. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [is a powerful ruler]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 99:2 (#2)

וְרָ֖ם הֽוּא עַל

“and he is high above”

The psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh were actually **high above** all the peoples in a physical sense. He means that Yahweh powerfully rules over all the peoples. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he powerfully rules over]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 99:3 (#1)

שִׁ֭שַׁמְּךָ גָּד֣וֹל וְנוֹרָ֑א

“your great and fearsome name”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you, who are great and fearsome]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 99:3 (#2)

שִׁ֭שַׁמְּךָ גָּד֣וֹל וְנוֹרָ֑א

“your great and fearsome name”

In this psalm, the psalmist switches between talking about Yahweh in the third person and addressing him in second person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this verse in the third person. Alternate translation: [his great and fearsome name]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 99:4 (#1)

וְעֹ֣ז מֶ֭לֶךְ

“And the strength of the king”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the king is strong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 99:4 (#2)

מִשְׁפָּ֣ט אָ֭הֵב

“he loves justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he loves doing what is just]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 99:4 (#3)

אַ֣תָּה כוֹנַ֣נְתָּ מֵישָׁרִ֑ים

“You, you have established fairness”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have established** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one who has established fairness. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you are the one who has established fairness]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 99:4 (#4)

כּוֹנַנְתָּ מֵישָׁרִים

“you have established fairness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fairness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you have given us laws that are fair]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 99:4 (#5)

מִשְׁפָּט וּצְדָקָה & אַתָּה עָשִׂיתָ

“you, you have done justice and righteousness”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have done** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one who has done justice and righteousness. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you are the one who has done justice and righteousness]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 99:4 (#6)

מִשְׁפָּט וּצְדָקָה בְּיַעֲקֹב & עָשִׂיתָ

“you have done justice and righteousness in Jacob”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **justice** and **righteousness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [everything that you have done for Jacob is just and right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 99:4 (#7)

בְּיַעֲקֹב

“in Jacob”

By **in Jacob**, the psalmist means in the land of Israel. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the land of Israel]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 99:5 (#1)

רוֹמְמוּ & וְהִשְׁתַּחֲווּ

“Exalt & and worship”

The command forms in this verse and verse 9 are plural, so use that form if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 99:5 (#2)

וְהִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לַהֲדֹם רַגְלָיו

“and worship at the stool for his feet”

If it would be helpful, you could explain in the text or a footnote that the psalmist is continuing to picture Yahweh as sitting above the ark of the covenant, which is in his temple in Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [and worship Yahweh before his throne in the temple]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 99:6 (#1)

בְּקֹרְאֵי שְׁמוֹ

“was} among those calling his name”

Here, **calling his name** represents praying to God or calling out to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [was among those calling out to him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 99:6 (#2)

וְהוּא יַעֲנֵם

“and he, he answered them”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **answered** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh himself responded to Moses, Aaron, and Samuel. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and he himself answered them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 99:6 (#3)

יַעֲנֵם

“he answered them”

By **he answered them**, the psalmist means that God helped Moses, Aaron, and Samuel when they called out to him for assistance. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he helped them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 99:7 (#1)

יְדַבֵּ֣ר אֲלֵיהֶ֑ם

“he spoke to them”

The pronoun **them** refers to Moses and Aaron mentioned in the previous verse, since they were the ones whom Yahweh spoke to out of the cloud. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [he spoke to Moses and Aaron]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 99:7 (#2)

שָׁמְר֥וּ

“They kept”

The pronoun **They** probably includes Samuel here, along with Moses and Aaron, since Yahweh also spoke directly to him and he obeyed. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Moses, Aaron, and Samuel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 99:8 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵ֖ינוּ

“our God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the God whom the people worship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the God whom we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 99:8 (#2)

אַתָּ֣ה עָנִ֔יתָם

“you, you answered them”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you answered** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that God himself personally answered them. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you answered them yourself]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 99:8 (#3)

עָנִ֔יתָם

“you answered them”

The pronoun **them** refers to Moses, Aaron, and Samuel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [you answered Moses, Aaron, and Samuel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 99:8 (#4)

עָנִ֔יתָם

“you answered them”

The implication is that God answered Moses, Aaron, and Samuel by helping them when they called out to him in times of need. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you helped them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 99:8 (#5)

עֲלִילוֹתָֽם

“their deeds”

Here the psalmist assumes that readers will know that **their deeds** refers to sinful or wrongful actions. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [their sinful deeds]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 99:9 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵ֣ינוּ

“our God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the God whom the people worship. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the God whom we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 99:9 (#2)

לְהַ֣ר קָדְשׁ֑וֹ

“at the hill of his holiness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **the hill** that is characterized by **his holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [at his holy hill]

See: Possession

Psalms 99:9 (#3)

לְהַ֣ר קָדְשׁ֑וֹ

“at the hill of his holiness”

By **the hill of his holiness**, the psalmist means the hill where God’s holy temple is located. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [at the hill where his holy temple is located]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 100 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 100 is the last of this group of six “worship psalms” (Psalms 95–100).

1. Call to joyful praise (1–2)
2. Reason for worship: Yahweh is God (3)
3. Enter with thanksgiving and praise (4)
4. Yahweh’s character is the foundation of praise (5)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s care for his creation

God made mankind and takes good care of people.

Psalms 100:1 (#1)

הָרִ֥יעוּ לַיהוָ֗ה

“Shout to Yahweh”

The command forms such as **shout** are plural in this psalm because the psalmist is calling all people to praise God, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. See how “shout” is translated in Psalms 47:1. Alternate translation: [Raise a shout to Yahweh]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 100:1 (#2)

כָּל־הָאָֽרֶץ

“all the earth”

Here, **all the earth** represents all the people who live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all people on earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 100:2 (#1)

בְּשִׂמְחָ֑ה

“with gladness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **gladness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [gladly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 100:2 (#2)

לְפָנָֽיו

“to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents being in the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [into his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 100:2 (#3)

בְּרִנָּֽה

“with rejoicing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rejoicing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [singing joyful songs]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 100:3 (#1)

דְּע֡וּ

“Know”

The word translated as **Know** is a command. If, in your language, someone would not command someone else to know something, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation to fully realize something. Alternate translation: [Let us fully realize] or [You must believe that it is true]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 100:3 (#2)

יְהוָ֣ה ה֭וּא אֱלֹהִ֑ים

“Yahweh, he {is} God”

The pronouns **Yahweh** and **he** both refer to God. The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though it could be omitted, in order to emphasize that it is Yahweh specifically who is God. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [it is Yahweh who is God]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 100:3 (#3)

הִוּא־עָשָׂנוּ

“he, he made us”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he made us** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one who made us and no one else. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [he is the one who made us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 100:3 (#4)

ולא אֲנַחְנוּ

“and not we”

Many ancient manuscripts read **and not we**. The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “and we are his.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [and we are his]

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 100:3 (#5)

ולא אֲנַחְנוּ

“and not we”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and it was not we who made ourselves]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 100:3 (#6)

וְצֹאן מַרְעִיתוֹ

“and the sheep of his pasture”

The psalmist is speaking here as if the people were actually **sheep** that belong to God. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he provides for us as though we were sheep in his pasture]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 100:4 (#1)

בְּתוֹדָה

“with thanksgiving”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thanksgiving**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as you thank him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 100:4 (#2)

בִּתְהִלָּה

“with praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as you praise him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 100:4 (#3)

שְׁמוֹ

“his name”

Here, **his name** represents who he is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 100:5 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is

a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [It is right to do this since]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 100:5 (#2)

לְעוֹלָ֗ם חַסְדּ֫וֹ

“his covenant faithfulness {is} to eternity”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **eternity**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [he is eternally faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 100:5 (#3)

לְעוֹלָ֑ם

“is} to eternity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **eternity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is everlasting]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 100:5 (#4)

אֱמוּנָתֽוֹ

“his truthfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truthfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he is trustworthy] or [he is truthful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 100:5 (#5)

וְעַד־דֹּ֣ר וָ֭דֹר אֱמוּנָתֽוֹ

“and his truthfulness until generation and generation”

The psalmist is using **generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “for all time” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and his truthfulness endures for all time]

See: Idiom

Psalms 100:5 (#6)

וְעַד־דֹּ֣ר וָ֭דֹר אֱמוּנָתֽוֹ

“and his truthfulness until generation and generation”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and his truthfulness lasts until generation and generation]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms - Chapter 101 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 101 is a psalm of David asking God’s help to live as a person should. With God’s help, David pledges to rule uprightly and to get rid of all evildoers.

1. David commits to upright life (1–2)
2. David rejects evil and deceit (3–7)
3. David promises justice and faithfulness (8)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Encouragement

David wanted to encourage all the good people in the land and restrain all the evil people. (See: evil, wicked, wickedness, unpleasant)

Psalms 101:1 (#1)

אָשִׁ֥ירָה

“I shall sing”

See the introduction to Psalms for an explanation of the word **shall**.

Psalms 101:1 (#2)

חֶ֭סֶד־וּמִשְׁפָּ֣ט

“of} covenant faithfulness and justice”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **justice**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [about how you are always fair and promised to be faithful to us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 101:2 (#1)

בְּדֶ֣רֶךְ תָּמִ֑ים

“the blameless way”

By **the blameless way**, David means the way of living that is morally perfect and without fault. You could

indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the blameless way to live]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 101:2 (#2)

מָתַי תָּבוֹא אֵלָי

“When will you come to me”

David is using the question form **When will you come to me** to emphasize the strength of his desire. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I want you to come to me!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 101:2 (#3)

אֶתְהַלֵּךְ

“I will walk”

David is speaking of how he will live his life as if it were the way in which he will **walk**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will behave]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 101:2 (#4)

בְּתֹם־לְבָבִי

“in the integrity of my heart”

The phrase **in the integrity of my heart** was a common expression meaning “with complete honesty” or “with pure motives.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [being honest with everyone] or [with a clear conscience]

See: Idiom

Psalms 101:3 (#1)

לֹא־אָשִׁית ׀ לְנֶגֶד עֵינָי דְּבַר־בְּלִיָּעַל

“I will not put a worthless thing before my eyes”

David is using **put a worthless thing before my eyes** as a common expression of his culture to mean “consider doing a worthless thing” or “focus my attention on a worthless thing.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will not consider doing a worthless thing]

See: Idiom

Psalms 101:3 (#2)

עֲשֹׂה־סֵטִים

“to do transgressions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **transgressions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [doing sinful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 101:3 (#3)

לֹא יִדְבַּק בִּי

“it will not cling to me”

David is speaking here as if wrongdoing were actually something physical that could **cling** to a person. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [doing transgressions will not be part of my behavior]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 101:3 (#4)

לֹא יִדְבַּק בִּי

“it will not cling to me”

The pronoun **it** refers to the act of doing transgressions, seen in the previous clause. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [doing transgressions will not cling to me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 101:4 (#1)

לֵבָב עִקֵּשׁ יָסוּר מִמֶּנִּי

“A perverse heart will turn away from me”

This could mean: (1) David will not allow himself to have a perverse heart. Alternate translation: [My heart will reject becoming perverse] or (2) David will not tolerate people with perverse hearts. Alternate translation: [People with perverse hearts will be far from me]

Psalms 101:4 (#2)

לֵבָב עִקֵּשׁ

“A perverse heart”

Here David is speaking as if a person’s intentions were his **heart**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Desiring to do perverse things]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 101:4 (#3)

יָסוּר מִמֶּנִּי

“will turn away from me”

Here David is speaking as if perverse intentions were actually objects that could physically **turn away** from him. He means that he will not allow himself to be influenced by perverse thoughts or intentions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will avoid] or [I will not allow myself]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 101:4 (#4)

רָ֝ע לֹ֗א אֵדָֽע

“I will not know evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will not know evil actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 101:4 (#5)

רָ֝ע לֹ֗א אֵדָֽע

“I will not know evil”

David is using **I will not know evil** as a common expression of his culture to mean “I will have nothing to do with evil.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will have nothing to do with evil] or [I will reject anything evil]

See: Idiom

Psalms 101:5 (#1)

מלושני & רֵעֵ֥הוּ

“The one slandering his neighbor”

David is not referring to a specific person **slandering** a specific **neighbor**. He means people who slander neighbors in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Whoever slanders his neighbor]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 101:5 (#2)

גְּבַהּ־עֵ֭ינַיִם וּרְחַ֣ב לֵ֑בָב

“The {one} lofty of eyes and the {one} wide of heart”

The terms **lofty of eyes** and **wide of heart** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Any prideful person]

See: Doublet

Psalms 101:5 (#3)

גְּבַהּ־עֵ֭ינַיִם

“The {one} lofty of eyes”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **one lofty of eyes**. He means people with lofty eyes in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Whoever is lofty of eyes]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 101:5 (#4)

גְּבַהּ־עֵ֭ינַיִם

“The {one} lofty of eyes”

David is using **lofty of eyes** as a common expression of his culture to mean “haughty” or “arrogant.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Any haughty person]

See: Idiom

Psalms 101:5 (#5)

וּרְחַ֣ב לֵ֑בָב

“and the {one} wide of heart”

David is not referring to a specific **one wide of heart**. He means all people with this characteristic. If it

would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and whoever is wide of heart]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 101:5 (#6)

וּרְחַב לֵבָב

“and the {one} wide of heart”

David is using **wide of heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “proud” or “arrogant.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and any proud person]

See: Idiom

Psalms 101:5 (#7)

אֹתוֹ לֹא אוּכָל

“him I cannot”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. The full meaning is **him I cannot** tolerate or stand. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [him I cannot stand] or [him I cannot tolerate]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 101:6 (#1)

עֵינַי ׀ בְּנֶאֱמְנֵי

“My eyes {are} on the faithful {ones} of”

Here, **My eyes are on** represents David’s attention or focus. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am seeking the faithful ones of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 101:6 (#2)

לָשֶׁבֶת עִמָּדִי

“to sit with me”

The implication is that these faithful people will **sit with** David as advisors or officials in positions of authority. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to rule under my authority]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 101:6 (#3)

הֹלֵךְ בְּדֶרֶךְ תָּמִים

“The {one} walking in the way of integrity”

Here David is speaking of living with integrity as if integrity were a path for his **walking**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [The one living with integrity]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 101:6 (#4)

הֹלֵךְ

“The {one} walking”

David is not referring to a specific **one walking**. He means anyone walking in the way of integrity in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Anyone walking]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 101:7 (#1)

לֹא־יֵשֵׁב ׀ בְּקֶרֶב בֵּיתִי עֹשֵׂה רְמִיָּה דֹּבֵר שְׁקָרִים לֹא־יִכּוֹן לְנֶגֶד עֵינָי

“A doer of deceit will not remain within my house; a speaker of lies will not be established before my eyes”

These two phrases **A doer of deceit will not remain within my house** and **a speaker of lies will not be established before my eyes** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [A doer of deceit will not remain within my house, no, a speaker of lies will not be established before my eyes]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 101:7 (#2)

עֹשֵׂה רְמִיָּה

“A doer of deceit”

David is not referring to a specific **doer of deceit**. He means deceitful people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Any doer of deceit]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 101:7 (#3)

דֹּבֵ֣ר שְׁקָרִ֑ים

“a speaker of lies”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **speaker of lies**. He means speakers of lies in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [any speaker of lies]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 101:7 (#4)

בְּקֶ֥רֶב בֵּיתִ֗י

“within my house”

The implication is that David is referring to his royal court or household staff, not just the physical building. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [as a member of my staff]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 101:7 (#5)

לֹא־יִ֝כּ֗וֹן

“will not be established”

The expression **will not be established** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I will not tolerate]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 101:7 (#6)

לְנֶ֥גֶד עֵינָֽי

“before my eyes”

Here, **before my eyes** represents “in my presence” or “under my supervision.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in my presence] or [under my supervision]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 101:8 (#1)

לַבְּקָרִ֗ים

“In the mornings”

By **In the mornings**, the psalmist means that he will consistently and regularly destroy the wicked, day after day. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Morning by morning] or [Each morning]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 101:8 (#2)

רִשְׁעֵי

“the wicked of”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked of]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 101:8 (#3)

לְהַכְרִ֥ית

“to cut off”

The psalmist is using **cut off** as a common expression of the culture to mean “remove.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to remove]

See: Idiom

Psalms 101:8 (#4)

כֹּ֖ל פֹּ֣עֲלֵי אָ֑וֶן

“workers of evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [evildoers] or [people who do evil things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 101:8 (#5)

מֵעִ֥יר־יְהוָֽה

“from the city of Yahweh”

The implication is that this **city** is Jerusalem, where God dwells with his people. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from this city, which is Yahweh's city]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 102 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 102 is a "lament."

1. Cry of distress and plea for mercy (1–11)
2. Confidence in Yahweh's eternal purposes and mercy (12–17)
3. Call to record and remember Yahweh's mercies (18–22)
4. Yahweh sustains and remains unchanging (23–28)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Salvation

The psalmist does not want to die young. He also wants to see Jerusalem saved. (See: save, saved, safe, salvation, rescue)

Psalms 102:1 (#1)

יְהוָה שִׁמְעָה תְפִלָּתִי וְשַׁוְעָתִי אֵלֶיךָ תָּבוֹא

"Hear my prayer, Yahweh; let my cry come unto you"

These two phrases **Hear my prayer, Yahweh** and **let my cry come unto you** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Hear my prayer, Yahweh, as I cry out to you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 102:1 (#2)

שִׁמְעָה תְפִלָּתִי

"Hear my prayer"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hear my prayer]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 102:1 (#3)

וְשַׁוְעָתִי אֵלֶיךָ תָּבוֹא

"let my cry come unto you"

The psalmist is speaking of **my cry** as if it were a living thing that could come to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [pay attention to what I cry to you]

See: Personification

Psalms 102:2 (#1)

אַל־תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ ׀ מִמֶּנִּי

"Do not hide your face from me"

The psalmist is using **hide your face from me** as a common expression of his culture to mean "ignore me" or "reject me." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not turn your back on me] or [Do not reject me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 102:2 (#2)

צַר לִי

"it distresses me"

Here the pronoun **it** could refer to: (1) any distressing thing in general. Alternate translation: [when things distress me] or (2) "the day" mentioned just before it. Alternate translation: [that distresses me]

See: Reflexive Pronouns

Psalms 102:2 (#3)

בְּיוֹם & בְּיוֹם

"on the day & On the day"

The phrase **on the day** appears twice in this verse with slightly different meanings. The first occurrence refers to any time when distressing things happen, while the second occurrence refers to the specific moment when the psalmist calls out to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use different expressions to distinguish between these general and specific time references, such as "when" for the first occurrence and "as soon as" or "the moment" for the second. Alternate translation: [when ... At the time]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:2 (#4)

הַטֵּה־אֵלַי אָזְנֶךָ

“Incline your ear to me”

The psalmist is using **Incline your ear to me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “pay attention to me” or “listen carefully to me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Pay attention to me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 102:3 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Do this because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 102:3 (#2)

כָּלּוּ בֶעָשָׁן יָמָי

“my days expire like smoke”

Here, **my days** refers to the author’s life, and the idea of **smoke** is something that quickly disappears. Alternate translation: [my life passes away quickly]

See: Simile

Psalms 102:3 (#3)

וְעַצְמוֹתַי כְּמוֹ־קֶרַח נָחָרוּ

“and my bones are charred like a fireplace”

The psalmist is speaking as if his bones were actually **charred like a fireplace**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and my bones feel like they are charred like a fireplace]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:3 (#4)

וְעַצְמוֹתַי כְּמוֹ־קֶרַח נָחָרוּ

“and my bones are charred like a fireplace”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a fireplace** becomes blackened and charred from repeated burning of fires in it, so the psalmist’s **bones** feel burned and damaged from his suffering. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and my bones are charred like a fireplace that has had many fires in it]

See: Simile

Psalms 102:3 (#5)

וְעַצְמוֹתַי כְּמוֹ־קֶרַח נָחָרוּ

“and my bones are charred like a fireplace”

The expression **are charred** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and it feels like fire has charred my bones as it chars a fireplace]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 102:4 (#1)

הוּכָּה־כָעֵשֶׂב וַיִּבַשׁ לִבִּי

“My heart is struck like grass and withered”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **heart**, to mean all of himself in the act of withering away. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am struck like grass and withered]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 102:4 (#2)

הוּכָּה־כָעֵשֶׂב וַיִּבַשׁ לִבִּי

“My heart is struck like grass and withered”

The psalmist is speaking here as if his heart were actually **grass** that has been **struck** and **withered**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [I feel as though my heart has been struck like grass and withered]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:4 (#3)

הוּכָּה־כָעֵשֶׂב וַיִּבַשׁ לִבִּי

“My heart is struck like grass and withered”

Here the psalmist is making a comparison between his heart and grass to show how he feels. The point of this

comparison is that just as **grass** becomes **withered** when it is struck down, so the psalmist's **heart** has become weak and almost lifeless. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [My heart feels as dead as grass that has been struck down and dried out]

See: Simile

Psalms 102:4 (#4)

הוּכָּה־כָעֵשֶׂב וַיִּבַשׁ לִבִּי

"My heart is struck like grass and withered"

The expression **My heart is struck like grass and withered** uses passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [My heart feels as dead as grass that the sun has killed and dried]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 102:4 (#5)

כִּי

"for"

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [indeed,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 102:4 (#6)

לַחְמִי

"my bread"

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a meal]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 102:5 (#1)

מִקּוֹל אַנְחָתִי

"From the voice of my groaning"

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **voice** that is characterized by **groaning**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [From my loud groans]

See: Possession

Psalms 102:5 (#2)

דָּבְקָה עַצְמִי

"my bone clings"

The psalmist is using the singular **bone** to refer to all of his bones in the act of becoming extremely thin from distress. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my bones cling]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 102:6 (#1)

דָּמִיתִי לְקָאַת מִדְבָּר הָיָיתִי כְּכוֹס חֳרָבוֹת

"I am like an owl of the wilderness; I have become like a screech owl in the ruins"

The psalmist is using two comparisons to describe his lonely and desolate condition. The point of those two comparisons is that just as **an owl of the wilderness** and **a screech owl in the ruins** are solitary creatures in desolate places, so is the psalmist in his distress. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I have become as solitary and lonely as an owl of the wilderness or as a screech owl in the ruins]

See: Simile

Psalms 102:6 (#2)

לְקָאַת מִדְבָּר

"an owl of the wilderness"

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **an owl** that is characterized by **the wilderness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [an owl that lives in the wilderness]

See: Possession

Psalms 102:6 (#3)

לְקָאַת

"an owl"

The word translated as "owl" here is obscure. Most scholars believe that the word refers to a type of owl. The ancient Greek translation used the word for "pelican" here, and that was followed by some older versions, although a pelican is a water bird that cannot live in a dry wilderness. If "pelican" is correct, then

the psalmist is saying that he feels as though he is living in a place where he cannot survive. If "owl" is correct, then the psalmist is saying that he feels alone and abandoned. You may want to use the word that the major translation in your area uses.

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 102:7 (#1)

שָׁקַ֗דְתִּי

"I am alert"

This could mean: (1) The psalmist is awake when he would like to be sleeping. Alternate translation: [I am unable to sleep] or (2) The psalmist is watching for Yahweh to answer him. Alternate translation: [I am watching]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:7 (#2)

וָאֱהִ֥יֶה כְּצִפּ֗וֹר בּ֣וֹדֵ֑ד

"and I have become like a bird alone"

The point of this comparison is that just as **a bird alone** is solitary and isolated, so is the psalmist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I have become as solitary as a bird alone]

See: Simile

Psalms 102:8 (#1)

בִּ֭בְיִ נִשְׁבָּ֣עוּ

"swear by me"

By **swear by me**, the psalmist means that his enemies use his name as a curse, saying something like "May you become as miserable as he is." You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [refer to me when they curse people]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:9 (#1)

כִּי־אֵ֭פֶר כַּלֶּ֣חֶם

"As ashes as bread"

The psalmist is speaking as if eating his **bread** were the same as eating **ashes**. He means that his food has no taste or appeal because of his deep sorrow and distress. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Bread and ashes taste the same to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:9 (#2)

כִּי־אֵ֭פֶר כַּלֶּ֣חֶם

"As ashes as bread"

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My food is as ashes]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 102:9 (#3)

בִּבְכִ֑י

"with weeping"

Here, **weeping** represents tears. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with my tears]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:9 (#4)

וְ֝שִׁקֻּוַ֗י & מָסָ֥כְתִּי

"and I mix my drink"

The implication is that the psalmist's drink is mixed with his tears because he is weeping. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and my drink becomes mixed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:10 (#1)

מִפְּנֵ֣י זַ֭עַמְךָ וְקִצְפֶּ֑ךָ כִּ֥י נְ֝שָׂאתַ֗נִי וַתַּשְׁלִיכֵֽנִי

"from the face of your fury and rage, for you have lifted me up and thrown me"

If it is more natural in your language to state the reason before the result, you could do so by moving this sentence to the previous verse. You would then present the combined verses as 102:9–10. Alternate translation: [because of your fury and rage, for you have lifted me up and thrown me, I eat ashes like bread and mix my drink with weeping]

See: Verse Bridges

Psalms 102:10 (#2)

מִפְּנֵי

“from the face of”

The psalmist is using **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of” or “on account of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of]

See: Idiom

Psalms 102:10 (#3)

זַעַמְךָ וְקִצְפֶּךָ

“your fury and rage”

The phrase **fury and rage** expresses a single idea. The word **fury** tells more about the **rage**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [your furious rage]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 102:10 (#4)

כִּי

“for”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [you see,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 102:10 (#5)

נְשָׂאתַנִי וַתַּשְׁלִיכֵנִי

“you have lifted me up and thrown me”

The psalmist is speaking as if God had literally **lifted** him **up** and **thrown** him away like an object. He means that he feels as though God has rejected and abandoned him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I feel like you have lifted me up and thrown me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:11 (#1)

יָמַי

“My days {are”

By **My days are** the psalmist means his remaining time to live. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [My remaining life is]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:11 (#2)

יָמַי כְּצֵל נָטוּי

“My days {are} like a lengthening shadow”

The psalmist is making a comparison. The point of this comparison is that just as **a lengthening shadow** grows longer and fainter as evening approaches, and then it disappears, so **My days** are coming to an end. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [My days are ending like an evening shadow ends the day]

See: Simile

Psalms 102:11 (#3)

וַאֲנִי כָּעֵשֶׂב אִיבָשׁ

“and I, like grass, have withered”

The point of this comparison is that just as **grass** withers and dies, so the psalmist views himself as withering and dying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I am dying as grass dies under the hot sun]

See: Simile

Psalms 102:12 (#1)

לְעוֹלָם תֵּשֵׁשֵׁב

“sit forever”

By **sit forever** the psalmist means that Yahweh sits on a throne to rule as king forever. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [sit on your throne as king forever]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:12 (#2)

וְזִכְרְךָ

“and your remembrance {is”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **remembrance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and you will be well-known]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 102:12 (#3)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“to generation and generation”

The psalmist is using **to generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “throughout all generations” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [throughout all generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 102:13 (#1)

אַתָּ֤ה תָ֭קוּם

“You, you will arise”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **You** separately, even though the verb translated as **you will arise** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is God who will act to show mercy to Zion. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [It will be you who will now arise]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 102:13 (#2)

תָ֭קוּם

“you will arise”

The psalmist is using **you will arise** as a common expression of the culture to indicate that God is about to begin taking action to help his people. He does not mean that God is getting out of bed or standing up from a seated position. If this expression does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will go into action] or [you will do something]

See: Idiom

Psalms 102:13 (#3)

צִיּ֑וֹן

“Zion”

Here, **Zion** represents the people who live there. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Zion]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:13 (#4)

תְּרַחֵ֥ם

“you will have mercy on”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **mercy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you will act mercifully toward]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 102:13 (#5)

מוֹעֵֽד

“the appointed time”

The expression **the appointed time** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [the time that you have appointed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 102:14 (#1)

כִּ֤י

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 102:14 (#2)

כִּֽי־רָצ֣וּ עֲ֭בָדֶיךָ אֶת־אֲבָנֶ֑יהָ וְאֶת־עֲפָרָ֥הּ יְחֹנֵֽנוּ

“For your servants cherish her stones and favor her dust”

The psalmist says **your servants cherish her stones and favor her dust** as an extreme statement for

emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [For your servants absolutely love the city of Jerusalem]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 102:14 (#3)

כִּי־רָצוּ עֲבָדֶיךָ אֶת־אֲבָנֶיהָ וְאֶת־עֲפָרָהּ יְחֹנָנוּ

“For your servants cherish her stones and favor her dust”

The psalmist is referring to all of Jerusalem by naming two components that are opposite in size, **her stones** and **her dust**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [For your servants love all of the city]

See: Merism

Psalms 102:14 (#4)

עֲבָדֶיךָ

“your servants”

The psalmist is speaking of himself and his people in the third person as **your servants** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [we, your people,]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 102:15 (#1)

גּוֹיִם

“The nations”

Here, **The nations** represents the people of the nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The people of the nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:15 (#2)

וְיִירְאוּ

“will fear”

The word translated as **fear** includes the sense of awe and respect. Use a word that includes these ideas, if possible. Alternate translation: [will deeply respect]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:15 (#3)

אֶת־שֵׁם יְהוָה

“the name of Yahweh”

Here, **name** represents who Yahweh is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who Yahweh is]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:15 (#4)

וְכָל־מַלְכֵי הָאָרֶץ אֶת־כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“and all the kings of the earth, your glory”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and all the kings of the earth will fear your glory]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 102:15 (#5)

אֶת־כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“your glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you, because you are glorious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 102:16 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 102:16 (#2)

נִבְנָה יְהוָה בְּכְבוֹדוֹ

“he appears in his glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he is glorious as he appears]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 102:17 (#1)

פָּנָה אֶל־תְּפִלַּת הָעַרְעָר וְלֹא־בָזָה אֶת־תְּפִלָּתָם

“He turns to the prayer of the destitute and he does not despise their prayer”

These two phrases **He turns to the prayer of the destitute** and **he does not despise their prayer** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He turns to the prayer of the destitute; certainly, he does not despise their prayer]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 102:17 (#2)

פָּנָה אֶל

“He turns to”

The psalmist is speaking as if God were physically **turning** himself toward the prayers of the destitute. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If not, you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [He pays attention to]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:17 (#3)

תְּפִלַּת הָעַרְעָר

“the prayer of the destitute”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **prayer** that is characterized by **the destitute**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the destitute when he prays]

See: Possession

Psalms 102:17 (#4)

וְלֹא־בָזָה אֶת־תְּפִלָּתָם

“and he does not despise their prayer”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **despise**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [and he accepts their prayer]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 102:18 (#1)

תִּכָּתֵב זֹאת

“This will be written”

The expression **This will be written** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the psalmist. Alternate translation: [I will write this]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 102:18 (#2)

וְעַם נִבְרָא

“and a people being created”

The expression **a people being created** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [and a people whom Yahweh is still creating]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 102:18 (#3)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 102:19 (#1)

כִּי

“that”

The connecting word **that** introduces the content of the praise mentioned in the previous verse. Use a way that is natural in your language to introduce what the praise is about. Alternate translation: [They will say that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 102:19 (#2)

כִּי־הִשְׁקִיף מִמְּרוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ יְהוָה מִשָּׁמַיִם ׀ אֶל־אֶרֶץ הִבִּיט

“that he looked down from the height of his holiness; Yahweh from heaven regarded the earth”

These two phrases **that he looked down from the height of his holiness** and **Yahweh from heaven regarded the earth** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [that he looked down from the height of his holiness; yes, Yahweh from heaven regarded the earth,]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 102:19 (#3)

מִמְּרוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ

“from the height of his holiness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **height** that is characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from his holy high-place]

See: Possession

Psalms 102:19 (#4)

מִמְּרוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ

“from the height of his holiness”

The phrase **the height of his holiness** refers to heaven, where God dwells. The psalmist assumes that readers will understand that this is describing God’s holy dwelling place above the earth. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from heaven]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:19 (#5)

אֶל־אֶרֶץ

“the earth”

Here, **the earth** represents the people living on earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people living on earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:20 (#1)

לִשְׁמֹעַ & לְפַתֵּחַ

“to hear & to release”

Here, **to hear** and **to release** mark these clauses as the goal or purpose of Yahweh looking down from heaven. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that he could hear ... so that he could release]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 102:20 (#2)

לִשְׁמֹעַ

“to hear”

By **to hear**, the psalmist means to respond to and help. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to respond to] or [to relieve]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:20 (#3)

בְּנֵי תְמוּתָה

“the sons of execution”

The psalmist is using **sons of execution** as a common expression of the culture to indicate people who have a certain characteristic. In this case, these people have the characteristic of being condemned to death. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those doomed to die] or [those who would soon be executed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 102:21 (#1)

לְסַפֵּר בְּצִיּוֹן שֵׁם יְהוָה וּתְהִלָּתוֹ בִּירוּשָׁלָם

“To recount the name of Yahweh in Zion and his praise in Jerusalem”

These two phrases **to recount the name of Yahweh in Zion** and **his praise in Jerusalem** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [to extol and praise the name of Yahweh in Zion]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 102:21 (#2)

שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה

“the name of Yahweh”

Here, **the name of Yahweh** represents Yahweh’s reputation or who he is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the great things that Yahweh is known for]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:21 (#3)

וּתְהִלָּתוֹ בִּירוּשָׁלָ͏ִם

“and his praise in Jerusalem”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and to recount his praise in Jerusalem]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 102:21 (#4)

וּתְהִלָּתוֹ

“and his praise”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean praise that is given to him. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and to praise him]

See: Possession

Psalms 102:22 (#1)

עַמִּים & וּמַמְלָכוֹת

“peoples and kingdoms”

The phrase **peoples and kingdoms** expresses a single idea. The word **kingdoms** tells more about **peoples**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [peoples from many kingdoms]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 102:23 (#1)

עִנָּה & כֹּחוֹ

“He has broken my strength”

The psalmist is speaking as if his physical vitality were actually an object that God could **break**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He has weakened my body]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:23 (#2)

בַּדֶּרֶךְ

“on the road”

The psalmist is speaking of his life as if it were actually **the road** that he was traveling along. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the middle of my life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:23 (#3)

יָמָי

“my days”

Here, **days** represents the psalmist’s lifetime. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my lifetime]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:24 (#1)

אַל־תַּעֲלֵנִי

“do not take me away”

The psalmist is speaking as if God would literally **take** him somewhere. He means that God would cause him to die. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not end my life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:24 (#2)

יָמֶיךָ

“my days”

Here, **days** represents “life.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my life]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:24 (#3)

שְׁנוֹתֶיךָ

“your years {are”

The psalmist is speaking as if God’s eternal existence were actually **years**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your lifespan is]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:24 (#4)

בְּדֹר דֹּורִים

“a generation of generations”

The psalmist is using **a generation of generations** as a common expression of his culture to mean “forever” or “for all time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [forever] or [unending]

See: Idiom

Psalms 102:24 (#5)

בְּדֹר דֹּורִים

“a generation of generations”

Some translations mark the end of this verse as the place where the direct quotation ends. Other translations consider that the direct quotation continues until the end of the psalm. You may wish to follow what the major translation in your area does.

See: Quote Markings

Psalms 102:25 (#1)

הָאָרֶץ יָסַדְתָּ

“you set the earth”

The psalmist is speaking as if the earth were actually **set** in place like an object that someone positions or establishes. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you made the earth what it is]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:25 (#2)

וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדֶיךָ שָׁמָיִם

“and the heavens {are} the work of your hands”

Here, **hands** represents the power and creative ability of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the heavens are your creative work]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:26 (#1)

הֵמָּה ׀ יֹאבֵדוּ

“They, they will perish”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **They** separately, even though the verb translated as **they will perish** already contains that meaning. He is doing that for emphasis because he is contrasting the earth and heavens (which will perish) with God (who will remain). If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [As for them, they will perish]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 102:26 (#2)

הֵמָּה ׀ יֹאבֵדוּ

“They, they will perish”

The pronouns **they** and **them** in this verse refers to the earth and the heavens mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The heavens and the earth will perish]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 102:26 (#3)

וְאַתָּה תַּעֲמֹד

“but you, you will stand”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you will stand** already includes this meaning. He is doing that for emphasis because he is contrasting the permanence of God with the temporary nature of the heavens and the earth. If a speaker of your language would use explicit pronouns for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [but you, in contrast, will stand]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 102:26 (#4)

תַּתַּעֲמֹֽד

“you will stand”

The psalmist is speaking as if God would physically **stand**. This means that he will continue or endure. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will continue] or [you will exist always]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:26 (#5)

תַּחֲלִיפֵֵם וְיַחֲלֹֽפוּ

“you will pass them off, and they will pass away”

The psalmist is repeating forms of the same verb, translated here as **pass**, in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [you will completely remove them, and they will be completely gone]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 102:27 (#1)

וְאַתָּה־הוּא

“But you {are} he”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, the God who always is. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [But you are the one who is]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 102:27 (#2)

וּשְׁנוֹתֶֽיךָ

“and your years”

Here, **years** represents “existence” or “life.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and your existence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 102:28 (#1)

יִשְׁכֹּֽנוּ

“will abide”

The implication is that the descendants will be safe and secure under God’s protection. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [will dwell securely]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 102:28 (#2)

וְזַרְעָם

“and their seed”

The psalmist is speaking as if the people who will descend from God’s servants were actually their **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and their descendants] or [and their children]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 102:28 (#3)

וְזַרְעָם & יִכּֽוֹן

“and their seed will be established”

The expression **their seed will be established** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [and you will establish their seed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 102:28 (#4)

לְפָנֶֽיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **to your face** represents being in Yahweh’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 103 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 103 is the first in a series of five “psalm of praise” to God (Psalm 103–107).

1. Call to bless Yahweh with whole being (1–2)
2. Yahweh’s forgiveness, healing, and provision (3–5)
3. Yahweh’s compassionate character (6–14)

4. Yahweh's covenant faithfulness from everlasting (15–22)
5. Yahweh's sovereign rule over all (19–22)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh's grace
God shows his goodness to us by forgiving our sins and not punishing us as much as we deserve.

Psalms 103:1 (#1)

בָּרֲכִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת־יְהוָה וְכָל־קְרָבַי אֶת־שֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

"Bless Yahweh, my soul! And all of my inward parts, the name of his holiness"

The phrases **Bless Yahweh, my soul** and **all of my inward parts, the name of his holiness** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Bless Yahweh, my soul! Yes, all of my inward parts, bless the name of his holiness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 103:1 (#2)

נַפְשִׁי

"my soul"

David is using the term **soul** to mean his entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [myself] or [my inner being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:1 (#3)

אֶת־שֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

"the name of his holiness"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [bless the name of his holiness]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 103:1 (#4)

אֶת־שֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

"the name of his holiness"

David is using the term **name** to refer to Yahweh's holy person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his holy person]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:1 (#5)

וְכָל־קְרָבַי

"And all of my inward parts"

Here, **all of my inward parts** represents David's entire being from an internal perspective. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and everything that I am]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:2 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי

"my soul"

Here, **my soul** represents David's entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [myself] or [my inner being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:2 (#2)

וְאַל־תִּשְׁכְּחִי

"And do not forget"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could avoid using the double negative **do not forget** by expressing the idea in a positive form. Alternate translation: [and remember]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 103:3 (#1)

הַסֹּלֵחַ לְכָל־עֲוֹנֵכִי

"The one pardoning all your sins"

The pronoun **your** in verses 3–5 refers to "my soul" in verse 2. In this way, David is referring to himself. If "your" communicates the meaning well in your language, consider using that. Otherwise, consider using

"my" here. Use the same translation decision for these phrases through verse 5. Alternate translation: [My soul, he is the one pardoning all your sins] or [He is the one pardoning all my sins]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 103:4 (#1)

חַיֶּיכִי

"your life"

Here, **life** represents the entire person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:4 (#2)

מִשַּׁחַת

"from the pit"

Here, **the pit** represents death. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from dying]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:4 (#3)

הַמְעַטְּרֵכִי חֶסֶד וְרַחֲמִים

"the one crowning you with covenant faithfulness and mercy"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **mercy**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the one keeping his covenant to love you and be merciful to you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:4 (#4)

הַמְעַטְּרֵכִי

"the one crowning you with"

The psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a king placing a **crown** on the psalmist. He means that God is honoring and blessing him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one blessing you with] or [the one honoring you with]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 103:5 (#1)

עֶדְיֶיךָ

"your ornaments"

The phrase **your ornaments** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. It seems that the scribe mistook the word translated as **ornaments** for a similar word that means "existence." The ancient Greek translation says, "your desires." You may want to follow one of those readings. Alternate translation: [your existence] or [your desires]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 103:5 (#2)

בַּטּוֹב

"with good"

David is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean good things. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [with good things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 103:5 (#3)

תִּתְחַדֵּשׁ

"renews itself"

The word **itself** indicates that the object of the verb is the same as the subject of the verb. Use a way that is natural in your language to indicate that the same thing fills two roles in the sentence. Alternate translation: [becomes renewed]

See: Reflexive Pronouns

Psalms 103:5 (#4)

כַּנֶּשֶׁר

"like the eagle"

The point of this comparison is that just as **the eagle** is capable and strong, so **your youth** being renewed makes you feel capable and strong. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like an eagle that can go wherever it desires to go]

See: Simile

Psalms 103:6 (#1)

עֹשֵׂה צְדָקוֹת יְהוָה

“Yahweh, doing righteousness”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, he is the one doing righteousness]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 103:6 (#2)

צְדָקוֹת & וּמִשְׁפָּטִים

“righteousness and justice”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **justice**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [what is right and just]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:6 (#3)

עֲשׁוּקִים

“those being oppressed”

The expression **those being oppressed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people whom others are oppressing]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 103:7 (#1)

עֲלִילוֹתָיו

“his deeds”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he made known his deeds]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 103:8 (#1)

אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם

“long of nostrils”

The psalmist is using **long of nostrils** as a common expression of his culture to mean “patient” or “slow to become angry.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [very patient]

See: Idiom

Psalms 103:8 (#2)

וְרַב־חָסֶד

“and abundant in covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and always faithful to his covenant with us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:9 (#1)

לֹא & יָרִיב

“He will not contend”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **contend** means to contend with us, his people. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He will not contend with us]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 103:9 (#2)

לָנֶצַח

“to the end”

The implication is that God will not **contend** or remain angry for an unlimited length of time, but will eventually cease his anger. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to the end of time]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 103:9 (#3)

וְלֹא & יִטּוֹר

“and he will not maintain”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he will not maintain his anger]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 103:10 (#1)

לֹא כַחֲטָאֵינוּ עָשָׂה לָּנוּ וְלֹא כַעֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ גָּמַל עָלֵינוּ

“He does not deal with us according to our sins, and he does not treat us according to our iniquities”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way, as in the UST. Otherwise, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He does not deal with us according to our sins; let me say again, he does not treat us according to our iniquities]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 103:10 (#2)

לֹ֤א כַחֲטָאֵ֨ינוּ֙ עָ֣שָׂה לָ֔נוּ וְלֹ֥א כַעֲוֹנֹתֵ֖ינוּ גָּמַ֥ל עָלֵֽינוּ

“He does not deal with us according to our sins, and he does not treat us according to our iniquities”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that people’s sins and iniquities deserve punishment from God. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He does not give punishment to us that is as bad as our sins, and he does not treat us as badly as our iniquities deserve]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 103:11 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation of how great Yahweh’s covenant faithfulness is toward those who fear him. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [You see,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 103:11 (#2)

כִּ֤י כִגְבֹ֨הַ שָׁ֪מַיִם ׀ עַל־הָ֡אָרֶץ גָּ֤בַר חַסְדּ֗וֹ עַל־יְרֵאָֽיו

“For as the heavens are high above the earth, his covenant faithfulness is strong toward those fearing him”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the heavens** are extremely **high above the earth**, so **his covenant faithfulness** is extremely **strong toward those fearing him**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [For just as it is impossible to measure how high the heavens are above the earth, it is also impossible to measure how strong his covenant faithfulness is toward those fearing him]

See: Simile

Psalms 103:11 (#3)

גָּ֤בַר חַסְדּ֗וֹ

“his covenant faithfulness is strong”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that is how strongly committed he is to being faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:12 (#1)

כִּרְחֹ֣ק מִזְרָ֣ח מִמַּעֲרָ֑ב הִרְחִ֖יק מִמֶּ֣נּוּ אֶת־פִּשְׁעֵֽינוּ

“As far as the sunrise {is} from the sunset, he has removed our transgressions from us”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the sunrise from the sunset** is an immeasurable distance, so how far **he has removed our transgressions from us** is an immeasurable distance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Just as it is impossible to measure how far the sunrise is from the sunset, it is also impossible to measure how far he has removed our transgressions from us]

See: Simile

Psalms 103:12 (#2)

כִּרְחֹ֣ק מִזְרָ֣ח מִמַּעֲרָ֑ב הִרְחִ֖יק מִמֶּ֣נּוּ אֶת־פִּשְׁעֵֽינוּ

“As far as the sunrise {is} from the sunset, he has removed our transgressions from us”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the sentence if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [As far as the sunrise is from the sunset, that is how far he has removed our transgressions from us]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 103:13 (#1)

כְּרַחֵם אָב עַל־בָּנִים רִחַם יְהוָה עַל־יְרֵאָיו

“As a father has compassion on his children, Yahweh has compassion on those fearing him”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [As a father has compassion on his children, in the same way, Yahweh has compassion on those fearing him]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 103:13 (#2)

כְּרַחֵם אָב עַל־בָּנִים רִחַם יְהוָה עַל־יְרֵאָיו

“As a father has compassion on his children, Yahweh has compassion on those fearing him”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a father has compassion on his children** very much, so also **Yahweh has compassion on those fearing him** very much. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [As a father has constant and strong compassion on his children, so Yahweh has constant and strong compassion on those fearing him]

See: Simile

Psalms 103:13 (#3)

כְּרַחֵם אָב עַל־בָּנִים רִחַם יְהוָה עַל

“As a father has compassion on his children, Yahweh has compassion on”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [As a father loves his children, Yahweh loves]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:14 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [You see,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 103:14 (#2)

יִצְרֵנוּ

“our form”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **form** refers to the physical nature and constitution of human beings. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the weakness of our form] or [what weak stuff we are made of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 103:14 (#3)

הוּא יָדָע

“he, he knows”

The pronoun **he** in the phrase **he, he knows** refers to Yahweh. The repetition of the pronoun emphasizes that Yahweh, more than anyone else, knows the frailty of human beings. If your language has a way to express this emphasis naturally, you may want to use it in your translation. Alternate translation: [he, more than anyone, knows]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 103:15 (#1)

אֱנוֹשׁ

“A man”

David is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Any person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 103:15 (#2)

כָּחָצִיר יָמָיו

“his days {are} like grass”

Here, **days** represents a person’s lifetime. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his lifetime is like the lifetime of grass]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:15 (#3)

כָּחָצִיר יָמָיו

“his days {are} like grass”

The psalmist is making a comparison to teach that just as **grass** lives for only a short time, so people live for only a short time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [his days are few, like the length of time that grass lives]

See: Simile

Psalms 103:15 (#4)

כְּצִיץ הַשָּׂדֶה כֵּן יָצִיץ

“like a flower of the field, thus he flourishes”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a flower of the field** flourishes for only a short time, so does a person’s life last for only a short time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a flower of the field, the time when he flourishes is short]

See: Simile

Psalms 103:16 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation of how people are like grass and flowers. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Indeed,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 103:16 (#2)

בּוֹ

“over it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the flower. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the flower]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 103:16 (#3)

וְלֹא־יַכִּירֶנּוּ עוֹד מְקוֹמוֹ

“and its place does not acknowledge it again”

The psalmist is speaking of **its place** as if it were a person who could **acknowledge** something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and there is nothing in its place to indicate that it had been there]

See: Personification

Psalms 103:17 (#1)

וְחֶסֶד יְהוָה ׀ מֵעוֹלָם

“But the covenant faithfulness of Yahweh {is} from everlasting”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [But Yahweh will be faithful to his covenant from everlasting]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:17 (#2)

מֵעוֹלָם וְעַד־עוֹלָם

“is} from everlasting to everlasting”

The psalmist is using **from everlasting to everlasting** as a common expression of his culture to mean “eternally” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [lasts forever]

See: Idiom

Psalms 103:17 (#3)

וְצִדְקָתוֹ

“and his righteousness {is”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and he will be righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:17 (#4)

לִבְנֵי בָנִים

“to the children of children”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **the children of children** refers to future generations. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to their descendants]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 103:18 (#1)

לְשֹׁמְרֵי בְרִיתוֹ וּלְזֹכְרֵי פִקֻּדָיו לַעֲשׂוֹתָם

“to the ones keeping his covenant, and to the ones remembering his precepts, to do them”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [to the ones keeping his covenant, that is, to the ones remembering his precepts, to do them]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 103:18 (#2)

לְשֹׁמְרֵי & וּלְזֹכְרֵי

“to the ones keeping & and to the ones remembering”

The pronoun **the ones** refers to people who fear Yahweh, as described in verse 17. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to those children ... and to the children] or [to those descendants ... and to the descendants]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 103:18 (#3)

וּלְזֹכְרֵי

“and to the ones remembering”

The implication is that they are actively keeping God’s precepts in their minds so that they can obey them. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [keeping in mind]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 103:18 (#4)

לַעֲשׂוֹתָם

“to do them”

Here, **to do them** marks this clause as the goal or purpose of **remembering his precepts**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order to do them]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 103:19 (#1)

הֵכִין כִּסְאוֹ

“has established his throne”

Here, **throne** represents the authority and power to rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is the supreme ruler]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:19 (#2)

וּמַלְכוּתוֹ

“and his kingdom”

Here, **kingdom** represents Yahweh ruling as king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he, as king,]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:20 (#1)

לִשְׁמֹעַ

“listening to”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **listening to the voice of his word** means obeying what God says. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [obeying]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 103:20 (#2)

בְּקוֹל דְּבָרוֹ

“the voice of his word”

Here, **the voice of his word** represents what God says. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what he says]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 103:21 (#1)

רְצוֹנוֹ

“his pleasure”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pleasure**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what pleases him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:22 (#1)

בָּרֲכוּ יְהוָה ׀ כָּל־מַעֲשָׂיו

“Bless Yahweh, all his works”

The psalmist is speaking to **all his works** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about praising Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about all of Yahweh's works. Alternate translation: [I want all of Yahweh's works to bless him,]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 103:22 (#2)

מְקֹמוֹת מֶמְשַׁלְתּוֹ

"the places of his reign"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **his reign**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the places where he reigns]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 103:22 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי

"my soul"

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean his entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my inner being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 104 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 104 is the second in the series of five "psalms of praise" to God (Psalm 103–107).

1. Yahweh's greatness in creation (1–6)
2. Yahweh's sustaining care over creation (7–30)
3. Yahweh's glory declared forever (31–32)
4. Everlasting praise to Yahweh (33–35)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh's creation

God has created everything good on earth, in the sky, and in the sea.

Psalms 104:1 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי

"my soul"

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean his entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [myself] or [my inner being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 104:1 (#2)

הוֹד וְהָדָר לָבָשְׁתָּ

"you are clothed with splendor and majesty"

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were **clothed with splendor and majesty**. He means that Yahweh possesses splendor and majesty just as a king might wear magnificent robes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent metaphor from your culture. Alternatively, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you are splendid and majestic]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:1 (#3)

הוֹד וְהָדָר

"splendor and majesty"

The terms **splendor** and **majesty** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [extreme magnificence]

See: Doublet

Psalms 104:1 (#4)

הוֹד וְהָדָר לָבָשְׁתָּ

"you are clothed with splendor and majesty"

The expression **you are clothed with splendor and majesty** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you are splendid and majestic]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 104:1 (#5)

הוֹד וְהָדָר לָבָשְׁתָּ

"you are clothed with splendor and majesty"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **splendor** and **majesty**, you could express the

same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [you are splendid and majestic]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 104:2 (#1)

עֹטֶה־אוֹר כַּשַּׂלְמָה

“wrapping light as the garment”

The psalmist is making a comparison to describe how God wears light. The point of this comparison is that just as **a garment** covers and adorns a person, so **light** covers and adorns God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [putting light around you as though it were a garment]

See: Simile

Psalms 104:2 (#2)

נוֹטֶה שָׁמַיִם כַּיְרִיעָה

“spreading out the heavens as the tent curtain”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a tent curtain** is stretched out to provide shelter, so the **heavens** are stretched out by God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [spreading out the heavens as a man would spread out a tent curtain]

See: Simile

Psalms 104:3 (#1)

הַמְקָרֶה בַמַּיִם עֲלִיּוֹתָיו

“the one setting his upper chambers on the waters”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were **setting his upper chambers on the waters**. This image pictures God’s dwelling place as being built above the sky, where the rain clouds are. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [It is as though you have set the upper chambers of your home on the waters in the sky]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:3 (#2)

הַשָּׂם־עָבִים רְכוּבוֹ

“the one appointing the clouds his chariot”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a king or mighty warrior who rode across the sky with **the clouds** serving as his **chariot**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It is as though you ride the clouds like chariots]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:3 (#3)

הַהֹלֵךְ עַל־כַּנְפֵי־רוּחַ

“the one walking on the wings of the wind”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were someone who could **walk on the wings of the wind**. He means that Yahweh moves about freely and swiftly, as if he were riding on the wind itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you move about freely as though you were flying along with the wind]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:4 (#1)

עֹשֶׂה מַלְאָכָיו רוּחוֹת מְשָׁרְתָיו אֵשׁ לֹהֵט

“making the winds his messengers, flaming fire, his servants”

In these clauses, the subjects and objects are not marked, and could fill either role. They could mean: (1) Yahweh makes the winds his messengers and he makes flaming fire his servants, as in the ULT, or (2) Yahweh makes his messengers winds and he makes his servants flaming fire. Alternate translation: [making his messengers winds, and his servants, flaming fire]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:4 (#2)

עֹשֶׂה מַלְאָכָיו רוּחוֹת

“making the winds his messengers”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were **making the winds his messengers**. This image means that Yahweh uses the winds to carry out his purposes, just as a king would send messengers to accomplish his will. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [sending the winds as he would send his messengers]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:4 (#3)

מְשָׁרְתָתָיו אֵשׁ לֹהֵט

“flaming fire, his servants”

The psalmist is speaking of **flaming fire** as if it were a person who could serve God. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [controlling flaming fire so that it serves him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:4 (#4)

מְשָׁרְתָתָיו אֵשׁ לֹהֵט

“flaming fire, his servants”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [making flaming fire his servants]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:5 (#1)

יָסַד־אֶרֶץ עַל־מְכוֹנֶיהָ

“He set the earth upon its foundations”

The psalmist is speaking of **the earth** as if Yahweh had placed it **upon** physical **foundations** like a building is constructed on a foundation. The psalmist means that Yahweh created the world to be stable and secure. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He made the earth to be stable]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:5 (#2)

בַּל־תִּתְמוֹט

“it will not be moved”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [never can anyone move it]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 104:6 (#1)

תְּהוֹם

“with} the deep”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **the deep** refers to the waters of the ocean or the primeval waters that once covered the earth. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [with deep water]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 104:6 (#2)

כַּלְבוּשׁ

“like a garment”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a garment** completely covers a person, so **the deep** completely covered the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as completely as if that were its clothing]

See: Simile

Psalms 104:6 (#3)

עַל־הָהָרִים יַעַמְדוּ־מָיִם

“the waters stood above the mountains”

The psalmist is speaking of **the waters** as if they were a living thing that could stand in a certain position. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the waters were higher than the mountains]

See: Personification

Psalms 104:7 (#1)

מִן־גַּעֲרָתְךָ יְנוּסָּוּן מִן־קוֹל רַעַמְךָ יֵחָפֵזוּן

“From your rebuke they fled; from your voice of thunder they hurried away”

These two phrases **From your rebuke they fled** and **from your voice of thunder they hurried away** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could combine the phrases. Alternate translation: [From your thunderous rebuke they fled away]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 104:7 (#2)

יְנוּסָּוּן & יֵחָפֵזוּן

“they fled & they hurried away”

The psalmist is speaking of **the waters** as if they were living things that could **flee** and **hurry away**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they receded ... they went away]

See: Personification

Psalms 104:7 (#3)

קוֹלְךָ֣ רַ֭עַמְךָ

“your voice of thunder”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **voice** that is characterized by **thunder**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your thunderous voice]

See: Possession

Psalms 104:7 (#4)

קוֹלְךָ֣ רַ֭עַמְךָ

“your voice of thunder”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **voice** as if it were **thunder** to express how loud it is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your loud voice]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:8 (#1)

יַֽעֲל֣וּ הָ֭הָרִים יֵֽרְד֣וּ בְקָעוֹת

“They ascended the mountains; they descended the valleys”

They refers to “the waters” from verse 6. This reflects the idea from Genesis 7:11 that the flood waters came from where they had been stored both above the firmament and underground. Here it is saying that after the flood God returned the waters to those places, so some of it **ascended the mountains** to return to the heavens and some **descended the valleys** to return to their places underground.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:8 (#2)

יַֽעֲל֣וּ הָ֭הָרִים יֵֽרְד֣וּ בְקָעוֹת

“They ascended the mountains; they descended the valleys”

Some translations take **the mountains** to be the subject of **ascended** and **the valleys** to be the subject of **descended**. This makes it difficult to translate the following verse however, since verse 9 continues to refer to the waters as “they.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to follow what it does here. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to follow the ULT. Alternate translation: [The mountains rose; the valleys descended]

Psalms 104:9 (#1)

יַֽעֲבֹ֥רוּן

“they & pass”

The pronoun **they** refers to the waters. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the waters]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:10 (#1)

הַ֭מְשַׁלֵּ֣חַ

“The one sending”

The one in verses 10, 13, and 14 refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, you send]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:11 (#1)

יַשְׁקוּ

“They give drink to”

The pronoun **They** refers to the springs (mentioned in the previous verse). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The streams of water give drink to]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:11 (#2)

יִשְׁבְּר֣וּ & צְמָאֵֽם

“break their thirst”

The psalmist is using **break their thirst** as a common expression to mean “quench their thirst” or “satisfy their thirst by drinking.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [quench their thirst] or [drink and are satisfied]

See: Idiom

Psalms 104:12 (#1)

עֲלֵיהֶם

“Alongside them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the streams of water mentioned in verse 10. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Alongside the streams of water]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:12 (#2)

יִתְּנוּ־קוֹל

“they give voice”

The psalmist is using **they give voice** as a common expression of his culture to mean “they sing” or “they chirp.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they chirp]

See: Idiom

Psalms 104:13 (#1)

מַשְׁקֶה

“The one watering”

The psalmist is using the phrase **The one watering** to refer to God without using a pronoun. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a name or pronoun to clarify the referent. Alternate translation: [Yahweh waters]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:13 (#2)

מֵעֲלִיּוֹתָיו

“from his upper chambers”

The psalmist is speaking of the sky as if it were **upper chambers** in a building from which God sends rain down on the mountains. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from high in the sky]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:13 (#3)

מִפְּרִי מַעֲשֶׂיךָ תִּשְׂבַּע הָאָרֶץ

“from the fruit of your works the earth is satisfied”

Here, **fruit** could be both literal and figurative. It could mean either of these things or both: (1) The work of watering the mountains produces literal fruit, which satisfies the creatures on earth. The next two verses list some of that fruit. Alternate translation: [this work of yours produces fruit, which satisfies the earth] or (2) The result of watering the mountains is that the earth is satisfied with the water. Alternate translation: [because you do this, the earth is satisfied]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:13 (#4)

תִּשְׂבַּע הָאָרֶץ

“the earth is satisfied”

Here, **the earth** represents the creatures that live on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the earthly creatures are satisfied]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 104:14 (#1)

מַצְמִיחַ חָצִיר

“The one making grass grow”

The phrase **The one** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, who makes grass grow]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:14 (#2)

וְעֵשֶׂב

“and plants”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and the one making plants grow]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:14 (#3)

לְהוֹצִיא

“to bring forth”

Here, **to bring forth** marks **bread from the earth** as the goal or purpose of **plants for the work of man**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear

that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order to produce]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 104:14 (#4)

לֶּ֭חֶם

“bread”

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to represent food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 104:15 (#1)

וְיַ֤יִן

“And wine”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And by providing wine]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:15 (#2)

לְבַב־אֱנ֗וֹשׁ

“the heart of man”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s inner self, including their emotions and sense of well-being. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all mankind] or [everyone]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:15 (#3)

לְהַצְהִ֣יל פָּ֭נִים

“to make the face shine”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **face**. He means faces in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to make people’s faces shine]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 104:15 (#4)

לְהַצְהִ֣יל פָּ֭נִים

“to make the face shine”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he gives olives to make the face shine]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:15 (#5)

וְ֝לֶ֗חֶם

“and bread”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and by providing bread]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:16 (#1)

יִשְׂבְּע֣וּ עֲצֵֽי־יְהוָ֑ה

“The trees of Yahweh are satisfied”

The psalmist is speaking of **the trees of Yahweh** as if they were living things that could be satisfied. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The trees of Yahweh get plenty of rain]

See: Personification

Psalms 104:16 (#2)

אַרְזֵ֖י לְבָנ֣וֹן אֲשֶׁ֣ר נָטָֽע

“the cedars of Lebanon which he planted”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the cedars of Lebanon which he planted are satisfied]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:17 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר־שָׁ֭ם צִפֳּרִ֣ים יְקַנֵּ֑נוּ

“where birds make their nests there”

The expression **where birds make their nests there** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in many languages. The word **there** repeats

the idea of **where**. If this would be unnatural in your language, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [where birds make their nests]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 104:17 (#2)

חֲסִידָ֥ה בְרוֹשִׁ֗ים בֵּיתָ֫הּ

“the stork, the cypress tree her home”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **stork**. He means storks in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [storks, cypress trees their home]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 104:17 (#3)

חֲסִידָ֥ה בְרוֹשִׁ֗ים בֵּיתָ֫הּ

“the stork, the cypress tree her home”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the stork makes the cypress tree her home]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:18 (#1)

הָרִרִ֣ים הַגְּבֹהִ֣ים לַ֭יְעֵלִים

“the high mountains for the wild goats”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the high mountains are the home for the wild goats]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:18 (#2)

סְלָעִ֥ים מַחְסֶ֗ה לַשְּׁפַנִּֽים

“the cliffs, a refuge for the hyraxes”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the cliffs are a refuge for the hyraxes]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:18 (#3)

לַשְּׁפַנִּֽים

“for the hyraxes”

A **hyrax** is a kind of small, furry animal that lives in rocky areas. If your readers would not be familiar with what a hyrax is, you could use the name of a similar animal that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [for the rock badgers]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 104:19 (#1)

עָ֭שָׂה

“He made”

The pronoun **He** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh made]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:19 (#2)

לְמוֹעֲדִ֑ים

“for appointed times”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that the **appointed times** are the festivals and religious observances that are determined by the phases of the moon. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to indicate the times for the special days of each month]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 104:19 (#3)

שֶׁ֝֗מֶשׁ יָדַ֥ע מְבוֹאֽוֹ

“the sun knows its setting”

The psalmist is speaking of **the sun** as if it were a living thing that could know when to set. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you made the sun to set at the proper time each night]

See: Personification

Psalms 104:20 (#1)

וַ֝יְהִי לָ֗יְלָה

“and it is night”

The psalmist uses **and** to indicate that **it is night** is the result of God setting **darkness**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [and night happens] or [which creates night]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:20 (#2)

בּוֹ

“in it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the darkness. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in the night]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:21 (#1)

וּלְבַקֵּשׁ מֵאֵ֥ל אָכְלָֽם

“and seeking their food from God”

The psalmist is speaking of the young lions as if they were **seeking their food from God**. He means that God provides food for the lions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as though they are asking God to give them their food]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:22 (#1)

תִּזְרַ֤ח הַשֶּׁ֨מֶשׁ

“The sun rises”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that he means that the young lions retreat because **the sun rises** and it becomes daytime. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When the sun rises]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:23 (#1)

לְפָעֳלֹ֑ו וְלַעֲבֹדָתֹ֥ו

“to his work and to his labor”

The terms **work** and **labor** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to all of his work that he does]

See: Doublet

Psalms 104:23 (#2)

אָדָֽם

“Man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **Man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Each person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 104:24 (#1)

בְּחָכְמָ֣ה

“with wisdom”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wisdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wisely] or [skillfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 104:24 (#2)

קִנְיָנֶֽךָ

“your creation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **creation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what you have created]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 104:25 (#1)

גָּד֥וֹל וּרְחַב־יָ֝דָ֗יִם

“great and broad of hands”

The terms **great** and **broad of hands** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [enormous in size]

See: Doublet

Psalms 104:25 (#2)

וּרְחַב־יָ֝דָ֗יִם

“and broad of hands”

The psalmist is using **broad of hands** as a common expression of his culture to mean that the shores of the sea are far apart. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a compa-

rable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and with distant shorelines]

See: Idiom

Psalms 104:25 (#3)

גְּדוֹלֹ֑ת

“great”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **great** refers to the sea’s vast size or extent. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [large]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 104:25 (#4)

וְאֵ֣ין מִסְפָּ֣ר

“and there is no number”

The psalmist says **there is no number** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [and there are too many to count]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 104:25 (#5)

חַיּ֥וֹת קְ֝טַנּ֗וֹת עִם־גְּדֹלֽוֹת

“living things, small with great”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the small living things are there with the great living things]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:25 (#6)

גְּדֹלֽוֹת

“great”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **great** refers to the large size of some of the sea creatures. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [large]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 104:25 (#7)

קְ֝טַנּ֗וֹת עִם־גְּדֹלֽוֹת

“small with great”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **small** and **great** as nouns to mean small creatures and large creatures. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate these words with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [small ones with large ones]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 104:25 (#8)

קְ֝טַנּ֗וֹת עִם־גְּדֹלֽוֹת

“small with great”

The psalmist is referring to all of the living creatures in the sea by naming two extremes, **small** and **great**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [of every size together]

See: Merism

Psalms 104:26 (#1)

לִ֝לְוְיָתָ֗ן

“Leviathan”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Leviathan travels there]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:27 (#1)

כֻּלָּ֑ם

“All of them”

The pronoun **them** refers to all of the living creatures that the psalmist has been describing, including the sea creatures mentioned in the previous verses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [All of these living creatures]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:27 (#2)

אֵלֶ֥יךָ יְשַׂבֵּרוּן

“look to you”

The psalmist is speaking of creatures depending on God for their food as if they were physically looking at someone for help. If it would be helpful in your lan-

guage, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [need you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:28 (#1)

תִּתֵּ֣ן לָהֶ֣ם יִלְקֹטֽוּן

“You give to them; they gather {it”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that it is when God provides the food that the creatures gather it. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When you give to them; then they gather it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:28 (#2)

תִּפְתַּ֣ח יָ֭דְךָ

“you open your hand”

The psalmist is using **you open your hand** as a common expression of his culture to mean “you give generously.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you give generously]

See: Idiom

Psalms 104:28 (#3)

יִשְׂבְּעוּן טּֽוֹב

“they are satisfied {with} good”

The adjective **good** is functioning as a noun, referring to good things (specifically, good food that God provides). If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this with a noun phrase or indicate what kind of good things are meant. Alternate translation: [they are satisfied with the good food]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 104:29 (#1)

תַּסְתִּ֣יר פָּנֶ֣יךָ יִבָּהֵ֑לוּן

“You hide your face; they are terrified”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that it is when God hides his face from his creatures that they then become terrified. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When you hide your face; then they are terrified]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:29 (#2)

תַּסְתִּ֣יר פָּנֶ֣יךָ

“You hide your face”

The psalmist is using **You hide your face** as a common expression of his culture to mean “You withdraw your care” or “You turn away from them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When you ignore them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 104:29 (#3)

יִבָּהֵ֑לוּן

“they are terrified”

The expression **they are terrified** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [that terrifies them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 104:29 (#4)

תֹּסֵ֣ף רוּחָ֣ם יִגְוָ֑עוּן

“you take away their breath; they expire”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that it is when God takes the breath away that creatures then expire. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When you take away their breath; then they expire]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:29 (#5)

וְאֶל־עֲפָרָ֥ם יְשׁוּבֽוּן

“and return to their dust”

The psalmist is using **return to their dust** as a common expression of his culture to mean “die and decay.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and turn into dirt]

See: Idiom

Psalms 104:30 (#1)

תְּשַׁלַּ֥ח רוּחֲךָ֗ יִבָּרֵ֫אוּן

“You send out your breath; they are created”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that it is when God sends out his breath that creatures then begin to live. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When you send out your breath; then they are created]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:30 (#2)

תְּשַׁלַּ֥ח רוּחֲךָ֗ יִבָּרֵ֫אוּן

“You send out your breath; they are created”

The same word that is translated as **breath** in this and the previous verse also means “spirit.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to translate as it does. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to translate as the ULT does. Alternate translation: [You send out your Spirit; they are created]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 104:30 (#3)

יִבָּרֵ֫אוּן

“they are created”

The expression **they are created** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [you create them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 104:30 (#4)

פְּנֵ֣י אֲדָמָֽה

“the face of the land”

Here, **the face of the land** represents everything living on the surface of the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everything living on the earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 104:31 (#1)

יְהִ֣י כְבוֹד־יְהוָ֣ה לְעוֹלָ֑ם

“May the glory of Yahweh be forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May his creatures honor Yahweh forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 104:31 (#2)

בְּמַעֲשָׂ֥יו

“in his creation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **creation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in what he has created]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 104:32 (#1)

הַמַּבִּ֥יט לָ֝אָ֗רֶץ

“The one looking at the earth”

The phrase **the one** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh looks at the earth]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:32 (#2)

הַמַּבִּ֥יט לָ֝אָ֗רֶץ וַתִּרְעָ֑ד

“The one looking at the earth, and it shakes”

The psalmist uses **and** to indicate that **it shakes** is the result of God **looking at the earth**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [the one looking at the earth, so that it shakes]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:32 (#3)

יִגַּ֣ע בֶּהָרִ֣ים וְיֶעֱשָׁ֑נוּ

“he touches the mountains, and they smoke”

The psalmist uses **and** to indicate that **they smoke** is the result of God touching **the mountains**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [he touches the mountains, which causes them to smoke]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 104:33 (#1)

לֵאלֹהַי

“to my God”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to describe his relationship with God. The phrase **my God** indicates the God whom the psalmist worships and serves. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to the God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 104:33 (#2)

בְּעוֹדִי

“during my existence”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the idea of **existence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [while I am alive]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 104:34 (#1)

שִׂיחִי

“my meditation”

By **my meditation**, the psalmist is probably referring to the things that he has expressed in this psalm. If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **meditation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things that I have expressed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 104:34 (#2)

יֶעֱרַב עָלָיו שִׂיחִי

“May my meditation be sweet to him”

The psalmist is speaking of his **meditation** as if it were something that could have a sweet taste. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May my meditation please him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:34 (#3)

אָנֹכִי אֶשְׂמַח

“I, I will rejoice”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will rejoice** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize his personal commitment to rejoice in Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [For my part, I will rejoice]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 104:34 (#4)

בַּיהוָה

“in Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a location that the psalmist could be **in**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of who Yahweh is]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 104:35 (#1)

וּרְשָׁעִים

“and the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean wicked people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 104:35 (#2)

וּרְשָׁעִים ׀ עוֹד אֵינָם

“and the wicked be no more”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may the wicked be no more]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 104:35 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean his entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [myself] or [my inner being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 104:35 (#4)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

"Hallelu Yah"

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 104:35 (#5)

יָהּ

"Yah"

Yah is a shortened form of the name "Yahweh," the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 105 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 105 is the third in a series of five "psalms of praise" to God (Psalm 103–107). Psalm 105 retells the history of Israel from Yahweh's covenant with Abraham, to the people's enslavement in Egypt, to Yahweh's liberation of the people through the plagues in Egypt, to Yahweh giving them the land of Canaan.

1. Praise Yahweh and seek his works (1–6)
2. Yahweh's covenant and deeds with the patriarchs (7–15)
3. Yahweh's guidance over Joseph and Israel in Egypt (16–25)
4. Yahweh's deliverance and provision in the wilderness (26–45)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh's protection

God protected Abraham and Jacob. He worked throughout Israel's history to bring Israel into the land he had promised them. (See: Promised Land)

Psalms 105:1 (#1)

קִרְאֻאוּ בִשְׁמֹוֹ

"call on his name"

The psalmist is using the term **name** to refer to Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [call on him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:3 (#1)

בְּשֵׁשֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

"in the name of his holiness"

Here, **the name of his holiness** represents Yahweh himself, who is holy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in Yahweh, who is holy]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:3 (#2)

בְּשֵׁשֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

"in the name of his holiness"

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **name** that is characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in his holy name]

See: Possession

Psalms 105:3 (#3)

יִשְׂמַח לֵב ו מְבַקְשֵׁי יְהוָה

"let the heart of the seekers of Yahweh rejoice"

Here the **heart** represents where a person's thoughts, feelings, and desires exist. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let the people who seek Yahweh rejoice]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:3 (#4)

יִשְׂמַח לֵב ׀ מְבַקְשֵׁי יְהוָה

“let the heart of the seekers of Yahweh rejoice”

The psalmist is speaking of people who desire to know Yahweh as if they were **seekers** of him, or trying to find him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let the heart of those who desire to know Yahweh rejoice]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:4 (#1)

דִּרְשׁוּ יְהוָה וְעֻזּוֹ

“Seek Yahweh and his strength”

The psalmist is speaking of needing to **Seek Yahweh** as if he were a lost object that needed to be sought and found. He means that the people should pray to Yahweh and desire to be in his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Pray to Yahweh and ask for his strength]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:4 (#2)

וְעֻזּוֹ

“and his strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for him to strengthen you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 105:4 (#3)

בַּקְּשׁוּ פָנָיו

“search for his face”

Here, **his face** represents his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [seek his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:5 (#1)

וּמִשְׁפְּטֵי־פִיהוּ

“and the decrees from his mouth”

Here, **his mouth** represents Yahweh speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the decrees that he spoke]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:6 (#1)

זֶרַע אַבְרָהָם עַבְדּוֹ בְּנֵי יַעֲקֹב בְּחִירָיו

“seed of Abraham his servant, sons of Jacob, his chosen ones”

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could move 105:6 before 105:7 as the UST does, in order to state who is being addressed before giving the content of the speech. You would then combine the verses into a verse bridge (105:5–6).

See: Verse Bridges

Psalms 105:6 (#2)

זֶרַע אַבְרָהָם

“seed of Abraham”

The psalmist is speaking of the Israelites as if they were the **seed of Abraham**. He means that they are Abraham’s descendants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [descendants of Abraham]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:6 (#3)

עַבְדּוֹ

“his servant”

The pronoun **his** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s servant]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:6 (#4)

בְּנֵי יַעֲקֹב

“sons of Jacob”

The psalmist is speaking as if the people of Israel were the **sons** of Jacob. He means that they are his descendants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [descendants of Jacob]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:6 (#5)

בְּחִירָיו

“his chosen ones”

The psalmist is using the adjective **chosen** as a noun to mean people who are chosen. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those he has chosen]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 105:7 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“our God”

By using this possessive form, our God, the psalmist is not saying that the Israelites possess or control Yahweh. Rather he is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom the Israelites worship as modeled in the UST.

See: Possession

Psalms 105:7 (#2)

בְּכָל־הָאָרֶץ מִשְׁפָּטָיו

“His decrees {are} in all the earth”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s decrees as if they were physical objects that existed **in all the earth**. He means that Yahweh’s laws and judgments apply to all people everywhere on earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His laws apply to everyone on earth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:8 (#1)

זָכַר

“He remembers”

The psalmist assumes that his audience will understand that God’s remembering is not merely recalling information but actively maintaining and fulfilling his commitments. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He keeps in mind]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:8 (#2)

זָכַר לְעוֹלָם בְּרִיתוֹ דָּבָר צִוָּה לְאֶלֶף דּוֹר

“He remembers his covenant forever, the word he commanded for a thousand generations”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He remembers his covenant forever, yes, the word he commanded for a thousand generations]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:8 (#3)

דָּבָר צִוָּה

“the word he commanded”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he remembers the word he commanded]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:8 (#4)

דָּבָר צִוָּה

“the word he commanded”

Here, **the word** represents the covenant that God spoke. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the covenant he commanded]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:8 (#5)

לְאֶלֶף דּוֹר

“for a thousand generations”

The psalmist is using **for a thousand generations** as a common expression of his culture to mean “for all time” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all time]

See: Idiom

Psalms 105:9 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר כָּרַת

“that he cut”

The psalmist is using the phrase **he cut** as a common expression of his culture to mean “he made.” This idiom comes from the ancient practice of cutting animals in two as part of making a covenant. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that he made]

See: Idiom

Psalms 105:9 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר כָּרַת

“that he cut”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the covenant that he cut]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:9 (#3)

וּשְׁבוּעָתוֹ

“and his oath”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the sentence if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he remembers his oath]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:10 (#1)

וַיַּעֲמִידֶהָ לְיַעֲקֹב לְחֹק לְיִשְׂרָאֵל בְּרִית עוֹלָם

“He confirmed it to Jacob as a statute; to Israel, an everlasting covenant”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He confirmed it to Jacob as a statute; yes, to Israel, an everlasting covenant]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:10 (#2)

לְיִשְׂרָאֵל בְּרִית עוֹלָם

“to Israel, an everlasting covenant”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the sentence if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he confirmed it to Israel, an everlasting covenant]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:11 (#1)

לֵאמֹר

“saying”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh said. You may wish to mark the words of this speech with a first-level quotation mark at the beginning and end of them or with some other punctuation or convention that your language uses to indicate a direct quotation.

See: Quote Markings

Psalms 105:11 (#2)

נַחֲלַתְכֶם

“your inheritance”

Here **your** is plural, indicating that Yahweh made this same covenant with Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and their descendants. Use the plural form here if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 105:12 (#1)

בִּהְיוֹתָם

“when they were”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:12 (#2)

בָּהּ

“in it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the land of Canaan. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in the land of Canaan]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:13 (#1)

מִגּוֹי אֶל־גּוֹי מִמַּמְלָכָה אֶל־עַם אַחֵר

“from nation to nation, from a kingdom to other people”

These two phrases **from nation to nation** and **from a kingdom to other people** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [repeatedly from one kingdom to another]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:13 (#2)

מִמַּמְלָכָה

“from a kingdom”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **kingdom**. He means kingdoms in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [from one kingdom]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 105:14 (#1)

עֲלֵיהֶם

“because of them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [because of the people of Israel] or [for the sake of the people of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:15 (#1)

אַל־תִּגְּעוּ בִמְשִׁיחָי

“Do not touch my anointed ones”

This is the beginning of what God said to the kings. You may wish to mark the words of this speech with a first-level quotation mark at the beginning and end of them or with some other punctuation or convention that your language uses to indicate a direct quotation.

See: Quote Markings

Psalms 105:15 (#2)

אַל־תִּגְּעוּ

“Do not touch”

The psalmist says **Do not touch** as a warning against doing even the slightest harm to emphasize God’s strictness about this. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [In no way should you hurt]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 105:16 (#1)

וַיִּקְרָא רָעָב עַל־הָאָרֶץ

“He called for a famine on the land”

The psalmist is speaking of the famine as if it were something that could hear and respond to Yahweh **calling** it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He made the land produce a famine]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:16 (#2)

כָּל־מַטֵּה־לֶחֶם שָׁבָר

“he broke all of the staff of bread”

The psalmist is using **he broke all of the staff of bread** as a common expression of his culture to mean “he caused there to be a famine” or “he made it so that there was no food.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he made the land unable to produce food]

See: Idiom

Psalms 105:16 (#3)

לֶחֶם

“bread”

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 105:17 (#1)

שָׁלַח

“He sent”

The pronoun **He** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh sent]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:17 (#2)

לִפְנֵיהֶם

“ahead of them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:17 (#3)

לְעֶבֶד נִמְכַּר יוֹסֵף

“Joseph was sold as a servant”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that God orchestrated Joseph’s sale into slavery as part of his plan to send Joseph ahead to Egypt. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Joseph was the man whom Yahweh sent ahead by allowing him to be sold as a servant]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:18 (#1)

עִנּוּ

“They oppressed”

The pronoun **They** refers to the prison guards in Egypt. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The prison guards in Egypt oppressed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:18 (#2)

בַּכֶּבֶל

“in a shackle”

A **shackle** is a device made of metal used to restrain a prisoner by fastening around the ankles or wrists. If your readers would not be familiar with what a shackle is, you could use a more general term or explain it in a footnote. Alternate translation: [in metal restraints used to fasten a prisoner’s wrists or ankles together]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 105:18 (#3)

בַּבַּרְזֶל

“the iron”

By **the iron**, the psalmist means an iron collar that was put around Joseph’s neck. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [an iron collar attached to a chain]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:19 (#1)

דְּבָרוֹ

“his word”

Here, **his word** represents what Joseph said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the things that he said]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:19 (#2)

צְרָפָתְהוּ

“refined him”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s testing of Joseph as if Yahweh were a metalworker who **refined** him. This image pictures God’s word purifying and strengthening Joseph’s character during his time of suffering, just as fire removes impurities from metal. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [tested and taught him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:20 (#1)

שָׁשַׁלַּח מֶלֶךְ וַיְתִּירֵהוּ מֹשֵׁל עַמִּים וַיְפַתְּחֵהוּ

“The king sent and released him; the one ruling the people, and liberated him”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including

both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [The king sent and released him; yes, the one ruling the people, and liberated him]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:20 (#2)

שָׁלַח מֶלֶךְ וַיַּתִּירֵהוּ

“The king sent and released him”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The king sent officials and released him]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:20 (#3)

מֹשֵׁל עַמִּים

“the one ruling the people”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the one ruling the people sent officials]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:21 (#1)

שָׂמְהוּ

“He appointed him”

The pronoun **He** refers to Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, while the pronoun **him** refers to Joseph. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The king appointed Joseph]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:21 (#2)

לְבֵיתוֹ

“of his house”

Here, **house** represents everything concerning the king’s palace. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of everything concerning his palace]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:22 (#1)

שָׂרָיו

“his princes”

The psalmist is speaking of the officials of Egypt as if they were **his princes**. The psalmist means that Pharaoh gave Joseph authority over Egypt’s highest-ranking officials. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his chief rulers]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:22 (#2)

לֶאְסֹר שָׂרָיו בְּנַפְשׁוֹ

“to bind his princes according to his soul”

The psalmist is using **according to his soul** as a common expression of his culture to mean “according to his will” or “according to his desire.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to subject his princes to Joseph’s desires]

See: Idiom

Psalms 105:22 (#3)

לֶאְסֹר שָׂרָיו בְּנַפְשׁוֹ

“to bind his princes according to his soul”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He appointed him to bind his princes according to his soul]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:23 (#1)

וַיָּבֹא יִשְׂרָאֵל מִצְרָיִם וְיַעֲקֹב גָּגַר בְּאֶרֶץ־חָם

“Then Israel came into Egypt, and Jacob sojourned in the land of Ham”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you

could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Then Israel came into Egypt; yes, Jacob sojourned in the land of Ham]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:24 (#1)

וַיְיַ֣פֶּר אֶת־עַמּ֗וֹ מְאֹֽד

“He made his people very fruitful”

The pronoun **He** refers to Yahweh. The pronoun **his** refers to Jacob. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh made Jacob’s people very fruitful]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:24 (#2)

וַיְיַ֣פֶּר אֶת־עַמּ֗וֹ מְאֹֽד

“He made his people very fruitful”

The psalmist is speaking of God causing his people to increase in number as if he were making them **fruitful**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He made his people multiply greatly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:24 (#3)

וַֽיַּעֲצִמֵ֖הוּ מִצָּרָֽיו

“and he made him stronger than his enemies”

The pronouns **him** and **his** refer to **people**, which is singular in form. If it would be helpful, you could use plural pronouns instead. Alternate translation: [and he made them stronger than their enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:25 (#1)

הָפַ֣ךְ לִבָּ֣ם

“He turned their hearts”

The psalmist is speaking of God changing the Egyptians’ attitudes as if he had physically **turned their hearts**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He changed their emotions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 105:25 (#2)

לְ֝הִתְנַכֵּ֗ל בַּעֲבָדָֽיו

“to plot against his servants”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He turned their hearts to plot against his servants]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:26 (#1)

אַֽהֲרֹ֥ן

“Aaron”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He sent Aaron]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:26 (#2)

אֲשֶׁ֖ר בָּחַ֣ר־בּֽוֹ

“whom he had chosen him”

The expression **whom he had chosen him** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in many languages, since the word **whom** already indicates Aaron as the object. If it would be clearer in your language, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [whom he had chosen]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 105:27 (#1)

שָׂ֤מוּ־בָ֨ם׀ דִּבְרֵ֬י אֹתֹתָ֗יו וּ֝מֹפְתִ֗ים בְּאֶ֣רֶץ חָֽם

“They performed among them the matters of his signs, and his wonders in the land of Ham”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [They

performed among them the matters of his signs, yes, his wonders in the land of Ham]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:27 (#2)

וּמֹפְתֵ֥ים בְּאֶ֗רֶץ חָֽם

“and his wonders in the land of Ham”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they performed his wonders in the land of Ham]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:27 (#3)

בָֽם

“among them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the Egyptians. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [among the Egyptians]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:28 (#1)

וְלֹא־מָ֝רֽוּ

“and they did not rebel against”

The pronoun **they** refers to Moses and Aaron. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and Moses and Aaron did not rebel against]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:28 (#2)

וְלֹא־מָ֝רֽוּ

“and they did not rebel against”

Here **they did not rebel** is a double negative consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative verb **rebel**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [and they obeyed]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 105:28 (#3)

אֶת־דְּבָרֽוֹ

“his words”

Here, **his words** represents what God said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what he said to them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:29 (#1)

וַיָּ֖מֶת אֶת־דְּגָתָֽם

“and killed their fish”

The word translated as **and** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [which killed their fish]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 105:30 (#1)

בְּֽחַדְרֵ֖י מַלְכֵיהֶֽם

“in the rooms of their kings”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [frogs swarmed in the rooms of their kings]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:31 (#1)

אָמַ֗ר

“He spoke”

The implication is that Yahweh commanded the flies to come. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh commanded the flies]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:31 (#2)

כִּ֝נִּ֗ים בְּכָל

“gnats in all”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [gnats came into all]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:31 (#3)

גְּבוּלָם

“their territory”

The pronoun **their** refers to the Egyptians. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Egyptians’ territory]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:32 (#1)

אֵשׁ לֶהָבוֹת

“fire of flames”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He made fire of flames]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:32 (#2)

אֵשׁ לֶהָבוֹת

“fire of flames”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **fire** that is characterized by **flames**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [flaming fire] or [burning fire]

See: Possession

Psalms 105:33 (#1)

וַיַּךְ

“He struck”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that God struck the vines and fig trees with the hail mentioned in the previous verse. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He destroyed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:34 (#1)

אָמַר

“He spoke”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **He spoke** means that God gave a command for the locusts to come. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh commanded the locusts]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:34 (#2)

וַיָּבֹא אַרְבֶּה וְיֶלֶק

“and the locust came, and the young locust”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **the locust** and **the young locust** refer to different kinds of locusts that came in large swarms, not just one of each. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and locusts came, and young locusts]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 105:34 (#3)

וְיֶלֶק

“and the young locust”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and the young locust came]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:34 (#4)

וְאֵין מִסְפָּר

“and there was no number”

The psalmist says **there was no number** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [in swarms that were impossible to count]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 105:35 (#1)

וַיֹּאכַל כָּל־עֵשֶׂב בְּאַרְצָם וַיֹּאכַל פְּרִי אַדְמָתָם

“And they ate all of the vegetation in their land; and they ate the fruit of their ground”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not say-

ing something additional. Alternate translation: [And they ate all of the vegetation in their land; yes, they ate the fruit of their ground]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:35 (#2)

פְּרִ֣י אַדְמָתָֽם

“the fruit of their ground”

The psalmist is using **the fruit of their ground** to represent all of the crops that grew in the land. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the crops that grew on their ground]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 105:36 (#1)

וַיַּ֥ךְ

“Then he struck”

The implication is that God killed all the firstborn people and animals in Egypt. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Then he killed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:37 (#1)

וַיּוֹצִיאֵ֣ם בְּכֶ֣סֶף וְזָהָ֑ב

“He brought them out with silver and gold”

The psalmist assumes that his readers will know that the **silver and gold** refers to items made of silver and gold that the Israelites carried out of Egypt, as described in Exodus. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He brought them out as they carried silver and gold]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:38 (#1)

שָׂמַ֣ח מִצְרַ֣יִם

“Egypt was glad”

Here, **Egypt** represents the people of Egypt. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The Egyptian people were glad]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:39 (#1)

וְאֵ֣שׁ

“and fire”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the sentence if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he spread fire] or [and he provided fire]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:40 (#1)

שָׁאַ֗ל

“He asked”

The pronoun **He** refers to Israel, which is a singular way to refer to all the people. If it would be helpful, you could use a plural pronoun instead. Alternate translation: [They asked]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:40 (#2)

וַיָּבֵ֣א שְׂלָ֑ו

“and he brought quail”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh brought quail]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:40 (#3)

שְׂלָ֑ו

“quail”

A **quail** is a kind of medium-sized game bird. If your readers would not be familiar with what a quail is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [medium-size birds]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 105:41 (#1)

פָּ֭תַח

“He split”

The pronoun **He** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh split]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:41 (#2)

הָלָ֑כוּ

“they went forth”

The pronoun **they** refers to the waters. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the waters went forth] or [the water went forth]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:41 (#3)

נָהָ֗ר

“a river”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [as a river] or [as much water as a river]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:42 (#1)

כִּ֤י

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [The reason he did those things was that]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 105:42 (#2)

זָכַ֣ר

“he remembered”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh remembered]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:42 (#3)

זָכַ֣ר

“he remembered”

The psalmist assumes that his audience will understand that God’s remembering is not merely recalling information but actively maintaining and fulfilling his commitments. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he kept in mind]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 105:42 (#4)

אֶת־דְּבַ֖ר קָדְשׁ֑וֹ

“the word of his holiness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **word** that is characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his holy word]

See: Possession

Psalms 105:42 (#5)

אֶת־דְּבַ֖ר קָדְשׁ֑וֹ

“the word of his holiness”

Here, **his holiness** represents his holy promise or covenant. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his holy covenant]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:42 (#6)

אֶת־אַבְרָהָ֖ם

“with Abraham”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [through which he made a promise to Abraham]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:43 (#1)

וַיּוֹצִ֣א עַמּ֣וֹ בְשָׂשׂ֑וֹן בְּרִנָּ֥ה אֶת־בְּחִירָֽיו

“He led his people out with joy, his chosen with shouts of triumph”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He

led his people out with joy, yes, his chosen with shouts of triumph]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:43 (#2)

וַיּוֹצִיא עַמּוֹ

“He led his people out”

The pronoun **He** refers to Yahweh. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use Yahweh’s name here. Alternate translation: [Yahweh led his people out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:43 (#3)

בְּשָׂשׂוֹן

“with joy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and they were joyful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 105:43 (#4)

אֶת־בְּחִירָיו

“his chosen”

The psalmist is using the adjective **chosen** as a noun to mean a certain kind of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [his chosen people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 105:43 (#5)

בְּרִנָּה

“with shouts of triumph”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **triumph**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [shouting triumphantly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 105:43 (#6)

בְּרִנָּה אֶת־בְּחִירָיו

“his chosen with shouts of triumph”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from earlier in the verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He led his chosen out with shouts of triumph]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 105:44 (#1)

וַיִּתֵּן לָהֶם אַרְצוֹת גּוֹיִם וַעֲמַל לְאֻמִּים יִירָשׁוּ

“Then he gave to them the lands of the nations, and they took possession of the toil of the peoples”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Then he gave to them the lands of the nations; yes, they took possession of the toil of the peoples]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:44 (#2)

וַיִּתֵּן לָהֶם

“Then he gave to them”

The pronoun **He** refers to Yahweh. The pronoun **them** refers to the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Then Yahweh gave to the Israelites]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 105:44 (#3)

וַעֲמַל לְאֻמִּים יִירָשׁוּ

“and they took possession of the toil of the peoples”

Here, **toil** represents what the people produced by their work. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they took possession of what other peoples had worked to produce]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 105:44 (#4)

יִירָשׁוּ

“they took possession of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **possession**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they took for themselves]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 105:45 (#1)

יִשְׁמְרוּ חֻקָּיו וְתוֹרֹתָיו יִנְצֹרוּ

“they might keep his statutes and comply with his laws”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [they might keep his statutes, that is, comply with his laws]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 105:45 (#2)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 105:45 (#3)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 106 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 106 is the fourth in a series of five “psalms of praise” to God (Psalm 103–107). The book of Psalms is divided into five sections, also called “books,” and Psalm 106 ends book four. Verses 47 and 48 are considered to be a closing petition and praise for book four, rather than belonging specifically to Psalm 106.

1. Praise Yahweh for his goodness and faithfulness (1–3)
2. Plea for pardon and Yahweh’s acceptance (4–6)
3. Recount Israel’s rebellion and Yahweh’s mercy (7–46)
4. Prayer and praise to Yahweh (47–48)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Israel’s sin

Although Israel continually sinned in the desert, God still took them to the Promised Land. (See: sin, sinful, sinner, sinning; and Promised Land)

Psalms 106:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 106:1 (#2)

כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ

“for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [give thanks to Yahweh for his covenant faithfulness is to forever]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 106:1 (#3)

כִּ֥י לְעוֹלָ֗ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

The psalmist is using **to forever** as a common expression of his culture to mean “eternally” or “without end.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for his covenant faithfulness lasts forever]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:1 (#4)

חַסְדּֽוֹ

“his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way he is faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:2 (#1)

מִ֭י יְמַלֵּ֣ל גְּבוּר֣וֹת יְהוָ֑ה יַ֝שְׁמִ֗יעַ כָּל־תְּהִלָּתֽוֹ

“Who can utter the mighty acts of Yahweh, proclaim all of his praise”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No one can utter the mighty acts of Yahweh or proclaim all of his praise.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 106:2 (#2)

יַ֝שְׁמִ֗יעַ כָּל־תְּהִלָּתֽוֹ

“proclaim all of his praise”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [who can proclaim all of his praise]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 106:2 (#3)

יַ֝שְׁמִ֗יעַ כָּל־תְּהִלָּתֽוֹ

“proclaim all of his praise”

Here, **praise** represents praiseworthy deeds. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [proclaim all of his praiseworthy deeds]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:3 (#1)

אַ֝שְׁרֵ֗י

“The happinesses of”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy are] or [Truly blessed are]

Psalms 106:3 (#2)

שֹׁמְרֵ֣י מִשְׁפָּ֑ט עֹשֵׂ֖ה צְדָקָ֣ה

“the guardians of justice, the doers of righteousness”

The terms **guardians of justice** and **doers of righteousness** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are careful to do what is right]

See: Doublet

Psalms 106:3 (#3)

שֹׁמְרֵ֣י מִשְׁפָּ֑ט

“the guardians of justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those who are always just]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:3 (#4)

עֹשֵׂ֖ה צְדָקָ֣ה

“the doers of righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those who do what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:4 (#1)

זָכְרֵנִי

“Remember me”

By **Remember me**, the psalmist is not implying that Yahweh forgot him, but he means for Yahweh to act favorably to him or to show him favor. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Pay attention to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:4 (#2)

בִּרְצוֹן עַמֶּךָ

“in the favor of your people”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **favor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when you are kind to your people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:4 (#3)

פָּקְדֵנִי

“visit me”

By **visit me**, the psalmist means “be kind to me” or “show favor to me.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [be kind to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:4 (#4)

בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ

“in your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when you save them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:5 (#1)

לִרְאוֹת ׀ בְּטוּבַת

“to look on the good of”

The psalmist is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean good things or good experiences. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to look on the good experiences] or [to look on the prosperity]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:5 (#2)

בְּחִירֶיךָ

“your chosen”

The psalmist is using the adjective **chosen** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [your chosen people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:5 (#3)

בְּשִׂמְחַת גּוֹיֶךָ

“in the gladness of your nation”

The psalmist is using the adjective **gladness** as a noun to mean a certain kind of experience or state. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [when your nation becomes glad again]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:5 (#4)

לְהִתְהַלֵּל עִם־נַחֲלָתֶךָ

“to boast with your inheritance”

Here the phrase **your inheritance** refers to the Israelites, the people who belong to Yahweh. When Yahweh saves them, they will **boast** about Yahweh. Alternate translation: [to boast of your greatness with your people] or [to boast with your people about you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:6 (#1)

אֲבוֹתֵינוּ

“our fathers”

Here the psalmist is using the term **fathers** to mean “ancestors.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our ancestors]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:6 (#2)

הֶעֱוִינוּ הִרְשָׁעְנוּ

“we have done wrong; we have done evil”

The terms translated as **we have done wrong** and **we have done evil** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [we have continually done what is wrong]

See: Doublet

Psalms 106:6 (#3)

הֶעֱוִינוּ הִרְשָׁעְנוּ

“we have done wrong; we have done evil”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **wrong** and **evil** as nouns to mean certain kinds of actions or behaviors. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [we have done what is wrong; we have done what is evil]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:7 (#1)

אֶת־רַ֭ב חֲסָדֶ֑יךָ

“the abundance of your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **abundance** and **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in other ways. Alternate translation: [how you were constantly faithful to your covenant with them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:7 (#2)

יֶ֥ם בְּיַם־סֽוּף

“the sea, the Sea of Reeds”

The terms **the sea** and **the Sea of Reeds** refer to the same place. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the Sea of Reeds]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 106:8 (#1)

לְמַ֥עַן שְׁמ֑וֹ

“on account of his name”

Here, **his name** represents his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for the sake of his reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:8 (#2)

לְ֝הוֹדִ֗יעַ

“to make known”

Here, **to make known** marks **to make known his power** as the goal or purpose of **he saved them on account of his name**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order to make known]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 106:8 (#3)

לְ֝הוֹדִ֗יעַ

“to make known”

The expression **to make known** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [so that everyone would know]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 106:8 (#4)

אֶת־גְּבוּרָתֽוֹ

“his power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how powerful he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:9 (#1)

וַיִּגְעַ֣ר בְּיַם־סֽוּף וַיֶּחֱרָ֑ב

“He rebuked the Sea of Reeds, and it dried up”

Here, **and it dried up** marks **it dried up** as the goal or purpose of **He rebuked the Sea of Reeds**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [He rebuked the Sea of Reeds so that it dried up]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 106:9 (#2)

כַּמִּדְבָּר

“as {through} a desert”

The psalmist is making a comparison about how God led the Israelites through the dried-up sea. The point of this comparison is that just as **a desert** is dry land that can be walked on, so were **the depths** of the sea after God dried it up. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and it was as dry as a desert]

See: Simile

Psalms 106:10 (#1)

וַיּוֹשִׁיעֵם מִיַּד שׂוֹנֵא וַיִּגְאָלֵם מִיַּד אוֹיֵב

“So he saved them from the hand of the hater, and he rescued them from the hand of the enemy”

These two phrases **he saved them from the hand of the hater** and **he rescued them from the hand of the enemy** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [So he saved them from the hand of the hater; yes, he rescued them from the hand of the enemy]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 106:10 (#2)

מִיַּד & מִיַּד

“from the hand of & from the hand of”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of ... from the power of]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:10 (#3)

שׂוֹנֵא

“the hater”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **hater**. He means haters in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [those who hated them]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 106:10 (#4)

אוֹיֵב

“the enemy”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **enemy**. He means enemies in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [their enemies]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 106:11 (#1)

אֶחָד מֵֽהֶם לֹא נוֹתָר

“one of them was not left”

The expression **one of them was not left** contains a passive verbal form. It means that none of them were left alive. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [all of them died]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 106:12 (#1)

בִּדְבָרָיו

“his words”

Here, **words** represents what God said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what he had said to them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:12 (#2)

תְּהִלָּתוֹ

“his praise”

Here, **praise** represents songs or words that praised God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [songs that praised him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:13 (#1)

מִֽהֲרוּ שָׁכְחוּ

“But they hurried, they forgot”

The phrases **they hurried, they forgot** express a single idea. The word **hurried** tells more about **forgot**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [But they quickly forgot]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 106:14 (#1)

בַּמִּדְבָּר & בִּישִׁימוֹן

“in the wilderness & in the wasteland”

These two phrases **in the wilderness** and **in the wasteland** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could indicate in some way that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [in the wilderness ... in that wasteland]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 106:14 (#2)

וַיִּתְאַוּוּ תַּאֲוָה

“And they craved a craving”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [And they had strong cravings]

See: Poetry

Psalms 106:14 (#3)

וַיְנַסּוּ־אֵל

“and they tested God”

The implication is that they tested God’s patience and faithfulness by demanding things from him and complaining against him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and they pushed the limits of God’s patience with them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:15 (#1)

וַיְשַׁלַּח רָזוֹן

“but he sent a wasting disease”

The psalmist is speaking as if God literally **sent a wasting disease**. This means that God caused the disease to affect the Israelites. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but he caused a wasting disease]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:15 (#2)

בְּנַפְשָׁם

“upon their lives”

The psalmist is using **upon their lives** as a common expression of his culture to mean “that killed them” or “that took their lives.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that took their lives] or [that killed many of them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:16 (#1)

וַיְקַנְאוּ

“And they became envious”

The pronoun **they** refers to some of the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And some of the men became envious]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 106:16 (#2)

לְאַהֲרֹן

“of Aaron”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they also became envious of Aaron]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 106:16 (#3)

קְדֹושׁ יְהוָה

“the holy one of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using the adjective **holy one** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the holy priest of Yahweh]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:17 (#1)

וַתִּבְלַ֖ע דָּתָ֑ן

“and swallowed Dathan”

The psalmist is speaking as if the earth were a person who **swallowed** Dathan. He means that the earth opened up and Dathan fell into it and died. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and Dathan went down in it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:17 (#2)

דָּתָ֑ן & אֲבִירָֽם

“Dathan & Abiram”

The words **Dathan** and **Abiram** are the names of men.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 106:17 (#3)

עֲדַ֖ת אֲבִירָֽם

“the congregation of Abiram”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **the congregation of Abiram** refers to Abiram’s followers who joined him in rebelling against Moses and Aaron. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the followers of Abiram]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:18 (#1)

וַתִּבְעַר־אֵ֥שׁ בַּעֲדָתָ֑ם לֶ֝הָבָ֗ה תְּלַהֵ֥ט רְשָׁעִֽים

“Fire blazed up in their congregation; a flame burned up the wicked”

These two phrases **Fire blazed up in their congregation** and **a flame burned up the wicked** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Fire blazed up in their congregation; indeed, a flame burned up the wicked]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 106:18 (#2)

רְשָׁעִֽים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:19 (#1)

יַֽעֲשׂוּ־עֵ֥גֶל בְּחֹרֵ֑ב וַ֝יִּשְׁתַּחֲווּ֗ לְמַסֵּכָֽה

“They made a calf at Horeb and worshiped a cast image”

These two phrases **They made a calf at Horeb** and **worshiped a cast image** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [They made a calf at Horeb; yes, they worshiped that cast image]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 106:19 (#2)

יַֽעֲשׂוּ־עֵ֥גֶל

“They made a calf”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that this **calf** was not a real calf but was made of gold as an idol to worship. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [They made a model of a calf]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:19 (#3)

וַ֝יִּשְׁתַּחֲווּ֗ לְמַסֵּכָֽה

“and worshiped a cast image”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **a cast image** refers to the golden calf that the Israelites made at Mount Horeb. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and worshiped that calf, which was a cast image]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:20 (#1)

אֶת־כְּבוֹדָם

“their Glory”

The implication is that **their Glory** refers to God himself, who is glorious. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [their God, who is glorious,]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:20 (#2)

וַיָּמִירוּ אֶת־כְּבוֹדָם בְּתַבְנִית שׁוֹר אֹכֵל עֵשֶׂב

“Thus they traded their Glory for the likeness of a bull eating grass”

The psalmist is speaking of worshiping an idol rather than God as though they had **traded** God for this idol. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Thus they replaced worshiping their Glory with worshiping the likeness of a bull eating grass]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:21 (#1)

שָׁכְחוּ אֵל

“They forgot God”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Israelites **forgot** God, that is, as if he had slipped from their memory. The psalmist means that they acted as if God did not exist or matter to them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They rejected God]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:21 (#2)

עֹשֶׂה גְדֹלוֹת

“the doer of great {deeds”

The implication is that God is the one who had done these great deeds to deliver the Israelites from Egypt. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [who had done great deeds]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:22 (#1)

נִפְלָאוֹת

“wonders”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wonders**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wonderful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:22 (#2)

בְּאֶרֶץ חָם

“in the land of Ham”

The implication is that the land of Ham refers to Egypt, since Ham was the ancestor of the Egyptians according to biblical genealogies. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the land where Ham’s descendants lived]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:23 (#1)

וַיֹּאמֶר לְהַשְׁמִידָם

“So he said to annihilate them”

The implication is that God was determined to destroy the Israelites because of their sin, but Moses interceded for them. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [So he intended to annihilate them] or [So he would have annihilated them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:23 (#2)

לוּלֵי מֹשֶׁה בְחִירוֹ עָמַד בַּפֶּרֶץ

“had not Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach”

The psalmist says **had not Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach** to introduce a situation that did not happen in order to help explain what would have happened if Moses had not interceded for the Israelites. Use a natural method in your language for introducing a situation that did not happen. Alternate translation: [if Moses, his chosen one, had not stood in the breach]

See: Hypothetical Situations

Psalms 106:23 (#3)

בְּחִירוֹ

“his chosen one”

The expression **his chosen one** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [the one whom God had chosen]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 106:23 (#4)

עָמַד בַּפֶּרֶץ

“stood in the breach”

The psalmist is using **stood in the breach** as a common expression of his culture to mean “defended them” or “interceded for them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [defended them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:23 (#5)

לְפָנָיו

“to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents being in God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:23 (#6)

לְהָשִׁיב חֲמָתוֹ מֵהַשְׁחִית

“to turn away his heat from destroying”

The psalmist is using **to turn away his heat** as a common expression of the culture to mean “to turn away his anger.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to keep him from destroying them in his anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:24 (#1)

לִדְבָרוֹ

“his word”

Here, **word** represents what God said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what he had said]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:25 (#1)

לֹא שָׁמְעוּ בְּקוֹל

“they did not listen to the voice of”

By **they did not listen to the voice**, the psalmist means they did not obey or heed what Yahweh said. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they did not heed the voice of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:25 (#2)

בְּקוֹל יְהוָה

“to the voice of Yahweh”

Here, **the voice of Yahweh** represents what Yahweh said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to what Yahweh said to them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:26 (#1)

וַיִּשָּׂא יָדוֹ לָהֶם

“Then he raised his hand to them”

The phrase **raised his hand** describes a symbolic action by which God showed that he was making a solemn oath or vow to the Israelites. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Then he made an oath to them]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 106:26 (#2)

לְהַפִּיל אֹתָם

“to make them fall”

The psalmist is using **to make them fall** as a common expression of his culture to mean “to kill them.” If this

phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to kill them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:27 (#1)

וּלְהַפִּ֣יל זַרְעָ֣ם בַּגּוֹיִ֔ם וּלְזָרוֹתָ֖ם בָּאֲרָצֽוֹת

“and to make their seed fall among the nations, and to scatter them among the lands”

These two phrases **to make their seed fall among the nations** and **to scatter them among the lands** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [and to scatter their descendants among people of foreign lands]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 106:27 (#2)

וּלְהַפִּ֣יל זַרְעָ֣ם

“and to make their seed fall”

The psalmist is speaking of the descendants of the Israelites as if they were **seed** that would fall and be scattered as a farmer scatters seed on a field. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and to spread their descendants]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:27 (#3)

בַּגּוֹיִ֔ם

“among the nations”

Here, **the nations** represents the people of foreign nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [among people of foreign nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:28 (#1)

וַיִּצָּמְד֥וּ

“They joined themselves”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Israelites had **joined themselves** to the Baal of Peor, that is, as if they were attaching themselves physically to the idol. The psalmist means that they gave their loyalty and devotion to this false god. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They gave their loyalty]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:28 (#2)

זִבְחֵ֖י מֵתִֽים

“the sacrifices of the dead”

This could mean: (1) the people worshiped their dead ancestors and treated them as gods. Alternate translation: [the sacrifices given to dead ancestors] or (2) the psalmist is describing Baal and the people’s other idols as dead. Alternate translation: [sacrifices given to lifeless idols]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:28 (#3)

זִבְחֵ֖י מֵתִֽים

“the sacrifices of the dead”

The psalmist is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the sacrifices for dead people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:28 (#4)

זִבְחֵ֖י מֵתִֽים

“the sacrifices of the dead”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean sacrifices offered to idols, which were considered to be dead gods. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the sacrifices given to those who had died]

See: Possession

Psalms 106:29 (#1)

וַיַּכְעִיסוּ

“And they angered”

Some ancient manuscripts read **And they angered**. The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “And they angered him.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use

the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [And they angered him]

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 106:29 (#2)

וַתִּפְרָץ־בָּם מַגֵּפָה

“and a plague broke out among them”

The psalmist is using **a plague broke out among them** as a common expression of his culture to mean “many of them became sick with a plague.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and many of them became sick with a plague]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:29 (#3)

וַתִּפְרָץ־בָּם מַגֵּפָה

“and a plague broke out among them”

The implication is that God sent the plague as judgment for their sinful actions. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh afflicted them with a plague]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:30 (#1)

וַיַּעֲמֹ֥ד פִּֽינְחָ֗ס

“Then Phinehas stood”

The psalmist is speaking of Phinehas as if he had **stood** up from a sitting position. The psalmist means that Phinehas took action courageously to intervene in the situation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then Phinehas showed his courage]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:30 (#2)

וַיְפַלֵּ֑ל

“and intervened”

The implication is that Phinehas acted on behalf of Yahweh to stop the plague by executing judgment on those who were sinning. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and acted on behalf of Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:30 (#3)

וַתֵּעָצַר הַמַּגֵּפָה

“and the plague was restrained”

The expression **the plague was restrained** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [and the plague stopped]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 106:31 (#1)

וַתֵּחָשֶׁב לֹ֑ו

“It was counted to him”

The expression **It was counted to him** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [People credited it to him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 106:31 (#2)

לִצְדָקָ֑ה

“as righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as a righteous deed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:31 (#3)

לְדֹ֣ר וָ֭דֹר

“to generation and generation”

The psalmist is using **to generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “throughout all generations” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and will be so throughout all generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:32 (#1)

וַיַּקְצִיפוּ

“And they angered”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And they angered Yahweh]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 106:32 (#2)

מְרִיבָה

“Meribah”

The word **Meribah** is the name of a place. Alternate translation: [the place called Meribah]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 106:32 (#3)

וַיֵּרַע לְמֹשֶׁה

“and it was bad for Moses”

The pronoun **it** refers to what happened at the waters of Meribah. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and what happened there was bad for Moses]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 106:33 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation of what happened to Moses at the waters of Meribah. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [What happened was that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 106:33 (#2)

הִמְרֲרוּ אֶת־רוּחוֹ

“they rebelled against his spirit”

Here, **his** could refer to: (1) Moses. Alternate translation: [they rebelled against Moses’ spirit] or (2) Yahweh. Alternate translation: [they rebelled against Yahweh’s Spirit]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 106:33 (#3)

הִמְרֲרוּ אֶת־רוּחוֹ

“they rebelled against his spirit”

Some ancient manuscripts read **they rebelled against his spirit**. The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “they embittered his spirit.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT. Alternate translation: [they embittered his spirit]

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 106:33 (#4)

הִמְרֲרוּ אֶת־רוּחוֹ

“they rebelled against his spirit”

Here, **his spirit** represents him as a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they rebelled against him]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:33 (#5)

וַיְבַטֵּא בִּשְׂפָתָיו

“and he spoke rashly with his lips”

It might seem that the expression **with his lips** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [and he spoke rashly]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 106:33 (#6)

וַיְבַטֵּא בִּשְׂפָתָיו

“and he spoke rashly with his lips”

Here the pronouns **he** and **his** refer to Moses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and Moses spoke rashly with his lips]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 106:35 (#1)

וַיִּתְעָרְבוּ בַגּוֹיִם

“but they mingled with the nations”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Israelites had **mingled** or mixed themselves physically with the nations.

He means that they intermarried with people from other nations and adopted their religious and cultural practices. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but they intermarried with people of the nations]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:35 (#2)

וַיִּתְעָרְבוּ בַגּוֹיִם

“but they mingled with the nations”

Here, **the nations** represents the people of those nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [but they intermarried with the people of the other nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:36 (#1)

וַיִּהְיוּ לָהֶם לְמוֹקֵשׁ

“and they became a snare to them”

The pronoun **they** refers to the idols, while the pronoun **them** refers to the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the idols became a snare to the people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 106:36 (#2)

וַיִּהְיוּ לָהֶם לְמוֹקֵשׁ

“and they became a snare to them”

The psalmist is speaking of the idols as if they were **a snare** that could trap the Israelites and destroy them. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this in plain language. Alternate translation: [and that was the beginning of their destruction]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:37 (#1)

וַיִּזְבְּחוּ

“And they sacrificed”

The pronoun **they** refers to the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Our ancestors sacrificed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 106:38 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁפְּכוּ דָּם נָקִי

“And they shed innocent blood”

Here, **blood** represents the lives of people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They killed innocent people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:38 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר זִבְחוּ לַעֲצַבֵּי כְנָעַן

“whom they sacrificed to the idols of Canaan”

Here, **idols** represents the spiritual beings that the people believed the idols represented. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [whom they sacrificed to the spirits that the people of Canaan worshiped]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:38 (#3)

וַתֶּחֱנַף הָאָרֶץ בַּדָּמִים

“and the land was desecrated by bloodshed”

By **the land was desecrated by bloodshed**, the psalmist means that the land became unfit for God’s people to live in because of the murders committed there. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and the land became unfit for the people of God to live in because they murdered people there]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:39 (#1)

וַיִּטְמְאוּ בְמַעֲשֵׂיהֶם וַיִּזְנוּ בְּמַעַלְלֵיהֶם

“And they became unclean by their deeds; and they prostituted themselves by their actions”

These two phrases **And they became unclean by their deeds** and **and they prostituted themselves by their actions** mean basically the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [And

they became unclean by their deeds; indeed, they prostituted themselves by their actions]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 106:39 (#2)

וַיִּטְמְאוּ

“And they became unclean”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Israelites had **become unclean** physically through their sinful actions. He means that they became spiritually defiled or morally corrupted by their idolatrous practices. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And they became very sinful]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:39 (#3)

וַיִּזְנוּ

“and they prostituted themselves”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Israelites were unfaithful wives who **prostituted themselves**. He means that they violated their covenant relationship with Yahweh by worshiping idols. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they violated their relationship with Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:40 (#1)

וַיִּחַר־אַף יְהוָה

“So Yahweh’s nose burned”

The psalmist is using the phrase **Yahweh’s nose burned** as a common expression of the culture to mean that Yahweh was angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [So Yahweh was very angry]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:40 (#2)

אֶת־נַחֲלָתוֹ

“his inheritance”

The psalmist is speaking of the people of Israel as if they were Yahweh’s **inheritance**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people who belonged to him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:41 (#1)

וַיִּתְּנֵם בְּיַד־גּוֹיִם

“And he gave them into the hand of the nations”

Here, **hand** represents the power and control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he gave them into the control of people of other nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:41 (#2)

וַיִּמְשְׁלוּ & שֹׂנְאֵיהֶם

“and the haters of them ruled”

The psalmist is using the verb **haters** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use verbs in the same way. If not, you can translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and people who hated them]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 106:42 (#1)

וַיִּלְחָצוּם אוֹיְבֵיהֶם וַיִּכָּנְעוּ תַּחַת יָדָם

“And their enemies oppressed them, and they were humbled under their hand”

These two phrases **And their enemies oppressed them** and **and they were humbled under their hand** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [And their enemies oppressed them; yes, they were humbled under their hand]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 106:42 (#2)

וַיִּכָּנְעוּ תַּחַת יָדָם

“and they were humbled under their hand”

The expression **they were humbled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and the hand of their enemies humbled them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 106:42 (#3)

וַֽיִּכָּנְעוּ֮ תַּ֪חַת יָ֫דָ֥ם

“and they were humbled under their hand”

Here, **hand** represents the power and control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they were humbled under their control]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:43 (#1)

וְהֵ֣מָּה יַמְרֻ֣רוּ

“but they, they were rebellious”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they were rebellious** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the contrast between God’s repeated rescue and the people’s persistent rebellion. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [but those people, they were rebellious]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 106:43 (#2)

בַּעֲצָתָ֑ם

“in their counsel”

The implication is that the Israelites were rebellious in their plans and decisions against God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in their thinking]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:43 (#3)

וַיָּ֖מָּכּוּ בַּעֲוֹנָֽם

“and sank in their sin”

The psalmist is speaking as if the Israelites were objects that **sank** down into something. He means that they became more and more deeply involved in sinful behavior. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and their sinfulness became progressively worse]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 106:44 (#1)

בַּצַּ֥ר לָ֝הֶ֗ם

“in the narrow to them”

The psalmist is using **in the narrow to them** as a common expression of his culture to mean “when they were in distress” or “when they were in trouble.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that these things were very hard for them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:44 (#2)

בְּ֭בַשָּׁמְעֹו אֶת־רִנָּתָֽם

“when he was hearing their cry”

The implication is that the Israelites were crying out to God for help during their distress. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [when he was hearing them cry out to him in distress]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:45 (#1)

וַיִּזְכֹּ֣ר

“And he remembered”

By **he remembered**, the psalmist means that God was mindful of his covenant, that he acted because of his covenant, not that he had forgotten about it and then remembered. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And he called to mind]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:45 (#2)

וַיִּנָּ֖חֶם

“and relented”

By **relented**, the psalmist means that God turned away from his anger and chose not to continue punishing his people. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your

readers. Alternate translation: [and held back from punishing them further]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 106:45 (#3)

כְּרֹ֣ב חסדו

“because of the abundance of his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **abundance** and **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because he is so abundantly faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:46 (#1)

וַיִּתְּנֵ֣ם אוֹתָ֣ם לְרַחֲמִ֑ים

“He gave them for compassion”

The psalmist is using **gave them for compassion** as a common expression of his culture to mean “caused them to be treated with compassion” or “made them objects of compassion.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He made them objects of compassion]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:46 (#2)

וַיִּתְּנֵ֣ם אוֹתָ֣ם לְרַחֲמִ֑ים לִ֝פְנֵ֗י כָּל־שׁוֹבֵיהֶֽם

“He gave them for compassion to the face of all of their captors”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He made all of their captors compassionate toward them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:46 (#3)

לִ֝פְנֵ֗י כָּל־שׁוֹבֵיהֶֽם

“to the face of all of their captors”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the thinking or consideration of their captors. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the thinking of all of their captors]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:47 (#1)

לְהֹד֣וֹת

“to give thanks”

Here, **to give thanks** marks giving thanks to God’s holy name as the goal or purpose of **Gather us from the nations**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order that we may give thanks]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 106:47 (#2)

לְהֹד֣וֹת לְשֵׁ֣ם קָדְשֶׁ֑ךָ

“to give thanks to the name of your holiness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **name** that is characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to give thanks to your holy name]

See: Possession

Psalms 106:47 (#3)

לְהֹד֣וֹת לְשֵׁ֣ם קָדְשֶׁ֑ךָ

“to give thanks to the name of your holiness”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to give thanks to you, the one who is known to be holy]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 106:47 (#4)

לְ֝הִשְׁתַּבֵּ֗חַ בִּתְהִלָּתֶֽךָ

“to glory in your praises”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praises**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to be proud about praising you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 106:48 (#1)

בָּר֣וּךְ־יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“May Yahweh, the God of Israel, be blessed”

The expression **be blessed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May people bless Yahweh, the God of Israel]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 106:48 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the God of Israel”

The psalmist is not using this possessive form **the God of Israel** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control God. Rather the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the one whom Israel worships. Alternate translation: [who is the God whom Israel worships]

See: Possession

Psalms 106:48 (#3)

מִן־הָעוֹלָם ו וְעַד הָעוֹלָם

“from everlasting and to everlasting”

The psalmist is using **from everlasting and to everlasting** as a common expression of his culture to mean “for all eternity.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Idiom

Psalms 106:48 (#4)

אָמֵן הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Amen. Hallelu Yah”

The words **Amen. Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Amen. Halleluia] or [May it be so. Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 106:48 (#5)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 107 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 107 is the last in a series of five “psalms of praise” to God (Psalm 103–107).

1. A call to thanksgiving (1–3)
2. Stories of Yahweh’s deliverance (4–32)
3. Yahweh’s transformative power (33–41)
4. A final exhortation (42–43)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Praise

The psalmist praises Yahweh for saving people lost in the desert, in prison, sick, in a storm at sea, homeless and oppressed. (See: save, saved, safe, salvation, rescue)

Psalms 107:1 (#1)

חַסְדּוֹ

“his covenant faithfulness {is”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he remains faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:1 (#2)

לְעוֹלָם

“to forever”

The psalmist is using **to forever** as a common expression of his culture to mean “eternally” or “for all time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everlasting]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:2 (#1)

גְּאוּלֵי יְהוָה

“the redeemed of Yahweh”

The expression **the redeemed of Yahweh** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [those whom Yahweh has redeemed]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 107:2 (#2)

יֹאמְרוּ גְּאוּלֵי יְהוָה

“Let the redeemed of Yahweh say {it”

By using **Let**, the psalmist is expressing what he desires or prays will happen. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that the redeemed of Yahweh say that they have been redeemed]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 107:2 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר גְּאָלָם

“who he rescued them”

It might seem that the expression **who he rescued them** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [whom he rescued]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 107:2 (#4)

מִיַּד־צָר

“from the hand of the opponent”

Here, **hand** represents the power or control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the control of the opponent]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:2 (#5)

צָר

“the opponent”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **opponent**. He means opponents in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [every opponent]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 107:3 (#1)

מִמִּזְרָח וּמִמַּעֲרָב מִצָּפוֹן וּמִיָּם

“from the sunrise and from the evening, from the north and from the sea”

The psalmist is referring to all of the earth by naming two extremes, **the sunrise** (the east) and **the evening** (the west), **the north** and **the sea** (the south). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from all directions and from everywhere in between]

See: Merism

Psalms 107:3 (#2)

מִמִּזְרָח וּמִמַּעֲרָב מִצָּפוֹן וּמִיָּם

“from the sunrise and from the evening, from the north and from the sea”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he has gathered them from the sunrise and from the evening, from the north and from the sea]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 107:3 (#3)

מִמִּזְרָח וּמִמַּעֲרָב

“from the sunrise and from the evening”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **the sunrise and the evening** refer to the east and the west. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from the east and from the west]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:3 (#4)

מִצָּפוֹן וּמִיָּם

“from the north and from the sea”

The implication is that **the sea** refers to the southern sea, since the psalmist has already mentioned the other three directions (east, west, and north). You could include this information if that would be helpful

to your readers. Alternate translation: [from the north and from the south]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:4 (#1)

תָּעֻ֥עוּ

“They wandered”

The pronoun **They** refers to the redeemed people whom Yahweh has gathered from foreign lands, as mentioned in the previous verses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Some of them wandered]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:4 (#2)

בִּישִׁימ֣וֹן דָּ֭רֶךְ

“with wilderness for a road”

By **with wilderness for a road**, the psalmist means that they had no proper road to travel on, only the trackless wilderness. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [with no road to walk on, only wilderness]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:5 (#1)

רְעֵבִ֖ים גַּם־צְמֵאִ֑ים

“Hungry and thirsty”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language as modeled in the UST.

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 107:5 (#2)

נַפְשָׁ֖ם בָּ֣הֶם תִּתְעַטָּֽף

“their soul fainted within them”

David is using **their soul fainted within them** as a common expression of his culture to mean “they felt like they were dying” or “they became weak and discouraged.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they felt like they were dying]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:6 (#1)

בַּצַּ֣ר לָ֭הֶם

“in the distressing to them”

The psalmist is using the adjective **distressing** as a noun to mean a certain kind of situation. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in their distress]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:6 (#2)

מִמְּצוּקוֹתֵיהֶ֗ם

“from their distresses”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distresses**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the distressing things that were happening to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:7 (#1)

עִ֣יר מוֹשָׁ֑ב

“a city of dwelling”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **a city** that is characterized by **dwelling**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a city to dwell in]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:8 (#1)

יוֹד֣וּ לַֽיהוָ֣ה

“May they thank Yahweh”

Here and repeatedly throughout this psalm, the psalmist is using **May** to express his wish or desire that the people would praise Yahweh. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that they thank Yahweh]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 107:8 (#2)

חַסְדּ֑וֹ

“for} his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for being faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:8 (#3)

לִבְנֵי אָדָם

“for the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “people” or “humanity.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for mankind]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:9 (#1)

נֶפֶשׁ שֹׁקֵקָה

“the thirsty soul”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **thirsty soul**. He means thirsty people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [every thirsty soul]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 107:9 (#2)

נֶפֶשׁ שֹׁקֵקָה

“the thirsty soul”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [any thirsty person]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:9 (#3)

וְנֶפֶשׁ רְעֵבָה

“and the hungry soul”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **hungry soul**. He means hungry souls in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and every hungry soul]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 107:9 (#4)

וְנֶפֶשׁ רְעֵבָה

“and the hungry soul”

Here, **soul** represents the entire person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and any hungry person]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:9 (#5)

מִלֵּא־טוֹב

“he fills with good”

The psalmist is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean good things. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [he fills with good things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:10 (#1)

יֹשְׁבֵי

“Sitting in”

The word **Sitting** starts a new section of the psalm and refers to another thing that happened to some of Yahweh’s people. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Some of Yahweh’s people had to sit in]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:10 (#2)

חֹשֶׁךְ וְצַלְמָוֶת

“darkness and gloom”

The terms **darkness** and **gloom** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [depressing darkness]

See: Doublet

Psalms 107:10 (#3)

אֲסִירֵי עֳנִי וּבַרְזֶל

“prisoners of affliction and iron”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **prisoners** that are characterized by **affliction and iron**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [prisoners afflicted by iron fetters]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:10 (#4)

אֲסִירֵי עֳנִי וּבַרְזֶל

“prisoners of affliction and iron”

The phrase **affliction and iron** expresses a single idea. The word **affliction** tells more about **iron**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [prisoners held by painful iron chains]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 107:11 (#1)

הִמְרָרוּ אִמְרֵי־אֵל וַעֲצַת עֶלְיוֹן נָאָצוּ

“they had rebelled against the words of God and despised the counsel of the Most High”

These two phrases **had rebelled against the words of God** and **despised the counsel of the Most High** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [they had rebelled against the words of God, indeed, they had despised the counsel of the Most High]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 107:11 (#2)

הִמְרָרוּ אִמְרֵי־אֵל

“they had rebelled against the words of God”

Here, **words** represents what God said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they had rebelled against God when he instructed them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:12 (#1)

לִבָּם

“their hearts”

Here, **their hearts** represents their inner selves or their pride. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [them]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:12 (#2)

בֶּעָמָל

“through hardship”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hardship**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by making them suffer]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:12 (#3)

כָּשָׁלוּ

“they stumbled”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the prisoners experiencing difficulties and hardships as if they **stumbled** while walking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they experienced troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:13 (#1)

וַיִּזְעֲקוּ אֶל־יְהוָה בַּצַּר לָהֶם מִמְּצֻקוֹתֵיהֶם יוֹשִׁיעֵם

“Then they cried out to Yahweh in the distressing to them; he saved them from their distresses”

See how you translated the similar phrases in Psalms 107:6. Alternate translation: [Then they prayed to Yahweh to help them in their trouble and he saved them from it]

Psalms 107:13 (#2)

בַּצַּר לָהֶם

“in the distressing to them”

The psalmist is using the adjective **distressing** as a noun to mean a certain kind of situation. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in their distress]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:13 (#3)

מִמְּצֻקוֹתֵיהֶם

“from their distresses”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distresses**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the distressing things that were happening to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:14 (#1)

מֵחֹשֶׁךְ וְצַלְמָוֶת

“of darkness and gloom”

The terms **darkness** and **gloom** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [of deep darkness]

See: Doublet

Psalms 107:14 (#2)

יֹוצִיאֵם מֵחֹשֶׁךְ וְצַלְמָוֶת וּמוֹסְרֹתֵיהֶם יְנַתֵּק

“He brought them out of darkness and gloom and broke apart their bonds”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the part about breaking **their bonds** before the part about bringing **them out of the darkness**, as in the UST.

See: Information Structure

Psalms 107:15 (#1)

חַסְדּוֹ

“for} his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for being faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:15 (#2)

לִבְנֵי אָדָם

“for the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **the sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “people” or “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for mankind]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:16 (#1)

כִּי־שִׁבַּר דַּלְתֵי נְחֹשֶׁת וּבְרִיחֵי בַרְזֶל גִּדֵּעַ

“For he has broken the gates of bronze and cut through the bars of iron”

If it is more natural in your language to state the reason before the result, you could do so by moving this sentence to the previous verse. You would then present the combined verses as 15–16 as modeled in the UST.

See: Verse Bridges

Psalms 107:16 (#2)

כִּי־שִׁבַּר דַּלְתֵי נְחֹשֶׁת וּבְרִיחֵי בַרְזֶל גִּדֵּעַ

“For he has broken the gates of bronze and cut through the bars of iron”

The implication is that God freed the prisoners by breaking down the prison **gates** and **bars**. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [For he has freed them from prison by breaking down the gates of bronze and cutting through the bars of iron]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:16 (#3)

כִּי

“For”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [They should do this because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 107:16 (#4)

דַּלְתֵי נְחֹשֶׁת

“the gates of bronze”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **gates** that are characterized by being made of **bronze**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in

another way. Alternate translation: [the gates made of bronze]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:16 (#5)

וּבְרִיחֵי בַרְזֶל

“the bars of iron”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **bars** that are characterized by being made of **iron**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the bars made of iron]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:17 (#1)

אֱוִלִים

“Foolish”

The word **Foolish** starts a new section of the psalm and refers to another thing that happened to some of Yahweh’s people. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Some of Yahweh’s people became foolish]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:17 (#2)

מִדֶּרֶךְ פִּשְׁעָם

“from their rebellious way”

The implication is that they were rebelling against Yahweh. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [because of rebelling against Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:18 (#1)

נַפְשָׁם

“their soul”

The psalmist is using the term **their soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual/emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [they]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:18 (#2)

וַיַּגִּיעוּ עַד־שַׁעֲרֵי מָוֶת

“and they touched the gates of death”

The psalmist is using **touched the gates of death** as a common expression of his culture to mean “came very close to dying.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they came close to dying]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:19 (#1)

וַיִּזְעֲקוּ אֶל־יְהוָה בַּצַּר לָהֶם מִמְּצוֹקוֹתֵיהֶם יוֹשִׁיעֵם

“Then they cried out to Yahweh in the distressing to them; he saved them from their distresses”

See how you translated the similar phrases in Psalm 107:6 and Psalm 107:13. Alternate translation: [Then they prayed to Yahweh to help them in their trouble and he saved them from it]

Psalms 107:19 (#2)

בַּצַּר לָהֶם

“in the distressing to them”

The psalmist is using the adjective **distressing** as a noun to mean a certain kind of situation. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in their distress]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:19 (#3)

מִמְּצוֹקוֹתֵיהֶם

“from their distresses”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distresses**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the distressing things that were happening to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:20 (#1)

יִשְׁלַח דְּבָרוֹ

“He sent his word”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s healing power as if it were **his word** that he could send like a messenger. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he commanded that they be healed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:20 (#2)

מִשְּׁחִיתוֹתָם

“from their destruction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from destroying themselves]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:21 (#1)

חַסְדּוֹ

“for} his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for being faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:21 (#2)

לִבְנֵי אָדָם

“for the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **the sons of man** as a common expression of the culture to mean “mankind” or “all people.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for mankind]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:22 (#1)

וְיִזְבְּחוּ זִבְחֵי תוֹדָה

“May they sacrifice sacrifices of thanksgiving”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [May they offer sacrifices of thanksgiving]

See: Poetry

Psalms 107:22 (#2)

וְיִזְבְּחוּ זִבְחֵי תוֹדָה

“May they sacrifice sacrifices of thanksgiving”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thanksgiving**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May they sacrifice sacrifices in order to thank him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:22 (#3)

בְּרִנָּה

“with a shout”

By **with a shout**, the psalmist means with a joyful shout or loud, celebratory exclamation. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [by shouting joyfully]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:23 (#1)

יוֹרְדֵי

“Going down”

The words **Going down** start a new section of the psalm and refer to another thing that some of Yahweh’s people did. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Some of Yahweh’s people went down]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:23 (#2)

בָּמַיִם רַבִּים

“on abundant waters”

The implication is that the **abundant waters** are the open seas where merchants would travel for international trade. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [by crossing large amounts of water]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:24 (#1)

הֵמָּה רָאוּ

“they, they saw”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they saw** already

includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that they are the only ones who saw the wonders that Yahweh created in the sea. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [they are the ones who saw]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:24 (#2)

וְנִפְלְאוֹתָ֥יו

“and his wonders”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wonders**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the wonderful things he did]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:24 (#3)

בִּמְצוּלָֽה

“in the deep”

By **in the deep**, the psalmist means in the deep parts of the ocean. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the deep parts of the ocean]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:25 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר וַֽיַּעֲמֵ֣ד רוּחַ֣ סְעָרָ֑ה

“Then he spoke and aroused the wind of a hurricane”

Here, **Then he spoke and aroused** marks **the wind of a hurricane** as the goal or purpose of **he spoke**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [Then he spoke to the wind so that it become as strong as a hurricane]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 107:26 (#1)

יַעֲל֣וּ שָׁ֭מַיִם יֵרְד֣וּ תְהוֹמ֑וֹת

“They went up {to} the sky; they went down {to} the depths”

The psalmist says **They went up to the sky; they went down to the depths** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [They went up very high; they went down very low]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 107:26 (#2)

יַעֲל֣וּ שָׁ֭מַיִם יֵרְד֣וּ תְהוֹמ֑וֹת

“They went up {to} the sky; they went down {to} the depths”

By **They went up to the sky; they went down to the depths**, the psalmist means that the ships were lifted high on the waves and then dropped low into the troughs between the waves. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The waves would carry their ships up to the sky; then the ships would fall to the depths between the waves]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:26 (#3)

נַפְשָׁ֣ם בְּרָעָ֣ה תִתְמוֹגָ֑ג

“Their souls melted in the disaster”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the sailors’ **souls melted** from fear and terror during the storm. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They lost all courage in the disaster]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:27 (#1)

כַּשִּׁכּ֥וֹר

“as intoxicated”

The psalmist is using the adjective **intoxicated** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [as though they were intoxicated]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:27 (#2)

וְכָל־חָ֝כְמָתָ֗ם תִּתְבַּלָּֽע

“and all their wisdom became confounded”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wisdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and even though

they were wise about sailing, they did not know what to do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:28 (#1)

וַיִּצְעֲקוּ אֶל־יְהוָה בַּצַּר לָהֶם וּמִמְּצוּקֹתֵיהֶם יוֹצִיאֵם

“Then they cried out to Yahweh in the distressing to them and he rescued them from their distresses”

See how you translated the similar phrases in Psalm 107:6, 107:13, and 107:19. Alternate translation: [Then they prayed to Yahweh to help them in their trouble and he saved them from it]

Psalms 107:28 (#2)

בַּצַּר לָהֶם

“in the distressing to them”

The psalmist is using the adjective **distressing** as a noun to mean a certain kind of situation. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in their distress]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:28 (#3)

וּמִמְּצוּקֹתֵיהֶם יוֹצִיאֵם

“and he rescued them from their distresses”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distresses**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and he rescued them from the distressing things that were happening to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:29 (#1)

יָקֵם סְעָרָה לִדְמָמָה

“He raised the storm to calmness”

The psalmist is using **raised the storm to calmness** as a common expression of the culture to mean “calmed the storm” or “made the storm stop.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He made the wind stop blowing]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:30 (#1)

וַיִּשְׂמְחוּ

“Then they rejoiced”

The words **they rejoiced** refer to the sailors mentioned in the previous verses who were in distress during the storm. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could clarify this referent. Alternate translation: [Then the people rejoiced]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:30 (#2)

כִּי־יִשְׁתֹּתְקוּ

“because they subsided”

The words **they subsided** refer to the waves mentioned in the previous verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could repeat the word “waves” here for clarity. Alternate translation: [because the waves subsided]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:30 (#3)

מְחֹוז חֶפְצָם

“the harbor of their desire”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desire**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the harbor where they had desired to arrive]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:31 (#1)

חַסְדּוֹ

“for} his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for being faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:31 (#2)

לִבְנֵי אָדָם

“for the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **the sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “people” or “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression

from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for mankind]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:32 (#1)

וְיָרֹמְמוּהוּ

“May they exalt him”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the people could physically **exalt** or lift up Yahweh. He means that they should honor and praise him highly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May they extol him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:32 (#2)

וּבְמוֹשַׁב זְקֵנִים יְהַלְלוּהוּ

“and praise him at the seat of the elders”

The **seat of the elders** is where the elders gather in a formal setting to make decisions and provide leadership for the community. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and praise him where the elders of the community sit to discuss important issues]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:33 (#1)

לְצִמָּאוֹן

“into thirsty land”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **land** as if it were a person who could be **thirsty**. He means that the land becomes dry and without water. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [into land that is without water]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:34 (#1)

אֶרֶץ פְּרִי

“fruitful ground”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he turns fruitful ground]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 107:34 (#2)

אֶרֶץ פְּרִי

“fruitful ground”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **land** as if it were **fruitful ground**. He means land that produces abundant crops. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [productive ground]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:34 (#3)

לִמְלֵחָה

“into salt land”

Here, **salt land** represents land that cannot produce crops. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [into land that cannot produce crops]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:34 (#4)

מֵרָעַת יֹשְׁבֵי בָהּ

“from the wickedness of the dwellers in it”

The implication is that God turns fruitful land into salt land because the people living there are wicked. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [because of the wickedness of the dwellers in it]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:34 (#5)

מֵרָעַת יֹשְׁבֵי בָהּ

“from the wickedness of the dwellers in it”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because the dwellers in it are so wicked]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:34 (#6)

מֵרָעַת יֹשְׁבֵי בָהּ

“from the wickedness of the dwellers in it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the fruitful ground that God turns into salt land. It may be helpful to clarify this

for your readers. Alternate translation: [because of the wickedness of the people who dwell in that land]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:35 (#1)

יָשֵׂ֣ם מִדְבָּ֣ר לַאֲגַם־מַ֑יִם וְאֶ֥רֶץ צִ֝יָּ֗ה לְמֹצָאֵ֥י מָֽיִם

“He turns the wilderness into a pool of water and dry land into springs of water”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He turns the wilderness into a pool of water and he turns dry land into springs of water]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 107:35 (#2)

יָשֵׂ֣ם מִדְבָּ֣ר לַאֲגַם־מַ֑יִם וְאֶ֥רֶץ צִ֝יָּ֗ה לְמֹצָאֵ֥י מָֽיִם

“He turns the wilderness into a pool of water and dry land into springs of water”

These two phrases **He turns the wilderness into a pool of water** and **dry land into springs of water** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [He turns the wilderness into a pool of water, yes, dry land into springs of water]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 107:35 (#3)

יָשֵׂ֣ם מִדְבָּ֣ר לַאֲגַם־מַ֑יִם וְאֶ֥רֶץ צִ֝יָּ֗ה לְמֹצָאֵ֥י מָֽיִם

“He turns the wilderness into a pool of water and dry land into springs of water”

The psalmist says this as an overstatement for emphasis. He assumes that readers will know that only parts of the **wilderness** and **dry land** become **water**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [He turns many areas of the wilderness into pools of water and places springs of water throughout the dry land]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 107:36 (#1)

רְעֵבִ֑ים

“the hungry”

The psalmist is using the adjective **hungry** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [hungry people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:36 (#2)

שָׁ֝֗ם

“there”

The pronoun **there** refers to the land that Yahweh has transformed from wilderness into a place with pools of water and springs. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in that land that was dry]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:36 (#3)

עִ֣יר מוֹשָׁ֑ב

“a city of dwelling”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **a city** that is characterized by **dwelling**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a city to dwell in]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:37 (#1)

וַיִּזְרְע֣וּ שָׂ֭דוֹת וַיִּטְּעוּ־כְ֑רָמִים

“Then they sow fields and plant vineyards”

The implication is that the people are able to settle and farm in the land that God has provided for them. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Then that land is able to produce crops, so they sow fields and plant vineyards there]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 107:37 (#2)

פְּרִ֖י תְּבוּאָֽה

“the fruit of the harvest”

The psalmist is using the possessive form **the fruit of the harvest** to describe fruit that is characterized by being harvested. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the crops that grew on the land]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:38 (#1)

וַיִּרְבְּבוּ מְאֹד

“and they become very many”

Here, **and** marks **they become very many** as the goal or purpose of **He blesses them**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so they become very many]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 107:38 (#2)

וּבְהֶמְתָּם לֹא יַמְעִיט

“and their cattle do not become few”

The psalmist is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with a mild expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [and their cattle become very many]

See: Litotes

Psalms 107:38 (#3)

וּבְהֶמְתָּם לֹא יַמְעִיט

“and their cattle do not become few”

Here, **and** marks **their cattle do not become few** as the goal or purpose of **He blesses them**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [and so their cattle do not become few]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 107:39 (#1)

וַיִּמְעֲטוּ וַיָּשֹׁחוּ

“Then they become few and become low”

Here, **they** could refer to: (1) Yahweh’s people, whom the psalmist describes in verses 36–38. Alternate translation: [Then those people become few and become low] or (2) The enemies of Yahweh’s people. Alternate translation: [Then their enemies become few and become low]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:39 (#2)

וַיָּשֹׁחוּ

“and become low”

The psalmist is speaking of people as if they could physically **become low**. He means that they become humbled or brought down in status and circumstances. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and become humbled]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:39 (#3)

מֵעֹצֶר רָעָה וְיָגוֹן

“from distress of evil and sorrow”

The word **from** indicates that what follows is a reason for the result that came before. The people became few and low because of the distress, evil, and sorrow they experienced. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because of distress of evil and sorrow]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 107:39 (#4)

מֵעֹצֶר רָעָה וְיָגוֹן

“from distress of evil and sorrow”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **distress** that is characterized by **evil and sorrow**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from distressing evil and sorrow]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:39 (#5)

מֵעֹצֶר רָעָה וְיָגוֹן

“from distress of evil and sorrow”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **distress**, **evil**, and **sorrow**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [from the evil things that make them distressed and sorrowful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:40 (#1)

שֹׁפֵךְ בּוּז עַל־נְדִיבִים

“He pours contempt on the leaders”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **contempt** as if it were a liquid that Yahweh could pour **on the leaders**. The psalmist means that God shows his contempt for these leaders. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He shows contempt for the leaders]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:40 (#2)

שֹׁפֵךְ בּוּז עַל־נְדִיבִים

“He pours contempt on the leaders”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **contempt**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He humbles the leaders]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:40 (#3)

בְּתֹהוּ לֹא־דָרֶךְ

“in an empty place of no road”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe an **empty place** that is characterized by having **no road**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in a land so empty that there is not even a road]

See: Possession

Psalms 107:41 (#1)

וַיְשַׂגֵּב אֶבְיוֹן מֵעֹנִי

“But he raises up the needy from affliction”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if affliction were a physical location from which God **raises up** the needy. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this in a different way. Alternate translation: [But he removes the needy from their affliction]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:41 (#2)

אֶבְיוֹן

“the needy”

The psalmist is using the adjective **needy** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [any needy people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:41 (#3)

מֵעֹנִי

“from affliction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **affliction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from what is afflicting them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 107:41 (#4)

וַיָּשֶׂם כַּצֹּאן מִשְׁפָּחוֹת

“and establishes families like a flock”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a flock** grows and multiplies, so God causes families to increase in number. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and establishes families so that they grow as a healthy flock of sheep grows]

See: Simile

Psalms 107:42 (#1)

יִשָּׁרִים

“The upright”

The psalmist is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [People who do what is right]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 107:42 (#2)

יִרְאוּ

“see”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order

to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [see all of these things]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 107:42 (#3)

וְכָל־עַוְלָתָהּ

“and all wickedness”

Here, **wickedness** represents “wicked people.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and every wicked person]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 107:42 (#4)

קָפְצָה פִּיהָ

“shuts its mouth”

The psalmist is using **shuts its mouth** as a common expression of his culture to mean “can say nothing” or “is silenced.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [can say nothing]

See: Idiom

Psalms 107:43 (#1)

מִי־חָכָם וְיִשְׁמָר־אֵלֶּה

“Who is wise? Then may he keep these things”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [May whoever is wise keep these things]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 107:43 (#2)

וְיִשְׁמָר־אֵלֶּה

“Then may he keep these things”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh’s actions that he has been describing were objects that a wise person can **keep**. He means for every wise person to think about these things. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then may he keep thinking about these things] or [Then may he remember these things]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 107:43 (#3)

וְיִשְׁמָר

“Then may he keep”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **wise** person by saying **may he keep**. He means wise people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Then may they keep]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 107:43 (#4)

וְיִתְבּוֹנְנוּ

“and may they ponder”

The pronoun **they** refers to people who are **wise**. These are the same people who are referred to as **he** in the first part of this sentence. Use a way that is natural in your language to indicate that this refers to the same wise people. Alternate translation: [and may all wise people ponder]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 107:43 (#5)

חַסְדֵי יְהוָה

“the covenant faithfulness of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the ways that Yahweh is faithful to his covenant with his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 108 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 108 is a psalm of praise and petition.

1. Praise for Yahweh’s covenant faithfulness (1–5)
2. Yahweh’s sovereign dominion and promised kingdom (6–9)
3. Prayer for deliverance and victory (10–13)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Victory

God affirms that he is in control of all nations, but the psalmist has not had success against his enemies. He

admits that only God can give him victory, and so he asks God to give him victory over Edom.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Verses 1–5 are very similar to Psalm 57:7–11, and verses 6–13 are very similar to Psalm 60:5–12. If you have already translated those psalms, look at them to see how to translate this psalm.

Psalms 108:1 (#1)

נָכוֹן לִבִּי

"My heart is made steadfast"

Here David is speaking as if his **heart** were something that could be **made steadfast**. He means that he has become determined and committed to praising God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have made myself steadfast]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 108:1 (#2)

נָכוֹן לִבִּי

"My heart is made steadfast"

The expression **My heart is made steadfast** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I have made my heart steadfast]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 108:1 (#3)

אַף־כְּבוֹדִי

"indeed, {with} my glory"

The word translated as **glory** could be: (1) a reference to all of David's strength. Alternate translation: [indeed, with all that I am] or (2) translated as the very similar word for "liver." In this case, it would be understood as functioning very much like **heart** in the first part of the verse, and also stand for the place in the body where a person's will and emotions are. Either way you translate it, the meaning is very similar. Alternate translation: [indeed, with my liver] or [indeed, with my entire will]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 108:2 (#1)

עֹורָה הַנֵּבֶל וְכִנּוֹר אָעִירָה שָׁחַר

"Awaken, lyre and harp; I will awaken the dawn"

See how you translated the similar phrases in Psalm 57:8.

Psalms 108:2 (#2)

עֹורָה הַנֵּבֶל וְכִנּוֹר

"Awaken, lyre and harp"

David is speaking of his **lyre and harp** as if they were living things that could wake up from sleep. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will start making music with my lyre and harp]

See: Personification

Psalms 108:2 (#3)

אָעִירָה שָׁחַר

"I will awaken the dawn"

David is speaking of **the dawn** as if it were a living thing that could be awakened. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will play them before the sun comes up]

See: Personification

Psalms 108:3 (#1)

אוֹדְךָ בָעַמִּים ׀ יְהוָה וַאֲזַמֶּרְךָ בַּל־אֻמִּים

"I will thank you, Yahweh, among the peoples; I will make music to you among the nations"

These two phrases **I will thank you, Yahweh, among the peoples** and **I will make music to you among the nations** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I will thank you and make music to you, Yahweh, among the peoples of other nations]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 108:4 (#1)

כִּי־גָדֹול מֵעַל־שָׁמַיִם חַסְדֶּךָ וְעַד־שְׁחָקִים אֲמִתֶּךָ

"For your covenant faithfulness {is} great from above the heavens, and your trustworthiness, above the clouds"

These two phrases **your covenant faithfulness is great from above the heavens** and **your trustworthiness above the clouds** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first

by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [For your covenant faithfulness and your trustworthiness are higher than the heavens]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 108:4 (#2)

כִּי־גָדֹל מֵעַל־שָׁמַיִם חַסְדֶּךָ וְעַד־שְׁחָקִים אֲמִתֶּךָ

“For your covenant faithfulness {is} great from above the heavens, and your trustworthiness, above the clouds”

Here David is speaking of God’s covenant faithfulness and trustworthiness as if they were physical things that could extend **above the heavens** and **above the clouds**. He means that God’s faithfulness and trustworthiness are immeasurably great. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [For your covenant faithfulness is better than any human covenant faithfulness, and your trustworthiness is better than any human trustworthiness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 108:4 (#3)

כִּי־גָדֹל מֵעַל־שָׁמַיִם חַסְדֶּךָ

“For your covenant faithfulness {is} great from above the heavens”

David is using **great from above the heavens** as a common expression of his culture to mean “higher than the heavens” or “greater than the heavens.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For your covenant faithfulness is higher than the heavens]

See: Idiom

Psalms 108:4 (#4)

חַסְדֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way that you faithfully love us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 108:4 (#5)

וְעַד־שְׁחָקִים אֲמִתֶּךָ

“and your trustworthiness, above the clouds”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and your trustworthiness is great from above the clouds]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 108:4 (#6)

אֲמִתֶּךָ

“your trustworthiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trustworthiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the amount that we can trust you is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 108:5 (#1)

רָרוּמָה עַל־שָׁמַיִם אֱלֹהִים וְעַל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“Be exalted, God, above the heavens, and your glory, over all the earth”

See how you translated the similar phrases in Psalm 57:5

Psalms 108:5 (#2)

רָרוּמָה עַל־שָׁמַיִם אֱלֹהִים וְעַל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“Be exalted, God, above the heavens, and your glory, over all the earth”

Here David is speaking of God as if he were a person who could be **exalted**, or lifted, above the heavens. David means that God should be recognized and praised as being greater than anything in the heavens. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Show how great you are, God, greater than the heavens, and show your glory to everyone on earth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 108:5 (#3)

וְעַל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ

“and your glory, over all the earth”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may your glory be exalted over all the earth]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 108:5 (#4)

וְעַ֖ל כָּל־הָאָ֣רֶץ כְּבוֹדֶֽךָ

“and your glory, over all the earth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and how glorious you are over all the earth]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 108:6 (#1)

לְמַ֤עַן יֵחָלְצ֨וּן יְדִידֶ֗יךָ הוֹשִׁ֣יעָה יְמִינְךָ֣ וַעֲנֵֽנִי

“So that your beloved ones may be rescued, save {with} your right hand and answer me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about the purpose, **So that your beloved ones may be rescued**, after the request, **save with your right hand and answer me**. Alternate translation: [Save with your right hand and answer me so that your beloved ones may be rescued]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 108:6 (#2)

לְמַ֤עַן יֵחָלְצ֨וּן יְדִידֶ֗יךָ

“So that your beloved ones may be rescued”

The expression **may be rescued** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [So that you rescue your beloved ones]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 108:6 (#3)

הוֹשִׁ֣יעָה יְמִינְךָ֣ וַעֲנֵֽנִי

“save {with} your right hand and answer me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please save with your right hand and answer me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 108:6 (#4)

יְמִינְךָ֣

“with} your right hand”

Here David is using **hand** to represent Yahweh’s power or strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by your ability] or [by your strength]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 108:6 (#5)

וַעֲנֵֽנִי

“and answer me”

Here, **answer me** represents “do what I have been requesting.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and do what I have been requesting]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 108:7 (#1)

אֱלֹהִ֤ים ׀ דִּבֶּ֣ר בְּקָדְשׁ֣וֹ אֶעְלֹ֑זָה אֲחַלְּקָ֥ה שְׁכֶ֝֗ם וְעֵ֣מֶק סֻכּ֣וֹת אֲמַדֵּֽד

“God has spoken in his holiness: “I shall rejoice; I shall divide Shechem and measure out the Valley of Succoth”

See how you translated this in Psalm 60:6

Psalms 108:7 (#2)

בְּקָדְשׁ֣וֹ

“in his holiness”

Here, **in his holiness** could either represent (1) the basis or source of God’s authority when he speaks. Alternate translation: [by his holy authority] or [from his holy nature] or (2) the holy place where God was thought to dwell. Alternate translation: [from his holy place] or [from his sanctuary]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 108:7 (#3)

אֲחַלְּקָ֥ה שְׁכֶ֝֗ם

“I shall divide Shechem”

By **I shall divide Shechem**, God means that he will divide the land where Shechem is located. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I shall divide the land surrounding Shechem]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 108:7 (#4)

וְעֵמֶק סֻכּוֹת אֲמַדֵּד

“and measure out the Valley of Succoth”

By **the Valley of Succoth**, God means the territory or region around the Valley of Succoth. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and measure out the territory of the Valley of Succoth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 108:7 (#5)

אֲמַדֵּד

“measure out”

By **measure out**, God means “measure out for my people to possess.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for my people make portions of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 108:8 (#1)

לִי גִלְעָד ׀ וְלִי מְנַשֶּׁה וְאֶפְרַיִם מָעוֹז רֹאשִׁי יְהוּדָה מְחֹקְקִי

“To me {is} Gilead; to me {is} Manasseh, and Ephraim {is} the protection of my head, Judah, my scepter”

See how you translated this in Psalm 60:7

Psalms 108:8 (#2)

לִי גִלְעָד ׀ וְלִי מְנַשֶּׁה

“To me {is} Gilead; to me {is} Manasseh”

God is using **To me is** as a common expression of his culture to mean “belongs to me” or “is mine.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Gilead belongs to me; Manasseh belongs to me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 108:8 (#3)

וְאֶפְרַיִם מָעוֹז רֹאשִׁי

“and Ephraim {is} the protection of my head”

Here God is speaking of **Ephraim** as if it were **the protection of my head**, meaning a helmet that protects a warrior in battle. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the people of Ephraim are my warriors]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 108:8 (#4)

יְהוּדָה מְחֹקְקִי

“Judah, my scepter”

Here God is speaking of **Judah** as if it were a **scepter**. He means that God rules through the kings of the tribe of Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I rule through the kings of the tribe of Judah]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 108:8 (#5)

יְהוּדָה מְחֹקְקִי

“Judah, my scepter”

God is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Judah is my scepter]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 108:9 (#1)

מוֹאָב ׀ סִיר רַחְצִי עַל־אֱדוֹם אַשְׁלִיךְ נַעֲלִי עָלַי־פְּלֶשֶׁת אֲתָרוֹעָע

“Moab {is} a tub for my washing; over Edom I throw my sandal; over Philistia I shout triumphantly”

See how you translated this in Psalm 60:8.

Psalms 108:9 (#2)

מוֹאָב ׀ סִיר רַחְצִי

“Moab {is} a tub for my washing”

Here God is speaking of **Moab** as if it were **a tub for my washing**. He means that the people of Moab will serve him in a menial way, like servants who bring a basin for washing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate

translation: [The people of Moab are like servants who wash my feet]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 108:9 (#3)

עַל־אֱדוֹם אַשְׁלִיךְ נַעֲלָי

“over Edom I throw my sandal”

Here God is speaking of **Edom** as if it were a servant who removes his sandals. This image shows that Edom will be completely defeated and will serve Israel in the most menial ways. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Edom are like servants who remove my sandals]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 108:10 (#1)

מִמִּי יְ֭בַלֵּנִי עִ֣יר מִבְצָ֑ר מִמִּי נָחַ֖נִי עַד־אֱדֽוֹם

“Who will bring me {into} the strong city? Who will lead me to Edom”

See how you translated this in Psalm 60:9.

Psalms 108:10 (#2)

מִמִּי יְ֭בַלֵּנִי עִ֣יר מִבְצָ֑ר מִמִּי נָחַ֖נִי עַד־אֱדֽוֹם

“Who will bring me {into} the strong city? Who will lead me to Edom”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about **Who will lead me to Edom** before the information about **Who will bring me into the strong city**. Alternate translation: [Who will lead me to Edom? Who will bring me into the strong city?]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 108:10 (#3)

מִמִּי יְ֭בַלֵּנִי עִ֣יר מִבְצָ֑ר

“Who will bring me {into} the strong city”

David assumes that readers will know that **the strong city** refers to a fortified city in Edom, likely its capital. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Who will bring me into the strong capital city of Edom?]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 108:10 (#4)

מִמִּי יְ֭בַלֵּנִי עִ֣יר מִבְצָ֑ר

“Who will bring me {into} the strong city”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Only God can bring me into the strong city.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 108:10 (#5)

מִמִּי נָחַ֖נִי עַד־אֱדֽוֹם

“Who will lead me to Edom”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Only God can lead me to Edom.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 108:11 (#1)

הֲלֹא־אֱלֹהִ֥ים זְנַחְתָּ֗נוּ וְלֹא־תֵצֵ֥א אֱ֝לֹהִ֗ים בְּצִבְאֹתֵֽינוּ

“God, have you not rejected us? And you do not go out with our army, God”

See how you translated this in Psalm 60:10.

Psalms 108:11 (#2)

הֲלֹא־אֱלֹהִ֥ים זְנַחְתָּ֗נוּ

“God, have you not rejected us”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [God, it seems that you have rejected us!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 108:12 (#1)

הָבָה־לָּ֘נוּ֮ עֶזְרָ֪ת מִ֫צָּ֥ר וְשָׁ֣וְא תְּשׁוּעַ֣ת אָדָֽם

“Give to us help against the enemy, and futility {is} the deliverance of man”

See how you translated this in Psalm 60:11.

Psalms 108:12 (#2)

מִצָּ֥ר

“against the enemy”

David is not referring to a specific **enemy**. He means enemies in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [against all of our enemies]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 108:12 (#3)

וְשָׁשְׁוְא תְּשׁוּעַת אָדָם

“and futility {is} the deliverance of man”

Here the word **and** introduces not an additional action but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [since futility is the deliverance of man]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 108:12 (#4)

וְשָׁשְׁוְא תְּשׁוּעַת אָדָם

“and futility {is} the deliverance of man”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **futility**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [since expecting humans to save us is futile]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 108:12 (#5)

תְּשׁוּעַת אָדָם

“the deliverance of man”

David is using this possessive form **the deliverance of man** to mean deliverance that comes from human beings. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [any deliverance by human beings]

See: Possession

Psalms 108:13 (#1)

בֵּאלֹהִים נַעֲשֶׂה־חָיִל וְהוּא יָבְבּוּס צָרֵינוּ

“With God we will accomplish valor; and he, he will trample our adversaries”

See how you translated this in Psalm 60:12.

Psalms 108:13 (#2)

נַעֲשֶׂה־חָיִל

“we will accomplish valor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **valor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [we will succeed valiantly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 108:13 (#3)

וְהוּא יָבְבּוּס צָרֵינוּ

“and he, he will trample our adversaries”

David is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **will trample** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is God who will defeat the enemies. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and it is he who will trample our adversaries]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 108:13 (#4)

וְהוּא יָבְבּוּס צָרֵינוּ

“and he, he will trample our adversaries”

Here David is speaking of God in the third person as **he** even though he has been addressing God directly in the previous verses. This may be to give encouragement to the Israelites who are listening. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the second person to maintain the direct address. Alternate translation: [and you, you will trample our adversaries]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 108:13 (#5)

וְהוּא יָבְבּוּס צָרֵינוּ

“and he, he will trample our adversaries”

Here David is speaking of God as if he were a warrior who would **trample** the enemies underfoot. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this plainly. Alternate translation: [and he, he will completely defeat our adversaries]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 109 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 109 is a "psalm of petition," asking Yahweh to give David relief from his enemies who are falsely accusing him and persecuting him. He also asks Yahweh to curse these people who are enemies of both Yahweh and David.

1. Complaint and accusation (1–5)
2. Curses against enemies (6–20)
3. David's plea for himself (21–29)
4. Praise and confidence (30–31)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Cursing of Enemies

In this psalm, David takes evil very seriously and calls on Yahweh to punish those who are doing evil to himself and others so that the evil will stop. It is important to note that David does not take vengeance personally, but only calls on Yahweh to combat evil and to perform justice, as Yahweh has promised to do.

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Singular and Plural

David refers to his enemies in the singular in verses 6–19 and in the plural in the rest of the psalm. You may want to use the plural throughout the psalm, or you may want to add a footnote at verse 6 that explains that in the section of verses 6–19 David may be speaking of the leader of his enemies or he may be speaking of each one individually.

Psalms 109:1 (#1)

לַֽמְנַצֵּֽחַ

"To the chief musician"

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 109:1 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵ֖י תְּהִלָּתִ֣י

"God of my praise"

Here David is using the possessive form **God of my praise** to describe God as the one whom he praises. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God whom I praise]

See: Possession

Psalms 109:1 (#3)

אַל־תֶּחֱרָֽשׁ

"do not be silent"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not be silent]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 109:2 (#1)

פִּ֤י רָ֣שָׁע וּפִי־מִ֭רְמָה עָלַ֣י פָּתָ֑חוּ

"a wicked mouth and a mouth of deceit open against me"

Here, **mouth** represents people who are speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [wicked and deceitful people speak against me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:2 (#2)

דִּבְּר֣וּ אִ֭תִּי לְשׁ֣וֹן שָׁ֑קֶר

"they speak a tongue of untruth with me"

Here, **tongue** represents the words that people speak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [they speak untrue things concerning me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:3 (#1)

וְדִבְרֵ֣י שִׂנְאָ֣ה סְבָבֻ֑ונִי

"and words of hatred surround me"

Here, **words of hatred** represents people speaking hateful things. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and people surround me saying hateful things]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:4 (#1)

תַּחַת־אַהֲבָתִי

“In return for my love”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Instead of loving me as I love them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:4 (#2)

יִשְׂטְנֻנוּנִי

“they accuse me”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [they accuse me of doing bad things]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:4 (#3)

וַאֲנִי תְפִלָּה

“but I—prayer”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [but I turn to prayer] or [but I continue to pray]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:5 (#1)

וַיָּשִׂימוּ עָלַי רָעָה תַּחַת טוֹבָה

“They put upon me evil in return for good”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **evil** and **good**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [They do evil things to me although I did good things to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:5 (#2)

וְשִׂנְאָה תַּחַת אַהֲבָתִי

“and hatred in return for my love”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **hatred** and **love**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and they hate me although I was loving to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:5 (#3)

וְשִׂנְאָה תַּחַת אַהֲבָתִי

“and hatred in return for my love”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they put hatred upon me in return for my love]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:6 (#1)

הַפְקֵד עָלָיו רָשָׁע

“Appoint a wicked one over him”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please appoint a wicked one over him]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 109:6 (#2)

הַפְקֵד עָלָיו רָשָׁע

“Appoint a wicked one over him”

Here David is speaking as if God would **appoint** a human judge to preside over his enemy. He means that he wants God to bring judgment upon his enemy. If this image does not communicate well in your language, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Appoint a wicked one to judge him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:6 (#3)

רָשָׁע

“a wicked one”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a wicked man]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 109:6 (#4)

וְשָׂטָ֣ן יַעֲמֹ֣ד עַל־יְמִינֽוֹ

“and may an accuser stand at his right hand”

By **an accuser**, David means someone who will bring formal charges against his enemy in court. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and may someone accuse him before that wicked judge of doing evil things]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:7 (#1)

בְּהִשָּׁפְטֽוֹ

“When he is judged”

The expression **is judged** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [When the wicked one judges him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 109:7 (#2)

יֵצֵ֣א רָשָׁ֑ע

“may he come out guilty”

David is using **may he come out guilty** as a common expression of his culture to mean “may the verdict be that he is guilty.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may the verdict be that he is guilty]

See: Idiom

Psalms 109:7 (#3)

וּתְפִלָּתֽוֹ תִּהְיֶ֖ה לַחֲטָאָֽה

“and may his prayer be as sin”

This could mean: (1) The enemy is praying to Yahweh and since his prayer is insincere, Yahweh should count it as sinful. Alternate translation: [and may his prayer be considered as another sin] or (2) The enemy is pleading with the judge, and the judge should count his plea as a further offense. Alternate translation: [and may his plea be considered as an offense]

Psalms 109:8 (#1)

יִהְיוּ־יָמָ֥יו מְעַטִּ֑ים

“May his days be few”

David is using **May his days be few** as a common expression of his culture to mean “May he die soon” or “May he live only a short time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May he live only a short time]

See: Idiom

Psalms 109:8 (#2)

פְּקֻדָּתֽוֹ יִקַּ֖ח אַחֵֽר

“may another take his position”

Here David is speaking of a person’s role or authority as if it were a **position** that someone could physically occupy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may another take his authority] or [may another replace him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:9 (#1)

וְאִשְׁתּ֖וֹ אַלְמָנָֽה

“and his wife a widow”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may his wife be a widow]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:10 (#1)

וְנ֣וֹעַ יְנִיעוּ֣ בָנָ֑יו

“And wandering, may his children wander”

David is repeating forms of the verb **wander** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [And may his children wander far away]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 109:10 (#2)

וְשֹׁאֵ֑לוּ וְדָרְשׁ֥וּ

“and beg and seek”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and beg and seek for food]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:10 (#3)

מֵֽחָרְבוֹתֵיהֶֽם

“from their desolations”

By **their desolations**, David means their ruined homes or destroyed dwellings. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from their destroyed houses]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:11 (#1)

יְנַקֵּ֣שׁ נוֹשֶׁ֣ה

“May a creditor snare”

Here David is speaking as if a creditor were a hunter or trapper who could **snare** the enemy’s possessions. He means that the creditor should seize or take control of everything the enemy owns. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May a creditor take]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:11 (#2)

לְכָל־אֲשֶׁר־לֽוֹ

“all that {is} to him”

David is using **all that is to him** as a common expression of his culture to mean “everything that belongs to him.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everything that belongs to him]

See: Idiom

Psalms 109:11 (#3)

יְגִיעֽוֹ

“his work”

The implication is that **his work** refers to the things that he worked for or the results of his labor. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the things that he worked for]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:12 (#1)

אַל־יְהִי־לֹ֑ו

“May there not be to him”

David is using **May there not be to him** as a common expression of his culture to mean “May he not have.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May he not have]

See: Idiom

Psalms 109:12 (#2)

מֹ֝שֵׁ֗שֶׁךְ חָ֫סֶד

“one} extending covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [someone who is kindly loyal to him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:12 (#3)

חֹ֭וֹנֵן לִיתוֹמָֽיו

“one} pitying his orphans”

The implication is that these would be children who have lost their father due to the curse pronounced against him in the previous verses. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [someone who pities his orphaned children]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:13 (#1)

יְהִי־אַחֲרִיתָ֥וֹ לְהַכְרֵ֑ית

“May his posterity be to cut off”

David is using **be to cut off** as a common expression of his culture to mean "die" or "be destroyed." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May his posterity be destroyed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 109:13 (#2)

יִמַּח שְׁמָם

"may their name be blotted out"

The expression **may their name be blotted out** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [may you blot out their name]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 109:13 (#3)

יִמַּח שְׁמָם

"may their name be blotted out"

Here David is speaking of making people be forgotten as if their names were written words that could be erased or **blotted out**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [may there be no one bearing their name] or [may no one remember their name]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:14 (#1)

יִזָּכֵר ׀ עֲוֹן אֲבֹתָיו אֶל־יְהוָה

"May the sin of his fathers be remembered to Yahweh"

The expression **be remembered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh keep in mind the sin of his fathers] or [May you remember the sin of his fathers]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 109:14 (#2)

אֲבֹתָיו

"his fathers"

David is using the term **fathers** to mean "ancestors." If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his ancestors]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:14 (#3)

וְחַטַּאת אִמּוֹ אַל־תִּמָּח

"and the offense of his mother not be blotted out"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may the offense of his mother not be blotted out]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:14 (#4)

וְחַטַּאת אִמּוֹ אַל־תִּמָּח

"and the offense of his mother not be blotted out"

The expression **not be blotted out** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [and do not blot out the offense of his mother]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 109:14 (#5)

וְחַטַּאת אִמּוֹ אַל־תִּמָּח

"and the offense of his mother not be blotted out"

David is using **not be blotted out** as a common expression of his culture to mean "not be forgiven." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the offense of his mother not be forgiven]

See: Idiom

Psalms 109:14 (#6)

וְחַטַּאת אִמּוֹ אַל־תִּמָּח

“and the offense of his mother not be blotted out”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **offense**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the things that his mother did that offended Yahweh not be blotted out]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:15 (#1)

יִהְיוּ נֶגֶד־יְהוָה תָּמִיד

“May they be before Yahweh continually”

The pronoun **they** refers to the sins of the enemy’s father and mother mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [May those sins be before Yahweh continually]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:15 (#2)

יִהְיוּ נֶגֶד־יְהוָה תָּמִיד

“May they be before Yahweh continually”

Here David is speaking of the sins as if they were objects that could be continually placed **before Yahweh** for him to see. He means he wants Yahweh to notice those sins. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh continually consider them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:15 (#3)

וְיַכְרֵת & זִכְרָם

“and may he cut off their remembrance”

David is using **cut off their remembrance** as a common expression of his culture to mean “destroy anything that would cause people to remember them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and may he destroy anything that would cause people to remember them]

See: Idiom

Psalms 109:15 (#4)

וְיַכְרֵת & זִכְרָם

“and may he cut off their remembrance”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, while the pronoun **their** refers to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and may he cut off any remembrance of those people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:15 (#5)

מֵאֶרֶץ

“from the earth”

Here, **the earth** represents any people living on earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from any people living on earth]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:16 (#1)

לֹא זָכַר׃

“he never remembered”

The pronoun **he** refers to David’s enemy. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [that man never remembered]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:16 (#2)

עֲשֹׂת חֶסֶד

“to do covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to be kind to others]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:16 (#3)

וַיִּרְדֹּף

“but pursued”

Here David is speaking of the man’s treatment of vulnerable people as if he **pursued** them like a hunter chasing prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but harassed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:16 (#4)

אִישׁ־עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן וְנִכְאֵה לֵבָב

“the humble man and the needy and the dejected in heart”

David is not referring to specific **humble** and **needy** and **dejected** people. He means people who were humble and needy and dejected in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use expressions that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people who were humble and needy and dejected in heart]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 109:16 (#5)

וְאֶבְיוֹן וְנִכְאֵה לֵבָב

“and the needy and the dejected in heart”

David is using the adjectives **needy** and **dejected** as nouns to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [and needy people and people dejected in their hearts]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 109:16 (#6)

וְנִכְאֵה לֵבָב

“and the dejected in heart”

Here David is speaking of people as if their emotions were located in their **heart**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and those who felt very sad]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:16 (#7)

לְמוֹתֵת

“to death”

The implication is that he pursued these people until they died. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [until they died]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:17 (#1)

וַתָּבוֹאֵהוּ

“and it came to him”

Here David is speaking as if cursing were an object that physically **came to** someone. He means that the person experienced the effects or consequences of cursing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and now those curses have fallen on him] or [and now I wish those bad things to happen to him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:17 (#2)

וְלֹא־חָפֵץ בִּבְרָכָה

“and he did not delight in blessing”

David is emphasizing a negative meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with a mild expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the negative meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [and he hated blessing]

See: Litotes

Psalms 109:17 (#3)

וַתִּרְחַק מִמֶּנּוּ

“and it was far from him”

Here David is speaking as if blessing were an object that could be physically **far from** his enemy. He means that his enemy will not receive any blessing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will not receive any]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:18 (#1)

וַיִּלְבַּשׁ קְלָלָה כְּמַדּוֹ

“And he put on cursing as his garment”

Here David is speaking of his enemy as if **cursing** were **his garment** that he put on. He means that cursing other people was habitual for this person, like clothing that someone wears regularly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he cursed other people continually]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:18 (#2)

וַתָּבֹא כַמַּיִם בְּקִרְבּוֹ

“and it entered into his inner being like water”

David is making a comparison between **it entered into his inner being like water** and how deeply cursing has become part of his enemy’s character. The point of this comparison is that just as **water** penetrates

thoroughly into a person when they drink, so **cursing** has penetrated deeply into this man's inner being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and it became a part of him like water does when we drink it]

See: Simile

Psalms 109:18 (#3)

וְכַשֶּׁ֥מֶן בְּעַצְמוֹתָֽיו

"and like oil into his bones"

David is making a comparison between how oil soaks into bones and how cursing has become part of his enemy's inner being. The point of this comparison is that just as **oil** penetrates deeply and becomes absorbed, so cursing has become deeply absorbed into the enemy's very nature. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and it became a part of him like oil would after it had entered into his bones]

See: Simile

Psalms 109:18 (#4)

וְכַשֶּׁ֥מֶן בְּעַצְמוֹתָֽיו

"and like oil into his bones"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and it entered into his inner being like oil penetrating his bones]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:19 (#1)

תְּהִי־לֹ֗ו כְּבֶ֫גֶד יַעְטֶ֥ה

"May it be to him like the clothing he wears"

David is making a comparison between curses and **clothing** that someone wears. The point of this comparison is that just as **clothing** clings closely to a person's body, so the curses should cling closely to his enemy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [May it wrap itself tightly to him like the clothing that he wears]

See: Simile

Psalms 109:19 (#2)

תְּהִי־לֹ֗ו כְּבֶ֫גֶד יַעְטֶ֥ה

"May it be to him like the clothing he wears"

The pronoun **it** refers to the cursing mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [May that cursing be to him like the clothing that he wears]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:19 (#3)

וּלְמֵזַ֗ח

"and for the belt"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may it be for him like the belt]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:19 (#4)

וּלְמֵזַ֗ח

"and for the belt"

David is making a comparison. The point of this comparison is that just as **the belt** is something that a person wears constantly, so the curse should cling to his enemy constantly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and may it always be around him as the belt]

See: Simile

Psalms 109:19 (#5)

תָּמִ֥יד יַחְגֹּרֶֽהָ

"he always girds himself with it"

It might seem that the expression **he always girds himself with it** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [he always girds himself with] or [with which he always girds himself]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

Psalms 109:20 (#1)

זֹ֤את

"This"

The pronoun **This** refers to the curse that David has been describing in the previous verses. It may be

helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [May the effects of this curse be]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:20 (#2)

זֹ֣את

“This”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [May the effects of this curse be]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:20 (#3)

זֹ֣את פְּעֻלַּ֣ת

“This, the payment”

Here, **This, the payment** could mean: (1) David is asking Yahweh that this be the payment to his accusers. Alternate translation: [May this be the payment] or (2) David is stating that this is the payment to his accusers. Alternate translation: [This will be the payment]

Psalms 109:20 (#4)

זֹ֣את פְּעֻלַּ֣ת שֹׂטְנַ֣י מֵאֵ֣את יְהוָ֑ה

“This, the payment of my accusers from Yahweh”

Here David is speaking of God’s punishment as if it were **payment** that God gives to David’s accusers. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [This, the punishment of my accusers from Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:20 (#5)

וְהַדֹּבְרִ֖ים רָ֣ע עַל־נַפְשִֽׁי

“and those speaking evil against my soul”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may this be the payment from Yahweh to those speaking evil against my soul]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 109:20 (#6)

וְהַדֹּבְרִ֖ים רָ֣ע עַל־נַפְשִֽׁי

“and those speaking evil against my soul”

Here, **soul** represents the entire person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and those speaking evil against me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:21 (#1)

עֲשֵׂ֣ה־אִתִּ֣י

“do with me”

By **do with me**, David means “treat me kindly” or “act favorably toward me.” You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [do good to me] or [do what I ask]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:21 (#2)

לְמַ֥עַן שְׁמֶ֗ךָ

“on account of your name”

Here, **name** represents who God is or God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on account of your character]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:21 (#3)

כִּי־טֽוֹב חַסְדְּךָ֥

“Because your covenant faithfulness {is} good”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Because you are good and faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:22 (#1)

עָנִ֣י וְאֶבְי֣וֹן אָנֹ֑כִי

“I am poor and needy”

The terms **poor** and **needy** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I am very poor]

See: Doublet

Psalms 109:22 (#2)

וְלִבִּי חָלַל בְּקִרְבִּי

“and my heart breaks within me”

Here David is speaking of his emotional distress as if his **heart breaks** physically. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am in great despair]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:23 (#1)

כְּצֵל־כְּנָטוֹתִי

“Like a shadow when it lengthens”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a shadow when it lengthens** quickly disappears, so David’s life is quickly passing away. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Like how quickly a shadow disappears as it lengthens]

See: Simile

Psalms 109:23 (#2)

נֻהַלָּכְתִּי

“I am made to go”

The expression **I am made to go** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I will leave]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 109:23 (#3)

נִנְעַרְתִּי כָּאַרְבֶּה

“I am shaken off like a locust”

The expression **I am shaken off** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I will fall off like a locust]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 109:23 (#4)

נִנְעַרְתִּי כָּאַרְבֶּה

“I am shaken off like a locust”

David is making a comparison. The point of this comparison is that just as **a locust** is easily shaken off, so David is easily dismissed or removed from his position. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I will disappear as quickly as someone shakes off a locust]

See: Simile

Psalms 109:24 (#1)

בִּבְרָכַי כָּשְׁלָה

“My knees are weak”

Here, **knees** represents the strength of the whole body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [My body is weak]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:24 (#2)

מִצּוֹם

“from fasting”

The word **from** indicates that **fasting** is the reason for the weakness described in the first part of the verse. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that the fasting is the cause of the weakness. Alternate translation: [because of fasting very much]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 109:24 (#3)

וּבְשָׂרִי כָּחַשׁ מִשָּׁמֶן

“and my flesh is gaunt from fatness”

By **my flesh is gaunt from fatness**, David means that his flesh is gaunt from the complete absence of fat. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and my flesh is gaunt, very far from being fat]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:25 (#1)

וַאֲנִי ׀ הָיִיתִי

“And I, I am”

The pronoun **I** is stated twice here for emphasis. David is emphasizing his own condition or state in contrast to his enemies. If a speaker of your language would use explicit pronouns for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing

that meaning here. Alternate translation: [As for me, I am]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:25 (#2)

הָיֵיתִי חֶרְפָּה לָהֶם

“I am a disgrace to them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **disgrace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I am disgusting to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:25 (#3)

יִרְאוּנִי

“they see me”

Here the word that is translated **they see me** does not clearly indicate when the action of seeing occurs. It could mean “whenever they see me” or refer to a specific instance. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [whenever they see me]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 109:25 (#4)

יְנִיעֻן רֹאשָׁם

“they shake their head”

The expression **shake their head** describes a symbolic action by which people showed contempt or mockery. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [they show that they despise me by shaking their heads]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 109:26 (#1)

עָזְרֵנִי

“Help me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please help me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 109:26 (#2)

אֱלֹהָי

“my God”

The psalmist is not using the phrase **my God** to mean that he possesses or controls Yahweh, but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God he worships as modeled in the UST. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion.

See: Possession

Psalms 109:26 (#3)

כְּחַסְדֶּךָ

“according to your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to your covenant to be faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 109:26 (#4)

כְּחַסְדֶּךָ

“according to your covenant faithfulness”

By **according to your covenant faithfulness**, David means according to God’s promise to be faithful to his people. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [since you have promised to be faithful to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:27 (#1)

וְיֵדְעוּ

“so that they know”

Here, **so that** marks **they know that this is your hand; you, Yahweh, you have done it** as the goal or purpose of “Help me, Yahweh my God; save me according to your covenant faithfulness” in the previous verse. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [because I want them to know]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 109:27 (#2)

וְיֵדְעוּ

“so that they know”

The pronoun **they** refers to David’s accusers. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [so that the people who accuse me know]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:27 (#3)

כִּי־יֶ֭דְךָ זֹּ֑את

“that this {is} your hand”

Here, **hand** represents the power of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that this is your doing]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:27 (#4)

אַתָּ֥ה יְהוָ֗ה עָשִׂ֥יתָה

“you, Yahweh, you have done it”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have done it** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one who has acted. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [it is you, Yahweh, who have done it]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:27 (#5)

אַתָּ֥ה יְהוָ֗ה עָשִׂ֥יתָה

“you, Yahweh, you have done it”

The pronoun **it** refers to Yahweh saving David, as he asked Yahweh to do in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [you, Yahweh, are the one who saved me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:28 (#1)

יְקַלְלוּ־הֵ֭מָּה

“They, they will curse”

The pronoun **They** refers to David’s accusers. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The people who accuse me, they will curse]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:28 (#2)

יְקַלְלוּ־הֵ֭מָּה וְאַתָּ֣ה תְבָרֵ֑ךְ

“They, they will curse, but you, you will bless”

David is stating the pronouns **they** and **you** separately for emphasis, even though the verbs translated as **they will curse** and **you will bless** already include their meanings. He is doing that to create a strong contrast between what his enemies will do (curse) and what God will do (bless). If a speaker of your language would use explicit pronouns for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [They are the ones who will curse, but you are the one who will bless]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 109:28 (#3)

קָ֝מוּ

“they arise”

By **they arise**, David means they arise to attack him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they arise to attack me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 109:28 (#4)

וְעַבְדְּךָ֥

“and your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [and I, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 109:29 (#1)

יִלְבְּשׁ֣וּ שׂוֹטְנַ֣י כְּלִמָּ֑ה וְיַעֲטְט֖וּ כַּמְעִ֣יל בָּ֣שְׁתָּֽם

“May my accusers be clothed with disgrace; may they wear their shame like a robe”

These two phrases **May my accusers be clothed with disgrace** and **may they wear their shame like a robe** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases

in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [May my accusers be clothed with shameful disgrace as though it were a robe]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 109:29 (#2)

יִלְבְּשׁוּ שׂוֹטְנַי כְּלִמָּה

“May my accusers be clothed with disgrace”

Here David is speaking of his accusers as if they were people who could be **clothed with disgrace**. He means that their disgrace should be clearly seen and obvious to everyone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May it be obvious how disgraceful my accusers are]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:29 (#3)

וְיַעֲטְוּ כַמְּעִיל בָּשְׁתָּם

“may they wear their shame like a robe”

David is making a comparison between **their shame** and **a robe**. The point of this comparison is that just as a robe is visible to everyone who sees the person wearing it, so David wants his accusers’ shame to be visible and obvious to everyone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [may their shame be so obvious to everyone that it is like a robe that they are wearing]

See: Simile

Psalms 109:30 (#1)

אֹודֶה יְהוָה מְאֹד בְּפִי

“With my mouth I greatly thank Yahweh”

Here, **mouth** represents speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will speak to greatly thank Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 109:30 (#2)

וּבְתוֹךְ רַבִּים

“and in the midst of many”

David is using the adjective **many** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and in the midst of many people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 109:31 (#1)

יַעֲמֹד לִימִין אֶבְיוֹן

“he stands at the right hand of the needy”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a person who could physically **stand at the right hand of the needy**. The image of standing at someone’s right hand means to be ready to help and defend them. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [he advocates for the needy] or [he helps the needy]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 109:31 (#2)

אֶבְיוֹן

“the needy”

David is using the adjective **needy** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [needy people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 109:31 (#3)

מִשֹּׁפְטֵי נַפְשׁוֹ

“from the judges of his soul”

By **the judges of his soul**, David means those who seek to condemn him to death. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from officials who want to take his life]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 110 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 110 is a psalm honoring the king as he becomes king and was also recognized as a prophecy about the coming messiah. (See: prophet, prophecy, prophesy, seer, prophetess; and Christ, Messiah)

1. The divine proclamation (1–2)
2. The people’s response (3)

3. The eternal priesthood (4)
4. The king's judgment & victory (5–7)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

King
Yahweh will enable the king to conquer his enemies. Christ is seen as both high priest and king. (See: high priest, chief priest)

Psalms 110:1 (#1)

שֵׁ֣שֶׁב לִֽימִינִ֑י

"Sit at my right hand"

Yahweh is using **Sit at my right hand** as a common expression of the culture to mean "Take the place of highest honor and authority beside me." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Sit with me in the honored place]

See: Idiom

Psalms 110:1 (#2)

עַד־אָ֭שִׁית אֹיְבֶ֣יךָ הֲדֹ֗ם לְרַגְלֶֽיךָ

"until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet"

Here Yahweh is speaking of defeating enemies as if he were making them into **a footstool for your feet**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [until I give you victory over your enemies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 110:2 (#1)

מַטֵּה־עֻזְּךָ֥ יִשְׁלַ֗ח יְ֭הוָה

"Yahweh will stretch out the scepter of your strength"

Here, **scepter** represents royal authority and power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will expand the area where you strongly rule]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 110:2 (#2)

מַטֵּה־עֻזְּךָ֥

"the scepter of your strength"

David is using the possessive form to describe a **scepter** that is characterized by **strength**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your strong scepter]

See: Possession

Psalms 110:2 (#3)

רְדֵ֥ה

"rule"

The word translated as **rule** is an imperative, but it communicates an invitation to rule rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate an invitation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an invitation. Alternate translation: [I want you to rule]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 110:3 (#1)

עַמְּךָ֣ נְדָבֹ֣ת

"Your people, freewill offerings"

David is speaking of **Your people** as if they were **freewill offerings**. He means that the people will willingly offer themselves to serve the king, just as people willingly bring offerings to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your people are like freewill offerings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 110:3 (#2)

בְּי֣וֹם חֵ֭ילֶךָ

"on the day of your strength"

David is using this possessive form **the day of your strength** to mean when you show how strong you are. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [when you show how strong you are]

See: Possession

Psalms 110:3 (#3)

בְּהַדְרֵי־קֹ֗דֶשׁ

"in the beauty of holiness"

David is using the possessive form to describe a **beauty** that is characterized by **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form

for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in holy beauty]

See: Possession

Psalms 110:3 (#4)

בְּהַדְרֵי־קֹדֶשׁ

“in the beauty of holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the ideas of **beauty** and **holiness**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [they will be beautiful and holy] or [because they are holy, they will be beautiful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 110:3 (#5)

מֵרֶחֶם מִשְׁחָרְךָ לְךָ טַל יַלְדֻתֶיךָ

“from the womb of the dawn, the dew of your youth {is} to you”

Here David is speaking of the king’s youthful vigor as if it were **the dew of your youth** that comes **from the womb of the dawn**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [you will be as fresh as the dew that comes early every morning]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 110:4 (#1)

וְלֹא יִנָּחֵם

“and will not revoke {it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the oath or solemn promise that Yahweh has made and that David is about to repeat. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and will not revoke this oath]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 110:5 (#1)

אֲדֹנָי עַל־יְמִינְךָ

“The Lord {is} at your right hand”

David is using **at your right hand** as a common expression of his culture to mean “near you to help you” or “fighting for you.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The Lord is near you to help you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 110:5 (#2)

אֲדֹנָי

“The Lord {is”

David assumes that readers will know that **The Lord** refers to Yahweh. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 110:5 (#3)

מָחַץ & מְלָכִים

“He crushes kings”

Here David is speaking as if the Lord were a person who physically **crushes kings**. He means that the Lord defeats enemy kings. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He defeats enemy kings]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 110:5 (#4)

בְּיוֹם־אַפּוֹ

“on the day of his nose”

David is using the phrase **the day of his nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean that the Lord is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on the day of his anger] or [when he displays his anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 110:6 (#1)

יָדִין בַּגּוֹיִם

“He will judge the nations”

By **He will judge the nations**, David means that Yahweh will punish the nations for their wickedness. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He will punish the nations]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 110:6 (#2)

בַּגּוֹיִם

“the nations”

Here, **the nations** represents the people who live in the nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people living in many nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 110:6 (#3)

מָלֵא גְוִיּוֹת

“he fills {with} bodies”

By **he fills with bodies**, David means he fills the battlefield with dead bodies. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [he fills the battlefield with dead bodies]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 110:6 (#4)

מָחַץ רֹאשׁ

“he crushes the head”

David is not referring to a specific **head**. He means the heads of the king’s enemies in general. The word translated as **head** could refer to: (1) the heads of the enemy soldiers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh crushes the heads of the enemy soldiers] or (2) the leaders of the enemy armies. Alternate translation: [Yahweh defeats the leaders of the enemy armies]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 110:6 (#5)

עַל־אֶרֶץ רַבָּה

“upon abundant land”

The word translated as **land** could refer to: (1) a battlefield. Alternate translation: [on a large battlefield] or (2) the earth. Alternate translation: [over the whole earth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 110:7 (#1)

יִשְׁתֶּה

“He will drink”

Here, **He** could refer to: (1) the king. Alternate translation: [The king will drink] or (2) Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will drink]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 110:7 (#2)

עַל־כֵּן

“Therefore”

Therefore introduces the result of Yahweh fighting for and strengthening the king, as the previous verses of this psalm describe. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Because Yahweh has fought for him]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 110:7 (#3)

יָרִים רֹאשׁ

“he will lift up the head”

David is using **he will lift up the head** as a common expression of his culture to mean “he will triumph over his enemies.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will triumph over his enemies]

See: Idiom

Psalms - Chapter 111 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 111 is a psalm of praise to God for his miracles and care. (See: miracle, wonder, sign)

1. Call to praise (1–2)
2. Yahweh’s majestic works (3–6)
3. Yahweh’s trustworthy and enduring nature (7–9)
4. Wisdom and praise (10)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s character

God is great. He has given his people food, land, and always keeps his promises to his people. (See: promise, promised; and people of God)

Psalms 111:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the

way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 111:1 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yah-weh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 111:1 (#3)

בְּכָל־לֵבָב

“with the whole heart”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the place where his emotions and will reside as his **heart**. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with my whole heart] or [with all that I am]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 111:1 (#4)

יְשָׁרִים וְעֵדָה

“the upright and congregation”

The phrase **upright and congregation** expresses a single idea. The word **upright** tells more about **congregation**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [the congregation of upright people]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 111:1 (#5)

יְשָׁרִים

“the upright”

The psalmist is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the upright people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 111:2 (#1)

דְּרוּשִׁים לְכָל־חֶפְצֵיהֶם

“searched by everyone desirous of them”

The expression **searched by everyone desirous of them** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [everyone desirous of them searches them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 111:2 (#2)

דְּרוּשִׁים לְכָל־חֶפְצֵיהֶם

“searched by everyone desirous of them”

The psalmist is using the adjective **desirous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [searched by everyone who desires them]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 111:2 (#3)

דְּרוּשִׁים לְכָל־חֶפְצֵיהֶם

“searched by everyone desirous of them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the works of Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [they are searched by everyone desirous of his works]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 111:2 (#4)

דְּרוּשִׁים

“searched”

This could mean: (1) people examine and study Yahweh’s works. Alternate translation: [studied] or (2) people are looking for Yahweh to do his works. Alternate translation: [eagerly awaited]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 111:3 (#1)

הוֹד־וְהָדָר פָּעֳלֹו

“His work {is} splendor and majesty”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **splendor** and **majesty**, you could express the

same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [His work is splendid and majestic]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 111:3 (#2)

וְצִדְקָתוֹ עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד

“and his righteousness stands forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and he is righteous forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 111:3 (#3)

וְצִדְקָתוֹ עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד

“and his righteousness stands forever”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God’s righteousness as if it were a structure that **stands forever**. He means that God’s righteousness is permanent and will never change or fail. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and his righteousness endures forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 111:4 (#1)

זֵכֶר עָשָׂה לְנִפְלְאֹתָיו

“He makes a remembrance for his wonders”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **remembrance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He makes sure that people will always remember the wonderful things that he does]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 111:5 (#1)

לִירֵאָיו

“to those fearing him”

The psalmist is using the adjective **fearing** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to the people who fear him]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 111:5 (#2)

יִזְכֹּר לְעוֹלָם בְּרִיתוֹ

“He remembers his covenant forever”

This means that Yahweh will always act according to his covenant. See how you translated this in Psalm 105:8. Alternate translation: [He will honor his covenant forever]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 111:6 (#1)

כֹּ֭חַ מַעֲשָׂיו

“the power of his works”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **works** that are characterized by **power**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his powerful works]

See: Possession

Psalms 111:6 (#2)

לָתֵת לָהֶם

“to give to them”

The implication is that Yahweh showed his power by means of giving his people the lands that had belonged to other nations as their inheritance. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [by giving to them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 111:6 (#3)

נַחֲלַת גּוֹיִם

“the inheritance of the nations”

The implication is that this refers to the land that belonged to other nations. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [land that belonged to other nations]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 111:7 (#1)

מַעֲשֵׂי יָ֝דָיו

“The works of his hands”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the things that God does as if they were **the works of his hands**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All the things that he does]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 111:7 (#2)

אֱמֶת֥ וּמִשְׁפָּ֗ט

“are} truth and justice”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **truth** and **justice**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [are true and just]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 111:7 (#3)

נֶאֱמָנִ֥ים כָּל־פִּקּוּדָֽיו

“all of his precepts are reliable”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know that **precepts** refers to God’s commands and instructions. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [We can rely on all of his instructions]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 111:8 (#1)

סְמוּכִ֥ים לָעַ֗ד

“They are established forever”

The expression **They are established** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [He established them to last forever]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 111:8 (#2)

לָעַ֣ד לְעוֹלָ֑ם

“forever, for eternity”

The terms **forever** and **for eternity** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Doublet

Psalms 111:8 (#3)

עֲשׂוּיִ֥ם בֶּאֱמֶ֗ת וְיָשָׁ֑ר

“done in faithfulness, and upright”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you can state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. This could mean: (1) Yahweh has given his instructions in a faithful and proper manner. Alternate translation: [made faithfully and uprightly] or (2) his people are to observe Yahweh’s instructions in a faithful and proper manner. Alternate translation: [for his people to observe faithfully and properly]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 111:8 (#4)

עֲשׂוּיִ֥ם בֶּאֱמֶ֗ת

“done in faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [done faithfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 111:8 (#5)

וְיָשָׁ֑ר

“and upright”

The psalmist is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean upright things or upright instructions. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and they are instructions that are upright]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 111:9 (#1)

פְּדוּת֮ ׀ שָׁלַ֪ח לְעַמּ֫וֹ

“He has sent redemption to his people”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **redemption**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [He has redeemed his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 111:9 (#2)

קָד֖וֹשׁ וְנוֹרָ֣א שְׁמֽוֹ

“holy and awesome {is} his name”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is holy and awesome]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 111:10 (#1)

יִרְאַ֣ת יְהוָ֑ה

“The fear of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean a deep reverence for Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. See how you translated this in Psalm 19:9. Alternate translation: [Revering Yahweh]

See: Possession

Psalms 111:10 (#2)

רֵ֣אשִׁ֣ית חָכְמָ֑ה

“is} the beginning of wisdom”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wisdom**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is how a person begins to become wise]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 111:10 (#3)

שֵׂ֥כֶל טֹ֗וב לְכָל־עֹשֵׂיהֶ֥ם

“good understanding to all those doing them”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [all those doing them will gain a good understanding of how to live well]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 111:10 (#4)

לְכָל־עֹשֵׂיהֶ֥ם

“to all those doing them”

The pronoun **them** refers to Yahweh’s precepts, mentioned in verse 7. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to all those doing his precepts]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 111:10 (#5)

תְּהִלָּתֹ֥ו עֹמֶ֗דֶת לָעַ֫ד

“His praise stands forever”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **praise** as if it were something that could **stand** in the sense of remaining upright and stable. He means that God will be praised forever. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His praise endures forever] or [He is to be praised forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 112 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 112 is a “wisdom psalm” teaching the value of a righteous life. (See: wise, wisdom; and righteous, righteousness, unrighteous, unrighteousness, upright, uprightness)

1. The blessings of the Yahweh-fearing (1–3)
2. The character and security of the upright (4–9)
3. The contrast with the wicked (10)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Righteous people

The righteous people will be well-known for their generosity and they will not have to worry about bad news because God is taking care of them.

Psalms 112:1 (#1)

הַֽלְלוּ־יָ֑הּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 112:1 (#2)

יָ֑הּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 112:1 (#3)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is] or [Truly blessed is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 112:1 (#4)

אִישׁ

“the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means any man who fears Yahweh. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [anyone]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 112:1 (#5)

בְּמִצְוֹתָיו חָפֵץ מְאֹד

“greatly delighting in his commandments”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [how happy is the one who greatly delights in his commandments]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 112:2 (#1)

זַרְעוֹ

“His seed”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the man’s children as if they were **seed** that he had planted. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His offspring]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:2 (#2)

דּוֹר יְשָׁרִים יְבֹרָךְ

“a generation of upright ones will be blessed”

The expression **will be blessed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will bless a generation of upright ones]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 112:2 (#3)

דּוֹר יְשָׁרִים

“a generation of upright ones”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **a generation** that is characterized by being **upright**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [everyone who is upright]

See: Possession

Psalms 112:3 (#1)

הוֹן־וָעֹשֶׁר

“Wealth and riches”

The terms **Wealth** and **riches** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Abundant riches]

See: Doublet

Psalms 112:3 (#2)

בְּבֵיתוֹ

“are} in his house”

The psalmist is using the term **house** to mean an entire household living together. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [belong to his household]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 112:3 (#3)

בְּבֵיתוֹ

“are} in his house”

The pronoun **his** refers to the man who fears Yahweh mentioned in verse 1. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [belong to such a person]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 112:3 (#4)

וְצִדְקָתוֹ

“and his righteousness”

The pronoun **his** refers to the man who fears Yahweh from verse 1. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and the righteousness of such a person]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 112:3 (#5)

וְצִדְקָתוֹ

“and his righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and each righteous thing that he does]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 112:3 (#6)

עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד

“stands forever”

This could mean: (1) Yahweh and/or people will always remember the righteous things that such a person does. Alternate translation: [continues to be remembered forever] or (2) Such people never stop doing righteous deeds. Alternate translation: [keeps going continually]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:4 (#1)

זָרַח בַּחֹשֶׁךְ אוֹר לַיְשָׁרִים

“Light shines in the darkness for the upright ones”

Here, **Light** could be: (1) the subject of the verb **shines** as in the ULT, or (2) the object of the verb **shines**, and then the subject of the verb would be “he,” continuing the subject of the previous verse. Alternate translation: [He shines light in the darkness for the upright]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 112:4 (#2)

זָרַח בַּחֹשֶׁךְ אוֹר לַיְשָׁרִים

“Light shines in the darkness for the upright ones”

The psalmist speaks of God blessing the upright person in difficult times as if his blessings were a **light** shining in darkness. Alternate translation: [The blessings that an upright person receives from God are like a light that shines in the darkness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:4 (#3)

חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם וְצַדִּיק

“gracious and compassionate and just”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [such a person is gracious and compassionate and just]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 112:5 (#1)

טוֹב־אִישׁ חוֹנֵן וּמַלְוֶה

“a gracious and lending man {is} good”

This could mean: (1) it is good to be person who is gracious and lends freely. Alternate translation: [It is good to be a gracious and lending man] or (2) good things will happen to a man who is gracious and lending. Alternate translation: [Life goes well for a gracious and lending man]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 112:5 (#2)

אִישׁ חוֹנֵן וּמַלְוֶה

“a gracious and lending man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [a gracious and lending person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 112:5 (#3)

יְכַלְכֵּל דְּבָרָיו בְּמִשְׁפָּט

“he conducts his affairs with justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he is just in all his dealings]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 112:6 (#1)

כִּי־לְעוֹלָם לֹא־יִמּוֹט

“For he will not be moved for forever”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [He does this because he will not be moved for forever]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 112:6 (#2)

כִּי־לְעוֹלָם לֹא־יִמּוֹט

“For he will not be moved for forever”

The expression **he will not be moved** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [For nothing will move him for forever]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 112:6 (#3)

כִּי־לְעוֹלָם לֹא־יִמּוֹט

“For he will not be moved for forever”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the righteous person as if he were an object that could be **moved** from its place. He means that nothing will cause the righteous person to fail or be overcome by difficulties. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For nothing will ever cause him to fail]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:6 (#4)

צַדִּיק

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 112:6 (#5)

לְזֵכֶר עוֹלָם יִהְיֶה

“will be for an eternal remembrance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **remembrance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [will always be remembered]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 112:7 (#1)

נָכוֹן לִבּוֹ

“his heart is sure”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and motives exist. The psalmist is speaking of a person’s inner confidence as if it were **sure**, meaning firmly established or steadfast. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he is confident]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:8 (#1)

סָמוּךְ לִבּוֹ

“His heart is upheld”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and motives exist. The psalmist is speaking of the righteous person’s emotional state as if his **heart** were **upheld** or supported, meaning that he is calm. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He is tranquil]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:8 (#2)

עַד אֲשֶׁר־יִרְאֶה בְצָרָיו

“until he looks over his adversaries”

The implication is that the righteous person will remain confident and unafraid while God vindicates him by defeating his enemies. This does not mean that he will begin to fear when he sees his enemies. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [all the way to the time that he looks triumphantly over his adversaries]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 112:9 (#1)

פִּזַּר ׀ נָתַן

“He scatters, he gives”

The terms **scatters** and **gives** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [He gives generously]

See: Doublet

Psalms 112:9 (#2)

לָאֶבְיוֹנִֽים

“to the poor”

The psalmist is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to anyone who is poor]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 112:9 (#3)

צִדְקָתוֹ עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד

“his righteousness stands forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his righteous works stand forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 112:9 (#4)

צִדְקָתוֹ עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד

“his righteousness stands forever”

This could mean: (1) Yahweh and/or people will always remember the righteous things that such a person does. Alternate translation: [his righteousness continues to be remembered forever] or (2) Such people never stop doing righteous deeds. Alternate translation: [his righteousness keeps going continually]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:9 (#5)

קַרְנוֹ תָּרוּם בְּכָבוֹד

“his horn is high with honor”

The psalmist is using **his horn is high** as a common expression of the culture to mean “he is honored and respected by others.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people respect and honor him]

See: Idiom

Psalms 112:10 (#1)

רָשָׁע יִרְאֶה

“The wicked will see”

The implication is that the wicked will see the prosperity and honor of the righteous person described in the previous verses. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The wicked will see these things happen]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 112:10 (#2)

רָשָׁע יִרְאֶה

“The wicked will see”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Wicked people will see]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 112:10 (#3)

שִׁנָּיו יַחֲרֹק

“he will grind his teeth”

The grinding of teeth is an expression of extreme anger. See how you translated a similar phrase in Psalms 35:16. Alternate translation: [he will grind his teeth in rage]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 112:10 (#4)

וְנָמָס

“and he will melt away”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the wicked person as if he were something that could **melt away** like ice or wax. He means that the wicked person will become unimportant and die. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will become unimportant and die]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 112:10 (#5)

תַּאֲוַת רְשָׁעִים תֹּאבֵד

“the desire of the wicked will perish”

Here, **desire** could mean: (1) the emotional desire that wicked people have to do wicked things. Alternate translation: [the things that wicked people want to do will never happen] or (2) it represents the things that wicked people have desired. Alternate translation: [wicked people will lose the things that they desired to have]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 113 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 113 is a "psalm of praise" to God for his goodness. (See: good, right, pleasant, better, best, goodness)

1. The call to universal and eternal praise (1–3)
2. The greatness of Yahweh's majesty (4–6)
3. The grace of Yahweh's compassion (7–9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh's help

God helps the poor and gives children to the wife who cannot conceive children.

Psalms 113:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ יָהּ

"Hallelu Yah"

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 113:1 (#2)

יָהּ

"Yah"

Yah is a shortened form of the name "Yahweh," the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 113:1 (#3)

הַלְלוּ אֶת־שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה

"praise the name of Yahweh"

Here, **name** represents who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [praise everything about Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 113:2 (#1)

יְהִי שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה מְבֹרָךְ

"Blessed be the name of Yahweh"

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [We bless Yahweh] or [Let us all praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 113:2 (#2)

יְהִי שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה מְבֹרָךְ

"Blessed be the name of Yahweh"

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Let us bless the name of Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 113:2 (#3)

יְהִי שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה מְבֹרָךְ

"Blessed be the name of Yahweh"

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Blessed be Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 113:2 (#4)

מֵעַתָּה וְעַד־עוֹלָם

"from now and to forever"

The psalmist is referring to all of time by naming two extremes, **now** and **to forever**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for all eternity]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 113:3 (#1)

מִמִּזְרַח־שֶׁמֶשׁ עַד־מְבוֹאֹו

“From the rising of the sun to its setting”

The psalmist is referring to all of the earth by naming two extremes, **the rising of the sun** and **its setting**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [All over the earth]

See: Merism

Psalms 113:3 (#2)

מְמֻהָלָּל שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה

“may the name of Yahweh be praised”

The expression **may the name of Yahweh be praised** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [may people praise the name of Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 113:3 (#3)

מְמֻהָלָּל שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה

“may the name of Yahweh be praised”

Here, **name** represents who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [may Yahweh be praised] or [may everything about Yahweh be praised]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 113:4 (#1)

רָרֵם עַל־כָּל־גּוֹיִם ׀ יְהוָה

“Yahweh is high above all nations”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were physically **high above** the nations, like someone standing on a mountain looking down. This image emphasizes Yahweh’s supreme authority and power over all earthly kingdoms. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is supreme over all nations]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 113:4 (#2)

עַל הַשָּׁמַיִם כְּבוֹדֹו

“his glory above the skies”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [his glory is high above the skies]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 113:4 (#3)

עַל הַשָּׁמַיִם כְּבוֹדֹו

“his glory above the skies”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **glory** as if it were positioned **above the skies**. The psalmist means that Yahweh’s glory is greater than anything that can be seen in the heavens. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his glory exceeds anything visible from earth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 113:4 (#4)

עַל הַשָּׁמַיִם כְּבוֹדֹו

“his glory above the skies”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he is more glorious than anything visible from earth]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 113:5 (#1)

מִי כַיהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“Who is like Yahweh our God”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis, which begins here and continues through verse 6. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [There is no one like Yahweh our God]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 113:5 (#2)

הַמַּגְבִּיהִי לָשָׁבֶת

“the one making high to sit”

The psalmist is using **the one making high to sit** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the one who sits on high” or “the one who rules in the highest position.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one sitting on high] or [the one who rules in the highest position]

See: Idiom

Psalms 113:6 (#1)

הַמַּשְׁפִּילִי לִרְאוֹת בַּשָּׁמַיִם וּבָאָרֶץ

“the one making low to look on the sky and on the earth”

This is the second part of the question form that began in verse 5. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for the purpose of creating emphasis as this does, you could translate these two verses as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [the one making low to look on the sky and on the earth.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 113:6 (#2)

הַמַּשְׁפִּילִי לִרְאוֹת בַּשָּׁמַיִם וּבָאָרֶץ

“the one making low to look on the sky and on the earth”

The psalmist is using **the one making low to look** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the one who humbles himself to look” or “the one who condescends to look.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who lowers himself to look down on the sky and on the earth]

See: Idiom

Psalms 113:7 (#1)

מְקִימִי מֵעָפָר דָּל מֵאַשְׁפֹּת יָרִים אֶבְיוֹן

“raising up the poor from the dust, he lifts the needy from the garbage”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [raising up the poor from the dust, yes, he lifts the needy from the garbage]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 113:7 (#2)

מְקִימִי מֵעָפָר דָּל מֵאַשְׁפֹּת יָרִים אֶבְיוֹן

“raising up the poor from the dust, he lifts the needy from the garbage”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the extremely poor condition of needy people as if they were sitting in **dust** and **garbage**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he takes the poor out of their dirty and poor condition]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 113:7 (#3)

מְקִימִי מֵעָפָר דָּל מֵאַשְׁפֹּת יָרִים אֶבְיוֹן

“raising up the poor from the dust, he lifts the needy from the garbage”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **poor** and **needy** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [raising up poor people from the dust, he lifts needy people from the garbage]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 113:8 (#1)

לְהוֹשִׁיבִי עִם־נְדִיבִים

“to seat him with princes”

The psalmist is using **to seat him with princes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “to give him a position of honor and authority.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state

the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to cause him to rule with princes]

See: Idiom

Psalms 113:8 (#2)

לְהוֹשִׁיבִ֥י עִם־נְדִיבִ֑ים

“to seat him with princes”

The pronoun **him** refers to the poor person mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [to seat the poor person with princes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 113:8 (#3)

עִ֝֗עִם נְדִיבֵ֥י עַמּֽוֹ

“with the princes of his people”

The phrase **with the princes of his people** clarifies who the princes are from the previous phrase. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [that is, to seat him with the princes of his people]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 113:8 (#4)

עִ֝֗עִם נְדִיבֵ֥י עַמּֽוֹ

“with the princes of his people”

Here, **his** could refer to: (1) Yahweh. Alternate translation: [with the princes of Yahweh’s people] or (2) the poor person. Alternate translation: [with the princes of the man’s people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 113:9 (#1)

מוֹשִׁיבִ֤י ׀ עֲקֶ֥רֶת הַבַּ֗יִת אֵם־הַבָּנִ֥ים שְׂמֵחָ֑ה

“He causes the barren woman of the house to dwell, the joyful mother of children”

The implication is that God transforms a barren woman into a mother by giving her children. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He causes a woman who is barren to become the joyful mother of children]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 113:9 (#2)

מוֹשִׁיבִ֤י ׀ עֲקֶ֥רֶת הַבַּ֗יִת

“He causes the barren woman of the house to dwell”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **barren woman**. He means barren women in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [He causes barren women of their houses to dwell]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 113:9 (#3)

הַלְלוּ־יָֽהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 113:9 (#4)

יָֽהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 114 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 114 is a “psalm of praise” to God for his miracles in bringing the people of Israel to the promised land. (See: miracle, wonder, sign; and Promised Land)

1. God claims his people (1–2)
2. Creation’s astonished response (3–6)
3. Earth’s reverent awe (7–8)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Praise
The psalmist praises God for all the ways he helped his people in the past. This psalm references many miraculous events the Israelites experienced like the parting of the Sea of Reeds (Red Sea), the reversal of the Jordan River, bringing water from a rock, and the awe-inspiring presence of God at Mount Sinai, with creation itself responding, as the earth trembled with, God's power as he delivered his people from Egypt and led them to the land he had promised them.

Psalms 114:1 (#1)

בְּצֵאת יִשְׂרָאֵל מִמִּצְרָיִם בֵּית יַעֲקֹב מֵעַם לֹעֵז

"When Israel went out from Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people speaking a foreign language"

These two phrases **When Israel went out from Egypt** and **the house of Jacob from a people speaking a foreign language** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [When Israel went out from Egypt, that is, the house of Jacob from a people speaking a foreign language]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 114:1 (#2)

יִשְׂרָאֵל

"Israel"

Here, **Israel** represents the Israelite people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Israelites]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 114:1 (#3)

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב מֵעַם לֹעֵז

"the house of Jacob from a people speaking a foreign language"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [when the house of Jacob went out from a people speaking a foreign language]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 114:1 (#4)

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב

"the house of Jacob"

Here, **the house of Jacob** represents the descendants of Jacob. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Jacob's descendants]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 114:2 (#1)

הָיְתָה יְהוּדָה לְקָדְשׁוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל מַמְשְׁלוֹתָיו

"Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his realm"

Here, **Judah** and **Israel** could refer to: (1) the territories of Judah and Israel, since the previous verse talks about leaving the territory of Egypt, as modeled in the UST, or (2) the people of Judah and Israel. Alternate translation: [The people of Judah became those among whom Yahweh lived, the people of Israel became those over whom he ruled]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 114:2 (#2)

הָיְתָה יְהוּדָה לְקָדְשׁוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל מַמְשְׁלוֹתָיו

"Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his realm"

The pronoun **his** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Judah became Yahweh's sanctuary, Israel Yahweh's realm]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 114:2 (#3)

יִשְׂרָאֵל מַמְשְׁלוֹתָיו

"Israel his realm"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and Israel became his realm]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 114:3 (#1)

הַיָּם רָאָה וַיָּנֹס

“The sea looked and fled”

The psalmist is speaking of **the sea** as if it were a living thing that could look and flee. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The sea parted as they approached]

See: Personification

Psalms 114:3 (#2)

הַיַּרְדֵּן יִסֹּב לְאָחוֹר

“the Jordan turned backward”

The psalmist is speaking of **the Jordan** as if it were a living thing that could turn around and go in the opposite direction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the water of the Jordan flowed away]

See: Personification

Psalms 114:4 (#1)

הֶֽהָרִים רָקְדוּ כְאֵילִלִּים גְּבָעוֹת כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“The mountains skipped like rams, the hills like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is speaking of **mountains** and **hills** as if they were living things that could skip and jump. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The mountains seemed to skip like rams, the hills like sons of the flock]

See: Personification

Psalms 114:4 (#2)

גְּבָעוֹת כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“the hills like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the hills skipped like sons of the flock]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 114:4 (#3)

כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is using **sons of the flock** as a common expression of the culture to mean “lambs.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as if they were lambs]

See: Idiom

Psalms 114:5 (#1)

מַה־לְּךָ הַיָּם כִּי תָנֻוס

“What {is} to you, sea, that you flee”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [It is amazing that the sea would flee away!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 114:5 (#2)

מַה־לְּךָ הַיָּם כִּי תָנֻוס

“What {is} to you, sea, that you flee”

The psalmist is speaking to the **sea** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about God’s mighty power over creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the sea. Alternate translation: [What happened to the sea, that it flees]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 114:5 (#3)

מַה־לְּךָ

“What {is} to you”

The psalmist is using **What is to you** as a common expression of the culture to mean “What is the matter with you?” or “What is wrong with you?” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What is the matter with you] or [What is wrong with you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 114:5 (#4)

הַיַּרְדֵּן תִּסֹּב לְאָחוֹר

“Jordan, you turn backwards”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [What is to you, Jordan, that you turn backwards]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 114:5 (#5)

הַיַּרְדֵּן תִּסֹּב לְאָחוֹר

“Jordan, you turn backwards”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [It is amazing that the Jordan would turn backwards!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 114:5 (#6)

הַיַּרְדֵּן תִּסֹּב לְאָחוֹר

“Jordan, you turn backwards”

The psalmist is speaking to **Jordan** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about God’s power over creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the Jordan. Alternate translation: [What happened to the Jordan, that it turns backwards]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 114:6 (#1)

הֶֽהָרִים תִּרְקְדוּ כְאֵילִלִּים גְּבָעוֹת כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“Mountains, you skip like rams, hills, like sons of the flock”

See how you translated these similar phrases in verse 4.

Psalms 114:6 (#2)

הֶֽהָרִים תִּרְקְדוּ כְאֵילִלִּים

“Mountains, you skip like rams”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context of the previous verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [What is to you, mountains, that you skip like rams]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 114:6 (#3)

הֶֽהָרִים תִּרְקְדוּ כְאֵילִלִּים

“Mountains, you skip like rams”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [It is amazing that the mountains would skip like rams!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 114:6 (#4)

הֶֽהָרִים תִּרְקְדוּ כְאֵילִלִּים

“Mountains, you skip like rams”

The psalmist is speaking of **Mountains** as if they were living things that could **skip**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why did the mountains seem to skip like rams]

See: Personification

Psalms 114:6 (#5)

הֶֽהָרִים תִּרְקְדוּ כְאֵילִלִּים

“Mountains, you skip like rams”

The psalmist is speaking to **Mountains** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about God’s power displayed in creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the mountains. Alternate translation: [What happened to the mountains, that they skip like rams]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 114:6 (#6)

גְּבָעוֹת כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“hills, like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context of the previous verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [what is to you, hills, that you skip like sons of the flock]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 114:6 (#7)

גְּבָעוֹת כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“hills, like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [it is amazing that the hills would skip like sons of the flock!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 114:6 (#8)

גְּבָעוֹת כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“hills, like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is speaking of **hills** as if they were living things that could skip. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [why did the hills seem to skip like sons of the flock]

See: Personification

Psalms 114:6 (#9)

גְּבָעוֹת כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“hills, like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is speaking to **hills** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about God’s power displayed in creation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the hills. Alternate translation: [what happened to the hills, that they skip like sons of the flock]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 114:6 (#10)

כִּבְנֵי־צֹאן

“like sons of the flock”

The psalmist is using **sons of the flock** as a common expression of the culture to mean “lambs.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as if they were lambs]

See: Idiom

Psalms 114:7 (#1)

מִלִּפְנֵי אָדוֹן חוּלִי אָרֶץ מִלִּפְנֵי אֱלוֹהַּ יַעֲקֹב

“Tremble, earth, from to the face of the Lord, from to the face of the God of Jacob”

The psalmist has asked in the previous verse why the mountains and hills moved, so this verse provides the answer: it is because of the presence of the Lord. But this verse also is an exhortation to the people who live on the earth to tremble with respect before the powerful God of Jacob. So **earth** here probably refers both to the physical earth and to the people who live on it. You may want to use the parallel structure to bring out both meanings. Alternate translation: [Tremble, earth, from to the face of the Lord, you people of earth, from to the face of the God of Jacob]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 114:7 (#2)

מִלִּפְנֵי אָדוֹן חוּלִי אָרֶץ מִלִּפְנֵי אֱלוֹהַּ יַעֲקֹב

“Tremble, earth, from to the face of the Lord, from to the face of the God of Jacob”

These two phrases **from to the face of the Lord** and **from to the face of the God of Jacob** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation as modeled in the UST. If, however, it would be more clear in your language, you could combine the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Tremble, earth, from to the face of the Lord, the mighty God of Jacob]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 114:7 (#3)

חוּלִי אָרֶץ

“Tremble, earth”

The psalmist is speaking to the **earth** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about God’s awesome power and presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the earth. Alternate translation: [The earth must tremble]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 114:7 (#4)

מִלִּפְנֵי אָדוֹן

“from to the face of the Lord”

The psalmist is using **from to the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of the presence of” or “on account of the presence of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of the presence of the Lord] or [on account of the Lord’s presence]

See: Idiom

Psalms 114:7 (#5)

מִלִּפְנֵי אֱלוֹהַּ יַעֲקֹב

“from to the face of the God of Jacob”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [tremble, earth, from to the face of the God of Jacob]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 114:8 (#1)

הַהֹפְכִי הַצּוּר אֲגַם־מָיִם חַלָּמִישׁ לְמַעְיְנוֹ־מָיִם

“the one turning the rock into a pool of water, flint into a spring of water”

These two phrases **turning the rock into a pool of water** and **flint into a spring of water** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the one turning the rock into a pool of water, even flint into a spring of water]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 114:8 (#2)

הַהֹפְכִי הַצּוּר אֲגַם־מָיִם חַלָּמִישׁ לְמַעְיְנוֹ־מָיִם

“the one turning the rock into a pool of water, flint into a spring of water”

Here the psalmist is speaking as though God turned **rock** into **water**. He means that God miraculously made water come out from solid rock for the Israelites in the wilderness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one making a pool of water come out of the rock, a spring of water come out of flint]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 114:8 (#3)

חַלָּמִישׁ לְמַעְיְנוֹ־מָיִם

“flint into a spring of water”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the one turning flint into a spring of water]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms - Chapter 115 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 115 is a “psalm of praise.”

1. Glory belongs to Yahweh alone (1–3)
2. Futility of idols (4–8)
3. Call for God’s people to trust Yahweh (9–11)
4. Yahweh’s Faithfulness and Blessing (12–15)
5. Life, praise, and hope in the living God (16–18)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s power

Yahweh is in heaven and is able to do whatever he wants. Idols can not do anything. Therefore, people and priests should trust Yahweh for their protection.

Psalms 115:1 (#1)

לֹא לָנוּ יְהוָה לֹא לָנוּ

“Not to us, Yahweh, not to us”

The psalmist is using the repetition for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Not at all to us, Yahweh]

See: Poetry

Psalms 115:1 (#2)

כִּי־לְשִׁמְךָ תֵּתֵן כָּבוֹד

“but to your name give honor”

The phrase **but to your name give honor** is an imperative, but rather than commanding, it is expressing a desire that something happen or that someone do something. If the imperative does not communicate this for your readers, then use a form in your language to indicate the speaker is expressing what he wants someone to do or what he wishes someone would do. Alternate translation: [but people should instead honor your name]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 115:1 (#3)

כִּי־לְשִׁמְךָ תֵּתֵּן כָּבוֹד

“but to your name give honor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **honor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [but let people honor your name]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 115:1 (#4)

כִּי־לְשִׁמְךָ תֵּתֵּן כָּבוֹד

“but to your name give honor”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but let people honor you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 115:1 (#5)

עַל־חַסְדְּךָ עַל־אֲמִתֶּךָ

“upon your covenant faithfulness, upon your trustworthiness”

The word translated as **upon** could mean: (1) the psalmist wants Yahweh to be honored for demonstrating his covenant faithfulness and trustworthiness, as in the UST, or (2) Yahweh deserves honor because of his covenant faithfulness and trustworthiness. Alternate translation: [because of your covenant faithfulness and trustworthiness]

Psalms 115:1 (#6)

עַל־חַסְדְּךָ עַל־אֲמִתֶּךָ

“upon your covenant faithfulness, upon your trustworthiness”

If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [by seeing your covenant faithfulness and by seeing your trustworthiness]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 115:1 (#7)

עַל־חַסְדְּךָ עַל־אֲמִתֶּךָ

“upon your covenant faithfulness, upon your trustworthiness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **trustworthiness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because they see that you are faithful to your covenant and that you are trustworthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 115:2 (#1)

לָמָּה יֹאמְרוּ הַגּוֹיִם

“Why should the nations say”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [The nations should not say]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 115:2 (#2)

אַיֵּה־נָּא אֱלֹהֵיהֶם

“Where, then, {is} their God”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Their God is doing nothing.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 115:3 (#1)

וֵאלֹהֵינוּ בַּשָּׁמָיִם

“And our God {is} in heaven”

Here the word **And** is not introducing something additional, but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show

how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [To that I say, our God is in heaven]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 115:4 (#1)

עֲעַצַּבֵּיהֶם

“Their idols”

The pronoun **Their** refers to the nations mentioned in verse 2. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The idols of the nations]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 115:4 (#2)

מַעֲשֵׂי יְדֵי אָדָם

“the work of the hands of man”

Here, **hands of man** represents the craftsmanship and ability of people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [the work of men] or [made by men]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 115:5 (#1)

פֶּה־לָהֶם

“A mouth {is} to them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the idols mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [A mouth is to those idols]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 115:5 (#2)

פֶּה־לָהֶם

“A mouth {is} to them”

The psalmist is using **A mouth is to them** as a common expression of the culture to mean “They have mouths.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They have mouths]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:5 (#3)

עֵינַיִם לָהֶם

“eyes {are} to them”

The psalmist is using **eyes are to them** as a common expression of the culture to mean “they have eyes.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those idols have eyes]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:6 (#1)

אָזְנַיִם לָהֶם

“ears {are} to them”

The psalmist is using **ears are to them** as a common expression of the culture to mean “they have ears.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those idols have ears]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:6 (#2)

אַף לָהֶם

“a nose {is} to them”

The psalmist is using **a nose is to them** as a common expression of the culture to mean “they have a nose.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they have a nose]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:7 (#1)

יְדֵיהֶם

“Their hands”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [The idols have their hands]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 115:7 (#2)

רַגְלֵיהֶם

“their feet”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [they have their feet]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 115:8 (#1)

עֹשֵׂיהֶם

“Their makers”

The pronoun **Their** refers to the idols mentioned in verse 4. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The makers of those idols]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 115:8 (#2)

כָּהֶמָּה יִהְיוּ

“are like them”

By **are like them**, the psalmist means that the people who make idols become as powerless and lifeless as the idols they create. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [are like them, lacking life and power]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 115:8 (#3)

כֹּל אֲשֶׁר־בֹּטֵחַ בָּהֶם

“everyone who is trusting in them”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [everyone who trusts in them is like them]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 115:9 (#1)

יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents the Israelite people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Israelite people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 115:9 (#2)

עֶזְרָם וּמָגִנָּם

“their help and their shield”

The psalmist switches here from the second person exhortation **trust in Yahweh** to the third person **their help and their shield**. It is probable that when this psalm was sung, a leader would sing the second person exhortation parts and a chorus would sing the third-person parts of verses 9–11. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate the third person parts as second person. Alternate translation: [your help and your shield]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 115:9 (#3)

עֶזְרָם

“their help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who helps them] or [the one who helps you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 115:9 (#4)

וּמָגִנָּם

“and their shield”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shield** that protects people in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the one who protects them] or [and the one who protects you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:10 (#1)

בֵּית אַהֲרֹן

“House of Aaron”

Here, **House** means all the people descended from a particular person. This image envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **House of Aaron** figuratively means all the people descended from Aaron, the first high priest. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Descendants of Aaron]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:10 (#2)

עֶזְרָם וּמָגִנָּם

“their help and their shield”

The psalmist switches here from the second person exhortation **trust in Yahweh** to the third person **their help and their shield**. It is probable that when this psalm was sung, a leader would sing the second person exhortation parts and a chorus would sing the third-person parts of verses 9–11. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate the third person parts as second person. Alternate translation: [your help and your shield]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 115:10 (#3)

עֶזְרָם

“their help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who helps them] or [the one who helps you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 115:10 (#4)

וּמָגִנָּם

“and their shield”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shield** that protects people from attack. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and the one who protects them] or [and the one who protects you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:11 (#1)

עֶזְרָם וּמָגִנָּם

“their help and their shield”

The psalmist switches here from the second person exhortation **trust in Yahweh** to the third person **their help and their shield**. It is probable that when this psalm was sung, a leader would sing the second person exhortation parts and a chorus would sing the third-person parts of verses 9–11. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate the third person parts as second person. Alternate translation: [your help and your shield]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 115:11 (#2)

עֶזְרָם

“their help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who helps them] or [the one who helps you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 115:11 (#3)

וּמָגִנָּם

“and their shield”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shield** that protects people in battle. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and the one who protects them] or [and the one who protects you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:12 (#1)

יְהוָה זְכָרָנוּ

“Yahweh remembers us”

The psalmist is using **Yahweh remembers us** as a common expression of the culture to mean “Yahweh thinks about us” or “Yahweh is mindful of us.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh thinks about us]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:12 (#2)

יְבָרֵךְ

“he will bless”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language as is modeled in the UST.

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 115:12 (#3)

אֶת־בֵּ֣ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“the house of Israel”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:12 (#4)

אֶת־בֵּ֣ית אַהֲרֹ֑ן

“the house of Aaron”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Aaron** figuratively means all the people descended from Aaron, the first high priest. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Aaron]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:13 (#1)

יִרְאֵ֣י

“those fearing”

The psalmist is using the adjective **fearing** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the people who fear]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 115:13 (#2)

הַ֝קְּטַנִּ֗ים עִם־הַגְּדֹלִֽים

“the small with the great”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **small** and **great** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [the small people as well as with the great people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 115:13 (#3)

הַ֝קְּטַנִּ֗ים עִם־הַגְּדֹלִֽים

“the small with the great”

The psalmist is speaking of insignificant people and prominent people as if they were physically **small** and **great**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the insignificant people along with the prominent people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:13 (#4)

הַ֝קְּטַנִּ֗ים עִם־הַגְּדֹלִֽים

“the small with the great”

The psalmist is referring to all people by naming two extremes, **the small** and **the great**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the insignificant ones to the important ones]

See: Merism

Psalms 115:14 (#1)

יֹסֵ֣ף יְ֭הוָה עֲלֵיכֶ֑ם

“May Yahweh add to you”

The psalmist assumes that readers will know what Yahweh should **add to you**. The context of blessing families suggests that this refers to adding children or descendants. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh add children to your families]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 115:14 (#2)

יֹסֵ֣ף יְ֭הוָה עֲלֵיכֶ֑ם

“May Yahweh add to you”

The word **you** is plural here because the psalmist is addressing the Israelites, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh add to all of you]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 115:14 (#3)

עֲלֵיכֶ֖ם וְעַ֣ל־בְּנֵיכֶֽם

“to you, to you”

The psalmist repeats **to you** for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [to you, yes, to you]

See: Doublet

Psalms 115:14 (#4)

וְעַל־בְּנֵיכֶם

“and to your sons”

The psalmist is speaking as if future generations were actually **sons**. He means descendants in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and to your descendants]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:15 (#1)

בְּרוּכִים אַתֶּם לַיהוָה

“May you be blessed by Yahweh”

The expression **May you be blessed by Yahweh** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh bless you]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 115:15 (#2)

בְּרוּכִים אַתֶּם לַיהוָה

“May you be blessed by Yahweh”

The word **you** is plural here because the psalmist is addressing all the people of Israel, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [May all of you be blessed by Yahweh]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 115:16 (#1)

הַשָּׁמַיִם שָׁמַיִם

“The heavens of heavens”

The psalmist is using **The heavens of heavens** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the highest heavens” or “the most exalted heavens.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The most heavenly heavens]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:16 (#2)

לַיהוָה

“are} to Yahweh”

The psalmist is using **are to Yahweh** as a common expression of the culture to mean “belong to Yahweh.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are Yahweh’s]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:16 (#3)

לִבְנֵי־אָדָם

“to the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to human beings]

See: Idiom

Psalms 115:17 (#1)

הַמֵּתִים

“The dead”

The psalmist is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Dead people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 115:17 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

The word **Yah** is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh” as modeled in the UST.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 115:17 (#3)

יֹרְדֵי דוּמָה

“descending {to} silence”

Here the psalmist is speaking of death as if it were **descending to silence**. This image portrays death as going down to a place where there is no speech or praise. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [going to the grave, where they are silent]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 115:17 (#4)

וְלֹ֣א כָל־יֹרְדֵ֣י דוּמָֽה

“and not any descending {to} silence”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and not any people descending to silence praise Yah]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 115:18 (#1)

וַאֲנַ֣חְנוּ ׀ נְבָ֭רֵךְ

“But we, we will bless”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **we** separately, even though the verb translated as **we will bless** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the contrast between the living and the dead. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [But as for us, we will bless]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 115:18 (#2)

נְבָ֭רֵךְ יָ֣הּ

“we will bless Yah”

The word **Yah** is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh.” Alternate translation: [we will bless Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 115:18 (#3)

הַֽלְלוּ־יָֽהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms - Chapter 116 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 116 is a “psalm of praise” for saving the psalmist’s life. (See: save, saved, safe, salvation, rescue)

1. Declaration of love and prayer (1–2)
2. Recounting deliverance and finding rest (3–9)
3. Vows, sacrifice, and public praise (10–19)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Healing

The psalmist was very sick and expected to die but God healed him. So he will pay his vow and sacrifice an offering of thanks. (See: promise, promised)

Psalms 116:1 (#1)

יְשָׁמַ֣ע ׀ יְהוָ֣ה אֶת־קֹ֭לִי

“Yahweh hears my voice”

Here, **my voice** represents the psalmist’s prayers and requests. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh hears me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:1 (#2)

תַּחֲנוּנָֽי

“my pleas”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [because Yahweh hears my pleas]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 116:2 (#1)

הַטָּ֣ה אָזְנ֣וֹ לִ֑לִי

“he extends his ear to me”

The psalmist is using **he extends his ear to me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “he listens to me” or “he pays attention to what I say.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he pays attention to what I say]

See: Idiom

Psalms 116:2 (#2)

וּבְיָמַי

“and throughout my days”

The psalmist is using the term **days** to refer to his lifetime. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and throughout my lifetime]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:2 (#3)

אֶקְרָא

“I will call out”

The psalmist assumes that readers will understand that **I will call out** means he will call out to Yahweh. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I will call out to Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:3 (#1)

אֲפָפָנִי ׀ חֶבְלֵי־מָוֶת וּמְצָרֵי שְׁאוֹל מְצָאוּנִי

“The cords of death surrounded me, and the constrictions of Sheol found me”

These two phrases **The cords of death surrounded me** and **the constrictions of Sheol found me** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [The cords of death surrounded me, indeed, the constrictions of Sheol found me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 116:3 (#2)

אֲפָפָנִי ׀ חֶבְלֵי־מָוֶת

“The cords of death surrounded me”

Here the psalmist is picturing death as if it were **cords** that could wrap around and bind someone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It seemed that I would die soon]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 116:3 (#3)

וּמְצָרֵי שְׁאוֹל מְצָאוּנִי

“and the constrictions of Sheol found me”

Here David is speaking of **the constrictions of Sheol** as if they were ropes or chains that could physically grip and restrain him. He means that he felt as though he was very close to dying. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I felt as though I were dying]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 116:3 (#4)

צָרָה וְיָגוֹן אֶמְצָא

“I found anguish and sorrow”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **anguish** and **sorrow**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [I was anguished and sorrowful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 116:4 (#1)

וּבְשֵׁם־יְהוָה אֶקְרָא

“Then I called on the name of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to refer to Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then I called on Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:4 (#2)

מַלְּטָה נַפְשִׁי

“rescue my life”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. Alternate translation: [I beg you to rescue my life]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 116:4 (#3)

מַלְּטָה נַפְשִׁי

“rescue my life”

Here, **life** represents the person himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [rescue me] or [keep me from dying]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:5 (#1)

וֵאלֹהֵינוּ מְרַחֵם

“and our God {is} compassionate”

Here **and** introduces not an addition but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, our God, is also compassionate]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 116:6 (#1)

פְּתָאיִם

“the naive”

The psalmist is using the adjective **naive** as a noun to refer to people who are inexperienced or who cannot care for themselves. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who cannot care for themselves]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 116:6 (#2)

דַּלֹּתִי וְלִי

“I was low”

Here the psalmist is speaking of his difficult circumstances as if he were physically **low**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I was in a bad way] or [I was in trouble]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 116:7 (#1)

שׁוּבִי נַפְשִׁי לִמְנוּחָיְכִי כִּי־יְהוָה גָּמַל עָלָיְכִי

“Return to your rest, my soul, for Yahweh has repaid you”

The psalmist is speaking to himself in the second person as **your** and **you**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 116:7 (#2)

שׁוּבִי נַפְשִׁי לִמְנוּחָיְכִי

“Return to your rest, my soul”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual/emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I must return myself to calmness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:7 (#3)

שׁוּבִי & לִמְנוּחָיְכִי

“Return to your rest”

By **rest**, the psalmist means “a state of restfulness.” You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Return to your state of restfulness]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:7 (#4)

כִּי־יְהוָה גָּמַל עָלָיְכִי

“for Yahweh has repaid you”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s good deeds as if they were **repaid** like a debt or wages. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for Yahweh has done good things for you] or [for Yahweh has done good things for me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 116:8 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 116:8 (#2)

כִּֽי חִלַּצְתָּ נַפְשִׁי מִמָּֽוֶת

“For you rescued my soul from death”

Here, **my soul** represents the psalmist himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [For you rescued me from death]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:8 (#3)

כִּֽי חִלַּצְתָּ נַפְשִׁי מִמָּֽוֶת

“For you rescued my soul from death”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **death**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [For you rescued my soul from dying]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 116:8 (#4)

אֶת־עֵינִי מִן־דִּמְעָֽה

“my eye from weeping”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **eye**, to mean all of him in the act of weeping. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me from weeping]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 116:8 (#5)

אֶת־רַגְלִי מִדֶּֽחִי

“my foot from stumbling”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **foot**, to mean all of him in the act of stumbling or falling. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me from stumbling]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 116:9 (#1)

אֶֽתְהַלֵּךְ לִפְנֵי יְהוָה

“I will walk to the face of Yahweh”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if he were literally walking **to the face of Yahweh**. He means that he will live in a way that acknowledges Yahweh in all that he does. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will acknowledge Yahweh in all that I do]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 116:9 (#2)

לִפְנֵי יְהוָה

“to the face of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using **to the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in the presence of” or “before.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [before Yahweh]

See: Idiom

Psalms 116:9 (#3)

בְּאַרְצוֹת הַחַיִּֽים

“in the lands of the living”

The psalmist is using **in the lands of the living** as a common expression of the culture to mean “as long as I am alive” or “during my lifetime.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as long as I live]

See: Idiom

Psalms 116:10 (#1)

הֶֽהֱאָמַנְתִּי

“I trusted”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I trusted Yahweh]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 116:10 (#2)

כִּֽי־אֲדַבֵּ֥ר

“though I spoke”

The implication is that the psalmist was speaking to himself or to God about his distress. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [though I said to myself]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:10 (#3)

אֲ֝אֲנִ֗י עָנִ֥יתִי מְאֹֽד

“I, I am very wretched”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** twice, even though it is not necessary for understanding. He is doing that to emphasize his personal distress and suffering. If a speaker of your language would use repeated pronouns for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [woe is me; I am very wretched]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 116:11 (#1)

אֲ֝אֲנִ֗י אָמַ֥רְתִּי

“I, I said”

The pronoun **I** is stated twice for emphasis. The psalmist is emphasizing that he himself was the one who made this statement. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [As for me, I said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 116:11 (#2)

אֲ֝אֲנִ֗י אָמַ֥רְתִּי

“I, I said”

By **I, I said**, the psalmist means that he said this to himself or thought this to himself. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I, I said to myself]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:11 (#3)

בְּחָפְזִֽי

“in my panic”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **panic**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I was panicking]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 116:12 (#1)

מָ֤ה־אָשִׁ֙יב לַיהוָ֔ה כָּל־תַּגְמוּלָ֖והִי עָלָֽי

“How can I return to Yahweh all of his bestowments to me”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [It is not possible for me to return to Yahweh all of his bestowments to me.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 116:12 (#2)

מָ֤ה־אָשִׁ֙יב לַיהוָ֔ה

“How can I return to Yahweh”

The implication is that the psalmist cannot fully repay Yahweh for all his goodness. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [How can I pay back to Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:12 (#3)

כָּל־תַּגְמוּלָ֖והִי עָלָֽי

“all of his bestowments to me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **bestowments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [everything that he has done to be kind to me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 116:13 (#1)

כּוֹס־יְשׁוּעוֹת֮ אֶשָּׂ֪א

“I will raise the cup of salvation”

This is probably a reference to a drink offering, which was a sacrifice that involved pouring wine on the altar, and which the psalmist will offer as a grateful

response to Yahweh for saving him. The full meaning of this statement can be made explicit. Alternate translation: [I will present a drink offering to Yahweh because he saved me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:13 (#2)

וּבְשֵׁ֖ם יְהוָ֣ה אֶקְרָֽא

“and call on the name of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to refer to Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and call on Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:14 (#1)

עַמּֽוֹ

“his people”

The implication is that these are people who have gathered to worship Yahweh. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the people who have gathered to worship him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:15 (#1)

יָקָ֤ר בְּעֵינֵ֨י יְהוָ֗ה הַ֭מָּוְתָה לַחֲסִידָֽיו

“Precious in the eyes of Yahweh {is} the death of his faithful”

The word **Precious** here does not imply that Yahweh desires the death of his faithful ones, but that the death of his saints is costly to him and grieves him. See how you translated a similar expression in Psalm 72:14. Alternate translation: [Yahweh considers the death of his faithful ones to be a costly thing]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:15 (#2)

יָקָ֤ר בְּעֵינֵ֨י יְהוָ֗ה הַ֭מָּוְתָה לַחֲסִידָֽיו

“Precious in the eyes of Yahweh {is} the death of his faithful”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **death**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [When one of his faithful people dies, that grieves Yahweh very much]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 116:15 (#3)

בְּעֵינֵ֨י יְהוָ֗ה

“in the eyes of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using **in the eyes of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in the judgment of” or “in the opinion of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in Yahweh’s judgment]

See: Idiom

Psalms 116:15 (#4)

הַ֭מָּוְתָה לַחֲסִידָֽיו

“is} the death of his faithful”

The psalmist is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [is the death of any of his faithful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 116:16 (#1)

אָ֤נָּה יְהוָ֨ה ׀ כִּי־אֲנִ֣י עַבְדֶּ֗ךָ אֲנִי־עַבְדְּךָ֥ בֶֽן־אֲמָתֶ֑ךָ פִּ֝תַּ֗חְתָּ לְמוֹסֵרָֽי

“Indeed, Yahweh, for I {am} your servant; I {am} your servant, the son of your servant woman; you have undone my bonds”

The psalmist here switches to second person by saying **your servant**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could continue using third person as in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [Indeed, for I am Yahweh’s servant; I am his servant, the son of his servant woman; he has undone my bonds]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 116:16 (#2)

כִּי־אֲנִ֣י עַבְדֶּ֗ךָ

“for I {am} your servant”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [definitely I am your servant]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 116:16 (#3)

אֲנִי־עַבְדְּךָ בֶן־אֲמָתֶךָ

“I {am} your servant, the son of your servant woman”

The phrase **the son of your servant woman** adds to the meaning of **I am your servant**. In the culture of the time, the son of a servant woman was a permanent servant, without the right to go free after six years. See Exodus 21:2–4. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I am your permanent servant, the son of your servant woman]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 116:16 (#4)

פִּתַּחְתָּ לְמוֹסֵרָי

“you have undone my bonds”

Here the psalmist is speaking of his troubles as if they were **bonds** that tied him up and prevented him from moving freely. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [you have freed me from my troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 116:17 (#1)

לְךָ־אֶזְבַּח זֶבַח תּוֹדָה

“I will sacrifice to you the sacrifice of thanksgiving”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [I will make a sacrifice to you to thank you]

See: Poetry

Psalms 116:17 (#2)

לְךָ־אֶזְבַּח זֶבַח תּוֹדָה

“I will sacrifice to you the sacrifice of thanksgiving”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thanksgiving**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will make a sacrifice to you to thank you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 116:17 (#3)

וּבְשֵׁם יְהוָה אֶקְרָא

“and I will call on the name of Yahweh”

Here, **name** represents the person of Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will call out to Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 116:18 (#1)

נְדָרַי לַיהוָה אֲשַׁלֵּם נֶגְדָּה־נָּא לְכָל־עַמּוֹ

“I will fulfill my vows to Yahweh right in front of all of his people”

See how you translated this in verse 14.

Psalms 116:18 (#2)

נֶגְדָּה־נָּא לְכָל־עַמּוֹ

“right in front of all of his people”

The psalmist says **right in front of all of his people** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [right in front of a gathering of his people]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 116:19 (#1)

בְּבֵית יְהוָה

“the house of Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of the temple of Yahweh as if it were a **house** in which he lived. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the temple of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 116:19 (#2)

בְּתוֹכֵכִי יְרוּשָׁלָ͏ִם

“in your midst, Jerusalem”

The psalmist is speaking to **Jerusalem** that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about his commitment to worship and praise God in the holy city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [in the midst of Jerusalem]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 116:19 (#3)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 116:19 (#4)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yah-weh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 117 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 117 is a “psalm of praise.”

1. Call to praise
2. Reasons to praise

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Praise

Everyone should praise God for his love and unending faithfulness. (See: love, beloved; and faithful, faithfulness, trustworthy)

Psalms 117:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ אֶת־יְהוָה כָּל־גּוֹיִם שַׁבְּחוּהוּ כָּל־הָאֻמִּים

“Praise Yahweh, all nations; extol him, all peoples”

These two phrases **Praise Yahweh, all nations** and **extol him, all peoples** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Praise Yahweh, all nations; yes, extol him, all peoples]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 117:1 (#2)

כָּל־גּוֹיִם

“all nations”

Here, **all nations** represents the people in all nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [you people in all nations]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 117:2 (#1)

כִּי גָבַר עָלֵינוּ ׀ חַסְדּוֹ

“For his covenant faithfulness is strong toward us”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [For he will never stop being faithful to his covenant to love us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 117:2 (#2)

וֶאֱמֶת־יְהוָה לְעוֹלָם

“and the trustworthiness of Yahweh {is} to forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trustworthiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh will be trustworthy to do this forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 117:2 (#3)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 117:2 (#4)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 118 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 118 is a “psalm of thanksgiving” written on the occasion of a military victory. At the same time, it is a messianic psalm that looks forward to the triumph of Jesus Christ. Jesus applied Psalm 118:22 to himself (Matthew 21:42, Mark 12:10, Luke 20:17), and the apostle Peter applied it to Jesus both in a speech recorded in Acts (Acts 4:11), and in his first letter (1 Peter 2:7). See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to Thanksgiving (1–4)
2. Testimony of deliverance (5–18)
3. Messianic celebration (9–29)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Rejected stone

The psalmist praised Yahweh for rescuing him. God enabled him to overpower his enemies. The new Testament, and even Jesus himself, saw the rejected stone as a reference to the Messiah’s rejection by the Jewish leaders. (See: Christ, Messiah)

Psalms 118:1 (#1)

הוֹדוּ לַיהוָה כִּי־טוֹב כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ

“Give thanks to Yahweh, for {he is} good, for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

See how you translated this in Psalm 106:1.

Psalms 118:1 (#2)

כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ

“for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [thank Yahweh for his covenant faithfulness is to forever]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 118:1 (#3)

חַסְדּוֹ

“his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he remains faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:1 (#4)

לְעוֹלָם

“is} to forever”

The psalmist is using **to forever** as a common expression of his culture to mean “eternally” or “without end.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [lasts throughout eternity]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:2 (#1)

יֹאמַר־נָא יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Let Israel indeed say”

Here, **Israel** represents the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Let the people of Israel indeed say]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 118:2 (#2)

יֹאמַר־נָא יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Let Israel indeed say”

The psalmist is saying what he wants **Israel** to do. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [May Israel indeed say]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 118:2 (#3)

כִּ֥י לְעוֹלָ֗ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“For his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

See how you translated this in the previous verse.

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:2 (#4)

כִּ֥י לְעוֹלָ֗ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“For his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [We praise Yahweh for his covenant faithfulness is to forever]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 118:3 (#1)

יֹֽאמְרוּ־נָ֥א בֵית־אַהֲרֹ֗ן

“Let the house of Aaron indeed say”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Aaron** figuratively means all the people descended from Aaron, who was the first high priest. Alternate translation: [Let the descendants of Aaron indeed say]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:3 (#2)

כִּ֥י לְעוֹלָ֗ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“For his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

See how you translated this in the previous verse.

Psalms 118:4 (#1)

כִּ֥י לְעוֹלָ֗ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“For his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

See how you translated this in the previous verse.

Psalms 118:5 (#1)

מִן־הַ֭מֵּצַר

“From the constriction”

The psalmist is using **From the constriction** as a common expression of the culture to mean “from a distressing situation” or “from a time of trouble.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From between a rock and a hard place] or [From a distressing situation]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:5 (#2)

קָרָ֣אתִי יָּ֭הּ עָנָ֣נִי & יָ֑הּ

“I called out to Yah; Yah answered me”

The word **Yah** is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh.” Alternate translation: [I called out to Yahweh and he answered me]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 118:5 (#3)

עָנָ֣נִי בַמֶּ֣רְחָ֑ב יָ֝הּ

“Yah answered me with wideness”

The psalmist is using **with wideness** as a common expression of the culture to mean “by setting me free” or “by relieving my distressing situation.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yah set me in a wide place] or [Yah answered me by relieving my distressing situation]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:6 (#1)

יְהוָ֣ה לִ֑לִי

“Yahweh {is} for me”

The psalmist is using **Yahweh is for me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “Yahweh supports me” or “Yahweh is on my side.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh wants me to succeed]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:6 (#2)

מַה־יַּ֖עֲשֶׂה לִ֣לִי אָדָֽם

“what can man do to me”

The psalmist is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [man do nothing to harm me]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 118:7 (#1)

יְהוָה לִ֭י בְּעֹזְרָ֑י

“Yahweh {is} for me as my helper”

The psalmist is using **Yahweh is for me as my helper** as a common expression of the culture to mean “Yahweh wants me to succeed and so he helps me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh wants me to succeed and so he helps me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:7 (#2)

וַ֝אֲנִ֗י אֶרְאֶ֥ה

“and I, I will gaze”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will gaze** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize his personal commitment to triumph over his enemies. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and so for my part, I will gaze]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 118:7 (#3)

בְּשֹׂנְאָֽי

“on the haters of me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **haters**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [on those who hate me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:8 (#1)

לַחֲסֹ֣ות בַּיהוָ֑ה

“to take shelter in Yahweh”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shelter** that people could go into for protection from danger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to let Yahweh protect us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:8 (#2)

מִבְּטֹ֖חַ בָּאָדָֽם

“than to trust in man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [than to trust in people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 118:9 (#1)

לַחֲסֹ֣ות בַּיהוָ֑ה

“to take shelter in Yahweh”

See how you translated this phrase in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [to let Yahweh protect us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:10 (#1)

כָּל־גּוֹיִ֣ם

“All the nations”

The psalmist says **All the nations** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [It seemed as though all the nations] or [So many nations]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 118:10 (#2)

בְּשֵׁ֣ם יְהוָ֑ה

“in the name of Yahweh”

Here, **name** represents the power and authority of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by Yahweh’s power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 118:10 (#3)

אֲמִילָֽם

“I fended them off”

The word translated as **I fended them off** could mean: (1) the psalmist’s army pushed back the other armies. Alternate translation: [I defeated them] or it could be a different word that is spelled the same way that means: (2) the psalmist’s army circumcised the enemy armies. Alternate translation: [I circumcised them] or [I cut them off]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:11 (#1)

סַבּוּנִי גַם־סְבָבוּנִי

“They surrounded me; yes, they surrounded me”

The expressions **They surrounded me** and **yes, they surrounded me** mean the same thing. The psalmist is using repetition for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [They had me completely surrounded]

See: Doublet

Psalms 118:11 (#2)

בְּשֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה כִּי אֲמִילַם

“in the name of Yahweh, indeed I fended them off”

See how you translated this in the previous verse.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:12 (#1)

סַבּוּנִי כִדְבוֹרִים

“They surrounded me like bees”

The psalmist is making a comparison between his enemies and **bees**. The point of this comparison is that just as **bees** swarm around aggressively when attacking, so his enemies surrounded him aggressively. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [They surrounded me like bees do when they are attacking someone]

See: Simile

Psalms 118:12 (#2)

דֹּעֲכוּ כְּאֵשׁ קוֹצִים

“they were extinguished like a fire of thorns”

The expression **they were extinguished** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they died away quickly like a fire burning thorns]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 118:12 (#3)

דֹּעֲכוּ כְּאֵשׁ קוֹצִים

“they were extinguished like a fire of thorns”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a fire of thorns** burns out quickly, so the psalmist’s enemies **were extinguished** quickly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they were extinguished as quickly as is a fire among thorns]

See: Simile

Psalms 118:12 (#4)

בְּשֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה כִּי אֲמִילַם

“in the name of Yahweh, indeed I fended them off”

See how you translated this in verse 10.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:13 (#1)

דַּחֹה דְּחִיתַנִי

“To push down, you pushed me down”

The psalmist is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [You pushed me down hard]

See: Poetry

Psalms 118:13 (#2)

לִנְפֹּל

“to fall”

Here, **to fall** marks this clause as the goal or purpose of **To push down, you pushed me down**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that I would fall]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 118:13 (#3)

דַּחֹה דְּחִיתַנִי לִנְפֹּל

“To push down, you pushed me down to fall”

Here the psalmist is speaking of his enemies' attack as if the enemies were able to **push** him **down** physically to make him **fall**. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [You attacked me violently in order to defeat me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:13 (#4)

דַּחֹתָה דְחִיתַנִי לִנְפֹּל

"To push down, you pushed me down to fall"

The psalmist is speaking to his enemies that he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about how violently they attacked him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about **his enemies**. Alternate translation: [My enemies attacked me violently in order to defeat me]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 118:14 (#1)

יָהּ

"Yah"

Yah is a shortened form of the name "Yahweh," the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers as modeled in the UST.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 118:14 (#2)

עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ

"Yah {is} my strength and song"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **strength** and **song**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Yah makes me strong and joyful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:14 (#3)

עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ

"Yah {is} my strength and song"

Here, **song** represents "a reason to sing" or "joy." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Yah gives me strength and the joy to sing]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 118:14 (#4)

וַיְהִי־לִי לִישׁוּעָה

"and he is to me for salvation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and he saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:15 (#1)

קוֹל ו רִנָּה וִישׁוּעָה

"The voice of a shout and salvation"

The phrase **a shout and salvation** expresses a single idea. The word **shout** tells more about **salvation**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [The voice of a victorious shout]

See: Hendiadys

Psalms 118:15 (#2)

צַדִּיקִים

"the righteous"

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 118:15 (#3)

יְמִין יְהוָה עֹשָׂה חָיִל

"the right hand of Yahweh does valor"

The psalmist may be quoting a song of victory, starting here and going through verse 16. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark this as the beginning of a song, as in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 118:15 (#4)

יְמִין יְהוָה עֹשָׂה חָיִל

"the right hand of Yahweh does valor"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **valor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the right hand of Yahweh does valiant things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:15 (#5)

יְמִין יְהוָה

“the right hand of Yahweh”

Here, **right hand** represents the power of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the power of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 118:15 (#6)

חָיִל

“valor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **valor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [valiant things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:16 (#1)

יְמִין יְהוָה רוֹמֵמָה

“The right hand of Yahweh is high”

The psalmist is using **The right hand of Yahweh is high** as a common expression of the culture to mean that Yahweh is superior to all others or that Yahweh is victorious. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is superior to all others]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:16 (#2)

יְמִין יְהוָה עֹשָׂה חָיִל

“the right hand of Yahweh does valor”

See how you translated this phrase in the previous verse.

Psalms 118:17 (#1)

לֹא אָמוּת כִּי־אֶחְיֶה

“I will not die, but live”

The psalmist uses the word **but** here to indicate a contrast between dying and living. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I will not die; instead, I will live]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 118:17 (#2)

יָהּ

“of Yah”

The word **Yah** is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh.” Alternate translation: [of Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 118:18 (#1)

יַסֹּר יִסְּרַנִּי יָהּ

“To chastise, Yah has chastised me”

The psalmist is repeating forms of the verb **chastise** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Yah has certainly chastised me]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 118:18 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers as modeled in the UST.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 118:18 (#3)

וְלַמָּוֶת לֹא נְתָנָנִי

“but to death he has not given me”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **death** as if it were a place or person that Yahweh could give him **to**. He means that Yahweh has not allowed him to die. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but he has kept me alive]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:19 (#1)

פִּתְחוּ־לִי

“Open to me”

The word translated as **Open** is a plural command form, addressed to the keepers of the gates, which could refer to (1) the gates of the temple, or (2) the gates of Jerusalem. If it would be helpful to your

readers, you could include the addressees, as in the UST.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 118:19 (#2)

שַׁעֲרֵי־צֶֽדֶק

“the gates of righteousness”

Here, **righteousness** could refer to (1) the people who are allowed to enter through the gates (as indicated in the next verse), which could be either the gates of the temple or the gates of Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [the gates where the righteous may enter] or (2) Yahweh, who is righteous and who dwells in the temple. Alternate translation: [the gates of the temple of the righteous God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:19 (#3)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers as modeled in the UST.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 118:20 (#1)

זֶ֤ה־הַשַּׁ֨עַר לַיהוָ֗ה צַדִּיקִ֥ים יָבֹ֗אוּ בּֽוֹ

“This {is} the gate of Yahweh; the righteous may enter through it”

The psalmist may be quoting the response of the gatekeeper in this verse. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark this as a quotation, as in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 118:20 (#2)

הַשַּׁ֨עַר לַיהוָ֗ה

“the gate of Yahweh”

Here, **the gate of Yahweh** probably does refer to the gate of the temple, and could mean (1) the gate belonging to Yahweh. Alternate translation: [the gate that belongs to Yahweh] or (2) the gate that leads to Yahweh. Alternate translation: [the gate to where Yahweh dwells]

See: Possession

Psalms 118:20 (#3)

צַדִּיקִ֥ים

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 118:21 (#1)

אוֹדְךָ֥ כִּֽי־עֲנִיתָ֑נִי וַתְּהִי־לִ֖י לִישׁוּעָֽה

“I will thank you, for you answered me, and you have become salvation for me”

The psalmist switches to addressing Yahweh directly using **you** in this verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could continue using the third person here. Alternate translation: [I will thank Yahweh, for he answered me, and he has become salvation for me]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 118:21 (#2)

כִּֽי־עֲנִיתָ֑נִי

“for you answered me”

The psalmist is using **answered me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “acted on my behalf” in response to a request. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for you acted on my behalf]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:21 (#3)

וַתְּהִי־לִ֖י לִישׁוּעָֽה

“and you have become salvation for me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and you have saved me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:22 (#1)

אֶ֤בֶן מָאֲסוּ֙ הַבּוֹנִ֔ים הָ֥יְתָה לְרֹ֖אשׁ פִּנָּֽה

“The stone that the builders rejected has become the head of the corner”

This is likely a proverb that the psalmist has used to describe either himself or the nation of Israel. If possible, translate this proverb in a way that will be recognized as a proverb and be meaningful in your language and culture. Otherwise, you could give the plain meaning. Alternate translation: [That which others have considered worthless, Yahweh has made to be the most important]

See: Proverbs

Psalms 118:22 (#2)

לְרֹ֣אשׁ פִּנָּֽה

“the head of the corner”

By **the head of the corner**, the psalmist means the cornerstone, which is the most important stone that holds a building together. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the cornerstone]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 118:23 (#1)

מֵאֵ֣ת יְ֭הוָה הָ֣יְתָה זֹּ֑את הִ֥יא נִפְלָ֝את בְּעֵינֵֽינוּ

“This is from Yahweh; it is marvelous in our eyes”

The psalmist may be quoting the response of the congregation to the psalmist in verses 23–27. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark this as a quotation, as in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 118:23 (#2)

מֵאֵ֣ת יְ֭הוָה הָ֣יְתָה זֹּ֑את

“This is from Yahweh”

The pronoun **This** refers to the rejected stone becoming the most important stone, as described in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [This reversal from rejection to victory is from Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 118:23 (#3)

הִ֥יא נִפְלָ֝את בְּעֵינֵֽינוּ

“it is marvelous in our eyes”

The psalmist is using **it is marvelous in our eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “we consider it to be a marvelous thing.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we consider it to be a marvelous thing]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:24 (#1)

זֶ֤ה־הַ֭יּוֹם עָשָׂ֣ה יְהוָ֑ה

“This {is} the day Yahweh made”

The psalmist is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time when God acted to bring about the events being celebrated. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh caused the events we are celebrating today to happen]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 118:24 (#2)

נָגִ֖ילָה וְנִשְׂמְחָ֣ה

“Let us rejoice and be glad”

The terms **rejoice** and **be glad** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let us rejoice greatly]

See: Doublet

Psalms 118:25 (#1)

הוֹשִׁ֘יעָ֤ה נָּ֗נָּא

“save please”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [save us please]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 118:25 (#2)

הַצְלִ֥יחָ֝ה נָּ֗א

“give success please”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [give us success please]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 118:25 (#3)

הַצְלִֽיחָה נָּא

“give success please”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **success**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [enable us to succeed please]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 118:26 (#1)

בָּר֣וּךְ הַבָּ֔א

“Blessed is the one coming”

The expression **Blessed is** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh blesses the one coming]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 118:26 (#2)

בְּשֵׁ֥ם יְהוָ֖ה

“in the name of Yahweh”

Here, **name** represents the power and authority of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with the authority of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 118:26 (#3)

בֵּֽרַכְנוּכֶ֑ם

“we bless you”

The word **you** is plural here because the psalmist is addressing all the people who have come to the temple. So use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [we bless you all]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Psalms 118:26 (#4)

מִבֵּ֖֣ית יְהוָֽה

“from the house of Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of the temple of Yahweh as if it were a **house** in which he lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the temple of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:27 (#1)

וַיָּ֣אֶר לָ֑נוּ

“and he has given light to us”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God’s favor and blessing as if it were **light** that God had given to them. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he has given us success]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:27 (#2)

אִסְרוּ־חַ֥ג בַּעֲבֹתִ֗ים עַד־קַרְנ֥וֹת הַמִּזְבֵּֽחַ

“bind the sacrifice with cords to the horns of the altar”

Here the psalmist ends his quotation of the people. You may want to indicate this with closing quote marks, as in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 118:28 (#1)

אֲרוֹמְמֶֽךָּ

“I will exalt you”

Here the psalmist is speaking of praising God as if it were **exalting** him or lifting him up to a high position. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will publicly praise you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 118:29 (#1)

הוֹד֣וּ לַיהוָ֣ה כִּי־טֽוֹב כִּ֖י לְעוֹלָ֣ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“Give thanks to Yahweh; for {he is} good; for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

See how you translated this in Psalm 106:1 and 118:1.

Psalms 118:29 (#2)

כִּ֖י לְעוֹלָ֣ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [give thanks to Yahweh for his covenant faithfulness is to forever]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 118:29 (#3)

כִּֽי לְעוֹלָ֖ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

The psalmist is using **to forever** as a common expression of his culture to mean “eternally” or “without end.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for his covenant faithfulness lasts forever]

See: Idiom

Psalms 118:29 (#4)

לְעוֹלָ֖ם חַסְדּֽוֹ

“his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he remains faithful to his covenant forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 119 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 119 is a “wisdom psalm” about the law of Yahweh. This psalm is an “acrostic” (see discussion in the Introduction to Psalms), an alphabetic poem with twenty-two groups of eight verses each. Each group begins with a letter of the alphabet in the order of the Hebrew alphabet.

The psalmist uses many different words to refer to Yahweh’s message to us. You could attempt to use a different word for each term (ULT uses words such as “precepts,” “commandments,” and “law”), but most languages will not have that many, so just use the words that your language has.

1. Blessing for those who walk in Yahweh’s law (1–32)
2. Prayer for understanding and guidance from Yahweh’s word (33–72)
3. Comfort and hope in Yahweh’s word during affliction (73–112)
4. Devotion to Yahweh’s law despite opposition (113–144)
5. Cry for deliverance and life through Yahweh’s word (145–176)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

The law

The psalmist loved the law of Yahweh and was blessed by obeying it. (See: love, beloved; and bless, blessed, blessing)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

“your word”

Throughout this psalm, the psalmist uses the phrase “your word” to refer more generally to Yahweh’s commandments, instructions, promises, and messages to us.

Request form

Throughout this psalm, the psalmist is requesting things from Yahweh by using an imperative which may sound like a command in your language. If this would be impolite in your language, then use a form that would be more appropriate for addressing Yahweh with a request.

Psalms 119:1 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵ֣י

“The happinesses of”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy are] or [How blessed are]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 119:1 (#2)

תְּמִימֵ֖י־דָ֑רֶךְ

“the blameless of way”

The psalmist is using the adjective **blameless** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who are blameless in their conduct]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:1 (#3)

תְּמִימֵי־דָ֑רֶךְ

“the blameless of way”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **way** that is characterized by being **blameless**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people whose way is blameless]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:1 (#4)

דָּ֑רֶךְ

“way”

Here the psalmist is speaking of behavior as if it were a **way** that a person walks along. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [conduct]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:1 (#5)

הַֽהֹלְכִ֥ים בְּתוֹרַ֖ת יְהוָֽה

“the ones walking in the teaching of Yahweh”

Here the psalmist is speaking of living according to Yahweh’s instructions as if it were **walking** along a path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who live by the teaching of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:2 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵ֣י

“The happinesses of”

See how you translated the exclamation starting with “The happinesses of” in the previous verse.

See: Exclamations

Psalms 119:2 (#2)

עֵד֥וֹתָ֗יו

“his testimonies”

The pronoun **his** refers to Yahweh, mentioned in verse 1. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the testimonies of Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:2 (#3)

יִדְרְשׁ֑וּהוּ

“They seek him”

The pronoun **They** refers to the keepers of Yahweh’s testimonies, while the pronoun **him** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Those who keep his testimonies seek Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:2 (#4)

יִדְרְשׁ֑וּהוּ

“They seek him”

Here the psalmist is speaking of wanting to know Yahweh as if people were looking for or seeking him. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They live to know him]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:2 (#5)

בְּכָל־לֵ֗בָב

“with a whole heart”

Here, **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts, feelings, and emotions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with all that I am]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:3 (#1)

עַ֭וְלָה

“injustice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **injustice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [unjust actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:3 (#2)

בִּדְרָכָ֖יו הָלָ֣כוּ

“they walk in his ways”

Here the psalmist is speaking of living in obedience to Yahweh’s commands as if it were to **walk** along his

paths or **ways**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they live according to his commands]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:4 (#1)

אַתָּה צִוִּיתָה

“You, you have commanded”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have commanded** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is now addressing Yahweh instead of the people. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [You yourself have commanded]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:4 (#2)

לִשְׁמֹר מְאֹד

“to keep diligently”

Here, **to keep diligently** marks careful obedience as the goal or purpose of giving the precepts. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that we would keep them diligently]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:5 (#1)

אַחֲלַי יִכֹּנוּ דְרָכָי

“Oh, that my paths would be established”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of desire and longing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [I earnestly desire that my paths would be established]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 119:5 (#2)

אַחֲלַי יִכֹּנוּ דְרָכָי

“Oh, that my paths would be established”

The expression **would be established** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Oh, how I want to firmly set my paths]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:5 (#3)

דְרָכָי

“my paths”

Here the psalmist is speaking of his behavior and conduct as if they were **paths** that he travels. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my conduct]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:6 (#1)

אָז לֹא־אֵבוֹשׁ

“Then I would not have shame”

The psalmist is making a conditional statement that sounds hypothetical, but he knows that the condition from the previous verse is not yet true. He is stating it as a condition to show that if always kept Yahweh’s statues, shame would not follow. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that the speaker believes is not yet true. Alternate translation: [If that were so, then I would not be feeling this shame]

See: Connect — Contrary to Fact Conditions

Psalms 119:7 (#1)

בְּיֹשֶׁר לֵבָב

“with uprightness of heart”

Here, **heart** represents where a person’s intentions and motives exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with integrity]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:7 (#2)

בְּיֹשֶׁר לֵבָב

“with uprightness of heart”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **heart** that is characterized by **uprightness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in

another way. Alternate translation: [with an upright heart]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:7 (#3)

בְּיֹ֫שֶׁר לֵבָ֥ב

“with uprightness of heart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **uprightness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with a right and sincere attitude]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:7 (#4)

בְּלָמְדִ֥י

“when I learn”

The word **when** indicates that the psalmist’s thanking and his learning happen at the same time. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [as I come to know]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

Psalms 119:7 (#5)

מִשְׁפְּטֵ֖י צִדְקֶֽךָ

“the judgments of your righteousness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **judgments** that are characterized by **righteousness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your righteous judgments]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:7 (#6)

צִדְקֶֽךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your righteous character]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:8 (#1)

אֶל־תַּעַזְבֵ֥נִי עַד־מְאֹֽד

“do not utterly leave me”

Here and throughout this psalm, the psalmist uses an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not utterly leave me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 119:9 (#1)

בַּמֶּ֤ה יְזַכֶּה־נַּ֨עַר֙ אֶת־אָ֣רְח֔וֹ

“How can a young man keep his path pure”

The psalmist is using the question form to emphasize how difficult this would be without the word of Yahweh as a guide. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [A young man can keep his path pure!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 119:9 (#2)

אֶת־אָ֣רְח֔וֹ

“his path”

Here the psalmist is speaking of a person’s conduct and behavior as if it were a **path** that the person travels. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his conduct]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:10 (#1)

בְּכָל־לִבִּ֣י

“With all of my heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts, feelings, and desires exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [With everything that I am]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:10 (#2)

דְּרַשְׁתִּ֑יךָ

“I seek you”

In this verse, the speaker shifts from third person to first person. The pronoun **I** refers to the psalmist, and **you** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [I seek you, Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:10 (#3)

אַל־תַּתַּשְׁגֵּנִי

“Do not let me stray”

Here the psalmist is speaking of disobeying Yahweh as if it were to **stray** from a path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not let me turn away]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:11 (#1)

בְּלִבִּי צָפַנְתִּי אִמְרָתֶךָ

“I have hidden your word in my heart”

Here the psalmist is speaking of memorizing Yahweh’s commands as if he had **hidden** them inside his **heart**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have stored up your word in my mind] or [I have memorized your words]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:11 (#2)

לְמַעַן לֹא אֶחֱטָא

“so that I might not sin”

Here, **so that I might not sin** marks avoiding sin as the goal or purpose of memorizing Yahweh’s word. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [with the purpose of avoiding sin]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:13 (#1)

בִּשְׂפָתַי

“With my lips”

The psalmist is using **lips** to mean speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [With my words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:13 (#2)

כֹּל מִשְׁפְּטֵי־פִיךָ

“all of the judgments of your mouth”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **judgments** that come from Yahweh’s **mouth**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [every judgment that you have pronounced]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:13 (#3)

כֹּל מִשְׁפְּטֵי־פִיךָ

“all of the judgments of your mouth”

The psalmist is using **mouth** to mean what Yahweh has spoken. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [every judgment that you have spoken]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:14 (#1)

בְּדֶרֶךְ עֵדְוֹתֶיךָ

“in the way of your testimonies”

Here the psalmist is speaking of following Yahweh’s **testimonies** as if it were walking along a **way** or path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in following your testimonies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:14 (#2)

כְּעַל כָּל־הוֹן

“as upon all riches”

The point of this comparison is that just as a person would rejoice over possessing great **riches**, so the psalmist rejoices in following Yahweh’s testimonies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as much as I would in having riches]

See: Simile

Psalms 119:15 (#1)

בְּפִקֻּדֶיךָ אָשִׂיחָה וְאַבִּיטָה אֹרְחֹתֶיךָ

“I will meditate on your precepts and I will study your paths”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I will ponder everything that you have taught me about how to live]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 119:15 (#2)

וְאַבִּיטָה אֹרְחֹתֶיךָ

“and I will study your paths”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s instructions as if they were **paths** to examine and follow. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will think carefully about your instructions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:16 (#1)

לֹ֣א אֶשְׁכַּ֑ח

“I will not forget”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **forget** to emphasize that he will carefully remember Yahweh’s precepts. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [I will continually keep in mind everything in]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 119:17 (#1)

עַל־עַבְדְּךָ

“with your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [with me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:18 (#1)

גַּל־עֵינַי

“Uncover my eyes”

Here the psalmist is speaking of gaining spiritual understanding as if Yahweh would **Uncover** someone’s **eyes** so they could see. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Help me to my understand]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:18 (#2)

וְאַבִּֽיטָה נִפְלָאוֹת

“so that I may gaze on the marvelous things”

Here the psalmist is speaking of understanding Yahweh’s teaching as if it were an object that someone could **gaze** at with his eyes. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so that I may understand the marvelous things]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:19 (#1)

גֵּ֣ר אָ֭נֹכִי בָּאָ֑רֶץ

“I am a sojourner in the land”

This could mean: (1) the psalmist speaks of his short life on earth as a **sojourner** as if he were a foreigner who is living a temporary life on earth, Alternate translation: [I am like a foreigner living a brief time in the land] or (2) the psalmist’s ignorance of Yahweh’s law as if he were a foreigner who did not know the laws of the land. Alternate translation: [I am ignorant like a foreigner in the land]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:19 (#2)

אַל־תַּסְתֵּ֖תֶר מִמֶּ֣נִּי מִצְוֹתֶֽיךָ

“do not hide your commandments from me”

The psalmist is speaking of the difficulty of understanding Yahweh’s **commandments** as if they were an object that Yahweh could **hide** from him. Your lan-

guage may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [do not keep me from understanding your commandments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:20 (#1)

גָּרְסָה נַפְשִׁי

“My soul languishes”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I languish]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:20 (#2)

לְתַאֲבָה

“with longing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **longing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [longingly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:20 (#3)

אֶל־מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ

“for your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the things you have decided]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:21 (#1)

זֵדִים אֲרוּרִים

“the proud, the cursed”

The psalmist is using the adjectives **proud** and **cursed** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [proud people, who are cursed]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:21 (#2)

הַשֹּׁגִים מִמִּצְוֹתֶיךָ

“those wandering from your commandments”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **commandments** as if they were a path and disobedience to them as if it were **wandering** away from that path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those disobeying your commandments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:22 (#1)

גַּל מֵעָלַי

“Roll from upon me”

The psalmist is speaking of **disgrace** and **humiliation** being removed from him as if these were objects that were placed on him that he needs Yahweh to **Roll** off of him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Rescue me from] or [Keep me from]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:22 (#2)

חֶרְפָּה וָבוּז

“disgrace and humiliation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **disgrace** and **humiliation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [anything that will disgrace and humiliate me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:22 (#3)

חֶרְפָּה וָבוּז

“disgrace and humiliation”

The terms **disgrace** and **humiliation** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [utter shame]

See: Doublet

Psalms 119:22 (#4)

כִּי עֵדֹתֶיךָ נָצָרְתִּי

“for I have guarded your testimonies”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is

a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I have guarded your testimonies]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:23 (#1)

עַבְדֶּךָ

“your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:24 (#1)

שַׁעֲשֻׁעָי

“are my pleasure”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pleasure**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are what please me greatly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:24 (#2)

אַנְשֵׁי עֲצָתִי

“my men of counsel”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **counsel**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my counselors]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:24 (#3)

אַנְשֵׁי עֲצָתִי

“my men of counsel”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **testimonies** as if they were people who could give advice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they advise me]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:25 (#1)

דָּבְקָה לֶעָפָר נַפְשִׁי

“My soul clings to the dust”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I cling to the dust]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:25 (#2)

דָּבְקָה לֶעָפָר נַפְשִׁי

“My soul clings to the dust”

The psalmist is speaking as if his **soul** were pressed down and clinging to the **dust** of the ground which could mean (1) being near death and being buried in the ground, Alternate translation: [I am close to death] or (2) being in deep despair. It was part of the culture to sit or lay in the dust to express deep sorrow or mourning. Alternate translation: [I am in deep despair]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:25 (#3)

חַיֵּנִי

“Revive me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Restore me to a full life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:26 (#1)

דְּרָכַי סִפַּרְתִּי

“I recounted my ways”

The psalmist is speaking of his experiences as if they were **ways** or paths that he had walked along. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I recounted what I have done]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:26 (#2)

לַמְּדֵנִי חֻקֶּיךָ

“Teach me your statutes”

The word **Teach** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add

an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please teach me your statutes]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 119:27 (#1)

דֶּרֶךְ־פִּקּוּדֶיךָ

“the way of your precepts”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s precepts or rules as if they were a **way** or path to follow. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how to follow your precepts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:27 (#2)

דֶּרֶךְ־פִּקּוּדֶיךָ

“the way of your precepts”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe the **way** that is characterized by following Yahweh’s **precepts**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way that your precepts prescribe]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:27 (#3)

וְאָשִׂיחָה

“so that I can meditate”

The phrase **so that I can meditate** indicates the purpose for which the psalmist wants understanding. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a purpose clause. Alternate translation: [in order for me to meditate]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:28 (#1)

דָּלְפָה נַפְשִׁי מִתּוּגָה

“My soul melts from grief”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I melt from grief]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:28 (#2)

דָּלְפָה נַפְשִׁי מִתּוּגָה

“My soul melts from grief”

The psalmist is speaking of becoming weak and tired from sadness or **grief** as if his **soul** were a solid object that **melts** and dissolves. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am weary from sadness]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:28 (#3)

מִתּוּגָה

“from grief”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **grief**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I am so sad]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:28 (#4)

קַיְּמֵנִי

“Lift me up”

The psalmist is speaking of being strengthened as if Yahweh would **lift** him up physically from the ground. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Strengthen me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:29 (#1)

דֶּרֶךְ־שֶׁקֶר הָסֵר מִמֶּנִּי

“Turn from me the path of deceit”

The word **Turn** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please turn from me the path of deceit]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 119:29 (#2)

דֶּרֶךְ־שֶׁקֶר

“the path of deceit”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the practice of deceiving]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:29 (#3)

דֶּרֶךְ־שֶׁקֶר

“the path of deceit”

The psalmist is speaking of deceptive behavior as if it were a **path** or road that a person walks along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [behaving in deceptive ways]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:29 (#4)

דֶּרֶךְ־שֶׁקֶר

“the path of deceit”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe the **path** that is characterized by **deceit**. If your language would not use this form, you could express the idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the deceitful path]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:30 (#1)

דֶּרֶךְ־אֱמוּנָה

“the way of faithfulness”

The psalmist is speaking of faithful behavior as if it were a **way** or path that he has **chosen** to walk along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to behave faithfully]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:30 (#2)

דֶּרֶךְ־אֱמוּנָה

“the way of faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to obey you faithfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:30 (#3)

דֶּרֶךְ־אֱמוּנָה

“the way of faithfulness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe the **way** that is characterized by **faithfulness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the faithful way]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:30 (#4)

שִׁוִּיתִי

“I agree with”

The word translated as **I agree with** could be: (1) a word meaning that the psalmist conforms himself with Yahweh’s judgments. Alternate translation: [I conform myself to] or (2) a different word that is spelled the same way that means to set or place something. But in this case, there is no indication of where the psalmist would place Yahweh’s judgments. Alternate translation: [I place]

Psalms 119:31 (#1)

אַל־תְּבִישֵׁנִי

“do not let me be shamed”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [do not let anyone put me to shame]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:31 (#2)

דָּבַקְתִּי בְעֵדְוֹתֶיךָ

“I cling to your testimonies”

The psalmist is speaking of being committed to obeying Yahweh’s **testimonies** as if they were an object he could hold tightly to or **cling to**. Alternate translation: [I hold tightly to your testimonies] or [I am committed to obeying your testimonies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:31 (#3)

אַל־תְּבִישֵׁנִי

“do not let me be shamed”

The expression **be shamed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could

express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [please do not shame me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:32 (#1)

דֶּרֶךְ־מִצְוֹתֶיךָ אָרוּץ

“I run in the way of your commandments”

The psalmist is speaking of being committed to obeying Yahweh’s commandments as if he would **run** along a **way** or path. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will be committed to obey your commandments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:32 (#2)

תַּרְחִיב לִבִּי

“you enlarge my heart”

The psalmist uses the phrase **you enlarge my heart** as if Yahweh were making his **heart** physically larger which could mean (1) that Yahweh is increasing the psalmist’s understanding his commandments, Alternate translation: [you give me greater understanding of your commandments] or (2) that Yahweh is giving the psalmist a greater desire to obey his commandments. Alternate translation: [you give me greater desire to obey your commandments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:33 (#1)

הוֹרֵנִי יְהוָה דֶּרֶךְ חֻקֶּיךָ

“Teach me, Yahweh, the way of your statutes”

The word **Teach** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please teach me, Yahweh, the way of your statutes]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 119:33 (#2)

דֶּרֶךְ חֻקֶּיךָ

“the way of your statutes”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s statutes as if they were a **way** or path to follow. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how to follow your statutes]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:33 (#3)

דֶּרֶךְ חֻקֶּיךָ

“the way of your statutes”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **way** that is characterized by following Yahweh’s **statutes**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way that your statutes prescribe]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:33 (#4)

וְאֶצְּרֶנָּה

“and I will keep it”

The phrase **and I will keep it** communicates a result of being taught. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a result clause. Alternate translation: [so that I will keep it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:34 (#1)

וְאֶצְּרָה תוֹרָתֶךָ וְאֶשְׁמְרֶנָּה

“and I will guard your teaching, and I will keep it”

The phrases **and I will guard your teaching, and I will keep it** communicate results of receiving understanding. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a result clause. Alternate translation: [so that I will guard your teaching, and so that I will keep it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:34 (#2)

וְאֶצְּרָה תוֹרָתֶךָ

“and I will guard your teaching”

The psalmist is speaking of his commitment to obeying Yahweh’s teaching as if he were physically standing **guard** over something. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will surely observe your

law] or [and I am completely committed to doing what it says]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:34 (#3)

בְּכָל־לֵב

“with a whole heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s devotion and commitments exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with complete devotion]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:35 (#1)

בִּנְתִיבַ֥ת מִצְוֹתֶ֑יךָ

“in the path of your commandments”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s commandments as if they were a **path** to walk along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in obeying your commandments]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:35 (#2)

בִּנְתִיבַ֥ת מִצְוֹתֶ֑יךָ

“in the path of your commandments”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe the **path** that is characterized by following Yahweh’s **commandments**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in the path your commandments have set out]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:36 (#1)

הַט־לִבִּי אֶל־עֵדְוֹתֶ֑יךָ וְאַ֝֗ל אֶל־בָּצַֽע

“Incline my heart toward your testimonies and not toward unrighteous gain”

Here the psalmist is speaking of desiring to do Yahweh’s will as if his **heart** were able to **incline** or lean toward Yahweh’s teachings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Cause me to desire your testimonies and not unrighteous gain]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:36 (#2)

בָּצַע

“unrighteous gain”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **gain**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [getting things wrongfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:37 (#1)

הַעֲבֵ֣ר עֵ֭ינַי

“Turn away my eyes”

Here, **eyes** represent the psalmist’s attention and desire. By asking Yahweh to **turn away** his eyes, he means he wants to keep his attention away. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Keep my attention away]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:37 (#2)

בִּדְרָכֶֽךָ

“in your ways”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s instructions as if they were **ways** or paths to walk along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [according to your instructions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:37 (#3)

חַיֵּ֑נִי

“revive me”

The word **revive** is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please revive me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 119:37 (#4)

חַיֵּ֑נִי

“revive me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [restore me to a full life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:38 (#1)

לְעַבְדֶּךָ

“for your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:38 (#2)

לְיִרְאָתֶךָ

“is} for the fear of you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fear**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is for those who reverently honor you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:39 (#1)

הַעֲבֵר חֶרְפָּתִי

“Turn away my reproach”

The psalmist is speaking as if **reproach** were a physical object that a person could **Turn away** from. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Stop my enemies from reproaching me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:39 (#2)

חֶרְפָּתִי

“my reproach”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the insults against me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:39 (#3)

כִּי מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ טוֹבִים

“for your judgments are good”

The phrase **for your judgments are good** introduces the reason or grounds for the request. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a reason clause. Alternate translation: [because your judgments are good]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:39 (#4)

כִּי מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ טוֹבִים

“for your judgments are good”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for you judge rightly and your decisions are good]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:40 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The psalmist is using the term **Behold** to focus attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen to me when I say that]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:40 (#2)

בְּצִדְקָתְךָ

“In your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Because you do what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:40 (#3)

חַיֵּנִי

“revive me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the

meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [restore me to a full life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:41 (#1)

וְיָבֹאֻנִי חֲסָדֶךָ

“And let your covenant faithfulness come to me”

The psalmist speaks of **covenant faithfulness** as if it were a person who could **come** to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And show me your faithful love]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:41 (#2)

תְּשׁוּעָתְךָ

“your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [rescue me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:41 (#3)

תְּשׁוּעָתְךָ

“your salvation”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and let your salvation come to me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 119:42 (#1)

חֹרְפִי

“the one reproaching me”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **one** of his enemies that is **reproaching** him. He means all his enemies who are insulting him in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [all my enemies who are insulting me]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 119:42 (#2)

וְאֶעֱנֶה חֹרְפִי דָבָר כִּי־בָטַחְתִּי בִּדְבָרֶךָ

“then I will answer the one reproaching me {with} a word, for I trust in your word”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since I I trust in your word, I will answer the one reproaching me with a word]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:43 (#1)

וְאַל־תַּצֵּל מִפִּי דְבַר־אֱמֶת עַד־מְאֹד

“So do not utterly snatch the word of truth from my mouth”

Here the psalmist is speaking about telling the **word of truth** about Yahweh saving him as if they were something that someone could **snatch** out of his **mouth**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [So do not keep me from being able to tell others the word of truth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:43 (#2)

דְּבַר־אֱמֶת

“the word of truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the word that is true]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:44 (#1)

לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד

“forever and ever”

The terms **forever** and **ever** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [always without end]

See: Doublet

Psalms 119:45 (#1)

וְאֶתְהַלְּכָה בָרְחָבָה

“And I will walk about in the broad”

The psalmist is speaking of living his life in freedom as if he could **walk about in the broad** open spaces. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will live in freedom]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:45 (#2)

בָרְחָבָה

“in the broad”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that the reader that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply it from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [in the broad open places]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 119:45 (#3)

כִּי פִקֻּדֶיךָ דָרָשְׁתִּי

“for I seek your precepts”

The phrase **for I seek your precepts** introduces the reason for the previous statement. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a reason clause. Alternate translation: [because I seek your precepts]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:45 (#4)

כִּי פִקֻּדֶיךָ דָרָשְׁתִּי

“for I seek your precepts”

Here the psalmist is speaking of trying to understand and follow Yahweh’s rules as if they were an object someone would actually go search for or **seek**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for I will try to follow your precepts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:46 (#1)

וְלֹא אֵבוֹשׁ

“and I will not have shame”

The psalmist is expressing a positive meaning by using a negative word together with a word that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will speak boldly]

See: Litotes

Psalms 119:48 (#1)

וְאֶשָּׂא־כַפַּי אֶל־מִצְוֹתֶיךָ

“And I will lift up my palms to your commandments”

The phrase **And I will lift up my palms** usually refers to prayer, but here it could mean: (1) that the psalmist is reaching out to receive Yahweh’s commandments. Alternate translation: [And I want more of your commandments] or (2) that the psalmist highly respects Yahweh’s commandments. Alternate translation: [And I honor your commandments]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:49 (#1)

לְעַבְדֶּךָ

“to your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [to me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:49 (#2)

יִחַלְתָּנִי

“you have given me hope”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you have caused me to hope]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:50 (#1)

זֹאת נֶחָמָתִי

“This {is} my comfort”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **comfort**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [This is what makes me feel better]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:50 (#2)

בְּעָנְיִ֑י

“in my affliction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **affliction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in what afflicts me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:50 (#3)

אִמְרָתְךָ֥ חִיָּתְנִי

“your promise revives me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and Yahweh’s **promise revives** or makes him alive again. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you restore my life through your promise]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:51 (#1)

זֵדִ֤ים

“The proud”

The psalmist is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to refer to a group of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [People who are proud]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:51 (#2)

מִתּוֹרָתְךָ֥ לֹ֗א נָטִ֫יתִי

“from your teaching I do not turn aside”

The psalmist is speaking of obedience to Yahweh’s **teaching** as if it were staying on a physical path, and disobedience as if it were to **turn aside** from that path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your teaching I do not disobey]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:53 (#1)

זַלְעָפָ֣ה אֲ֭חָזַתְנִי מֵרְשָׁעִ֑ים עֹ֝זְבֵ֗י תּוֹרָתֶֽךָ

“Rage has seized me from the wicked rejecting your teaching”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases as modeled in the UST, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:53 (#2)

זַלְעָפָ֣ה אֲ֭חָזַתְנִי

“Rage has seized me”

The psalmist is speaking of **Rage** as if it were a person who could **seize** or grab someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am overcome with rage]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:53 (#3)

זַלְעָפָ֣ה אֲ֭חָזַתְנִי

“Rage has seized me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Rage**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I become extremely angry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:53 (#4)

מֵרְשָׁעִ֑ים

“from the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to refer to a group of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could add a word such as “people.” Alternate translation: [from wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:54 (#1)

זְמִרוֹת֮ הָי֤וּ לִ֗י חֻקֶּ֫יךָ

“Your statutes are music to me”

The psalmist is speaking of **your statutes** as if they were **music** that brings delight. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your statutes are a delight to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:54 (#2)

בְּבֵ֖ית מְגוּרָֽי

“in the house of my sojourning”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sojourning**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [where I temporarily dwell]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:54 (#3)

בְּבֵ֖ית מְגוּרָֽי

“in the house of my sojourning”

The psalmist is speaking of his life on earth as if it were a temporary dwelling place, calling it **the house of my sojourning**. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [during my temporary stay on earth]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:55 (#1)

זָ֭כַרְתִּי & שִׁמְךָ֣

“I remember your name”

Here, **your name** represents Yahweh himself, including his character and reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I think about who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:56 (#1)

זֹ֣את

“This”

Here, **This** refers to what the psalmist has described in the preceding verse, his practice of remembering Yahweh and obeying his teaching. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [What I have described]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:57 (#1)

חֶלְקִ֥י יְהוָ֗ה

“Yahweh {is} my portion”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as the most valuable thing the psalmist possesses as if **Yahweh** were his **portion**, an allotment of land, or inheritance. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is my treasure]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:57 (#2)

חֶלְקִ֥י יְהוָ֗ה

“Yahweh {is} my portion”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh in the third person even though he has been addressing him directly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the second person. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, you are my portion]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:58 (#1)

חִלִּ֣יתִי פָנֶ֑יךָ

“I entreat your face”

Here, **your face** represents Yahweh’s presence and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I earnestly seek your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:58 (#2)

בְּכָל־לֵ֗ב

“with a whole heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s intentions and motives exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with complete sincerity] or [with sincere devotion]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:59 (#1)

חִשַּׁ֣בְתִּי דְרָכָ֑י וָאָשִׁ֥יבָה רַגְלַ֝י

“I examine my ways and turn my feet”

The word **and** here indicates a sequence of events. First the psalmist examines his conduct, and then he redirects himself toward Yahweh’s instructions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this sequence more explicit. Alternate translation: [I examine my ways and then turn my feet]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Psalms 119:59 (#2)

חִשַּׁבְתִּי דְרָכָי

“I examine my ways”

The psalmist is speaking of his behavior or conduct as if it were physical paths or **ways** that he could study or **examine**. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I consider my conduct]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:59 (#3)

וָאָשִׁיבָה רַגְלַי אֶל־עֵדֹתֶיךָ

“and turn my feet to your testimonies”

The psalmist is speaking of obedience to Yahweh’s **testimonies** as if it were on a physical path, and he would **turn** his **feet** to follow that path. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and redirect myself to obey your testimonies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:60 (#1)

חַחַשְׁתִּי וְלֹא הִתְמַהְמָהְתִּי

“I hurry and do not delay”

The phrases **I hurry** and **do not delay** mean similar things. The psalmist is saying it first positively and then negatively in order to emphasize the urgency with which he obeys Yahweh’s commands. If a speaker of your language would not use repetition like this, in your translation you can convey the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [I quickly determine]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 119:61 (#1)

חֶבְלֵי רְשָׁעִים עִוְּדֵנִי

“The cords of the wicked ensnare me”

The psalmist is speaking of the schemes of **wicked** people as if they were physical **cords** that are intended to **ensnare** him. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Those who are wicked try to trap me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:61 (#2)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to refer to a group of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could add a word such as “people.” Alternate translation: [people who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:61 (#3)

לֹא שָׁכָחְתִּי

“I do not forget”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **forget** to emphasize that he will carefully remember Yahweh’s precepts. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [I will continually keep in mind everything in]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 119:62 (#1)

עַל מִשְׁפְּטֵי צִדְקֶךָ

“because of the judgments of your righteousness”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because of the judgments of your righteousness, I rise in the middle of the night to praise you]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:62 (#2)

מִשְׁפְּטֵי צִדְקֶךָ

“the judgments of your righteousness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **judgments** that is characterized by **righteousness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the judgments that reflect your righteousness]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:62 (#3)

צִדְקֶךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your just character]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:64 (#1)

חַסְדְּךָ֣ מָלְאָ֣ה הָאָ֑רֶץ &

“Your covenant faithfulness fills the earth”

The psalmist is speaking of **covenant faithfulness** as if it were a substance that could **fill** a physical space. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your covenant faithfulness includes everyone throughout the earth]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:64 (#2)

חַסְדְּךָ֣

“Your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The way you faithfully love]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:65 (#1)

עַבְדְּךָ֣

“your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:66 (#1)

טּ֥וּב טַ֝עַ֗ם וָדָ֥עַת

“good discernment and understanding”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **discernment** and **understanding**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [to discern well and to understand]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:66 (#2)

טּ֥וּב טַ֝עַ֗ם וָדָ֥עַת

“good discernment and understanding”

The terms **discernment** and **understanding** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [wise understanding]

See: Doublet

Psalms 119:67 (#1)

טֶ֤רֶם אֶעֱנֶ֨ה אֲנִ֪י שֹׁגֵ֡גַ

“Before I was afflicted, I was going astray”

The word **Before** here indicates a sequence of events. First there was a time of going astray, and then affliction came. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this sequence more explicit. Alternate translation: [I was going astray, and then I was afflicted]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Psalms 119:67 (#2)

אֶעֱנֶ֨ה

“I was afflicted”

The expression **was afflicted** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [you caused me to suffer]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:67 (#3)

אֲנִ֪י שֹׁגֵ֡גַ

“I was going astray”

The psalmist is speaking of disobedience as if it were physically **going astray** from a path. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I was disobeying your instructions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:68 (#1)

וּמֵטִ֥יב

“and you do good”

The psalmist is leaving out information that the reader needs in order to understand the sentence. If it would

be helpful in your language, you could supply this information from the context. Alternate translation: [and everything you do is good]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 119:69 (#1)

זֵדִים

“The arrogant”

The psalmist is using the adjective **arrogant** as a noun to refer to a group of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you could add a word such as “people.” Alternate translation: [Arrogant people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:69 (#2)

טָפְלוּ עָלַי שֶׁקֶר

“smear lies on me”

The psalmist is using **smear lies on me** as a common expression of his culture to mean to slander someone by spreading false accusations about them. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [spread false accusations about me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 119:69 (#3)

אֲאַנֲי בְּכָל־לֵבָב ׀ אֶצֹּר פִּקּוּדֶיךָ

“I, with a whole heart, I keep your precepts”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I keep** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is making a commitment to obey Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [but as for me, I wholeheartedly promise to keep your precepts]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:69 (#4)

בְּכָל־לֵבָב

“with a whole heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s intentions and motives exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with complete devotion] or [with full intentionality]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:70 (#1)

טָפַשׁ & לִבָּם

“Their hearts {are} unfeeling”

Here, **hearts are unfeeling** represents that the enemies’ **hearts** which represent their inner thoughts are **unfeeling** which means their emotions do not work and they lack feelings. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They are insensitive]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:70 (#2)

טָפַשׁ כַּחֵלֶב לִבָּם

“Their hearts {are} unfeeling like fat”

The point of this comparison is that just as **fat** is insensitive, so his enemies’ **hearts** are unable to feel or understand. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Their hearts are dull]

See: Simile

Psalms 119:70 (#3)

אֲאַנֲי תּוֹרָתְךָ שֲׁעָשֲׁעְתִּי

“I, {in} your teaching, I delight”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I delight** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize his enjoyment of obeying Yahweh’s teaching. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [but as for me, I find joy in obeying your teaching]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:72 (#1)

תּוֹרַת־פִּיךָ

“The teaching of your mouth”

Here, **your mouth** represents Yahweh speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The teaching that you speak]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:72 (#2)

תּוֹרַת־פִּיךָ

“The teaching of your mouth”

The psalmist uses the possessive form **teaching of your mouth** to indicate that the **teaching** comes from Yahweh’s **mouth**, meaning he is the source of the teaching. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this relationship in another way. Alternate translation: [The teaching that you have spoken]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:72 (#3)

מֵאַלְפֵי זָהָב וָכָסֶף

“more than thousands of gold and silver”

The psalmist says the teaching is **more than thousands of gold and silver**. This is a generalization for emphasis, meaning he considers Yahweh’s teaching to be incomparably better and more valuable than any amount of wealth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [better than any amount of gold and silver]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 119:73 (#1)

יָדֶיךָ עָשׂוּנִי

“Your hands have made me”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh creating him as if he **made** him by using his **hands** to shape him as an object might be formed out of clay. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are the one who created me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:73 (#2)

וַיְכוֹנְנֻנִי

“and established me”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh has made him who he is as if he were a structure being **established** or firmly built. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:74 (#1)

יְרֵאֶיךָ יִרְאוּנִי וְיִשְׂמָחוּ כִּי לִדְבָרְךָ יִחָלְתִּי

“May the fearful of you see me and rejoice because I hope in your word”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I hope in your word, may those who fear you see me and rejoice]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:74 (#2)

יְרֵאֶיךָ

“the fearful of you”

The psalmist is using the adjective **fearful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who fear you]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:75 (#1)

מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ

“your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things you have judged]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:75 (#2)

וֶֽאֱמוּנָה

“and {in} faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and in being faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:76 (#1)

חַסְדְּךָ לְנַחֲמֻנִי

“your covenant faithfulness be to comfort me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way you faithfully love me comforts me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:76 (#2)

לְעַבְדֶּךָ

“to your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:77 (#1)

יְבֹאוּנִי רַחֲמֶיךָ

“May your compassion come to me”

The psalmist is speaking of **compassion** as if it were a person who could travel or **come** to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you show compassion to me]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:77 (#2)

רַחֲמֶיךָ

“your compassion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your merciful care]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:77 (#3)

שַׁעֲשֻׁעָי

“is} my delight”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **delight**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what delights me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:78 (#1)

זֵדִים

“the proud”

The psalmist is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are proud]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:78 (#2)

אֲנִי אָשִׂיחַ

“I, I will meditate”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will meditate** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to mark a contrast between himself and the proud who slander him. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [as for me, I will meditate]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:79 (#1)

יְרֵאֶיךָ

“the fearful of you”

The psalmist is using the adjective **fearful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who fear you]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:79 (#2)

יָשׁוּבוּ לִי יְרֵאֶיךָ

“May the fearful of you turn to me”

The psalmist is speaking as if the people were not paying attention to him but he wants them to **turn** back to him and pay attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May the fearful of me pay attention to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:79 (#3)

וידעו

“so that they may know”

Some ancient manuscripts read “so that they may know.” The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient manuscripts read “also those knowing.” If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

Psalms 119:80 (#1)

יְהִי־לִבִּי

“May my heart be”

Here, **my heart** represents where the psalmist’s inner life and devotion exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May my inner being be]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:81 (#1)

כָּלְתָה & נַפְשִׁי

“My soul faints”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, **My soul**, to represent his whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I faint]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:81 (#2)

לִתְשׁוּעָתְךָ

“for your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for you to deliver me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:82 (#1)

כָּלוּ עֵינַי

“My eyes faint”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **eyes**, to represent his whole person in the act of watching expectantly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I grow weary with looking]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:82 (#2)

מָתַי תְּנַחֲמֵנִי

“When will you comfort me”

The psalmist is using the question form to express urgent longing rather than to seek information. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or a request. Alternate translation: [Please comfort me soon!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 119:83 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [In fact,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 119:83 (#2)

כְּנֹאד בְּקִיטֹר

“like a wineskin in the smoke”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a wineskin** left **in the smoke** becomes shriveled and no longer useful, so the psalmist feels dried out and useless. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as useless as a wineskin that is ruined by smoke]

See: Simile

Psalms 119:83 (#3)

לֹא שָׁכָחְתִּי

“I do not forget”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **forget** to emphasize that he will carefully remember Yahweh’s precepts. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [I will continually keep in mind everything in]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 119:84 (#1)

כַּמָּ֥ה יְמֵי־עַבְדֶּ֑ךָ

“How many {are} the days of your servant”

The psalmist is using the question form to express his frustration with waiting so long. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [My life is too short to wait any longer.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 119:84 (#2)

עַבְדֶּ֑ךָ

“your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:84 (#3)

מָתַ֤י תַּעֲשֶׂ֨ה בְרֹדְפַ֪י מִשְׁפָּ֡ט

“When will you act in pursuing justice for me”

The psalmist is using the question form to urge Yahweh to act, not to seek information about timing. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please act soon in pursuing justice for me!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 119:84 (#4)

בְרֹדְפַ֪י מִשְׁפָּ֡ט

“in pursuing justice for me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in judging justly for me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:85 (#1)

זֵדִ֗ים

“The proud”

The psalmist is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Proud people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:85 (#2)

כָּ֭רוּ־לִ֣י שִׁיחוֹת֑

“have dug pits for me”

The psalmist is speaking of his enemies plotting harm as if they had **dug pits** to trap him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have plotted to harm me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:86 (#1)

אֱמוּנָ֥ה

“are truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are trustworthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:86 (#2)

שֶׁ֝שֶׁ֗קֶר

“in} deceit”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [deceitfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:87 (#1)

כִּמְעַ֤ט כִּלּ֨וּנִי

“As a little they have made an end of me”

The psalmist is using **As a little they have made an end of me** as a common expression of his culture to mean that the psalmist’s enemies have nearly destroyed him. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They have almost destroyed me]

See: Idiom

Psalms 119:87 (#2)

וַאֲנִי֮ לֹא־עָזַבְתִּי

“but I, I have not rejected”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **have not rejected** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize a contrast between the psalmist and his enemies. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [but I myself have not rejected]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:88 (#1)

כְּחַסְדְּךָ֗

“According to your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [According to how you love me so faithfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:88 (#2)

עֵדֻ֣ות פִּ֑יךָ

“the testimony of your mouth”

The psalmist uses the possessive form **the testimony of your mouth** to indicate that **the testimony** comes from Yahweh’s **mouth**, the source of the testimony. Alternate translation: [the testimony that you have spoken]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:88 (#3)

עֵדֻ֣ות פִּ֑יךָ

“the testimony of your mouth”

The psalmist is using the term **mouth** to mean what Yahweh has spoken. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all that you have told us to do]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:89 (#1)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר כּוֹנַ֖נְתָּ אֶ֣רֶץ וַתַּעֲמֹֽד׃

“your word is established in the heavens”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **word** as if it were a physical structure that is permanently **established in the heavens**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what you have said will be true in heaven forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:89 (#2)

דְּבָרְךָ֥ נִצָּ֗ב

“your word is established”

The expression **is established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you have established your word]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:90 (#1)

אֱמוּנָתֶ֑ךָ

“Your faithfulness {is”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You are faithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:90 (#2)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“to generation and generation”

The psalmist is using to **to generation and generation** as a common expression of his culture to mean “throughout all generations” or “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [throughout all generations]

See: Idiom

Psalms 119:90 (#3)

כּוֹנַ֖נְתָּ אֶ֣רֶץ וַתַּעֲמֹֽד׃

“you have established the earth, and it stands”

The phrase **and it stands** describes the result of Yahweh’s having established the earth. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what

follows is a result. Alternate translation: [you have established the earth, and that is why it remains firm]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:91 (#1)

לַמִּשְׁפָּטֶיךָ עָמְדוּ הַיּוֹם

“By your judgments, they stand today”

The pronoun **they** refers to heaven and earth, which the psalmist described in the previous two verses. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that plainly. Alternate translation: [By your judgments, heaven and earth stand today]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:91 (#2)

לַמִּשְׁפָּטֶיךָ

“By your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [According to your decisions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:91 (#3)

הַכֹּל עֲבָדֶיךָ

“all things are your servants”

The psalmist is speaking of **all things** as if they were people who could serve Yahweh as **servants**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everything you created obeys your commands]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:92 (#1)

לוּלֵי תּוֹרָתְךָ שַׁעֲשֻׁעָי אָז אָבַדְתִּי בְעָנְיִי

“If your teaching {had} not {been} my delight, then I would have perished in my affliction”

The psalmist is speaking as if **your teaching had not been my delight** were a hypothetical possibility, but he means that Yahweh’s teaching has been his delight. If your readers might think that what the psalmist is saying is uncertain, then you could translate this as a confident positive statement. Alternate translation: [Because your teaching has been my delight, I have not perished in my affliction]

See: Connect — Contrary to Fact Conditions

Psalms 119:92 (#2)

בְעָנְיִי

“in my affliction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **affliction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [when I was afflicted]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:93 (#1)

לֹא־אִשְׁכַּח

“I will not forget”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **forget** to emphasize that he will carefully remember Yahweh’s precepts. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [I will continually keep it in mind]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 119:93 (#2)

כִּי בָם חִיִּיתָנִי

“for through them you have preserved me alive”

The word **for** indicates that the psalmist is giving the reason why he will not forget Yahweh’s precepts. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason. Alternate translation: [because I obeyed them, you have kept me alive]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:94 (#1)

פִּקּוּדֶיךָ דָרָשְׁתִּי

“I seek your precepts”

Here the psalmist is speaking of trying to obey Yahweh’s instructions as if they were an object for which a person must **seek**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I try hard to obey all your precepts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:95 (#1)

רְשָׁעִים

“The wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:95 (#2)

עֵדֹתֶיךָ אֶתְבּוֹנָן

“I pay attention to your testimonies”

The phrase **I pay attention to your testimonies** marks a contrast between the psalmist and the wicked who wait to destroy him. Use a connector in your language that makes this contrast clear. Alternate translation: [I, however, pay attention to your testimonies]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 119:96 (#1)

תִּכְלָה

“perfection”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **perfection**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [things that are perfect]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:96 (#2)

לְכָל תִּכְלָה רָאִיתִי קֵץ

“I have seen an end for all perfection”

Here the psalmist uses or invents a proverb in order to convey the idea that even the best that man can do has its limits and comes to an end. Translate this proverb in a way that will be recognized as a proverb and be meaningful in your language and culture. Alternate translation: [I have seen that even the best has a limit]

See: Proverbs

Psalms 119:96 (#3)

רְחָבָה מִצְוָתְךָ מְאֹד

“your commandment is very broad”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **commandment** as if it were a physical space that is **very broad**, meaning it is without limit in its scope or application. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your commandment has no limits]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:96 (#4)

רְחָבָה מִצְוָתְךָ מְאֹד

“your commandment is very broad”

If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. [however, your commandment is very broad]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 119:97 (#1)

שִׂיחָתִי

“my meditation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **meditation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I think deeply about]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:98 (#1)

מֵאֹיְבַי תְּחַכְּמֵנִי מִצְוֹתֶךָ כִּי לְעוֹלָם הִיא־לִי

“Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is with me forever”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I meditate on your commandment all the time, it makes me wiser than my enemies]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:99 (#1)

מִכָּל־מְלַמְּדַי הִשְׂכַּלְתִּי כִּי עֵדְוֹתֶיךָ שִׂיחָה לִי

“I have more insight than all my teachers, for your testimonies are a meditation to me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since your testimonies are a meditation to me, I have more insight than all my teachers]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:99 (#2)

שִׂשְׂיחָה לִי

“are a meditation to me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **meditation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are what I meditate on]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:100 (#1)

מִזְּקֵנִים אֶתְבּוֹנָנָן כִּי פִקּוּדֶיךָ נָצָרְתִּי

“I understand more than the elders, for I have kept your precepts”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I have kept your precepts, I understand more than the elders]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:101 (#1)

כָּלֶ֫אתִי רַגְלָ֫י

“my feet”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **feet**, to mean all of himself in the act of conducting his life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have kept myself]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:101 (#2)

מִכָּל־אֹ֫רַח רָ֥ע

“evil path”

The psalmist is speaking of avoiding sinful behavior as if he were staying away from walking on an **evil path**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from every sinful behavior]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:102 (#1)

לֹא־סָ֫רְתִּי

“I have not turned aside”

The psalmist is speaking of disobeying Yahweh’s **judgments** as if they were path that he could physically **turn aside from** or depart from. Your language may have a comparable expression you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have not departed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:102 (#2)

מִמִּשְׁפָּטֶ֫יךָ

“from your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from what you have decreed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:102 (#3)

אַ֭תָּה הוֹרֵ֣תָנִי

“you, you have taught me”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **have taught** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is Yahweh himself who has taught him. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you yourself have taught me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:103 (#1)

מַה־נִּמְלְצ֣וּ לְ֭חִכִּי אִמְרָתֶ֑ךָ

“How your word is sweet to my palate”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **word** as pleasing and satisfying as if it were food that could be eaten and taste **sweet**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [How pleasing your word is to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:104 (#1)

אֶתְבּוֹנָנָן

“I gain understanding”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **understanding**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I come to understand things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:104 (#2)

עַל־כֵּ֤ן שָׂנֵ֨אתִי ׀ כָּל־אֹ֬רַח שָֽׁקֶר

“therefore, I hate every path of falsehood”

The term translated as **therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [as a result, I hate every path of falsehood]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:104 (#3)

כָּל־אֹ֬רַח שָֽׁקֶר

“every path of falsehood”

The psalmist is speaking of behavior as if it were a **path** that a person walks along. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [every way of living that is false]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:104 (#4)

כָּל־אֹ֬רַח שָֽׁקֶר

“every path of falsehood”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **path** that is characterized by **falsehood**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [every false path]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:104 (#5)

שָֽׁקֶר

“falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:105 (#1)

נֵ֣ר־לְרַגְלִ֣י דְּבָרֶ֑ךָ וְ֝א֗וֹר לִנְתִיבָתִֽי

“Your word {is} a lamp to my foot and a light to my path”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **word** providing guidance for how to live as if it were a **lamp** and a **light** that illuminate a dark **path** that a person is walking along. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your word guides my steps and shows me how to live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:105 (#2)

נֵ֣ר־לְרַגְלִ֣י & וְ֝א֗וֹר לִנְתִיבָתִֽי

“is} a lamp to my foot and a light to my path”

These two phrases **a lamp to my foot** and **a light to my path** mean basically the same thing. The psalmist is using the two phrases together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [is a guide for where I should walk]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 119:106 (#1)

לִ֝שְׁמֹ֗ר מִשְׁפְּטֵ֣י צִדְקֶֽךָ

“your righteousness”

Here, **to keep** marks **the judgments of your righteousness** as the goal or purpose of **I have sworn and I will confirm it**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that I would keep the judgments of your righteousness]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:106 (#2)

מִשְׁפְּטֵ֣י צִדְקֶֽךָ

“your righteousness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **judgments** that is characterized by **righteousness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the judgments that reflect your righteousness]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:106 (#3)

מִשְׁפְּטֵ֣י צִדְקֶֽךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract nouns for the ideas of **judgments** and **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all that you have declared to be right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:107 (#1)

נַעֲנֵיתִי עַד־מְאֹד

"I have been afflicted exceedingly"

The expression **been afflicted exceedingly** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Others have afflicted me exceedingly] or [I have suffered exceedingly]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:107 (#2)

חַיֵּנִי

"revive me"

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [restore me to a full life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:108 (#1)

נִדְבוֹת פִּי

"the freewill offerings of"

The psalmist is speaking of the praises that he says with his **mouth** as if they were a physical **freewill offerings** that he is voluntarily or freely presenting to Yahweh. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the praises that I freely bring to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:109 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי בְכַפִּי תָמִיד

"My soul {is} in my palm continually"

The psalmist is using **My soul is in my palm** as a common expression of his culture to mean that the psalmist's life is in constant danger. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My life is in constant danger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 119:109 (#2)

לֹא שָׁכָחְתִּי

"I do not forget"

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **forget** to emphasize that he will carefully remember Yahweh's precepts. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [I will continually keep in mind everything in]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 119:110 (#1)

רְשָׁעִים

"The wicked"

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:110 (#2)

נָתְנוּ & פַּח לִי

"have set a snare for me"

The psalmist is speaking of the wicked plotting against him as if they had **set a snare** for him like a hunter trapping an animal. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [have plotted to catch me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:110 (#3)

וּמִפִּקּוּדֶיךָ לֹא תָעִיתִי

"but I have not wandered from your precepts"

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh's **precepts** as if they were a path and disobedience to them as if it were **wandering** away from that path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning

plainly. Alternate translation: [but I have not stopped obeying your instructions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:111 (#1)

נָחַלְתִּי עֵדְוֹתֶיךָ לְעוֹלָם

“I have inherited your testimonies forever”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **testimonies** being a valuable gift that the psalmist has given to keep forever as if they were **inherited** gift of land or goods which is given to someone’s descendants. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your testimonies are a valuable gift to me for all time]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:111 (#2)

שְׂשׂוֹן לִבִּי

“the joy of my heart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what makes my heart rejoice]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:111 (#3)

לִבִּי

“my heart”

The psalmist is using the word **heart** to refer to the place where his inner feelings and emotions exist. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my inner being]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:112 (#1)

נָטִיתִי לִבִּי

“I have inclined my heart”

Here the psalmist is speaking of desiring or resolving to do Yahweh’s will as if his **heart** were **inclined** or leaning toward Yahweh’s teachings. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have resolved]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:113 (#1)

סֵעֲפִים

“The double-minded”

The psalmist is using the adjective **double-minded** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [People who are double-minded]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:113 (#2)

סֵעֲפִים

“The double-minded”

Here the psalmist is speaking of a person who is not fully committed to obeying Yahweh as if they had two minds or were **double-minded**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Those who are not completely committed to obeying you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:114 (#1)

סִתְרִי וּמָגִנִּי אָתָּה

“My hiding place and my shield {are} you”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh protecting him as if he were a **hiding place** and a **shield** that provide safety from danger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are the one who hides me and defends me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:114 (#2)

סִתְרִי וּמָגִנִּי אָתָּה

“My hiding place and my shield {are} you”

The terms **hiding place** and **shield** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [You are my sure protection]

See: Doublet

Psalms 119:115 (#1)

מְרֵעִֽים

“doers of evil”

The psalmist is using the phrase **doers of evil** to describe people. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [you who make a practice of doing evil things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:115 (#2)

וְאֶצְּרָ֖ה מִצְוֹ֣ת אֱלֹהָֽי

“and let me keep the commandments of my God”

Here, **and let me keep** marks **the commandments of my God** as the goal or purpose of the evildoers departing. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order to allow me to keep the commandments of my God]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:116 (#1)

מִשִּׂבְרִֽי

“of my hope”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of what I hope for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:117 (#1)

וְאִוָּשֵׁ֑עָה

“so that I will be saved”

The expression **will be saved** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [so that you will save me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:117 (#2)

וְאִוָּשֵׁ֑עָה וְאֶשְׁעֲ֖ה

“so that I will be saved, and so I may gaze”

Here, **so that** marks **I will be saved** and **I may gaze on your statutes** as two goals or purposes of the request **Support me**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that these are the purposes. Alternate translation: [in order that I will be saved and may gaze]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:117 (#3)

וְאֶשְׁעֲ֖ה בְּחֻקֶּ֣יךָ

“and so I may gaze on your statutes”

Here the psalmist is speaking of understanding Yahweh’s **statutes** as if it were an object that someone could **gaze** at with his eyes. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so that I may understand all of your instructions]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:118 (#1)

כָּל־שֹׁוגִ֥ים מֵחֻקֶּ֑יךָ

“all those straying from your statutes”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s **precepts** as if they were a path and disobedience to them as if it were **straying** away from that path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all those disobeying your statutes]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:118 (#2)

תַּרְמִיתָֽם

“their deceit”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how they deceive]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:118 (#3)

שֶׁ֝שָּֽׁקֶר

“is} falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:119 (#1)

סִגִּ֥ים הִשְׁבַּ֖תָּ כָּל־רִשְׁעֵ֣י

“You cause to cease {as} dross all the wicked of”

The point of this comparison is that just as a metal-worker removes **dross** or worthless waste from metal, so Yahweh removes **the wicked** from the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [You discard like worthless waste all the wicked of]

See: Simile

Psalms 119:119 (#2)

רִשְׁעֵי־אָ֫רֶץ

“the wicked of the earth”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this word with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those on earth who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:119 (#3)

לָ֭כֵן

“therefore”

The term translated as **therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [This is why]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:120 (#1)

סָמַ֣ר & בְּשָׂרִ֑י

“My flesh shudders”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **flesh**, to mean all of himself in the act of trembling with fear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I shudder]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:120 (#2)

מִפַּחְדְּךָ֥

“from dread of you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dread**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I dread you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:120 (#3)

וּ֝מִמִּשְׁפָּטֶ֗יךָ יָרֵ֥אתִי

“and I fear your judgments”

The phrase **and I fear your judgments** is explaining the a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I fear your judgments]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:121 (#1)

מִשְׁפָּ֣ט וָ֭צֶדֶק

“justice and righteousness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **justice** and **righteousness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [what is just and what is right]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:122 (#1)

עֲרֹ֣ב עַבְדְּךָ֣ לְטוֹב֮ אַל־יַעַשְׁקֻ֪נִי זֵדִ֫ים

“Be surety for your servant for good; do not let the arrogant oppress me”

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. If the imperatives do not communicate polite requests for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please guarantee the safety of your servant; please do not let arrogant people oppress me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 119:122 (#2)

עֲרֹ֣ב עַבְדְּךָ֣

“Be surety for your servant”

Here, **Be surety** means to be a guarantor for. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Guarantee the safety of your servant]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 119:122 (#3)

עַבְדְּךָ֣

“for your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:122 (#4)

זֵדִים

“the arrogant”

The psalmist is using the adjective **arrogant** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [arrogant people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:123 (#1)

עֵינַי כָּלְ֭לוּ

“My eyes”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **eyes**, to mean all of himself in the act of watching and waiting. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have grown weary from watching]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:123 (#2)

לִישׁוּעָתֶ֑ךָ

“for your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [waiting for you to rescue me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:123 (#3)

וּלְאִמְרַ֖ת צִדְקֶֽךָ

“and for the word of your righteousness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **word** that is characterized by **righteousness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and for your righteous word]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:123 (#4)

צִדְקֶֽךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your righteous promise]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:124 (#1)

עַבְדְּךָ

“your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:124 (#2)

כְּחַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“according to your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by loving me faithfully as you have promised]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:126 (#1)

עֵ֤את לַעֲשׂ֖וֹת לַיהוָ֑ה הֵ֝פֵ֗רוּ תּוֹרָתֶֽךָ

“It is} time for Yahweh to act; they have broken your law”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because they have broken your law, it is time for Yahweh to act]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:126 (#2)

לַיהוָ֑ה

“for Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh in the third person even though he has been addressing him directly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate

this in the second person. Alternate translation: [for you, Yahweh,]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:127 (#1)

עַל־כֵּ֤ן אָהַ֖בְתִּי מִצְוֹתֶ֑יךָ

“Therefore, I love your commandments”

The term translated as **Therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of the psalmist’s reaction to what came before. Here the psalmist’s reaction to the commandments is in contrast with those mentioned in the previous verse who broke Yahweh’s laws. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [Because, unlike those people, I love your commandments]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:128 (#1)

עַל־כֵּ֤ן

“Therefore”

The term translated as **Therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [Because of this]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:128 (#2)

כָּל־אֹ֖רַח שֶׁ֣קֶר

“every path of falsehood”

Here the psalmist is speaking of behavior as if it were a **path** that a person walks on. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [every way of living that is false]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:128 (#3)

כָּל־אֹ֖רַח שֶׁ֣קֶר

“every path of falsehood”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **path** that is characterized by **falsehood**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [every false path]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:128 (#4)

שֶׁ֣קֶר

“falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:129 (#1)

נְצָרָ֥תַם נַפְשִֽׁי

“my soul has kept them”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have kept them]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:130 (#1)

פֵּ֖תַח דְּבָרֶ֣יךָ יָאִ֑יר

“The doorway of your words gives light”

Here the psalmist is speaking of understanding and insight that he gets from Yahweh’s words as if it were a **light** shining through an open **doorway**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When your words are explained, they bring insight]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:130 (#2)

מֵבִ֥ין פְּתָיִֽים

“giving understanding to the simple”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **understanding**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [helping the simple to understand]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:130 (#3)

פְּתָיִֽים

“the simple”

SPEAKER is using the adjective **simple** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate

this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are unlearned]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:131 (#1)

פִּי־פָעַרְתִּי וָאֶשְׁאָפָה כִּי לְמִצְוֹתֶיךָ יָאָבְתִּי

“I open wide my mouth and I pant, for I long for your commandments”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I long for your commandments, I open wide my mouth and I pant]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:131 (#2)

פִּי־פָעַרְתִּי וָאֶשְׁאָפָה

“I open wide my mouth and I pant”

Here the psalmist is speaking of his spiritual desire for Yahweh’s commandments as if it caused him to **open wide** his **mouth** and **pant**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I eagerly desire and yearn deeply]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:132 (#1)

כְּמִשְׁפָּט

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כְּמִשְׁפָּט”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to how you judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:132 (#2)

פְּנֵה־אֵלַי

“to me”

The psalmist is speaking as if God were not looking at him and he asked him to **turn to** him and notice him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Consider me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:132 (#3)

שְׁמֶךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שְׁמֶךָ”

Here, **your name** represents Yahweh himself, including his character and reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everything about who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:133 (#1)

פְּעָמַי הָכֵן בְּאִמְרָתֶךָ

“Establish my steps in your word”

Here the psalmist is speaking of his conduct in life as if it were **steps** that Yahweh could **Establish** or direct. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Guide my conduct by your word]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:133 (#2)

וְאַל־תַּשְׁלֶט־בִּי כָל־אָוֶן

“and do not let any iniquity rule over me”

The psalmist is speaking of **iniquity** as if it were (1) a living thing that could **rule over** someone, Alternate translation: [and do not let me be controlled by any sin] or (2) evil men that could have power over the psalmist. Alternate translation: [and do not let wicked men have power over me]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:133 (#3)

אָוֶן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wicked thing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:134 (#1)

מֵעֹשֶׁק אָדָם

“from the oppression of man”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **oppression**, you could express the same idea

in another way. Alternate translation: [from those who mistreat me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:134 (#2)

מֵעֹ֣שֶׁק אָדָ֑ם

“from the oppression of man”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **oppression** that is performed by **man**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from those who mistreat me]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:135 (#1)

פָּנֶ֣יךָ הָאֵ֣ר

“Make & shine”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh showing favor and kindness as if his **face** could **shine** on someone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Show favor]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:135 (#2)

פָּנֶ֣יךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: פָּנֶ֣יךָ”

Here, **your face** represents Yahweh’s presence and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:135 (#3)

בְּעַבְדֶּ֑ךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּעַבְדֶּ֑ךָ”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [on me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:136 (#1)

פַּלְגֵי־מַ֥יִם יָרְד֗וּ עֵינָֽ֫י

“Streams of water go down {from} my eyes”

Here the psalmist is speaking of his many tears as if they were **Streams of water** coming out of his **eyes**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I weep greatly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:136 (#2)

לֹא־שָׁמְר֥וּ תוֹרָתֶֽךָ

“they do not keep your law”

Here the psalmist is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people do not keep your law]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 119:137 (#1)

צַדִּ֣יק אַתָּ֣ה יְהוָ֑ה וְיָשָׁ֖ר מִשְׁפָּטֶֽיךָ

“Yahweh”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Righteous are you, Yahweh, indeed, upright are your judgments]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 119:138 (#1)

צָ֭צַקְתָּ עֵדֹתֶ֣יךָ וֶאֱמוּנָ֑ה מְאֹֽד

“your testimonies {in} righteousness and faithfulness exceedingly”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [your testimonies rightly and faithfully beyond measure]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:139 (#1)

צִמְּתַ֥תְנִי קִנְאָתִ֑י

“My zeal consumes me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **zeal**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I am overwhelmingly angry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:140 (#1)

צְרוּפָ֣ה אִמְרָתְךָ֣ מְאֹ֑ד

“Your word {is} refined exceedingly”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the purity of Yahweh’s **word** as if it were metal that has been **refined** by fire to remove impurities. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your word is completely pure]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:140 (#2)

צְרוּפָ֣ה אִמְרָתְךָ֣ מְאֹ֑ד

“Your word {is} refined exceedingly”

The expression **is refined** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [You have completely tested and proven your word to be pure]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:140 (#3)

וְעַבְדְּךָ֥

“and your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:141 (#1)

וְנִבְזֶ֑ה

“and despised”

The expression **despised** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is people generally. Alternate translation: [and others look down on me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 119:141 (#2)

לֹ֣א שָׁכָ֣חְתִּי

“not”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **forgotten** to emphasize that he will carefully remember Yahweh’s precepts. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [I have carefully kept in my mind]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms 119:142 (#1)

צִדְקָתְךָ֣ צֶ֭דֶק לְעוֹלָ֑ם

“Your righteousness {is} righteousness forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You always do what is right, and you will always be righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:142 (#2)

וְאֱמֶ֥ת

“truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [trustworthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:143 (#1)

צַר־וּמָצ֥וֹק מְצָא֗וּנִי

“Narrow and distress have found me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I am troubled and distressed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:143 (#2)

צַר־וּמָצ֥וֹק מְצָא֗וּנִי

“Narrow and distress have found me”

The terms **Narrow** and **distress** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Great trouble has found me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 119:143 (#3)

צַר־וּמָצוֹק מְצָאוּנִי

“Narrow and distress have found me”

The psalmist is speaking of **Narrow and distress** as if they were living things that could have **found** a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am experiencing great trouble]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:143 (#4)

מִצְוֹתֶיךָ שַׁעֲשֻׁעָי

“your commandments {are} my delight”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **delight**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your commandments delight me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:144 (#1)

צֶֽדֶק עֵדְוֹתֶיךָ לְעוֹלָם

“The righteousness of your testimonies {is} forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Your testimonies are righteous forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:144 (#2)

צֶֽדֶק עֵדְוֹתֶיךָ לְעוֹלָם

“The righteousness of your testimonies {is} forever”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **testimonies** that are characterized by **righteousness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Your righteous testimonies last forever]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:144 (#3)

הֲבִינֵנִי

“give me understanding”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **understanding**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [enable me to understand them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:145 (#1)

בְּכָל־לֵבָב

“with a whole heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s intentions and motives exist. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with complete sincerity]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:146 (#1)

הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“save me”

The psalmist is using the imperative **save me** to make a request to Yahweh. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please save me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 119:147 (#1)

קִדַּמְתִּי בַנֶּשֶׁף

“I preempt the dawn”

The psalmist is using **preempt the dawn** as a common expression of his culture to mean rising before the sun comes up. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I wake up before daylight]

See: Idiom

Psalms 119:148 (#1)

קִדְּמ֣וּ עֵינַ֣י אַשְׁמֻרֹ֑ות

“My eyes preempt the night watches”

Here, **My eyes preempt the night watches** represents the psalmist staying awake throughout the night (the night was divided into 3 periods called **watches**). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I stay awake through the night]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:148 (#2)

לָ֝שִׂ֗יחַ בְּאִמְרָתֶֽךָ

“to meditate on your word”

The phrase **to meditate on your word** communicates the purpose for staying awake. The psalmist stays awake in order to think about what Yahweh has said. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this connection more explicit. Alternate translation: [in order to meditate on your word]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 119:149 (#1)

קֹולִ֣י שִׁמְעָ֣ה

“Hear my voice”

Here, **my voice** represents what the psalmist says when he prays. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Hear my prayer]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:149 (#2)

כְּחַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“according to your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [loving me faithfully as you have promised]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:149 (#3)

כְּמִשְׁפָּטֶ֖ךָ

“according to your judgment”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to the way you judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:149 (#4)

חַיֵּֽנִי

“revive me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [bring me back to right living]

Psalms 119:150 (#1)

רֹ֝דְפֵ֗י זִמָּ֥ה

“The pursuers of evil purpose”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil purpose**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Those who are scheming to do evil things to me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:150 (#2)

מִתֹּורָתְךָ֥ רָחָֽקוּ

“from your law they are far away”

The psalmist is speaking of the wicked people as if they were physically **far away** from Yahweh’s law. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they do not obey your law at all]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:151 (#1)

קָר֣וֹב אַתָּ֣ה יְהוָ֑ה

“Near {are} you, Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of the closeness of Yahweh’s presence and help as if he were physically **Near**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are present with me, Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:151 (#2)

אֱמֶֽת

“are} truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are true]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:152 (#1)

כִּֽי לְעוֹלָ֗ם יְסַדְתָּ֫ם

“that you have founded them forever”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh’s testimonies as if they were a structure built on a strong foundation that will last **forever**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that you issued them to last forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:153 (#1)

עָנְיִ֑י

“my affliction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **affliction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how I am afflicted]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:153 (#2)

כִּֽי־תוֹרָתְךָ֥ לֹ֝א שָׁכָ֗חְתִּי

“not & your law”

Here, **for** introduces the reason why the psalmist appeals to Yahweh. He grounds his request in his faithfulness to Yahweh’s law. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this connection more explicit as modeled in the UST.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:154 (#1)

רִיבָ֣ה רִ֭יבִי

“Plead my plea”

The psalmist is using a construction in which the verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [Please defend my cause]

See: Poetry

Psalms 119:154 (#2)

לְאִמְרָתֶ֗ךָ

“for your word”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because of what you have promised]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:154 (#3)

חַיֵּֽנִי

“revive me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [preserve my life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:155 (#1)

רָחְקוֹק מֵרְשָׁעִ֥ים יְשׁוּעָ֑ה כִּֽי־חֻקֶּ֥יךָ לֹ֝א דָרָֽשׁוּ

“Salvation {is} far & they have not sought”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because the wicked have not sought your statutes, salvation is far from them]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:155 (#2)

רָחְקוֹק מֵרְשָׁעִ֥ים יְשׁוּעָ֑ה

“Salvation {is} far”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh not saving the wicked as if **Salvation** were an object that was physically **far** from them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The wicked have no hope of being delivered]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:155 (#3)

יְשׁוּעָה

“Salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Being saved]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:155 (#4)

מֵרְשָׁעִים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מֵרְשָׁעִים”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to refer to a type of person. If your language does not use adjectives this way, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [from those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:156 (#1)

רַחֲמֶיךָ

“Your compassions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Your acts of compassion]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:156 (#2)

כְּמִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ

“according to your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to the way you judge]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:156 (#3)

חַיֵּנִי

“revive me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [preserve my life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:157 (#1)

רֹדְפַי וְצָרָי

“my pursuers and my adversaries”

The terms **my pursuers** and **my adversaries** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my enemies who pursue me]

See: Doublet

Psalms 119:157 (#2)

מֵעֵדְוֹתֶיךָ לֹא נָטִיתִי

“from your testimonies I do not turn aside”

The psalmist is speaking of obedience to Yahweh’s **testimonies** as if it were staying on a physical path, and disobedience as if it were to **turn aside** from that path. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I do not disobey your testimonies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:158 (#1)

בֹּגְדִים

“the treacherous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **treacherous** as a noun to refer to a type of person. If your language does not use adjectives this way, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [treacherous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 119:159 (#1)

כְּחַסְדְּךָ

“according to your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to how you love me so faithfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:159 (#2)

חַיֵּנִי

“revive me”

The psalmist is speaking as if he were dead and is asking Yahweh to **revive** or make him alive again. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [preserve my life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:160 (#1)

רֹאשׁ־דְּבָרְךָ

“The head of your word”

The psalmist is speaking of the essence or totality of Yahweh’s **word** as if it were the **head**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The essence of your word]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:160 (#2)

אֱמֶת

“is} truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is trustworthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:160 (#3)

כָּל־מִשְׁפַּט צִדְקֶךָ

“every judgment of your righteousness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **judgment** characterized by Yahweh’s **righteousness**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this differently. Alternate translation: [every judgment that comes from your righteousness]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:160 (#4)

צִדְקֶךָ

“of your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [of your right standards]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:161 (#1)

ומדבריך פָּחַד לִבִּי

“and my heart trembles from your words”

Here, **and** introduces a contrast. Even though his enemies are persecuting the psalmist without cause, his fear and reverence are directed toward Yahweh’s words, not toward the princes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this contrast more explicit. Alternate translation: [however, my heart trembles from your words]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 119:161 (#2)

פָּחַד לִבִּי

“my heart trembles”

Here the psalmist describes his deep inner reverence or awe as if his **heart** were actually trembling in fear. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am in awe]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:162 (#1)

כְּמוֹצֵא שָׁלָל רָב

“like one finding great plunder”

The point of this comparison is to emphasize the great joy the psalmist finds in Yahweh’s word, comparing it to the joy of discovering something very valuable or **great plunder**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the meaning of this comparison more explicit. Alternate translation: [as joyful as one who finds a great treasure]

See: Simile

Psalms 119:163 (#1)

שָׁקֶר

“Falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Everything that is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:163 (#2)

שָׂנֵאתִי וָאֲתַעֵבָה

“I hate and I abhor”

The terms **I hate** and **I abhor** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I completely despise]

See: Doublet

Psalms 119:164 (#1)

שֶׁבַע בַּיּוֹם

“Seven times in the day”

The psalmist says **Seven times in the day** as a generalization to emphasize how frequently he praises Yahweh. He does not necessarily mean exactly seven times. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [Many times in the day]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 119:164 (#2)

מִשְׁפְּטֵי צִדְקֶךָ

“the judgments of your righteousness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **judgments** characterized by Yahweh’s **righteousness**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this differently. Alternate translation: [your righteous judgments]

See: Possession

Psalms 119:164 (#3)

צִדְקֶךָ

“your righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your right standards]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:165 (#1)

שָׁלוֹם

“peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [well-being]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:165 (#2)

וְאֵין־לָמוֹ מִכְשׁוֹל

“and there is no stumbling block for them”

The psalmist is speaking of sinning as if it were a physical **stumbling block** which those who love Yahweh’s law do not need to trip over. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and nothing causes them to sin]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:166 (#1)

לִישׁוּעָתְךָ

“for your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for when you will save me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:167 (#1)

שָׁמְרָה נַפְשִׁי עֵדֹתֶיךָ

“My soul keeps your testimonies”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to represent his whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I keep your testimonies]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:168 (#1)

שָׁמַרְתִּי פִקּוּדֶיךָ וְעֵדֹתֶיךָ כִּי כָל־דְּרָכַי נֶגְדֶּךָ

“I keep your precepts and your testimonies, for all my ways {are} before you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because all my ways are before you, I keep your precepts and your testimonies]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:168 (#2)

כָּל־דְּרָכַי נֶגְדֶּךָ

“all my ways {are} before you”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh seeing and knowing everything he does as if his **ways** were physical paths that are visible **before** Yahweh. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for you see everything I do]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 119:169 (#1)

תִּקְרַב רִנָּתִי לְפָנֶיךָ

“May my cry come near to your face”

The psalmist is speaking of his **cry** as if it were a living thing that could **come near** to Yahweh on its own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly here and in the other verses. Alternate translation: [May you hear my cry]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:169 (#2)

תִּקְרַב רִנָּתִי לְפָנֶיךָ

“May my cry come near to your face”

From this verse through verse 175, the psalmist is expressing his desire that something will do something using third-person verb forms. Here he wants his **cry** to **come near** to Yahweh. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that my cry would come near to you]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 119:169 (#3)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **your face** represents being in Yahweh’s presence and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to your attention]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:169 (#4)

הֲבִינֵנִי

“give me understanding”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **understanding**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [cause me to understand]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:170 (#1)

תָּבֹא תְחִנָּתִי לְפָנֶיךָ

“May my plea come to your face”

The psalmist is speaking of his **plea** as if it were a living thing that could **come** to Yahweh on its own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you hear my plea]

See: Personification

Psalms 119:170 (#2)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **your face** represents your presence and attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to your attention]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:171 (#1)

שְׂפָתַי

“my lips”

Here, **my lips** represents the psalmist’s speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:171 (#2)

תְּהִלָּה

“praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [words that praise you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:172 (#1)

לְשׁוֹנִי

“my tongue”

Here, **my tongue** represents the psalmist’s speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my voice]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 119:172 (#2)

צֶדֶק

“are} righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are just and fair]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:173 (#1)

תְּהִי־יָדְךָ לְעָזְרֵנִי כִּי פִקּוּדֶיךָ בָחָרְתִּי

“May your hand be to help me, for I have chosen your precepts”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I have chosen your precepts, let your hand be to help me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 119:173 (#2)

תְּהִי־יָדְךָ

“May your hand be”

The psalmist is using one part of Yahweh, his **hand**, to mean all of him in the act of helping him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you act]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:174 (#1)

לִישׁוּעָתְךָ

“for your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for you to save me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:174 (#2)

שַׁעֲשֻׁעָי

“is} my delight”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of delight, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [delights me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:175 (#1)

תְּחִי־נַפְשִׁי וּתְהַלְלֶךָּ

“May my soul live, and may it praise you”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let me live, and let me praise you]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 119:175 (#2)

וּמִשְׁפָּטֶךָ

“your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things you have decided]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 119:176 (#1)

תָּעִיתִי כְּשֶׂה אֹבֵד

“I have strayed like a perishing sheep”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **perishing sheep** has wandered away from its shepherd and is lost and vulnerable, so the psalmist has **strayed** from Yahweh’s ways and is in need of rescue. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I have wandered away and am lost and vulnerable like a sheep that is about to die]

See: Simile

Psalms 119:176 (#2)

בַּקֵּשׁ עַבְדֶּךָ

“seek your servant”

The psalmist is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [seek for me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 119:176 (#3)

מִצְוֹתֶיךָ לֹא שָׁכָחְתִּי

“I have not forgotten your commandments”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **forgotten** to emphasize that he will carefully remember Yahweh’s commandments. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [I have carefully kept your commandments in my mind]

See: Double Negatives

Psalms - Chapter 120 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 120 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Plea for deliverance (1–2)
2. Judgment on the deceiver (3–4)
3. Complaint of distant dwelling (5–7)

Psalms 120:1 (#1)

בַּצָּרָתָה לִּי

“in the distress to me”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [while I was suffering]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 120:2 (#1)

הַצִּילָה נַפְשִׁי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הַצִּילָה נַפְשִׁי”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please deliver my soul]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 120:2 (#2)

נַפְשִׁי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: נַפְשִׁי”

The psalmist is using **my soul** to represent himself as a whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 120:2 (#3)

מִשְּׂפַת־שָׁקֶר מִלְּשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִשְּׂפַת־שָׁקֶר מִלְּשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [from those who speak lies]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 120:2 (#4)

מִשְּׂפַת־שָׁקֶר מִלְּשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִשְּׂפַת־שָׁקֶר מִלְּשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה”

The psalmist is using is using parts of a person, **lips** and **tongue** to represent his enemies who are telling lies about him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from people speaking falsehood and deceit about me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 120:2 (#5)

מִשְּׂפַת־שָׁקֶר

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִשְּׂפַת־שָׁקֶר”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from those who speak falsely]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 120:2 (#6)

מִלָּשׁשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִלָּשׁשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from those who deceive]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 120:3 (#1)

מַה־יִּתֵּן לְךָ וּמַה־יֹּסִיף לָךְ

"What & to you, and what & to you"

The psalmist is using the question form to warn his enemies of certain punishment from God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this question as a statement or as exclamation. Alternate translation: [He will give punishment to you, and he will add more to you]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 120:3 (#2)

מַה־יִּתֵּן לְךָ וּמַה־יֹּסִיף לָךְ

"What & to you, and what & to you"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [What severe punishment will he give to you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 120:3 (#3)

יִתֵּן

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: יִתֵּן"

The pronoun **he** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [will Yahweh give]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 120:3 (#4)

לָשׁשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה

"O tongue of"

As in the previous verse, **tongue of deceit** represents the psalmist's enemies who are telling lies about him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [O you who speak deceitfully]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 120:4 (#1)

חִצֵּי גִבּוֹר שְׁנוּנִים עִם גַּחֲלֵי רְתָמִים

"a warrior & with & broom trees"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context of the previous verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He will give you arrows of a warrior, sharpened, with coals of broom trees]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 120:4 (#2)

חִצֵּי גִבּוֹר שְׁנוּנִים

"a warrior"

Here the psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh's punishment were **arrows of a warrior, sharpened**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Severe punishment]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 120:4 (#3)

שְׁנוּנִים

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שְׁנוּנִים"

The expression **sharpened** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that someone has sharpened]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 120:4 (#4)

גַּחֲלֵי רְתָמִים

"broom trees"

Here the psalmist is speaking as if God's punishment were **coals of broom trees**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [burning destruction]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 120:5 (#1)

אוֹיָה־לִּ֫י

"Woe to me"

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, distress, about his situation. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what the psalmist was feeling. Alternate translation: [How miserable I am]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 120:5 (#2)

גַּ֭רְתִּי מֶ֣שֶׁךְ שָׁ֑כַנְתִּי עִם־אָ֝הֳלֵ֗י קֵדָֽר

"I am sojourning {in} Meshech; I am dwelling with the tents of Kedar"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. The places named both refer to the people who lived in those places who were considered barbarian or savage. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I have lived for a long time among hostile people]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 120:5 (#3)

אָ֝הֳלֵ֗י קֵדָֽר

"the tents of Kedar"

Here, **the tents of Kedar** represents the people who live in those tents. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Kedar]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 120:6 (#1)

רַ֭בַּת שָׁכְנָה־לָּ֣הּ נַפְשִׁ֑י

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: רַ֭בַּת שָׁכְנָה־לָּ֣הּ נַפְשִׁ֑י"

The psalmist is using **My soul** to represent himself as a whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have dwelt for a long time]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 120:6 (#2)

שׂוֹנֵ֖א שָׁלֽוֹם

"a hater of"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those who hate to live peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 120:7 (#1)

אֲנִי־שָׁ֑לוֹם

"ן"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I am for peace]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 120:7 (#2)

שָׁלֽוֹם

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שָׁלֽוֹם"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [am someone who wants to live peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 120:7 (#3)

וְכִֽי־אֲדַבֵּ֥ר

"but when"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [but when I speak about peace]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 120:7 (#4)

וְכִכְיִ

“but when”

The psalmist uses the word **but** here to indicate a contrast between his peaceful disposition and his neighbors’ desire for conflict. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and yet when]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 120:7 (#5)

הֵ֣מָּה לַמִּלְחָמָֽה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הֵ֣מָּה לַמִּלְחָמָֽה”

The pronoun **they** refers to those who hate peace mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [those people are for war]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 120:7 (#6)

לַמִּלְחָמָֽה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמִּלְחָמָֽה”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **war**, you could express the same idea in another way as is modeled in the UST.

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 121 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 121 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Confession of trust (1–2)
2. Assurance of protection (3–6)
3. Promise of preservation (Verses 7–8)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Multiple speakers

This psalm is a dialogue between two individuals as is made clear by the implied information in the UST. Make sure this is clear to your readers.

Psalms 121:1 (#1)

אֶשָּׂ֣א עֵ֭ינַי

“I lift up my eyes”

The psalmist is using **lift up my eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “to look up at” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I look up]

See: Idiom

Psalms 121:1 (#2)

מֵ֝אַ֗יִן יָבֹ֥א עֶזְרִֽי

“From where does my help come”

The psalmist is using the question form to set up a confident answer that he provides in verse 2. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I know where my help comes from!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 121:1 (#3)

עֶזְרִֽי

“my help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [someone to help me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 121:2 (#1)

עֶזְרִ֥י מֵעִ֗ם יְהוָ֫ה

“My help {is} from with Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The one who helps me is Yahweh]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 121:2 (#2)

שֹׁמֵ֖ר שָׁמַ֣יִם וָאָֽרֶץ

“heaven and earth”

The psalmist is referring to all of creation by naming two extremes, **heaven** and **earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all creation]

See: Merism

Psalms 121:3 (#1)

אַל־יִתֵּ֣ן לַמּ֣וֹט רַגְלֶ֑ךָ אַל־יָנ֝֗וּם שֹׁמְרֶֽךָ

“May he not give your foot to the slipping; may your keeper not slumber”

By using **May**, the psalmist is expressing what he desires or prays will happen. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that he will not give your foot to the slipping; that your keeper will not slumber]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 121:3 (#2)

אַל־יִתֵּ֣ן

“May he not give”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, who was named in verse 2. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers as is modeled in the UST.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 121:3 (#3)

לַמּ֣וֹט רַגְלֶ֑ךָ

“your foot to the slipping”

The psalmist is speaking of experiencing danger or hardship as if it were a person’s **foot slipping** and causing him to fall. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you over to danger]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 121:3 (#4)

שֹׁמְרֶֽךָ

“your keeper”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the one who keeps you safe. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the one who keeps you safe]

See: Possession

Psalms 121:4 (#1)

הִנֵּ֤ה

“Behold”

The psalmist is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Pay attention]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 121:4 (#2)

לֹ֤א־יָנ֨וּם וְלֹ֗א יִישָׁ֥ן

“he will not slumber, and he will not sleep”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [he will not slumber, indeed, he will not sleep]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 121:4 (#3)

שֹׁמֵ֖ר יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“the keeper of Israel”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the one who keeps Israel safe. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the one who keeps Israel]

See: Possession

Psalms 121:5 (#1)

יְהוָ֥ה צִלֶּ֑ךָ

“Yahweh {is} your shade”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh as if he were **shade** that protects a person from the heat of the sun. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is your protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 121:5 (#2)

עַל־יַ֥ד יְמִינֶֽךָ

“upon your right hand”

The psalmist is using **upon your right hand** as a common expression of the culture to mean “at your side” or “close beside you.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at your side]

See: Idiom

Psalms 121:6 (#1)

הַשֶּׁ֭מֶשׁ לֹא־יַכֶּ֣כָּה וְיָרֵ֑חַ בַּלָּֽיְלָה

“not & and the moon”

The psalmist is speaking of **the sun** and **the moon** as if they were living things that could **strike** a person and cause harm. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the heat of the sun will not harm you, and the moon will not harm you by night]

See: Personification

Psalms 121:6 (#2)

וְיָרֵ֑חַ בַּלָּֽיְלָה

“and the moon”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and the moon will not strike you by night]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 121:7 (#1)

יְהוָ֥ה יִשְׁמָרְךָ֗ מִכָּל־רָ֫ע֥ יִשְׁמֹ֥ר אֶת־נַפְשֶֽׁךָ

“Yahweh & evil & your soul”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will protect you from all evil, yes, he will keep your soul]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 121:7 (#2)

מִכָּל־רָ֫ע֥

“evil”

The psalmist is using the adjective **evil** as a noun to mean evil things in general. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [from all evil things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 121:7 (#3)

אֶת־נַפְשֶֽׁךָ

“your soul”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, his **soul**, to mean all of him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your very life]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 121:8 (#1)

צֵאתְךָ֥ וּבוֹאֶ֑ךָ

“your going out and your coming in”

The psalmist is referring to all of a person’s activities by naming two extremes, **your going out** and **your coming in**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [you safe everywhere you go]

See: Merism

Psalms 121:8 (#2)

מֵ֝עַתָּ֗ה וְעַד־עוֹלָֽם

“and to forever”

The psalmist is referring to all of time by naming two extremes, **now** and **forever**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for all time]

See: Merism

Psalms - Chapter 122 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 122 one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Joy of arrival and worship (1–2)
2. The commendation of Jerusalem (vv. 3–5)
3. A prayer for peace and prosperity (6–9)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

"house of Yahweh"
In this psalm, the phrase "house of Yahweh" is used to talk about the temple. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning plainly.

"Jerusalem"
Many times in this Psalm, the psalmist speaks directly to the city of Jerusalem even though it is not a person and cannot hear. He refers to Jerusalem in both the second and third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Jerusalem.

Psalms 122:1 (#1)

בֵּ֣ית יְהוָ֑ה

"to} the house of Yahweh"

David is speaking of the temple where Yahweh is worshiped as if it were a **house** in which he lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the temple of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 122:2 (#1)

עֹמְדֹ֥ת הָי֗וּ רַגְלֵ֫ינוּ

"Our feet are standing"

Here David is using one part of their bodies, their **feet**, to mean all of them in the act of standing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We are standing]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 122:2 (#2)

בִּ֭בְשָׁעָרַ֣יִךְ יְרוּשָׁלָ֑ם

"in your gates, Jerusalem"

David is speaking to **Jerusalem**, which is a city that cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him how he feels about Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [within the gates of Jerusalem]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 122:2 (#3)

בִּ֭בְשָׁעָרַ֣יִךְ

"in your gates"

Here the word **gates** refers to the entire city or town. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [within you, the city of]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 122:3 (#1)

כְּ֭עִיר שֻׁחְבְּרָה־לָּ֣הּ יַחְדָּ֑ו

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כְּ֭עִיר שֻׁחְבְּרָה־לָּ֣הּ יַחְדָּ֑ו"

The point of this comparison is that just as a city whose parts are **joined** together is compact and unified, so is Jerusalem well-constructed and cohesive. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [so that all its parts are compact and unified]

See: Simile

Psalms 122:3 (#2)

שֻׁחְבְּרָה־לָּ֣הּ יַחְדָּ֑ו

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שֻׁחְבְּרָה־לָּ֣הּ יַחְדָּ֑ו"

The expression **is joined** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that holds itself together]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 122:4 (#1)

שִׁבְטֵי־יָ֭הּ

"the tribes of Yah"

David is using this possessive form to mean that the tribes belong to and worship Yahweh because he is their God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the tribes that worship Yahweh]

See: Possession

Psalms 122:4 (#2)

יָ֭הּ

"Yah"

The word **Yah** is a shortened form of the name "Yahweh," the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 122:4 (#3)

עֵדָ֥ות לְיִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

"a testimony to Israel"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **testimony**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as Yahweh instructed the people of Israel to do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 122:4 (#4)

לְ֝הֹדֹ֗ות לְשֵׁ֣ם יְהוָֽה

"to give thanks to the name of Yahweh"

Here, **to** marks **give thanks to the name of Yahweh** as the goal or purpose of the tribes going up. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that they can give thanks to the name of Yahweh]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 122:4 (#5)

לְשֵׁ֣ם יְהוָֽה

"to the name of Yahweh"

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to Yahweh himself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 122:5 (#1)

כִּֽי־ שָׁ֭מָּה ׀ יָשְׁב֣וּ כִסְאֹ֑ות לְמִשְׁפָּֽט

"For there sit thrones for judgment"

Here, **For** introduces the reason why the tribes go up to Jerusalem: it is the place where kings will sit on their thrones to render justice. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason. Alternate translation: [Because that is where kings sit on thrones for judgment]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 122:5 (#2)

כִּסְאֹ֑ות לְמִשְׁפָּֽט

"thrones for judgment"

Here, **thrones** represents the kings' royal authority to rule and judge. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [kings to carry out their judicial authority]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 122:5 (#3)

לְמִשְׁפָּֽט

"for judgment"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [where kings are judging]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 122:5 (#4)

כִּסְאֹ֑ות לְבֵ֖ית דָּוִֽיד

"thrones for the house of David"

David is leaving out words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [there sit thrones for the house of David]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 122:5 (#5)

לְבֵ֖ית דָּוִֽיד

"for the house of David"

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of David** figuratively means all the people descended from David. Alternate translation: [for the descendants of David]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 122:6 (#1)

שַׁ֭אֲלוּ שְׁלֹ֣ום יְרוּשָׁלִָ֑ם יִ֝שְׁלָ֗יוּ אֹהֲבָֽיִךְ

"the ones loving you"

David is using words with similar sounds for poetic effect. In the original language, the words for **ask**,

peace, and **prosper** all share sounds similar to the word for **Jerusalem**. David is using this wordplay to connect his prayer for the city with its very name. You may want to reproduce this effect if poetry in your language does this. If not, you could indicate it in a footnote.

See: Poetry

Psalms 122:6 (#2)

שַׁאֲלוּ שְׁלֹ֣ום יְרוּשָׁלָ֑ם

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שַׁאֲלוּ שְׁלֹ֣ום יְרוּשָׁלָ֑ם"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Ask that those in the city of Jerusalem may live peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 122:6 (#3)

יְרוּשָׁלָ֑ם

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: יְרוּשָׁלָ֑ם"

Here the name **Jerusalem** represents the people who live in that city. Alternate translation: [those who live in Jerusalem]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 122:6 (#4)

יִשְׁלָ֖יוּ אֹהֲבָֽיִךְ

"the ones loving you"

In this verse and to the end of the psalm, David is again speaking to Jerusalem, which is a city that cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about the welfare of those who love the city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Jerusalem. Alternate translation: [may the ones loving Jerusalem prosper]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 122:6 (#5)

יִשְׁלָ֖יוּ אֹהֲבָֽיִךְ

"the ones loving you"

David is saying what he wants to happen. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about "let" and "may" and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I pray that the ones loving you will prosper]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 122:7 (#1)

יְהִי־שָׁלֹ֥ום בְּחֵילֵ֑ךְ שַׁלְוָ֖ה בְּאַרְמְנוֹתָֽיִךְ

"Let there be"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the ideas of **peace** and **prosperity**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [May people live peacefully within your rampart, prosperously in your citadels]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 122:7 (#2)

יְהִי־שָׁלֹ֥ום בְּחֵילֵ֑ךְ שַׁלְוָ֖ה בְּאַרְמְנוֹתָֽיִךְ

"Let there be"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. David uses the two phrases together to emphasize his desire for the well-being of Jerusalem. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way, as the UST does. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Let there be peace within your rampart, yes, let there be prosperity in your citadels]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 122:7 (#3)

יְהִי־שָׁלֹ֥ום

"Let there be"

David is asking Yahweh to bless the people of Israel. In your translation, use a form that people would recognize as a blessing in your language. You might express this as a prayer, if that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh bring peace]

See: Blessings

Psalms 122:7 (#4)

שַׁלְוָ֖ה

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שַׁלְוָ֖ה"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [let there be prosperity]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 122:8 (#1)

לְמַ֣עַן אַחַ֣י וְרֵעָ֑י

“For the sake of my brothers and my companions”

Here, **For** marks **the sake of my brothers and my companions** as the motivation for David speaking peace. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [Because I love my brothers and my companions]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 122:8 (#2)

אַחַ֣י

“my brothers”

The psalmist is using the term **brothers** to describe people who are descended from the same ancestor or all the Israelites. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my countrymen]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 122:8 (#3)

אֲדַבְּרָה־נָּ֖א שָׁלֹ֣ום בָּֽךְ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: אֲדַבְּרָה־נָּ֖א שָׁלֹ֣ום בָּֽךְ”

David is using **please, peace in you** as a common expression of his culture used to wish someone well or to pronounce a blessing. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let me say, “Peace be with you”] or [I pray for peace for you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 122:8 (#4)

שָׁלֹ֣ום בָּֽךְ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שָׁלֹ֣ום בָּֽךְ”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [may people live peacefully within you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 122:9 (#1)

לְמַ֣עַן בֵּית־יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵ֔ינוּ

“For the sake of & Yahweh our God”

Here, **For** marks **the sake of the house of Yahweh our God** as the motivation for David seeking good. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [Because I love the house of Yahweh our God]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 122:9 (#2)

בֵּית־יְהוָ֣ה

“Yahweh”

David is speaking of the temple where Yahweh is worshiped as if it were a **house** in which he lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the temple of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 122:9 (#3)

טֽוֹב

“good”

David is using the adjective **good** as a noun to refer to good things. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [what is good]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms - Chapter 123 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 123 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. The servant’s posture: looking to Yahweh (1–2)
2. The servant’s plea: request for mercy (3–4)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Trust
Just as a servant trusts his master to protect him, so the psalmist is trusting God to stop proud people from insulting him. (See: trust, trusted, trustworthy, trustworthiness)

Psalms 123:1 (#1)

נָשָׂאתִי אֶת־עֵינָי

“I lift up my eyes”

The psalmist is using **I lift up my eyes** as a common expression of the culture to mean that he looks expectantly toward God for help. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I look expectantly]

See: Idiom

Psalms 123:1 (#2)

נָשָׂאתִי אֶת־עֵינָי

“I lift up my eyes”

Here the pronouns **I** and **my** refers to the psalmist, who speaks as an individual in this verse. However, in verse 2, the psalmist shifts to the plural **our** and **us**, indicating that he is now speaking on behalf of a group. If using the singular form of the pronouns here would not be natural in your language, you could use the plural forms in your translation. Alternate translation: [we lift up our eyes]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 123:2 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The psalmist is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 123:2 (#2)

כְּעֵינֵי עֲבָדִים אֶל־יַד אֲדוֹנֵיהֶם כְּעֵינֵי שִׁפְחָה אֶל־יַד גְּבִרְתָּהּ כֵּן עֵינֵינוּ אֶל־יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“as the eyes of servants {are} to the hand of their masters, as the eyes of a maidservant {are} to the hand of her mistress, thus our eyes {are} to Yahweh our God”

The point of this comparison is that just as **servants** look to the hand of **their masters** for provision and direction, so the psalmist and his people look to **Yahweh** to provide for them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as servants depend on their masters, and just as a maidservant depends on her mistress, so we wait on Yahweh our God]

See: Simile

Psalms 123:2 (#3)

כְּעֵינֵי עֲבָדִים אֶל־יַד אֲדוֹנֵיהֶם כְּעֵינֵי שִׁפְחָה אֶל־יַד גְּבִרְתָּהּ

“as the eyes of servants {are} to the hand of their masters, as the eyes of a maidservant {are} to the hand of her mistress”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. In the first phrase, the psalmist refers to male **servants** and their **masters**, and in the second, to a **maidservant** and her **mistress**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [as servants watch the hand of their masters for direction] or [as the eyes of the servants are to the hand of their masters, indeed, as the eyes of a maidservant are to the hand of her mistress]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 123:2 (#4)

יַד אֲדוֹנֵיהֶם & יַד גְּבִרְתָּהּ

“the hand of their masters & the hand of her mistress”

Here, **hand** represents the provision and direction of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the direction of their masters … the direction of her mistress]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 123:3 (#1)

חָנֵּנוּ יְהוָה חָנֵּנוּ

“Be gracious to us, Yahweh, be gracious to us”

Be gracious is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please be gracious to us, Yahweh, be gracious to us]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 123:3 (#2)

כִּי־רַ֣ב שָׂבַ֣עְנוּ בּֽוּז

“for we are greatly satiated with contempt”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. The psalmist asks Yahweh to be gracious because they have been despised for so long. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because we are greatly satiated with contempt]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 123:3 (#3)

רַ֣ב שָׂבַ֣עְנוּ בּֽוּז

“we are greatly satiated with contempt”

The psalmist is speaking of being treated with **contempt** as if it were food that fills a person. He means that they have experienced so much contempt that they cannot endure any more. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we have experienced more contempt than we can endure]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 123:3 (#4)

בּֽוּז

“with contempt”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **contempt**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with how others despise us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 123:4 (#1)

שָׂבְעָה־לָּ֣הּ נַפְשֵׁ֣נוּ הַלַּ֣עַג

“our soul is satiated with it, the scorn of”

The psalmist is speaking of being treated with **scorn** as if it were food that fills a person. He means that they have experienced so much scorn that they cannot endure any more. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we have been treated with too much scorn from]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 123:4 (#2)

שָׂבְעָה־לָּ֣הּ נַפְשֵׁ֣נוּ

“our soul is satiated with it”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, their **soul**, to mean all of them in the act of experiencing scorn and contempt. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we are satiated with]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 123:4 (#3)

שָׂבְעָה־לָּ֣הּ

“is satiated with it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the scorn and contempt that the psalmist specifies later in the verse. The psalmist uses this pronoun before naming what it refers to. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [is satiated with these things]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 123:4 (#4)

הַלַּ֣עַג הַשַּׁאֲנַנִּ֑ים הַ֝הַ֗בּוּז לִגְאֵיוֹנִֽים

“the scorn of the arrogant, the contempt of the proud”

These two phrases **the scorn of the arrogant** and **the contempt of the proud** mean basically the same thing. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [the great mockery of arrogant people]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 123:4 (#5)

הַלַּ֣עַג

“the scorn of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **scorn**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being mocked by]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 123:4 (#6)

הַשַּׁאֲנַנִּֽים

“the arrogant”

The psalmist is using the adjective **arrogant** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [arrogant people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 123:4 (#7)

הַלַּעַ֥ג

“the contempt of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **contempt**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being despised by]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 123:4 (#8)

הַלַּעַ֥ג

“the contempt of”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [satiated with the contempt of]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 123:4 (#9)

לִגְאַיּוֹנִֽים

“the proud”

The psalmist is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [proud people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms - Chapter 124 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 124 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Acknowledge Yahweh’s protection from enemies (1–5)
2. Bless Yahweh who did not let us be destroyed (6–7)
3. Confess Yahweh as our help and creator (8)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Various images for enemies

The psalmist depicts enemies through three different images: devouring beasts (verses 3, 6), an overwhelming flood (verses 4–5), and a trapper’s snare (verse 7). Translators should preserve these distinct images.

Psalms 124:1 (#1)

לוּלֵ֤י יְהוָ֨ה שֶׁהָ֪יָה לָ֡נוּ

“If not Yahweh who was for us”

David is making a conditional statement **If not Yahweh**, that sounds hypothetical, but he knows that the condition is not true. Yahweh was indeed for Israel, and therefore the disastrous results David goes on to describe did not happen. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that the speaker believes is not true. Alternate translation: [If Yahweh had not been on our side]

See: Connect — Contrary to Fact Conditions

Psalms 124:1 (#2)

יֹ֖אמַר־נָ֣א יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“let Israel indeed say”

David is saying what he wants the people of Israel to do and inviting them to join in communal recitation. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [Israel should indeed say]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 124:2 (#1)

בָּקָ֗וּם עָלֵ֥ינוּ אָדָֽם

“when man rose up against us”

Here David is speaking as if the enemies attacking the Israelites actually **rose up** physically above Israel to destroy them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. [when our enemies came to fight against us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 124:2 (#2)

אָדָם

“man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 124:3 (#1)

אֱאָזַי

“then”

Here and through verse 5, the word **then** introduces what the consequences could have been if the condition proposed in the previous verse (if Yahweh had not been with them when their enemies attacked) had actually happened. Use a natural form in your language for introducing the consequence of this possible condition. Alternate translation: [in that case,]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 124:3 (#2)

חַיִּים בְּלָעֻנוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: חַיִּים בְּלָעֻנוּ”

Here David is speaking as if the enemies who could have killed all the Israelites were wild animals that could have **swallowed** Israel **alive**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [then they would have killed us all]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 124:3 (#3)

בְּלָעֻנוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּלָעֻנוּ”

The pronoun **they** refers to the enemies described as “man” in verse 2. The singular “man” has shifted to a plural pronoun here and following. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [then those enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 124:3 (#4)

בַּחֲרֹ֣ת אַפָּ֣ם בָּ֑נוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בַּחֲרֹ֣ת אַפָּ֣ם בָּ֑נוּ”

David is using **nose burned** as a common expression of his culture to mean “to be very angry.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they were fiercely angry with us]

See: Idiom

Psalms 124:4 (#1)

הַמַּ֥יִם שְׁטָפֻ֑נוּ נַ֝חְלָ֗ה עָבַ֥ר עַל־נַפְשֵׁ֑נוּ

“the torrent would have passed over”

Here David is speaking of the attacks of the enemies as if they were **waters** and a **torrent** that was like a river overflowing its banks or a flood that could overwhelm and drown Israel. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then the enemies would have overwhelmed us; the attacks would have destroyed us]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 124:4 (#2)

נַפְשֵׁנוּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: נַפְשֵׁנוּ”

Here, **soul** represents the people themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all of us]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 124:5 (#1)

אֱאָזַי עָבַר עַל־נַפְשֵׁנוּ הַמַּ֖יִם הַזֵּדוֹנִֽים

“Then the raging waters would have passed over our soul”

This phrase is basically repeating the two phrases from the previous verse; “the waters would have over-

flowed us" and "the torrent would have passed over our soul," The second and third phrases emphasize the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could begin this phrase with a connecting word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Then indeed, our enemies would have completely annihilated us]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 124:5 (#2)

נַפְשֵׁנוּ

"our soul"

Here, **soul** represents the people themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all of us]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 124:6 (#1)

בָּרָוּךְ יְהוָה

"Blessed {be} Yahweh"

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [We bless Yahweh] or [Let us praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 124:6 (#2)

שֶׁלֹּא נְתָנָנוּ טֶרֶף לְשִׁנֵּיהֶם

"who did not make us prey for their teeth"

Here David is speaking of the enemies attacking and destroying Israel as if they were predatory animals that could devour Israel as **prey** with **their teeth**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who did not hand us over to be destroyed by our enemies]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 124:6 (#3)

לְשִׁנֵּיהֶם

"for their teeth"

The pronoun **their** refers to the enemies described as "man" in verse 2 and "they" in verse 3. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [for the teeth of our enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 124:7 (#1)

נַפְשֵׁנוּ כְּצִפּוֹר נִמְלְטָה מִפַּח יוֹקְשִׁים

"Our soul {is} like a bird {that} escaped from the snare of the trappers"

The point of this comparison is that just as a **bird** that **escaped from the snare of the trappers** flew away to safety, so the people of Israel escaped from the power of their enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [We are like a bird that escaped from the trap of the hunters]

See: Simile

Psalms 124:7 (#2)

נַפְשֵׁנוּ כְּצִפּוֹר

"Our soul {is} like a bird"

David is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [We are like a bird]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 124:7 (#3)

הַפַּח נִשְׁבָּר

"the snare was broken"

The expression **was broken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the snare broke]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 124:7 (#4)

וְאֲנַחְנוּ נִמְלָטְנוּ

"and we, we escaped"

David is stating the pronoun **we** separately, even though the verb translated as **we escaped** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the tension of the escape. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same

purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing this emphasis. Alternate translation: [and we indeed escaped!]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 124:8 (#1)

עֶזְרֵנוּ בְּשֵׁם יְהוָה

“Our help & of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [It is Yahweh himself who helps us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 124:8 (#2)

בְּשֵׁם יְהוָה

“of Yahweh”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and his authority and power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [is in Yahweh himself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 124:8 (#3)

שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ

“and earth”

David is referring to all of creation by naming two extremes, **heaven** and **earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [of all things]

See: Merism

Psalms - Chapter 125 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 125 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion. This song is also a “psalm of trust,” expressing communal confidence that Yahweh protects his people as permanently as mountains surround Jerusalem. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Those who trust in Yahweh are secure (1–2)
2. Yahweh preserves the righteous from evil rule (3–5)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh’s protection as surrounding presence
The psalmist pictures Yahweh’s care as physical encirclement, like the hills around Zion. This spatial metaphor may need adaptation where mountains are unfamiliar.

The righteous and the wicked
The psalm contrasts the righteous with workers of iniquity, promising that evil rule will not persist over God’s allotted land.

Psalms 125:1 (#1)

כְּהַר־צִיּוֹן

“are} like Mount Zion”

The point of this comparison is that just as **Mount Zion** is immovable and endures permanently, so those **trusting in Yahweh** are secure and will endure permanently. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [are as stable and immovable as Mount Zion]

See: Simile

Psalms 125:1 (#2)

לֹא־יִמּוֹט לְעוֹלָם יֵשֵׁב

“it will not be shaken; forever it abides”

The pronoun **it** refers to Mount Zion in both instances. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Mount Zion will not be shaken; forever Mount Zion abides]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 125:1 (#3)

לֹא־יִמּוֹט

“it will not be shaken”

The expression **be shaken** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one can move it] or [nothing can shake it]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 125:2 (#1)

יְרוּשָׁלַ͏ִם הָרִים סָבִיב לָהּ וַיהוָה סָבִיב לְעַמּוֹ

“Jerusalem—mountains {are} around her, and Yahweh {is} around his people”

David is speaking of Yahweh protecting his people as if he were physically wrapped **around** them like the **mountains** around Jerusalem. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [Yahweh surrounds and protects his people just as mountains surround Jerusalem]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 125:2 (#2)

וַיהוָה סָבִיב לְעַמּוֹ

“and Yahweh {is} around his people”

The psalmist is speaking of Yahweh protecting his people as if he were physically **around** his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh protects his people on every side]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 125:3 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation of why those who trust in Yahweh are secure as stated in the previous verse. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 125:3 (#2)

שֵׁבֶט הָרֶשַׁע

“the rod of wickedness”

Here, **the rod** represents the rule or authority of wicked people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the rule of wicked people]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 125:3 (#3)

שֵׁבֶט הָרֶשַׁע

“the rod of wickedness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **rod** that is characterized by **wickedness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wicked rod] or [the rod of wicked rulers]

See: Possession

Psalms 125:3 (#4)

הָרֶשַׁע

“wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wicked] or [those who do wicked things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 125:3 (#5)

לֹא יָנוּחַ & עַל־גּוֹרָל הַצַּדִּיקִים

“will not rest on the lot of the righteous”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the authority the wicked would have over the righteous people as if the ruler’s rod were able to **rest** on them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will not have authority over the righteous]

Psalms 125:3 (#6)

גּוֹרָל הַצַּדִּיקִים

“the lot of the righteous”

Here, **the lot** represents the land that was allotted to the righteous as their inheritance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the land allotted to the righteous] or [the inheritance of the righteous]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 125:3 (#7)

גּוֹרָל הַצַּדִּיקִים

“the lot of the righteous”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean the land that was allotted to the righteous people. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the land belonging to the righteous]

See: Possession

Psalms 125:3 (#8)

הַצַּדִּיקִֽים

“the righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who trust in God]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 125:3 (#9)

לְמַ֤עַן

“so that”

Here, **so that** marks the clause that follows as the purpose of the rod of wickedness not resting on the lot of the righteous. The goal is that the righteous will not be tempted to do wrong. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order that]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 125:3 (#10)

לֹא־יִשְׁלְח֣וּ הַצַּדִּיקִ֣ים בְּעַוְלָ֣תָה יְדֵיהֶ֑ם

“the righteous will not stretch out their hands in unrighteousness”

Here, **hands** represents actions and participation. The expression **stretch out their hands** means to participate in or engage in something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [those who trust in God will not participate in unrighteousness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 125:3 (#11)

בְּעַוְלָ֣תָה

“in unrighteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **unrighteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in doing ungodly things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 125:4 (#1)

הֵיטִ֣יבָה יְהוָ֔ה

“Do good, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. The psalmist is praying to Yahweh and asking him to act. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do good, Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 125:4 (#2)

לַטּוֹבִ֑ים וְלִישָׁרִ֖ים בִּלְבּוֹתָֽם

“to the good”

These two phrases **to the good** and **to the upright in their hearts** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional, as the UST does. Another approach would be to combine them into a single phrase and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [to those who sincerely try to do good things]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 125:4 (#3)

לַטּוֹבִ֑ים

“to the good”

The psalmist is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to good people] or [to those who are good]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 125:4 (#4)

וְלִישָׁרִ֖ים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: וְלִישָׁרִ֖ים”

The psalmist is using the adjective **upright** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and to upright people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 125:4 (#5)

בְּלִבּוֹתָם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּלִבּוֹתָם”

The psalmist is speaking of the **hearts** of the upright as if the heart were the location of a person’s true motives and intentions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in their inner being]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 125:5 (#1)

וְהַמַּטִּים עֲקַלְקַלּוֹתָם

“And those twisting their crooked {ways”

The psalmist is speaking of the behavior of these people as if it were a path that they walk along. He speaks of their disobedience as **twisting their crooked ways**, that is, deviating from the straight path of righteousness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And those who behave dishonestly]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 125:5 (#2)

פֹּעֲלֵי הָאָוֶן

“the workers of iniquity”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **workers** who are characterized by **iniquity**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the people who do evil things]

See: Possession

Psalms 125:5 (#3)

הָאָוֶן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wicked things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 125:5 (#4)

שָׁלוֹם עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Peace {be} upon Israel”

The psalmist is asking Yahweh to bless the people of Israel. In your translation, use a form that people would recognize as a blessing in your language. You might express this as a prayer, if that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh give peace to Israel]

See: Blessings

Psalms 125:5 (#5)

שָׁלוֹם

“Peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Well-being]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 126 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 126 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion. This song is a “psalm of praise” for Yahweh bringing captives home. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Rejoice in Yahweh’s past restoration (1–3)
2. Pray for renewed restoration and blessing (4–6)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Sorrow and joy

People may have sorrow now; but later it will turn into joy. (See: joy, joyful, rejoice, glad)

Psalms 126:1 (#1)

אֶת־שִׁיבַת

“the captivity of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **captivity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those whom our enemies had captured from]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 126:1 (#2)

הָיִינוּ כְּחֹלְמִים

“we were like ones dreaming”

The point of this comparison is that just as people who are **dreaming** have a hard time believing what is happening, so the people of Israel could hardly believe that Yahweh was restoring them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [we could hardly believe it was real]

See: Simile

Psalms 126:2 (#1)

אָ֤ז יִמָּלֵ֣א שְׂחֹ֣וק פִּ֑ינוּ֝ וּלְשׁוֹנֵ֗נוּ רִנָּ֥ה

“Then our mouth was filled {with} laughter, and our tongue {with} a shout of joy”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way, as in the UST. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Then our mouth was filled with laughter, indeed, our tongue with a shout of joy]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 126:2 (#2)

יִמָּלֵ֣א שְׂחֹ֣וק פִּ֑ינוּ֝

“our mouth was filled {with} laughter”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, their **mouth**, to mean all of them in the act of laughing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we were filled with laughter]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 126:2 (#3)

יִמָּלֵ֣א

“was filled {with”

The expression **was filled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [overflowed with]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 126:2 (#4)

וּלְשׁוֹנֵ֗נוּ רִנָּ֥ה

“and our tongue {with} a shout of joy”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and our tongue was filled with a shout of joy]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 126:2 (#5)

וּלְשׁוֹנֵ֗נוּ

“and our tongue”

The psalmist is using one part of a person, their **tongue**, to mean all of them in the act of shouting. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we were filled]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 126:2 (#6)

רִנָּ֥ה

“with} a shout of joy”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with joyful shouting]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 126:2 (#7)

יֹ֭אמְרוּ בַּגּוֹיִ֣ם

“they said among the nations”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of other nations. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people of other nations said among themselves]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 126:2 (#8)

יֹ֭אמְרוּ בַּגּוֹיִ֣ם

“they said among the nations”

The words **they said among the nations** introduce a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [the people of other nations said]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 126:2 (#9)

הִגְדִּ֣יל יְ֭הוָה לַעֲשׂ֣וֹת עִם־אֵ֑לֶּה

“Yahweh has made great to do with these”

The psalmist is using **has made great to do** as a common expression of the culture to mean “has done great things.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has done great things for his people]

See: Idiom

Psalms 126:3 (#1)

הִגְדִּ֣יל יְהוָ֣ה לַעֲשׂ֣וֹת עִמָּ֑נוּ

“Yahweh has made great to do with us”

The psalmist is using **has made great to do** as a common expression of the culture to mean “has done great things.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has done wonderful things for us]

See: Idiom

Psalms 126:4 (#1)

שׁוּבָ֣ה יְ֭הוָה אֶת־שבותנו כַּאֲפִיקִ֥ים בַּנֶּֽגֶב

“Return, Yahweh, our captivity”

The point of this comparison is that just as the dry streambeds in the desert are suddenly restored to flowing **streams** when rain comes, so the psalmist asks Yahweh to suddenly restore the fortunes of his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Restore those who were taken captive, Yahweh, just as you suddenly restore the dry streams in the Negev with rain]

See: Simile

Psalms 126:4 (#2)

שׁוּבָ֣ה יְ֭הוָה אֶת־שבותנו

“Return, Yahweh, our captivity”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please return, Yahweh, our captivity]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 126:4 (#3)

אֶת־שבותנו

“our captivity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **captivity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [our people whom our enemies have captured]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 126:5 (#1)

הַזֹּרְעִ֥ים בְּדִמְעָ֑ה בְּרִנָּ֥ה יִקְצֹֽרוּ

“will reap”

Here the psalmist is speaking of people who keep working even while they suffer as if they were farmers **sowing** their seeds even though **in tears**, and of the future joy they will experience as a result as if they would **reap** their harvest with **a shout of joy**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Those who do their work while suffering will celebrate joyfully when they see the results]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 126:5 (#2)

בְּרִנָּ֥ה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּרִנָּ֥ה”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with a joyful shout]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 126:6 (#1)

הָ֭הָלוֹךְ יֵ֣לֵךְ ׀ וּבָכֹ֗ה

“Going, he may go and weeping”

The psalmist is repeating forms of the verb **go** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [He may indeed go, weeping]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 126:6 (#2)

מֶשֶׁךְ־הַזָּרַע

“the bag of seed”

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean a bag that contains seed. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the bag full of seed]

See: Possession

Psalms 126:6 (#3)

בֹּא־יָבוֹא

“Coming, he will come”

The psalmist is repeating forms of the verb **come** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [He will certainly come]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 126:6 (#4)

בְּרִנָּה

“in a shout of joy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with a joyful shout]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 127 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 127 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Recognize the futility of work without Yahweh (1–2)
2. Receive children as Yahweh’s gift and blessing (3–5)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Blessings

Yahweh wants his people to have rest. It is a blessing to have many children. (See: bless, blessed, blessing)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

“of Solomon”

The superscription of this psalm is “of Solomon.” This may mean that Solomon wrote this psalm. But it may also mean that someone else wrote this psalm in honor of Solomon. We recommend that you translate the superscription in a way that allows for this possibility as well as for the possibility that Solomon was the author.

Psalms 127:1 (#1)

שָׁשְׁוְא ׀ עָמְלֹוּ בוֹנָיו בּוֹ

“in} vain its builders have labored on it”

This phrase introduces the consequence of the condition proposed in the previous phrase. Use a natural form in your language for introducing the consequence of this possible condition. Alternate translation: [then it does not help for its builders to labor on it]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 127:1 (#2)

שָׁשְׁוְא ׀ שָׁקַד שׁוֹמֵר

“in} vain the watchman has stayed awake”

This phrase introduces the consequence of the condition proposed in the previous phrase. Use a natural form in your language for introducing the consequence of this possible condition. Alternate translation: [then it does no good for the watchman to stand guard over it]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 127:2 (#1)

מַשְׁכִּכֵי קוּם מְאַחֲרֵי־שָׁבֶת

“the ones rising early to get up, the ones being late to sit down”

Solomon is referring to all of a person’s working time by naming two extremes, **the ones rising early to get up** and **the ones being late to sit down**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the ones working from early morning until late at night]

See: Merism

Psalms 127:2 (#2)

אֹֽכְלֵי֮ לֶ֪חֶם הָ֫עֲצָבִ֥ים

“the ones eating the bread of toils”

Solomon is speaking of working hard to raise the food that people eat as if it were **bread of toils**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those toiling to earn your food]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 127:2 (#3)

לֶ֪חֶם הָ֫עֲצָבִ֥ים

“the bread of toils”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **toils**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [bread gained by toiling]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 127:2 (#4)

לֶ֪חֶם הָ֫עֲצָבִ֥ים

“the bread of toils”

Solomon is using the possessive form to describe **bread** that is characterized by **toils**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [bread earned through hard work]

See: Possession

Psalms 127:2 (#5)

כֵּ֤ן יִתֵּ֖ן לִֽידִידֽוֹ שֵׁנָֽא

“certainly he gives to his beloved one sleep”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, who is named in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [certainly Yahweh gives to his beloved one sleep]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 127:3 (#1)

הִנֵּ֤ה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הִנֵּ֤ה”

Solomon is using the word **Behold** to focus the readers’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 127:3 (#2)

נַחֲלַ֣ת יְ֭הוָה בָּנִ֑ים שָׂ֖כָר פְּרִ֣י הַבָּֽטֶן

“the inheritance of Yahweh”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and you may want to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [what Yahweh gives as an inheritance is sons, indeed, the fruit of the womb is his reward]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 127:3 (#3)

נַחֲלַ֣ת יְ֭הוָה

“the inheritance of Yahweh”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what Yahweh gives as a gift]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 127:3 (#4)

שָׂ֖כָר

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שָׂ֖כָר”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **reward**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what he gives to reward you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 127:3 (#5)

פְּרִ֣י הַבָּֽטֶן

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: פְּרִ֣י הַבָּֽטֶן”

Solomon is using **fruit of the womb** as a common expression of his culture to mean "children" or "offspring." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is having children]

See: Idiom

Psalms 127:4 (#1)

כְּחִצִּ֗ים בְּיַד־גִּבּ֥וֹר כֵּ֑ן בְּנֵ֖י הַנְּעוּרִֽים

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כְּחִצִּ֗ים בְּיַד־גִּבּ֥וֹר כֵּ֑ן בְּנֵ֖י הַנְּעוּרִֽים"

The point of this comparison is that just as **arrows** in the hand of a warrior are powerful and useful for defense, so **the sons** a man has in his youth can help defend a man from his enemies when he grows old. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [The sons of a man's youth are a powerful defense and as useful as arrows in the hand of a warrior]

See: Simile

Psalms 127:4 (#2)

בְּנֵ֖י הַנְּעוּרִֽים

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּנֵ֖י הַנְּעוּרִֽים"

Solomon is using this possessive form to describe **sons** who were born during a man's **youth**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [are sons born during one's youth]

See: Possession

Psalms 127:5 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵ֤י

"The happinesses of"

Solomon is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy about the man who has many sons. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [How happy is] or [Truly blessed is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 127:5 (#2)

הַגֶּ֣בֶר

"the man"

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means any man in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [any man]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 127:5 (#3)

מִלֵּ֣א אֶת־אַשְׁפָּתֹ֣ו מֵהֶ֑ם

"has filled his quiver of them"

Solomon is continuing the arrow imagery from the previous verse, speaking of having many sons as if the father had **filled his quiver** with arrows. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has been given many children]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 127:5 (#4)

אֶת־אַשְׁפָּתֹ֣ו

"his quiver"

A **quiver** is a container that a warrior carries on his back or at his side for holding arrows. If your readers would not be familiar with what a quiver is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [his arrow bag]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 127:5 (#5)

לֹ֣א־יֵבֹ֑שׁוּ כִּ֥י־יְדַבְּר֖וּ

"They will not have shame when they speak"

The pronoun **They** likely refers to men who have many sons. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The man who have many sons will not have shame when he speaks]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 127:5 (#6)

לֹ֣א־יֵבֹ֑שׁוּ

"They will not have shame"

By **have shame**, Solomon means that they will not feel the shame of being defeated by the adversary. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [They will not feel the shame of defeat]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 127:5 (#7)

לֹא־יֵבֹ֫שׁוּ

“They will not have shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [They will not be ashamed by being defeated]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 127:5 (#8)

בַּשָּׁעַר

“in the gate”

Solomon assumes that his readers will know that **the gate** of a city was where important legal and public matters were discussed and settled. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the place where public disputes are settled]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 128 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 128 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Enjoy the fruit of fearing Yahweh (1–4)
2. Experience peace and prosperity from Yahweh (5–6)

Psalms 128:1 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי כָּל־יְרֵ֫א יְהוָ֑ה

“The happinesses of everyone fearing Yahweh”

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [How happy is everyone fearing Yahweh] or [Truly blessed is everyone who fears Yahweh]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 128:1 (#2)

הַ֝הֹלֵ֗ךְ בִּדְרָכָֽיו

“the one walking in his ways”

The psalmist is speaking of a person who obeys Yahweh as if that person were **walking** along Yahweh’s **ways**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one living according to his commands]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 128:2 (#1)

יְגִ֣יעַ כַּפֶּ֑יךָ

“The labor of your palms”

Here, **labor of your palms** represents the result of the work done with someone’s hands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The results of your work]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 128:2 (#2)

אַ֝שְׁרֶ֗יךָ

“is} your happiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **happiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [makes you happy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 128:3 (#1)

אֶשְׁתְּךָ֤ ׀ כְּגֶ֬פֶן פֹּרִ֗יָה

“Your wife {is} like a fruitful vine”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **fruitful vine** produces much fruit, so the man’s **wife** will have many children. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your wife will have many children]

See: Simile

Psalms 128:3 (#2)

בָּנֶ֑יךָ כִּשְׁתִלֵ֖י זֵיתִ֣ים

“Your sons {are} like shoots of olive trees”

The point of this comparison is that just as **shoots of olive trees** are vigorous and healthy, so the man’s **sons** will be strong and thriving. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your sons will be strong and healthy]

See: Simile

Psalms 128:3 (#3)

בָּנֶיךָ

“Your sons {are”

Here the masculine term **sons** has a generic sense that includes both male and female children. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [Your sons and daughters]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 128:4 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The psalmist is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Indeed]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 128:4 (#2)

יְבֹרַךְ גָּבֶר יָרֵא יְהוָה

“the man fearing Yahweh will be blessed”

The expression **will be blessed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will bless the man who fears him]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 128:4 (#3)

גָּבֶר

“the man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [everyone]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 128:5 (#1)

וּרְאֵה בְּטוּב יְרוּשָׁלִָם

“that you may look on the good of Jerusalem”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **good**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that you might see Jerusalem prospering]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 128:6 (#1)

וּרְאֵה

“and that you may see”

Here, **and that** marks **you may see sons to your sons** as a further goal or purpose of Yahweh’s blessing in the previous verse. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [and also so that you may see]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 128:6 (#2)

בָּנִים לְבָנֶיךָ

“sons to your sons”

Here the masculine term **sons** has a generic sense that includes both male and female descendants. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [children of your children]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 128:6 (#3)

בָּנִים לְבָנֶיךָ

“sons to your sons”

The psalmist is using **sons to your sons** as a common expression of the culture to mean grandchildren. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [many descendants]

See: Idiom

Psalms 128:6 (#4)

שָׁלוֹם עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Peace {be} upon Israel”

The psalmist is asking Yahweh to bless the people of Israel. In your translation, use a form that people would recognize as a blessing in your language. You might express this as a prayer, if that would be more

natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh give peace to Israel]

See: Blessings

Psalms 128:6 (#5)

שָׁלֹום עַל

“Peace {be} upon”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May well-being come upon]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 129 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 129 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Recall Israel’s long affliction (1–4)
2. Trust Yahweh to defeat the enemies of Zion (5–8)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Yahweh saves

Israel’s enemies have always persecuted them but God has saved them from their enemies. He prays that this enemy will be destroyed with no one to wish them well. (See: save, saved, safe, salvation, rescue)

Translation Issues in This Psalm

Israel addressed as a person

The first section of this psalm, verses 1–4, uses first person singular pronouns since the Israelites are asked to speak as a person who is reciting the story of how he has been cruelly treated by his enemies since he was young. This can be seen as the Israelites recitation of Israel’s history as a nation. If it would be more clear in your language you could use plural pronouns in this section.

Psalms 129:1 (#1)

רַבַּת

“Abundantly”

The word translated as **Abundantly** could refer to: (1) affliction that is frequent. Alternate translation: [Often] or (2) affliction that is severe. Alternate translation: [Severely]

Psalms 129:1 (#2)

צָרְרוּנִי מִנְּעוּרַי

“they have afflicted me from my youth”

The pronoun **me** here signals that from here through verse 4, people of Israel are speaking together as though they are the nation of Israel. See the discussion in the introduction to this psalm to decide whether your translation will use the plural pronoun forms or keep the singular. Alternate translation: [they have afflicted us from our youth]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 129:1 (#3)

צָרְרוּנִי

“they have afflicted me”

The pronoun **they** does not refer to a specific group of people. It refers generally to the enemies of Israel throughout its history. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that more clearly. Alternate translation: [my enemies have afflicted me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 129:1 (#4)

יֹאמַר־נָא יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Let Israel indeed say”

The psalmist is saying what he wants the people of Israel to say and inviting them to join in communal recitation. See the discussion in the introduction to Psalms about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to say. Alternate translation: [Israel should indeed say]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 129:2 (#1)

גַּם לֹא־יָכְלוּ לִי

“however, they did not prevail against me”

The psalmist uses the word **however** here to indicate a contrast between the repeated affliction described in the first half of the verse and the failure of the enemies to ultimately prevail. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [in spite of that, they did not prevail against me]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 129:3 (#1)

עַל־גַּבִּי חָרְשׁוּ חֹרְשִׁים הֶאֱרִיכוּ לְמַעַנוֹתָם

“Upon & plowed; they made long their furrows”

The psalmist is speaking of the enemies’ oppression as if they were farmers plowing furrows on his back. The image of **the plowers plowed** upon his back and **they made long their furrows** represents severe and prolonged suffering. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [They made me suffer, like a farmer plowing a field they made deep wounds in my back]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 129:4 (#1)

קִצֵּץ עֲבֹתוֹת רְשָׁעִים

“the cords of”

The psalmist is speaking of the control that wicked people had over Israel as if they were **cords** binding them, and God’s deliverance as if he **cut** those cords. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has freed me from the control of wicked people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 129:4 (#2)

רְשָׁעִים

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: רְשָׁעִים”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to refer to a type of person. If your language does not use adjectives in this way, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who do evil]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 129:5 (#1)

יֵבֹשׁוּ

“Let them have shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [May they feel disgraced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 129:5 (#2)

צִיּוֹן

“Zion”

The psalmist is using the name **Zion**, to represent the people who live in Jerusalem and worship God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who worship God]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 129:6 (#1)

כַּחֲצִיר גַּגּוֹת שֶׁקַּדְמַת שָׁלַף יָבֵשׁ

“like grass of the rooftops, that before one pulls {it} out, it dries up”

The point of this comparison is that just as **grass of the rooftops**, or worthless weeds which grow in a thin layer of soil dry up quickly before anyone can even pull it out, so the psalmist wishes that the lives of his enemies will be insignificant and short-lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as insignificant and short-lived as grass on a rooftop which withers before anyone call pull it out]

See: Simile

Psalms 129:7 (#1)

שֶׁלֹּא מִלֵּא כַפּוֹ קוֹצֵר וְחִצְנּוֹ מְעַמֵּר

“the reaper & his palm {with}, and & does} not fill his bosom”

These two phrases are continuing the comparison of the enemies to the grass from the previous verse. Both phrases describe the worthlessness of the grass: **the reaper** cannot gather a handful of it nor can **the one binding sheaves** fill his arms with it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [so insignificant that the reaper cannot harvest it, nor can the one binding sheaves gather an armful to carry]

See: Simile

Psalms 129:8 (#1)

בִּרְכַּת־יְהוָה אֲלֵיכֶם בֵּרַכְנוּ אֶתְכֶם בְּשֵׁם יְהוָה

“The blessing of Yahweh {be} upon you; we bless you in the name of Yahweh”

This is a traditional harvest blessing that workers would exchange with those passing by. The psalmist is saying that the enemies of Zion will never receive such

a blessing. In your translation, use a form that people would recognize as a blessing in your language. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh make you prosper; may Yahweh bless you]

See: Blessings

Psalms 129:8 (#2)

בִּרְכַּת־יְהוָה

“The blessing of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **blessing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The favor of Yahweh]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 129:8 (#3)

בְּשֵׁ֣ם יְהוָ֑ה

“in the name of Yahweh”

Here, **the name of Yahweh** represents the person and authority of Yahweh himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by the authority of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 130 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 130 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion. It is a “psalm of praise” that God forgives sins. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Cry out to Yahweh from the depths (1–4)
2. Wait and hope in Yahweh’s redeeming love (5–8)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Forgive

God forgives sin and helps the sinner. So Israel should trust in God for his forgiveness. (See: trust, trusted, trustworthy, trustworthiness)

Psalms 130:1 (#1)

מִמַּעֲמַקִּ֣ים

“Out of the depths”

The psalmist is speaking as if being in distress over all his troubles were being in the **depths** or a place of deep water. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Because of my many troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 130:2 (#1)

שִׁמְעָ֥ה בְקֹלִ֑י תִּהְיֶ֥ינָה אָ֝זְנֶ֗יךָ קַשֻּׁבוֹת֮ לְקֹ֪ול תַּחֲנוּנָֽי

“hear my voice; let your ears be attentive to the voice of my supplications”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [listen attentively to my pleas for mercy] or [hear my voice, indeed, may your ears be attentive to the voice of my supplications]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 130:2 (#2)

לְקֹ֪ול תַּחֲנוּנָֽי

“to the voice of my supplications”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **supplications**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to my voice as I plead with you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 130:3 (#1)

אִם־עֲוֹנֹ֥ות תִּשְׁמָר־יָ֑הּ

“If you, Yah, would mark sins”

Here, **If** introduces a hypothetical condition. The psalmist is saying that this is something that could happen. He is implying that no one could endure God’s judgment if he kept a record of sins. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [Yah, suppose you would mark sins]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 130:3 (#2)

עֲוֹנֹ֥ות תִּשְׁמָר־יָ֑הּ

“you, Yah, would mark sins”

The psalmist is using **mark sins** as a common expression of the culture to mean “keep a strict tally of sins.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you, Yah, would keep a count of our sins]

See: Idiom

Psalms 130:3 (#3)

יָ֑הּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

Psalms 130:3 (#4)

מִֽי יַעֲמֹ֗ד

“who could stand”

The psalmist is using the question form to emphasize that no one would be able to endure God’s judgment. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [no one could stand!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 130:3 (#5)

יַעֲמֹ֗ד

“could stand”

The psalmist is speaking about staying alive or surviving attack or punishment as if it were being able to physically **stand**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [could survive] or [could withstand the punishment]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 130:4 (#1)

עִמְּךָ֣ הַסְּלִיחָ֑ה

“there is} forgiveness with you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **forgiveness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you forgive people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 130:4 (#2)

לְ֝מַ֗עַן תִּוָּרֵֽא

“so that you may be feared”

Here, **so that** marks **you may be feared** as the goal or purpose of **there is forgiveness with you**. The psalmist is saying that God forgives so that people will revere him. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order that people may fear you]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 130:4 (#3)

תִּוָּרֵֽא

“you may be feared”

The expression **you may be feared** contains a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is people. Alternate translation: [people may fear you]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 130:5 (#1)

קִוִּ֣יתִי יְ֭הוָה קִוְּתָ֣ה נַפְשִׁ֑י

“I wait for Yahweh; my soul waits”

These two phrases **I wait for Yahweh** and **my soul waits** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I wait eagerly for Yahweh]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 130:5 (#2)

קִוְּתָ֣ה נַפְשִׁ֑י

“my soul waits”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or

plain language. Alternate translation: [I wait with all my being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 130:5 (#3)

וְלִדְבָרוֹ הוֹחָלְתִּי

“and in his word I hope”

The psalmist is using the term **word** to represent what Yahweh has promised. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and in Yahweh’s promises I hope]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 130:6 (#1)

נַפְשִׁי לַאדֹנָי מִשֹּׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר

“my soul for the Lord, more than watchmen for the morning”

The point of this comparison is that just as **watchmen** stand on guard and eagerly watch **for the morning**, the psalmist eagerly anticipates the Lord’s help. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I eagerly anticipate the Lord’s help just as eagerly as watchmen wait for the morning]

See: Simile

Psalms 130:6 (#2)

נַפְשִׁי לַאדֹנָי

“my soul for the Lord”

The psalmist is leaving out one of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the previous verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [My soul waits for the Lord]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 130:6 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי לַאדֹנָי

“my soul for the Lord”

The psalmist is using the term **soul** to mean the entire person from the perspective of his spiritual and emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I myself wait for the Lord]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 130:6 (#4)

מִשֹּׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר שֹׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר

“more than watchmen for the morning, watchmen for the morning”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the previous verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [more than watchmen wait for the morning, watchmen wait for the morning]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 130:6 (#5)

מִשֹּׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר שֹׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר

“more than watchmen for the morning, watchmen for the morning”

The phrase **watchmen for the morning** is repeated as a poetic device for emphasis. If your language has a poetic way to indicate the emotion of this phrase, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [more than watchmen for the morning, even more eagerly than watchmen waiting for the morning]

See: Poetry

Psalms 130:7 (#1)

יַחֵל יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶל־יְהוָה כִּי־עִם־יְהוָה הַחֶסֶד וְהַרְבֵּה עִמּוֹ פְדוּת

“Israel, hope in Yahweh, for with Yahweh {is} covenant faithfulness, and with him {is} abundant redemption”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second and third phrases give the reasons for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because with Yahweh is covenant faithfulness and with him is abundant redemption, Israel should hope in Yahweh]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 130:7 (#2)

עִם־יְהוָה הַחֶסֶד וְהַרְבֵּה עִמּוֹ פְדוּת

“with Yahweh {is} covenant faithfulness, and with him {is} abundant redemption”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **redemption**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Yahweh faithfully keeps his covenant, and he abundantly redeems his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 130:8 (#1)

וְהוּא יִפְדֶּה

“And he, he will redeem”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will redeem** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh himself will be the one to redeem Israel. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [And it is he himself who will redeem]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 130:8 (#2)

עֲוֹנֹתָיו

“his sins”

The pronoun **his** refers to Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Israel’s sins]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 131 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 131 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion. It is a “psalm of trust.” See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Reject pride and self-exaltation (1)
2. Rest quietly in Yahweh like a weaned child (2)
3. Call Israel to hope in Yahweh (3)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

Humility as Contentment

The psalmist expresses humility not as self-deprecation but as willing acceptance of one’s place before God, refusing to pursue matters beyond his scope.

The Weaned Child

A weaned child resting on its mother is content without demanding anything. This simile pictures a soul at peace with God, no longer driven by unmet desire.

Psalms 131:1 (#1)

לֹא־גָבְהָה לִבִּי וְלֹא־רָמּוּ עֵינָי

“my heart is not high and my eyes are not raised up”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Both phrases express that David is not proud. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way as in the UST. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I am not at all proud, nor do I act arrogantly]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 131:1 (#2)

לֹא־גָבְהָה לִבִּי

“my heart is not high”

Here the **heart** represents a person’s thoughts and attitudes. David is speaking of a proud person’s thoughts as if his heart were physically **high**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my thoughts are not proud]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 131:1 (#3)

וְלֹא־רָמּוּ עֵינָי

“and my eyes are not raised up”

The expression **are not raised up** contains a passive verbal form. If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and my eyes do not look too high]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 131:1 (#4)

וְלֹא־רָמּוּ עֵינָי

“and my eyes are not raised up”

David is speaking of a proud person’s arrogant attitude as if his **eyes** were physically **raised up**. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my attitude is not arrogant]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 131:1 (#5)

וְלֹא־הִלַּכְתִּי ׀ בִּגְדֹלוֹת וּבְנִפְלָאוֹת

“and I do not walk in great and marvelous {things”

David is speaking of occupying himself with things as if he were able to **walk** among them. If your language has a comparable expression, you could use it in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I do not occupy myself with great and marvelous things]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 131:2 (#1)

אִם־לֹא

“Rather”

David uses the word **Rather** here to indicate a contrast between what he denied about himself in the previous verse and what he now positively affirms about himself. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [On the contrary]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 131:2 (#2)

שִׁוִּיתִי ׀ וְדוֹמַמְתִּי

“I have stilled and quieted”

The terms **stilled** and **quieted** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I have completely calmed]

See: Doublet

Psalms 131:2 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using the term **soul** to mean his entire person from the perspective of his emotional existence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my inner self]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 131:2 (#4)

כְּגָמֻל עֲלֵי אִמּוֹ כַּגָּמֻל עָלַי נַפְשִׁי

“like a weaned child upon his mother; like a weaned child upon me {is} my soul”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a weaned child** resting **upon his mother** is calm and content, no longer crying for milk, so David’s inner being (**my soul**) is at peace. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [so that I am content and at rest; my inner being is truly at peace]

See: Simile

Psalms 131:2 (#5)

אִמּוֹ

“his mother”

The pronoun **his** refers to the weaned child in the simile. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [upon the child’s mother]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 131:3 (#1)

מֵעַתָּה וְעַד־עוֹלָם

“from now and until forever”

David is referring to all of time by naming its two extremes, **now** and **forever**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [always]

See: Merism

Psalms - Chapter 132 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 132 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Remember David’s devotion to Yahweh (1–9)
2. Affirm Yahweh’s promise to David’s line (10–12)
3. Celebrate Yahweh’s choice of Zion (13–18)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Psalm

The Davidic Covenant
Yahweh swore that David's descendants would reign if they kept his covenant.

Psalms 132:1 (#1)

זְכוֹר־יְהוָה

"Remember, Yahweh"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. The psalmist is praying to God. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please remember, Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 132:1 (#2)

אֵת כָּל־עֱנוֹתוֹ

"all of his afflictions"

The pronoun **his** refers to David. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [all of David's afflictions]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 132:1 (#3)

עֱנוֹתוֹ

"his afflictions"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **afflictions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the hardships he endured]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 132:2 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע לַיהוָה נָדַר לַאֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב

"who swore to Yahweh; vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob"

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way, as the UST does. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [who swore to Yahweh, yes, he vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 132:2 (#2)

נָדַר לַאֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב

"vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob"

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark the end of this verse in a way that shows that the next verse is the beginning of David's oath. Alternate translation: [vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob, saying,]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 132:3 (#1)

אִם־אָבֹא בְּאֹהֶל בֵּיתִי אִם־אֶעֱלֶה עַל־עֶרֶשׂ יְצוּעָי

"If I go into the tent of my house, if I go up on the bed of my couch"

Following the custom of the culture, David is swearing an oath by stating several conditions ("if") from this verse through verse 5, but not the consequences for not meeting those conditions ("then"). The implied meaning is that something bad will happen to him if he does these things before finding a place for Yahweh.

See: Oath Formulas

Psalms 132:4 (#1)

לְעַפְעַפַּי תְּנוּמָה

"slumber to my eyelids"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [if I give slumber to my eyelids]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 132:5 (#1)

עַד־אֶמְצָא מָקוֹם לַיהוָה מִשְׁכָּנוֹת לַאֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב

"until I find a place for Yahweh, dwellings for the Mighty One of Jacob"

Following the custom of the culture, the psalmist is quoting David as swearing an oath by stating the first part of a condition ("if" clauses in verses 3 and 4) but not the second part ("then"). If it would be

helpful to your readers, you could explicitly state the consequence of not meeting this condition. Alternate translation: [until I find a place for Yahweh, dwellings for the Mighty One of Jacob, then may God strike me down]

See: Oath Formulas

Psalms 132:5 (#2)

מִמְּשְׁכְּנוֹת לְאֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב

“dwellings for the Mighty One of Jacob”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [until I find dwellings for the Mighty One of Jacob]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 132:6 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הִנֵּה”

The psalmist is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Pay attention]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:6 (#2)

שְׁמַעֲנֻהוּ בְאֶפְרָתָה מְצָאנֻהוּ בִּשְׂדֵי־יָעַר

“in Ephrathah; we found it & of Jaar”

The pronoun **it** in both clauses refers to the ark of the covenant. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [we heard of the ark of the covenant in Ephrathah; we found the ark in the fields of Jaar]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 132:7 (#1)

נָבוֹאָה לְמִשְׁכְּנוֹתָיו

“Let us go to his dwellings”

This is the beginning of what the community of worshipers said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of the community. Alternate translation: [We said to one another, “Let us go to his dwellings]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 132:7 (#2)

לְמִשְׁכְּנוֹתָיו

“to his dwellings”

The pronoun **his** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s dwellings]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 132:7 (#3)

נִשְׁתַּחֲוֶה

“let us bow down”

Here, **bow down** is describing a symbolic action by which people showed reverence and submission as an act of worship. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation. Alternate translation: [let us bow down in worship]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 132:7 (#4)

לַהֲדֹם רַגְלָיו

“at the footstool of his feet”

Here the psalmist is speaking of the ark of the covenant as if it were **the footstool of his feet**, that is, the place where Yahweh rests his feet as he sits enthroned above the cherubim. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the place where he rests his feet]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:8 (#1)

קוּמָה יְהוָה

“Arise, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. The psalmist is praying to God. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please arise, Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 132:8 (#2)

קוּמָה

“Arise”

The psalmist is using **Arise** as a common expression of the culture to tell Yahweh to take action and come to his resting place. He is not telling Yahweh to stand up from a seated position. If this expression does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

See: Idiom

Psalms 132:8 (#3)

לִמְנוּחָתֶךָ

“to your resting place”

Here Yahweh is speaking of remaining in one place as if he were **resting** there. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [come where you can remain]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:8 (#4)

וַאֲרוֹן עֻזֶּךָ

“and the box”

Here, **strength** represents Yahweh’s powerful presence. The box (ark of the covenant) is called the box of Yahweh’s strength because it symbolized his powerful presence among the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and the box where your power resides]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 132:9 (#1)

כֹּהֲנֶיךָ יִלְבְּשׁוּ־צֶדֶק וַחֲסִידֶיךָ יְרַנֵּנוּ

“Let your priests wear righteousness, and let your faithful shout for joy”

The psalmist is saying what he wants the priests and the faithful ones to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [Your priests should wear righteousness and your faithful ones should shout for joy]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 132:9 (#2)

כֹּהֲנֶיךָ יִלְבְּשׁוּ־צֶדֶק

“Let your priests wear righteousness”

Here the psalmist is speaking of **righteousness** as if it were clothing that the priests could **wear**. He means that the priests should be characterized by righteous behavior. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let your priests be righteous in all they do]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:9 (#3)

צֶדֶק וַחֲסִידֶיךָ יְרַנֵּנוּ

“righteousness, and let your faithful shout for joy”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [righteous acts and let your faithful shout joyfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 132:9 (#4)

וַחֲסִידֶיךָ יְרַנֵּנוּ

“and let your faithful shout for joy”

The psalmist is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean people who are faithful to God. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and your faithful people should shout for joy]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 132:10 (#1)

אַל־תָּשֵׁב פְּנֵי מְשִׁיחֶךָ

“do not turn back the face of your anointed”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. The psalmist is asking God not to reject the anointed king. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not turn back the face of your anointed]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 132:10 (#2)

תְּהָתֵּשֵׁב פְּנֵי

“turn back the face of”

The psalmist is using **turn back the face** as a common expression of his culture to mean “reject.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [reject]

See: Idiom

Psalms 132:11 (#1)

אֱמֶת֮

“in} truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [surely]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 132:11 (#2)

לֹא־יָשׁוּב מִמֶּנָּה

“he will not turn back from it”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, and the pronoun **it** refers to the oath that he swore. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will not turn back from his promise]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 132:11 (#3)

לֹא־יָשׁוּב מִמֶּנָּה

“he will not turn back from it”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh changing his mind about his promise as if he were going one way and then decided to **turn back from it**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will not change his mind about it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:11 (#4)

מִפְּרִי־בִטְנְךָ֥

“From the fruit of your body”

After the clause “he will not turn back from it,” Yahweh’s direct speech begins. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh said, “From the fruit of your body]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 132:11 (#5)

מִפְּרִי־בִטְנְךָ֥

“From the fruit of your body”

Here Yahweh is speaking of David’s children as if they were **the fruit** that his body produces. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From among your offspring]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:11 (#6)

אָאֲשִׁ֤ית לְכִסֵּא־לָךְ

“I will set {one} on the throne for you”

Here Yahweh is speaking of choosing one of David’s sons to rule his kingdom after him as if he were going to physically **set** him **on the throne**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will cause one of your sons to rule over Israel after you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:11 (#7)

לְכִסֵּא

“on the throne”

Here, **the throne** represents royal authority and the right to rule as king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [as king over your kingdom]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 132:12 (#1)

בְּרִיתִי֮ וְעֵדֻתִ֪י

“my covenant and my testimonies”

The terms **covenant** and **testimonies** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [all my commands]

See: Doublet

Psalms 132:12 (#2)

יֵשְׁבוּ לְכִסֵּא־לָךְ

“will sit on the throne for you”

Here, **sit on the throne** represents ruling as king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [will succeed you as kings]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 132:13 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [Certainly,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 132:14 (#1)

זֹאת־מְנוּחָתִי

“This {is} my resting place”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh said, “This is my resting place]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 132:14 (#2)

מְנוּחָתִי

“is} my resting place”

Here Yahweh is speaking of remaining in one place as if he were **resting** there. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [where I will remain]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:14 (#3)

כִּי־אִוִּיתִיהָ

“for I have desired it”

The word **for** here indicates that what follows is a reason for Yahweh’s decision to dwell in Zion. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I have desired it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 132:15 (#1)

בָּרֵךְ אֲבָרֵךְ

“I will bless”

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **bless** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I will abundantly bless]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 132:15 (#2)

צֵדָהּ

“her provisions”

Here and through the next verse, the pronoun **her** refers to Zion (see verse 13). It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Zion’s provisions]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 132:15 (#3)

אֶאֱבִיוֹנֶיהָ

“her needy”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I will bless her needy]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 132:15 (#4)

אֶאֱבִיוֹנֶיהָ

“her needy”

Yahweh is using the adjective **needy** as a noun to mean people who are in need. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [her needy people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 132:15 (#5)

לָחֶם

“with} bread”

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [with enough to eat]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 132:16 (#1)

וְכֹהֲנֶיהָ אַלְבִּישׁ יֶשַׁע

“And her priests I will clothe {with} salvation”

Here Yahweh is speaking the priests being examples of his saving power as if **salvation** were clothing that the priests could wear. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And her priests I will make examples of my saving power]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:16 (#2)

יֶשַׁע וַחֲסִידֶיהָ רַנֵּן יְרַנֵּנוּ

“with} salvation, and her faithful, shouting they will shout for joy”

If your language does not use an abstract nouns for the ideas of **salvation** and **joy**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [with the evidence that I save people, and her faithful people will shout joyfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 132:16 (#3)

וַחֲסִידֶיהָ

“and her faithful”

Yahweh is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean people who are faithful to God. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and her faithful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 132:16 (#4)

רַנֵּן יְרַנֵּנוּ

“shouting they will shout for joy”

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **shout** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [they will shout loudly for joy]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 132:17 (#1)

שָׁשָׁם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שָׁשָׁם”

The word **There** refers to Zion, which was mentioned in verse 13. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [There in Zion]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 132:17 (#2)

אַצְמִיחַ קֶרֶן לְדָוִד

“I will make a horn sprout for David”

Here Yahweh is speaking of son of David’s being born who will be powerful as if he were a **horn** that would **sprout** like a plant growing. A horn represents strength and power, and sprouting represents the arising of something new. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will make a powerful king rise up from David’s line]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:17 (#3)

עָרַכְתִּי נֵר לִמְשִׁיחִי

“a lamp”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the continuing dynasty of the anointed king as if it were **a lamp** that keeps burning. A lamp that stays lit represents the continuation of a family line or kingdom. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a continuing dynasty for my anointed one]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:18 (#1)

אֹיְבָיו אַלְבִּישׁ בֹּשֶׁת

“His enemies”

Here Yahweh is speaking of **shame** as if the enemies would wear it like clothing. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His enemies I will thoroughly put to shame]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 132:18 (#2)

אֹיְבָיו

“His enemies”

Here, **His** and the pronoun **him** later in the verse refer to the anointed one mentioned in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The anointed one’s enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 132:18 (#3)

אַלְבִּישׁ בֹּשֶׁת

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: אַלְבִּישׁ בֹּשֶׁת”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will shame]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 132:18 (#4)

וְעָלָיו יָצִיץ נִזְרוֹ

“but upon him his crown will flourish”

Yahweh uses the word **but** here to indicate a contrast between the fate of the anointed one’s enemies and the fate of the anointed one himself. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [however, upon him his crown will flourish]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 132:18 (#5)

יָצִיץ נִזְרוֹ

“his crown will flourish”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the anointed one’s crown as if it were a plant that would **flourish** and grow. He means that the anointed one’s reign will prosper and thrive. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his reign will be successful]

See: Metaphor

Psalms - Chapter 133 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 133 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Celebrate the goodness of unity (1–2)
2. Declare Yahweh’s blessing where unity dwells (3)

Psalms 133:1 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

David is using the word **Behold** to focus the attention of his listeners on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Consider]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 133:1 (#2)

טוֹב וּמַה־נָּעִים

“good and how pleasant”

The terms **good** and **pleasant** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [truly delightful]

See: Doublet

Psalms 133:2 (#1)

כַּשֶּׁמֶן הַטּוֹב ׀ עַל־הָרֹאשׁ יֹרֵד עַל־הַזָּקָן זְקַן־אַהֲרֹן

“Like the good oil on the head, coming down on the beard, the beard of Aaron”

David assumes that readers will know that the **good oil** being poured on **the head** and **beard** of Aaron refers to Aaron’s anointing as High Priest which was a solemn and joyful occasion. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [It is as good and pleasant as the anointing oil that is pouring down over Aaron’s head and]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 133:2 (#2)

פִּי מִדּוֹתָיו

“the mouth of his garments”

Here, **the mouth of his garments** is a common expression that means the opening or neckline of a garment. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or

you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the neckline of his garments]

See: Idiom

Psalms 133:3 (#1)

שָׁ֝שָׁ֗ם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: שָׁ֝שָׁ֗ם”

Here the word **there** refers to Zion. David is using this word to refer back to the mountains of Zion that he mentioned previously. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [it was there on Zion that]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 133:3 (#2)

כְּטַל־חֶרְמ֭וֹן שֶׁ֣יֹּרֵד ׀ עַל־הַרְרֵ֣י צִיּ֑וֹן

“Hermon & on the mountains of Zion”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the dew of Hermon** is refreshing and life-giving as it falls on the land, so the unity of God’s people is refreshing and brings life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as the refreshing dew from Hermon falls on the mountains of Zion, so the unity of God’s people refreshes and gives life]

See: Simile

Psalms 133:3 (#3)

אֶת־הַבְּרָכָ֑ה

“the blessing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **the blessing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that he would bless his people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 133:3 (#4)

חַיִּ֥ים עַד־הָעוֹלָֽם

“to forever”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **life**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that they would live forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 134 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 134 is one of the songs of ascents (Psalms 120–134). These are generally understood to be songs that were customarily sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem for one of the three major annual festivals. The term “ascents” is used because going up to the temple in Jerusalem involved a climb up Mount Zion.

1. Call Yahweh’s servants to bless him (1–2)
2. Receive blessing from Yahweh the creator (3)

Psalms 134:1 (#1)

הִנֵּ֤ה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: הִנֵּ֤ה”

The psalmist is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Pay attention]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 134:1 (#2)

בְּבֵית־יְהוָ֗ה

“Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of the temple of Yahweh as if it were a **house** in which he lived. Alternate translation: [in the temple of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 134:2 (#1)

שְׂאוּ־יְדֵכֶ֥ם

“Lift up your hands”

To **Lift up** the **hands** was a symbolic action by which the Israelites showed their reverence and devotion to Yahweh in prayer. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation. Alternate translation: [Lift up your hands in prayer]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 134:2 (#2)

קֹ֑דֶשׁ

“to the} holiness”

The word translated as **holiness** could refer to: (1) the holy place in the temple. Alternate translation: [to the

holy place] or (2) the hands of the worshipers. Alternate translation: [in holiness]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 134:3 (#1)

יְבָרֶכְךָ יְהוָה

“May Yahweh bless you”

The pronoun **you** here is singular and refers to each individual worshiper among the servants addressed earlier in this psalm. There the psalmist addressed the servants as a group using plural forms, but here the blessing shifts to the singular. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh bless each of you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 134:3 (#2)

מִצִּיּוֹן

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִצִּיּוֹן”

Here, **Zion** represents the place where Yahweh dwells among his people. The psalmist is using the name of this location to refer to God’s special presence there. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from his dwelling on Zion]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 134:3 (#3)

שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ

“and earth”

The psalmist is referring to all of creation by naming two extremes, **heaven** and **earth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all things]

See: Merism

Psalms - Chapter 135 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 135 is a “psalm of praise” focusing on worshiping God because his greatness.

1. Call to praise Yahweh (1–4)
2. Yahweh’s power over creation and history (5–14)
3. Idols are worthless but Yahweh is worthy of praise (15–21)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Praise

The people, priests and their helpers should praise God because he is so great. He defeated the Egyptians and led his people to the promise land. Idols have no power.

Psalms 135:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 135:1 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 135:1 (#3)

אֶת־שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה

“the name of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [everything about Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 135:2 (#1)

בְּבֵית יְהוָה

“in the house of Yahweh”

The psalmist is speaking of the temple where Yahweh is worshiped as if it were a house in which he lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the

meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the temple of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 135:2 (#2)

בְּחַצְרוֹת בֵּית

“in the courts of the house of”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [who are standing in the courts of the house of]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 135:2 (#3)

אֱלֹהֵינוּ

“our God”

By using this possessive form, **our God**, the psalmist is not saying that the Israelites possess or control Yahweh. Rather he is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom the Israelites worship. See the introduction to Psalms for further discussion. Alternate translation: [the God whom we worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 135:3 (#1)

הַֽלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 135:3 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 135:3 (#3)

לְשִׁמְוֹ

“to his name”

Here, **his name** represents who Yahweh is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [to Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 135:4 (#1)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 135:4 (#2)

יַעֲקֹב

“Jacob”

The psalmist is using the name **Jacob** to refer to the people of Israel who were all descendants of the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 135:4 (#3)

יִשְׂרָאֵל לְסְגֻלָּתְוֹ

“Israel for his special possession”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he chose Israel for his special possession]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 135:4 (#4)

לְסְגֻלָּתְוֹ

“for his special possession”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **possession**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [as his own special people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 135:5 (#1)

כִּֽי־

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Psalms 135:5 (#2)

אֲנִ֣י יָ֭דַעְתִּי

“I, I know”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I know** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize how confident he is in this knowledge. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I definitely know]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 135:5 (#3)

וַֽאֲדֹנֵ֗ינוּ מִכָּל־אֱלֹהִֽים

“and our Lord than all gods”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and our Lord is greater than all gods]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 135:5 (#4)

מִכָּל־אֱלֹהִֽים

“than all gods”

The term “god,” when applied to a being other than Yahweh, can refer to an idol, but, as here, it can also refer to any lesser spirit being. Alternate translation: [than any other spiritual being]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 135:6 (#1)

בַּשָּׁמַ֣יִם וּבָאָ֑רֶץ בַּ֝יַּמִּ֗ים וְכָל־תְּהֹמֽוֹת

“in the heavens and on the earth, in the seas and all deeps”

The psalmist is referring to everywhere in all of creation by naming two pairs of extremes, **the heavens** and **the earth**, as well as **the seas** and **all deeps**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everywhere in all of creation]

See: Merism

Psalms 135:7 (#1)

מַעֲלֶ֣ה נְ֭שִׂאִים מִקְצֵ֣ה הָאָ֑רֶץ

“bringing up clouds from the end of the earth”

Here the word translated **bringing up** does not have an explicit subject. The context of the previous verse makes clear that the subject is Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is bringing up clouds from the end of the earth]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 135:7 (#2)

מִקְצֵ֣ה הָאָ֑רֶץ

“from the end of the earth”

The psalmist is using the phrase **from the end of the earth** as a common expression to mean “from distant places.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from everywhere on earth]

See: Idiom

Psalms 135:7 (#3)

מֵאֽוֹצְרוֹתָ֥יו

“from his storehouses”

The psalmist is speaking of wind as if it were kept in **storehouses**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from where he has prepared it]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 135:8 (#1)

שֶׁשָּׁהַכָּה בְּכוֹרֵי מִצְרָיִם

“who struck the firstborn of Egypt”

The word **who** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh struck the firstborn of Egypt]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 135:8 (#2)

שֶׁשָּׁהַכָּה

“who struck”

Here, **struck** represents to kill or slaughter. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language as modeled in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Psalms 135:8 (#3)

מֵאָדָם עַד־בְּהֵמָה

“from man to beast”

The psalmist is referring to all living beings by naming two extremes, **man** and **beast**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [of every kind of creature of Egypt]

See: Merism

Psalms 135:9 (#1)

אֹתוֹת וּמוֹפְתִים

“signs and wonders”

The terms **signs** and **wonders** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [extraordinary demonstrations of his power]

See: Doublet

Psalms 135:9 (#2)

בְּתוֹכֵכִי מִצְרָיִם

“into your midst, Egypt”

The psalmist is speaking to **Egypt**, which cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about what God did there. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Egypt. Alternate translation: [right in front of the Egyptians]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 135:10 (#1)

שֶׁשָּׁהַכָּה גּוֹיִם רַבִּים

“who struck many nations”

The word **who** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh struck many nations]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 135:10 (#2)

שֶׁשָּׁהַכָּה

“who struck”

Here, **struck** represents killing or defeating in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who conquered]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 135:11 (#1)

לְסִיחֹן ׀ מֶלֶךְ הָאֱמֹרִי

“Sihon, king of the Amorite”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He defeated Sihon, king of the Amorite]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 135:12 (#1)

וְנָתַתָּן אַרְצָם

“And he gave their land”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh, while the word **their** refers to the defeated kings mentioned in the previous verses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh gave the land of those kings]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 135:12 (#2)

נַחֲלָה נַחֲלָה

“as} an inheritance, an inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to them as a gift to inherit]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 135:13 (#1)

יְהוָה שִׁמְךָ לְעוֹלָם יְהוָה זִכְרְךָ לְדֹר־וָדֹר

“Yahweh, your name {is} to forever; Yahweh, your remembrance {is} to generation and generation”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, you will be known and remembered through every generation] or [Yahweh, your name is to forever, indeed, your remembrance is to generation and generation]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 135:13 (#2)

שִׁמְךָ

“your name”

Here, **name** represents Yahweh’s reputation and character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [your reputation]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 135:13 (#3)

לְעוֹלָם

“is} to forever”

The psalmist is using **to forever** as a common expression of his culture to mean “eternally” or “without end.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [lasts throughout eternity]

See: Idiom

Psalms 135:13 (#4)

זִכְרְךָ לְדֹר־וָדֹר

“your remembrance {is} to generation and generation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **remembrance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people will remember you from generation to generation]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 135:13 (#5)

לְדֹר־וָדֹר

“is} to generation and generation”

The psalmist is using the phrase **to generation and generation** as a common expression to mean “forever.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is through all generations] or [is forever]

See: Idiom

Psalms 135:14 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

The word **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 135:15 (#1)

מַעֲצַבֵּי יְדֵי אָדָם

“the work of the hands of man”

Here, **the hands of man** represents the craftsmanship and ability of people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the idea with an equivalent expression. Alternate translation: [the work of men] or [made by men]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 135:16 (#1)

פֶּה־לָהֶם וְלֹא יְדַבֵּרוּ עֵינַיִם לָהֶם וְלֹא יִרְאוּ

“A mouth {is} to them, but they do not speak; eyes {are} to them, but they do not see”

See how you translated the same phrases in Psalm 115:5.

See: Idiom

Psalms 135:17 (#1)

אָזְנַיִם לָהֶם וְלֹא יַאֲזִינוּ

“Ears {are} to them, but they do not listen”

See how you translated the similar phrase, “ears are to them, but they do not hear” in Psalm 115:6.

See: Idiom

Psalms 135:18 (#1)

כְּמוֹהֶם יִהְיוּ עֹשֵׂיהֶם כֹּל אֲשֶׁר־בֹּטֵחַ בָּהֶם

“Their makers are like them— everyone who is trusting in them”

See how you translated the same phrases in Psalm 115:8.

Psalms 135:19 (#1)

בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל

“House of Israel”

Here, **House** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **House of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [People of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 135:19 (#2)

בֵּית אַהֲרֹן

“house of Aaron”

Here the psalmist is using the word **house** to mean all the people descended from Aaron. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Psalms 135:20 (#1)

בֵּית הַלֵּוִי

“House of the Levite”

Here the psalmist is using the word **House** to mean all the people descended from Levi. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All you Levites]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 135:21 (#1)

בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה ׀ מִצִּיּוֹן

“Blessed {be} Yahweh from Zion”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is the worshippers of Yahweh. Alternate translation: [May we bless Yahweh from Zion]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 135:21 (#2)

שֹׁכֵן יְרוּשָׁלָ͏ִם

“the one dwelling {in} Jerusalem”

Here, **the one** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [who dwells in Jerusalem]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 135:21 (#3)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 135:21 (#4)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 136 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 136 is a "psalm of thanksgiving." It is a responsive psalm. One person or group would sing the first part and then the other group would sing the repeated refrain.

1. Give thanks for who Yahweh is (1–3)
2. Give thanks for Yahweh's works in creation (4–9)
3. Give thanks for Yahweh's acts of deliverance and care (10–26)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Israel blessed

God has blessed Israel throughout its history and taken care of the needy people. (See: bless, blessed, blessing)

Psalms 136:1 (#1)

הוֹדוּ לַיהוָה כִּי־טוֹב כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ

"Give thanks to Yahweh, for {he} is good, for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever"

See how you translated these same phrases in Psalm 106:1.

See: Idiom

Psalms 136:1 (#2)

חַסְדּוֹ

"his covenant faithfulness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea here and throughout this psalm in another way. Alternate translation: [the way he is faithful to his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 136:2 (#1)

לֵאלֹהֵי הָאֱלֹהִים

"to the God of the gods"

The term "god," when applied to a being other than Yahweh, can refer to an idol, but, as here, it can also refer to any lesser spirit being. Alternate translation: [to the God who is above any other spiritual being]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 136:2 (#2)

כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ

"for his covenant faithfulness {is} to forever"

Here and throughout the psalm where this phrase is repeated, the psalmist is using **to forever** as a common expression of his culture to mean "eternally" or "without end." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for his covenant faithfulness lasts forever]

See: Idiom

Psalms 136:3 (#1)

לַאֲדֹנֵי הָאֲדֹנִים

"to the Lord of the lords"

The psalmist is using this possessive form to mean that Yahweh is the supreme Lord, greater than all other rulers. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Lord who is above all other lords]

See: Possession

Psalms 136:4 (#1)

לְעֹשֵׂה נִפְלָאוֹת גְּדֹלוֹת

"To the doer of great wonders"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one doing great wonders]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:5 (#1)

לְעֹשֵׂה הַשָּׁמַיִם

"To the maker of the heavens"

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one making the heavens]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:5 (#2)

לְעֹשֵׂה הַשָּׁמַיִם בִּתְבוּנָה

“To the maker of the heavens by understanding”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **understanding**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [To the one who skillfully made the heavens]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 136:6 (#1)

לְרֹקַע הָאָרֶץ

“To the one spreading out the earth”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one spreading out the earth]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:7 (#1)

לְעֹשֵׂה אוֹרִים גְּדֹלִים

“To the maker of great lights”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one making great lights]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:8 (#1)

אֶת־הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ לְמֶמְשֶׁלֶת בַּיּוֹם

“the sun for dominion in the day”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [who made the sun for dominion in the day]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:8 (#2)

אֶת־הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ לְמֶמְשֶׁלֶת בַּיּוֹם

“the sun for dominion in the day”

The psalmist speaks of **the sun** as if it were a king that could have **dominion** or rule over the day. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the sun to give light in the day]

See: Personification

Psalms 136:8 (#3)

לְמֶמְשָׁלֶת

“for dominion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dominion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to govern]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 136:9 (#1)

אֶת־הַיָּרֵחַ וְכוֹכָבִים לְמֶמְשְׁלוֹת בַּלָּיְלָה

“the moon and stars for dominion in the night”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [who made the moon and stars for dominion in the night]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:9 (#2)

אֶת־הַיָּרֵחַ וְכוֹכָבִים לְמֶמְשְׁלוֹת בַּלָּיְלָה

“the moon and stars for dominion in the night”

The psalmist speaks of **the moon and stars** as if they were kings that could have **dominion** or rule over the night. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the moon and stars to give light in the night]

See: Personification

Psalms 136:10 (#1)

לְמַכֵּה מִצְרַיִם בִּבְכוֹרֵיהֶם

“To the striker of Egypt in their firstborn”

Here, **striker** represents one who kills. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [To the one who killed the Egyptian’s firstborn]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 136:10 (#2)

לְמַכֵּ֣ה מִצְרַ֣יִם

“To the striker of Egypt”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one striking Egypt]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:10 (#3)

מִצְרַ֣יִם

“Egypt”

Here, **Egypt** represents the people of Egypt. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Egyptians]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 136:11 (#1)

יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 136:11 (#2)

מִתּוֹכָ֑ם

“from their midst”

The pronoun **their** refers to the Egyptians. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the midst of the Egyptians]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 136:12 (#1)

בְּיָ֣ד חֲזָקָ֔ה וּבִזְרֹ֖עַ נְטוּיָ֑ה

“By a strong hand and by an outstretched arm”

The terms **a strong hand** and **an outstretched arm** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [By his very great power]

See: Doublet

Psalms 136:12 (#2)

בְּיָ֣ד חֲזָקָ֔ה וּבִזְרֹ֖עַ נְטוּיָ֑ה

“By a strong hand and by an outstretched arm”

Here, **strong hand** and **outstretched arm** both represent the power of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [By his mighty power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 136:13 (#1)

לְגֹזֵ֣ר יַם־סֻ֔ף

“To the parter of the Sea of Reeds”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one parting the Sea of Reeds]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:14 (#1)

יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 136:14 (#2)

בְּתוֹכֹ֑ו

“the midst of it”

The pronoun **it** refers to the Sea of Reeds. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the midst of the Sea of Reeds]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 136:16 (#1)

לְמוֹלִ֣יךְ עַמּ֔וֹ

“To the one leading his people”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one leading his people]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:17 (#1)

לְמַכֵּה מְלָכִים גְּדֹלִים

“To the one striking great kings”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Give thanks to the one striking great kings]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:17 (#2)

לְמַכֵּה

“To the one striking”

Here, **striking** represents killing, defeating, or conquering. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [To the one conquering]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 136:19 (#1)

לְסִיחוֹן מֶלֶךְ הָאֱמֹרִי

“Sihon, king of the Amorite”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He conquered Sihon, king of the Amorite]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:20 (#1)

וּלְעוֹג מֶלֶךְ הַבָּשָׁן

“and Og, king of the Bashan”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he killed Og, king of the Bashan]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 136:21 (#1)

אַרְצָם

“their land”

The pronoun **their** refers to the defeated kings, Sihon and Og. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the land of those kings]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 136:21 (#2)

לְנַחֲלָה

“as an inheritance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **inheritance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the Israelites to inherit]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 136:22 (#1)

לְיִשְׂרָאֵל עַבְדּוֹ

“to Israel his servant”

Here, **Israel his servant** represents the people of Israel who served Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the Israelites, his servants]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 136:22 (#2)

עַבְדּוֹ

“his servant”

Here the pronoun **his** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s servant]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 136:23 (#1)

שֶׁשִּׁפְלֵנוּ זָכַר לָנוּ

“who, in our humiliation, remembered us”

Here the psalmist shifts from speaking about Israel in the third person to speaking as one of the Israelites, using the pronouns **our** and **us**. If it would be helpful in

your language, you could maintain a consistent perspective. Alternate translation: [who, when his people were humbled, remembered them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 136:23 (#2)

שֶׁשָּׁפְלֵנוּ

“who, in our humiliation”

The pronoun **who** refers to Yahweh, while the pronoun **our** refers to the Israelites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [even when we Israelites were humiliated, Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 136:23 (#3)

שֶׁשָּׁפְלֵנוּ

“who, in our humiliation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **humiliation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who, when we were humbled]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 136:24 (#1)

וַיִּפְרְקֵנוּ מִצָּרֵינוּ

“And he tore us away from our adversaries”

Here the psalmist is speaking of Yahweh saving his people as if he physically **tore** them away from their enemies, as one would tear an object from the grip of another person. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he rescued us from our adversaries]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 136:25 (#1)

נֹתֵן לֶ֭חֶם לְכָל־בָּשָׂ֑ר

“giving bread to all of flesh”

Here the psalmist does not explicitly state who the one **giving**. The subject is Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, who gives bread to all of flesh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 136:25 (#2)

לֶ֭חֶם

“bread”

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 136:25 (#3)

לְכָל־בָּשָׂ֑ר

“to all of flesh”

The psalmist is using **all of flesh** to represent all living creatures. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to everyone]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms - Chapter 137 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 137 is a “psalm of supplication” or “lament.” See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Grief and remembrance in exile (1–4)
2. Commitment to remember Jerusalem (5–6)
3. Cry for Yahweh’s justice against enemies (7–9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Songs of Zion

The captives are told to sing songs of Zion there in Babylon but they felt too unhappy to want to sing. The army from Babylon was cruel when it destroyed Jerusalem and the people of Edom encouraged them to destroy Jerusalem. They prayed that God will be cruel to the people of Edom and Babylon.

Psalms 137:1 (#1)

אֶת־צִיּ֑וֹן

“Zion”

Here, **Zion** represents the temple and the community of God’s people who worshiped there. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [our homeland]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 137:2 (#1)

עַל־עֲרָבִ֥ים בְּתוֹכָ֗הּ

“On the willows”

The psalmist refers to **willows** that are a kind of tree. If your readers would not be familiar with what willows are, you could use the name of another kind of tree that was common in that part of the world that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [On the trees in Babylon]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 137:3 (#1)

וְתוֹלָלֵ֥ינוּ שִׂמְחָ֑ה שִׁ֝֗ירוּ

“and our tormentors, joy: “Sing”

This is the beginning of what the captors and tormentors said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote. Alternate translation: [and our tormenters, joy, demanding, “Sing]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 137:3 (#2)

וְתוֹלָלֵ֥ינוּ שִׂמְחָ֑ה

“and our tormentors, joy”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and our tormentors requested of us joy]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 137:4 (#1)

אֵ֤יךְ נָשִׁ֨ירָ֔ אֶת־שִׁ֖יר־יְהוָ֑ה עַ֝֗ל אַדְמַ֥ת נֵכָֽר

“How & the song of Yahweh on the land of foreignness”

The psalmist is using the question form to emphasize that the people of Israel were not able to sing the song of Yahweh while in exile. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [We cannot sing the song of Yahweh on the land of foreignness!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 137:4 (#2)

עַ֝֗ל אַדְמַ֥ת נֵכָֽר

“on the land of foreignness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **foreignness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in a land that is not our own]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 137:5 (#1)

אִם־אֶשְׁכָּחֵ֥ךְ יְרוּשָׁלִַ֑ם תִּשְׁכַּ֖ח יְמִינִֽי

“If”

The psalmist is presenting a possible condition and its consequence. He says that if he forgets Jerusalem, then his right hand should no longer be able to play the harp. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [If I forget you, Jerusalem, then let my right hand forget]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 137:5 (#2)

אִם־אֶשְׁכָּחֵ֥ךְ

“If”

Here the psalmist shifts from speaking about the community as “we” in the previous verses to speaking as an individual using the pronoun **I**. He is making a personal vow.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 137:5 (#3)

תִּשְׁכַּ֖ח יְמִינִֽי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: תִּשְׁכַּ֖ח יְמִינִֽי”

The psalmist is using **let my right hand forget** as a common expression of the culture to mean that his hand would lose its ability to play a musical instrument. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let my right hand lose its skill] or [let my right hand wither]

See: Idiom

Psalms 137:5 (#4)

תִּשְׁכַּ֖ח יְמִינִֽי

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: תִּשְׁכַּח יְמִינִי"

The psalmist is saying what he wants to happen if he breaks his vow. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about "let" and "may" and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that my right hand would forget] or [may my right hand forget]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 137:6 (#1)

תִּדְבַּ֣ק־לְשׁוֹנִ֣י ׀ לְחִכִּ֑י אִם־לֹ֥א אֲ֝זְכְּרֵ֗כִי אִם־לֹ֤א אַעֲלֶה֙ אֶת־יְרוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם עַ֖ל רֹ֣אשׁ שִׂמְחָתִֽי

"Let my tongue cling to my palate if I do not remember you, if I do not cause Jerusalem to go up above the head of my joy"

The psalmist is presenting the consequence first and then the condition. It may be helpful to reorder this sentence so that the conditional statement is first. Alternate translation: [If I fail to remember you, if I do not cause Jerusalem to go up above the head of my joy, then let me tongue cling to my palate]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 137:6 (#2)

תִּדְבַּ֣ק־לְשׁוֹנִ֣י ׀ לְחִכִּ֑י

"Let my tongue cling to my palate"

The psalmist is using **tongue cling to my palate** as a common expression of the culture to mean that he would be unable to speak or sing. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let me be unable to sing] or [Let my mouth be silenced]

See: Idiom

Psalms 137:6 (#3)

אִם־לֹ֥א אַעֲלֶה֙ אֶת־יְרוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם עַ֖ל רֹ֣אשׁ שִׂמְחָתִֽי

"if I do not cause Jerusalem to go up above the head of my joy"

The psalmist is using **go up above the head** as a common expression of the culture to mean to the "highest point" or "greatest extent." If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [if I do not cause Jerusalem to give me more joy than anything else]

See: Idiom

Psalms 137:6 (#4)

שִׂמְחָתִֽי

"my joy"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what makes me rejoice]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 137:7 (#1)

לִבְנֵ֣י אֱד֑וֹם

"for the sons of Edom"

The psalmist is speaking as if the people of the tribe of Esau were actually the **sons** of Edom, another name for Esau. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Esau] or [the people of Edom]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 137:7 (#2)

אֵ֖ת יְר֣וֹם יְרוּשָׁלָ֑͏ִם

"the day of Jerusalem"

The psalmist is using **the day of Jerusalem** as a common expression of the culture to mean the time when Jerusalem was destroyed. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what happened to Jerusalem] or [the destruction of Jerusalem]

See: Idiom

Psalms 137:7 (#3)

עָ֭רוּ ׀ עָ֣רוּ

"Lay bare, lay bare"

The psalmist is using repetition of the phrase **lay bare** for poetic effect. You may want to reproduce this effect if poetry in your language does this. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Completely demolish]

See: Poetry

Psalms 137:7 (#4)

בָּהּ

“in her”

The pronoun **her** refers to Jerusalem. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in Jerusalem]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 137:8 (#1)

בַּת־בָּבֶל

“Daughter Babylon”

The psalmist is speaking of **Babylon** as if it were a woman by calling it **Daughter**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Babylon] or [The city of Babylon]

See: Personification

Psalms 137:8 (#2)

בַּת־בָּבֶל

“Daughter Babylon”

The psalmist is speaking to **Babylon** as if the city could hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about the judgment that Babylon deserves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Babylon. Alternate translation: [As for Babylon]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 137:8 (#3)

הַשְּׁדוּדָה

“the devastated one”

The phrase **the devastated one** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. You may want to follow an alternative reading from some ancient Greek and Aramaic translations. The UST follows that reading. Alternate translation: [you destroyer]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 137:8 (#4)

אַשְׁרֵי

“the happinesses of”

The psalmist is using an exclamation to express a strong desire for justice against Babylon. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [how happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 137:8 (#5)

אֶת־גְּמוּלֵךְ שֶׁגָּמַלְתְּ לָּנוּ

“your repayment that you paid to us”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **repayment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in order to repay you for all you did to us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 137:9 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

“The happinesses of”

The psalmist is using an exclamation to express a strong desire for judgment on Babylon. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [How happy will be]

See: Exclamations

Psalms - Chapter 138 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm is a psalm of praise.

1. Wholehearted praise (1–3)
2. Global worship (4–6)
3. Confidence in God’s protection (7–8)

Psalms 138:1 (#1)

בְּכָל־לִבִּי

“with my whole heart”

Here the **heart** represents the seat of a person’s emotions and will. David is saying that he will thank Yahweh with complete devotion. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with all of my being]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 138:1 (#2)

נֶגֶד אֱלֹהִים

“before the gods”

Here, **the gods** could refer to: (1) idols of other nations that the psalmist sees either within Israel or while traveling. Alternate translation: [idols of foreign gods] or (2) God’s heavenly council of angelic beings. Alternate translation: [the heavenly assembly]

Psalms 138:2 (#1)

הֵיכַל קָדְשְׁךָ

“the temple of your holiness”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **temple** that is characterized by God’s **holiness**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your holy temple]

See: Possession

Psalms 138:2 (#2)

קָדְשְׁךָ

“your holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you, the Holy One] or [all that is holy about you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 138:2 (#3)

אֶת־שִׁמְךָ

“your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and to refer to his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 138:2 (#4)

חַסְדְּךָ וְעַל־אֲמִתֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness and for your trustworthiness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **trustworthiness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the way you are faithful to your covenant and for being trustworthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 138:2 (#5)

חַסְדְּךָ וְעַל־אֲמִתֶּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness and for your trustworthiness”

The terms **covenant faithfulness** and **trustworthiness** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [your complete reliability]

See: Doublet

Psalms 138:2 (#6)

כִּי־הִגְדַּלְתָּ עַל־כָּל־שִׁשְׁמְךָ אִמְרָתֶךָ

“for you have exalted above all of your name your word”

The phrase **for you have exalted above all of your name your word** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. Scholars have proposed some alternative readings, and you may want to follow one of those. The UST follows the first alternative. Alternate translation: [for you have exalted above all else your name and your word] or [for you have exalted above all names your word]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 138:2 (#7)

אִמְרָתֶךָ

“your word”

David is using the term **word** to represent what Yahweh has spoken. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all that you have spoken]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 138:3 (#1)

בְּנַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using the word **soul** to refer to his whole self. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 138:3 (#2)

עֹז

“with} power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to be mighty]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 138:4 (#1)

כָּל־מַלְכֵי־אֶרֶץ

“all the kings of the earth”

David is saying **all the kings of the earth** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [kings everywhere]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 138:4 (#2)

אִמְרֵי־פִיךָ

“the words from your mouth”

David is using **the words from your mouth** to represent everything that Yahweh has communicated. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the things you have declared]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 138:5 (#1)

בִּדְרָכֵי יְהוָה

“of the ways of Yahweh”

David is speaking of what Yahweh does as if those actions were **ways** or paths that he walks along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [of what Yahweh does]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 138:5 (#2)

גָּדוֹל כְּבוֹד יְהוָה

“great is the glory of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is very glorious]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 138:6 (#1)

כִּי־רָם יְהוָה וְשָׁפָל יִרְאֶה

“Though Yahweh is high, yet he sees the lowly”

David uses the word **Though** here to indicate a contrast between Yahweh’s supreme status and his attention to those who are humble. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Even though Yahweh is high, he still sees the lowly]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 138:6 (#2)

רָם יְהוָה

“Yahweh is high”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh’s supreme status as if it were a physical height, saying **Yahweh is high**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is supreme]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 138:6 (#3)

וְשָׁפָל יִרְאֶה

“yet he sees the lowly”

David is using the adjective **lowly** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [yet he sees lowly people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 138:6 (#4)

וְגָבֹהַּ מִמֶּרְחָק יְיֵדָע

“and the proud he knows from far off”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh’s relationship to proud people as if it involved physical distance, saying he **knows** them **from far off**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the proud he keeps at a distance]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 138:6 (#5)

וְגָבֹהַּ

“and the proud”

David is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and those who are proud]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 138:7 (#1)

אִם־אֵלֵךְ ׀ בְּקֶרֶב צָרָה תְּחַיֵּנִי

“Though I walk in the middle of trouble, you will keep me alive”

David uses the word **Though** here to indicate a contrast between the danger he faces and the protection Yahweh provides. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Despite that I walk in the middle of trouble, you will still keep me alive]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 138:7 (#2)

אֵלֵךְ ׀ בְּקֶרֶב צָרָה

“I walk in the middle of trouble”

Here David is speaking of experiencing danger as if it were a place through which he walks, saying he will **walk in the middle of trouble**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I experience great trouble]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 138:7 (#3)

תִּשְׁלַח יָדֶךָ

“you will stretch out your hand”

Here, **hand** represents Yahweh’s power to act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will use your power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 138:7 (#4)

אַף אֹיְבַי

“the nose of my enemies”

Here, **nose** represents the anger of David’s enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the anger of my enemies]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 138:7 (#5)

וְתוֹשִׁיעֵנִי יְמִינֶךָ

“and your right hand will save me”

Here, **right hand** represents Yahweh’s power to deliver. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you will powerfully save me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 138:8 (#1)

יְהוָה יִגְמֹר בַּעֲדִי

“Yahweh will accomplish for my benefit”

By **Yahweh will accomplish for my benefit**, the psalmist means that whatever Yahweh does will be to fulfill his purpose for David. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will accomplish his purpose for my benefit]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 138:8 (#2)

חַסְדְּךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 138:8 (#3)

מַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ אַל־תֶּרֶף

“Do not forsake the works of your hands”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression

such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not forsake the works of your hands]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 138:8 (#4)

מַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ

“the works of your hands”

Here, **the works of your hands** represents what Yahweh has made and accomplished. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [what you have made]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 139 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 139 is a psalm of praise.

1. God knows everything about me (1–6)
2. God is everywhere with me (7–12)
3. God formed me wonderfully (8–18)
4. God’s righteous anger guides me (19–22)
5. Inviting God’s search (23–24)

Psalms 139:1 (#1)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“For the chief musician”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 139:1 (#2)

חֲקַרְתַּנִי

“you have searched me”

Here David is speaking of God examining him thoroughly as if God had **searched** for something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have thoroughly examined me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:2 (#1)

אַתָּה יָדַעְתָּ שִׁבְתִּי וְקוּמִי בַּנְתָּה לְרֵעִי מֵרָחוֹק

“You, you know my sitting down and my rising up; you understand my thought from far away”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [You fully know everything I do and think, even from far away] or [You, you know my sitting down and my rising up; indeed, you understand my thought from far away]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:2 (#2)

אַתָּה יָדַעְתָּ

“You, you know”

David is stating the pronoun **You** separately, even though the verb **know** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is Yahweh specifically who knows these things. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, you know]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 139:2 (#3)

שִׁבְתִּי וְקוּמִי

“my sitting down and my rising up”

David is referring to all of his activities by naming two extremes, **my sitting down** and **my rising up**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everything I do]

See: Merism

Psalms 139:2 (#4)

שִׁבְתִּי וְקוּמִי

“my sitting down and my rising up”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **sitting down** and **rising up**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [when I sit down and when I rise up]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:2 (#5)

לְֽרֵעִ֑י

“my thought”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thought**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I think]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:3 (#1)

אָרְחִ֣י וְרִבְעִ֣י זֵרִ֑יתָ וְכָל־דְּרָכַ֖י הִסְכַּנְתָּֽה

“My path and my lying down you have winnowed, and you are familiar with all of my ways”

These two phrases **My path and my lying down you have winnowed** and **you are familiar with all of my ways** mean basically the same thing. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You have carefully examined everything I do; in fact, you know all of my activities intimately]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:3 (#2)

אָרְחִ֣י וְרִבְעִ֣י זֵרִ֑יתָ

“My path and my lying down you have winnowed”

Here David is speaking of God examining his life in detail as if God had **winnowed** grain to separate what is valuable from what is not. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My path and my lying down you have carefully examined]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:3 (#3)

אָרְחִ֣י וְרִבְעִ֣י

“My path and my lying down”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **path** and **lying down**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [where I go and where I lie down]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:3 (#4)

וְכָל־דְּרָכַ֖י הִסְכַּנְתָּֽה

“and you are familiar with all of my ways”

David is speaking of how he lives as if that were a **way** or path that he was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you are familiar with all of the things I do]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:4 (#1)

כִּֽי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כִּי”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [Certainly,]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 139:4 (#2)

בִּלְשׁוֹנִ֔י

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בִּלְשׁוֹנִי”

Here, **on my tongue** represents what David is about to say. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [that I am about to speak]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:4 (#3)

כֻּלָּ֖הּ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כֻּלָּהּ”

The pronoun **it** refers to what David will say. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [all of what I will say]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 139:5 (#1)

אָח֣וֹר וָקֶ֑דֶם צַרְתָּ֥נִי

“Behind and before”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about the direction

with the information about what God does. Alternate translation: [You have enclosed me behind and before]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 139:5 (#2)

אָחוֹר וָקֶדֶם צַרְתָּנִי

“Behind and before”

Here David is speaking of God protecting and guarding him as if God had physically **enclosed** him on all sides. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Behind and before you have guarded me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:5 (#3)

אָחוֹר וָקֶדֶם

“Behind and before”

David is referring to every direction by naming two extremes, **Behind** and **before**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [On every side]

See: Merism

Psalms 139:5 (#4)

כַּפֶּכָה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כַּפֶּכָה”

Here, **your palm** represents God’s power and protective control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your protective power]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:6 (#1)

דַּעַת

“Such} knowledge {is”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **knowledge**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [That you know all of this is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:6 (#2)

נִשְׂגְּבָה

“it is high”

Here David is speaking of God’s knowledge being impossible for him to comprehend as if **it** were physically **high** above him and out of reach. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [it is beyond my understanding]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:6 (#3)

נִשְׂגְּבָה

“it is high”

The pronoun **it** refers to the knowledge David described in the previous phrase. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [this knowledge is high]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 139:7 (#1)

אָאֶנָּגַה אֵלֵֵךְ מֵרוּחֶֶךָ וְאָאָנָה מִפָּנֶֶיךָ אֶבְרָח

“Where shall I go from your spirit? And where shall I flee”

These two phrases **Where shall I go from your spirit?** and **where shall I flee from your face?** mean basically the same thing. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [There is truly nowhere I could go to escape your presence!] or [Where shall I go from your spirit? Indeed, where shall I flee from your face?]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:7 (#2)

אָאֶנָּגַה אֵלֵֵךְ מֵרוּחֶֶךָ

“Where shall I go from your spirit”

David is using the question form to emphasize that there is nowhere he could go to escape from God’s spirit. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I cannot go anywhere to escape from your spirit!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 139:7 (#3)

וְאָאָנָה מִפָּנֶֶיךָ אֶבְרָח

“And where shall I flee”

David is using the question form to emphasize that there is nowhere he could flee to escape from God's presence. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [There is no place to which I could flee from your presence!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 139:7 (#4)

מִפָּנֶיךָ

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִפָּנֶיךָ"

Here, **your face** represents being in God's presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:8 (#1)

אִם־אֶסַּק שָׁמַיִם שָׁם אָתָּה וְאַצִּיעָה שְׁאוֹל הִנָּךְ

"If I ascend {to} the heavens, you {are} there, and I spread out {in} Sheol, behold, you"

These two phrases **If I ascend to the heavens** and **I spread out in Sheol** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words, using a contrasting image. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [No matter where I go, whether to the highest or lowest place, you are there]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:8 (#2)

אִם־אֶסַּק שָׁמַיִם

"If I ascend {to} the heavens"

Here, **If I ascend to the heavens** introduces the first part of a possible condition. David is using this hypothetical situation to emphasize that God is present everywhere. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a hypothetical condition. Alternate translation: [Even if I were to go up to the heavens]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 139:8 (#3)

שָׁמַיִם שָׁם אָתָּה וְאַצִּיעָה שְׁאוֹל

"to} the heavens, you {are} there, and I spread out {in} Sheol"

David is referring to everywhere in the universe by naming two extremes, **the heavens** and **Sheol**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the highest place and the lowest place]

See: Merism

Psalms 139:8 (#4)

הִנָּךְ

"behold, you"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [behold, you are there]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 139:9 (#1)

אֶשָּׂא כַנְפֵי־שָׁחַר אֶשְׁכְּנָה בְּאַחֲרִית יָם

"If} I lift up the wings of the dawn, dwell in the farthest part of the sea"

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [If I travel to the most distant place in the world]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:9 (#2)

אֶשָּׂא

"If} I lift up"

Here, **If I lift up** introduces the first part of a possible condition that continues from the hypothetical condition David began in verse 8. David is using this hypothetical situation to emphasize that God is present everywhere. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [Even if I lift up]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Psalms 139:9 (#3)

כַנְפֵי־שָׁחַר אֶשְׁכְּנָה בְּאַחֲרִית יָם

"the wings of the dawn, dwell in the farthest part of the sea"

David is referring to everywhere by naming two extremes, the **wings of the dawn**, representing the east where the sun rises, and the **farthest part of the sea**, representing the distant west. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the farthest eastern horizon and the most remote western shore]

See: Merism

Psalms 139:9 (#4)

כַּנְפֵי־שָׁ֭חַר

“the wings of the dawn”

David is speaking of **the dawn** as if it were a bird that had **wings**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the first rays of the morning light]

See: Personification

Psalms 139:9 (#5)

אֶֽשְׁכְּנָ֥ה בְּאַחֲרִ֗ית יָ֑ם

“dwell in the farthest part of the sea”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [if I dwell in the farthest part of the sea]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 139:10 (#1)

יָדְךָ֥ תַנְחֵ֑נִי וְ֝תֹאחֲזֵ֗נִי יְמִינֶֽךָ

“your hand will lead me, and your right hand will hold me”

These two phrases **your hand will lead me** and **your right hand will hold me** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [you yourself will surely guide me and sustain me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:10 (#2)

יָדְךָ֥ תַנְחֵ֑נִי

“your hand will lead me”

Here, **hand** represents the power and agency of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your strength will lead me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:10 (#3)

וְ֝תֹאחֲזֵ֗נִי יְמִינֶֽךָ

“and your right hand will hold me”

Here, **right hand** represents the power and strength of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your power will hold me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:11 (#1)

וָ֭אֹמַר אַךְ־חֹ֣שֶׁךְ יְשׁוּפֵ֑נִי

“And I said, “Surely darkness will crush me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [And I said that surely darkness would crush me and night would be the light around me]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Psalms 139:11 (#2)

חֹ֣שֶׁךְ יְשׁוּפֵ֑נִי

“darkness will crush me”

David is speaking of **darkness** as if it were a living thing that could **crush** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [darkness will completely surround me]

See: Personification

Psalms 139:11 (#3)

וְ֝לַ֗יְלָה אוֹר בַּעֲדֵֽנִי

“and night, the light around me”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and night will be the light around me]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 139:12 (#1)

גַּם־חֹ֭שֶׁךְ לֹא־יַחְשִׁ֣יךְ מִמְּךָ֑ וְ֝לַ֗יְלָה כַּיּ֥וֹם יָאִ֑יר

“Even darkness does not make it dark to you, and the night shines like the day”

These two phrases **Even darkness does not make it dark to you** and **the night shines like the day** mean basically the same thing. See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Not even the deepest darkness can hide anything from you, because you see just as clearly at night as during the day]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:12 (#2)

וְלַ֥יְלָה כַּיּ֗וֹם יָאִ֫יר

“and the night shines like the day”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the day** is fully bright and visible, so **the night** is equally bright and visible to Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the night is as bright to you as the day]

See: Simile

Psalms 139:12 (#3)

כַּֽחֲשֵׁיכָ֖ה כָּאוֹרָֽה

“like darkness, like light”

David is referring to all conditions of visibility by naming two extremes, **darkness** and **light**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [whether it is dark or light, it is the same to you]

See: Merism

Psalms 139:12 (#4)

כַּֽחֲשֵׁיכָ֖ה כָּאוֹרָֽה

“like darkness, like light”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [To you, vision in darkness is like vision in light]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:13 (#1)

כִּ֤י

“For”

The word **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. David is giving the reason why darkness and light are the same to Yahweh: because Yahweh is the all-knowing Creator. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 139:13 (#2)

אַ֭תָּה קָנִ֣יתָ

“you, you created”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb **created** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it was Yahweh himself who created him. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you yourself created]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 139:13 (#3)

כִלְיֹתָ֑י

“my kidneys”

Here, **my kidneys** represents David’s deepest inner being, including his emotions and thoughts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my innermost being]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:13 (#4)

תְּ֝סַכֵּ֗נִי

“you knit me together”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh creating him as if Yahweh were a craftsperson **knitting** material together. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you carefully crafted me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:14 (#1)

נִ֭פְלֵיתִי

“I am wonderfully made”

The expression **I am wonderfully made** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [you made me wonderfully]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 139:14 (#2)

מַעֲשֶׂיךָ

“your works”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **works**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things that you have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:14 (#3)

וְנַפְשִׁי יֹדַעַת

“and my soul knows {it”

David is using **my soul** to represent his whole self. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I know it]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 139:15 (#1)

לֹא־נִכְחַד עָצְמִי מִמְּךָ

“My frame was not hidden from you”

The expression **was not hidden** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [No one hid my frame from you]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 139:15 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר־עֻשֵּׂיתִי

“when I was made”

The expression **when I was made** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [when you made me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 139:15 (#3)

רֻקַּמְתִּי

“when} I was woven”

The expression **when I was woven** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [when you wove me]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 139:15 (#4)

רֻקַּמְתִּי

“when} I was woven”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh creating him as if Yahweh were a craftsperson **weaving** cloth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when you carefully assembled me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:15 (#5)

בְּתַחְתִּיּוֹת אָרֶץ

“in the depths of the earth”

Here David is speaking of his mother’s womb as if it were **the depths of the earth**. He is comparing the hidden, enclosed place where he was formed to the deep interior of the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the hidden place of my mother’s womb]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:16 (#1)

רָאוּ עֵינֶיךָ

“your eyes saw”

Here, **your eyes** represents Yahweh’s perception and awareness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you perceived] or [you observed]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:16 (#2)

גָּלְמִ֑י

“my unformed substance”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **unformed substance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [me before my body had taken shape]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:16 (#3)

וְעַל־סִפְרְךָ֥ כֻּלָּ֗ם יִכָּ֫תֵ֥בוּ

“And in your book all of them were written”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh’s plan for his life as if it were a written record **in your book**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you recorded all of them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:16 (#4)

כֻּלָּ֗ם יִכָּ֫תֵ֥בוּ

“all of them were written”

The expression **all of them were written** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [you wrote all of them]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 139:16 (#5)

כֻּלָּ֗ם

“all of them”

Here, **all of them** could refer to the days of David’s life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [all of my days]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 139:16 (#6)

יָמִ֥ים יֻצָּ֑רוּ וְלֹא אֶ֖חָד בָּהֶֽם

“the days were formed, and {yet} not one of them {was”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reorder this clause to clarify its meaning. David is saying that Yahweh recorded his days before any of them actually existed. Alternate translation: [and yet when not one of them had come to be, the days were formed]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 139:16 (#7)

יָמִ֥ים יֻצָּ֑רוּ

“the days were formed”

The expression **the days were formed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [you formed the days]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 139:17 (#1)

רֵעֶ֑יךָ

“your thoughts”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thoughts**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things that you think]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:17 (#2)

מֶ֣ה עָ֭עְצְמוּ רָאשֵׁיהֶֽם

“How numerous are their heads”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of amazement at how many things God thinks about. Alternate translation: [You think of so many things]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 139:17 (#3)

רָאשֵׁיהֶֽם

“their heads”

David is using **their heads** as a common expression of the culture to mean “their total number.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they all] or [they in quantity]

See: Idiom

Psalms 139:18 (#1)

מֵחָ֫וֹל יִרְבֽוּן

“they are more than the sand”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the sand** cannot be counted, so God’s thoughts cannot be counted. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they are too many to count, like grains of sand]

See: Simile

Psalms 139:18 (#2)

מֵחָ֫וֹל יִרְבֽוּן

“they are more than the sand”

David says **they are more than the sand** as an extreme statement to emphasize that God’s thoughts are too many to count. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [they are far too many to count]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 139:19 (#1)

אִם־תִּקְטֹ֣ל אֱ֭לוֹהַּ ׀ רָשָׁ֑ע

“If only you would kill the wicked, God”

This is a wish that David is expressing to God rather than a command. If your language has a way of expressing a strong wish, use that form here. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [God, please kill the wicked]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 139:19 (#2)

וְאַנְשֵׁ֖י דָּ֣מִ֑ים

“And men of bloodshed”

David is using **men of bloodshed** as a common expression of the culture to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, these men have the characteristic of being violent. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And violent men] or [And men who love violence]

See: Idiom

Psalms 139:19 (#3)

וְאַנְשֵׁ֖י דָּ֣מִ֑ים

“And men of bloodshed”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **bloodshed**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And men who shed blood]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:19 (#4)

דָּ֣מִ֑ים

“bloodshed”

Here, **bloodshed** represents violence and murder. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [violence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:19 (#5)

סְ֝ר֗וּ מֶּ֥נִּי

“depart from me”

This is a wish that David is expressing rather than a direct command. If the imperative does not communicate a strong wish for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a strong wish. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please depart from me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 139:20 (#1)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר יֹ֭אמְרֽוּךָ

“who speak of you”

The pronoun **who** refers to the men of bloodshed mentioned in the previous verse. The pronoun **you** refers to Yahweh. Alternate translation: [men of bloodshed who speak of you, Yahweh,]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 139:20 (#2)

לִ֝מְזִמָּ֗ה

“for an evil purpose”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **purpose**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in order to do evil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:20 (#3)

נָשְׂאֽוּ לַשָּׁוְא

“they lift up {your name} to emptiness”

David is using **they lift up your name to emptiness** as a common expression of the culture to mean “they misuse your name.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they misuse your reputation] or [they speak your name for worthless purposes]

See: Idiom

Psalms 139:20 (#4)

נָשְׂאֽוּ לַשָּׁוְא

“they lift up {your name} to emptiness”

David is using the term **name** to represent who God is and to refer to God’s reputation. Alternate translation: [they lift up your reputation to emptiness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:20 (#5)

נָשְׂאֽוּ לַשָּׁוְא עָרֶֽיךָ

“they lift up {your name} to emptiness—your enemies”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about who these people are before the information about what they do. Alternate translation: [your enemies, they lift up your name to emptiness]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 139:20 (#6)

לַשָּׁוְא

“to emptiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **emptiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for what is worthless]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:21 (#1)

הֲלֹוֹא־מְשַׂנְאֶ֣יךָ יְהוָ֣ה ׀ אֶשְׂנָ֑א וּבִתְקוֹמְמֶ֥יךָ אֶתְקוֹטָֽט

“Do I not hate the ones hating you, Yahweh? And do I not loathe the ones rising up against you”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, I certainly hate and loathe all those who oppose you!] or [Do I not hate the ones hating you, Yahweh; yes, do I not loathe the ones rising up against you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:21 (#2)

הֲלֹוֹא־מְשַׂנְאֶ֣יךָ יְהוָ֣ה ׀ אֶשְׂנָ֑א

“Do I not hate the ones hating you, Yahweh”

David is using the question form to emphasize his loyalty to God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, I certainly hate the ones hating you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 139:21 (#3)

וּבִתְקוֹמְמֶ֥יךָ אֶתְקוֹטָֽט

“And do I not loathe the ones rising up against you”

David is using the question form to emphasize his loyalty to God. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I certainly loathe the ones rising up against you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 139:21 (#4)

וּבִתְקוֹמְמֶ֥יךָ אֶתְקוֹטָֽט

“And do I not loathe the ones rising up against you”

David is using **the ones rising up against you** as a common expression of the culture to mean ‘those who oppose you.’ If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And do I not loathe those who rebel against you] or [And do I not loathe those who oppose you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 139:22 (#1)

תַּכְלִית שִׂנְאָה שְׂנֵאתִים לְאוֹיְבִים הָיָוּ לִי

“With} a completeness of hatred I hate them; they have become enemies to me”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [I completely hate them, for they are my enemies] or [{With} a completeness of hatred I hate them; indeed, they have become enemies to me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:22 (#2)

שִׂנְאָה

“hatred”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **completeness** and **hatred**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [I completely hate]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:23 (#1)

חָקְרֵנִי אֵל וְדַע לִבָּבִי בְּחָנֵנִי וְדַע שַׂרְעַפָּי

“Search me, God, and know my heart; examine me and know my cares”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [God, please thoroughly examine everything about me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 139:23 (#2)

חָקְרֵנִי אֵל וְדַע לִבָּבִי

“Search me, God, and know my heart”

This is a request that David is making to God rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please search me, God, and know my heart]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 139:23 (#3)

חָקְרֵנִי

“Search me”

Here David is asking God to thoroughly examining his inner being, to **Search** through him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a comparable expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Thoroughly examine me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:23 (#4)

לִבָּבִי

“my heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and motives exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my innermost thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 139:23 (#5)

בְּחָנֵנִי וְדַע שַׂרְעַפָּי

“examine me and know my cares”

This is a request that David is making to God rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please examine me and know my cares]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 139:23 (#6)

שַׂרְעַפָּי

“my cares”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **cares**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things that concern me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:24 (#1)

וּרְאֵה אִם־דֶּרֶךְ־עֹצֶב בִּי

“And see if a way of hurtfulness {is} in me”

This is a request that David is making to God rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such

as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please see if a way of hurtfulness is in me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 139:24 (#2)

אִם־דֶּרֶךְ־עֹצֶב

“if a way of hurtfulness”

David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [if a harmful way of living]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:24 (#3)

עֹצֶב

“hurtfulness”

The word translated as **hurtfulness** could refer to: (1) something that causes harm or pain. Alternate translation: [pain] or (2) an idol. Alternate translation: [idolatry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 139:24 (#4)

וּנְחֵנִי בְּדֶרֶךְ עוֹלָם

“and lead me in the way of eternity”

This is a request that David is making to God rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [and please lead me in the way of eternity]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 139:24 (#5)

בְּדֶרֶךְ עוֹלָם

“in the way of eternity”

David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path along which that the person was walking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the way of living that lasts forever]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 139:24 (#6)

בְּדֶרֶךְ עוֹלָם

“in the way of eternity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **eternity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way that lasts forever]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 140 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 140 is a deliverance psalm. (See: deliver, deliverer, deliverance, delivered)

1. Cry to Yahweh for protection from the wicked (1–5)
2. Trust Yahweh as defender and refuge (6–8)
3. Ask Yahweh to judge evil and uphold the righteous (9–13)

Psalms 140:0 (#2)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

The word translated as **chief musician** likely refers to the person in charge of music for worship. Some languages may have a term for a music leader. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the leader of worship music]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 140:1 (#1)

חַלְּצֵנִי יְהוָה מֵאָדָם רָע מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים תִּנְצְרֵנִי

“Rescue me, Yahweh, from an evil man; from a man of violence preserve me”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, rescue me and preserve me from evil, violent people]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 140:1 (#2)

חַלְּצֵנִי

“Rescue me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please rescue me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 140:1 (#3)

מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים

“from a man of violence”

David is using the possessive form to describe **a man** who is characterized by **violence**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a violent man]

See: Possession

Psalms 140:1 (#4)

מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים

“from a man of violence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from a man who acts violently]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:1 (#5)

תִּנְצְרֵנִי

“preserve me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please preserve me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 140:2 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר חָשְׁבוּ רָעוֹת

“who plot evil things”

The word **who** refers to the evil man and the man of violence from the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [these evil people devise evil things]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 140:2 (#2)

חָשְׁבוּ רָעוֹת בְּלֵבָב

“plot evil things in the heart”

Here, **heart** represents a person’s thoughts and intentions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [have devised evil things in their thoughts]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:2 (#3)

כָּל-יוֹם

“all the day”

David is saying **all the day** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [constantly] or [all the time]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 140:2 (#4)

יָגֻרוּ מִלְחָמוֹת

“they travel around {to} battles”

The phrase **travel around** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. Many translations, however, follow an alternative reading found in one Hebrew manuscript and some ancient translations. The UST follows that reading. Alternate translation: [they stir up battles]

See: Alternative Readings

Psalms 140:2 (#5)

יָגֻרוּ מִלְחָמוֹת

“they travel around {to} battles”

The pronoun **they** refers to the evil man and the man of violence from verse 1. David uses the plural because he has multiple enemies in view. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [these evil people stir up battles]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 140:3 (#1)

שָׁנְנוּ לְשׁוֹנָם כְּמוֹ־נָחָשׁ

“They have sharpened their tongue like a serpent”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **serpent** has a dangerous, darting tongue, so the speech of these evil people is harmful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [They use their words to harm people, as a serpent uses its tongue to strike]

See: Simile

Psalms 140:3 (#2)

לְשׁוֹנָם

“their tongue”

Here, **their tongue** represents their speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [their words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:3 (#3)

חֲמַת עַכְשׁוּב תַּחַת שְׂפָתָיו

“venom of a viper {is} under their lips”

David is speaking of the harmful words of these evil people as if the words were **venom of a viper** under their lips. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the words they speak are deadly and destructive]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 140:3 (#4)

תַּחַת שְׂפָתָיו

“is} under their lips”

Here, **their lips** represents what they say. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in their speech]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:4 (#1)

שָׁמְרֵנִי יְהוָה ׀ מִּיְדֵי רָשָׁע מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים תִּנְצְרֵנִי

“Guard me, Yahweh, from the hands of the wicked; from the man of violence preserve me”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, guard me and preserve me from wicked, violent people]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 140:4 (#2)

שָׁמְרֵנִי

“Guard me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please guard me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 140:4 (#3)

מִּיְדֵי רָשָׁע

“from the hands of the wicked”

Here, **the hands** of the wicked represents their power and control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the control of the wicked]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:4 (#4)

רָשָׁע

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 140:4 (#5)

מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים

“from the man of violence”

David is using the possessive form to describe **the man** who is characterized by **violence**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the violent man]

See: Possession

Psalms 140:4 (#6)

מֵאִ֣ישׁ חֲמָסִ֑ים

“from the man of violence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the man who acts violently]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:4 (#7)

מֵאִ֣ישׁ

“from the man of”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [from anyone of]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 140:4 (#8)

תִּנְצְרֵ֥נִי

“preserve me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please preserve me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 140:4 (#9)

אֲשֶׁ֥ר חָ֝שְׁב֗וּ לְדָחֹ֥ות פְּעָמָֽי

“who have planned to push down my steps”

David is speaking of his way of life as if it were a path with **steps** that his enemies could **push down**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who have planned to ruin my life]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 140:4 (#10)

אֲשֶׁ֥ר חָ֝שְׁב֗וּ

“who have planned”

The word **who** refers to the wicked and the man of violence. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the wicked people that have planned]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 140:5 (#1)

טָמְנ֣וּ גֵאִ֣ים ׀ פַּ֣ח לִ֑י וַחֲבָלִ֗ים פָּ֭רְשׂוּ רֶ֣שֶׁת לְיַד־מַעְגָּ֑ל מֹקְשִׁ֖ים שָׁ֣תוּ־לִֽי

“The proud have hidden a snare for me, and cords; they have spread out a net to the hand of the path; traps they have set for me”

David is speaking of his enemies as if they were hunters setting **a snare**, **cords**, **a net**, and **traps** to capture him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The proud have made secret plans to ruin me; they have plotted to catch me in their schemes wherever I go]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 140:5 (#2)

גֵּאִ֣ים

“The proud”

David is using the adjective **proud** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Those who are proud] or [Those who act proudly]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 140:6 (#1)

הַאֲזִ֣ינָה יְ֭הוָה קֹ֣ול תַּחֲנוּנָֽי

“Give ear, Yahweh, to the voice of my supplications”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please give ear, Yahweh, to the voice of my supplications]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 140:6 (#2)

הַאֲזִינָה

“Give ear”

David is using the term **ear** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:6 (#3)

קֹ֖ול תַּחֲנוּנָֽי

“to the voice of my supplications”

Here, **the voice** represents the words that David speaks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the words of my supplications]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:6 (#4)

תַּחֲנוּנָֽי

“my supplications”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **supplications**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my cries for help]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:7 (#1)

עֹ֣ז יְשׁוּעָתִ֑י

“the strength of my salvation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **strength** and **salvation**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the mighty one who rescues me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:7 (#2)

עֹ֣ז יְשׁוּעָתִ֑י

“the strength of my salvation”

David is speaking of God’s ability to save him as if it were physical **strength**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you who powerfully deliver me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 140:7 (#3)

סַכֹּ֖תָה לְרֹאשִׁ֣י בְּיֹ֣ום נָֽשֶׁק

“you have covered my head in the day of weaponry”

David is speaking of Yahweh’s protection as if Yahweh had physically **covered** his **head** with armor in battle. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have protected me when I was in battle]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 140:7 (#4)

בְּיֹ֣ום נָֽשֶׁק

“in the day of weaponry”

David is using **in the day of battle** as a common expression to mean “at the time of battle.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when I was in battle] or [at the time of fighting]

See: Idiom

Psalms 140:8 (#1)

אַל־תִּתֵּ֣ן יְ֭הוָה מַאֲוֵ֣י רָשָׁ֑ע

“Do not grant, Yahweh, the desires of the wicked”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not grant, Yahweh, the desires of the wicked]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 140:8 (#2)

מַאֲוֵ֣י רָשָׁ֑ע

“the desires of the wicked”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desires**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what the wicked wish for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:8 (#3)

רָשָׁעֵ֑ע

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 140:8 (#4)

זִמָּמ֣וֹ אַל־תָּ֭פֵק

“do not bring forth his plot”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not bring forth his plot]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 140:8 (#5)

זִמָּמ֣וֹ אַל־תָּ֭פֵק

“do not bring forth his plot”

David is using **bring forth** as a common expression of the culture to mean “grant success to.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [grant success to his plot]

See: Idiom

Psalms 140:8 (#6)

זִמָּמ֣וֹ

“his plot”

The pronoun **his** is singular, even though David used the plural **the wicked** earlier in the verse. This is because he is thinking of the wicked as a group that acts with a single purpose. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [their plot]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 140:8 (#7)

יָרֹ֑ומוּ

“lest} they rise up”

It is difficult to know how the word translated as **they rise up** fits with the rest of the verse. The interpretation of the ULT and UST is one way. Some scholars believe that the word belongs with the first line of the next verse in which case it would start a new sentence with something like: “Those who surround me raise their heads.” Here are some other possibilities. Alternate translation: [when they rise up] or [or they will rise up]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 140:9 (#1)

עֲמַ֣ל שְׂפָתֵ֣ימוֹ יכסומו

“let the mischief of their lips cover them”

David is saying what he wants to happen to his enemies. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants to happen. Alternate translation: [I desire that the mischief of their lips cover them]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 140:9 (#2)

עֲמַ֣ל שְׂפָתֵ֣ימוֹ יכסומו

“let the mischief of their lips cover them”

David is speaking of the harmful things his enemies have said as if those words could physically **cover them** like a burden. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let the trouble they have caused by their words overwhelm them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 140:9 (#3)

עֲמַ֣ל שְׂפָתֵ֣ימוֹ

“the mischief of their lips”

Here, **their lips** represents what they say. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the mischief of their words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:9 (#4)

עֲמַ֣ל שְׂפָתֵ֣ימוֹ

“the mischief of their lips”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **mischief**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the troublesome things they have spoken]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:10 (#1)

יִמּ֤יטוּ עֲלֵיהֶ֨ם גֶּ֪חָלִ֡ים

“Let burning coals fall on them”

David is saying what he wants to happen to his enemies. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants to happen. Alternate translation: [I desire that burning coals fall on them]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 140:10 (#2)

בָּאֵ֥שׁ יַפְּלֵ֑ם

“let him cast them into the fire”

David is saying what he wants God to do to his enemies. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants God to do. Alternate translation: [may he cast them into fire]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 140:10 (#3)

יַפְּלֵ֑ם

“let him cast them”

The pronoun **him** most likely refers to God and **them** refers to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [let God cast the enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 140:11 (#1)

אִ֭ישׁ לָשׁ֣וֹן בַּל־יִכּ֣וֹן בָּאָ֑רֶץ

“Let not a man of tongue be established in the land”

The expression **be established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [May God not establish a man of tongue in the land]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 140:11 (#2)

לָשׁ֣וֹן

“tongue”

Here, **tongue** represents slanderous speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [slanderous words]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:11 (#3)

אִ֭ישׁ לָשׁ֣וֹן

“a man of tongue”

David is using the possessive form to describe **a man** who is characterized by his **tongue**, that is, by his slanderous speech. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a man who speaks slander]

See: Possession

Psalms 140:11 (#4)

אִישׁ־חָמָ֗ס

“a man of violence”

David is using the possessive form to describe **a man** who is characterized by **violence**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a violent man]

See: Possession

Psalms 140:11 (#5)

אִישׁ־חָמָ֗ס

“a man of violence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a man who acts violently]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:11 (#6)

רָ֭עָה יְצוּדֶ֣נּוּ לְמַדְחֵפֹ֑ת

“let evil hunt him with blows”

David speaks of **evil** as if it were a living thing that could **hunt** a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let him experience one disaster after another]

See: Personification

Psalms 140:12 (#1)

יַעֲשֶׂה יְהוָה דִּין עָנִי מִשְׁפַּט אֶבְיֹנִים

“Yahweh will do the cause of the poor, the justice of the needy”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [will defend poor and needy people and bring them justice]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 140:12 (#2)

יַעֲשֶׂה יְהוָה דִּין עָנִי מִשְׁפַּט אֶבְיֹנִים

“Yahweh will do the cause of the poor, the justice of the needy”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **cause** and **justice**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will defend the poor and judge fairly for the needy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 140:12 (#3)

עָנִי

“the poor”

David is using the adjective **poor** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. He does the same thing with the word **needy** later in the verse. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who are poor]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 140:13 (#1)

צַדִּיקִים יוֹדוּ לִשְׁמֶךָ יֵשְׁבוּ יְשָׁרִים אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ

“the righteous will praise your name; the upright will dwell before your face”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [righteous and upright people will give you thanks and live in your presence]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 140:13 (#2)

צַדִּיקִים

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. He does the same thing with the word **upright** later in the verse. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are righteous]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 140:13 (#3)

יוֹדוּ לִשְׁמֶךָ

“will praise your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [will thank you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 140:13 (#4)

יֵשְׁבוּ יְשָׁרִים אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ

“the upright will dwell before your face”

Here, **your face** represents Yahweh’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the upright will live before you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms - Chapter 141 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 141 is a “lament.”

1. Ask Yahweh to hear and accept the prayer (1–2)
2. Pray for purity in speech and actions (3–5)
3. Trust Yahweh for protection and deliverance (6–10)

Psalms 141:1 (#1)

מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד

“A psalm of David”

This is poetic language. If your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here.

See: Poetry

Psalms 141:1 (#2)

חְוּשָׁה לְלִי

“Hurry to me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hurry to me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 141:1 (#3)

הַאֲזִינָה קוֹלִי

“Give ear to my voice”

David is using **Give ear to my voice** as a common expression of the culture to mean “listen attentively to what I am saying.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Pay attention to what I say] or [Listen closely to my words]

See: Idiom

Psalms 141:2 (#1)

תִּכּוֹן תְּפִלָּתִי

“May my prayer be established”

The expression **May my prayer be established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [May you establish my prayer]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 141:2 (#2)

קְטֹרֶת לְפָנֶיךָ

“like} incense to your face”

The point of this comparison is that just as **incense** rises up as a pleasing aroma before God, so David wants his prayer to rise up and be acceptable to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as a pleasing offering before you]

See: Simile

Psalms 141:2 (#3)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **to your face** represents “in your presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before you] or [in your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 141:2 (#4)

תִּכּוֹן תְּפִלָּתִי קְטֹרֶת לְפָנֶיךָ מַשְׂאַת כַּפַּי מִנְחַת־עָרֶב

“May my prayer be established {like} incense to your face, a raising of my palms {like} the evening sacrifice”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [May my prayer and my uplifted hands be truly acceptable to you, like a pleasing offering]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 141:2 (#5)

מַשְׂאַת כַּפַּי מִנְחַת־עָרֶב

“a raising of my palms {like} the evening sacrifice”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the evening sacrifice** is an acceptable offering to God, so David wants his raised hands in prayer to be equally acceptable. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [my lifted hands as an acceptable offering to you]

See: Simile

Psalms 141:2 (#6)

מִנְחַת־עָרֶב

“like} the evening sacrifice”

The **evening sacrifice** is a kind of grain offering that the Israelites presented to God at twilight each day. If your readers would not be familiar with what the evening sacrifice is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [the offering presented at twilight] or [the daily evening offering]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 141:3 (#1)

שִׁיתָ֣ה יְ֭הוָה שָׁמְרָ֣ה לְפִ֑י נִצְּרָ֥ה עַל־דַּ֝֗לֶת שְׂפָתָֽי

“Yahweh, place a guard over my mouth; guard the door of my lips”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, carefully watch over everything I say]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 141:3 (#2)

שִׁיתָ֣ה יְ֭הוָה שָׁמְרָ֣ה לְפִ֑י

“Yahweh, place a guard over my mouth”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, please place a guard over my mouth]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 141:3 (#3)

שָׁמְרָ֣ה לְפִ֑י

“a guard over my mouth”

Here David is speaking as if his mouth were an opening that needed **a guard** posted over it to control what comes out. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [someone to watch over what I say] or [restraint on my speech]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 141:3 (#4)

עַל־דַּ֝֗לֶת שְׂפָתָֽי

“the door of my lips”

Here David is speaking as if his lips were **the door** of a building that needed to be guarded. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the opening of my lips] or [what my lips let pass through]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 141:4 (#1)

אַל־תַּ֣ט־לִ֭בִּי לְדָבָ֣ר ׀ רָ֑ע

“Do not turn my heart toward an evil thing”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not turn my heart toward an evil thing]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 141:4 (#2)

אַל־תַּ֣ט־לִ֭בִּי לְדָבָ֣ר ׀ רָ֑ע

“Do not turn my heart toward an evil thing”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s desires and inclinations exist. David is speaking as if someone could **turn** his heart in a direction toward evil, meaning his desires could be directed toward wrongdoing. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not cause me to desire an evil thing] or [Do not direct my desires toward an evil thing]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 141:4 (#3)

בְּרֶ֣שַׁע

“in wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in wicked ways]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 141:4 (#4)

אֶת־אִישֵׁ֥י פֹ֝עֲלֵי־אָ֗וֶן

“with men, doers of evil”

Here the masculine term **men** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [with people, doers of evil]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 141:4 (#5)

פֹּעֲלֵי־אָוֶן

“doers of evil”

David is using the participial phrase **doers of evil** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who do evil things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 141:4 (#6)

וּבַל־אֶאֱלְחַם בְּמַנְעַמֵּיהֶם

“And may I not dine on their delicacies”

David is expressing what he desires for himself. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he desires. Alternate translation: [I desire that I not dine on their delicacies] or [I should not dine on their delicacies]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 141:4 (#7)

וּבַל־אֶאֱלְחַם בְּמַנְעַמֵּיהֶם

“And may I not dine on their delicacies”

Here David is speaking as if sharing in the pleasures and rewards of the wicked were dining on **their delicacies**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And may I not partake of their pleasures] or [And may I not share in their rewards]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 141:4 (#8)

בְּמַנְעַמֵּיהֶם

“on their delicacies”

The pronoun **their** refers to the men, doers of evil, mentioned earlier in the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [on the delicacies of the doers of evil]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:5 (#1)

יֶהֱלְמֵנִי־צַדִּיק

“Let the righteous hit me”

David is saying what he wants the righteous to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that the righteous hit me] or [The righteous should hit me]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 141:5 (#2)

צַדִּיק

“the righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 141:5 (#3)

חֶסֶד

“covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because he is being faithfully loyal to me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 141:5 (#4)

וְיוֹכִיחֵנִי

“and he is correcting me”

The pronoun **he** refers to the righteous person mentioned at the beginning of the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:5 (#5)

שֶׁשֶׁמֶן רֹאשׁ אַל־יָנֵנִי רֹאשִׁי

“Oil for the head may my head not refuse”

David assumes that readers will know that anointing someone’s head with oil was a way of honoring or blessing that person. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [May my head not refuse oil for the head, which would be a sign of such honor]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 141:5 (#6)

כִּי־עֹוד וּתְפִלָּתִי בְּרָעוֹתֵיהֶם

“For my prayer {is} continually against their wickedness”

The pronoun **their** refers to the doers of evil mentioned in verse 4. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [For my prayer is continually against the wickedness of the doers of evil]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:5 (#7)

כִּי־עֹוד וּתְפִלָּתִי בְּרָעוֹתֵיהֶם

“For my prayer {is} continually against their wickedness”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because my prayer is continually against their wickedness]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 141:5 (#8)

כִּי־עֹוד וּתְפִלָּתִי בְּרָעוֹתֵיהֶם

“For my prayer {is} continually against their wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [For my prayer is continually against the wicked things they do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 141:5 (#9)

עֹוד

“continually”

David is saying **continually** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [again and again]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 141:6 (#1)

נִשְׁמְטוּ בְיָדֵי־סֶלַע שֹׁפְטֵיהֶם

“Their judges are thrown down beside a cliff”

The expression **Their judges are thrown down** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Someone throws their judges down]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 141:6 (#2)

שֹׁפְטֵיהֶם

“Their judges”

The pronoun **Their** refers to the wicked people described in verse 4. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The judges of the wicked people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:6 (#3)

וְשָׁמְעוּ אִמְרַי כִּי נָעֲמוּ

“and they hear my words, that they are pleasant”

In the phrase **and they hear my words, that they are pleasant**, the first **they** could refer to the wicked people or to their judges, and the second **they** refers to David’s words. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. [and the wicked people hear my words, that my words are pleasant]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:7 (#1)

כְּמֹו פֹלֵחַ וּבֹקֵעַ בָּאָרֶץ

“Just as splitting and breaking up in the ground”

The point of this comparison is that just as **splitting and breaking up** the ground scatters clods of earth everywhere, so their bones lie scattered about near death. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Just as clods of earth are scattered when one breaks up the ground]

See: Simile

Psalms 141:7 (#2)

כְּמוֹ פֹלֵחַ וּבֹקֵעַ בָּאָרֶץ נִפְזְרוּ עַצְמֹתֵינוּ לְפִי שְׁאוֹל

“Just as splitting and breaking up in the ground, our bones are scattered at the mouth of Sheol”

The words of this verse may be (1) the words of the wicked. See the UST for how you could mark this as a direct quote of the wicked. Or this may be (2) the words of the psalmist, describing the danger that he feels from his wicked oppressors. In this case, there would be no quote marks around the verse.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Psalms 141:7 (#3)

פֹלֵחַ וּבֹקֵעַ

“splitting and breaking up”

The terms **splitting** and **breaking up** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [breaking apart]

See: Doublet

Psalms 141:7 (#4)

נִפְזְרוּ עַצְמֹתֵינוּ

“our bones are scattered”

The expression **our bones are scattered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [death scatters our bones]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 141:7 (#5)

עַצְמֹתֵינוּ

“our bones”

The pronoun **our** represents a shift from the singular “I” that David has been using to a plural form. Here David is speaking on behalf of himself and his companions, or he is quoting what the persecuted righteous say together. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:7 (#6)

לְפִי שְׁאוֹל

“at the mouth of Sheol”

David is speaking of **Sheol** as if it were a living creature that could swallow the dead with its **mouth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the entrance to Sheol] or [the opening of the grave]

See: Personification

Psalms 141:8 (#1)

כִּי אֵלֶיךָ ׀ יְהוִה אֲדֹנָי עֵינָי

“Yet my eyes are on you, Yahweh, Lord”

David uses the word **Yet** here to indicate a contrast between his desperate situation described in the previous verse and his continued trust in God. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But despite all of this, my eyes are on you, Yahweh, Lord]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 141:8 (#2)

אֵלֶיךָ ׀ יְהוִה אֲדֹנָי עֵינָי

“my eyes are on you, Yahweh, Lord”

Here, **my eyes are on you** represents “I look to you with trust and dependence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I put my trust in you] or [I look to you for help]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 141:8 (#3)

בְּכָה חָסִיתִי

“in you I take refuge”

Here David is speaking as if God were a physical shelter where he could **take refuge** from danger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in you I find safety] or [you are my protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 141:8 (#4)

אַל־תְּעַר נַפְשִׁי

“do not uncover my soul”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please do not uncover my soul] or [please do not leave my soul unprotected]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 141:9 (#1)

שָׁמְרֵ֣נִי מִמְּיֵדֵ֣י פַּ֭ח יָקְשׁ֣וּ לִ֑י

"Keep me from the hands of the snare they have laid for me"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please keep me from the hands of the snare they have laid for me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 141:9 (#2)

פַּ֭ח יָקְשׁ֣וּ לִ֑י וּמֹקְשׁ֥וֹת פֹּעֲלֵי־ אָֽוֶן

"the snare they have laid for me, and the traps of the workers of evil"

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [all the traps that evildoers have set to catch me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 141:9 (#3)

מִמְּיֵדֵ֣י פַּ֭ח

"from the hands of the snare"

Here David is speaking as if the snare had **hands** that could grab and hold him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the grip of the snare] or [the power of the snare]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 141:9 (#4)

יָקְשׁ֣וּ לִ֑י

"they have laid for me"

The pronoun **they** refers to the doers of evil mentioned later in the verse as "the workers of evil." It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the workers of evil have laid for me]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:9 (#5)

וּמֹקְשׁ֥וֹת פֹּעֲלֵי־ אָֽוֶן

"and the traps of the workers of evil"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and keep me from the traps of the workers of evil]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 141:10 (#1)

רְשָׁעִ֗ים

"the wicked"

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 141:10 (#2)

יִפְּל֣וּ בְמַכְמֹ֣רֶת֣יו רְשָׁעִ֣ים יַ֑חַד

"Let the wicked fall into his nets together"

Here David is speaking as if the punishment that the wicked deserve were nets that they would **fall into**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Let the wicked be caught in their own schemes together] or [Let the wicked be ensnared by their own plans altogether]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 141:10 (#3)

בְּמַכְמֹ֣רֶת֣יו

"into his nets"

The singular pronoun **his** is used to refer collectively to each of the wicked people. David uses a singular form even though he is speaking of the wicked as a

group. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [together into the nets of the wicked people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 141:10 (#4)

אָאֲנֹכִי עַד־אֶעֱבֹור

“I, while I cross over”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will cross over** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he himself will do something different than what the wicked will do. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [while I myself cross over]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 142 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 142 is a psalm of deliverance from his enemies. (See: deliver, deliverer, deliverance, delivered)

1. Pour out complaint and trouble to Yahweh (1–4)
2. Declare Yahweh as refuge and portion (5–7)

Psalms 142:0 (#2)

מַשְׂכִּיל

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מַשְׂכִּיל”

The superscription to this psalm identifies it as a **maskil**. Since the meaning of this word is not certain, you may wish to represent it in its Hebrew form and spell it the way it sounds in your language. See the discussion of that term in the Introduction to Psalms.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 142:1 (#1)

קֹולִי אֶל־יְהוָה אֶזְעָק קֹולִי אֶל־יְהוָה אֶתְחַנָּן

“My voice to Yahweh—I cry out; my voice to Yahweh —I plead for favor”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I earnestly cry out to Yahweh for favor]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 142:1 (#2)

קֹולִי אֶל־יְהוָה

“My voice to Yahweh”

David is using **My voice** to represent his prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [My prayer to Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 142:2 (#1)

אֶשְׁפֹּךְ לְפָנָיו שִׂיחִי

“I pour out my lament to his face”

David is speaking of his lament as if it were a liquid that he **pours out** before Yahweh. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I express my lament to his face]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 142:2 (#2)

שִׂיחִי

“my lament”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **lament**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I lament]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 142:2 (#3)

לְפָנָיו

“to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents being in the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 142:2 (#4)

צָֽרָתִֽי

“my distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what distresses me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 142:3 (#1)

בְּהִתְעַטֵּ֣ף עָלַ֣י ׀ רוּחִ֑י

“When my spirit faints within me”

David is using the word **spirit** to represent his whole self. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When I grow faint]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 142:3 (#2)

וְאַתָּ֣ה יָדַ֣עְתָּ

“then you, you know”

The word **you** is repeated for emphasis. David is emphasizing that Yahweh is the one who truly knows his path. If your language does not use repetition for emphasis, you could express this in another way. Alternate translation: [then you alone know]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 142:3 (#3)

נְתִיבָתִ֑י

“my path”

David is speaking of how he lives and what he does as if that were a **path** that he was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my situation]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 142:3 (#4)

טָ֝מְנ֗וּ פַּ֣ח לִֽי

“they have hidden a trap for me”

David is speaking of his enemies’ schemes as if they were a **trap** that **they** had **hidden** for him to fall into. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they have secretly planned to harm me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 142:3 (#5)

טָ֝מְנ֗וּ

“they have hidden”

David is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense to refer to his enemies without specifying who they are. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [others have hidden] or [people have hidden]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 142:4 (#1)

הַבֵּ֣יט יָ֭מִין ׀ וּרְאֵ֑ה

“Look right and see”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please look right and see]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 142:4 (#2)

הַבֵּ֣יט יָ֭מִין

“Look right”

Looking to the right was a symbolic action by which a person looked for his defender, since the right side was the position where a protector would stand. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Look for my defender]

See: Symbolic Action

Psalms 142:4 (#3)

לְנַפְשִׁ֑י

“for my soul”

David is using the word **soul** to represent his whole self. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 142:5 (#1)

מַחְסִי

“my shelter”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shelter** that could protect him from danger. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my protection]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 142:5 (#2)

חֶלְקִי

“my portion”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **portion** of inherited land. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all that matters to me]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 142:5 (#3)

בְּאֶרֶץ הַחַיִּים

“in the land of the living”

The expression **the land of the living** was a common expression meaning “among those who are alive on earth.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [during my life on earth]

See: Idiom

Psalms 142:5 (#4)

הַחַיִּים

“the living”

David is using the adjective **living** as a noun to mean people who are alive. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are alive]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 142:6 (#1)

כִּי־דַלֹּתִי מְאֹד

“for I am very low”

The word **for** indicates that what follows is the reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I am very low]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 142:6 (#2)

דַּלֹּתִי מְאֹד

“I am very low”

David is speaking of his distress as if he were physically in a **low** position. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am very weak]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 142:6 (#3)

כִּי אָמְצוּ מִמֶּנִּי

“for they are stronger than I”

The word **for** indicates that what follows is the reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [since they are stronger than I]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 142:7 (#1)

הוֹצִיאָה מִמַּסְגֵּר ׀ נַפְשִׁי

“Bring out my soul from prison”

David is speaking of his trouble as if it were a **prison** from which he needs to be brought out. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Free me from my troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 142:7 (#2)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

David is using the word **soul** to represent his whole self. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 142:7 (#3)

לְהוֹדוֹת אֶת־שְׁמֶךָ

“to praise your name”

Here, **to** marks **praise your name** as the purpose for which David asks Yahweh to bring him out of trouble. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that I may praise your name]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 142:7 (#4)

אֶת־שְׁמֶךָ

“your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is and his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 142:7 (#5)

צַדִּיקִים

“The righteous”

David is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean righteous people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 142:7 (#6)

כִּי תִגְמֹל עָלָי

“because you will fulfill for me”

The word **because** indicates that what follows is the reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [for you will fulfill for me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 142:7 (#7)

תִגְמֹל עָלָי

“you will fulfill for me”

The implication is that Yahweh will fulfill David’s request or his promise. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you will fulfill your promise to me] or [you will answer my prayer]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms - Chapter 143 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 143 is a deliverance psalm. The psalmist prays for deliverance from his enemies. (See: deliver, deliverer, deliverance, delivered)

1. Plead for Yahweh’s mercy and not judgment (1–2)
2. Describe distress and longing for Yahweh (3–6)
3. Ask Yahweh for guidance, deliverance, and renewal (7–12)

Psalms 143:1 (#1)

שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי הַאֲזִינָה אֶל־תַּחֲנוּנַי

“Hear my prayer & listen to my pleas”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Hear my prayer, Yahweh; yes, listen to my pleas]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 143:1 (#2)

שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי

“Hear my prayer”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please hear my prayer]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:1 (#3)

הַאֲזִינָה אֶל־תַּחֲנוּנַי

“listen to my pleas”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please listen to my supplications]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:1 (#4)

בֶּאֱמֻנָתְךָ֣ עֲנֵ֣נִי בְצִדְקָתֶֽךָ׃

"On account of your faithfulness answer me in your righteousness"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **faithfulness** and **righteousness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Because you are faithful, answer me, because you are righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 143:1 (#5)

עֲנֵ֣נִי

"answer me"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please answer me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:2 (#1)

וְאַל־תָּבֹ֣א בְמִשְׁפָּ֣ט

"And do not enter into judgment"

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please do not enter into judgment]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:2 (#2)

וְאַל־תָּבֹ֣א בְמִשְׁפָּ֣ט אֶת־עַבְדֶּ֑ךָ

"And do not enter into judgment with your servant"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And do not judge your servant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 143:2 (#3)

לְפָנֶ֗יךָ

"to your face"

Here, **to your face** represents being in the presence of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in your presence]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 143:2 (#4)

כִּֽי

"for"

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 143:2 (#5)

לֹא־יִצְדַּ֖ק לְפָנֶ֣יךָ כָל־חָֽי

"everyone living is not righteous to your face"

David is saying **everyone living is not righteous** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [no living person is truly righteous]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 143:3 (#1)

כִּֽי

"For"

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 143:3 (#2)

רָדַ֣ף אוֹיֵ֣ב ׀ נַפְשִׁ֑י

“the enemy has pursued my soul”

Here, **my soul** represents David himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the enemy has pursued me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 143:3 (#3)

דִּכָּ֣א לָאָ֣רֶץ חַיָּתִ֑י

“he has crushed my life to the ground”

Here David is speaking as if his enemy had physically **crushed** his **life to the ground**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has completely defeated me] or [he has brought me very low]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:3 (#4)

בְּמַחֲשַׁכִּ֔ים

“in dark places”

Here David is speaking as if his suffering were being in **dark places**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in places of despair] or [in places where it is as if I were dead]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:3 (#5)

כְּמֵתֵ֥י עוֹלָ֖ם

“like the dead of ages”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the dead of ages** are unable to help themselves, so is David in his suffering. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like people who have been dead for a long time]

See: Simile

Psalms 143:3 (#6)

כְּמֵתֵ֥י עוֹלָ֖ם

“like the dead of ages”

David is using the adjective **dead** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [like those who died long ago]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 143:4 (#1)

וַתִּתְעַטֵּ֣ף עָלַ֣י רוּחִ֑י בְּתוֹכִ֥י יִשְׁתּוֹמֵ֖ם לִבִּֽי

“So my spirit faints within me; my heart despairs inside me”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [So my spirit and my heart lose hope within me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 143:4 (#2)

וַתִּתְעַטֵּ֣ף עָלַ֣י רוּחִ֑י

“So my spirit faints within me”

Here David is speaking as if his **spirit** were a person who could **faint**. He means that he is losing his strength and vitality. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am growing weak inside]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:4 (#3)

בְּתוֹכִ֥י יִשְׁתּוֹמֵ֖ם לִבִּֽי

“my heart despairs inside me”

Here the **heart** represents where David’s feelings exist. He is saying that deep inside himself he feels dismay. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I feel hopeless]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:5 (#1)

הָגִ֣יתִי בְכָל־פָּעָלֶ֑ךָ בְּמַעֲשֵׂ֖ה יָדֶ֣יךָ אֲשׂוֹחֵֽחַ

“I meditate on all your works; I reflect on the works of your hands”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [In my mind I review all that you have done] or [I meditate on

all your works; indeed, I reflect on the works of your hands]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 143:5 (#2)

בְּמַעֲשֵׂי֥ה יָדֶ֗יךָ

“on the works of your hands”

Here, **your hands** represents God’s power and agency. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [on what you have accomplished]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 143:6 (#1)

פֵּרַ֣שְׂתִּי יָדַ֣י אֵלֶ֑יךָ

“I spread out my hands to you”

Here David is speaking as if to **spread out** his **hands** were the act of praying itself. He means that he is praying to God. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I lift my hands in prayer to you] or [I pray earnestly to you]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:6 (#2)

נַפְשִׁ֥י ׀ כְּאֶ֣רֶץ־עֲיֵפָ֣ה לָ֑ךְ

“my soul, as a thirsty land, to you”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [my soul longs for you as a weary land longs for water]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 143:6 (#3)

נַפְשִׁ֥י ׀ כְּאֶ֣רֶץ־עֲיֵפָ֣ה לָ֑ךְ

“my soul, as a thirsty land, to you”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a weary land** desperately needs water, so David desperately needs God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I need you the way a weary land needs rain]

See: Simile

Psalms 143:7 (#1)

מַהֵ֣ר עֲנֵ֣נִי ׀ יְהוָ֣ה

“Hurry! Answer me, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hurry and answer me, Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:7 (#2)

כָּלְתָ֣ה רוּחִ֑י

“my spirit is expiring”

Here David is speaking as if his **spirit** were something that could be **expiring** or used up. He means that he is losing all hope and strength. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am losing all strength] or [I have no more endurance]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:7 (#3)

אַל־תַּסְתֵּ֣ר פָּנֶ֣יךָ מִמֶּ֑נִּי

“Do not hide your face from me”

Here, **your face** represents God’s attention and favor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Do not hide your favor from me] or [Do not ignore me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 143:7 (#4)

וְנִמְשַׁלְתִּ֥י עִם־יֹרְדֵ֖י בֽוֹר

“or I will become equal with those going down to the pit”

The word translated as **or** indicates that what follows is a negative consequence that will happen if the previous request is not fulfilled. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [otherwise]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 143:7 (#5)

יֹ֝רְדֵ֗י בֽוֹר

“those going down to the pit”

David is referring to death in a polite way by using the phrase **the descenders of the pit**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [those who descend to their death] or [those who die]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 143:8 (#1)

הַשְׁמִ֣יעֵ֣נִי בַבֹּ֣קֶר ׀ חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“Let me hear your covenant faithfulness in the morning”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please cause me to hear your covenant faithfulness]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:8 (#2)

חַסְדֶּ֑ךָ

“your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 143:8 (#3)

הוֹדִ֣יעֵ֣נִי דֶּ֣רֶךְ־זֹ֣ו אֵלֵ֑ךְ

“Make known to me this way I should walk”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please make known to me the way that I should walk]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:8 (#4)

דֶּ֣רֶךְ־זֹ֣ו אֵלֵ֑ךְ

“this way I should walk”

David is speaking of how he should live as if that were a **way** that he was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how I should live]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:8 (#5)

כִּֽי־אֵלֶ֖יךָ נָשָׂ֣אתִי נַפְשִׁ֑י

“for I lift up my soul to you”

David is using **I lift up my soul to** as a common expression of his culture to mean “I completely depend on.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for I completely depend on you]

See: Idiom

Psalms 143:9 (#1)

הַצִּילֵ֣נִי מֵאֹיְבַ֣י

“Rescue me from my enemies”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please rescue me from my enemies]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:10 (#1)

לַמְּדֵ֣נִי ׀ לַעֲשׂ֣וֹת רְצוֹנֶ֑ךָ

“Teach me to do your will”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please teach me to do your will]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 143:10 (#2)

רְצוֹנֶךָ׃

“your will”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **will**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what you want me to do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 143:10 (#3)

אֱלֹוֹהָי

“my God”

David is not using this possessive form **my God** to indicate that he possesses or controls God. Rather David is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom he worships. Alternate translation: [the God whom I worship]

See: Possession

Psalms 143:10 (#4)

בְּאֶרֶץ מִישׁוֹר

“in a level land”

Here David is speaking as if God’s guidance were leading him on **level land** that is good to walk upon. He means that God gives him a life free from obstacles and difficulties. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [along a safe path] or [help me live in a way that righteous]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 143:10 (#5)

כִּי־אַתָּה אֱלֹוֹהָי

“for you {are} my God”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 143:11 (#1)

לְמַעַן־שִׁמְךָ

“for the sake of your name”

Here, **your name** represents God’s reputation and character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for the sake of your reputation] or [to bring honor to who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 143:11 (#2)

בְּצִדְקָתְךָ֥ ׀ תוֹצִ֗יא מִצָּרָ֥ה נַפְשִׁ֑י

“in your righteousness may you bring my soul out of distress”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness** and **distress**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [because you are righteous, please bring me out of my distressing situation]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 143:11 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי

“my soul”

Here, **my soul** represents David himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [me]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 143:12 (#1)

וּבְחַסְדְּךָ֥

“And in your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And because you are faithful to your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 143:12 (#2)

תַּצְמִ֥ית אֹיְבָ֑י וְ֝הַאֲבַדְתָּ֗ כָּל־צֹרְרֵ֥י נַפְשִׁ֑י

“may you destroy my enemies and exterminate all the adversaries of my soul”

The terms **destroy my enemies** and **exterminate all of the adversaries of my soul** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [please completely eliminate all who oppose me]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 143:12 (#3)

צֹרְרֵי נַפְשִׁי

“the adversaries of my soul”

Here, **my soul** represents David himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my adversaries]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 143:12 (#4)

כִּי

“for”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms - Chapter 144 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 144 is a specific type of psalm of supplication, a psalm of trust. (See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.) The psalmist does not cry out urgently for help. Instead, he begins by saying how reliable and trustworthy Yahweh is. In the rest of the psalm, the psalmist asks for deliverance from his enemies, but this petition is punctuated by confident expressions of praise for Yahweh as the deliverer.

1. Statement of trust (1–4)
2. Petition (5–8)
3. Expression of praise (9–10)
4. Petition (11–14)
5. Expression of praise (15)

Psalms 144:1 (#1)

בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה

“Blessed {be} Yahweh”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. The psalmist is expressing his desire to praise Yahweh. If it would be unnatural to use that form for this purpose, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I bless Yahweh] or [Let me praise Yahweh]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 144:1 (#2)

צוּרִי

“my rock”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a high **rock** that David could climb up to reach safety from danger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [my protector]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 144:1 (#3)

הַמְלַמֵּד יָדַי לַקְרָב אֶצְבְּעוֹתַי לַמִּלְחָמָה

“the one teaching my hands for war, my fingers for battle”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [the one teaching my hands for war, the one training my fingers for battle]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 144:2 (#1)

חַסְדִּי

“my covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one who is faithfully committed to me by covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 144:2 (#2)

וּמְצוּדָתִי מִשְׂגַּבִּי וּמְפַלְטִי לִי מָגִנִּי

“and my fortress, my stronghold and the one rescuing me, my shield”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were **my fortress** and **my stronghold**, strong places where he could go for safety, and as if he were **my shield**, a defensive weapon that protects from attack. If these images communicate well in your language, please use them. If not, you could express them in a different way. Alternate translation: [and my protector, my safe place and the one rescuing me, my defender]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 144:2 (#3)

וּמְצוּדָתִי֮ מִשְׂגַּבִּ֪י

“and my fortress, my stronghold”

The terms **fortress** and **stronghold** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my strong fortress]

See: Doublet

Psalms 144:2 (#4)

וּבְל֣וֹ חָסְיִ֑תִי

“and in whom I take refuge”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a place of **refuge** where he could go to hide from danger. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and in whom I find safety]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 144:3 (#1)

מָה־אָ֭דָם וַתֵּדָעֵ֑הוּ בֶּן־אֱ֝נ֗וֹשׁ וָתְחַשְּׁבֵֽהוּ

“what {is} man, that you know him, the son of man, that you consider him”

David is not asking for information about **man**. He is using the question form to emphasize how small and insignificant people are compared to God. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate his words as a statement or an exclamation and communicate the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [people are so insignificant that you should not pay attention to them, and the son of man is not worth considering.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 144:3 (#2)

מָה־אָ֭דָם וַתֵּדָעֵ֑הוּ בֶּן־אֱ֝נ֗וֹשׁ וָתְחַשְּׁבֵֽהוּ

“what {is} man, that you know him, the son of man, that you consider him”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [what is man, that you know him; indeed, what is the son of man, that you consider him]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 144:3 (#3)

מָה־אָ֭דָם

“what {is} man”

The psalmist is not referring to a specific **man**. He means people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [what is a human being]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Psalms 144:3 (#4)

בֶּן־אֱ֝נ֗וֹשׁ

“the son of man”

Although the term **son of man** is masculine, David is using the phrase in a generic sense that includes both men and women. Alternate translation: [the child of humanity] or [a human being]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 144:4 (#1)

אָ֭דָם לְהֶ֣בֶל דָּמָ֑ה

“Man compares to vapor”

David is speaking of **Man** as if he were **vapor**, something that appears briefly and then is gone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [A person is like a puff of smoke]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 144:4 (#2)

אָ֭דָם

“Man”

Although the term **Man** is masculine, David is using the word in a generic sense that includes both men and women. Alternate translation: [A person]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 144:4 (#3)

יָ֝מָ֗יו כְּצֵ֣ל עוֹבֵ֑ר

“his days {are} like a passing shadow”

David uses a comparison to express how quickly a person's **days** pass. He says they are **like a passing shadow**, something that quickly moves and vanishes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent comparison or express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his days pass quickly]

See: Simile

Psalms 144:5 (#1)

הַט־שָׁמֶ֥יךָ וְתֵרֵ֑ד

"bow your heavens and come down"

These are imperatives, but they communicate polite requests rather than commands. Use forms in your language that communicate polite requests. It may be helpful to add an expression such as "please" to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please bow your heavens and come down]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 144:5 (#2)

גַּ֖ע בֶּהָרִ֣ים וְיֶעֱשָׁנ֑וּ

"touch the mountains, that they may smoke"

The phrase **that they may smoke** communicates the purpose for which David asks God to touch the mountains. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that the second phrase describes the purpose for the first phrase. Alternate translation: [touch the mountains so that they smoke]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 144:5 (#3)

גַּ֖ע בֶּהָרִ֣ים וְיֶעֱשָׁנ֑וּ

"touch the mountains, that they may smoke"

The psalmist is saying what he wants **Yahweh** to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about "let" and "may" and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [please touch the mountains, that they may smoke]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 144:6 (#1)

בְּרָ֣ק בָּ֭רָק וּתְפִיצֵ֑ם שְׁלַ֖ח חִצֶּ֣יךָ וּתְהֻמֵּֽם

"Light lightning and scatter them; send your arrows and rout them"

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. It would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be unclear in your language, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [Light lightning and scatter them; yes, send your arrows and rout them]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 144:6 (#2)

בְּרָ֣ק בָּ֭רָק

"Light lightning"

David is repeating forms of the word **lighten** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Flash your lightening]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 144:6 (#3)

וּתְפִיצֵ֑ם

"and scatter them"

The pronoun **them** refers to David's enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this explicitly. Alternate translation: [and scatter my enemies]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 144:6 (#4)

שְׁלַ֖ח חִצֶּ֣יךָ

"send your arrows"

David is speaking of lightning bolts as if they were **arrows** that God shoots at his enemies. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [send your lightning bolts]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 144:7 (#1)

שְׁלַ֣ח יָ֭דֶיךָ מִמָּר֑וֹם

"Send your hands from above"

Here, **hands** represents Yahweh's power and action. David speaks of God acting on his behalf as if God were

reaching out his **hands from above**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Use your power from above]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:7 (#2)

פְּצֵנִי וְהַצִּילֵנִי

“break me free and deliver me”

The phrases **break me free** and **deliver me** mean similar things. David is using the two phrases together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [deliver me to freedom]

See: Doublet

Psalms 144:7 (#3)

מִמַּיִם רַבִּים

“from many waters”

David is speaking of his troubles as if they were **many waters** that could overwhelm him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from great troubles]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 144:7 (#4)

מִיַּד בְּנֵי נֵכָר

“from the hand of sons of a foreigner”

Here, **the hand** represents the power or control that the foreigners have. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of sons of a foreigner]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:7 (#5)

בְּנֵי נֵכָר

“sons of a foreigner”

David is using the possessive form to describe **sons** or people who are characterized by being a **foreigner**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [foreigners]

See: Possession

Psalms 144:8 (#1)

פִּיהֶם דִּבֶּר־שָׁוְא

“their mouth speaks worthlessness”

Here, **their mouth** represents the foreigners themselves speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they speak worthlessness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:8 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר פִּיהֶם דִּבֶּר־שָׁוְא וִֽימִינָם יְמִין שֶׁקֶר

“who, their mouth speaks worthlessness, and their right hand {is} a right hand of falsehood”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **worthlessness** and **falsehood**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [who, their mouth speaks what is worthless, and their right hand is a right hand of what is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 144:8 (#3)

וִֽימִינָם יְמִין שֶׁקֶר

“and their right hand {is} a right hand of falsehood”

Here, **their right hand** represents the oath that a person swears by raising the right hand. David says their oath is **a right hand of falsehood**, meaning they swear falsely. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they swear false oaths]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:10 (#1)

הַנּוֹתֵן תְּשׁוּעָה

“the one giving salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [who provides salvation] or [who grants deliverance]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 144:10 (#2)

אֶת־דָּוִד עַבְדּוֹ

“David his servant”

David is speaking about himself in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [me, David, your servant] or [me, who serves you]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 144:10 (#3)

מֵחֶרֶב רָעָה

“from the evil sword”

Here, **the evil sword** represents violence and warfare. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from violent warfare]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:11 (#1)

מִיַּד בְּנֵי־נֵכָר

“from the hand of the sons of a foreigner”

Here, **the hand** represents the power or control that the foreigners have. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of the sons of a foreigner]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:11 (#2)

פִּיהֶם דִּבֶּר־שָׁוְא

“their mouth speaks worthlessness”

Here, **their mouth** represents the foreigners themselves in the act of speaking. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they speak worthlessness]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:11 (#3)

דִּבֶּר־שָׁוְא וִֽימִינָם יְמִין שֶׁקֶר

“speaks worthlessness, and their right hand {is} a right hand of falsehood”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **worthlessness** and **falsehood**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [what is worthless and they swear to what is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 144:11 (#4)

וִֽימִינָם יְמִין שֶׁקֶר

“and their right hand {is} a right hand of falsehood”

Here, **their right hand** represents the oath that a person swears by raising the right hand. David says their oath is **a right hand of falsehood**, meaning they swear falsely. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they swear false oaths]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 144:12 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר בָּנֵֽינוּ ׀ כִּנְטִעִים׃

“that our sons {may be} like plants”

The word **that** introduces the purpose for which David has been asking God to rescue him and his people. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows describes the purpose for the previous actions. Alternate translation: [so that our sons may be like plants]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 144:12 (#2)

בָּנֵֽינוּ ׀ כִּנְטִעִים׃ מְגֻדָּלִים בִּנְעוּרֵיהֶם

“our sons {may be} like plants having been enlarged in their youth”

Here David compares **sons** to **plants** that are well-established and growing. This means the sons are strong and healthy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent comparison or express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our sons may be strong and healthy]

See: Simile

Psalms 144:12 (#3)

מְגֻדָּלִים

“having been enlarged”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that grow large]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 144:12 (#4)

בְּנוֹתֵֽינוּ כְּזָוִיֹּת מְחֻטָּבוֹת תַּבְנִית הֵיכָל

“our daughters, like corner pillars carved {in} the pattern of a palace”

Here David compares **daughters** to **corner pillars** that are carved beautifully. This means the daughters are beautiful and strong. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent comparison or express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [our daughters may be beautiful and strong]

See: Simile

Psalms 144:12 (#5)

בְּנוֹתֵ֫ינוּ כְּזָוִיּ֥וֹת מְמֻחֶ֑טֶבֶת תַּבְנִ֖ית הֵיכָֽל

“our daughters, like corner pillars carved {in} the pattern of a palace”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [that our daughters may be like corner pillars carved in the pattern of a palace]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 144:12 (#6)

מְמֻחֶ֑טֶבֶת תַּבְנִ֖ית הֵיכָֽל

“carved {in} the pattern of a palace”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that someone carved to decorate a palace]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 144:13 (#1)

מְפִ֘יקִ֤ים מְזָ֨ון ׀ אֶ֬ל־זַ֗ן

“furnishing from kind to kind”

The implication is that the storehouses are full of many different **kind** of food. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express that explicitly. Alternate translation: [providing many different kinds of food]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 144:13 (#2)

צֹאנֵ֫נוּ מַ֭אֲלִיפוֹת

“may our flocks be thousanding”

In keeping with the conventions of his language, David is using the numbers “thousand” and “myriad” as verbs. He does not mean those exact numbers. He is using them to mean great quantities. Translate these numbers according to the conventions of your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [may our flocks multiply by the thousands and ten thousands in our fields] or [may our flocks multiply in very great numbers in our fields]

See: Numbers

Psalms 144:14 (#1)

אַלּוּפֵ֑ינוּ מְסֻבָּ֣לִים

“May} our oxen {be} burdened”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could state this in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May our oxen carry heavy burdens]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 144:14 (#2)

אֵ֤ין־פֶּ֨רֶץ ׀ וְאֵ֬ין יוֹצֵ֗את וְאֵ֣ין צְעָקָ֑תָה

“no breach and no going out and no cry”

The implication is that there will be **no breach** in the city walls, **no going out** to war, and **no cry** of distress in the streets. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express that explicitly. Alternate translation: [no enemy breaks through our walls, and no one goes out to war, and no one cries of distress]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Psalms 144:15 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵ֣י הָ֭עָם שֶׁכָּ֣כָה לּ֑וֹ אַשְׁרֵ֖י

“The happinesses of the people for whom {it is} thus to it! The happinesses of”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy or blessing. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is the people for whom it is thus to it! How happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 144:15 (#2)

שֶׁכָּ֣כָה לּ֑וֹ

“for whom {it is} thus to it”

Here, **it** refers back to **the people**, which is a singular noun which refers to a group. David is saying the people have the blessings he has just described. If it

would be helpful in your language, you could make the referent explicit. Alternate translation: [who has all of these blessings]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 144:15 (#3)

שֶׁיְּהוָה אֱלֹהָיו

“for whom Yahweh {is} its God”

Here, **its** refers back to **the people**, which is a singular noun which refers to a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the referent explicit or use a plural pronoun. Alternate translation: [whose God is Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms - Chapter 145 Introduction

Psalm 145 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 145 is a psalm of praise. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms. But instead of issuing the usual calls to worship, the psalmist states that he and future generations always will worship Yahweh. He makes this statement repeatedly, interspersing it with reasons to worship.

1. Statement of worship (1–7)
2. Reason to worship: Yahweh is compassionate (8–9)
3. Statement of worship (10–13)
4. Reason to worship; Yahweh provides and help and support (14–20)
5. Statement of worship (21)

Psalms 145:1 (#1)

אֲרוֹמִמְךָ֣ אֱלוֹהַ֣י הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ וַאֲבָרְכָ֖ה שִׁמְךָ֥ לְעוֹלָ֖ם וָעֶֽד

“I will exalt you, my God, the King, and I will bless your name forever and ever”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [I will exalt you, my God, the King, yes, I will bless your name forever and ever]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 145:1 (#2)

שִׁמְךָ֥

“your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 145:1 (#3)

לְעוֹלָ֖ם וָעֶֽד

“forever and ever”

The terms **forever** and **ever** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [continually]

See: Doublet

Psalms 145:2 (#1)

שִׁמְךָ֥

“your name”

David is using the term **name** to represent who God is or to refer to God’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who you are]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 145:2 (#2)

לְעוֹלָ֖ם וָעֶֽד

“forever and ever”

The terms **forever** and **ever** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [for all time]

See: Doublet

Psalms 145:3 (#1)

וּמְהֻלָּ֣ל מְאֹ֑ד

“and being much praised”

The expression **being much praised** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is people. Alternate translation: [people praise him very much]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 145:3 (#2)

וְלִגְדֻלָּתוֹ

“and & of his greatness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **greatness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how great he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:4 (#1)

דּוֹר לְדוֹר יְשַׁבַּח מַעֲשֶׂיךָ וּגְבֻרֹתֶיךָ יַגִּידוּ

“Generation to generation will proclaim your works, and they will declare your mighty acts”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Generation to generation will proclaim your works; indeed, they will declare your mighty acts]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 145:4 (#2)

דּוֹר לְדוֹר יְשַׁבַּח מַעֲשֶׂיךָ וּגְבֻרֹתֶיךָ יַגִּידוּ

“Generation to generation will proclaim your works, and they will declare your mighty acts”

The pronoun **your** refers to Yahweh. The pronoun **they** refers to the generations mentioned in the first part of the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Generation to generation will proclaim your works, Yahweh, and the generations will declare your mighty acts, Yahweh.]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 145:5 (#1)

הֲדַר כְּבוֹד הוֹדֶךָ

“On} the splendor of the glory of your majesty”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **splendor**, **glory**, and **majesty**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how splendidly glorious and majestic you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:5 (#2)

הֲדַר כְּבוֹד הוֹדֶךָ

“On} the splendor of the glory of your majesty”

The terms **splendor**, **glory**, and **majesty** mean similar things. David is using these terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [your very great majesty]

See: Doublet

Psalms 145:6 (#1)

יֹאמֵרוּ

“And they will tell”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people and generations mentioned in 145:4. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [generations of people will tell]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 145:6 (#2)

וגדולתיך

“and & your greatness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **greatness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that you are great]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:7 (#1)

זֵכֶר רַב־טוּבְךָ יַבִּיעוּ וְצִדְקָתְךָ יְרַנֵּנוּ

“They will pour forth the remembrance of the abundance of your goodness, and they will sing joyfully {about} your righteousness”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [They will pour forth the remembrance of the abundance of your goodness; indeed, they will sing joyfully about your righteousness]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 145:7 (#2)

זֵכֶר רַב־טוּבְךָ יַבִּיעוּ וְצִדְקָתְךָ יְרַנֵּנוּ

“They will pour forth the remembrance of the abundance of your goodness, and they will sing joyfully {about} your righteousness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **remembrance**, **abundance**, **goodness**, and **righteousness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [They will remember your abundant good ways, and they will sing joyfully, celebrating your righteous acts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:7 (#3)

יַבִּיעוּ

“They will pour forth”

Here David is speaking as if speech about God’s goodness were a liquid that people **pour forth**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They will eagerly tell their]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 145:8 (#1)

אֶֽרֶךְ אַפַּ֗יִם

“long of nostrils”

David is using **long of nostrils** as a common expression of the culture to mean “slow to become angry.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [slow to anger]

See: Idiom

Psalms 145:8 (#2)

חֶסֶד

“covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [faithfully keeping his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:9 (#1)

וְרַחֲמָ֗יו

“and his compassions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [his compassionate acts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:10 (#1)

יוֹדֻךָ֣ יְ֭הוָה כָּל־מַעֲשֶׂ֑יךָ וַחֲסִידֶ֥יךָ יְבָרְכֻכָֽה

“All your works will thank you, Yahweh, and your faithful will bless you”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [All your works will thank you, Yahweh; indeed, your faithful will bless you]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 145:10 (#2)

יוֹדֻךָ֣ יְ֭הוָה כָּל־מַעֲשֶׂ֑יךָ

“All your works will thank you, Yahweh”

David is speaking of **all your works** as if they were living things that could **thank** God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Everything you have made shows how good you are, Yahweh]

See: Personification

Psalms 145:10 (#3)

וַחֲסִידֶ֥יךָ

“and your faithful”

David is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [your faithful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 145:11 (#1)

כְּבֹ֣וד מַלְכוּתְךָ֣ יֹאמֵ֑רוּ וּגְבוּרָתְךָ֥ יְדַבֵּֽרוּ

“They will tell the glory of your kingdom, and they will speak {of} your power”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [They will tell the glory of your kingdom; yes, they will speak of your power]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 145:11 (#2)

כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתְךָ יֹאמֵרוּ וּגְבוּרָתְךָ יְדַבֵּרוּ

“They will tell the glory of your kingdom, and they will speak {of} your power”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory**, **kingdom**, and **power**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how gloriously you rule, and they will speak of how powerful you are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:12 (#1)

לְהוֹדִיעַ ׀ לִבְנֵי הָאָדָם גְּבוּרֹתָיו וּכְבוֹד הֲדַר מַלְכוּתוֹ

“to make known to the sons of man his mighty acts and the glory of the splendor of his kingdom”

Here, **to make known** marks the following phrases as the goal or purpose of telling about God’s kingdom and power in the previous verse. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [so that the sons of man will know his mighty acts and the glory of the splendor of his kingdom]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 145:12 (#2)

לִבְנֵי הָאָדָם

“to the sons of man”

The psalmist is using **sons of man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “human beings.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to people everywhere]

See: Idiom

Psalms 145:12 (#3)

וּכְבוֹד הֲדַר מַלְכוּתוֹ

“and the glory of the splendor of his kingdom”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory**, **splendor**, and **kingdom**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [how gloriously and splendidly he rules]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:12 (#4)

וּכְבוֹד הֲדַר

“and the glory of the splendor of”

The terms **glory** and **splendor** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [the glorious splendor]

See: Doublet

Psalms 145:12 (#5)

גְּבוּרֹתָיו וּכְבוֹד הֲדַר מַלְכוּתוֹ

“his mighty acts and the glory of the splendor of his kingdom”

David has been addressing Yahweh directly in the second person, saying **your kingdom** and **your power** in the previous verse, but here he speaks of Yahweh in the third person, saying **his mighty acts** and **his kingdom**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the second person to be consistent. Alternate translation: [your mighty acts and the glory of the splendor of your kingdom]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Psalms 145:13 (#1)

מַלְכוּתְךָ מַלְכוּת כָּל־עֹלָמִים וּמֶמְשַׁלְתְּךָ בְּכָל־דּוֹר וָדוֹר

“Your kingdom {is} a kingdom of all of eternities, and your dominion {is} in every generation and generation”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Your kingdom is a kingdom of all of eternities; indeed, your dominion is in every generation and generation]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 145:13 (#2)

דּוֹר וָדוֹר

“generation and generation”

The psalmist is repeating the word **generation** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it

conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [succeeding generation]

See: Reduplication

Psalms 145:13 (#3)

מַלְכוּתְךָ מַלְכוּת כָּל־עֹלָמִים וּמֶמְשַׁלְתְּךָ בְּכָל־דֹּר וָדֹר

“Your kingdom {is} a kingdom of all of eternities, and your dominion {is} in every generation and generation”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **kingdom** and **dominion**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [You rule as king over everything for all of eternities, and you reign supremely over every generation and generation]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:14 (#1)

הַכְּפוּפִים

“the ones being bowed down”

Here David is speaking as if those of God’s people who are afflicted were **the ones being bowed down**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones experiencing hardships]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 145:15 (#1)

עֵינֵי־כֹל

“The eyes of all”

Here, **the eyes of all** represents all creatures looking to God. David is using one part of the body to represent the whole creature’s action of waiting expectantly. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All created beings]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 145:15 (#2)

וְאַתָּה נוֹתֵן

“and you, you are giving”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you are giving** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is Yahweh himself who provides food. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you yourself are giving]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 145:16 (#1)

פּוֹתֵחַ אֶת־יָדֶךָ

“opening your hand”

David is using **opening your hand** as a common expression of the culture to mean “giving generously.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [giving generously]

See: Idiom

Psalms 145:16 (#2)

רָצוֹן

“with respect to} desire”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desire**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with what they desire]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:18 (#1)

בֶּאֱמֶת

“in truth”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [truthfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:19 (#1)

רְצוֹן־יְרֵאָיו

“the desire of the ones fearing him”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desire**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what the ones fearing him desire]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 145:19 (#2)

וְאֶת־שַׁוְעָתָם יִשְׁמַע וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם

“and he hears their cry, and he saves them”

The pronouns **their** and **them** refer to the ones who fear Yahweh, mentioned earlier in the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [he hears the cry of those who fear him, and he saves those who fear him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 145:20 (#1)

וְאֵת כָּל־הָרְשָׁעִים יַשְׁמִיד

“but he destroys all of the wicked”

David is drawing a contrast between how Yahweh treats those who love him and how he treats the wicked. Use a connector in your language that indicates this contrast. Alternate translation: [however, he destroys all of the wicked]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 145:20 (#2)

הָרְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

David is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 145:21 (#1)

פִּי

“My mouth”

Here, **my mouth** represents David himself in the act of speaking. David is using one part of the body to represent his whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I myself]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 145:21 (#2)

כָּל־בָּשָׂר

“all flesh”

Here, **all flesh** represents all living people and creatures. David is using one aspect of the body to represent all living beings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all living creatures]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 145:21 (#3)

שֵׁשֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

“the name of his holiness”

David is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is or to refer to his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [him, the one who is holy,]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 145:21 (#4)

לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד

“forever and ever”

The terms **forever** and **ever** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [for all time]

See: Doublet

Psalms 145:21 (#5)

תְּהִלַּת יְהוָה יְדַבֶּר־פִּי וִיבָרֵךְ כָּל־בָּשָׂר שֵׁשֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ

“My mouth will speak the praise of Yahweh, and all flesh will bless the name of his holiness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **praise** and **holiness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [My mouth will speak words that praise Yahweh, and all flesh will bless the name of the one who is holy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms - Chapter 146 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 146 is a psalm of praise. The psalmist begins by calling himself to worship Yahweh, and he then gives reasons others to worship him. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship (1–2)
2. Reason to worship: Yahweh is eternal and powerful (3–6)

3. Reason to worship: Yahweh helps people in need and in trouble (7–9)
4. Reason to worship: Yahweh reigns forever (10)

Psalms 146:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 146:1 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 146:1 (#3)

הַלְלִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת־יְהוָה

“Praise Yahweh, my soul”

The psalmist is speaking to his own soul, which cannot hear him. He is doing this to express how strongly he feels about praising Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about himself. Alternate translation: [I will praise Yahweh with all of my being]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 146:1 (#4)

הַלְלִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת־יְהוָה

“Praise Yahweh, my soul”

The psalmist is using one part of himself, his **soul**, to mean all of himself in the act of praising. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I myself will praise Yahweh]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 146:2 (#1)

אֲהַלְלָה יְהוָה בְּחַיָּי אֲזַמְּרָה לֵאלֹהַי בְּעוֹדִי

“Let me praise Yahweh in my life; let me make music to my God while I yet {am”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Let me praise Yahweh my God with music for as long as I live]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 146:3 (#1)

בְּבֶן־אָדָם

“in the son of man”

The psalmist is using the phrase **the son of man** as a common expression of the culture to mean a human being. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in any human being]

See: Idiom

Psalms 146:3 (#2)

תְּשׁוּעָה

“salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [ability to save]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 146:4 (#1)

תֵּצֵא רוּחוֹ יָשֹׁב לְאַדְמָתוֹ

“His breath goes out, he returns to his ground”

The pronouns **His** and **he** refer to the mortal person described in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation:

[That person's breath goes out, that person returns to his ground]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 146:4 (#2)

תֵּצֵא רוּחוֹ

"His breath goes out"

The psalmist is referring to dying in a polite way by using the phrase **His breath goes out**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [He dies]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 146:4 (#3)

יָשֻׁב לְאַדְמָתוֹ

"he returns to his ground"

The psalmist is referring to the burial of a dead body in a polite way by using the phrase **he returns to his ground**. This alludes to the account in Genesis where God formed man from the ground. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [his body decays and becomes dust again]

See: Euphemism

Psalms 146:4 (#4)

אָבְדוּ עֶשְׁתֹּנֹתָיו

"his thoughts perish"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thoughts**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what he was planning comes to nothing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 146:5 (#1)

אַשְׁרֵי

"The happinesses of"

The psalmist is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling of joy. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what the psalmist was feeling. Alternate translation: [Oh, how happy is]

See: Exclamations

Psalms 146:5 (#2)

שֶׁשָּׁאֵל יַעֲקֹב בְּעֶזְרֹו

"the one} who {has} the God of Jacob for his help"

The psalmist is not using the possessive form **the God of Jacob** to indicate that Jacob possesses or controls God. Rather the psalmist is using these words to indicate that God is the one whom Jacob worshiped. Alternate translation: [the one who has the God whom Jacob worshiped for his help]

See: Possession

Psalms 146:5 (#3)

בְּעֶזְרֹו שִׂשְׂבְרֹו עַל־יְהוָה אֱלֹהָיו

"for his help; his hope {is} in Yahweh his God"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **help** and **hope**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [to help him; he confidently waits for Yahweh his God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 146:6 (#1)

שֶׁעָשָׂה שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ אֶת־הַיָּם וְאֶת־כָּל־אֲשֶׁר־בָּם

"the heavens and the earth, the sea and all that {is} in them"

The psalmist is referring to all of creation by naming its major components, **the heavens** and **the earth**, and then adding **the sea and all that is in them**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everything that exists]

See: Merism

Psalms 146:6 (#2)

אֱמֶת

"faithfulness"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [faithful to his promises]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 146:7 (#1)

עֹשֶׂה מִשְׁפָּט

"doing justice"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [judging fairly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 146:7 (#2)

לָעֲשׁוּקִֽים

“for the oppressed”

The psalmist is using the adjective **oppressed** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [for those whom others oppress]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 146:7 (#3)

לֶחֶם

“bread”

The psalmist is using one kind of food, **bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [nourishment]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 146:7 (#4)

לָרְעֵבִֽים

“to the hungry”

The psalmist is using the adjective **hungry** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [to hungry people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 146:8 (#1)

פֹּקֵחַ עִוְרִֽים

“is opening the blind”

Here, **opening** represents giving sight to. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [giving sight to the blind]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 146:8 (#2)

פֹּקֵחַ עִוְרִֽים

“is opening the blind”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is opening the eyes of the blind]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 146:8 (#3)

עִוְרִֽים

“blind”

The psalmist is using the adjective **blind** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [blind people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 146:8 (#4)

זֹקֵף כְּפוּפִֽים

“is raising up the one bowed down”

The psalmist is speaking of those who are discouraged or oppressed as if they were people who were physically **bowed down**. If this image does not communicate well in your language, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is lifting up those who are discouraged]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 146:8 (#5)

צַדִּיקִֽים

“righteous”

The psalmist is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 146:9 (#1)

וְדֶ֣רֶךְ רְשָׁעִ֣ים יְעַוֵּֽת

“but the way of the wicked, he overturns”

The word **but** introduces a contrast between how Yahweh treats the vulnerable and how he treats the wicked. Yahweh protects the sojourners, the orphan,

and the widow, **but** he overturns the way of the wicked. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this contrast. Alternate translation: [however, the way of the wicked, he overturns]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Psalms 146:9 (#2)

וְדֶ֣רֶךְ רְשָׁעִ֑ים

“but the way of the wicked”

The psalmist is speaking of how a person lives and behaves as if it were a **way** or path that the person walks on. If this image does not communicate well in your language, you could express this as a comparison or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but the plans of the wicked]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 146:9 (#3)

רְשָׁעִ֑ים

“the wicked”

The psalmist is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 146:10 (#1)

אֱלֹהַ֥יִךְ צִיּ֗וֹן לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“your God, Zion, to generation and generation”

The psalmist is leaving out the verb that would naturally appear in this phrase. The reader can supply it from the first part of the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could supply this verb explicitly. Alternate translation: [your God, Zion, reigns to generation and generation]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 146:10 (#2)

אֱלֹהַ֥יִךְ צִיּ֗וֹן

“your God, Zion”

The psalmist is speaking to the city of Zion, which cannot hear him. He is doing this to express how strongly he feels about Yahweh’s eternal reign. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Zion. Alternate translation: [the God of Zion]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 146:10 (#3)

לְדֹ֣ר וָדֹ֑ר

“to generation and generation”

The psalmist is using the phrase **to generation and generation** as a common expression of the culture to mean “forever”. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for all time]

See: Idiom

Psalms 146:10 (#4)

הַלְלוּ־יָ֝הּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 146:10 (#5)

יָ֝הּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 147 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 147 is a psalm of praise. It presents alternating calls to worship and reasons to worship. These reasons include God’s greatness in creating the world, the way he protects his people and provides for them, and the way he gave his people his laws. See the discussion

of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship Yahweh (1a)
2. Reason to worship Yahweh (1b–6)
3. Call to worship Yahweh (7)
4. Reason to worship Yahweh (8–11)
5. Call to worship Yahweh (12)
6. Reason to worship Yahweh (13–20)

Psalms 147:1 (#1)

הַֽלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 147:1 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 147:1 (#3)

כִּי־טֹ֣וב זַמְּרָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵ֑ינוּ

“For {it is} good to make music {to} our God”

The psalmist uses **For** to introduce the reason for the preceding exhortation. Use a connector that is natural in your language for introducing a reason. Alternate translation: [Because it is good to make music to our God]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 147:1 (#4)

תְּהִלָּ֗ה

“praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [praising him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:1 (#5)

נָ֝עִ֗ים נָאוָ֥ה

“is} pleasant and suitable”

The terms **pleasant** and **suitable** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [very pleasant]

See: Doublet

Psalms 147:2 (#1)

נִדְחֵ֖י יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“the scattered of Israel”

The expression **the scattered of Israel** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is their enemies. Alternate translation: [the Israelites whom enemies scattered]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 147:3 (#1)

הָרֹפֵ֣א לִשְׁבְר֣וֵי לֵ֑ב וּמְחַבֵּ֖שׁ לְעַצְּבוֹתָֽם

“healing the broken of heart and binding up their wounds”

The psalmist is speaking of **healing** emotional distress and **binding up their wounds** as if people’s sadness were physical injuries. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [comforting those who are very sad and relieving their pain]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 147:3 (#2)

לִשְׁבְר֣וֵי לֵ֑ב

“the broken of heart”

The psalmist is using **the broken of heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean “people who have suffered emotional wounds.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language

that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who are deeply grieving]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 147:5 (#1)

גָּדוֹל אֲדוֹנֵינוּ

“Great is our Lord”

The psalmist places the adjective **Great** before the subject for emphasis. If it would be more natural in your language, you could use standard word order. Alternate translation: [Yahweh our Lord is great]

See: Information Structure

Psalms 147:5 (#2)

וְרַב־כֹּחַ

“and abundant of power”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **power**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [abundantly powerful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:5 (#3)

לִתְבוּנָתוֹ אֵין מִסְפָּר

“his understanding {is} without number”

The psalmist is using an extreme statement to emphasize how great God’s understanding is. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [greater than anyone can measure] or [beyond anyone’s ability to assess]

See: Hyperbole

Psalms 147:5 (#4)

לִתְבוּנָתוֹ

“his understanding”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **understanding**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what he understands] or [how much he comprehends]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:6 (#1)

עֲנָוִים

“the poor”

The psalmist uses the adjective **poor** as a noun to describe a group of people. Your language may use adjectives similarly. If not, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are humble] or [people who are poor]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 147:6 (#2)

מַשְׁפִּיל רְשָׁעִים עֲדֵי־אָרֶץ

“bringing down the wicked to the ground”

The psalmist is speaking of God humiliating **the wicked** as if he were physically **bringing** them **down to the ground**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [humbling the wicked] or [making the wicked fail]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 147:6 (#3)

רְשָׁעִים

“the wicked”

The psalmist uses the adjective **wicked** as a noun to describe a group of people. Your language may use adjectives similarly. If not, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are wicked] or [people who do wicked things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 147:7 (#1)

עֱנּוּ לַיהוָה בְּתוֹדָה זַמְּרוּ לֵאלֹהֵינוּ בְכִנּוֹר

“Sing to Yahweh with thanksgiving; make music to our God with the harp”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Make music to Yahweh our God with grateful singing and the harp]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 147:7 (#2)

עֱנּוּ לַיהוָה בְּתוֹדָה

“Sing to Yahweh with thanksgiving”

The psalmist uses the imperative form here as an exhortation to worship. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this exhortation in a way

that is natural for your language. Alternate translation: [Let us sing to Yahweh and give him thanks]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 147:7 (#3)

בְּתוֹדָה

“with thanksgiving”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **thanksgiving**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [giving thanks] or [thankfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:9 (#1)

לִבְנֵי עֹרֵב

“to the sons of the raven”

The expression **the sons of the raven** is an idiom that means young ravens. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use an idiom from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the young ravens]

See: Idiom

Psalms 147:9 (#2)

נוֹתֵן לִבְהֵמָה לַחְמָהּ לִבְנֵי עֹרֵב אֲשֶׁר יִקְרָאוּ

“He gives its food to the beast, to the sons of the raven when they call”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He gives its food to the beast, and he gives food to the sons of the raven when they call]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 147:10 (#1)

לֹא בִגְבוּרַת הַסּוּס יֶחְפָּץ לֹא־בְשׁוֹקֵי הָאִישׁ יִרְצֶה

“He does not delight in the strength of a horse; he does not take pleasure {in} the legs of a man”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [He does not value the strength of a horse or the physical ability of a person]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 147:10 (#2)

בִּגְבוּרַת הַסּוּס

“in the strength of a horse”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in how strong a horse is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:10 (#3)

בְּשׁוֹקֵי הָאִישׁ

“in} the legs of a man”

Although the term **man** is masculine, the psalmist is using it in a generic sense to refer to any person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a phrase that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [the legs of a person]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Psalms 147:10 (#4)

בְּשׁוֹקֵי הָאִישׁ

“in} the legs of a man”

The psalmist is using one part of the body, **the legs**, to represent physical ability in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a person’s physical ability] or [how fast a person can run]

See: Synecdoche

Psalms 147:11 (#1)

לְחַסְדּוֹ

“for his covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for him to keep his covenant promises] or [for him to show them kindness because of his covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:12 (#1)

שַׁבְּחִי יְרוּשָׁלַ͏ִם אֶת־יְהוָה הַלְלִי אֱלֹהַיִךְ צִיּוֹן

“Extol Yahweh, Jerusalem; praise your God, Zion”

The psalmist uses the imperative form here as an exhortation to worship. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this exhortation in a way that is natural for your language. Alternate translation: [You people of Jerusalem should praise Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 147:12 (#2)

שַׁבְּחִ֥י יְרוּשָׁלַ֑͏ִם אֶת־יְהוָ֥ה הַלְלִ֖י אֱלֹהַ֣יִךְ צִיּֽוֹן

“Extol Yahweh, Jerusalem; praise your God, Zion”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Praise Yahweh, you people of Jerusalem]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 147:12 (#3)

יְרוּשָׁלַ֑͏ִם אֶת־יְהוָ֥ה הַלְלִ֖י אֱלֹהַ֣יִךְ צִיּֽוֹן

“Yahweh, Jerusalem; praise your God, Zion”

The psalmist is speaking to the city of **Jerusalem**, also called **Zion**, as if it could hear, but he is really addressing the people of that city. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, people of Jerusalem; praise your God, people of Zion]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 147:13 (#1)

כִּֽי־חִזַּ֥ק בְּרִיחֵ֑י שִׁעָרָ֣יִךְ

“For he strengthens the bars of your gates”

The psalmist uses **For** to introduce the reason for the preceding exhortation. Use a connector that is natural in your language for introducing a reason. Alternate translation: [Because he strengthens the bars of your gates]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 147:14 (#1)

הַשָּׂ֣ם־גְּבוּלֵ֑ךְ שָׁלֹ֥ום

“The one putting peace {at} your borders”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The one making your borders safe and secure]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:14 (#2)

חֵ֖לֶב חִטָּ֣ים

“with} the fat of wheat”

The psalmist is speaking of the best quality of **wheat** as if it were **the fat** part. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with the finest wheat] or [with the best wheat]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 147:15 (#1)

עַד־מְהֵרָ֥ה יָרֻ֗וץ דְּבָרֹֽו

“his word runs to swiftness”

The psalmist speaks of God’s **word** as if it were a person who could **run**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his word goes out very quickly] or [what he commands happens immediately]

See: Personification

Psalms 147:15 (#2)

עַד־מְהֵרָ֥ה יָרֻ֗וץ

“runs to swiftness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **swiftness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [goes out very quickly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:16 (#1)

שֶׁ֖לֶג כַּצָּ֣מֶר

“snow like wool”

The psalmist compares **snow** to **wool** to emphasize how the snow covers the ground in a white, soft layer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the point of comparison explicit. Alternate translation: [snow that is white like wool]

See: Simile

Psalms 147:16 (#2)

כְּכָפֹ֥ור כָּאֵ֖פֶר

“frost like ashes”

The psalmist compares **frost** to **ashes** to emphasize how the frost is spread across the ground lightly and in fine particles. If it would be helpful in your

language, you could make the point of comparison explicit. Alternate translation: [frost like gray ashes]

See: Simile

Psalms 147:17 (#1)

קַרְחֹו כְּפִתִּתִֽים

“his hail like crumbs”

The psalmist compares **hail** to **crumbs** to emphasize that the hailstones are small pieces. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make the point of comparison explicit. Alternate translation: [his hailstones like small crumbs]

See: Simile

Psalms 147:17 (#2)

לִפְנֵ֣י קָרָ֣תֹו מִ֭י יַעֲמֹֽד

“who can stand to the face of his cold”

The psalmist uses a rhetorical question to emphasize that no one can endure God’s cold. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this question as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [no one can stand in such cold!] or [no one can endure when he makes it so cold.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Psalms 147:17 (#3)

לִפְנֵ֣י קָרָ֣תֹו

“to the face of his cold”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **cold**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in his freezing weather] or [when he makes it freeze]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:17 (#4)

לִפְנֵ֣י קָרָ֣תֹו

“to the face of his cold”

Here, **the face of** represents the presence or force of something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when he sends his cold] or [outside in his freezing cold]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 147:18 (#1)

יִשְׁלַ֣ח דְּבָר֣וֹ וְיַמְסֵ֑ם

“He sends his word, and he makes them melt”

The psalmist is speaking of God’s **word** as if it were a messenger that God could **send**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He gives a command, and he makes them melt]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 147:18 (#2)

רוּחֹ֥ו

“his wind”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe the **wind** that comes from God. If your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express the idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wind he sends]

See: Possession

Psalms 147:19 (#1)

חֻקָּ֣יו וּמִשְׁפָּטָ֑יו

“his statutes and his judgments”

The terms **statutes** and **judgments** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [all his laws]

See: Doublet

Psalms 147:19 (#2)

מַגִּ֣יד דברו לְיַעֲקֹ֣ב חֻקָּ֣יו וּמִשְׁפָּטָ֑יו לְיִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“He declared his word to Jacob, his statutes and his judgments to Israel”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. A resulting parallelism is modeled in the UST. Alternate translation: [He declared his word to Jacob; indeed, he declared his statutes and judgments to Israel]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 147:19 (#3)

חֻקָּ֣יו

“his statutes”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **statutes**, you could express the same idea in

another way. Alternate translation: [the rules he has set]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:19 (#4)

וּמִשְׁפָּטָ֑יו

“and his judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the decisions he has judged]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 147:19 (#5)

לְיַעֲקֹ֗ב & לְיִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“to Jacob & to Israel”

Here, **Jacob** and **Israel** represent the descendants of Jacob, who was also called Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to Jacob’s descendants] or [to the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 147:20 (#1)

הַֽלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 147:20 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 148 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 148 is a psalm of praise. It presents alternating calls to worship and reasons to worship. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship Yahweh from the heavens (1–4)
2. Reason to worship Yahweh from the heavens (5–6)
3. Call to worship Yahweh from the earth (7–12)
4. Reason to worship Yahweh from the earth (13–14)

Psalms 148:1 (#1)

הַֽלְלוּ אֶת־יְהוָה֮ מִן־הַשָּׁמַ֪יִם הַֽלְלוּ֥הוּ בַּמְּרוֹמִֽים

“Praise Yahweh from the heavens; praise him in the heights”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Praise Yahweh, all of you who are in the heavens above]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 148:1 (#2)

הַֽלְלוּ יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 148:1 (#3)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 148:2 (#1)

הַלְלוּהוּ כָל־מַלְאָכָיו הַלְלוּהוּ כָּל־צְבָאו

“Praise him, all of his angels; praise him, all of his armies”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Praise him, all of his heavenly beings]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 148:3 (#1)

הַלְלוּהוּ שֶׁמֶשׁ וְיָרֵחַ

“Praise him, sun and moon”

The psalmist is speaking to the **sun and moon** as if they could hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about all of creation praising Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about the sun and moon. Alternate translation: [Let the sun and moon praise him]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 148:3 (#2)

כּוֹכְבֵי אוֹר

“the stars of light”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **stars** that are characterized by **light**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the glowing stars]

See: Possession

Psalms 148:3 (#3)

הַלְלוּהוּ שֶׁמֶשׁ וְיָרֵחַ הַלְלוּהוּ כָּל־כּוֹכְבֵי אוֹר

“Praise him, sun and moon; praise him, all of the stars of light”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Praise him, all you lights in the sky]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 148:4 (#1)

שְׁמֵי הַשָּׁמָיִם וְהַמַּיִם אֲשֶׁר ׀ מֵעַל הַשָּׁמָיִם

“heavens of the heavens, and the waters that {are} above the heavens”

The psalmist is speaking to the **heavens** and the **waters** as if they could hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about all of creation praising Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about these things. Alternate translation: [for the highest heavens and the waters above the heavens should praise him]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 148:4 (#2)

שְׁמֵי הַשָּׁמָיִם

“heavens of the heavens”

The psalmist is using **heavens of the heavens** as a common expression in the original language to mean “the highest heavens.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the most exalted heavens]

See: Idiom

Psalms 148:5 (#1)

יְהַלְלוּ אֶת־שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה

“Let them praise the name of Yahweh”

The psalmist is saying what he wants all the things he has just mentioned to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [They should praise the name of Yahweh]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 148:5 (#2)

אֶת־שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה

“the name of Yahweh”

The psalmist is using the term **name** to represent who Yahweh is, referring to his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh himself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 148:5 (#3)

כִּֽי־הֽוּא֥ צִוָּ֗ה וְנִבְרָֽאוּ

“for he, he commanded, and they were created”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because he, he commanded, and they were created]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 148:5 (#4)

הֽוּא֥ צִוָּ֗ה

“he, he commanded”

The psalmist is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **commanded** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh alone is the one who created all things. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [he himself commanded]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 148:5 (#5)

וְנִבְרָֽאוּ

“and they were created”

The expression **they were created** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [and he caused them to exist]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 148:6 (#1)

וַיַּעֲמִידֵ֣ם לָעַ֣ד לְעוֹלָ֑ם חָ֥ק־נָ֝תַ֗ן וְלֹ֣א יַעֲבֽוֹר

“And he established them forever and ever; he gave a decree, and it will not pass away”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [And he established them permanently by an unchanging decree]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 148:6 (#2)

לָעַ֣ד לְעוֹלָ֑ם

“forever and ever”

The terms **forever** and **ever** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to last permanently]

See: Doublet

Psalms 148:7 (#1)

תַּנִּינִ֥ים וְכָל־תְּהֹמֽוֹת

“sea creatures and all depths”

The psalmist is speaking to **sea creatures** and **all depths** as if they could hear him. He is doing this here and in following verses to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about all of creation praising Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about these things. Alternate translation: [creatures of the sea and all that lives below the waters]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 148:8 (#1)

עֹשָׂ֖ה דְּבָר֣וֹ

“doing his word”

The psalmist is speaking of the **wind of tempest** as if it were a living thing that could obey commands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that goes where he sends it]

See: Personification

Psalms 148:8 (#2)

עֹשָׂ֖ה דְּבָר֣וֹ

“doing his word”

The pronoun **his** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [doing Yahweh’s word]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Psalms 148:8 (#3)

רוּחַ סְעָרָה

“wind of tempest”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **wind** that is characterized by **tempest** or violence. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [violent wind]

See: Possession

Psalms 148:9 (#1)

הֶהָרִים וְכָל־גְּבָעוֹת עֵץ פְּרִי וְכָל־אֲרָזִים

“mountains and all hills, tree of fruit and all cedars”

Again, the psalmist is speaking inanimate objects, now to **mountains and all hills, tree of fruit and all cedars**, as if they could hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about all of creation praising Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about them. Alternate translation: [let the mountains and all of the hills, the fruit trees and all the cedars praise Yahweh]

See: Apostrophe

Psalms 148:9 (#2)

עֵץ פְּרִי

“tree of fruit”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **tree** that is characterized by bearing **fruit**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [fruit-bearing trees]

See: Possession

Psalms 148:10 (#1)

רֶמֶשׂ וְצִפּוֹר כָּנָף

“the creeper and the bird of wing”

The psalmist is referring to all kinds of small creatures by naming two extremes, **the creeper** on the ground and **bird of wing** in the sky. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [every kind of small creature]

See: Merism

Psalms 148:10 (#2)

וְצִפּוֹר כָּנָף

“and the bird of wing”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe a **bird** that is characterized by having wings. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the bird with wings]

See: Possession

Psalms 148:11 (#1)

מַלְכֵי־אֶרֶץ וְכָל־לְאֻמִּים שָׂרִים וְכָל־שֹׁפְטֵי אָרֶץ

“kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all judges of the earth”

The psalmist is referring to all of human society by naming two major components, **kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all judges of the earth** who represent both rulers and those who are ruled. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [everyone on earth, both rulers and ordinary people]

See: Merism

Psalms 148:12 (#1)

בַּחוּרִים וְגַם־בְּתוּלוֹת

“young men and also young women”

The psalmist is referring to all young people by naming two major components, **young men** and **young women**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all the young people]

See: Merism

Psalms 148:12 (#2)

זְקֵנִים עִם־נְעָרִים

“old men with youths”

The psalmist is referring to people of every age by naming two extremes, **old men** and **youths**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [people of every age]

See: Merism

Psalms 148:13 (#1)

כִּי־נִשְׂגָּב שְׁמוֹ לְבַדּוֹ

“for his name alone is exalted”

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because his name alone is exalted]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 148:13 (#2)

נִשְׂגָּב שְׁמוֹ לְבַדּוֹ

“his name alone is exalted”

The expression **his name alone is exalted** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [his name alone surpasses all others]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 148:13 (#3)

הוֹדוֹ עַל־אֶרֶץ וְשָׁמָיִם

“his splendor {is} over the earth and the heavens”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the abstract noun **splendor** with an adjective. Alternate translation: [he is splendid over the earth and the heavens]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 148:13 (#4)

אֶת־שֵׁשֵׁם יְהוָה כִּי־נִשְׂגָּב שְׁמוֹ לְבַדּוֹ

“the name of Yahweh, for his name alone is exalted”

Here the psalmist is using the term **name** twice to represent who Yahweh is and to refer to his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh himself; for he alone is high above all]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 148:13 (#5)

אֶרֶץ וְשָׁמָיִם

“the earth and the heavens”

The psalmist is referring to all of creation by naming two major components, **earth** and **heavens**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all of creation]

See: Merism

Psalms 148:14 (#1)

וַיָּ֤רֶם קֶ֨רֶן ׀ לְעַמּ֗וֹ

“And he has raised up a horn for his people”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh had given his people a **horn**, which is an animal’s horn that represents strength and power. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and he has given strength to his people]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 148:14 (#2)

תְּהִלָּ֥ה לְכָל־חֲסִידָ֑יו

“praise for all of his faithful”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [honoring his faithful people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 148:14 (#3)

חֲסִידָ֑יו

“his faithful”

The psalmist is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [his faithful people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 148:14 (#4)

לִבְנֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“for the sons of Israel”

The psalmist is using **the sons of Israel** as a common expression in the original language to mean “the people of Israel” or “the descendants of Israel.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could

state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Idiom

Psalms 148:14 (#5)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 148:14 (#6)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 149 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 149 is a psalm of praise. It first presents a call to worship and a reason for worship. It then presents a call to worship and a purpose for worship, specifically, to help fight his enemies. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship Yahweh (1–3)
2. Reason to worship Yahweh (4)
3. Call to worship Yahweh (5–6a)
4. Purpose for worshiping Yahweh (6b–9)

Psalms 149:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 149:1 (#2)

יָהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name Yahweh. You could use the full form of the name in your translation, as the UST does, or you could represent the shortened form in the way that is most natural in your language.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 149:1 (#3)

שִׁ֭ירוּ לַיהוָ֣ה שִׁ֣יר חָדָ֑שׁ

“Sing to Yahweh a new song”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please sing to Yahweh a new song]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Psalms 149:1 (#4)

תְּהִלָּתוֹ֙ בִּקְהַ֣ל חֲסִידִֽים

“his praise in the assembly of the faithful”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [sing his praise in the assembly of the faithful]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 149:1 (#5)

תְּהִלָּתוֹ

“his praise”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **praise**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [songs praising him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 149:1 (#6)

חֲסִידִים

“the faithful”

The psalmist is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the faithful ones]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 149:2 (#1)

יִשְׂמַח יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּעֹשָׂיו בְּנֵי־צִיּוֹן יָגִילוּ בְמַלְכָּם

“Let Israel rejoice in his Maker; let the sons of Zion be glad in their king”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Let all of God’s people rejoice greatly in their Maker and King]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 149:2 (#2)

יִשְׂמַח יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּעֹשָׂיו בְּנֵי־צִיּוֹן יָגִילוּ בְמַלְכָּם

“Let Israel rejoice in his Maker; let the sons of Zion be glad in their king”

The psalmist is saying what he wants Israel and the sons of Zion to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [Israel should rejoice in his Maker; the sons of Zion should be glad in their King]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 149:2 (#3)

בְּנֵי־צִיּוֹן

“the sons of Zion”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if the people of Zion were actually the **sons** of Zion. He means the people who live in Zion. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Zion]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 149:2 (#4)

בְּמַלְכָּם

“in their king”

Here the psalmist is speaking of God as if he were a **king** who rules over his people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who rules over them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 149:3 (#1)

יְהַלְלוּ שְׁמוֹ בְמָחוֹל בְּתֹף וְכִנּוֹר יְזַמְּרוּ־לוֹ

“Let them praise his name in the dance; let them make music to him with the tambourine and the harp”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Let them joyfully praise his name with dancing and music from tambourines and harps]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 149:3 (#2)

שְׁמוֹ

“his name”

Here, **name** represents who Yahweh is and his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh himself]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 149:4 (#1)

כִּי־רוֹצֶה יְהוָה בְּעַמּוֹ

“For Yahweh is taking pleasure in his people”

Here, **For** introduces the reason why the psalmist has been calling on God’s people to praise him and rejoice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a word or phrase that introduces a reason. Alternate translation: [Because Yahweh is pleased with his people]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Psalms 149:4 (#2)

יְפָאֵר עֲנָוִים בִּישׁוּעָה

“he beautifies the humble with salvation”

Here the psalmist is speaking as if Yahweh **beautifies** the humble with salvation the way one adorns people with fine clothing. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he honors the humble by saving them]

See: Metaphor

Psalms 149:4 (#3)

עֲנָוִים

“the humble”

The psalmist is using the adjective **humble** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [humble people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 149:4 (#4)

בִּישׁוּעָה

“with salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by saving them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 149:5 (#1)

יַעְלְזוּ חֲסִידִים בְּכָבוֹד יְרַנְּנוּ עַל־מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם

“Let the faithful exult in glory; let them sing joyfully on their beds”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Let the faithful celebrate joyfully, singing even on their beds]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 149:5 (#2)

חֲסִידִים

“the faithful”

The psalmist is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [those who are faithful]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 149:5 (#3)

בְּכָבוֹד

“in glory”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because God has glorified them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 149:6 (#1)

רוֹמְמוֹת אֵל בִּגְרוֹנָם

“Let} the exaltations of God {be} in their throat”

Here, **throat** represents the voice and the act of singing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the exaltations of God be on their lips]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 149:6 (#2)

רוֹמְמוֹת אֵל

“Let} the exaltations of God”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **exaltations**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [words exalting God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 149:6 (#3)

וְחֶרֶב פִּיפִיּוֹת

“and a sword of mouths”

The psalmist is using **a sword of mouths** as a common expression of the culture to mean a sword with two sharp edges. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a double-edged sword]

See: Idiom

Psalms 149:6 (#4)

בְּיָדָם

“in their hand”

Here, **hand** represents possession or the act of holding something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in their grasp]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 149:7 (#1)

נָקָמָה בַּגּוֹיִם תּוֹכֵחוֹת בַּל־אֻמִּים

“vengeance on the nations, punishments on the peoples”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [deserved punishment on all the foreign nations]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 149:7 (#2)

לַעֲשׂוֹת נָקָמָה בַּגּוֹיִם

“to execute vengeance on the nations”

Here, **to execute vengeance on the nations** marks the purpose of the activities described in the previous verses. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order to execute vengeance on the nations]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Psalms 149:7 (#3)

תּוֹכֵחוֹת בַּל־אֻמִּים

“punishments on the peoples”

The psalmist is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [to execute punishments on the peoples]

See: Ellipsis

Psalms 149:7 (#4)

נָקָמָה בַּגּוֹיִם תּוֹכֵחוֹת

“vengeance on the nations, punishments”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **vengeance** and **punishments**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [to avenge on the nations, to punish the peoples]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 149:7 (#5)

לַעֲשׂוֹת נָקָמָה בַּגּוֹיִם תּוֹכֵחוֹת בַּל־אֻמִּים

“to execute vengeance on the nations, punishments on the peoples”

The terms **nations** and **peoples** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to execute vengeance and punishment on all the foreign nations]

See: Doublet

Psalms 149:8 (#1)

לֶאְסֹר מַלְכֵיהֶם בְּזִקִּים וְנִכְבְּדֵיהֶם בְּכַבְלֵי בַרְזֶל

“to bind their kings with chains and their nobles with shackles of iron”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [to imprison all of their leaders in iron chains]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 149:8 (#2)

מַלְכֵיהֶם בְּזִקִּים וְנִכְבְּדֵיהֶם

“their kings with chains and their nobles”

The terms **kings** and **nobles** mean similar things. The psalmist is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [all of their leaders]

See: Doublet

Psalms 149:9 (#1)

מִשְׁפָּט כָּתוּב

“the judgment written”

The expression **the judgment written** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [the judgment that God wrote]

See: Active or Passive

Psalms 149:9 (#2)

חֲסִידָ֥יו

“his faithful”

The psalmist is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [his faithful ones]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Psalms 149:9 (#3)

מִשְׁפָּ֣ט כָּת֣וּב הָדָ֑ר

“the judgment written & honor”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **judgment** and **honor**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [to judge them as God has decreed ... God will honor]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 149:9 (#4)

הַלְלוּ־יָֽהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way that they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Halleluia] or [Praise Yah]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 149:9 (#5)

יָֽהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name Yahweh. You could use the full form of the name in your translation, as the UST does, or you could represent the shortened form in the way that is most natural in your language.

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms - Chapter 150 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Psalm 150 is a psalm of praise, but instead of presenting calls to worship and reasons to worship as such psalms typically do, it presents a single call to worship. See the discussion of the types of psalms in the introduction to the book of Psalms.

1. Call to worship (1–6)

Psalms 150:1 (#1)

הַלְלוּ־יָֽהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Praise Yah, all people]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 150:1 (#2)

יָֽהּ

“Yah”

Yah is a shortened form of the name “Yahweh,” the God of Israel. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names

Psalms 150:1 (#3)

הַלְלוּ־אֵ֥ל בְּקָדְשׁ֑וֹ הַֽלְל֥וּהוּ בִּרְקִ֖יעַ עֻזּֽוֹ

“Praise God in his sanctuary; praise him in the expanse of his strength”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation:

[Praise God in his sanctuary and in his mighty heavens]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 150:1 (#4)

בִּרְקִיעַ עֻזּוֹ

“in the expanse of his strength”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe an **expanse** that is characterized by **strength**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in his mighty expanse]

See: Possession

Psalms 150:1 (#5)

בִּרְקִיעַ עֻזּוֹ

“in the expanse of his strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in the expanse where he is mighty]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 150:2 (#1)

הַלְלוּהוּ בִּגְבוּרֹתָיו הַלְלוּהוּ כְּרֹב גֻּדְלוֹ

“Praise him for his mighty deeds; praise him according to the abundance of his greatness”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Praise him for his mighty deeds; yes, praise him because he is so abundantly great]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 150:2 (#2)

כְּרֹב גֻּדְלוֹ

“according to the abundance of his greatness”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **greatness** that is characterized by **abundance**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [according to how abundantly great he is]

See: Possession

Psalms 150:2 (#3)

כְּרֹב גֻּדְלוֹ

“according to the abundance of his greatness”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **abundance** and **greatness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because he is greater than any other thing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 150:3 (#1)

שׁוֹפָר

“a shofar”

A **shofar** is a musical instrument made from a ram’s horn. If your readers would not be familiar with what a **shofar** is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a ram’s-horn trumpet] or [a horn]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 150:4 (#1)

בְּתֹף

“with the tambourine”

A tambourine is a musical instrument, a percussion instrument with a head like a drum that can be hit. It has pieces of metal around the side edges; they make a rattling sound when the instrument is shaken. Alternate translation: [with the sound of the tambourine]

See: Translate Unknowns

Psalms 150:5 (#1)

הַלְלוּהוּ בְצִלְצְלֵי־שָׁמַע הַלְלוּהוּ בְּצִלְצְלֵי תְרוּעָה

“Praise him with cymbals of hearing; praise him with cymbals of a shout”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of phrases in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Praise him with all kinds of cymbals]

See: Parallelism

Psalms 150:5 (#2)

בְצִלְצְלֵי־שָׁמַע

“with cymbals of hearing”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **cymbals** that are characterized by **hearing**. If a

speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with cymbals that ring out clearly]

See: Possession

Psalms 150:5 (#3)

בְצִלְצְלֵי־שָׁמַע

“with cymbals of hearing”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hearing**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with cymbals that can be clearly heard]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 150:5 (#4)

בְּצִלְצְלֵי תְרוּעָה

“with cymbals of a shout”

The psalmist is using the possessive form to describe **cymbals** that are characterized by **a shout**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with cymbals that sound like a shout]

See: Possession

Psalms 150:5 (#5)

תְרוּעָה

“of a shout”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **a shout**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that ring out loudly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Psalms 150:6 (#1)

כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה תְּהַלֵּל יָהּ

“Let all of the breath praise Yah”

The psalmist is saying what he wants **all of the breath** to do. See the discussion in the introduction to this book about “let” and “may” and follow the decision of your team of how a speaker will express in this context what he wants someone to do. Alternate translation: [I desire that all of the breath praise Yah]

See: Third-Person Imperatives

Psalms 150:6 (#2)

כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה

“all of the breath”

Here, **all of the breath** represents all living creatures. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [all living creatures]

See: Metonymy

Psalms 150:6 (#3)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** are Hebrew words, containing a plural command to praise Yahweh. You will need to decide if you will use these words in their Hebrew form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. If you use the Hebrew words, you could spell them the way they sound in your language and then put the translation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Praise Yah, all people]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Psalms 150:6 (#4)

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

“Hallelu Yah”

The words **Hallelu Yah** mean “praise Yahweh.” The word **Yah** is a shortened form of the name Yahweh. You could use the full name if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Praise Yah, that is, Yahweh]

See: How to Translate Names